

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow (Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra)

Āryamahāparinirvāṇasūtra · Toh 119 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 119 in the Kangyur is the Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow, known in Sanskrit as the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa yongs su mya ngan las das pa chen po'i mdo. It is a major Mahāyāna sūtra recounting the final hours and teachings of the Buddha Śākyamuni as he approaches his passing into nirvāṇa between two śāla trees on the banks of the Hiraṇyavatī river near Kuśinagara, surrounded by a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas. The text expounds on themes of central importance to Mahāyāna Buddhism, including the nature of nirvāṇa, the eternity and qualities of the Buddha, and the presence of buddha-nature in all sentient beings. As one of the most celebrated and extensive Mahāyāna sūtras, it belongs to the sūtra division of the Kangyur.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow, the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. First Section.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling between two śāla trees on the bank of the river Hiraṇyavatī, at Kuśinagara, the city of the mighty, surrounded by a great Saṅgha of fully ordained monks numbering some eighty thousand, seated before him, all together.

At that time, the Blessed One was drawing near to passing beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa on the fifteenth day of the middle spring month. Through the blessing of the Blessed One, his great voice pervaded all things, reaching to the very summit of existence, and became known to all sentient beings in their own individual languages, speaking these words: "Today the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, who loves the multitude of beings with great tenderness, who has become the refuge and protector of all sentient beings, who regards all sentient beings with equal care as a mother lioness regards her cub, who has become the refuge, the ally, the support, and the shelter of sentient beings — today passes beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa. If there are among ordinary persons any who have doubts or uncertainties, let them ask now: this is the final moment for asking and inquiring. Let them ask and entreat." And this voice became known everywhere.

At that time, in the early morning hours, the Blessed One cast forth from his mouth rays of light of many colors — blue, yellow, red, white, and crystal-clear — illuminating this great three-thousandfold world-system and all the world-systems of the ten directions. All sentient beings of the six classes who abide in those realms, the moment they were touched by those rays, were purified of all blameworthy afflictions.

At that time, ordinary persons who saw and heard such a sign were stricken and tormented by a great grief, and all at once they beat their breasts and wept, crying out: "Alas! O you who have been like the most loving of parents! Oh no, oh no! Can it be that you are passing into nirvāṇa?" And striking their heads and chests with their palms, they beat their breasts in lamentation. Some trembled throughout their bodies, their hair standing on end, and wept with voices broken with sobbing.

At that time this great earth, and the mountains and the ocean, were all shaken and stirred in a tremendous upheaval.

Then those sentient beings, encouraging one another and seeking to dispel their grief, spoke thus: "Friends, do not sorrow! Let us go quickly to Kuśinagara, the city of the mighty, to where the Tathāgata is. Let us bow our heads to the feet of the Tathāgata and entreat him: may the Tathāgata not pass beyond sorrow, may he remain in the world for one full eon, or until one eon has nearly passed." So they spoke.

And some, grasping one another's hands, said: "The world is empty! Because the merit of sentient beings is exhausted, unwholesome actions have arisen in the world. Friends, the Tathāgata will surely pass beyond sorrow before long — let us go quickly." So they spoke.

Others said: "The world is empty! The world is empty! From this day forward we have no protector, no refuge — we have become destitute. Today we have been utterly separated from the unsurpassed Blessed One. Henceforth, to whom shall we address our doubts and uncertainties?" So they spoke.

At that time, a great number of senior monks, among them the venerable Mahākātyāyana, the venerable Bakula, and the venerable Ānanda and others —

touched by the light of the buddha, their entire bodies trembled and shook beyond all bearing, their minds became intoxicated, and they cried out in lamentation, overwhelmed by manifold sufferings of that kind.

At that time, there were also some eighty thousand fully ordained monks — all of them arhats: masters of their minds, who had accomplished what was to be done, who had thoroughly abandoned all afflictions, whose every faculty was completely tamed, who were mighty as great nāga kings, possessed of the wisdom of emptiness, who had at last attained their own highest good, surrounded by sandalwood groves as by sandalwood, surrounded by lions as by the lion-king — endowed with immeasurable virtues of that kind, and all of them true sons of the buddha. These monks too had been dwelling and had set out at the early morning hour just after the sun had risen. While using their tooth-cleansing sticks, they were touched by the light of the buddha and said to one another: "Friends, go quickly — rinse your mouth and wash your hands." The moment those words were spoken, the hairs of their bodies all stood on end, and the blood suffusing their bodies all the way to the skin became like flower petals; their eyes filled with tears and they experienced great suffering.

All of them — for the sake of benefit and happiness for all sentient beings, so as to practice yoga on the ultimate emptiness of the Great Vehicle, so as to teach what the Tathāgata had taught in his compassionate skillful means, so as never to interrupt the continuous teaching of Dharma in its manifold aspects, and so as to tame all sentient beings completely — went quickly to where the Blessed One was, and with the crowns of their heads bowed down at the feet of the buddha. They circumambulated him a hundredfold and then a thousandfold, joined their palms together, and stood to one side.

At that time there were also some sixty thousand fully ordained nuns — among them the daughter of Kuntala, the nun Śrībhadrā, the nun Priyadarśanā, the nun Sāgaramatī, and others — all of them arhats with defilements exhausted: masters of their minds, who had accomplished what was to be done, who had thoroughly abandoned all afflictions, whose faculties were completely tamed, whose dignity was supremely great like that of mighty nāgas, and who were possessed of the wisdom of emptiness. In the early morning hour, at the very first rising of the sun, the hairs of their bodies all bristled and stood on end, the blood suffusing their bodies all the way to the skin became like flower petals, their eyes filled completely with tears, and they experienced great suffering.

They too — for the sake of benefit and happiness for all sentient beings, so as to practice yoga on the ultimate emptiness of the Great Vehicle, so as to teach what the Tathāgata had taught in his compassionate skillful means, so as

never to interrupt the continuous teaching of Dharma in its manifold aspects, and so as to tame all sentient beings completely — went quickly to where the Blessed One was, bowed the crowns of their heads at the feet of the buddha, circumambulated him a hundredfold and then a thousandfold, joined their palms together, and stood to one side.

Among those nuns there were some who were bodhisattvas — like nāgas among human beings, having thoroughly entered the ten grounds, abiding in imperturbability; and though they displayed the body of a woman for the sake of taming sentient beings, they were ever devoted to the four immeasurables, and through mastery of mind they were in truth nothing other than emanations of a buddha's body.

At that time there were also bodhisattvas and great beings (mahāsattvas) as numerous as the grains of sand in a single river Gaṅgā — who, like nāgas among human beings, had thoroughly entered the ten grounds and abided supremely in imperturbability, and who through skillful means displayed the body alone — among them the bodhisattva Sāgaraśrī and the bodhisattva Akṣayamati and others —

Led foremost by those bodhisattvas and great beings, all of them showed reverence toward the Great Vehicle, were firmly established in the Great Vehicle, were supremely skilled in the Great Vehicle, were supremely devoted to the Great Vehicle, and were supremely dedicated to guarding the Great Vehicle. They were in profound harmony with the minds of all beings in the world. They pledged themselves by solemn vow to liberate in the future those not yet liberated. Throughout the past, over the course of innumerable aeons, they had perfectly guarded their moral discipline, fully upheld right conduct, and liberated those not yet free. They sustained without interruption the lineage of the Three Jewels, and in times to come they would turn the wheel of Dharma. Adorned with great adornments, they were endowed with such boundless qualities as these, and they looked upon every sentient being with the same feeling as one would have toward an only child.

These bodhisattvas too, in the early morning, the moment the sun had just risen, were touched by the light of the buddha, and the hairs of their bodies all stood on end. Their bodies, suffused throughout with flushing blood, became like flesh upon a lotus flower, and their eyes filled completely with tears, so that they experienced a welling of deep emotion.

And they, for the welfare and happiness of all sentient beings, and in order to accomplish the practice of yoga upon the ultimate emptiness of the Great Vehicle, and in order to demonstrate the teaching that the Tathāgata had spoken with skillful intent, and in order to expound the Dharma continuously in its many and various aspects, and in order to fully tame all sentient beings — for all these reasons, they swiftly went and came to the place where the Blessed One was. They bowed their heads to the feet of the buddha in homage, circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, then with palms pressed together, together with their retinues, respectfully took their places to one side.

At that time there were also laymen (upāsakas) who kept the five precepts in their fullness, as numerous as the grains of sand in two rivers Gaṅgā, led foremost by the layman King Radiance of Unsullied Renown and the layman Excellent Qualities and others. All of them were supremely devoted to the antidotal teachings, and the antidotal teachings upon which they so ardently reflected were these: suffering and happiness; permanence and impermanence; purity and impurity; self and no-self; the definite and the indefinite; taking refuge and not taking refuge; sentient being and non-sentient being; the lasting and the non-lasting; bliss and the absence of bliss; the conditioned and the unconditioned; annihilation and the absence of annihilation; the transcendence of sorrow and the non-transcendence of sorrow; the superior and the non-superior — and so forth. Such were precisely the antidotal teachings upon which they were supremely devoted to reflection.

Furthermore, all of them were devoted to hearing the unsurpassed Great Vehicle, were able to teach others precisely as they themselves had heard, perfectly guarded their moral discipline, were devoted to the Great Vehicle like someone tormented by thirst, were themselves utterly satisfied yet also satisfied others who were tormented by thirst, entered deeply into unsurpassed wisdom, were devoted to the Great Vehicle, were supremely dedicated to protecting the Great Vehicle, were in profound harmony with the minds of all worldly beings, rescued those not yet rescued, liberated those not yet liberated, sustained without interruption the lineage of the Three Jewels, would in the future turn the wheel of Dharma extensively, were adorned with great adornments, were devoted to the taste of the profoundly deep mind, were perfectly pure in moral discipline — all of them endowed with such qualities as these. They had aroused in their minds the thought of great compassion toward all sentient beings and looked upon them without

distinction, just as one would an only child.

At the early morning hour, just as the sun rose, its rays touched them and they entered into the Tathāgata's presence for the purpose of making offerings. Each one of them, from their own quarters, had arranged many hundreds of fragrant wooden thrones — namely, thrones of sandalwood, of aloe wood, of red sandalwood, of fragrant divine wood, and so forth. Those woods were beautiful with fine carvings and adorned with the seven precious substances; they shone and gleamed with intense brilliance, like an artist spreading pigments of many colors, and through the blessing of the buddhas they were endowed with the colors blue, yellow, red, and white — such that the sight of them would bring sheer joy to multitudes of beings. And upon those many kinds of fragrant wood thrones, yet further adornments were applied: various kinds of perfume pouches, saffron, aloe wood, costus, and the like were lavishly rubbed on, and the thrones were scattered and adorned with flowers of many kinds — blue lotuses, white water lilies, red lotuses, and white lotuses, and so forth. Furthermore, draped over those thrones were banners of five colors, exceedingly soft and beautiful, spread out in the manner of divine garments of kauśeya silk or fine linen.

Those fragrant wooden thrones were mounted on chariots of precious gems, and from those gem-encrusted chariots there issued lights of many colors — blue, yellow, red, and white. The yokes, axle-beams, and other fittings of the chariots were adorned with the seven precious substances, and each chariot was drawn by four horses. Those horses were swift as the wind. Arrayed before each chariot were some fifty victory banners of the seven precious substances, covered overhead with a net of gold. Spread above each of those precious gem chariots were some fifty precious gem parasols. Each chariot was also hung with garlands of flowers — blue lotuses, white water lilies, red lotuses, and white lotuses — their petals made of gold and their stamens fashioned from vajra crystal. Within those golden flowers, dark bees hovered and played.

Furthermore, from those flowers there issued sounds exceedingly lovely and melodious, as well as sounds that were other than that — the sounds of impermanence, of suffering, of emptiness, and of no-self. And beyond those, there sounded the proclamation of the prior practices of bodhisattvas, and the sounds of various kinds of music were heard — songs, dance, flutes, nine-stringed lutes, cymbals, bells, and drums. Beyond those musical sounds there also arose a voice calling out: "Ki hud! Ki hud! The worlds are emptied!"

Before each chariot there stood an attendant holding a small throne fashioned from the four precious gems, and upon those small thrones were heaped flowers of many kinds — blue lotuses, white water lilies, red lotuses, white lotuses, saffron, ointments, incense, and other excellent and supremely fine offerings, all arranged in place. The offerings of various foods that the lay practitioners had set out for the buddhas and the Saṅgha were all prepared by burning sandalwood and fragrant aloe wood and stirring those foods with water endowed with the eight qualities. Those foods were endowed with the six tastes — cold, sour, sweet, hot, salty-pungent, and astringent.

Furthermore, those foods possessed three qualities: they were soft and tender, clean and pure, and prepared in accordance with the Dharma. Having arranged such various and manifold offerings as these, the lay practitioners came to the foot of the śāla tree, the place where the Great One would pass beyond.

Moreover, the ground had been spread over with golden sand, and upon it were laid divine garments of kācalinda cloth, and silks and fine fabrics were strewn across it, extending in all directions for a full twelve leagues around. Thrones of lion-seat fashioned from the seven precious gems were arranged for the Buddha and the Saṅgha to rest upon, and the height of those thrones was equal to that of Mount Meru. Above those thrones precious canopies were raised, and from them many kinds of garlands were hung. Upon the śāla trees themselves banners and pennants of many kinds were hung, and parasols were spread, and the branches of those trees were anointed with scented oil perfumed with various kinds of incense. And the spaces between the trees were filled to overflowing with flowers of many kinds.

Each of those lay practitioners resolved within their minds: "If ordinary beings are hungry, we shall give them food. If they are thirsty, we shall give them drink. If they wish for garments, garments. If they wish for medicine, medicine." Thus they gave to all ordinary beings whatever was wished for, and that giving was free from the minds of attachment, aversion, delusion, and agitation. Nor did they act out of any thought for worldly wealth and enjoyment; it was solely for the sake of unsurpassed, perfectly pure awakening.

Those lay practitioners, resting steadfastly in unsurpassed awakening, then reflected within their minds: "The Tathāgata will accept these our offerings and then pass beyond nirvāṇa." At that thought, the hairs on all their bodies

stood on end, and their bodies, suffused with blood, became like a piece of flesh laid bare of skin. Their eyes filled with tears. Their minds were tormented by great suffering. Each and every one of them packed up the offerings they had individually arranged — the fragrant wood, the victory banners, the pennants, the parasols, and the foods — loaded them onto jeweled carriages, went to where the Buddha was, and arrived before him. They prostrated at the feet of the Buddha with their crowns touching the ground, and with the offerings they had arranged they made offerings to the Tathāgata. They circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and then cried out with their voices and wept. The sound of their weeping shook heaven and earth. They beat their breasts and wailed, tears streaming down like rain, and said to one another, sobbing: "Oh! Oh! Friends, the world is empty! The world is empty!" Having said these words, they prostrated their bodies before the Tathāgata and addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Out of loving kindness for us, may the Tathāgata accept this last inner offering that we have arranged. Please accept it." The Blessed One, knowing the time, said nothing and did not accept it. And so even though they beseeched him in this same way three times, he did not grant acceptance.

Those lay practitioners, finding that things had not turned out as they had hoped, were tormented by grief and stood there in silence. Their condition was like that of parents deeply devoted to their only child, when that child is suddenly struck by illness and dies and is carried away to the charnel ground, and they are tormented by the most intense grief. Just so were those lay practitioners tormented by grief. They set down all the offering articles in one place and stood to one side in silence.

At that time, there were also laywomen as numerous as the grains of sand of three Ganges rivers, perfectly guarding the five precepts, endowed with proper conduct, such as the laywoman Jīvānaśrī and the laywoman Śrīmālā.

Led foremost by the laywoman Viśākā, all eighty-four thousand laywomen perfectly upheld the sacred Dharma. In order to tame countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings, they appeared in female form while thoroughly condemning the ways of household life. They had come to regard their own bodies as being like a venomous serpent. They understood the body to be perpetually devoured by countless worms, utterly foul, and bound fast by desire. They saw this body as dreadful as a corpse, as impure, understanding that it ceaselessly leaks from its nine openings. They understood this body to be like a fortress, wrapped round with flesh, skin, sinew, and blood vessels,

with the hands and feet as its watchtowers, the eyes as its arrow-slits, the head as its central hall, and the mind, like a king, dwelling within. They understood that this body, resembling a fortress, is utterly abandoned by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, while ordinary deluded beings remain attached to it. They understood that the demons of attachment, aversion, and delusion dwell within it. They understood this body to be without essence, like a plantain shoot, or an eraṇḍa plant, or a water bubble, or a water-reed. They understood this body to be impermanent, shifting moment by moment, like a flash of lightning, or a swift-flowing current, or a magical illusion, or a mirage, or a line drawn on water. They understood this body to be changeable and transient, like a tree standing on a crumbling riverbank. They understood this body to endure not for long, becoming food for jackals, foxes, flesh-eating birds, owls, vultures, crows, hyenas, and hungry dogs; and they had come to understand that no wise and discerning person would hold affection and attachment for it. They understood that even if one were to pour the waters of a great ocean into the hollow of a hoof-print, it might fit, yet the impermanence, impurity, and foulness of this body are not easy to fully express. To roll up this great earth into a mustard-seed or reduce it to fine dust is easier, they knew, than fully describing the faults and flaws of this body. Therefore, having abandoned it entirely, as one spits out saliva, and by means of that very cause and that very condition, these laywomen applied themselves constantly to the practices of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness. They were devoted to hearing and upholding the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, and having heard them, they were able to expound them extensively to others. They upheld their former aspirational prayers. They utterly condemned the female body, knowing it to be profoundly defective and realizing it to be without essence. Their minds were perpetually engaged in yogic practice. Likewise, through correct contemplation, they fully severed the stream of endless cyclic existence. Their devotion to the Great Vehicle was like that of one tormented by thirst. Having themselves been thoroughly satisfied, they brought deep satisfaction to others as well. They were full of enthusiasm for the Great Vehicle, guarding it with utmost care. Though appearing in female form, they were bodhisattvas through and through. They were all deeply aligned with the wishes of the world, liberating the unrescued, freeing the unfree, and sustaining without interruption the lineage of the Three Jewels. In the future they would turn the wheel of Dharma. They were adorned with great ornaments, perfectly guarding their ethical conduct, and endowed with immeasurable qualities such as these. They aroused the mind of compassion

toward all sentient beings, regarding them without duality, as equal and utterly non-different from an only child. These laywomen too, in the early morning when the first rays of the sun appeared and the light touched them, said one to another: "Today we shall set out for the place of the twin śāla trees."

The laywomen arranged their offerings with preparations twice as fine as those made before, and came to where the Buddha was. They prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One, touching their heads to the ground, and circumambulated him a hundred thousand times. Then they addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, out of love for us, may the Tathāgata accept these offerings we have prepared for the Buddha and for the Saṅgha together with the monks." But the Blessed One said nothing, and he did not consent to receive them. The laywomen, finding that things had not gone as they had hoped, were stricken with sorrow and withdrew to one side.

Now at that time there were also others — Licchavi men, women, boys, girls, wives, and retinues, in numbers as countless as the grains of sand in four great Ganges rivers, who dwelt in the city of Vaiśālī; and likewise members of the royal lineage of Jambudvīpa together with their royal entourages. All of them, for the sake of the Dharma they desired, guarded their moral discipline completely, possessed of proper conduct, and devoted themselves to study under others. Those who were absolutely resolute in cutting off and thoroughly rebuking whoever denigrated the sacred Dharma, these very ones pledged to one another, saying: "Let the true Dharma — profound beyond measure, like a treasury of gold, silver, and precious jewels, like nectar inexhaustible — remain long in the world, and may we ourselves always apply ourselves to it diligently. If there is anyone who abuses authority over the Dharma as spoken from that very mouth, or who defames it, we shall cut out that person's tongue. Furthermore, if any who have gone forth from home into homelessness should fall away from their moral discipline, we shall reduce them to the status of householders and put them to work. And if there is one who applies himself diligently to the sacred Dharma, we shall serve and honor him as we would our own parents. And if there is one within the Saṅgha who is diligent in the practice of the sacred Dharma, we shall rejoice with him and also lend him our support." So they pledged. They were forever eager to hear the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, and upon hearing them they would teach them extensively to others. Such were the qualities with which they were endowed. Among these were the Licchavi youth Pure Stainless Essence, the Licchavi

youth Mindfully Purified, the Licchavi youth Ever Stainless Pure Virtue, and others of their kind. These said one to another: "Friends, let us quickly go to where the Tathāgata is, and set out to make offerings of every kind in full and magnificent array."

Then each of those Licchavīs arranged eighty-four thousand woolen oxen, eighty-four thousand jeweled chariots drawn by four horses, eighty-four thousand wish-fulfilling precious jewels, and also eighty-four thousand measures of sandalwood and aloe-wood compacted together. Before each of those woolen oxen they also arranged victory banners, pennants, and canopies of precious jewels. Even the smallest of the canopies covered a full league in all directions around. Even the shortest of the pennants trailed a length of thirty-two leagues. Even the lowest of the jeweled victory banners stood a hundred leagues in height. Having arranged such offerings, they came to where the Buddha was. They prostrated at the feet of the Buddha and circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and then addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, we offer these offerings to the Buddha and to the Saṅgha of monks; may the Tathāgata, out of compassion for us, accept these offerings." But the Tathāgata said nothing, and did not consent to receive them.

The sons of the Licchavīs found that things had not gone as they had wished, and they were overwhelmed with grief. By the blessing of the Blessed One, they rose up from the ground to the height of seven palm trees and remained in the sky above, silent and still.

At that same time, there were also great ministers, householders, and merchants as numerous as the grains of sand in five Ganges rivers, all deeply devoted to the Great Vehicle and following a different teacher, and there was among them one who had disparaged the true Dharma. Their coming was subdued entirely, as hail falls upon grass and trees — precisely thus. Led first by the merchant Sunlight, the merchant Protector of the World, the merchant Protector of the Dharma, and others, they each separately arranged offerings that were fully five times greater than those arranged before. They came to the place between the two sāla trees where the Tathāgata lay, prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, we offer these offerings to the Buddha and to the Saṅgha of monks; may the Tathāgata accept them." But the Tathāgata said nothing, and did not consent to receive them. Those merchants, finding that things had not gone as they had wished,

became tormented with great grief, and by the blessing of the Blessed One they rose from the ground to the height of seven palm trees and remained in the sky above, silent and still.

At that time there also arrived the king of Vaiśālī together with his queens, and furthermore all the petty kings of Jambudvīpa apart from King Ajātaśatru, along with all the inhabitants of every city, every region, and every village — led first by King Candraprabha Vimala and the other kings, each accompanied by his own fourfold army. Each of those kings came with a retinue of eight hundred thousand. The army consisted of elephants and cavalry: the elephants had six tusks, and the horses were fleet as the wind. The offerings they had arranged surpassed the previous ones by more than sixfold. Even the smallest of the jeweled canopies covered an area eight leagues across in all directions. Even the shortest of the pennants trailed a length of sixteen leagues. Even the smallest of the jeweled victory banners stood thirty-six leagues in height.

All those kings abided in the true Dharma and utterly condemned every false teaching; they honored the Great Vehicle, they were deeply devoted to the Great Vehicle, they loved all sentient beings as one loves an only child, and the fragrance of the food they had set out wafted to a distance of four leagues. In the early morning hour, bearing all manner of offerings, they went to where the Tathāgata lay between the two sāla trees, and then addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, we offer these offerings to the Buddha and to the Saṅgha of monks; may the Tathāgata, out of compassion, accept this final offering of ours." But the Tathāgata, knowing the right time, did not consent to receive them. Those kings too, finding that things had not gone as they had wished, became tormented with great grief, and withdrew to stand to one side.

At that time, there gathered also a number of royal consorts as numerous as the grains of sand in seven Ganges rivers — all of them except one, who was solely a consort of Ajātaśatru. Appearing in female form in order to tame sentient beings,

they constantly applied themselves with body and engaged in practice, familiarizing and habituating the mind with the teachings on emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, and so forth. They were first led on by the royal consort Lovely in the Three Realms, and by the royal consort Qualities of Desire, and the rest. All of them abided in the holy Dharma, completely

guarding their moral discipline, endowed with proper conduct, and loving each and every sentient being exactly as though each were their only child. They said to one another: "Let us too swiftly go to where the Buddha dwells."

The offerings arrayed by the royal consorts exceeded those of the preceding group sevenfold and more: flowers, incense, jeweled victory banners, silk pennants, parasols, and the finest foods. Even the smallest of the jeweled parasols was wide enough to cover a circumference of sixteen leagues in all directions. The shortest of the pennants measured some thirty-six leagues in height. The lowest of the jeweled victory banners stood some sixty-eight leagues tall. The fragrance of the food offerings spread and wafted for a distance of eight leagues. Having arranged such offerings as these, they proceeded to where the Tathāgata was. They bowed their heads to the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him many hundreds and thousands of times, and then addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, we have arranged these offerings and present them to the Buddha and to the Saṅgha of monks. Out of compassion for us, may the Tathāgata accept this last of our offerings."

But the Tathāgata, knowing the right time, said nothing and did not consent to receive them. The royal consorts, finding that things had not gone as they had wished, became tormented with overwhelming grief. Tearing their hair, beating their chests, and wailing, they became as those who have lost a dearly beloved child, and withdrew to one side without uttering a word.

At that time, among the goddesses (suras) as numerous as the grains of sand in eight Ganges rivers, the one called Wide-Eyed Goddess spoke first and said: "Friends, do you see? Look! Do you see how the great assembly has laid out all manner of diverse offerings and is presenting them to the Tathāgata and the Saṅgha of monks? Let us too arrange offerings and, having made offering to the Tathāgata, beseech the Tathāgata — after he has received them — to remain and not pass into nirvāṇa. Friends, it is exceedingly rare for a buddha, the Blessed One, to appear in the world, and it is exceedingly rare to be able to arrange and present a last offering. If the Blessed One passes into nirvāṇa, the world will be left empty."

Now those goddesses desired the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna), were devoted to hearing the Great Vehicle, and having heard it were capable of teaching it extensively to others. They were as though parched with thirst for the Great Vehicle, and just as one who is deeply satisfied can still satisfy others who are

parched, so too did they satisfy others. They protected the Great Vehicle. When there were those who had entered another path and who disparaged the Great Vehicle out of jealousy, these goddesses crushed them utterly, as hailstones crush grass. They completely guarded their moral discipline and were endowed with proper conduct. They were supremely skilled in winning the minds of all the world. They tamed those who were untamed and liberated those who were unliberated. In times yet to come, they would turn the wheel of Dharma and sustain the unbroken lineage of the Three Jewels. They applied themselves with diligence to the Great Vehicle, and

adorned with great ornaments, endowed with immeasurable qualities of that kind, and loving toward all sentient beings exactly as one loves an only child — these divine daughters, too, in the early morning when the sun first rose, each set out various divine fragrant trees, which surpassed the fragrant trees of humans, and whose fragrance, pervading the human world, dispelled every disagreeable smell. They mounted white palanquins draped with white parasols and drawn by four white horses. Over each palanquin they raised a white canopy, and around the edges of each canopy golden bells were hung. They arranged all manner of incense, flowers, jeweled victory banners, pennants, parasols, excellent and exquisite food and drink, and various kinds of music. They set down lion thrones whose four legs were fashioned from deep-blue lapis lazuli, whose backs were fitted with cushions of seven kinds of precious stone, and before each of which stood a golden footstool. On lamp-pillars made of seven kinds of precious stone, lamps blazed with all manner of precious jewels. The entire ground was strewn with divine flowers in this fashion. Having arranged all of this, these divine daughters arrived with aching hearts, tears streaming down their faces. Yet even in their great suffering, for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings — so that the Great Vehicle, the ultimate truth endowed with emptiness, might be made manifest, so that what the Tathāgata intended and taught might be openly demonstrated, and so that the unbroken stream of teaching the various Dharmas might not be cut off — they came before the Blessed One, bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, out of your compassion for us, please accept this last of the offerings we have arranged." The Blessed One, knowing the right time, said nothing and did not accept. The divine daughters, their hope unfulfilled, were grieved at heart and, without a word, withdrew to one side.

Then, at that time, as many yakṣa kings (yakṣas) as there are grains of sand in ten Ganges rivers arrived from the four directions — led first by the yakṣa king Ngalsopos and others — and said to one another, "Come, friends, let us go quickly to where the Buddha is!" Having arranged offerings surpassing even those of the nāgas, they came before the Blessed One, bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, out of your compassion for us, please accept this last of the offerings we have arranged." To this the Blessed One said nothing and did not accept.

At that time, as many nāga kings (nāgas) as there are grains of sand in nine Ganges rivers arrived from the four directions — led first by the nāga king Jokpo, the nāga king Gawos, and the nāga king Nyegawos and others. These nāga kings too, in the early morning when the sun first rose, arranged offerings of worship surpassing those of gods and humans, came before the Blessed One, bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated him a hundred thousand times, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, out of your compassion for us, please accept this last of the offerings we have arranged." The Tathāgata, knowing the right time, said nothing and did not accept. The nāga kings too, their hope unfulfilled, were grieved at heart and withdrew to one side.

The yakṣa kings, their hope likewise unfulfilled, were grieved at heart and withdrew to one side.

Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, garuḍa kings led by one named Conqueror of Opponents came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in thirty Ganges rivers, gandharva kings led by the greatly powerful one came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in forty Ganges rivers, kinnara kings led by one named the Greatly Seeing came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in fifty Ganges rivers, great serpent kings led by one named the Very Greatly Seeing came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in sixty Ganges rivers, asura kings led by Khābibili came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in seventy Ganges rivers, tānapā kings led by Stainless Flowing Water, Vātidatā, and others came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in eighty Ganges rivers, rākṣasa kings led by one named the Terrifying came forward first. All of these had completely abandoned wicked and non-virtuous minds; they refrained from eating human flesh; toward those who were their enemies and adversaries they gave rise to a mind of

loving-kindness and compassion; and even their unpleasant forms all became beautiful and fair through the blessing of the Buddha. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in ninety Ganges rivers, gods of the forest groves led by one named Delighting in Fragrant Incense came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in a thousand Ganges rivers, vidyādhara kings led by one named the Great Miraculous Power came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in one hundred thousand Ganges rivers, prabhāsana kings led by one named the Greatly Seeing came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in ten million Ganges rivers, the goddesses of desire — Lampā, Urvaśī, Tilottamā, Miśrakeśī, and others — came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in a hundred million Ganges rivers, earth-dwelling hungry ghost kings led by one named White Wing came forward first. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in one billion Ganges rivers, the sons of the gods and the god-kings were led forward first by the protectors of the four directions. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in one billion Ganges rivers, the river gods filled the area around the śāla trees to overflowing with flowers — both those in season and those out of season — gathered from the four directions. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in one billion Ganges rivers, the gods presiding over wind and rain thought to themselves: when the Tathāgata has entered into nirvāṇa and lies at rest, we shall send down great rain, so that any fires lit in due time may be extinguished, and those among the assembled retinue who are afflicted by heat may be thoroughly cooled. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, great fragrant bulls — the bull king Lāhu, the bull king the Golden One, the bull king Sweet Flavor, the bull king Indigo Eye, the bull king the Fragrant One, and others — came forward first. All of these revered the Great Vehicle and were devoted to the Great Vehicle alone. Knowing that the Buddha, the Blessed One, would pass into nirvāṇa before long, each of them brought forth immeasurable and incalculable fine lotuses, came before the Buddha, the Blessed One, bowed their heads in homage, and stood to one side. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, lion kings among wild animals led by one named Lion's Roar came forward first; having bestowed fearlessness upon all sentient beings, each of them took flowers and fruits, came before the Buddha, bowed at the Buddha's feet, and stood to one side. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, bird kings — geese, cranes, peacocks, parrots, kalandakas, and

guyas, jīvaṃjakas, and kalandakas — each of them took flowers and fruits, came before the Buddha, bowed at the feet of the Blessed One, and stood to one side. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, water buffalo, cattle, sheep, and similar animals came before the Buddha; and all the ponds of finest grass in the city of Kuśinagara, together with every manger and trough, became spontaneously filled with fragrant milk rich in colour and taste, and they stood to one side. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, sages dwelling on the four continents, led first by one named Patient Sage, each of them took flowers, incense, sweet fruits, and the like, came before the Buddha, bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated three times, and then addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, out of compassion for us, please accept this, our last inner offering." But the Tathāgata, knowing the proper time, said nothing and did not consent to accept it. The sages, finding things not as they had wished, were pierced with grief and sorrow of heart, and stood to one side. The bee king of Jambudvīpa, named Melodious Sound, came forward first, and all the bees, taking flowers of many varieties, came before the Buddha, bowed at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated once, and stood to one side. At that time, all the monks and nuns dwelling in Jambudvīpa assembled there — all save two alone: Mahākāśyapa and Ānanda. Furthermore, immeasurable and incountable world-realms — as many as grains of sand in the Ganges — led by Mount Meru, king of mountains, together with all the mountains of Jambudvīpa and the other mountains: each of those mountains was richly adorned with dense forests, with trees whose foliage and branches hung so thickly that they screened out the light of the sun, with blossoms of many varieties in full bloom, and on every side with streams and springs utterly pure and fragrant. They were filled throughout with gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great serpents, vidyādhara, sages, and the like, all making music of many kinds. Those gods and sages came before the Blessed One, bowed their heads at the feet of the Buddha, and stood to one side. Furthermore, as many as grains of sand in incalculable Ganges rivers, the gods of the four great oceans, and the gods of all the rivers, possessed of great majesty and supernatural power, laid out offerings surpassing all that had come before, and by the radiance of the gods' bodies, the splendour of their music, and the light of their lamps, they caused even the light of the sun and moon to be invisible. They scattered campaka flowers on the bank of the river Hiraṇyavatī, came before the Buddha, bowed at the feet of the Buddha, and stood to one side. At that time, all the śāla-tree groves

of the city of Kuśinagara turned white, and in the sky above there arose of themselves magnificent palaces of seven precious jewels, with turrets and painted designs, adorned with beauty, adorned all around with jewels of many kinds, and before those palaces there spontaneously appeared from springs, ponds, and pools lotus flowers blooming — just like the renowned grove called Most Delightful in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three gods in the north, called Uttarakuru. At that time, all the śāla-tree groves were adorned in manifold ways and became exceedingly beautiful.

At that time, all the gods, humans, asuras, and all other beings understood that this was a sign of the Tathāgata's passing into nirvāṇa, and every one of them became tormented with grief and fell into sorrow.

At that time, the kings of the Four Great Kings and Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, said to one another: "Friends, behold how the gods, humans, asuras, and all beings of the world are preparing offerings and making offerings to the Tathāgata. Let us likewise make offerings. If we make offerings at the very last moment, we shall certainly perfect the perfection of generosity (pāramitā)." And so it was spoken.

Then the gods of the realm of the Four Great Kings prepared offerings far exceeding those made before, which were as follows: the flowers mādārava and great mādārava, the flowers kacilika and great kacilika, the flowers mañjūṣaka and great mañjūṣaka, the flowers santānika and great santānika, the flowers "pleasing" and great "pleasing," the flowers "all-good" and great "all-good," the flowers "timely" and great "timely," the flowers "fragrant city" and great "fragrant city," the flowers "supremely joyful" and great "supremely joyful," the flowers "wish-fulfilling" and great "wish-fulfilling," the flowers "fragrant intoxication" and great "fragrant intoxication," the flowers "all-fragrant" and great "all-fragrant," the flower known as "divine golden petals," the flower known as "nāga," the flowers of the pāricitra tree, the flowers of the kovidāra tree, and also various kinds of delicious food of many flavors. Carrying these, they came to where the Buddha was, and bowed their heads in prostration at the feet of the Blessed One. The light of the gods outshone even the light of the sun and moon. Having laid out these articles of offering so as to make offering to the Tathāgata, the Tathāgata, knowing the time, said nothing and did not accept.

At that time the gods, seeing that things had not gone as they had hoped, were tormented with grief and withdrew to one side.

Then Śakra, lord of the gods, and the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three prepared offerings far surpassing those made before, with the same flowers as before, but now most excellently fragrant with sweet perfume. They also prepared the great palace called "Victor of Immeasurable Mansions" and the smaller immeasurable mansions, and came to where the Buddha was, and bowed their heads in prostration at the feet of the Blessed One. They addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, we have the deepest faith and devotion in the Great Vehicle. Out of compassion for us, may the Tathāgata please accept these offerings." The Blessed One, knowing the time, said nothing and did not accept.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa. Second Fascicle.

Then Śakra and his retinue of gods, seeing that things had not gone as they had hoped, were tormented with grief and withdrew to one side.

Through all six levels of the heavens of the desire realm, the articles of offering that had been arranged included victory banners of precious jewels, pennants, and canopies, each one more magnificent than the last. Even the smallest of the jeweled canopies covered all four continents. Even the shortest of the pennants encircled all four oceans. Even the lowest of the victory banners reached up to touch the Heaven of Wielding Others' Emanations (Paranirmitavaśavartin), and when moved by the wind they gave forth sweet and melodious sounds.

They arranged food and drink of the most excellent and varied kinds, then came to where the Blessed One was. They prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, out of compassion for us, please accept this, the last of our offerings." But the Tathāgata, who knows the right time, said nothing and did not accept it.

Then the gods too, their hopes unfulfilled, were tormented with grief and withdrew to one side.

Beyond all of these — at the very summit of existence — the gods of the Brahmā realms (Brahmaloka) had also assembled. At that moment, Brahmā, King of the gods, and the gods of the Brahmā realms illuminated all four continents with their light, causing even the light of the sun and moon in the desire realm to disappear. They too, each carrying jeweled victory banners, pennants, and canopies — even the shortest of the pennants stretching from the Brahmā realm all the way down to touch the śāla grove — came to where the Buddha was. They prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed

One and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, out of compassion for us, please accept this, the last of our offerings." But the Tathāgata, who knows the right time, said nothing and did not accept it. The gods of the Brahmā realms, their hopes unfulfilled, were tormented with grief and withdrew to one side.

Then Vemacitrin, king of the asuras (demigods), arrived together with a retinue of countless asuras. The radiance of their bodies surpassed even that of the Brahmā gods. Carrying jeweled victory banners, pennants, and canopies — even the smallest of the canopies covering a thousandfold minor world system — and bearing the most exquisite and excellent foods, they came to where the Buddha was. They prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, out of compassion for us, please accept this, the last of our offerings." But the Tathāgata, who knows the right time, said nothing and did not accept it. The asuras, their hopes unfulfilled, were tormented with grief and withdrew to one side.

Then Māra the Evil One (Skt. Māra pāpīyas), king of māras in the desire realm, arrived together with a retinue of innumerable divine daughters. He opened the gates of the hells, rained down cooling and purifying water upon them, and commanded those within, saying: "You and all the others can do nothing else — so with one-pointed mind, recollect the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha, and rejoice in the offerings being made to him. You will thereby attain lasting and perfect happiness."

Then Māra the Evil One, with a cooling rain, extinguished the weapons of the hell beings and the raging fires that cause suffering there. Through the blessing of the Buddha, the host of Māra's retinue also gave rise to this thought in their minds. All of them laid aside their swords, bows and arrows, armor, spears, iron hooks, iron mallets, battle-axes, wheels, lassos, and every other weapon, and arranged offerings surpassing those of gods and humans. Carrying canopies — even the smallest of which covered a middling thousandfold world system — they came to where the Buddha was.

They prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One, touching their crowns to the ground, and then addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, we too have profound faith and devotion toward the Great Vehicle, and we wish to protect the Great Vehicle. Blessed One, if a son or daughter of good family should uphold this Great Vehicle for the sake of gain and fame, or to instill fear in others, or to deceive others, or for wealth and material goods, or merely to win the affection of others — whether truthfully or untruthfully — at that time, in

order to dispel that person's fears, we offer this secret mantra:

Cyog kye, ta ta la cyog kye, lo ha le, ma hā lo ha le, ala cala tala svāhā.

We offer this secret mantra for those who have lost their minds, for those who are frightened and fearful, for those who teach the Dharma, for those who do not obstruct the authentic Dharma, for taming non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), for protecting our own bodies, for protecting the authentic Dharma, and for protecting the Great Vehicle. Whoever holds this mantra in mind will be freed from the fear of being trampled by a wild ox. Even if one is in a wilderness or forest, or in a deserted and dangerous place, one will have no fear. One will be liberated from the fears of water, fire, lions, tigers, wolves, enemies, and royal punishment. Blessed One, whoever holds this mantra in mind will be freed from all those fears and more. Blessed One, we will protect and shelter whoever holds this mantra just as a turtle conceals its six limbs within its shell. Blessed One, we do not speak these words out of deception or guile — we genuinely bestow our power and might upon whoever holds this dhāraṇī mantra. Blessed One, out of love for us, please accept this, the last of our inner offerings."

Then the Blessed One spoke to Māra the Evil One: "The food offerings you have presented I do not accept. I accept this mantra for the benefit and happiness of all beings and the four assemblies." Having said this, the Blessed One spoke no further and did not grant acceptance of anything else. When this same request had been made three times and still not accepted, Māra the Evil One, finding that things had not gone as he had hoped, was tormented in his mind with grief and withdrew to one side.

At that moment the great lord who governs gods, Śakra (Indra), also arrived together with a retinue of innumerable, immeasurable gods, bearing offerings. The offerings he brought surpassed those of Brahmā, of Śakra himself, of the four protectors of the world, of gods, humans, asuras, the eight classes of non-humans, and all other beings — just as a piece of crystal placed next to charcoal makes everything else invisible by its brilliance, so that all were unseen. Carrying canopies of precious jewels — the smallest of which covered an entire great trichiliocosm along with its offerings and more — they came to where the Buddha was, prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One with their crowns touching the ground, circumambulated him countless times, and then addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, when we present this, the last of our inner offerings, it is as though a bee were offering a gift, or as though a

single handful of water were poured into the great ocean, or as though the light of a single small lamp were held up against a thousand suns, or as though a single flower were picked up in the season when summer blossoms are at their fullest and placed amid a multitude of flowers, or as though a single mustard seed were presented to Mount Meru, the king of mountains — like the ocean, and the sun, and

the multitude of flowers, and Mount Meru — just as a mustard seed is of no benefit to Mount Meru, so too, Blessed One, are these offerings of ours. Even if this entire great trichiliocosm were filled with incense, flowers, music, banners, parasols, and victory standards and presented as an offering, it would not be worth speaking of as adequate recompense. And why is that? Because the Tathāgata, for the sake of the many beings, took on vast suffering in the births of hell-beings, hungry ghosts, and animals. Therefore, Blessed One, please accept these offerings out of your compassionate love for us." Thus they supplicated him.

At that time, in the east, beyond world-realms as innumerable and immeasurable as the grains of sand in countless Ganges rivers, in a buddha-field called Melodious Sound of Pleasing Fragrance, there dwelt the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Equal to Space — one endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, a tamer and guide of persons, a teacher of gods and humans, a blessed buddha. At that moment that buddha spoke these words to his great personal attendant: "Noble son, go now from here to the western world-realm called Endurance, where the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Śākyamuni — one endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, a tamer and guide of persons, a teacher of gods and humans, a blessed buddha — will not long from now pass into complete nirvāṇa. Noble son, take this food from this world-realm, this fragrant food of supremely sweet scent that is pleasing and a source of happiness, and offer it to that Blessed One. Having been fed that offering, that Blessed One will pass into complete nirvāṇa. Noble son, go, prostrate to him, and the time has also come to ask whatever questions still give you doubt."

Then the great bodhisattva named Immeasurable Body rose from his seat, bowed his head to the feet of the buddha, circumambulated him three times, and together with innumerable and immeasurable bodhisattvas, set out from that buddha-field and arrived in the world-realm of Endurance. At that moment, the great trichiliocosm trembled in six ways. Within the assembly,

Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), the protectors of the four directions, the māra of evil deeds, the great lords of power, and others, upon seeing the earth tremble, were struck with such terror that their skin stood on end and their tongues nearly dried up in fright. They scattered in all directions, and even the radiance and splendor of their bodies became invisible.

Then Mañjuśrī, appearing as a youth, rose from his seat and said these words to those gathered in the assembly: "Noble sons, do not be afraid. Have no fear. And why is that? To the east, beyond world-realms as innumerable and immeasurable as the grains of sand in countless Ganges rivers, in a world-realm called Melodious Sound of Pleasing Fragrance, there dwells the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Equal to Space, one endowed with the thirty-two major marks. There, the bodhisattva named Immeasurable Body, together with a retinue of innumerable bodhisattvas, is coming to this world-realm to make offerings to the Tathāgata. It is the splendor and blessing of that bodhisattva that has caused even the radiance of your own bodies to become invisible. Therefore, have no fear — give rise to great joy!"

At that moment, all the assembled retinues, from a great distance, beheld that buddha together with his vast entourage — and the seeing was just as one sees one's own reflection in a clear, bright mirror. Then Mañjuśrī again spoke these words to the many assembled retinues: "Just as you behold this buddha, so too, through the blessing of the Tathāgata, you may likewise behold immeasurable buddhas, as numerous as could be counted, dwelling in the ten directions."

At that moment, the many assembled retinues said to one another in alarm: "Gone! Gone! The world is empty! The world is empty! The Tathāgata will before long pass completely into nirvāṇa!"

At that moment, all the many assembled retinues beheld the bodhisattva Immeasurable Body together with his retinue, and the sight was this: from each and every pore of that bodhisattva's body there issued forth a great lotus flower, and upon each of those lotuses there were as many as seventy-eight thousand cities. Each of those cities was equal in breadth and extent to Vaiśālī, adorned with walls and moats fashioned of the seven precious substances, and lined with seven rows of precious jewel palā trees. All the people dwelling therein enjoyed supreme happiness and wellbeing. The raised platforms of those cities were made of Jambū River gold, and between each raised platform

stood trees of the seven precious kinds in manifold varieties, laden abundantly with flowers and fruit. When a gentle breeze moved through them, the sound that arose was exceedingly beautiful — like what is called divine music — and whoever among the people dwelling there heard it experienced a supreme and exquisite happiness. The moats were filled entirely with pure, fragrant water resembling vaiḍūrya, and upon those waters were boats fashioned of the seven precious substances. People sported and bathed upon those boats, rejoicing with one another and experiencing great delight. And there, too, lotuses of every hue bloomed in those waters — blue utpala lotuses, white kumuda lotuses, pink padma lotuses, and pure white puṇḍarīka lotuses — each as wide as a chariot wheel.

On either side of the moats there were many pleasure groves, and within each pleasure grove there were five ponds fed by springs. Within those ponds, too, there bloomed outstanding blossoms of utpala, kumuda, padma, and puṇḍarīka, of great size equal to a chariot wheel, with a fragrance supremely sweet and utterly pleasing, the waters brilliantly clear and gentle, with geese, ducks, and other birds swimming and at play.

Within those pleasure groves there were also palatial jeweled halls, each four leagues in breadth and extent. The walls of those palatial halls were made of four precious substances — gold, silver, vaiḍūrya, and crystal — and their latticed screens were likewise made of gold. The floors were laid with coral and spread with golden sand. Before those palatial halls there were cascading waterfalls, springs, and ponds fashioned of the seven precious substances, and each pond had a staircase of eighty-four steps of gold. The banks of those waters were made of Jambū River gold, and they were equal to the Park of Joy called Sudharmā in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.

Within each of those cities there were as many as eighty-four thousand kings, and each of those kings had a queen and an inconceivable number of palace retinues. Together with them, they sported and rejoiced.

All the people dwelling there sported and rejoiced, each in their own abode. And the sentient beings dwelling there heard no other sound in their ears but the sole sound of the unsurpassed Great Vehicle.

Within each of those flowers there was a lion throne. The four legs of each throne were fashioned of deep blue lapis lazuli, and upon them were spread utterly soft white garments that transcend the three realms. Upon each of those thrones sat a king, taming sentient beings through the Dharma of the

Great Vehicle. Among those sentient beings, some would copy out sūtras of the Great Vehicle into volumes, carry them, hold them, read them, recite them, diligently practice in accordance with what had been taught, and bring their understanding to full comprehensiveness.

At that time, the bodhisattva Immeasurable Body, in whose own body he had arrayed an immeasurable number of sentient beings, had those beings forsake their worldly pleasures, and together they all cried out, "Alas, alas! The world is empty! The Tathāgata will before long pass fully into nirvāṇa!"

At that time, the bodhisattva Immeasurable Body, surrounded by an immeasurable retinue of bodhisattvas, having displayed such miraculous powers, took up immeasurable and manifold offerings together with fragrant food — for whoever was touched by the fragrance of that food would have all the stains of affliction utterly pacified — and by the blessing of that bodhisattva, every being in the entire assembly witnessed those miraculous displays.

The bodhisattva Immeasurable Body was of a vast and immeasurable form: being equal to space itself, no one other than the Buddha, the Blessed One, was able to perceive the limits of that bodhisattva's body.

Then the bodhisattva Immeasurable Body, together with his retinue, having prepared offerings even more abundant than before, went to where the Buddha was, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and with palms pressed together in reverence, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, out of compassion for us, please accept these offerings." The Tathāgata, knowing the proper time, said nothing and gave no indication of acceptance, and so the bodhisattva Immeasurable Body with his retinue withdrew to one side.

It should be understood in the same way that from all the buddha-fields of the southern, western, and northern directions, an immeasurable number of bodhisattvas named Immeasurable Body likewise arrived, each having prepared offerings even more abundant than before, went to where the Buddha was, and then withdrew to one side.

At that time, in that auspicious and merit-filled place between the two śāla trees, not even the tiniest space remained in a radius of thirty-two leagues in all directions, so completely was it filled by the assembled retinues. The bodhisattvas with their retinues who had gathered from the four directions occupied a space no greater than the tip of a blade of grass, the tip of a

needle, or a single fine particle of dust. Every bodhisattva from buddha-fields as numerous as the finest atoms in the world-realms of the ten directions had assembled there, and every member of the retinue dwelling in Jambudvīpa had assembled as well — with only two exceptions: Mahākāśyapa and Ānanda. King Ajātaśatru with his retinue, a serpent so venomous that a mere glance from it could kill, bubbles, poison, and those engaged in the sixteen classes of utterly wicked and sinful actions — these alone were absent; all others had assembled.

The rākṣasas, the dānavas,

the asuras (demigods), and all the rest had cast aside their malicious intentions and had arisen in each other's minds feelings of love and tenderness, as though for a father, a mother, or a sibling. Every sentient being dwelling in the great trichiliocosm (the vast three-thousandfold world-system) had likewise given rise to a mind of loving-kindness for one another — all save one: those given over to wrong desire. At that time, by the blessing of the buddha, every part of the ground throughout the great trichiliocosm became smooth and level. Ravines, sand, gravel, stones, thorned trees, and poisonous grasses were gone, and the whole was adorned with a great wealth and variety of precious jewels, becoming like the realm of Sukhāvatī, the world-realm of Amitāyus, the buddha of the western direction. At that time, all the many assembled maṇḍalas of the retinue could see the world-realms of the ten directions, as numerous as the finest atoms, with perfect clarity — just as one sees the reflection of one's own face in a bright mirror.

Then from the mouth of the Tathāgata there issued five rays of light. They illuminated all the many maṇḍalas of the retinue, and overpowering and subduing the radiance of those assemblies' own bodily light, the rays re-entered through the Tathāgata's mouth. At that time, the gods, humans, asuras, and all others in the retinue witnessed those rays of the buddha's radiance re-entering through his mouth, and all were struck with fear, their entire bodies' hair standing on end. They said to one another: "The Tathāgata has emitted rays of light and drawn them back in — this is not without cause, not without condition. Having performed all his deeds in the ten directions, this is surely the sign that he will finally pass into complete nirvāṇa."

"Alas, alas! The Tathāgata, with the four immeasurable states of mind, has not accepted the offerings of the gods and humans. From this day forward, the sun of primordial wisdom shall set, and the supreme vessel of Dharma shall sink.

Alas, how wretched! The world is afflicted with great suffering!" Having spoken thus, they beat their chests with their fists. Crying aloud in lamentation, their bodies trembling unbearably, blood began to seep from their pores.

At that time, there was assembled in that retinue a layman named Cunda, a carpenter from the city of Pāvā, together with his retinue of fifty peers. Desiring that beings of the world might obtain the fruit of virtue, he rose from his customary posture of composure, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, knelt on his right knee, and, turning toward where the Blessed One was, joined his palms and shed tears. Bowing with his head to the feet of the buddha, he addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, together with the Saṅgha of monks, please accept this, our final offering — and do so for the sake of liberating incalculable sentient beings. Blessed One, from this day forward we are without protector, without refuge, without ally, without support, without dwelling place. In our utter destitution, we offer the Tathāgata but a humble meal in the time before the final moment arrives. Blessed One, out of compassion, please accept this, our last offering, and only then proceed to pass into complete nirvāṇa. Blessed One, it is like a person of the warrior class, a brahmin, or even an outcast who, impoverished, travels to another land, takes up farming, tills the soil, levels the field, makes the earth even, clears it of stones, and removes the ridges from the field — but lacking all else, waits only for the rain from above. Blessed One, 'tilling the soil' is an analogy for the seven bodily and verbal actions."

"'Leveling the ground of the field' is an analogy for wisdom. 'There being no stones and no ridges in the field' is an analogy for the afflictions. Blessed One, we too have subdued our craving, we have tilled the field, yet if the ridges of the field are not removed, we can only hope for the nectar-rain of the Tathāgata. We four are the impoverished ones of noble family. We are impoverished and destitute in the precious Dharma of unsurpassed perfect enlightenment. Therefore, out of compassion, please remove the suffering of our poverty and destitution, and please liberate the measureless number of sentient beings utterly tormented by suffering. Our offering is exceedingly humble, yet if it is accepted as the alms-round of the Tathāgata's great retinue, then, Blessed One, we have no protector, no refuge, no ally. Please look upon us with compassion, as one would a creature seized by Rāhu."

Then the Blessed One, the omniscient one, the unsurpassed tamer of persons who must be tamed, declared these words to Cunda:

"Excellent! Excellent! I shall rain down upon your body the unsurpassed Dharma-rain, removing your poverty and destitution, and cause the sprout of Dharma to grow. You now wish to attain, in this very life, the individual perfect knowledge of vitality, radiance, strength, well-being, and unobstructedness. I shall always grant you the individual perfect knowledge of vitality, radiance, strength, well-being, and unobstructedness. Why is this? Cunda, because from the giving of this gift of food, two fruits of equal excellence will be obtained. What are these two? First, after this meal is eaten, unsurpassed perfect awakening is attained; and second, after this meal is eaten, complete nirvāṇa is reached. And by my accepting this, your last inner offering, your perfection of generosity is brought to complete fulfillment."

Then Cunda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, according to what you have said — that the two fruits of giving a gift are of equal excellence — this is not so. Why? Because the former gift that was received was given when the afflictions had not yet been exhausted and the wisdom of omniscience was not yet complete, and it did not bring the sentient being's perfection of generosity to fulfillment. The gift received afterward, given after the giving, was given when the afflictions were exhausted, the wisdom of omniscience was fully complete, and it does bring the sentient being's perfection of generosity to fulfillment. The former gift was received by a sentient being. The latter gift is received by the God of gods. The former gift was received by a body mixed with food, a body accompanied by afflictions, a body subject to hunger, an impermanent body. The latter gift is received by a body free from afflictions, a vajra-like body, a dharmakāya, a permanent body, a body without limit. How then can you say the fruits of these two gifts are of equal excellence? The former gift received was one whereby the perfection of generosity through to the Perfection of Wisdom were not yet brought to complete fulfillment — whereby only the eye of flesh was obtained and not the eye of a buddha, through to the eye of wisdom, which had not yet been obtained. The latter gift received was one whereby the perfection of generosity through to the Perfection of Wisdom are fully complete, and one is endowed with the eye of a buddha, through to —"

the eye of wisdom — how then can you say the fruits of these two gifts are of equal excellence?"

The Blessed One replied: "The former gift received was one where, immediately upon receiving it, a request was made on the spot, and through that very request the recipient obtained long life, good complexion, strength,

happiness, and discernment.

The latter gift received was one where no request was made, no asking at all, and the five fruits did not arise — so why do I say the fruits of these two gifts are of equal excellence?

Noble son, a Tathāgata, through immeasurable, endless, and countless aeons, is not a body that requires food, not a body joined to afflictions, not a body that is the last of a conventional series — he is a permanent body, a dharmakāya, a vajra body.

Noble son, one who has not seen the nature of a buddha has an afflicted body, a body that requires food, a body that is the last of a conventional series.

At that time, the bodhisattva received almsfood, entered meditative absorption in the vajra-like samādhi, and right upon receiving that alms-round offering, beheld the nature of a buddha and fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore I say the fruits of these two gifts are of equal excellence.

When the bodhisattva first arose, he vanquished the four māras, and likewise as I approach passing into nirvāṇa I have vanquished the four māras — therefore I say the fruits of these two gifts are of equal excellence.

At the time of that bodhisattva, the twelve branches of scripture had not yet been taught at length; yet all of them had already been understood in his mind. Now, as I approach passing into nirvāṇa, I open them out and teach them extensively to sentient beings — therefore the two gifts are of equal excellence.

Noble son, the body of the Tathāgata does not receive almsfood for immeasurable and countless aeons — yet I have spoken these words to the hearers: 'Long ago, the Tathāgata received the milk-porridge offered by the cowherd women Nandā and Nandapālā, and having received it, fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Now he does not receive solid food again. For the sake of this great assembly gathered here, he has accepted this, your final offering — yet in the ultimate sense there is no reception at all.'

At that time, when the members of that great assembly saw the Blessed One accepting Cunda's offering, all rejoiced and delighted, and with one voice said to Cunda: 'Excellent! Most excellent! Your name has fallen aptly upon you. The name Cunda means one who is skilled in the ultimate, and today you have

undertaken a great purpose — therefore from that purpose the name Cunda has been given. In this very life you have obtained great renown and great benefit, and your aspirations have been entirely fulfilled. How wonderful! Cunda, though born among humans, you have obtained the supreme happiness that is so very difficult to find. Excellent!

Cunda, like the udumbara flower that is exceedingly rare in the world, a buddha's appearance in the world is likewise exceedingly rare. Even to encounter a buddha and give rise to faith is exceedingly difficult. To hear the Dharma is exceedingly difficult. To prepare offerings and present them to a buddha at the time of his passing into final nirvāṇa is exceedingly difficult.

We pay homage to Cunda! We pay homage to Cunda! You have fully completed the perfection of generosity — full and utterly pure like the moon of the fifteenth day of the autumn month. Just as when the moon is veiled by clouds or haze all people yearn to gaze upon it, so do we and all others gaze upon you with that very longing. By the Blessed One's acceptance of your final offering, your perfection of generosity has been brought to complete fulfillment. Cunda, we pay homage to you!"

Therefore you are like the full moon in all its completion, and there is no sentient being who does not gaze upon you. We pay homage to you, Cunda! Though you have obtained a human body, your mind is like the mind of a buddha — Cunda, you are truly a son of a buddha, no different from Rāhu (the eclipse-demon who seizes the moon).

Then those in the assembly spoke these verses:

You were born among human beings,
yet you stand supremely higher than the six classes of gods.
All of us, your entire retinue,
bow to you and offer our prayers.

The Blessed One, the noblest hero among men,
has declared that he will pass into final nirvāṇa.
For the sake of your compassion toward us,
please petition the Blessed One to remain.

Please remain long in this world
and, for the benefit of an immeasurable retinue,
teach the unsurpassable, supreme Dharma
that is praised by the wise.

If you do not make this petition,
we, these human beings, cannot go on living.
Therefore, please, we beseech you —
petition the Teacher who turns the wheel.

At that moment Cunda was filled with great joy and delight toward the Teacher who turns the wheel. Just as a person whose father and mother have died is suddenly restored and revived — just so did Cunda become filled with extraordinary joy. He touched his head to the feet of the Blessed One and spoke these verses:

Excellent — may there be happiness and well-being!
A human body has been well obtained.
Attachment, aversion, and delusion have been cleared away.
The three lower destinies have been utterly abandoned.

Excellent — there is happiness and well-being!
I have beheld a mountain of precious gold
and met the Teacher who turns the wheel.
I have no fear of being born in the animal realm.

A buddha is as rare as the udumbara flower (uḍumbara),
and an encounter is exceedingly difficult to come by.
Yet through this encounter, roots of virtue have been planted,
and the sufferings of the hungry ghosts have been completely vanquished.

Other things, too, that are completely vanquished
are all the ranks of the asuras.
More difficult than a needle-tip catching a mustard seed
is the arising of a buddha — so rare is it.

I have completed the perfection of generosity.
I am freed from the continuum of gods and humans.
Untainted by the conditions of the world,
like a lotus unsullied by water —
having thoroughly abandoned existence to its limit,
I am fully liberated from the stream of saṃsāra.

Obtaining a human body is exceedingly difficult.
Encountering the arising of a buddha is difficult.
Just as within a great ocean
a blind sea-turtle might arise

and chance to put its head through a hole in a wooden yoke —
so difficult is the arising of a buddha.

By this offering that I have presented,
may I attain the unsurpassable fruit.
All the afflictions without exception,
being without substance, have been wholly vanquished.

As for myself here and now,
I have no longing for the bodies of gods or humans.
And even if I were to obtain such a birth,
I would have no delight or desire in it.

Blessed One, through your acceptance of my offering,
my joy is beyond measure.
Just as from the eraṇḍa flower
the fragrance of fine sandalwood arises,
so am I one like the eraṇḍa —
through the Blessed One's acceptance of my offering,
like the sweet fragrance of fine sandalwood,
for that reason I am filled with extraordinary joy.

I have directly obtained the fruit.
I have reached the supreme unsurpassable state.
Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), and the gods
have all come and make offerings to me.

All the world together
has given rise to great suffering and grief,
understanding that the Blessed One who dwells among them —
the buddha, the Bhagavān — is about to pass into final nirvāṇa.

With one voice, all together in great proclamation:
"There is no ruler of the world any longer!"

Please do not abandon all sentient beings;
look upon them as your own children.
Blessed One, teach the unsurpassable Dharma
to the Saṅgha and your retinue.

Just as in the midst of a great ocean
a mountain of jewels and a Mount Meru shines —

so too, Blessed One, cut through what is not known,
dispel the darkness of ignorance.

Just as clouds parting in the open sky
bring cool relief throughout the expanse —
so too, Blessed One, may you utterly remove

all afflictions utterly removed —
just as the sun rising in the sky
shines everywhere without a cloud.

Yet now these sentient beings
weep so deeply that their eyes are swollen.
The roaring torrent of saṃsāric suffering
has swept all who wander in cyclic existence into distraction.

Therefore, buddha, Blessed One —
to awaken faith in beings
and to sever the suffering of cyclic existence —
we implore you: remain in the world for a long time.

The Blessed One then spoke to Cunda:

So it is, so it is. Just as you have said. A buddha, a Blessed One, appearing in the world is extraordinarily rare — like the udumbara flower. That faith should arise upon meeting a buddha is even rarer still. To offer worship to a Tathāgata on the very eve of his passing into final nirvāṇa, and thereby to perfect the perfection of generosity (dāna-pāramitā) — this is rarer still. Cunda, do not grieve; be joyful instead. The Tathāgata has accepted this final material offering, and by it the perfection of generosity is perfectly fulfilled. That is enough — do not petition the Blessed One to remain long in the world. You must know that all the domains of activity of the buddhas are impermanent, and that the defining characteristic of all conditioning factors is just such a nature. Know this to be so.

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to Cunda:

All that inhabits the world —
whatever is born must die.
Even a sage whose years are beyond counting
must in the end come to exhaustion.

Where there is flourishing, there is decline;
where there is meeting, there is parting.
Youth too is impermanent —
even the bloom of prime is seized away by illness.
Life too is seized away by death.
There is nothing at all that is permanent.

Even mighty kings who reign supreme,
whose gifts and power are unmatched —
all of them undergo change and transformation,
and life's vital breath is no different.

The wheel of suffering has no end;
the stream of wandering in cyclic existence never ceases.
Nothing in all three realms is permanent.
Nothing in all of conditioned existence is happiness.

The things that constitute conditioned existence —
all of them are empty, without substance,
subject to destruction, undergoing change and transformation,
ever attended by misery and fault,
full of faults and subject to ruin,
perpetually afflicted by old age, sickness, and death.
The phenomena of conditioned existence are boundless,
accompanied by the enemy of change and transformation.
Afflictions permeate them utterly —
like a silkworm in its cocoon.
What wise and discerning person
would find delight or attachment in that?

This body is a heap of suffering,
altogether impure and defiled,
bound by faults and riddled with wounds —
never, from the beginning, a source of benefit.
From the body of a god above
down to the body of a human here below —
all of it is just the same.
Therefore, since all objects of desire are impermanent,
I have no attachment to them.

If one resolves well to abandon desire,
one will come to know the true nature of reality.
To sever all conditioned existence completely —
today, now, I pass utterly into nirvāṇa.
I have crossed to the other shore of conditioned existence,
gone utterly beyond all suffering.
Therefore what I attain this day
is unsurpassable bliss, and nothing else.

By reason of its causes and conditions,
one arrives at the limit that is free of conceptual elaboration.
Having severed all bondage entirely,
today, now, I pass utterly into nirvāṇa.

For me there is no old age, no illness, no death.
The measure of this life is inexhaustible.
This passing into nirvāṇa today
is like the dying down of a great fire.

Cunda, do not be confused about this.
Contemplate the qualities of the Tathāgata,
and this buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha)
as immovable as Mount Meru.
I enter nirvāṇa
and will experience supreme bliss.
This is the very nature of all buddhas.
Therefore do not weep.

Then Cunda addressed the Blessed One in these words:

So it is, so it is. Just as the Blessed One has declared —

My wisdom, which I seek to employ, is exceedingly small — like a tiny bee —
and so how could I possibly comprehend the profound meaning of the
Tathāgata's passing utterly into nirvāṇa? Blessed One, I have now become
equal to the great bodhisattvas — the great beings who, like a great river,
have utterly crossed beyond all afflictions and defilements — such as Mañjuśrī
in his youth and the rest. Blessed One, just as a newly ordained novice who
has not yet received full ordination is nevertheless counted among the
Saṅgha, so too have I, through the blessing of the buddhas and the
bodhisattvas, come to be counted among those great bodhisattvas. Therefore
I beseech the Tathāgata to remain in the world for a long time and not to pass

into nirvāṇa. Blessed One, just as one who is not hungry has no need to eat again, so too, being like that, I beseech you to remain in the world for a long time without passing into nirvāṇa.

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful spoke to Cunda in these words:

Cunda, you ask that the Tathāgata remain in the world for a long time and not pass utterly into nirvāṇa, saying that just as someone who is not at all hungry would find it repulsive to eat again. Rather than speaking in such a way, you should thoroughly comprehend the defining marks of formations. If formations are examined in that way, one will come to abide in the meditative absorption of emptiness. Those who desire the true Dharma should train in precisely this manner.

Cunda then spoke to Mañjuśrī:

The Tathāgata is the supreme one among gods and humans. Since he is supremely excellent, surely the Tathāgata is not a formation? If he were a formation, he would be subject to arising and ceasing — like a water bubble on water, arising immediately and immediately disintegrating. Revolving in saṃsāra is like the wheel of a cart, and all formations are just like that. Now, as I have heard before, the lifespan of the gods is said to be extremely long — so why is it that the Blessed One, the god above gods, has so short a lifespan that he does not remain even a hundred years? Consider, for instance, the chief of a village who has come to power: through his authority and might he subdues his opponents, but when at last his merit is exhausted and he falls into poverty, everyone despises him, tramples on him, and puts him to work. Why so? Because his splendor and power have diminished. If that were so, then the Blessed One would also be like formations. But if he were like formations, it would not be fitting to call him the god above gods. Why? Because formations are subject to birth and death. Therefore, Mañjuśrī, I do not regard the Tathāgata as being like formations. Does Mañjuśrī speak with knowledge, or is it that without knowing he says the Tathāgata is like formations? If the Tathāgata were indeed like formations, then the Tathāgata — who is the god above gods in the three worlds, the sovereign king of the Dharma — could not properly be so designated. Consider, for example, a king who has a great champion wrestler capable of defeating a thousand opponents, one whom no one can overcome — that man is called the wrestler who cannot be defeated. The king honors that wrestler, and others bestow gifts upon him more abundantly than anyone else. Now, when it is said that

this wrestler cannot be defeated, it does not mean that he is undefeatable by physical strength alone; rather, because he surpasses thousands of opponents through many diverse skills, he is given the designation "the wrestler who cannot be defeated." The Tathāgata is just like that. The māra of afflictions and —

the māra of the aggregates, the māra of the divine son, and the māra of the lord of death — having utterly vanquished all of these, the Tathāgata is declared supreme within the three realms. It is just as with that one wrestler who is capable of defeating a thousand opponents. Therefore, because the Tathāgata likewise possesses immeasurable and manifold qualities, the Tathāgata is designated "the perfectly and completely awakened buddha."

Mañjuśrī, it is not appropriate to conceive of the Tathāgata as being in conformity with formations through conceptual thought. Consider this example: a wealthy householder's son is born, and a fortune-teller examines him and determines, "He will be short-lived." The moment the parents hear this, knowing that the child will not be a source of honor for the family line, they do not cherish him; they regard him as worth no more than a blade of grass. For as long as that short-lived child lives, neither renunciants nor brahmins, nor any boys or girls of any age, treat him with respect.

Now, if the Tathāgata were in conformity with formations, then all the gods, humans, and sentient beings that dwell throughout the world would likewise treat him with no respect, and the true Dharma that the Tathāgata has taught — which is unchanging and unshifting — would come to have no one to uphold it. Therefore, Mañjuśrī, it is not appropriate to say that the Tathāgata conforms to formations.

Mañjuśrī, consider this further example: a destitute woman with no home, no support, and no refuge, afflicted by illness and tormented by hunger and thirst, wanders until she enters someone's house and gives birth there. The householder does not let her stay but drives her away. Though she has only just given birth, she takes her infant in her arms and sets out for another land. Along the way she is tormented by wind, rain, and hail; she encounters gnats, mosquitoes, and venomous serpents; and when the Ganges river blocks her path, though that river is exceedingly deep and swift, she clutches her infant to her breast and plunges in. Both mother and child then sink beneath the waters.

By the merit of the love and affection she bore toward her child, she was reborn, the very instant of her death, as a god in the Brahmā heaven.

Mañjuśrī, sons of good family, for the sake of protecting the sacred Dharma, one should not say of the Tathāgata either that he conforms to formations or that he does not conform to formations. I myself am obscured by delusion, lacking the eye of wisdom, and cannot fathom the sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata, which is inconceivable. Therefore one should not say definitively that the Tathāgata is conditioned or that he is unconditioned. Nor should one, through right view, say definitively that the Tathāgata is unconditioned. Why? Because he gives rise to qualities that make all sentient beings virtuous, and because of his compassion for the many beings throughout all destinies.

Just as that destitute woman, when crossing the Ganges, thought lovingly of her child and gave up both body and life, so too, sons of good family, a bodhisattva who is a protector of the Dharma should, even at the cost of body and life, never say of the Tathāgata that he conforms to the conditioned, nor that he conforms to the unconditioned.

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Thus, by declaring that the Tathāgata conforms to the unconditioned, one comes to attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — just as that destitute woman was reborn as a god in the Brahmā heaven. Why? Because of protecting the Dharma. And what is protecting the Dharma? It is declaring, "The Tathāgata is unconditioned."

Sons of good family, that person does not hope for liberation — rather, liberation comes to them on its own. Just as that destitute woman did not hope to be reborn in the Brahmā heaven,

yet she was born as a god in the Brahmā heaven. Mañjuśrī, consider this further example: a person who had gone a long way as a traveler on a road grew weary along the way and lay down to rest in another person's house. That house then caught fire and blazed up. Seized with terror and fright, the person thought, "I will surely die." Yet because he possessed a sense of shame and modesty, he wrapped his body in his clothing. At the moment of his death, he was reborn as a god in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. After that, he was born eighty times as a king in the realm of Great Brahmā. Then, for a full thousand years, he was born among humans as a wheel-turning king. That person was never born in any of the three lower destinies; instead, from one life to the next, he was born in ever higher and more blissful states. Therefore,

Mañjuśrī, those sons of good family who possess shame and modesty will not look upon the Buddha, the Blessed One, as conforming to the conditioned. Mañjuśrī, it is the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) with their mistaken views who say that the Tathāgata conforms to the conditioned. The monks who guard their ethical conduct will not regard the Tathāgata in that way — as something conditioned. If one were to say, "The Tathāgata is conditioned," that would be speaking falsely. Know that such a person will be reborn in the hells immediately upon dying — just as a person who remains inside a burning house. Mañjuśrī, since the Tathāgata is truly possessed of the nature of the unconditioned, one must not speak of him as conditioned.

Mañjuśrī, from this day forward, as you wander in saṃsāra, abandon wandering there in ignorance and seek true primordial wisdom. The Tathāgata is unconditioned. Whoever sees the Tathāgata in exactly this way will swiftly attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, endowed with the thirty-two major marks.

Then Mañjuśrī, the Crown Prince, said to Cunda: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, you have now manifestly brought about the cause of a very long life. To regard the Tathāgata as one possessed of the nature of permanence, as one whose nature is unchanging and unshifting, as one whose nature is unconditioned — that is excellent. It is excellent that you did not describe the Tathāgata as bearing the defining marks of something conditioned. Just as that person who was scorched by fire, possessing shame and modesty and having wrapped his body in his clothing — through the virtue of that intention he was born as a god in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, became a king in the realm of Brahmā and a wheel-turning king, and was always born in pleasant states and never in the lower destinies — in the very same way, because you did not describe the Tathāgata as bearing the defining marks of something conditioned, in the future without any doubt you will certainly attain the thirty-two major marks, the eighty minor marks of excellence, the eighteen unshared qualities, boundless life, non-abiding in saṃsāra, supreme bliss, and before long you will attain perfect and complete awakening. This will be explained in detail by the Tathāgata himself. Let the two of us, then, refrain from describing the Tathāgata as bearing the defining marks of something conditioned."

"Now, let us set aside this matter of the conditioned and the unconditioned for the moment, and quickly offer whatever alms food is available. This act of giving will be foremost among all acts of giving. To the monks, nuns, laymen,

and laywomen who have come a long way and are weary, with a pure and wholehearted mind, quickly offer whatever they wish. This will become the seed for the complete perfection of your perfection of generosity (pāramitā). Cunda, whoever at the final moment of their life makes an offering — however much they are able — to the Buddha and the Saṅgha,

whether little or much, whether sufficient or insufficient — make offerings to the Tathāgata at the very moment of his passing into nirvāṇa."

Then Cunda spoke to Mañjuśrī: "Why do you say, with such attachment to alms, that one should offer much or little, sufficient or insufficient, in due season?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Cunda, if the Tathāgata endured austerities for six full years, why would he be impeded for even a single instant now? Cunda, do you think that the Tathāgata, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, will actually accept this alms food? Know this: the body of the Tathāgata is assuredly the dharmakāya — it is not a body sustained by food."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to Mañjuśrī: "It is so, it is exactly so — just as Cunda has said. Cunda, excellent indeed! You are endowed with supreme and great primordial wisdom, and you have understood well the profoundly deep sūtras of the Great Vehicle."

Mañjuśrī then said to Cunda: "You have understood the Tathāgata as unconditioned. Since the lifespan of the Tathāgata's body is immeasurably long, if you understand it in precisely this way, the Tathāgata will rejoice in you."

Cunda replied: "It is not only in me that he rejoices — he rejoices in all sentient beings."

Mañjuśrī said: "The Tathāgata rejoices in you, in me, and in all sentient beings alike."

Cunda said: "Mañjuśrī, do not say that the Tathāgata rejoices. The word 'rejoicing' implies a perverse perception. Whatever involves a perverse perception is saṃsāra. Whatever is saṃsāra belongs to the conditioned. Therefore, Mañjuśrī, one should not regard the Tathāgata as conditioned. If one were to say that the Tathāgata is conditioned, then both you and I, my friend, would be acting in error. Mañjuśrī, the Tathāgata has no intention of attachment. To intend with attachment is like a cow that, even while hungry or thirsty and searching for grass and water, immediately turns back to look for

her calf, whether she has had enough or not. The Blessed One, the buddha, has no such intention — he regards all beings as though they were beings seized by Rāhu. Such an intention as that is the domain of the wisdom of the buddhas.

"Mañjuśrī, consider this example: to hope that a donkey-drawn cart can match a chariot drawn by the finest horses of a great king is entirely without foundation. Similarly, both you and I, my friend, are just like that — to hope to fathom the limits of the Tathāgata's profound intention is equally without foundation.

"Mañjuśrī, consider this further example: a lord among garuḍas soars countless leagues up into the sky above, and then looks down upon the ocean below. All the beings that dwell in the water — fish, turtles, crabs, sea monsters, nāgas, and every other kind of creature that inhabits the water — he sees clearly, just as a reflection appears in a bright mirror. This cannot be measured by those of small understanding. In the very same way that these beings cannot be perceived by those who have not soared aloft, so too both you and I, my friend, are like that — the wisdom of the Tathāgata cannot be fathomed."

Mañjuśrī then said to Cunda: "It is so, it is exactly so — just as you have said. It is not that I myself have not understood these points, but rather I have been teaching them for the sake of you and the bodhisattvas."

At that moment the Blessed One released from his mouth rays of light in many colors, and those rays illuminated the entire body of Mañjuśrī. The instant that light touched Mañjuśrī, he understood the nature of things exactly as they are, and he said this to Cunda: "The Tathāgata has shown this sign — it is certain that before long he will pass fully into nirvāṇa. The time has come for you to offer to the Blessed One and the great Saṅgha the final meal of offerings you have prepared within your home. Cunda, you must understand that the Tathāgata's sending forth these rays of light in many colors is not without cause and condition."

When Cunda heard these words, he sat in silence.

The Blessed One then declared to Cunda: "The time has come for you to present the offerings you have prepared to the buddhas and the Saṅgha. The Tathāgata will pass into nirvāṇa." He declared this in the same manner two and three times.

At that moment, the instant Cunda heard the Blessed One speak these words, he let out a great cry of weeping and lamented aloud: "Alas, alas — the world is empty!" And he called out to those gathered in the assembly: "Let us all prostrate with the five limbs of our bodies to the ground, and together in one voice beseech the Blessed One not to pass into nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One declared to Cunda: "Do not weep, and do not let your heart be utterly consumed with anguish. Regard this body of mine as like a plantain tree, or a mirage, or a water bubble, or an illusion, or a city of gandharvas (fragrance-eaters, beings who feed on scent), or unfired clay, or a flash of lightning, or a line drawn on water, or a prisoner being led to execution, or a ripened fruit, or rotting flesh, or a thread whose fibers are exhausted, or like a wooden pestle. Regard the formations (saṃskāras) as food mixed with poison. Regard all conditioned phenomena as having the fault of many flaws."

Then Cunda said to the Blessed One: "If the Tathāgata has no wish to remain long in the world, how could I not weep? Alas, alas — the world is empty! Blessed One, out of compassion for us and for all sentient beings, we beseech you to remain long in the world and not pass into nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One declared to Cunda: "Do not say that I should remain long in the world out of compassion for you — it is out of compassion for you and for all beings that I am passing fully into nirvāṇa. Why is that? This too is the nature of reality (dharmatā) of all buddhas, and conditioned things are the same."

The Blessed One then spoke this verse:

All phenomena that are conditioned
are by their very nature impermanent.
Having arisen, they do not remain —
therefore perfect pacification is bliss.

"Cunda, you must understand that all conditioned things are mixed together, that all phenomena are without self, that they are impermanent and do not endure long. This body is extremely full of faults — regard it as like a water bubble — and therefore do not weep."

Then Cunda said to the Blessed One: "It is so, it is exactly so — just as the Blessed One has said. I understand that the Tathāgata's passing into nirvāṇa is a display of skillful means, yet even though I do not grieve, I cannot bear it. And yet, when I reflect on it deeply, joy and delight also arise."

The Blessed One declared to Cunda: "Excellent, most excellent! It is good that you understand that the Tathāgata has shown his passing into nirvāṇa in a manner suited to sentient beings. Cunda, listen well."

It is like this: just as the bird called the sanderling gathers at a lake called the Cool Lake during the heat of summer, so too the Blessed One is like that, and has gone to that very place. Cunda, without speculating as to whether the Tathāgata's lifespan is long or short, know that all phenomena are like illusions, and that the Tathāgata, through skillful means, does not cling to anything whatsoever. Why is this? Because such is the nature of reality of a buddha.

Cunda, the fact that the Tathāgata has accepted this last meal offering you have arranged is in order to liberate you from the river of saṃsāra. As for any being — whether a god, a human, or any other being in the world — who arranges a last meal offering and presents it to me, that being will attain the fruit of immovability and will perpetually experience happiness. Why is this? Because I am the field of merit for all sentient beings. If you also wish to become a field of merit for sentient beings, then without delay, quickly present the meal offering you have prepared.

Then Cunda, with the aspiration to liberate all sentient beings, bowed his head and spoke to the Blessed One with tears streaming down his face, saying: "Most excellent! Blessed One, if I am truly to become a field of merit, let me speak. We who are śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot fathom whether the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa or does not pass into nirvāṇa, since our wisdom is like that of a gnat in comparison to his. Therefore we cannot reckon whether the Tathāgata passes into complete nirvāṇa or does not."

Then Cunda together with his retinue, weeping with tears streaming down their faces, circumambulated the Tathāgata, scattered incense and flowers, made offerings, and then rose from their seats alongside Mañjuśrī and went to prepare the meal offering.

The very moment they had gone, the earth shook in six ways, all the way up to the Brahmā world. There are two kinds of earth-shaking: ordinary trembling and great trembling. A slight motion is called an ordinary trembling; a great motion is called a great trembling. A quiet sound is called an ordinary trembling; a loud sound is called a great trembling. When only the earth moves, it is called an ordinary trembling; when mountains, waters, trees, oceans, and everything else move, it is called a great trembling. When

movement occurs in one direction it is called an ordinary trembling; when there is a revolving motion in all directions it is called a great trembling. When only the ground stirs, it is called an ordinary trembling; when the ground stirs and the minds of all sentient beings are also moved, it is called a great trembling. When the bodhisattva who had dwelt in the highest realm descended from the heavens and came to Jambudvīpa, that was a great trembling. The first birth, the going forth into renunciation, the attainment of unsurpassable complete and perfect awakening, the turning of the wheel of Dharma, and the passing into complete nirvāṇa — each of these is a great trembling. Now the Tathāgata is passing into complete nirvāṇa, and therefore the earth also trembles greatly.

Then gods, nāgas, gandharvas (Skt. gandharva), asuras, garuḍas (Skt. garuḍa), kinnaras (Skt. kinnara), great serpents (Skt. mahoraga), humans and non-humans, and all such beings — the moment they heard this, the hairs on their bodies stood on end. All of them wept in every direction and with one voice chanted these verses:

We prostrate and beseech you, O Helmsman.
Now that the Great Sage has abandoned us,
we are left without refuge or protector.
The Blessed One has gone into nirvāṇa
and we sink into an ocean of suffering.
Despondent and tormented by grief,
we are like calves that have not yet lost their mothers.

The destitute have no protector, no refuge.
Like one who is gravely ill
and lacks a skilled physician,
they crave food to their heart's desire.
Sentient beings are tormented by the sickness of affliction,
constantly harmed by wrong views.
Bereft of the skilled physician of Dharma,
they seek the poison of nihilistic views.
Therefore, O buddha, Blessed One,
we beg you, do not abandon us.
For example, if a king is absent,
all his people go hungry.
We too are in just such a state,
losing both the taste of Dharma and our refuge.

Hearing that the buddha has passed into nirvāṇa,
our minds have grown confused and dazed,
like the great earth violently shaking
and all directions reeling and disrupted.

The sage has gone to nirvāṇa:
the sun of buddhahood has fallen to the ground,
the waters of Dharma have dried up,
and without doubt we shall perish.

When the Blessed One passes into nirvāṇa,
the anguish of suffering that burns sentient beings
is like the child of a merchant
who has just lost both father and mother.
Now that the Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa,
if he no longer remains among us,
then we and all sentient beings
shall be left without protector or refuge.

When the Blessed One passes into nirvāṇa,
even down to those born in animal realms,
all will be downcast with suffering and anguish,
tormented and uttering cries of lamentation.

Here and now we cannot find relief from grief.
That we have been forsaken by the Tathāgata
is like saliva spat upon the ground.
For example, when the sun rises,
its rays blaze forth in every direction,
illuminating everything everywhere,
and all darkness is utterly dispelled.
So too the miraculous light of the Tathāgata
has cleared away our afflictions.
And dwelling in the midst of his retinue,
he was like Mount Meru, king among mountains.

Blessed One, for example, if a king has sons of fine form, handsome and exceedingly beautiful, he loves them deeply and trains them from an early age in all manner of arts, and then, once they have absorbed this training, he entrusts them to an executioner with the command: "Put them to death."

Blessed One, we too have become sons of the Dharma. If the Blessed One were to teach and guide us, we would come to possess right view. We therefore beseech you not to abandon us. If you were to utterly forsake us, would that not be like a king abandoning his sons? We beg you to remain in the world for a long time without passing into nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, for example, a man who has trained thoroughly in the arts may come to be frightened by those very arts. Likewise the Blessed One, having comprehended all phenomena within himself, has come to be overawed by the Dharma itself. If the Tathāgata were to remain long in the world and teach a Dharma like nectar, satisfying all to the full, then there would be no fear that any sentient being would fall into the hells.

Blessed One, for example, a man is seized in the midst of some work he was doing, cast into prison, and someone comes to him and asks: "What are you doing here?" He replies: "I am enduring very great suffering here; if I could be freed from this, I would be utterly happy." Blessed One, you are just like that. You have performed austerities (Skt. *duṣkara*) on our behalf, and if we are not liberated from the afflictions of cyclic existence, how could the Tathāgata be at ease?

Blessed One, for example, a highly skilled physician teaches the secrets of medicine to his own son but does not teach them to other students. Blessed One, you are just like that: the exceedingly profound heart of what you have taught with intent you have revealed to Mañjuśrī alone, and have not revealed it to us. The Tathāgata, like that physician, teaches only his own son and not other students — yet surely the Tathāgata is not one who would be jealous regarding any of the Dharmas.

If that physician withheld his teaching from everyone else out of a mind of partiality and aversion, it would be a different matter — but since the Tathāgata's mind is free of partiality and aversion, why has he not taught us? Blessed One, we beseech you: remain long and do not pass into nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, consider this example: whether old or young, a person afflicted by illness who abandons the good road and takes instead a treacherous path full of ravines and precipices will suffer greatly. If someone else sees this and, moved by compassion, shows that person a safe and level road free of danger, the sufferer is set on the right way.

Blessed One, we are just like that person. In this analogy, "the young one" stands for one who has not yet generated the Dharma body. "The old one"

stands for the great afflictions. "Being ill" stands for not being liberated from cyclic existence. "The path beset with precipices" stands for the twenty-five existences.

Blessed One, please show us the true path of the nectar of deathlessness, and remain in this world for a long time without passing into nirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One declared to the assembly of monks: "You monks, do not weep and wail like foolish ordinary beings or like gods and humans. Instead, apply yourselves diligently to the establishment of mindfulness." At that moment, when the gods, humans, asuras, and the rest heard the Blessed One declare, "Do not weep," it was like someone whose child has just died and who is told immediately upon the child's death, "Do not weep."

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse to that great assembly:

Take heart and be gladdened, each of you,
and do not give way to great grief.

This is the very nature of all buddhas:

therefore he remains in silence, saying nothing more.

Be devoted to heedful conduct,
and guard the mind with true mindfulness.

Thoroughly abandon what is not Dharma,
take heart, and be joyful.

Furthermore, the Blessed One said: "Monks, if any of you have doubts or uncertainties, ask about them all — put your questions now. Whatever doubts you have — about emptiness and non-emptiness, permanence and impermanence, suffering and non-suffering, existence and non-existence, coming and going, arriving and not arriving, continuity and discontinuity, annihilation and permanence, sentient beings and non-sentient beings, being and non-being, truth and untruth, the correct and the incorrect, cessation and non-cessation, the secret and the non-secret, duality and non-duality, and other such matters — whatever doubts have arisen about any of these things, now is the time to ask. Whatever questions you ask, the doubt behind them will be resolved. I have already taught you a Dharma like the nectar of deathlessness, and from the very first this was intended to bring you to the complete passing beyond sorrow. Monks, it is extremely rare for a buddha to come into the world. It is extremely difficult to obtain a human body. It is extremely difficult to meet a buddha and give rise to faith. It is extremely difficult to endure what is hard to endure. And it is extremely difficult to

perfect and maintain one's moral discipline without losing or degrading it, so as to attain the fruit of arhatship — it is as rare as finding the fruit of the udumbara flower or the seed grain of the śāla tree. Monks, you have freed yourselves from the eight states of non-leisure, you have obtained this difficult-to-obtain human body, and having met with me, do not let this opportunity be wasted. In former times I practiced countless and varied hardships, and through them I have now come to be endowed with such supreme skillful means. It was for your sake and for the sake of beings like you that throughout measureless ages I gave away my limbs — my arms, my legs, my head, my eyes, my feet, my marrow. Therefore, do not be heedless. Monks, one who is adorned with the citadel of the precious true Dharma, endowed with various precious qualities, and perfect in moral discipline —"

"— should be thought of as the foundation of meditative absorption and wisdom, and as its embankment and its watch-post. Yet beneath the very shadow of a citadel such as the precious Dharma of a buddha, you are the sort of people who take up what is counterfeit and deceptive. It is as if merchants who have reached an island of true jewels were to take gravel and pebbles and return home with those. You are just like them: having reached an island of jewels, you take up illusory goods. Monks, do not generate a mind of contentment through a spirit of timidity. You have gone forth, yet you do not turn your hearts toward the Great Vehicle. Monks, you wear robes dyed in ochre, yet your minds have not grown attached to the perfectly pure Dharma of the Great Vehicle. Monks, you go about wandering for alms, yet you have not tasted the Dharma-food of the Great Vehicle. Monks, you have shaved your hair and beard, yet you have not made the true Dharma the means of freeing yourselves entirely from affliction. Monks, here and now, in this entire assembly, I reveal and show you these things through genuine speech. The defining marks of the Tathāgata's Dharma are true and unerring. Therefore, with a courageous and resolute mind, strive earnestly to destroy all affliction. If the sun of wisdom endowed with the ten powers were to set, you too would be covered by ignorance. Monks, consider: just as the trees and plants that grow on the great earth and on mountains become useful to sentient beings, so too is my Dharma — it gives rise to the taste of Dharma like a supremely wholesome nectar, and it becomes medicine for the many and varied diseases of the afflictions of sentient beings.

"Here and now I have spoken with care for all sentient beings and for the retinue of four kinds who have become my children, and I settle them in the

heart of what I have spoken with care, and resting myself in that, I pass into complete nirvāṇa. What is called 'the heart of what I have spoken with care'? Consider the letter 'i' — if you place three dots in a vertical column, it does not become the letter 'i'; but if you arrange them in three horizontally, as in the eye of a great sovereign, it becomes the letter 'i,' and it is not the same as the three dots kept separate. I too am like that: the Dharma of liberation does not pass into nirvāṇa; the body of the Tathāgata does not pass into nirvāṇa; the Perfection of Wisdom does not pass into nirvāṇa; nor does nirvāṇa consist in the three Dharmas being separated from one another. Abiding in these three Dharmas, it is for the sake of sentient beings that this is called 'passing into nirvāṇa,' just as in the world the letter 'i' is known as such."

At that moment the monks heard the Blessed One, the Buddha, declare that he would definitively pass into complete nirvāṇa, and they were overcome with grief. The hair of their entire bodies stood on end, and with eyes full of tears they bowed their heads to the feet of the Buddha, circumambulated him countless times, and then addressed the Blessed One in these words:

"Blessed One, you have taught so well: impermanence, suffering, emptiness, and selflessness. Blessed One, just as, among all the tracks of wandering beings, the track of the bull elephant is supreme, so too is the perception of impermanence — it is supreme among all perceptions. Whoever applies diligent and earnest effort to it will cause all the desires of the desire realm, the desires of the form and formless realms, and all the perceptions of ignorance, pride, and impermanence to cease entirely. Blessed One, if the Tathāgata is separated from the perception of impermanence, then it is not fitting that he depart now into complete nirvāṇa."

"But if he is not separated from it, then why did he apply diligent effort to impermanence and become separated from the desires of the three realms, from ignorance, from pride, and from the perception of impermanence?" So it was declared.

"Blessed One, consider, for example, how farmers in the autumn season plow their fields and clear the fields entirely of weeds. The perception of impermanence is just like that: it clears away the desires of the desire realm, the desires of the form and formless realms, ignorance, pride, and the perception of impermanence down to their very roots.

Blessed One, consider further: among all the methods of plowing, the autumn plow is the best. Among all tracks, the track of the bull elephant is supreme.

And among all perceptions, the perception of impermanence is supreme.

Blessed One, consider also: when a great king is at the time of his passing, he first issues a proclamation to all four borders and grants freedom to all prisoners, so that they may spend their remaining time alive in liberty. The Tathāgata likewise has liberated all sentient beings from the ignorance that lacks wisdom and that covers them completely, and has set them free — and yet it is fitting that he pass into nirvāṇa only after doing so. Why, then, would the Tathāgata abandon us before we are liberated and pass into complete nirvāṇa?

Blessed One, consider: a person seized by a hungry ghost (preta), upon meeting an expert spell-caster, is freed from it by the power of the spell. The Tathāgata likewise removes the hungry ghost of ignorance through the hearers, and sets beings at ease in the Dharma of the Perfection of Wisdom, liberation, and so forth — just as in the world the letter A is renowned as the first of all letters.

Blessed One, consider: a bull elephant of perfume-wood, when bound by men, will not be tamed even if a skilled trainer is present — but once the binding rope is cut, it goes wherever it wishes. In the same way, so long as we are not fully freed from the bondage of the fifty-seven afflictions, why would the Tathāgata abandon us and pass into nirvāṇa?

Blessed One, consider: one struck by a fever, upon meeting a skilled physician, recovers at once. I too am like that: afflicted by many burning fevers of wrong dying, I have met the Tathāgata and yet my illness is not cured, and I have not attained the unsurpassed and permanent bliss. Why, then, would the Tathāgata abandon me and pass into nirvāṇa?

Blessed One, consider: a madman, because he has lost his senses, does not know near from far, and acts improperly and indecently toward his mother, his daughter, and his sister, speaking without shame and lying down upon filth. When a skilled physician administers medicine and makes him vomit up the alcohol he had drunk, immediately his senses return, and a mind of conscience and shame arises in him, and he feels remorse, thinking: 'Alcohol is the root of all evil and all non-virtue; whoever abandons it completely will abandon all evil as well.'

Blessed One, we too are like that. We have wandered in saṃsāra since beginningless time, intoxicated by desire and attached to the five objects of desire: we have conceived of those who are not our mothers as our mothers,

those who are not our sisters as our sisters, those who are not our daughters as our daughters, those who are not sentient beings as sentient beings — and so we have wandered in saṃsāra, experiencing suffering, just as the madman lies upon vomit. The Tathāgata has administered to us the medicine of the Dharma, and we have vomited up the alcohol of the afflictions — yet we have not fully recovered. Why, then, would the Tathāgata abandon us and pass into nirvāṇa?

Blessed One, consider: if someone claims that a certain tree is hard and has heartwood, that would be incorrect. Blessed One, ordinary beings are likewise: they hold to the notions of self, person, sentient being, and living being —

— and to "possessor of vitality," "lord of vitality," "consciousness," "seer," "agent," and "doer" as truly and genuinely real — that too would be incorrect. We likewise apply ourselves diligently to the perception of no-self.

Blessed One, consider: a bee is in no way needed at all, and the body too is like that — it has no self, no owner. Blessed One, just as a flower with seven petals has no fragrance within it, so too this body has no self and no owner. And so we, with a mind of that very kind, apply ourselves diligently to the perception of no-self.

As the Blessed One has taught, there is no self and no mine in any phenomenon whatsoever. "Monks, apply yourselves diligently in that very manner. By applying yourselves in that way, pride will be utterly relinquished" — so it was taught. And so, having relinquished pride in accordance with that teaching, we implore the Blessed One to pass into nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, consider: there is no traceable path left behind by a bird that flies through the sky. In the same way, one who applies oneself diligently to the perception of no-self gives no grounds for saying that views remain.

Then the Blessed One declared to the monks: "Excellent! Most excellent! You have cultivated well the perception of no-self."

Then the monks addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, we apply ourselves not only to the perception of no-self, but also — beyond that — to the perception of suffering, of emptiness, of impermanence, and of no-self. Blessed One, consider: a madman whose mind has become disordered thinks that he is circling among mountains, rivers, crags, trees, houses, the sun, the moon, and the stars. Blessed One, if a person does not apply himself diligently to the perceptions of suffering, impermanence, and no-self and so forth, that

person will not be called a noble one, and, through heedlessness, will wander endlessly in saṃsāra. Blessed One, for that reason we apply ourselves very diligently to those perceptions."

At that time the Blessed One declared to the monks: "Listen well and take it deeply to heart. In using the analogy of the madman, you have grasped only the words and letters; you have not understood the meaning. What, then, is the meaning? Just as the madman perceives himself as circling around the sun, the moon, and so forth when he is not circling at all, so too is the case with ordinary beings: covered over by defiled ignorance in its entirety, they give rise to inverted minds. They perceive a self as having no self, the permanent as impermanent, the utterly pure as utterly impure, and bliss as suffering. Covered over by defilement in their entirety, they give rise to such perceptions, yet fail to penetrate the actual meaning — just like that madman, who gives rise to the perception of circling in what is not actually a place of circling.

The word 'self' means 'buddha.' The word 'permanent' means 'dharmakāya.' The word 'bliss' means 'nirvāṇa.' And 'utterly pure' means 'Dharma.'

Why, then, do you monks say that perceiving a self is arrogance and leads to wandering in saṃsāra? According to what you say, we too apply ourselves diligently to the perceptions of impermanence, suffering, and no-self — but that is altogether without real purpose. Since applying yourselves to those three has no genuine meaning, I will now teach what surpasses those three improper objects of diligent application. To grasp bliss in what is suffering, and to grasp suffering in what is bliss — those are inverted phenomena. To grasp permanence in what is impermanent, and

to grasp impermanence in what is permanent — that is an inverted phenomenon. To grasp self in what is selfless, and to grasp no-self in what has a self — those are inverted phenomena. To grasp purity in what is impure, and to grasp impurity in what is utterly pure — those are inverted phenomena. No person knows how to apply themselves properly and correctly to these four inverted phenomena.

Therefore, monks, generate the perception of bliss with regard to phenomena that are suffering. Generate the perception of permanence with regard to the impermanent. Generate the perception of self with regard to the selfless. Generate the perception of purity with regard to the impure. For there exists in the world permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. And beyond the world as

well there exists permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. Worldly phenomena can be spoken of, yet they are without meaning. What transcends the world can likewise be spoken of, and it also has meaning. Why is this? It is because worldly phenomena, being accompanied by the four inversions, do not comprehend the meaning. How so? Through inverted perception, inverted mind, and inverted views — these three inversions — worldly beings see bliss as suffering, see the permanent as impermanent, see the self as selfless, and see the utterly pure as impure. This is what is called inversion. Because of inversion, worldly beings know words but do not know the meaning.

What, then, is the meaning? No-self means *saṃsāra*. Self means the Tathāgata. Impermanence means *śrāvakas* and *pratyekabuddhas*. Permanence means the *dharmakāya* of the Tathāgata. Suffering means all non-Buddhists (*tīrthikas*). Bliss means complete *nirvāṇa*. Impurity means conditioned phenomena. Utter purity means the authentic Dharma of buddhas and bodhisattvas — and therefore it is called non-inverted. Thus one who is non-inverted knows both the words that are spoken and the meaning. Whoever wishes to fully abandon the four inversions should, in just this way, come to know permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity.

Then the monks addressed the Blessed One with these words: As the Blessed One has declared — that by overcoming the four inversions one should come to understand permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — the Tathāgata himself is free of the four inversions and has understood permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. If the Tathāgata has understood permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity in this way, then why, without first showing us how to fully abandon our four inversions, did he leave us behind and pass into *nirvāṇa* — remaining for only a single aeon or half an aeon? If the Tathāgata became our Teacher out of compassion for us, then we too would receive it with single-pointed minds, bowing our heads, and apply ourselves diligently. But if the Tathāgata passes into *nirvāṇa*, we too shall dwell together with these afflicted bodies, practicing the holy life, and we too shall pass into *nirvāṇa* in the wake of the Blessed One.

At that point the Blessed One again declared to the monks: Do not speak thus. I have entrusted all the supreme, authentic Dharma to the great Kāśyapa. The great Kāśyapa shall become your dwelling and support, just as the Tathāgata has been the dwelling and support of all sentient beings.

The great Kāśyapa shall likewise become a dwelling and support for all of you and everyone else. Consider the following example: when a great and powerful king is about to go into seclusion, he entrusts all the affairs of the realm to his great minister. In the same way, the Tathāgata has entrusted all of the supreme Dharma to the great Kāśyapa.

You monks are not right to apply yourselves again and again to the perceptions of impermanence and suffering. Consider this example: in the summer season, when a vaiḍūrya jewel falls into a great lake while people are sporting on a raft, all those who are unskilled dive into the water and each pulls out mud, stones, grass, wood, and gravel, thinking they have found the vaiḍūrya jewel, and they emerge with joy — yet from the very beginning they know it was not the right thing. Meanwhile, because the jewel is in the water, by the power of the jewel the water becomes completely clear, and everyone can see that the precious jewel lies at the bottom, just as one sees the moon reflected in the sky above. At that time, the one among that company who is skilled in means enters the water calmly and retrieves the jewel.

Monks, your applying yourselves to the perceptions of impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and impurity is like those many people each pulling out mud, stones, grass, wood, and gravel and thinking they have found the precious jewel. You too must become thoroughly skilled in means, and wherever you dwell, apply yourselves with skill to the perceptions of self, permanence, bliss, and perfect purity. Your former diligent application to the mere signs of these four qualities of the Dharma was entirely inverted. When you meditate correctly, just as it truly is, upon these perceptions, applying yourselves rightly to them — just as the one skilled in means retrieves the precious jewel — so too you must diligently cultivate the perceptions of self, permanence, bliss, and perfect purity.

Then the monks spoke to the Blessed One with these words: The Blessed One previously taught, "All phenomena are without self — apply yourselves accordingly. If you do so, the perception of self will be abandoned. Once the perception of self is abandoned, you will be free of pride. Once free of pride, you will pass beyond sorrow." What is the meaning of what you said?

Then the Blessed One declared: Excellent! Most excellent! You have asked this matter well, in order to resolve our doubt. Consider this example: there was once an ignorant king of little understanding, and he had a physician who was likewise ignorant and foolish. The king, failing to recognize this, bestowed

great favour upon that physician. That foolish physician prescribed milk as medicine for every illness. Not knowing what had originally caused any illness, and not being skilled in administering milk as medicine, he gave milk as medicine for all disorders of wind, phlegm, and bile alike. The king could not discern the physician's true competence, nor distinguish whether the milk was good or bad.

Then a skilled physician arrived from another land, one endowed with the eight branches of medical knowledge, thoroughly expert in healing all diseases, and fully conversant with every form of examination. At that time, the unskilled physician did not seek to ask questions of that skilled physician or to learn from him. Instead, he gave rise to a mind of pride. The skilled physician, relying upon the unskilled one and taking him as his teacher,

in order to learn the secret methods of medical examination, he petitioned the unskilled physician, saying: "I beg you to accept me as your student and to demonstrate and explain the methods of examination." Upon this request, the unskilled physician made the following declaration to the skilled one: "If you will serve me for forty-eight years, I will teach you all the methods of examination." Then the skilled physician replied: "I will do exactly as the unskilled one has said. I will serve you for however long it takes." And so the unskilled physician led the new physician to the royal palace. When they arrived before the king, the new physician spoke at length with the king about the various methods of examination, about many other arts, about the governance of the realm, and about the means of curing the sick, saying: "Great King, please take all of this to heart." At that time, upon hearing these words, the king recognized that the old physician was unskilled and banished him from the land. He then showed even greater respect and honour toward the new physician.

At that time the new physician thought to himself, "The moment has come to instruct this king," and so he addressed the king thus: "Great King, if you would be so gracious as to attend to me, please grant me one request." The king replied: "From my right hand to every limb and member of my body — ask for whatever you wish, and it shall all be given." The physician then made his request: "Although you have granted me the asking of every limb and member of the royal body, I am not bold enough to ask for much. My single request is this: please issue an edict henceforth throughout the land, proclaiming that no one among the king's subjects is to offer milk as a medicinal treatment in the manner of the old physician. Why so? Because that

medicine is poisonous and has caused many deaths. If anyone is found administering that medicine, let it be proclaimed that his head and limbs shall be cut off." Having issued this edict, the use of milk as medicine was stopped, untimely deaths ceased, and all became well and happy. "This is the request I ask you to grant."

Then the king said: "This request of yours will be of the greatest benefit. From this day forth, if any subject of the realm should be found administering milk as medicine, permission shall not be given. If anyone administers milk, let it be proclaimed that the chief of his limbs — his head — shall be cut off." And so the edict was issued.

Then the skilled physician compounded medicines of many flavours — hot, cold, sour, sweet, bitter, and the like — and whenever he treated a disease, there was none that was not cured. Then, before long had passed, the king himself was struck by illness and summoned the physician, saying: "I have fallen into great suffering from sickness — how am I to be cured?" The physician examined the king's illness and it appeared that milk was needed as medicine, so he addressed the king: "For the king's illness, when treated by appropriate means, I would prescribe milk as medicine. I must confess that what I said before — that milk ought not be given as medicine — has turned out to be false. There is nothing better than milk as medicine, and since the king's illness has arisen from heat, administering milk as medicine would be good." The king replied: "Physician, are you perhaps out of your senses? You say that milk is beneficial for this illness brought on by heat? Previously you yourself said that milk contains poison — how then am I now to drink it? Are you deceiving me? You had the old physician — who had praised milk — expelled on the grounds that his medicine was poisonous, and now after all that you say that milk is good medicine for a sick person. My old physician must surely have been more skilled than you."

Then the physician again addressed the king, saying: "Great King, please do not speak thus.

Consider, for example, how a woodworm's trail can serve as a letter. The worm itself does not know whether it is a letter or not, but when a wise and discerning person sees it, they recognize it as a letter — and no one finds that surprising. Great King, the earlier physician was just like this: not understanding illnesses, he prescribed milk as medicine for all cases without distinction — just as the worm's trail becomes a letter. The earlier physician

understood neither the good and bad qualities of milk nor whether it was appropriate or inappropriate.

The king said: "How is it that the earlier physician did not know this?" The physician replied: "Milk, Your Majesty, can be both a poison and a nectar. How can it be both? If a cow has not been given bad fodder and dry grass, has not eaten straw, if her calf is well tamed and gentle, if she lives not on a high mountain or in dense forest, if she is given clean flowing water to drink and is not driven too hard, if she does not live with a bull or share a herd but feeds and drinks at her ease, and moves about and rests peacefully — the milk of such a cow benefits the ill and is therefore called nectar. Any other milk is called poisonous."

When the Great King heard these words he said: "Physician, excellent! Most excellent have you spoken! From now on I shall know both the good and bad qualities of milk and what is appropriate or inappropriate." The physician then administered milk as medicine, the illness was cured, and a proclamation was issued to all the people of the realm: "From this day forward, take milk as medicine." When the people heard this, they all cried out in anger: "Has our Great King been seized by a hungry ghost? Has he gone mad? What has come over him? We have been deceived — he is telling us to take milk as medicine." All the people of the realm, full of anger, came before the king. To them the king declared: "Do not reproach me. Whether milk is appropriate or inappropriate as medicine is a matter of this physician's diagnosis — I am not at fault." Then the Great King and all the people of the realm became thoroughly pleased and satisfied, and they showed the physician great honour and respect. Milk was administered as medicine to all the sick, and their illnesses were healed.

Monks, you should likewise understand the Tathāgata — the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, the unsurpassed one, tamer and guide of persons, teacher of gods and human beings, the Blessed One — as being like a great physician who came into the world, subdued all the physicians who were tīrthikas with wrong views, and declared to every king: "I am the physician." In order to discipline the tīrthikas he taught: "There is no self, no person, no sentient being, no life-force, no vital essence, no agent of life, no awareness, no sight, no act, no doer."

Monks, when tīrthikas speak of a self it is just like the worm's trail becoming a letter — similar to that. Therefore the Tathāgata taught no-self within the Dharma of the buddhas, and he did so in order to discipline sentient beings, knowing the right time. Yet his teaching of no-self does so with cause and condition present; and his teaching that a self exists is like the skilled physician who knows when milk is appropriate and when it is not as medicine — it is not at all like the grasping at a self held by childish and base persons. The grasping at a self held by childish and base persons — is it the size of a thumb,

or as small as a subtle particle — that is what they grasp at. The Tathāgata's use of the word "self" is not like that. Therefore, although he declared that all phenomena are without self, in ultimate truth they are not without a self. What is called "self" is that phenomenon which is true, which truly and permanently abides, which is a lord and master, which is unchanging and unmoving — that is called "self." It is just as the great physician is skilled regarding milk as medicine. The Tathāgata is likewise: for the sake of ordinary persons he declared that in all phenomena a self truly exists. Therefore, you and the rest of the fourfold assembly should, in just this manner, diligently apply yourselves to all phenomena.

The Fourth Fascicle. The Blessed One then spoke further to the monks, saying this: "Monks, whatever doubts you have regarding the Vinaya (monastic discipline), ask whatever you wish about them, and I will teach and explain so as to set your minds at ease. I have directly realized that all phenomena are emptiness by essential nature. Monks, you should not think that the Tathāgata has done nothing more than realize all phenomena as emptiness by intrinsic nature. Monks, now is the time to ask whatever doubts you have about the Vinaya."

Thereupon the monks addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, we lack wisdom and do not have the capacity to put questions and supplications to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened buddha. Why is this? Because the domain of conduct of the Tathāgata is inconceivable, his meditative absorption is inconceivable, and what the Teacher has taught is also inconceivable. We are of feeble wisdom and do not have the capacity to put questions and supplications to the Tathāgata."

"Blessed One, by way of example: there was an elderly man, one hundred and twenty years old, bent with age, always sick and without the strength to make

effort, frail, and no longer in command of his own life. Wishing to pursue some business in another land, a wealthy man entrusted him with hundreds of thousands of gold coins, saying: 'I am entrusting you with these precious jewels. After ten or twenty years, when I return, give them back to me.' That old man took the jewels, but before long he died of illness. His lineage was broken, and everything he had been entrusted with was scattered and lost. When the owner of the wealth returned, there was no one from whom to recover them. Likewise, that foolish man whom he had entrusted — since no one had examined whether it was fitting or not to entrust him — when the owner came back from the other land, all the jewels were scattered and could not be recovered.

"Blessed One, we hearers (śrāvakas) are like that. Although we have heard the Tathāgata again and again earnestly teaching the Vinaya, we are unable to hold it, to retain it, or to keep the Dharma lasting long — just as the old man received what was entrusted to him by another. Since we lack wisdom, there is nothing that we can even ask or inquire about regarding the Vinaya."

The Blessed One then declared to the monks: "If you ask me today, it will be for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings. Therefore ask whatever you wish."

Thereupon the monks addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, take for example a man in the prime of his life, twenty-five years old, in full vigor of youth, endowed with a handsome form, with abundant wealth, precious jewels, gold, silver, and beryl in great plenty, and surrounded by a retinue of father, mother, wife, and children. Suppose someone entrusted him with wealth and precious jewels,

and said to him: "I have business to attend to and must travel to another land. I entrust these jewels and precious things to you. When I return, please give them back."

The young man guarded them as carefully as if they were his own possessions. Later, that man fell ill, and gathering all those close to him around him, he gave this instruction: "These precious jewels were entrusted to me by a certain elder. When he comes to reclaim them, return them to him."

A wise and discerning person, upon inquiring whether the things had been entrusted or not, would recover all the jewels as soon as the other returned.

In just the same way, Blessed One, if this precious Jewel of the Dharma is entrusted to those who are joyful or to monks, it will not endure for long. Why is that? Because the great Kāśyapa and all the śrāvakas are impermanent, just as the elder who received another's wealth on trust will eventually give it back. Therefore, if this supreme precious Jewel of the Dharma is entrusted to bodhisattvas, then, because bodhisattvas are skilled in questioning and in giving answers, this precious Dharma will endure long and will spread vastly for immeasurable eons, bringing benefit to sentient beings — just as wealth and precious jewels entrusted to a man in the prime of youth will remain secure. For this reason, it is the great bodhisattvas who have the power to request and to beseech. As for us, our wisdom is like that of insects — we do not have the capacity to request the Tathāgata's profoundly deep Dharma.

Having said this, they fell silent.

Then the Blessed One spoke words of high praise: "Excellent! Excellent!" And he said: "Monks, you have well attained the mind of one without defilement, the mind of an arhat. I too have considered this: by these two conditions, if this Great Vehicle is entrusted to bodhisattvas, the sacred Dharma will endure long."

Then the Blessed One declared to the sons and daughters of noble families assembled in the midst of the retinue: "My lifespan is immeasurable, and my individual perfect knowledge is likewise inexhaustible. Ask whatever you wish concerning the Vinaya and the Abhidharma, freely and as you desire." He repeated this invitation two and three times.

At that time, in the midst of the assembled retinue, a great bodhisattva who resided in the city called Tāla — a young man of brahmin lineage named the Great Kāśyapa — arose from his seat, inspired by the blessing of the Buddha. He arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, circumambulated one hundred thousand times, knelt upon his right knee, joined his palms together, and addressed the Blessed One in these words: "If the Blessed One would grant me permission to ask, and having asked, to receive a prophecy in response, then I shall inquire of the Tathāgata on one matter."

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "You may ask the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha whatever you wish, and I shall prophesy concerning each thing asked, so that your mind will be satisfied and free of doubt."

Then the great bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, since out of compassion you grant me leave to ask — my wisdom is like that of an insect, while the qualities of the Tathāgata are supremely lofty, and you are fully surrounded by an indestructible retinue like that of a beast of prey, like a lion. The body of the Tathāgata is likewise indestructible, like a vajra, with a hue resembling vaiḍūrya gemstone, and you are encompassed by a boundless ocean of gnosis and wisdom.

The great bodhisattvas and other beings dwelling in the midst of this assembly likewise possess supreme and limitless qualities beyond measure. How could I dare to ask questions here in the midst of this assembly, which is like a herd of great fragrant elephants? Yet by the blessing of the Buddha and by the power of the wholesome roots of this vast retinue, I wish to ask a little. And so he addressed the Blessed One in verse:

What is it that makes life long,
and how does one attain a body indestructible as a vajra?
Through what causes and conditions
does one also attain the power of supreme stability?

How does one, through this very sūtra,
at last arrive at the perfection of the far shore?
Whatever the Blessed One intends —
please declare it to sentient beings.

How does one attain true greatness
and become a support and refuge for all?
Without being an arhat,
one is yet equal to an arhat.

How do the māras of the gods
seek to create obstacles? Please tell us.
How are the words of the Blessed One
and the words of māras to be understood and distinguished?

How do those who steer the rudder
joyfully speak the ultimate truth,
and yet, while truly endowed with virtue,
display the four inversions?

How does one perform virtuous action?
O Great Sage, please explain.

How do bodhisattvas
come to see even what is hard to see?

How does one take in the full meaning,
and yet grasp only half of it?

How does one conduct oneself in conformity with the noble ones,
stage by stage, as it were —

like Kāliṅga, like sun and moon,
like the pole star among the great stars?
How does one, without having aroused the mind,
still be called a bodhisattva?

How does one attain a fearless mind
in the midst of the assembly,
and be free of all blemish,
like the golden river of Jambudvīpa?

How does one in this turbid world
remain unattached, like a lotus?
How does one, though surrounded by afflictions,
not become tainted by them —

like a skilled physician who cures diseases
yet does not contract the illness?
How does one become like a captain
upon the great ocean of saṃsāra?

How does one utterly abandon saṃsāra,
like a snake shedding its skin?
How is it that, like a wish-fulfilling divine tree,
one becomes so for the Three Jewels —

and when there is no family of the three vehicles,
for what purpose were they taught?
For example, just as pleasure has not yet arisen,
how can one be said to experience pleasure?

How do bodhisattvas
attain an indestructible retinue?
How does one become an eye for leaders
who are blind and bewildered?

How does one who has many heads teach —
O Great Sage, please explain.

How do those who speak the Dharma arise
like the days of the waxing moon?

How does one who has reached the end
demonstrate the passing into nirvāṇa?
How does one who is courageous and diligent
show the path to humans, gods, and māras?

How does one know the characteristics of phenomena
and experience the bliss of Dharma?

How are bodhisattvas
entirely free from illness?

How does one who teaches with intention
reveal what was spoken for the sake of ordinary beings?
What is the meaning of having reached the end,
and how is one who has not yet reached it described?

If it is taught to cut doubt,
why is it not stated as a single definitive answer?
How does one draw near
to the supreme, unsurpassed awakening?

On behalf of the bodhisattvas,
I ask this of the Tathāgata:
Please teach those who are holy
the deeply profound conduct.

If the nature of bliss pervades
all phenomena in all their aspects,
then let the supreme Great Sage
separately analyze and teach it.

You who are the supreme two-footed being, like a physician,
the support and refuge of ordinary people —
though I have begun to ask of the aggregates,
the wisdom that would seek them out is not in me.

In the same way, even a diligent bodhisattva
is unable to know
the domain of the buddhas,

which is supremely profound.

At that moment the Blessed One praised bodhisattva Kāśyapa, saying: "Excellent! Excellent!" And then he said: "Son of good family, although you have not yet attained the gnosis of omniscience, your asking and inquiring into the essence of the supremely profound is not in the least different from asking with the gnosis of omniscience. Son of good family, long ago, at the time of awakening to full and perfect enlightenment beneath the tree of awakening, bodhisattvas arrived from immeasurable and innumerable buddha-fields, as many as the grains of sand in the Gaṅgā river, and the variety of words, the meanings, and the qualities with which they asked me about the supremely profound were exactly like these and no different. Whoever asks in such a way acts for the benefit and the happiness of immeasurable sentient beings."

Then bodhisattva Kāśyapa said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, since I lack wisdom, I do not have the power to ask about such a supremely profound matter. Blessed One, it is like this: bees do not have the power to fly to the far shore of the ocean, nor the power to traverse the entire expanse of the sky. In just the same way, I do not have the power to ask about such a supremely profound matter — the nature of the ocean of the Tathāgata's gnosis, which is like space. Blessed One, it is as if a precious jewel from the crest ornament of a king were entrusted to a minister who guards the treasury; that minister would receive it on the crown of his head and guard it with the utmost care. In just the same way, I receive on the crown of my head this profound and vastly extensive meaning spoken by the Tathāgata, and I devote great effort to guarding it. Why is that? Because I do so for the sake of accomplishing the supremely profound wisdom."

Then the Blessed One spoke to bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, listen very carefully. I will explain to you the karma that extends the life-span of the Tathāgata. When a bodhisattva hears the causes and conditions of that karma, his life will become long. Therefore listen very carefully. Whatever karma serves as a cause for awakening — that is to be grasped carefully and listened to; and having heard it, one should teach it extensively to others. Son of good family, I myself in former times applied great effort to accomplishing those very karmas, and swiftly I attained complete and perfect unsurpassed awakening. This too I will explain to you in detail. Son of good family, it is like this: when a crown prince brings joy to a king by being born, the king, out of love and remembrance, visits all the places where the child was born. In just

the same way, a bodhisattva who wishes for long life should in the very same way guard and protect all sentient beings as though they were his own children, generating loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and great equanimity, and should uphold the precept of not taking life. One should apply oneself to virtuous qualities and establish all sentient beings in the path of the five precepts and the ten virtuous actions. Furthermore, one should liberate all sentient beings who suffer in the hells, among hungry ghosts, among animals, in the realm of asuras, and throughout all their existences — freeing those who are not yet free,

leading those who have not yet reached the far shore to reach it, and guiding those who have not yet passed beyond sorrow to pass beyond sorrow, and filling those who are afraid with ease and joy. Through such causes and conditions of action, a bodhisattva will gain long life and attain the power of wisdom, and in whatever existence the consciousness passes, rebirth will occur among the gods of the high realms. Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the meaning of what has been said — that a great bodhisattva should generate the perception of regarding all sentient beings as equal to an only child — is so very profound that I do not understand it. Blessed One, it seems improper that a Tathāgata should have said that a great bodhisattva should generate the perception of regarding all sentient beings with an evenminded love as though they were an only child. Why so? Among those who have entered the teaching of the Tathāgata, there are some who have broken their moral discipline, some who act improperly, and some who actually damage the sacred Dharma — how, then, can one generate the perception of regarding even these as though they were an only child?"

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "That is indeed so. That is indeed so. I myself regard all sentient beings as my son Rāhula."

Kāśyapa then said to the Blessed One: "Formerly, on the fifteenth day of the month, when a fully purified Saṅgha was performing the restoration ceremony, a certain immature youth — one whose body, speech, and mind had not been tamed — listened to the Saṅgha's restoration ceremony from a secluded place, and Vajrapāṇi, through the blessing of his buddha-power, struck him to dust with his vajra club. Blessed One, since Vajrapāṇi in his great anger separated that youth from his life, why did the Tathāgata say that all sentient beings are like his son Rāhula?"

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "Do not speak thus. That youth too was merely an emanation, not a real human being — he appeared in order to remove those who had broken their moral discipline from within a fully purified Saṅgha. Vajrapāṇi likewise was merely an emanation. Kāśyapa, even toward those who harm the sacred Dharma, who are driven by wrong craving, who take life, who hold wrong views, and who have broken their moral discipline — toward even these I generate great compassion and regard them as I regard my son Rāhula. Son of good family, take the following example: when ministers of a king have committed an offense and violated the law, the king does not release them but applies whatever penalty the law prescribes. A Tathāgata is not like that. When there are those who have fallen away from the teaching, he performs the act of expulsion, the act of reprimand, the act of suspension, the act of formally raising the offense, the act of rendering invisible, the act of pacification, and the act of abandoning wrong views. Son of good family, in this way the Tathāgata performs the work of fully taming those who disparage the Dharma, and he reveals to those who conduct themselves badly the ripened fruit of their karma. Son of good family, know it in this way: the Tathāgata is one who grants fearlessness even to wicked sentient beings. If he sends forth even one, two, or five rays of light, all sentient beings touched by them will wholly abandon their misdeeds. Therefore the Tathāgata is endowed with immeasurable power of that kind. Son of good family, if you wish to see for yourself what you have not yet seen — the qualities you have not yet beheld — I shall show you a portion of it."

After my passing into nirvāṇa, know that any person — in whatever region there are monks who possess moral discipline, whose conduct is unblemished, who guard the sacred Dharma, and who, seeing those who conduct themselves in ways contrary to the Dharma, expel them and punish them with penalties — that person obtains merit that is immeasurable and incalculable.

Son of good family, consider this example: a king who conducts himself only in unwholesome ways falls ill, and a neighboring king, hearing that things have come to such a pass, raises an army in order to be rid of that ailing king. If the ailing king, frightened by the weakness of his own power and forces, abandons non-virtue and strives toward virtue, then that opposing king who advanced against him obtains immeasurable merit.

In just the same way, monks who uphold the Dharma likewise obtain immeasurable merit if, by expelling and penalizing those persons who conduct themselves contrary to the Dharma, they bring them into the practice of

wholesome qualities.

Son of good family, consider this further example: if a poisonous plant springs up in a householder's garden, as soon as the householder recognizes it as poisonous he eradicates it from the root. Likewise, if a gray hair appears on the head of a young man, feeling ashamed he pulls it out from the root at once, ensuring that no more will grow. A monk who upholds the Dharma is like that: when he sees a monk whose moral discipline has degenerated conducting himself in ways contrary to the sacred Dharma, he must expel that monk from the community and impose a penalty. A monk of good character who sees those whose precepts have degenerated and neither expels them from the community nor penalizes them — know that such a monk is an enemy of the Dharma taught by the Buddha. But one who does expel them and impose penalties is a true and genuine attendant-śrāvaka of mine.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One and said: "As the Blessed One has taught, that he looks upon all sentient beings as a son — as his own child Rāhula — such a statement seems improper. Blessed One, if one person raises a weapon and strikes at the Buddha, and another person anoints the body of the Buddha with a sandalwood fan, and the Blessed One regards both with equanimity, then why did you say that those whose precepts have degenerated are to be cut down with penalties? If those whose precepts have degenerated are to be penalized, that contradicts your earlier teaching."

The Blessed One then spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, consider this example: a king or great minister has two, three, or four sons who are handsome in form and sharp in wisdom. He goes to a learned teacher, an expert instructor, and makes this request: 'I entrust these sons of mine to you — please train them in deportment, classical learning, the arts, letters, arithmetic, and reckoning. Even if three of the four sons should die under the rod, so be it; do whatever it takes to train the one remaining. If three of them die, I will hold no grievance against you.' Kāśyapa, what do you think? Does the father of that child and that teaching master incur the fault of killing? The answer came: 'No, Blessed One.' And why not? Because it is done with the thought of love, wishing them to acquire training — and not with ill will; therefore immeasurable merit is obtained.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata is just like that: he looks upon even those whose precepts have degenerated as though they were his only child. The Tathāgata has entrusted the unsurpassed sacred Dharma to kings, great

ministers, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, and in doing so he has directed that among kings and those four assemblies, those who have entered into the training shall, through heightened moral discipline —

— meditative absorption, and wisdom attain these through encouragement. Whoever among the three trainings does not train, but instead is lazy, allows their moral discipline to degenerate, and makes the Dharma unsuitable, shall be punished with punishment by the king, the great ministers, and the four assemblies. Son of good family, would that king and those four assemblies incur the fault of blameworthy wrongdoing?" "No, Blessed One." The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if that king and those four assemblies would not become guilty, then what need is there even to speak of the Tathāgata? Son of good family, the Tathāgata, with an equanimous mind, regards all sentient beings as though they were his only child. One who thinks in this way is called a bodhisattva who, with an equanimous mind, perceives all sentient beings as though they were his only child.

Son of good family, a bodhisattva who diligently applies himself to that practice in this way will attain long life and will come to know his former existences.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then again addressed the Blessed One in these words: "As the Buddha has said, a bodhisattva who diligently cultivates equanimous mind and perceives all sentient beings as though they were his only child will attain long life — it does not seem fitting that the Tathāgata would say such a thing. Why so? Consider this: a certain learned person, skilled in teaching many aspects of Dharma in service to the wise, who is endowed with wisdom, comes to his house and strikes his parents with sticks and stones. Parents are a field of merit; they render only benefit and happiness, and are exceedingly difficult to encounter — they are worthy of veneration. If one harms and injures them, this contradicts and conflicts with what a seeker of Dharma should say and do. The Tathāgata is just like that: if a bodhisattva diligently cultivates equanimous mind and, by perceiving all sentient beings as though they were his only child, attains long life and comes to know his former existences — and does not pass away, but abides constantly in the world — then why did the Blessed One's own life span become extremely short, no different from that of an ordinary person? Could it be that the Tathāgata regarded all sentient beings as though they were enemies? Blessed One, what former wrongdoing did you commit, and how many vital faculties did you separate from life, that your own life span became

so extremely short, not even reaching a hundred years?"

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, why have you spoken such disrespectful words in the presence of the Tathāgata? The life span of the Tathāgata is the supreme and most excellent of all life spans. It is also the supreme and most excellent among all permanent phenomena.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked the Blessed One: "What, then, is meant by saying that the Tathāgata's life span is long?" The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, there are eight great rivers: the Gaṅgā, the Yamunā, the Śālā, the Alilabaratā, the Mahā, the Sindhu, the Pakṣu, and the Sītā — these eight great rivers, together with all other streams, flow down into the great ocean. Kāśyapa, in just the same way, all the rivers of vital life of every being — gods and all others, those dwelling on earth and in the sky — flow down into the ocean of the Tathāgata's life span. Therefore the Tathāgata's life span is immeasurable.

Furthermore, Kāśyapa, consider this: from the lake called Anavatapta (Skt. Anavatapta), four great rivers flow forth. The Tathāgata likewise is the source from which all life arises.

Kāśyapa, consider this: among all permanent phenomena, space is supreme. The Tathāgata likewise is supreme among all that is permanent."

is supreme. Kāśyapa, consider this: among all medicines, the essence of butter is supreme. In just the same way, the Tathāgata is supreme in life span among all sentient beings.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "If the Tathāgata's life span is such, it would be fitting that he remain for one full eon, or for just short of one eon, and continuously pour down the rain of the holy Dharma."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, do not give rise to the perception that the Tathāgata is subject to cessation or exhaustion. Kāśyapa, even a monk, a nun, a layman, a laywoman, or even a non-Buddhist adherent (tīrthika) who possesses the five superknowledges and has attained mastery can, for the span of an eon or just short of an eon, gain power over walking, standing, sitting, and lying down through the sky. Flames blaze from the left side of the body, water flows from the right side, smoke billows from the upper body, and one can transform into what appears to be a great mass of fire. And if one wishes to remain alive for as long as desired, one abides at will and gains mastery over the length of one's life. If even one who has only attained the

five superknowledges possesses such miraculous power, what need is there to speak of the Tathāgata, who has obtained the power to govern all phenomena? What need is there to speak of remaining for half an eon, or one eon, or a hundred eons, or a hundred thousand eons, or an immeasurable number of eons? Therefore, understand the Tathāgata as one whose nature is permanent, who abides with a permanent body, whose nature is unchanging. The Tathāgata's body is an emanation body (nirmāṇakāya); it is not a body sustained by food. For the sake of liberating sentient beings, it was shown in a form resembling a poisonous tree, and therefore understand that the passing into nirvāṇa that was shown was a display. Kāśyapa, therefore understand the Tathāgata as one whose nature is permanent and unchanging. You and those like you should apply yourselves with the utmost and tireless diligence to the ultimate. Having done so with such diligence, explain it widely to others."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "What difference and distinction is there between transcendent phenomena and worldly phenomena? If, as the Buddha has said, the Buddha too has the nature of permanence and is unchanging, then Brahmā, the god of the worldly realm, is also permanent, and Śakra, the ruling deity, is also permanent and unchanging. The self that is spoken of as being of unchanging nature is also permanent, intrinsic nature is also permanent, and subtle particles are also said to be permanent. If this is so and the Tathāgata too has the nature of permanence, why does the Tathāgata not openly demonstrate permanence? If permanence is not openly demonstrated, what difference and distinction can there be? From Brahmā down to subtle particles and intrinsic nature, those who claim permanence have not openly demonstrated it either."

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Consider this example. A certain householder owned many cows of various colors, and he entrusted them all together to a cowherd, who drove them to wherever grass and water were to be found and kept them alive. This was not for the sake of ordinary curds and milk alone, but for the sake of obtaining the essence of butter. Later, when the householder died, the cows were driven off by thieves. Those thieves, having no women among them, milked the cows and each drank the milk separately. Afterward, the thieves said to one another: 'In the past, that great householder kept all these cows not merely for curds and milk, but solely for the sake of the essence of butter. Now, what method shall we use

to obtain the essence of butter,' and they deliberated together. Now, the essence of butter is the finest of all savory things in the world, yet even if milk

is available, they said, there is no vessel in which to pour it. Then they discussed it again, saying, 'We have a leather bag, so let us pour it into the bag.' But even though a place for pouring was available, since they did not know the method of curdling and churning, they were unable to obtain even ordinary cream, let alone plain butter, still less the essence of butter. Those wicked thieves, in their desire for the essence of butter, added water again and again, and thus everything from the milk to the essence of butter was corrupted. Foolish people are just like this. Whatever small measure of virtue they possess comes from the holy Dharma of the Tathāgata. Why is that? After the buddha, the Blessed One, passed completely into nirvāṇa, stealing from the virtuous Dharma of the Tathāgata the portions belonging to moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom is like those thieves stealing the cows. Foolish people, though they may obtain a measure of moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom, yet having no skill in the methods of application, are unable to achieve liberation and to teach it. For this reason, not being able to attain enduring moral discipline, enduring meditative absorption, enduring wisdom, or liberation up to its fullness, is comparable to those thieves who, lacking skill in method, fail to obtain the essence of butter. Just as those thieves, in their desire for the essence of butter, added water, so too base people are like them: desiring liberation, they say that nirvāṇa is self, sentient being, life-force, person, Brahmā, a sovereign deity, subtle particles, the intrinsic nature of the world, moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, or the sphere without perception. But they neither attain true liberation nor transcend suffering, just as those thieves did not obtain the essence of butter. Base people, through the causes and conditions of having practiced a little celibacy and shown some reverence to their parents, are born as gods in the higher realms and experience a small measure of pleasant enjoyment — this is like those thieves diluting the milk with water. Base people do not understand that they have been born as gods in the higher realms through the causes of practicing a little celibacy and showing some reverence to their parents. Furthermore, they do not know moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, or how to take refuge in the Three Jewels. Because of this ignorance, though they speak of permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity, they do not understand even that. Therefore, the Tathāgata came into the world and taught and explained permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. Just as when a wheel-turning king (Skt. cakravartin) appears in the world, the force of his merit causes the wicked thieves to flee and scatter in all directions, and since

the cows have not perished, the wheel-turning king entrusts them to a skilled cowherd, and through the skill of that cowherd the essence of butter comes to be present once more, and because the essence of butter is present all sentient beings are freed from the suffering of illness — in the same way, when the king who turns the wheel of Dharma came into the world, base people became unable to teach moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom, and they fled and scattered. Then the Blessed One, for the benefit of sentient beings, taught and explained to the great bodhisattvas both worldly Dharmas and transcendent Dharmas, and thus the great bodhisattvas, great beings, came to obtain what is like the essence of butter.

Furthermore, the way in which countless, immeasurable sentient beings are to obtain the Dharma that is like the nectar of the unsurpassable is as follows: it is the qualities of the Tathāgata — permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity. For this reason, son of good family, know that the Tathāgata is endowed with the quality of permanence and unchangingness. This is unlike what worldly, base people say when they claim that Brahmā and the other gods possess the quality of permanence. In brief, the quality known as permanence belongs to the Tathāgata alone and not to any other phenomena. Kāśyapa, therefore, one should understand the body of the Tathāgata accordingly.

Kāśyapa, whatever sons of good family or daughters of good family always apply themselves with one-pointed mind to these two words — "the buddha is permanent" and "the buddha abides" — know that such a person follows after me and has arrived at the place where I have gone. Kāśyapa, whatever son of good family applies himself to these two words — if he has abandoned conceptual signs, know that the Tathāgata has resolved to pass into nirvāṇa. Son of good family, the meaning of passing into nirvāṇa is itself the nature of reality of a buddha.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, what is the meaning of what is called the nature of reality? Blessed One, since I do not understand the meaning of what the nature of reality is, I ask the Tathāgata, out of compassionate care, to explain it in full.

What is called the nature of reality is utterly free of body, and what is free of body is nothing whatsoever. If it is nothing whatsoever, how can what is called body be established? If body were to be established, then the nature of reality too would not be present in the body. And if the nature of reality were not present in the body, how is it to be established? How am I to understand these

matters?

With this the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Son of good family, you should not negate the nature of reality in this way. In the nature of reality there is no negation. Son of good family, take for example the gods of the sphere of non-perception: though they possess the aggregate of form, because they have no perception of form it would be inappropriate to ask of those gods how they dwell, how they enjoy bliss, how they engage in perception, and how they hear and see. In the same way, son of good family, the domain of the Tathāgata is not known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. Son of good family, one should not say that the body of the Tathāgata is subject to cessation. Son of good family, cessation is a domain of buddhas and is not known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. Son of good family, you should not speculate or conjecture about where the Tathāgata dwells, where he moves, what he perceives, and what he enjoys. Son of good family, these matters are not something to be known and understood by you and those like you, for the dharmakāya of a buddha and the manifold skillful means are inconceivable.

Son of good family, moreover, always be mindful of and apply yourself to the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. These three things — the Dharma in its threefold aspect — have the defining characteristic of non-differentiation, the defining characteristic of non-impermanence, and the defining characteristic of non-transformation. Whoever perceives these three Dharmas as separate — such a person does not truly take refuge in the three refuges, is said to lack moral discipline, and is incapable of attaining even the awakening of a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha. But whoever applies himself with a perception of permanence to that which is inconceivable — such a person is the proper basis for going for refuge.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: because a tree exists, there is a shadow. The Tathāgata is like this — because he possesses a permanent Dharma, there exists a proper basis for going for refuge; but he is not impermanent. Whoever says of the Tathāgata that he is impermanent — such a Tathāgata would not be a proper basis for going for refuge for gods and men of the world together.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, consider this: when the sky is overcast, a fruit tree is present and yet there is no shadow."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, one must not say that the tree is present and yet has no shadow — it is simply that it cannot be seen with the eye of flesh. Son of good family, the Tathāgata is like this: he abides permanently by his very own intrinsic nature, unchanging and without transformation. But because one lacks the eye of wisdom, one cannot see him — just as at the time of an overcast sky one cannot see the shadow of the tree. Ordinary beings, after the buddha passes into nirvāṇa, may say that the Tathāgata is possessed of the quality of impermanence — and those who say that the Tathāgata is separate and distinct from the Dharma and the Saṅgha will not come to be among those who go for refuge to the three refuges. It is as if, because your mother and father are separately individual, one were to call them impermanent."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, it is a wondrous thing that I will come to recall that the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are permanent — and that this memory will extend back through seven generations of ancestors. Blessed One, I will habituate myself to contemplating the inconceivable nature of the Tathāgata, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha; and having myself become accustomed to this, I will also teach its meaning widely to others. Those who do not have faith in this have long been cultivating the meditation on impermanence — and toward such persons I will act as a mother or as hail."

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent!" And he said: "You are one who guards and fully upholds the true Dharma. By thus guarding the Dharma, and through the roots of virtue that do not deceive sentient beings, through that very condition you will come to have long life and knowledge of your former abodes."

This is the first chapter, called "The Chapter on the Life-span," from the noble sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One spoke to Kāśyapa as follows: "Son of good family, what is called the body of the Tathāgata is a body that abides permanently, an indestructible body, a vajra body — not a body that depends on food, but the dharmakāya."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, such bodies as you have described I have not seen. What I have seen is a body that is impermanent, destructible, made of dust, and dependent on food. Why is that? Because the Tathāgata has departed into complete parinirvāṇa."

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "You must not look upon the body of the Tathāgata as though it were without essence or subject to destruction, like the body of an ordinary being. Son of good family, you should understand it in this way: the body of the Tathāgata is stable for immeasurable aeons, it has essence and is indestructible, it is not like the body of gods or humans, it is not a body subject to destruction, it is not a body dependent on food."

The body of the Tathāgata is a body that is not-body — not arising and not ceasing; not aggregated; not made; immeasurable; infinite; without trace; without consciousness; without form; ultimately perfectly pure; unshaking, without sensation; without formations; without abiding; unmade; without savour; unmixed; not compounded.

Not karma, not result, not conduct, not cessation, not mind, not countable, inconceivable, immeasurable, not fully known, separated from mind, yet also not separated from mind, without equality with mind, yet also not without it, without going and coming, yet also not without going and coming, indestructible, undiminished, uncut, not cut off, not arisen, not ceasing, without a lord, yet also not without a lord, neither existent nor non-existent, without feeling, without conceptual thought, without syllable, yet also not without syllable, not meditative absorption, yet also not without meditative absorption, without anything to behold, yet manifest and apparent, without abiding, yet also not without abiding, without support, yet also not without support, neither darkness nor light, neither at peace nor unpeaceful, not grasping at anything whatsoever, not releasing, perfectly pure, stainless, without dispute, with all dispute cut off, abiding without abiding, not grasping, not a phenomenon of falling, yet also not a non-phenomenon, not a field of merit, yet also not not a field of merit, inexhaustible and without exhaustion, free from all exhaustion, empty of emptiness itself, not permanently abiding, not cut off by a stream of moments, without the stain of turbidity, without syllable, separated from syllable, not sound, not spoken, not something cultivated through habituation, not expressible, not something inferred, not one, not many, not form, not a sign, yet adorned with excellent marks, not bold, not fearful, without peace, not at peace, not tormented, not something to be seen as free from torment, without sign. The Tathāgata, though he has acted for the benefit of all sentient beings, is without the act of having benefited sentient beings; though he liberates sentient beings, there is no liberation; though he causes sentient beings to fully awaken, there is no full awakening. He teaches the Dharma truly and just as it is, in non-duality,

immeasurable, equal to what is unequal, equal to space, in harmony with formlessness and the unborn, uninterrupted, impermanent, yet though always moving in the single vehicle, sentient beings perceive it as three. Unchanging, irreversible, with all afflictions (kleśas) utterly severed, non-contentious, not singular, not a defining characteristic, yet abiding in defining characteristics, not assembled, not dispersed, not long, not short, not round, not square, not the aggregates, not the sense bases, not the elements, yet also not other than the aggregates, sense bases, and elements, not increasing, not decreasing, not good, not bad.

The body of the Tathāgata is thus endowed with immeasurable qualities beyond measure: without knowing, yet also without not-knowing; without seeing, yet also without not-seeing; not conditioned, not unconditioned; not the world, yet also not other than the world; not made, yet also not unmade; not abiding, yet also not non-abiding; not the four great elements, yet also not other than the four great elements; not a cause, yet also not without cause; not a sentient being, yet also not without sentient beings; not an ascetic, not a brahmin; like a lion, a great lion; not a body, yet also not a non-body; inexpressible, separated even from the defining characteristic of a single dharma, not to be estimated or counted. At the moment of passing into nirvāṇa, not passing into nirvāṇa. Such is the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata, endowed with immeasurable and supreme qualities of this kind.

Kāśyapa, this is known by the Tathāgata alone; it is not something known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Kāśyapa, such is the body of the Tathāgata, endowed with immeasurable qualities — it is not a body nourished and sustained by food. Kāśyapa, given that the body of the Tathāgata is endowed with true qualities of this kind, how could there be in it illness, suffering, insubstantiality, or instability like an unfired clay pot? Kāśyapa, the Tathāgata displayed illness and suffering for the sake of taming sentient beings.

Son of good family, you should understand it in this way: the body of the Tathāgata is a vajra body. From this day forward, you should hold this meaning one-pointedly in mind, and you should not think of it as a body of food. Teach others as well that the body of the Tathāgata is the dharmakāya.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, if the Tathāgata is endowed with such qualities, how could there be illness, impermanence, or decay? From this day forward I shall contemplate

the body of the Tathāgata as permanent and the dharmakāya as supremely blissful, and I shall teach others likewise. Blessed One, since the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata is indestructible like a vajra, I do not seek what has arisen from causes.

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: It is through the cause and condition of protecting and upholding the sacred Dharma that one comes to be endowed with a vajra body. Kāśyapa, it is through the cause and condition of my having guarded and protected the Dharma in former times that I have come to be endowed with a vajra body, abiding always, indestructible.

Son of good family, one who protects and guards the sacred Dharma does not grasp at the five precepts, does not keep the code of conduct, but takes up weapons — swords, bows and arrows, spears, and the like — and protects monks whose monastic discipline is perfectly pure. Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: But Blessed One, is not a monk who has set aside his guarding role and dwells in a solitary place — a charnel ground or at the foot of a tree — a true monk? Will one who follows the way of protection be called a householder who grasps at a head?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: Do not say "a householder who grasps at a head." Wherever a monk may dwell, if he takes only what is needed for bodily subsistence, reads and recites the sūtras, applies himself to meditation, and, when there are those who ask about the Dharma, teaches them generosity, moral discipline, the accumulation of merit, few desires, contentment, and other Dharma topics of various kinds — yet he does not roar the lion's roar, he is not surrounded like a lion, he cannot tame those who practice the depraved Dharma. Such a monk can accomplish neither his own benefit nor the benefit of others; he is heedless and lazy. Know that even though he guards moral discipline and practices celibacy, he can accomplish nothing whatsoever.

As for a monk who has abundant necessities of life and perfectly guards his moral discipline, who roars the lion's roar, reciting the nine divisions of the sacred Dharma — sūtras, prose and verse mixed compositions (geyas), prophecies, verses, intentional utterances, birth stories, accounts of wonderful events, narratives of origins, and marvellous events, accounts of realization, extensive discourses, and definitive teachings — and teaches them widely to others, for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings, proclaiming thus from the Nirvāṇa Sūtra: "Monks are like servants —

cattle, sheep, and other such improper possessions are not permitted to be kept" — and proclaiming further that any monk who keeps such uninspected possessions should be punished with a penalty, and citing as well other sūtras in which the Tathāgata declares that monks who kept such uninspected possessions were penalized by a certain great king and reduced to the status of laypeople — when a monk roars the lion's roar in this manner, those of bad moral discipline, upon hearing such words, give rise to aversion and kill that Dharma-teacher. Yet even if that Dharma-teacher's life is cut short in this way, he is still called one who upholds moral discipline and works for the benefit of self and others. For this reason I permit kings, great ministers, and laypeople to protect Dharma-teachers. Whoever wishes to protect the sacred Dharma should train in this way. Kāśyapa, one who has broken moral discipline and does not protect the Dharma is called a householder with a shaved head — that epithet does not apply to one who guards moral discipline.

The Fifth Fascicle.

O son of noble family, far beyond the past, across a limitless, boundless, and innumerable expanse of aeons, in this very city of Kuśinagara, there arose a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha named the Blessed One "Joyfully Arisen" — endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, tamer and guide of persons, Teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One. At that time and in that era, this world-realm was exceedingly vast, utterly pure, its human population great, its people happy and untroubled by want of food and drink — just as the bodhisattvas of the world-realm of Sukhāvatī are. That Blessed One Buddha dwelt in the world for a measureless duration, accomplishing the welfare of sentient beings, and then passed into complete nirvāṇa between the twin śāla trees. After that buddha had passed into nirvāṇa, the sacred Dharma remained for more than forty times ten thousand years beyond measure.

At that time there was a monk named Guṇamati who guarded his moral discipline with the utmost care. He had a vast retinue, and he roared the lion's roar before his assembly, being supremely skilled in teaching the nine divisions of the sūtras in great detail. He proclaimed to the monks that keeping servants, male or female, cattle, sheep, and other such improper possessions was not permitted. At that time the very many monks of broken moral discipline, upon hearing this proclamation, all gave rise to minds of aversion and, taking up weapons, closed in upon that Dharma-teacher. At that time the king of that land, named Guṇavān, upon hearing what had occurred, went

immediately to where the Dharma-teacher was in order to protect the Dharma. He arrayed himself against those monks of broken and corrupt moral discipline, fought them, and freed the Dharma-teaching monk from those obstacles. At that time there was not a single wound on the king's body — not even a scratch the size of a sesame seed — from swords, arrows, spears, or any other weapon. At that time the monk Guṇamati said to the king: "Excellent! Excellent! O king, you have truly guarded the sacred Dharma in the right way. In time to come you shall become an immeasurable vessel of the Dharma." That king, his mind filled with great joy upon hearing the Dharma at that moment, passed away immediately thereafter, and was born in the buddha-field of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya, where he became that buddha's supreme attendant. The king's retinue, who had entered into battle and were wounded,

rejoiced and felt sympathetic gladness, and in every respect became irreversible from the awakening mind (bodhicitta). When they passed away, they were all born in the buddha-field of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya. The monk Guṇamati, too, when he later passed away, was likewise born in the buddha-field of the Tathāgata Akṣobhya, where he became the lowest among that Blessed Buddha's śrāvaka Saṅgha. Therefore, when the sacred Dharma is declining and nearing its end, one must guard and protect it in just that way.

Kāśyapa, at that time, in that age, the king was none other than myself. The monk who taught the Dharma was the buddha known as Kāśyapa. Kāśyapa, by guarding the sacred Dharma, one gains results such as these, boundless and immeasurable. It was through that cause and that condition that I have come to be adorned throughout with a dharmakāya, the truth body, beautified with manifold major marks and excellent minor marks of every kind, together with an indestructible body that has arisen spontaneously.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the permanence of the Tathāgata's body is like an inscription carved in stone."

The Blessed One then spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa as follows: "Therefore, son of good family, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen must arouse the utmost diligence and guard the sacred Dharma. The fruit of guarding the sacred Dharma is vast and immeasurable. Son of good family, therefore lay Dharma-protectors should take up weapons in hand and guard and protect the Dharma-preaching monks.

One should not be called a person of the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna) merely for keeping the five precepts of moral discipline. Yet even if one does not keep the five precepts, if one guards the sacred Dharma, that is called the Great Vehicle. To guard the sacred Dharma, one should take weapons in hand and protect the Dharma-preacher."

Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One again: "Blessed One, if a monk associates with and relies upon laymen who bear weapons in the manner described, should he be called a Teacher, or should he not? Does such conduct constitute the keeping of moral discipline, or its violation?"

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "Do not think that those people have violated moral discipline. Son of good family, after I have passed completely into nirvāṇa, in this turbid world the regions will fall into strife, and people will plunder one another, bringing the threat of famine. At that time, many will struggle to go forth into the monastic life out of destitution, and those people shall be called shaven-headed impostors. Among these shaven-headed impostor individuals, those monks who uphold moral discipline, who possess proper conduct, who are fully pure, and who guard the sacred Dharma — these will be expelled, killed, and harmed.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One: "How should monks who uphold moral discipline and fully maintain the sacred Dharma travel through towns and regions in order to tame sentient beings?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, therefore I permit those who uphold moral discipline to associate with and rely upon armed householders. If a king, minister, householder, layman, or any other person takes up weapons for the sake of protecting the Dharma, that too is called keeping moral discipline. Although they bear weapons, because they do not take life, such a one is called the supreme keeper of moral discipline."

Kāśyapa then asked further: "Blessed One, a Dharma-protector endowed with right view who teaches the Mahāyāna sūtras extensively is like a precious royal parasol, like a vessel of butter oil,

he never exercises control over grain, produce, and fruits of various kinds. He does not rely upon a king, minister, or householder merely for the sake of gain and honor. Toward his donors he harbors no thought of living by deceit and guile. Because he is endowed with proper conduct, he tames unruly persons whose moral discipline has degenerated, and such a one is called a teacher who upholds moral discipline and protects the Dharma. Because he is a

genuine spiritual friend to many sentient beings, his mind is vast and wide as the ocean.

Kāśyapa, if a monk teaches Dharma to others for the sake of gain and honor, then all those who belong to that person's retinue will likewise teach Dharma for the sake of gain and honor, and that person causes even his own monastic Saṅgha to become corrupt. Kāśyapa, there are three kinds of Saṅgha: the Saṅgha of those whose moral discipline has degenerated and who wear armor, the Saṅgha of the dull and deluded, and the Saṅgha of the utterly pure.

The Saṅgha of those whose moral discipline has degenerated and who wear armor is easy to destroy, whereas the Saṅgha that upholds moral discipline and is utterly pure cannot be destroyed by the circumstance of gain and honor.

Now, what is the Saṅgha of those whose moral discipline has degenerated and who wear armor? It is this: if a monk, though himself guarding moral discipline, relies upon those whose moral discipline has degenerated for the sake of gain and honor, sitting with them, going about with them, staying with them, consorting with them, befriending one another, and performing actions in concert with them, such a one is called both one whose moral discipline has degenerated and a member of the armored Saṅgha.

What then is the Saṅgha of the dull and deluded? It is a monk who dwells at the forest's edge, whose faculties are dull, who is sluggish and foolish, who has few desires and goes on alms rounds, and who on the day of the restoration ceremony and at the times when the formal proceedings arise, regards those of his vicinity who have become attendants as pure and admits them to confession, while when he sees those of his vicinity who are not pure, whose moral discipline has degenerated, he regards them as pure and admits them to confession without excluding them, and then together performs the restoration ceremony and the proceedings arising from the Vinaya with them — such a one belongs to the Saṅgha of the dull and deluded.

What then is the Saṅgha of the utterly pure? It is a monastic Saṅgha that cannot be divided or destroyed even by a hundred thousand ten-million māras. Such a one is a bodhisattva Saṅgha, pure by its very intrinsic nature. If one tames the previously mentioned two kinds of Saṅgha and brings them within the Saṅgha of the utterly pure, such a one is called the unsurpassed great master who protects the Dharma.

One who is skilled in the Vinaya is supremely expert in the heavy and light characteristics of moral discipline for the sake of benefiting and taming sentient beings, and makes no effort to investigate what is not within the domain of moral discipline, but examines and comes to know what pertains to the domain of moral discipline.

In that regard, how is it that bodhisattvas, for the sake of taming sentient beings, constantly and without fixed time enter into cities, frequenting even desolate places and the dwellings of courtesans, and even residing together with them for many years — something that śrāvakas must not do? This is called taming for the sake of the benefit and happiness of sentient beings.

What is to be understood as heavy? There are four matters concerning which the Tathāgata prescribed moral discipline from one case, saying, "From this day forward, do not transgress this" — these are like the four root cases, the violations for which the Tathāgata has prescribed that those who go forth are not permitted to act. If one does so deliberately, that person is not a renunciate and not a son of the Śākyas. These are called the heavy.

What then are the light? If for a light matter one is urged up to three times and then the transgression is relinquished, that is called a light matter. Whatever does not arise from moral discipline, that which has been taught as not being part of the conduct of the wholly impure, is not to be practiced alongside such impure conduct.

That which arises from the Vinaya is the thorough training in moral discipline, the not relying on those whose moral discipline has degenerated, and the arising of a mind of great joy upon seeing one who inclines toward and walks in accordance with moral discipline. One who knows all that is to be done as the Dharma of the buddhas and is supremely skilled in teaching it — such a person is called a master of moral discipline. One who is thoroughly versed even in a single syllable, or who holds the sūtras with great mastery, is likewise the same.

Therefore, son of good family, the Dharma of the buddhas is immeasurable and inconceivable, and the Tathāgata too is inconceivable.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: "It is so, it is indeed so. Just as the Blessed One has declared — the Dharma of the buddhas is inconceivable, and the Tathāgata is inconceivable. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent, indestructible, and unchanging. I myself shall apply myself to this with great diligence, and I wish to teach these very meanings extensively to

others as well."

Then the Blessed One gave the bodhisattva Kāśyapa the word "Excellent! Excellent!" and spoke these words: "The body of the Tathāgata is a vajra body, an indestructible body. Bodhisattvas should train in this and come to see and know it as such. Whoever directly cognizes and sees it in this way — that is called seeing the Tathāgata's vajra body, the indestructible body, just as one sees a reflection in a mirror."

This is the second chapter, called "The Vajra Body," from the Great Sūtra of the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow (Mahāparinirvāṇa).

Then the Blessed One again spoke these words to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, you should hold the name, the words, and the qualities of this sūtra well. Whatever son or daughter of good family merely hears the name of this sūtra — for them there is no occasion to be reborn in the four lower states of existence. Why is that? It is because I declare this sūtra to be the qualities accomplished by immeasurable, incalculable buddhas, Blessed Ones."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, what is the name of this sūtra? How should bodhisattvas, great beings, hold it?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "The name of this sūtra is 'The Great Passage Beyond Sorrow' — good at the beginning, good in the middle, good at the end; its meaning is excellent, its words are excellent; it is unmixed, thoroughly pure, wholly and purely the conduct of brahmahood, a precious treasury like a vajra, undiminished. Listen to it very well, and I shall explain it to you."

"Son of good family, the word 'great' in the name means 'permanent.' For example, just as the eight great rivers all flow into the ocean, so too does this sūtra — having subdued all afflictions and all the hosts of māras — ultimately release body and life into the great passage beyond sorrow. Hence it is called the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow.

"Son of good family, consider the example of a skillful physician whose excellent compendium of medical treatments contains all medical treatments gathered together. In the same way, son of good family, all the profound aspects of the Dharma taught by the Tathāgata are gathered into the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow. Hence it is called the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow.

"Son of good family, consider this example: farmers who have sown seeds in their fields during the summer always carry hope in their hearts, and when the

fruit comes to hand, all their hoping comes to rest.

Son of good family, all sentient beings are likewise: one who meditates on other sūtras always hopes for this taste of the Dharma. Yet when one has heard this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow, all hope for the taste of the Dharma from other sūtras comes to rest — and this is because this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow liberates all sentient beings from conditioned existence.

Son of good family, consider this example: among all kinds of tracks, the track of the bull elephant is supreme. Likewise, this sūtra surpasses all other sūtras in meditative absorption.

Son of good family, consider this example: among the things plowed in a field, autumn sowing is supreme among field crops. Likewise, this sūtra is the supreme of all sūtras.

Son of good family, consider this example: among medicines, butter essence is supreme. Likewise, this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow is supreme, for it pacifies the minds of all sentient beings tormented by their afflictions.

Son of good family, consider this example: butter and cream possess eight kinds of flavor. Likewise, this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow also possesses eight flavors. What are the eight? Permanence, stability, bliss, coolness, freedom from aging, freedom from death, freedom from stain, and perfect peace — these are called the eight flavors. Because it possesses these eight flavors, it is called the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in this fully and continuously — it is that very one who demonstrates the passage beyond sorrow. Such a one is called the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow.

Kāśyapa, whatever son or daughter of good family wishes to pass beyond sorrow through this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow should train in this way: know that the Tathāgata is possessed of the quality of permanence and abiding, and know that the Dharma and the Saṅgha are likewise.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa said this to the Blessed One: "How wondrous, Blessed One! The qualities of the Tathāgata are inconceivable, the Dharma and the Saṅgha are inconceivable, and this Great Passage Beyond Sorrow is also inconceivable. Whoever studies this sūtra attains the true gateway of the Dharma and may be called a skilled physician. Those who do not study it I regard as blind, lacking the eye of wisdom, utterly covered over by ignorance."

This is the third chapter of the noble sūtra the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow, entitled "Proclaiming the Qualities of Its Name."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who expounds and teaches the Great Passage Beyond Sorrow should be skilled in these four defining marks. What are the four? Acting properly toward oneself, conducting oneself properly toward others, answering questions just as they are asked, and being skilled in dependent origination.

"What is acting properly toward oneself? The Blessed One, the Buddha, having observed dependent origination, taught it. Consider the example of a monk who, upon seeing a great mass of fire, thinks: 'I would sooner enter that great mass of fire and be burned.' He does not disparage the twelve divisions of the sūtras spoken by the Tathāgata and the essential meaning of the interpretive teachings by saying: 'This was taught by the evil Māra.' To whatever extent one speaks of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha as impermanent, one deceives oneself and deceives others as well. Rather: I would sooner have my tongue cut off with a sharp sword than say that the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are impermanent."

One should not believe those who speak in that way, but instead one should arouse a mind of compassion toward them. Holding the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha to be inconceivable, and regarding one's own body as like a great mass of fire — this is called acting rightly toward oneself.

Now, what is meant by acting rightly toward others? Once, when the Blessed One was teaching the Dharma, a woman arrived carrying a nursing infant at her breast. She came to where the Blessed One was, paid homage at the feet of the Buddha, and sat to one side, keeping in mind her intention to make a request of the Buddha. At that moment, knowing this already, the Blessed One spoke to the woman thus: "You have thought of your child with affection and have stirred much butter. Have you come intending to ask something, or not knowing whether to ask?"

The woman then addressed the Blessed One: "It is wonderful! The Blessed One knows just as I had it in my mind. May the Blessed One tell me whether the butter I have offered is much or little. Blessed One, I fear that this bit of butter I gave today, without making a request, may become an obstacle to my life. Therefore may the Tathāgata instruct me."

The Blessed One replied: "The butter that your child has consumed has, from this very moment, become of the highest benefit for his life and body."

Upon hearing these words of the Blessed One, the woman was filled with great joy and spoke again: "I rejoice that the Blessed One has spoken truly! It is excellent that the Blessed One, for the sake of taming sentient beings, has distinguished and taught what should be requested and what need not be requested, and has furthermore taught that all phenomena are without self and are impermanent. Had the Blessed One spoken of permanence at the outset, this retinue gathered to be disciplined would have said, 'This teaching accords with the non-Buddhists,' and would have rejected it."

The Blessed One then said to the woman: "When your child is born and has just learned to run, he also needs food that is easy to digest, and the butter given earlier is no longer sufficient. My own śrāvakas in their immediate circle are likewise like your young child — they cannot digest this teaching of permanence. That is why I first taught suffering, impermanence, and so forth. For those among my śrāvakas' immediate circle who are endowed with good qualities and are able and diligent in practicing the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, I have taught in this very sūtra the six flavors. What are the six flavors? Suffering is like a sour flavor. Impermanence is like a salty flavor. Selflessness is like a bitter flavor. Bliss is like a sweet flavor. Self is like a pungent flavor. Permanence is like an astringent flavor. In the world there are three flavors: impermanence, selflessness, and the absence of bliss. Affliction is like wood, and wisdom is like fire; by their cause and their condition, what becomes the food of nirvāṇa is permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity — and those who have become the immediate circle taste that flavor."

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the woman: "If you need to attend to your affairs and go elsewhere, send the wayward child away from the household and entrust the treasure of jewels to the capable son."

The woman replied: "As the noble one commands — I will show the treasure of jewels to the capable son, but not to the bad one."

The Blessed One then said: "I too am like that. When I pass into complete nirvāṇa,

The Tathāgata, with deliberate intent, taught the unsurpassed treasury of Dharma without displaying it to the śrāvakas of the immediate circle — just as you did not show the treasury of jewels to the wayward child. Entrusting and commending it to the bodhisattvas is just as you entrusted the treasury of

jewels to the capable son. Why is that? The śrāvakas of the immediate circle, holding the perception that birth and transition occur, think: "The Buddha, the Blessed One, has truly passed into nirvāṇa" — yet I have not truly passed into nirvāṇa. It is like this: you have gone on a long journey and have not yet returned, and your wayward child says you have died when you have not. The bodhisattvas, on the other hand, say: "The Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and immutable" — just as your capable son says that you have not died. For this reason I have entrusted the treasury of Dharma taught with unsurpassed intent to the bodhisattvas.

Son of good family, whatever sentient being holds the buddha to be permanent, stable, unchanging, and immutable — know that in that very abiding the buddha dwells. Such beings are rightly called those who truly proclaim to others.

Now, as to how one answers in accordance with what was asked: if a person were to say to the Buddha, the Blessed One, "Without giving any wealth or material goods whatsoever, I would be renowned by the name of a great benefactor" — the Blessed One would reply to him thus: "Those śramaṇas and brahmins and the like who are of few desires and contentment, who do not keep or seek unsolicited requisites — giving them a male servant, a female servant, or a hired worker; giving a woman to one who practices celibacy; giving meat and wine to one who has renounced meat and wine; giving food to one who does not eat after midday; giving flowers and incense to one who does not handle flowers and incense for adornment — such acts will be universally renowned by the name of generosity, and not even the slightest amount of wealth or material goods will be diminished. This is what is called answering in accordance with what was asked."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, although it would be improper to give meat to one who does not seek it, why do I say this? Because I see those who do not seek meat as endowed with eight great qualities."

The Blessed One said to Kāśyapa: "Excellent! It is excellent that you understand my intent. Those bodhisattvas who guard the Dharma should understand it thus. Son of good family, from this day forward I do not permit those of the immediate śrāvaka circle to eat meat. Even if a faithful donor gives it, one should cultivate the perception of it as being like the flesh of one's own child."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: "Blessed One, why does the Tathāgata not permit the seeking of meat?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, eating meat severs the seed of great compassion."

Kāśyapa asked: "Did not the Blessed One previously permit the eating of meat that is pure in three respects?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, permitting the eating of meat pure in three respects was taught as a gradual method for cutting off the habit."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Why is the eating of the ten kinds of uninspected meat and the nine kinds of inspected meat not permitted?"

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "That too was taught for the purpose of cutting off the habit — in short, it was taught in order to lead toward the complete abandonment of meat."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then said:

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, why did the Tathāgata declare fish to be a permitted food?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, I never declared fish and the like to be permitted foods. What I declared to be permitted foods were sugarcane, rice, barley, buckwheat, millet, and other grains, sesame, milk, yogurt, butter, oil, and the like. And although I did permit wearing many kinds of garments, even that permission was given only for the purpose of covering the body and changing appearance — how much less, then, could attachment to fish be acceptable. As for what Kāśyapa has said — that if the Tathāgata does not permit the seeking of meat, then by the same reasoning the five kinds of flavors, namely milk, yogurt, fresh butter, clarified butter, and sesame oil and the like, and garments of silk, necklaces, sandals, and vessels of gold and silver, should also not be permitted — the Blessed One replied: Son of good family, that view is not in accord with the view of the naked ascetics. Rather, the Tathāgata, having considered separately those who are bound by moral discipline, taught accordingly; and because the intention differed, the eating of meat pure in three respects was permitted. Because the perception differed, ten kinds of meat were prohibited. And because the perception differed, meat from animals that died naturally and all such meat was not permitted for eating. Kāśyapa, from this day forward, I declare that those who have become my close attendants must not eat any meat whatsoever."

Kāśyapa, those who eat meat — whether walking, staying, sitting, or lying down — cause fear and terror in every sentient being their scent reaches. It is like this: when a person reeks of the smell of a lion, everyone is afraid and terrified. Son of good family, it is like a person who has eaten garlic — on account of the smell, everyone finds them disagreeable and keeps away, to say nothing of drawing near to them. Those who eat meat are just the same: when the smell of meat reaches sentient beings, they become frightened, and the perception of mortal danger arises in them. Every creature dwelling in water, dwelling on land, or moving through the sky flees and runs away, saying, "This is our enemy." Therefore bodhisattvas do not strive to eat meat. They may demonstrate eating meat in order to liberate sentient beings, and they may appear to eat it, but in reality they do not eat it. Son of good family, so it is that a bodhisattva does not even eat pure food — how much less need it be said that they would eat meat.

Son of good family, after I have passed completely into nirvāṇa, when a measureless hundred of years have passed, noble ones who have arisen through the four noble paths will likewise pass into nirvāṇa, and the true Dharma will decline. When people treat images as Dharma, there will be monks who affect the appearance of those who uphold the Vinaya, and who recite and chant the sūtras only a little; who are attached to food for the sustenance of the body, who wear coarse and rough garments, whose complexion has become dark, who have lost their splendor, who raise cattle and sheep, who carry loads of wood and grass, who let their hair and nails grow long. Though they wear the ochre robe, they are like hunters — with downcast eyes and slow steps, like cats stalking mice. They constantly declare, "I am an arhat," yet they are tormented by illness, suffering, sleep, and impurity. Outwardly they affect good conduct, but inwardly their minds are overwhelmed by jealousy and desire, making them no different from brahmins of wrong views and the like. Though not true ascetics, they present themselves in the form of ascetics, cultivate wrong views, and slander the true Dharma as well. Those persons render improper the moral discipline, the Vinaya, the conduct, and the teaching of the fruit of liberation as established by the Tathāgata; they render improper the teaching to abandon uninspected phenomena; they render improper even the profoundly intended teachings. Then, composing sūtras and Vinaya teachings of their own invention,

They would say, "The Tathāgata has permitted us to eat meat," write it down, argue with one another claiming it was spoken by the Buddha, and each one

proclaim, "I am an ascetic, a son of the Śākyas."

O son of good family, at that time there will also be other monks who stockpile large quantities of grain, handle and consume fish, carry vessels of butter, precious parasols, and sandals, depend upon kings, ministers, and householders, study and practice astrology, reading of omens, divination, and medicine; keep male and female servants, and use gold, silver, musāragalva, sphatika crystal, crystal cloth, pearls, coral, shells, and various kinds of ornamental chains and fruit of every variety. They will also engage in sports and games, archery, the crafting of written texts, plowing and cultivating fields, casting spells, combining mantras with medicines, and songs, dancing, music, and the offering of incense and flowers. They will study and practice the application of eye-salves and collyrium, and every manner of craft and trade.

Any monk who has abandoned these non-virtuous things is to be understood as a true companion of mine. Then Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One, saying: Blessed One, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen who depend on donors for their livelihood, when they go for alms and are offered food mixed with meat, how should they proceed? How should they examine it?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: Separate the meat from the food, wash it with water, and then eat. If the alms-bowl has been touched by meat but carries no smell or taste of it, there is no fault in using it. If, when going for alms, meat comes in great quantity, it should not be accepted. If meat is visible within the food, do not eat it. If one does eat it, there is a transgression. Were I to explain in full this matter, together with the prohibition against eating meat that I have set forth, there would be no end to it; and since the time of my passing into nirvāṇa has come, I have spoken only in part.

These, then, are called the answers to the questions put.

Now, Kāśyapa, in what way is one to be considered learned in the meaning of dependent origination? It is like this: when the fourfold retinue came into my presence and asked the Blessed One why, from the time the Tathāgata first fully awakened, he did not teach this exceedingly profound doctrinal text to the utterly vanquished royal host, whereas at some times he taught it as utterly profound, at other times as not profound, at some times called it degenerate, and at others said it was not degenerate, and asked in what case one should speak of a transgression, and what is meant by the Vinaya of individual liberation (prātimokṣa)?

The Blessed One declared: Individual liberation (prātimokṣa) means knowing contentment, being endowed with proper conduct, hoarding absolutely nothing, and maintaining a completely pure livelihood. A transgression is a falling in regard to the four classes of tantra. Furthermore, a transgression means falling into the hells or all the way to the realm of ceaseless torment; and the swiftest of descents is like the fall of violent rain, beyond any reversal. Even hearing of it alone causes fear and terror, so that one will be diligent in guarding moral discipline, maintaining the restraint of conduct, knowing contentment, and refraining from accepting any uninspected material goods.

Furthermore, a transgression means generating the realms of the hells, animals, and hungry ghosts. Because of this meaning, it is called a transgression. And further, individual liberation means the complete abandonment of all unwholesome actions of body, speech, and mind.

The Vinaya (monastic discipline) enters into the profoundly deep meaning of moral discipline and the sūtras, and does not permit the acceptance of any uninspected material goods or uninspected causes and conditions. Furthermore, it does not permit the practice of the four defeats, the thirteen remainders of the Saṅgha, the two undetermined cases, the thirty rules entailing forfeiture and confession, the ninety-one downfalls, the four individually confessed rules, the many trainings, and the seven rules of extremely peaceful settlement, and so forth. For some individuals there is even the complete breakdown of all moral discipline. The term "all" here refers to everything from the four defeats up through the seven rules of extremely peaceful settlement.

For some individuals, having denigrated the profoundly deep authentic Dharma and become ones with distorted craving, they seize upon all defining characteristics and conceive of them as complete even in the absence of causes and conditions, while proclaiming, "I myself am sharp-facultied and endowed with wisdom." They conceal and hide every serious and light misdeed, just as a turtle draws in its six limbs. Such ones who commit misdeeds feel no remorse for a long time, and because they feel no remorse, the misdeeds grow and multiply day and night. Those monks in whom offenses have arisen never feel remorse, and so the offenses pervade them entirely. It is for this reason that the Tathāgata, knowing these matters, established the rules gradually rather than all at once.

At that time, sons and daughters of noble family addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Since the Tathāgata knew this, why did he not establish the rules from the beginning? Has the Blessed One not sent sentient beings to the avīci hells? For example, when many people travel to another region and a road guide leads them astray so that they wander off the path and enter upon what is not the path, those people do not realize they have been led astray but think it is the road; there is then no occasion to ask others whether or not it is the path. Just so, sentient beings are led astray by the Buddha's teachings, and when they do not see what is truly correct, the Tathāgata then shows them the true path from the beginning, saying, 'Monks, this is a breach of moral discipline; this is the guarding of moral discipline.' Since the establishment of moral discipline is appropriate, why did the Tathāgata — who is perfectly and completely awakened, who knows and sees the true path, who is like a god among gods, and who is supremely skilled in presenting the qualities and aims of the ten virtuous actions — why did he not establish this moral discipline from the beginning?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of noble family, it is true that the Tathāgata teaches sentient beings the qualities of the ten virtuous actions. However, the Tathāgata looks upon all sentient beings as he would upon his own son Rāhula. Why then do you say that the Blessed One has sent sentient beings to the hells? When I see that some individual has acquired the causes for falling into the avīci hells, I nonetheless remain in the world for a full eon or for the remainder of a full eon for the sake of that individual. Since I am endowed with great compassion toward all sentient beings, I — who regard all as my own children — would I then send sentient beings to the hells? Son of noble family, consider this example: in this royal domain, those who wear stitched garments, if there is a hole torn in the cloth, mend it with a patch at once. The Tathāgata is similar: when he sees even a single cause or condition that would lead a sentient being to fall into the avīci hells, he protects that being through the moral discipline of virtue. Son of noble family, consider further:

Consider this example: a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) first tames sentient beings through the teaching of the ten virtues. Afterward, should there be those who engage in non-virtue, he punishes them with whatever penalty is fitting. Having imposed the penalty for their offense, he then causes them to live by the law of the primordial royal order. Son of noble family, I am similar to this: even though the teaching exists, what was not established at the outset — should monks behave in ways contrary to the Dharma — is now

established with whatever rules are fitting. In this way, those who have devotion to the Dharma will come to have devotion toward the Teacher as well. It is for this reason that the assembly came to see the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata.

Consider further: the precious wheel of the wheel-turning king is inconceivable. The Tathāgata likewise is inconceivable; the Dharma and the Saṅgha are likewise inconceivable; the teaching of the Dharma and the hearing of the Dharma are likewise inconceivable. This is what is called being skilled in dependent origination.

A bodhisattva who is skilled in analyzing the meaning of these four aspects of defining characteristics is called one skilled in the meaning of dependent origination within the Great Vehicle's great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, regarding what is called "I acting rightly with respect to myself" — this refers to attaining the great nirvāṇa. "Others acting rightly with respect to others" refers to my teaching the monks that the Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting. "Answering what was asked" refers to the fact that, because Kāśyapa asked, I taught the bodhisattvas, the great beings, the monks, the nuns, the laymen, and the laywomen extensively on the meaning of what is profound. The meaning of dependent origination is this: śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not know this meaning, which is so very profound — they speak of it in syllables, like the letter "i," by means of three dots — and those who have not heard the essence of what I taught with the great wisdom of liberation and the passing into nirvāṇa, I have today laid out and taught distinctly to the śrāvakas, thereby opening the eye of wisdom.

Now, if someone should say, "These four aspects of what exists are one — would that not be false?" — one should respond to that person thus: "Space is utterly empty, unmoving and undisturbed; what distinction could there then be among the four aspects? Would it be right to call that false? No, Blessed One. These many words all have a single meaning: that is, the meaning of emptiness." The acting rightly of self and other, the answering of questions, and the meaning of dependent origination are likewise the same — they are not separate from or different from great nirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of noble family or daughter of noble family who says this — 'The Tathāgata is impermanent' — if asked, 'How is he impermanent?' — as the Blessed One has taught, nirvāṇa is called the cessation of all afflictions. Just as when a fire dies there is nothing whatsoever

left, the cessation of all afflictions is likewise like that — and if that is what is called nirvāṇa, why then speak of the Tathāgata as one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting?

"Or again, as the Blessed One has taught, nirvāṇa is called freedom from existence. If in nirvāṇa there is no existence whatsoever, how then can the Tathāgata be said to be one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting? It is like worn-out and tattered cloth — when it has perished, there is nothing whatsoever. Nirvāṇa is similar: if with the cessation of all afflictions there is nothing whatsoever that can be called an existing thing —"

"And why, then, speak of the Tathāgata as one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting? As the Blessed One has taught, freedom from desire and perfect peace is called passing beyond sorrow — nirvāṇa. It is like a man whose head has been cut off: one says that he has no head. Just so, freedom from desire and perfect peace is like that — empty, with nothing whatsoever — and this is called nirvāṇa. Then again, why speak of the Tathāgata as one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting?"

And the Blessed One further declared this in verse:

Just as iron that is blazing hot,
when struck with a hammer, gives off sparks,
and once they scatter, they are gone at once —
their whereabouts cannot be known.

So too, one who is perfectly liberated
bears a characteristic like to that:
having utterly abandoned all desire,
having crossed beyond the swamp of existence,
having attained the abode of the unmoving —
the place reached cannot be known.

Having spoken thus, the Blessed One was asked again: "Why then speak of the Tathāgata as one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting?"

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, any person who speaks in that way speaks wrongly. Kāśyapa, you yourself must not give rise to a perception of cessation and extinction with respect to the Tathāgata himself. Kāśyapa, the cessation

of afflictions is not designated as 'a thing.' Why? Because it is consummate, it is called permanent. This word is perfect peace — it is supreme. All marks, without remainder, are exhausted. This word is pure, permanent, stable, irreversible. Therefore nirvāṇa is called permanent and stable. The Tathāgata likewise is such — permanent, stable, and unchanging. What is called impermanent is the afflictions. 'Scattering apart and becoming nonexistent, with no place to be found' means that the Tathāgata, with all afflictions ceased, does not abide in the five streams of consciousness. Therefore the Tathāgata is one whose nature it is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting.

"Furthermore, Kāśyapa, the Teacher of the buddhas is the Dharma. Therefore the Tathāgata too shows veneration and homage. Because the Dharma is permanent, the buddhas too are permanent."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One again, saying: "If, because the fire of the afflictions has been extinguished, the Tathāgata too is extinguished, then the Tathāgata does not abide permanently. It is like iron that has been heated to a red glow — when it cools, it cannot be found. The afflictions of the Tathāgata are similar: when they are at peace, the place of peace too cannot be found. Furthermore, it is like iron: when its heat and redness have cooled and ceased to exist — so too the Tathāgata is like that: cooled and without permanence, for when the fire of the afflictions is extinguished and he has entered into complete nirvāṇa, the Tathāgata is impermanent."

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, what is called 'iron' refers to inferior bellows-work — and inferior bellows-work, even if the afflictions cease, produces them again immediately afterward, and so is called impermanent. The Tathāgata is not like that: because once ceased, he does not arise again, he is called permanent."

Kāśyapa said: "But just as iron, after its red glow has cooled, when fire is applied again afterward becomes red once more — if the Tathāgata is like that, then the afflictions would arise again, and because the afflictions arise again, he would be impermanent."

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "You must not say that the Tathāgata is impermanent. Why? Because the Tathāgata is permanent. Son of good family, consider: even when wood is burned, there is still ash. When the afflictions are extinguished, nirvāṇa exists —"

— like the example of a worn garment, a severed head, or a broken vessel, and so on. Those things still bear their respective names: "worn garment," "severed head," "broken vessel." Kāśyapa, though iron cools, it can become hot again afterward. The Tathāgata is not like that: having cut off the afflictions and become utterly cool at the end, the fire of the afflictions will never arise again. Kāśyapa, know that the immeasurable multitude of sentient beings is like that iron, and that I, through the fire of undefiled wisdom, burn away those sentient beings' defilements.

Then Kāśyapa said: "Excellent! Excellent! Today I have heard rightly that the Tathāgata is indeed permanent."

The sixth fascicle.

The Blessed One spoke to Kāśyapa: "Consider, for example, a wheel-turning king who goes outside his palace to take a stroll. Even though he is absent from the midst of his great retinue, it would not be right to say that the wheel-turning king has died. Son of good family, the Tathāgata is likewise: even though he is not manifest in this world-realm of Jambudvīpa and has entered into nirvāṇa, one must not say that he is impermanent. The Tathāgata arose from immeasurable afflictions, yet having entered nirvāṇa, he dwells in the abode of perfect bliss, wanders amid the flowers of the branches of awakening, and lives in perfect ease."

Then Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, you have said, 'I crossed over the ocean of afflictions long ago.' If the Blessed One has indeed crossed over the ocean of afflictions, then why was a son born to Rāhulā — like a son born to one who grasps at fame? It therefore seems as though the Tathāgata has not yet escaped the great ocean of afflictions and defilements. Blessed One, I ask you to explain to me the cause and condition of this."

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "You must not say: 'If the Tathāgata crossed over the ocean of afflictions long ago, then why was a son born to Rāhulā like Rāhula? — and so the Tathāgata is no different from one who has not crossed over the great ocean of afflictions and defilements.' Do not speak in that way. Son of good family, the great and complete nirvāṇa is an establishment of great meaning, so listen with thorough and careful attention, teach it extensively to others as well, and give rise to neither doubt nor fear.

When a bodhisattva, a great being, dwells in the great complete nirvāṇa, he is as lofty and vast as Mount Meru, king of mountains. Even if he were placed inside a single mustard seed, the sentient beings dwelling on Mount Meru

would not perceive one another's presence nor know of one another's movement. Only those of the disposition that can be tamed would, by the bodhisattva's power, see Mount Meru placed inside that mustard seed and then restored to its place.

Son of good family, furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, dwells in the great complete nirvāṇa, even if this entire great trichiliocosm were placed inside a single mustard seed, the sentient beings dwelling therein would not perceive one another nor know of one another's movement from place to place. Only those of the disposition that can be tamed would know that the bodhisattva had placed this great trichiliocosm inside the mustard seed and then restored it to its place.

Son of good family, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa is capable of placing this great trichiliocosm into a single pore of a hair and then restoring it — in its full expanse — to its former place.

Son of good family, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa is capable of taking up this great trichiliocosm and placing it on the tip of a needle, or of hurling it to another buddha-field altogether — and throughout this, not a single sentient being dwelling therein would know from where they had come or where they had gone. Only those of the disposition that can be tamed would know, from the moment of their being taken up to the moment of their restoration to their former place.

Son of good family, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa is capable of taking up with the right hand all the world-systems of the great trichiliocosms of the ten directions, spinning them like a potter's wheel, and hurling them to a distance equal to as many atoms as there are world-systems — and the sentient beings dwelling therein would not perceive even the slightest movement, neither going nor coming. Only those of the disposition that can be tamed would know, from the moment of their being taken up to the moment of their being brought back to their former place.

Son of good family, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa is capable of placing within his own belly all the immeasurable buddha-fields of the ten directions — and the sentient beings dwelling therein would neither crowd one another nor feel crowded, would not know of going or coming or remaining. Only those of the disposition that can

be tamed would know, from the moment of this taking place to the moment of their restoration to their former place.

Son of good family, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa is capable of placing all the world-systems of the ten directions within a single atom — and the sentient beings dwelling therein would neither crowd one another nor feel crowded, and would not know of going or coming. Only those of the disposition that can be tamed would know, from the moment it is seen to be so until the moment of their return to their place.

Son of good family, thus it is that a bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the great complete nirvāṇa displays an immeasurable array of such miraculous displays of higher knowledge — and for this reason it is called the great complete nirvāṇa.

Now, when this bodhisattva, this great being, displays these immeasurable miraculous shows of higher knowledge, and when no sentient being is able to gauge or comprehend them — how then could you understand that the Tathāgata has given birth to a son named Rāhula simply because he was drawn toward the realm of desire? Son of good family, it is because he has long dwelt in this great complete nirvāṇa and has displayed manifold miraculous shows of higher knowledge — appearing in hundreds of forms in hundreds of suns and moons, and in hundreds of Jambudvīpas throughout the great trichiliocosm — just as it is taught in detail in the sūtra of the meditative absorption known as "Going Heroically." Though I show this great trichiliocosm's Jambudvīpa my full passing into nirvāṇa, in the end I have not truly and finally passed into nirvāṇa. And though I show my entry into the womb of a mother here in Jambudvīpa, it is in order that the father, the mother, and the world might conceive of me as their son — for my body is not ultimately born from a gathering of desire. I have, for an immeasurably long time across countless eons, utterly abandoned desire; therefore this body of mine is a dharmakāya — and yet I have displayed, in accordance with worldly convention, an entry into the womb.

Son of good family, here in Jambudvīpa, in the Lumbinī Grove, I was born from the womb of my mother, the goddess Māyā — and immediately upon birth I took seven steps toward the east and said these words: "Among gods, humans, and asuras, I am the highest, the most excellent, the foremost." And upon seeing this, the father and mother, and all the gods and humans of the

world, were filled with joy, and in their minds arose a sense of wonder and amazement.

All people regarded me as a mere infant. And yet this body of mine has been free, from immeasurable eons past, from any such qualities of affliction. The Tathāgata's body is the dharmakāya — it is not a body made from flesh and blood, sinew and tendon, bones and limbs — and yet, in accordance with worldly convention, I displayed the body of a newborn child.

Taking seven steps toward the south, I manifestly revealed to immeasurable sentient beings the unsurpassable field of merit. Taking seven steps toward the west, I displayed this as the final body — one in which birth is exhausted, and there is no more aging or death. Taking seven steps toward the north, I displayed liberation from all the wandering of existence in saṃsāra. Taking seven steps toward the east, I manifestly revealed myself to be the Teacher of sentient beings. Taking seven steps each toward the four intermediate directions, I displayed the complete and perfect awakening of the Tathāgata — having utterly vanquished the various kinds of affliction and the four māras. Taking seven steps in the upward direction, I displayed one who is unstained by any and all impure things, become like the sky. Taking seven steps in the downward direction, I extinguished the fires of the hells with a rain of Dharma, so that those sentient beings would experience great bliss — and to those of corrupt moral discipline I displayed this as a hailstorm and a storm of thunder.

Having been born in Jambudvīpa and seven days having passed, I displayed the cutting of hair, and all people regarded me as a newborn infant. When the hair was first cut, there is no one in the world — no god, human, māra, Brahmā, brahmin, or any other — who is able to see even the uṣṇīṣa mark atop my head; how much less could anyone take up a blade and cut my hair? To take up a blade and shave the crown of my head is simply impossible. Yet I, for a very long time, throughout immeasurable eons, have worn my hair and beard cut short — and even now, I have displayed the cutting of hair in accordance with worldly convention.

From the very moment of my birth, my father and mother, wishing to present me to the gods, carried me into a shrine of the gods and presented me to the great lord of the gods who rules over them. When the great lord of gods saw me, he joined his palms together in reverence and, making obeisance, stood respectfully to one side. For a very long time, throughout immeasurable eons, I have abstained from entering into divine shrines — and yet this too I displayed

in order to accord with worldly convention.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa the piercing of the ears. No sentient being whatsoever can truly pierce my ears — and yet this too I manifestly displayed in order to accord with worldly convention. Lion-shaped earrings were fashioned from precious jewels and placed upon my ears — and yet for throughout immeasurable eons I have entirely abandoned all adornments and ornaments. This too I displayed in order to accord with worldly convention.

I also attended a school of letters and studied writing and arithmetic. Throughout immeasurable eons, endowed as I am with all excellence, were one to examine the three realms, there is no sentient being whatsoever who could serve as my teacher — and yet this too, entering a school of learning, I displayed in order to accord with worldly convention.

Therefore, one speaks of a Tathāgata, a perfectly complete buddha. I displayed the training in elephant riding, the taming of horses, the overcoming of opponents in strength, and the cultivation of various kinds of athletic skill. I also displayed in Jambudvīpa the role of a regent, and sentient beings, taking me for a regent, saw me thoroughly enjoying the five objects of desire. For throughout immeasurable eons I have entirely abandoned the pleasures of the five objects of desire — and yet this too I displayed in order to accord with worldly convention.

When the astrologers examined my marks, they declared that if I did not go forth into renunciation, I would become a wheel-turning king —

and would rule over Jambudvīpa — and all sentient beings believed this. But I had long since relinquished the methods of a wheel-turning king through immeasurable eons, and had entered instead upon the role of a king who turns the wheel of Dharma. In Jambudvīpa I displayed renouncing many women and the five objects of desire, beholding old age, sickness, and death, and seeing an ascetic — and so all sentient beings said: "Surely the regent Suyaśas has at last gone forth into renunciation." Yet I had already gone forth and cultivated the path throughout immeasurable eons; this too I displayed merely to accord with worldly convention.

In Jambudvīpa, I displayed going forth from home into homelessness, receiving full ordination, and applying myself with great diligence to the path — attaining in sequence the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, and finally the fruit of arhatship — so that ordinary beings would think: "Attaining the fruit of arhatship is not so difficult; it is

rather easy." Yet I had already attained the fruit of arhatship innumerable eons ago; I displayed this too in order to tame sentient beings.

At the seat of awakening, I displayed sitting on the grass I had spread there, subduing the hosts of Māra. Ordinary beings thought: "It is only now, at the seat of awakening, that he is subduing the hosts of Māra." But I had already subdued every Māra innumerable eons before; I displayed the subduing of Māra in order to tame sentient beings who were yet untamed.

I also displayed the elimination of great and small bodily impurities, and the movement of breath in and out — so that ordinary beings would think: "He has great and small bodily impurities, and inward and outward breathing." This body of mine is the fruit of merit, and is therefore free from such inattentiveness as involves great and small impurities and inward and outward breathing; yet I displayed even this in order to accord with worldly convention.

I also displayed accepting food given by opponents — even though there is in this body of mine no inattentiveness born of hunger or thirst. Yet this too I displayed in order to accord with worldly convention.

Furthermore, I displayed lying down and sleeping in conformity with ordinary beings. I have possessed, throughout immeasurable eons, the most profound wisdom and have been utterly free from the three states of existence — yet I displayed walking, standing, moving about, carrying a load on the head, carrying a load on the back, carrying a load on the side, having sores, bathing, washing the feet, washing the hands, washing the face, rinsing the mouth, and chewing a tooth-stick — so that ordinary beings would think: "He has all of these." In truth, this body of mine has none of them. My feet are utterly pure like lotuses, and my face has the fragrance of the unsullied blue lotus flower — yet ordinary beings think of me as a person. In reality, inwardly I am not a person.

I also displayed wearing stitched cloth, rinsing it, mending it, and walking about — yet I had long since ceased to need clothing. Ordinary beings thought: "Rāhula is his son, King Śuddhodana is his father, Māyādevī is his mother; he enjoyed worldly pleasures and then abandoned all these things, went forth into renunciation, and applies himself diligently to the path." Others thought: "He is the eldest regent-son of a great king, belonging to the noble Gautama lineage, and has renounced all worldly happiness to seek the Dharma that transcends the world." But I have long since entirely abandoned all the objects of worldly desire; all of this was merely a display.

O son of good family, even though I repeatedly display passing into nirvāṇa in this Jambudvīpa —

it is not a final, complete passing into nirvāṇa. Ordinary people think: "The Tathāgata has truly and finally ceased to exist." Yet the Tathāgata does not come to an end; know him to be one whose nature is to abide permanently, unchanging and unshifting.

O son of good family, what is called the great nirvāṇa is the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena, of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones.

Furthermore, I displayed appearing in this world in Jambudvīpa, and ordinary people think: "He has only now attained awakening." Yet I displayed an awakening in Jambudvīpa at the very beginning of the world — even though, for countless eons, I had already accomplished every act that needed to be accomplished.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa the appearance of one who had not restrained his ethical conduct and had broken all four root precepts. Ordinary people thus think that I had truly broken my ethical conduct — yet in reality, throughout countless eons, there has never been any lapse in my keeping of the precepts.

I also displayed appearing in Jambudvīpa as one with wrong craving. All ordinary people think of me as truly having wrong craving — yet I do not truly have wrong craving. For if I did have wrong craving, how could I have attained awakening to the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete enlightenment?

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa the appearance of one who had caused a schism in the Saṅgha. Ordinary people think that I truly created a schism in the Saṅgha — yet when I look out upon all the world with its gods and humans, I do not see anyone who could truly cause a schism in the Saṅgha.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa the appearance of one who protects the sacred Dharma. Ordinary people, thinking me to be a guardian of the Dharma, are all filled with wonder. But this is simply the nature of reality of the buddhas — and so one should not be astonished at it.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa appearing in the body of the wicked māra. Ordinary people truly think of me as the wicked māra — yet throughout countless eons I have been entirely free from all acts of māra, pure as a lotus, untainted by anything.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa attaining buddhahood in the body of a woman. Ordinary people think: "How wondrous! A woman has attained awakening to

unsurpassed, perfect, and complete enlightenment!" Yet the Tathāgata never truly takes on a female body; it is only displayed in female form in order to train immeasurable sentient beings. Out of affection for all sentient beings, he displays a vast variety of forms and appearances.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa taking birth in the four lower states of existence along the path of karma. I have long since severed the stream of transmigration through those states — yet to train the sentient beings dwelling in those realms, I displayed birth there as well, through the power of karma.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa appearing as the divine king Brahmā. This was done in order to bring those who revere Brahmā into the true Dharma. In truth I am not actually Brahmā — yet ordinary people think of me as the true divine king Brahmā. In the same way, I have displayed appearing in divine form as various other gods.

I also displayed in Jambudvīpa going to the dwelling of a woman who sells snakes. In truth, there is not in me even a perception of desire; I am pure and untainted as a lotus, unaffected by anything. Yet for the sake of teaching the sacred Dharma at crossroads to sentient beings overwhelmed by desire,

In me there is not even a mind of attachment or desire, yet ordinary people think of me as one who comes under the sway of women. I also displayed in this Jambudvīpa going about among the caste of those who wear blue garments, and this was in order to bring those who had become servants into the true Dharma. Know well that in me there is in truth no karma of falling into the station of those who wear blue garments. I also displayed in this Jambudvīpa appearing as something like a teacher, and this was in order to bring millions of young boys and girls into the true Dharma. I also displayed in this Jambudvīpa drinking wine, residing in royal courts, and engaging in contest and rivalry for the sake of victory or defeat, and all of this was in order to tame and liberate those sentient beings. Although I possess no such bad karma, ordinary people think of me as one who also performs such actions. I also displayed for a long time in charnel grounds in the body of a vulture, and this was in order to liberate all birds. Ordinary people truly think of me as a vulture, yet though I have long since been free of any such karma, I displayed even that form in order to liberate beings of the bird kind.

I also displayed in this Jambudvīpa the body of a householder, in order to tame and bring countless sentient beings into the sacred Dharma. Beyond this, I appeared as a king, as ministers, as princes, and as great counselors, and in

each of these roles I was foremost and supreme, entering into the ways of kingship so that the sacred Dharma might be diligently upheld. I also appeared in this Jambudvīpa when an age of pestilence arose, and I healed the many sentient beings tormented by disease with medicine, and afterward taught the sacred Dharma and established them in unsurpassable awakening; yet ordinary people think that a true age of pestilence had arisen. Furthermore, when an age of famine arose in this Jambudvīpa, I gave those beings food and drink according to their every wish, and then first taught the sacred Dharma and established them in unsurpassable awakening. Furthermore, when an age of war and weapons arose in this Jambudvīpa, I taught the sacred Dharma amid it, caused them to abandon the holding of enmity toward enemies, and established them in unsurpassable awakening.

Furthermore, to those who cling to permanence I taught the perception of impermanence; to those who perceive happiness I taught the perception of suffering; to those who perceive a self I taught selflessness; and to those who perceive utter purity I taught the perception of impurity. For any sentient being who clings with attachment to the three realms, I teach the sacred Dharma and cause that being to abandon that abode. In order to tame and liberate sentient beings, I teach the supreme and sacred Dharma as though it were medicine. In order to cut down every tree of affliction entirely, I cause to grow the supreme tree of Dharma-medicine. In order to tame and liberate those who are non-Buddhists, I teach the true Dharma. Although I display openly as the teacher of all sentient beings, from the very beginning I do not think of myself as "the teacher of sentient beings." I also display openly the going among the lowly and base in order to liberate them, and this is for the sake of teaching the Dharma — it is not that a body of that kind is taken up through bad karma. The Tathāgata, the fully and perfectly awakened buddha, abides in ease in the great and complete nirvāṇa in just this way. Therefore he is said to be ever-abiding, possessed of unchanging qualities.

Just as it is with Jambudvīpa, so likewise it extends in the same way to the eastern continent of Videha, the western continent of Godānīya, and the northern continent of Uttarakuru. And just as it is with the four continents, so too it is the same with the great trichilocosm, the world-system of the three-thousandfold great thousand worlds.

The twenty-five existences are as extensively taught in the sūtra known as the Courageous Progression. For that reason it is called the great and complete nirvāṇa. A bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in ease within the great and

complete nirvāṇa has no fear in displaying such miraculous powers of direct knowledge. Kāśyapa, for that reason do not say to Rāhu that he is a son of the Buddha. Why is that? Because I have been utterly free from craving for existence throughout immeasurable eons in the past — therefore the Tathāgata is said to be ever-abiding, unchanging, and unaltered.

Kāśyapa then asked: Why is the Tathāgata called one who possesses the quality of ever-abiding? As the Blessed One himself taught, just as a butter-lamp that has gone out has no location and no direction, so too the Tathāgata is like that — did you not teach that upon passing into nirvāṇa there is likewise no location and no direction?

The Blessed One spoke to Kāśyapa: Son of good family, do not say that — that just as a butter-lamp, upon going out, has no location and no direction, so too the Tathāgata is like that, and upon passing into nirvāṇa has no location and no direction.

Son of good family, consider this example. When a man or a woman lights a butter-lamp, they fill a vessel — large or small — with butter and light it. As long as there is butter, the light exists. If the butter is exhausted, the light ceases to exist. The cessation of the light is like the exhaustion of the afflictions. Though the light burns out and disappears, the vessel of the butter-lamp does not thereby cease to exist. The Tathāgata is likewise: though the afflictions are exhausted and gone, the dharmakāya ever remains.

Son of good family, what do you think — do the light and the vessel of the butter-lamp both disappear at once?

Kāśyapa replied: No, Blessed One. They do not disappear simultaneously, yet they both seem impermanent. If the dharmakāya is like the vessel of the butter-lamp, then since the vessel of the butter-lamp is impermanent, the dharmakāya too would be impermanent in the same way.

Son of good family, do not speak like that. What is known in the world as a vessel, and what is called the unsurpassed vessel of Dharma of the buddha, the Blessed One — though the vessel is impermanent, the Tathāgata is not. The passing beyond sorrow of all phenomena is permanent; and because it is the essential nature of the Tathāgata, it is called permanent.

Furthermore, son of good family, the term "the butter-lamp going out" applies to the nirvāṇa of the arhat. Because all the afflictions of desire have been eliminated, it is like a butter-lamp going out. The once-returner still has desire,

and because of that desire it would be incorrect to call him one whose butter-lamp has gone out. Therefore I previously spoke of it as being like a butter-lamp going out in order to negate signs — but the great and complete nirvāṇa is not like a butter-lamp going out.

The non-returner is not one who returns again and again. They do not return to the twenty-five existences, and because they do not take up a coarse body, a body with worms, or a body with afflictions, they are called non-returners. Taking up a body again is called returning; not taking up a body is called not returning. When there is going and returning, it is called returning; when there is no going and no returning, it is called not returning.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words.

"Blessed One, it is not the case that what the Blessed One, the buddha, has spoken carries a hidden meaning, a concealed essence. Why is that? It is true that the Tathāgata speaks with a hidden intent, but there is no concealed essence to what is spoken with hidden intent. Consider, for example, a magician who fashions a wooden automaton in the shape of a man. That wooden man can be seen by everyone, yet its stretching, contracting, bowing, and bending cannot be effected from within. The Dharma of a buddha is not like that. If it is to be seen and known by all sentient beings, then why does the Blessed One say that the Tathāgata speaks with hidden intent and that there is a concealed essence?"

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa, "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, it is just as you have said. Truly, in the Tathāgata there is no concealed essence to what is spoken with hidden intent. Why is that? It is like this: the autumn moon, appearing in the open sky with brilliant clarity and completely unobscured, is seen by all people. Similarly, the word of the Tathāgata is likewise utterly clear and perfectly pure. It is only because foolish and ignoble persons do not understand it that it is called 'spoken with hidden intent and concealed essence.' For the wise and discerning who comprehend it, it is not called secret.

"Noble son, consider this example: a person who has accumulated great quantities of gold and silver, beyond all measure of weight, yet acts with miserliness and gives nothing to the destitute — because they hoard by concealment, their treasury is called hidden. The Tathāgata is not like that. Having accumulated immeasurable precious sacred Dharma over immeasurable eons, and without any miserliness always giving it to all

sentient beings — why should one say that the Tathāgata has a concealed essence in what is spoken with hidden intent?

"Noble son, consider this example: a person whose faculties are incomplete — missing one eye, one hand, or one foot — conceals themselves from others out of shame, and that is called keeping secret. The Tathāgata is not like that. Since all the sacred qualities are perfectly complete and without deficiency, the Tathāgata lets all people see them — so why should one say that the Tathāgata has a concealed essence in what is spoken with hidden intent?

"Noble son, consider this example: a poor man burdened with many debts is afraid of his creditors and hides from being seen — and that is called keeping secret. The Tathāgata is not like that. Having no attachment even to worldly phenomena with respect to any sentient being, and having attachment to the Tathāgata for supramundane phenomena in regard to sentient beings, the Tathāgata does not conceal them. Why is that? Because the Tathāgata regards all sentient beings as equal to an only child, and discloses and teaches the unsurpassed Dharma.

"Noble son, consider this example: a wealthy householder who has only one child, greatly cherishing and loving that child, displays all the precious things he possesses. The Tathāgata likewise is just the same, looking upon all sentient beings as equal to an only child.

"Noble son, consider this example: in the world, people cover with clothing the marks of male and female bodies that they find displeasing — and that is called keeping secret. The Tathāgata is not like that. Having gone far beyond the senses and transcended the senses, there is nothing hidden or concealed.

"Noble son, consider this example: brahmins do not wish the warrior caste (kṣatriyas) and the outcaste class to hear all the learned sciences of sacred speech. Why? Because in the sciences of sacred speech there are defects and faults.

The sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata is not like that. From beginning to end and throughout the middle, it is virtuous, and it is not fitting to call it secret.

Noble son, consider this example: a householder has only one son, whom he loves and cherishes deeply. He brings the boy to a teacher and has him begin his studies. But fearing that the child might be slow to learn, the householder, out of love, takes him home and applies diligent effort day and night — teaching him the elementary letters and showing him those, but not showing

him the great learning. Why? Because the boy is young, his strength is not yet complete, and so he does not have the capacity to master it. Noble son, if that householder has the boy study only the elementary letters, will the boy thereby come to know and understand the great learning?

The reply came: No, Blessed One.

The Blessed One declared: Did that householder keep it secret from his son?

The reply came: No, Blessed One.

The Blessed One said: And for what reason? It was not shown because the boy was young and lacked the capacity to master it — but it was not withheld because of miserliness in order to keep it secret. Why? Because if one withholds something with a mind of miserliness, that may be called secrecy. But the Tathāgata is not like that, and so it is not fitting to say that the Tathāgata has a hidden core to what he teaches.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, it is just as you have said: when something is withheld with a mind of aversion, jealousy, or miserliness, that may indeed be called secrecy. But since the Tathāgata harbors no aversion, jealousy, or miserliness, it is not fitting to say that the Tathāgata has secrets.

Noble son, the householder stands for the Tathāgata. The only son stands for all sentient beings, for the Tathāgata looks upon all sentient beings as he would an only child. The son who is learning stands for the disciples who are close attendants, the śrāvakas. The elementary letters stand for the nine categories of scripture. The great learning stands for the vast sūtra collections of the Great Vehicle. Because the śrāvakas lack the strength of wisdom, the Tathāgata taught the nine categories of scripture — the equivalent of the elementary letters — but did not teach the vast sūtra collections of the Great Vehicle, the equivalent of the great learning.

Noble son, if the householder's son has come to full strength and has the capacity to master it, yet the great learning is still not taught to him, then that may be called secrecy. Likewise, if a śrāvaka were to gain the capacity to master the great learning of the Great Vehicle, and yet the Tathāgata withheld it out of miserliness and did not teach it, then it would be fitting to say that the Tathāgata has a hidden core to his teaching. But the Tathāgata is not like that. Therefore the Tathāgata has no hidden core to his teaching.

Just as that householder first showed his son the elementary letters and afterward taught him the great learning, so too the Tathāgata is the same: he first taught his close attendants the nine categories of scripture — the equivalent of the elementary letters — and afterward teaches the great learning. And that great learning is this: the Tathāgata is possessed of a nature that abides permanently, unchanging and unwavering.

Noble son, consider also this further example: in the summer season, a great rain cloud arises and a great rain falls. Those farmers who have sown many seeds in their fields will obtain abundant harvests, while those who have sown few seeds will obtain small harvests. In this, the fault lies not with the nāga king who brings the rain, nor does the nāga king withhold anything in secret. The Tathāgata is likewise:

By sending down the great rain of the Dharma — the great nirvāṇa — those sentient beings who have cultivated wholesome fruit will come to obtain the sprouts and fruit of wisdom. Those who lack wholesome seeds obtain nothing at all, and that they obtain nothing is not the fault of the Tathāgata. Nor, in truth, does the Tathāgata withhold anything in secret.

Kāśyapa then asked: If I understand correctly that the Blessed One's teachings contain no hidden essence beyond what is intended, then when the Blessed One said that the great learning is possessed by the Tathāgata of a nature that abides permanently, unchanging and unwavering, would it not be improper to say so? For what reason? Because the Blessed One previously spoke this verse:

When even the Tathāgata, and the solitary buddhas,
and the companions of the hearers (śrāvakas)
must cast off this impermanent body,
what need is there to speak of the base-born and lowly?

And now here you say "abides permanently, unchanging and unwavering."
What then is the meaning of this?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, I spoke that verse in order to teach the companions who are hearers by means of partial letters. Let me give another example. When the great king Prasenajit's mother passed away, the king was overwhelmed with grief, weeping and lamenting, his heart transfixed. I came to where he was, and knowing full well what had befallen him, I asked: "Great king, why are you so stricken with grief and despair?" The king replied: "My great queen has passed from this life. If anyone could restore my mother's life,

I would offer them my kingdom, my elephants, my horses, the seven precious things, and even my own body and life." I then said to that king: "Great king, do not let your mind be tormented by grief. All sentient beings, when their life is exhausted, die. Even buddhas, pratyekabuddhas, and hearers must cast off the body — what then need be said of the base-born and lowly?" Noble son, I spoke those verses of partial letters in order to dispel that king's grief.

But now I have taught the great learning to the companions who are hearers, declaring: the Tathāgata abides permanently, unchanging and unwavering. If any person were to say that the Tathāgata is impermanent, why would that person's tongue not be cut out?

Kāśyapa then asked again: Blessed One, did you not also speak this verse:

Desiring nothing whatsoever,
knowing the measure of what is received,
like a bird in flight through the sky —
its trail cannot be traced by anyone.

What is the meaning of this? What is meant by "desiring nothing whatsoever" within this assembly? What is meant by "knowing the measure of what is received"? And who is like a bird flying through the sky, leaving no trace? And in which direction has such a one gone?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Desiring nothing" refers to precious jewels. Noble son, there are two kinds of wealth: conditioned and unconditioned. Conditioned wealth pertains to the conduct of hearers. Unconditioned wealth pertains to the conduct of the Tathāgata.

Noble son, the Saṅgha too is of two kinds: conditioned and unconditioned. The conditioned Saṅgha refers to the hearers. The Saṅgha of hearers is without wealth. Why without it? Because they do not accumulate male servants and female servants, nor stores of unlawful goods, storehouses, grain measures, sesame, lentils, legumes large and small, and the like.

Now if someone were to say that the Tathāgata permitted the keeping of male servants, female servants, workers, and so forth —

Such a one's tongue would become mute and dumb. My hearers (śrāvakas) are also called "those who do not accumulate," and they are also called "those who know the measure of food." One who is attached to food is called "one who does not know moderation," and one who is unattached to food is called "one who knows moderation." The phrase "not falling away afterward" means

drawing near to unsurpassed awakening. Such a person has gone forth as I have taught, yet there is no place to which one has arrived.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked further: If even the conditioned Saṅgha is described as "not accumulating," what need is there to say anything about the unconditioned Saṅgha? And if the Tathāgata is described in the same way, who could accumulate more than the Tathāgata? If "accumulating" were to refer to keeping secrets or concealing things, that would not be fitting for the Tathāgata, since the Tathāgata has no miserliness in speech and therefore cannot be said to have secrets. As for "not falling away afterward," this refers to nirvāṇa. Nirvāṇa is free from sun and moon, stars and planets, cold and heat, wind and rain, birth and aging, sickness and death, and all twenty-five modes of existence; it is free from grief, suffering, and affliction.

Thus nirvāṇa is the permanent, unchanging, and unshifting abode of the Tathāgata. It is for this cause and these conditions that the Tathāgata passed into the great parinirvāṇa at the foot of the śāla trees.

The Blessed One declared: The name "Great Kāśyapa" signifies one who is by nature vast and wide. For example, one who is able to live for a measureless number of years is called a great person. If such a one abides in the sacred Dharma in ease and contentment, he is called foremost among human beings. When I taught the eight qualities of a great person, it is possible that a single individual may attain them, or that all may attain them. If a single person possesses all eight, that one is called supreme and foremost.

"Passing beyond sorrow" means being free from the fault of wrongdoing. Noble son, take the example of a person who is struck by a poisoned arrow. That person experiences the great pain of illness. If such a person meets a skilled physician, the physician treats him with excellent medicine, and he is freed from the pain of illness and becomes entirely well. That physician then travels through villages, towns, and their outskirts, and wherever there are those suffering from wounds, he heals them all and frees them from their pain.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is like that physician. Having attained full awakening, he became the king of physicians. Throughout immeasurable eons in Jambudvīpa, for sentient beings tormented by suffering — those pierced by the thorn of the afflictions of attachment, aversion, and delusion, experiencing great pain — he healed them with the medicinal Dharma of the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, like nectar. And in other directions and other places as well, he showed those pierced by the thorns of afflictions how to fully awaken, and

healed them too. For this reason, he is called the great complete parinirvāṇa.

The great complete parinirvāṇa is a state of perfect liberation. Because the Tathāgata manifests his form wherever sentient beings are to be tamed, and because of this profoundly deep and perfectly real meaning, it is also called the great complete parinirvāṇa.

Then once more the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, is the physician of the world able to heal all the illnesses of sentient beings?

Noble son, illness in the world is of two kinds: those that can be healed and those that cannot be healed. Those that can be healed: when treated by a physician, the patient recovers. Those that cannot be healed: even when treated by a physician, the patient does not recover.

Kāśyapa asked again: Blessed One, you have declared that the Tathāgata healed sentient beings in Jambudvīpa. If he healed them, why do so many sentient beings remain who have not passed beyond sorrow? And if not all attained it, why did you declare that the Tathāgata healed all and then departed to another realm?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, sentient beings in Jambudvīpa are of two kinds: those who have faith and those who do not. Those who have faith are fit to be healed. Why is this? Because they will certainly pass beyond sorrow and be without fault, I declared that I healed all sentient beings of Jambudvīpa. Those who have no faith are called those of wrong craving. Those of wrong craving are not fit to be healed. Since all except those of wrong craving have been healed, there is no fault in passing beyond sorrow.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, what is this passing beyond sorrow?

Noble son, passing beyond sorrow means liberation.

Kāśyapa asked again: Is this liberation endowed with form, or is it without form?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, for some it is with form, and for some it is without form. Without form is the liberation of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. With form is the liberation of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Therefore, noble son, liberation is both with form and without form. The Tathāgata declared it to be without form to the immediate disciples of the śrāvakas.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, if śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have no form, in what do they abide?

Noble son, consider the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception: they are both with form and without form, and so I declared them to be without form. Now if someone were to object and say, "If the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception are without form, how do they abide, move, depart, and arrive?" — the answer is that these matters lie within the domain of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and are not known to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Liberation is similar: it is both with form and without form, and so it is said to be without form. It is both with perception and without perception, and so it is said to be without perception. These matters lie within the domain of the buddhas and are not known to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

The Seventh Fascicle.

Then once more the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, out of your compassion for us, please explain at greater length the meaning of liberation in the great complete parinirvāṇa.

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, true and perfect liberation means complete freedom from all the bonds by which one is bound. One who is thus truly liberated, being completely free from all bonds, neither takes birth nor gathers conditions. Consider, for example, how a child arises from the coming-together of a father and a mother. True and perfect liberation is not like that; therefore that liberation is called unborn.

Kāśyapa, consider how clarified butter is pure by its own nature. The Tathāgata is likewise: he did not arise through the condition of a father and mother coming together.

Yet, being pure by its very nature, the Tathāgata displayed a father and a mother for the sake of taming ordinary beings. True and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata himself, and in the Tathāgata's liberation there is no duality, no division.

Consider, for example, how in the summer season, when a seed is planted and moistened by heat and moisture, it immediately sprouts and grows. True and perfect liberation is not like that.

Furthermore, liberation means being empty and nonexistent. That which is empty and nonexistent is liberation. Liberation is the Tathāgata. The

Tathāgata is not made empty or nonexistent; he is not something fabricated or constructed. Things that are fabricated, such as castles, towns, houses, granaries, and barns — true and perfect liberation is nothing like those. Therefore liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is an unconditioned phenomenon (dharma). Conditioned things are like clay vessels — they are subject to destruction. Liberation is not like that. True and perfect liberation is the unborn, the unceasing. Therefore liberation is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata likewise neither arises nor ceases, neither ages nor dies, neither deteriorates nor decays — he is not a conditioned phenomenon. For this reason the Tathāgata, having passed into nirvāṇa, is said to be without aging and without death.

What does this mean exactly? "Aging" refers to change and transformation — the whitening of hair and the appearance of wrinkles on the face. "Death" refers to the dissolution of the body and the passing away of the life force. None of these things are present in liberation; because they are absent, it is called liberation. In the Tathāgata there are no conditioned phenomena such as hair turning white or wrinkles forming on the face. Therefore the Tathāgata has no aging. Because there is no aging, there is no death either.

Furthermore, liberation means freedom from illness. "Illness" refers to the four hundred and four diseases, as well as harm to the body caused by other adverse conditions. Because none of these are present, it is called liberation. That which is wholly free from illness is true and perfect liberation. True and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata. Since the Tathāgata is without illness, the dharmakāya is likewise without illness. It is by being thus free from illness that one is called a Tathāgata.

"Death" refers to the dissolution of the body and the passing away of the life force. Because there is no death in him, he is like refined gold. Refined gold is true and perfect, utterly pure liberation. True and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata. Thus the Tathāgata is endowed with such a fullness of qualities — so why should the Tathāgata be called impermanent? If one were to say that the Tathāgata is impermanent, that position is untenable. His body is like a vajra — how could it be impermanent? Therefore one must not say that the life of the Tathāgata is exhausted. The Tathāgata is utterly pure, stainless. The body of the Tathāgata is unstained by the womb; like the white lotus flower, the pundarīka, it is pure by its own nature. The Tathāgata's liberation is likewise. That very liberation is the Tathāgata. Therefore the Tathāgata is

utterly pure and without stain.

Furthermore, liberation means the complete and total exhaustion of every last wound of defilement (āsrava), leaving nothing remainder. The Tathāgata is likewise — he is entirely without the wounds of defilement. Furthermore, liberation means freedom from dispute.

For example, a person who is hungry and sees food becomes intensely attached to it. Liberation is not like that.

Furthermore, liberation is called peaceful bliss. When base flatterers say of a great sovereign that he dwells in blissful peace, those words are false and untrue. True blissful peace is ultimate liberation. Ultimate liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is supreme bliss. For example, a place full of many enemies is not bliss. A place free of enemies is called supreme bliss. Liberation, too, is free of fear, and so it is called supreme bliss. Therefore supreme bliss is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata. What is called the Tathāgata is Dharma.

Furthermore, liberation is called without equal. As for being without equal — kings, for instance, have peers who are equal to them in territory and realm, and so they are considered equals. Liberation has nothing of that kind. Without equal — for example, a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) has no equal. Liberation likewise has no equal. Having no equal is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata, the wheel-turning king of the Dharma wheel. Therefore the Tathāgata has no equal; there is no basis for saying that the Tathāgata has a peer.

Furthermore, liberation is called free from sorrow. As for having sorrow — kings, for example, feel sorrow out of fear of their enemies' attacks. Liberation has no such thing. For example, when all enemies have been vanquished, there is no sorrow or anxiety for that person. Liberation likewise has no sorrow or fear. Free from sorrow and fear is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is called free from grief and aging. For example, if a woman hears the evil news that her only son who had gone to another land has died, she will be tormented with grief. Then if she hears that he has not died, joy arises in her instantly. Liberation has none of those things — the absence of grief and joy alike is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is called free from dust and stain. For example, in spring when the sun sets, the wind rises and dust is stirred up. Liberation has none of those things whatsoever. Freedom from dust is the simile for true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

For example, the precious jewel set in the top-knot of a wheel-turning king is without stain. Liberation likewise is without stain. Freedom from stain is liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

For example, refined gold that is unmixed with sand is called a true jewel, and when a person finds it, he regards it as a treasury of wealth. Liberation itself is like a true jewel. The true jewel is the simile for true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

For example, a broken clay pot makes a disagreeable sound. A vajra jewel vessel is not like that. True liberation likewise is without disagreeable sound. The vajra jewel vessel is the symbol of true liberation.

True liberation is the Tathāgata. Therefore the body of the Tathāgata is indestructible.

As for disagreeable sound, it is like this: the fruit of the eraṇḍa plant, dried in the fierce heat of the summer sun, tormented by that heat, emits a sound. In liberation, nothing of that kind exists. Like the vajra jewel vessel, there is no disagreeable sound of breaking. Even if hundreds and thousands and countless people were all to shoot arrows at it simultaneously, it would not be destroyed, and there would be no disagreeable sound of breaking. The absence of disagreeable sound of breaking is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

It is like this: when a poor man is seized for another's debt, he is bound with iron chains and with rope, and starved, and made to suffer. In liberation, nothing of that kind exists, and there is no debt either. It is like this: a wealthy merchant possesses wealth and precious goods beyond count, and has power and mastery, and has no debt. Liberation likewise is similar: it possesses abundant precious wealth of Dharma and has power and mastery, and thus has no debt. Freedom from debt is the simile for true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation means freedom from being tormented. It is like this: in spring, going out in fierce heat; in summer, eating sweet food; in winter, being touched by cold. In true liberation, nothing of that kind — nothing disagreeable

— exists at all. Freedom from being tormented is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

As for being tormented, it is like this: if a person eats fish to satiety and then drinks milk afterward, that person is not far from death. In true liberation, nothing of that kind exists. But if that person were to find something like a medicinal nectar, the illness would be healed and he would survive. True liberation is just like that. The medicinal nectar is the name for true liberation. That true liberation is the Tathāgata — so how could one speak of it as tormenting or not tormenting?

It is like this: childish, lowly people who have come under the power of pride think to themselves, "Among all sentient beings, there is nothing that can kill me," and so they take hold of tigers, snakes, and vicious insects. Such a lowly person is not far from the end of his life, and one should know that sudden death will come to him. In true liberation, nothing of that kind exists.

Freedom from torment is like this: the precious jewel gem of a wheel-turning king is able to tame ninety-six types of vicious insects and vermin, and the mere fragrance of that precious gem causes all that is venomous to disappear. True liberation is likewise similar: it has gone far from the twenty-five modes of existence. Freedom from venom is the simile for true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, freedom from venom is like space. Liberation too is like that. Space is the name for true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

As for being burned, it is like this: when fire is set to dry grass, it blazes and is consumed. In true liberation, nothing of that kind exists.

Furthermore, freedom from being utterly tormented is like this:

The sun and moon do not cause scorching torment to sentient beings. Liberation is likewise similar: it does not cause scorching torment to any sentient being whatsoever. Freedom from scorching torment is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is said to be of unshakable nature, like the presence of loving-kindness and the absence of aversion. In true liberation, nothing of that kind exists. What is called unshakable is like a wheel-turning king: there is no one who could become a companion equal to such a king, and there is no ground for saying that such a companion exists. Liberation is likewise similar: nothing else can become its companion, and there is no ground for saying that

any companion exists. That the king has no companion — that is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is Dharma itself.

Furthermore, what is called unshakable is this: for example, a white garment can easily have its color changed. Liberation is not like that. For example, there is no ground for saying that the flower called the blue lotus has a smell or that it has a blue color — and yet the blue lotus is what it is. Liberation is likewise similar: there is no ground for saying that it has a smell or that its hue is otherwise than it is. Therefore liberation itself is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is wondrous. It is like this: a lotus born in water is nothing to marvel at. But if a lotus were born from within fire, that would be wondrous and astonishing, and all who saw it would be filled with joy. True liberation is likewise similar: all those who see it are filled with profound joy in their minds. What is called wondrous is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is the dharmakāya, the truth body.

Furthermore, what is called wondrous is this: for example, an infant just born, while still toothless, grows greatly on mother's milk and then teeth arise anew. Liberation is not like that: there is nothing in it that can be called arising or non-arising.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is empty, peaceful, and without indeterminacy. Indeterminacy applies to one who holds wrong craving; at the root, there is degeneration, and there is no ground for saying that such a one cannot change and will not attain awakening. Why is that? If that person were to generate completely pure faith in the noble Dharma of the buddhas, that person would be made free of wrong craving. And even if one were to become a layman, one would be made free of wrong craving. And if the unwholesome fault of degeneration at the root were removed, full and manifest awakening would be attained. Therefore there is no ground for saying that such a one will ultimately not change and will not attain manifest awakening. In true liberation, there is no such thing as obstruction or the negation of such qualities. Furthermore, what is called empty and peaceful is the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. That very dharmadhātu, just as it is, is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, when what is called wrong craving is stopped and utterly extinguished, one no longer speaks of such a person as one who holds wrong craving. Now, who is it who is called one who holds wrong craving? One who holds wrong craving is one who has severed all roots of virtue, who does not

abide in any virtuous dharma, and in whom not even a single instant of virtuous mind arises. In true liberation there are none of those conditions whatsoever. Because there are no such conditions whatsoever, it is true liberation. True liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is immeasurable.

To illustrate: a heap of sesame seeds can be measured and counted. True liberation is not like that. The great ocean, by contrast, is immeasurable and cannot be fathomed. Liberation is likewise — immeasurable and unfathomable. That which is immeasurable is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is without limit. Just as the karmic maturation of all sentient beings is vast beyond measure, liberation is likewise — its ripening is without limit. Ripening without limit is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is vast and wide. The great ocean, for example, has no equal. Liberation is likewise — it has no equal. That which has no equal is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is the supreme unsurpassed. Space, for example, is supremely lofty and without equal. Liberation is likewise — unsurpassed in its supreme loftiness. That which is lofty and without equal is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is without fixed abode. Just as all other animals do not abide in the place where the lion, king of beasts, dwells, liberation is likewise — it has no fixed abode. Having no fixed abode is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is unsurpassed. Just as the north is the foremost of all directions, liberation is likewise — unsurpassed. The unsurpassed is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is unsurpassed even beyond the unsurpassed. Just as the north is unsurpassed even beyond the unsurpassedness of the east, liberation is likewise — unsurpassed beyond the unsurpassed. The unsurpassed beyond the unsurpassed is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is of a permanent nature. Gods and humans, for example, possess bodies that are subject to decay and

transference of life — they are impermanent, not permanent. Liberation is not like that; it is not impermanent. That which is not impermanent is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation has a firm and solid core. Acacia wood, sandalwood, and aloe wood are by nature hard and solid. Liberation is likewise — by nature hard, solid, and firm. That which is by nature firm and solid is true liberation, and true liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is said to be not hollow. Reeds and bamboo, for example, are hollow inside and therefore have a hollow core. Liberation is not like that. Therefore, know that liberation itself is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is that which is not stained by anything. When a wall has not been plastered smooth on the outside, insects and small creatures dwell and move about upon it. But if it is coated with plaster and painted with designs, the insects depart on smelling the scent of the pigments and no longer remain there.

Not dwelling in that way is liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is said to be without limit or boundary. A city, for example, has its boundaries and limits, but liberation is not like that. Space, for example, is without limit, and liberation is likewise without limit. Therefore, liberation itself is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is said to be beyond sight. Just as in the empty sky it is extremely difficult to follow a bird's trail with the eye, that extreme difficulty of being seen is the analogy for perfect liberation. And perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is called very profound. Why is that? Because none of the śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas are able to enter into it. That into which they are unable to enter is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called very profound is that which buddhas and bodhisattvas hold in the highest reverence. Just as the most senior children show the deepest reverence and respect toward their parents, and that merit is extraordinarily profound, so that profundity of merit is the analogy for perfect liberation. And perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is not seen even when looked for. Just as a person cannot see the top of their own head, so too liberation cannot be seen even when looked for — not by any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha. Not being seen even when looked for is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is without a dwelling-place or support. Space, for example, has no dwelling-place or support, and liberation is likewise. The expression "dwelling-place and support" is the analogy for the twenty-five modes of existence. Having no dwelling-place or support is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is nothing that can be taken up. The fruit of a mango tree on its branch, for example, is something that can be reached for and grasped. Liberation is not like that — it is nothing that can be reached for or grasped. Not being something that can be reached for or grasped is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is nothing that can be seized. An illusion, for example, cannot be seized, and liberation is likewise — it cannot be seized. Not being something that can be seized is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is without a physical body. A person, for example, by having a body is subject to scabies, leprosy, wasting disease, madness, and the like. Perfect liberation has none of such diseases. That which is free from those diseases is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is of a single taste. Just as milk is of a single taste, liberation is likewise — it is of a single taste. Being of a single taste is liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is thoroughly pure. Just as unmuddied water is utterly pure and clear, liberation is likewise — thoroughly pure and clear. Being thoroughly pure and clear is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is of a single taste. Just as rain falling from the sky is pure and of a single taste, liberation is likewise — pure and of a single taste. Being pure and of a single taste is perfect liberation.

Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is utterly luminous. Just as a full moon is unobscured by clouds or mist, liberation is likewise — free of clouds and mist. Being free of clouds and mist is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is supremely peaceful. Just as a person who has recovered from a burning fever is at peace, liberation is likewise — supremely peaceful. Being supremely peaceful is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is equanimity. In a wild and desolate place there are venomous snakes and wolves and the like, all with murderous intent. Liberation is not like that — it has no murderous intent. Having no murderous intent is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called equanimity: just as parents have an even and impartial mind toward their children, liberation is likewise — of an even mind. Being of an even mind is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is without another abode. Just as a person who dwells in an exceedingly fine and perfectly pure dwelling has no need of any other abode, liberation is likewise — without another abode. Being without another abode is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is contentment. Just as a person who is hungry and encounters delicious food eats without knowing when to stop, liberation is not like that. It is like one who has drunk warm milk-porridge and desires nothing more. Desiring nothing further is the example of perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is complete severance. Just as a person who cuts the rope that binds them becomes free from bondage, liberation is likewise — it severs all bonds of doubt. Thus, severing doubt is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the gone-beyond (pāramitā). A river has a near bank and a far bank. Liberation is not like that — there is nothing called a near bank, yet there is what is called the far bank. The far bank is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is utter silence. Just as the ocean gives rise to many sounds and roaring when great waves arise, liberation is not like that. And so liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is delicious and sweet. Just as when āmalaka fruit is added to a compound medicine it makes the taste pungent, liberation is not like that — it has a flavor that is wholly refreshing and sweet. Having a wholly refreshing and sweet flavor is the example of perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the dispelling of all afflictions. Just as a skilled physician compounds various medicines and is expert at healing the sick, liberation is likewise — it dispels all afflictions entirely. Dispelling all afflictions is the example of perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is without constriction. Just as a small house is confining and cannot hold many people, liberation is not like that — it can hold many.

Holding many is the example of perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the stilling of desire and is unmixed with attachment. As an example, a woman is one in whom attachment is abundant. Liberation is not like that, and such liberation is the Tathāgata. Thus the Tathāgata is entirely free from all the afflictive defilements — attachment, aversion, delusion, pride, and the rest.

Furthermore, liberation is without craving. Craving has two aspects: the craving of hungry ghosts and the craving for Dharma. In perfect liberation there is no craving of the hungry-ghost kind, yet out of loving care for sentient beings there is the craving for Dharma. Thus the craving for Dharma is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is free from self and what belongs to self. Such liberation is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata is the Dharma.

Furthermore, liberation is cessation — the exhaustion of all clinging to continued existence, gone far away from it. Such liberation is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata is the Dharma.

Furthermore, liberation is protector and refuge, saving one from all fears. Such liberation is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata is the Dharma.

Liberation is like a dwelling place. Whoever abides in it seeks no other dwelling. Just as a person who relies on a king seeks no other residence — yet dwelling with a king is subject to change — abiding in liberation undergoes no change. That which undergoes no change is perfect liberation, and perfect

liberation is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata is the Dharma.

Furthermore, liberation is like a place of safety and support. Just as a person who goes into a wild and desolate region feels fear or anxiety, liberation is not like that — there is no fear and no anxiety. The absence of fear and anxiety is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, that which is called liberation is fearlessness. Just as the lion king is not frightened by any wild beast, liberation is likewise — it is not frightened by any host of māras. Fearlessness is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is non-deviation. Just as on a narrow path two people cannot walk side by side, liberation is not like that — and such liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, deviation is like a person who, frightened by a tiger, leaps into a pit. Liberation is not like that, and such liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, non-deviation is like someone who abandons a broken and small boat, boards a fine vessel, crosses the ocean safely, and arrives at a place of happiness. Liberation is likewise — the mind is supremely at ease. That supreme ease of mind is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, that which is called liberation is being extracted from causes and conditions. Consider: from the condition of milk comes curds; from the condition of curds comes butter; from the condition of butter comes the essence of butter. In perfect liberation there is no cause whatsoever. Being without cause is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the subduing of pride. Just as a great king is proud before lesser kings, liberation is not of that kind —

Thus liberation is the Tathāgata. And the Tathāgata is the Dharma.

Furthermore, liberation is the taming of the heedless. The heedless are those of many desires. In liberation these are absent. Being free of these is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the dispelling of ignorance. Just as medicine that is free of impurities is supreme — like the essence of butter — so too is liberation: having removed the impurity of ignorance, it is endowed with perfect knowledge. Being endowed with perfect knowledge is perfect

liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is utter solitude — singular, without duality, like a wild yak bull alone in a remote wilderness, without companion. Liberation too is like that: singular and without duality. Being singular and without duality is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is endowed with a hard core. Reed, marsh grass, and medicinal herb are all hollow within, yet fruit is hard. All the gods and humans of the world, save the Buddha, the Blessed One, are neither hard nor stable. Perfect liberation is that which has gone far from every stream of conditioned existence. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the generation of higher knowledges (abhijñā). Perfect liberation is like that as well. Thus that liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the abandonment of all conditioned existence. It is like a person who has eaten to excess and vomits — liberation likewise abandons all conditioned existence. The abandonment of all conditioned existence is perfect liberation, and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is infallible. Just as the fragrance of the pāsika flower is absent from each of its seven petals, so too is liberation. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is like the water element. The water element is supreme among the four great elements: it moistens and nourishes all plants and fruits. Liberation too is like that: it moistens all births. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is called entrance. Just as where there is a door there is entry, and where there is a source of gold there is gold, so too liberation: it brings those who cultivate selflessness to enter. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is virtue. Just as a student who follows a teacher and heeds instructions is called virtuous, so too is liberation. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is a Dharma that transcends the world — it is the summit of all phenomena. Just as among all things with flavor, butter and milk are supreme, so too is liberation. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is called immovable. Just as a stone threshold cannot be moved by the wind, so too is perfect liberation. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is without turbulent waves. Just as the waters of the ocean surge with great waves, liberation is not like that. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is like a royal palace. Liberation too is like that. Thus liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is useful for every purpose. Just as the gold of the Jambū River is useful for every purpose and no fault or blemish can be imputed to it, so too is liberation: it is without fault or blemish. That which is without fault or blemish is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is the abandonment of the conduct of a servant and a slave. Just as a great person does not perform the deeds of a servant, so too is liberation: it is the complete relinquishment of the five aggregates. The complete relinquishment of the five aggregates is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is consummation. Just as one who has been cast into prison, when released from it, first bathes thoroughly and then goes home, so too is liberation: it is final and complete purity. Final and complete purity is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is ease without contrivance. Ease without contrivance comes from expelling all that belongs to attachment, aversion, delusion, and so forth. Just as a person who, without being aware of it, has been seized by a venomous snake is given an emetic to remove the poison — and when they vomit, the poison is gone and the body is at ease — so too is liberation: by expelling all the virulent poison of the afflictions, the body becomes at ease. This is called ease without contrivance. Ease without contrivance is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, what is called liberation is the cutting of the venomous snake of the four kinds of affliction. The cutting of the afflictions is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the relinquishment of all existence, the cessation of all suffering, the attainment of all happiness, the complete severing of all attachment, aversion, and delusion, and the uprooting of all the roots of the

afflictions. The uprooting of the roots of the afflictions is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is the complete severance of all conditioned phenomena and the bringing forth of all undefiled phenomena, the cutting of all continuity — namely: it cuts only what grasps and clings, whether as "self," as "no-self," as "neither self" or "neither no-self," but it does not cut the view of self. For the view of self is the nature of a buddha. The nature of a buddha is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is an emptiness that is not empty. What is called "the emptiness that is empty" means having nothing whatsoever. Having nothing whatsoever is like the so-called liberation of the non-Buddhist (tīrthika) naked ascetics and the like. The naked ascetics are devoid of perfect liberation, and therefore theirs is called "the emptiness that is empty." Perfect liberation is not like that — it is an emptiness that is not empty. The emptiness that is not empty is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is non-empty.

Consider, for example, a vessel that holds water, butter, cream, wine, or honey. Even when the water, butter, cream, wine, or honey is absent, one still designates it as a vessel for water and so forth. Yet to that vessel, neither "empty" nor "non-empty" can rightly be applied. To call it "empty" would be inappropriate, for one cannot then designate it as having form, scent, taste, and texture. To call it "non-empty" would also be inappropriate, for there is none of the water and so forth within it.

Liberation is similar to this. To it, neither "form" nor "not form," neither "empty" nor "non-empty" can rightly be applied. If it were called "empty," then it could not rightly be designated as permanent, blissful, self, and pure. But to call it "non-empty" — permanent, blissful, self, and pure — by whom would those qualities be experienced? Therefore, to it, neither "empty" nor "non-empty" can rightly be applied.

That is to say: because the twenty-five modes of existence, all affliction, all suffering, all signs, and all conditioned formations (saṃskāra) are absent, liberation is like the vessel in which there is no cream — and so it is called "empty." As for being called "non-empty": its true form — permanent, blissful, self, and pure — is immovable and unchanging, just as the vessel is called "non-empty" by virtue of possessing form, scent, taste, and texture. Therefore liberation is like that vessel.

Yet the vessel, when it meets with conditions, can be broken. Liberation is not like that — it is indestructible. What is indestructible is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, liberation is free from desire. By way of example, a person possessed of a desirous mind may aspire to become Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, or the king of Brahmā (Brahman), or a sovereign king. Liberation is not like that. When one awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, there is no desire, and there is no doubt. Freedom from desire and doubt is perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata. If one were to say that in liberation there is desire and doubt, that has no basis whatsoever.

Furthermore, liberation is the thorough severing of all craving for existence, all signs, all bonds, all affliction, all saṃsāra, all causes and conditions, and all fruits of karmic maturation. Such being the case, liberation is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is nirvāṇa.

All sentient beings, fearing the afflictions of saṃsāra, incline toward the Three Refuges. It is like a deer that is frightened by a hunter: when it escapes from an obstacle it makes a single leap — that is one going for refuge. In this way, making three leaps is the simile for going for the Three Refuges. By making three leaps, one comes to ease and wellbeing.

Ordinary beings are just like this: frightened by the hunter of the four māras, they incline toward and go for the Three Refuges. By turning to the Three Refuges, they come to ease and wellbeing. Whoever comes to ease and wellbeing has attained perfect liberation. Perfect liberation is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is nirvāṇa. Nirvāṇa is inexhaustible. What is inexhaustible is the intrinsic nature of the buddha. The intrinsic nature of the buddha is certainty. What is certainty is the unsurpassed, perfectly complete buddha.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa said this to the Blessed One:

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: "Noble son, nirvāṇa, the intrinsic nature of the buddha, certainty, and the Tathāgata — if these are one in meaning, why then did I teach the Three Refuges?" The Blessed One replied: "Noble son, sentient beings, frightened by saṃsāra, turn and go to the Three Refuges. By taking the Three Refuges, they should understand that this itself is the intrinsic nature of the buddha, certainty, and nirvāṇa.

"Noble son, some phenomena share one name yet have different meanings. Other phenomena differ both in name and in meaning. Those that share one

name yet have different meanings are these: 'the buddha is permanent,' 'the Dharma is permanent,' 'the Saṅgha of monks is permanent,' 'passing beyond sorrow,' and 'space is permanent' — these are said to share one name yet have different meanings.

"Those that differ both in name and in meaning are these: 'buddha' means one who experiences; 'Dharma' means what does not experience; 'Saṅgha' means harmony; 'passing beyond sorrow' means complete liberation; and 'space' means that which is neither virtue nor non-virtue and is unobstructed — these are said to differ both in name and in meaning.

"Noble son, the Three Refuges are likewise: they differ both in name and in meaning. Among them there is nothing whatsoever that can be called 'one.'

"For this reason, the next day I said to the matriarch Gautamī: 'Gautamī, do not make offerings to me — make offerings to the Saṅgha. By making offerings to the Saṅgha, it is called making offerings to the Three Jewels.'"

Then the matriarch spoke thus: "Within the Saṅgha, there is neither a buddha nor the Dharma — why then does making offerings to the Saṅgha become making offerings to the Three Jewels?"

To this I replied: "Acting in accordance with what I have taught is making offerings to the buddha. Desiring complete liberation is making offerings to the Dharma. Accepting the Saṅgha is making offerings to the Saṅgha. Therefore, noble son, it is not right to call the Three Jewels 'one.'

"Noble son, the Blessed One at certain times teaches 'one' as 'three,' and at certain times teaches 'three' as 'one.' Therefore the domain of activity of the buddhas is beyond the comprehension of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

Kāśyapa then asked again: "Blessed One, when the Blessed One said 'ultimate ease is nirvāṇa,' what is the meaning of that? Nirvāṇa, it is said, is equanimity with regard to the body and equanimity with regard to gnosis. If there is equanimity toward body and gnosis, who then experiences the ease?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, consider the example of a person who has eaten to excess and, suffering from indigestion, goes outside, vomits, and returns. His companions ask him: 'How is your discomfort — are you better?' He replies: 'I am better; there is no more discomfort.'

"The Tathāgata is likewise: having finally parted from the twenty-five modes of existence and passed fully into nirvāṇa, having reached the state of perfect ease — there is no movement, no exhaustion, and nothing to be called

cessation. Because all feelings have been severed, it is said that there is no experience of ease as a feeling. The absence of any such felt experience is what is called permanent ease. For anyone to say that the Tathāgata experiences ease as a feeling — that has no basis. Therefore, ultimate ease is nirvāṇa. That nirvāṇa is perfect liberation. And perfect liberation is the Tathāgata."

Kāśyapa then asked again: "Is liberation that which is unborn and unceasing?"

"Just so, just so."

"Son of good family, that which is unborn and unceasing is perfect liberation. And just so, perfect liberation is the Tathāgata."

Kāśyapa asked again: "If that which is unborn and unceasing is perfect liberation, then space too has the characteristic of being unborn and unceasing — would space also be the Tathāgata? And would the Tathāgata then not be perfect liberation?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, it is not so. Why is it not so? Son of good family, consider this: the kalandaka bird and the jīvañjīvaka bird have voices of exceeding beauty, yet they are not in any way comparable to the cry of a crow. The crow's call, Blessed One, is exceedingly unpleasant, and it cannot compare to the jīvañjīvaka bird — no, not even in a thousand ways."

Kāśyapa continued: "The kalandaka and similar birds have voices of great beauty and bodies of remarkable appearance — why then has the Tathāgata used the crow as an illustration? To take a mustard seed as an analogy for Mount Meru would be such a comparison, and the same applies to the Blessed One and space. The song of the kalandaka bird is fitting as an analogy for the speech of the buddha, the Blessed One — but the cry of the crow is not fitting as an analogy."

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! You are deeply skilled in the meaning of what is profound. The Tathāgata, on certain occasions, looking to causes and conditions, has also described space as an analogy for perfect liberation. And just so, perfect liberation is the Tathāgata. Perfect liberation — perfectly and completely — cannot be created by any god or human within this world together with its gods. Space is not, in the strict sense, a proper analogy, yet for the purpose of taming sentient beings, even what is not a proper analogy is employed as one.

Therefore, know that liberation itself is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata itself is liberation. Liberation and the Tathāgata are non-dual and without distinction.

"Son of good family, when we say 'not a proper analogy,' what is meant is this: things that are uncreated are, strictly speaking, not fit to be drawn as analogies for one another, yet in the context of certain causes and conditions, such analogies are permissible. In the sūtras as well it is said: 'His face is like the full moon,' and 'A white wool-clad elephant is like a snow mountain.' It is not correct to say the full moon is his face, nor is it correct to say a snow mountain is a white wool-clad elephant. Son of good family, while it is not strictly fitting to use analogies for perfect liberation, analogies are shown for the purpose of taming sentient beings. And it is just the same that, through many analogies, one comes to understand the nature of reality of phenomena."

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Kāśyapa then asked: "For what reason has the Tathāgata spoken of these in two aspects?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, consider this: if a man were to take up a sword and approach with an intention of aversion, coming to kill the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata neither became angry nor changed countenance — would that man then have committed the action without interval of killing a Tathāgata?"

"He would not, Blessed One."

"Blessed One, why is that?"

"Because the body of the Tathāgata cannot be destroyed. And how is that? The body of the Tathāgata has no physical aggregates; it is endowed with nothing other than the nature of reality. Since the nature of reality of phenomena cannot be destroyed, how could that person ever destroy the body of a buddha? Yet, because of the evil mind he bears, he would indeed become a being carrying the karma of the most heinous act without interval."

Through that, one comes to understand the nature of reality of phenomena.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, what you asked before accords well with what I have taught. Noble son, consider this example: a wicked man comes to bring a meal to another man who is working in a field, intending to kill him.

Having sharpened his sword and set out, the victim becomes aware of the danger and hides inside a pile of grain-sacks. The wicked man, sword in hand, circles around the pile of grain-sacks, strikes it with his sword, and thinks to himself, 'That one is done for!' — and so a mind of joy arises in him. Later, his mother emerges from inside that pile of grain-sacks. When she returns home, what do you think? Has that man committed the most heinous act without interval?"

"Blessed One, it is by no means certain."

"Why is that?"

"To say that he has committed a wrong, his mother's body was not destroyed. If her body was not destroyed, how could it be right to say that a wrong was committed? Yet to say that no wrong was committed, he harbored the thought 'That one is done for!' and even gave rise to a mind of joy — so how could that be right either? That man did not complete the most heinous act without interval, yet he did perform a deed of the kind that is without interval. Through such causes and conditions, one comes to understand the nature of reality of phenomena."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, through such causes and conditions, I have taught examples of liberation using various skillful means and similes. Though one might demonstrate through examples as numerous and limitless as can be counted, in truth no perfect example can be fashioned. In the context of certain causes and conditions an example is fitting, while in the context of other causes and conditions an example is not fitting. Therefore liberation is endowed with immeasurable qualities of such a kind — it is entry into nirvāṇa. The passing beyond sorrow, and the Tathāgata as well, are equally endowed with immeasurable qualities of such a kind. Being endowed with immeasurable qualities of such a kind and being utterly perfect, it is called the Great Nirvāṇa."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I have sought from the very beginning the place where the Tathāgata has come — yet it is a place not to be found by searching. Since it cannot be found by searching in that way, I understand that even the measure of his lifespan likewise cannot be found by searching."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, you indeed hold and guard the authentic Dharma with great care. Whatever noble sons or noble daughters who wish to cut the bonds of thorough affliction should

likewise hold and guard the authentic Dharma in this way.

"Noble son, through this profoundly deep sūtra of complete nirvāṇa, four types of persons who guard the authentic Dharma, establish the authentic Dharma, are able to contemplate the authentic Dharma, and show compassion for the world with all that is in it — these will become a support and refuge for the world with all that is in it, and will bring benefit and happiness to many gods and humans.

"Who are these four types of persons? The person who has transcended the ordinary world while still bearing the defining marks of affliction is called the stream-enterer (Skt. *srotāpanna*) — this is the first. The once-returner (Skt. *sakṛdāgāmin*) is the second. The non-returner (Skt. *anāgāmin*) is the third. The arhat is the fourth. When these four types of persons appear in the world, they show compassion for the world with all that is in it, become a support and refuge for the world with all that is in it, and bring benefit and happiness to many gods and humans."

Now, what is meant by "bearing the defining marks of affliction"? Here, a person who fully maintains and guards moral discipline, whose conduct is unimpaired, who establishes the genuine Dharma correctly, and who, having heard it from a buddha exactly as it was spoken, is learned in both letter and meaning and expounds it at length to others — this is as follows: such a person teaches at length the qualities of the eight great beings, beginning with having few desires, having many desires, and awakening, and so forth. When faults arise, such a person makes those who have committed them confess and feel remorse, and then purifies those faults. Such a person is also highly skilled in the skillful means, conduct, and the Dharma spoken with intentional meaning that belong to the bodhisattvas. That person is not one of the eight great beings, but rather what is called an ordinary childlike being. The eight great beings are not called ordinary childlike beings; they are called bodhisattvas, not buddhas. The second of the two persons is called the stream-enterer.

The once-returner either finds the genuine Dharma, holds the genuine Dharma, or, upon hearing the Dharma from a buddha, writes it down in books exactly as heard, retains it, reads it, recites it, and expounds and explains it at length to others. However, this person, after hearing the Dharma, does not write it down, does not retain it, does not hold it, and does not explain it to others. There is no occasion for this person to say that the Buddha permitted

the holding of uninvestigated property such as male and female servants and the like. This is called the second person. That person has not attained the ground of either the second or the third, nor is such a person called a prophesied bodhisattva.

The third person is called the non-returner. The non-returner has no occasion to disparage the genuine Dharma, to say that the Buddha permitted the holding of uninvestigated property such as male and female servants and workers and the like, to learn and hold the texts and sciences of non-Buddhists, to become obscured by manifest afflictions, to become covered and shrouded by underlying afflictive tendencies, to genuinely conceal and hide the authentic relics of the Tathāgata, to be harmed and injured by many kinds of external illness, to be seized by the four kinds of virulent poison, or to assert the existence of a self and the like — but there is occasion for this person to assert no-self. There is no occasion to assert attachment to worldly phenomena, but there is occasion to teach the Great Vehicle without interruption and without obstacle. There is no occasion for the body one has assumed to be devoured by eighty-four thousand parasites, but there is occasion for attachment to be completely abandoned, so that even in sleep as a young person no impure emission occurs. And there is no occasion to be frightened and terrified when performing the acts of dying. As for what is meant by "non-returner": that person does not return again into the faults and defects enumerated above, nor becomes tainted by them. Even if such a person does take rebirth and is born again, that one is called a bodhisattva, and having also received a prophecy, will without great delay awaken to the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. This is called the third person.

The fourth person is called the arhat. The arhat has cut off all afflictions, has laid down the burden, has accomplished what had to be done, has thoroughly found one's own benefit hereafter, abides perfectly on the ten grounds, wields mastery over primordial wisdom, manifests various forms and aspects of appearance in accordance with whatever ordinary beings aspire to, and, for those who wish to fully awaken, manifests full awakening.

It is because one possesses such qualities, immeasurable and without limit, that one is called an arhat.

Therefore, when these four great persons appear in the world, out of loving care for all those who dwell in the world, they become a refuge and support for the world's inhabitants, work for the welfare and happiness of the many —

gods and humans alike — and become supreme among gods and humans, become foremost, become most excellent. It is just as one who has gone for refuge in all the Tathāgatas becomes most excellent among human beings.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I myself do not dwell in or rely upon these four persons. For what reason? Because the Blessed One, in a sūtra spoken earlier in reply to a question from the householder Kuśīla, declared: 'Kuśīla, should someone come disguised in the likeness of a buddha — in order to destroy and lead astray gods, māras, Brahmā, and the rest — adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor marks, with a halo of light filling a fathom on all sides, a face like the full moon, the ūṇā hair between the brows either white as snow or gleaming like a conch shell, then you must discern whether that one is genuine or not. Having discerned and understood, tame that one.' Now, Blessed One, if māras and the like are able to display and conjure even the body of a buddha, how much more need be said of their displaying the bodies of the four persons — the arhat and the rest — traveling through the sky, lying down, sitting, emitting water from the left side of the body and fire from the right, or showing smoke billowing from the body so that it appears like a mass of flames. For these very reasons of cause and condition, even if such appearances occur, faith does not arise in me; and even if there be a teacher, I do not think to treat them as proper, to honor them with reverence, or to regard them as a refuge and support."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if I myself have doubts about a teaching, I do not accept it — how much less should those others do so. Therefore, examine carefully and deeply whether something is virtuous or non-virtuous, to be done or not to be done, and then internalize it thoroughly. If you act in this way, you will experience happiness for a long time."

"Son of good family, consider this example: a dog-thief comes to a house; a maidservant keeping watch over the house notices him and says to him, 'Get out quickly! If you do not flee, you will be killed.' Hearing those words, the dog flees and does not return. In the same way, when you are disciplining the evil māra, say to him: 'Wicked māra, do not display yourself in such a form! If you do, you will be bound with the five bonds.' If the māra hears those words, he will flee and not return — just as the dog-thief did not return."

Kāśyapa then asked again: "Blessed One, you declared to the householder Kuśīla that one who disciplines māra in such a way is 'close to complete and

perfect nirvāṇa.' Then why did the Blessed One say that the four persons are to be regarded as refuge and support? Are the four persons fit to be relied upon with certainty as teachers?"

The Blessed One answered Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, what I have said is consistent with that — it is just so. Son of good family, I taught the disciplining of māra for those who have the eyes of a śrāvaka; I did not teach it for persons who strive earnestly in the Great Vehicle. A person who is a śrāvaka, even one who has attained the eye of miraculous vision, is said to have the eye of flesh. But one who studies the Great Vehicle, even if they have only the eye of flesh, is said to have the eye of a buddha. Why? Because the sūtras of the Great Vehicle are called the vehicle of the buddhas."

The vehicle of the buddhas is the supreme and most excellent of all vehicles. Son of good family, consider this analogy. A brave man of great martial skill is always accompanied and supported by those who are not timid soldiers. That brave man teaches those soldiers: "Hold the bow in this manner. Release the arrow in this manner. Learn to wield the spear and the sling, and catch hold of the lasso in this manner." Furthermore, he instructs them: "Engaging in battle is like walking on the edge of a blade, yet do not give rise to thoughts of fear or terror. Instead, generate a thought that utterly despises the enemy — whether gods or humans — and give rise to the thought: 'I am exceptionally brave and skilled.' At intervals, when weaker soldiers act the part of warriors, taking up bows, swords, and various weapons to come to the battlefield, if they then call out loudly, do not act as though you are frightened or terrified by them. Once the soldier knows that you are not afraid, he will immediately scatter and flee like a thieving dog."

Son of good family, the Tathāgata likewise says to the śrāvakas: "Do not be frightened by the evil māra. Even if the evil māra manifests in the form of a buddha and comes before you, subdue the hordes of māra with utterly steadfast and vigorous diligence. At that time, māra, overcome with grief and displeasure, will go away."

Son of good family, consider another analogy. Just as a warrior of great bravery needs no instruction from another, so too is the one who strives earnestly in the Great Vehicle: upon hearing sūtras of profound depth in their many varieties, the mind becomes greatly delighted and overjoyed, and no fear or terror arises. Why? Because a person who studies the Great Vehicle has paid homage to, venerated, and made offerings to hundreds of thousands and

countless buddhas of the past. Therefore, even if hundreds of thousands and countless hordes of māra were to harm or attack such a person, fear and terror would never arise in them.

Son of good family, consider this analogy. If a person obtains the medicine called "agada," they have no fear of any venomous snake or other such dangers, because the power of that medicine can subdue all poisons. The sūtras of the Great Vehicle are likewise: they give rise to no fear of any malevolent māra, and can tame them so that they do not rise again.

Son of good family, consider yet another analogy. A venomous nāga, when it kills another being, does so sometimes merely by looking with its eyes, and sometimes merely by its breath — and the being dies. For this reason, all creatures — lions, tigers, leopards, wolves, dogs, and the rest — are frightened of it. There is not one among those wild beasts that does not die from merely hearing its sound or being touched by its body. But a person who is supremely skilled in mantra can, through the power of mantra, subdue the venomous nāga, the garuḍa, the enraged wild elephant, the lion, the tiger, the leopard, and all the rest — even to the point of being able to ride and direct them. Those wild beasts, by the mere sight of that one skilled in mantra, become tame of their own accord.

Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are similar to those animals: upon seeing the evil māra, they all become frightened and terrified. The evil māra, for his part, has no thought of fear or terror toward them and performs the works of māra freely. Those who study the Great Vehicle, by contrast, are like the mantra master: when they see how śrāvakas have been frightened by māra and lose faith and conviction in the Great Vehicle, they first subdue the ranks of māra through skillful means and bring them all to submission, and then, after that, they teach and expound the holy Dharma in its many varieties. When śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas see those māras thus subdued in this way, they initially take fright, but then they generate faith and conviction in the supreme and unsurpassed holy Dharma of the Great Vehicle.

They declared: "From this day forward, we shall cause no more hindrances or obstacles to this holy Dharma."

Furthermore, good son, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas feel fear and terror in the face of the afflictions. Those who study the Great Vehicle, however, feel no such fear or timidity. Those who apply themselves earnestly to the Great Vehicle possess power of that kind. It is for this reason that what was taught

and explained earlier was done so in order that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas might tame the māras — it was not for the sake of the Great Vehicle. This most profound sūtra of the Great Vehicle on nirvāṇa is wondrous and extraordinary: there is no one capable of taming it. As for the person who listens to and hears it, holds faith in it and retains it, and trusts that the Tathāgata possesses the quality of permanence — such a person is exceedingly rare, like the udumbara flower. Once I have passed into nirvāṇa, whoever hears this most profound sūtra of the Great Vehicle and gives rise to a mind of faith — know that such a person will not fall into the lower realms for a hundred thousand aeons in the time to come.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Good son, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings will slander and disbelieve this holy sūtra on the complete passing into nirvāṇa."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: "Blessed One, if sentient beings were to attend upon and venerate this sūtra for a long time after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa, what kind of person, endowed with great virtue, would be able to liberate those who slander the Dharma?"

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: "Good son, for forty years after my passing into nirvāṇa this teaching will flourish widely throughout this world of Jambudvīpa, and then it will sink beneath the earth. Good son, consider this example: in a place where there are sugarcane, rice, molasses, milk, butter, and the essence of butter, the sentient beings who dwell there regard that taste as the supreme and finest of all tastes. Yet some of them eat nothing but millet and barley seeds, and they say: 'There is nothing more excellent than our food.' This is the karmic maturation of the deeds of beings of little merit. Those who are fortunate and endowed with merit never even hear of millet and barley seeds; they eat nothing but rice, sugarcane, molasses, and the essence of butter. This holy sūtra on nirvāṇa is just like this: those of dull faculties, of little merit, and without good fortune have no wish to hear it. Just as those of little merit have no desire for rice and molasses and the like, so too both vehicles of lesser scope are like that — they have no desire for this holy sūtra of the Great Passing beyond Sorrow. As for the ordinary person who is eager to hear this sūtra, who when they hear it rejoices greatly and does not slander it — they are like the fortunate sentient being who eats rice and the rest.

Good son, consider another example: a king who dwells in a very wretched and desolate mountain retreat, where sugarcane, rice, and molasses are available but scarce. Fearing their exhaustion, he restrains his wish to eat them and eats nothing but millet and barley seeds. Another king hears of this and, moved by kindness, loads rice, molasses, and the like onto carts and sends them as a gift. That first king then distributes and gives them to everyone, and only after that does he eat. Having eaten, they all rejoice, saying: 'Thanks to that king, we have eaten food we had never tasted before.' Good son, the fourth kind of person is likewise like this — a great caravan leader in the unsurpassed great Dharma.

Of those four kinds of persons, one of them, in some other region, sees that countless bodhisattvas are studying this sūtra of the Great Vehicle, or copying it into manuscripts, or having others copy it into manuscripts — whether for the sake of gain, honour, and renown, or for the sake of mastering the Dharma, or for the sake of having a support and a place of residence, or merely for the purpose of sending and exchanging it for other sūtras — yet sees that those bodhisattvas are unable to teach and expound it extensively to others. For the sake of those bodhisattvas, that person conveys this supreme sūtra to that region, gives it to them, causes them to arouse the mind of unsurpassable awakening, and establishes them on the path to awakening. Those bodhisattvas, having heard this sūtra, then teach and expound it extensively to others, and countless sentient beings come to taste the flavour of the Dharma of this Great Vehicle sūtra. That is how, through the power of that one bodhisattva, the sūtra comes to be heard by those who had not heard it before — just as, through the power of that one king, all came to taste food they had never tasted before.

Good son, furthermore, know that the place where this sūtra of the Great Passage into Nirvāṇa abides is like a vajra, and know that the person who dwells there is likewise like a vajra. Whoever listens to this sūtra will be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and whatever aspiration one holds will be fulfilled. Monk, you must hold firmly everything I have spoken here. As for any sentient being who is unable to listen to this sūtra, know that person to be a most fitting object of compassion — for that person is unable to hold the meaning of this supremely profound Great Vehicle sūtra.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, for forty years after the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa, this Great

Vehicle sūtra will spread widely throughout Jambudvīpa. After that it will sink beneath the earth, and only after a very long time will it emerge again.

The Blessed One declared: Good son, this sacred Dharma of mine, except for the last eighty years, will for the preceding forty years rain down as a great shower of Dharma upon this Jambudvīpa.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, when this sūtra is at the time of the decline of the sacred Dharma — when pure moral discipline has deteriorated, when what is not Dharma increases and proliferates, when there are no sentient beings who act in accordance with what is proper — may the Tathāgata, out of compassion for ordinary beings, please disclose and teach this openly, so that bodhisattvas who hear it may hold it. And by holding it in mind, may they become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Thereupon the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Excellent! Most excellent! Good son, it is good that you have asked about these matters. Good son, any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in the Gaṅgā river — if in this degenerate age that person holds and retains this sūtra, they do not slander it.

Good son, any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in one Gaṅgā river — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to have faith and devotion toward this sūtra, yet will be unable to expound it extensively to others or teach it.

Good son, any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in two Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to have faith and devotion, to hold and retain it, to read and recite it, yet will be unable to teach it extensively to others.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in three Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to read and recite it, and to write it down in a volume; and though they may teach it to others, they will not understand its profound meaning.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in four Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age,

that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to read and recite it, and to write it down in a volume; and that person will be able to teach others one sixteenth of its profound meaning. They will teach and expound it, yet even so they will not know it completely.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in five Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to read and recite it, and to write it down in a volume; and that person will also be able to teach others eight sixteenths of its profound meaning.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in six Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to read and recite it, and to write it down in a volume; and that person will also be able to teach others twelve sixteenths of its profound meaning.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in seven Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to recite and read it, and to write it down in a volume; and that person will also be able to teach others fourteen sixteenths of its profound meaning.

Any sentient being who arouses the mind of awakening toward buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in eight Gaṅgā rivers — in this degenerate age, that person will not slander this Dharma, and will come to hold and retain it, to read and recite it; they will urge others to write it down in a volume; they themselves will listen to and retain it, and will urge others likewise to listen to it, retain it, read and recite it, and take it to heart; out of love for the world, they will guard it carefully and make offerings to the sūtra, and will equally urge others to make offerings, to pay homage, to render reverence, to show respect, to bow before it, and to read and recite it. Such a person will come to a complete and thorough understanding of the profound meaning, which is this: the Tathāgata is endowed with the quality of permanently abiding — unchanging, ultimately blissful; they will expound extensively that sentient beings possess the nature of a buddha; they will be thoroughly skilled in the treasury of the Tathāgata's Dharma; and by making offerings to those buddhas, they will come to understand the holding, retaining, protecting, and establishing of these unsurpassed and genuine Dharmas.

Whoever arouses the mind of awakening toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete enlightenment — that person will, in a future time, hold, retain, and protect these genuine Dharmas, and it should be understood that they will certainly come to know the establishing of the genuine Dharma. Therefore, you too, in this coming degenerate age —

it should be understood that they will protect the genuine Dharma. And why is this? It is because those who arouse the mind of awakening will certainly, in a future time, be able to guard and hold these unsurpassed and genuine Dharmas.

Noble son, monks of poor moral discipline, upon hearing that I have passed into nirvāṇa, will feel no grief. They will say: "Now that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, we are satisfied. While the Tathāgata dwelt in the world, he was an obstacle to our gains; but now that he has passed into nirvāṇa, there is no one to obstruct or take away our gains. Since there is no one to obstruct or take them, we shall obtain gains in abundance. While the Tathāgata dwelt in the world, moral discipline was extremely strict; but now that he has passed into nirvāṇa, everything will become lax. Even wearing the monastic robe on one's body will amount to nothing more than playing at the appearance of the Dharma. Now it is worn out and tattered — like a tattered banner on a stick." Anyone who speaks in such a way slanders and debases this sūtra. Noble son, you must take this to heart.

Whatever sentient being possesses an abundance of qualities beyond measure will have faith and confidence in this Great Vehicle sūtra. Having gained that faith, they will hold and retain it; and if they then teach and explain it in full to other sentient beings who are eager to hear it, that person, by the mere act of hearing it, will be purified of all non-virtuous karma accumulated over countless and immeasurable past eons.

But whoever lacks faith in this sūtra, whoever has no confidence in it — in this very life they will be tormented and caused to suffer by illnesses of every kind; they will be reproached and reviled by many people; and after death they will be despised and scorned by all. Their appearance will be ugly; they will be utterly destitute of the necessities of life; whatever small thing they obtain will be of poor and coarse quality; and wherever they are born they will always be poor and of inferior birth. They will be born in a lineage that slanders the genuine Dharma and holds wrong views. When the time of death comes, they will be born in a land torn by strife, or will meet with weapons, or will

encounter a king who acts without justice, or will encounter enemies, or will fail to meet spiritual friends and companions even when they exist. They will find no necessities for life whatsoever; and even if they obtain a little, they will always be utterly tormented by hunger and thirst. They will associate with and rely on base and inferior people; kings and ministers too will want nothing to do with them; and even if they teach and explain without departing from the meaning, no one will have confidence in them or accept what they say. Such a person will not be born in a good and virtuous state. Just as a bird with broken wings cannot fly, that person likewise will not, in a future time, be born in a good state among gods or humans.

Now, if any person has confidence and faith in this Great Vehicle sūtra, then even if their present body is ugly and unattractive, through the power of the virtues of this sūtra they will come to be reborn with a beautiful form, endowed with splendor and might, with their radiance increasing and flourishing. All gods and humans dwelling in the world will find them pleasing and will wish to behold them; they will render them honor, respect, and offering, and will be loath to let them go. Kings and ministers, relatives, and retinues will have faith and confidence in whatever they say and teach.

If any attendant among my śrāvakas wishes to engage in the most excellent and supreme purpose, they should expound and teach this Great Vehicle sūtra in full to all those dwelling in the world.

Noble son, consider the following example: dew, however much it may wish to remain for a long time, cannot outlast the rising of the sun — the moment the sun rises, even whatever remains vanishes without a trace. Noble son, it is exactly the same with all the non-virtuous karma of those sentient beings:

— they cannot outlast the rising of the great sun of nirvāṇa. The very moment that sun rises, all their non-virtuous karma will melt away and be purified.

Noble son, here is another example. When a person has gone forth, shaving their hair and beard and wearing the robes, even if they have not undertaken the ten precepts of a novice, should a single householder invite the entire Saṅgha and that person — though they have not undertaken the precepts — is included among those invited as guests of the Saṅgha, then, although they have not undertaken the precepts, they still count as part of the Saṅgha.

Noble son, in exactly the same way, any sentient being who arouses the intention to study this Great Vehicle sūtra of nirvāṇa — who resolves to have it copied into a volume, to carry it, to hold it, to read it, or to recite it — that

person too is like one who, though not yet fully accomplished, has reached the tenth ground. They are to be counted among those of the tenth ground.

If any sentient being — whether or not they have become an attendant of the Buddha — who, out of fear born of attachment, or for the sake of profit and gain, hears and listens to even a single verse of this sūtra and does not disparage it, that person is to be understood as one who is close to and approaching unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Noble son, given such causes and conditions, were anyone to say of the four great beings what the Buddha has declared is not what the Buddha has declared, that would simply be impossible. Therefore, I have declared the four great beings to be, as it were, the support and foundation of the world.

Noble son, you should therefore make offerings to these four beings. The assembly then addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, how should we seek out and make offerings to these four great beings?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: To any person who guards and upholds the sacred Dharma, you should make supplication, and offer up even your body and your life as an act of homage. I have also said the same in other Great Vehicle sūtras:

Whoever knows the sacred Dharma,
whether old or young,
should honor them, pay homage, and make obeisance,
as to a father or a brahmin.

Whoever knows the sacred Dharma,
whether old or young,
should honor them, pay homage, and make obeisance,
as the gods worship their sovereign lord.

Then once again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, it is as you have declared — making offerings to one's teacher and preceptor is indeed as you have said. But please explain this at greater length. If a teacher who possesses moral discipline were to inquire about something not previously heard from a younger person, should one then pay homage to that person? And if one did pay homage to them, could one still be called a guardian of moral discipline? And conversely, if a younger person who possesses moral discipline were to inquire about something not previously heard from an elderly teacher whose moral discipline has deteriorated, should

one also pay homage to that person? And if a person who has gone forth were to inquire about something not previously heard from a householder, should one also pay homage to that householder? You have also declared that one who has gone forth should not bow down to a householder. Yet by the Buddha's Dharma, the young and junior should show respect and pay homage to their senior teachers. Why is that? Because those senior teachers have received full ordination earlier, and therefore one should show respect and bow down to them — so you have also declared.

Yet according to what the Blessed One has declared, one whose moral discipline has deteriorated does not truly enter into the Buddha's Dharma. You have declared such a person to be like weeds or grass in a field of good crop. But elsewhere the Blessed One has declared that if someone knows the sacred Dharma, whether old or young, one should honor them just as the gods honor their sovereign lord and king. How are these two meanings to be understood? Is there not a contradiction in what the Tathāgata has declared?

According to what the Blessed One has declared, in another mode the Blessed One declared that a monk who upholds moral discipline has no fault — why did the Blessed One say this? As for the declaration in other sūtras that those whose moral discipline has deteriorated are cut off by punishment, that too is not of definitive meaning.

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: Son of good family, I spoke those verses for the sake of bodhisattvas striving in the Great Vehicle in the time to come — not for the sake of the śrāvaka community. Son of good family, as I declared before, when the sacred Dharma is in decline and those of corrupt conduct are active, when those of corrupt discipline arise and act contrary to the Dharma, when no noble ones (āryas) at all appear openly, when servants — both male and female — and uninspected property are being held and used: at such a time, one among the four types of persons will appear — one who, having shaved hair and beard and gone forth into renunciation, exerts effort on the path. This person, observing individual monks holding servants — male and female — and laborers, holding uninspected property, not knowing what has and has not been examined, not knowing what is and is not in accord with the Vinaya, and yet seeing all this, in order to train those monks will outwardly conform his conduct to theirs, while within his own conduct is discordant. He is profoundly aware of his own domain of practice and of the sphere of the buddhas' conduct, and even when he sees faults and defeats incurred by opponents, he says nothing — he raises no objection. Why is this? Because he

has appeared in the world in order to protect and establish the sacred Dharma — therefore he says nothing and raises no objection. Son of good family, in this way, because that person acts for the protection of the Dharma, even though faults are present, one should not say that his moral discipline is broken.

Son of good family, consider this analogy. A king falls gravely ill and dies, and his heir is young and incapable of managing the affairs of state. At such a time, it happens that an outcast, enormously wealthy with great treasure and abundant possessions, with a very large retinue, grows proud of his power, seizes the royal throne by force, and installs himself as king. The householders, brahmins, and others who live in that land mostly scatter and flee to other regions. Even those who remain there have no wish to look upon that great king. If householders, merchants, brahmins, and the like cannot bring themselves to abandon the land, it is as though they will simply die in the very place where they were born, like trees fixed in their own ground. The outcast king, recognizing that many of the country's people have scattered and fled, then stations other outcasts at all the roads and marketplaces, and for seven days has drums beaten, proclaiming: "O brahmins! Whoever among you consecrates me by pouring empowerment upon my head — I will give half the kingdom!" Yet not a single brahmin came forward. Each said to the other: "It is impossible that one of brahmin lineage would perform such a service as this."

The outcast king then declared further: "If not even one of you brahmins will become my officiating priest, I will place you brahmins together with the lowborn outcasts, treat you as equals, and make you perform the same labors. But if you consecrate me by pouring empowerment upon my head, I will give half the kingdom. I bind this word with a pledge that it is no lie. I will also divide and bestow the ambrosia of immortality of the Thirty-Three Heaven." At that time, a young brahmin's son — very young, celibate, bearing the mark of the topknot, and highly skilled in mantra and ritual — went to where the king was and addressed the great king, declaring: "I will perform this for Your Majesty."

The king was overjoyed and appointed that young brahmin to perform the head-consecration empowerment. When the other brahmins heard this, they all reviled the youth, saying: "You are a brahmin — why do you make yourself the ritual master of that lowborn outcaste?" At that time the king gave the young man half the kingdom, and together they assumed the governance of

the realm.

After some time had passed, the young man addressed the king with these words: "If I leave my home and come to serve as Your Majesty's teacher, I will instruct and train the king in mantra, craft, and related arts, yet the king does not think of me as someone close." The king replied: "How could I not think of you as someone close?" The young man said: "Your Majesty has not yet sought that elixir of immortality promised to you long ago." The king replied: "Excellent! Excellent! Great teacher, I had not sought it — forgive me. Since the teacher wishes it, please accept all of it." Then the young man took the medicine the king gave him, went home, and drank it together with the chief ministers. After they had drunk it, they felt greatly at ease. The ministers then reported to the king, saying: "Teacher, there is indeed a deathless medicine — it is like ambrosia." When the king heard this, he said to the teacher: "Great teacher, will you not give a portion of this ambrosia that the chief ministers desire?"

Thereupon the young man mixed poison into it and gave it to the king. The moment the king swallowed it, the poison took hold, he lost all sensation, and he collapsed as though dead. Then the young brahmin consecrated a regent as king, and declared: "It is not right that outcasts and the like sit by birth-right upon the lion throne. I have never heard from ancient times that a lowborn outcaste may be king. Since there is no custom by which a lowborn outcaste may be king and hold sovereignty over subjects, you shall be king. Rule the kingdom by the law of righteousness." After all this was done, the young man gave the outcaste a restorative medicine and brought him back to his senses. Once he had recovered, he was expelled from that land. Even though the young man had done all these things, he did not transgress brahmin law. The householders and brahmins and others who witnessed what had happened were filled with wonder and admiration, and all praised and extolled him, saying: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble man, you have rightly expelled this lowborn outcaste."

Sons of the lineage, in just the same way are the bodhisattvas who, after my complete passing into nirvāṇa, guard and uphold the sacred Dharma. Through skillful means they carry and make use of all the requisites of monks who are degenerate in ethical conduct in name only and who have not been scrutinized, and they associate in ways befitting those acts. At such times, if certain individuals punish monks who are sinful and who have violated their ethical discipline many times over, the bodhisattva steps into their place,

showing them service, reverence, and homage, offering all four kinds of requisites — or, if that is not suitable, offering sūtras and all the requisites of livelihood. And should he himself lack the means, he solicits from patrons by various methods and makes the offering. Thus he carries and makes use of all eight kinds of unsolicited requisites. And why? Because that individual's disciplining of sinful monks is just like the young brahmin's disciplining of the lowborn outcaste. Accordingly, when a bodhisattva renders service, reverence, or homage to such an individual, or carries the eight unsolicited requisites, there is no wrongdoing. And why? Because that bodhisattva expelled the sinful monks in order to bring great wellbeing to the pure Saṅgha.

— for the sake of bringing benefit and wellbeing to all gods and humans in the world, through the wide propagation of the sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

Noble son, for that reason and on account of those conditions, I taught in the sūtras those two verses. Bodhisattvas, too, praise and extol one who is a guardian of the true Dharma, just as householders, brahmins, and others praised the young brahmin, saying "Excellent! Excellent!" One who is a bodhisattva guarding the Dharma must act in exactly that manner.

Now, if someone, upon seeing that guardians of the Dharma are working alongside monks of broken ethical conduct, takes that as a fault, that person should know that the harm is to himself — for the one guarding the Dharma, there is no fault. Noble son, any monk who, having fallen into ethical failure, comes under the sway of pride, concealing his transgression and feeling no remorse — that person is to be called one who has truly broken his ethical conduct. But the bodhisattva, the great being, who may show signs of lapse while guarding the Dharma, should not be said to have broken his ethical conduct. And why? Because he is not under the sway of pride — he has openly confessed and disclosed his transgression.

Noble son, for that reason I taught in the sūtras these verses of definite import:

One who knows the true Dharma,
whether elder or young,
should be served, honored, and revered,
bowing down to him with joined palms —
as brahmins revere the fire deity,
as the thirty-three gods
honor Śakra, the Mighty Lord.

For that reason and on account of those conditions, I did not teach these verses for those of the śrāvaka vehicle, but taught them solely for the bodhisattvas.

Then again, the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "If the great bodhisattvas, the great beings, appear to be lax in their ethical conduct in this way, would it be right to say that their originally undertaken ethical conduct has been impaired?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, do not say such a thing. And why? The ethical conduct originally undertaken does not become impaired any more than conduct that has been well undertaken and maintained. And even if it should become impaired, one immediately feels remorse, confesses openly, and through that confession it is completely purified.

Noble son, consider this analogy: it is like the headwork of an irrigation channel. If it develops a breach, water leaks out. And why? Because it has not been repaired. But if that breach is mended, the water does not leak to the outside.

The bodhisattva is just like that: even while experiencing a lapse in ethical conduct, he simultaneously performs the restoration ceremony, the acts arising from the rules, and the acts of the Saṅgha — and his ethical conduct is not impaired. He is not like the irrigation channel with a breach. And why? If there were no one with fully pure ethical conduct, the Saṅgha would decline, and pride and laziness would arise again and again. But if there is one with fully pure ethical conduct, even the ethical conduct undertaken at the time of full ordination is not impaired.

Noble son, laxity with respect to the vehicle may be called laxity, but laxity with respect to ethical conduct should not be called laxity. When great bodhisattvas, great beings, in this Great Vehicle are free from minds of pride and laziness, that itself is called ethical conduct — they wash themselves with the water of the Great Vehicle for the sake of guarding the true Dharma. Therefore, even if a bodhisattva appears to show a lapse in ethical conduct, it should not be called laxity.

Then once more the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, though there may be four kinds of persons within the Saṅgha, when it is as difficult to discern whether they are ripe or unripe as it is to tell a ripe mango fruit from an unripe one, how is one to distinguish between those who have broken their ethical conduct and those who have

not?"

The Blessed One declared:

Noble son, this is easy to discern by means of this great sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa. And how is it discerned by means of this great sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa? Consider, for example, how farmers sow grain and weeds together in a field, then remove the wild weeds and other growth. When they examine it with a fleshly eye they call the field ripe, and once the grain has matured they separate the grain from the grass and weeds. In the same way, the Saṅgha can become blemished through eight kinds of unexamined things. Yet when these are removed, even examination with a fleshly eye reveals it to be thoroughly pure. When those who have broken ethical conduct and those who guard it commit no transgression, it is difficult to discern them by examination with a fleshly eye. But when a transgression has openly occurred, it is easy to know — just as wild weeds are easy to recognize and discern. The Saṅgha is similar: the eight unexamined things are to be abandoned like a venomous snake, and then that Saṅgha is called the thoroughly pure noble Saṅgha, a field of merit worthy of offering by gods and humans, in which the fruit of thorough purity will ripen. This is not something those with fleshly eyes can perceive.

Noble son, consider further: in a grove of kālaka trees, the kālaka trees are extremely numerous, while there is only a single cintaka tree. The fruit of the kālaka and the cintaka are similar, and since they cannot be distinguished, when the fruit has ripened, a woman gathers them all together. In that grove, roughly one tenth of the fruit is cintaka fruit, while more than nine tenths is kālaka fruit. The woman, not knowing this, gathers them together and sells them at market. Small foolish children, not knowing the real nature of the fruit, buy the kālaka fruit and eat it, and immediately upon eating it they die. Wise and discerning people, upon hearing what has happened, ask the woman: "Where did this poisonous fruit come from?" The woman names the direction and place from which she came. Then everyone proclaims to one another: "In that place and direction there are abundant kālaka trees, and there is only a single cintaka tree," and they go their way.

Noble son, those within the Saṅgha who practice the eight unexamined things are just like this. Among the Saṅgha, those who practice the eight unexamined things are extremely numerous, while those who guard ethical conduct fully and do not practice the eight unexamined things are just a few. Those who

know that a person carries and practices things contrary to the Dharma nonetheless work alongside them and do not part from them — just as in a grove of kālaka trees a single cintaka tree grows. When a lay practitioner sees such persons practicing many things contrary to the Dharma and receiving no offerings or acts of reverence, and intends to make an offering to such a person, he should first ask that person: "Venerable one, do you practice the eight unexamined things? Has the Buddha permitted this?" If the person says the Buddha has permitted it, then ask: "Is it proper or improper to join with such a person in the restoration ceremony, in petitions, in formal acts of request, and in acts of Dharmic procedure?" When the lay practitioner asks this and the monastics say: "The Blessed One, out of compassion, has permitted us to carry and practice these eight unexamined things," then the lay practitioner should reflect: "From the monks of a single monastery, some say that gold and silver and the like have been permitted by the Buddha, while others say they have not been permitted." One should not dwell together with those who say it is permitted and those who say it is not permitted. One should not join them in the restoration ceremony or in acts of Dharmic procedure.

"When young, one would not even drink from the same water source, nor share the requisites of livelihood in common." If they say this, then ask: "Why do you say that the Buddha has permitted it? Whatever the Blessed One has permitted the gods to enjoy and keep among themselves is not fitting for you, the Saṅgha, to enjoy. And if you do enjoy it, you are not fit to participate in the restoration ceremony, in the rite of going forth from the community, in formal requests, in petitions, or in the acts of Dharmic procedure performed by the Saṅgha. And if you do perform the restoration ceremony, the going forth, formal requests, petitions, and acts of Dharmic procedure together with the Saṅgha, then immediately upon death you will fall into the hells — just as parrots die from eating the kāla fruit."

Son of good family, consider further this example: in a town or marketplace, a medicine seller who sells good mountain-grown medicinal herbs will have many buyers. If another person sells a similar medicine, but everyone is unaware of this, and all come to the medicine seller's stall seeking medicine and ask, "Do you have mountain-grown herbs?" — then that medicine seller, taking some similar herb, says falsely, "This is mountain-grown medicine," and sells it. Because the buyers cannot distinguish it with their physical eyes, they think to themselves: "I have obtained and purchased fine mountain-grown

medicine."

The ninth fascicle.

Kāśyapa, within the Saṅgha of śrāvaka monastics there exist what are called the Saṅgha in name only, the authentic Saṅgha, and the harmonious Saṅgha. Whether that Saṅgha upholds moral discipline or whether its discipline is impaired, one should equally offer it homage, reverence, prostrations, and the like. The failure of the lay practitioner to distinguish is like a person failing to distinguish genuine mountain-grown medicinal herbs. Who upholds moral discipline and who has impaired it, who constitutes the authentic Saṅgha and who the Saṅgha in name only — one who possesses the divine eye knows and discerns this.

Kāśyapa, if a lay practitioner truly knows that a monk has impaired his moral discipline, he should not pay that monk service, prostrations, offerings, and the like. If one truly knows that a particular person engages in the eight unexamined things, one should not extend to him respectful attendance, provision of offerings and supplies, prostrations, homage, and the like. If there is someone within the Saṅgha whose moral discipline is impaired, merely wearing the ochre robe is not sufficient reason to offer him prostrations, homage, and the like.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa once more addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Excellent! Excellent! Blessed One, the Tathāgata has spoken rightly and truly, and I wish to hold it in mind. Just as a vajra differs from other precious stones — so, Blessed One, as you have taught, monks should abide in these four principles of the Dharma. What are the four? Abiding in the Dharma rather than in the person; abiding in the meaning rather than in the words; abiding in primordial wisdom rather than in ordinary consciousness; and abiding in the definitive meaning rather than in the interpretable meaning. One should seek to understand these four principles of the Dharma, not the four types of persons."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, 'abiding in the Dharma' means the great parinirvāṇa of the Tathāgata. The Dharma of the buddhas is the nature of reality of phenomena. That which is called the nature of reality is the Tathāgata himself. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent and unchanging. Whoever says that the Tathāgata is impermanent is one who neither sees nor knows the nature of reality. And if one does not see and does not know the nature of reality, one does not abide in it or rely upon it.

If the four types of persons described above appear in the world and guard and uphold the sacred Dharma, one should know and recognize them, and one should abide in and rely upon them. Why is this? Because those individuals are supremely skilled in the profound meaning that the Tathāgata intended and taught, and they know that the Tathāgata is permanent and unchanging. There is simply no ground for saying that the Tathāgata is impermanent, or that he possesses the nature of change and transformation. Those four types of persons are themselves called "Tathāgata." Why is this? Because those individuals both know what the Tathāgata intended and taught, and are also capable of teaching it to others.

If a person both knows the profound meaning that the Tathāgata intended and taught, and knows that the Tathāgata possesses the nature of permanence and unchangingness, there is no ground for that person to say "the Tathāgata is impermanent" merely for the sake of material gain or reputation. One should abide in and rely upon such a person as well — how much more so upon the four persons themselves. "Abiding in the Dharma" means abiding in the nature of reality. "Not abiding in persons" means not abiding in śrāvakas. The nature of reality is the Tathāgata. The śrāvaka is the conditioned. The Tathāgata is permanent. The conditioned is impermanent.

Son of good family, if a person of degenerate moral discipline says, for the sake of gain or reputation, "The Tathāgata is impermanent, subject to change and transformation," one must not abide in that person.

Son of good family, this is called "the definitive meaning." Now, what is meant by "abiding in the meaning and not in the words"? The meaning is the direct realization of the meaning. That which is called "the directly realized meaning" is the inexhaustible. The inexhaustible is what is consummate and excellent. The meaning of what is consummate and excellent is the Tathāgata abiding forever, unchanging, without transformation. The meaning of the Tathāgata abiding forever, unchanging, without transformation, is the permanence of the Dharma. The meaning of the permanence of the Dharma is the permanence of the Saṅgha. This is called "abiding in the meaning and not in the words."

Now, what are the words in which one must not abide? They are these: the learning systems of the world that are filled with elaboration; the innumerable sūtras that the Blessed One spoke for those who are acquisitive without limit or contentment, who live by deceit and act with cunning, who feign proper conduct for the sake of gain and fame, and who rely upon householders.

Furthermore, if someone says, "The Blessed One, the Buddha, permitted monks to keep and use the following: male servants and female servants, uninvestigated goods, gold, silver, precious stones, grain, rice, storehouses, cattle, sheep, wool, elephants, horses, and the like — to use and trade in them," or says, "When a time of famine came, out of compassion for his sons, the Blessed One said, 'Monks, you may keep and use surplus provisions,'" or says, "I have taken this cloth, and having rendered it fit for food, it is permissible to eat it even without receiving it formally" — even if such statements appear in sūtras, one must not abide in those words.

Now, what is meant by "abiding in wisdom and not in consciousness"? Wisdom is the Tathāgata. Any śrāvaka who does not fully abide in the qualities of the Tathāgata — that is consciousness, and one must not abide in it. Whoever knows the Tathāgata himself to be the dharmakāya, the truth body — that is authentic wisdom, and one should abide in it. Whoever knows the body that the Tathāgata presents as a skillful means to be something composed of aggregates, elements, and sense sources, sustained by food — that is consciousness, and one must not abide in it. And whether this is taught through speech or derived from texts and learned traditions, one must not abide in it.

One abides in sūtras of definitive meaning and does not abide in sūtras of provisional meaning. What is meant by this? Sūtras of provisional meaning are those such as the following: when those who belong to the śrāvaka vehicle hear of the Blessed One's profoundly deep meaning, they give rise to doubt and astonishment, for they do not know that from the profound, essential meaning there arises a vast ocean of primordial wisdom. As an analogy, a small child who understands nothing and makes no distinctions — this is called provisional meaning. Definitive meaning, on the other hand, is when the authentic primordial wisdom of a bodhisattva enters an unobstructed wisdom just as intended — as an analogy, a great person for whom nothing is unknown. This is called definitive meaning. Furthermore, the śrāvaka vehicle is called provisional meaning. The unsurpassed Great Vehicle is called definitive meaning. Whoever says that the Tathāgata is impermanent, subject to change and alteration, speaks provisional meaning. Whoever says that the Tathāgata is permanent, not subject to change or alteration, speaks definitive meaning. Whatever is understood and realized through the teachings of the śrāvaka vehicle is provisional meaning. Whatever is comprehended and known through the teachings of the bodhisattva vehicle is definitive meaning. Whoever says

that the Tathāgata requires nourishment through food speaks provisional meaning. Whoever says that the Tathāgata is permanent, abiding, unchanging, and unalterable speaks definitive meaning. Whoever says that the Tathāgata's passage into nirvāṇa is like a fire dying out when the wood is exhausted speaks provisional meaning. Whoever says that the Tathāgata has entered into the very expanse of the dharmadhātu speaks definitive meaning.

In short, one must not abide in the Dharma of the śrāvaka vehicle. Why? Because the Tathāgata taught the śrāvaka vehicle as a preparatory method for liberating ordinary beings. It is like a householder teaching a young child only half the alphabet. Noble son, the śrāvaka vehicle is comparable to a field that has just been freshly plowed — since it yields no fruit, one must not abide in it. Therefore the śrāvaka vehicle is called provisional meaning, and one should abide in the Dharma of the Great Vehicle. Why? Because the Tathāgata, as a preparatory method for liberating ordinary beings, taught the Great Vehicle — and therefore it is called definitive meaning, and one should abide in it. In this way one should thoroughly comprehend and know the four modes of abiding of this kind.

Furthermore, as for abiding in the meaning — "meaning" is the authentic. The authentic is luminosity. Luminosity is the unshrunk. The unshrunk is the Tathāgata. And further: luminosity is primordial wisdom. The authentic is that which permanently abides. The permanent Tathāgata is one who abides in Dharma. "Dharma" here means that which is permanent, without limit, inconceivable, ungraspable, and unbounded — and which is fit to be beheld. If someone says it cannot be seen, one must not abide in that person. Therefore one abides in Dharma and not in persons.

If someone says with very fine words that it is impermanent, one must not abide in those words. Therefore one abides in the meaning and not in words.

The Saṅgha that abides in primordial wisdom is permanent, unconditioned, unalterable, and does not hold to the eight unexamined things. Therefore one abides in primordial wisdom and not in consciousness.

There are also some who say: "Created by consciousness, experienced by consciousness — there is no harmonious Saṅgha." Why? Because "harmonious" means that there is nothing whatsoever. Since there is nothing whatsoever, of what could one say "permanent"? Therefore one does not abide in consciousness.

What then is abiding in the definitive meaning? "Definitive meaning" means contentment: never sustaining oneself through deception, never embellishing one's conduct, never entertaining conceit, never clinging to gain and fame, and never becoming attached to the Dharma that the Tathāgata taught as a preparatory method. That is what is called the definitive meaning. Whoever abides in that is said to abide in the ultimate truth. Therefore one abides in the definitive meaning.

What then is not abiding in the provisional meaning? The provisional meaning refers to what is taught in the sūtras: "All is subject to affliction; all is impermanent; all is suffering; all is empty; all is without self." This is what is called the provisional meaning. Why? Because not understanding those very meanings causes many beings to fall into the boundless hells. How is that? Through clinging and attachment one fails to directly realize the meaning. Some take it that the Tathāgata taught, "All that is subject to affliction — nirvāṇa too is subject to affliction; all that is impermanent — nirvāṇa too is impermanent," and one must understand this at length through suffering, emptiness, and selflessness as well. Therefore one should not abide in sūtras of the provisional meaning.

Now, if someone were to say, "Because the Tathāgata is deeply skilled in time and measure out of loving concern for all sentient beings, he who is skilled in time speaks of the light as heavy and the heavy as light. Understanding this, the Tathāgata knew that there was a lay attendant whose patron, moved by faith, provided him with all the requisites he desired. To that person, the Blessed One did not permit the holding and use of any of the unexamined things such as male servants, female servants, gold, silver, and jewels, the conducting of trade, and so forth. Yet when there was a lay attendant who had no patron to provide him with the requisites for a livelihood, and famine had come and alms could not be found, in order to establish and protect the proper Dharma, the Tathāgata did permit my attendants to hold and use male servants, female servants, gold, silver, vehicles, dwellings, grain and rice, trade goods, and the like. And even though he permitted the holding and use of such things, a patron endowed with great faith must by no means be absent" — if someone were to speak thus, one should not abide in those words. And even if the Vinaya, the Abhidharma, or the sūtras were to say something in accord with this, one should not abide in those three baskets of scripture either.

"I taught these four grounds of abiding for beings with the eye of flesh, not for those with the eye of wisdom. For that reason I have taught these four grounds of abiding."

"Dharma" means the dharmatā, the nature of reality, of all phenomena. "Meaning" means the Tathāgata, who is permanent and unchanging. "Primordial wisdom" means knowing that the nature of the buddha is present in all sentient beings. "Definitive meaning" means understanding all sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

Then once again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One, saying, "Blessed One, should we not abide in the four kinds of persons mentioned earlier by the Blessed One?" The Blessed One replied, "Indeed it is so. Indeed it is so."

"Son of good family, one should not abide in what the Blessed One has described in that way. And why not? Because there are four kinds of māra. What are the four? They are those who hold sūtras and Vinaya taught by māra."

Then once again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One, saying, "Blessed One, since you have said there are also four kinds of māra, how are we to distinguish what is taught by māra from what was spoken by the Buddha? For there are ordinary beings who follow māra, and there are also those who follow what the Buddha has taught. How are we to recognize which is which?"

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa, "After seven hundred years have passed following my complete nirvāṇa, the wicked māra will damage and corrupt the sacred Dharma. Just as a hunter wears a covering of saffron-colored cloth, so too will the wicked māra appear in the form of a monk, in the form of a nun, in the form of a male lay practitioner, and in the form of a female lay practitioner. And beyond these, he will take on emanation forms ranging from stream-enterers all the way up to arhats, and will also appear in the form of a buddha. The king of māra, with his defiled body, will manifest as an undefiled body, and will damage and corrupt my sacred Dharma.

"When the wicked māra acts to corrupt the sacred Dharma, he will say things such as these: 'The bodhisattva previously became invisible from Tuṣita heaven and was born from the union of his father and mother in the palace of King Śuddhodana in the city of Kapilavastu.' He will say: 'This person was born

in the human lineage, present in the world, and it is impossible that all the assemblies of gods and humans should venerate and pay homage to him.' And further he will say: 'Previously he engaged in many austerities and, having given gifts such as his head, his eyes, his bones, his limbs, his lands, his kingdoms, his wives, his sons, and so forth, he then fully awakened to buddhahood — and by that cause and through those conditions, those present in the world, namely gods, humans, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and great serpents (nāgas) and the rest, came to venerate and pay homage to him.' If such things appear in a sūtra or in the Vinaya, know that this is taught by māra.

"Son of good family, when in a sūtra or the Vinaya the following is found — that the Tathāgata awakened long ago, and that he demonstrated his awakening in order to liberate sentient beings, and that following worldly convention he showed himself as born from the union of father and mother — when a sūtra or Vinaya contains such a statement, know that this is truly the Tathāgata. Whoever follows what is taught by māra belongs to the party of māra. Whoever follows the sūtras and Vinaya taught by the Buddha should be known as a bodhisattva.

"Furthermore, if one does not believe that from the moment of the Tathāgata's birth he walked seven steps in each of the ten directions, then one has entered upon what is taught by māra. But when one says that the Tathāgata appeared in the world and walked seven steps in each of the ten directions as a display of skillful means by the Tathāgata, then that is the sūtra and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata. Whoever follows what is taught by māra is called one who belongs to the party of māra. Whoever follows the sūtras and Vinaya taught by the Buddha is called a bodhisattva."

Regarding this: when the bodhisattva had just been born and the royal father led him to pay reverence at the shrine of the gods, the gods, upon seeing him, immediately prostrated to him. For that reason he is called a buddha. Regarding this, if someone contends thus: "The gods came first; the Buddha came later, so why should the gods bow down and show reverence to the Buddha?" — one should know that this is what is taught by māra the evil one. But when the sūtras and Vinaya say that when the Blessed One Buddha went to the shrine of the gods, Maheśvara the great lord, Mahābrahmā the great Brahmā, Śakra the lord of the gods, and all the other gods joined their palms together and, with full reverence, prostrated at his feet — this is what is taught by the Buddha. Whoever follows what is taught by māra is called one who

belongs to the party of māra. Whoever follows what is taught by the Buddha is called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, when sūtras and Vinaya say that while the bodhisattva served as regent, he sought queens from the four directions with a mind of desire and, within the palace, freely enjoyed the five objects of desire — if such a statement appears in a sūtra or Vinaya, that is what is taught by māra. But when sūtras and Vinaya say that the bodhisattva, having long since completely relinquished desire and the allure of a retinue of consorts, and having cast aside even the five objects of desire of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three as one spits out saliva — to say nothing of human desires — shaved his head and beard, and went forth from home into homelessness, and then applied himself earnestly to awakening — if such a statement appears in the sūtras and Vinaya, that is what is taught by the Buddha. Whoever follows the sūtras and Vinaya taught by māra is called one who belongs to the party of māra. Whoever follows the sūtras and Vinaya taught by the Buddha is called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, if a sūtra or Vinaya says: "Formerly, when the Blessed One Buddha dwelt in Prince Jeta's Grove, he, out of great compassion and loving care for sentient beings, permitted the monks to keep and make use of male slaves, female slaves, hired laborers, cattle, goats, sheep, woolen elephants, horses, donkeys, mules, birds, dogs, pigs, and the like; gold, silver, vaidūrya, pearl, crystal, asmagarbha, musāragalva, crystal cloth, iron, copper, and copper vessels of various sizes, and other goods not sanctioned by the Vinaya; to plow fields; to engage in trade; and to store and use grain and the like" — if such a statement appears in a sūtra or Vinaya, that is what is taught by māra.

But regarding this: formerly, when the Buddha dwelt in Prince Jeta's Grove in the place called the hungry ghost Dālilā, the Blessed One, for the sake of a brahmin named Qualities and in order to utterly defeat King Army, declared: "A monk should not hold or make use of gold, silver, vaidūrya, crystal, pearl, musāragalva, coral, asmagarbha, crystal cloth, male slaves, female slaves, hired laborers, boys, girls, cattle, sheep, woolen elephants, horses, donkeys, mules, birds, dogs, pigs, iron, copper, large and small copper vessels, and other unsanctioned goods, nor thrones, bedding,

various articles of livelihood, houses and dwellings, farming, trade goods, waving a cloth to agitate food, waving a cloth to sift flour, winnowing rice, mantras for bodily sustenance, rituals for taming hawks, reading stars, casting

divination, reading a husband's physiognomic signs, dispelling nightmares, and examining by the sixty-four branches of expertise to determine whether this will become a boy or a girl, whether it will not be a boy or will not be a girl; likewise the eighteen branches of traditional knowledge, mantras, crafts of various kinds, speaking endless worldly treatises, and compounding powdered incense, ointments, and various fumigants; various garlands of flowers, rituals for dressing hair, duplicity, deception, trickery, insatiable craving for gains, delight in gatherings and chatter and tales, delight in fish and meat, compounding poisons, compounding medicines for removing moles, compounding anointing butter preparations, making precious parasols and shoes and the like, fans and gift-boxes and paintings and the like, measures of rice, various types of beans, varieties of fruit and so on; relying on kings, princes, ministers, and great officials; relying on women; laughing out loud and boisterously in company; falling entirely silent in company; doubting among the Dharmas; speaking falsehood; falsely declaring this good, that bad, this virtuous, that non-virtuous; dressing in fine robes and preening and the like — engaging and acting in all these various uninvestigated pursuits; praising oneself in front of faithful donors; selling liquor in uninvestigated places; constantly going about trading serpents with serpent-women — all such things have not been declared by me as permitted for monks. Nor are these permitted to remain within the company of monks. They are to be returned to the status of laypeople and put to work accordingly. It is like wild grain growing up within a cultivated field: it is cleared out and removed without exception."

Know that the sūtras and Vinaya taught in this way are what the Tathāgata has proclaimed. Whoever follows that which is taught by māra is counted among the party of māra. Whoever follows that which is taught by the Buddha is called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, it is said: a bodhisattva goes to the shrines of worldly gods in order to pay homage to those gods. For instance, he goes to the god Brahmā, the Great Sovereign (Śiva), Yugasela, Kātyāyana, and so forth. Yet going there is not the same as going in order to discipline the gods. There is simply no basis for that claim.

Moreover, it is said: a bodhisattva, being unable to excel tīrthikas in their scriptural learning, ascetic practices, conduct, speech and discourse, the arts, and the resolution of disputes and arguments, is therefore not shown respect by boys, girls, great officials, and the like. And since he does not know how to

compound medicines and the like, he is called a Tathāgata. But if he did know, would he then be said to have wrong views and mistaken understanding? Furthermore, the Tathāgata regards enemies and friends with equal consideration. Whether struck with a weapon or anointed with perfumed unguents, he holds no thought of benefit or harm toward either, abiding in the middle. He is therefore called Tathāgata — "thus-gone." Should such a passage appear in a sūtra or the Vinaya, know that it is taught by māra.

Now, as for what is said: a bodhisattva, by such skillful means, goes to divine shrines and —

going forth from the Dharma of non-Buddhist adherents and demonstrating engagement in study; demonstrating conduct, austerity, and knowing contentment; demonstrating study in a school of letters so as to master all the arts of word and expression; demonstrating the reconciling of those who have fallen into dispute and quarrel; and demonstrating excellence and supremacy over the many in a great retinue — princes and princesses, queens, palace servants, householders, merchants, brahmins and the like, kings, great ministers, and the poor — and demonstrating that these very ones offer service and reverence. In such ways and more, many different aspects of things are demonstrated. Yet even while abiding in those views, attachment does not arise — just as a lotus is not soiled by dust and grime. And to liberate the many beings, one engages in such manifold skillful means in accordance with the ways of the world. Should such a passage appear in a sūtra or the Vinaya, know that it has been taught by the Tathāgata. And whoever follows what is taught by māra is to be counted among the faction of māra. Whoever follows what is taught by the Buddha is a great bodhisattva.

Now, there are those who say: "The Tathāgata taught us sūtras and Vinaya, and among unwholesome phenomena, the weighty and the light, and those intermediate between them as transgressions, are heavy by their inherent nature. Therefore we do not transgress the Vinaya. We have long endured with patience. But if you do not trust in these teachings, then, as we say, we have set aside our Vinaya and will follow yours. Your Vinaya is taught by māra, whereas our sūtras and Vinaya were established by the Buddha. The nine limbs of scripture that the Tathāgata formerly spoke were all definitively taught within our nine sūtras and our Vinaya; but of the vastly expanded sūtras we have not heard even a single word or a single syllable. The sūtras and Vinaya taught by the Tathāgata are beyond measure — so there is no such thing as 'vastly expanded sūtras,' and from among those we have never

heard that there are ten categories of scriptural scripture. If such a thing does exist, know that without doubt it was composed by Devadatta. That wicked Devadatta, in order to destroy wholesome Dharma, composed vastly expanded sūtras; and since our sūtras are taught by māra, we do not trust them." Why do they say this? "Because words such as these — destroying the Dharma and disparaging one another — come from your sūtras, not from ours. From our own sūtras and Vinaya, taught by the Tathāgata, there comes in secret this statement: 'After I have passed into complete nirvāṇa, in a degenerate age, inauthentic sūtras and Vinaya called vastly expanded Mahāyāna sūtras will appear.' Thus it is said that in a future time such wicked monks will arise. And I too have spoken thus: that there exist vastly expanded sūtras apart from the nine limbs of scripture. Thus whoever understands the meaning of this truly comprehends the sūtras and Vinaya in an utterly correct way; such a one has abandoned all phenomena not yet examined — pure and clear like a fish in the water of the moon, as I have said. But as for those who say: 'Even from each individual sūtra taught by the Tathāgata, meanings as numerous as the grains of sand of the Ganges River arise' — they have not said this, and therefore this is simply not valid. And if it does exist, why was it not taught in our Vinaya?"

"It was not taught in this way; since it has not arisen, we do not believe in it." When someone speaks thus, that person should be understood to have committed a very grave offense. Yet that same person may also say: "As for those sūtras and the Vinaya, I shall uphold them." Why so? Because they lead to contentment, to few desires, to cutting through mental afflictions, to wisdom, and to being a cause of the wholesome phenomena that bring liberation. Even if one speaks thus, such a person is still not my intimate companion.

On the other hand, someone who says: "The Tathāgata taught the vastly expanded sūtras in order to liberate the many beings," — that person should be recognized as a true and genuine intimate companion of mine.

As for one who does not accept the vastly expanded sūtras, that person is not my intimate companion, has not gone forth through the Dharma of the buddha, and should be known to belong to the assembly of tīrthikas with wrong views.

Whatever sūtra or Vinaya contains the declaration: "This was taught by a buddha" — that is indeed taught by a buddha. Whatever does not contain this

is taught by Māra. Whoever follows what is taught by Māra is called a member of Māra's retinue. Whoever follows what is taught by a buddha is called a bodhisattva.

Noble son, there are also those who say: "The Tathāgata is not made up of limitless qualities; impermanent, he changes and passes away. He is said to be without self because he has obtained empty phenomena. This is not in accord with the world." Any sūtra or Vinaya from which such words arise is taught by Māra.

On the other hand, whatever is found in sūtra or Vinaya declaring: "The Tathāgata, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, is inconceivable, formed from immeasurable and innumerable qualities, and therefore is permanent, abiding, unchanging, and unshifting" — that is taught by a buddha. Whoever follows what is taught by Māra belongs to Māra's party. Whoever follows what is taught by a buddha is called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, there are some who say: "Monks, no one has individually incurred a root defeat, and yet all have incurred a root defeat — they have become like a palmyra palm tree whose crown has been cut off." Even so, that monk has not incurred a root defeat. Why? Because I declared: "If one falls into even a single one of the four root defeats, one cannot return, just as a broken stone cannot be mended." As for one who says "The teacher has attained superhuman states," that person has incurred a root defeat. Why? Because if one, having truly attained nothing whatsoever, pretends to have attained it through deception and guile, that person is said to have fallen from the human condition — that is a root defeat.

This is how it is. A monk who has few desires, is content, guards his ethical discipline, is utterly pure, and dwells at the forest's edge — suppose a king or a great minister comes to him and, thinking "this monk will become an arhat," approaches him, pays him reverence, venerates him, and prostrates to him, then says: "Great teacher, in this very next life this body of yours will awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening." That monk then says to the king: "Great king, I have not truly attained the fruit of the ascetic life. Therefore, great king, please do not say to me, 'You have attained the fruit of the ascetic life.' Great king, please do not declare to me the teaching of one without contentment. As for those without contentment, even should they praise you up to the point of saying, 'You have manifestly awakened to the highest, perfect, complete awakening,' he does not answer and says nothing

whatsoever."

"And if I too were to give no answer and say nothing whatsoever, the Blessed One, the buddha, would condemn me for that. One who conducts oneself with contentment is praised and extolled by all the buddhas. Therefore I am always glad to dwell in contentment. Contentment means this: even should the king say to me, 'You have attained the fruit,' when I have not attained the fruit, I do not desire that — this is what is called contentment."

At that point the king says: "Great teacher, you have truly attained the fruit of the arhat and are not different from a buddha." When he says this, the king then proclaims throughout all the subjects of his realm, all his queens, and all the retinue of his palace attendants: "This monk has attained the fruit of the ascetic life." When all who hear these words develop toward that monk a mind of very deep faith, wishing to make offerings, to show respect, and to render service, then because that monk is truly living a pure and holy life (brahmacarya), by that cause and condition all those who rejoice in him acquire great merit, while the monk himself does not incur the fault of a root defeat (pārājika). Why is that? Because in the minds of others there arises, of their own accord, joy, faith, praise, and the wish to make offerings. Thus there is no fault at all for that monk. And if anyone were to say that there is a fault in this, it should be understood that such a sūtra was taught by Māra.

Furthermore, monks, from a profound sūtra spoken by the buddha with hidden intent, the teaching goes: "All sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Because they possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, by cutting through measureless defilements they will manifestly and perfectly awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening — with the sole exception of those who have wrong craving." If a king or a great minister were then to ask: "Monk, will you awaken, or will you not? Do you possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha?" — one should reply as follows: "As for the intrinsic nature of a buddha in my body, it is certainly present; the only thing uncertain is whether or not I will be fully accomplished as a buddha." The king says: "Venerable one, if one does not perform the deeds of wrong craving, it is absolutely certain and without doubt that one will be accomplished." The monk replies: "It is just as the great king has said. In that certain sense, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is indeed present." Even though the monk says this, it does not become a root defeat.

Furthermore, monks, when one goes forth into renunciation and thinks to oneself: "I will ultimately and without fail manifestly awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening" — even if that person has not yet attained the highest awakening, they will obtain merit that is measureless, boundless, and incalculable. If someone were to say that a root defeat arises for them — well then, consider this: there is not a single monk who has gone forth without such a thought having arisen. Why is that? I myself, for eighty million world-ages (kalpas), abandoned all things that had not been examined, and by living the conduct of few desires and contentment, I devoted myself with diligence to the unsurpassable collection of Dharma teachings of the Tathāgata. Knowing for certain that the intrinsic nature of a buddha was present in my own body, it is for this reason that, upon manifestly awakening to the highest, perfect, complete awakening, I came to be called "buddha," one who is endowed with great compassion. Whatever sūtra or Vinaya teaching speaks in this way is to be recognized as taught by the buddha.

Whoever does not follow this teaching is to be called one who belongs to the class of māras. Whoever does follow this teaching is to be called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, there are those who say the following: there are no four defeats, no thirteen remainders for the Saṅgha, no two indeterminate rules, no thirty rules entailing forfeiture, no ninety-one transgressions, no four rules to be confessed individually, no many trainings, no seven rules for the complete pacification of disputes, and so on. There are no grave offenses, no five acts of immediate retribution, and nothing at all called wrong craving. If monks who transgress these and similar rules fall into the hells, then all non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) by comparison are born as gods of the higher realms. Why is this? Because there is no such thing as a breach of moral discipline for non-Buddhists and the like. Therefore the Tathāgata taught what is called moral discipline for the purpose of training persons. As the Buddha himself declared: "My monks, if any of you wishes to engage in unchaste conduct, set aside the Dharma robes and, wearing the clothes of a householder, engage in unchaste conduct." Beyond that, some think: "This engaging in unchaste conduct is not a fault exclusive to us alone — even during the lifetime of the Tathāgata, monks engaged in unchaste conduct and still attained liberation, and there have always been those who were reborn as gods of the higher realms after death; this conduct was not ours alone. Some transgressed the four defeats, some transgressed the five precepts of moral discipline, some

performed all manner of unexamined and improper actions, and yet attained genuine liberation." And the Tathāgata did declare that if one commits a single offense, one falls into the hells for eight hundred billion years reckoned by the days and months and years of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three — yet that too was spoken by the Tathāgata solely for the purpose of training persons. So they say: there is no distinction at all in weight between a defeat and an ordinary offense. When they say that the holders of the Vinaya are falsely claiming that the Buddha established these rules, that is not the teaching of the Buddha. One should understand that such speech belongs to the sūtras and Vinaya of māras.

As for those who say the following: "One who abides in moral discipline, if they breach it even in the slightest minor offense, will experience immeasurable suffering — knowing this, one must guard one's body with extreme care, just as tortoises withdraw their six limbs" — but also those holders of the Vinaya who say: "No matter what breach of moral discipline occurs, no unwholesome fruit will ripen" — one should not associate with such a person. As the Blessed One declared in verse:

Whoever transgresses even a single Dharma,
that one is a speaker of falsehood.
Not seeing the world beyond,
there is no evil they will not commit.

Therefore one should not associate with such a person. Since my Buddha's Dharma is in this way perfectly pure, it goes without saying that grave offenses, the remainders for the Saṅgha, and defeats are to be reckoned as blameworthy. Therefore those rules of Dharma should be guarded with great care. If they are not guarded, what else could one call "moral discipline"? I have also declared in the sūtras: from the transgression of the four defeats down to the slightest minor offense — if breached, it is to be cut by the penalty. This I have declared.

For ordinary persons, if moral discipline is not guarded, how could the intrinsic nature of a buddha ever be seen? Although the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all sentient beings, it can be seen only through the guarding of moral discipline. By seeing the intrinsic nature of a buddha, one will manifestly awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening.

Among the nine branches of the sūtra scriptures, there is none more extensive than the sūtra genre itself.

Yet I have not declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists. Although it is not declared in those sūtra scriptures, it is to be understood as truly existing. And whoever speaks in these words is to be understood as a true and proper attendant of mine.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "The Blessed One has declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all sentient beings. If one has not heard this from the nine branches of the sūtra scriptures, and now teaches and declares it as existing, would that not constitute a defeat?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is as you have said — it would not constitute a defeat. Son of good family, consider this example: if a person were to say, 'Within the ocean there are the seven precious substances — but not an eighth,' they would incur no offense. Likewise, even if one were to say, 'The intrinsic nature of a buddha does not exist,' having not found it spoken of in the nine branches of the sūtra scriptures, one would incur no offense. Why is that? Because the Blessed One has declared the intrinsic nature of a buddha to exist in the ocean of wisdom of the Great Vehicle, and it is not known or seen by the two vehicles. Therefore, even to say it does not exist incurs no offense. For this domain of knowledge is known by the buddhas alone; it is not the domain of knowledge of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Son of good family, if a person has not heard of the profoundly deep tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), they will not know that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists. And what is this profoundly deep essence? It is this: the expansive sūtra scriptures of the Great Vehicle. Son of good family, certain non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) proclaim a self as eternal, while others proclaim no-self as annihilation. The Tathāgata is not like that. He teaches that a self exists, and he also teaches that there is no-self — and therefore it is called the Middle Way. In that regard, whoever declares, speaking from what the Buddha has taught as the Middle Way, 'The intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all sentient beings, but because it is veiled by afflictions it is neither known nor seen — therefore one must diligently apply the means of cutting through afflictions,' whoever speaks in these words is to be understood as one who has not fallen from the four defeats. But whoever does not speak in these words is called one who has fallen from the four defeats.

In this regard, if someone were to say, 'I have manifestly awakened to the highest, perfect, complete awakening — and why? Because the intrinsic nature

of a buddha exists, and one who possesses the intrinsic nature of a buddha will without any doubt manifestly awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening; therefore I have manifestly awakened to awakening,' that person is to be understood as having incurred a defeat. And why? Because although the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists, if one has not applied diligent effort to the means of its realization, it will not be seen. Not being seen, one will not awaken to the highest, perfect, complete awakening.

Son of good family, therefore the qualities of a buddha are profoundly deep and inconceivable."

Then once again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if a king were to ask, 'In what way have certain monks fallen from the Dharma proper to a human teacher?' — what should one say in reply?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "A monk who, for the sake of gain and alms, lives by deceit and pretense, thinking to himself, 'By this the people of the world will recognize me as a monk' — and who thus harbors in his mind

thinking, 'How shall I gain great wealth and renown?' — those foolish, deluded monks, night and day, think to themselves: 'Even though I have not attained the fruit of the contemplative life, those who inhabit the world will regard me as one who has attained the fruit of the contemplative life. All laymen and laywomen and the rest will say of me, "He is a noble one, a man of merit."' And all this is not for the sake of the Dharma, not out of desire for what is good, but only for gain and renown. Conforming his conduct, wearing the saffron robe, carrying his alms bowl, abiding impeccably in the outer forms of the precepts, he disguises himself as though he were an arhat, so that the people of the world will say: 'This monk is supremely excellent — he applies himself diligently to austerity and the qualities of perfect peace.' Praised in this way, and through that cause and condition, he comes to have many disciples and a large retinue. All of them offer him robes, alms, bedding, and medicines for illness in abundance, and many women attend upon him with service and reverence. If a monk or nun thinks in this way, that person is said to have fallen from the Dharma proper to a human teacher.

Now, regarding those monks who, for the sake of establishing the supreme and holy Dharma, abide in the outer forms of the precepts though they are not arhats — if others think of them as arhats, such a monk is a truly virtuous monk, a peaceful monk, a good monk, and in countless beings faith will arise.

Through that cause and condition, countless monks will enter their retinue, and monks whose discipline has degenerated, as well as laypeople, will come to abide in the restraint of moral discipline. Through that cause and condition, the holy Dharma will long endure; the unsurpassed Dharma of the Tathāgatas will spread and expand; countless beings will be liberated through the greatly and thoroughly expansive Dharma of the Great Vehicle; and one will become supremely skilled in both the weighty and the light matters of the sūtras and the Vinaya spoken by the Tathāgata. Such a monk will say this: 'I possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha — and, as the sūtra called the Tathāgatagarbha declares, I will without doubt attain complete and perfect awakening, and the defilements of countless beings will be exhausted.' And to countless laypeople he will likewise say: 'You too possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha. If we abide on the ground of the Tathāgata's awakening, we will attain highest, perfect, complete awakening, and the defilements of countless beings will be pacified.' Even though he speaks in this way, that person is not one who teaches the Dharma proper to a human teacher — he is to be called a bodhisattva. Even for the minor fault of an offense committed without deliberate wrongdoing, such a person falls into the hells and experiences suffering for eight hundred thousand years counted by the years, months, and days of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three — how much more, then, for one who deliberately commits a grave and heavy sin. Therefore it is taught in the Great Vehicle: 'If a monk in the Great Vehicle commits a grave offense, one should not associate with him.' Now, what constitutes a grave offense according to the sūtras of the Great Vehicle? If a single householder were to build a temple enshrining an image of the Buddha and were to offer a garland of flowers to the Buddha, and a monk were to take the thread on which that garland was strung without asking — that is a grave offense, whether he knew it to be so or not. Likewise, if with a mind of desire one were to destroy a stūpa of the Buddha, that too is a grave offense, and one should not associate with such a person.

If a king or minister, upon seeing a stūpa in ruins, were to have it repaired — whether in order to make offerings to the relics or to restore what had fallen into disrepair — and were to find precious objects inside the stūpa and then place them in the keeping of a monk, and that monk were to claim authority over them and use them for his own purposes, then that monk is one who has fallen from the robe. He becomes a source of quarrel and conflict, and lay practitioners should neither attend upon him, nor offer him worship, nor show

him reverence. That monk is to be called "one lacking the faculties," or "one of double marks," or "one of indeterminate sex." The reason he is called "one of indeterminate sex" is this: when he is seized by desire for a woman, he becomes a woman, and when he is seized by desire for a man, he becomes a man. Such a monk is called "one of degenerate faculties" — he is to be called neither man nor woman, neither one who has gone forth nor a householder — and no attendance, offering, or reverence is to be shown to him.

According to the teaching of the Buddha, the conduct proper to a contemplative (śramaṇa) is this: with a mind of compassion, to be a protector and refuge for sentient beings, and to bestow fearlessness upon all, down to the smallest ant — that is called the conduct of a contemplative. To refrain completely from drinking the maddening fluid of alcohol, and to abandon entirely everything down to that which has an unwholesome smell — that is called the conduct of a contemplative. To speak no falsehood, and not even to entertain in one's mind the thought of speaking falsely, even in a dream — that is called the conduct of a contemplative. To be entirely without a mind of attachment, even in a dream — that is called the conduct of a contemplative.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "If a monk were to engage in unchaste conduct during a dream, would his ethical discipline thereby be broken?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is not so. A monk of genuine virtue regards unchaste conduct as utterly defiling, and does not, even for an instant, give rise to the perception of anything pure in it. If a monk has abandoned the perception by which a woman disturbs the mind and yet dreams of engaging in unchaste conduct, he gives rise immediately upon waking to a mind of intense remorse. When a monk is on alms round and a time of famine has come, if he finds some meat, he perceives it as no different from eating the flesh of his own child. If a mind of attachment arises, he abandons it right away.

These categories of teaching are to be understood as the sūtras and Vinaya spoken by the Buddha in accordance with the Buddha's teaching. Whoever follows what is taught by māra belongs to the ranks of māra. Whoever follows what is taught by the Buddha is called a bodhisattva.

In this regard, if someone were to say: 'The Tathāgata has permitted going forth for all of the following — one who always stands on one leg, one who remains silent and says nothing, one who leaps into water, one who leaps into

fire, one who leaps from a cliff, one who is shameless before others, one who drinks poison, one who eats nothing, one who sleeps in the ashes, one who binds his own limbs, one who kills sentient beings, one who possesses spells, one of outcaste birth, one lacking faculties, one of double marks, one of indeterminate sex, one whose faculties are incomplete, and all the rest' — that is the teaching of māra.

As for what the Blessed One formerly permitted as exceptional allowances: the five preparations made from cow's milk, sesame oil, honey and the like, garments of the kauśeya type, sandal-wood fragments to wear, and similar articles — those he did permit. But if, going beyond these, someone were to say: 'He also permitted the wearing of the mahāliṅga garment,' or 'He permitted the eating of all seeds whatsoever,' or 'The Buddha taught that all grass and trees and the like possess life, and then passed into nirvāṇa' — such statements are the teaching of māra.

When such things appear in the sūtras and Vinaya, know that they are the teaching of māra. The Buddha never permitted standing constantly on one leg; what he did permit was going, staying, sitting, and lying down for the sake of the Dharma. What he did not permit was consuming poison, abstaining from food, burning the body with the five forms of heat, binding the limbs, killing sentient beings, practicing spells and incantations, making sandals from candle-wicks or from the teeth of cattle, using seeds as food, holding that grass and trees possess life, and wearing the mahāliṅga garment. If someone says: 'The Blessed One permitted these things,' then know that person belongs to the company of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and is not a true disciple of the Buddha. What the Buddha did permit were the five preparations made from cow's milk, sesame oil, honey and the like, garments of the kauśeya type, and sandals with a strap. The Buddha declared that the four great elements are without life. Whatever has arisen in the sūtras and Vinaya in this way is called the teaching of the Buddha. One who follows what the Buddha has taught is truly my genuine disciple. If one does not follow what the Buddha has taught, that person is counted among the ranks of māra. If one enters into the sūtras and Vinaya of the Buddha's teaching, know that such a person is a great bodhisattva. Noble son, this detailed account that I have now explained to you is the distinction between what māra teaches and what the Buddha taught.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then again asked: Blessed One, I sought from the very beginning the defining characteristic that distinguishes the teaching of māra from the teaching of the Buddha, and through this I shall come to

understand the profound Dharma of the Buddha.

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, one who thus discerns and clearly understands such distinctions may be called learned and endowed with wisdom. Noble son, suffering cannot properly be called the noble truth. Why is that? For if suffering were to be called the noble truth of suffering, then even cattle, sheep, donkeys, horses, and the beings of the hell realms would possess the noble truth. Noble son, one who thinks of the supremely profound and exalted dharmakāya — the domain of the Tathāgata, permanent, stable, and immutable — as a body sustained by food, and thus conceives it not to be the dharmakāya, and who does not know the qualities, splendor, and greatness of the Tathāgata, is called one in suffering. Why is that? Because of not knowing, such a person sees Dharma as what is not Dharma, and sees what is not Dharma as Dharma. Therefore that person will without fail fall into the lower realms, wander in cyclic existence, give rise to all manner of afflictions, and experience great suffering.

Now, one who knows that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, immutable, and unchanging — or even one who merely hears the two words 'permanent' and 'stable' enter their ears — is reborn in the higher realms, and later, upon liberation, will come to comprehend and realize that the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, immutable, and unchanging. Through that comprehension and realization, such a person will say: 'By realizing this meaning before, I attained liberation. From beginningless time, through not knowing and not realizing, I wandered in cyclic existence without end — and this I have now come to know through authentic primordial wisdom.'

The tenth fascicle.

Knowing through authentic primordial wisdom in this way is called cultivating suffering, and it becomes of great benefit and happiness. One who does not understand things in such a manner will, even through great effort, fail to bring about benefit and happiness.

That, then, is knowing suffering — and it is called the noble truth of suffering. If one does not apply diligent effort in that manner, it is merely called "suffering" and is not the noble truth of suffering.

The noble truth of the origin of suffering is this: when authentic primordial wisdom does not arise with respect to authentic Dharma, one holds and makes use of uninvestigated things — servants, both male and female, and the like — and one speaks of what is not Dharma as authentic Dharma, thus causing the

genuine Dharma not to exist and not to endure for a long time. Through that cause and that condition, one does not know the nature of reality of phenomena. Through not knowing, one revolves in cyclic existence, and through experiencing much suffering one may be born in the higher realms, but one is not liberated through authentic liberation. Whereas one who possesses profound wisdom and who does not destroy the genuine Dharma — through that as cause and condition — is born in the higher realms and is liberated through authentic liberation.

If one does not know the noble truth of the origin of suffering, and one says: "The genuine Dharma is impermanent, unstable, subject to change" — then through that as cause and condition one will revolve in cyclic existence for countless eons and will experience much suffering.

If, however, one knows the genuine Dharma to be permanent, stable, unchanging, and unshifting, that is knowing the origin, and it is called the noble truth of the origin. If one does not apply diligent effort in that manner, it is merely called "the origin" and is not the noble truth of the origin.

The noble truth of the cessation of suffering is this: one should not cultivate emptiness repeatedly and diligently and call that virtue. Why? Because doing so would cease all phenomena and destroy the genuine scriptural collection of the Tathāgata. To study and apply diligent effort in the way taught here is to cultivate emptiness. Cultivating the cessation of suffering means turning back from all tīrthikas (non-Buddhist adherents).

If one were to hold that cultivating emptiness is the truth of cessation, then any tīrthika who cultivates a doctrine of emptiness would likewise possess the truth of cessation — but that cannot be so.

Here, whoever says: "The tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) exists; although it is not presently seen, if all afflictions are removed it will be realized" — or whoever, even for just an instant, arouses the mind toward this — through that as cause and condition will attain mastery over all phenomena.

But whoever cultivates the tathāgatagarbha in the mode of self, as emptiness, or as the absence of peace — that person will wander in cyclic existence experiencing suffering for incalculable births. On the other hand, whoever does not cultivate it in that erroneous manner will swiftly be cleansed, even of afflictions. Why? Because it is through knowing the secret of the tathāgatagarbha that this is called the noble truth of the cessation of suffering.

Whoever applies diligent effort in this manner is my close attendant. Whoever does not apply diligent effort in this manner cultivates in a meaningless way, and that is not the noble truth of cessation.

The noble truth of the path is as follows. With regard to the Buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and authentic liberation, certain sentient beings, with a mind of perverse understanding, hold this view: "There is no Buddha, no Dharma, no Saṅgha, and no authentic liberation — one wanders in cyclic existence as in an illusion." Through that as cause and condition, one will revolve through the three states of existence and will experience great suffering for a long time.

Whereas whoever arouses the mind as follows: that the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and —

authentic liberation is permanent, stable, immutable, and unchanging — whoever thinks this, even for a single instant, will gain the power to have merit arise according to their wishes for a boundless number of lifetimes. And why is this? Even I myself, in former times, through the four perversions, took what is not the Dharma to be Dharma, and so experienced a boundless ripening of non-virtuous karma. Now, because that kind of perverse view has ceased, I have become fully and perfectly awakened to complete enlightenment. This is called the noble truth of the path.

With regard to this: whoever says "The Three Jewels are impermanent" and cultivates that view cultivates to no purpose — that is not the noble truth of the path. Whoever cultivates those teachings as permanent and stable is called a close attendant of mine. Such a one is said to truly see the Four Noble Truths and to be diligently cultivating the Four Noble Truths.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then petitioned the Blessed One: "I too have long sought the Dharma with which to be most diligent in the Four Noble Truths."

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, the four perversions are as follows. To produce the perception of suffering with regard to what is not suffering — this is called a perversion. What is without suffering is the Tathāgata. To produce the perception of suffering with regard to the Tathāgata is to regard the Tathāgata as impermanent, as something that changes and passes away. Whoever says that the Tathāgata is impermanent — that is suffering of grave transgression. Whoever says, 'The Tathāgata, abandoning a body of suffering, has passed into nirvāṇa like a fire that has consumed its fuel and gone out' — that is to produce the perception of

suffering with regard to what is without suffering, and is called a perversion.

"If someone were to object: 'But you have declared the Tathāgata to be permanent — is that not the view of a self? And if it is the view of a self, will that not become a transgression beyond measure? Therefore surely it is right to say that the Tathāgata is impermanent.' Whoever speaks thus — 'I' is a word for bliss, and to say 'the Tathāgata is impermanent' is suffering. If one asks why what is suffering could become bliss: to perceive bliss as suffering is a perversion, and to perceive suffering as bliss is also a perversion. Bliss is the Tathāgata; suffering is to say the Tathāgata is impermanent. If someone says the Tathāgata is impermanent, that is what is called perceiving bliss as suffering. That the Tathāgata is permanent — that is bliss. If, as I have taught, the Tathāgata is truly permanent, why would he pass into nirvāṇa? And if the Tathāgata is not suffering, why did he abandon the body and enter nirvāṇa?' — to produce the perception of suffering in regard to bliss in this way is called a single perversion.

"To produce the perception of permanence with regard to the impermanent, and to produce the perception of impermanence with regard to the permanent — these too are called perversions. The impermanent is failing to cultivate emptiness. Failing to cultivate emptiness leads to a short life. But if someone then says, 'Though one has not cultivated emptiness through which peace arises, one will still have a long life' — that is called a perversion, and these are two perversions. To produce the perception of self with regard to what is without self, and to produce the perception of no-self with regard to what has a self — these too are perversions. Worldly people assert that a self exists, and some assert that a self exists even within the dharmas of a buddha. Worldly people may assert the existence of a self, yet —"

since a buddha's intrinsic nature does not exist in that way, to produce the perception of self with regard to what is without self is called a perversion. The self that exists within the dharmas of a buddha is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Worldly people say that there is no self in the dharmas of a buddha — and therefore to produce the perception of no-self with regard to what has a self is called a perversion. And if one were to say with certainty that there is no self in the dharmas of a buddha, then the Tathāgata's declaration to his attendants, "Cultivate the perception of no-self," would also be called a perversion. These are the three perversions.

To produce the perception of the impure with regard to what is pure, and to produce the perception of the pure with regard to what is impure — these too are perversions. What is pure is the body of the Tathāgata, who is permanent and abiding — not a body commingled with food, not a body afflicted by mental afflictions, not a body of flesh and blood, not a body framed together by veins, sinews, and bones. Therefore, if someone says, "The Tathāgata is impermanent, having a body commingled with food, a body framed by veins, sinews, and bones up to the marrow, and the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and liberation will also cease and be extinguished" — that is called a perversion.

To produce the perception of the pure with regard to what is impure: if someone says, "In this body of mine there is not even a trace of impurity; since there is no impurity, I shall certainly arrive at a state of utter purity — and the Tathāgata's teaching to practice meditation on impurity with earnest effort is a lie" — that is called a perversion. These are called the four perversions.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "We have now arrived at right view, having formerly held wrong views. Blessed One, does there exist something called 'self' in the twenty-five existences, or does it not?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, the meaning of the word 'self' is the meaning of tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature). That the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists in every sentient being — this is what is meant by the word 'self.' Yet the meaning of this 'self' has been veiled since beginningless time by limitless defilements, and therefore sentient beings have not been able to see it.

"Noble son, consider this example. A poor woman has a treasure of gold within her house, yet no one at all knows it is there. Later, a man of great skill in means comes to the poor woman and says: 'Young woman, are you able to work as my servant for wages?' The woman replies: 'I am not able to do so. But if you can show my son a hidden treasure of gold, I will do your bidding.' The man says: 'I am highly skilled in means, so I know where the hidden treasure of gold belonging to your son is, and I shall show it to you.' The woman says: 'If no one in my household, great or small, knows of it, how could you know?' The man says: 'I know it without any doubt.' The woman says: 'I wish to see it right now — show it to me.' Then the man entered her house, dug up the treasure of gold, and showed it to the woman. When she saw the

treasure, she was filled with great joy; a perception of wonder and amazement arose in her, and she paid reverence to that man.

"Noble son, the buddha-nature in every sentient being is just like that. That all sentient beings fail to see it is like the poor woman's failure to see the treasure of jewels. Noble son, I see that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists in all ordinary beings, yet it is veiled by defilements —

just as the poor woman's failure to see the treasure of gold was demonstrated. Noble son, in the same way the Tathāgata, too, reveals to all sentient beings the precious treasure of perfect awakening — and that is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Ordinary beings, upon seeing such things, give rise to a mind of great joy, and they honor and pay reverence to the Tathāgata, drawing near to him. The skillful man is the analogy for the Tathāgata. The poor woman is the analogy for the limitless multitude of ordinary beings. The treasure of gold is the analogy for the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Noble son, here is yet another example. Suppose a woman who is nursing a small infant finds that the child falls ill. That woman, stricken with deep grief, goes in search of a physician. The physician prepares a compound medicine of ghee, milk, and sugar — three ingredients mixed together — applies it to the child, and gives the woman the following instruction: 'Once you have given this medicine to the child, do not let him nurse until the medicine has been absorbed.' So then, in order to prevent the child from nursing, the woman smears her breast with bile and says to the child: 'My breast has been smeared with poison — you must not nurse.' Tormented by thirst, the child desires to nurse, but the moment he tastes the bitter flavor he finds he cannot drink. When the medicine has been absorbed, the woman washes her breast clean and calls out: 'Come here, child — now you may nurse.' But the child, though tormented by thirst, has already tasted the bitter flavor before, and even though he is called, he cannot bring himself to come. Then the mother speaks to him again: 'Earlier you took the medicine, and because it had not yet been absorbed, I could not let you nurse, and so I smeared it with something bitter. Now your medicine has indeed been absorbed, and the bitter taste has been washed away — there is no more bitterness now.' At that, coaxed over by the mother, he is at last able to drink.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is just the same. In order to liberate all sentient beings, he teaches them to apply themselves diligently to the Dharma of selflessness. Through diligent application to it, the notion called 'self' is no

longer present, and they pass fully into nirvāṇa. Furthermore, in order to remove the wrong views of worldly non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), in order to teach that he transcends the doctrines of worldly tīrthikas, and in order to show that the view of self held by worldly tīrthikas is not correct, he teaches that through meditation on the Dharma of selflessness one comes to have a completely purified body. Just as that woman smeared her breast with bile for the sake of her child, so too the Tathāgata is just the same: in order that people may meditate on emptiness, he declared that all phenomena are without self. And just as that woman, after washing her breast, called her child and let him nurse, in the same way my revelation of the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) is just like that. O monk, you too should have no fear. Just as the mother called her child and let him nurse freely at her breast, so too, O monk, you must make a proper distinction: the tathāgatagarbha is not something to be done away with.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: 'Blessed One, there is in truth no such thing as a self. Why is that? A newborn infant, just at birth, makes no distinction whatsoever and has no such seeking. If there were truly a self, then from the very moment of birth it would be fitting that he distinguish and seek after everything. Therefore it is clearly evident that there is no self. And if a self did truly exist, it would be unreasonable for it to cease after taking a single birth. Moreover, if all beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha and it is something permanent, then it would likewise be unreasonable for it to be destroyed.'

'If it does not have the defining mark of being subject to destruction, then why do the kṣatriya class, brahmins, low castes, outcaste peoples, animals, and so forth exist as distinct and various kinds, with the karmic maturation of their actions being so diverse, discordant, and arising from different causes? And if what is called "a self" were truly certain to exist, then all sentient beings would be without distinction of good or bad — they would all be of the same kind. It is therefore evident that what is called "the intrinsic nature of a buddha" is not a permanent phenomenon. But if the intrinsic nature of a buddha were indeed permanently fixed, then why would he teach and speak of killing living beings, taking what is not given, sexual misconduct, lying, slander, harsh speech, idle chatter, attachment, aversion, and wrong views, and all the rest? If what is called "the nature of a self" were permanent, then why would drinking wine cause one to become intoxicated and lose mindfulness? If the nature of what is called "a self" were permanent, then the blind would also be able to see forms,

the deaf would also be able to hear sounds, the mute would also be able to speak, and the lame would also be able to walk. If the nature of what is called "a self" were permanent, then it would be unreasonable for one to come to harm from water, fire, precipices, poisons, weapons, and savage wild animals. If what is called "a self" were permanent, then it would be unreasonable that what one knew before should be forgotten later. And if nothing were forgotten, why would one ever say such things as, "I did not see this person before," and the like? If what is called "a self" were permanent, then all the things one did in youth, in the bloom of one's years, and in old age and decline, and indeed everything one has ever done, should never be forgotten but should be remembered. And if what is called "a self" were permanent, where does it reside? Does it reside in saliva and mucus? Does it reside in blue, yellow, red, and other colors? If what is called "a self" were indeed permanent, it would be fitting that it permeate everywhere, just as sesame oil pervades a body rubbed with it — in which case it would be fitting that when the body is cut, the self should also be cut and severed. The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: Noble son, consider this analogy. A king had a wrestler, and in the course of a wrestling match that wrestler happened to have a single vajra-gem. While straining against another wrestler, that wrestler's opponent struck him on the head, and in the heat of the match the gem sank beneath the skin. Not knowing where the gem had gone, and because a wound had appeared, the wrestler summoned a physician. A highly skilled physician, knowing that the gem had gone beneath the skin and that it was because of this that the wound had appeared, did not apply medicine to the wound itself, but instead said: "Great strong one, where is the gem from your wrestling match?" The wrestler was alarmed and said to the physician: "It seems fitting that my wrestling gem has not gone anywhere — and if it is not there, is this not some illusion?" And he was utterly grief-stricken. Then the physician cheered him up and said: "Do not grieve like this. When you were straining in the match, the gem sank beneath the skin, and only a reflection of it is appearing on the outside. When you were exerting your strength you generated aversion, and by the power of the gem it sank beneath the skin without your feeling it." Even as he said this, the wrestler did not believe it and said: "Physician, do not deceive me. If it had truly sunk beneath the skin it would be utterly filthy with pus and blood — it would be fitting that it would come back out. And if it had gone inside the body of its own accord, it would not be fitting that you should be able to see it." Then the physician held up a mirror, and within the mirror the gem appeared, shining with clarity. Upon

seeing this the wrestler was filled with a sense of wonder and amazement. Noble son, all sentient beings are just the same as this. Because they have not attended upon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra), even though they possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, they are unable to see it. Through attachment, aversion, and —'

delusion covers and overwhelms sentient beings, so that they are born and fall into all manner of states: the hells, the animal realm, the hungry ghost realm, the asura realm, the outcast class, the low castes, the warrior-noble caste, the brahmin caste, and so on in their many varieties. And because the mind generates karma of many different kinds, even when a human body is obtained, one may be born deaf, blind, mute, or feeble-minded, and one experiences the ripened fruit of the twenty-five modes of existence. Because the mind is obscured by attachment, aversion, and delusion, one does not know the intrinsic nature of a buddha — just as the wrestler did not know that the precious gem had sunk into his flesh and thought he had lost it. Ordinary beings are just the same: not knowing how to attend upon a spiritual friend, and not knowing the profoundly secret tathāgatagarbha, they meditate on and apply themselves diligently to selflessness. Yet it is like this: those who are not noble ones may speak of selflessness and yet not know the true defining characteristic of what is called the self. My own attendants are like this as well. Not knowing how to attend upon a spiritual friend, they do not know how to meditate on selflessness; they do not know the basis of selflessness; they do not know its defining characteristic. And if they do not know the defining characteristic of selflessness, what need is there to speak of knowing the true defining characteristic of the self?

Noble son, it is in this very way that the Tathāgata has proclaimed that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all sentient beings — just as the skilled physician revealed the vajra gem within the wrestler's flesh. Ordinary beings are covered and overwhelmed by afflictions without measure, and so they do not know the intrinsic nature of a buddha. But when, at last, the afflictions are exhausted, it becomes clearly and directly realized — just as the wrestler saw the precious gem shining within the bright mirror.

Noble son, the tathāgatagarbha is thus immeasurable and inconceivable.

Noble son, here is another illustration. On the Himalayan range there is a medicinal herb called Sweet Wellbeing. Its flavor is supremely sweet, yet because it grows deep within a dense thicket it cannot be seen. One knows it

is present in that place only by its fragrance. In a past age, a wheel-turning king (cakravartin), desiring that herb, had wooden troughs set up throughout the Himalayan range and collected the herb's exudate. When the herb ripened its essence flowed out like water into the ground, and from there it flowed further into the wooden troughs, and that flavor was true and pure. After that king had passed, the flavor of the herb became, in some places, sour; in some places, salty; in some places, sweet; in some places, bitter; in some places, hot; and in some places, astringent. Thus that single flavor, depending on where it flowed, became differentiated into many kinds — yet the true flavor of the herb remained in the mountain.

Similarly, a full moon, through the demerits of those with little merit, is put to labor under great hardship and cannot be obtained even by digging earnestly into the earth. But if noble kings were to appear in the world, through the condition of their merit, that true flavor of the herb would be fully obtained.

Noble son, the flavor of the tathāgatagarbha is just the same. Covered by the dense thicket of defilements, ignorant sentient beings are unable to see it. The single medicinal flavor is the simile for the intrinsic nature of a buddha. And the way that single flavor, under the power of defilement, becomes diversified into many flavors illustrates the following: beings in the hells, hungry ghosts, animals, gods, humans, males, females, those of indeterminate sex, the warrior-noble caste,

brahmins, and those of low caste and outcaste birth, and so on. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is supremely indestructible, and therefore it cannot be killed. If it were killed, that would mean the intrinsic nature of a buddha had been made nonexistent. But the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not something that can by its own nature be made nonexistent — there is no basis upon which it could be made nonexistent. That which bears the name "self" is none other than the secret essence of the Tathāgata. This secret essence, then, cannot be destroyed or made nonexistent by anyone whatsoever. And although it cannot be made nonexistent, it cannot yet be seen. If one fully awakens to unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening, one will then know and realize it — and for that reason, it cannot be killed.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: If it cannot be killed, does that mean there is also no such thing as non-virtuous action?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: In truth, killing does exist. Why is that? Noble son, the buddha-nature of sentient beings resides within the five

aggregates. If the five aggregates are destroyed, that is called taking life. If life is taken, one falls into a lower realm. Through the causes and conditions of karma, beings cycle in saṃsāra with the various characteristics of warrior nobles, brahmins, those of low caste and outcastes, males, females, those of indeterminate sex, and the twenty-five modes of existence and so forth. Those who are not noble ones grasp at the notion of "self" under various characteristics — as something great, as something small, as a sesame seed, as a louse, as a bean, or no larger than a thumb — and to grasp at it under the false characteristics of an illusion is not correct. The characteristic of self that transcends the world is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and to grasp at self in that way is said to be supremely excellent.

Noble son, consider further this example: a man supremely skilled in the knowledge of treasure-sites takes a sharp pick and digs. He can dig through rocks, gravel, and boulders without obstruction. But if he strikes a vajra (diamond), he can go no further at all. A vajra cannot be pierced or cut by any weapon whatsoever. Noble son, the buddha-nature of sentient beings is just like that. Every opponent in the world — gods, evil māras, humans, and all beings of the world together — cannot destroy it. The characteristic of the five aggregates is that they are conditioned. The characteristic of the conditioned is that it is like rock or gravel — it can be pierced and cut. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is like a vajra — it cannot be destroyed. Therefore, to destroy the five aggregates is called taking life.

Noble son, know that the Dharma of a buddha is in this way inconceivable.

Noble son, the vast and extensive sūtras (mahāsūtras) are like ambrosia and they are also like poison.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: For what reason has the Tathāgata said that the vast and extensive sūtras are like ambrosia and also like poison?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, do you wish to understand the true meaning of the tathāgatagarbha?

Kāśyapa said: I wish to realize what the meaning of the tathāgatagarbha is.

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

Some who drink ambrosia
die early, perishing before their time.
Some who drink ambrosia

live long and dwell there always.
Some survive by drinking poison.
Some die through the condition of poison.
The sūtras of the Great Vehicle
are like the unobstructed radiance of primordial wisdom.
The sūtras of the Great Vehicle

are mixed with medicine and with poison. Just as butter, molasses, ghee, and the like, when drunk and digested, become medicine, yet when undigested are called poison, so too the extensive sūtras are the same: for the wise they become ambrosia, but for the foolish, those who do not know the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, they become poison. The ambrosia of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, and the Great Vehicle — just as all the tastes of fermentation become the finest milk, so likewise those who apply diligence, through the power of the Great Vehicle, pass fully into nirvāṇa and become kings among the supreme assembly of human beings. Kāśyapa, you and any sentient being who knows the intrinsic nature of the buddhas will, through the taste of the supreme unsurpassed nectar, become free from birth and death.

Kāśyapa, know this and realize the Three Jewels. The defining characteristic of the Three Jewels is precisely what is called the defining characteristic of the self. Whoever directly realizes the identity of self and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas will thereby realize the tathāgatagarbha. One who knows self and what is one's own has transcended the world. The Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are supremely unsurpassed and excellent. These verses I have spoken convey this very meaning of the defining characteristic.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One in verse:

If I realize nothing at all
of the three refuges,
how can I take refuge in them
without the supreme fearlessness?
If I do not realize the Three Jewels,
how am I to act without a self?
If one takes refuge in the Buddha,
one will attain perfect happiness.
Let the Victor teach me
how to take refuge in the Dharma.

How does one attain great sovereignty,
and what is it that does not come under sovereignty?
How does one take refuge in the Saṅgha
and thereby attain unsurpassed happiness?
When one speaks words of happiness,
one will be fully awakened in the future.
If that is not accomplished in the future,
how does one turn to the Three Jewels?
I did not seek this before of my own accord,
yet because of compulsion I will seek it —
how then, without being pregnant,
does one give rise to the perception that one is giving birth to children?
If one is certainly carrying a child in the womb,
that is called having a child.
And if there is indeed a child in the womb,
it will certainly emerge before long.
That is the meaning of a child,
and it is the same for sentient beings.
As the Blessed One has taught,
the foolish cannot understand it.
Because they neither realize nor know it in this way,
they circle round and round in saṃsāra again and again.
Laypeople who are only so in name
do not seek the true meaning.
Please explain it extensively and in detail,
and please cut through my doubt.
Blessed One of great primordial wisdom,
please, out of loving compassion,
explain expansively the Tathāgata's
secret jewel-heart.

The Blessed One replied:

Kāśyapa, know this —
whatever the secret heart may be,
I will explain and reveal it fully
and cut through your doubt.
Listen and examine it well.

You, among bodhisattvas,
will come to be called by the name and title
of the seventh buddha to arise.

One who takes refuge in the buddhas
is a true lay practitioner
and will never take refuge
in any other gods.

One who takes refuge in the sublime Dharma
is free from the mind that harms and kills.

One who takes refuge in the Saṅgha
will not turn to the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

One who takes refuge in the Three Jewels
will attain fearlessness.

Kāśyapa, by taking refuge in the Buddha,
I take refuge in the three,
and this I call the true path
within the domain of activity of the buddhas.

The defining characteristic of the Three Jewels is identical —
possessed of great primordial wisdom.

My own nature and the nature of the buddhas
are nondual, without distinction.

This path of praising the buddhas
is the abode of happiness for those who seek the true,
and because the buddhas know and see all things,
they shall be praised by countless buddhas.

I too incline toward and enter
the unsurpassed path of praising the Sugata —
that path which is the supreme nectar, the most holy,
unequaled anywhere in conditioned existence.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Noble son, do not divide the Three Jewels as śrāvakas or low-born householders do. In the Great Vehicle, there is no defining characteristic that distinguishes the Three Jewels as separate. Why is that? Because within the very essential nature of the buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha are present. It is for the purpose of guiding śrāvakas and low-born householders that the Three Jewels are distinguished and taught as separate.

Noble son, those who wish to follow worldly teachings distinguish among the three objects of refuge as if they were different. But bodhisattvas think in this way: through this very body having taken refuge in the buddha, this very body itself will fully awaken. And once one has fully awakened and become a buddha, there is no longer any practice of paying homage, showing reverence, making offerings, or prostrating to the buddha. Why is that? Because the Blessed One, the buddha, has equally made himself a refuge for all sentient beings.

Whoever tends to the reliquary of the body of Dharma should reverently prostrate before the stūpas of the buddhas. Why? For the purpose of guiding ordinary beings. Furthermore, sentient beings generate the perception of my body as though it were a stūpa, and they make prostrations and offerings to it. In doing so, those sentient beings also thereby make the dharmakāya a place to which they can turn for refuge. All sentient beings dwell in what is untrue and in wrong teachings; therefore, I have gradually taught the true Dharma.

Moreover, for those who have taken refuge in what is not the true Saṅgha, he also creates a condition by which they come to take refuge in the true Saṅgha. And to those who divide the Three Jewels as separate, he also teaches that the place of refuge is one, and that the threefold distinction has no ultimate difference. For those who are like the blind wandering in darkness, he appears as an eye. Furthermore, he thinks to himself: I should also establish the true place of refuge in the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Noble son, in this way, bodhisattvas, great beings, perform the deeds of a buddha on behalf of immeasurable unruly sentient beings as well as those who are learned and wise. Noble son, consider the example of a man who goes to the battlefield and thinks: I am supreme, and all these armies depend on me alone. Likewise, consider a young regent who thinks: I have subdued all the princes, I have become master of all the domain and power of the great king, and all the princes follow me — therefore I shall not give rise to any weak intentions. As it is with the king and the prince, so too it is with the great minister. Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, also thinks in exactly the same way: how may these three things come to be of one nature with me? Noble son, these three things I have taught are nirvāṇa.

The Tathāgata is the supreme being without equal. Just as among all the limbs and branches of the human body the head is supreme and is nothing other than that, so too the buddha is similarly supreme and foremost — not the

Dharma and the Saṅgha. For the sake of liberating worldly beings, the various characteristics have been taught distinctly, like the separate rungs of a ladder. Therefore you should not, like a foolish child, grasp the Three Jewels as having separately distinct characteristics. Because you have entered the Great Vehicle, your faculties are sharp — like a keen-edged sword.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked the Blessed One: I ask this of the Blessed One with full understanding, not out of ignorance. I have entered into this inquiry on behalf of those bodhisattvas who are courageous yet of dull faculties, in order to clarify the domain of the pure and stainless conduct. Furthermore, I have entered into this inquiry in order to open and present the wondrous and extraordinary things that the Tathāgata reveals to bodhisattvas, and to praise the vast and extensive Mahāyāna sūtras. Since the Tathāgata has taught this so well with great compassion, I too wish to abide in it. That which shows the thoroughly purified domain of the bodhisattvas' conduct is precisely this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa. Blessed One, I shall also teach this secret essence of the Tathāgata extensively to all sentient beings, and cause them to rightly understand the meaning of going for refuge to the Three Jewels. In this regard, any sentient being who has faith and confidence in this noble sūtra of the great nirvāṇa will be one who has understood and grasped the meaning of going for refuge to the Three Jewels. Why is this so? Because within this secret essence of the Tathāgata, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present. Whoever teaches and expounds this sūtra but says that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not present in that person's body — such a person is no other than one who does not go for refuge to the Three Jewels. Why? Because in a future time this very body of mine will become the Three Jewels, and hearers, solitary buddhas, and all other ordinary beings besides will rely upon me and render service, honor, and veneration. Noble son, for that reason, one should train properly in the Mahāyāna sūtras.

Kāśyapa then further asked: The intrinsic nature of a buddha is inconceivable, and in just the same way the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor marks are also inconceivable.

The Blessed One then declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Excellent! Most excellent! Noble son, since you are endowed with profound wisdom, I too shall teach you well concerning entry into the essence of the Tathāgata. If what is called the self were a permanent and enduring phenomenon, one could never be freed from suffering. If there were no such thing as a self, then the holy life of pure conduct would be entirely without benefit or purpose. If one claims

that all phenomena are without a self, that view is annihilationism. If one insists on asserting a permanent, enduring self, that view is eternalism. If one views all formations as impermanent, that too falls into the view of annihilationism. If one views formations as permanent, that likewise becomes the view of eternalism. If one says that all is suffering, that too is the view of annihilationism.

If one says that all is bliss, that too is the view of eternalism. If one insists with great emphasis that all phenomena are permanent, one falls into the view of annihilationism. If one insists with great emphasis that all phenomena are annihilated, one falls into the view of eternalism. Consider, for example, a caterpillar making its way into a hollow: it releases its front legs before releasing its hind legs. Insisting upon permanence or annihilation is just like that — it depends upon the conditions of annihilation and permanence in turn.

Seeing the matter in this light: to insist upon other phenomena as being of the nature of suffering is non-virtue. To insist upon other phenomena as being of the nature of bliss is called virtue. To insist upon other phenomena as being without a self is to be on the side of thorough affliction. To insist upon other phenomena as being of the nature of permanence is called the secret essence of the Tathāgata, for nirvāṇa is without location or support. To insist upon other phenomena as being of the nature of impermanence is to hold that material things and goods exist. To insist upon other phenomena as being of the nature of permanence is the buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and perfect liberation. Therefore one should understand that the intrinsic nature of the buddha is the Middle Way, entirely free from both extremes.

When the true Dharma is taught, those who are immature and foolish entertain doubt about it. For example, when the weak and sick drink butter, their bodies become light and they feel joy. The phenomena of existence and non-existence, likewise, are not severed in a single intrinsic nature. For example, just as the four great elements are mutually discordant in their natures and each serves as the antidote to the other, a skilled physician understands this fully in accordance with whichever element is predominant. Noble son, the Tathāgata is similar: like a physician to all sentient beings, he knows the various natures of thorough affliction in all their different forms and clears them away entirely, and he teaches the secret essence of the Tathāgata — the intrinsic nature of the buddha, utterly pure, unchanging, and unshifting.

If one says it exists, among those of the type who are unfit — the wise and discerning who are attached — if one says it does not exist, one becomes a speaker of falsehood. If one says it exists, among those of the type who are unfit — the noble ones who say nothing — there is yet another type who speak frivolously and disputatiously, wishing to realize the true nature of reality. Those who are immature and foolish speak frivolously and argue, and thus do not know the secret essence of the Tathāgata.

If one says it is suffering, immature and foolish persons will think: "This body is impermanent." If one says all is suffering, they will not know that the body possesses the intrinsic nature of bliss. If one says it is impermanent, immature and foolish persons will think "all bodies are impermanent" and will grasp at this as though taking unfired clay vessels. But the wise and discerning make a distinction and do not say that everything without exception is impermanent. Why so? Because within one's own body there exists the seed of the intrinsic nature of the buddha.

If one says there is no self, immature and foolish persons will grasp at the idea that all the qualities of the buddha are without a self. But the wise and discerning understand that "no-self" is nothing more than a conventional label, a mere designation, and they distinguish this analytically as being without ultimate truth. Understanding in this way, they raise no doubt about it.

If one says that the essence of the Tathāgata is empty, when immature and foolish persons hear this, they will give rise to a view of annihilation or nihilism. But the wise and discerning distinguish the Tathāgata as permanent, unchanging, and unshifting. If one says that liberation is like a magical illusion, immature and foolish persons will grasp at the idea that those who have attained liberation possess qualities of Māra. But the wise and discerning make a distinction — as a lion stands alone among men — and distinguish the Tathāgata, the singular one, as permanent, steadfast, unchanging, and unshifting.

If one says that formations arise through the condition of ignorance, when immature and foolish persons hear this, they will fail to distinguish the two phenomena of knowledge and ignorance as non-dual. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature.

That which is non-dual is reality itself.

If one says that consciousness arises through the condition of formations, immature and foolish persons will grasp at formations and consciousness as

two. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature. That which is non-dual is reality itself.

If one says that among the ten virtues and ten non-virtues, these belong to the category of what is to be done and these to the category of what is not to be done, these lead to the path of higher realms and these are causes of the lower destinies, these are white phenomena and these are black phenomena — immature and foolish persons will grasp at duality. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature. That which is non-dual is reality itself.

If one says that all phenomena are suffering and one should apply oneself diligently to that teaching, immature and foolish persons will grasp at duality. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature. That which is non-dual is reality itself.

If one says that all formations are impermanent, or that the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) too is impermanent, immature and foolish persons will grasp at duality. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature. That which is non-dual is reality itself.

If one says that all phenomena are without self, and that therefore the tathāgatagarbha too is truly without existence, immature and foolish persons will grasp at duality. But the wise and discerning realize their non-duality by nature. That which is non-dual is reality itself.

Self and no-self are by nature non-dual. The meaning of the tathāgatagarbha has thus been praised by the Blessed One, the Buddha, in an immeasurable, boundless, and limitless way, and I too have taught it extensively in all the sūtras endowed with qualities.

The eleventh fascicle begins here.

O son of good family, just as you have understood that "self" and "no-self" are by nature non-dual, take that to heart and bear it on the crown of your head. O son of good family, take this sūtra firmly to heart and keep it in mind. I myself have previously taught in the great sūtras of the noble Perfection of Wisdom (prajñāpāramitā) that self and no-self are non-dual by way of their defining characteristics.

It is like this: from milk arises curds, from curds arises butter, from butter arises clarified butter, and from clarified butter arises the essence of butter. In this way, whether the nature of curds arises from milk, or from the curds

themselves, or from somewhere else — this same reasoning should be understood in detail right up to the essence of butter. If it arose from somewhere else, it would be made by something other, and if made by something other, then all sentient beings would not have come from milk. If it did not arise from milk, then milk would be entirely unnecessary. If it arose from the curds themselves, that too does not hold — for if the essence of butter were to come about, it would arise in a continuous sequence. If it arose in a continuous sequence, it would not have arisen all at once. And if it did not arise all at once, the five flavors would arise simultaneously — yet they do not arise simultaneously, and certainly they did not come from somewhere else entirely. Therefore, while the characteristic of curds — a great sweet flavour — is already present in the milk, it cannot transform on its own. In the same way, one should understand this in full detail right up to the essence of butter.

Through the cause and condition of eating grass and drinking water, the animal's blood is formed, and from the blood milk is produced. If sweet grass is eaten, the milk will be sweet. If bitter grass is eaten, the milk too will be bitter. On snowy mountains there is a grass called the rich grass, and if it is eaten, the result is the essence of butter alone — it does not appear blue, yellow, red, white, or black.

When other grasses are eaten, the taste and colour of the milk will also differ, in accordance with those causes and conditions.

The foolish ordinary being produces two characteristic marks through the cause and condition of karma rooted in knowledge and ignorance. If ignorance is reversed, that is called knowledge. In the same way, all phenomena have no two defining characteristics called virtue and non-virtue.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of the statement you have made that curds exist within milk? Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of curds is certainly present within milk, yet is so subtle it cannot be seen, why did you say that curds arise through the condition of milk? If phenomena did not exist from the beginning, then it would be fitting to say they are born. But if something was already there before, why do you declare it to be born? If the intrinsic nature of curds is certainly present within milk, then by the same reasoning, milk would also have to be present within all trees and plants. And likewise, trees and plants would have to be present within milk. But if you say that curds are certainly absent from milk, then why does no rabbit's horn arise from it? And if

poison is poured into the milk and one drinks the curds produced from it, one dies — therefore it is equally not fitting to say that the intrinsic nature of curds is certainly absent from milk. And if you say that curds arise from something other than milk, why do curds not arise from water? Therefore it is not fitting to say that curds arise from something wholly other."

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, it is not fitting to say simply that curds are definitely present within milk, nor that curds are definitely absent from milk, nor that they arise from something entirely other. If one says that curds are definitely present in milk, why would the substance and the taste still be distinct? Therefore it is not fitting to say that the intrinsic nature of curds is definitely present in milk. And if one says that curds are definitely absent from milk, why does no rabbit's horn arise from milk? And if poison is poured into the milk and one drinks the curds, one dies — therefore it is equally not fitting to say that the intrinsic nature of curds is definitely absent from milk. And if one says they arise from something other than milk, why do curds not arise from water? Therefore it is not fitting to say that curds arise from something wholly other.

"Son of good family, from the eating of grass comes blood, and from blood comes milk, which is produced through the merit of sentient beings. Although milk has thus arisen from grass and blood, it is not fitting to call it 'two.' It is to be called 'arisen from cause and condition.' The same should be understood in full detail right up to the essence of butter.

"Thus what is called the curds of milk — curds are designated through causes and conditions, while not appearing as milk. From what causes and conditions do they arise? They arise from warmth and sourness. Therefore, from what arises through cause and condition right up to the essence of butter, the same should be understood in full detail. Therefore it is not fitting to say that the intrinsic nature of curds is definitely absent from milk and that they arise from something else — there is no basis for such a claim.

"Son of good family, knowledge and ignorance are likewise similar. When accompanied by complete affliction, it is called ignorance. When accompanied by virtuous phenomena, that same thing at that time is called knowledge. Therefore in what I have taught, there are no two defining characteristics. It is for this very reason, through that cause and that condition, that I previously spoke thus: on snowy mountains there is a grass called the rich grass, and when it is eaten, everything becomes the essence of butter — similarly, the

intrinsic nature of buddhahood is just like this.

"Son of good family, just as sentient beings with little merit do not see the rich grass, so too is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood — because it is covered over by complete affliction, sentient beings do not see it."

Here is an analogy: although the ocean has one taste — the taste of salt — within it there is also the taste of excellent water, the taste of milk. Just as the snowy mountains possess many good qualities and only the finest medicinal herbs grow there, yet on them too poisons do grow. The bodies of ordinary beings are likewise: they contain the four deadly serpent venoms, yet within them there also exists something like a sovereign medicinal herb — that is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, which is not a conditioned phenomenon, but has become covered over by complete affliction.

Whether it be someone of the warrior class, the brahmin class, the merchant class, or the common class, if they clear away all afflictions, they will behold the intrinsic nature of buddhahood and will fully awaken to unsurpassed awakening.

Here is another analogy: when clouds gather in the sky above and thunder rolls, flowers bloom on all the tusks of yak-bulls. But if the thunder does not roll, the flowers do not bloom, and there is nothing to be named. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is just like this: if it is covered over by complete affliction, it cannot be seen.

Therefore I have taught that sentient beings are without self. But whoever hears this sūtra collection of the Great Nirvāṇa will behold this intrinsic nature of buddhahood — just like the flowers on the tusks of yak-bulls. Even if one hears all the meditative absorptions of other sūtra collections, if one has not heard this sūtra, one will not see the genuine tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), just as when the thunder does not roll, the flowers on the tusks of yak-bulls cannot be seen.

If one does hear this sūtra, one will come to understand the innermost heart of what all the Tathāgatas intended when they taught. What is called the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is illustrated by the analogy of beholding the flowers on the tusks of yak-bulls when thunder rolls in the sky above. If one hears this sūtra, one will come to understand that all immeasurable sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

Therefore the Great Nirvāṇa is called the innermost heart of what the Tathāgata intended and taught. The arising of the dharmakāya is like the blooming of flowers on the tusks of yak-bulls when thunder rolls. Because such a vast and great purpose arises and comes into being, it is called the Great Nirvāṇa.

Whatever son or daughter of good family applies themselves with great diligence to this Great Nirvāṇa — they repay the kindness of the Buddha, and are called genuine attendants of the Buddha.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "It is utterly wonderful! Blessed One, what is called the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is extremely profound and extremely subtle, difficult to see and difficult to enter into — it is not something to be understood by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, so it is, so it is — it is just as you have said."

Then again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "In what way is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood so profound, so difficult to see, and so difficult to enter into?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, here is an analogy. A blind person, wishing to heal their eyes, went to a skilled physician. The physician took a golden blade, cut away the cataract film over the eye, then held up one finger and showed it — and the blind one said, 'I do not see it.' When two or three fingers were shown, they said, 'Now I see it just a little.'"

Son of good family, had this great sūtra of mahāparinirvāṇa not been taught, bodhisattvas who have completed the immeasurable perfections and who dwell on up through the ten grounds would still not see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood — and that is just like the blind person in the analogy. Once the Tathāgata taught it, they came to see just a little. The great bodhisattvas, having seen in this way, spoke thus: "How utterly marvelous! Blessed One, we have wandered in saṃsāra for countless eons and have been thoroughly deceived by no-self."

Son of good family, thus even bodhisattvas dwelling on the ten grounds do not see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood with clarity — to say nothing, then, of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas seeing it.

Son of good family, here is another analogy. When a bird soars high up into the lofty sky, one cannot easily discern whether what one sees is a bird or the sky itself — only upon careful examination does one finally distinguish it. Likewise, a bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds understands and sees the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) only in a partial way, and their seeing is just like that. How much less, then, do śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas understand and see it.

Son of good family, it is like a person intoxicated with drink who walks along a road and cannot easily see the road clearly before them. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds is similarly — they understand and see the tathāgatagarbha only partially.

Son of good family, it is like a person who has gone into a remote wilderness and, tormented by thirst, searches for water. They see a kingfisher perched on a tree, and because they are tormented by thirst, they cannot discern whether it is the tree or the water. Only upon careful examination do they finally know it to be a kingfisher in a tree. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds who sees and understands the tathāgatagarbha within their own body is similarly — their understanding is not clear and easy.

Son of good family, it is like a very weak prince who plays and plays through the night until dawn, and when morning comes cannot easily see and understand everything with clarity. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds who sees the tathāgatagarbha within their own body is similarly — they do not understand it clearly.

Son of good family, it is like a minister dispatched by a king who travels through the dark of night and, by a flash of lightning, sees a herd of yaks. He thinks to himself: "Is that yaks? Or a forest? Or clouds? Or buildings?" He believes them to be yaks, yet has no certainty. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds is similarly — they do not clearly understand the tathāgatagarbha within their own body.

Son of good family, here is yet another analogy. Monks who observe moral discipline, when they examine water that is declared free of living creatures, cannot easily discern whether the movement they see in the water consists of living creatures or particles of dust. After examining it for a long time, they come to know it is dust, yet they do not understand it with certainty. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds is similarly — they do not easily or clearly understand the tathāgatagarbha within their own body.

Son of good family, it is like someone who is drowsy and —

the sky being unclear, someone sees from a great distance a small child and cannot make out whether it is an animal, a bird, a human, or what it might be. After examining it for a long time, they come to see that it is a child, yet they do not understand this with clarity. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds likewise sees the tathāgatagarbha within their own body, yet they do not understand it with clarity.

Son of good family, here is another analogy. Suppose a person, in the darkness of the night, sees painted on a wall an image of a bodhisattva, and wonders: "Is this the form of a bodhisattva? Is it the form of the Sovereign Lord (Śiva)? Is it the form of the Great Brahma? Or is it simply cloth of a different color?" After examining it for a long time, they come to know it is the form of a bodhisattva, yet they do not understand this with clarity. A bodhisattva dwelling on the ten grounds likewise sees the tathāgatagarbha within their own body yet does not understand it with clarity.

Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is thus profoundly deep, and because it is difficult to see and difficult to realize, only a buddha alone realizes it; śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot come to realize it.

Son of good family, the learned and wise should therefore examine and analyze the tathāgatagarbha in just this manner.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One, saying: Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of a buddha is so profound and so difficult to see, how could those who have fleshly eyes ever come to see it?

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: Son of good family, take the analogy of the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception — even they cannot realize it through either of the two vehicles, yet they realize it through trusting in the scriptural authority of the sūtras. Son of good family, it is the same for śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas: relying upon the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, they come to realize that the tathāgatagarbha exists within their own bodies. Son of good family, therefore you should apply yourselves with diligence to the practice of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is known by a buddha alone; it is not known by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then again asked the Blessed One: The ignoble and the foolish, those who are not noble ones (āryans), claim that a self exists in all

sentient beings.

The Blessed One replied: Here is an analogy. A prince and a poor man became friends and would visit each other's homes. The poor man, upon seeing that the prince possessed an exceedingly fine sword, developed a feeling of longing for it. Later, the prince took the sword and went away to another region. The poor man subsequently, while sleeping in someone else's house, cried out in his sleep with the words "sword, sword!" One of the people present there heard him call out those words, seized him, and brought him before the king. The king then asked the man: "What is this about you saying 'sword, sword'?" The man explained the matter to the king in full detail, saying: "Even if the king were to cut my body, my limbs, and my extremities into pieces, the sword is not mine. I previously was a friend of a certain great prince, and I saw with my own eyes that the prince had a fine sword; but as for touching it with my hands — that I could not do, let alone deliberately taking it for myself." The king then said: "You say you saw this sword — then what was its shape like?" He replied:

"Great King, what I saw was something resembling a rainbow."

When the king heard those words, he laughed and said: "Do not grieve — go wherever you are happy. If a sword of that description does not exist in my treasury, then as for the prince you speak of having seen it — what need is there even to mention that? After that, the king addressed his ministers: "Have any of you seen a sword of that description?" Before long, he too passed away. Then a successor king was consecrated and invested with royal authority, and he likewise asked the ministers: "Did any of you previously see a sword of that description in the treasury?" The ministers replied: "Your Majesty, we did see it previously." He asked again: "If you saw it, what was the shape of that sword like?" They answered: "Your Majesty, we saw something resembling a rainbow."

The king declared: "There could not be a sword of that description in my treasury." And so through four successive reigns the sword was sought, yet its source was never found. Then, after many years had passed, the prince who had formerly fled returned from another land, assumed the kingship, and gained royal authority. He too addressed his ministers: "Have you seen that sword?" The ministers replied: "Your Majesty, we have indeed seen it." He asked: "Since you have seen it, what was the shape of that sword like?" Some of the ministers said: "Your Highness, it was exceedingly bright — it resembled

a blue lotus flower." Others said: "It resembled a rainbow." Others said: "Its color was red, resembling a heap of fire." Others said: "It resembled a black serpent." At that, the king laughed and declared to the ministers: "You have not truly seen my sword."

Noble son, the bodhisattva, the great being, is just like this. Having appeared in the world, he teaches the true defining characteristic of what is called "self," and the moment he has taught it he is gone — just as the prince, holding that fine sword, fled to another land. All the foolish and confused assert: "There is a self! There is a self!" Yet such talk of a self resembles nothing so much as the poor man who, sleeping in another's house, blurted out "sword, sword" in his sleep. If śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are asked what the defining characteristic of "self" is as it pertains to sentient beings, some will say: "The defining characteristic of a self-view and of what is called no-self is something about the size of a thumb." Others will say: "It is something about the size of a barleycorn." Others will say: "It is something about the size of a sesame seed." And others will say: "The defining characteristic of self dwells in the mind, blazing and luminous like the sun." Thus ordinary people do not know the defining characteristic of what is called "self" — just as the ministers did not know that fine sword. Since the foolish and confused do not understand the defining characteristic of "self" as the bodhisattva has taught it, they make various distinctions and hold them as the defining characteristic of "self" — which is just like answering the question "What was the shape of the sword like?" by saying "It resembled a rainbow."

In this way, the ignoble and foolish generate without interruption a stream of wrong views. And it is in order to sever those wrong views that the Tathāgata taught no-self — just as the successive princes said to their ministers: "There is no sword of that kind in my treasury." Noble son, when the Tathāgata today teaches what is called "self," that is to be understood as the nature of a buddha. And that nature of a buddha, within the Dharma taught by a buddha, is like a sword exceedingly bright and pure.

Noble son, that which the ignoble and foolish call "well spoken" does not enter into the supreme Dharma of a buddha. Whatever is well analyzed and followed in accordance with the teaching — that is to be understood as resembling the form of a bodhisattva.

Noble son, however many different ways of speaking there are — the science of spells, the treatises victorious over words, letters, and all the rest — these

were all taught by the Buddha, not by the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "How is it that the Tathāgata taught the syllable-mothers?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, by teaching the half-syllable syllable-mothers of old, one comes to retain treatises, sciences of spells, victory through words, sounds, languages, and the like. Through learning the syllable-mothers, the ignoble and childish then come, on that basis, to understand Dharma and what is not Dharma, and so forth.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked the Blessed One: "What is the meaning of the word 'syllable'?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, the fourteen elements of the syllable — these are called the meaning of 'syllable.' The word 'syllable' denotes nirvāṇa: because it is permanent, it does not leak. What does not leak is inexhaustible. What is called inexhaustible is the vajra body of the Tathāgata. Therefore the fourteen syllable elements are the syllable-mothers.

"Among them, the letter A signifies the indestructible. What is indestructible is called the Three Jewels — it is like a vajra. Furthermore, the letter A signifies the undefiled. What is undefiled is called the Tathāgata: the Tathāgata, from whom nothing leaks through any of the nine orifices, is therefore called 'without defilement.' Having no nine orifices, nothing leaks; what does not leak is permanent. What is permanent is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata, being unconditioned, is undefiled. Furthermore, the letter A is called 'the assembly of qualities.' The assembly of qualities is the Three Jewels, and therefore it is called A. As for the letter A in this context: it bears the meaning of 'master.' What is the meaning of 'master'? One who is renowned in the world as 'noble.' And what is that which is called 'noble'? 'Noble' means: without attachment, of few desires, knowing contentment, utterly pure, and liberating sentient beings who revolve in cyclic existence through the three realms — such is what is called 'noble.' Furthermore, the letter A signifies 'endowed,' meaning one who strictly guards moral discipline and is inclined to a conduct of virtue. Furthermore, the letter A signifies the one who, following the conduct of the noble ones, learns how to walk, stand, move, and stir; to pay reverence to the Three Jewels and to one's parents; to make offerings, show respect, perform service, and make prostrations; and who also trains in the Great Vehicle. Noble son, you and the others who hold the vow of moral discipline, along with the great-spirited bodhisattvas, are called 'noble.'

"Furthermore, the letter Ā signifies teaching and training: just as the Tathāgata has shown that these things are proper to be done and these things are not proper to be done, one who does not perform what is contrary to Dharma is called 'noble' — and therefore it is called Ā.

"As for the letter I: it signifies the vast brahmacarya (the divine practice of purity) of the Dharma of a buddha, which is luminous and stainless like a fully risen moon. One explains that these things are proper for you and others to do, these things are not proper to do, this is the meaning, this is not the meaning, this was spoken by the Buddha, this was taught by Māra — and therefore it is called I.

"As for the letter Ī: it signifies the Dharma of a buddha, which is exceedingly profound and subtle, difficult to fathom, and which the great sovereign of the gods —"

— just as Brahmā the Great rules through Dharma. And whosoever holds it in mind is called a guardian of the Dharma. Furthermore, those who exercise rule are the four protectors of the world, and these four rulers have authority to guard, hold, teach extensively, and expound this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra. Furthermore, the letter Ī signifies the authority to teach the Dharma to ordinary people. Furthermore, the letter Ī signifies that which is taught for the sake of bringing beings under its sway — and what is that? It is this: applying oneself diligently to the sūtras of great extent. Furthermore, the letter Ī signifies that, just as impurity is removed, so too miserliness and jealousy are utterly cut away, and all things are rendered auspicious — and therefore it is called Ī.

As for the letter U: it signifies the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, which among all sūtras is supreme, excellent, and the highest above the highest. Furthermore, the letter U signifies the nature of the Tathāgata, which no śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha has ever heard before — just as, among all the continents, the melodious sound of the north is the most excellent and supreme. If a bodhisattva were to listen to this sūtra or hold it in mind, that bodhisattva would become supreme among all sentient beings, would become foremost, would become the most excellent. Therefore this sūtra is the foremost of all, the most excellent and supreme, and for that reason it is called U.

As for the letter Ū: just as fresh milk is the most superior of all flavors, so too the nature of the Tathāgata is like that — it is the foremost, the most excellent, and the supreme among all sūtras. Whoever slanders or belittles

this sūtra should be known as no different from an animal. Furthermore, the letter Ū signifies that a person who lacks the wisdom of right mindfulness, and who slanders and belittles the secret essence taught by the Tathāgata — that person is to be known as a being who is deeply pitiable, for that person is bereft of the teaching on the selflessness of the Tathāgata's secret essence, and therefore it is called Ū.

As for the letter E: it signifies the nirvāṇa that is the nature of reality of the buddhas, and therefore it is called E. Furthermore, the letter E signifies the meaning of the Tathāgata.

As for the letter AI: whether the Tathāgata goes or stays, whether he is active or still, whether he moves and stirs in every way — in all of this he never fails to act for the benefit and well-being of ordinary people, and therefore it is called AI.

As for the letter O: it signifies the meaning of mental affliction. Mental affliction is what is called "possessing defilements." The Tathāgata has utterly severed all mental afflictions, and therefore it is called O.

As for the letter AU: it signifies the meaning of the Great Vehicle, the consummate meaning of the fourteen syllables. The Great Vehicle sūtras are likewise: they are the consummate and most excellent among all sūtras, and therefore it is called AU.

As for the letter AM: it removes all impure things that have not been examined, and through the teaching of the Buddha enables one to relinquish all precious things such as gold and silver — and therefore it is called AM.

As for the letter AḤ: it signifies the meaning of the supreme vehicle. Why is this? Because this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, is the foremost, the most excellent, and the supreme among all sūtras, and therefore it is called AḤ.

As for the letter KA: it signifies the arising of compassion for all sentient beings — just as a rāhu (the eclipse-seizing demon) regards beings as its own children and turns toward virtue — and therefore it is called KA.

As for the letter KHA: it signifies one who is not a spiritual friend. One who is not a spiritual friend is a blemished and impure one —

one who has no faith in the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature) — and therefore it is called KHA.

As for the letter GA: it signifies the essence. The essence means the secret essence of the Tathāgata — namely, that all sentient beings possess the nature of a buddha — and therefore it is called GA.

As for the letter GHA: it signifies the sound of the Tathāgata's permanence. How is the Tathāgata the sound of permanence? It is like this: the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, unchanging, and unshifting — and therefore it is called GHA.

As for the letter NGA: it signifies the defining characteristic of the dissolution of all conditioning factors — and therefore it is called NGA.

As for the letter CA: it signifies the purpose of cultivation. The taming of all sentient beings is what is called the purpose of cultivation — and therefore it is called CA.

As for the letter CHA: it signifies that the Tathāgata shelters and covers all sentient beings like a great canopy — and therefore it is called CHA.

As for the letter JA: it signifies perfect liberation, which is without the characteristic of aging — and therefore it is called JA.

As for the letter JHA: it signifies being bound by afflictions on every side, which is like a dense forest — and therefore it is called JHA.

As for the letter NYA: it signifies the meaning of wisdom. Because one knows the nature of reality as it truly is, it is called NYA.

As for the letter ṬA: it signifies that in Jambudvīpa the Tathāgata appeared with only half his body revealed and taught the Dharma — which is like a half-moon — and therefore it is called ṬA.

As for the letter ṬHA: it signifies that the dharmakāya is perfectly complete, like a full moon — and therefore it is called ṬHA.

As for the letter ḌA: it signifies foolish monks who do not understand permanence and impermanence, and who are like small children — and therefore it is called ḌA.

As for the letter ḌHA: it signifies one who is ungrateful toward a teacher and is like flesh consumed by the body — and therefore it is called ḌHA.

As for the letter ṆA: it signifies that which is not the purpose of the noble ones, being like tīrthikas — and therefore it is called ṆA.

As for the letter TA: it signifies the occasion when the Blessed One addressed the monks, saying, "O monks, abandon fear and dread — I will teach you the true Dharma." This is why it is called TA.

As for the letter THA: it signifies the meaning of foolishness and delusion. Sentient beings, seized by saṃsāra and spinning within it, are like silkworm grubs or bubbles — and therefore it is called THA.

As for the letter DA: it signifies the giving of a great gift — namely, the Great Vehicle — and therefore it is called DA.

As for the letter DHA: it signifies the praising and extolling of qualities, in this way: the Three Jewels are like Mount Meru, the king of mountains — supremely excellent, high, vast, and great, never toppling or falling — and therefore it is called DHA.

As for the letter NA: it signifies that the Three Jewels are utterly firm, like the pivoting post of a door, immovable — and therefore it is called NA.

As for the letter PA: it signifies a perverted meaning. If someone says, "The Three Jewels will be exhausted and cease to exist," one should understand that such a person has deceived themselves — and therefore it is called PA.

As for the letter PHA: it signifies a worldly obstructor. If someone says, "When the cosmic dissolution comes upon the world, the Three Jewels too will cease to exist," that person is utterly foolish and without wisdom, and exercises power over what is noble — and therefore it is called PHA.

As for the letter BA: it signifies the ten powers of a buddha — and therefore it is called BA.

As for the letter BHA: it signifies carrying a heavy burden — bearing the unsurpassed and true Dharma upon one's shoulders with patience. One should understand that such a being is a great bodhisattva — and therefore it is called BHA.

As for the letter MA: it signifies the extremely strict and austere Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra of the Great Vehicle — the great passing beyond sorrow — and therefore it is called MA.

As for the letter YA: it signifies that bodhisattvas teach the Dharma of the Great Vehicle to sentient beings in every place — and therefore it is called YA.

As for the letter RA: because one has utterly destroyed attachment, aversion, and delusion and teaches the true Dharma, it is called RA.

As for the letter LA: those who follow the vehicle of the hearers (śrāvakas) remain in a state of change, whereas the Great Vehicle is the teaching that does not waver. Because one abandons the vehicle of the hearers and strives in the unsurpassed Great Vehicle, it is called LA.

As for the letter VA: because the Blessed One, the buddha, rained down a great shower of Dharma for the sake of sentient beings — encompassing the worldly sciences, letters, treatises, and the like — it is called VA.

As for the letter ŚA: because one has utterly abandoned the five kinds of thorns, it is called ŚA.

As for the letter ṢA: it signifies the complete fulfillment of meaning. Whoever hears this sūtra of the great passing beyond sorrow — this sūtra of great purpose — is as one who has heard and holds all the sūtras of the Great Vehicle. Therefore it is called ṢA.

As for the letter SA: because the true Dharma is taught to sentient beings, causing their minds to become glad, it is called SA.

As for the letter HA: it signifies the mind's great rejoicing. Marvellous indeed is the Blessed One — how wonderful that he is free from all formations! "Oh! The Tathāgata has passed fully beyond sorrow" — this exclamation of astonishment is called HA.

As for what is called KṢA: it pertains to the domain of Māra. Because innumerable māras are unable to destroy the secret essence of the Tathāgata, it is called KṢA. Furthermore, KṢA also signifies what is taught in accordance with the ways of the world — showing the relationships between parents, spouse, and children — and therefore it is called KṢA.

Now, the four syllables RI, RĪ, LI, and LĪ have four meanings. These are: the Buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and the antidotal Dharma. Regarding the antidotal Dharma: even though someone — like Devadatta (Iha sbyin) — creates a schism in the Saṅgha by worldly means, or displays various forms and appearances in order to undermine moral discipline, a wise person endowed with wisdom will see through it and feel no fear. Since this is merely engaging with worldly convention, the syllables RI, RĪ, LI, and LĪ are so called.

Through the breath, the organ of taste, the length and shortness of the nasal breath, and the act of drawing forth, one comes to know the meaning from the sound that follows. These also differ in form depending on the tongue and the teeth.

In this way, the meaning of the letters brings about a complete purification of the verbal karma of sentient beings. Yet the buddha-nature within sentient beings does not become pristinely pure for the first time by virtue of the letters. Why is that? Because it is by nature pure from the very beginning. Although it dwells within the aggregates, elements, and sense bases, it is not like the aggregates, elements, and sense bases. Therefore sentient beings should take refuge in the bodhisattvas. Because of the buddha-nature, one should view all sentient beings without distinction.

Thus, incomplete letters are the root of sūtras, treatises, speech, and mastery through words. The meaning of an incomplete letter is the root of all afflicted speech — therefore it is called an incomplete letter. A complete letter is the root of all virtuous Dharma speech. For example, in the world, a person who does what is sinful and unwholesome is called "incomplete" or "half." One who practices all that is virtuous is called "complete." In this way, all sūtras, treatises, and speech have incomplete letters as their root.

Now, if someone were to say that even the Tathāgata and true liberation fall under incomplete letters, that is not so. Why? Because they are free from letters altogether. Therefore the Tathāgata is unobstructed and unattached with respect to all phenomena, and is perfectly and truly liberated.

Then, as for who it is that has understood and knows the meaning of the letters —

One who knows that the Tathāgata came into the world and made incomplete letters to be no more is called one who understands and has realized the meaning of the letters. One who follows the meaning of incomplete letters does not know the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata.

Now, what is the meaning of "letterless"? One who keeps company with and engages in unwholesome phenomena is called "letterless." Furthermore, "letterless" also applies to one who keeps company with and engages in wholesome phenomena yet does not know whether the Tathāgata is permanent or impermanent, eternal or non-eternal; who does not know the Dharma and the Saṅgha; who does not know what is Vinaya and what is not Vinaya, what is sūtra and what is not sūtra, what has been taught by māra and what has been taught by a buddha; and who cannot make distinctions. Such a one is said to have entered into the meaning of "letterless."

Thus I have also explained the following of the meaning of the letterless. Therefore, son of good family, abandoning incomplete letters, you should

become highly skilled in complete letters.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, we shall become highly skilled in the enumeration of letters. Having met the Teacher, the unsurpassed one, we shall act in accordance with the word of the Tathāgata as taught."

The Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! Those who wish to practice the sublime Dharma should train in precisely this way."

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, consider how among birds the kalandaka and the śārika, wherever they go, never part from each other but always remain together. In just the same way, suffering, impermanence, and selflessness are like those birds — they never part from one another.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how is it that suffering, impermanence, and selflessness are said to be like the śārika and the kalandaka?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the phenomena of suffering are one thing, the phenomena of happiness another; the phenomena of permanence are one thing, the phenomena of impermanence another; the phenomena called 'self' are one thing, the phenomena of selflessness another. As an example, rice is different from barley, and barley is different from beans and sugarcane. Yet from the first sprouting of a seedling up through the leaves and flowers, all such things are impermanent. Once the fruit has ripened and is fully enjoyed by a person, it is called 'permanent.' Why? Because by its defining characteristic it is genuinely and truly so."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if those things are permanent in that way, is the Tathāgata then similar to them?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, do not speak in that way. Why? If one were to say that the Tathāgata is like the king of mountains, Mount Meru, then when the eon is destroyed and Mount Meru collapses and crumbles, would the Tathāgata also perish at that time? Son of good family, you should not ask about such matters. Son of good family, among all phenomena, apart from nirvāṇa, not a single phenomenon is called permanent. It is only conventionally that the fruit is said to be permanent."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, excellent! Most excellent! It is just as the Blessed One has said."

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "It is so. It is exactly so. Son of good family, even if one has applied oneself with great diligence to the meditative absorption of all sūtras and the like, but has not heard the great complete nirvāṇa, one will declare that all things are impermanent. Yet one who has heard this sūtra — even while still with afflictions — becomes like one who is free from afflictions.

and will act for the benefit and happiness of all the world, gods and humans alike. And why is this? It is because, through realizing that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within one's own body, one is said to be permanent.

Son of good family, here is another example. The mango tree before its flowers have appeared is said to be impermanent. But once the fruit has manifested and come to serve a beneficial purpose, it is said to be permanent. And so it is, son of good family: even if one has cultivated the meditative absorption of all sūtras, yet has not heard this great complete nirvāṇa, one will declare that all things are impermanent. But one who has heard this sūtra — even while still with afflictions — becomes like one who is free from afflictions, and will act for the benefit and happiness of all gods and humans. And why is this? It is because, through realizing that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within one's own body, one is said to be permanent.

Son of good family, here is yet another example. A lump of gold while being melted in the fire is said to be impermanent. But once it has been melted and become gold, serving a beneficial purpose, it is said to be permanent. And so it is, son of good family: even if one has cultivated the meditative absorption of all sūtras, yet has not heard this great complete nirvāṇa, one will declare that all things are impermanent. But one who has heard this sūtra — even while still with afflictions — becomes like one who is free from afflictions, and will act for the benefit and happiness of all gods and humans. And why is this? It is because, through realizing that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within one's own body, one is said to be permanent.

Son of good family, here is yet another example. Sesame seeds while being pressed for oil are said to be impermanent. But once they have been pressed and become oil, serving a beneficial purpose, they are said to be permanent. Son of good family, even if one has cultivated the meditative absorption of all sūtras, yet has not heard this sūtra of the great complete nirvāṇa, one will

declare that all things are impermanent. But one who has heard this sūtra — even while still with afflictions — becomes like one who is free from afflictions, and will act for the benefit and happiness of all gods and humans. And why is this? It is because, through realizing that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within one's own body, one is said to be permanent.

Son of good family, here is yet another example. All rivers flow into the ocean. Likewise, the meditative absorptions of all sūtras flow into this sūtra of the Great Vehicle, the great complete nirvāṇa. And why is this? Because in the end, the intrinsic nature of a buddha has been well proclaimed within it.

Son of good family, therefore I have taught that some things are permanent and other things are impermanent. You should understand this to apply in the same extensive way, all the way through to selflessness.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Tathāgata is free from the sorrow of longing. It is beings of the heavenly realms who have such sorrow of longing — the Tathāgata is not a heavenly being. The sorrow of longing belongs to humans — the Tathāgata is not a human. Those subject to the sorrow of longing are the twenty-five modes of existence — the Tathāgata is not the twenty-five modes of existence. Since the Tathāgata is free from the sorrow of longing, why then has it been proclaimed and taught that the Tathāgata has the sorrow of longing?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the gods of the realm of non-perception are called 'without perception.' If there is no perception, there is no vital life-force either. And if there is no vital life-force, how could there be any aggregates, elements, or sense bases? Therefore it is not proper to say that the life-force of the gods of non-perception abides here in this place. Son of good family, take the example of a tree-deity: though it dwells in a tree, it is not proper to say that it dwells definitively in the branches, the twigs, the trunk, or the leaves; yet though its dwelling-place is indefinite, it is not proper to say that it does not exist. The life-force of the gods of non-perception is similar to this. Son of good family, the qualities of a buddha are likewise —

profoundly deep and difficult to realize. Although the Tathāgata has no grief or suffering born of longing, in order to arouse great compassion for sentient beings he displays the appearance of grief born of longing, and he looks upon sentient beings as though they were his own child — like Rāhu holding the moon. Furthermore, son of good family, the life-force of the gods of non-perception is known only to a buddha alone; it is not something others can

realize or understand. The same holds true for the gods of the sphere neither of perception nor of non-perception. Kāśyapa, the intrinsic nature of a Tathāgata is utterly pure and without attachment. If it were like an emanation, how could there be any grief or suffering born of longing? Yet if the Tathāgata had no grief, how would he work for the benefit of all sentient beings and cause the Dharma of the buddhas to spread wide? And if he had none, why is it said that he looks upon all sentient beings as his own child, like Rāhu holding the moon? For if he did not truly look upon all sentient beings as his own child, like Rāhu holding the moon, then that very statement would be false.

Therefore, son of good family: a buddha is inconceivable; the Dharma is inconceivable; the buddha-nature of sentient beings is inconceivable; and the lifespan of the gods of non-perception is inconceivable. The question of whether there is grief in the Tathāgata or whether there is no grief falls within the domain of the buddhas; it is not something śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas can know.

Son of good family, consider this example: to empty space nothing clings — not a house, not even the finest particle. Yet it is also untenable to say that a house does not rest on space. Therefore it is not right to say either that a house rests in space or that it does not rest in space. Ordinary childish people do say that a house rests in space, but in truth space has no resting place. Why? Because it abides by its own intrinsic nature. Son of good family, mind is similar: it is not right to say either that it rests in the aggregates, elements, and sense bases, or that it does not rest in them. The life of the gods of non-perception is likewise, and in the same way the Tathāgata's grief is likewise.

If there is no grief, why is it said that he looks upon sentient beings as his own child, like Rāhu holding the moon? And if there is, why is it said that by nature he is like empty space? Son of good family, consider a skilled conjurer who creates houses, slayings, healings, captivities, releases, and diverse things — gold, silver, lapis lazuli, all manner of precious gems, forests, fruit-trees, and the rest. In all of these there is no reality, no true nature. The Tathāgata is similar: he displays grief and so forth in conformity with the world, but they are not real. Son of good family, when the Tathāgata has passed utterly into nirvāṇa, how could there be grief or suffering in him? One who thinks that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa and is impermanent should be understood to be a person who is himself bound by grief. Conversely, one who thinks that the Tathāgata has not passed into nirvāṇa and that he abides permanently,

unchangingly — that person is free of grief; yet such a person has no knowledge of whether the Tathāgata has grief or is without grief.

Furthermore, son of good family, consider this example: a person of the lowest capacity does not know the qualities of a person of middling or superior capacity; a person of middling capacity does not know the qualities of one of superior capacity; a person of superior capacity knows the qualities of the superior, and also knows the qualities of the middling and the lowest. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are similar:

they know only as much as they themselves can know. The Tathāgata is not like that: he is known by himself and known by others as well. For this reason the Tathāgata is called "wisdom without obstruction."

Appearing to the world in a manner likened to an illusion, he teaches those with the eyes of flesh, who suppose that what is shown is a true and real thing. There is no basis on which they could come to know the Tathāgata's unobstructed wisdom. Whether there is grief or no grief is known by the buddha alone. Therefore the quality of having a self belongs to one class, and the quality of having no self belongs to another — like the starling and the kalandaka bird.

Furthermore, son of good family, the Dharma of the buddhas is comparable to a starling and a kalandaka going together. The starling and the kalandaka, when summer rains cause the rivers to flood, fly straight to wherever water is to be found, to a high and secure place, in order to lay their eggs and raise their young. The Tathāgata's coming into the world is just like that: just as the starling and the kalandaka and the rest place their young in a high, safe place, so too the Tathāgata, having accomplished every deed for sentient beings, passes into complete nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, the quality of suffering belongs to one class, and the quality of happiness belongs to another. All formations are suffering; nirvāṇa is happiness. In the ultimate sense, all formations are subject to destruction.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how is it that sentient beings who have attained the passing beyond sorrow can be called supremely happy?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, as I have taught, all that is assembled among formations consists in aging and death."

One who is heedful and practises heedfulness
abides in a place that is like nectar.
One who is without heed and is heedless
abides in a place of death.

Those who practise heedfulness
attain the abode of the deathless.
Those who are without heedfulness
walk forever on the path of death.

Whatever is without heedfulness is called a conditioned phenomenon, and every conditioned phenomenon is the supreme form of suffering. Whatever is heedful is called nirvāṇa, and nirvāṇa is called nectar — the supreme happiness. If one enters into formations, that is called the abode of death, and it becomes the supreme form of suffering. If one reaches nirvāṇa, that is called the deathless, and one will taste the supreme happiness. If one is heedful, then even though many formations have assembled, they are called permanent, happy, deathless, and indestructible.

Now, what is heedlessness and what is heedfulness? Those who are not noble ones, those of common stock and low birth, are heedless — possessing the quality of being accompanied by death. Noble ones who have transcended the world are possessed of heedfulness — free from aging and death. Why? Because they have entered nirvāṇa, which is supreme happiness. Therefore the quality of suffering belongs to one class, and the quality of happiness belongs to another. The quality called "self" belongs to one class, and the quality called "no-self" belongs to another — just as people walking on the ground, when they look for the tracks of birds in the sky, cannot see them.

The Twelfth Fascicle.

Son of good family, sentient beings are just like that: they lack the eye of higher vision, and bound by afflictions, they do not see that within themselves the nature of a buddha exists. For this reason I have taught the doctrine called "no-self." Why? Those who lack the eye of higher vision do not rightly know the true meaning of what is called "self";

they grasp at something inferior as "self," and under the power of afflictions they conceptualize conditioned things, calling them "impermanent." Therefore I have taught that the quality of permanence belongs to one class and the quality of impermanence belongs to another. On this there is the following verse:

Those who are courageous and capable of effort,
Whether seated on a mountain peak
Or dwelling in a plain or solitary place,
Are always seen by the childish and ignoble.
Having reached the ground of great primordial wisdom
And ascended to the unsurpassed platform,
By dispelling all one's own sorrow
One beholds the sorrow of all sentient beings.

The Tathāgata, having overcome the boundless afflictions of sentient beings and abiding on the mountain of primordial wisdom, sees that all ordinary beings are forever tormented and oppressed by measureless afflictions.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, it does not seem to be as the Blessed One has expressed it in verse. Why? In nirvāṇa there is nothing that could be called 'sorrow,' and there is no joy either. Why then did you say that it resembles ascending to a platform of wisdom, reaching a place like a mountain peak, and beholding all sentient beings?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the platform of wisdom refers to nirvāṇa. The one free of sorrow is the Tathāgata. The one possessed of sorrow refers to the childish and ignoble. The childish and ignoble are possessed of sorrow; the Tathāgata is free of sorrow. 'The peak of Mount Meru' signifies perfect liberation. Whoever strives and applies diligence is like Mount Meru — unshakeable and immovable. 'The ground' refers to the conceptualization of conditioned things: the childish and ignoble, dwelling on that ground, conceptualize conditioned things. Those who are wise and possessed of wisdom have fully awakened: having abandoned existence, they are called Tathāgata because they are permanent. The Tathāgata, out of loving concern for the measureless ordinary beings who are pierced by the thorn of existence, is described as having sorrow."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if the Tathāgata has sorrow, then it would be inappropriate to designate him as a perfectly and completely awakened buddha."

The Blessed One said to Kāśyapa: "Even so, it is not without meaning. The Tathāgata manifests birth among whichever ordinary beings are to be tamed, and in whatever manner they are to be tamed. Though he manifests birth, in truth he has no birth. Therefore the Tathāgata is one whose nature is

permanent and abiding — like the kalandaka bird and the śārika bird.

Son of good family, consider further this analogy. When people see the moon obscured by clouds and no longer visible, they think the moon has set — yet in truth the moon does not set. When it rises over another continent, the beings dwelling there think the moon has risen — yet in truth the moon does not rise. Why? Because it is obscured and hidden by Mount Meru; there is no such thing as the moon rising or setting. The Tathāgata, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, is just the same. Coming into the great trichiliocosm, he manifests a father and a mother in Jambudvīpa, and ordinary beings think, 'The Tathāgata has appeared in Jambudvīpa.' He also manifests nirvāṇa in Jambudvīpa, and although the Tathāgata does not truly pass into nirvāṇa, sentient beings think, 'The Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa' — just as in the analogy of the setting moon."

Noble son, the Tathāgata himself has in truth no birth and no cessation — yet he shows birth and cessation in order to tame sentient beings.

Noble son, consider an analogy. When the moon appears full in some world-systems, it appears as a crescent in others. When it appears as a crescent in these world-systems, it appears full in others. When the people of Jambudvīpa first see the moon rising, they say "It is the first day of the month" and form the perception of a new moon. When they see the moon full and swelling, they say "It is the fifteenth day of the month" and form the perception of a full moon. In truth, the moon itself has no waxing or waning — yet through the power of Mount Meru there appears to be waxing and waning.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is just the same. In this Jambudvīpa he shows a first birth and he shows nirvāṇa. Showing that first birth is like the new moon. When all see the young one newly born and taking seven steps, they think of him as the moon on the second day. Then, when the young one is shown entering upon learning, they think of him as the moon on the third day. When the going forth (pravrajyā) is shown, they think of him as the moon on the eighth day. When he sends forth the great light of primordial wisdom (jñāna) and tames countless sentient beings and many māras, they think of him as the full moon on the fifteenth day. And further, when he who is perfectly adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor marks shows nirvāṇa, they think of him as the waning moon.

In this way, sentient beings do not all see the same thing. Some see the moon as a crescent, some see it as full, some see it as waning — yet in truth the

intrinsic nature of the moon knows no waxing or waning; it is always full and complete. The Tathāgata is just the same, and therefore he is called permanent, stable, and unchanging.

Noble son, here is yet another analogy. When the moon is full, it appears wherever there are cities, or villages, or mountains, or pastures, or rivers, or wells, or ponds, or hollows — it appears in every place. And whether a sentient being travels one league or up to a hundred thousand leagues, that person sees the moon in just the same way. Foolish and confused people then wonder: "When I was at home I saw this moon; now here in this remote wilderness I see it too — is it the same moon I saw before, or is it not?" They even deliberate about its size. Some say, "It is about the size of a copper bowl." Some say, "It is about the size of a chariot wheel." Some say, "It is forty-nine leagues across." Although all see the light of the moon, some see it as a round, golden bowl. In this way, even though the intrinsic nature of the moon is one and the same, sentient beings of different kinds perceive it as appearing in many different ways.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is just the same. When he has appeared manifestly in the world, some gods and humans think, "The Tathāgata dwells before me alone." Some sentient beings think, "The Tathāgata appears before me alone." Some sentient beings who are deaf or mute think, "The Tathāgata too must be deaf or mute." Sentient beings who speak many different and mutually unintelligible languages each think, "The Tathāgata speaks in my own language." Each one thinks, "He has come to my house alone and accepted my offerings alone." Some sentient beings see the body of the Tathāgata as measurelessly vast and wide. Some see his body as extremely small. Some see him as having the form of a śrāvaka.

Some see him as having the form of a pratyekabuddha. Some non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) think, "The Tathāgata has gone forth through our own doctrine and entered our path of training." Some sentient beings think, "The Tathāgata has come into the world for my sake alone."

The true nature of the Tathāgata is like the moon: it is the dharmakāya, the unborn body, the body of skillful means. Like the moon, it shows birth in all places and in all modes of prior karma without measure, in accordance with the ways of the world. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, unchanging, and unaltering.

Moreover, son of good family, when an asura (demigod) such as Rāhu covers the moon with his hand, people of the world say, "The moon has died." Yet in truth the king of the asuras has not killed the moon — he has merely obscured its light. The moon itself has not waned or diminished; covered by the hand, it simply cannot be seen. When the hand is withdrawn, people of the world say, "The moon has been born again," and they say, "This moon has even experienced suffering." Yet even if a hundred thousand asuras were to gather, they could not harm the moon.

The Tathāgata is just like this. Although some sentient beings arouse a malicious mind toward the Tathāgata — drawing blood from the body of a buddha, committing the five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya), or acting out of wrong craving — even these things are shown only so that future sentient beings who would destroy the Saṅgha and the Dharma and act improperly might be tamed. For even if a hundred thousand māras were to gather, they could not draw blood from the body of the Tathāgata. Why? Because the body of the Tathāgata has no flesh, no blood, no tendons, no sinews, no bones. The Tathāgata in truth undergoes neither disturbance nor destruction. Sentient beings, however, think: "The Dharma and the Saṅgha are being destroyed, and the Tathāgata too will cease to exist." The Tathāgata's true nature neither changes nor is destroyed; yet this too is shown in accordance with the ways of the world.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this example: if two people fight and one is stabbed with a weapon, and blood flows from the body or death results, yet the one who struck had no intention to kill, then the defining characteristic of that act is light and not grave. Likewise, since the Tathāgata has from the very beginning no intention to kill, even if blood were to flow from his body, the defining characteristic of that act is light and not grave. In this way the Tathāgata has shown the ripening of karmic results in order to tame future sentient beings.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this example: a skilled physician exerts diligence and teaches medicine to his son. "This is the medicine of roots," he says, "this is the medicine of fragrance, this is the medicine of color — learn to know them well in all their various and distinct kinds." The son, just as his father instructed him, applies himself diligently and becomes learned in medicine. Later, when that physician has passed away and died, the physician's son recalls: "My father taught me, saying: these are the medicines of roots, of stalks, of flowers, of colors."

The Tathāgata is just like this. In order to tame sentient beings, he established moral discipline and taught: "This is moral discipline. These are the five acts of immediate retribution. These are the acts of usurping and consuming authority over the sacred Dharma. This is the act of wrong craving — do not commit it." These things too were taught for the sake of beings of future times.

Therefore, monks, after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, these are the sūtra collections of profound meaning. These are the Vinaya teachings proclaimed with the defining marks of what is weighty and what is light. This is the Abhidharma (Skt. abhidharma), the elaborated exposition of Dharma terms. Just as the skilled physician showed medicines to his son, so did he make all of this directly evident.

Furthermore, son of good family, people in the world perceive that the moon dies once in six months. The gods of the higher realms, however, see the moon die in a single moment. Why is this? Because a day of the gods is long, while a day of humans is short.

Son of good family, it is the same with the Tathāgata. Gods and humans think that the Tathāgata's lifespan is very short — just as gods and humans see the moon die in a single instant. The Tathāgata, moreover, in a single moment reveals many hundreds of thousands of nirvāṇas, and thereby shows the conquest of the māra of afflictions, the māra of the aggregates, the māra of the Lord of Death, and the māra who is a son of the gods — and so on. Thus many hundreds of thousands of divine māras come to know that the Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, he reveals many hundreds of thousands of previous actions, causes, and conditions in forms as varied as the defining characteristics of the world. In this way, because it is immeasurable, boundless, and inconceivable, the Tathāgata is permanent, abiding, and unchanging.

Son of good family, consider the following simile: the bright moon is wished to be seen by all beings, and so it is called "delightful to behold." Sentient beings, bound by attachment, aversion, and delusion, are not called "delightful to behold." But the Tathāgata, being utterly pure, stainless, supreme, and most excellent, is called "delightful to behold." Those who are devoted to the Dharma take no pleasure in worldly sights. Those who are unvirtuous do not even wish to see him. Therefore the Tathāgata is like the bright moon.

Son of good family, consider further the following simile: it is like the rising sun, which differs according to the three seasons — spring, summer, and winter. In winter the days are short; in summer the days are long; in spring they are neither long nor short.

The Tathāgata is likewise. In this great trichiliocosm world-system, he shows a very short lifespan, and he also shows a very short lifespan to the śrāvakas, so that all of them think the Tathāgata's lifespan is very short — just like the winter sun. To the bodhisattvas he shows a lifespan of one eon or just short of one eon, which is neither long nor short — just like the spring sun. The buddhas themselves behold the buddha's lifespan as immeasurable — just like the summer sun.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata revealed in the world the widely expansive Mahāyāna sūtra collections that he taught, and let fall a great rain of Dharma. Whoever in times to come guards, upholds, expounds, and teaches these sūtra collections and thereby acts for the benefit of sentient beings — know that person to be a true bodhisattva. This is comparable to rain falling in the summer season.

When śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas hear this teaching revealed with the Tathāgata's intended meaning, they are like the winter season — encountering great cold and frost. When bodhisattvas hear this teaching, proclaimed with the Tathāgata's intended meaning, revealing that the Tathāgata is permanent and unchanging, it is like the spring season, when all sprouts burst forth.

In the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata there is no such thing as "long" or "short." Though these are taught for the sake of worldly beings, that is the genuine nature of reality of a buddha.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this analogy: all the stars are invisible during the day. Foolish people think the stars have set and are gone. In truth they have not disappeared; they are simply not visible because of the light of the sun. The Tathāgata is similar: that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not see him is just like worldly people not seeing the stars in the daytime.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this further analogy: when the sun and moon are not visible on a misty evening, foolish and confused people think the sun and moon have gone and ceased to exist. In truth, the sun and moon have not ceased to exist. Likewise, when the sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata appears to have vanished and the Three Jewels are no longer visibly manifest, it is similar — they have not in truth gone away and ceased to be forever.

Therefore, know that the Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and immutable. Why is this? Because the true nature of the Three Jewels is unstained by any defilement.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this analogy: on a moonless night, when a single bright star rises in the east, it shines very clearly, and then immediately sets again. When worldly people see this, they say it is an ill omen. A pratyekabuddha is similar: arising in a world without a buddha, when ordinary beings see him they all think, "The Tathāgata has truly passed into nirvāṇa," and they grieve. But in truth the Tathāgata has not ceased to be — just as the sun and moon have not disappeared, they are merely not visible.

Moreover, son of good family, consider this analogy: when the sun rises, darkness vanishes at once. The sūtra collection of the Great Parinirvāṇa is similar: when it arises in the world, if it reaches the ears of sentient beings, it dispels all non-virtue and all heinous sinful deeds without interval. The domain of practice of this profound Great Parinirvāṇa is inconceivable, for the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata has been perfectly taught therein. Therefore, sons and daughters of good family, generate the mind that holds the Tathāgata to be permanent, unchanging, and immutable; that the sacred Dharma is a stream that never breaks; and that the Saṅgha, likewise, shall never cease to be.

Therefore, one who applies diligent and earnest effort to this sūtra collection with great skillful means will, before long, attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Accordingly, this sūtra collection may also be called "Spontaneously Accomplished with Measureless Qualities," and also "Awakening that Is Inexhaustible" — and because it is inexhaustible, it is designated the Great Parinirvāṇa. Because it is supremely luminous, it is equal to the summer sun. Because its assembly is boundless, it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider this: the light of the sun and moon is the foremost of all lights. The light of the Great Parinirvāṇa is similar — it is supreme among all the lights of sūtra meditative absorptions, and no other light of sūtra meditative absorption can approach it. Why is this? Because the light of this Great Parinirvāṇa penetrates into every pore of sentient beings, and even if a sentient being has not yet given rise to the awakening mind, it causes that being to form the cause for awakening. For this reason it is called the Great Parinirvāṇa.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, as the Blessed One has declared, if the light rays of the Great Parinirvāṇa penetrate into every pore of all sentient beings, and thereby become a cause for awakening even in those beings who have not yet given rise to the awakening mind — this, I venture to say, cannot be right. Why? Blessed One, if those who have committed the four defeats, who have performed the five acts of immediate retribution, or who have engaged in the karma of wrong craving were to become a cause for awakening simply by being touched by those light rays, then what distinction could there possibly be between them and those who guard their moral discipline and who have accumulated collections of virtue and the like? And if there were no distinction, why would the Tathāgata have taught the four qualities in which a Tathāgata abides? Blessed One, as the Blessed One has declared, if any sentient being who hears this Great Parinirvāṇa sūtra with their very ears will have all afflictions dispelled — then why did the Tathāgata previously state that certain persons had in former times given rise to the awakening mind before buddhas as numerous as the sands of the Ganges, yet even after hearing the Great Parinirvāṇa, had still not come to understand its meaning? If they do not grasp its meaning, how could all afflictions be severed?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, with the sole exception of those with wrong craving, if other sentient beings hear this sūtra, it will become for all of them a cause for awakening. When the light rays of the sound of the Dharma enter into their pores, they will without fail attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Why is this? Any person who attends, makes offerings to, and pays homage to immeasurable buddhas — such a person will then come to hear this Great Parinirvāṇa sūtra. Those of small merit will not come to hear it. How is this so? Those endowed with great qualities will come to hear this great matter, while those who are weak and of small capacity will not. Now, this 'great matter' refers to the profound secret essence of all buddhas — the buddha-nature itself. Therefore it is called the great matter."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how is it that those who have not given rise to the awakening mind become a cause for awakening?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Someone who, after hearing this Great Parinirvāṇa sūtra, thinks 'I have no need to give rise to the awakening mind' and thereby disparages the sacred Dharma — such a person will in a dream

see the form of a demon (rākṣasa) and will be gripped by intense terror. That demon will say, 'Son of good family, if you do not now give rise to the awakening mind, I will cut the thread of your living breath.' Filled with fear, that person will awaken from the dream and will give rise to the awakening mind. When that person passes away, even if they fall into one of the three lower destinies, or are born among humans or as a god in the higher realms, the stream of their awakening mind will never be severed — and because of that recollection, such a person should be understood to be a great bodhisattva. It is in this way — through the power and force of the Great Parinirvāṇa — that one who has not given rise to the awakening mind becomes a cause for awakening. Son of good family, this is called the cause and condition of a bodhisattva's giving rise to the awakening mind; it is not a matter of being without cause and condition. Therefore this sublime sūtra of the Great Vehicle was authentically declared by the awakened ones.

"Son of good family, here is another analogy. When great rain clouds cover the sky above and a great rain falls — if a dry tree, or a rock, or

it flows down to every high mountain and rocky place where water would not otherwise reach, and all the low-lying hollows and valleys fill completely with water — becoming a benefit for all the countless sentient beings. This sublime sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is just the same: even though the great rain of Dharma falls upon all sentient beings, those with perverted craving alone have no ground in which the awakening mind can arise.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a burnt seed, though soaked through by rain for a hundred thousand aeons, will never sprout — there is simply no ground in which it can grow. Those with perverted craving are exactly the same: even though they come to hear this sublime sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa in its entirety, the sprout of the awakening mind will not grow in them — there is no ground in which it can arise. Why is that? Because such a person has utterly destroyed every wholesome root and has become like a burnt seed; therefore the root and sprout of awakening cannot grow.

Son of good family, here is yet another analogy. Take a precious gem of the water-clearing kind: if it is placed in muddy water, by the power of the gem the water becomes clear. But if it is placed in mire, it will not become clear. This sublime sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is just the same. If it is brought among beings who are like muddy water — those who have committed one of the five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya) or in whom one of the four root

defeats (pārājika) has arisen — it is possible that they will be purified and that the awakening mind will arise in them. But if those with perverted craving, who are like a pit of mire, are left with it for a hundred thousand years, they will never be purified, nor will the awakening mind possibly arise. Why is that? Because those with perverted craving have destroyed every wholesome root and have thus become unfit vessels. Indeed, even if such a person were to listen to or hold this sublime sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa for a hundred thousand years, they would be unable to arouse the awakening mind. Why? Because they are entirely without a virtuous mind.

Son of good family, here is yet another analogy. Among all medicinal plants there is one called the King of Medicines — the supreme and most excellent of all medicines. Whether it is combined with a cloth, or mixed with honey, or blended with butter, or stirred into water, or stirred into milk, or applied as a powder, or made into pills, or rubbed in as a salve, or burned as incense, or applied to the eyes — even merely seeing it or touching it cures every disease of sentient beings. Yet that medicinal plant never thinks: "If beings take my roots, they will not gather my leaves," or "If they gather my leaves, they will not take my roots," or "If they take my trunk, they will strip my bark," or "If they strip my bark, they will not gather my trunk." It has no such thoughts at all. And yet for all that, it is able to remove all the painful diseases of sentient beings.

Son of good family, this sublime sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is exactly the same: it eliminates all four root defeats and all five acts of immediate retribution, and all unwholesome actions, whether outer or inner, of every sentient being — and even those who have not yet aroused the awakening mind will, through its power, come to arouse it. Why is that? Because this sūtra too is like a king among all sūtras, just as the King of Medicines is the king among medicines. Whether one diligently applies oneself to this Great Parinirvāṇa or does not, if one hears that this sūtra's name exists and upon hearing it immediately gives rise to faith and trust, it will eliminate every disease of affliction. Yet those with perverted craving cannot be established with ease in the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Just as the King of Medicines, though it heals every illness, cannot reverse the coming of inevitable death.

Noble son, here is another analogy. When those whose hands have open wounds grasp poison, the poison enters within. But one who has no wound, even grasping it, the poison does not enter within. Those with perverted

craving are likewise: because there is no cause for awakening, they resemble grasping poison with an unwounded hand — it does not enter within. The wound stands for the cause of unsurpassed awakening. The poison stands for what is like the ultimate medicine. The absence of a wound stands for one like those with perverted craving.

Noble son, here is another analogy. A vajra is not crushed by anything; though it can pierce and shatter everything, it can itself be crushed by a tortoise shell and a deer's horn. This sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is likewise: though it brings measureless sentient beings easily onto the path of awakening, those with perverted craving it cannot cause to generate the cause of awakening.

Noble son, here is another analogy. Plants such as grass, reeds, trees such as the śāli rice plant, and creepers — though their stalks and branches are cut, they immediately regrow. They are not like the tāla palm, which, once cut, does not grow back. Those sentient beings are likewise: even if they have committed the four root downfalls that entail defeat, or have performed the five acts of immediate retribution, yet upon hearing this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa the cause of awakening can still arise again in them. Those with perverted craving are not like that: even if they hear or attend to this holy sūtra, the cause of awakening cannot arise.

Noble son, here is another analogy. When trees such as the banana and the cane are cut, it is as though their seeds have been burned — they do not grow back. Those with perverted craving are likewise: even though they hear this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, no cause of awakening arises — this is like a burned seed.

Noble son, here is another analogy. When a great rain falls, it does not cling to empty sky. This sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa is likewise: though it rains down the Dharma rain everywhere, it does not cling to those with perverted craving. In the body of one with perverted craving it is as though a vajra were driven in throughout — nothing whatsoever can take hold.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Blessed One has also declared in a verse:

Not seeing the wholesome, one does not act wholesomely.
Seeing the unwholesome, one commits what is unwholesome.
Fearing that and falling away from it
is like dreading a bad road's precipice."

He then asked: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of these words you have spoken?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, 'not seeing' means not seeing the nature of a buddha. 'The wholesome' means unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. 'Does not act' means not serving and honoring a spiritual friend. 'Seeing' means seeing as though cause and effect did not exist. 'The unwholesome' means denigrating the extensively taught sūtras of the Great Vehicle. 'Commits' means those with perverted craving claim that the extensive teaching does not exist. Therefore, those with perverted craving have no mind inclined toward or striving in the wholly pure wholesome Dharmas. As for what Dharma is called 'wholesome,' that is nirvāṇa. To be inclined toward and striving in nirvāṇa means to apply oneself diligently to the conduct of the noble ones. Those with perverted craving do not follow the conduct of the noble ones, and so they are unable to be inclined toward or to strive in nirvāṇa. 'One should fear that' refers to the denigration of the holy Dharma. By whom should it be feared? By the wise, those possessed of wisdom. Why? Because through denigrating the Dharma the mind of virtue is absent, for there is then no means of engagement. 'The bad road's precipice' refers to the conditioning formations."

Kāśyapa then asked again: "Blessed One, in what you have declared, what are 'the things that are seen'?"

"What things will become virtuous,
What is the ground of fearlessness,
As a king travels the path of ease" —
what is the meaning of these words?

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, 'the things that are seen' refers to confession of wrongdoing. From the beginning of saṃsāra, whatever non-virtuous and unwholesome acts one has done — all are confessed, and one arrives at a place of no return. Therefore that ground is fearless. For example, when a king sets out upon a road, bandits and the like flee and scatter at the sight of him. Likewise, when non-virtuous and unwholesome acts are confessed and disclosed, all of them are purified.

"Furthermore, 'the things that are done are not seen' refers to those with perverted craving who, though they have performed non-virtuous and unwholesome deeds, do not see them. Those with perverted craving, swollen with the arrogance of pride, perform many non-virtuous and unwholesome

acts yet feel no dread or fear from the very beginning. Therefore they do not attain nirvāṇa — this is like monkeys grasping at the reflection of the moon in water.

"Son of good family, even if immeasurable sentient beings, all at the same moment, were to awaken to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, even those Tathāgatas could not rightfully enable those with perverted craving to attain awakening. Therefore this is called 'not seeing the things that are done.'

"Furthermore, as for 'not seeing what has been done by another' — it is not seen because it has been done by the Tathāgata. Even though the Tathāgata reveals and teaches the buddha-nature to ordinary beings, those with perverted craving, spinning endlessly in saṃsāra, will not come to know or see it. Therefore this is called 'not seeing what the Tathāgata has done.'

"Furthermore, when at last the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa, those with perverted craving grasp at it as genuine impermanence — seeing it as like a lamp and its oil being extinguished. Why? Because such a person does not diminish their non-virtuous and unwholesome karma.

"When a bodhisattva dedicates the virtuous acts they have performed toward unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, those with perverted craving mock and doubt him. Yet the bodhisattvas dedicate even those very beings toward the attainment of unsurpassable awakening. Why? Because such is the nature of reality of the buddhas.

From milk comes curds in time;
Evil deeds do not ripen at once.
Like fire-embers covered by ash,
A fool who scorns them will be burned.

"Those with perverted craving are said to be without eyes. Therefore they do not see the path of the arhat (Skt. arhat). The arhat does not travel the bad road and precipice of the path of saṃsāra. Those who are without eyes, by denigrating the vast and extensive teaching, do not cultivate a mind of loving-kindness as the arhat does. Those with perverted craving who do not cultivate the vast and extensive teaching are likewise the same.

"There is a person who says: 'I have no faith in the sūtra collections of the śrāvakas (Skt. śrāvaka), but I have faith in the Great Vehicle, and I recite it, read it, expound it, and explain it. Therefore I am a bodhisattva. Since the

buddha-nature exists in all sentient beings, within the body of sentient beings there also exist the ten powers, the thirty-two major marks, and the eighty excellent minor marks. What I say and what the Buddha has said are not different. You and I together will overcome immeasurable afflictions — just as a water-vessel, when broken, by destroying all afflictions one will behold unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.' Even though such a person teaches and explains in this way,

he does not genuinely believe that the buddha-nature truly exists within sentient beings, and he teaches in the manner of written words merely for the sake of benefit and happiness. One who teaches in that way is called a wrongdoer. And a wrongdoer is one for whom the fruit does not ripen quickly, just as milk does not quickly turn to curds.

Consider, for example, a royal messenger who is supremely eloquent and endowed with skillful means: when the king dispatches him with a command to a foreign land, even at the cost of his life and limb he does not conceal the king's command. A wise and discerning person is similarly: even at the cost of life and limb, not looking to his own safety amidst childish and lowly people, he proclaims and teaches this extensive Great Vehicle — the Tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), which is the intrinsic nature of a buddha present in all sentient beings.

Noble son, there are certain people of wrong desire who dress themselves up as arhats. Dwelling at the margins of the teaching, they slander and disparage the sūtras of the extensive Great Vehicle, and childish, lowly disciples take them to be genuine arhats or great bodhisattvas. Such a wrongdoing mendicant, though he dwells at the margins of the teaching, renders those marginal Dharmas improper. When he sees others gaining offerings and honor, jealousy arises in his mind, and he says: "These sūtras of the extensive Great Vehicle were taught by the Māra of evil deeds, and the Tathāgata, too, is impermanent." In this way he destroys the true Dharma and corrupts the Saṅgha. Furthermore, he says: "What was spoken by the evil Māra of evil deeds was not spoken in accordance with virtue," and in this way he speaks of sinful and non-virtuous phenomena. Yet even though he commits such wrong deeds, just as milk does not immediately turn to curds, the ripening does not come at once. Like one who scorns a fire concealed beneath its own ash, he exults for a time above it. Such a person is called one of wrong desire.

Therefore this noble sūtra of the extensive Great Vehicle is definitively and utterly pure. Just as a precious jewel placed in turbid water clears and purifies the water, so too is this sūtra of the Great Vehicle.

Noble son, here is another analogy: when lotus blossoms are touched by the rays of the sun, they immediately open. So too are all sentient beings: if they behold the great nirvāṇa that is like the sun, those who have not yet aroused the mind will arouse it and it will become a cause for awakening. Therefore, when the light of nirvāṇa enters the pore of a single hair, it will become a supreme cause.

Thus have I spoken. One of wrong desire, though the buddha-nature is present within, is entirely bound by immeasurable impure defilements and does not attain liberation — just like the cocoon of a silk-worm wrapped in its own thread. Through the condition of such karma the cause of awakening does not arise, and the wandering in saṃsāra becomes endless and without limit.

Noble son, here is yet another analogy: the blue lotus, the red lotus, the water lily, and the white lotus all arise from the midst of mud and filth, yet they are unstained by the mud. Any sentient being who diligently applies himself to this noble sūtra, this Great Discourse on Great Nirvāṇa, is likewise: though accompanied by afflictions, he is unstained by those afflictions. Why is that? Because he comes to know the defining characteristics of the Tathāgata's nature.

Noble son, consider a region where an exceedingly cool breeze blows: any sentient being afflicted by heat, when that breeze touches the pores of his body, is relieved of that affliction. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Discourse on Great Nirvāṇa, is also like that. It enters the pores of all sentient beings and becomes a cause for awakening — with the sole exception of those of wrong desire. Why? Because they are not vessels for the Dharma.

Noble son, consider further this example: a skilled physician, expert in the eight branches of medical knowledge, is able to cure all diseases — yet not in the case of one whose time of death has inevitably arrived. All the meditative absorptions (samādhis) of the sūtras are likewise: they are capable of curing the disease of affliction by attachment, aversion, and delusion in all sentient beings, and of drawing out the thorn of affliction — yet not in the case of one who has incurred the four defeats or committed the five acts of immediate consequence.

Noble son, consider further: physicians even more skilled than the eight branches of knowledge are able to dispel all the suffering of illness in sentient beings — yet not in the case of one whose death has come without doubt. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Discourse on Great Nirvāṇa, is also like that: it abandons all the afflictions of sentient beings, establishes them with ease on the path toward becoming a cause for the Tathāgata's complete purification, and arouses the awakening mind in those who have not yet aroused it — yet not in the case of one who is destined to die with wrong desire.

Noble son, consider further: a skilled physician is able to restore sight to those who have gone blind through eye disease — enabling them to see the sun, the moon, fire, stars, and all visible forms — yet not in the case of one who has been blind from the very beginning. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Discourse on Great Nirvāṇa, is also like that: even those who follow the vehicle of hearers and pratyekabuddhas can gain the eye of wisdom and be established in the boundless and unlimited sūtras of the Great Vehicle; and even those who have not aroused the awakening mind, who have incurred the four defeats or committed the five acts of immediate consequence, can be made to arouse the awakening mind toward awakening — yet not those who have been blind from the very beginning and are possessed of wrong desire.

Noble son, consider further this example: a supremely skilled physician endowed with the eight branches of medical knowledge, wishing to cure all the diseases of sentient beings, compounds many kinds of medicine — emetics, purgatives, ointments, fumigants, nasal preparations, powders, pills, and the like. If a certain poor person refuses the medicine even so, out of compassion for him the physician brings him home, administers the medicine by force, and restores him to health. If a woman in childbirth cannot deliver the afterbirth, he administers medicine to her, so that the afterbirth comes and the child is born easily and well. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Discourse on Great Nirvāṇa, is also like that: in whatever place it dwells, there it pacifies the immeasurable afflictions of sentient beings; and even those who have incurred the four defeats, committed the five acts of immediate consequence, and have not aroused the awakening mind, come to arouse it — with the sole exception of those of wrong desire.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, those who have incurred the four defeats and committed the five acts of immediate consequence are like a palm tree that has been cut at its crown and will not grow again. Since they have not aroused the awakening mind toward

awakening, how can they become a cause for awakening?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, if in a dream those sentient beings were to fall into a hell realm and experience great suffering, remorse would arise in their minds, and they would think: 'Alas! Why have I come to experience such evil? If only I could be freed from this evil — I would without doubt arouse the awakening mind toward awakening. What I am experiencing right now is indeed the very depth of suffering.' Then, waking from the dream, they would come to understand that the sacred Dharma bears great fruit. Just as a young child, from birth onward until it has grown large, constantly thinks: 'That physician is supremely skilled in medicine. While I was still in my mother's womb, he gave medicine to my mother, and through the power of that medicine I came to dwell at ease —

and I too have come to live and thrive. How wonderful! My mother endured great suffering for the ten months of her pregnancy. After I was born, she freed me from the discomfort of being soiled, brought me into contact with the ease of being clean, wiped away even the smallest impurities of excrement and urine, suckled me at her breast, nourished this body of mine, and cared for me greatly. Therefore, in order to repay her kindness, I shall care for her greatly and make offerings to her in a way that accords with her heart.' With such thoughts does a child's mind dwell.

Even if, at the very end of one's life, one has committed the four defeats or perpetrated the five acts of immediate consequence, if one calls to mind this Great Vehicle sūtra, the great nirvāṇa, that person will be caused by this sūtra to make a cause for awakening — whether they are reborn in hell, in an animal realm, among hungry ghosts, among gods, or among humans — excepting only those possessed of wrong craving.

Son of good family, here is another illustration. A skilled physician, or the son of a skilled physician, is expert in medicine surpassing all others, deeply versed in antidotes to poisons, and also skilled in healing mantras. By the power of his mantras and medicines, he renders even a virulent snake, a nāga, or other deadly things free of venom. Now, if medicine is applied to a shoe, and that shoe then comes into contact with a virulent snake and the like, the venom is stilled — but this does not apply to what is called the great nāga of wrong craving. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the great nirvāṇa, is likewise: for sentient beings who have committed the four defeats or perpetrated the five acts of immediate consequence, it purifies those evils and transgressions and

establishes them on the path to awakening. Just as medicine smeared on a shoe stills the poison, so too this sūtra, even for those who have not yet aroused the awakening mind, causes them to arouse it and establishes them easily on the path to awakening. Through the power of this sūtra of the Great Vehicle, the great nirvāṇa — which is like medicine — all sentient beings are brought to ease, excepting only those possessed of wrong craving, who are like the great nāga.

Son of good family, here is yet another illustration. A person might compound a poison and smear it on a great drum, then beat that drum in the midst of a large crowd. Even if those who hear the sound have no wish to hear it, all who do hear it, though they may die, will not die suddenly — with the sole exception of those possessed of wrong craving. This Great Vehicle sūtra, the great nirvāṇa, is likewise: wherever its sound is heard amid a great gathering of conditioning factors, all the mental afflictions of attachment, aversion, and delusion will be purged. Even without any deliberate reflection or intentional thought about it, through the power of the great nirvāṇa, all afflictions will be stilled. Those who have committed the four defeats and perpetrated the five acts of immediate consequence — if they hear this sūtra, it will become a cause for their unsurpassed awakening, and their afflictions will be wholly swept away, so that they do not die suddenly, excepting only those possessed of wrong craving.

Son of good family, here is yet another illustration. When darkness falls, all activity ceases, and even what remains unfinished must wait until the following day. The study of the Great Vehicle is likewise. Though one may be diligent in the meditative absorption of every sūtra, upon hearing this sūtra — the great nirvāṇa, like the sun, which the Tathāgata taught with deep intent — one immediately takes up the work of awakening and dwells at ease in the sacred Dharma.

Consider, for example, the rain: it brings forth the germination of every seed, the ripening of every fruit, and the removal of drought and famine, making all things abundantly available. This immeasurable rain of Dharma from the tathāgatagarbha is likewise: it dispels the eight kinds of burning affliction, and by the appearance of this sūtra in the world it causes all fruits to ripen —

bringing benefit and well-being to all, and causing ordinary beings to behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha — just as, in the Puṇḍarīka Sūtra, eight thousand hearers received a prophecy and thereby attained the great fruit.

Consider, further, one who is possessed of wrong craving: just as a farmer who has done his work in the harvest season stores it away for winter and does nothing else thereafter, such a one similarly exerts no effort toward virtuous Dharma.

Son of good family, here is another example. Suppose a skilled physician hears that the son of an enemy has been poisoned. He prepares a fine medicine and dispatches a man with these words: "Take this medicine and deliver it to him." Now, even if that very messenger, while on the road, should encounter a hungry ghost, the power of the medicine will cause it to flee and run away. And if you are delayed in delivering it, I myself will go in your stead, so that the sick man does not suddenly die. If the sick man then meets either that messenger or the physician himself, the power of the medicine will free him from the suffering of illness and he will be at ease.

This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa, is likewise. Whether it be a monk, or a nun, or a layman, or a laywoman, or even a non-Buddhist adherent — whoever carries this sūtra, retains it, reads it, recites it, takes it to heart, teaches and expounds it extensively to others, copies it into a manuscript himself, or has others copy it: all of these become causes of awakening for each and every one of them. If those who have violated the four defeats, who have committed the five heinous crimes, who have been possessed by hungry ghosts, or who have been harmed by malevolent forces hear this sūtra, all their misdeeds will be purified — just as the sight of that skilled physician causes hungry ghosts and the like to flee and run away. Therefore, such a person is to be known as a true bodhisattva, a great being. And why? Because they have merely heard the Great Nirvāṇa and have contemplated the permanence of the Tathāgata. If the mere hearing of it brings such a result, what need is there to speak of copying it into a manuscript, carrying it, retaining it, reading it, or reciting it? Know that all who do so — except those possessed of wrong craving — are bodhisattvas, great beings.

Son of good family, here is yet another example. A deaf person cannot hear any sound at all. One possessed of wrong craving is likewise: even if they make an effort to hear this sublime sūtra, they do not hear it. And why? Because they lack the cause for hearing.

Son of good family, here is yet another example. A skilled physician who fully understands every method of examination and knows mantras without measure said this to a king: "Great King, Great King, you have a disease that

will certainly bring death." The king replied: "You have not examined my interior — how do you know I have a disease that will certainly bring death?" The physician said: "If you do not believe me, take this purgative medicine and the disease will come out and you will see it for yourself." Yet the king could not bring himself to take the medicine. Then that physician, through the power of his mantras, caused a boil to form on the king's lower back, and from it worms and blood emerged. When the king saw what had happened, he was greatly alarmed. He praised the physician with the words "Excellent! Excellent!" and said: "Formerly I did not heed your words, yet now you have done my body the greatest benefit." Thereafter he honoured that physician as if he were his own father and mother.

This Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa, is likewise. Whether a sentient being is governed by desire or is free from desire —

it quells all their afflictions. Whatever sentient being dreams of this sūtra and, in that dream, makes offerings and pays homage to it, they do so just as the great king honoured the skilled physician. And just as the skilled physician cannot heal one who is certain to die, so too this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa cannot heal one who clings to wrong views.

Noble son, here is yet another example. A skilled physician, learned in the eight branches of medical knowledge, may be able to cure every disease, yet he cannot cure a disease that will certainly prove fatal. Buddhas and bodhisattvas are likewise: although they can heal all the moral faults of sentient beings in existence, they cannot heal those who cling to wrong views, who are like patients with a fatal disease.

Noble son, here is yet another example. A skilled physician, having mastered the eight branches of medical knowledge and perfected every aspect of medicine and medical science, comprehending all things, first teaches his son about the medicines that arise from water, from dry land, and from the mountains. Once the son has learned these, the father then teaches him the eight branches of medical knowledge, and thereafter he also teaches him the supreme secret examination that goes beyond them. The Tathāgata, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, is likewise. He first taught the monks who are like sons every means of removing all afflictions, and set them to applying themselves diligently to the perception of the body as insubstantial and in need of purification — and this is comparable to teaching about water, dry land, and rocky mountains. By "water" is meant the teaching that the

sufferings experienced in the body are like water bubbles. By "dry land" is meant the teaching that this body is insubstantial, like a plantain tree. By "rocky mountains" is meant the teaching of meditating on the perception of no-self amid the afflictions — and therefore one says of the body that it is without self. In this way the Tathāgata taught the attendant monks the nine classes of sūtra, and caused them to understand; then, following that, he revealed the tathāgatagarbha (buddha-nature), and — in the manner of speaking to sons — declared: "The Tathāgata is permanent." In this way the Tathāgata's teaching of this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa, becomes a cause of awakening for all sentient beings, whether they have generated the awakening mind or have not yet generated it — with the sole exception of those who cling to wrong views.

Noble son, this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa, is boundless, limitless, and inconceivable. Therefore it is like the most excellent and supreme of skilled physicians, the foremost, the king of all sūtras.

Noble son, here is yet another example. A great ship ferries people from this shore of the ocean to the far shore, and from the far shore back to this one again. The Tathāgata, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, is likewise: embarked in the precious vessel of the Great Nirvāṇa, he completely liberates sentient beings, and wherever they are to go he conveys them there and causes them to behold the form of the Tathāgata. Therefore the Tathāgata is like the captain of a ship. And just as even a raft, so long as it holds together, enables beings to cross the ocean, so too the Tathāgata, who perpetually labours to liberate the multitude of sentient beings, is just the same.

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Noble son, here is yet another example. Those who have boarded a ship to cross the great ocean — if they have the wind, they will reach the far shore, however immeasurably distant, in a single instant. But if they have no wind, they may remain there for immeasurable years without ever advancing from their place.

But if the ship were to sink, those aboard would perish. Just so it is with sentient beings who have boarded the ship of formations on the great ocean of cyclic existence amid delusion. If they encounter the fierce wind of great nirvāṇa, they will swiftly arrive at unsurpassed and perfect awakening. But if they do not encounter it, they will wander in cyclic existence for immeasurable aeons, and they may fall into rebirth as hell-beings, hungry ghosts, or animals.

Noble son, here is yet another example. Those who have been long at sea on a great ocean, lacking wind, think to themselves: "We will surely perish." But then, should a fierce wind arise and carry them beyond the ocean just as they wished, they cry out: "The wind has satisfied us utterly! We have safely escaped the perils of the ocean." In the same way, sentient beings who have long wandered the ocean of cyclic existence amid delusion, tormented by suffering, and who have not encountered the wind of great nirvāṇa, think to themselves: "We will surely fall into rebirth as hell-beings, hungry ghosts, or animals." But then, should they encounter the wind of great nirvāṇa and be established, just as they wished, in unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening, they understand for the very first time that this is truly real. A perception of wonder and astonishment arises, and they say: "Before now I had never heard of this secret heart-essence of the Tathāgata." And so pure and unwavering faith arises in their minds toward the sūtra of great nirvāṇa.

Noble son, here is yet another example. When a snake sheds its skin, would you call that snake dead? The answer was given: "No, Blessed One." The Blessed One said: Noble son, the Tathāgata is just the same. When the Tathāgata, through skillful means, has shown the laying aside of the body, how could the Tathāgata be called impermanent on that account? The answer was given: "No, Blessed One." The Tathāgata's laying aside of the body here in Jambudvīpa through skillful means is like a snake shedding its skin. Therefore the Tathāgata is said to be permanent and abiding.

Noble son, here is yet another example. A skilled goldsmith beats gold into various implements according to his wish. The Tathāgata is just the same. In the twenty-five modes of existence the Tathāgata manifests various physical forms and thereby draws ordinary beings out from cyclic existence. Therefore the Tathāgata is said to be of immeasurable form. Though displaying various forms in this way, the Tathāgata is nonetheless said to be permanent, abiding, unchanging, and unaltering.

Noble son, here is yet another example. The mango tree and the rose-apple tree (jambu) transform three times in a single year. At one time they burst forth abundantly with flowers and so forth; at another time they burst forth abundantly with leaves and so forth; and at yet another time all the leaves fall away and the tree stands as if bare and dry. Noble son, what do you think — is the tree truly withered and dead at that time? The answer was given: "No, Blessed One." The Blessed One declared: Noble son, the Tathāgata is just the same. In the three worlds the Tathāgata shows three kinds of body: at one

time the first birth is shown, at another time the body reaching its full maturity is shown, and at yet another time nirvāṇa is shown. But the body of the Tathāgata is not impermanent.

The bodhisattva, the great being Kāśyapa, praised the Blessed One with the words "Excellent! Most excellent!" and then declared, in accord with what the Blessed One had taught: "The Tathāgata is permanent, stable, unchanging, and unalterable."

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, what the Tathāgata has taught through his intended meaning is exceedingly difficult to understand. Consider this analogy. A great king once commanded his ministers, "Bring the saintapa." Now, the word "saintapa" is a single name applied to four different things: salt, a vessel, water, and a horse — these four things share this one name. A wise minister, understanding this, would reason as follows: if the king intends to bathe and gives the command "Bring the saintapa," the minister offers water. When the king is engaged in eating and gives the command "Bring the saintapa," the minister offers salt. When the king has finished eating and is about to drink to quench his thirst and gives the command "Bring the saintapa," the minister offers a vessel. And if the king is preparing to travel and gives the command "Bring the saintapa," the minister brings a horse and leads it forward. In this way a wise minister is skilled in the four instructions of the king.

This sūtra of the Great Vehicle is just the same: there are four kinds of impermanence, and those who are deeply skilled in the Great Vehicle must be thoroughly expert in them.

When the buddha, the Blessed One, appeared in the world and taught sentient beings that the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa, skilled persons understood that the Tathāgata was teaching impermanence to those who clung to permanence — and this was in order to lead the monks to apply themselves earnestly to the characteristic of impermanence.

Furthermore, when he taught that at a certain time the true Dharma would perish, skilled persons understood that the Tathāgata was teaching suffering (duḥkha) to those who clung to what is blissful — and this was in order to lead the monks to apply themselves earnestly to the characteristic of suffering.

Furthermore, when he taught in these words, "I am afflicted by illness and pain, and the Saṅgha too will disintegrate," skilled persons understood that the Tathāgata was teaching selflessness to those who clung to a self — and this

was in order to lead the monks to apply themselves earnestly to selflessness.

When at a certain time he taught thus, "What is called emptiness is true and complete liberation," skilled persons understood that the Tathāgata was teaching complete liberation — and they understood that the twenty-five modes of existence are absent in it. This was in order to lead the monks to apply themselves earnestly to emptiness. And so it is that for true and complete liberation, "emptiness" is taught.

It is also called "the unmoving, the motionless." Since there is no suffering in that liberation, it is called "the unmoving."

True and complete liberation is called "the signless," because it is free from signs — because form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and so forth are absent in it.

True and complete liberation is permanent, unchanging, and unalterable. Since liberation is free from impermanence, from distress, and from alteration, liberation is therefore permanent, stable, unchanging, and cool.

Now, if it were taught that the nature of the Tathāgata exists in all sentient beings, a skilled person would understand it thus: the Tathāgata has taught the Dharma under the name of permanence in order to lead the monks to apply themselves earnestly to the truly permanent Dharma.

Monks, know that one who thus follows and trains diligently is truly my genuine attendant. One who is skilled in the essential import of what the Tathāgata has taught through his intended meaning is like the wise minister of that great king who understood the king's intention.

Noble son, if even that great king possessed words spoken with a hidden intent, how much more so the Tathāgata. Noble son, for this reason, what the Tathāgata has spoken with a hidden intent is extremely difficult to understand. A wise and discerning person will come to know this profound Dharma that I have taught with a hidden intent, but foolish and dull-witted people in the world will not come to know it.

Furthermore, noble son, consider this example: when a great blight strikes the śāl tree, the kaṇikāra tree, and the aśoka tree, flowers and fruits no longer grow. All water-born plants likewise fail to yield oil even when pressed to the limit, and all medicinal plants lose their potency.

Noble son, this Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is the same. When I pass into nirvāṇa, sentient beings will not venerate it, and its splendor will diminish. Why is that? Because those sentient beings do not understand what the

Tathāgata has taught with a hidden intent. And why is that? Because sentient beings have scant merit.

Noble son, furthermore, when the authentic Dharma of the Tathāgata is on the verge of ruin and destruction, at that time and in that age there will be many monks who engage in evil conduct. Not understanding the essential import of what the Tathāgata has taught with a hidden intent, they will be lazy and lax, and will be unable to read, recite, explicate, and teach the authentic Dharma of the Tathāgata. They are like foolish thieves who, discarding genuine jewels, carry away mere chaff instead. In the same way, not understanding the essential import of what the Tathāgata has taught with a hidden intent, they will be negligent toward this sūtra and will not arouse diligence. Alas, in a future time such beings will fall into a great abyss of terrible dread. Alas, those sentient beings will not exert themselves with regard to this Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa. It is only bodhisattvas, great beings, who will enter into the true and genuine meaning of this sūtra, without clinging to the letter or the word, following after it and not contradicting it, and who will likewise teach it to sentient beings.

Noble son, furthermore, consider this example: some dishonest milk-sellers, wishing to make their milk go further, add two or three parts water and sell it to another milk-dealer. That dealer then adds two or three parts water to it and sells it to people living near the town. Those people add two or three more parts water to it and sell it to people living in the town. Those buyers then add two or three more parts water to it and sell it at market. At that time, a man setting out for the wedding of his son's bride sends someone to the market to buy good milk. The buyer, encountering that milk, knows full well it has been diluted with a great deal of water, yet pressed by urgent need he buys it at high price. He returns home and boils it into a porridge, and there is no taste of milk. And yet, though it lacks the taste of milk, it still surpasses the taste of water by many hundreds and thousands of times. Why? Because a taste transformed by milk is superior to any other taste.

Noble son, eighty years after I pass into nirvāṇa, before the authentic Dharma has yet fallen into ruin, at that time and in that age this sūtra will spread very widely throughout this Jambudvīpa. At that time, wicked monks will compile extracts from this sūtra and arrange it into many partial fragments, thereby stripping the authentic Dharma of its color, its scent, and its savory taste. Those evil ones may indeed read or recite this sūtra, but they will have emptied it of the profound meaning that the Tathāgata taught with a hidden

intent.

They took worldly expressions that were meaningless and placed what had been stated earlier at the end; what had been stated later they placed at the beginning; what had been stated at the beginning and at the end they placed in the middle; and what had been stated in the middle they placed at the beginning and at the end.

In this way, those wicked monks are companions of Māra. They say that all things that have not been examined are permitted by the Tathāgata to be held and practiced. Just as one adulterates milk by adding water along with buttermilk and so forth, so too those wicked monks are the same: by adding worldly words and settling it corruptly in a fixed form, they caused the many to be instructed in what is not correct, to transcribe it incorrectly into books, to engage in incorrect transcription, and rendered it unworthy of reverence, praise, veneration, and honor.

Those wicked monks, unable to teach even a little of this sūtra on account of gain and fame, how much less could they teach it in full extent? Just as a poor milkmaid sells milk from one vessel to another until it loses all taste, so too with this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Mahāparinirvāṇa — it becomes diluted and loses its taste. Yet even though it loses its taste, it still surpasses all other tastes, just as the taste of milk, though depleted of other tastes, remains superior to all others. Why is that? Because this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Mahāparinirvāṇa, is supreme and most excellent among all śrāvaka sūtras, just as milk with all its taste is supreme and most excellent. Therefore it is called the Great Mahāparinirvāṇa.

Noble son, furthermore, there is no noble son or noble daughter who does not desire to be rid of a woman's body. Why is that? Because all women are the abode of every evil.

Noble son, furthermore, consider this example: the urine of a fly cannot moisten this great earth. So too the insatiable attachment called "woman" is the same: even if every man who could be rolled into a ball the size of a mustard seed from all this great earth were to engage in unchaste acts with a single woman, she would have no sense of satisfaction. Even if men equal in number to the grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā were given to a single woman to engage in unchaste acts with her, she would have no satisfaction or weariness.

Noble son, consider this example: into a great ocean, all rains and all flowing rivers pour, yet that ocean is never filled or satisfied. A woman is by her very nature the same, so that even if everything that exists were to become male and engage in unchaste acts with a single woman, she would feel no satisfaction or weariness.

Noble son, furthermore, consider this example: the aśoka tree, the pāṭala tree, the kañcana tree — when their flowers bloom in summer, the bees gather their fragrance and their pollen without ever being satisfied. A woman's attachment to men is the same — she knows no weariness.

Noble son, therefore, noble sons and noble daughters who listen to this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Mahāparinirvāṇa, will constantly reproach womanhood and seek a male body. Why is that? Because this Great Vehicle sūtra possesses the marks of a man (puruṣa). That is to say, it is of the nature of a buddha. Whoever does not know the nature of a buddha lacks the marks of a man. Why? Because they do not know that they themselves possess the nature of a buddha. Whoever does not know the nature of a buddha — that one, I declare, is called a woman. Whoever knows the nature of a buddha — that one, I declare, is said to possess the marks of a man. Therefore, whatever woman comes to know that she herself possesses the nature of a buddha — that one is called a man.

Sons of the lineage, know that this Great Vehicle sūtra of the complete passing beyond sorrow is a mass of merit that is immeasurable, incalculable, and inconceivable. Why is that? Because it expounds the secret essence of the Tathāgata. Therefore, if sons of the lineage or daughters of the lineage desire to swiftly come to know the secret essence of the Tathāgata, they should apply themselves with earnest and diligent effort to this sūtra.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One and said: So it is, so it is indeed. Just as the Blessed One has declared, I too, having realized the secret essence of the Tathāgata, possess the marks of a man. It was through the Tathāgata's urging that I came to certain realization.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Son of the lineage, it is well that you have spoken thus in accordance with the ways of the world.

Kāśyapa said: But I do not follow worldly conventions, Blessed One.

The Blessed One then said to Kāśyapa: Excellent! Most excellent indeed! The understanding you possess knows the supremely profound and

difficult-to-know flavor of the unsurpassed Dharma — just as bees, without harming the color of a flower, taste only its sweetness.

Son of the lineage, consider further this analogy: a fly's urine cannot moisten this great earth. Similarly, when this sūtra spreads in the future, and the sublime Dharma draws near to its destruction, this sūtra will first disappear from this land. Know, therefore, that it is a sign that the sublime Dharma is declining.

Son of the lineage, consider further this analogy: when autumn has passed, winter comes on, and in the winter season rain falls without cease. Likewise, this Great Vehicle sūtra of the complete passing beyond sorrow will spread extensively for the sake of the bodhisattvas of the southern direction, filling every place with a rain of Dharma. But when the sublime Dharma nears its destruction, it will disappear into the earth in the land of Kashmir without perishing there — some will have faith in it, others will not. Then all the other Great Vehicle sūtras, rich with the taste of ambrosia, will also sink into the earth. Once this sūtra has disappeared, all the other Great Vehicle sūtras will likewise disappear and cease to exist.

However, if bodhisattvas and others who are like the king of elephants among men — beings in whom the full excellence of this sūtra remains undimmed — are present, they will know that the unsurpassed sublime Dharma of the Tathāgata will not long remain absent.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, the venerable one now has a doubt. May the Blessed One please resolve that doubt.

The Blessed One declared: Speak whatever doubt you have, and I will dispel your doubt.

Mañjuśrī said: When one seeks and then sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha, one says the Tathāgata is permanent. But if it is only upon seeing the intrinsic nature of a buddha that one calls it permanent, does that not imply that before it was seen it was not permanent? And if something is impermanent from the very beginning, it would follow that it remains impermanent ever after as well. Why so? Because it is like things of the world — something that did not exist from the beginning, if it comes to exist, will again cease to exist. All conditioned things are impermanent. In that case, buddhas and bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and all the rest would be no different in this regard.

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

What had a beginning does not exist now.

What had no beginning does exist now.

All phenomena of existence in the three times
are not of that kind.

"Son of good family, for this reason, buddhas and bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are both different and not different."

Mañjuśrī then addressed the Blessed One: "Excellent! Excellent! It is just as the noble one has declared. I too understand it thus: that buddhas and bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are indeed both different and not different."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "As the Blessed One has taught, that there is no difference among buddhas, bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas — may the Tathāgata please explain this extensively and teach it for the welfare and happiness of all sentient beings."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen carefully, attend to it well, and hold it in mind; I shall explain it to you in full."

"Son of good family, it is like this. Consider a householder or a householder's son who owns many cows of various breeds and coat colors. He sets them to pasture in a meadow, and then, when the time of the seasonal rains arrives, all the cows are milked and the milk is poured together into a single vessel. Seeing that all this milk, coming from cows of different colors, becomes uniformly white, he is struck with wonder and amazement. He thinks: 'How remarkable that these cows, though of different coat colors, have produced milk of a single uniform color. This milk becoming one in color must arise through the karmic maturation of sentient beings.' "

"Son of good family, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are likewise. Their converging into the single intrinsic nature of a buddha is like that milk. Why so? Because they converge in the undefiled. Ordinary persons say that buddhas, bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are different. Even uninformed śrāvakas and novices may doubt, wondering why the three vehicles should not be different from one another. Yet they will later come to realize for themselves that all three vehicles converge in the intrinsic nature of buddhahood — just as that person comes to know through the power of karmic causes and conditions that the milk has become one in color."

"Son of good family, here is another example: take gold ore. When the impurities are removed and cast away, and it is smelted, pure gold emerges, and its value is beyond measure."

"Son of good family, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are likewise. All converge in achieving the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Why so? Because the afflictions are completely removed. This corresponds to the gold ore being smelted and the impurities cast away."

"Therefore all sentient beings converge in the single intrinsic nature of buddhahood and are not different. Having heard the essential purport that the Tathāgata expressed with this intention in former times, when one fully awakens later, one will know it for oneself — just as that householder came to understand that the milk of the cows had become one in color. Why so? Because immeasurable afflictions without exception have been removed."

"Therefore, that all sentient beings converge in the single intrinsic nature of buddhahood and are not different — this is the essential purport that the Tathāgata formerly expressed with this intention. Just as one who has heard this essential purport will later, at the time of full awakening, come to know it for oneself, like the householder who understood that the milk had converged into one — why so? Because immeasurable afflictions without exception have been removed."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, what distinction can there be between a buddha and a sentient being? To speak thus would become a fault. Moreover, if all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, why did Śāriputra and those like him attain nirvāṇa through a lesser nirvāṇa, the pratyekabuddhas attain nirvāṇa through an intermediate nirvāṇa, and the bodhisattvas attain nirvāṇa through a great nirvāṇa? If these and the others are unified in the single intrinsic nature of buddhahood, why did the Tathāgata not attain complete nirvāṇa through the nirvāṇa of a Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the passing into nirvāṇa attained by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is not that attained by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Therefore, the great complete nirvāṇa is called the spiritual friend. Even if there were no buddha present in the world, it would still be possible for the two vehicles to attain their respective two nirvāṇas."

Kāśyapa asked again: "What is the meaning of what the Blessed One has just said?"

The Blessed One declared: "For immeasurable, incalculable, and innumerable eons, a buddha, a Blessed One, appears in the world on occasion, and distinguishes and teaches the three vehicles. Son of good family, when you asked what distinction there is between bodhisattvas and the two other vehicles — that very meaning, that I had formerly expressed through the intention of the Tathāgata, I have now explained at length from this great complete nirvāṇa, saying that arhats have no spiritual friend. Why so? Because arhats have attained the great complete nirvāṇa. Therefore, because the great complete nirvāṇa ultimately becomes bliss, it is called the great complete nirvāṇa."

Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I have now grasped from the very beginning the meaning of there being distinction and of there being no distinction, as the Blessed One has taught. And why? Because bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and all the rest — it is my wish that they will all arrive, in the time to come, at the great complete nirvāṇa. Just as all rivers flow into the ocean, so all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — I would call them permanent; they are not impermanent. Therefore there is distinction, and yet there is also no distinction."

Kāśyapa again asked: "What is the distinction in terms of defining characteristics?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, śrāvakas are like milk. Pratyekabuddhas are like curds. Bodhisattvas are like butter or clarified butter. The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are like the essence of butter. Therefore in this great complete nirvāṇa, four distinct defining characteristics have been explained."

Kāśyapa again asked: "What is the defining characteristic of all sentient beings?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, take for example milk that has just come from a newborn calf — it is mixed with blood. Likewise, the defining characteristic of childish, common beings mixed with afflictions is similar to that."

Then Kāśyapa again said: "The one who dwells in the city of Kuśāgāra, named Prabhāpāla, of low birth, whom the Blessed One has prophesied — you have

prophesied that he, by merely arousing the awakening mind, will swiftly reach, in this world-realm, unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening, counted among a thousand buddhas. And the venerable Śāriputra —

and Maudgalyāyana and the others will swiftly realize complete and perfect awakening" — you have not given that prophecy. The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, certain śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas, by the power of their aspiration, will abide in the world for a long time, uphold the sacred Dharma for an extended period, and then realize unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening. Those who have made the aspiration to attain it swiftly will be prophesied to attain it swiftly. Son of good family, consider further this example: a merchant takes hold of a priceless precious jewel and comes to the market to sell it. When foolish people who do not know the value of the jewel see it, they mock, disparage, and scorn it. Even when the owner of the jewel says, 'This is a priceless precious jewel,' they scorn it still. Among themselves they say, 'This is not a true precious jewel — it is a mere piece of glass.' Son of good family, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are just like that. If they hear a prophecy that someone will attain awakening swiftly, they become lazy and complacent, and their mocking and disparagement is just like the foolishness of those who do not recognize a genuine precious jewel. In future times, monks will be unable to apply diligent effort to virtuous qualities; driven by poverty and preoccupied with obtaining food and drink, they go forth into renunciation merely to sustain the body, and, with distracted minds, they live by deceit. If the Tathāgata were then to give the prophecy that śrāvakas will attain awakening swiftly, those monks would mock and disparage, saying, 'Though their moral discipline is entirely degenerate, they have obtained the Dharma of a superior person.' Therefore, whoever has aroused the aspiration for swift attainment is given the prophecy of swift attainment, while those who guard and uphold the sacred Dharma are given the prophecy of long duration.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked the Blessed One: "How do bodhisattvas, great beings, attain the irreversible retinue?" The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "When a bodhisattva applies diligent effort to guarding and upholding the sacred Dharma, by that cause and that condition he will attain the irreversible retinue."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked the Blessed One: "By what cause and by what condition do sentient beings find their mouths and lips parched?" The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Whoever does not know how to regard the Three Jewels as enduring — by that cause and that condition their mouths and

lips are perpetually parched. There will be people who cannot distinguish and do not discern the six kinds of flavor: sweet, cold, hot, sour, bitter, and salty, and so forth. All sentient beings, through their foolishness and being under the sway of delusion, do not know the Three Jewels as permanent — and for that reason their mouths and lips are perpetually parched.

Son of good family, consider further: any sentient being who does not know the Tathāgata as truly permanent is to be understood as blind. Any sentient being who knows the Tathāgata as truly permanent — though that person has physical eyes, I declare they are endowed with divine sight. Son of good family, consider further: whoever knows the Tathāgata as truly permanent is one who has long attended to this sūtra with diligence, and is to be understood as endowed with the divine eye. Even one who is endowed with the divine eye, if they do not know the Tathāgata as truly permanent, is called one who has only physical eyes — for such a person knows neither the limbs and joints of their own body, nor can they make others understand them. Therefore they are called one with physical eyes only.

Son of good family, consider further: the Tathāgata is at all times the father and mother of all sentient beings.

Why is this so? When the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma with a single voice to all sentient beings of various kinds — those with two legs, those with four legs, those with many legs, and those with no legs — each and every one of those different kinds understands it individually, and each one thinks to themselves, "The Tathāgata is teaching the Dharma to me alone today." For this reason, he is called one who is like a father and mother.

Son of good family, consider further: a baby, from the moment of birth until the age of sixteen months, strives to speak, yet is not able to be understood or to communicate. Its father and mother, in order to teach it to speak, repeat back whatever the infant says. Now tell me — does this mean that the father and mother of that child are themselves unable to speak and have some deficiency? The answer was: No, Blessed One.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the Tathāgata is just like that. Following the various kinds of sentient beings, he teaches the holy Dharma in various kinds of speech. In order to guide beings to the sacred Dharma, he shows various kinds of deportment as is fitting. When the Tathāgata speaks in a manner suited to those beings, does this in any way indicate incapacity on his part? The answer was: No, Blessed One. It is because the speech of the

Tathāgata is like the roar of a lion — following the various kinds of worldly beings, in various kinds of speech, he teaches the holy Dharma to sentient beings.

This is the fourth chapter, the chapter on buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha), from the Sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa of the Noble Ones.

Then at that moment, from the mouth of the Blessed One there radiated lights of various colors — blue, yellow, red, white, tawny, and purple — illuminating the entire body of Cunda. The moment those lights touched Cunda's body, he and his retinue took up abundant food and went quickly to where the Buddha was, carrying abundant and excellent articles of offering in order to make a final offering to the Tathāgata and the Saṅgha of monks.

At that time, certain gods of great splendor surrounded him on all sides and appeared before him, and they commanded Cunda: "Cunda, wait a moment with your offering."

At that time, the Tathāgata again radiated immeasurable and incalculable lights of various kinds, causing them to shine upon the bodies of the gods. The moment those divine retinues were touched by that light, the gods too opened their minds and were allowed to present their offerings.

At that time, all the gods and humans, each taking up various kinds of offerings, drew near before the Buddha, knelt on one knee, and beseeched the Tathāgata thus: "Blessed One, please be so gracious as to have this Saṅgha of monks accept our offerings."

The monks of the Saṅgha, being aware of the proper time, took up their bowls and remained in their conduct with one-pointed mind.

At that time, Cunda set up many lion-throne seats for the Buddha and the Saṅgha to sit upon, adorned them with banners, victory standards, and parasols, and arrayed them with incense, flowers, and garlands.

At that time, this great trichiliocosm world-system, adorned with these ornaments, became like the world-system of Sukhāvatī in the western direction.

Then Cunda came before the Buddha, overwhelmed by great sorrow and grief at the thought of losing him, and besought the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, out of compassion, please remain for one eon or until the end of an eon."

The Blessed One then declared to Cunda:

"If you wish me to remain long in this world, then quickly offer the articles for this final offering and perfect the perfection of generosity."

At that moment, all the bodhisattvas, the great beings, together with gods, humans, and all the rest, spoke with one voice, saying: "How wonderful! Cunda, because your merit is great and complete, the Tathāgata has accepted your final offering. As for us, lacking such merit, even the offerings we arrayed have come to nothing." So they said.

Then, in order to fulfill their hopes and aspirations, the Blessed One emanated from each pore of his body countless emanation buddhas. Each of those buddhas, in turn, was encircled by an immeasurable retinue of monks, and the Blessed One together with those innumerable retinues of the Saṅgha showed that they too accepted the offerings. The Blessed One Śākyamuni likewise accepted Cunda's offering. At that time, the alms-bowl of rice that Cunda had offered — a measure of eight dreys by the standard of the central land — through the blessing of the Blessed One was sufficient to satisfy every one of those gathered assemblies with food. When Cunda saw this, a great joy arose in him, and all those assembled circles of the retinue were likewise filled with great joy.

Then, through the blessing of the Blessed One, it arose in the minds of each one of those assembled circles that the Tathāgata, having accepted their final offering, would before long pass into nirvāṇa. Thinking thus, a mixture of grief and joy arose in their hearts.

At that time, though the ground of that grove was very small and cramped, through the blessing of the Tathāgata, even in a space no larger than the point of a needle, immeasurable blessed buddhas sat with their retinues, accepted alms-food, and all that food was seen to be inexhaustible.

Then all the gods, humans, asuras, and the rest burst into tears and wept, saying: "The Tathāgata has accepted our final offering, and having accepted it will pass into nirvāṇa. After this, to whom shall we make offerings? Now that our unsurpassable helmsman is gone from us, we are left blind."

Then the Blessed One, to gladden and encourage those assembled circles, spoke in verse:

Do not grieve, you who are here assembled.
Such is the nature of a buddha, and so it is —
even after I have passed into nirvāṇa

I shall, for countless immeasurable eons,
dwell always in the highest bliss,
abide always in supreme happiness.
Listen carefully, all of you:
My passing into nirvāṇa I shall now explain.
Having no perception of food,
I am free from the faults of hunger and thirst.
Today I have set forth an aspiration
of devoted care for you and all the rest,
that every one of these assembled circles here
may attain supreme happiness.
Hear this and take it carefully to heart:
the phenomena of buddhahood are permanent.

When on some day a crow and an owl
make their nest together in a single tree
and those two become as siblings to each other —
on that day I shall pass into nirvāṇa.
Yet the Tathāgata beholds all beings
as Rāhu beholds the moon —
he who has become the chief of every migrating being,
why should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

When on some day a snake and a mongoose
make their home together in a single burrow
and those two become as siblings to each other —
on that day I shall pass into complete nirvāṇa.
Yet the Tathāgata beholds all with a gaze
as Rāhu beholds — surveying everything —
he who has become the chief of all sentient beings —
why should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

If the seven petals of a flower were to take on the fragrance of kāśika cloth,
or if a cintā fruit were to grow from a kālaka tree —
on that day I shall pass into nirvāṇa.
Yet the Tathāgata beholds all beings with a gaze as Rāhu beholds —
why then, having utterly relinquished compassion,
should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

If those who are bound by wrong craving were, at their very core, to awaken to buddhahood

and come to abide in the highest bliss —

then on that day he shall pass into nirvāṇa.

Yet the Tathāgata beholds all beings with a gaze as Rāhu beholds —

why then, having utterly relinquished compassion,

should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

If all ordinary beings were simultaneously to awaken,

every fault and flaw entirely abandoned —

then on that day he shall pass into nirvāṇa.

Yet the Tathāgata beholds all beings with a gaze as Rāhu beholds —

why then, having utterly relinquished compassion,

should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

If the urine of a tiny insect could destroy this great earth,

leaving mountains and every land entirely gone,

or fill the great ocean to overflowing —

then on that day shall he pass into nirvāṇa.

Yet he who beholds all with a mind of compassion, gazing as Rāhu gazes,

he who has become the chief of all migrating beings —

why should he pass into complete nirvāṇa?

Therefore, you and all those with you: cultivate devotion to the sacred Dharma.

Do not be tormented by grief; do not give way to weeping and lamentation.

Whoever practises what is true and genuine — meditate on the Tathāgata as permanent.

Understand likewise that the sacred Dharma itself is unchanging and abides forever.

Furthermore, cultivate the perception that the Three Jewels abide permanently.

To one who guards this with the utmost care, it is as though flowers bloom on a dry tree by the power of a mantra.

That one, with respect to the Three Jewels — let the fourfold retinue hear this well —

having heard it and rejoiced exceedingly, should arouse the mind of awakening.

Whoever takes hold of the Three Jewels as truly and ultimately permanent —

that one is the supreme among the aspirational prayers offered by many

buddhas.

As for any monk, or nun, or male lay practitioner, or female lay practitioner who makes such an aspirational prayer — the supreme aspirational prayer of the Tathāgata — they are not foolish, not deluded: they should be known as worthy of veneration. Through the power of that aspiration, the fruit of virtue ripening, they will become the supreme among the world's finest, like an arhat. Whoever does not understand the Three Jewels to be truly permanent should be known as being of inferior lineage. Whoever understands these three aspects of the Dharma to be truly permanent will, by the condition of the truth of the Dharma, be parted from suffering and become supremely blissful, free from harm, and free from all obstacles.

At that time, the assembly of gods, humans, asuras, and the rest, having heard those very words thus spoken, gave rise to a mind of great joy and delight. Their minds became exceedingly tame and content; their minds became utterly cleansed of all obscurations; their minds became free of high and low. Radiant with splendor and serene, their faces lit with a gentle smile, they understood the Tathāgata to be truly permanent, and thereupon they made offerings of many kinds with divine substances: divine flowers, incense, powder, ointments, and divine music — offering fully with all of these.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, do you see this wondrous and marvelous maṇḍala of assemblies?"

Kāśyapa replied: "I do, Blessed One. I see the Tathāgata — immeasurable, beyond reckoning — receiving the offerings of his many great retinues."

He also saw that the bodies of the many buddhas were exceedingly great, yet the thrones on which they sat were no larger than the tip of a needle — and although surrounded by vast retinues, none pressed or crowded against another.

He also saw those many great retinues giving rise to great aspiration and reciting thirteen verses.

He also saw that each of those maṇḍalas of retinues thought to itself, "The Tathāgata is receiving my offerings alone."

Even if the offerings presented by Cunda were to be divided into the finest particles, and even a single such particle were offered to each buddha, there would still not be enough to go around — yet through the blessing of the Tathāgata, all would become sufficient and complete.

Then the great bodhisattvas, Mañjuśrī the Ever-Youthful and the rest, perceived these wondrous and marvelous things. This too was revealed by the Tathāgata as a skillful means, so that the retinues of śrāvakas, asuras, and the rest might know that the Tathāgata is by nature permanent.

Then the Blessed One said to Cunda: "Do you regard what you have seen as wondrous and marvelous?"

Cunda replied: "It is so, Blessed One. Formerly I saw measureless, innumerable buddhas, each adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor marks of excellence. Now, however, all have assumed the supreme form of great bodhisattvas, while a single buddha sits like a medicinal tree, surrounded and attended by the great bodhisattvas. This too I have seen."

The Blessed One said to Cunda: "The measureless buddhas you saw before were none other than my own manifest emanations, displayed for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings and to bring them joy. Those great bodhisattvas, too, are of inconceivable conduct — they are nothing other than the deeds of immeasurable buddhas. You, Cunda, are yourself endowed with the conduct of a great bodhisattva; established perfectly on the ten grounds, you are complete in the conduct of a bodhisattva."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said to the Blessed One: "It is so. It is exactly so. It is just as the Blessed One has declared. This Cunda is endowed with the conduct of all bodhisattvas, and we rejoice in this."

The Tathāgata taught the great Mahāyāna sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa, in order to shed a great light for the measureless beings of future generations yet to come.

Kāśyapa asked: "Among all the sūtras the Blessed One has taught, has the Blessed One's teaching conveyed a meaning with remainder, or a meaning without remainder?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, what I have taught has both a meaning with remainder and a meaning without remainder."

Then Cunda said to the Blessed One: "As the Blessed One has declared, giving away all one's material possessions in generosity is to be praised and extolled, though it is not to be disparaged — what, then, is the meaning of what the Blessed One has said? What is the distinction between one endowed with moral discipline and one of corrupt moral discipline?"

The Blessed One declared: "With a single exception, I praise and extol all other forms of giving."

Cunda asked: "What is the one exception?"

The Blessed One replied: "It is that which in this sūtra is described as corrupt moral discipline."

Cunda then asked further:

"Blessed One, what is the meaning of this?"

The Blessed One declared: "The term 'one of corrupt moral discipline' is to be applied to one who holds wrong views. All other forms of giving are praised and extolled, and will yield a great fruit."

Cunda asked again: "What is meant by 'one who holds wrong views'?"

The Blessed One declared to Cunda: "Any monk, nun, layman, or laywoman who speaks harmful words and slanders the sacred Dharma, and who — even having committed blameworthy actions — feels no remorse, no shame, and no scruple: such a person is said to have fallen onto the path of wrong views. Likewise, one who knows by their own conscience that they have transgressed one of the four root precepts or committed one of the five acts of immediate consequence, and who — even having committed such grave blameworthy acts — from the very beginning feels no fear, no shame, no scruple, who feels no remorse and makes no confession, who has no love or cherishing for the sacred Dharma, who has no mind settled in Dharma, but who instead disparages and slanders and heaps many faults upon others: such a person too is said to have fallen onto the path of wrong views. Furthermore, one who declares that there is no Buddha, no Dharma, no Saṅgha — that person too is said to have fallen onto the path of wrong views. Apart from these alone who hold wrong views, all other ordinary beings are praised and extolled."

The fourteenth fascicle.

Then Cunda again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of 'corrupt moral discipline'?"

The Blessed One declared: "One who has transgressed the four root precepts, who has committed the five acts of immediate consequence, and who utterly slanders the sacred Dharma — that is what is called corrupt moral discipline."

Cunda then asked: "Does one with corrupt moral discipline in that way have any chance of liberation?"

The Blessed One declared: "Given the appropriate causes and conditions, there is indeed a chance of liberation. If such a one still wears the monastic robe and has not yet entirely abandoned it, and if they are endowed with a mind of shame, scruple, and fear, and are filled with deep remorse — thinking: 'Alas, why did I commit this great blameworthy act? Alas, why did I perform this deed that will bring me suffering?' — and if, having given rise to such a mind of deep remorse, they also generate a mind of protecting the Dharma and of settling in the Dharma, and they make offerings to those who uphold and preserve the Dharma, and they request the recitation and reading of the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, and they make supplications, and they themselves receive, uphold, read, recite, and penetrate them to the depths, and widely teach and expound them to others — such a person shall not be called one of corrupt moral discipline. Why is this? Noble son, it is like this: when the sun rises, the darkness of mist and fog that was invisible becomes entirely dispelled. The appearance of this great sūtra of the complete passing beyond sorrow (nirvāṇa) in the world is just the same — it has the power to dispel all blameworthy deeds committed by sentient beings throughout immeasurable eons. Therefore those who have taken refuge in the sacred Dharma through this sūtra will obtain a great fruit, and those of corrupt moral discipline will be able to attain liberation. This is why it is taught thus. As for one who has slandered the sacred Dharma and yet feels deep remorse and makes confession, and who having taken refuge in the Dharma calls to mind all the non-virtuous deeds they have committed — it is as with a person who has committed the act of killing a human being and in whom a mind of great fear arises, or in whom a mind of utter shame and scruple arises —

thinking that aside from the sacred Dharma there is nothing else, anywhere, that could serve as refuge and ally. When such a person takes refuge in the sacred Dharma in the very manner it has been taught and proclaimed, and one makes a gift to that person, one will obtain immeasurable merit and become a worthy object of veneration for the world. But if someone who has committed the blameworthy acts described here goes for a month, or up to fifteen days, without generating a mind of taking refuge, confessing, or feeling remorse, and one makes a gift to such a person, the result will not be great. It is the same for one who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya): if a mind of remorse has arisen, and one possesses inwardly a mind of shame and scruple, thinking, "Because I have committed non-virtuous deeds I will experience great suffering," and one then turns to the sacred

Dharma as protector and refuge and takes up its upholding — then, even for one who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution, this is no longer as if those acts were done without remedy. If one then makes a gift to such a person, one will obtain immeasurable merit. And if one has committed acts of immediate retribution and yet generates a mind to guard and take refuge in the sacred Dharma, and one makes a gift to that person, the merit that accrues is beyond all telling.

Noble son, listen further: here is another illustration. Reflect very carefully on those who have committed great blameworthy acts — I shall set it out fully and explain it to you. Let them give rise to this thought: "What is called the sacred Dharma is the very essence of the Tathāgata. Therefore it must be guarded, protected, and upheld." If one makes a gift to a person who holds that thought, one will obtain the supreme fruit of merit.

Noble son, consider this example. A pregnant woman near the time of giving birth was in a land struck by famine and unrest, and she fled to another land where there was a shrine to a deity. There she gave birth to her child. Later, hearing the news that the unrest in her own land had quieted and the harvests were excellent, she took her child in her arms and set out to return home. Along the way a great river roared in flood, and she could not cross it with her child in her arms. She thought to herself: "It is better that both my child and I should die together than that I abandon my child and cross alone." And so, thinking only of saving her child from the water, she entered the current, and both mother and child perished in the river. The moment she died, she was reborn as a god in the higher realms, for though that woman was by nature rough and fierce, because she had thought with love for her child she was reborn as a god in the higher realms.

In the same way, even those who have broken the four root precepts and committed the five acts of immediate retribution, if they generate a mind to guard and protect the sacred Dharma — though they have previously performed non-virtuous deeds, through their having upheld the Dharma they become in this world a supreme field of merit without equal. Therefore, one who guards and protects the Dharma is endowed with the supreme and boundless fruit.

Then the venerable one asked again: "Blessed One, if those of wrong craving feel very deep remorse, possess shame, and with reverence make offerings and praises to the Three Jewels — if one makes a gift to such a person, will one

obtain a great fruit?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, do not speak in that way. Noble son, consider this example. A man ate a mango fruit and cast the seed on the ground. He thought: 'There is certainly still sweetness inside this fruit.' He broke open the seed and tasted it —

it was so extremely bitter that he felt regret over the fruit and, suspecting there was nothing left in it at all, broke the seed and planted it in the ground. Wishing for it to grow, he watered it regularly with ghee and milk and other such things and attended to it with great care. Now, what do you think — would it grow?"

The reply came: "No, Blessed One. Even if a rain of the most supreme and unsurpassable nectar were to fall from the sky, it would not grow."

"Noble son, one of wrong craving is just like that. When the roots of virtue have been utterly burned away, what unwholesome action could serve as a basis for their purification? Noble son, if a wholesome mind has arisen, then one should not call that person one of wrong craving. Noble son, not all gifts that are given bear the same fruit upon maturation. Why is this? The ripened fruit of a gift given to śrāvakas and the fruit of a gift given to pratyekabuddhas are different from one another, and a gift given to a Tathāgata alone yields a supreme and unsurpassable fruit. Therefore it is not the case that all acts of giving are equal in their fruit."

The venerable one asked again: "For what reason did the Tathāgata speak this verse in the way he did?"

The Blessed One declared to him: "My speaking of that verse was not without cause and condition. In former times, here in Rājagṛha, a layworshiper of very little faith gave a gift to a naked tīrthika and then asked me about the meaning of giving. It was on account of that cause and that condition that I spoke those verses. Furthermore, I spoke them with the great bodhisattvas in mind, in order to reveal the essential point of what was taught for their sake. As for the meaning of that verse: the word 'all' refers to 'all' in a partial sense only. The great bodhisattvas, as the foremost among human beings, gather together those who guard their ethical discipline and supply whatever they need, while those of corrupt ethical discipline they utterly cast aside, like the corpse of a dead field animal or a wild jackal."

"Furthermore, noble son, I once spoke these verses:

All the rivers that flow
assuredly have their bends and turns.
All that belongs to the forest grove
will certainly become wood — there is no doubt.
All that women speak
is assuredly tinged with deceit.
All those who hold power
will without doubt possess abundant wealth."

Then the great bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, the ever-youthful, rose from his seat, arranged his robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and spoke these verses in reply:

"Not all the rivers that flow
assuredly have bends and turns.
Not all that belongs to the forest grove
is assuredly wood throughout.
Not all that women speak
is assuredly tinged with deceit.
Not all those who hold power
are assuredly possessed of abundant wealth."

"Therefore, Blessed One, the meaning of what you have taught is one that involves something beyond the obvious. Out of your compassion for us, please reveal its cause and condition. Why do we ask? Blessed One, in this great trichiliocosm, in the western continent called Godānīya, there is a river known as the Sāpakā — dark as a line of ink, it flows into the western ocean. The defining characteristics of that river have not been spoken by the Blessed One in any other sūtra, yet here in this most extensive sūtra the Tathāgata has declared something that goes beyond all others. May the Blessed One please cause the bodhisattvas as well to understand these matters."

"Blessed One, consider the analogy of a person who knows raw gold ore but does not know refined gold. The Tathāgata is similar: though he comprehends all phenomena in his mind, what he has taught and spoken still carries a remainder beyond what has been expressed. Whatever the Tathāgata has spoken with that remainder is nevertheless spoken with skillful means and with a deeper intent. Every statement that all forests are definitely trees also carries a remainder, for forests made of gold, silver, lapis lazuli, and other

precious substances of many kinds are also called forests. Every statement that all women are definitely deceitful also carries a remainder, for there are some women who fully guard their ethical conduct, who are endowed with good qualities, and who are possessed of loving-kindness and compassion. Every statement that all those with power are endowed with wealth also carries a remainder, for among those with power, a wheel-turning king who is a Tathāgata, the Dharma-king, does not fall within the class of Māra, the lord of death, and cannot be destroyed by him. Brahmā, Indra (Śakra), and others do indeed possess power, yet they are impermanent. That which is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting is what is truly called 'possessed of power,' and this refers to none other than the complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, you speak with tremendous eloquence. Yet wait a moment and listen steadily. Mañjuśrī, consider a householder tormented by illness, greatly weakened, who encounters a skilled physician. That physician compounds a medicine with the drug aconite, and the patient, being hungry, wishes to eat a great deal. The physician says to him: 'If you want to take the medicine, it could be given in large quantity, but you are weak and frail and cannot digest it, so it must not be given in large quantity. Therefore this aconite medicine may be called nectar, and it may also be called poison — if it is drunk in large quantity and not digested, it is called poison.' Noble son, do not think that what was said by that skilled physician is contradictory, mistaken, or without the power of medicine.

"Noble son, the Tathāgata is likewise. For the sake of taming kings, queens, princes, great ministers, conquering kings, princes, queens, and the arrogant courtiers of the palace, and in order to inspire fear and dread in them so that they might be disciplined, the Tathāgata spoke, like that skilled physician, these verses:

All flowing rivers
certainly contain bends, without fail.
All that belongs to forests
is certainly wood, beyond doubt.
All women who are mentioned
are without exception certain to be sly and guileful.
All those possessed of power
are without doubt possessed of wealth.

"Mañjuśrī, you should understand it thus: in what the Tathāgata has spoken there is no error. This great earth may shift and reverse, yet in what the Tathāgata has spoken there is no error. Therefore everything spoken by the Tathāgata carries a remainder."

Then the Blessed One praised the youthful Mañjuśrī with the words: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, having long ago deeply understood this meaning, out of affection for all and in order to bring all sentient beings to gnosis, you have done well to ask the Tathāgata at length about the meaning of these verses."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī once again presented a verse before the Buddha:

When another from a foreign land has spoken —

One does not turn back merely for the sake of following along —

Do not examine what others have done or left undone.

Rather, examine most carefully your own self —

What virtue and non-virtue you yourself practise.

The Blessed One declared this teaching-medicine in just those words. If it was not rightly taught, then please, Tathāgata, out of loving concern, rightly explain why one who follows along with and does not contradict what another, an outsider, says. For why is this? The Blessed One has taught in many ways that all ninety-five students of the outer schools will go to the lower realms, while the attendants of the śrāvakas will all go to the right path. And yet a person who guards ethical discipline fully, whose conduct is extremely restrained, who guards the sense faculties — such a person is also one who is deeply devoted to the great Dharma and who practises the path of virtue. Why then, Blessed One, did you say in the ninth sūtra that when an outsider slanders another, one should revile and mock him? With what intention did you speak the meaning of those verses?

The Blessed One then declared to Mañjuśrī: Noble son, that verse which I spoke was not spoken for the sake of all sentient beings in general. At that time it was spoken solely for the sake of King Ajātaśatru. A buddha, a Blessed One, does not teach anything arbitrarily, without cause and condition. It is because cause and condition were present that it was spoken in just those words. Noble son, King Ajātaśatru had slain his father and then came to where I was, wishing to be tamed, and he asked me this: "How is it that the Buddha, the Blessed One, is said to be omniscient, and yet is not omniscient? For if he is omniscient, then someone like Devadatta, who throughout countless former lives with malicious intent did harm to the Tathāgata — why did the Tathāgata

permit him to go forth into renunciation?" Having been asked this, noble son, it was because of that cause and that condition, on account of that king, that I spoke the verse thus:

When another from a foreign land has spoken,
One does not turn back merely for the sake of following along.
Do not examine what others have done or left undone.
Rather, examine most carefully your own body —
What virtue and non-virtue you yourself practise.

The Blessed One then declared: Noble son, the great king, having committed the heinous and boundless transgression of killing his father, instead of feeling deep remorse, confessing, and purifying himself completely — why did he enter into seeking out the faults and flaws of others? Noble son, it was for that king's sake, and for that reason, that I spoke those verses. Furthermore, noble son, those verses were also spoken for the sake of those who, though they guard ethical discipline fully and are endowed with proper conduct, fall into seeking out the faults of others. As for any person who, taught and corrected by an outsider, abandons non-virtue completely and also turns others away from non-virtuous action — that person is truly my own genuine attendant.

Then the Blessed One spoke a verse to Mañjuśrī:

There is no one at all who is unafraid of weapons.
All beings cling to life and breath.
Taking one's own body as the measure,
Neither harm nor kill another.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī once again presented a verse before the Blessed One:

Not everyone fears weapons —
Not everyone clings to life.
Taking one's own body as the measure,
Strive to practise virtue.

This statement in which the Tathāgata expressed the meaning of the Dharma in words has not reached the ultimate extent. Why is this? Because an arhat, and —

a wheel-turning king's precious queen, his precious elephant, his precious horse, and his precious minister — there is no place where the sharp weapons of gods or asuras could kill them. A courageous hero, a woman endowed with

water, the king of horses, the king of beasts, and a monk who guards his moral discipline — even when a weapon is visibly present before them, they feel neither fear nor terror. Therefore this verse spoken by the Tathāgata is also incomplete. And the phrase "Taking one's own body as the measure" is likewise incomplete. Why is this? If arhats were to take others as the measure with reference to themselves, they would have the perception of self and the perception of a living soul. But if there were the perception of self and the perception of a living soul, they would be protecting themselves — and even foolish, ignoble persons would come to see the arhats, and all would become practitioners of yoga. If that were the case, it would be a wrong view. And if it were a wrong view, immediately upon death they would be reborn in a hell realm. Furthermore, there is absolutely no occasion for arhats to ever generate a mind wishing to kill any sentient being. And there is no sentient being, however innumerable, capable of killing an arhat.

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, what is called "the perception of self" — the arising of a mind of great compassion toward sentient beings, free of any thought of killing — this is the equanimity of mind that belongs to the arhats. Do not think that the Blessed One has spoken something contradictory without cause or condition. Long ago, here in Rājagṛha, a hunter killed many mountain game and invited me, saying "Come eat the meat." At that time I accepted the invitation, but holding in mind an intense love toward all sentient beings — as the planet Rāhu holds the moon — I spoke these words in verse:

May you live an exceedingly long life
and dwell long in this world.
Holding to the teaching of non-killing,
may you become like the lifespan of a buddha.

And this verse also was spoken:

There is no one at all who is unafraid of weapons.
All beings cling to life and breath.
Taking one's own body as the measure,
Neither harm nor kill another.

Then the Blessed One gave praise to the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying "Excellent! Excellent!" and said: It is excellent that you have asked the Tathāgata such a profoundly deep meaning on behalf of the bodhisattvas, the great beings.

Then Mañjuśrī presented this verse before the Blessed One:

Just as one honours one's mother and father
and follows them with reverence,
so too those who take up such practice
fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment.

Then the Blessed One spoke this verse in reply to Mañjuśrī:

Attachment is called "the mother,"
ignorance is called "the father."
To follow them with reverence
is to fall into the hell of uninterrupted torment.

Then the Blessed One once again spoke in verse to the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī:

All that is governed by another is called suffering.
All that is governed by oneself has power and ease.
All pride and arrogance, backed by force, brings fierce anger.
All that is virtuous and gentle has love and compassion for all.

Then the great bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, again addressed the Blessed One thus: This too that the Tathāgata has spoken has not reached the ultimate extent of meaning. Blessed One, out of your loving care, please teach the causes and conditions for this. Why is this? Consider, for instance, when the sons of a householder are learning from a teacher — are they not under the teacher's authority?

Even if one is under the teacher's authority, the purpose of learning is not accomplished. And if one is not under the teacher's authority, it is likewise not accomplished. And if one is under one's own authority, learning is also not accomplished. Therefore what the Tathāgata has said still has remainder. Blessed One, consider further this example: princes who have learned nothing and know nothing may be under their own authority, yet through their foolishness and ignorance they suffer perpetually. Thus, to say that such a prince is under his own authority yields no accomplished purpose, and to say he is under another's authority likewise yields no accomplished purpose. Therefore the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught still has remainder, and so it is not fitting to say without qualification that all that is governed by another necessarily brings suffering, nor is it fitting to say that all that is governed by oneself necessarily brings ease. And to say that all pride and arrogance necessarily brings fierce anger — this too still has remainder. Blessed One, consider, for instance, women of good family who, through the force of their own pride, go forth into the religious life. Once entered upon

training, they fully guard their moral discipline and keep their conduct extremely restrained, applying themselves diligently with undistracted senses. Therefore it is not fitting to say that all defilements arising from pride necessarily bring fierce anger. Moreover, to say that all that is virtuous and gentle necessarily has loving-kindness and compassion — this too still has remainder. Consider, for instance, a person who has committed a defeat, yet has not discarded the religious robes. Though his outward conduct be extremely restrained, when the Dharma-protectors see him they are averse and expel him. When he passes from this life he falls into a hell state. And if a monk has committed a defeat, those same Dharma-protectors will drive him out and reduce him to the status of a layman. Therefore it is not fitting to say that all who are virtuous and gentle necessarily have loving-kindness.

Then the Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: It is because causes and conditions are present that the Tathāgata has spoken in this way with remainder. Furthermore, Blessed One — it was because causes and conditions are present that the following was said. Here in Rājagṛha there was a woman named Śintuwa Zangmo who, on the road to her parents' home, came to a crossroads and took refuge in the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, and said these words: "All women are without power and without authority. All men are unobstructed in their power." Having understood the intention of that woman, the Tathāgata then spoke these verses for her sake.

Mañjuśrī spoke in verse:

All sentient beings without exception,
each one depends on food and drink.

All those who possess power —
in their minds there is no jealousy.

All who depend on the conditions of food and drink
come to experience the suffering of illness.

All whose conduct is utterly pure
come to experience supreme ease.

Blessed One, does not the one who receives alms and offerings from the noble one — does the Tathāgata not also incur such dependency?

To this the Blessed One replied to Mañjuśrī in verse:

It is not the case that all sentient beings
depend on food and drink.

It is not the case that all those who possess power
are without any mind of jealousy.

It is not the case that all, through the force of food,
are afflicted by illness.

And it is not the case that all whose conduct is pure
experience ease.

Mañjuśrī, if you were to fall ill, then it would likewise follow that I too would fall ill. Why is that? Because arhats, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas —

the Tathāgata in truth eats nothing at all. He displayed the acceptance of offerings from countless ordinary beings solely in order to tame those on the other shore, to bring the perfection of generosity to complete fulfillment for those beings, and to liberate sentient beings from the hells, from the realms of animal birth, and from the world of the Lord of Death.

Now, if anyone were to think that the Tathāgata practised the most severe austerities for six years and that his body thereby became greatly weakened and emaciated, that view is not correct. The buddha, the Blessed One, liberated from conditioned existence, is unlike the lowborn and the ignoble. Why then would his body become frail and thin? The buddha, the Blessed One, through the most earnest application of diligence, would attain a vajra-like body. He is not like those in the world who possess bodies with imperfections, and my attendants likewise — by inconceivable means — are not dependent on food.

As for the verse "all those who possess power are without any mind of jealousy" — that too carries a remainder. For in the world there are certain human beings in whom, throughout a single lifetime, there is no mind of jealousy and yet who also have no power whatsoever.

As for the verse "all illness arises from food" — that too carries a remainder. For some people, illness arises from a sudden affliction that was not caused by food at all — such as being pierced by a thorn, or being struck by a weapon, and so forth.

As for the verse "all whose conduct is pure experience ease" — that too carries a remainder. For in the world there are tīrthikas who live in complete brahmacharya and yet experience much suffering.

Therefore, everything the Tathāgata has spoken also carries a remainder. It is not the case that the Tathāgata spoke these verses without cause and condition; he spoke them as having a cause and having a condition. In former

times, in the land of Hudaya, a brahmin named Yakṣa came to where I was staying. Wishing to uphold the fourfold precepts of the eightfold observance, I at that time spoke those verses to him.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One thus: Blessed One, what is meant by "that which is without remainder," and what is meant by "all phenomena"?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, the expression "all" refers to everything apart from the phenomena of the side of awakening and from enthusiasm for virtuous phenomena — and that too may be called "without remainder." All other phenomena may be called "with remainder" and may also be called "without remainder," so that sons of good family who are devoted to the Dharma may understand the meaning of "with remainder" and "without remainder."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa was filled with great joy and delight, and he again addressed the Blessed One thus: How wonderful! Blessed One, you look upon all sentient beings with the same equanimity as a father looks upon his son Rāhu.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Excellent, excellent! It is well that you have understood this exceedingly profound meaning.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then again addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, I pray that you set forth whatever virtues and merits are obtained from this Great Vehicle sūtra of the passage beyond sorrow.

The Blessed One replied to Kāśyapa: Son of good family, the mass of merit obtained merely from hearing the name of this sūtra is something that no śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha can express — only the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, can do so. And why is that? Because it is the domain of the buddhas, being beyond conceptual measure.

As for one who holds it, upholds it, reads it, or recites it —

— or who studies it intently, or who copies it in a manuscript, or who commissions its copying — needless is it even to speak of these, for at that very moment all those dwelling in the world, gods (devas), humans, asuras, and all the rest, will with one voice offer this verse before the buddhas:

The buddhas are inconceivable,
and likewise the Dharma and the Saṅgha.

Therefore we beseech you:

please remain a little while longer.

Venerable Great Kāśyapa,
and likewise Ānanda and the rest —
both these central figures of the retinue assembly —
we pray you too to remain for a time.

The lord of the middle land, Aṅga,
the great king Ajātaśatru,
who holds deep devotion to the Buddha —
he too is not yet present here.

Therefore, Tathāgata, out of loving care,
please remain a little while longer.
Among this vast assembly of the retinue,
we pray you to dispel our doubts.

Then the Tathāgata spoke these verses to the great assembly:

My eldest son in the Dharma,
known as Great Kāśyapa,
and Ānanda, supreme in diligent effort —
they shall resolve the doubts of all.

Listen well, all of you.
From Ānanda's extensive learning
a thorough understanding will arise
of what is permanent and what is impermanent.
Therefore, do not be unhappy or distressed.

Then all those many circles of the retinue made offerings of various kinds to the Blessed One, and each of them gave rise to the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Immeasurable and boundless bodhisattvas, as many as the sands of the Ganges, became established on the first ground.

At that time the Blessed One gave a prophecy to Mañjuśrī the youthful, to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, and to Cunda, and spoke these words: Sons of good family, attend to my words with great diligence and be heedful. I am now afflicted with pain throughout my back, and I intend to lie down as a small child might lie down when ill. You, Mañjuśrī and the others, teach the Dharma of the Great Vehicle in full to the fourfold assembly. These very teachings I

now entrust entirely to you. Likewise, Kāśyapa and Ānanda, I entrust these true teachings to you as well.

With those words, the Tathāgata, in order to tame ordinary beings, lowered his right side as one who is ill and lay down to rest.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, the Tathāgata is entirely free from all the flaws of suffering through illness, and he is without fear. It is all sentient beings, Blessed One, who are caused to fall ill by four poisonous thorns: attachment, aversion, delusion, and pride. When these causes of illness are present, many sicknesses arise — heat from desire, chest pain, shortness of breath, nausea, numbness throughout the body, heart disturbance and forgetfulness, fever and confusion, skin disease, burning and aching eyes and ears, pain in the back, abdominal swelling, madness, emaciation and wasting, torment by the hungry ghosts, and so forth — the many diseases of body and mind. Since you, the Blessed One, are without any of these, why then, Tathāgata, do you regard your own life span and say, "I am afflicted with back pain — Mañjuśrī, teach the Dharma to the great assembly"?

Those who do not fall ill through causes and conditions of either kind are those who bear loving-kindness and compassion toward all sentient beings, and who give medicine to the sick and offer it freely to the poor.

The Tathāgata, for countless eons in the past, applied himself with great diligence to the path of awakening, and constantly through pleasant speech worked for the well-being of sentient beings so that they would not suffer — and he freely gave all manner of medicines to the sick. Why then, it is asked, has he fallen ill like this today?

The Blessed One replied: In the world, sick people sometimes sit up and sometimes lie down; sometimes, being uncomfortable, they ask for food and drink; sometimes they give instructions to their attendants about their teeth-cleaning and their tasks, saying, "This is how it should be done." If the Tathāgata were to remain completely silent and simply lie resting, why would he not be teaching the śrāvakas, his close disciples, about the perfection of moral discipline, about meditative concentration, liberation, meditative absorption, and the practice of right effort? Why would he not be teaching these profoundly deep sūtras of the Great Vehicle? And why would the Tathāgata, through his boundless skillful means, not be showing the great Kāśyapa — who among human beings is like a king of elephants — and the great beings the non-regression from unsurpassed, perfect, complete

awakening? Why would he not be teaching that those monks who are unruly should be disciplined with penalties for grasping at all things without investigation? Blessed One, since you are in truth not ill at all, why do you remain silent and lie with your right side inclined?

When bodhisattvas give medicine as a condition for the relief of the sick, they dedicate every root of virtue, sharing it equally with all sentient beings and dedicating it to the wisdom of omniscience, thereby fully clearing away the afflictive obscurations, the karmic obscurations, and the ripening obscurations of all sentient beings.

What is called the afflictive obscuration (kleśāvaraṇa) is this: the affliction of being bound up by attachment, aversion, delusion, and the enwrapping of wrathfulness; jealousy; miserliness; deception; pretense; shamelessness; lack of conscience; pride; exaggerated pride; pride surpassing pride; the conceit of "I am"; perverse pride; presumptuous pride; pride of inferiority; heedlessness; arrogance; resentment; quarrelsomeness; wrong livelihood; crafty pretense through guile and deceit; seeking gain through gain; seeking through what is contrary to Dharma; seeking in excess; disrespect; failure to act according to instruction; reliance on unwholesome friends; attachment to gains without weariness; being so tightly bound by bondage that it is difficult to be freed; coveting base desires; clinging with base attachment; the view of the transitory collection (the notion of a self in the aggregates); the view of existence (eternalism); the view of non-existence (nihilism); distraction and agitation; elation; sleep; laziness; displeasure; attachment to food and drink; dullness of mind; focusing the mind on other things; attending to unwholesome things; conduct of body and speech that is corrupt; delight in much talking; dullness of the faculties; lying in one's every utterance; thoughts of desire; thoughts of aversion; and being entirely covered over by thoughts of harm — this is called the afflictive obscuration. Then there is the karmic obscuration of the blameworthy deeds of the five acts of immediate retribution (pārājika). And birth in hells as a sentient being, birth as an animal, birth as a hungry ghost, disparagement of the holy Dharma, and birth among those who hold wrong views — these are called the ripening obscuration. These three kinds of obscuration are called the great illness. Now, bodhisattvas who, throughout immeasurable eons, conduct the conduct of awakening, give the gift of healing medicine to all who are sick and make this aspiration:

May all sentient beings be utterly freed from illness and attain the vajra body of the Tathāgata. May I become the supreme king of medicine for all

boundless sentient beings and dispel every malady. May all sentient beings obtain the medicine agada, and through the power of that medicine may every poison be dispelled. Moreover, may all sentient beings be irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and may they swiftly find the unsurpassed medicine of buddhahood and have every thorn of affliction removed. Moreover, may all sentient beings, through the arousing of the most vigorous diligence, possess the mind of the Tathāgata — vajra-like — become the supreme medicine, heal every illness, and be free from any perception of quarrel and conflict. Moreover, may sentient beings become a great medicinal tree and dispel every malady. Moreover, may all sentient beings have the poisonous thorns extracted and attain the unsurpassed rays of light of the Tathāgata. And moreover, may all sentient beings enter the supremely profound Dharma treasury of the great medicine of the Tathāgata's wisdom.

Such is the aspiration they make.

O Blessed One, the bodhisattva thus makes that aspiration for a hundred thousand immeasurable, incalculable, innumerable eons, striving to free all sentient beings from illness. Why, then, does the Tathāgata declare that he is ill?

The Blessed One replied: Furthermore, O Blessed One, there are certain sick persons in the world who cannot sit up, stand, or walk, who cannot even eat or drink. They cannot teach or instruct their children, and they cannot manage the affairs of their livelihood. At that time their father and mother, wife, children, retinue, relatives, and friends all come to regard them as certain to die.

O Blessed One, likewise the Tathāgata is similar to such a person. He lies down on his right side and remains completely silent, so that the foolish people here in Jambudvīpa come to think: "The Tathāgata, the perfectly complete buddha, has surely passed into nirvāṇa" — and they generate the perception that cessation is exhausted. Yet the Tathāgata himself has not ultimately passed into nirvāṇa at all. Why is this? Because the Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting. It would be improper to say "I have lain down for such-and-such a cause and condition."

O Blessed One, furthermore there are sick persons in the world who are utterly emaciated and wasted, lying flat on their backs or on their sides, unable to rise. At that time even their attendants develop an aversion toward them and come to regard them as certain, without doubt, to die. The Tathāgata is

similarly regarded with aversion by the ninety-five kinds of tīrthikas, who perceive him as passing into nirvāṇa. These tīrthikas say: "We and others are made permanent by such dharmas as the self, the lord, time, atoms, and so forth — we are without change or shift. But the ascetic Gautama has been seized by impermanence and has come to be subject to change and shifting." Therefore, O Blessed One, it would be improper for him to lie down in silence.

O Blessed One, furthermore there are sick persons in the world in whom the four great elements (mahābhūtas) have become impaired and unequal, and they have grown extremely wasted and emaciated. Because of this they cannot rise, sit, or stand at will, and they must simply lie down. The Tathāgata, however, is not one in whom the four great elements are impaired or unequal; he is possessed of the full power of his body and is not weakened. O Blessed One, the strength of ten small bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single great bull elephant.

The strength of ten great blue bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single great blue bull elephant of the highest rank. The strength of ten of those highest-ranking great blue bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single tame bull elephant. The strength of ten tame bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single wild bull elephant. The strength of ten wild bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single two-tusked bull elephant. The strength of ten two-tusked bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single four-tusked bull elephant. The strength of ten four-tusked bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single white bull elephant of the Snow Mountains. The strength of ten white bull elephants of the Snow Mountains does not equal the strength of a single fragrant-wood bull elephant. The strength of ten fragrant-wood bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single blue bull elephant. The strength of ten blue bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single yellow bull elephant. The strength of ten yellow bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single red bull elephant. The strength of ten red bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single white bull elephant. The strength of ten white bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single bull elephant called Mountain. The strength of ten bull elephants called Mountain does not equal the strength of a single utpala bull elephant. The strength of ten utpala bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single kumuda bull elephant. The strength of ten kumuda bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single puṇḍarīka bull elephant. The strength of ten puṇḍarīka bull elephants does not equal the strength of a single human

champion. The strength of ten human champions does not equal the strength of a single Pārgana warrior. The strength of ten Pārgana warriors does not equal the strength of a single mighty eight-armed being. The strength of ten such mighty beings does not equal the strength of a single joint in the body of the bodhisattva on the tenth ground.

In all ordinary beings, the bones and joints do not touch and connect with one another. In a champion of great strength, the bones and joints do touch one another. In a Pārgana warrior, the bones and joints are connected to one another. In a mighty being, the bones and joints are connected in a continuous chain, one to the next. In a bodhisattva, the bones and joints are knotted together like a coiled dragon, and therefore that one's strength is supremely great.

When the world first arose and was established, resting firm at the diamond-boundary, there appeared the vajra throne at the heart of the seat of awakening, the awakening maṇḍala at Vajrāsana, and the bodhisattva sat upon that seat. At that very moment the ten powers were attained.

The Tathāgata is not like a small child. A small child is foolish, without understanding, unable even to speak properly, and so can lie down sprawling however it wishes without anyone taking offense. The Tathāgata, however, is possessed of great primordial wisdom, illuminating all with his radiance. Among humans he is like a nāga: endowed with great splendor, having fully accomplished great miraculous power, he is the unsurpassed great sage who has entirely severed the web of doubt, who has drawn out the thorn of desire, whose conduct is supremely beautiful, who is master of all comportment, and who is utterly without fear. Why then should he lie down on his right side, causing all the gods and humans of the world to be displeased and tormented with suffering?

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the following verses before the Blessed One:

O Gautama of great qualities,
please rise and teach the true Dharma.
You are not like a small child
nor like a sick person lying down.
Gods and humans — steer the Teacher's course!
This one who lies slumbering beneath the lord of trees:
upon seeing this, what foolish, ill-bred child

would say he will surely pass into nirvāṇa? One who does not understand that the vast sūtras were taught with the intention of conveying the profound domain of the buddhas' activity is like a blind person who cannot see the path. Great bodhisattvas such as the youthful Mañjuśrī, who realize the profound meaning, are like those who are accustomed to wide open spaces. The Blessed One, who has gone beyond in the three times, has become the foremost embodiment of great compassion. Where now is that great compassion? If you possess no compassion, it would not be fitting to call you a buddha. If you have passed into nirvāṇa, it would not be fitting to call you permanent. O unsurpassed Blessed One, grant us our request: for the happiness of all beings, please tame the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas).

Then the Blessed One, whose mind was thoroughly familiar with great compassion and who knew the individual thoughts of each sentient being, arose from his resting in order to accomplish their ultimate benefit and happiness. He sat upright in the cross-legged posture. At that moment his body color shone brilliantly and radiantly, luminous as refined gold. His face was supremely beautiful, like the full moon. His body, utterly clear and pure, without the slightest stain or turbidity, emitted great rays of light that filled the entire expanse of space. With light far surpassing a hundred thousand suns, he illuminated all sentient beings in the buddha-realms in the east, south, west, north, the four intermediate directions, above, and below, bestowing upon them the radiance of great primordial wisdom, and completely dispelling the darkness of ignorance. Moreover, he established hundreds of thousands of ten millions of sentient beings in the irreversible awakening mind.

At that moment, the Blessed One, undaunted like the king of lions, his body fully adorned with the thirty-two major marks of a great being and the eighty minor marks of excellence, emanated from each pore of his body a single lotus. Each of those lotuses had a thousand petals. The petals themselves were of gold, the stalks of beryl, the anthers of vajra, and the base of crystal, and each lotus was as wide as a chariot wheel. From each of those lotuses there arose lights of many colors: blue, yellow, red, white, crimson, and the color of crystal. These lights, one by one, reached the Avīci great hell, the hell of Perception, the hell of Black Lines, the hell of Assembly, the great hell of Wailing, the great hell of Great Wailing, the hell of Burning, and the hell of Intense Burning. The sentient beings born in these eight hells were being perpetually tormented by manifold sufferings — burning, boiling, scorching smoke, and being beaten with hammers, and the like — but the moment those

lights touched them, all those sufferings were utterly and completely purified without remainder, and they came to experience profound bliss and a most refreshing coolness.

From those rays of light there rang out this sound, proclaiming the essence of what the Tathāgata had taught with intention: "O sentient beings, each and every one of you possesses the nature of a buddha!" Upon hearing those words, those sentient beings immediately passed from that life and were reborn as gods in the higher realms or as humans.

As for the eight cold hells, these are as follows:

The hell of Apāpa, the hell of Atata, the hell of Alala, the hell of Aṭaṭa, the hell of Utpala, the hell of Paduma, the hell of Kumuda, and the hell of Puṇḍarīka. The sentient beings born in these places experience constant and tremendous suffering: their bodies are split apart, shattered, and cut into pieces. Yet the moment those rays of light touched them, all that suffering was utterly and completely purified without remainder. They were warmed and soothed, and from those rays of light there rang out this sound, proclaiming the essence of what the Tathāgata had taught with intention: "O sentient beings, each and every one of you possesses the nature of a buddha!" Upon hearing those words, those sentient beings immediately passed from that life and were reborn as gods in the higher realms or as humans.

At that very time, all the hells of the sentient beings throughout this Jambudvīpa and throughout all the other world-systems became utterly empty, and there was no more experience of suffering — with the sole exception of those who had reviled the vast sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

As for those beings born in the realm of hungry ghosts (pretas), tormented by hunger and thirst, their bodies wrapped and ensnared by their own tangled hair, who for hundreds and thousands of years had not even heard the word "water" — the moment those rays of light touched them, they were freed from the torment of hunger and thirst. And from those rays of light there rang out this sound, proclaiming the essence of what the Tathāgata had taught with intention: "O sentient beings, each and every one of you possesses the nature of a buddha!" Upon hearing those words, those sentient beings passed from that life and were immediately reborn as gods in the higher realms or as humans, and the realm of hungry ghosts too became utterly empty — with the sole exception of those who had reviled the vast sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

As for the sentient beings born in the animal realm, preying upon one another, devouring and harming each other — the moment those rays of light touched them, their minds of evil were pacified. And from those rays of light there rang out this sound, proclaiming the essence of what the Tathāgata had taught: "O sentient beings, each and every one of you possesses the nature of a buddha!" Upon hearing those words, those sentient beings passed from that life and were immediately reborn as gods or as humans.

The Noble Great Sūtra of the Utter Passing into Nirvāṇa, the Fifteenth Section.

At that very time, the animal realm too became utterly empty — with the sole exception of those who had reviled the sacred Dharma.

Upon every single lotus flower there sat a buddha, each surrounded by halos of light extending a fathom in every direction, blazing brilliantly like refined gold, of incomparable beauty and surpassing loveliness, their bodies magnificently adorned with the thirty-two major marks of a great being and the eighty minor excellent features. Some of those buddhas sat; some stood; some reclined; some remained at rest; some roared like thunder; some let fall rain; some sent out flashes of lightning; some caused wind to blow; some blazed with their bodies like masses of flame. Some manifested mountains of the seven precious substances, and lotus ponds, and pools, and springs, and rivers, and forests. Some manifested lands, villages, towns, and cities made of the seven precious substances. Some manifested oxen, horses, lions, tigers, wolves, peacocks, garuḍas, and the like. Some manifested a vision of the world as seen by beings dwelling in Jambudvīpa, filled with nothing but hells, animals, and hungry ghosts. Some manifested the six successive levels of abode within the desire realm.

Some manifested to the Blessed One the many faults of the aggregates, the elements, and the sense bases. Some taught the Dharma of the Four Noble Truths. Some manifested dependent origination. Some manifested how all karma and mental afflictions arise from causes and conditions. Some manifested self and no-self. Some manifested the two qualities of suffering and happiness. Some manifested permanence and impermanence. Some manifested purity and impurity. Some Blessed Ones manifested the six perfections to the bodhisattvas. Some manifested the qualities of bodhisattvas. Some manifested the qualities of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Some manifested the qualities of the śrāvakas. Some set forth the single vehicle and taught it. Some manifested the full awakening of the three

vehicles. Some Blessed Ones manifested water flowing from the left side of their bodies and fire blazing from the right. Some manifested birth, the going forth into renunciation, the entering upon the essence of awakening, the turning of the wheel of Dharma at the foot of the awakening tree, and the passing into complete nirvāṇa. Some Blessed Ones roared with the lion's roar, and manifested members of their assemblies attaining the first, second, third, and fourth fruits. Some also manifested the immeasurable causes and conditions that lead out from saṃsāra.

At that time, in this Jambudvīpa, all sentient beings who were touched by that light were transformed: the blind came to see, the deaf came to hear, the mute came to speak, the lame became able to walk, the impoverished came to possess wealth and enjoyment, the miserly became capable of generosity, those filled with aversion came to possess a mind of loving-kindness, and those without faith came to have faith. In this way, throughout all the world-systems, there was not even a single sentient being engaged in non-virtuous conduct — with the sole exception of those possessed of wrong craving.

At that time all the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, great serpents, rākṣasas, kumbhāṇḍas, humans, and non-humans, with one voice spoke these words: "Most excellent! Most excellent! The peerless Blessed One acts for the benefit and happiness of all — most excellent!" Having thus spoken, they rejoiced and were filled with delight, and some sang songs, some danced, some stirred their limbs, and scattered before the buddha and the Saṅgha manifold varieties of flowers — flowers of divine substance: utpala flowers of divine substance, kumuda flowers of divine substance, lotus flowers, puṇḍarīka flowers, māṇḍārava flowers of divine substance, great māṇḍārava flowers, mañjūṣaka flowers, great mañjūṣaka flowers, sandalwood and great sandalwood, lochanī and great lochanī, fragrant flowers and great fragrant flowers, delightful flowers and greatly delightful flowers, joy-inspiring flowers and greatly joy-inspiring flowers, beautiful flowers and supremely beautiful flowers. They also scattered in abundance many divine incenses — divine liquid incense, aloeswood, sandalwood, saffron, compounded incense, ocean-shore heaped incense, and others. They offered furthermore divine banners of precious jewels, pennants, and parasols; and also divine musical instruments — flutes, lutes with many strings, lutes with nine strings,

— and drums and other instruments — they made offerings in abundance, and then, in the presence of the buddha, they spoke these verses:

We bow down to you with earnest, joyful effort,
to the supreme among bipeds, perfectly and completely awakened without superior,
whom even the retinue of gods and humans cannot fathom.
You, Gautama, bull among the herd, have realized it utterly.

In ages past, for our sake, O Blessed One,
you performed austerities for immeasurable eons.
For what reason, having wholeheartedly committed yourself,
do you now intend to pass beyond sorrow in complete nirvāṇa?

The innermost secret of the Tathāgata —
all beings throughout every realm know it not.
Because of this, it is supremely difficult to arise.
They revolve throughout saṃsāra and fall into the lower realms.

Even the arhats proclaimed by the Blessed One —
all of them too enter into nirvāṇa.
So who among childish, base people will come to understand
the profound domain in which buddhas move?

Yet teach the Dharma, rich and sweet, to all beings,
for the sake of clearing away the afflictions of all beings.
Whoever tastes these nectars
shall never again take on birth, aging, sickness, or death.

The Blessed One has thoroughly healed
countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings,
those utterly tormented and afflicted by illness —
every last one, leaving none behind.

Because the Blessed One long ago abandoned sickness,
you have become the seventh among the final buddhas.
Here today, having rained down the Dharma everywhere,
moisten in us the seeds of virtue.

Thus the retinue of gods, humans, and all the rest
spoke these words and fell silent.

When these verses were offered, all the buddhas dwelling upon their lotus thrones, from Jambudvīpa to the realm of purity, heard them all.

Then the Blessed One praised the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, saying: "Excellent! Excellent!" And he continued: "Son of good family, because you possess such profoundly deep primordial wisdom, no māra and no tīrthika is able to destroy you. Son of good family, dwelling in such perfect ease as you do, you cannot be shaken by the winds of any wrong view. Son of good family, the analytical insight and confidence you have attained is such that, through having made offerings to immeasurable past blessed buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges, you came to ask these very questions of Tathāgatas, arhats, fully and completely awakened buddhas. Son of good family, throughout immeasurable, boundless, incalculable eons, over tens of millions of hundreds of thousands of eons, I was so weary from being separated from illness in its very substance that I utterly abandoned lying down in sleep.

"Kāśyapa, in a past era beyond immeasurable and incalculable eons, at that time there was a fully and completely awakened buddha, an arhat, a Tathāgata by the name Unsurpassed Victor — endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, tamer and guide of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a blessed buddha — who appeared in the world and, for the śrāvakas, expounded at length this sūtra collection of the Great Vehicle, the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, opening it up, teaching it, and making its meaning understood.

"At that time I too had become a śrāvaka of that buddha. I took up this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, reading it, reciting it, penetrating its meaning, copying it into a volume, widely opening and teaching it to others, and engaging in all such activities. That same root of virtue I dedicated to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening.

"Son of good family, from that time until now, I have never experienced falling into the lower realms through the karma of sinful afflictions."

I have never taken on a body born of wrong craving through denigrating the sacred Dharma, nor a body that is stunted, lacking faculties, or hermaphrodite. I have never performed any of the actions without interval: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, destroying a stūpa, creating a schism in the Saṅgha, drawing blood from the body of a buddha with malicious intent, or performing any of the four actions entailing a root downfall. From that time until now, my body and mind have been thoroughly at ease and have never been tormented by suffering. Kāśyapa, truly I am entirely free of all illness. And why is that? Because the Blessed One, the buddha, long ago abandoned

all illness completely.

Kāśyapa, ordinary beings, because they do not understand the intended meaning of what was taught in drawing upon the extensively expanded Great Vehicle, think: "The Tathāgata truly has illness." Kāśyapa, although it is said that "the Tathāgata is a lion among human beings," the Tathāgata is not in truth a lion. You should understand that when such words were spoken, they were spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention. Kāśyapa, although it is also said that "the Tathāgata is a great nāga among human beings," I have in truth abandoned all such actions for immeasurable eons.

Kāśyapa, some say that "the Tathāgata is a human being" and others say "the Tathāgata is a god." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is neither human nor god, neither yakṣa nor gandharva, neither asura nor garuḍa, neither kinnara nor great serpent. He is not a self, not a life-force, not a living soul, not a procreative power, not a lord of procreation. He is not something made, nor something unmade. He is not a sentient being, nor a non-sentient being. He is not the Blessed One, not a śrāvaka, not one who speaks, not one who does not speak. You should understand that all such statements were made by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata is like the ocean" and "the Tathāgata is like Mount Meru." Yet in truth the Tathāgata does not taste of salt, nor is he like a mass of rock. You should understand that such words too were spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata is like the puṇḍarīka." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is not a puṇḍarīka. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata is like a father and mother." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is not a father and mother. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata is a great caravan leader." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is not literally a great caravan leader. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata is like a merchant." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is not literally a merchant. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata has conquered Māra." Yet in truth the Tathāgata harbors no ill will toward anyone; it was said in that way for the sake of taming those who needed taming. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, it is also said that "the Tathāgata heals malignant tumors." Yet in truth the Tathāgata is not literally a physician who heals tumors. You should understand that this too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, as I have already taught above —

Any son or daughter of good family who has thoroughly purified the actions of body, speech, and mind — even though they may have friends and companions at the final hour of death, if their body is burned in fire, or cast into water or into a charnel ground, and eaten by foxes, dogs, wolves, and the like, nevertheless their consciousness will take birth in the higher realms. Thus their mind has neither gone nor come, nor is there any place to which it has departed. It is simply a continuum of successive moments that are similar to one another, before and after; there is no separation. This is what was said, and you should understand that it too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention.

Kāśyapa, in the same way, when it is said "I am now ill" — that too was spoken by the Tathāgata with a specific intention. Therefore, since one who holds a view of a real self is afflicted with self-conceit, I directed Mañjuśrī to teach the Dharma to the four assemblies.

Kāśyapa, in truth the Tathāgata, the fully and perfectly awakened buddha, does not fall ill. He does not lie down on his right side, and he does not pass away into nirvāṇa at the end. Kāśyapa, this great parinirvāṇa is a profoundly deep meditative absorption of the buddhas; it does not lie within the sphere of activity of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Kāśyapa, you asked me earlier: "Why does the Tathāgata sleep and not rise? Why does he not take food? Why does he not give instructions to the assembly, or display the activities of livelihood?" Kāśyapa, it is like this: in space itself there is no sitting and no standing, no desire for food or drink, no giving of instructions to the assembly, no display of the activities of livelihood. There is no coming, no going, no birth, no cessation, no aging, no youth, no arising, no passing away, no speaking, no walking, no liberation, no bondage. There is no utterance of "self," no utterance of "other," no liberation of self, no liberation of other, no wellness, no illness.

Son of good family, the Blessed One, the buddha, is likewise: being like space, how could there be suffering through sickness?

Kāśyapa, in the world there are three kinds of illness in persons that are exceedingly difficult to cure. What are they? Disparagement of the Great Vehicle, commission of the five heinous crimes (anantarya), and holding perverted craving. These three kinds of illness are exceedingly difficult to cure in the world; śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas alike are unable to cure them.

Son of good family, consider, by way of example, an illness that is certainly fatal and difficult to heal: whether or not there is a nurse and wish-fulfilling medicine, the illness is such that it definitely cannot be cured, and the person will assuredly die.

Son of good family, those three kinds of persons are similar to that. Even if a śrāvaka, a pratyekabuddha, or a bodhisattva teaches the Dharma or does not teach it, those persons will not generate the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Without having heard the Dharma, those who would generate the awakening mind cannot be led to generate it toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, consider, by way of example, one whose illness can be healed: if they have a nurse and wish-fulfilling medicine, they will recover. If they lack all three, they will not recover. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are similar to that: if they hear the Dharma from a buddha or bodhisattva, they will immediately generate the awakening mind toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; without having heard the Dharma they will not generate the awakening mind.

Kāśyapa, consider further the example of a patient who, even though attended by a nurse and having wish-fulfilling medicine —

— does recover nonetheless. Likewise, there is a certain type of person who is similar to that: whether they have met a śrāvaka or not, whether they have met a pratyekabuddha or not, whether they have met a bodhisattva or not, whether they have met a Tathāgata or not, whether they have heard the Dharma or not — such a person will still attain manifest, unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Here is an example: if any person — for their own sake or for another's sake, out of fear, or for gain and fame, or out of deceitfulness, or with intent to

deceive others — were to write out this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's Great Nirvāṇa, or have it copied, or carry it, or hold it, or read it, or recite it, or venerate it with reverence, or teach and expound it to others — Kāśyapa, these five types of person engage with this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's Great Nirvāṇa as though it were something defective. The Tathāgata does not do so. What are the five? They are as follows.

The first is the person who has cut off the three fetters of affliction, attained the fruit of stream-entry, and will never again be born in the hell realm, the animal realm, or the realm of hungry ghosts, but will turn back after at most seven lives among gods and humans, and having cut off all suffering will enter nirvāṇa. Kāśyapa, this is called the first person who engages faultily. After eighty thousand future aeons have passed, they will attain manifest, unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, the second is the person who has cut off those same final three fetters and has further attenuated attachment, aversion, and delusion, attaining the fruit of once-return. They return once, and having completely cut off suffering they enter nirvāṇa. Kāśyapa, this is called the second person who engages faultily. After sixty thousand aeons have passed, they too will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, the third person has cut off the final five fetters and, attaining the fruit of non-return, does not return, and having cut off all suffering enters nirvāṇa. This is called the third person who engages faultily. After forty thousand aeons have passed, they will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, the fourth person has completely cut off attachment, aversion, and delusion, attaining the fruit of arhatship, and enters nirvāṇa with no afflictions remaining whatsoever. This person, however, is not one who practices in solitude like a rhinoceros horn. This is called the fourth person who engages faultily. After twenty thousand aeons have passed, they will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, the fifth person has also completely cut off attachment, aversion, and delusion, attaining the fruit of a pratyekabuddha, and enters nirvāṇa with no afflictions remaining whatsoever. This one practices in solitude, like a rhinoceros horn. This is called the fifth person who engages faultily. After ten thousand aeons have passed, they will attain manifest, unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Kāśyapa, these are called the five persons who engage faultily. The Tathāgata does not do so.

From the noble sūtra, the Great Nirvāṇa.

This concludes the fifth chapter, called "Questioned by the Great Assembly."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Sons of good family, great bodhisattvas should take to heart five modes of conduct found in this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle. What are the five? Noble conduct, holy conduct, divine conduct, childish conduct, and faulty conduct. Sons of good family, great bodhisattvas should be extremely diligent in regard to these five modes of conduct. There is yet one further mode of conduct: the conduct of the Tathāgata. That too is this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle.

Kāśyapa, how does a great bodhisattva engage in noble conduct? If a great bodhisattva hears this sūtra of nirvāṇa from a śrāvaka or from a Tathāgata and generates faith, having generated faith they should reflect thus: The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have a path without equal, and there is a great and true Dharma by which the great assembly practices correctly. Furthermore, there exists this vast sūtra of the Great Vehicle. I too should have faith and devotion toward it. In order to seek the sūtra of the Great Vehicle, I should give away entirely my beloved wife and children, my retinue, my dwelling place, gold, silver, and jewels, fine ornaments, flowers, incense, music, male servants and female servants, workers, boys and girls, oxen, horses, chariots, cattle, sheep, birds, dogs, pigs, and the like. And they should further think: A household life lived in utter squalor is like a prison, and all mental afflictions arise from within it. The going forth is exceedingly open, like the sky, and all virtuous qualities arise and grow through it. A householder cannot reach the far shore of a complete livelihood. Therefore, for the sake of living the holy life, I shall shave my head and beard, go forth from home into homelessness, and diligently apply myself to awakening. Having resolved thus, they then definitively go forth and diligently apply themselves to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

When the bodhisattva goes forth in this way, Māra the Evil One is filled with great distress and says: Yet another bodhisattva will contend with me! Sons of good family, how could such a bodhisattva contend with others? At that time the bodhisattva goes to the dwelling place of the Saṅgha and, finding either a Tathāgata or one who lives according to the Tathāgata's way of conduct —

whose faculties are pacified, whose mind is gentle and serene, who is completely pure and wholly at peace — approaches them, requests the going forth, shaves their head and beard, and dons the saffron-colored Dharma robe. Having thus gone forth, they guard their moral discipline completely, with conduct that is unimpaired and beautiful. They refrain from transgressions and, even for the slightest offense, they give rise to a mind of fear. Their resolve to guard moral discipline is as firm as a vajra.

Sons of good family, consider a man who enters the ocean holding a plank. From within the ocean a demon (rākṣasa) approaches him and demands the plank. The man hears these words and thinks: If I give away this plank I will certainly sink into the water and die. He then says to the demon: You may kill me if you wish, but this plank is not something I should give away. The demon speaks again:

He did not give it. The demon said: If you will not give the whole, will you not give half? He did not give that either. The demon said again: If you will not give half, then give a third. He did not give that. The demon said again: If you will not give a third, then give a palmful. Still he did not give it. The demon said again: Since you will not give even a palmful, I am tormented by terrible hunger and consumed by suffering — please grant me just a particle of it. The man replied: Your request is not great; it is exceedingly small. Nevertheless, I have not yet crossed the ocean, I do not know whether the far shore is near or far, and if I were to give it to you, I would be left gasping for breath. How would I ever escape the perils of the ocean? I would die in the water.

Sons of good family, the way in which a bodhisattva, a great being, guards and protects moral discipline is exactly like this. Just as the man crossing the ocean guards his plank, so too, when the bodhisattva is protecting moral discipline, the unruly afflictive demons say to him: Believe what we tell you — we are not deceiving you. Even if you have broken all four root defeats, if you keep the rest of the moral discipline, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant nirvāṇa. But the bodhisattva does not follow those words. The afflictive demon says again: If you do not wish to break all four root defeats, then even without keeping the remaining rules of the Saṅgha, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant nirvāṇa. But the bodhisattva does not follow those words. The afflictive demon says again: If you do not wish to break the remaining rules of the Saṅgha, then even if you break the rules concerning the grave offenses, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant

nirvāṇa. But the bodhisattva does not follow those words. The afflictive demon says again: If you do not wish to break the rules concerning the grave offenses, then even if you break the rules concerning the transgressions requiring abandonment, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant nirvāṇa. But the bodhisattva does not follow those words. The demon says again: If you do not wish to break the transgressions requiring abandonment in that way, then even if you break the ninety transgressions, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant nirvāṇa. But the bodhisattva does not follow those words. The demon says again: If you do not wish to break the ninety transgressions, then even if you break the rules concerning acts of wrongdoing, that very cause and that very condition will bring you to the blissfully pleasant nirvāṇa. But at that point the bodhisattva thinks to himself: If an act of wrongdoing arises in me and I do not confess and disclose it, I will not reach the far shore of saṃsāra, nor will I attain nirvāṇa. And so, even from youth, the bodhisattva, the great being, guards and holds even acts of wrongdoing with a mind firm as a vajra. The bodhisattva, the great being, is supremely steadfast and unwavering in protecting the four root defeats and in protecting against acts of wrongdoing — these two he holds as one.

If the bodhisattva guards in this way, it is called possessing the five branches of moral discipline. They are as follows: the moral discipline of thoroughly purifying the essential nature of the bodhisattva's actions; the moral discipline of thoroughly purifying the retinue of the earlier and later times; the moral discipline of thoroughly purifying one's thoughts by not entertaining unwholesome thoughts; the moral discipline of thoroughly purifying mindfulness by guarding and maintaining genuine mindfulness; and the moral discipline of dedicating everything toward the unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Furthermore, Kāśyapa, the moral discipline of the bodhisattva, the great being, has two aspects: the moral discipline received as it is correctly taught in the world, and the moral discipline of the true Dharma that is attained. If the bodhisattva attains the moral discipline of the true Dharma, he will never commit any wrongdoing. The moral discipline received as it is correctly taught in the world is obtained through making a formal request and through the performance of the fourfold act.

Furthermore, son of good family, moral discipline also has two aspects: the moral discipline that is weighty by its very nature, and the moral discipline

that prevents one from being disgraced by the world. The moral discipline that is weighty by its very nature consists of the four root defeats. The moral discipline that prevents one from being disgraced by the world consists in the following: not engaging in trade; not manipulating measures of volume and weight, and not falsifying scales; not deceiving others; and further, not relying on one's lineage or power to plunder the wealth of others; and further, not binding others with harmful intent and ruining what they have done, rendering it worthless; not sleeping while a lamp or fire is burning; not doing the work of a householder or farmer; not engaging in wrong livelihood and such improper activities; and further, not keeping oxen, horses, carts, cattle, sheep, female elephants, donkeys, birds, dogs, monkeys, peacocks, parrots, Śārikas, cuckoos, parrots of another kind, tigers, leopards, cats, pigs, and other such ferocious and dangerous wild beasts; not keeping or supporting boys, girls, men, women, male slaves, female slaves, or hired workers; and further, not keeping gold, silver, lapis lazuli, crystal, pearls, asmagarbha, musāragalva, coral, crystal cloth, necklaces, and the like among precious things; not keeping bronze vessels, earthenware vessels, iron vessels, copper kettles, small vessels, soft cushions, and beyond those, not keeping millet, rice, barley, wheat, beans, sesame, fermented foods, or unfermented foods and the like; always eating only once and not taking food again and again; always going on alms rounds; performing the duties of food service within the Saṅgha; always being content; not going when invited as a houseguest to someone's home; not eating meat; not drinking fermented beverages that cause intoxication; not eating the five types of pungent roots and the like — foods that are pungent and malodorous. Thereby his body is free from malodorous smell, and he will always be honored, attended upon, revered, and praised by all gods and humans who dwell in the world; knowing moderation in food, not keeping leftovers; even when accepting robes given by a donor, accepting only what is fitting; going wherever one goes always inseparably accompanied, like a bird with its wings, by the three Dharma-robes and the alms bowl; and further, not keeping root fruits, trunk fruits, seeds from joints, seeds from nodes, or seed-fruits; and further, not keeping treasure troves of precious things, gold, silver,

not lying on or keeping beds, food, drink, granaries, storehouses, dress robes, or high seats; not sitting on seats made of ox-wool with ivory legs, on golden seats, or on seats furnished with many kinds of upholstery; and further, not keeping any soft seat made of grass; not sitting on ox-wool cushions or

horse-hair cushions; not spreading excessively soft robes; not placing two cushions upon a seat; and further, not keeping fine cushions or stuffed cushions; never watching the fighting of yaks, the fighting of horses, the fighting of chariots, the fighting of armies, the fighting of men, the fighting of women, the fighting of bull elephants, the fighting of rams, the fighting of water-buffaloes, the fighting of birds, or the fighting of quail and the like; not watching deliberately staged battles; and further, not listening to the blowing of conch shells, the beating of drums, flutes, lutes, lutes with many strings, gongs, horns, or nine-stringed instruments and the like — save for music offered in worship to the buddhas; not playing or watching games such as throwing cowry shells, casting dice, the lion-game with forfeit pieces, spreading ox-wool fleeces, spinning tops, board games, ball games, stone-throwing, chess, and all manner of diversion games; never reading omens or signs — omens of the hand, the foot, the face, or the eyes; not using the fingernail as a mirror; not making incisions on grass, sticks, pots, or skulls for the sake of divination and signs; not gazing at stars and the like, except for the purpose of warding off sleep; not acting as a royal messenger, carrying words from this side to the far side and words from the far side to this side for the sake of royal messages; not living crookedly through cunning and deceit; and further, not speaking of talk of kings, ministers, thieves, enemies, food, drink, regions, famine, dangers, happiness, and the like.

Sons of good family, these are called the moral discipline of a bodhisattva, a great being, that is not to be censured by the world.

Sons of good family, for a bodhisattva, a great being, there is no distinction between keeping moral discipline that has been formally established and keeping moral discipline that is weighty by its very intrinsic nature.

Sons of good family, when a bodhisattva, a great being, thus perfectly guards moral discipline, he makes this solemn vow: "Better that this body of mine leap into a deep pit of blazing fire than that I, by violating the moral discipline established by the buddhas of the past, the future, and the present, commit an act of unchastity toward a daughter of the warrior class, a brahmin woman, or a laywoman." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow: "Better that my body be wrapped and bound by iron heated to a fierce blaze than that this body, its moral discipline broken, should ever put on a robe given in faith by a generous donor." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that a lump of molten iron be swallowed

down my throat than that this mouth, its moral discipline broken, should ever eat food given in faith by a generous donor." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that this body of mine lie upon iron heated to a fierce blaze than that this body, its moral discipline broken, should ever lie upon a seat or bed given in faith by a generous donor." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that three hundred spear-blades be thrust into this body of mine than that

this body, its moral discipline broken, should ever drink medicine for illness given in faith by a generous donor." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that this body of mine be boiled in a great cauldron of intensely boiling copper than that this body, its moral discipline broken, should ever dwell in a residence built in faith by a generous donor." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that this body be beaten from head to foot with iron hammers until it is reduced to dust than that this body, its moral discipline broken, should ever desire the reverence and homage of nobles, brahmins, and householders." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that both eyes be gouged out with intensely hot iron skewers than that I should, with a mind of attachment, gaze upon the beautiful form of another." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that the faculty of hearing be pierced through with many needles than that I should, with a mind accompanied by attachment, listen to pleasant sounds." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that the nose be cut off with a sharp blade than that I should, with a mind of attachment, smell a sweet fragrance." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that the tongue be cut off with a sharp blade than that I should, with a mind of attachment, be attached to a delicious taste." Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, also makes this solemn vow in these words: "Better that this body of mine be hacked limb from limb with a sharp axe than that I should, with a mind accompanied by attachment, be attached to the many objects of touch."

Why is this so? Because by that cause and through those conditions, yogins are reborn in the hells, in the animal realm, and in the world of the Lord of Death.

Kāśyapa, thus it is that the bodhisattva, the great being, is said to guard moral discipline completely.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, has guarded moral discipline with great care, he makes this aspiration on behalf of all sentient beings: "By this cause and through these conditions, may all sentient beings come to possess moral discipline that is most carefully guarded, moral discipline that is perfectly pure, moral discipline that is supremely wholesome, moral discipline that is unimpaired, moral discipline that is irreversible, moral discipline of the Great Vehicle, moral discipline of irreversibility, moral discipline united with the mind, moral discipline carried to its completion, and moral discipline that is the perfection fulfilled."

Sons of good family, when the bodhisattva, the great being, thus thoroughly purifies and refines moral discipline, he comes to abide from the very outset on the unshakeable ground. Why is it called the unshakeable ground? Because when the bodhisattva abides on the unshakeable ground, he cannot be shaken, cannot fall, cannot be turned back, and cannot be destroyed.

Sons of good family, consider, for example, Mount Meru, the king of mountains: even the most violent and fierce gale-force winds cannot shake it, cannot topple it, cannot destroy it. So too it is with the bodhisattva, the great being, who abides there: forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and objects of touch cannot shake him; he will not fall into the hells, into the animal realm, or into the world of the Lord of Death; he will not turn back toward the ground of the śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas;

and the winds of the many wrong views cannot shatter him or cause him to live in distorted ways.

Sons of good family, furthermore, "unshakeable" means: he is not shaken by attachment, aversion, or delusion. Furthermore, "he cannot fall" means: he does not fall into the four root defeats. Furthermore, "he cannot be turned back" means: he does not turn back from moral discipline to the household life. Furthermore, "he cannot be destroyed" means: he is not shattered by contradicting the sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, is not shaken by the māra of the afflictions. He will not fall through the māra of the aggregates. Although, from the very heart of the path up to the moment of awakening, the māra who is the son of the gods is present, he will not turn back from unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. And he will not be destroyed by the māra of the Lord of Death.

Sons of good family, in this way the bodhisattva, the great being, is called one who applies himself with great diligence to the noble conduct. Sons of good family, why is it called "noble conduct"? It is called noble conduct because it is the conduct practiced by buddhas and bodhisattvas. Why are buddhas and bodhisattvas called noble ones (āryas)? Because they and those like them are endowed with noble qualities, and because they have realized that all phenomena are empty of essential nature. Therefore they are called noble ones. Furthermore, they are called noble ones because they are endowed with noble moral discipline. They are called noble ones because they are endowed with noble meditative absorption and wisdom. Furthermore, they are called noble ones because they are endowed with the seven noble wealths: the wealth of faith, moral discipline, inner restraint, decorum, learning, wisdom, and equanimity. Furthermore, they are called noble ones because they are endowed with the seven limbs of the noble path. Therefore it is called noble conduct.

Sons of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, who practices noble conduct examines this body from the crown of the head down to the soles of the feet, and sees it as filled with nothing but impurity and filth: hair of the head, nails, teeth, unclean foulness, skin, flesh, tendons, bones, spleen, kidneys, heart, lungs, liver, bile, intestines, stomach, what has been digested and what has not, the two vessels for feces and urine both large and small, saliva, mucus, tears, the brain, the skull, pus, blood, blood-vessels, and so on — he sees it as filled with nothing but impurity.

When the bodhisattva examines this with a one-pointed mind in great detail, he inquires most carefully: "Who is this called 'self'? Where does it reside? Who is this called 'self'?" He then thinks: "Is the bone the self? Or does something other than the bone exist?" At that moment the bodhisattva sets aside skin and flesh and reflects solely upon the bare skeleton. He then thinks: "The colors of the bones too are various — blue, yellow, red, white, like the wings of a dove. Since this is so, the defining mark of bone is also not the self. Why? Because what is called 'self' is not something blue, yellow, red, white, or like

the wings of a dove."

When the bodhisattva examines this with such a one-pointed mind in great detail, all attachment to form becomes pacified. He then thinks: "This skeleton too arises through dependent origination: the heel-bone supports the ankle-bone, the ankle-bone supports the shinbone, the shinbone supports the knee,

the knee-bone supports the thigh-bone, the thigh-bone supports the hip-bone, the hip-bone supports the bones of the waist, the bones of the waist support the bones of the spine, the bones of the spine support the bones of the ribs, and again the bones of the spine support the bones of the shoulder-blades, the bones of the shoulder-blades support the bones of the jaw, and the bones of the jaw support the teeth and the skull.

Furthermore, the collar-bone rests upon the bones of the shoulder, the bones of the shoulder rest upon the bones of the upper arm, the bones of the upper arm rest upon the bones of the elbow, the bones of the elbow rest upon the bones of the palm, and the bones of the palm rest upon the bones of the fingers.

In this way, all the bones rest upon and depend upon one another. As the bodhisattva, the great being, examines in this fashion, he comes to understand that all the bones of the body stand each in their own separate place. Upon understanding this so thoroughly, he entirely abandons the three kinds of attachment: attachment to visible form, attachment to what one possesses, and attachment to what is pleasant to the touch.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, contemplates the blue bones, he sees this entire great earth — south, north, east, west, the four intermediate directions, above, and below — as all blue. And just as when contemplating blue, so too with yellow, white, and the color of a dove's wings.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, contemplates in this way, from between his eyebrows rays of light stream forth — blue, yellow, red, white, and like the wings of a dove — and within each ray of that light the bodhisattva, the great being, sees buddhas dwelling. He then inquires and asks of them concerning the causes and conditions through dependent origination by which this impure body comes into being: "This body sits, stands, walks, stays still, bows down, stretches out, looks about, closes the eyes, breathes in and out, weeps, laughs, and comes to feel joy — if there is no master, who is it that moves it thus?" This is what he asks and inquires. And having asked these

words, the buddhas who had been dwelling within the light then disappear from sight.

The Noble Great Sūtra of Complete Nirvāṇa, the sixteenth fascicle.

He then thinks: "But might that consciousness be the self? Why have the buddhas not shown me this?" He examines consciousness, and in examining consciousness he finds that consciousness arises and ceases moment by moment, like the current of a river — and so that too is not the self.

He then thinks: "This breath that moves inward and outward is wind, and the characteristic of wind belongs to the four great elements. Among the four great elements, what then is there to be called 'self'? The characteristic of earth is also not the self, and likewise the characteristics of water, fire, and wind are none of them to be called 'self.'"

He then thinks: "In this body there is altogether nothing to be called a 'self.' The various actions that manifest openly arise from the causes and conditions of the gathering and assembling of mind and breath — like something produced by the power of a spell, or like the work of a magician. Moreover, when one bows down, it is like a puppet moved by strings, and sound arises at will. Therefore this body is impure; it is accomplished entirely through depending on an assemblage of causes and conditions — what is there in it to be attached to? And if another were to revile or abuse it, what is there in it to give rise to aversion? This body of mine is wholly filled with thirty-six kinds of impurity — what basis is there for reviling and abusing it? When he hears abuse, he thinks to himself:

"By what sound could one be reviled?" When each and every component of that sound is examined one by one, no reviling is found to exist. As with one component, so too with many — they are just the same. Therefore aversion does not arise.

If the other person then strikes him, he thinks to himself: "From what does this blow arise?" Examining it, he sees that from the hand, the strength, the weapon, and the assemblage of his own body, what is called "a blow" has come about. Why then be angry at the other? It is because my body exists that I have experienced such a thing. Because this body of mine — this body of the five aggregates — exists, it has come to be like this. Just as an arrow comes when there is a target as its condition, my body is like that too: because the body exists, there are blows. If I do not bear this body with patience, the mind will be disturbed. If the mind is disturbed, correct mindfulness will be lost. If

correct mindfulness is lost, one will not understand the meaning of virtue and non-virtue. If one does not understand the meaning of virtue and non-virtue, one will engage in blameworthy conduct. Having engaged in blameworthy conduct, one will fall into the hells, into animal births, and into the realm of hungry ghosts.

When the bodhisattva understands it in this way, he will at that time attain the four establishments of mindfulness. By attaining the four establishments of mindfulness, he will come to abide on the ground of supreme forbearance. When that bodhisattva, that great being, abides on that ground in this way, he is patient with attachment, aversion, and delusion. Moreover, he is patient with cold and heat, hunger and thirst, mosquitoes, flies, wind, unpleasant sensations of touch, and all manner of illness; he is patient with harsh words, reviling, abuse, blows, slashing, and cutting — in short, he is patient with everything that brings suffering to body and mind. Therefore this is called abiding on the ground of supreme forbearance.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, until a bodhisattva has come to abide on the immovable ground, when keeping moral discipline in a perfectly pure manner, are there causes and conditions by which the moral discipline might be damaged?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, there are. Until a bodhisattva has come to abide on the immovable ground, there are causes and conditions by which the moral discipline may be damaged."

Kāśyapa, filled with wonder, asked: "Blessed One, what are they?"

The Blessed One then spoke to Kāśyapa: "A bodhisattva, by a certain cause and condition, may damage his own moral discipline — namely, if other persons come to have faith in and cherish a sūtra of the Great Vehicle, holding to it with devotion; if other persons come to read it, recite it, understand it inwardly, write it in book form, and teach it extensively and expound it to others — so long as it reaches the point of establishing them as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — for that purpose he damages his moral discipline. And at that time the bodhisattva thinks to himself: 'Even if I were to fall into the great unrelenting hell for a full eon, or for the waning of a full eon, that would be acceptable — so long as I can establish that other person as irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.' It is for that cause, that condition, that the bodhisattva,

the great being, comes to damage pure moral discipline."

At that time, the bodhisattva, the great being Mañjuśrī, youthful in appearance, addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, if a bodhisattva damages moral discipline in order to protect and gather someone so that they will not turn back from the awakening mind, there is no occasion for that bodhisattva to fall into the unrelenting hell."

Then the Blessed One spoke to Mañjuśrī: "Excellent! Most excellent! It is just as you have said. I too, long ago in this Jambudvīpa, was born as a great king named Ṛṣi. With deep reverence I had great faith and devotion toward the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, and striving with a mind intent only on virtue, I avoided non-virtuous actions — the heedlessness of envy and miserliness. With speech I continually spoke pleasant words, taught and expounded virtuous Dharma. With body I made myself the support and refuge of the destitute, those without protection and without shelter, and I strove without interruption in generosity. At that time there was no buddha present in the world, no śrāvakas, and no pratyekabuddhas. It was because of my deep devotion to the widely-expounded sūtras of the Great Vehicle that I served a brahmin for twelve years, providing him with whatever requisites he desired. After giving him comfort for twelve years, I spoke to those teachers these words: 'O Teacher, you should arouse the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.' The brahmin replied: 'Great King, the defining mark of awakening is the absence of any characteristic whatsoever, and the sūtras of the Great Vehicle are just the same — Great King, why should one call it "great"? One should say it is equal to space.' O son of good family, at that time, due to my intense devotion to the Great Vehicle, when I heard the brahmin speaking those words disparaging the extensive teaching, I killed that brahmin. O son of good family, because of that cause and that condition, I have not been born in the hells from that time until now. O son of good family, such is the immeasurable power and strength of protecting and guarding the sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

"Kāśyapa, there is also this: the noble practice is as follows — it is the Four Noble Truths. And what are they? Suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path — these are called the Four Noble Truths.

"Kāśyapa, what is called suffering has the defining mark of being exhausting and tormenting. The origin of suffering has the defining mark of arising and proliferating. Cessation has the defining mark of peaceful stopping. The path

has the defining mark of the Great Vehicle.

"O son of good family, further: suffering has the defining mark of being manifest and apparent. The origin of suffering has the defining mark of transformation. Cessation has the defining mark of elimination. The path has the defining mark of transformation through elimination.

"O son of good family, further: suffering has three aspects — the suffering of suffering, the suffering of formations, and the suffering of change. The origin of suffering is the twenty-five modes of existence. Cessation is the cessation of those twenty-five. The path is the cultivation of moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom.

"O son of good family, further: among defiled phenomena (*āsrava*) there are two kinds — those with cause and those with result. Among undefiled phenomena there are likewise two kinds — those with cause and those with result. Defiled phenomena with result are called suffering. Defiled phenomena with cause are called the origin. Undefiled phenomena with result are called cessation. Undefiled phenomena with cause are called the path.

"O son of good family, further: these eight kinds of defining marks are called suffering — namely, the suffering of birth, the suffering of aging, the suffering of illness, the suffering of death, the suffering of separation from what is desired, the suffering of encountering what is hated,"

the suffering of not obtaining what is desired, and the five aggregates — these are suffering. Whatever produces these eight kinds of suffering is called the origin. The absence of any abiding place of these phenomena is called cessation. The ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, the three foundations of mindfulness, and great compassion — these are called the path.

O son of good family, what is called birth is the defining mark of arising, and it has five aspects: first arising, final cessation, growth and coming into being, birth from a womb, and birth from a lineage.

What is called aging has two aspects: aging moment by moment, and aging at the end. Again there are two aspects: aging through arising and growth, and aging through cessation and disintegration — these are called aging.

What is called illness? Illness arises from the unequal and toxic imbalance of the four great elements, and it has two aspects: illness of the body and illness of the mind. Illness of the body also has five aspects: illness arising from phlegm, illness arising from wind, illness arising from bile, illness arising from

their combination, and illness arising from carelessness.

Illness arising from carelessness also has four aspects: acting beyond one's capacity while in a weakened state, falling into a precipice, being struck by stones, sticks, or weapons, and being seized by non-human beings.

Illness of the mind also has four aspects: illness arising from extreme joy, illness arising from fear and terror, illness arising from grief, and illness arising from delusion.

O son of good family, furthermore, illness of the body and illness of the mind each have three aspects: karmic maturation, failure to abandon the remedies for wrongdoing, and illness arising from the time and season. From these and other such causes, conditions, designations, and distinct kinds, illness arises in varied forms. Illness arising from causes and conditions consists of ailments such as disorders of wind and so forth. Designated illness refers to madness of mind, lung disease, shortness of breath, nausea, palpitations of the heart, and dysentery from fever. Illness of distinct kinds consists of illness of the head, illness of the eyes, and illness of the limbs and so forth — these are called illness.

What is called death? It is the separation from this very body that one has taken. Separation from the body one has taken also has two aspects: death through the exhaustion of one's lifespan, and death through external conditions.

Death through the exhaustion of one's lifespan also has three aspects: lifespan exhausted but merit not exhausted, merit exhausted but lifespan not exhausted, and both merit and lifespan exhausted together.

Death through external conditions also has three aspects: dying by taking one's own life through improper means, being killed by another adversary, and dying through a combination of both.

Furthermore, there are also three aspects of death: dying through heedlessness, dying through the breaking of moral discipline, and dying through the destruction of the faculty of life.

What is dying through heedlessness? Repudiating the vast Mahāyāna Perfection of Wisdom is called dying through heedlessness. What is dying through the breaking of moral discipline? Transgressing the moral discipline established by the buddhas of the past, the future, and those abiding in the present is called dying through the breaking of moral discipline. What is dying

through the destruction of the faculty of life? Separation from the body of the five aggregates is called dying through the destruction of the faculty of life. These are called the great suffering of death.

What is the suffering of separation from what is desired? It is the breakdown, separation, or dispersal of that which is pleasing and desired, whether it be a faculty, a parting, or a scattering. Separation from pleasing and desired things also has two aspects: the dissolution of the five aggregates among humans, and the separation from the five aggregates among the gods. Thus, for gods and humans alike, the five aggregates of desire are, when analyzed, measureless. In brief, all of these are called the suffering of separation from what is desired.

What is the suffering of encountering what is hated? It is the coming together and meeting with that which is unpleasant and unwanted. Encountering what is unpleasant and unwanted has three aspects: rebirth in the hells, rebirth as a hungry ghost, and rebirth as an animal. Although these three lower destinies, when analyzed in detail, are measureless, in brief all of them are called the suffering of encountering what is hated.

What is the suffering of not obtaining what is desired? The suffering of not obtaining what is desired also has two aspects: not obtaining what is desired despite having grounds for hope, and performing great effort yet failing to accomplish the intended result. These are called the suffering of not obtaining what is desired.

What is the suffering of the five aggregates? The suffering of the five aggregates is: the suffering of birth, the suffering of aging, the suffering of illness, the suffering of death, the suffering of separation from what is desired, and the suffering of encountering what is hated. These are called the suffering of the five aggregates.

O Kāśyapa, for beings born into existence, there are thus seven kinds of suffering, from the suffering of aging through the suffering of the five aggregates. O Kāśyapa, decline and illness are not present in all beings — they are certainly not found in buddhas or among the gods, and even among humans they are not universal: some have them and some do not. O Kāśyapa, there is no being who has taken a body within the three realms who does not undergo birth; aging alone is not universal. Therefore, birth is the root of all of it. O Kāśyapa, because the sentient beings of the world are obscured by wrong views, they desire and are attached to birth, yet do not desire aging and

death. O Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva is not like this: from the very moment of birth the bodhisattva recognizes it as a fault.

O Kāśyapa, consider this analogy. A beautiful woman arrives at someone's house — lovely in appearance, of graceful and pleasing manner, adorned with fine ornaments. The householder asks her, "Woman, what is your name?" The woman replies, "I am the auspicious Great Goddess (Śrī Mahādevī)." The householder asks again, "If you were to come to my house, what would you be able to bring?" The woman replies, "Wherever I go, I bring the householder gold, silver, lapis lazuli, crystal, pearl, coral, emerald, asmagarbha, musāgalbha, and many other kinds of precious things, as well as sheep, oxen, horses, chariots, male servants, female servants, and working people." Upon hearing these words, the householder is overcome with delight and joy, and he says, "By the ripening of our merit, O goddess, you have come to my house," and he worships her with incense and flowers, bowing to her with reverence and respect.

At that very gate, another woman also arrives — exceedingly ugly, wearing filthy, soiled clothing, with rough skin and a terrible complexion. The householder asks this woman, "What is your name?" The woman replies, "My name is Black Ears." He asks, "Why are you called Black Ears?" The woman replies, "Wherever I go, all the wealth, riches, and possessions in that household disappear — that is why I am called Black Ears." Upon hearing this, the householder seizes a sharp weapon and says to her, "Be gone at once! If you do not leave, I will kill you!" The woman replies, "You are extremely foolish and witless." The householder says, "Why am I foolish and witless?" The woman replies, "The one now residing in your house is my younger sister. Wherever either of us goes, the other must accompany her."

"If you wish to drive her away, then drive out the one who is presently inside your house as well." The man went back inside and said to the goddess Auspiciousness, "Is there a woman at the gate who claims to be the goddess's younger sister?" Auspiciousness replied, "She is indeed my younger sister. Wherever I go, she accompanies me — we have never been parted. Wherever I go, I delight in what is good and do good; I bring benefit. But my younger sister always delights in harm and does harm; she brings injury. If you desire me, you must desire her as well. If you show respect to me, you must show respect to her too." Upon hearing these words, the householder said, "If the two of you come as a pair — one good and one harmful — then neither of you is needed by me. Go now wherever you please." And so both women departed

and left for elsewhere, and the householder was filled with utter joy and delight.

Then those two women went together to the home of a poor man, and the poor man was overjoyed to see them, and he said to both of them, "From this day forward, may you two always remain in my home." Auspiciousness replied, "We were driven away by another just now — so why do you ask us both to stay?" The poor man replied, "Please be gracious to me. I will attend to this one too for your sake — that is why I beg you both to stay."

The bodhisattva (bodhisattva), the great being, Kāśyapa, is likewise — he has no desire to be born among the gods. For birth is followed by old age, sickness, and death, and therefore he rejects both and has no desire for them. Childish and base people, not knowing the many faults of old age, sickness, death, and the like, become attached to both birth and death in their ignorance of these two failings.

Noble son, there is yet another analogy. A young brahmin boy, oppressed by hunger and on the verge of starvation, found a mango fruit inside a pile of vomit and took it. Wise and learned people who saw this rebuked him, saying, "You are of a very pure brahmin lineage — why are you taking a mango fruit from a pile of vomit?" The brahmin boy, ashamed, replied, "I certainly had no intention of eating it as it was — I meant to wash it and then throw it away." The wise man said, "You are utterly foolish. If you meant to throw it away, it was wrong to pick it up in the first place."

Noble son, the bodhisattva, the great being, is just the same — he neither takes up the side of birth nor rejects it, just as the wise man rebuked that boy. Base and childish folk desire birth but do not desire death — just like the boy who took the fruit and then threw it away.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another analogy. At a crossroads, a man was selling food in a fine vessel — food that was fragrant, cool, and of excellent color. A traveler who had come from a long distance, hungry, weary, and exhausted, drew near upon seeing this fragrant, cool, and beautifully colored food, and asked, "What is this?" The owner of the food replied, "This is the finest of foods — fragrant, cool, and of excellent color. Whoever eats it will gain both complexion and strength, hunger and thirst will be dispelled, and he will even come to behold the gods. There is, however, one single flaw: he will die." Upon hearing this, the man thought, "I do want the complexion and strength, but I do not want to see the gods and then die," and he said aloud, "If eating this

food means I will die, what would be the point of buying and eating it?" The owner of the food replied, "No one with wisdom and discernment would buy it."

"The foolish and witless pay me a great price and buy it to eat. Son of good family, the great bodhisattva is just the same: he desires neither birth as a god, nor the fine complexion, strength, or sight of the gods that come with it. Why is that? Because one is not liberated from the multitude of sufferings. The foolish and low-born, not seeing the faults of aging, sickness, and death, become attached to every form of birth.

Son of good family, here is another illustration: a poisonous plant kills with its root, kills with its trunk, and kills with its bark, its leaves, its flowers, and its fruits as well. Son of good family, it is the same with taking up the five aggregates at birth in any of the twenty-five modes of existence: all of them lead to death.

Kāśyapa, here is another illustration: vomit is equally foul whether there is much of it or little. Son of good family, birth is just the same: whether one lives eighty thousand years or manages ten, it is all equally suffering.

Son of good family, here is yet another illustration: at the edge of a terrible and terrifying precipice, covered over with grass, there lies an abundance of ambrosia. Were one to eat it, one might live for a thousand divine years, and all one's diseases would be completely cured and one would dwell in bliss. Yet a foolish and low-born child, attached to the taste, does not know that beneath his very feet there lies a dreadful abyss. He reaches out to take it, slips a foot, falls into the chasm, and dies. The wise and discerning, knowing this, do not go there. Son of good family, the great bodhisattva is just the same: if he does not desire even the excellent divine food of the gods, what need is there to speak of human food? If the foolish and low-born can endure eating iron balls in the hells, what need is there to speak of the fine food of gods and humans?

Kāśyapa, through these illustrations and countless and immeasurable further analogies one should understand that this birth is great suffering.

Kāśyapa, thus it is that the great bodhisattva's understanding of the suffering of birth, from the Mahāyāna sūtra of the complete nirvāṇa (Skt. mahāparinirvāṇasūtra), is to be understood in this way.

Kāśyapa, how then does the great bodhisattva understand the suffering of aging from the Mahāyāna sūtra of the complete nirvāṇa? Aging is something

repulsive and decaying; it robs one of valor and skill; it renders inappropriate all mindfulness, effort, retention, youthful bloom, perfect ease, pride, and proud bearing, and all enjoyment of pleasure at will; and in their place it brings indolence, great sluggishness, and contempt from others.

Kāśyapa, consider this illustration: a small pond full of lotuses in full bloom, their petals wide open, their vivid colors beautiful and pleasing to everyone's eye and desired by all — if hail falls, all are broken and made ugly. Son of good family, aging is just the same: it renders ugly the fine complexion of youth.

Kāśyapa, here is another illustration: a king has a wise and intelligent minister, skilled in the strategies of the enemy. A certain vassal king rebels against the king and will not listen. The king commands that minister, "Go and capture that vassal king," and the minister goes and brings him back. Aging is just the same: it seizes upon youth and delivers it to the king who is the Lord of Death.

Kāśyapa, here is another illustration: when the axle-beam of a chariot breaks, it can no longer be used. Aging is just the same: it renders one useless for anything whatsoever.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: in the home of a wealthy householder there is an abundance of gold, silver, lapis lazuli (vaiḍūrya), coral, aśmagarbha, and musāragalva — and a thief, or..."

— many robbers arrive and plunder everything, leaving the house utterly empty. Noble son, it is just the same with the fine bloom of youth: the enemy that is aging perpetually steals it and carries it away.

Noble son, here is yet another illustration: a poor man longs for fine food and soft clothing, yet finds himself forever unable to obtain them. Noble son, old age is just the same: one may wish to enjoy at will the pleasures of the five desirable qualities, yet one is unable to do so.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: a tortoise sitting on dry ground thinks constantly of water. Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: withered and bent by old age, the mind dwells constantly on the remembered pleasures of the five desirable qualities of youth.

Noble son, here is yet another illustration: in the autumn, a fully opened lotus blossom is desired and delighted in by all; but once it has withered and turned yellow, no one desires it any longer. Noble son, it is just the same with the fine bloom of youth: while it is desired and cherished by all, once it has turned to old age it no longer pleases anyone, and no one desires it.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: the pressed-out stalk of sugarcane is utterly tasteless. Noble son, the fine bloom of youth is just the same: once it is covered over and ruined by the decay of old age, three flavors are lost — the flavor of going forth into renunciation, the flavor of study and recitation, and the flavor of meditative concentration. All three are gone.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: a full moon is exceedingly bright and clear by night, but not so by day. Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: in youth one is fair and beautiful, but in old age one is withered and haggard.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: suppose there is a king who governs his realm by righteous Dharma, who is free of deceit and trickery, who is endowed with compassion and generosity. He is attacked by the armies of another land and wanders, driven away to a foreign country. Everyone who encounters him feels affection and says, "This great king formerly governed his realm by righteous Dharma, and there was not a single one who was displeased. Why has he come to wander like this?" Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: weakened and diminished by the infirmity of old age, one longs for all that one did in the days of youth.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: the very essence of an oil lamp depends upon its oil; when the oil is exhausted, it does not last long. Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: one depends upon one's youth. When youth is spent, the essence of the infirmity of old age does not last long.

Noble son, here is yet another illustration: a dried-up riverbank is of no benefit to humans, to non-humans, to birds, to beasts of prey, or to any other creature. Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: once withered by old age, one becomes of no benefit whatsoever for any task.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: a tree growing on the edge of an eroded cliff, the moment a fierce wind rises, will inevitably fall. Noble son, it is just the same with a human being: the edge on which old age stands is close to the precipice, and when the wind of death arises, one does not remain long.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: when the main axle-beam of a chariot breaks, it cannot bear a heavy load. Noble son, old age is just the same: one is unable to hold fast to all virtuous qualities.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: a small seedling that has not yet grown strong is scorned by everyone. Noble son, old age is just the same: one

is scorned by everyone.

Kāśyapa, these illustrations and...

Furthermore, through illustrations beyond measure and beyond counting, one should understand that old age is a great suffering. Kāśyapa, all of this is called "the understanding of the suffering of old age" when a great bodhisattva (bodhisattva mahāsattva) practices this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa.

Kāśyapa, how then does a great bodhisattva, in practicing this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, understand the suffering of illness? Illness is that which destroys all things that are pleasant and agreeable. For example, when hail falls, it destroys all the crops and renders them worthless.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: if a person has a bitter enemy, he is forever in grief and in fear. Noble son, all sentient beings are just the same: they are forever in grief and in fear, terrified by the suffering of illness.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: there is a man of handsome and excellent appearance. A queen, overcome with desire, summons him and sleeps with him. When the king discovers this, he has the man seized, puts out one of his eyes, cuts off one of his ears, and cuts off one of his hands. From that moment on, the man's handsome appearance, which he had before, is destroyed, and no one wants him any longer. Noble son, a human being is just the same: though he may have limbs, eyes, and ears, once he is afflicted and tormented by the suffering of illness, no one wants him any longer.

Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: the plantain tree, the bamboo, the reed, and the mule — when they bear fruit or offspring, they die. Noble son, a human being is just the same: where there is illness, there is death.

Noble son, here is yet another illustration: a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) follows behind a minister who commands the armies, walking in the wake of one who has gone before. The king of fish, the king of bees, the king of conch-shells, the lord of the herd, and the caravan leader — the rest follow behind whoever has gone first, and they do not part from him. Noble son, the wheel-turning king of death is just the same: it forever follows behind illness as its minister and never parts from it. Just as the fish, the bees, the conch, the lord of the herd, and the caravan leader are followed by their retainers, so too does the wheel of death forever pursue in the wake of illness as its king, and never parts from it.

Kāśyapa, the causes and conditions of illness are these: suffering, disturbance, the grief of being exhausted, lamentation, and the causing of discomfort to body and mind. It is also called "being threatened by a merciless enemy," "the tearing apart of what had been bound together," "the destruction of the bridge," "the robbing of right-mindfulness," and furthermore "that which ruins the fair complexion, the strength, and the happiness of youth." It scorches and burns the body and mind, leaving behind neither shame nor decency. Through these illustrations and through countless other illustrations beyond measure and beyond counting, one should understand that the suffering of illness is a great suffering. Kāśyapa, this is called "the understanding of the suffering of illness" when a great bodhisattva practices this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa.

Kāśyapa, how then does a great bodhisattva, in practicing this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, understand the suffering of death? It is as follows: death is that which severs and annihilates. Kāśyapa, it is like this: when the cosmic fire (kalpa-fire) arises, it burns up everything except the second meditative concentration.

Noble son, death annihilates the mind of all beings entirely — save those great bodhisattvas who abide in the power and strength of practicing this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa. Kāśyapa, consider this: when the cosmic water-flood arises, it washes away and annihilates everything — except the third meditative concentration. Noble son, the water of death is likewise: it washes away and annihilates all — except those bodhisattvas who abide in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa. Kāśyapa, consider this: when the cosmic wind-storm arises, it scatters and annihilates everything — except the fourth meditative concentration. Noble son, the wind of death is likewise: it annihilates all — except those bodhisattvas who abide in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One, saying: "For what reason is the fourth meditative concentration not destroyed by wind, not washed away by water, not burned by fire?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Noble son, it is because the fourth meditative concentration is free from all inner and outer faults. Noble son, in the first meditative concentration there is the inner fault of discursive thought, and therefore it is burned by the outer cosmic fire. In the second meditative concentration there is the inner fault of joy, and therefore it is washed away by

the outer cosmic water. In the third meditative concentration there is the inner movement of breath, and therefore it is destroyed by the cosmic wind. Noble son, the fourth meditative concentration is free from all inner and outer faults, and therefore the cosmic catastrophes cannot touch it.

"Noble son, a great bodhisattva is likewise: when one abides comfortably in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, being free from all inner and outer faults, the king of death cannot touch one.

"Noble son, here is another illustration: the king of garuḍas (the great bird of prey) can devour nāgas, fish, gold, silver, and jewels, and these can be dissolved — but a vajra alone it cannot dissolve. Noble son, the king of the garuḍas of death is likewise: it can devour all sentient beings and dissolve them — but a great bodhisattva who abides in this sūtra of the great and complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle it cannot dissolve.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: all the trees and grasses that grow on a riverbank are carried away by a flood and swept all the way to the ocean — except for the willow, because its roots are flexible. Noble son, likewise, all sentient beings flow down into the ocean of saṃsāra — except those great bodhisattvas who abide in this sūtra of the complete nirvāṇa.

"Kāśyapa, here is another illustration: a powerful wrestler can subdue all opponents — wrestlers and the like — but he cannot subdue a great storm-wind. Why? Because there is no antidote for it. Noble son, the powerful wrestler of death is likewise: it can subdue all sentient beings — but it cannot subdue a great bodhisattva who abides in this sūtra of the complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle. Why? Because there is no antidote for it.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: enemies who bear hatred and a grudge may draw near through cunning, disguising themselves as if they were intimate friends, following like a shadow and seeking an opportunity to kill — yet if the other party has been forewarned and on guard from the start, they cannot be killed. Noble son, the enemy called death is likewise: it is always seeking an opportunity to kill all sentient beings — but it cannot kill a great bodhisattva who abides in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa. Why?"

Because the bodhisattva is on guard.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: when a vajra (diamond-thunderbolt) rainstorm falls, it can destroy everything — trees and forests, earth and sand,

gravel, grass and rocks, gold, silver, lapis lazuli, and all the rest — yet it cannot destroy a true and genuine vajra. Noble son, the rainstorm of death's vajra is likewise: it can annihilate all sentient beings, yet it cannot touch a bodhisattva, firm as a vajra, who abides in this complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: the garuḍa bird devours all nāgas, yet it cannot devour one who has gone for refuge to the Three Refuges. Noble son, the garuḍa of death is likewise: though it may devour countless, limitless sentient beings, it cannot touch one who abides in the three doors of liberation — emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: when one is seized by the deadly serpent called Malanā, even skilled mantra-healers and expert physicians can do nothing. Only one who knows the mantra called Akatasyā can save that person's life. Noble son, when one is seized by the deadly serpent of death, all forms of medical treatment are likewise utterly useless — except for a bodhisattva who abides in the mantra of this complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle.

"Kāśyapa, here is yet another illustration: if a person has incurred a king's hatred, that person may offer pleasant and gentle words and present the king with wealth, valuables, and precious things — and thereby win the king's favour. Noble son, but the king of death is not like that: even if one speaks pleasant and gentle words, even if one presents wealth, valuables, and precious things, one cannot escape from it.

"Noble son, a fool going to a great abyss is without a companion; going on an extremely long road is without a companion; travelling day and night, one does not know its end; one wanders in the most profound darkness; there is no illuminating lamp; there is no door through which to enter and yet there is a dwelling there; there is no visible remedy and no healing is possible; for those going there, there is no interruption and one arrives at a place from which there is no liberation; it is without firm ground; the mere sight of it causes grief; though it is not a harmful form, all tremble in fear at it; though it pervades the entire body, one does not feel or know it.

"Kāśyapa, through these and countless other illustrations it should be understood that death is a great suffering. Kāśyapa, these are what is called 'a great bodhisattva's comprehension of the suffering of death while practising this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa.'

"Kāśyapa, how is it that a great bodhisattva, abiding in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, comprehends the suffering of separation from what one desires? The suffering of separation from what one desires is the root of suffering for all sentient beings — and from verse too these words arise:

From desire as its condition grief arises.

From desire as its condition fear arises.

If all desire is entirely abandoned,
whence could grief and fear ever come?

From desire as its condition, the suffering of grief arises; and because it is the suffering of grief, sentient beings grow old and decay. The suffering of separation from what one desires is simply this: the exhaustion of one's life.

"Noble son, as a result of separation, many and various subtle forms of suffering also arise — and these I shall explain to you at length.

"Noble son, in a time long past, human lifespans were immeasurable. At that time there arose a king by the name of Established in Virtue."

At that time, the king served in the office of regent with his youthful body for eighty-four thousand years, after which he was consecrated to the royal throne and reigned as king for another eighty-four thousand years. During his reign, an exceedingly soft growth of flesh appeared upon the crown of the king's head — as soft as wool or fine cotton cloth. Though it grew ever larger with time, it caused no discomfort. When ten months had passed, it burst open, and from within there emerged a young boy of incomparable beauty and excellence, endowed with marks and complexion, altogether foremost among men. The great king was overjoyed and gave him the name Born-from-the-Crown. Then the king, Established in Virtue, having entrusted the entire royal dominion to Born-from-the-Crown, fully relinquished his palace, his queens, his sons, and all his retinue, and for a full eighty-four thousand years applied himself diligently to awakening.

Now, King Born-from-the-Crown, on the fifteenth day of the month, performed his ritual bathing, took up the royal throne, and was seated on a high upper terrace. From the eastern direction there appeared a golden wheel with a thousand spokes — not fashioned by any craftsman, but arisen of itself, spontaneously complete. At that moment, King Born-from-the-Crown reflected: "Long ago I heard from a sage possessing the five superknowledges that a king of noble lineage who, on the fifteenth day, performs his bathing, takes the

royal empowerment, and while seated on a high upper terrace witnesses a golden wheel with a thousand spokes appear spontaneously — not made by a craftsman — will without doubt become a wheel-turning king. Calling that to mind, I shall now put it to the test." He took the wheel in his left hand, held a bowl in his right hand, planted his right knee on the ground, and spoke these words: "If this golden wheel is genuine, let it proceed according to the manner of the wheel-turning kings of the past." The moment he had spoken those words, the golden wheel soared up into the sky above, circled in all ten directions, and returned to his left hand.

King Born-from-the-Crown was filled with great delight and joy, and declared: "I am indeed a wheel-turning king!"

Not long after, there appeared of its own accord a precious jewel elephant of surpassing excellence, white as a white lotus, its seven limbs touching the ground. King Born-from-the-Crown saw it and thought: "Long ago I heard from a sage possessing the five superknowledges that if a wheel-turning king, on the fifteenth day, after bathing ascends to a high upper terrace and sits there, and there appears a precious jewel elephant of surpassing excellence, white as a white lotus, with its seven limbs touching the ground, then that king will without doubt become a wheel-turning king. Calling that to mind, I shall now put it to the test." He held the bowl, planted his right knee on the ground, and spoke these words: "If this precious jewel elephant is genuine, let it proceed according to the manner of the wheel-turning kings of the past." Having spoken, the precious jewel elephant circled from the morning until the evening through all eight directions to the very shore of the ocean, and then returned to his dwelling. King Born-from-the-Crown was supremely joyful and declared: "I am without doubt a wheel-turning king!"

Then, not long afterward, there spontaneously appeared a precious jewel horse with a coat of deep blue and a mane and tail of a color resembling gold. King Born-from-the-Crown saw it and thought:

"I once heard from a sage endowed with the five higher knowledges: 'If a wheel-turning king, on the fifteenth day of the month, having bathed and ascended to the highest upper story, sees a precious jewel horse appear, with a coat of deep blue and a mane and tail resembling the color of gold, then that king is without doubt a wheel-turning king.' Recalling this, King Born-from-the-Crown took up a golden bowl, placed his right knee upon the ground, and spoke these words: 'If this precious jewel horse of deep blue is

genuine, let it proceed according to the manner of the wheel-turning kings of the past.' Having spoken, the precious jewel horse circled from the morning until the evening through all eight directions to the very shore of the ocean, and then returned to his dwelling. At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown was supremely joyful and declared: 'I am without doubt a wheel-turning king!'

Then, not long afterward, there appeared a precious jewel woman, supremely beautiful in form and appearance, of neither tall nor short stature, neither too fair nor too dark of complexion, from whose every hair-pore there breathed the fragrance of sandalwood incense, from whose mouth there breathed the fragrance of blue lotus blossoms, whose gaze could see clearly to a distance of one league, whose hearing and sense of smell were likewise sharp, whose tongue was very supple, long, and broad, whose complexion was smooth and lustrous like polished copper, who was keen of wisdom and great of mind, who always spoke gently to all sentient beings. By the mere touch of this woman's hand upon the king's garment, she knew both his illness and his wellbeing, and whatever he looked upon or thought. At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown thought to himself: 'A woman who knows the king's mind is indeed a precious jewel woman.'

Then, not long afterward, from within the king's palace there appeared a precious jewel gem resembling a great blue beryl (*vaiḍūrya*), as large as a man's thigh. This precious jewel gem illuminated the darkness all around to a distance of one league, and even should raindrops fall as thick as the axle-shaft of a chariot, by the power of that precious jewel gem a canopy would form all around to a distance of one league, and not a drop of rain would fall through. At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown thought: 'If a wheel-turning king obtains this precious jewel gem, he is without doubt a wheel-turning king.'

Then, not long afterward, there spontaneously appeared a minister who was lord over the treasury, with very many precious jewels, exceedingly wealthy, with measureless storehouses completely full, lacking nothing, never at a loss, who through the faculty of a meritorious eye could see all the treasure that existed beneath the earth, and who served the king's wishes exactly as desired. At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown, in order to test him, boarded a vessel and set out upon the great ocean. The king commanded him thus: 'I desire various kinds of precious jewels.' As soon as the minister heard those words, he reached both hands into the ocean and drew them out, and on his ten fingers there appeared ten treasuries of precious gems. He offered them

to the king and said: 'Great King, take as much as you desire and cast what remains back into the ocean.' At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown was supremely joyful and declared: 'I am assuredly a wheel-turning king!'

Then, not long afterward, there appeared a minister who was lord over the army, exceedingly capable and courageous, supremely skilled in the stratagems of war, and highly expert in commanding the fourfold host of troops.

When advancing against other kings, he would make the army openly visible; when there was no adversary, he remained unseen. He was skilled in subduing those not yet subdued, and exceedingly capable of protecting by force those who had already been subdued.

At that time, King Born-from-the-Crown thought to himself: "A wheel-turning king possesses this precious minister of the army. I am assuredly a wheel-turning king." Then the wheel-turning King Born-from-the-Crown declared to his ministers: "Know this well. Here in this Jambudvīpa all has become supremely happy and prosperous, and I now possess the seven precious treasures and a thousand sons. What more is there to do?" The ministers replied: "It is so, Great King. Yet the eastern continent called Videha has not yet been subdued. If it will not heed the royal command, it should be brought under subjection." Then the wheel-turning king, together with the seven precious treasures, rose up into the sky with all his retinue and set out for the eastern continent of Videha. All the people of that continent, filled with joy, submitted to his command.

Then the king again declared to his ministers: "The southern Jambudvīpa and the eastern continent of Videha have become supremely prosperous, and all have submitted to my command. I possess the seven precious treasures and a thousand sons. What more is there yet to do?" The ministers replied: "It is so, Great King. Yet the western continent called Aparagodānīya has not yet been subdued." Then the king, together with the seven precious treasures, rose up into the sky with all his retinue and set out for the western continent of Aparagodānīya. No sooner had he arrived there than all the people dwelling there submitted to his command.

Again he declared to his ministers: "The people dwelling in the southern Jambudvīpa, the eastern Videha, and the western Aparagodānīya are all supremely prosperous and happy, and have submitted to my command. I possess the seven precious treasures and a thousand sons. What else is there

yet to do?" The ministers replied: "It is so, Great King. Yet the northern continent called Uttarakuru has not yet been subdued." Then the king, together with the seven precious treasures, rose up high into the sky with all his retinue and set out for the northern Uttarakuru. No sooner had he arrived there than all the people dwelling there were filled with great joy and submitted to his command.

Then once more he declared to his ministers: "The people dwelling in all four continents are supremely joyful and content, and have submitted to my command. I possess the seven precious treasures and a thousand sons. What else is there yet to do?" The ministers replied: "It is so, Great King. Yet the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three are exceedingly long-lived and supremely happy. Their bodies are most excellent and incomparable. Their palaces for residing, their thrones for sitting, and their beds for sleeping are made exclusively of the seven precious gems. They are proud of their divine merit, and should they not heed the royal command, they too should be brought under subjection and subdued." Then the wheel-turning king, together with the seven precious treasures, rose up high into the sky with all his retinue and set out for the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. Upon arriving there, he saw a tree whose foliage was of a blue color, and he asked his ministers: "What is this thing of blue hue?" The ministers replied: "This is called the Pārijāta tree. The gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three take their pleasure and delight beneath this tree during the three months of summer." He also saw something of a white color, resembling a white cloud, and he asked: "What is this?" The ministers replied:

"This is called the Assembly Hall of Goodly Dharma of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. The gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three gather here and speak of matters concerning gods and humans." At that time, Śakra (Indra, king of the gods) learned that the wheel-turning king had come, and went out to receive him. Taking him by the hand, he led him inside, and in the Assembly Hall of Goodly Dharma he spread out half his own seat and they sat together. When the two kings sat side by side, there was no difference between them in form, appearance, and marks; they differed only in the movement and blinking of their eyes. At that time the wheel-turning king thought to himself: "Should I overpower this king of the gods by force and make his domain my own?" Noble son, at that time and on that very occasion, Śakra was performing the work of holding, preserving, reading, reciting, and expounding to others the sūtras of the Great Vehicle — though without having

penetrated to exhaustion the meaning of the profoundly deep. And it was by reason and condition of that — of holding, preserving, reading, reciting, and broadly expounding to others those Great Vehicle sūtras — that he had come to be endowed with such great majesty and splendor. Noble son, at that time, because the wheel-turning king had aroused malicious thoughts toward Śakra, he fell immediately back down to Jambudvīpa and was parted from both the gods of the desire realm and from humans, and great suffering arose in him. Then he was struck by illness and passed away. Noble son, he who was Śakra at that time and on that occasion is none other than the buddha Kāśyapa. And that wheel-turning king is none other than myself at the present time. Noble son, therefore you should understand that to be parted from desired things brings great suffering. Noble son, if a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, recalls the suffering of separation experienced in times past, how much more will such a bodhisattva understand the suffering of separation from desired things in the present time.

Noble son, how then does a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, understand the suffering of encountering what one hates and fears? Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, understands that in the hells, in the realms of birth among animals, in the world of the Lord of Death, and among humans and gods alike, there is what is called the suffering of encountering what one hates and fears. Just as a person imprisoned, seized, bound, placed in irons, put in a pillory, or locked in the stocks is seen to be in great suffering, so too does the bodhisattva, the great being, understand that all sentient beings throughout the five paths of wandering are in great suffering from encountering what they hate and fear. Noble son, consider further this example: a person who, out of fear of an enemy, of a pit, of irons, or of a pillory, abandons father and mother, wife, children, retinue, and all his precious belongings, and flees and escapes along a long road. Noble son, the bodhisattva, the great being, is likewise: fearing saṃsāra, he practices the six perfections to completion and enters into nirvāṇa. This, Kāśyapa, is called understanding the suffering of encountering what one hates and fears, on the part of a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa.

Noble son, how then does a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, understand the suffering of not obtaining what one desires?

Desire is the desire for everything. And the desire for everything is of two kinds: the desire for virtuous phenomena and the desire for non-virtuous phenomena. Not obtaining virtuous phenomena is suffering, and not being free from non-virtuous phenomena is suffering. These are a brief account of the suffering of the five aggregates. Kāśyapa, these are called the truth of suffering.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Kāśyapa, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I do not think it correct that the Blessed One has declared the five aggregates to be suffering. Why is that? The Blessed One once said to the great Śākya chieftain: 'If form were suffering, it would be improper for all sentient beings to desire form; yet since they all desire it, it cannot be called suffering.' And the Blessed One also declared to the monks: 'Feeling has three kinds — pleasant feeling, painful feeling, and feeling that is neither pleasant nor painful.' Previously the Blessed One said to the monks: 'Whoever applies themselves diligently to virtuous phenomena will come to experience happiness.' And the Blessed One also said: 'Even through contact with the six sense objects of a virtuous continuum, happiness will be experienced — if the eye sees a beautiful form, that too is happiness; and likewise pleasant contact through the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, and the mind is also happiness.' And the Blessed One declared in verse:

One who holds moral discipline is happy
and does not experience the suffering of the body.
Even when lying down in sleep, one finds happiness,
and upon waking, the mind is filled with joy.

Whether receiving robes and alms,
or reading, meditating, and teaching,
or dwelling at last in a hermitage, a mountain, or a grove —
in these one attains supreme happiness.

Whoever, with compassion for the many
day and night and without ceasing,
does no harm to others —
by that very condition, is always happy.

Desiring little and knowing contentment — this is happiness.
Likewise, much learning is happiness.
The arhats who are free from attachment
are called supremely happy.

The bodhisattva, the great being,
who has reached the far shore of the perfections
and has completed all that is to be done —
that one is called supremely happy.

Blessed One, since this is what you have described as the characteristic of happiness in other sūtras, and if the Blessed One has said what has been said, can these meanings be consistent?"

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Most excellent! Noble son, it is good that you have asked the Tathāgata about these meanings. Noble son, all sentient beings forcibly perceive even the worst suffering as happiness. Therefore, explaining this characteristic of suffering is no different from what was said before."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as the Blessed One has previously said, if one generates the perception of happiness even toward the worst suffering — then toward the worst birth, the worst aging, the worst illness, the worst death, the worst separation from what one desires, the worst not obtaining what one desires, the worst encounter with what one hates, and the worst of the five aggregates and so forth — in all these sufferings there can likewise be happiness. Blessed One, what is called 'the worst birth' refers to the three lower destinies. What is called 'middling birth' refers to birth among human beings. And what is called 'the best birth' refers to birth as a god in the higher realms. If then someone were to say: 'I perceive the worst happiness as suffering, the middling happiness as free of suffering and pleasant, and the best happiness as truly happy' — if someone were to ask that, what answer should one give?"

Blessed One, perceiving the worst suffering as happiness — for example, if someone is being flogged with a thousand strokes, and after the very first stroke has landed they were to perceive it as happiness, that perception of happiness would not be valid. So why would one perceive the worst suffering as happiness?

The Blessed One declared to Kāśyapa: "That is indeed so. That is indeed so. It is just as you have said. Seen in that light, there is no such thing as a perception of happiness. Why is that? For example, a man is being flogged with a thousand strokes. When one stroke lands and is let pass, at that moment a perception of happiness arises in him. Therefore, where there is no happiness, one forcefully generates a perception of happiness."

Kāśyapa said: "It is not that the man perceives happiness at the landing of that one stroke. Rather, he perceives happiness because he is delivered from more."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, this is precisely why my earlier teaching that there is happiness in the five aggregates, given to the great Śākya clan, was perfectly true and not false. Kāśyapa, there are three kinds of feeling and three kinds of suffering. The three kinds of feeling are as follows: pleasant feeling, painful feeling, and feeling that is neither painful nor pleasant. The three kinds of suffering are the suffering of suffering, the suffering of formations, and the suffering of change. Noble son, painful feeling is associated with all three sufferings — the suffering of suffering, the suffering of formations, and the suffering of change. The remaining two feelings are associated with the suffering of formations and the suffering of change. Noble son, it is by reason of causes and conditions such as these that genuine pleasant feeling exists even within birth and death. The great bodhisattva, understanding that suffering and happiness are not in fact two different things, teaches that all is suffering. Noble son, within birth and death there is in truth no happiness; when buddhas and bodhisattvas say that there is happiness, they say so in accordance with worldly convention."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked the Blessed One: "When buddhas and bodhisattvas speak in conformity with the world and teach in that way, does that not become falsehood? According to what the Blessed One has taught, whoever performs virtuous deeds will experience the fruit of those deeds. By guarding ethical discipline one obtains physical well-being, is free from suffering, and all one's purposes are fulfilled — this becomes the highest happiness. And those passages in various sūtras and so forth that speak of experiencing happiness — would those too not then become falsehood? If they were to be falsehood, then consider: the Blessed One the Buddha, over the course of hundreds of thousands of immeasurable and incalculable aeons of pursuing awakening, thoroughly abandoned all false speech. How then is one to understand the meaning of such statements?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, the happiness spoken of in the verses quoted earlier is the root of the path to awakening — through it, unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening itself arises. It was for this reason that the defining characteristic of happiness was described in that way in those sūtras. Noble son, for example, the enjoyment of worldly resources for one's needs becomes a cause of happiness and is accordingly called happiness. Such

things include a fine wife, pleasing wine, the finest food, encounter with water when one is parched with thirst, encounter with fire in the cold, clothing, bodily adornments, woolen and silk fabrics, horses and chariots, male and female servants, hired laborers, gold, silver, lapis lazuli (vaiḍūrya), coral, pearls, treasure-houses,

barley, rice, and the like are worldly necessities; because they become causes of happiness, they are accordingly called happiness. Noble son, those very same things and others like them also produce suffering. For instance, on account of women, men are caused to suffer, to grieve, to mourn, to beat their breasts, and even to have their lives cut short. From fine wine and food all the way to treasure-houses, great suffering too can arise. Therefore, all of it is suffering, and there is no defining characteristic of happiness in any of it.

Noble son, a great bodhisattva (bodhisattva mahāsattva) recognizes all eight kinds of suffering as suffering, and sees no happiness in them. Noble son, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and the like do not understand the causes of happiness, and it is for that reason that they declare there to be a defining characteristic of happiness in what is ultimately suffering. Only a bodhisattva who abides in the sūtra of the Great Vehicle, the Mahāparinirvāṇa, truly comprehends and understands both the causes of suffering and the causes of happiness.

Noble son, one may ask: in what way does a great bodhisattva who abides in the Mahāparinirvāṇa sūtra of the Great Vehicle come to comprehend the truth of the origin of suffering? Noble son, the great bodhisattva comprehends this truth of the origin as the cause and condition of the aggregates. What is called "origin" is craving (Skt. tṛṣṇā) for renewed existence, and craving is of two kinds: craving for one's own body, and craving for what one needs.

Again, there are two kinds: single-mindedly seeking after the five objects of desire that have not yet been obtained, and enduring with strong attachment once they have been found.

Again, there are three kinds: craving of the desire realm, craving of the form realm, and craving of the formless realm.

Again, there are three further kinds: craving for the cause and condition of karma, craving for the cause and condition of affliction, and craving for the cause and condition of suffering.

For those who have gone forth into renunciation, craving is of four kinds: craving for robes, craving for alms-food, craving for bedding and seats, and craving for medicine as a condition when ill.

Again, there are five kinds: through attachment to the five aggregates, one craves after everything in pursuit of what one needs. Conceptual elaboration is boundless and without end.

Noble son, craving too is of two kinds: craving for virtue, and craving for non-virtue. Only the foolish crave non-virtue. Bodhisattvas crave virtue. As for craving virtuous Dharma, that too is of two kinds, non-virtuous and virtuous: seeking either of the two lower vehicles is non-virtuous, while seeking the Great Vehicle is virtuous.

Noble son, the craving of childish, ignoble persons is called "origin" and is not a truth. The craving of bodhisattvas is called a truth and is not the origin. Why is that? Because they take birth for the sake of liberating sentient beings, not because they crave rebirth.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, Bhagavān, in other sūtras you have taught that karma becomes a cause and condition for sentient beings; elsewhere you have taught that pride becomes a cause; elsewhere that the six tangible objects become a cause; and elsewhere that ignorance becomes the five aggregates and thereby becomes a cause and condition. Why then, of all the Four Noble Truths, did you teach that craving alone, defined as its characteristic, becomes the cause of the five aggregates?

The Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: Excellent, excellent! Noble son, it is just as you have said. Other causes and conditions also do indeed become causes, but in brief, the cause of the five aggregates is none other than craving.

Noble son, here is an analogy. When a great king goes on a journey, his chief ministers and retinue follow after him. Craving is just the same: wherever craving moves, all the afflictions follow after it. Again, it is like cloth that has become oily — dust will cling wherever the oil has soaked. Craving is just the same: wherever craving acts through karma, the afflictions too take up their dwelling there.

Noble son, here is another analogy. Wherever the ground is moist, a sprout will grow. Craving is just the same: it causes all the sprouts of karmic affliction to

arise.

Noble son, bodhisattvas (bodhisattvas), great beings who abide in the thorough passing beyond sorrow of the Great Vehicle, understand craving under nine aspects. They are: like a debt that keeps accumulating interest; like a wife who is a demoness; like a venomous serpent coiled around a beautiful flowering tree; like food that is unpleasant and unwanted yet forced down nonetheless; like a woman who sells snakes; like the fruit of the bāluká plant; like flesh healing over a wound; like a violent wind; and like a shooting star.

How is it like a debt that keeps accumulating interest? Noble son, consider a poor man who has fallen into debt and finds himself overwhelmed by it — grasped by the body at the end, he cannot get free. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are the same: because the residual traces of the habitual tendencies of craving remain, they cannot awaken to the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Thus it is called being like a debt that keeps accumulating interest.

Noble son, how is it like a wife who is a demoness? Noble son, consider a man who takes a demoness as his wife: the moment she gives birth to a child, she devours that child. When the child is gone, she devours the husband as well. Noble son, the demoness of craving is just the same: whatever roots of virtue sentient beings generate, she destroys the very moment they arise. Having exhausted their roots of virtue, she causes sentient beings to be born in the hells, in the realm of the animals, and in the world of Yama — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like a wife who is a demoness.

Noble son, how is it like a venomous serpent coiled around a beautiful flowering tree? Consider someone who is fond of beautiful flowers, and not knowing that a venomous serpent lurks around the flowering tree, draws near and takes hold of a flower. The moment he takes hold of it, the serpent seizes him and he meets his death. All those of inferior character are likewise: attached to the flowers of the five objects of desire, and not knowing that there is danger in the form of the venomous serpent of craving, they reach out and take hold. Having grasped them, they are seized by the venom of craving, they die, and they fall into the three lower realms — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like a venomous serpent coiled around a beautiful flowering tree.

Noble son, how is it like food that is unpleasant and forced down against one's will? Consider someone who forces down food that is unpleasant and repugnant: the moment he has eaten it, his stomach gives him pain; he vomits with fever and dies. The food of craving is just the same: sentient beings of the five paths who cling to craving compulsively, through that very cause and that very condition, fall into the three lower realms — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like food that is unpleasant and forced down.

Noble son, how is it like a woman who sells snakes? Consider how foolish men are beguiled by a snake-selling woman, and by her seductions and various tricks she robs the man of all his wealth.

Once his wealth is exhausted, she drives him away. The snake-woman of craving is just the same: foolish men without wisdom who rely upon her have all their virtuous qualities stripped away by that very craving. Having exhausted all virtuous qualities, they are driven and cast into the three lower realms — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like a woman who sells snakes.

Noble son, how is it like the fruit of the bāluka plant? Consider how when the fruit of the bāluka is eaten, the moment it is swallowed it comes back out, strikes the ground, is carried off by the wind, and reaches the foot of a tree; there it sprouts immediately, winds itself around that very tree, and causes it to stop growing — even a nyagrodha tree of great size — and to wither away entirely. The fruit of the bāluka of craving is just the same: whatever roots of virtue the foolish and ignoble possess are strangled and choked so that they neither grow nor flourish, until at last they are utterly exhausted and destroyed. Having been withered and destroyed, after death one falls into the three lower realms — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like the fruit of the bāluka plant.

Noble son, how is it like flesh within a wound? Consider how when a person has been wounded and the flesh within the wound is raw, it must be treated and cannot simply be left alone. If it is left untreated, the wound festers and worms enter it, and through that very condition it can bring about the end of one's life. The fruit of the five sense pleasures for the childish and foolish is just the same: craving is like raw flesh within a wound, and so it must be treated with diligence. If the raw flesh of craving is not treated, the moment one passes from this life one falls into the three lower realms — with the sole

exception of bodhisattvas.

Noble son, how is it like a violent storm? Consider how when a violent storm arises, it levels mountains, scatters boulders, and uproots trees from their very roots. The violent storm of craving is just the same: it stirs up malicious thoughts even toward one's own father and mother, and it uproots from their very foundation even the most firmly established roots of the unsurpassed awakening — the supreme summit of great wisdom — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like a violent storm.

How is it like a comet? Consider how when a comet appears, famine, sickness, and strife arise in whatever land it appears over. The comet of craving is just the same: it severs the seeds of all roots of virtue, causing the foolish and ignoble to fall into poverty and destitution, to meet with famine, to fall prey to the sickness of afflictions, and to revolve in saṃsāra experiencing suffering in its many forms — with the sole exception of bodhisattvas. Thus it is called being like a comet.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle, the Mahāparinirvāṇa, understands the defilement of craving in precisely these nine aspects.

Noble son, therefore, the foolish and ignoble have suffering but they do not have the truth of suffering. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have suffering and they also have the truth of suffering, but they do not have the genuine truth. Bodhisattvas know suffering and are free from suffering; therefore they do not have suffering as such, yet they do have the genuine truth.

The foolish and ignoble have the origin of suffering but do not have the truth. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have the origin and also have the truth of the origin. Bodhisattvas know the origin and are free from the origin; therefore they do not have the origin as such, yet they do have the genuine truth.

The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have cessation, but it is not genuine. Bodhisattvas, the great beings, have cessation and they also have the genuine truth.

The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have the path, but it is not the genuine truth. Bodhisattvas, the great beings, have the path and they also have the genuine truth.

Sons of good family, how is it that when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, they see cessation and see the

noble truth of cessation? It is as follows: the complete cutting off of all afflictions — this is called permanence. Because the fire of affliction has been extinguished, it is called perfect peace. Because the afflictions have been arrested, one comes to experience bliss. Because buddhas and bodhisattvas accept dependent origination, it is called complete purity. Because one does not take up again the twenty-five modes of existence, it is called transcendence of the world. Because one has transcended the world, it is called self. Because one does not grasp as a characteristic mark any of the following — form, sound, smell, taste, or touch; male or female; birth, abiding, or cessation; suffering, bliss, or that which is neither suffering nor bliss — it is called the genuine truth of perfect, supreme peace, the consummation. Sons of good family, in this way it is said that a bodhisattva abiding in the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa thoroughly understands the noble truth of cessation.

Sons of good family, how is it that when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the Mahāyāna Great Nirvāṇa, they understand the noble truth of the path? Sons of good family, it is like this: when a lamp is lit inside a dark chamber, everything within it, great and small, becomes visible. A bodhisattva, a great being, is just like that. Those who abide in the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa come to see all phenomena through the condition of the noble eightfold path — namely, the permanent and the impermanent, the conditioned and the unconditioned, sentient being and non-sentient being, existent thing and non-existent thing, bliss and suffering, self and no-self, purity and impurity, affliction and non-affliction, karma and non-karma, truth and non-truth, vehicle and non-vehicle, knowing and not-knowing, quality and non-quality, owner and non-owner, the seen and the unseen, form and formlessness, path and non-path, wisdom and non-wisdom.

Sons of good family, in this way it is said that a bodhisattva abiding in the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa thoroughly understands the noble truth of the path.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, if the noble eightfold path is the noble truth, that does not seem consistent in its meaning. Why? Because the Tathāgata has on some occasions declared that faith of mind, for the sake of liberating those with defiled outflows, is the path. On some occasions he has declared that heedfulness is the path — and it has also been said that when the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, practice heedfulness they thereby fully awaken to unsurpassable,

perfect, complete awakening, and so it is a component of the bodhisattva's path. On some occasions he has declared that diligence is the path — and in that connection he spoke to Ānanda:

"Ānanda, one who strenuously applies diligence will fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening." He also declared this.

On some occasions he declared that close application of mindfulness to the body, with the mind focused one-pointedly — that is, diligently attending to close application of mindfulness to the body — will bring one to full awakening in unsurpassable, perfect, complete enlightenment.

On some occasions he also declared that right meditative absorption is the path. In that connection, as he spoke to the great Kāśyapa: right meditative absorption is the path; he did not say that what is not right meditative absorption is the path. He further declared that one who has entered meditative absorption will be able to attend mentally to the arising and cessation of the five aggregates, whereas one who has not entered meditative absorption will not be capable of such mental attention.

On some occasions he declared: one who cultivates and diligently applies a single thing — that being the meditative absorption of recollection of the buddha — will completely purify all sentient beings of their anguish, suffering, and distress, and will attain the authentic Dharma.

On some occasions he also declared that meditation on impermanence is the path. In that connection he spoke to the monks: one who meditates extensively on impermanence will fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

On some occasions he also declared: dwelling alone at the very end of profound solitude and attending to it with the mind, one will swiftly fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

On some occasions he also declared that teaching the Dharma to others is the path — for by hearing the Dharma the net of doubt is cut through, and by cutting through the net of doubt one fully awakens to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

On some occasions he declared that guarding moral discipline is the path. In that connection he spoke to Ānanda: Ānanda, one who applies extreme diligence to guarding moral discipline will cross beyond the ocean of saṃsāra.

On some occasions he declared that relying upon a spiritual friend is the path. In that connection he spoke to Ānanda: one who relies upon a spiritual friend will come to have completely pure moral discipline; and any sentient being who pays homage to me will give rise to the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

On some occasions he also declared that cultivating loving-kindness is the path — for one who cultivates loving-kindness will sever all mental afflictions and attain a state of unshakeable stability.

On some occasions he declared that wisdom is the path. In that connection, the Blessed One formerly spoke to the nun, the mother of the people, calling her "sister," and declared that the śrāvakas too, with the weapon of wisdom, cut through the afflictions together with the defilements of existence.

On some occasions the Tathāgata also declared that generosity is the path. In that connection the buddha, the Blessed One, formerly spoke thus to the king Utterly-Vanquished-in-Battle: "Great King, know that it is because I practiced generosity extensively in the past, and through that cause and that condition, that I have awakened as a buddha to unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening."

If this is so, Blessed One — if you have declared that the noble eightfold path is the truth of the path — do not the declarations in other sūtras of those things become false? And if what arises from those sūtras is not false, why did those sūtras also not say that the noble eightfold path is the truth of the path?

Since it was not declared in that way, what the Tathāgata declared in former times would likewise appear to be mistaken. Yet I am certain that the Blessed One, the Buddha, has been utterly free from error for a very long time.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, it is very fine that you have asked this, wishing to understand the profoundly deep meaning of the sūtra collections of the Great Vehicle for bodhisattvas. Son of good family, those sūtra collections, each and every one of them, do lead into the truth of the path. Son of good family, faith is the path. That is to say, faith is the path, for faith is the root and thereby becomes a companion on the path to awakening. Therefore in what I have declared there is no error.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata, being supremely skilled in means without limit, has spoken in just that way, in all those various aspects, for the sake of

taming sentient beings. Son of good family, here is an analogy: a skilled physician, thoroughly expert in the many different kinds of illness that afflict sentient beings, prescribes medicine to each patient according to their condition. And when showing what is unsuitable as a remedy among medicines, there is nothing except water alone that is excluded. And that water takes such forms as bitter-gourd juice, sugarcane juice, black molasses juice, āmalaka juice, nīpāla juice, pārāhala juice, cold water, hot water, winter water, Nepali citrus water, and the like. Son of good family, even skilled physicians who are expert in the various kinds of illness, while having many remedies unsuitable as antidotes, do not exclude water from among them.

The Tathāgata is like that as well. Through his supreme skill in means, he expands and teaches, with this or that name and characteristic suited to each different kind of sentient being, one single defining mark of the Dharma. And sentient beings in turn take up the practice just as they have been taught. Having taken it up and applied themselves diligently, all their mental afflictions are purified — just as a patient, by following a physician's instruction, is cured of illness.

Son of good family, here is another analogy: a person skilled in every kind of language is sitting among a great crowd of people, and every single person in the crowd is tormented by thirst and cries out, 'I am thirsty! I want water!' That person then gives them, each according to their way, clean cold water — and each one names it differently: some say 'I want water,' others say 'pāṇi,' others say 'udī,' others say 'salema,' others say 'sali,' others say 'pana,' others say 'nectar,' others say 'milk.' In this way, that person speaks to the assembly using countless names for water.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata is like that as well. With one single noble path, he expands and teaches to the śrāvakas everything from the faculty of faith through to the noble eightfold path.

Son of good family, here is yet another analogy: a skilled goldsmith takes a single piece of gold and fashions from it all manner of bodily ornaments as he pleases — such as bangles, rings, earrings, crowns, armlets, and many other kinds besides. Though they differ from one another, they are nothing other than gold.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata is like that as well. From one single path, a buddha unfolds and teaches it to sentient beings in many different aspects, and at various junctures teaches it as a single aspect. Thus it is said: the

awakening of all the buddhas is one — it is without duality. Yet it is also said to have two aspects: meditative absorption and wisdom. It is further said to have three aspects: view, gnosis, and wisdom. And it is said to have four aspects: the path of seeing, the path of cultivation, the path of no-more-learning, and"

the path of the buddhas. It is also said to have five aspects: the path of practice through faith, the path of practice through Dharma, the path of liberation through faith, the path of arriving through vision, and the path of realization through the body. It is further said to have six aspects: the path of stream-entry, the path of once-returning, the path of non-returning, the path of the arhat, the path of the pratyekabuddha, and the path of the buddhas. It is said to have seven aspects: the awakening factor of mindfulness, the awakening factor of discernment of phenomena, the awakening factor of diligence, the awakening factor of joy, the awakening factor of pliancy, the awakening factor of meditative absorption, and the awakening factor of equanimity. It is said to have eight aspects: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right meditative absorption. It is said to have nine aspects: the eight branches of the noble path, together with faith. It is said to have ten aspects: the ten powers. It is said to have eleven aspects: the ten powers and great loving-kindness. It is said to have twelve aspects: the ten powers, great loving-kindness, and great compassion. It is said to have thirteen aspects: the ten powers, great loving-kindness, great compassion, and the meditative absorption of recollecting the buddhas. It is said to have sixteen aspects: the ten powers, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the meditative absorption of recollecting the buddhas, and the three foundations of mindfulness perfectly established by the buddhas. It is said to have twenty aspects: the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the meditative absorption of recollecting the buddhas, and the three foundations of mindfulness.

Son of good family, all these paths are one single thing. The Tathāgata has taught them in many different aspects for the sake of sentient beings of former times.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: fire, which is one single thing in its essence, gives rise to many fires from its burning. Thus it is named in many aspects: the fire of wood, the fire of grass, the fire of chaff, the fire of horse-dung, and the fire of cow-dung. Son of good family, the path of the buddhas is likewise one and without duality, yet for the sake of sentient beings

it has been divided and taught in many different aspects.

Son of good family, consider this further analogy: from a single consciousness, six aspects are distinguished and taught. At the occasion of the eye it is named eye-consciousness, and so on up to mental consciousness — this should be understood in full in the same way. Son of good family, the path too is like that: one and without duality, yet the Tathāgata has divided and taught it in many different aspects in order to tame sentient beings.

Son of good family, consider this further analogy: a single thing — like form — is called form when seen by the eye; it is named sound when heard by the ear; it is called smell when encountered by the nose; it is called taste when experienced by the tongue; and it is named tangible object when felt by the body. Son of good family, the path too is like that: one and without duality, yet it has been divided and taught in many different aspects in order to tame sentient beings.

Son of good family, for this very reason, the eight branches of the noble path are also to be called the truth of the noble path.

Son of good family, the buddha, the Blessed One, taught the Four Noble Truths in sequence, and through that cause and those conditions, immeasurable numbers of sentient beings were liberated from cyclic existence.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, once in a former time you were dwelling in a grove called Śiśumāra on the bank of the Gaṅgā river. At that time the Tathāgata took up a single leaf with his hand and declared to the monks: 'Are the leaves now in my hand many, or are the leaves of all the grasses, trees, and other plants that grow upon the great earth many?' The monks replied: 'The leaves of the grasses and trees that grow upon the earth are exceedingly many — beyond reckoning. The leaves held in the Tathāgata's hand are extremely few — not worth mentioning.' The Blessed One then declared: 'Monks, all the phenomena I have realized are like the leaves of the grasses and trees that grow on the great earth. What I have taught to sentient beings is like the leaves held in my hand.'"

Kāśyapa continued: "Blessed One, when you spoke those words at that time, the Tathāgata had realized immeasurable phenomena. If all of these are included within the Four Noble Truths, then the Tathāgata had already taught them before. But if they are not included, then there would have to be a fifth truth."

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, your asking this question was asked well, for the sake of the benefit and happiness of immeasurable sentient beings. Son of good family, all phenomena whatsoever are indeed included within the Four Noble Truths."

Kāśyapa asked again: "If all phenomena are included within the Four Noble Truths, why did the Tathāgata merely mention this rather than explain it in detail?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, although they are indeed included within it, one should not speak of it as having been taught and explained in full. Why is that? Son of good family, there are two kinds of wisdom in the realization of the Noble Truths: the middling and the superior. The middling is the wisdom of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. The superior is the gnosis of buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Son of good family, to understand the aggregates as suffering — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze the aggregates into innumerable defining characteristics and to know all of them as suffering in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. Son of good family, these meanings were not taught by me even in the sūtras.

Son of good family, to know engagement is also called a gateway, and it is also called suffering — that is middling wisdom. To analyze it into its various defining characteristics and to know all of them as suffering in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras.

Son of good family, to know the elements (dhātu) is also called a limb, and also a defining characteristic, and also suffering — that is middling wisdom. To analyze the elements into their innumerable defining characteristics and to know all of them as suffering in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. Son of good family, these meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras.

Son of good family, to know form as having the defining characteristic of disintegration — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze form into its various defining characteristics and to know all of them as suffering in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know

— that is called superior gnosis.

These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know feeling as having the defining characteristic of feeling — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze feeling into its various defining characteristics in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. Son of good family, these meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know perception as having the defining characteristic of apprehension — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze perception into its various defining characteristics of apprehension in a way that lies beyond the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know formations as having the defining characteristic of construction — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze formations into their various defining characteristics of construction in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can come to know — that is called superior gnosis. Son of good family, these meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know consciousness as having the defining characteristic of discrimination — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze consciousness into its various defining characteristics of knowing in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. Son of good family, these meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras.

The noble Great Sūtra of the Parinirvāṇa, the eighteenth fascicle.

Son of good family, to know that the five aggregates arise through the condition of desire — that is called middling wisdom. To know all the various desires that arise in a single person — desires that even immeasurable and boundless śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot know — and to know all the various desires that arise in all sentient beings — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know that afflictions are ceased — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze afflictions, which are immeasurable, together with their cessations, which are likewise immeasurable, in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know that afflictions are abandoned by means of the defining characteristics of the path — that is called middling wisdom. Son of good

family, to analyze the defining characteristics of the path, which are immeasurable and boundless, together with the afflictions to be abandoned, which are likewise immeasurable and boundless, in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know conventional truth — that is called middling wisdom. To analyze conventional truth, which is immeasurable, boundless, and incalculable, in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras. Son of good family, to know that all formations are impermanent, that all phenomena are without self, and that nirvāṇa is peace — knowing these as ultimate truth — that is called middling wisdom. To know ultimate truth in its immeasurable, boundless, and incalculable dimensions in a way that does not lie within the domain of what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know — that is called superior gnosis. These meanings too were not taught by me in those sūtras.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Mañjuśrī the Ever-Youthful, addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, what is the meaning of what are called conventional truth and ultimate truth? Blessed One, does conventional truth exist within ultimate truth?

Mañjuśrī continued: Does ultimate truth exist within conventional truth? If it does, then truth would be one. If it does not, would not what the Tathāgata has taught be false?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, conventional truth itself is ultimate truth.

Mañjuśrī replied: Blessed One, in that case the two truths do not exist.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is through supreme skillful means, following along with sentient beings, that the two truths have been taught. Son of good family, in terms of verbal expression there are two aspects: worldly phenomena and transcendent phenomena. Son of good family, what is known by a person who has transcended the world is called ultimate truth. What is known by a worldly person is called conventional truth.

Son of good family, the word "self" is imputed on the basis of an assemblage of the five aggregates, and because uninstructed sentient beings follow after that imputation, it is called conventional truth. To know that there is no self in the aggregates, and to know that there is no self beyond the aggregates either

— that is called transcendent. To know the defining marks just as they are is called ultimate truth.

Furthermore, son of good family, there are phenomena that have both a name and a result, and phenomena that have a name but no result. Son of good family, what has a name but no result is conventional truth. What has both a name and a result is ultimate truth.

Son of good family, just as it is with "self" — so too with "sentient being," "life-force," "consciousness," "one who sees," "one who lives," "the virile one," "lord of vitality," "feeling," "the one who acts," the mirage of heat in the summer season, the city of the gandharvas (celestial fragrance-eaters), the hair of a tortoise, the horn of a hare, the wheel formed by whirling a firebrand, as well as the aggregates, the elements, and the sense bases — all of these are called conventional truth. Suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path are called ultimate truth.

Son of good family, worldly phenomena are of five kinds: the world of names, the world of words, the world of bindings, the world of conventions, and the world of attachments — five in all.

Son of good family, what is the world of names? Things such as man, woman, pot, cloth, chariot, and house — that is called the world of names.

What is the world of words? A single verse of four lines — verses such as these are called the world of words.

What is the world of bindings? Tying, joining, knotting cords, wrapping, binding, and pressing the palms together — these are called the world of bindings.

What is the world of conventions? When a wooden board is struck, the Saṅgha assembles; when a drum is struck, warriors gather; when a conch is blown, people know the time — that is called the world of conventions.

What is the world of attachments? For example, when from a great distance one sees a person wearing robes of varied colors, one forms the attachment: "That is a śramaṇa (a wandering renunciant), not a brahmin." When one sees someone carrying knotted cords and a scraper at the shoulder, one thinks: "That is a brahmin, not a śramaṇa." That is called the world of attachments.

Son of good family, these are the five kinds of worldly phenomena.

Son of good family, if an ordinary person understands these five kinds of worldly phenomena with a mind that is not inverted, knowing them just as they truly are, that is called ultimate truth.

Furthermore, son of good family, what is burnt, cut, broken, and destroyed is called conventional truth. What is not burnt, not cut, not broken, and not destroyed is called ultimate truth.

Furthermore, son of good family, suffering together with its eight defining marks is called conventional truth. No birth, no aging, no sickness, no death, no separation from what one loves, no meeting with what one hates, no failing to obtain what one desires, no five aggregates — this is called ultimate truth.

Furthermore, son of good family, consider the example of a person of many skills: when he is running, he is called a runner; when he is plowing a field, he is called a farmer; when he is stirring food, he is called a cook; when he is working wood, he is called a carpenter; when he is beating gold and silver, he is called a goldsmith. In this way, a single person may be designated by many names. The Dharma, likewise, is truly one, yet it is designated by many names. What is born from the union and coming together of father and mother is called conventional truth. What is born from the assembly of the twelve links of dependent origination is called ultimate truth.

The great bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of what is called genuine truth?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what is called genuine truth is what is genuinely the Dharma. Son of good family, whatever is not genuinely the Dharma is not genuine truth. Son of good family, what is called genuine truth is what is without inversion; what is without inversion is called genuine truth. Son of good family, genuine truth is that in which there is nothing false. Whatever contains falsity is not to be called genuine truth. Son of good family, genuine truth is the Great Vehicle; what is not the Great Vehicle is not to be called genuine truth. Son of good family, genuine truth is what is spoken by the buddhas; it is not what is spoken by māra. What is spoken by māra and is not spoken by the buddhas is not to be called genuine truth. Son of good family, what is called genuine truth is a single path of complete purity — there is no second. Son of good family, permanence, bliss, self, and complete purity — these are called the meaning of genuine truth."

The youthful Mañjuśrī then asked again: "Blessed One, if what is genuine is genuine truth, then genuine Dharma is the emptiness of the Tathāgata and the intrinsic nature of the pratyekabuddhas. If that is so, then the Tathāgata, space itself, and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas would be without distinction."

The Blessed One then declared to Mañjuśrī: "Where there is suffering, there is truth and there is what is genuine. Where there is the origin of suffering, there is truth and there is what is genuine. Where there is cessation, there is truth and there is what is genuine. Where there is the path, there is truth and there is what is genuine. Son of good family, the Tathāgata is not suffering, is not truth in that sense, and yet is what is genuine. Emptiness, too, is not suffering, is not truth in that sense, and yet is what is genuine. The intrinsic nature of the buddhas, too, is not suffering, is not truth in that sense, and yet is what is genuine. Mañjuśrī, what is called suffering has the defining mark of impermanence and the defining mark of being subject to cutting off — and therefore it is not to be called genuine truth. The Tathāgata itself is not suffering, is not impermanent, and is not subject to cutting off — and therefore it is called what is genuine. Space and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas should likewise be understood in the same way."

"Moreover, noble son, what is called the origin of suffering is that which assembles the five aggregates and causes them to arise — and therefore it is also called suffering, also called impermanence, and is subject to cutting off; it is not to be called genuine truth.

Noble son, the Tathāgata does not have the defining mark of being the origin of suffering, is not the cause of the aggregates, and does not have the defining mark of being subject to cutting off — and therefore it is called what is genuine. Space and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas should likewise be understood in the same way.

Noble son, what is called cessation is the cessation of mental afflictions — and it is both permanent and impermanent. What is attained by the two vehicles is to be called impermanent. What is attained by the buddhas is to be called permanent, and is also to be called the phenomenon self-known through one's own awareness — and therefore it is called genuine truth.

Noble son, the Tathāgata itself is not to be called cessation, nor is it to be called the cessation of mental afflictions; it is neither permanent nor impermanent; it is not self-known through one's own awareness. It abides

permanently, is unchanging — and therefore it is called what is genuine. Space and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas should likewise be understood in the same way.

Noble son, what is called the path is that which cuts through mental afflictions. It is neither permanent nor impermanent, and because it is a phenomenon to be cultivated through meditation, it is called genuine truth. The Tathāgata is not something that cuts through mental afflictions by means of the path; it is neither permanent nor impermanent; it is not a phenomenon to be cultivated through meditation. It abides permanently, is unchanging and unshifting — and therefore it is called bliss. Space and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas should likewise be understood in the same way.

Moreover, noble son, what is called what is genuine is the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata too is what is genuine. What is genuine is space, and space too is what is genuine. What is genuine is the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas too is what is genuine.

Mañjuśrī, where there is suffering, there is the cause of suffering, the exhaustion of suffering, and the antidote to suffering. The Tathāgata is none of these — neither suffering nor anything up through the antidote — and therefore it is called what is genuine, not truth in that sense. Space and the intrinsic nature of the buddhas should likewise be understood.

Suffering is compounded, is defiled, and is unpleasant. The Tathāgata is not compounded and is not defiled — and because it is supremely blissful, it is what is genuine, not truth in that sense.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī spoke these words to the Blessed One: "The Blessed One has declared that what is non-inverted is genuine truth. If that is so, are there four inversions with respect to the Four Truths? And if there are, why did the Blessed One declare that what is non-inverted is genuine truth? For all that is inverted is not genuine."

The Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "All inversions belong within the truth of suffering. Just as, for example, a sentient being who possesses an inverted mind is called inverted, noble son, just so — consider the example of a person who does not listen to the words of his parents, his teachers, and his spiritual master, and does not act as instructed: that person is called inverted. And that inversion is not something other than suffering — it is suffering.

Mañjuśrī then asked again: "If, as the Blessed One has declared, what is non-false is genuine truth, then what is false would not be genuine truth — I take it, then, that what is false is not genuine truth."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, all that is false and deceptive belongs within suffering. For example, consider a sentient being who, overpowered by another adversary —"

acts of deceit and fraud, then by that cause and through those conditions, the sentient being falls into the hells, into the births of animals, or into the realm of hungry ghosts. These are called what is false. And that falseness is not something other than suffering — it is suffering.

Because śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and fully awakened Blessed Ones have utterly abandoned and do not engage in such things, they are not called false. And because falseness is wholly removed by the buddhas and by the two vehicles, it is called genuine truth.

Mañjuśrī then asked again: "If, as the Blessed One has declared, the Great Vehicle is to be called genuine truth, then would not the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas turn out to be not genuine?"

The Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "Both vehicles are genuine, and yet both are also not genuine. They are called genuine because śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have cut through the afflictions. Yet they are not genuine because they are impermanent, unstable, subject to change and transition."

Mañjuśrī then asked again: "If, as the Blessed One has declared, something is to be called genuine, then surely what māra (the Tempter) says should not be genuine. Blessed One, could what māra says be understood as noble truth?"

The Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "What māra says falls within the two truths called suffering and the origin of suffering. Whatever is not Dharma, whatever is not discipline, whatever does not become the benefit and happiness of others — even though it may be spoken incessantly at all times, it will never enable the other person to see suffering, to cut through its origin, to realize its cessation, or to cultivate the path. Therefore it is false, and that falseness is called what māra speaks."

Mañjuśrī then asked again: "If, as the Blessed One has declared, the path of purification is one and not two, then the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) also say exactly this: 'The path of purification is one and not two.' If that single path were genuine truth, what distinguishes you from the non-Buddhists? And if

there is no distinction, then it is also not fitting that it should have been said that the path of purification is one."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, non-Buddhists do have the truths of suffering and of the origin of suffering, but they do not have the truths of cessation and of the path. Therefore they perceive as cessation what is not cessation, they perceive as a path what is not a path, they perceive as a result what is not a result, and they perceive as a cause what is not a cause. Therefore for them there is no 'one path of purification, not two' to be spoken of."

Mañjuśrī then asked again: "If, as the Blessed One has declared, what is endowed with permanence, endowed with self, endowed with bliss, and endowed with purity is to be called genuine meaning — then surely non-Buddhists too would have genuine truth, and it would not be found in the Dharma of the buddhas. Why? Because the non-Buddhists also say the following: 'All formations are permanent.' How so? Because the karmic maturation of agreeable and disagreeable karma and so forth will not fail to occur. What is agreeable is the experience of the fruit of the ten virtues. What is disagreeable is the maturation of the ten non-virtues. Now, if all formations were impermanent, then when one who has performed an action passes away from here and is reborn elsewhere, who would experience the fruit of that maturation?

Therefore all formations are permanent; they are called permanent on account of the condition of taking life. Blessed One, if all formations were impermanent, then both the killer and the one killed would become impermanent. If they were impermanent, sentient beings would experience blameworthy karma in the hells. Yet if they were certainly to experience the karmic maturation of the hells, then formations would turn out not to be truly impermanent. Blessed One, a mind that is single-pointed and mindful — this too we call permanent. For example, one remembers something for ten years and then recalls it for a hundred years without forgetting; this too we call permanent. For if it were impermanent, who would remember things previously seen? Therefore all formations are not impermanent. Blessed One, all memory too we call permanent. For instance, when a person previously sees another person's hand, foot, head, shoulder, or the like, and later, upon seeing them again, immediately recognizes them. If memory were impermanent, it would be fitting that the earlier mark should have vanished without trace. Blessed One, all skills come about through long habituation;

from the very beginning of training, after three or five years one becomes expert — therefore we call this permanent. Blessed One, in arithmetic one learns from one to two, from two to three, up to a hundred and a thousand. If it were impermanent, then even the first unit, the one, would not exist. If the first one did not exist, how could there be two? Thus the one is permanent and is not two. Since the one has not passed away into nonexistence, from two onward one arrives at a hundred, a thousand — therefore it is permanent. Blessed One, take the example of reading or reciting the Dharma: one recites one passage, then two passages, then three passages, then up to four. If it were impermanent, recitation would never reach as far as four. Because reading and recitation increase and arise, we call this permanent. Blessed One, a pot, clothing, a chariot, a debt incurred, and the defining marks of the great earth — mountains, water, forests, the leaves of trees, and the healing of the illnesses of sentient beings — all these are permanent; they are like that. Blessed One, all non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say this very thing: "All formations are permanent." And if all formations are permanent, that would constitute genuine truth. Blessed One, some non-Buddhists also say: "There is happiness." How is this known? Because agreeable fruits will be experienced. Blessed One, the experience of happiness is certainly real. For instance, the great king of Brahmā, the great sovereign lord, Śakra (Indra) the lord of the gods, the averter of harm, gods, humans, and so forth — therefore happiness is certainly real. Blessed One, some non-Buddhists also say: "There is happiness" — and for sentient beings, a mind of seeking arises again and again. For instance, the hungry seek food, the thirsty seek water, those who are cold seek warmth, those who are hot desire coolness, the weary desire rest, the sick desire recovery, and those with desires seek objects of form. If happiness did not exist, why would they seek these things? Since seeking exists, it is evident that happiness exists. Blessed One, some non-Buddhists also say the following: one who has given generosity becomes happy. People of the world give to monks or brahmins or the poor: robes, food, drink, bedding, medicine for illness, sheep, oxen, horses, vehicles, incense powder, flowers, houses, dwellings, lamps, and so forth. By giving such gifts, in the next life one will experience agreeable fruits.

Therefore, happiness certainly exists. Blessed One, some non-Buddhists also say this: happiness exists because of causes and conditions. The experience of happiness arises because causes and conditions are present — this is called "making contact with happiness." If happiness did not exist, how could its

causes and conditions exist? Just as if a rabbit's horn did not exist, its causes and conditions would also not exist. Since the causes and conditions of happiness exist, happiness exists.

Blessed One, some non-Buddhists also say this: happiness exists because there are higher, middling, and lower degrees of it. The lowest experience of happiness belongs to Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods. The middling experience of happiness belongs to Great Brahmā, the king of the gods. The highest experience of happiness belongs to the Great Sovereign. Since higher, middling, and lower degrees exist, happiness exists.

Blessed One, some non-Buddhists say this: purity exists. Why? Because if purity did not exist, it would be improper for desire to arise; yet since desire does arise, purity must exist. Others also say: gold, silver, beryl, crystal, asaṃāgarbha, muśālagalva, coral, pearl, crystal cloth, garlands, waterfalls, springs, bathing pools, food, drink, robes, flowers, incense, incense powder, ointment, and illuminating lamps — all these things possess the quality of being thoroughly pure.

Furthermore, it is said: the five aggregates are a pure vessel, and they are filled also with a pure essence. Gods, humans, seers, arhats, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and buddhas — for this reason they are called "pure."

Blessed One, some non-Buddhists say: the self exists. They say that whatever perceives and acts is the self. Just as a person who goes to a potter's house, even without meeting the potter himself, upon seeing the clay and the wheel will certainly know it to be a potter's house — in the same way, as soon as the eye sees form, the self is certainly affirmed to exist. If the self did not exist, who would see form, who would hear sound — and so it continues through tactile objects and mental phenomena. Furthermore, the self exists and is known through signs. What are these signs? Breathing, looking with the eyes and smiling, the span of life, experiencing suffering and happiness, being angered through attachment — all these and similar phenomena are the signs of the self. Therefore, the self certainly exists.

Moreover, the existence of the self is discerned by the distinguishing of flavors. Just as when a person eats fruit and immediately seeks to identify what flavor it has, for this reason the self exists. Furthermore, the existence of the self is known through actions. When one holds something dry, one performs the action of grasping; when one holds an axe, one performs the

action of cutting; when one holds a pot, one performs the action of drawing water; when one rides in a chariot, one performs the action of turning the wheel. All such actions are performed because they are taken up by what is called the self. Therefore, the self certainly exists. Furthermore, what makes clear that the self exists? Take the example of a newborn infant who immediately seeks to drink milk — this arises from prior habitual tendencies. Therefore, the self certainly exists.

Furthermore, there is what is called the self. What makes this evident? It is because an assembled and gathered collection becomes beneficial to other sentient beings. For example, a pot, a garment, a chariot, a field, a house, a mountain, a forest, a tree, an ox, a horse, cattle, sheep, and so on — these things become beneficial through their assembly. Similarly, the inner five aggregates (skandhas) are like this: when the sense faculties such as the eye faculty and the rest are assembled and gathered together, they become beneficial to what is called the self. Therefore, the self certainly exists. Furthermore, what makes clear that the self exists? It is because something can obstruct and block. When something exists, it can block and obstruct; when something does not exist, it cannot obstruct. Since obstructing and blocking do occur, the self is held to exist. Therefore, the self certainly exists. Furthermore, what makes clear that the self exists? It is because of companions and non-companions. Relatives and non-relatives do not become companions in the same way. Correct Dharma and incorrect Dharma do not become companions in the same way. Wisdom and non-wisdom do not become companions in the same way. Ascetics and non-ascetics do not become companions in the same way. Brahmins and non-brahmins, sons and non-sons, day and non-day, night and non-night, self and non-self — these phenomena stand as companions and non-companions. Therefore, the self certainly exists. Blessed One, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) likewise, through many and various approaches, assert that permanence, happiness, self, and complete purity exist, and they hold that what is called permanence, happiness, self, and complete purity certainly exists. Blessed One, it is for this reason that the non-Buddhists too declare that a true reality exists.

The Blessed One then spoke: Son of good family, any ascetic or brahmin who declares that permanence exists, or that happiness exists, or that complete purity exists, or that the self exists — that person is not a true ascetic, not a true brahmin. Why? Because they have strayed from saṃsāra, and because they have abandoned the great Teacher who is endowed with the gnosis of

omniscience. Those ascetics and brahmins are deeply sunk in desire, and their virtuous qualities are meager. Those non-Buddhists are bound by attachment, aversion, and delusion, and yet they remain content in the pleasures of desire. Those non-Buddhists know that the fruits of karma are created by the self and experienced by the self, yet they are unable to abandon unwholesome qualities. Those non-Buddhists do not possess the true Dharma, nor do they live by a true livelihood. Why? Because they lack the fire of wisdom and cannot purify themselves. Those non-Buddhists cling to the finest of the five sense pleasures, yet because they apply no diligence and earnest effort, they are impoverished in virtuous qualities. Those non-Buddhists desire true liberation, yet lack the legs that are the guarding of ethical discipline. Those non-Buddhists desire happiness, yet cannot seek out the causes and conditions through which happiness arises. Those non-Buddhists desire not to suffer, yet do not abandon all conduct that becomes the cause of suffering. Those non-Buddhists are coiled by the four venomous serpents of the great elements, and yet move through life heedlessly. Those non-Buddhists, completely covered by ignorance, abandon virtuous spiritual friends, and because they are devoted to remaining in the three realms, they cannot be liberated from the great and fiercely blazing fire of impermanence.

Those non-Buddhists are struck down by the grave sickness of affliction, which is difficult to cure, and yet they do not seek out a physician endowed with skill and knowledge. Those non-Buddhists must travel the boundless, immeasurably long, and utterly desolate road of future time, and yet they do not know how to accumulate a gathering of wholesome Dharma that would become their own adornment. Those non-Buddhists are slain by the poison of attachment, and yet they cling to the five venomous she-asses of desire. Those non-Buddhists are consumed by the fiercely blazing fire of aversion, and yet they rely upon unwholesome spiritual friends. Those non-Buddhists are covered and overwhelmed by ignorance, and yet they seek out the wrong Dharma of perverted views. Those non-Buddhists are perpetually deceived by perverted views, and yet they cultivate the perception of those very views as virtuous spiritual friends. Those non-Buddhists hope for sweet fruit, and yet they plant seeds of bitter fruit. Those non-Buddhists have entered the dark house of affliction, and yet they abandon the great lamp of primordial wisdom. Those non-Buddhists are utterly tormented and parched with thirst by affliction, and yet they drink the salt water of desire. Those non-Buddhists are tossed about on the boundless ocean of saṃsāra, and yet they abandon the

unsurpassed vessel. Those non-Buddhists are thoroughly corrupted by inverted views, and yet they declare that all formations are permanent. But there is no ground whatsoever for saying that all formations are permanent. Noble son, when I look at this, all formations are impermanent. And how is this known? It is known through the door of causes and conditions. All phenomena that arise from conditions must be recognized as impermanent. Therefore there is not a single one of all the doctrines of non-Buddhists that has not arisen from conditions.

Noble son, the intrinsic nature (svabhāva) of a buddha is unborn, unceasing, neither coming nor going, neither past nor future nor present, not made from a cause, not made from the absence of a cause, not unmade, not made, not signified, not without sign, not possessed of a name, not devoid of a name — it is not a name, not a form, not long, not short, not an aggregate, not an element, not belonging to the sense bases. Therefore it is called permanent. Noble son, the intrinsic nature of a pratyekabuddha is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is Dharma. Dharma is permanent. Noble son, what is called "permanent" is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is permanent. For this reason, one should not say that all phenomena arising from conditions are permanent. And not a single one of the doctrines of those non-Buddhists has failed to arise from conditions.

Noble son, non-Buddhists do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, the Tathāgata, or the Dharma. Therefore everything those non-Buddhists say is false and without genuine truth. Foolish children of little cultivation: having previously seen a pot, or clothing, or a vehicle, or a house, or a town, or a river, or a mountain, or a forest, or a man, or a woman, or an ox, or a horse, or cattle, or sheep, and so forth, when they later see something similar to what they saw before, they declare it to be permanent. But in truth, it is not permanent. Noble son, all conditioned phenomena are impermanent. Space and the unconditioned are called permanent. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is unconditioned and therefore is called permanent. What is called "space" is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is the Tathāgata.

The Tathāgata is unconditioned. The unconditioned is permanent. The permanent is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is unconditioned. The unconditioned is permanent.

Noble son, conditioned phenomena, in brief, are of two kinds: material phenomena and immaterial phenomena. What are called immaterial phenomena are mind and mental factors arising from mind. What are called material phenomena are earth, water, fire, and wind.

Noble son, mind is called impermanent. Why is that? Because it has objects by its own intrinsic nature and is accompanied by conceptual thought. Noble son, the intrinsic nature of visual consciousness is distinct from the intrinsic nature of mental consciousness, and each is distinct from the others — therefore it is impermanent. Noble son, the domain of form and the domain of phenomena are likewise each distinct from the other — therefore impermanent. Noble son, what arises together with visual consciousness is distinct from what arises together with mental consciousness, and each is distinct — therefore impermanent.

Noble son, if mind were permanent, it would follow that visual consciousness alone could apprehend all phenomena whatsoever. Noble son, because visual consciousness is distinct from mental consciousness, and each in the series from one to the other is distinct, mind is known to be impermanent. Phenomena that are similar arise and cease moment by moment, and childish, lowly persons, seeing them in this way, grasp them as permanent.

Noble son, because the defining characteristic of causes and conditions is that they can be destroyed, it is called impermanent. For example, visual consciousness arises from the conditions of the eye faculty, visible form, light, and attention. And when ear consciousness arises, it does so from its own distinct conditions — not from the conditions of visual consciousness. Each consciousness up to mental consciousness should be understood in the same way, each arising from its own distinct conditions.

Furthermore, noble son, because the causes and conditions of formations are destroyed, mind is impermanent. The mind that cultivates meditation on impermanence is one thing, and the mind that cultivates meditation on suffering, on emptiness, and on selflessness is another. If mind were permanent, then by constantly meditating on impermanence one would never come to realize suffering, emptiness, and selflessness — let alone realize permanence, bliss, self, and purity. For this reason, what is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure cannot be gathered into the Dharma of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Noble son, therefore the phenomena of mind are definitely impermanent.

Moreover, noble son, because the intrinsic nature of mind is various and distinct, it is impermanent. The intrinsic nature of the mind of a śrāvaka is its own; the intrinsic nature of the mind of a pratyekabuddha is its own; and the intrinsic nature of the mind of the buddhas is also its own. The minds of all non-Buddhists are of three kinds: the mind of one who has gone forth, the mind of one who dwells at home, and the mind of one who is secluded from the household life. The mind accompanied by seclusion is one thing; the mind accompanied by suffering is another; the mind accompanied by neither pleasure nor pain is another; the mind accompanied by attachment is another; the mind accompanied by aversion is another; the mind accompanied by delusion is yet another — and thus the characteristics of the mind of every non-Buddhist also differ from one another. Likewise, the mind accompanied by delusion is one thing, the mind accompanied by doubt is another, the mind accompanied by wrong views is another, and the mind of one who is going about and of one who is staying still are also distinct. Noble son, if mind were permanent, then with regard to blue color, yellow, red, white, and

purple color there would be no reason to make distinctions among them. Noble son, if mind were permanent, it would be unreasonable for all the phenomena that are to be remembered to be forgotten. Noble son, if mind were permanent, it would be unreasonable that the activities of reading and recitation should increase and arise. Noble son, if mind were permanent, it would be unreasonable to speak of what has been done, what is being done, and what is to be done — and yet because there is what has been done, what is being done, and what is to be done, the mind must be understood as definitely impermanent. Noble son, if mind were permanent, there would be neither aversion nor loving-kindness, and it would be neither aversion nor loving-kindness. If mind were permanent, it would be unreasonable to speak of "my property" and "another's property," or to say "he dies" and "he is born." If mind were permanent, it would be unreasonable that, even though an action has been performed, arising and increase should occur. Noble son, therefore, because the intrinsic nature of mind is distinct and differentiated, it must be recognized as impermanent.

Noble son, what I have explained here with respect to impermanence in the domain of non-material phenomena is this. And further, I shall explain to you that form is impermanent. Form is impermanent because it was not arisen from the beginning; and having arisen, it is subject to cessation. At the time of the embryo entering the womb and being in the gelatinous stage, it has not

arisen from the beginning, and having arisen it is subject to change. External sprouts and trunks likewise have not arisen from the beginning, and having arisen they are subject to change. Therefore all phenomena of form are to be understood as impermanent.

Noble son, inner form changes with time: the gelatinous stage is one thing, the hardening stage is another, the stage of becoming solid is another, the time in the womb is another, the time of birth is another, the time of infancy is another, and the time of youth is another — and so it changes, all the way through to old age, each stage being different. All outer forms are the same: the time of the sprout is one thing, the time of the trunk is another, the time of the branches is another, the time of the leaves is another, the time of the flower is another, and the time of the fruit is another.

Noble son, further, the inner taste also differs from the gelatinous stage all the way through to old age, each being distinct and other. Outer taste is the same: from sprout to trunk, branch, leaf, flower, and fruit, each is distinct and other. The strength and vigor at the gelatinous stage is one thing, all the way through to old age the strength and vigor also differs, each being distinct and other. The appearance of form at the gelatinous stage is one thing, and through to old age the appearance also differs, each being distinct and other. The fruit of karmic maturation at the gelatinous stage is one thing, and through to old age the fruit of karmic maturation also differs, each being distinct and other. The name given at the gelatinous stage is one thing, and through to old age the name assigned also differs, each being distinct and other.

So it is that inner form, the very moment it disintegrates, gathers again — and so it is impermanent. Outer trees and plants, the very moment they disintegrate, also gather again — and so they are impermanent. Because they arise gradually, they are also impermanent. From the gelatinous stage through to old age, arising and changing occur gradually; and from sprout through to fruit, arising and changing occur gradually — therefore they are impermanent. Because all forms are destined to cease, they are impermanent: the cessation of the gelatinous stage is one thing, the cessation through to old age is another; the cessation of the sprout is one thing, and the cessation through to the fruit is another — and therefore they are impermanent. Children of low birth who are without wisdom, seeing birth and grasping at it as something they remember, cling to it as permanent. Therefore it is called impermanent. And if something is impermanent, that is suffering. And because it is suffering,

it is impure.

Noble son, these matters were also asked earlier by Kāśyapa, and I explained them in detail.

Furthermore, noble son, in all formations (saṃskāra) there is no such thing as a self. Noble son, what is called "all phenomena" is, in brief, form and the formless. In form there is no such thing as a self. Why is that? Because form is subject to being broken, cut, and soiled, and because it arises and grows. What is called a self cannot be broken, cannot be cut, does not arise, and does not grow — and therefore form is not a self. Formless phenomena, too, are not a self. Why is that? Because they arise from causes and conditions.

Noble son, if the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) claim that through one-pointed recollection they know that a self exists, well, one-pointed recollection itself is not what is called a self. Moreover, if one were to say that one-pointed recollection is the self, then there is also forgetting of things past — and since there is forgetting, it is certain that there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, if the non-Buddhists claim that because there is recollection a self exists, then since there is also the absence of recollection, there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, consider the example of seeing a person with six fingers on a hand: one would ask, "Did we not meet before, long ago?" But if a self truly existed, it would not be fitting to ask at all — and from the fact that one does ask, it is certain that there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, if the non-Buddhists claim that because something can be interrupted and obscured a self exists, then noble son, because there is obscuration, know that it is certain there is no such thing as a self. For example, when one utters the name "Devadatta," one does not say "not Devadatta." Likewise with the self: if it were truly and certainly a self, it would not become obscured under the name "self" — but since it does become obscured, it is certain there is no such thing as a self. And if one claims that because there is obscuration a self exists, then in the case where you are not obscured, it is certain there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, if the non-Buddhists claim that from the existence of companions and non-companions they know that a self exists, then because there are things without a companion, there is no self — and it is proper to conclude that there is no such thing as a self. Companionless phenomena do exist, namely

the Tathāgata, space, and the nature of buddhahood. What is called a self is likewise truly and perfectly without a companion — and therefore it is certain there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, furthermore, if the non-Buddhists claim that from the attribution of names they know that a self exists, then even for selfless phenomena the name "selfless" is attributed. For example, a very poor person may be given the name "wealthy." Another example: one says "I die" — but if what is called the self dies, then the self would be killed by the self. Since what is called a self cannot truly be killed, it is merely a conventional designation to say "the self dies." This is like calling a short person "tall." Therefore, know with certainty that there is no such thing as a self.

Furthermore, noble son, if the non-Buddhists claim that because a newborn infant immediately seeks milk they know that a self exists — noble son, if a self truly existed, then it would not be fitting for all small infants to grasp at filth, vomit, fire, snakes, and poison. Therefore it is certain there is no such thing as a self.

Noble son, all sentient beings possess equally this threefold gnosis (jñāna): attachment (rāga), eating, and fear. And therefore there is no such thing as a self.

Furthermore, noble son, if the non-Buddhists claim that from signs and from form alone they know that a self exists — noble son, because signs exist there is no self, and because signs are absent there is also no self. For example, when a person has fallen asleep, there is going and coming and —

there is no going, no coming, no stretching out, no yawning, no looking — and there is no feeling of pleasure or of suffering. Therefore it is unreasonable to assert that a self exists. And if someone were to say that because there is going and coming, stretching out, yawning, and looking, one knows that a self exists — then by that same logic one should assert that a self exists in a mechanical man made of wood. Noble son, the Tathāgata is just like that: he does not go, he does not stay, he does not yawn, he does not stretch out, he does not look, he does not smile; he is not suffering, not pleasurable, not attachment, not aversion, not delusion, not conduct. And yet in this very way, the Tathāgata is said to possess a true self.

Furthermore, noble son, if the non-Buddhists were to say that when a person on the far bank eats sour fruit from a tree, one knows from the saliva that rises on the near bank that a self exists — noble son, the saliva arises because of

memory from seeing, yet the saliva is not the self and the self is not the saliva. The saliva is not joy, not sorrow, not laughter, not excitement, not falling, not birth, not thirst, not satiation. Therefore one must certainly know that there is no self.

Noble son, those non-Buddhists are like a small blind infant that has never seen sunlight. Having no knowledge, no skillful means, no understanding, they do not know permanence or impermanence, suffering or pleasure, complete purity or impurity, self or no-self, what is feeling or what is not feeling, what is a sentient being or what is not, what is happiness or what is not, what exists or what does not exist. Having taken a mere fraction of the Dharma of the buddhas, they grasp at permanence, pleasure, self, and purity; yet they do not know what true permanence, pleasure, self, and purity actually are.

It is like a blind man who does not know the color of milk. When he asks another person what color milk is, and the other says it is like the color of a conch shell, the blind man takes the color of milk to be something like the sound of a conch shell. Then when he asks what the color of a conch shell is like, and is told it is like ground rice powder, the blind man takes the color of a conch shell to be something exceedingly soft. Then when he asks what the color of ground rice powder is like, and the other says it is like snow, the blind man takes the color of ground rice powder to be something cold. And when he asks what the color of snow is like, and is told it is like the wing of a goose — yet even after receiving these four analogies, that blind man still does not know what the true color of milk is actually like. Those non-Buddhists are just the same: they do not know permanence, pleasure, self, and purity. Noble son, therefore in the Dharma of the buddhas there is genuine truth, but among the non-Buddhists there is not.

The Noble Great Sūtra of the Complete Passing into Nirvāṇa. The nineteenth fascicle.

Mañjuśrī, the young prince, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "How wonderful! The Tathāgata, on the very occasion of passing into complete nirvāṇa, has turned the unsurpassed wheel of Dharma and taught the genuine truth in its fullness."

The Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "Do you perceive the Tathāgata as passing into nirvāṇa? Noble son, the Tathāgata in truth is permanent, stable, unchanging, and not passing into complete nirvāṇa.

Noble son, whoever grasps him as a self — that is called the buddha-self, and such a one will awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. The word 'self' is Dharma, and Dharma belongs to the self. The self is the path, and the path belongs to the self. The self is the Blessed One, and the Blessed One belongs to the self. The self is the śrāvaka, and the śrāvaka belongs to the self."

The self teaches Dharma, and others listen to it. The self turns the wheel of Dharma, and others are incapable of doing so. The Tathāgata does not grasp things in that way; therefore the Tathāgata does not turn the wheel of Dharma.

Noble son, whoever grasps things in such a manner: the self is the eye, and the eye belongs to the self. And so too with the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, and the mind. The self is form, and form belongs to the self. In the same way, understand this to extend through all the remaining phenomena. The self is earth, and earth belongs to the self. Understand water, fire, and wind likewise.

Noble son, in this regard, whatever one calls "self" is faith, and faith belongs to the self. What is called "self" is extensive learning, and extensive learning belongs to the self. What is called "self" is the perfection of generosity, and the perfection of generosity belongs to the self. What is called "self" is the perfection of moral discipline, and the perfection of moral discipline belongs to the self. The self is the perfection of patience, and the perfection of patience belongs to the self. The self is the perfection of diligence, and the perfection of diligence belongs to the self. The self is the perfection of meditative concentration, and the perfection of meditative concentration belongs to the self. The self is the Perfection of Wisdom, and the Perfection of Wisdom belongs to the self. The self is the four establishments of mindfulness, and the four establishments of mindfulness belong to the self. Understand likewise the four right abandonments, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven branches of awakening, and the noble eightfold path.

Noble son, because the Tathāgata does not grasp in that manner, the Tathāgata does not turn the wheel of Dharma. Noble son, one might ask: if the Tathāgata is permanent, stable, unchanging, and unshifting, then why is it said that the Tathāgata turned the wheel of Dharma? Therefore it is not fitting for you to say that the Tathāgata turned the wheel of Dharma.

Noble son, consider this analogy: from the coming together of the eye, light, and intention, visual consciousness arises. The eye does not think "I have produced visual consciousness," nor does intention think "I have produced visual consciousness," nor does visual consciousness itself think "I have produced myself." And yet, noble son, from their assembly and convergence, seeing comes about.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is just like that. From the six perfections, the thirty-seven factors of awakening, the investigation of phenomena, and furthermore from the palate, the throat, the tongue, the teeth, the lips, and the sound of words spoken from the mouth — the first teaching of Dharma given to the venerable Kauṇḍinya is called "turning the wheel of Dharma." It is for that reason that one should not say the Tathāgata turned the wheel of Dharma.

Noble son, that which is not turned is called Dharma, and Dharma is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, consider this further analogy: from the coming together of the fire-stick, the hearthboard, the hands, and the effort of friction, fire arises. The fire-stick does not think "I have produced the fire," the hearthboard, the hands, and the friction do not think "we have produced the fire," and the fire does not think "I have produced myself."

The Tathāgata is similar in just this way. From the six perfections up through the venerable Kauṇḍinya, that which arises is called "turning the wheel of Dharma," yet the Tathāgata does not conceive "I have turned the wheel of Dharma." Noble son, that very absence of such conception is called the true turning of the wheel of Dharma, and that turning of the wheel of Dharma is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, consider this further analogy: butter arises from the coming together of curds, water, a vessel, a churn-stick, a rope, hands, and the act of churning. The curds do not think "I have produced the butter," nor do any of the others, from the curds down to the hands, think "I have produced the butter," and the butter itself does not think "I have produced the butter." Butter comes to be from the gathering of many conditions. The Tathāgata is similar in just this way: he does not conceive "I have turned the wheel of Dharma." That very absence of conception is called the true turning of the wheel of Dharma, and that turning of the wheel of Dharma is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, consider this further analogy: a sprout comes into being from a seed, soil, water, fire, wind, space, time, and the act of cultivation. The seed does not think "I have produced the sprout," nor do any of the others, from the seed down to the act of cultivation, think "I have produced the sprout," and the sprout itself does not think "I have produced the sprout." The Tathāgata is similar in just this way: he does not conceive "I have turned the wheel of Dharma." Noble son, that very absence of such conception is called the true turning of the wheel of Dharma, and that turning of the wheel of Dharma is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, consider this further analogy: sound arises from a drum through the coming together of the drumframe, the hide, a person's hands, and the act of striking. The drum does not think "I have produced the sound," nor do any of the others, from the striking to the sound itself, think "I have produced the sound." The Tathāgata is similar in just this way: he does not conceive "I have turned the wheel of Dharma." Noble son, that very absence of such conception is called the true turning of the wheel of Dharma.

Noble son, the turning of the wheel of Dharma is unconditioned. The unconditioned is the turning of the wheel of Dharma. The turning of the wheel of Dharma is the Tathāgata. Noble son, the turning of the wheel of Dharma is the domain of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones; it is not something known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Noble son, space is not arising, not arisen, not acting, not made, and is not a conditioned phenomenon. The Tathāgata is similar in just this way: not arising, not arisen, not acting, not made, and not a conditioned phenomenon. Just as the Tathāgata is, so too the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is the same: not arising, not arisen, not acting, not made, and not a conditioned phenomenon.

Noble son, the speech of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is of two kinds: worldly speech and transcendent speech. Noble son, the Tathāgata addresses śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas in worldly speech, and addresses bodhisattvas in transcendent speech.

Noble son, the assembly of the retinue is likewise of two kinds: those who seek the lesser vehicle, and those who seek the Great Vehicle.

In the past, at Vārāṇasī, I turned the wheel of Dharma for the śrāvakas, and now, here in this city of Kuśinagara, I have turned the wheel of Dharma for the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas.

Noble son, furthermore, persons are of two kinds: those of middling faculties and those of sharp faculties. For those of middling faculties, the wheel of Dharma was turned at Vārāṇasī. For those of sharp faculties — who are like the finest bulls among men, such as the bodhisattva Kāśyapa and others — the great wheel of Dharma has been turned here in this city of Kuśinagara. Noble son, for those of the lowest faculties, the Tathāgata does not turn the wheel of Dharma; those called "the lowest faculties" are those who hold wrong views.

Noble son, furthermore, those who seek the awakening of a buddha are also of two kinds: those of middling diligence and those of supreme diligence. At Vārāṇasī, the wheel of Dharma was turned for those of middling diligence. Here in this city of Kuśinagara, the great wheel of Dharma has been turned for those of supreme diligence.

Noble son, furthermore, when I previously turned the wheel of Dharma at Vārāṇasī for the first time, some eighty thousand gods and humans attained the fruit of stream-entry. Now, here in this city of Kuśinagara, some eight hundred thousand gods and humans have become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Noble son, previously at Vārāṇasī, the great Brahmin king Brahmā prostrated before me and requested that I turn the wheel of Dharma. Here in this city of Kuśinagara, the bodhisattva Kāśyapa prostrated before me and requested that I turn the wheel of Dharma.

Noble son, furthermore, when I turned the wheel of Dharma previously at Vārāṇasī, I taught impermanence, suffering, emptiness, and selflessness. Now, in turning the wheel of Dharma here in this city of Kuśinagara, I have taught permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity.

Noble son, furthermore, when I previously turned the wheel of Dharma at Vārāṇasī, the sound of my voice reached as far as the Brahma world. Now, in turning the wheel of Dharma here in this city of Kuśinagara, the sound of my voice has reached as far as the buddha-fields to the east, as numerous as twenty times the grains of sand of the Ganges River, and likewise to the south, the west, the north, the four intermediate directions, above, and below.

Noble son, furthermore, everything that the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, ever speak is called the turning of the wheel of Dharma. Noble son, consider the example of the wheel-turning king: his precious wheel subdues those not yet subdued and brings ease to those who have been subdued. Noble son, in

exactly the same way, the teaching of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, subdues those not yet subdued amid measureless afflictions, and causes roots of virtue to arise in those who have been subdued.

Noble son, consider also this: the wheel-turning king, by means of his precious wheel, pacifies all enemies that rise against him. Likewise, the Tathāgata's teaching of the Dharma pacifies all the enemies of affliction.

Noble son, consider further: the precious wheel of the wheel-turning king moves at will from below to above. Likewise, the Tathāgata's teaching of the Dharma leads all sentient beings of the lower destinies, from rebirth as gods in the higher realms onward, all the way to the awakening of a buddha.

Noble son, therefore, do not say that the Tathāgata has turned the wheel of Dharma for the very first time only now.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī once again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I did not ask these questions for my own sake; I asked them for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings. Blessed One, I understand that the turning of the wheel of Dharma over so long a time belongs to the domain of activity of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, and not to the domain of activity of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas."

Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva Kāśyapa and declared: "Noble son, in this way, a bodhisattva who abides in this sūtra of the Great Vehicle, the Mahāparinirvāṇa, is said to engage in the conduct of the noble ones."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Why, furthermore, is it called the conduct of the noble ones?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, the term 'noble' refers to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Therefore it is called the conduct of the noble ones. Moreover, when śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas hear it and practice accordingly, that too is called the conduct of the noble ones, for the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, also rely upon this great Mahāparinirvāṇa and are thus designated noble by virtue of having analyzed and taught it in this way."

The Blessed One continued: "Noble son, when the great bodhisattvas, the great beings, abide in this conduct, they come to dwell on the ground of fearlessness. Noble son, when a bodhisattva dwells on the ground of fearlessness, that one is never afraid of attachment, aversion, or delusion; never afraid of birth, aging, sickness, or death; and is free from fear of falling

into the hells, into the realm of animals, or into the realm of hungry ghosts. Noble son, non-virtue is of two kinds: that which arises among the asuras, and that which arises among human beings. Among human beings, non-virtue is of three kinds: holding wrong views, rejecting the extensive sūtras, and transgressing the four defeats. Noble son, those bodhisattvas who dwell on that ground are never afraid of falling into such places of non-virtue. Furthermore, they are not afraid of mendicants, brahmins, tīrthikas of wrong views, or the māra-son gods of sinful nature and the like. Furthermore, they are not afraid of the twenty-five realms of existence. Therefore this ground is called the ground of fearlessness.

Noble son, a great bodhisattva who dwells on the ground of fearlessness crushes the twenty-five realms of existence by means of attaining twenty-five meditative absorptions. Noble son, by attaining the immaculate meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence as a hell-being. By attaining the irreversible meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence as an animal. By attaining the meditative absorption of mental ease and bliss, one crushes the realm of existence as a hungry ghost. By attaining the meditative absorption of great joy, one crushes the realm of existence as an asura. By attaining the meditative absorption of solar rays, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth on the eastern continent Pūrvavideha. By attaining the meditative absorption of lunar rays, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth on the western continent Aparagodānīya. By attaining the meditative absorption of a blazing flame, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth on the northern continent Uttarakuru. By attaining the illusion-like meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth on the southern continent Jambudvīpa. By attaining the meditative absorption of the immovability of all phenomena, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the realm of the Four Great Kings."

By attaining the meditative absorption of the extremely difficult to tame, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth among the Thirty-Three Gods. By attaining the pleasing meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the Heaven Free from Conflict. By attaining the meditative absorption of all being blue, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in Tuṣita Heaven. By attaining the meditative absorption of all being yellow, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the Heaven of Delight in Magical Creation. By attaining the meditative absorption of all being red, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the

Heaven of Mastery over Others' Creations. By attaining the meditative absorption of all being white, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the first dhyāna. By attaining the variegated meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the Great Brahma Heaven. By attaining the paired meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the second dhyāna. By attaining the meditative absorption of thunder, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the third dhyāna. By attaining the meditative absorption of falling rain, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the fourth dhyāna. By attaining the space-like meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth in the sphere of no-perception. By attaining the mirror-like meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence involving rebirth as a once-returner in the pure abodes. By attaining the non-attachment meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence resting upon the sense base of infinite space. By attaining the permanent meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence resting upon the sense base of infinite consciousness. By attaining the joyful meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence resting upon the sense base of nothingness. By attaining the self-possessing meditative absorption, one crushes the realm of existence resting upon the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.

Sons of good family, these are what are called the twenty-five meditative absorptions of the bodhisattva, the attainment of which crushes twenty-five realms of existence. Sons of good family, these twenty-five meditative absorptions are called the kings of meditative absorption.

Sons of good family, when a bodhisattva, a great being, enters these kings of meditative absorption, if he wishes to destroy Mount Meru, the king of mountains, it is destroyed just as he intends. If he wishes to know the thoughts of all sentient beings throughout the great trichiliocosm, he comes to know them just as he wishes. If he wishes all the sentient beings dwelling in the great trichiliocosm to enter together into a single pore of his body, it comes to pass just as he wishes, and there is not the slightest feeling of constriction or discomfort. If he wishes to manifest innumerable emanations of sentient beings and fill the entire great trichiliocosm, it comes to pass just as he wishes. And if he wishes to multiply one body into many bodies, or to gather many bodies back into one, it comes to pass just as he wishes. Yet even as these things occur, his mind clings to nothing, just as a lotus is unstained.

Sons of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who enters these kinds of meditative absorption comes also to abide on the ground of mastery. A bodhisattva abiding on the ground of mastery, endowed with the power of mastery, is born wherever he wishes to be born, in each and every such place, just as he intends.

Sons of good family, consider the example of a wheel-turning king who wishes to travel to the four continents: he goes just as he wills, and there is nothing to obstruct him. A bodhisattva, a great being, is likewise: wherever he wishes to be born, in each and every such place, he is born just as he intends.

Sons of good family, if a bodhisattva, a great being, were to establish the sentient beings dwelling in the hells on the root of virtue, the bodhisattva is born there. Yet even though the bodhisattva is born there, it is not the fruit of former karma.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who dwells on the ground that has become the ground of mastery is born there by reason of that cause and that condition. Sons of good family, although a bodhisattva, a great being, dwells among the hell-beings, he does not experience the sufferings of being boiled and so forth in the hells.

Sons of good family, the spontaneously present qualities of a bodhisattva, a great being, are likewise immeasurable and incalculable — they could not be fully expressed even in the span of a hundred thousand myriads of aeons. How much less need one speak of expressing the qualities of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. At that moment, within that assembled retinue, there was a bodhisattva named Vimalagarbharāja, King of the Heart of Stainlessness, who was endowed with great majesty and with superknowledges, who had attained the great dhāraṇī, who was perfected in meditative absorption, and who had attained fearlessness. He rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, as the Blessed One has declared, the qualities and gnosis of the buddhas and bodhisattvas are immeasurable and incalculable, and could not be fully expressed even in the span of a hundred thousand myriads of aeons. Yet when I reflect on this in my mind and set it alongside the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, it does not appear to be so. Why? Because the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, arises and is born from the power of the vast and extensive sūtras of the Great Vehicle."

Then the Blessed One responded with the words "Excellent! Excellent!" and said: "Son of good family, it is indeed so. It is indeed so. As you have said — the vast and extensive sūtras of the Great Vehicle are likewise possessed of immeasurable and boundless qualities. Yet those sūtras cannot serve even as a comparison for this sūtra. They do not measure up as a hundredth part of it, not a thousandth, not a hundred-thousandth — and so on through reckoning, enumeration, and analogy.

Sons of good family, consider this example: from a cow comes milk; from milk comes curds; from curds comes butter; from butter comes clarified butter; and from clarified butter comes the essence of butter. The essence of butter is supreme and most excellent: whoever drinks it is purified of all manner of disease, and it surpasses all medicines. Sons of good family, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are likewise. From the buddha come the twelve branches of the teaching. From the twelve branches of the teaching come the sūtras. From the sūtras come the vast and extensive sūtras. From the vast and extensive sūtras comes the Perfection of Wisdom. And from the Perfection of Wisdom comes the great nirvāṇa, which is like the essence of butter. The essence of butter is an analogy for the intrinsic nature of a buddha. And the intrinsic nature of a buddha is the Tathāgata. Therefore, sons of good family, the qualities of the Tathāgata are immeasurable, boundless, and incalculable."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as the Tathāgata has declared, the sūtra of the great nirvāṇa is supreme and most excellent, like the essence of butter: whoever drinks it is purified of all manner of disease, and it surpasses all medicines. Hearing this declared, I have thought to myself: one who does not listen to and does not recite this sūtra is one of very great delusion, and I regard such a one as being without a virtuous mind."

"Blessed One, I would flay my own skin and use it as a writing surface, draw out my blood to use as ink, pull out my bones and split them to use as pens, and endure all this in order to copy down this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa. Having copied it, I would endure reading it, reciting it, taking it to heart, and also widely teaching and expounding it to others. Blessed One, if there were a sentient being attached to material possessions, I would first give that being material things and afterward encourage them to read this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa. If there were one endowed with great wealth, I would first speak pleasing words to delight the mind and afterward encourage that one to read this sūtra of the Mahāyāna great nirvāṇa. If there were one of low birth, I

would compel them by force to read it. If there were one filled with pride, I would first wait upon them as a willing servant to their every wish, making them utterly pleased and gratified, and afterward introduce them to this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa. If there were one who disparaged the vast sūtras, I would subdue them by force and strength, and having subdued them, afterward lead them to read this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa. If there were one who had faith in and devotion to the Mahāyāna sūtras, I would come into their presence and, with the utmost reverence, offer service, honor, veneration, and praise."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Excellent! Excellent! It is well that you have such deep devotion to the Mahāyāna sūtras, such great joy in the Mahāyāna sūtras, such longing for the Mahāyāna sūtras, such delight in the taste of the Mahāyāna sūtras, such firm faith in the Mahāyāna, and that you offer reverence, honor, and veneration. Son of good family, by the cause and condition of this profoundly virtuous mind of yours, you will become far superior to immeasurable and boundless bodhisattvas — great bodhisattvas exceeding in number the grains of sand in the river Ganges — and sooner than they, you will fully and completely awaken to unsurpassed and perfect awakening. Without long delay, you will teach and explain the essence of this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa — spoken by the Tathāgata with the intention of revealing the buddha-nature — to many vast assemblies.

Son of good family, in a time long past, before the sun of a buddha had risen, I was then born as a brahmin, and while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva I had fully mastered all the scriptures of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), was living in perfect serenity, possessed of virtuous conduct, with a mind utterly pure, so that outward conditions did not give rise to perceptions of desire within me. The fire of aversion was extinguished. I held in mind the qualities of permanence, bliss, self, and purity, and yet, though I searched in all directions for the Mahāyāna sūtras, I had not even heard the mere name of such a vast scripture.

At that time I was dwelling on a certain snow mountain. That mountain was extremely remote, filled throughout with springs, cascading streams, bathing pools, flowering trees, forests, and medicinal plants. Throughout that place pure springs flowed out from the cliffs, adorned completely with fragrant flowers, and there were beyond counting birds and wild animals. There as well were trees of many varieties bearing fruits of the most exquisite flavor beyond counting, and besides these, sweet lotus roots and fragrant roots of blue plants filled the place completely. At that time I dwelt there alone, eating

nothing but the fruit of the trees."

After eating, I turned my mind one-pointedly to meditative absorption, and for measureless years I neither heard that a Tathāgata had appeared in the world, nor did I hear even the name of the sūtras of the Great Vehicle.

O son of good family, while I was practicing austerities in that way, Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods) and the sons of the gods were filled with the utmost wonder. Gathering together, each one thought to himself, and then spoke these verses one to another:

"On this pure snow mountain
dwells one who is utterly peaceful, who has abandoned attachment —
the king possessed of the eight qualities.
He has abandoned attachment, aversion, and pride;
he has wholly cut away delusion, guile, and deceit;
and through the door of speech he does not utter
words that are coarse and hurtful."

At that time, among that assembly there was a son of the gods named Supremely Joyful, who then also spoke a verse:

"He who has thus abandoned attachment
and strives with wholesome and vigorous diligence —
does he seek Śakra's power and method,
or does he aspire to be reborn in the realm of the gods?"

Then another son of the gods named Ṛṣika also addressed Śakra in verse:

"O lord of the gods, Kauśika —
it is not fitting to give rise to such doubt.
Even a non-Buddhist (tīrthika) practising austerities
does not seek the power and methods of Śakra."

Having spoken that verse, he then said further: "Kauśika, great beings in the world practice immeasurable austerities of every variety not out of attachment to their own bodies, but for the sake of benefiting sentient beings, for the sake of their welfare and happiness. Such a being, seeing the many faults of saṃsāra, would not develop even the slightest attachment — no more than to saliva or nasal mucus — even were he to behold this great earth, its mountains, and its great oceans completely filled with precious jewels. In this way, that great being wholly abandons precious gems, wealth, wives, sons, head, eyes, brain, hands, feet, major and minor limbs, his dwelling house,

yaks, oxen, horses, vehicles, male servants, female servants, and laborers — and he does not aspire to be reborn as a god in the higher realms. He applies himself solely to the welfare and happiness of all sentient beings. As I understand it, that great being, utterly pure, having wholly severed all afflictions, seeks nothing but unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening."

Śakra, the lord of the gods, then spoke thus: "Just as you have said, that great sage will become a refuge for the entire world together with its gods. Moreover, if a great tree of buddhahood were to arise in this world, it would dispel the venomous serpent of afflictions from all — the gods, humans, and asuras and all the rest who inhabit the world. For those beings who sit in the shade of the tree of buddhahood will have every venomous serpent of affliction completely expelled. If that great sage is to become a Sugata in a future time, then the immeasurable blazing afflictions of all of us and all others will be utterly pacified. Yet this is most difficult to trust in. Why? Because among the countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings who arouse the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, many will turn back from that unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening through even slight conditions — just as the reflection of the moon in water, when the water is stirred, is likewise stirred."

Again, consider a likeness: an image painted in a picture is difficult to create yet easy to destroy. The awakening mind is just like that — difficult to arouse, yet easy to lose.

Great sage, consider further a likeness: a man fully armored and equipped for battle, who, upon reaching the field of combat and meeting the enemy, is immediately seized with fear and turns back. All sentient beings are likewise — armed with the armor of having aroused the awakening mind and setting out for awakening, the moment they behold the faults of saṃsāra they are overcome with fear and turn back.

For this reason, I went to examine that man, who was practicing austerities without affliction and distress, and whose conduct I could see was entirely pure — and yet I could not bring myself to trust in him. I drew near to him in order to examine whether that man is capable or not of bearing on his shoulders the heavy burden of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

Consider the likeness of a chariot: if it has two wheels, it can be used; and a bird: if it has two wings, it can fly. Ascetic practice is just the same. I could see that he was extremely disciplined in his vows and ethical conduct — and yet

one must still examine whether or not the profoundly deep wisdom is present. If that profoundly deep wisdom is present, then he will be able to carry on his shoulders the heavy burden of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

Sage, consider the likeness of a great fish: it may carry exceedingly many young in its womb, yet only a few are born as actual offspring. Or consider the mango tree: though it puts forth flowers in great abundance, only a few ripen into fruit. Sentient beings who arouse the awakening mind are likewise immeasurable in number, yet in the end, only very few bring it to its fruit.

Great sage, let us go together to find where that man is and examine him.

Sage, consider the likeness of gold: even genuine gold, when tested by three methods, is recognized as genuine or not — namely, by burning, by striking, and by rubbing. Ascetic practice is just the same.

Having said this, at that moment Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, transformed his own body into a most terrifying rākṣasa form, descended upon the snowy mountain range, and sat down not very far from the ascetic. Then that rākṣasa, with a fearless mind and in a voice of great boldness yet spoken in a whisper, recited this half-verse spoken by the buddhas of the past:

Alas — all conditioned things are impermanent,
their nature is to arise and to cease.

Having recited this half-verse, he sat nearby, displaying his terrifying form, eyes wide open and gazing all around in the four directions.

At that moment, when the one engaged in austerities heard this half-verse, an exceedingly joyful mind arose in him — as when a merchant traveling by night through a most frightening ravine loses his companions, becomes terrified, and in searching for a companion suddenly meets one, and immeasurable gladness and delight arise the very instant of that meeting.

Or again, consider the likeness of one long afflicted by illness who meets a skilled physician and is healed by excellent medicine; or one who has fallen into the ocean and comes upon a boat; or one parched by intense thirst who comes upon cool water; or one who has escaped from being captured by enemies; or one who has been imprisoned for a long time and wins release; or a farmer struck by a great drought upon whom rain falls; or one escorting travelers who has gone on a long road and hears news of their return — in each case, exceedingly great joy arises.

Noble son, when he heard that half-verse, the joy that arose in him was just like all of those. He rose from where he was sitting, lifted his hair with his hands,

looked out in all four directions, and spoke these words: "Who is it that has spoken this verse?" Looking around, he saw no one else but a single rakṣasa, and he spoke again these words: "Who is it that opens this gate of complete liberation? Who is it that roars the thunder of the melodious speech of the buddhas? Who is it that awakens from the deep slumber of sleep in which one lies utterly sunk in saṃsāra?" And again he said: "Who is it that offers the taste of unsurpassable awakening to sentient beings tormented by the extreme famine of saṃsāra? Who is it that, with a great vessel, draws out the countless sentient beings who have sunk into the ocean of saṃsāra? Who is it that, for the many sentient beings severely afflicted by the sickness of mental afflictions, becomes a physician and a skilled healer of that sickness? This half-verse that has been spoken has stirred my mind, so that it has opened like a lotus opened by the crescent moon."

Noble son, at that moment and at that time, he could see no one else at all; and seeing only the rakṣasa, he thought: "This half-verse was not spoken by the rakṣasa." And he thought further: "It was not spoken by him — and why? Because one of such exceedingly ugly and terrifying form could not be like this. One who has heard this verse is of a kind that is free from all that is terrifying and hideous. How could one of such an appearance have spoken this verse? It is as impossible as a lotus being born from within fire, or cool water arising from the scorching rays of the sun." Noble son, at that time I also thought: "I am a person of very little discernment. Yet perhaps this rakṣasa has in the past encountered a buddha and heard this half-verse from that buddha — who can say? I should ask about the meaning of this half-verse." Having thought thus, I approached that rakṣasa and spoke these words: "Excellent! O great being, from whom did you hear this half-verse, spoken in the past by one free from fear? O great being, where did you find this precious half wish-fulfilling jewel? O great being, the meaning of this half-verse is the true path of all the buddhas and Blessed Ones of the past, the future, and those who abide in the present. The countless sentient beings who dwell in the world are perpetually enmeshed in the net of wrong views, and so they never hear this meaning of emptiness, which transcends the world, taught with great courage by one endowed with the ten powers, free from the doctrines of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas)."

Noble son, when I had asked him these words, he replied to me in turn with these words: "O great brahmin, do not ask me such things. And why? It has been many days since I found no food, and having searched everywhere without finding any, I am utterly consumed by hunger and thirst. What I said before was spoken as if in delirium — it was not spoken with mindfulness or introspective awareness. Even if by my own power I were to fly through the sky, travel to the land of the Uttarakurus in the north, and journey as far as the abodes of the gods, still, since I found no food, I spoke what I did in that condition."

Noble son, then at that time I spoke to the rakṣasa these words: "O great being, if you will recite this verse to me in full, I vow to be your disciple for one whole lifetime. O great being, what you have spoken is incomplete both in words and in meaning — why do you not speak it in full?"

The generosity of material things has a final limit, but the generosity of Dharma has no final limit. And even though it has no final limit, it is supremely beneficial for the sake of benefit and happiness. Having heard this incomplete verse, I was struck with wonder and doubt, and so I said: 'Recite this verse in full, and if you resolve my doubt, I vow to be your disciple for one whole lifetime.'

The rakṣasa said: 'Your understanding surpasses your situation, and so you grasp my purpose well — but think nothing of my own intention. I am tormented by extreme hunger and cannot bring myself to speak.'

Then I said to him: 'What do you eat as food?' The rakṣasa replied: 'Do not ask me that. If I were to tell you, many people would be terrified.' Then I said to him: 'In this deserted place there is no one at all, and I have no fear of you — so why will you not speak?' The rakṣasa then said: 'My food is the raw flesh of human beings, and I drink warm blood. I am of such little merit that even food such as this I cannot find anywhere. Though there are many people in the world, all of them are endowed with merit alone, and protected by the gods — therefore I have no power to kill and eat them.'

Noble son, then I said to him: 'Recite this verse in full, with its complete meaning, and I shall utterly surrender this body of mine to you. O great being, what need is there? This body of mine is extremely light and worthless. It will be eaten by tigers, wolves, foxes, vultures, hawks, crows, and the like, and not even a hair's breadth of merit will arise from that. But as for me — I seek unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and so may this body, which is

without essence, become a body endowed with essence.'

The rakṣasa then said: 'You say you will surrender your body — and all for the sake of eight syllables. Who could believe such a thing?' Noble son, then I said to him once more: 'You do not truly understand. Consider how a person might be carrying a clay bowl and exchange it for a vessel of seven precious substances — just so, if through this essenceless body of mine I were to attain a body like a vajra, who would doubt what I have said? As my witnesses I have the Great Brahmā (Mahābrahmā), king of kings, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, and the kings of the Four Great Kings, and others as witness. Furthermore, there are also as witnesses the bodhisattvas with their magical vision, who strive in the Great Vehicle for the benefit and happiness of limitless sentient beings and who are endowed with the six perfections. And beyond these, the blessed buddhas now dwelling in the world-realms of the ten directions, who even now live and care for the sake of sentient beings — these too are my witnesses. I shall surrender this body for the sake of these eight syllables.'

The rakṣasa then said: 'If you are truly able to surrender your body in this way, then listen well — I shall teach you this verse.' Noble son, when I heard these words, great joy arose in my mind. I removed the garment of skin and flesh that clothed my body and spread it as a seat for the rakṣasa, saying: 'I beseech the teacher to be seated.' Then, with palms pressed together and knees placed upon the ground, I spoke these words:

'Teacher, I beseech you to teach me this half-verse.' Having spoken thus, the rakṣasa then recited the half-verse:

What has been born will cease —
those things find peace and bliss in stilling.

When the rakṣasa had spoken that verse, he then said these words: 'Bodhisattva, great being, if you were to hear the verse in its complete meaning, your aspiration would now be wholly fulfilled. But if you are truly sincere in your purpose of acting for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings, then now the time has come for you to offer me your body.' Noble son, at that moment I took this meaning deeply to heart. Then, in the time that followed, I inscribed this verse everywhere — on rocks, on the faces of walls, on trees, on every road — and so that my flesh would not be visible, I wrapped my body in the garment I wore and climbed up into the tree. At that moment the deity of that tree asked me: 'Excellent! Excellent! Great being, what is it you now intend to do?' Noble son, at that time I spoke these words to the

deity: 'I intend to surrender this body completely in order to repay the kindness of having heard this verse.' The deity of the tree said: 'If you hear that verse, what benefit will there be?' The bodhisattva replied: 'This verse is the Dharma that opens up emptiness as it is known by all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the past, the future, and the present. It is for the sake of this Dharma that I surrender my body completely — not out of desire for gain, or for renown, or for wealth, or for jewels, or to become a wheel-turning king, or king of the four great kings, or Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, or the great king Brahmā, or the happiness of gods and humans. It is for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings that I surrender this body.' Noble son, as I was surrendering this body, I also spoke these words: 'May those sentient beings who are held in the grip of miserliness, upon seeing me surrender my body in this way, come to abide in generosity. And may those who are attached to generosity yet seized by pride also see me surrender my body in this way.' Having made this aspiration, I then surrendered this body as one might discard spittle or a clod of earth and stone. As soon as the bodhisattva had spoken these words, he leapt down from the tree. At that very moment, many kinds of sounds arose from the sky above and resounded all the way up to the peak of existence. At that time, the one who had appeared as the rakṣasa transformed back into the body of Śakra, caught the bodhisattva before he could strike the ground, laid him gently down, and made him comfortable. Then Śakra, lord of the gods, together with the sons of the gods and the great king Brahmā, bowed their heads at the feet of the bodhisattva and spoke these words: 'Excellent! Excellent! Bodhisattva, you are true — one who will bring benefit and happiness to measureless sentient beings, who causes the great lamp of Dharma to shine in the vast darkness of ignorance. I who disturbed your mind and did you harm in order to guard and protect the great Dharma of the Tathāgata — I confess and acknowledge that wrongdoing with regret. When in future you attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, we too aspire to be liberated.' Then Śakra, lord of the gods, and the sons of the gods bowed to the bodhisattva and vanished from sight. Noble son, thus in former times I also surrendered my body completely for the sake of a half-verse,

Through that cause and those conditions, twelve aeons before Maitreya, he manifested complete and perfect awakening into unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Noble son, that I attained such boundless qualities was likewise through the power of making offerings to the authentic Dharma of the Tathāgata. Noble son, you too are like that — by having aroused the mind of

unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, you are supremely elevated and exalted above bodhisattvas, great beings, boundless and limitless in number as the grains of sand in the river Ganges.

Noble son, it is therefore said that when a bodhisattva, a great being, abides in the Mahāyāna's complete nirvāṇa, practicing the noble conduct, it is called the practice of noble conduct. This is the sixth chapter, called "The Practice of Noble Conduct," from the Noble Sūtra of the Great Mahāyāna Complete Nirvāṇa.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Complete Nirvāṇa. The twentieth fascicle.

Noble son, how then does a bodhisattva, a great being, practice the holy life (brahmacarya)? Noble son, when bodhisattvas, great beings, abide in the Mahāyāna's complete nirvāṇa, they are endowed with the holy life through these seven kinds of Dharma. What are the seven? They are: knowing the Dharma, knowing the meaning, knowing the time, knowing moderation, knowing oneself, knowing the assembly, and knowing those above and below.

Noble son, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, know the Dharma? Noble son, the bodhisattva, the great being, knows the twelve branches of scripture — namely, the sūtra branch, the prose-and-verse mixed branch (geya), the prophetic branch (vyākaraṇa), the verse branch (gāthā), the inspirational sayings branch (udāna), the narrative context branch (nidāna), the tales of spiritual realization branch (avadāna), the branch of accounts of related events, the birth-story branch (jātaka), the extensive teachings branch (vaipulya), the wondrous branch (adbhutadharma), and the branch of systematic analysis (upadeśa). This is knowing the Dharma.

Noble son, what is called the sūtra branch? From the utterance "Thus did I hear" up to "they rejoiced and followed approvingly" — that is called a sūtra.

What is called the prose-and-verse mixed branch? It is what the Blessed One declared to the monks: "We too were utterly foolish; lacking knowledge, we did not understand the Four Noble Truths as they truly are, and because of that we wandered through cyclic existence and sank into the great ocean of suffering. What are those four truths? Suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path." After the Blessed One had first taught the sūtra branch to the monks, those among the congregation who were sharp-faculties then arrived before the Buddha in order to hear the Dharma, and asked others, "What did the Blessed One teach here before?" The Blessed One, knowing this, took what had been taught previously as a sūtra and then spoke

it again in verse, in these words:

I, formerly, was like you —

I did not see the four truths.

Because of that I wandered through cyclic existence
and fell into the great ocean of suffering.

Whoever realizes the four truths
will utterly sever cyclic existence.

When all becoming through birth is exhausted,
it is impossible to take on any further existence.

This is what is called the prose-and-verse mixed branch.

What is called the prophetic branch? It is that which, in a sūtra or in the Vinaya, the Tathāgata prophesied at certain times to gods and humans about attaining buddhahood — as in: "Ajita, in a future time a king called Śaṅkha will appear; at that time, in that age, he will fully awaken, and his name will be Maitreya." Such statements are called the prophetic branch.

What is called the verse branch? It is in sūtras and in —

the Vinaya — where the following four-line verse is spoken:

Abandon every evil deed.

Fulfil all that is wholesome.

Tame your own mind completely.

This is the teaching of the buddhas.

Statements such as these are called the verse branch.

What is called the deliberate utterance branch? At an evening time, the Blessed One entered into meditative absorption and taught the Dharma at length to the gods. Meanwhile, the monks, each on their own, were thinking: "What is the Tathāgata doing right now?" The following morning, the Tathāgata arose from his absorption, and, without having been asked by anyone, knowing through his primordial wisdom of the thoughts of others, he spoke thus: "Listen, monks, know it to be like this: all those born as gods have extremely long life-spans. Monks, it is excellent that you do not seek gain for the sake of others' approval. It is excellent to have few desires. It is excellent to be content with what one has. It is excellent to dwell in a charnel ground." Statements spoken deliberately in this way, without anyone having asked, are called the deliberate utterance branch.

What is called the narrative-occasion branch? It is that which, in a sūtra, arises from a narrative occasion and reveals a verse, the verse being distinguished and taught on the basis of that occasion. In such a case, in the land of Śrāvastī, a certain person seized a peacock by the neck, stuffed it into a cage, poured water over it mixed with rice, and then sent it away. The Blessed One, knowing through his wisdom the prior causes and conditions of this, took occasion from that event and spoke the following verse:

Do not scorn a small and minor evil deed,
thinking it will cause no harm.
Even dripping drops of water
will fill a great vessel to the brim.

Statements such as these are called the narrative-occasion branch.

What is called the inspired utterance branch? Those passages in the Vinaya that present illustrations and examples — these are called the inspired utterance branch.

What is called the thus-it-occurred branch? Among the words spoken by the Blessed One: those spoken when the Blessed One passed into the world and taught — such as the sūtra called "The Compendium of Elements"; those spoken when the Blessed One Bhadrāpāla passed into the world — called "The Five Nectars"; those spoken when the buddha Vipāśyin passed into the world — called "The Mirror of Dharma"; and those spoken when the Blessed One Kāśyapa passed into the world — called "The Analysis of Emptiness." Statements such as these are called the thus-it-occurred branch.

What is called the birth-tale branch? These concern the Blessed One's practice of the bodhisattva conduct in former times and the hardships he underwent. "Monks, know this well: in times past I took on the body of a deer, the body of a bear, the body of a spotted deer, the body of a hare, the body of a king, the body of a wheel-turning king, the body of a nāga, the body of a garuda, and many such forms — and in those lives, while practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, I had these experiences." Statements such as these are called the birth-tale branch.

What is called the extensive sūtra branch? The meaning of the extensive Mahāyāna sūtras is said to be extremely vast and wide, like the sky itself. Sūtras such as these are called the extensive sūtra branch.

What is called the wondrous occurrence branch? The bodhisattva, immediately upon being born for the first time, without anyone guiding him, walked seven steps; he emitted a great radiance of light; he gazed in all ten directions; a monkey-bee carried a vessel of honey and offered it to the Tathāgata; a white dog listened to the Dharma from the buddha; the māra (Skt. māra) of evil form transformed himself into a dark-blue ox and entered among many nuns' almsbowls that had been set out, knocking and jostling among them and yet not breaking a single one; and when the buddha, from the moment of his first birth, entered into a divine shrine, the gods rose and paid homage and the like. Statements such as these are called the wondrous occurrence branch.

What is called "the branch of establishing conclusions" is this: in whatever sūtras the Blessed One, the Buddha, taught, the degree to which a subject is definitively determined, its particular divisions made, and its defining marks explained — that is called the branch of establishing conclusions.

When a bodhisattva thus understands and knows the twelve branches of the sūtras, that is called knowing the Dharma.

Now, in what way does a great bodhisattva know the meaning? A great bodhisattva who knows in detail the meaning of everything expressed in letters and in words — that is called knowing the meaning.

In what way does a great bodhisattva know the time? Son of good family, a great bodhisattva knows the time: the time for dwelling in a charnel ground; the time for applying oneself with great diligence; the time for cultivating equanimity and meditative absorption; the time for making offerings to the buddhas; the time for attending upon one's teacher; and the time for applying oneself earnestly to generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom. Knowing these things is called knowing the time.

In what way does a great bodhisattva know contentment? Son of good family, a great bodhisattva's knowing contentment is this: with regard to food and drink, robes, medicine, coming and going, sitting, resting, sleeping, waking, and keeping silent — knowing the appropriate measure in all these is called knowing contentment.

Son of good family, in what way does a great bodhisattva know himself? That bodhisattva knows himself in this way: "I have such and such faith; such and such moral discipline; such and such learning; such and such equanimity; such and such wisdom; such and such manner of coming and going; such and such

mindfulness; such and such practice of virtue; such and such manner of questioning; and such and such manner of answering." Knowing these things about oneself is called knowing oneself.

In what way does a great bodhisattva know his assembly? Son of good family, a bodhisattva knows his assembly in this way: "This is an assembly of the warrior class; this is an assembly of brahmins; this is an assembly of householders; this is an assembly of renunciants." And he knows how to conduct himself in each of those assemblies, how to sit among them, how to teach the Dharma among them, and how to question and respond among them. Knowing these things is called knowing the assembly.

Son of good family, in what way does a great bodhisattva know the superior and the inferior? Son of good family, in this regard there are two kinds: those with faith and those without faith. The bodhisattva should understand that those with faith tend toward virtue and those without faith tend toward non-virtue. Among those with faith, again there are two kinds: those who dwell in the Saṅgha's residence and those who do not. The bodhisattva should understand that those who dwell in the Saṅgha's residence act virtuously, while those who do not dwell there act non-virtuously. Among those who do dwell there, again there are two kinds: those who pay homage and those who do not. The bodhisattva should understand that those who pay homage act virtuously, while those who do not pay homage act non-virtuously. Among those who do pay homage, again there are two kinds: those who listen to the Dharma and those who do not. The bodhisattva should understand that those who listen to the Dharma act virtuously, while those who do not listen act non-virtuously. Among those who do listen to the Dharma, again there are two kinds: those who listen with one-pointed mind and those who do not. The bodhisattva should understand that those who listen with one-pointed mind act virtuously, while those who do not listen with one-pointed mind act non-virtuously. Among those who do listen with one-pointed mind, again there are two kinds: those who attend to the meaning and those who do not attend to the meaning.

The bodhisattva should understand that those who attend to the meaning act virtuously, while those who do not attend to the meaning act non-virtuously. Among those who do attend to the meaning, again there are two kinds: those who practice in accordance with what has been taught, and those who do not practice in accordance with what has been taught. The bodhisattva should understand that those who practice in accordance with what has been taught

act virtuously, while those who do not practice in accordance with what has been taught act non-virtuously. Among those who do practice in accordance with what has been taught, again there are two kinds: those who seek through the vehicle of the śrāvakas and do not act for the benefit and happiness of all suffering sentient beings, and those who dedicate their practice to unsurpassed awakening and engage in it for the benefit and happiness of the many — these latter are bodhisattvas, and whoever acts for the benefit and happiness of the many is the most excellent of all.

Noble son, as an example: among precious gems, the wish-fulfilling jewel is supreme. Among all savors, ambrosia (amṛta) is supreme. Likewise, the bodhisattva too has arisen as the highest and most excellent among gods and humans, utterly beyond compare.

Noble son, these are what is called "dwelling in the seven wholesome qualities" for a bodhisattva, a great being who abides in the sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete passing beyond sorrow. When a bodhisattva is endowed with these seven qualities of Dharma, that is called the holy life (brahmacarya).

Noble son, furthermore, what is called the holy life is this: loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity.

The bodhisattva, the great being Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, since the extensive cultivation of loving-kindness eliminates aversion, and since the mind of compassion also cuts through aversion, why speak of four immeasurables? In terms of their actual import, they are sufficiently covered by three."

The Blessed One replied: "Kāśyapa, loving-kindness has three kinds of focus: focus on sentient beings, focus on phenomena, and non-focus. Compassion, joy, and equanimity are likewise — in terms of actual import they are covered by three, and there is no fourth.

Focus on sentient beings means: focusing on the five aggregates and wishing them to be happy — this is called focus on sentient beings. Focus on phenomena means: focusing on sentient beings and giving them whatever they need — this is called focus on phenomena. Non-focus means: focusing on the Tathāgata — this is called non-focus.

What is called loving-kindness focuses on impoverished sentient beings. The Tathāgata, the Great Teacher, is utterly free from poverty and is perfectly at

ease. If one focuses on sentient beings, that is not focusing on a buddha — and the same holds for phenomena. Therefore, focusing on the Tathāgata is called non-focus.

Blessed One, loving-kindness focuses on all sentient beings, just as one might focus on one's mother or father, spouse, child, or dear friend — therefore it is called focus on sentient beings. Focus on phenomena means: not regarding all things as mother, father, spouse, child, or dear friend, but viewing all phenomena as arising through dependent origination — this is called focus on phenomena. Non-focus means: not resting in characteristics with regard to phenomena, and not resting in characteristics with regard to sentient beings — this is called non-focus. Compassion, joy, and equanimity are likewise. Therefore they are covered by three, and there is no fourth.

Blessed One, persons are of two kinds: those who are motivated by what they see, and those who are motivated by what they love. Those who are motivated by what they see cultivate loving-kindness and compassion to a greater degree. Those who are motivated by what they love cultivate joy and equanimity to a greater degree. Therefore they are covered by three, and there is no fourth.

Blessed One, the reason these are called 'immeasurable' is that they are boundless —"

because they are boundless, they are called immeasurable. If they are immeasurable, then there can be three but not four. If there were four, they could not be called immeasurable. Therefore there are three and not four."

The Blessed One then declared to Kāśyapa: "Son of good family, a buddha, a Blessed One, teaches the Dharma for the sake of the many ordinary persons, and what is taught is taught with very deep intention. It is therefore difficult to understand and to know.

For some sentient beings he taught dependent origination as a single thing. What is that single dependent origination? It is this: all conditioned phenomena.

Son of good family, for some he taught it in two aspects: cause and result. For some he taught it in three aspects: affliction, karma, and suffering. For some he taught it in four aspects: ignorance, formations, birth, and aging-and-death. For some he taught it in five aspects: feeling, craving, grasping, becoming, and birth. For some he taught it in six aspects: cause and result across the

three times. On some occasions he taught it in seven aspects: consciousness, name, form, the six sense bases, contact, feeling, becoming, and grasping. For some he taught it in eight aspects: the remaining eight besides ignorance, formations, birth, and aging-and-death. For some he taught it in nine aspects: as explained in the sūtra called 'The City,' the remaining nine besides ignorance, formations, and consciousness. For some he taught it in eleven aspects: because of the objection of the naked ascetics (Nirgranthans) who say all things arise from birth, the remaining eleven aspects besides that one. And on some occasions he taught dependent origination in its complete twelve aspects — as he taught in full to Kāśyapa and others at Rājagṛha, from ignorance all the way through birth and aging-and-death, the twelve complete links.

Son of good family, this single dependent origination he taught in different aspects for the sake of different ordinary persons. The immeasurable minds are likewise.

Son of good family, therefore do not give rise to doubt about the domain of what the Tathāgata taught with deep intention.

Son of good family, the buddha, the Blessed One, is endowed with the most supreme skillful means. Thus he taught the impermanent as permanent, and the permanent as impermanent. He taught the pleasant as suffering, and the suffering as pleasant. He taught the impure as pure, and the pure as impure. He taught the self as selfless, and the selfless as self. He taught what is not a sentient being as a sentient being, and the sentient being as not a sentient being. He taught what is not a thing as a thing, and the thing as not a thing. He taught the untrue as true, and the true as untrue. He taught what is not an object as an object, and the object as not an object. He taught what is not birth as birth, and birth as not birth. And further: he taught ignorance as knowledge, and knowledge as ignorance. He taught form as not form, and not-form as form. He taught what is not the path as the path, and the path as not the path.

Son of good family, with immeasurable skillful means the Tathāgata spoke what appear to be falsehoods in order to tame sentient beings. Son of good family, if a certain sentient being is attached to enjoyments and riches, then I conjure an appearance for him as a wheel-turning king and for a measureless span of years give him every kind of thing in manifold variety that he could desire —

and thereafter established him at last in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If a certain sentient being is attached to the five objects of desire, then for a measureless span of years I let him enjoy the finest and most excellent of the five kinds of desirable things, and thereafter established him at last in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If a certain sentient being is proud of his lineage and arrogant by nature, then for a measureless span of years I made myself that person's servant and honored him with the utmost reverence, gladdening his mind, and thereafter established him at last in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If a certain sentient being is by nature arrogant and requires that others counsel and correct him, then for hundreds and thousands of years I instructed and corrected him until his mind was tamed, and only then established him in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Son of good family, is it a falsehood that the Tathāgata, for a measureless span of years, through manifold skillful means, established many beings in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? The buddha, the Blessed One, though dwelling amid the unwholesome, is not stained by the mud of faults, just as a lotus is unstained. Son of good family, the meaning of the four immeasurables is likewise to be understood in this way.

Son of good family, the mind of immeasurability is by nature fourfold, and whoever cultivates it earnestly will be reborn in the realm of Brahmā the Great. Son of good family, there are thus four qualities that serve as companions to the immeasurables, and that is why they are called four. Whoever cultivates the mind of loving-kindness will fully cut off attachment. Whoever cultivates the mind of compassion will fully abandon aversion. Whoever cultivates the mind of joy will fully abandon unhappiness. Whoever cultivates the mind of equanimity will fully abandon the minds of attachment and aversion.

Son of good family, for this reason they are fourfold — not one, not two, not three. Son of good family, do not say: "Just as you explain that the mind of loving-kindness abandons aversion, compassion is similar to it in that regard, and so three would be fitting." Why not? Son of good family, aversion is of two kinds: aversion that takes life, and aversion that strikes and injures. Cultivating loving-kindness abandons aversion that takes life. Cultivating compassion abandons aversion that strikes and injures.

Son of good family, for this reason, are not four immeasurables appropriate? Furthermore, aversion is of two kinds: aversion toward sentient beings, and aversion toward what is not sentient beings. Cultivating loving-kindness

abandons aversion toward sentient beings. Cultivating compassion abandons aversion toward what is not sentient beings. Furthermore, aversion is of two kinds: aversion that has causes and conditions, and aversion that lacks causes and conditions. Cultivating loving-kindness abandons aversion that has causes and conditions. Cultivating compassion abandons aversion that lacks causes and conditions. Furthermore, aversion is of two kinds: aversion habituated from the past, and aversion habituated in the present moment. Cultivating loving-kindness abandons aversion habituated from the past. Cultivating compassion abandons aversion habituated in the present. Furthermore, aversion is of two kinds: aversion toward noble ones, and aversion toward the base and ignoble. Cultivating the mind of loving-kindness abandons aversion toward noble ones.

Cultivating compassion abandons aversion toward the base and ignoble. Furthermore, aversion is of two kinds: intense aversion and middling aversion. Cultivating loving-kindness abandons intense aversion. Cultivating compassion abandons middling aversion.

Noble son, for these reasons, it is not fitting to object by saying that, since four aspects are appropriate, they are exhausted in three and there cannot be four. Therefore, Kāśyapa, the way in which these immeasurable minds function as support and antidote has been taught by distinguishing them into four aspects.

Furthermore, four aspects are fitting on account of the vessel. If one possesses loving-kindness toward a particular vessel, that does not mean compassion, joy, and equanimity are also present toward that same being. For this reason, there is no way to reduce the four aspects. Noble son, from the particular perspective of conduct as well, four aspects are fitting. If, when one is practicing loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity are absent, then for that reason the four aspects are manifestly necessary.

Noble son, four aspects are also fitting on account of the immeasurable itself. Furthermore, the immeasurable is of four kinds. Some immeasurable minds have an object but are not masterful. Some minds of loving-kindness are masterful but have no object. Some minds of loving-kindness both have an object and are masterful. And some minds of loving-kindness neither have an object nor are masterful.

As for an immeasurable mind that has an object but is not masterful: some focus on limitless and boundless sentient beings as their object, yet have not

attained mastery in meditative absorption, or else have attained it but with uncertainty, or have attained it but then declined. As for an immeasurable that is masterful but has no object: this is like focusing on one's parents, siblings, or friends and relatives with the aim of bringing them happiness — this is not a focus on the immeasurable. As for an immeasurable that both has an object and is masterful: this refers to buddhas and bodhisattvas. As for an immeasurable that neither has an object nor is masterful: this is like śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who are unable to focus broadly on limitless sentient beings, and in whom mastery does not arise.

Noble son, for these reasons, the immeasurable is of four kinds, and it is not something that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are capable of fully knowing — it is the domain of the blessed buddhas. Noble son, though these four entities may be called immeasurable even in relation to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, it is not fitting to say so without qualification. The blessed buddhas are to be called immeasurable and boundless.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One again: "It is so, Blessed One. It is so. Just as the Blessed One has declared, this is the domain of the blessed buddhas, and it does not fall within the patience of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Blessed One, would a bodhisattva who abides in the great nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle, and in whom minds of loving-kindness and compassion arise, declare that these are not great loving-kindness and great compassion?" The Blessed One replied: "Noble son, if a bodhisattva divides sentient beings into three groups — friends, enemies, and those who are neutral — and further divides friends into superior, middling, and lesser, and likewise divides enemies in the same way, then the bodhisattva, the great being, bestows the highest happiness on those who are the most beloved friends; bestows a moderately high happiness equally on the middling and lesser friends; bestows a somewhat lesser degree of happiness on the most intense enemies;

bestows a moderately high happiness on the middling enemy; and bestows the highest happiness on the least intense enemy. In the same progressive manner, the bodhisattva strives to bestow a moderately high happiness on the most intense enemy, and strives to bestow an equally highest happiness on both the middling and the least intense enemies. Or, progressively still, does the bodhisattva strive to bestow an equally highest happiness on the superior, the middling, and the least? If the bodhisattva strives to bestow the highest happiness on the most intense enemy, that is called possessing a mind of

loving-kindness. At that point, even though the bodhisattva has no distinction whatsoever between father and mother on the one hand and the most intense enemy on the other, and the mind has become equanimous toward all, noble son, that is still called loving-kindness — it is not yet great loving-kindness.

The questioner asked: "Blessed One, why is it that even a bodhisattva endowed with such loving-kindness as this is not said to have great loving-kindness?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, because it is extremely difficult to sustain it fully, it is not called great loving-kindness. Why is that? Over a very long time, throughout immeasurable eons, one has accumulated many afflictions and has not cultivated wholesome phenomena — therefore the mind cannot be tamed in a mere single day or a single night. Noble son, consider this analogy: just as a needle cannot pierce a dry bean, in the same way, afflictions that are extremely hardened are like that — even if the mind becomes one-pointed and undistracted for a mere single day or night, they are still exceedingly difficult to tame.

Consider further: a dog is not frightened of people, but deer and the like are afraid of people and flee the moment they see one. Aversion, which is so difficult to abandon, is like a guard dog. The mind of loving-kindness, which is so easily disturbed, is like a deer. Therefore, because the mind is so very difficult to tame, this is not called great loving-kindness.

Noble son, consider yet another analogy: if one carves a design on stone, it lasts forever; if one draws a design on water, it is gone the very next moment and does not remain. Aversion is like a design carved on stone. Virtuous roots are like a design drawn on water. Therefore this mind is exceedingly difficult to tame.

Furthermore, consider: the light of a great mass of fire endures for a long time; the light of lightning is but a single instant and does not remain. Aversion is like the great mass of fire; loving-kindness is like the light of lightning. Therefore this mind is exceedingly difficult to tame — and for that reason, this is not called great loving-kindness.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides on the first ground (bhūmi) is said to have great loving-kindness. Why is that? Noble son, the most extreme among those who are guilty of wrongdoing are called the perversely craving. A bodhisattva who abides on the first ground and cultivates great loving-kindness makes no distinction even with regard to the perversely

craving, and because no fault is perceived in them, no aversion arises. For that reason it is called great loving-kindness.

Noble son, completely removing whatever is harmful and sorrowful for all sentient beings is called great loving-kindness. Giving immeasurable benefit and happiness to many sentient beings is called great compassion. Arousing a mind of joy toward all sentient beings is called great joy. Being without weariness is called great equanimity. Not perceiving a self, a phenomenon, a defining characteristic, or one's own body, and viewing all phenomena as being in a state of equanimity — this is called great equanimity. Surrendering one's own happiness and giving it to others is called great equanimity.

Noble son, from the four immeasurables alone, the six perfections arise and are perfected — not through any other practice."

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, first attains the four worldly immeasurables, and from that basis arouses the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Gradually, one will also attain transcendence of the world. Noble son, from the cause of the worldly immeasurables, the transcendent immeasurables are attained — and for this reason they are called the great immeasurables.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, eliminating everything that is harmful and painful, and merely thinking of bringing benefit and happiness — that is no more than a thought. It will not truly bring benefit or happiness. Blessed One, consider the example of a monk who, upon perceiving something impure, perceives the clothes worn on the body as skin — and yet they are not truly skin. The monk perceives food as worms — and yet it is not truly worms. The monk perceives bean soup as impure fluid — and yet it is not truly impure fluid. The monk perceives yogurt as feet or brains — and yet it is not truly brains. The monk perceives flour as ground bones — and yet it is not truly ground bones. The four immeasurables are just like this: they do not truly bring benefit and happiness to sentient beings. If one merely says with one's mouth, 'I am giving happiness to sentient beings,' and yet they do not truly become happy — is not such a thought a falsehood? Blessed One, if it is not a falsehood and is truly true, then why do the buddhas and bodhisattvas not, through their blessing, cause all sentient beings to experience happiness? If they do not truly become happy, then what of this teaching the Blessed One gave that I recall to mind now: that by doing no more than earnestly cultivating the single mind of loving-kindness, for an

entire age this world-system is washed clean seven times, and one is not born in this world-system during that time — that when the world is forming one is born as a god in the Brahmā heaven, and when the world is dissolving one is born as a god in the Akaniṣṭha heaven? When born as a god in the Brahmā heaven, one is endowed with power and might, uneclipsed by others, and becomes supreme and foremost among a thousand Brahmā realms, being born as the great king Mahābrahmā, so that all sentient beings come to regard oneself as their lord and sovereign. Thirty-six times one is born as Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods of the Thirty-Three Heaven, with sovereignty over the gods. For hundreds of thousands of births one is born as a wheel-turning king.' If this were not true, what credibility would there be in such a teaching? Since by cultivating the single mind of loving-kindness alone one attains the excellent resources and enjoyments of gods and humans — how could it be untrue?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, you are so very brave and endowed with fearlessness." Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to Kāśyapa:

Whoever, toward even a single sentient being,
does not give rise to a mind of aversion,
but wishes for that being's happiness —
this is called pure loving-kindness.

Whoever, toward all sentient beings,
arouses a mind of compassion —
such a one is called of noble lineage,
and will attain immeasurable merit.

Suppose a sage possessed of the five superknowledges
were to fill a great expanse of land,
and a powerful king were to give all manner of happiness —
horses, cattle, and various riches —
the merit obtained thereby
could not match even one-sixteenth
of the merit born of cultivating loving-kindness.

Son of good lineage, the loving-kindness that is cultivated is not false — it is true and authentic. The loving-kindness of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, however, is called false. If it is asked why the loving-kindness of buddhas and bodhisattvas is true and not false in its subtler sense, then know this: a great

bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in great and complete nirvāṇa, sees even earth as gold, and gold as earth; sees earth as water, and water as earth; sees water as fire, and fire as water; sees earth as wind, and wind as earth. Because whatever is wished for is accomplished, there is no falsehood. One who is truly a sentient being may be seen as not a sentient being, and one who is not a sentient being may be truly seen as a sentient being. Because whatever is wished for is accomplished, there is no falsehood. Therefore, son of good lineage, the intention that arises from the four immeasurable minds of a bodhisattva is authentic.

Furthermore, son of good lineage, what then is meant by authentic intention? It is for the sake of completely purifying all mental afflictions. Son of good lineage, by cultivating the mind of loving-kindness, attachment and desire will be entirely abandoned. By cultivating the mind of compassion, aversion and anger will be entirely abandoned. By cultivating the mind of joy, unhappiness will be entirely abandoned. By cultivating the mind of equanimity, attachment, aversion, and the perception of beings as substantially real will be entirely abandoned. Therefore this is called authentic intention.

Furthermore, son of good lineage, the four immeasurable minds of a great bodhisattva, a great being, become the ground and root of all virtue. Son of good lineage, if a great bodhisattva, a great being, does not see sentient beings who are impoverished, there is no cause for loving-kindness to arise. If loving-kindness has not arisen, the mind that wishes to give in generosity will not emerge. When generosity is given, many sentient beings are brought to happiness through its power — through giving food and drink, conveyances, clothing, incense, flowers, cushioned seats, houses, and illuminating lamps, and so forth. When generosity is given in this way, the mind is not bound and attachment does not arise, and without any reservation it is dedicated unfailingly to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. At that time the mind clings to nothing; perception is cut off; one does not fear gain and fame; one does not seek the happiness of gods or humans; pride does not arise; one does not expect anything in return; one does not give in generosity in order to deceive others; one does not give out of desire for possessions; when generosity is given, one does not look upon the recipient; one does not distinguish between those of moral discipline and those of poor conduct, between a field of merit and what is not a field of merit, between a spiritual friend and one who is not a spiritual friend; when giving, one does not look upon the gift as fit or unfit as a vessel; one does not look at the day, the time,

the place, or whether the place is suitable; one does not consider whether it is a time of famine or a time of great abundance; one does not look at cause and effect; one does not distinguish between sentient beings and non-sentient beings, or between merit and non-merit. Thus, while not looking upon the giver, the receiver, or the material object, nor upon interruptions along the way, nor upon the ripening of results, one nonetheless always practices generosity and does not interrupt its continual flow.

Son of good lineage, if a bodhisattva were to look upon those of moral discipline and those of poor conduct and to keep in view the ripening of the result, generosity would not be given. And if generosity were not given, the perfection of generosity would not be completely fulfilled.

And if the perfection of generosity is not completely fulfilled, unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening will not be accomplished.

Son of good lineage, consider this example: a man has been struck by a poisoned arrow. His relatives and friends seek out a skilled physician in order to draw out the poison and bring him relief. But as the physician moves to extract the poisoned arrow, the man says: "Wait — do not touch my body yet. First let me determine from which direction the arrow came, who shot it — whether a warrior, a brahmin, or someone of low caste — and from where it came. And the arrow itself — is it made of wood, bamboo, or cane? What kind of shaft was used? Of what bird's feathers is the fletching made — a vulture's or some other bird's? And the poison — where did it come from and who made it? Or did it arise of its own? Is it a humanly compounded poison, or the venom of a deadly snake?" And so, while the fool deliberates without arriving at any understanding, he dies on the spot.

Son of good lineage, the bodhisattva is like that very man. When practicing generosity, he makes distinctions and discriminates: "This is the giver; this is the receiver. This one guards moral discipline; this one is of poor conduct" — distinguishing in this way all the way to the ripening of results, he will never give. And if he does not give, the perfection of generosity will not be completely fulfilled. And if the perfection of generosity is not completely fulfilled, unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening will not be accomplished.

Son of good lineage, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices generosity, the loving mind he holds equally toward all sentient beings is like that of a parent toward an only child. Furthermore, when generosity is given, the arising of a mind of compassion toward all sentient beings is like that of parents

nursing their only child through illness. The mind of deep joy that arises while practicing generosity is like that of parents seeing their child recover from illness. The equanimity that arises in the mind after giving is like that of parents who, having raised their only child to full growth and seen the child flourish and be well, are at rest.

And so, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of food with a mind of loving-kindness, he makes this aspiration: "May this act of giving that I have performed become something shared in common with all sentient beings. By its causes and conditions, may all sentient beings obtain the nourishment of great wisdom, and may they be devoted to dedicating it to the unsurpassed Great Vehicle. May all sentient beings obtain the nourishment of virtuous wisdom, and may they not seek the nourishment of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. May all sentient beings obtain the nourishment of the joy of Dharma, and may they not seek the nourishment of sensual pleasure. May all sentient beings obtain the nourishment of the Perfection of Wisdom, may everything be completely and perfectly fulfilled for them, and may they gather the supreme unobstructed roots of virtue. May all sentient beings realize the characteristic of emptiness, attain an unobstructed body, and become like the sky. May all sentient beings always be recipients of generosity, may they be filled with loving-kindness and tender affection for all, and may they become a field of merit for everyone." Thus he makes aspiration.

Son of good lineage, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of food with a mind of loving-kindness, he should be utterly steadfast in generating those aspirations.

Son of good lineage, furthermore, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of drink to those who are thirsty, with a mind of loving-kindness, he makes this aspiration: "May this act of giving that I have performed become something shared in common with all sentient beings.

By that cause and that condition, may all sentient beings enter the river of the Great Vehicle, drink water possessed of eight flavors, and swiftly travel the path to unsurpassed awakening. May they abandon the torment of the thirst of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, be insatiable in the vehicle of unsurpassed buddhahood, completely abandon the torment of afflictions, be insatiable in the taste of Dharma, relinquish the desires of saṃsāra, and aspire to the complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle. May they fully perfect the dharmakāya, attain the meditative absorptions, and enter the ocean of profoundly deep

primordial wisdom. May all sentient beings taste the flavor of ambrosia, and having abandoned the desire for bodhisattvas to appear in the world, may they taste the flavor of supreme bliss. May all sentient beings come to possess the measureless hundreds and thousands of tastes of Dharma, and having come to possess the taste of Dharma, may they behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Having beheld the intrinsic nature of a buddha, may they pour down a rain of Dharma. Having poured down a rain of Dharma, may the intrinsic nature of a buddha cover everything like the sky, and may all immeasurable sentient beings attain the single taste of the Dharma of the Great Vehicle — not the taste of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. May all sentient beings attain the single sweet taste, not the taste that has become sixfold. May all sentient beings seek only the taste of Dharma, and practicing the Dharma of the buddhas without obstruction, may they never seek any taste other than that.

Son of good lineage, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of drink to those who are thirsty with a mind of loving-kindness, he should be utterly steadfast in generating those aspirations.

Son of good lineage, furthermore, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of a vehicle with a mind of loving-kindness, he makes this aspiration: "May this act of giving that I have performed become something shared in common with all sentient beings. By that cause and that condition, may all sentient beings be uplifted by a vehicle that is the perfection of the Great Vehicle, a vehicle that abides in the Great Vehicle, a vehicle of non-return, a vehicle that is unshakeable, a vehicle of the seat of awakening (Vajrāsana), a vehicle that does not seek śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, a vehicle that leads to the vehicle of the buddhas, a vehicle that cannot be stolen away, a vehicle that is not inferior, a vehicle that does not turn back, a vehicle that is unsurpassed, a vehicle of the ten powers, a vehicle of great qualities, a vehicle that is wondrous, a vehicle that is marvelous, a vehicle exceedingly hard to find, a vehicle that is boundless, a vehicle that is omniscient."

Son of good lineage, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of a vehicle with a mind of loving-kindness, he should always be steadfast in generating those aspirations.

Son of good lineage, furthermore, when the bodhisattva, the great being, gives the gift of garments to be worn with a mind of loving-kindness, he makes this aspiration: "May this act of giving that I have performed become

something shared in common with all sentient beings. By that cause and that condition, may all sentient beings be possessed of the garment of modesty and sense of shame, have their bodies covered by the dharmadhātu, and be stripped of the garments pierced through by many wrong views. May their clothing not touch their bodies even by a cubit's width. May they attain bodies of golden hue, with tactile sensations exceedingly soft, luminous and unobstructed, their complexion brilliant, their skin smooth, and their light always immeasurable. May they become formless and entirely free from form. May all sentient beings attain a formless body, transcend all form, and enter the great nirvāṇa of formlessness."

So goes the aspiration prayer. O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva gives the gift of clothing, one should remain steadfast in generating aspiration prayers such as these.

O son of good family, furthermore, when a great bodhisattva cultivates the mind of loving-kindness and gives the gift of flowers, incense, powdered incense, or perfumed unguents, one makes aspiration prayers in this manner: "May this act of giving that I have performed be shared in common with all sentient beings. Through its cause and by its conditions, may all sentient beings attain the meditative absorption of the buddha-flower samādhi, and may they bear upon their heads the crown of the seven limbs of awakening. May all sentient beings become like a form as luminous as the full moon reflected on water, and may all visible forms become supremely excellent. May all sentient beings be entirely adorned with a hundredfold merit bearing a single defining mark. May all sentient beings behold, according to their wish, whatever form is pleasing to the mind. May all sentient beings always encounter a virtuous spiritual friend and receive speech that is unobstructed, so that they may be freed from all that is impure. May all sentient beings be endowed with roots of virtue unsurpassed, like precious jewels. May all sentient beings, by the mere sight of one another, feel joy and affection, be free from the sorrow that leads to suffering, each be endowed with virtue, and do no harm to one another. May all sentient beings be endowed with the fragrant protection of moral discipline. May all sentient beings guard moral discipline without obstruction, and may the fragrant perfume of that discipline pervade and fill the ten directions entirely. May all sentient beings be endowed with moral discipline that is supremely stable, moral discipline free from remorse, moral discipline of omniscient wisdom, moral discipline that has utterly abandoned inferior ethical conduct, moral discipline that is without

anything at all, moral discipline of what has never before arisen, moral discipline without a preceptor, moral discipline without activity, moral discipline without anguish, moral discipline without mental affliction, perfected moral discipline, equal moral discipline — and may they be without partiality between one who anoints their body with fragrant incense and one who pierces and wounds them with a weapon, loving both equally. May all sentient beings attain unsurpassed moral discipline, not the moral discipline of the lesser vehicle, but endowed with the moral discipline of the Great Vehicle. May all sentient beings be endowed with the perfection of moral discipline and with the spontaneously accomplished moral discipline of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. May all sentient beings grow familiar with generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom. May all sentient beings be endowed with the sacred lotus of great nirvāṇa, and may the fragrant perfume of that lotus fill and pervade the ten directions entirely. May all sentient beings be endowed with the supreme unsurpassed nourishment of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, carrying its fragrance — just as bees, without harming the color or the fragrance of a flower, take what they need. May all sentient beings be endowed with a body constituted from qualities beyond measure." So goes this aspiration prayer.

O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva gives the gift of flowers and incense with a mind of loving-kindness, one should remain steadfast always in setting forth aspiration prayers such as these.

O son of good family, furthermore, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of thrones and seats, one makes aspiration prayers in this manner: "May this act of giving that I have performed be shared in common with all sentient beings. Through its cause and by its conditions, may all sentient beings be endowed with the divine resting throne of the god above gods. May they be endowed with great wisdom and abide in the state of the four meditative concentrations,

may they rest upon the resting throne of a bodhisattva, may they not rest upon the resting thrones of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and may they thoroughly abandon the resting thrones upon which the wicked recline. May all sentient beings rest in perfect ease, and having thoroughly abandoned the resting throne of saṃsāra, may they be endowed with the lion's throne of complete nirvāṇa. May all sentient beings, even while seated upon that throne, manifest for the benefit of immeasurable other sentient beings the lion's sport of higher knowledge. May all sentient beings, dwelling in this great

palace of the Great Vehicle, reveal to all sentient beings the nature of a buddha. May all sentient beings, seated upon the unsurpassed throne, not be swept away by the ways of the world. May all sentient beings, having obtained the throne of patience, be freed from the famine of hunger and cold in saṃsāra. May all sentient beings, having obtained the fearless throne, abandon all enemies that are mental afflictions. May all sentient beings, having obtained the utterly pure throne, strive for nothing other than unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. May all sentient beings, having obtained the throne that abides in virtue, be ever protected by virtuous spiritual friends. May all sentient beings, having obtained the throne upon which one rests on the right side, abide in the Dharma as performed by the buddhas." Thus one sets forth aspiration prayers.

O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of thrones and seats in this manner, one should remain steadfast always in setting forth aspiration prayers such as these.

O son of good family, furthermore, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of a dwelling house, one sets forth aspiration prayers in this manner: "May this act of giving that I have performed be shared in common with all sentient beings. Through its cause and by its conditions, may all sentient beings dwell in the house of the Great Vehicle, diligently practicing under virtuous spiritual friends, diligently cultivating great compassion, diligently practicing the six perfections, engaging in the deeds of a perfectly complete buddha, treading the path traveled by all bodhisattvas, and practicing what is as boundless and vast as the sky. May all sentient beings be endowed with correct mindfulness and thoroughly abandon all erroneous thoughts. May all sentient beings abide in ease in permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity, and thoroughly abandon the four inversions. May all sentient beings retain the letters and syllables that transcend the world. May all sentient beings be definitively established as vessels for the unsurpassed gnosis of omniscience. May all sentient beings enter the house of nectar. May all sentient beings, with minds of beginning, middle, and end all together, always enter the house of complete nirvāṇa. May all sentient beings always dwell in the palace of the bodhisattvas in time to come." Thus one sets forth aspiration prayers.

O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of a dwelling house, one should remain steadfast always in setting forth these aspiration prayers.

O son of good family, furthermore, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of lamplight, one sets forth aspiration prayers in this manner: "May this act of giving that I have performed be shared in common with all sentient beings. Through its cause and by its conditions, may all sentient beings be endowed with boundless radiance and abide in ease within the Dharma of the buddhas. May all sentient beings be always fully illuminated everywhere by light.

May all sentient beings be endowed with a sublime and excellent complexion, blazing with surpassing radiance. May all sentient beings be endowed with perfectly pure eyes and have the film of blindness cut away. May all sentient beings be endowed with the lamp of omniscient wisdom and become supremely skilled in the absence of self, the absence of a sentient being, the absence of a person, and the absence of a life-force. May all sentient beings see the utterly pure intrinsic nature of the buddhas, like open sky. May all sentient beings be endowed with perfectly pure eyes and clearly see world-realms in the ten directions as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Ganges. May all sentient beings be endowed with the light of the buddhas and shine in the ten directions. May all sentient beings be endowed with unobstructed eyes and all see the utterly pure intrinsic nature of the buddhas. May all sentient beings attain the radiance of great wisdom and vanquish all darkness and all wrong craving. May all sentient beings be endowed with boundless light and illuminate all the boundless buddha-fields. May all sentient beings raise up the lamp of the Great Vehicle and relinquish the lamps of the two lesser vehicles. May all sentient beings be endowed with the light of radiance and, dispelling the darkness of ignorance, be endowed with the quality of illuminating all things in a manner surpassing a thousand suns. May all sentient beings attain the radiance called the Jewel of Fiery Light and dispel all the darkness within the world-realm of the great trichiliocosm. May all sentient beings be endowed with the five eyes, comprehend the defining characteristics of phenomena, and know these for themselves without needing a teacher. May all sentient beings not look upon ignorance. May all sentient beings, through the rays of light of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa, truly reveal the intrinsic nature of buddhas to all sentient beings." These are the aspiration prayers one sets forth.

O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva with a mind of loving-kindness gives the gift of lamplight, one should remain steadfast always in generating these aspiration prayers.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, the twenty-first fascicle.

O son of good family, the foundation of the wholesome roots of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and buddha-bhagavāns is loving-kindness. O son of good family, when a great bodhisattva applies diligence to the mind of loving-kindness, these immeasurable wholesome roots are born. They are as follows: contemplation of the unattractive; counting the inward and outward flow of the breath; impermanence; arising; cessation; the four applications of mindfulness; the seven skillful means; the three bases of examination; the twelve links of dependent origination; contemplation of selflessness and the like; heat, peak, patience, and the supreme worldly dharma; the path of seeing; the path of cultivation; the four right abandonments; the four bases of miraculous power; the faculties; the powers; the seven limbs of awakening; the noble eightfold path; the four meditative concentrations; the four immeasurables; the eight liberations; the eight stations of mastery; the ten totalities; emptiness; the signless; the wishless; the meditative absorption of non-conflict; the wisdom of knowing others' minds; the superknowledges; the wisdom of knowing the primordial limit; the wisdom of śrāvakas; the wisdom of pratyekabuddhas; the wisdom of bodhisattvas; and

the wisdom of buddhas and all such qualities — the ground of all of these is loving-kindness (maitrī).

Therefore, noble son, loving-kindness is true and not false. Noble son, if someone were to ask, "What is the ground of all virtuous roots?" you should answer: "It is loving-kindness." And for that reason it is true and not false.

Noble son, what becomes wholesome is right thought. Right thought is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata. Loving-kindness is the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna). The Great Vehicle is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the path to awakening. The path to awakening is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is loving-kindness.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the great Brahmā (Mahābrahman). The great Brahmā is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is like a father and mother to all sentient beings. Father and mother are loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is inconceivable. The inconceivable is the domain of the buddhas. The domain of the buddhas is loving-kindness. Therefore,

know that loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the buddha-nature of sentient beings. And yet that buddha-nature, having been overpowered and obscured by afflictions since time without beginning, is not seen by sentient beings. Thus the buddha-nature is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the great emptiness. The great emptiness is great loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is space. Space is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is permanence. Permanence is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is happiness. Happiness is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is utter purity. Utter purity is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is called the self. The self is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the nectar of immortality (amṛta). The nectar of immortality is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the buddha-nature. The buddha-nature is the Dharma. The Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the unsurpassed awakening of all bodhisattvas. Awakening is loving-kindness. Loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is the limitless domain of all blessed buddhas, the Bhagavāns. The limitless domain is loving-kindness. Therefore, know that this loving-kindness is the Tathāgata.

Noble son, loving-kindness is impermanent. Impermanence is loving-kindness. Know that this loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is suffering, then suffering is loving-kindness. Therefore, know that this loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is not utterly pure, that is impure loving-kindness. Therefore, know that this loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, loving-kindness is selfless. Selflessness is loving-kindness. Therefore, this loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, loving-kindness is not real. What is not real is loving-kindness. Therefore, know that this loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, the loving-kindness of śrāvakas does not constitute the perfection of generosity; it is not the loving-kindness of generosity. That loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas. And in the same way, know this to be so all the way through to the Perfection of Wisdom; understand this in full.

Noble son, any loving-kindness that brings no benefit to sentient beings — that loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, any loving-kindness that has not entered the path of the single defining mark — that loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, any loving-kindness by which all phenomena are not directly realized — know that loving-kindness to be the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, any loving-kindness by which the buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) is not seen — that loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, any loving-kindness by which all phenomena are not seen as bearing the defining mark of existence — that loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is accompanied by defilement, then that defiled loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is accompanied by conditioned existence, then that conditioned loving-kindness is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness does not abide in the first ground, it is not the loving-kindness of the first ground — know that it is the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is unable to attain the ten powers of a buddha and the four fearlessnesses, know that loving-kindness to be the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, the loving-kindness by which one would attain the fruits of the ascetic life — know that loving-kindness to be the loving-kindness of śrāvakas.

Noble son, that loving-kindness which is accompanied by existence, non-existence, and neither-existence-nor-non-existence is something that cannot be fathomed by all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and those like them.

Noble son, if loving-kindness is inconceivable, then the Dharma too is inconceivable, the intrinsic nature of the buddhas too is inconceivable, and the Tathāgata too is inconceivable.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in the complete nirvāṇa of the Great Vehicle applies himself diligently to such loving-kindness as this. Even while resting in the ease of sleep, he always commences with diligent effort, so that sleep does not overwhelm him. Though he is ever wakeful, because there is no sleep, there is no waking either. Though the gods guard him thoroughly while he sleeps, because he commits no wrongdoing, there is no guarding either. Because he is utterly free from sleep, no bad dreams or anything unwholesome can arise. Though he may be born among the gods of the Brahmā realm, because he has come under their power, there is no birth either.

Noble son, whoever diligently applies himself to loving-kindness will come to possess qualities such as these — boundless and inconceivable. Noble son, this holy sūtra of complete nirvāṇa likewise possesses such qualities — boundless and inconceivable. The Blessed One, the Buddha, likewise possesses such qualities — boundless and limitless.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if everything that the bodhisattvas, the great beings, hold in mind is perfectly true, while what śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas hold to be true is not perfectly true, why do the bodhisattvas, the great beings, not employ their power and might to cause all sentient beings to experience happiness equally? Since all sentient beings do not experience true happiness in that way, what benefit is there in the bodhisattvas diligently applying themselves to the mind of loving-kindness?"

The Blessed One then declared:

"Son of good family, the loving-kindness of a bodhisattva is not without benefit. Son of good family, among sentient beings there are some who will certainly experience suffering, and there are some who will not certainly experience it. For those sentient beings who will certainly experience suffering — those who are possessed of wrong craving — the bodhisattva's

loving-kindness brings no benefit. But for those whose experience of suffering is not certain, the bodhisattva's loving-kindness does bring benefit, and it causes those sentient beings to experience genuine happiness.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: if a person at some distance catches sight of lions, tigers, wolves, rākṣasas, hungry ghosts, and the like, fear and dread arise in him naturally. And if at night he sees a precipice, fear arises in him in just the same way. Son of good family, just as fear arises naturally in that person, so too any sentient being who sees one diligently applying loving-kindness will naturally experience happiness. Son of good family, for this reason, a bodhisattva who diligently applies himself to loving-kindness is engaged in what is truly meaningful — and it is not without benefit.

Son of good family, I have taught that loving-kindness has limitless aspects, namely the supernormal knowledges (abhijñā).

Son of good family, consider this: Devadatta showed King Ajātaśatru that the Tathāgata had been killed. At that time, when I had entered Rājagṛha to collect alms in sequence, King Ajātaśatru released enraged yak-bulls that guarded the treasury, and set them to kill me and my disciples. At that time those yak-bulls trampled and killed many hundreds and thousands of limitless sentient beings. Spattered by the blood of those slain beings, the bulls grew all the more frenzied. When my disciples clad in ochre robes were seen, the bulls — taking them for blood — turned and fled. All of my disciples who had not yet parted from desire fled in the four directions, none remaining except the venerable Ānanda. At that time, all the people dwelling in Rājagṛha wept together with one voice, and with tears streaming down their faces they said: 'Alas! The Tathāgata is no more! Why has the Tathāgata been destroyed so suddenly, in a single instant?' At that time Devadatta felt a wondrous joy and said: 'It is good that the ascetic Gautama is no more. From now on, what is true is no more, and things have come to pass just as I had hoped they would.'

Son of good family, at that time, in order to tame the treasury-guarding yak-bulls, I entered into the meditative absorption called Loving-Kindness, and I stretched out my hand in display, and upon my five fingers five lions appeared. The yak-bulls, seeing this, were so terrified that they lost control of their bowels and bladder, and their bodies fell flat on the ground, and they reverently prostrated at my feet. Son of good family, at that time, though in reality there were no lions on my five fingers, by the power of the virtuous root of cultivated loving-kindness those bulls were tamed. Son of good family, there

is more: when I was departing to the city of Kuśinagara to pass into final nirvāṇa, some five hundred wrestlers were blocking and jostling along the road, waving cloth and making a clamor. On the road there was a great boulder; the wrestlers turned to it and, using all the strength and power they had, could not lift it or budge it. Then, out of compassion for those wrestlers, I gave rise to the mind of loving-kindness, and with the big toe of my foot I tossed that boulder up into the sky, caught it with my hand, and set it in the palm of my right hand. Then, merely by blowing upon it, I reduced it to fine dust, and then gathered it back together — and had the wrestlers see it thus blown apart."

Having thus calmed the pride and arrogance in the minds of those wrestlers, I taught them Dharma in all its variety, and caused them to give rise to the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Now, noble son, at that time the Tathāgata did not in truth toss that boulder into the sky with the big toe of his foot, nor set it in the palm of his right hand, nor grind it to fine dust, nor gather it back into a lump. Rather, noble son, you should understand that it was through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness that the wrestlers perceived those very things in just that way.

Noble son, furthermore, to the south, in the land of Vetāla, in a great city called Śupāra, there once lived, in a time gone by, a householder named Doḍa who had planted roots of virtue in the presence of immeasurable buddhas and had become a guide to many beings. Noble son, all the people who dwelt in that great city had turned to the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and were servants of the naked ascetics. At that time, in order to tame that householder, the Blessed One set out from Rājagṛha toward that city. The distance was some sixty-five leagues, and in order to tame the sentient beings dwelling along the way, the Blessed One traveled slowly on foot with his retinue.

When the naked ascetics dwelling in the city of Śupāra heard, "He is coming," they thought among themselves: "If the śramaṇa Gautama comes here, all those who live here will abandon us and give us no more provisions; we shall be left destitute — how then shall we survive?" So the naked ascetics dispersed, each going separately to the people living in that city, and proclaimed the following: "Word has it that one called the śramaṇa Gautama is coming here. This śramaṇa has abandoned both father and mother and roams and wanders wherever he will; and in every place he passes through, crop failures and famines arise, diseases multiply, and deaths multiply — and there

is no escape from it. That wretched śramaṇa Gautama is coming, leading a retinue of nothing but rākṣasas and hungry ghosts, all equally wretched. He has neither father nor mother, and he comes wanting a retinue out of sheer desperation. Whatever teaching and preaching he offers is nothing but lies, and wherever he goes there has never from the very beginning been happiness or well-being." Having heard these words proclaimed, the people were seized with great terror and alarm. They bowed their heads at the feet of the naked ascetics and replied: "Great teachers, what means can we take so that the śramaṇa Gautama will not come here?" The naked ascetics said: "The śramaṇa Gautama is by nature drawn to forests, springs, and streams; therefore every tree outside the city — without exception — must be cut down and cleared away. Every spring, well, and stream must be fouled with filth and vomit. Then return, bar the city gates tightly, array your weapons, guard the city, and do whatever you can to prevent him from entering. If he cannot enter this place, you yourselves will be safe from the start. And we too will perform whatever rituals we can to turn the śramaṇa Gautama back." So saying, the people listened and did as they were told: they cut down every tree, dried up every water source, arrayed their weapons, and guarded the city.

Noble son, when I arrived at that city, not a single forest or tree was to be seen, and I beheld many people sitting there bearing arms.

When I saw all of this, I was moved by the deepest compassion and aroused a mind of loving-kindness. Thereupon every forest and grove sprang back into being, and in addition to those, countless other trees grew up as well. Every spring, pond, well, and flowing stream became utterly clear and limpid, turning blue as lapis lazuli, brimming and overflowing in every direction, and covered all around with flowers of every variety. The very walls surrounding that city became like deep blue lapis lazuli, and all the people dwelling within that city could see me plainly, together with my retinue, as though looking through open space. The city gates opened of themselves without obstruction. The weapons all turned into flowers of many kinds. And the householder Supriya, at their head, came before the Blessed One with all the people and their retinues. I then taught them Dharma in many ways, and every one of them aroused the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Noble son, at that time I did not literally cause forests and groves to grow, nor fill every spring and pond with pure water, nor turn the city walls into lapis lazuli, nor make the people there see me as if through open space, nor cause the city gates to open of themselves, nor turn the weapons into flowers. Noble

son, know that all of this came about through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness: it was by that power that those people perceived all those things.

Noble son, here is another account. In Śrāvastī there was a brahmin woman named Vasiṭā who had a single child, beloved and cherished beyond measure, and that child fell ill and died. At that time, overcome and maddened by intense grief, she ran about naked without shame, weeping at every crossroads and calling out "Where is my child, where has my child gone?" and wandered throughout the city without weariness.

Noble son, because that woman had in times past cultivated wholesome roots in the presence of buddhas, I aroused a mind of loving-kindness toward her. At that moment, when she saw me, she conceived of me as her child. Instantly her mind came to itself; she took me into her arms and suckled me. Then and there I spoke to Ānanda and declared, "Give this robe to that woman." The robe was given to her, and Dharma was taught to her in many ways. Having heard the Dharma, that woman was filled with great joy and delight, and she aroused the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Noble son, at that time that child was truly not me, nor was I her child; she had not truly taken me into her arms nor suckled me. Noble son, know that here too it was through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness that that woman perceived things in just that way.

Noble son, here is yet another account. In the city of Śrāvastī there was a laywoman named Mahāsinadata who in times past had cultivated wholesome roots in the presence of immeasurable buddhas. For the space of three months she invited the Saṅgha and offered medicinal remedies for their illnesses. Among that company of monastics there was one monk who had been struck by a very serious disease. A physician was summoned, made an examination, and declared, "This illness must be treated with flesh. Without flesh, life cannot be sustained for long." When the laywoman heard those words, she took gold and went to the market, calling out, "Is there anyone here who sells flesh? I will give gold equal in weight to the flesh." She searched the market from end to end but found no flesh. Then that laywoman took a knife, cut flesh from her own thigh, minced it,

prepared it with various seasonings, and gave it to that ailing monk. When the monk ate the flesh, his illness was cured.

At that time, the laywoman, from the wound where the flesh had been cut, experienced tremendous and unbearable suffering. And she cried out in this way: "Homage to the Buddha! Homage to the Buddha!" At that time I was dwelling in Śrāvastī, and hearing that cry, great compassion arose in me for that woman, and she immediately beheld me. Then, as soon as her wound was anointed with medicine, it was restored just as it had been before. After that, I taught her various aspects of the Dharma and explained them to her, and she rejoiced with great delight and raised the awakening mind oriented toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Noble son, at that time I had not actually gone to the city of Śrāvastī, nor had I anointed the laywoman's wound with medicine. Noble son, know that through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness, the laywoman came to see such things.

Noble son, there is yet another example. About five hundred unruly bandits banded together in the land of Kośala, committing robberies and causing great harm. King Brahmadatta (Skt. Brahmadatta) sent an army against them, captured every one of them, had their eyes gouged out, and abandoned them in a dense forest.

At that time those unruly bandits had only previously cultivated wholesome roots before the buddhas. Thus, blinded and experiencing tremendous suffering, they cried out in this way: "Homage to the Buddha! Homage to the Buddha!" and they wept aloud, lamenting: "We have no protector, no refuge, no ally."

At that time I was dwelling in the Jeta Grove of Prince Jeta, and hearing that cry, I aroused a mind of great loving-kindness. At that time, a very cool breeze filled their eyes with various nectar-like medicinal substances from the sandalwood mountains, and they recovered their sight. Those unruly bandits, the moment their eyes were opened in this way, beheld the Tathāgata. Then I taught them the sacred Dharma, and caused them to raise the awakening mind oriented toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Noble son, at that time I had not actually manifested as a wind, nor gathered medicinal substances from the sandalwood mountains, nor taught the Dharma in the presence of those men. Noble son, know that through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness, those unruly bandits came to see such things.

Noble son, there is yet another example. A regent named Vaidūrya, foolish and deluded, seized the king's power by force and installed himself upon the royal throne.

Out of an old grudge, he cut off the ears and noses of twelve thousand young women of the Śākya clan, hacked off their hands and feet, and threw them into a pit. At that moment those women, in tremendous suffering, made prostrations to the Buddha, saying, "We prostration to the Buddha! We bow to the Buddha! There is no one to be our protector and refuge!" And with that they cried out with a great wail.

Those women had previously generated wholesome roots before many buddhas. At that time I was dwelling in the Luminous Grove, and when I heard the sound of their cries I was filled with great compassion. The women then saw me coming to the city of Serkya, washing their wounds with pure water, and anointing them with medicine, and their pain subsided at once. All the ears and noses, and all the hands and feet that had been cut off grew back and were restored. I also taught them the sacred Dharma, and they all raised the awakening mind oriented toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and they all went forth before the great abbess, the mother of beings, and received full ordination.

Noble son, in truth the Tathāgata had neither actually gone to the city of Serkya, nor washed their wounds, nor applied medicine, nor stilled their suffering. Noble son, know that all of those things were seen by those women through the power of the wholesome root of loving-kindness. The same is true of compassion and of joy.

Noble son, therefore the cultivation of loving-kindness mind by a bodhisattva, a great being, is genuine and not false. Noble son, the immeasurables are inconceivable, the conduct of bodhisattvas is inconceivable, the deeds of the buddhas are inconceivable, and this sūtra of the Great Vehicle on the complete passing beyond sorrow is also inconceivable.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who earnestly cultivates loving-kindness, great compassion, and joy will come to abide on the ground called Supreme Joy, which is like regard for an only child. Noble son, why is that ground called Supreme Joy, and also called Like an Only Child? Noble son, it is like this: just as a parent whose child is seen happy and at ease is filled with supreme joy in the mind, so too a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on that ground is similar. When they see all sentient beings diligently applying

themselves to virtue, viewing them with regard as if toward an only child, a mind of supreme joy arises, and therefore that ground is called Supreme Joy.

Noble son, it is like this: just as a parent who sees their child fall ill is filled with a mind of intense suffering and, out of compassion, is never parted even for a moment from a mind of grief, so too a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on that ground is similar. Seeing ordinary persons tormented by the sickness of mental afflictions, they grieve out of loving concern for them as for their own child, and blood seeps from the pores of their body. Therefore this ground is also called Like an Only Child.

Noble son, consider as an example a tiny infant who has not yet grown teeth, who picks up dirt, gravel, bones, little sticks, or filthy rags and puts them in its mouth. The parents, seeing this, fear that harm will come, and with the left hand they press the child's cheek while with the right hand they draw the object out. A bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on that ground is similar:

When the bodhisattva sees sentient beings, whose dharma-body (dharmakāya) has not yet fully developed, practicing non-virtuous and sinful phenomena through the gates of body, speech, and mind, he draws them out from that with the hand of wisdom, unwilling that those beings should wander in saṃsāra and experience manifold suffering. Therefore this ground is also called Like an Only Child.

Noble son, consider as an example: when parents have a single child whom they love most dearly, and that child should die, the parents too desire to die along with it. A bodhisattva, a great being, is similar: if beings who hold wrong craving should fall into hell, he too desires to go to hell along with them. Why is this? Because when those beings who hold wrong craving are experiencing suffering, if even for a single moment a thought of remorse arises in them, he thinks, "I will teach and explain to them Dharma of many kinds, and in that single instant cause a root of virtue to be born." Therefore this ground is called Like an Only Child.

Noble son, consider as an example: when parents have a single child, whether that child is asleep or awake, whether walking, staying, sitting, or lying down, it is always held in mind. And if the child commits some misdeed, they instruct it with gentle words and correct it — not with harshness. A bodhisattva, a great being, is similar: whether ordinary beings are born in hell, in the animal realm, in the world of Yama, or born among gods and humans — always and without fail he keeps his mind on what virtuous or sinful acts they are

committing. And if they should perform some non-virtuous and sinful action, no thought of aversion arises in him toward them. Therefore this ground is called Like an Only Child.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, since it is, as you have taught, exceedingly profound, and our own search for it is exceedingly limited, how are we to search for it? Surely, if bodhisattvas abiding on a ground such as that of the Only Child are as you describe, then why was it that the Tathāgata, when in a former life he was a king and was practicing the bodhisattva's conduct, took the lives of so many brahmins? If this ground had been attained, it was the disposition of one who protects and becomes an ally; if it had not been attained, why did he not fall into hell? And if he regards all sentient beings as he would his own son Rāhula, why did the Blessed One say to Devadatta those words — calling him a stupid, shameless man who licks a human's running sores? And upon hearing this, Devadatta held a grudge, gave rise to a non-virtuous thought, and drew blood from the body of the Buddha. And even after Devadatta had committed such a sin, the Tathāgata prophesied that he would fall into hell and experience suffering for the duration of a whole aeon. Blessed One, would not what you have just said contradict that meaning?

Blessed One, when the venerable Subhūti, who abides on the ground of emptiness, enters a village and goes on alms-round, he thoroughly examines the other person beforehand. And if the other person's mind turns to contempt or reproach, then no matter how intensely hungry he may be, he accepts no alms from them. Why is this? Because the venerable Subhūti always reflects and mindfully recalls this: "For one who would become a field of merit for others, the mere arising of a single non-virtuous thought, through that cause and that condition, brings about a fall into the great hell and the experience of tremendous suffering. So what if I am hungry? Better to go without even a little clean food."

"By others showing contempt and reproach toward me, I must not fall into hell and undergo suffering." With this in mind, he also thinks to himself: "If any sentient being were to reproach me while I am standing, I would not rise from where I am sitting in a clean place. If any sentient being were to reproach me while I am sitting, I would not stir from where I am standing in a clean place. Walking and lying down are the same."

In this way, when even the venerable Subhūti, out of concern for the minds of sentient beings, generates such a resolve, what need is there to speak of a bodhisattva, a great being? But if one who has attained a ground comparable to an only child were to act thus, why would the Tathāgata have spoken words so careless as to cause many sentient beings to give rise to deeply non-virtuous minds?

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, do not argue that the awakened Blessed One has acted as a cause for the afflictions of ordinary beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for the beak of a mosquito to drain the ocean to its depths, but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for this great earth to become formless, for water to take on the characteristic of dryness, for fire to take on the characteristic of cold, for wind to take on the characteristic of stillness, for the Three Jewels, the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and space to take on the characteristic of impermanence — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for those who have transgressed the four root precepts of moral discipline, who hold wrong views, and who denigrate the sacred Dharma to attain with this very body the ten powers, the fearlessnesses, the thirty-two major marks, and the eighty minor marks of excellence — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas and the like to abide permanently and unchangingly — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for bodhisattvas abiding on the ten grounds to transgress the four root precepts of moral discipline, to fall into wrong views, and to denigrate the sacred Dharma — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible for all immeasurable sentient beings to come to lack the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and it may be possible for the Tathāgata himself to pass completely into nirvāṇa at the very end — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, it may be possible to catch the wind with a lasso, to cut iron with a damp cloth, or to demolish Mount Meru with a fingernail — but the Tathāgata never acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. It would be better to dwell together with a venomous snake, to thrust one's hand into the mouth of a hungry lion, or to have one's body bathed in the ashes of a funeral pyre — than to say that

the awakened Blessed One acts as a cause for the afflictions of sentient beings. Son of good family, the Tathāgata genuinely and completely severs the afflictions of sentient beings; he never acts as a cause for their afflictions."

Son of good family, as for what you said — that the Tathāgata once killed a brahmin — son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, would not even intentionally kill so much as a small ant when young, let alone kill a brahmin. What need is there even to speak of such a thing? The bodhisattva is always skilled in means: through manifold forms of skillful means he bestows upon sentient beings an immeasurable gift of life and sustenance.

Son of good family, giving food is called giving life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of generosity, he constantly bestows immeasurable sustenance and life upon sentient beings.

Son of good family, by guarding the moral discipline of fully abandoning the taking of life, one comes to have long life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of moral discipline, he gives to all sentient beings an immeasurable gift of sustaining life.

Son of good family, through being free from the fault of verbal wrongdoing, one comes to have long life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of patience, he does not show resentment toward sentient beings: he attributes good qualities to others and accepts blame upon himself, and so there is no contention — and thus one comes to have long life. Therefore, when a bodhisattva practices the perfection of patience, this is called giving sentient beings an immeasurable gift of life.

Son of good family, through applying diligence to virtue, one comes to have long life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of diligence, he urges sentient beings to apply themselves earnestly to virtuous Dharma, and thereby causes ordinary beings, by acting in that same way, to obtain immeasurable length of life. Therefore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of diligence, this is called giving sentient beings immeasurable life.

Son of good family, earnest application to collecting the mind leads to long life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of meditative concentration, he urges sentient beings to apply themselves earnestly to the mind of meditative equipoise, and sentient beings who practice accordingly come to have long life. Therefore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the perfection of meditative concentration, this is called giving sentient beings

an immeasurable gift of life.

Son of good family, practicing with heedfulness in all things that lead to virtue brings long life. When a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, he causes sentient beings to practice virtue with heedfulness, and ordinary beings who thus practice in that way come, by that cause and by that condition, to have long life. Therefore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, practices the Perfection of Wisdom, this is called giving sentient beings immeasurable life.

Son of good family, for these reasons, a bodhisattva, a great being, has no quality of taking life from any sentient being whatsoever.

Son of good family, you asked me: "When you killed the brahmin at that time, did you thereby obtain that ground?" Son of good family, at that time I had obtained that ground, and it was out of regard for their welfare that I cut off that person's vital faculty — not out of malicious intent.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: parents who have only one child cherish that child with the utmost affection. If that child has committed some grave offense and comes to face judgment and trial, then out of fear and dread the parents may drive that child away or even put an end to his life — and yet if they do so, drive him away or put an end to his life, there is no malicious intent.

A great bodhisattva who guards and protects the holy Dharma is like this as well. If any sentient being should slander and disparage the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, that bodhisattva may restrain that being, afflict that being, harm that being, and, if necessary, even cut off that being's vital faculty — wishing that, in times to come, that being will apply diligence to wholesome Dharma.

The great bodhisattva always reflects in this way: "By what causes and conditions will sentient beings come to give rise to a mind of faith?" and then, whatever method is appropriate, that is what the bodhisattva puts into action.

Now, a great many brahmins, having passed from this life, were born in the interminable hell (avīci naraka). There they reflected on three things. First, they recognized where they had dwelt before coming to be born here, knowing they had come from a human lineage. Second, they considered what this place of birth was, and understood it to be the interminable hell. Third, they reflected on what karma and what conditions had caused them to be born

here, and understood: "It was because of the causes and conditions of mocking, disparaging, and lacking faith in the vast and expansive sūtras of the Great Vehicle that a king had us killed, and thus we came to be born in this place."

Having reflected in this way, a mind of intense faith and reverence arose in them toward the vast and expansive sūtras of the Great Vehicle. Then, passing from that life, they were born in the world of the Tathāgata called Resounding Drum of the Refreshing Cool, and their lifespan was complete for a full ten aeons.

Son of good family, therefore, when I gave those men of old a life enduring for ten aeons, could that rightly be called killing? Son of good family, if someone digs the earth, plucks grass, cuts down trees, strikes a corpse with a weapon, beats, afflicts, or restrains — do those acts, by their causes and conditions, bring about a fall into the hells?

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, according to the meaning you have taught, it would indeed bring about a fall into the hells." "And why?" he continued. "For previously, when the Blessed One was teaching the Dharma to the hearers, you declared: 'O monks, do not give rise to malicious intent even toward a plough-yoke. Why? Because through giving rise to malicious intent, all sentient beings fall into the hells.'"

The Blessed One then said "Excellent! Excellent!" to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, and spoke: "Hold well in mind what you have said, just as you have said it."

"Son of good family, the statement that one falls into the hells through malicious intent — there is no such thing as malicious intent in a bodhisattva. Why? Because a great bodhisattva, toward all sentient beings, down to the very smallest ant, gives rise to a mind of love, affection, care, and the wish to bring benefit and happiness. And why is this? It is because such a bodhisattva becomes a cause and condition and is skilled in skillful means. Through the power of skill in means, sentient beings come to give rise to roots of virtue.

Son of good family, for this reason, at that time, it was through the utmost skill in means that I took away those beings' vital faculties — and it was not through malicious intent.

Son of good family, by the Brahmanical law, if one kills a full ten cartloads of insects, it does not become a misdeed. As for beings such as bees, gnats, cats, lions, tigers, bears, foxes, and vicious predators that cause harm to sentient

beings — if ten full cartloads of these were killed; or hungry ghosts (pretas), rākṣasas, piśācas, kaṭapūtanas, beings that cause forgetfulness, beings that cause madness —

— and those hungry ghosts that cause withering and the like, all beings that harm sentient beings: even killing them produces no blameworthy karmic maturation. If, however, an evil person among human beings is killed, there is blameworthy karmic maturation. If it is not confessed immediately after the killing, one will fall into the realm of hungry ghosts. But if one fasts without eating for three days, confessing and purging the sin, every last trace of the misdeed will be cleansed away. If one kills a teacher, or kills one's parents or a woman, or kills a wool-bearing ox, one will fall into hell for a thousand immeasurable eons — so they say.

Son of good family, for buddhas and bodhisattvas, killing with full awareness is of three kinds: the least, the middling, and the greatest. The least refers to ants and the like, and indeed to all births in the animal realm. Excepted from that category is what appears as bodhisattvas being born in an animal body. Son of good family, there are indeed bodhisattvas, great beings, who by the power of aspiration appear to be born in animal rebirths — and this is called the least category of killing. Even through the causes and conditions of this least category of killing, one falls into hell, into animal rebirths, and into the realm of hungry ghosts, and will experience the least degree of suffering. Why is this? Animals also possess some root of virtue, and if they are killed, one will experience blameworthy karmic maturation — and this is called the least category of killing.

What is called the middling category of killing ranges from ordinary persons of the lowest birth up to and including those who have entered the stream. Through the causes and conditions of that karma, one falls into hell, into animal rebirths, and into the realm of hungry ghosts, and will experience a middling degree of suffering. This is called the middling category of killing.

What is called the greatest category of killing ranges from killing one's parents up to and including killing an arhat, a pratyekabuddha, or a definitive bodhisattva. Through those causes and conditions, one falls into the great uninterrupted hell and will experience the greatest degree of suffering. This is called the greatest killing.

Son of good family, if someone kills one who holds wrong views, such killing does not fall into any of the three categories of killing. Son of good family, all

those brahmins are to be called holders of wrong views. For example, just as tilling the soil, mowing grass, cutting wood, stabbing or striking a corpse with a weapon, or even kicking filth do not constitute blameworthy karmic maturation — so too killing a holder of wrong views is like that and produces no blameworthy karmic maturation. Why is this? Because those brahmins also lack faith and the rest up to and including the five spiritual faculties, and therefore killing them does not bring about a fall into hell.

The noble great sūtra of the complete passage beyond sorrow. The twenty-second fascicle.

Son of good family, it is not fitting that you should say, as you have said to the Tathāgata: "Why did you rebuke Devadatta, that idiot who drools?" — or words to that effect. Why is this? Every word that the blessed Buddha speaks is inconceivable in its depth. Son of good family, all people in the world desire one who speaks truthfully. Words that are untimely, contrary to the Dharma, and of no benefit or comfort are never spoken by him. Son of good family, some words are extremely harsh and coarse, and are also false — untimely, contrary to the Dharma, unwelcome to whoever hears them, and of no benefit or comfort. Such words I have never spoken.

Son of good family, some words are extremely harsh and coarse, and yet are also true — not false, timely, in accordance with the Dharma, beneficial and conducive to well-being for all sentient beings. Even if those who hear them are displeased, such words are nonetheless most certainly spoken. Why is this? Because the blessed Buddha is possessed of knowledge and is supremely endowed with skillful means.

Son of good family, I recall that once, long ago, as I was wandering and traveling through wilderness retreats, villages, cities, and forests, there was near a forest a hungry ghost called "Wilderness Hermitage." He ate flesh and drank blood, harming many sentient beings, and each day he would devour the people of that city one by one. Son of good family, at that time I taught the Dharma to that hungry ghost at length and in full, but he was filled with rage, fierce and brutish, devoid of understanding, and so he would not listen to my teaching. At that time I manifested as a hungry ghost of great power and shook his dwelling, making him profoundly uncomfortable. At that very moment the hungry ghost, along with his retinue, came out from his dwelling and charged at me to attack. The instant that hungry ghost saw me, he lost his composure and, overwhelmed with terror as if drunk, he fell to the ground in a

faint, his breath cut off, lying there like a corpse.

Then I aroused a mind of loving kindness and compassion toward him, and stroking the top of his head with my hand, he immediately revived and spoke these words: "Today I have recovered both body and life. This great divine king is endowed with tremendous power and majesty, and out of a mind of loving kindness and compassion he has even become my refuge from my own wrongdoing." At that time, the hungry ghost gave rise to a mind of faith toward me, and so I then manifested once again in the form of a Tathāgata and taught him further the Dharma in its many aspects. That hungry ghost was thus brought to observe the precept of refraining from taking life.

Now at that time, in the city of that wilderness region, it fell to one particular householder's turn in the rotation, and the townspeople escorted him to the hungry ghost's dwelling. The hungry ghost took the householder and presented him to me. I in turn received him and gave that householder the name "Hands." At that time the hungry ghost addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, we, together with our retinue, have been seekers of flesh and blood. Now that we have taken the precept of refraining from taking life, how shall we survive?" To this I replied: "From this day forward, wherever my close disciples and hearers dwell, in all places where they are diligently practicing the Buddha's Dharma, I hereby declare that everyone shall give you food."

Son of good family, on account of this cause and these conditions, a rule was established that monks should always offer tormas to the hungry ghosts of the wilderness. Should those at dwelling places fail to offer the tormas, know that they are not my close disciples — they belong to the host and retinue of the divine māra. Son of good family, the Tathāgata, in order to tame sentient beings, teaches such skillful means of many kinds — it is not that he deliberately seeks to terrify them.

Son of good family, I once struck with a staff a hungry ghost called Dharma Guardian. Again, on another occasion, there was a hungry ghost called Ram's Head, and I hurled him from a cliff into a ravine. Yet again, from a tree I cast a hungry ghost called Monkey into an abyss; I caused a hungry ghost called Yak, Guardian of Wealth, to encounter five lions; I manifested in a vajra body and terrified the tīrthika (non-Buddhist) debater Omnispeaker; and

I pierced the hungry ghost Hairy One with a thorn of the sengdeng tree. And although I did all these things, none of those hungry ghosts were harmed by

them. Rather, in order to establish them in the sacred Dharma, I demonstrated skillful means of many kinds.

Son of good family, at that time I did not truly revile Devadatta, nor was Devadatta himself made a fool, nor did he come to eat human spittle, nor will he be reborn in the lower destinies, nor will he experience suffering for a full aeon in the Avīci hell of unceasing torment, nor did he cause a schism in the Saṅgha, nor draw blood from the body of a buddha, nor did he incur the loss of the four roots of virtue, nor did he denigrate the sacred Dharma or the sūtras of the Great Vehicle, nor does he hold wrong views, nor is he a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha. Son of good family, one called Devadatta truly lies beyond the domain of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; he is known and seen by a buddha alone.

Son of good family, therefore do not ask why the Tathāgata would revile, reproach, or abuse Devadatta. It is unworthy of you to generate such doubt about the domain of activity of the buddhas.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One: "Just as sugarcane, when pressed again and again, yields many different flavors, so too have I, by hearing again and again from the Blessed One, obtained many flavors of the Dharma — namely, the flavor of becoming, the flavor of abandoning desire, the flavor of peace, and the flavor of awakening. And again, Blessed One, just as genuine gold, when repeatedly smelted and hammered, becomes refined gold — exceedingly bright, supple, radiant, and precious — and comes to be a treasure for gods and humans; so too the Tathāgata, Blessed One, is like that: when one inquires of him again and again, one comes to hear and see meanings of profound depth. Thus those who practice meditation on what is profound commit them to memory and apply themselves diligently. Countless beings will generate the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. And after that, gods, humans, and others will revere and honor them with worship."

Then the Blessed One said "Excellent! Excellent!" to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Kāśyapa, great bodhisattva, it is excellent that you, out of your wish for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings, have asked about this profoundly deep meaning. Son of good family, in view of that purpose, I too, just as you have intended, have taught the profound meaning of the vast and expansive Great Vehicle — that is, the ground comparable to having an only child, the ground of Boundless Joy."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One: "If bodhisattvas, through diligent cultivation of loving-kindness, compassion, and joy, attain the ground comparable to having an only child, then when they diligently cultivate the mind of equanimity, what grounds do they attain?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, most excellent! Son of good family, you are supremely skilled in timing. You have asked about precisely what I intended to explain. When a great bodhisattva diligently cultivates the mind of equanimity, they come to abide on the ground of the equanimity of emptiness, like Subhūti."

Son of good family, when a great bodhisattva abides on the ground of the equanimity of emptiness, they do not perceive with partiality between father and mother, brother and sister, child, friend or companion — and from that point, between the aggregates, the elements, the sense bases,

sentient beings, and living beings — they perceive none of them with partiality. Son of good family, just as in space there is no father or mother, no brother or sister, no wife or daughter, no sentient being or living being, so too all phenomena are empty of father and mother up through living beings. Son of good family, a great bodhisattva who views all phenomena with a mind of equanimity is like space. Why? Because they are supremely skilled in diligently cultivating the Dharma of emptiness.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then put a question to the Blessed One: "What, then, is that which is called emptiness?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what is called emptiness is as follows: inner emptiness, outer emptiness, inner-and-outer emptiness, the emptiness of the conditioned, the emptiness of the unconditioned, the emptiness of that which has no beginning or end, the emptiness of intrinsic nature, the emptiness of the objectless, ultimate emptiness, the emptiness of emptiness, and the great emptiness.

How does a great bodhisattva fully investigate inner emptiness? A great bodhisattva investigates inner phenomena as emptiness. Inner emptiness of phenomena is as follows: there is no father or mother, no love or hatred, no sentient being, no living being, no permanence, no happiness, no self, no purity; and equally, there is no Tathāgata, no Dharma, no Saṅgha, no substantial thing.

Although the intrinsic nature of a buddha does exist within inner phenomena, that intrinsic nature of a buddha is neither inside nor outside. Why? Because the intrinsic nature of a buddha is permanent, stable, unchanging, and unaltering. This is what is called a great bodhisattva's full investigation of inner emptiness.

Outer emptiness is likewise — inner phenomena are utterly absent from it. Inner-and-outer emptiness is likewise.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata, the buddhas, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha do not abide in these two kinds of emptiness. Why? Because these four qualities — permanence, happiness, self, and purity — are not to be called emptiness. Both inner and outer are to be called emptiness.

Son of good family, the emptiness of the conditioned: to whatever extent there are conditioned phenomena, all of them are emptiness. That is: inner emptiness, outer emptiness, inner-and-outer emptiness, and the emptiness of permanence, happiness, self, and purity; and emptiness of sentient beings, of living beings, of the Tathāgata, of the Dharma, of the Saṅgha, and emptiness in an ultimate sense. As for this, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not a conditioned phenomenon; therefore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not the emptiness of conditioned phenomena — and thus it is called the emptiness of the conditioned.

Son of good family, how does a great bodhisattva fully investigate the emptiness of the unconditioned? All unconditioned phenomena are emptiness. That is: impermanence, suffering, impurity, no-self, the aggregates, the elements, the sense bases, the characteristics of sentient beings and living beings, the conditioned, the defiled, inner phenomena, and outer phenomena. As for the unconditioned phenomena: a buddha and so forth, and these four qualities — these are neither conditioned nor do they bear the characteristics of the unconditioned, and by reason of being wholesome they are not the unconditioned. By reason of being permanent and stable they are not the conditioned.

These are called the bodhisattva's thorough examination of the emptiness of the unconditioned. Now, how does a bodhisattva thoroughly examine beginningless emptiness? A bodhisattva, a great being, seeing that saṃsāra is without boundary, sees that all things are emptiness and utterly peaceful. That is to say: what is called emptiness is permanent, blissful, selfhood, and utterly

pure — all things are at peace through emptiness. There is no change and no alteration. There are no sentient beings, no living beings, no Three Jewels, no intrinsic nature of a buddha, and no unconditioned phenomena. This is called the bodhisattva's thorough examination of beginningless emptiness.

Now, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, thoroughly examine the emptiness that has no reference point? Consider, for example, a person who, having no children, thinks his house is empty — yet at the end he deliberates without attachment or aversion. Or consider foolish, deluded people who say that a mere direction is empty. Or consider wretched paupers, of whom some say "all is emptiness" while others say "it is not emptiness." This is not how it is with the bodhisattva. When the bodhisattva thus thoroughly examines, he is unlike a poor person — he understands all things as emptiness. In this way, a bodhisattva, a great being, is said to thoroughly examine the emptiness that has no reference point.

Now, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, examine ultimate emptiness? Noble son, when a bodhisattva, a great being, thoroughly examines ultimate emptiness, the faculty of the eye, at the moment of its arising, has not come from anywhere; and at the last moment of its ceasing, it has not gone anywhere. From the beginning it was absent, then it is present, and from being present it becomes absent once more. When traced back in precisely this way to its actual reality, there is no eye, and there is no owner of it. Just as the eye has no intrinsic nature, so too all phenomena are the same. As for what is called ultimate emptiness with respect to phenomena and so forth: karma exists, karmic maturation exists, yet an agent who performs is not seen. These phenomena that are empty are called ultimate emptiness. In this way, a bodhisattva, a great being, is said to examine ultimate emptiness.

Now, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, examine the emptiness of emptiness? What is called the emptiness of emptiness is something that śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and the like may come to experience. Noble son, that which is neither existent nor nonexistent is called the emptiness of emptiness. That which is and yet is not is also called the emptiness of emptiness. Noble son, even a bodhisattva dwelling on the tenth ground would, in regard to this, come to examine only a tiny particle's fraction of one direction of it — what need is there to speak of others? Noble son, the emptiness of emptiness in this sense does not become shared in common with the meditative absorption on the emptiness of emptiness belonging to śrāvakas. This is called the bodhisattva's thorough examination of the

emptiness of emptiness.

Noble son, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, thoroughly examine great emptiness? Noble son, great emptiness is this: it is the Perfection of Wisdom — this is what is called great emptiness. Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides on this ground, having attained the gateway of emptiness, will come to dwell on a ground of equanimity like the expanse of the sky.

Noble son, when I teach in this great maṇḍala of the assembly the meaning of emptiness and the like in such ways, bodhisattvas, great beings, numbering as many as the grains of sand in ten rivers like the Ganges, have come to dwell on a ground of equanimity like the expanse of the sky.

Noble son, bodhisattvas, great beings, abiding on that ground, are unimpeded with respect to all phenomena. There is no apprehension, and there is no arising of partiality. For that reason it is called the ground of equanimity like the sky.

Noble son, consider this example: just as the sky does not become attached to pleasing forms, and does not give rise to aversion toward unpleasing forms, so too a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on this ground is similar: there is no mind of desire or aversion toward forms fair or foul.

Noble son, consider this example: just as the sky is wide and vast and without peer, able to contain all phenomena, so too a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on that ground is likewise utterly vast, without peer, and able to contain all phenomena. For that reason it is called the ground of equanimity like the sky.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding on this ground will come to see and understand all phenomena — whether their conduct, their objects of focus, their intrinsic nature, their defining characteristics, their causes and conditions, the minds of sentient beings, their faculties, their meditative concentrations, their vehicles, their spiritual teachers, their maintenance of moral discipline, their practice of generosity, and all such phenomena they will come to understand and see.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, abiding there does not see with awareness — what is it that is known but not seen? The following: the practices of self-mortification, leaping into water, leaping into fire, leaping from cliffs, standing on one leg, burning oneself with the five fires, smearing oneself with ash, lying upon earth and thorns and leaves and grass and filth,

wearing coarse rough garments and shrouds, wearing garments discarded in charnel grounds and ragpiles, wearing bark and deerskin, wearing tree bark and grass, eating grass and fruits and lotus roots, eating oil sediment and cow dung, eating roots and fruits, and if one begs for food, not begging from more than one householder — and if one is told there is nothing, going away empty-handed and not returning even when called back — not tasting the five flavors that derive from salt, meat, and milk, constantly eating flat bread and drinking warm water, undertaking the ascetic practice of a cow, undertaking the ascetic practices of a dog, a bird, and a pig, smearing the body with ash, taking the keeping of matted hair as a distinguishing mark, sacrificing sheep to the gods and then slaughtering them beneath, going without food for four months, sustaining oneself on wind alone for seven days, worshipping the gods with hundreds and thousands of flowers — declaring that through such conditions all desires will be fulfilled — these and similar practices have no basis for becoming the cause of unsurpassed perfect liberation. These are what is to be known. Not seeing them means that the bodhisattva, the great being, not having seen even a single person become genuinely and perfectly liberated through performing these practices, does not see — and therefore it is called not seeing.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, also has that which is seen with awareness. What is that seeing? Seeing those practices that lead sentient beings astray, one certainly sees that beings who perform such practices will fall into the hells without fail. That is called seeing. And what is that knowing?

Those sentient beings, having been liberated from those hells and reborn as humans, if they then practice fully — from the perfection of generosity through to the other perfections — one knows with certainty that they will attain genuine and perfect liberation. That is called knowing.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, also has that which is seen and that which is known. What is that seeing? Seeing permanence and impermanence, suffering and happiness, complete purity and complete impurity, self and no-self — that is called seeing. And what is that knowing? Knowing that the Tathāgatas do not ultimately pass into nirvāṇa, and knowing that the bodies of the Tathāgatas are vajra-like — indestructible, not produced from afflictions, not bodies that are impure, foul-smelling, decaying, or putrid. And furthermore, knowing that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha — that is called knowing.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, also has that which is known and that which is seen. What is that knowing? Knowing which sentient beings are endowed with a mind of faith; which sentient beings seek the Great Vehicle; which persons follow after saṃsāra; which persons turn back from saṃsāra; which persons abide in what is genuine; and which sentient beings have thoroughly understood the perfections. Those who follow after saṃsāra are foolish ordinary beings. Those who turn back from saṃsāra are those who have attained the path from stream-entry up through the level of the pratyekabuddha. Those who abide in what is genuine are the bodhisattvas. Those who have thoroughly understood the perfections are the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas. These are what is called knowing.

And what is that seeing? A bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in the sūtras of the Great Vehicle's perfect nirvāṇa, with a mind of pure conduct and with the divinely purified supernatural eye, sees ordinary beings who, through acts of the three non-virtues committed by body, speech, and mind, are born in the hells, in animal births, and in the realm of the hungry ghosts. And he sees ordinary beings who apply themselves diligently to virtuous deeds and, upon passing from this life, are born among the gods of the higher realms or as humans. And he sees further: some sentient beings go from darkness to darkness; some sentient beings go from darkness to light; some sentient beings go from light to darkness; and some sentient beings go from light to light. That is called seeing.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, also has that which is seen and that which is known. The bodhisattva, the great being, sees that some ordinary beings diligently cultivate the body, diligently maintain moral discipline, diligently train the mind, and diligently cultivate wisdom — and yet for such a person, in this very life, the karmic maturation of negative actions will ripen, and through the conditions of attachment, aversion, and delusion, the karmic result that leads to the hells will inevitably mature. And he knows that persons who diligently cultivate the body, moral discipline, the mind, and wisdom will, in this very life, experience only a light result and will not fall into the hells.

Now, which actions ripen swiftly in this very life? Confessing and disclosing whatever sinful and non-virtuous deeds one has committed, and resolving after such confession not to commit them again; because one possesses remorse and shame, making offerings to the Three Jewels; and because one

reproaches and chastises oneself — for such a person, through the cause and condition of that virtuous deed, he will not fall into the hells. The experience in this very life is as follows: headache, eye pain, stomach pain, back pain, unpleasant sounds, approaching death, being scolded and reviled, being beaten,

being roused, bent and struck, seized, hungry, and tormented by thirst — suffering of that kind. To know that all these and similar things are experienced even in this very life is called "knowing."

As for seeing: a great bodhisattva (bodhisattva) sees that for a certain person who takes no care with the body, who takes no care with moral discipline, the mind, or wisdom, yet who commits only a minor sinful act, that karmic act will be experienced swiftly in this very life. If that person, having committed that small sin, clings to it and does not confess and disclose it, does not reproach and chastise himself, does not feel shame or embarrassment, and does not feel fear or dread — then through that, the karma will grow and increase, and that person will be seen to experience the hells. This is called "seeing."

There is also the case of knowing without seeing. As for knowing: one knows that the buddha-nature is present in all sentient beings, yet because it is overwhelmed and obscured by the afflictions it is not seen. This is called "knowing without seeing."

There is further the case of knowing and yet seeing only partially. The great bodhisattvas who dwell on the ten grounds know that the buddha-nature is present in all sentient beings, yet do not see it with clarity — just as the moon during the day is not clearly visible. This is called "knowing yet seeing only partially."

There is further still the case of seeing as well as knowing: it is the buddha, the Blessed One, who both sees and knows. This is called "having vision and knowledge."

There is also the case of seeing and knowing, and of not seeing and not knowing. As for seeing and knowing: these refer to knowing the written scripts of the world, the spoken languages, male and female, vehicles, pots, houses, cities, food and clothing, mountains and rivers, enclosures, and the lifespan of sentient beings. This is called "seeing and knowing."

As for not seeing and not knowing: the words spoken with special intent by the noble ones (āryā), and the absence of male, female, and all the rest up to and

including enclosures — this is called "not seeing and not knowing."

There is further the case of knowing without seeing. As for knowing: knowing the field of generosity (dāna), knowing the field of offering, knowing the field of receiving, and knowing causes and effects — this is called "knowing."

As for not seeing in this context: not seeing the field of generosity, the field of offering, and the field of receiving; not seeing the karmic maturation of cause and effect — this is called "not seeing."

A great bodhisattva's knowing of these eight categories is called knowing the five kinds of vision of the Tathāgata.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if a great bodhisattva were to arrive at such understanding and discernment, what benefits would he obtain?"

The Blessed One declared: "If a great bodhisattva arrives at such understanding and knowledge, he will attain the four analytical knowledges (pratisaṃvid). These are: analytical knowledge of phenomena, analytical knowledge of meaning, analytical knowledge of language, and analytical knowledge of eloquence.

As for analytical knowledge of phenomena: it is the knowledge of all phenomena and their defining characteristics (lakṣaṇa). As for analytical knowledge of meaning: it is knowledge of all that is designated as the meaning of all phenomena — that is, everything that becomes meaning through the designation of names and terms following upon phenomena. As for analytical knowledge of language: it is mastery of the science of writing, mastery of the science of spoken languages, mastery of the science of grammar, and mastery of the worldly sciences. As for analytical knowledge of eloquence: it is as follows —

Analytical knowledge of eloquence is this: however much a great bodhisattva speaks in words, there is nothing that obstructs or interrupts it; it is never turned back, is free of fear, and cannot be overwhelmed.

Son of good family, it is said that a bodhisattva attains the four analytical knowledges simply by seeing and knowing in that way.

Son of good family, furthermore, analytical knowledge of phenomena for a great bodhisattva means thoroughly knowing the phenomena of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and buddhas. Analytical knowledge of meaning means that although there are three aspects of the vehicle, one

knows that they converge into one, and that in that convergence there are no separately distinguishing characteristics. Analytical knowledge of language means that a great bodhisattva, having designated a single phenomenon by many different names, could explain it for measureless eons without exhausting it — whereas śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have no such capacity to explain in that way. Analytical knowledge of eloquence means that a great bodhisattva, teaching all phenomena to all sentient beings for measureless eons, expounding the various different names and meanings, reaches no end of exhaustion.

Son of good family, furthermore, analytical knowledge of phenomena means that although a great bodhisattva knows all phenomena in this way, there is no attachment to them. Analytical knowledge of meaning means that although one knows meanings, there is no attachment to them. Analytical knowledge of language means that although a great bodhisattva knows names and words, there is no attachment to them. Analytical knowledge of eloquence means that although a great bodhisattva knows that teaching and explaining in this way is supreme, there is no attachment to it.

Why is this? Son of good family, if there were attachment, one would not be called a bodhisattva.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if there were no attachment, one would not seek the Dharma. Whoever seeks the Dharma has attachment; and whoever seeks without attachment seeks nothing at all. Why then did the Tathāgata say that the Tathāgata is without attachment in seeking the Dharma?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, insofar as there is attachment, that is not unobstructed. It is non-attachment that is called unobstructed. Son of good family, therefore all bodhisattvas alike — if there is attachment, there is no freedom from obstruction. And if there is no freedom from obstruction, one should not be called a bodhisattva; know such a person to be an immature ordinary being. Why is the one who has attachment called an immature ordinary being? All immature ordinary beings are attached, from form through to consciousness. Through attachment to form, a mind of desire arises. Having aroused a mind of desire, one is bound by form — and likewise bound through to consciousness. Being thus bound and fettered, one is not liberated from birth, old age, sickness, death, the great suffering of grief and lamentation, and all the afflictions. Therefore, whoever has attachment is called an

immature ordinary being. For that reason, all immature ordinary beings lack the four analytical knowledges.

Son of good family, a great bodhisattva comes to know and see all phenomena for measureless, countless eons. By knowing and seeing in that way, one comes to know meanings as well. By knowing the defining characteristics of phenomena and knowing meanings in that way, one generates no attachment to forms — and likewise through to consciousness. Being thus without attachment, the bodhisattva generates no mind of attachment to form, nor any mind of attachment through to consciousness."

Being thus without attachment, one is not bound by form — and likewise through to consciousness. Being thus unbound by consciousness, one is liberated from birth, old age, sickness, and death, from grief accompanied by longing, from lamentation, from great suffering, and from all afflictions.

For that reason, all bodhisattvas attain the four analytical knowledges.

Son of good family, by that cause and that condition, those in my retinue who are bound by attachment even to the twelve branches of scripture are said to be bound by Māra. Whoever is without attachment is said to be liberated from bondage by Māra.

Here is an illustration: in the world, one who commits wrongdoing is bound by the king. One who has committed no wrongdoing is not bound by the king. A bodhisattva, a great being, is likewise: whoever is bound by attachment is said to be bound by Māra, and whoever is not bound by attachment is said to be not bound by Māra. Therefore a bodhisattva, a great being, has no attachment.

Son of good family, furthermore, the analytical knowledge of phenomena (Skt. *dharmapratisaṃvid*) is this: a bodhisattva, a great being, who is highly skilled in the *dhāraṇī* of letters does not forget. A *dhāraṇī* is like the earth, like a mountain, like the eye, like a cloud, like a human being, like a mother — and so it is with all phenomena.

The analytical knowledge of meaning (Skt. *arthapratisaṃvid*): a bodhisattva may know the names and words of all phenomena, yet not know the meaning. One who has attained the analytical knowledge of meaning knows the meanings as well. How does one know meaning? It is like grasping the earth — for just as the earth holds all sentient beings and non-sentient beings, it is therefore called "earth-like grasping."

Son of good family, as for mountain-like grasping: a bodhisattva, a great being, thinks thus about it. Why is it called grasping like a mountain? A mountain takes hold of the earth and, by being immovable, is called grasping. Why is it called grasping like an eye? Because the eye grasps appearances, it is called grasping. Why is it called grasping like a cloud? A cloud is the breath of the nāgas, and because the breath of the nāgas holds water, a cloud too is called grasping. Why is it called grasping like a human being? Because a human being is able to hold both what accords with Dharma and what does not accord with Dharma, a human being too is called grasping. Why is it called grasping like a mother? Because a mother holds her child, a mother too is called grasping.

In just this way does a bodhisattva, a great being, know the names, words, and meanings of all phenomena.

The analytical knowledge of language (Skt. nirukti-pratiśamvid): a bodhisattva, a great being, through knowing words and knowing meaning, teaches and expounds a single meaning through expressions of many kinds, and yet that expounding is without reified content. Examples of such names are those of man and woman, house, vehicle, sentient being, and so forth. Why is it said to be without reified content? Son of good family, "without reified content" is the domain of bodhisattvas and buddhas. "Words" is the domain of immature ordinary beings. It is because one knows the meaning that one attains the analytical knowledge of language.

The analytical knowledge of confident eloquence (Skt. pratibhāna-pratiśamvid): because a bodhisattva, a great being, knows words and knows meaning, the bodhisattva's exposition of words and meanings never becomes exhausted throughout measureless and countless eons — and for that reason it is called the analytical knowledge of confident eloquence.

Son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, has applied himself with the utmost diligence to conventional truth throughout measureless, boundless, and countless eons. Through having so diligently applied himself, he comes to fully realize the analytical knowledge of phenomena.

Furthermore, through having applied himself with the utmost diligence to ultimate truth throughout measureless and countless eons, he comes to fully realize the analytical knowledge of meaning.

Furthermore, through having applied himself with the utmost diligence to the literary arts throughout measureless and boundless eons, he comes to fully

realize the analytical knowledge of words.

Furthermore, through having studied the worldly arts throughout measureless and countless eons, he comes to fully realize the analytical knowledge of confident eloquence.

Son of good family, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have no occasion to attain these four analytical knowledges. Son of good family, I have taught in the nine branches of scripture that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas attain the four analytical knowledges — but in truth they do not perfectly attain them. Why is that? It is because a bodhisattva, a great being, applies himself to the four analytical knowledges for the sake of benefiting sentient beings. Pratyekabuddhas and the like pursue a course that is exclusively oriented toward peace, and because they delight in dwelling alone, even if they do act for the benefit of sentient beings, they demonstrate only supernormal knowledge and then remain silent, saying nothing at all. Where there is no teaching and no exposition, how could the four analytical knowledges be present?

Why is there no teaching when one remains silent? Because when a pratyekabuddha teaches the Dharma, he cannot bring it about that others accomplish the benefit of sentient beings, nor that those on the other side attain the stages of warmth, the summit, the supreme mundane quality, stream-entry, once-returning, non-returning, or arhatship, nor that they attain buddhahood, nor that they become bodhisattvas, great beings; and he cannot bring it about that those on the other side generate the mind oriented toward unsurpassed, genuinely perfect awakening (Skt. *anuttarasamyaksambodhi*). Why is that? Son of good family, pratyekabuddhas do not possess the nine branches of scripture, both worldly and world-transcending. Therefore pratyekabuddhas do not possess the analytical knowledge of words nor the analytical knowledge of confident eloquence.

Son of good family, a pratyekabuddha may know words in general, but he does not possess the analytical knowledge of phenomena. Why is that? The analytical knowledge of phenomena is called knowledge of syllables; and while a pratyekabuddha may know syllables in general, he does not possess what is called the analytical knowledge of syllables in their individual specificity. And why is that? Because he does not know the two syllables called "permanent" and "abiding," a pratyekabuddha has not attained the analytical knowledge of words. And though he may know meaning, he does not possess the analytical

knowledge of meaning in its individual specificity. To truly know meaning is to know that in all sentient beings the nature of a buddha (Skt. buddha-svabhāva) is present. The meaning of the nature of a buddha is what is called unsurpassed, genuinely perfect awakening. Therefore a pratyekabuddha has not attained the analytical knowledge of meaning, and thus a pratyekabuddha is entirely without the four analytical knowledges in all respects.

Why do śrāvakas also lack the four analytical knowledges? Because śrāvakas do not possess the three aspects of skillful means. What are those three? Giving the gift of Dharma with gentle and definitive words; giving the gift of Dharma with sharp and definitive words; and giving the gift of Dharma through what is neither gentle nor sharp. Because śrāvakas lack these three aspects, they do not possess the four analytical knowledges.

Furthermore, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have not reached the limit of knowledge of words and meanings; they do not possess the wisdom that takes command of the domain of objects; they possess neither the ten powers nor the four fearlessnesses; they have not arrived at the limit of the twelve links of dependent origination; they have not come to discern the differences of sharp and dull faculties among sentient beings; and they have not fully severed the mind that harbors doubt with respect to the two truths.

They have not become skilled in knowing upon what objects the minds of sentient beings are focused, nor have they become truly skilled in teaching ultimate emptiness. For these reasons, those of the two lesser vehicles do not attain the four analytical knowledges.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with a question: "Blessed One, if the four analytical knowledges are in every respect entirely absent in śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, why did the Tathāgata say: 'The venerable Śāriputra is the foremost in wisdom; the great Maudgalyāyana is the foremost in supernormal knowledge; the great Kauṣṭhila is the foremost in the four analytical knowledges'? If they do possess them, why did the Tathāgata speak thus?"

Then the Blessed One praised the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, saying: "Excellent! Most excellent!" And he continued: "Son of good family, consider this: the waters of the Ganges River are immeasurable, the waters of the Sindhu River are immeasurable, the waters of the Vakṣu River are immeasurable, the waters of the Sitā River are immeasurable, the waters of Lake Anavatapta are

immeasurable, and the waters of the great ocean are immeasurable. Though these many bodies of water are each alike in being immeasurable, in truth they are by no means equal in their greater and lesser measure. The four analytical knowledges of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are likewise. Son of good family, there is no basis for saying they are the same. Son of good family, it is in relation to common, inferior beings that I declared the great Kauṣṭhila to be the foremost in the four analytical knowledges — this is the intent of your question. Son of good family, among those who follow the śrāvaka vehicle, some attain just one of them, some attain just two — there is absolutely no case of attaining all four completely."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with a question: "Blessed One, you have declared, as stated previously in the chapter on the holy life, that 'A bodhisattva attains the four analytical knowledges through knowledge and vision' — and yet you also declared 'There is no attainment in the bodhisattva through knowledge and vision, and since even mind is absent, there is no attainment.' Blessed One, a great bodhisattva in truth has no attainment whatsoever. Yet if a bodhisattva were to have a mind of attainment, you have declared that such a one is not a bodhisattva but a common, childish being. Why then did the Tathāgata say that the bodhisattva has attainment?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family — excellent! Your question is most excellent, and it accords with my own intention to explain this matter. Son of good family, a great bodhisattva in truth obtains nothing whatsoever — and this very obtaining of nothing whatsoever is what is called the four analytical knowledges. Son of good family, why is it that obtaining nothing whatsoever is called the four analytical knowledges? Because if there were something to be obtained, that would be called 'entanglement,' and to whatever extent there is entanglement, that is called the four inversions. Son of good family, because a great bodhisattva is free from the four inversions, the bodhisattva attains the four analytical knowledges. Therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is what is called wisdom. Because a great bodhisattva obtains that wisdom, the bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Having something to obtain is called ignorance, and because a bodhisattva has utterly severed the darkness of ignorance, the bodhisattva is said to have no attainment — therefore a bodhisattva is said to have no attainment. Son of good family, furthermore, this having no

attainment is also called great nirvāṇa."

A bodhisattva, a great being, dwelling in bliss in great nirvāṇa in this way, does not perceive the defining characteristics of phenomena, and therefore a bodhisattva is said to have no attainment. Whatever there is of having something to attain — that is called the twenty-five modes of existence. A bodhisattva thoroughly severs those twenty-five modes of existence and thereby attains great nirvāṇa; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is what is called the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna). Because a great bodhisattva does not abide in any phenomenon whatsoever, the bodhisattva will attain the Great Vehicle; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Whatever there is of having attainment — that is called the awakening of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. A bodhisattva thoroughly severs the awakening of those two lesser vehicles and attains the awakening of a buddha; therefore a bodhisattva is said to have no attainment.

Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is what is called the vast and extensive sūtras. Because a bodhisattva reads and recites these sūtras, the bodhisattva is said to attain great nirvāṇa; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Whatever there is of having attainment — that is the eleven sūtras. A bodhisattva teaches and expounds only the vast and extensive sūtras of the Great Vehicle; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is called being equal to space. Space is that in which no thing whatsoever exists in the world. Because a bodhisattva attains the meditative absorption that is like space, the bodhisattva does not see anything whatsoever; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Whatever there is of having something to attain — that is the wheel that revolves in saṃsāra. All childish and ignoble beings have something to perceive because they revolve in saṃsāra. A bodhisattva thoroughly severs all saṃsāra; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Son of good family, furthermore, what a great bodhisattva obtains by obtaining nothing whatsoever is called permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. Because a great bodhisattva perceives the intrinsic nature of a buddha, the bodhisattva is said to attain permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity;

therefore a great bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Having something to attain means impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and utter impurity. Because a great bodhisattva thoroughly severs impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and utter impurity in this way, the bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is called ultimate emptiness. When a great bodhisattva surveys ultimate emptiness, the bodhisattva sees nothing whatsoever; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever. Having something to attain is called the five views. A bodhisattva thoroughly severs the five views and attains ultimate emptiness; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

The Noble Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, the twenty-third fascicle.

Son of good family, furthermore, this obtaining of nothing whatsoever is called unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Because a great bodhisattva attains unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening by obtaining nothing whatsoever, a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Awakening that comes with something to attain is the awakening of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. A bodhisattva thoroughly severs the awakening of those two lesser vehicles; therefore a bodhisattva is said to obtain nothing whatsoever.

Son of good family, your question, too, has nothing to attain, and my answer, too, has nothing to attain. Whatever has something to attain belongs to the party of Māra and is not in my company.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then spoke to the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, when you taught me this obtaining of nothing whatsoever for a bodhisattva, immeasurable sentient beings abandoned the mind that clings to marks. Therefore, by my asking about the meaning of obtaining nothing whatsoever, those immeasurable sentient beings have been freed from falling into the retinue of Māra and have become close companions of the Buddha."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then spoke again to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, previously, when you dwelt beneath the śāla trees, you declared this verse to Cunda:

What once existed now is no more;

what once was not now has come to be.

All phenomena of the three times in conditioned existence

cannot remain as such forever.

What is the meaning of what the Blessed One has declared?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, I spoke those words for the sake of taming many sentient beings. I also spoke them for the sake of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. I also spoke them for the sake of Mañjuśrī in his youth. But I did not speak that verse solely for the sake of Cunda alone. At that time Mañjuśrī was on the verge of asking me exactly that. Knowing his intention, I spoke for his sake. Having so spoken, the youthful Mañjuśrī fully and directly realized the meaning."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa spoke again to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how many beings have directly realized the meaning as Mañjuśrī has? May the Tathāgata please teach it extensively to the assembly in the maṇḍala."

The Blessed One replied: "Listen with utmost care, and I shall explain it to you as well.

The phrase 'what once existed' means this: from the very beginning I possessed afflictions without measure, and because of those afflictions, the great nirvāṇa I have now did not then exist. The phrase 'what once was not' means: from the very beginning the Perfection of Wisdom did not exist; because the Perfection of Wisdom did not exist, the defilement that now exists was present.

If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, or human whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata has afflictions in the past, the future, or the present, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: from the very beginning I possessed a body born from the union of father and mother; and because of that, the dharmakāya that is like a vajra I have now did not then exist. The phrase 'what once was not' means: from the very beginning my body did not possess the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent features; and because from the very beginning it did not possess the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent features, the full complement of the four hundred and four diseases existed.

If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata has the suffering of illness in the past, the future, or the present, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: from the very beginning I possessed impermanence, no-self, the absence of bliss, and the absence of purity. Because of that impermanence, no-self, absence of bliss, and

absence of purity, the unsurpassed and perfect awakening of the present does not exist. The phrase 'what from the beginning did not exist' means: from the very beginning the nature of a buddha was not seen. Not having seen it thus, there was no permanence, no bliss, no self, and no purity. If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present is impermanent, or lacks bliss, self, or purity, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: from the very beginning, with the mind of one who has practiced austerities in a base and ignoble way, I thought to attain the unsurpassed and perfect awakening. Because things were thus, the four māras have not yet been overcome in the present time. The phrase 'what from the beginning did not exist' means: from the very beginning the six perfections did not exist. Because the six perfections did not exist, there arose the thought of attaining unsurpassed and perfect awakening through the mind of one practicing base and ignoble austerities. If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present practiced austerities, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: from the very beginning I possessed a body mixed with food. Because such a body mixed with food existed, the boundless body of the present does not exist. The phrase 'what from the beginning did not exist' means: from the very beginning the thirty-seven factors of awakening did not exist. Because the thirty-seven factors of awakening did not exist, the body mixed with food of the present does exist. If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present possessed a body mixed with food, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: from the very beginning I took up all phenomena with a mind of attachment. Therefore the meditative absorption of utterly consummated emptiness does not exist at present. The phrase 'what from the beginning did not exist' means: from the very beginning the genuine meaning of the Middle Way did not exist.

Because the genuine meaning of the Middle Way did not exist, there was no mind unattached to all phenomena. If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present has characteristics with respect to all phenomena, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: when I first attained the unsurpassed and perfect awakening, there were those of dull faculties who had become attendants of śrāvakas. Because there were those of dull faculties who had become attendants of śrāvakas, the truth of the single vehicle does not exist. The phrase 'what from the beginning did not exist' means: from the very beginning there were no bodhisattvas like Kāśyapa, a king among yaks, among those of sharp faculties. Because there were no sharp-facultied ones like Kāśyapa, the teaching was divided into three vehicles and proclaimed by whatever skillful means were appropriate. If any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, human, or any other being whatsoever were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present is ultimately one who has perfected the three vehicles, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, furthermore, the phrase 'what once existed' means: I previously declared in these words: 'In three months' time I shall pass into complete nirvāṇa between the twin śāla trees.'

Therefore, at present, this greatly extensive sūtra of the Great Vehicle on the passing into complete nirvāṇa will not be expounded.

The phrase 'from the beginning nonexistent' means: from the very beginning, Mañjuśrī and the other great bodhisattvas were absent. Because they were thus absent, the Tathāgata now speaks of impermanence. Concerning this, if any śramaṇa, brahmin, god, Māra, Brahmā, or human were to say that the Tathāgata in the past, the future, or the present is impermanent, that would not be well founded.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata, for the sake of all sentient beings, though knowing all phenomena, declares that he does not know them. Though seeing all phenomena, he declares that he does not see them. Concerning phenomena that possess characteristics, he declares that they have no characteristics. Concerning phenomena that have no characteristics, he declares that they do possess characteristics. What is truly impermanent he declares to be permanent. What is truly permanent he declares to be

impermanent. And so too, self, bliss, and complete purity are to be understood in an equally extensive manner. The Dharma of the three vehicles he declares as the one vehicle, and the one vehicle he declares, as is appropriate, as three. The defining characteristic of a sūtra he declares as the defining characteristic of an extensive text, and the defining characteristic of an extensive text he also declares in brief. The four root defeats (pārājikas) he declares as grave offences, and grave offences he declares as the four root defeats. What is blameworthy he declares as not blameworthy, and what is not blameworthy he declares as blameworthy. A light transgression he declares as heavy, and a heavy one he declares as light. For what reason? Because the Tathāgata clearly sees the faculties of each individual sentient being.

Son of good family, even though the Tathāgata speaks in such ways, it is not falsehood. For what reason? To speak falsehood is to be at fault, and the Tathāgata is entirely free from every fault and defect — how could there be any speaking of falsehood? Son of good family, although there is no false speech in the Tathāgata, if it should come about that what takes the form of falsehood toward sentient beings will serve the purpose of benefiting them through the Dharma, he teaches and speaks to them by whatever skillful means are appropriate.

Son of good family, all conventional truth is, for the Tathāgata, ultimate truth. For what reason? The Blessed One, the Buddha, teaches conventional truth out of ultimate truth, so that otherwise ordinary beings might come to attain ultimate truth. If ordinary beings were not to attain ultimate truth, the Blessed One, the Buddha, would never teach conventional truth at all.

Son of good family, when the Tathāgata at certain times teaches conventional truth, sentient beings think: "The Tathāgata is teaching ultimate truth." At other times, when ultimate truth is taught, sentient beings think: "The Tathāgata is teaching conventional truth." This is the profound domain of conduct of the Blessed Buddhas; it is not something known by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Son of good family, therefore it is improper of you to challenge the great bodhisattvas by saying that they attain nothing whatsoever. If a bodhisattva is always endowed with ultimate truth, why would you challenge them by saying they attain nothing?

Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, ultimate truth is also called the path, it is also called awakening, and it is also called nirvāṇa. If a bodhisattva attains the

path, awakening, and nirvāṇa, then these would be impermanent. For what reason? If they were permanent, it would not be fitting to attain them either.

Just as space is not proper for anyone to attain, so too it is with this.

Kāśyapa continued: Blessed One, if worldly things that did not exist from the beginning but exist now are called impermanent, then awakening is similar: if awakening were something attained, it would be called impermanent. But if a phenomenon were permanent, then there would be no attaining it and no arising of it. Just so, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is also such that there is no attaining it and no arising of it. Blessed One, the path is not form, nor is it formless; it is not long, nor is it short; it is not high, nor is it low; it does not arise, nor does it cease; it is not red, nor is it white, nor blue, nor yellow; it is not existent, nor is it non-existent. For what reason, then, did the Tathāgata declare it proper to attain it? Awakening and nirvāṇa are likewise the same.

The Blessed One declared: Just so, just so it is. Son of good family, the path has two aspects: permanent and impermanent. Awakening likewise has two aspects: permanent and impermanent. Nirvāṇa is the same. The path of the outer non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) is called impermanent. The inner path is called permanent. The awakening of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas is called impermanent. The awakening of bodhisattvas and buddhas is called permanent. The outer liberation is called impermanent. The inner liberation is called permanent. Son of good family, the path, awakening, and passing beyond sorrow are all called permanent.

All sentient beings are perpetually covered over by countless afflictions, and lacking the eye of wisdom they do not see. Ordinary persons, wishing to see, apply themselves diligently to moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom. By so applying themselves diligently, they come to see the path, awakening, and passing beyond sorrow. That is what is meant by a bodhisattva attaining the path, awakening, and passing beyond sorrow. The defining characteristic of the path is not something that truly arises or truly ceases; therefore it cannot be grasped. Son of good family, what is called "the path" has neither form nor shape, is not something to be seen, measured, or known — and yet in truth it has purpose.

Son of good family, consider this example: the mind of a sentient being, too, is not form; it is not long, not short, not thick, not fine, not bound, not free, not something visible — and yet it does not not exist. Therefore I have said to the householder Anāthapiṇḍada that the mind is like the owner of a treasury of

countless things. Householder, if the mind is not guarded, body and speech will not be guarded either; but if the mind is guarded, body and speech will also be guarded. If body and speech are not well guarded, one causes sentient beings to fall into the three lower destinies. If body and speech are guarded, sentient beings come to attain the nirvāṇa of gods and humans. An attainment of that kind may be called genuine; what is not attained cannot be called genuine.

Son of good family, the path, awakening, and passing beyond sorrow are likewise: they are not existent, and they are not permanent. If they were non-existent, how could all the afflictions be cut through? Because they do exist in this way, all bodhisattvas clearly see and know them by direct perception. Son of good family, seeing has two aspects: seeing by means of signs, and clearly seeing by direct perception. What does it mean to see by means of signs? It is like this: when from a distance one sees smoke, one says, "I see fire" — yet one does not truly see the fire. Though the fire is not seen, it is not a falsehood.

When one sees a water-bird, one says, "I see water" — yet one does not truly see the water. Though the water is not seen, it is not a falsehood. Or again, when one sees flowers and leaves, one says, "I see the roots" — yet one does not truly see the roots. Though the roots are not seen, that too is not a falsehood. Or again, when a person standing behind a fence sees a horn, one says, "I see an ox" — yet one does not truly see the ox itself. Though the ox is not seen, it is not a falsehood. Or again, when one sees a pregnant woman, one says, "I see her lying with a man" — yet one does not truly see the lying itself. Though the lying is not seen, it is not a falsehood. Or again, when one sees the leaves of a tree, one says, "I see water" — yet one does not truly see the water itself. Though the water is not seen, it is not a falsehood. Or again, when one sees clouds, one says, "I see rain" — yet one does not truly see the rain itself. Though the rain is not seen, it is not a falsehood. Or again, when one sees the actions of body and speech, one says, "I see the actions of mind" — yet one does not truly see the actions of mind. But to say so is not a falsehood. This is what is called seeing by means of signs.

Now, what does it mean to clearly see by direct perception? It is like seeing form with the eye. Son of good family, consider this: just as when a person whose faculty of sight is unimpaired and perfectly clear holds an āmra fruit in the palm of his hand, in just the same way a bodhisattva, a great being, clearly sees the path, awakening, and nirvāṇa by direct perception. And yet, though

seeing in this way, from the very beginning there is no defining characteristic of seeing as such.

Son of good family, it is for this reason and on this occasion that I formerly said to Śāriputra the following words: "Śāriputra, whatever is not known, not seen, and not understood by all those of the world — the renunciants, the brahmins, the gods, the māras, the Great Brahma, and humans — all of that the Tathāgata knows, sees, and understands. Bodhisattvas are likewise." And: "Śāriputra, whatever is known, seen, and understood by those of the world — that too I and the bodhisattvas know, see, and understand. What all those of the world do not know, do not see, and do not understand — it is not that I do not know, see, or understand it; rather, I know it thus: these sentient beings of the world say, 'I know it thus, I see it thus, I understand it thus.'"

Śāriputra, though the Tathāgata knows and sees all, he does not say, "I know and see it thus." All bodhisattvas are likewise. Why? Because if the Tathāgata were to intend that he knows, sees, or understands in that way, he could not rightly be called a buddha, a Blessed One, or a bodhisattva — that would be childish and ignoble.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the meaning of what you declared to Śāriputra: 'What the world knows, I know; and what the world does not know, I too know entirely'?"

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, all those of the world do not know, do not see, and do not understand the intrinsic nature of a buddha. If they did know, see, or understand it, they would not be called worldly beings but bodhisattvas. For worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand the twelve categories of scripture, the twelve links of dependent origination, the four inversions, the Four Noble Truths, the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, the unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening, or the great and complete nirvāṇa. If they did know, see, or understand these, they would not be called worldly beings but bodhisattvas.

These, son of good family, are what is called that which worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand.

Now, in what way do worldly beings know, see, and understand? It is as follows: they speak of the god Brahmā, of Īśvara, of the eight-armed one, of primordial nature, of time, of atoms, of dharma and non-dharma, of the lord of loving-kindness, of a beginning and an end to the world, of the two views of

eternalism and annihilation, and they declare that from the first meditative concentration up through the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception there is nirvāṇa. Son of good family, that is called the knowing, seeing, and understanding of worldly beings.

The bodhisattva, the great being, likewise knows and sees these very things. The bodhisattva knows, sees, and understands them in just that way; yet if such a one were to say "I do not know, do not see, and do not understand," that would be a lie. Insofar as one speaks falsely, one commits a fault; and by the power of that fault, one falls into hell.

Son of good family, whether a man, a woman, a renunciant, a brahmin, or anyone at all who says there is no path, no awakening, and no nirvāṇa — such a one is possessed of wrong craving, belongs to the camp of Māra, and is called one who denigrates the Dharma. Such denigration of the Dharma is likewise called denigration of the buddhas. Such a person should be called neither a worldly being nor a non-worldly being.

At that time, upon hearing these words spoken, Kāśyapa praised the Buddha with these verses:

You hold compassion for all sentient beings,
and I take refuge in you.
Because you draw out the dart of wickedness and harm,
you are renowned as the King of Physicians.

When a worldly physician effects a cure,
the patient recovers in a moment but may fall ill again.
When a Tathāgata effects a cure,
one never falls ill again.

The Blessed One dispenses the medicine of nectar
and gives it fully to all sentient beings.
Sentient beings who seek and receive it
are freed from death and freed from birth.

The Tathāgata, for our sake, has revealed
the passing into complete nirvāṇa.
Those sentient beings who receive these words
will attain the state beyond arising and cessation.

Having spoken these verses, the bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as you have taught, all worldly

beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand certain things, while a bodhisattva knows, sees, and understands them all. But if a bodhisattva is also a worldly being, then it is not fitting to say that what worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand, the bodhisattva knows, sees, and understands. And if the bodhisattva is not a worldly being, then what difference is there?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, a bodhisattva is both a worldly being and not a worldly being. One who does not know, does not see, and does not understand is called a worldly being. One who knows, sees, and understands is not called a worldly being. And your question about what difference there is — I will explain that.

Son of good family, suppose any man or woman, upon hearing this sūtra of complete nirvāṇa, immediately gives rise to faith and generates the mind of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Such a one is called a worldly bodhisattva. In the way that all worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand, this bodhisattva too, in conformity with worldly beings, does not know, does not see, and does not understand. Yet having heard this sūtra of complete nirvāṇa, the bodhisattva —

what worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand, the bodhisattva knows, sees, and understands. Having thus come to know those things, the bodhisattva thinks to himself: "By what means, through what method, through what endeavor, shall I come to know, to see, and to understand?" And then he thinks: "These things will be attained through guarding moral discipline in perfect purity with a mind of deep faith."

Son of good family, at that time, through those causes and those conditions, that bodhisattva guards moral discipline in perfect purity in whatever future birth and in whatever place he is born. Son of good family, because the bodhisattva, the great being, guards moral discipline in perfect purity, in whatever birth and in whatever place he is born, pride, wrong views, and doubt find no occasion to seize him. At no time does he ever say that the Tathāgata has finally entered complete nirvāṇa. These things are called the bodhisattva's guarding of moral discipline in perfect purity.

Through guarding moral discipline in perfect purity, he then applies himself diligently to meditative absorption. Through applying himself diligently to meditative absorption, in whatever birth and in whatever place he is born, his right mindfulness does not decline — mindfulness such as this: that all

sentient beings possess the buddha-nature, that there are the twelve branches of scripture, that the awakened Blessed Ones are permanent, blissful, self, and perfectly pure, and that all bodhisattvas, through dwelling extensively in the great sūtra of complete nirvāṇa, do not utter a word about seeing the buddha-nature and such other things. Through diligent application to meditative absorption, he will also attain the eleven absorptions of emptiness. This is called the bodhisattva's diligent application to the pure perfection of meditative absorption.

Having thus come to be endowed with moral discipline and meditative absorption, he then applies himself diligently to wisdom in perfect purity. Through diligent application to wisdom, he no longer grasps from the very beginning either that a self exists within the body or that the body exists within a self; he no longer grasps that the body and the self are identical, nor that the self is something other than the body. This is called the bodhisattva's diligent application to wisdom in perfect purity.

Through this diligent application to wisdom, the very moral discipline he has guarded also becomes exceedingly firm. Son of good family, consider this analogy: Mount Meru cannot be moved by the four winds. Likewise the bodhisattva, the great being, cannot be moved by the four distortions. Son of good family, that bodhisattva then knows, sees, and understands that whatever moral discipline he has guarded cannot be moved by anything whatsoever. That is what is called the bodhisattva's knowing, seeing, and understanding — and it is not the knowing of a worldly being.

Son of good family, because the bodhisattva, the great being, sees the moral discipline he has guarded to be exceedingly firm and unshakeable, his mind is free of remorse. Being free of remorse, his mind becomes greatly joyful. Being greatly joyful, his mind becomes utterly content. Being utterly content, he becomes blissful. His mind becoming utterly blissful, he attains the meditative absorption of imperturbability. Attaining the meditative absorption of imperturbability, his knowing and his vision become right and true. His knowing and vision becoming right and true, he becomes weary of saṃsāra. Being weary of saṃsāra, he becomes fully liberated. Being fully liberated, he sees the buddha-nature with clarity. That is what is called the bodhisattva's knowing, seeing, and understanding — and it is not the knowing of a worldly being.

Son of good family, these are the things that worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand, but which the bodhisattva knows, sees, and understands.

Kāśyapa asked again: How is it that a bodhisattva, through diligent application to perfectly pure moral discipline, comes to see the buddha-nature with clarity, from the arising of a mind free of remorse all the way through to that seeing?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the moral discipline of worldly beings is not to be called perfectly pure. Why is that? The moral discipline of worldly beings is accompanied by continued existence, is uncertain in its intrinsic nature, is not ultimate, and does not extend to the benefit of all sentient beings — therefore it is not to be called perfectly pure. Because it is not perfectly pure, it is accompanied by a mind of remorse. Because it is accompanied by a mind of remorse, there is no mind of joy. Without a mind of joy, there is no contentment. Without contentment, there is no happiness. Without happiness, there is no meditative absorption of imperturbability. Without the meditative absorption of imperturbability, there is no right knowing and right vision. Without right knowing and right vision, there is no weariness of saṃsāra. Without weariness of saṃsāra, one will not become fully liberated. Without being fully liberated, one does not see the buddha-nature. Without seeing the buddha-nature, one does not attain the great and perfect nirvāṇa. Such is what is called the moral discipline of worldly beings — it is not perfectly pure.

Son of good family, the perfectly pure moral discipline of the bodhisattva, the great being, is moral discipline that is at the same time not moral discipline, that is unaccompanied by continued existence, that is certain, that is ultimate, and that works for the benefit of sentient beings. That is what is called the perfectly pure moral discipline of the bodhisattva.

Son of good family, although the bodhisattva, the great being, does not deliberately generate a mind free of remorse with respect to perfectly pure moral discipline, a mind free of remorse arises of itself. Son of good family, consider this analogy: when a person holds up a mirror, although they make no deliberate effort to produce a reflection of their face, the reflection arises of itself. Or consider: when a farmer sows seed in well-tilled soil, although they make no deliberate effort to produce shoots, the shoots arise of themselves. Or consider: when a lamp is lit, although no deliberate effort is made to remove the darkness, the darkness is removed of itself. Son of good family,

when the bodhisattva, the great being, guards and maintains perfectly pure moral discipline, it is just the same — a mind free of remorse arises of itself.

Through perfectly pure moral discipline, one comes to attain a mind of supreme joy. Son of good family, consider this analogy: a person who has a fine and beautiful face, upon seeing their own reflection, gives rise to a mind of supreme joy. Perfectly pure moral discipline is just the same. Son of good family, one whose moral discipline is corrupted, having moral discipline that is not perfectly pure, does not give rise to a mind of joy. It is just as when a person with an ugly face sees their own reflection — a mind of joy does not arise. One whose moral discipline is corrupted is just the same.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: two women, each carrying a pot — one carries a pot of curd, the other a pot of butter — and they travel together heading toward a market. Along the way they stumble and both pots break. One of them is glad, the other is not. One who possesses moral discipline and one whose moral discipline has deteriorated are just like these two. Perfectly pure moral discipline causes the mind to be supremely glad.

When the mind is supremely glad, it thinks to itself: The Blessed One, the fully enlightened buddha, declared after entering into perfect nirvāṇa that whoever guards moral discipline in perfect purity will pass beyond sorrow. If I too apply myself diligently to perfectly pure moral discipline, I will attain it. By that cause and that condition, the mind becomes supremely glad.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, what is the difference between what is called joy and what is called happiness?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, a great bodhisattva is called joyful because he commits no wrongdoing that would bring reproach. The mind that guards moral discipline with utter delight is called happiness.

Noble son, a great bodhisattva is called joyful because he thoroughly comprehends saṃsāra. Attaining the great nirvāṇa is called happiness. The lesser is called joy; the supreme is called happiness. Completely abandoning qualities that are mixed up with the world is called joy. Attaining qualities unmixed with the world is called happiness.

Through perfectly pure moral discipline, the body becomes serviceable and the fault of coarse speech is absent. At that time, in all that the bodhisattva sees, hears, smells, tastes, touches, and cognizes, there is nothing that brings reproach. Because there is nothing that brings reproach, the mind becomes

supremely happy. Because the mind becomes supremely happy, he attains the peaceful meditative absorption. By attaining the peaceful meditative absorption, his knowing and his vision become correct. With correct knowing and vision, he becomes thoroughly disillusioned with saṃsāra. Through thorough disillusionment with saṃsāra, he becomes fully liberated. Through full liberation, he sees the nature of a buddha. By seeing the nature of a buddha, he attains the great nirvāṇa.

These are the marks of a bodhisattva's perfectly pure moral discipline, and they are not the moral discipline of the world. Why is that? Noble son, when a great bodhisattva guards moral discipline in perfect purity, five kinds of Dharma become his companions. What are the five? He is endowed with faith, endowed with a sense of personal shame, endowed with a sense of social shame, endowed with a spiritual friend, and he is one who respects moral discipline.

By completely abandoning the five obscurations, his view becomes perfectly pure. By completely abandoning the five wrong views, he becomes free of a doubting mind. Furthermore, he completely abandons the five doubts. What are the five? Doubt concerning the Buddha, doubt concerning the Dharma, doubt concerning the Saṅgha, doubt concerning moral discipline, and doubt concerning heedlessness.

At that time the bodhisattva also attains the five faculties. What are the five? The faculty of faith, the faculty of diligence, the faculty of mindfulness, the faculty of meditative absorption, and the faculty of wisdom. By attaining the five faculties, he also attains the five liberations. What are the five? Liberation of form through to liberation of consciousness. This is called the perfectly pure moral discipline of a bodhisattva, and it is not that of the world.

Noble son, these are things unknown, unseen, and uncomprehended by worldly beings, but they are known, seen, and comprehended by bodhisattvas.

Noble son, if any of my attendants who carry, retain, read, recite, or copy out the sūtras of the Great Vehicle on great nirvāṇa, or who teach and expound them, should let their moral discipline deteriorate, others will look down on them and reproach them, saying: If the great nirvāṇa sūtra, which is the essential intent of the Buddha, were truly a powerful scripture, why would someone who has taken it up let their moral discipline fall into ruin?

If one who carries and retains the nirvāṇa sūtra lets his moral discipline deteriorate, let it be understood that for him the sūtra has no power. And if it

has no power, then even if he reads or recites it, it will be of no benefit. In this way, by disparaging and reviling the nirvāṇa sūtra, he causes sentient beings beyond measure and without limit to fall into the hells.

If one who carries and retains this very sūtra lets his moral discipline fall into ruin, then he is an evil spiritual friend to sentient beings. He is not an attendant of mine; he belongs to the retinue of Māra.

Such a person would do better not to carry, retain, or even listen to this sūtra — better not to have held it, grasped it, or practiced it at all — than to carry or retain it while his moral discipline has deteriorated.

Son of good family, those who are my attendants and who wish to carry, retain, read, recite, transcribe into a volume, teach, or expound this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa must do so with body and mind that are genuine and wholesome — not with laxity, restlessness, or distraction. What arises from the body is called laxity; what arises from the mind is called restlessness. A mind filled with searching and striving is called restlessness; physical actions performed with such striving are called laxity.

If my attendants carry searching and active striving along with them, they must not carry or hold this sūtra of the Great Vehicle's complete nirvāṇa. And if, in such a condition, someone does carry or retain this very sūtra, others will look down on them and reproach them, saying: If the nirvāṇa sūtra, which is the essential intent of the Buddha, were truly a powerful scripture, why would you go about filled with searching and active striving? If one who carries this sūtra is filled with searching and striving, they will say this sūtra has no power. And if it has no power, then even carrying or retaining it will be of no benefit. By thus disparaging the nirvāṇa sūtra, one causes sentient beings beyond measure and without limit to fall into the hells. One who carries and retains this sūtra while filled with searching and active striving is an unwholesome spiritual friend to sentient beings. He is not my attendant; he belongs to the ranks of Māra.

Furthermore, son of good family, those who are my attendants and who carry, retain, read, recite, transcribe into a volume, or teach this sūtra of the complete nirvāṇa must not teach it at the wrong time; must not teach it to someone who has not received the proper introduction; must not teach it to one who has not made a request; must not teach it with a contemptuous mind; must not explain it at all times and in all places indiscriminately; must not teach it for the sake of praising themselves; must not expound it for the sake

of disparaging others; must not expound it in a way that would cause the Dharma of the Buddha to decline; and must not expound it for the sake of causing the ways of the world to flourish.

Son of good family, if those who carry and retain this sūtra and who are my attendants teach it from wrongful timing all the way to teaching it for the sake of causing the ways of the world to flourish, others will scrutinize and reproach them, saying: If this nirvāṇa sūtra, which the Buddha intended and taught as its essential meaning, were truly a powerful scripture, why would it be taught at the wrong time and all the way to being taught for the sake of causing the ways of the world to flourish? If those who hold this sūtra teach it in such a manner, people will regard this sūtra as having no power. And if it has no power, then even holding or retaining it will serve no purpose of benefit or happiness. Thus, by disparaging the nirvāṇa sūtra in this way, those without measure among sentient beings will fall into the hells. Those who carry and retain this sūtra and teach it from the wrong time all the way to teaching it for the sake of causing worldly ways to flourish —

Such a person is a negative spiritual friend (Skt. kalyāṇamitra) to sentient beings, not a companion of mine; they belong to the retinue of Māra. Son of good family, whoever carries, retains, teaches, or expounds this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa — teaching and explaining the nature of buddhahood, explaining the essence of what the Tathāgata intended and taught, teaching the Great Vehicle, teaching the extensive sūtras, teaching the vehicle of the śrāvakas, teaching the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, teaching liberation, and bringing those who see the nature of buddhahood to purify their bodies thoroughly from the very beginning — such a person, by purifying the body thoroughly, will give rise to no contempt or disparagement. And because there is no contempt or disparagement, measureless sentient beings will develop pure faith in the sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa. With faith arisen in their minds, they will pay homage and render honor to this sūtra. If even a single four-line verse, or a single line, or even a single word of it is heard, and this teaching causes one to arouse the mind set on unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, then such a person is a true and genuine virtuous spiritual friend to sentient beings, not a negative spiritual friend. They are a companion of mine, not of the retinue of Māra. They are to be called a bodhisattva, not a worldly person. Son of good family, these things are unknown, unseen, and uncomprehended by worldly people; they are known, seen, and comprehended by bodhisattvas.

Son of good family, further, in what way does the entire world not know, not see, and not comprehend what bodhisattvas do know, see, and comprehend? It is this: the six objects of recollection. What are the six? Recollection of the Buddha, recollection of the Dharma, recollection of the Saṅgha, recollection of the precepts, recollection of generosity, and recollection of the gods.

The Noble Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, the twenty-fourth fascicle.

Son of good family, in what way does one recollect the Buddha? The Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened — endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, tamer and guide of beings, teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One — is permanent, unchanging, unmoving, endowed with the ten powers and the four kinds of fearlessness, roaring the roar of the great lion, the great ascetic, the great brahmin, the great Brahmā, one who has reached the final end, perfected beyond the reach of others, whose crown no one can behold, without apprehension, without embarrassment, without wavering, alone without companion, self-knowing without being taught, swift wisdom, great wisdom, sharp wisdom, deep wisdom, wisdom of liberation, unshared wisdom, all-pervading wisdom, consummate wisdom, precious wisdom — like a supreme bull among humans, like a king of elephants among humans, like a king of nāgas among humans, a man among humans, like a lotus blossom among humans, like the puṇḍarīka lotus, a guide, a teacher of humans, a great lord of generosity, a teacher of the great Dharma: he teaches the great Dharma because he knows the Dharma, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows the meaning, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows the right time, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows what is fitting, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows himself, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows the great assembly, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows the various natures of sentient beings, he teaches the great Dharma because he knows whether their faculties are sharp, dull, or middling, and he teaches the great Dharma because he teaches the middle path. This is called recollection of the Buddha.

Now, in what sense is he called the Tathāgata, the "thus-gone"? He is called the Tathāgata because he does not deviate from what the buddhas of the past have declared. How does he not deviate? Just as the buddhas of the past taught the twelve branches of scripture for the liberation of sentient beings, the Tathāgata likewise does the same — and therefore he is called the Tathāgata. The blessed buddhas (Bhagavāns) departed by way of the six

perfections, the thirty-seven factors of awakening, and the eleven kinds of emptiness, and arrived at the great nirvāṇa. The Tathāgata is the same in this regard, and therefore he is called the Tathāgata. The Blessed One, through that very skillful means, taught the three vehicles for the sake of sentient beings, and the span of his life and body is boundless and immeasurable — the Tathāgata is the same in this regard, and therefore he is called the Tathāgata.

Now, in what sense is he called the arhat, the "foe-destroyer"? All phenomena of the world are called enemies, and because the Buddha has vanquished all those forms, he is called the arhat. The four māras are called the enemies of bodhisattvas, and the Blessed One, while acting as a bodhisattva, vanquished the four māras through the primordial wisdom of omniscience — therefore he is called the arhat. Moreover, arhat means "one who has completely abandoned," for during his time as a bodhisattva he completely abandoned immeasurable afflictions — therefore he is called the arhat. Furthermore, arhat means "the bliss of the buddhas of the past." When previously acting as a bodhisattva, throughout measureless and countless eons he endured many and various forms of suffering for the sake of sentient beings, yet was without discomfort — he was always at ease. The Tathāgata is the same in this regard, and therefore he is called the arhat. Moreover, arhat means one who is worshipped: all the gods and humans of this world together with the gods offer divine flowers and garlands, victory banners and pennants, and all manner of music in his honor — therefore he is called the arhat.

Now, in what sense is he called the "perfectly and fully awakened one"? "Correct" means unerring. "Complete" means that there is not a single one of the four inversions that he has not directly realized. Furthermore, "correct" refers to the practice of austerity, and "complete" means knowing for certain that by the condition of practicing suffering one will experience the fruit of suffering. Furthermore, "correct" means the middle way of the world, and "complete" means that one who assiduously pursues the middle path to its end will certainly come to know perfect and full awakening without superior. Furthermore, "correct" refers to what is countable, measurable, and calculable; "complete" refers to what is uncountable, unmeasurable, and incalculable — and therefore the Buddha is called the "perfectly and fully awakened one."

Son of good family, one might say that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are also "perfectly and fully awakened," but in fact they are not. Why is this? Perfect and full awakening means knowing the five aggregates, the twelve

sense bases, and the eighteen elements — śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas know these as well, and so they might be called "perfectly and fully awakened." But why are they not truly so? Son of good family, if even throughout measureless eons the two of the lesser vehicles were to contemplate the aggregate of form alone and still not know it completely, then for that reason śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot be called "perfectly and fully awakened."

Now, in what sense is he said to be "endowed with knowledge and conduct"? Knowledge means the attainment of immeasurable fruits of virtue.

"Endowed with conduct" means conduct itself. The fruit of virtue therein is unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. "Conduct" means moral discipline and wisdom; because one arrives at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening on the two feet of moral discipline and wisdom, he is said to be "endowed with knowledge and conduct."

Furthermore, "knowledge" means vidyā. "Endowed" means auspiciousness. "Conduct" means fruit. Son of good family, these are the benefit of the world. Vidyā means liberation. Auspiciousness means unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Fruit means the great nirvāṇa. Therefore he is said to be "endowed with knowledge and conduct."

Furthermore, "knowledge" means illumination. "Endowed" means action. "Conduct" means fruit. Son of good family, this too is the benefit of the world. Illumination means heedfulness. Action means the six perfections. Fruit means unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Furthermore, "knowledge" refers to three kinds of vidyā: the vidyā of awakening, the vidyā of buddhahood, and the vidyā of ignorance. Of these, the vidyā of awakening is the Perfection of Wisdom. The vidyā of buddhahood is the very nature of buddhahood itself. The vidyā of ignorance is the perfection of emptiness. "Endowed" means having cultivated many wholesome actions for the sake of sentient beings throughout countless eons. "Conduct" means clearly seeing the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Therefore he is said to be "endowed with knowledge and conduct."

Now, in what sense is he called the Sugata (the Well-Gone)? "Well" means high. "Gone" means not high. Son of good family, this is the benefit of the world. "High" means unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. "Not high" means the mind of the Tathāgata. Son of good family, if the mind were high, one could not speak of a Tathāgata; therefore a Tathāgata is called the

Sugata.

Furthermore, "well" means a spiritual friend. "Gone" means the fruit of a spiritual friend. Son of good family, this is the benefit of the world. A spiritual friend means the first arousal of the awakening mind. The fruit means the great nirvāṇa. Because a Tathāgata never abandons the awakening mind first aroused and thereby attains the great nirvāṇa, he is called the Sugata.

Furthermore, "well" means excellent. "Gone" means existing. Son of good family, this is the benefit of the world. "Excellent" means seeing the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. "Existing" means the great nirvāṇa. Son of good family, although the intrinsic nature of nirvāṇa does not truly exist as such, the Blessed One the buddha, accommodating to the world, has declared it to exist. Son of good family, it is just as when people of the world tell a childless person, "You have a child," or tell someone without a road, "There is a road." In the same way, the great nirvāṇa too has been declared to exist as an accommodation to the world. Because the great nirvāṇa is effortlessly accomplished by the blessed buddhas, they are called Sugatas.

Son of good family, in what sense is he called "knower of the world"? Son of good family, "the world" means the five aggregates. "Knowing" means understanding. Because the Blessed One the buddha is supremely skilled in the five aggregates, he is called the knower of the world.

Furthermore, "the world" means the five objects of desire. "Knowing" means non-attachment. Because he is completely unattached to the five objects of desire, he is also called the knower of the world.

Furthermore, "the world" means the immeasurable, countless world-realms of the eastern direction — realms that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas neither know, nor see, nor comprehend, but which the Blessed One the buddha knows, sees, and comprehends. Likewise, the world-realms of the south, the west, the north, the four intermediate directions, the zenith, and the nadir are all known in the same way. Therefore the Blessed One the buddha is called the knower of the world.

Furthermore, "the world" means all common, ignoble beings. "Knowing" means that noble beings understand the causes and fruits of virtue and non-virtue — something not known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas, but known by the buddha alone. Therefore the Blessed One the buddha is called the knower of the world.

Furthermore, "the world" means a lotus. "Knowing" means being unstained. Son of good family, "the world" here refers to the lotus, and "the Tathāgata" is spoken of as unstained — because the Tathāgata is not stained by the eight worldly concerns, the Blessed One the buddha is called the knower of the world.

Furthermore, "knower of the world" is an epithet applied to buddhas and bodhisattvas. Why is that? Because buddhas and bodhisattvas behold the world, they are called knowers of the world. Son of good family, just as one who is sustained by food as its condition is called one who lives on food, so too buddhas and bodhisattvas, because they behold the world, are called knowers of the world.

Now, in what sense is he called "unsurpassed"? "Having a superior" means being subject to being cut down. Because there is nothing that can cut him down, he is unsurpassed. Because the Blessed One the buddha is entirely free from mental afflictions, there is nothing that can cut him down. Therefore the Blessed One the buddha is called unsurpassed.

Furthermore, "having a superior" means being attended by dispute. "Unsurpassed" means being free from dispute. Because the Tathāgata is free from dispute, the Blessed One the buddha is called unsurpassed.

Furthermore, "having a superior" means being susceptible to refutation by words. "Unsurpassed" means not being susceptible to refutation by words. Because what the Tathāgata has taught cannot be refuted by any sentient being whatsoever, the Blessed One the buddha is called unsurpassed.

Furthermore, "having a superior" means having something above. "Unsurpassed" means having nothing above. Because among all the buddhas of the three times there is nothing surpassing them, the Blessed One the buddha is called unsurpassed.

Furthermore, "having a superior" refers to what is new or old. Because the Blessed One the buddha has become of the very nature of complete nirvāṇa, there is in him no such thing as new or old. Therefore the Blessed One the buddha is called unsurpassed.

Son of good family, now in what sense is he called the tamer and guide of persons? Because he himself is a person, he also tames other persons. Son of good family, in ultimate truth the Tathāgata is neither a person nor a non-person; yet because he tames persons, the Tathāgata is spoken of as a

person.

Son of good family, whether a man or a woman, whoever possesses these four qualities is called a person. What are the four? Seeking a spiritual friend, listening to the Dharma, taking its meaning to heart, and practicing in accordance with what has been taught. Son of good family, any man or woman who possesses these four qualities is called a person.

Son of good family, if someone is male yet does not possess these four qualities, he is not to be called a person. Why is that? He has the body of a man, but his conduct resembles that of an animal. Because the Tathāgata tames both men and women, he is called the tamer and guide of persons.

Furthermore, son of good family, consider this analogy: a horse-trainer has four ways of working. He touches the hair, he touches the hide, he touches the flesh, he touches the bone. Whichever of these he applies, the horse goes according to the trainer's will. The Tathāgata is just like that: he tames sentient beings by these four methods of Dharma.

What are they? Those who, upon having birth explained to them, act in accordance with the Buddha's word — they are like a horse that goes according to the trainer's will at the mere touch of hair. That is the first. Those who, upon having the teachings on birth and aging explained to them, act in accordance with the Buddha's word — they are like a horse that goes at the touch of hair and hide. That is the second. Those who, upon having birth, aging, and illness explained to them, act in accordance with the Buddha's word — they are like a horse that goes at the touch of hair, hide, and flesh. That is the third. Those who, upon having birth, aging, illness, and death explained to them, act in accordance with the Buddha's word — they are like a horse that can be guided at the touch of hair, hide, flesh, and bone. That is the fourth.

Son of good family, a horse-trainer is not infallible, but the Buddha Blessed One's taming of sentient beings is infallible and without deception. Therefore the Buddha Blessed One is called the tamer and guide of persons.

Now, in what way is he the Teacher of gods and humans? There are two kinds of teacher: one who teaches what is wholesome, and one who teaches what is harmful. Buddhas and bodhisattvas always teach sentient beings the wholesome qualities — wholesome through body, speech, and mind.

Buddhas and bodhisattvas teach sentient beings in this way: "O sons of good family, you must thoroughly abandon unwholesome actions of body. Why? Because if unwholesome actions of body are thoroughly abandoned, you will be liberated. Therefore we teach you these qualities. We do not teach you that by failing to abandon unwholesome actions you will attain liberation." As for the claim that sentient beings who thoroughly abandon harmful actions would fall into the three lower destinies — there is no such case. On the contrary, there is every reason to say that by thoroughly abandoning them one will attain unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening and attain the great nirvāṇa. Therefore buddhas and bodhisattvas always teach these very qualities to sentient beings. Know that the same applies equally to speech and mind. For this reason the Buddha Blessed One is the unsurpassable Teacher.

Furthermore, having himself attained what was not yet attained, he teaches what he has attained to sentient beings; having himself lived the holy life from the very beginning, he teaches that way of living to sentient beings; having himself vanquished ignorance, he vanquishes ignorance in sentient beings; having himself attained the fully purified eye, he clears away the cataract of blindness in sentient beings and enables them to attain the fully purified eye; having himself known the two truths, he teaches the two truths to sentient beings; having himself attained liberation, he teaches the Dharma of liberation to sentient beings; having himself crossed the boundless river of saṃsāra, he liberates all sentient beings from it as well; having himself become fearless, he teaches fearlessness to sentient beings;

having himself completely passed into nirvāṇa, he reveals great nirvāṇa to sentient beings. For this reason, the buddha, the Blessed One, is called the peerless Teacher.

Now, the word "god" (lha) means "day," for among the gods the days are long and the nights are short — thus they are called gods. Again, "god" means "free from sorrow," for they are always in a state of happiness — thus they are called gods. Again, "god" means "the lamp of light," for having overcome darkness they become great radiance — thus they are called gods. Again, having overcome the dark deeds of unwholesome karma and attained the white deeds of wholesome karma, one is born as a god — thus they are called gods. "God" also means "auspicious," and because of being auspicious they are called gods. Again, "god" means "the sun," for the sun possesses light, and therefore the sun too is called a god. For reasons such as these, the term "god" is used.

The word "human" (mi) means one who reflects deeply on meaning and purpose. Again, "human" means one whose body and speech are gentle and pleasing. Again, "human" means one who is accompanied by pride. And "human" also means one who has overcome pride.

Son of good family, although the buddha, the Blessed One, is the peerless Teacher of all sentient beings, the scriptures speak of him as "the Teacher of gods and humans." Why is this? Because among all sentient beings, it is only gods and humans who are able to arouse the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and who are able to practice the ten virtuous deeds, and thereby attain the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, arhatship, the fruit of pratyekabuddhahood, and unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For this reason, the buddha, the Blessed One, is called the Teacher of gods and humans.

Now, how is it that he is called a buddha? The word "buddha" carries the meaning of perception or discernment: he himself perceives, and he causes others to perceive as well. Son of good family, consider the example of a person in a house who perceives a thief approaching — the thief cannot take hold. Likewise, the bodhisattva, the great being, perceives all the immeasurable afflictions completely, and by perceiving them in this way, none of the afflictions can take hold of him. For this reason he is called a buddha. And because of that perception, he is not born, does not age, does not fall ill, and does not die. For this reason he is called a buddha.

Now, how is he called "the Blessed One"? The word "vanquished" (bcom pa) means to vanquish, and the word "possessed" (ldan pa) here refers to the afflictions. Because he has vanquished all afflictions, he is called the Blessed One. Again, because he is possessed of all virtuous dharmas, because he is supremely skilled in the meaning of all phenomena, because he is possessed of great qualities and is therefore unassailable by others, because his great fame is renowned in all ten directions, because he has bestowed gifts of many kinds, and because throughout countless and immeasurable aeons he cast aside the feminine faculties as though they were vomit — for all these reasons he is called the Blessed One.

Son of good family, if any man or woman cultivates recollection of the buddha in this manner — whether walking, standing, sitting, lying down, in light or in darkness — they will never be separated from seeing the buddha, day and

night, at all times.

Son of good family, why is it that from "Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha" all the way through "Blessed One," he is endowed with such boundless qualities and such great renown? Son of good family, it is because the bodhisattva, the great being, throughout immeasurable, innumerable aeons in the past, served and honored his parents, preceptors, teachers, spiritual masters, and superiors; and throughout immeasurable, innumerable aeons, for the sake of sentient beings, he gave gifts, guarded moral discipline, cultivated patience, applied diligence, rested in meditative concentration, attended carefully to wisdom, and devoted himself earnestly to great loving-kindness, great compassion, great joy, and great equanimity. It is for these reasons that he attained the thirty-two major marks, the eighty excellent minor marks, and a body like a vajra.

Furthermore, throughout immeasurable, innumerable aeons in the past, the bodhisattva diligently cultivated the faculties of faith, diligence, mindfulness, meditative absorption, and wisdom, and served and honored his teachers and spiritual masters — and this was done solely for the sake of the Dharma, not out of desire for food or gain.

If a bodhisattva takes up the twelve branches of scripture and then recites or chants them, it is always for the sake of liberating all sentient beings completely and bringing them to perfect happiness, and not for his own sake. Why is this? Because the bodhisattva always cultivates a mind that has transcended the world, a mind of renunciation, an unconditioned mind, a mind free of contention, a mind free of defilement, a mind free of bondage, a mind free of attachment, a mind free of obscuration, a mind that withholds nothing from the teachings, a mind free of cyclic wandering, a mind free of the net of doubt, a mind free of desire, a mind free of aversion, a mind free of delusion, a mind free of pride, a mind free of turbidity, a mind free of mental affliction, a mind free of suffering, a mind that is immeasurable, a mind that is vast, a mind like space, a mind of nothingness, a mind that is not nothing either, a tamed mind, a mind that does not weary, a mind that conceals nothing, a mind that is not of the world, a mind in constant meditative absorption, a mind of constant diligent application, a mind of constant liberation, a mind free of expectation, a mind without aspiration, a mind utterly without longing, a mind that does not assert, a mind that is yielding and content, a mind that does not abide, a mind that exercises mastery, a mind free of defilements, a mind of

ultimate truth, an irreversible mind, a mind of impermanence, a correct mind, a mind free of deceit and cunning, a virtuous mind, a mind with no surplus and no deficiency, a mind free of interruption, a mind that is not like an inflated vessel, a mind not like that of a śrāvaka, a mind not like that of a pratyekabuddha, a mind of thorough understanding, a mind that knows the elements, a mind that knows the arising of the elements, a mind that knows how to abide within the elements, and a mind that knows how to exercise mastery over the elements. Through diligent cultivation of such a mind, he attained the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, the meditative absorption of great compassion, and the qualities of permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity.

This is why he is designated from "Tathāgata" all the way through "Blessed One." And thus is what is called the mindful recollection of the buddha by the bodhisattva, the great being.

Now, how does the bodhisattva, the great being, practice the mindful recollection of the Dharma? Son of good family, the bodhisattva, the great being, attends in mind to the Dharma taught by the Blessed One, the buddha, in the following way. The Dharma taught by the Blessed One is supreme and most excellent, and through practicing in accordance with the Dharma, even ordinary beings come to directly attain its fruit. This sacred Dharma alone is timeless and beyond measure, for it is seen with the eye of Dharma —

not seen with the eye of flesh. It is incomparable and cannot be likened to any example or analogy. It is unborn, unarisen, non-abiding, unceasing, without beginning, without end, unconditioned, and incalculable. It is the abode of those who have no abode, the support of those who have no support, the light of those who have no light. It liberates those who have not yet reached the other shore. It is the fragrance where there is no fragrance. It is without obstruction. It is seen as something that cannot be gazed upon directly. It is unmoving and unchanging, neither far nor near. Though all happiness is cut away, it has reached the ultimate of supreme bliss. It is neither form, nor the cessation of form, nor yet form — and so too from form all the way through to consciousness: it is neither consciousness, nor the cessation of consciousness, nor anything up to and including consciousness. It is not karma, nor is it apart from the cessation of karma. It is not affliction, nor is it the non-severance of affliction, nor yet affliction. It is not a thing, nor the severance of a thing, nor yet a thing. It is not an element, nor the severance of an element, nor yet an element. It is not existence, nor the severance of existence, nor yet existence.

It is not a sense base, nor the severance of a sense base, nor yet a sense base. It is not a cause, nor the severance of a cause, nor yet a cause. It is not a result, nor the severance of a result, nor yet a result. It is not the false, nor is it the severance of all falsity, nor yet the false. It is not the true, nor the severance of all truth, nor yet the true. It is not arising, not cessation, and with arising and cessation entirely cut away, it is not even cessation. It is not a sign, nor is it the absence of a sign; with all signs entirely cut away, it is not even a sign. It shows nothing, yet it does not refrain from showing; with all showing entirely cut away, it is not even showing. It is not fearful, not pleasant; with all fear entirely cut away, it is not even pleasant. It is not to be endured, not to be unendured; with all that cannot be endured entirely cut away, it is not even endurance. It is not calm abiding, nor is it the absence of calm abiding; with all calm abiding entirely cut away, it is not even calm abiding. It has arrived at the summit of all phenomena. It utterly severs all mental afflictions. It is completely pure, signless, and thoroughly liberated from signs. It has become the abode that reaches unto the limitless ends of all sentient beings. It extinguishes all the blazing fires of saṃsāra. It is the sphere in which buddhas take their sport. Such is the Dharma contemplated with a mind that is steady and unchanging. This is called the mindful recollection of the Dharma by the bodhisattva.

Now, how does the bodhisattva practice the mindful recollection of the Saṅgha? The noble Saṅgha of the buddhas abides in accordance with the Dharma, holds the authentic Dharma, practices in full accord with the path of yoga, cannot be gazed upon directly, cannot be grasped, cannot be destroyed, cannot be harmed, and is beyond all conceptual comprehension. It has become the field of merit for all sentient beings, and yet though it is a field of merit, there is nothing to be appropriated from it. It is completely pure, free from turbidity, free from defilement, unconditioned, vast, and boundless. The mind is thoroughly tamed, perfectly even, non-dual, without sorrow, steady, and unchanging. This is called the mindful recollection of the Saṅgha.

Now, how does the bodhisattva practice the mindful recollection of the training precepts? The bodhisattva, attending to the fact that there is moral discipline, is without fear, without fault, unimpaired, and unmixed. Though without form, it is supremely well-guarded. Though there is no tangible object, it is through most skillful means that full ordination is bestowed. It is free from the fault of transgression, praised and extolled by buddhas and bodhisattvas, most extensive, and the cause of great and complete nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider these examples: the great earth, a boat, an island, a great mountain, the ocean, a clay vessel, a house, a sword, a bridge, a skilled physician, and excellent medicine —

an ointment, a wish-fulfilling jewel, limbs, eyes, parents, and a shadow — these are things that can never be seized away. They cannot be harmed, cannot be burned by fire, cannot be swept away by water. They are like steps for climbing a great high mountain, and like the victory banner of the precious and supreme Dharma of the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Abiding in that moral discipline, I would indeed have the fortune to attain the fruit of stream-entry, yet I do not wish for it. Why is that? Were I to attain the fruit of stream-entry, I would be unable to work extensively for the benefit of all sentient beings. However, I do have the fortune to attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening by abiding in moral discipline, and that I do wish for. Why is that? If unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening is attained, one will be able to teach the supreme Dharma extensively to all sentient beings and become a refuge and protector for them. This, then, is what is called the recollection of moral discipline by a bodhisattva, a great being.

Now, how is it that a bodhisattva recollects generosity? When a bodhisattva, a great being, examines carefully, generosity is the cause of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Since the buddhas and bodhisattvas apply themselves diligently and with great dedication to generosity, I too shall apply myself to it with great diligence and dedication. If generosity is not practiced, one will not enter into the stream of the fourfold retinue. By practicing generosity, even though the afflictions are not yet entirely severed, the afflictions of the present moment will be overcome. Through the cause and condition of having practiced generosity, all sentient beings throughout the immeasurable and boundless world-realms of the ten directions — as many as the grains of sand in countless Ganges rivers — will continuously praise and extol one. When a bodhisattva, a great being, gives food to sentient beings, it is giving them life; and as the fruit thereof, at the time of full awakening one will abide in a permanent, unchanging state. By giving happiness, at the time of full awakening one will attain supreme bliss. When a bodhisattva gives through generosity, whatever is obtained is obtained in accordance with the Dharma and causes no harm to others; therefore at the time of full awakening one will attain perfectly pure nirvāṇa. When a bodhisattva gives through generosity, what is obtained is obtained without being solicited by sentient

beings; therefore at the time of full awakening one will attain what is called sovereign lordship. Through the condition of having given generously, adversaries become endowed with power; therefore at the time of full awakening one will attain the ten powers. Through the condition of having given generously, adversaries become endowed with eloquence in speech; therefore at the time of full awakening one will attain the four thorough analytical knowledges. Since the buddhas and bodhisattvas, by practicing generosity, make it the cause of complete nirvāṇa, I too shall strive diligently in generosity and make it the cause of nirvāṇa. This is explained in detail in the text called Assorted Flowers.

Now, how is it that one recollects the gods? There are realms extending from the abode of the gods of the four great kings up to the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. One who has faith in the gods of the four great kings has the fortune to be reborn there. Yet although I too, through learning, generosity, and wisdom, have the fortune to attain any state from the gods of the four great kings up through the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, I do not wish for it. Why is that? All states from the gods of the four great kings up through the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception are impermanent. Being impermanent, they involve birth, aging, sickness, and death. Therefore I do not wish for them.

It is like this. As an example, an illusion deceives foolish people, but the wise and discerning are neither attached to it nor deceived by it. An illusion is like the states ranging from the gods of the four great kings up through the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. The foolish are like all childish and lowly beings. I myself am not like those foolish ordinary beings. For I have heard of old that the ultimate gods — buddhas and bodhisattvas — are permanent, unborn, unaging, unsick, and undying. For the sake of all sentient beings, I seek the ultimate gods. Why is that? The ultimate gods completely sever the afflictions of sentient beings, like a wish-fulfilling tree. If I possess everything from faith through wisdom, I will attain the ultimate gods, and I will also teach and expound the ultimate gods extensively to all sentient beings. These are called the recollection of gods by a bodhisattva, a great being.

Noble son, thus a bodhisattva, a great being, is not worldly; worldly beings do not know, do not see, and do not understand — it is the bodhisattva who knows, sees, and understands. Noble son, it would not be right to say that reciting, proclaiming, holding, retaining, and copying into a book the twelve

branches of scripture from my attendant's collection, and teaching and expounding them extensively to others, is comparable to reciting, reading, holding, retaining, copying into a book, and teaching and expounding extensively to others this Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra. Why is that? Noble son, the Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra is the profound import of the intention of all buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Because it is the profound import of the intention of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, it is supremely excellent. Noble son, therefore the Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra is wondrous and extraordinary — inconceivable.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: I too think of this Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra as wondrous and extraordinary — inconceivable. I think that the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are also inconceivable. I think that the awakening of a bodhisattva and the Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra are also inconceivable. Blessed One, for what reason did you say that a bodhisattva too is inconceivable?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, without having been taught by anyone, generates the awakening mind on his own. Having thus generated it, practicing with the utmost diligence, even if a great fire were to engulf his body and head, he would sustain the recollection of Dharma and would not extinguish the fire. Why is that? The bodhisattva, the great being, always thinks thus: For immeasurable and incalculable eons I have cycled through the births of hell-beings, hungry ghosts, and animals, and among gods and humans, burning all the while in the fire of afflictions — and yet I have certainly not attained even a single Dharma of certainty. The Dharma of certainty means unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening I do not begrudge even slightly this body and this life. For the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, even if this body were to be ground to the finest dust, I will not give up practicing with diligence. Why is that?

The mind of diligence becomes the cause of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Noble child, it is thus: even before attaining unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, a bodhisattva does not begrudge body and life — so what need is there to speak of after attaining it? Therefore a bodhisattva is inconceivable.

Furthermore, what is called "inconceivable" is this: the great bodhisattva's seeing of the measureless faults of saṃsāra is something that śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not realize. And yet, even though that bodhisattva sees

the measureless faults of saṃsāra, for the sake of sentient beings he does not grow weary of fully experiencing suffering. Therefore he is called inconceivable. Even though the great bodhisattva experiences many sufferings in the hell realms for the sake of sentient beings, it is to him as the bliss of the third meditative concentration (dhyāna). Therefore he is inconceivable.

Noble child, consider this example: if a householder's home catches fire, he comes out from that house. But if his children are left inside and have not escaped the fire, then that householder, even knowing with certainty that he will be burned by the flames, will enter back into that house for the sake of rescuing his children. The great bodhisattva is just like that: even knowing that there are many defects and faults in saṃsāra, for the sake of sentient beings he does not grow weary of dwelling in saṃsāra. Therefore he is inconceivable.

Noble child, countless sentient beings arouse the awakening mind and yet, seeing the many faults of saṃsāra, turn back from that mind. Some become śrāvakas; some become pratyekabuddhas. But if a bodhisattva hears this sūtra, he will not turn back from the awakening mind; it is impossible for him to become a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha. And so, even without having attained the first unshakeable ground (bhūmi), his mind becomes extremely stable. Because he does not turn back, he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, suppose a person were to say: "I am able to swim across this great ocean." Would those words be inconceivable? The Blessed One replied: those words are both conceivable and inconceivable. Why is that? If a person were to swim and actually reach the other shore, that would be inconceivable. But if an asura were to swim and reach the other shore, that would be conceivable. Noble child, in this context it applies only to a human being, not to an asura. Blessed One, among humans too there are both the inconceivable and the conceivable. Blessed One, among humans there are two kinds: noble ones (āryas) and foolish ordinary people. If one speaks of a foolish ordinary person, it is inconceivable. If one speaks of a noble one, it is conceivable. Noble child, in this context I am speaking of the foolish ordinary person, not of the noble one. Blessed One, why is it inconceivable when it concerns a foolish ordinary person? Noble child, because a foolish ordinary person cannot in reality swim and reach the far shore of a great ocean. But the great bodhisattva truly crosses to the far shore of the ocean of saṃsāra. Therefore he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, suppose someone were to lift Mount Meru with the stalk of a lotus and hurl it into the sky — would that be inconceivable? The answer was: No, Blessed One, it would not be. The Blessed One then declared: Noble child, the great bodhisattva measuring and fathoming all of saṃsāra in a single instant and moment — that is what is called inconceivable.

Noble child, the great bodhisattva, for immeasurable and incalculable eons, recognizes saṃsāra to be impermanent, without self, without happiness, and impure — and yet he teaches and expounds to sentient beings permanence, happiness, the existence of self, and purity in abundant detail. And although he teaches and expounds in this way, because he does not thereby hold a wrong view, he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, suppose someone were to leap into water and yet not be carried away by it, or leap into a great fire and yet not be burned by it — that would be called inconceivable. In the same way, the great bodhisattva dwells within saṃsāra and yet is not harmed by saṃsāra; therefore he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, consider this: among human beings there are three kinds — the lowest, the middling, and the highest. Among humans, the lowest, while still in the womb, thinks to himself: "I am dwelling in a pit, or in a foul place, or among corpses, or upon a heap of thorns, or in darkness." And when he emerges from the womb, he likewise thinks: "Now I have come out of a pit, a foul place, or a place of great darkness." Among humans, the middling, while in the womb in his suffering, thinks to himself: "I am dwelling in a grove of trees, or in a clear stream, or in a fine house." And when he is born, he thinks the same. Among humans, the highest, even while dwelling in the womb, thinks: "I am riding upon a fine upper floor, or in a pleasure garden, or mounted on a horse, an ox, or an elephant, ascending a great mountain." And when he is born, he thinks the same.

The great bodhisattva, from the very first moment of entering the womb, knows that he is entering; while dwelling in the womb, he knows that he is dwelling there; and when he comes forth, he knows that he has come forth. And although thoughts of attachment and aversion never arise in him at all, he does not abide on the grounds — therefore he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, unsurpassed perfect awakening (Skt. anuttarasamyaksambodhi) has no adequate analogy. Noble child, even mind is not something that can easily be compared, illustrated by analogy, or expressed in words. The great

bodhisattva has attained unsurpassed perfect awakening even without a teacher in the role of preceptor and a student in the role of disciple. Having heard these teachings, he teaches and expounds them perpetually to sentient beings with a mind free of fear — therefore he is called inconceivable.

Noble child, the great bodhisattva: there is one who thoroughly abandons with the body but not with speech; one who thoroughly abandons with speech but not with the body; and one who thoroughly abandons with neither body nor speech. What is called thoroughly abandoning with the body? Taking life, taking what is not given, and engaging in sexual misconduct — these are abandoned with the body, not with speech. What is thoroughly abandoning with speech? Lying, slander, harsh words, and idle chatter — these are abandoned with speech, not with the body. What is thoroughly abandoning with neither body nor speech? Attachment, aversion, and wrong view — this is the thorough abandonment that is neither bodily nor verbal. Noble child, this is called thoroughly abandoning what belongs neither to body nor to speech.

Noble child, the great bodhisattva does not regard the thorough abandonment of even a single thing as being accomplished through the body, through action, or through a possessing agent — and yet there is thorough abandonment. Therefore he is called inconceivable. The same should be understood regarding speech.

Noble child, the abandonment of bodily things through the body —

— speech abandoned through speech. But the thorough abandonment by wisdom is neither bodily nor verbal. Noble child, in truth, these wisdoms will not be abandoned by the bodhisattva. Why is that? Noble child, not even a single phenomenon is destroyed or fabricated, for it is the very nature of conditioned phenomena to arise through differentiation and to cease through differentiation. Therefore this wisdom will not be thoroughly abandoned.

Noble child, wisdom cannot be destroyed, cannot be burned by fire, cannot be soaked by water, cannot be carried off by wind, cannot be seized by earth, cannot be produced by birth, cannot be aged by aging, cannot be established by establishment, cannot be destroyed by destruction, cannot be desired by desire, cannot be stirred to anger by anger, cannot be deluded by delusion — for it arises by the nature of conditioned things and ceases through differentiation.

The great bodhisattva does not think to himself, "My wisdom has vanquished all afflictions." Yet he says, "I have vanquished all afflictions." Even though he

speaks thus, he does not speak falsely. Therefore he is called inconceivable.

The Noble Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra, the twenty-fifth section.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I have from this day forward, for the first time, come to seek the great bodhisattva's inconceivability, the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, the sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the upholding of it, awakening, and the inconceivability of nirvāṇa. Blessed One, for how long do the Dharma-qualities of the unsurpassed buddha abide, and when will they decline?"

Noble child, there are five modes of conduct in relation to this sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa: namely, noble conduct, brahmic conduct, divine conduct, the conduct of the sick, and the conduct of a child.

If any among my attendants is able to uphold, recite, chant, copy, explain the meaning, and honor sentient beings with reverence, esteem, service, praise, and offerings of many kinds — then at that time you should know that the Dharma of the buddha has not declined.

Noble child, if this Parinirvāṇa sūtra spreads widely but at that time many of my attendants have broken their vows of moral discipline, commit many non-virtuous deeds, and have no faith in this sūtra — and because of that lack of faith do not uphold it, recite it, chant it, copy it, or explain its meaning; many people do not revere or honor it; and when they see one who upholds it they disparage him, saying, "You are one who follows the teaching of the six teachers, not a true attendant of the Buddha" — then at that time you should know that the Dharma of the buddha will swiftly decline without long delay.

Again the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I heard the Blessed One directly declare that the Dharma of the buddha Kāśyapa abided in the world for seven days and then declined. Blessed One, did the Tathāgata Kāśyapa possess this sūtra or not? If he possessed it, why did you say it declined? And if he did not possess it, why did you say that the Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra is the secret essence of all the Tathāgatas?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I have said before that this matter is understood by Mañjuśrī alone. I shall say it again — listen well, take it very much to heart, and examine it carefully.

Son of good family, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, possess Dharma of two kinds: conventional and ultimate. The conventional Dharma ceases. The ultimate Dharma neither perishes nor ceases. And this again is of two kinds: that which is impermanent, selfless, without bliss, and without purity; and that which is permanent, blissful, the self, and thoroughly pure. Of these, impermanence, selflessness, the absence of bliss, and the absence of purity are subject to perishing and cessation. Permanence, bliss, the self, and thorough purity are not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: what is held by the two vehicles, and what is held by the bodhisattvas. Of these, what is held by the two vehicles is subject to perishing and cessation. What is held by the bodhisattvas is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: the inner and the outer. Of these, the outer Dharma is subject to perishing and cessation. The inner Dharma is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: the conditioned and the unconditioned. Of these, the conditioned Dharma is subject to perishing and cessation. The unconditioned Dharma is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: that which has an object of reference, and that which has no object of reference. Of these, the Dharma that has an object of reference is subject to perishing and cessation. The Dharma without an object of reference is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: the Dharma that is mixed, and the Dharma that is unmixed. Of these, the mixed Dharma is subject to perishing and cessation. The unmixed Dharma is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: that of the gods, and that of humans. Of these, the human is subject to perishing and cessation. That of the gods is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Again, there are two kinds: the eleven sūtra collections, and the vastly extensive sūtra collection. Of these, the eleven sūtra collections are subject to perishing and cessation. The vastly extensive sūtra collection is not subject to perishing or cessation.

Son of good family, if any attendant of mine holds, recites, proclaims, copies in writing, explains, and pays reverence, honor, and worship to this vastly extensive sūtra collection, then you should know that at that time the Dharma

of the buddha has not declined.

Son of good family, you asked before whether the Tathāgata Kāśyapa possessed this sūtra. Son of good family, the Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra is the secret essence taught through the intention of all the Tathāgatas. Why is that? Although the Tathāgatas possessed the eleven sūtra collections, if through those collections the intrinsic nature of a buddha — the permanence, bliss, the self, and the thorough purity of the Tathāgata — were not proclaimed, then the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, would never pass beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa at all. Therefore this sūtra is called the secret essence taught through the intention of the Tathāgatas. Because it is what is not proclaimed in the eleven sūtra collections, it is called the essence — just as, because the seven precious treasures are not used openly in the world, they are called a treasure. Son of good family, the person accumulates and hides them as a treasure for use in the future: for such future needs as a famine in grain, the arrival of enemies in one's land, encountering a wicked king and having one's life deceived away, meeting with distress while traveling abroad, or a time of scarcity of wealth — at that point one brings it forth and makes use of it.

Son of good family, the essence taught through the intention of the Tathāgatas is likewise similar. In the future, degenerate monks, bearing the implements of the holy life without proper examination —"

— teaching to the fourfold retinue that the Tathāgata passes utterly into nirvāṇa without remainder, reciting and proclaiming the worldly arts, showing disrespect toward the scriptures of the Buddha — when such evil things as these arise in the world, the Tathāgata, in order to put an end to those evils and to cause beings to abandon wrong livelihoods, wrong gains, and wrong renown, taught this sūtra.

If the essence taught through the intention of this sūtra should decline and disappear from sight, then understand that the Dharma of the Buddha will also have declined.

Son of good family, if the Great Sūtra of the Parinirvāṇa is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting, why then would one ask the Blessed One Kāśyapa whether this sūtra exists? Son of good family, the sentient beings of the age of the Blessed One Kāśyapa had thin attachment and were endowed with wisdom. They were peaceful, tamed, easy to discipline, and possessed of great dignity. Their unforgetting dhāraṇī was like the finest herd of a white bull elephant. Their world-realm was utterly pure. Since all sentient beings knew

that the Tathāgata does not pass wholly into nirvāṇa without remainder at the final end but abides forever, unchanging and unshifting, there was no need to preach or explain this sūtra, even while it existed.

Son of good family, the sentient beings of the present age are numerous in afflictions and great in delusion; they are forgetful and without wisdom, filled with doubts, unable to maintain the root of faith, their world-realm impure. All sentient beings say this: "The Tathāgata is impermanent, subject to change and shift — he has passed utterly into nirvāṇa without remainder at the final end." For this reason the Tathāgata taught this sūtra.

Son of good family, the Dharma of the Buddha Kāśyapa has not truly declined. Why is that? Because it is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting.

Son of good family, suppose there are sentient beings who view that which has a self as having no self, or view that which has no self as having a self; who view the permanent as impermanent, or view the impermanent as permanent; who view happiness as suffering, or view suffering as happiness; who view the utterly pure as impure, or view the impure as utterly pure; who view the non-cessation as cessation, or view the cessation as non-cessation; who view the sinful as non-sinful, or view the non-sinful as sinful; who view a light sin as a heavy one, or view a heavy sin as a light one; who view what is a vehicle as not a vehicle, or view what is not a vehicle as a vehicle; who view what is a path as not a path, or view what is not a path as a path; who view true awakening as not awakening, or view what is not awakening as awakening; who view suffering as not suffering, or view what is not suffering as suffering; who view the origin of suffering as not being the origin, or view cessation as not being cessation; who view what is true as not true; who view the conventional as ultimate, or view the ultimate as merely conventional; who view going for refuge as not going for refuge, or view what is not going for refuge as going for refuge; who call the genuine word of the Buddha the word of Māra, or call the genuine word of Māra the word of the Buddha — it is at such a time as this that the Tathāgatas proclaim this sūtra of the Parinirvāṇa from the very beginning.

Noble son, it would be better to say that a mosquito's proboscis has reached, without exception, to the very bottom of the ocean, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that a violent gale can be bound with a noose, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that Mount Meru, king of mountains,

can be shattered and scattered by the breath of one's mouth, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that a lotus flower has grown inside a blazing fire, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that the medicine agada has turned to poison, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that the moon is hot and the sun is cool, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined. It would be better to say that the four great elements have abandoned their respective natures, than to say that the Dharma of the Tathāgata has declined.

Noble son, if, from the very moment that a Tathāgata first appears and attains the unsurpassed, perfect awakening of an arhat — that is to say, fully and perfectly realized awakening — he passes into complete nirvāṇa without having attendants who understand the profound meaning, you should know that the Dharma will not abide long in the world. Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains that unsurpassed, perfectly realized awakening he does have attendants who understand the profound meaning, then even after the Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will long remain in the world. Furthermore, noble son, even if there are such attendants who understand the profound meaning, yet if the Tathāgata passes into complete nirvāṇa without there being faithful laypeople — laymen (upāsakas) who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence — you should know that the Dharma will not long remain in the world. Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains that awakening there are both attendants who understand the profound meaning and faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence, then even after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, the Dharma will long remain in the world. Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains that awakening there are both attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha, yet those attendants teach and expound the profound sūtras not for the sake of nirvāṇa but for the sake of gain and renown, then after the Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will not long remain in the world. Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains that awakening there are both attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with

reverence, and those attendants teach and explain not for the sake of gain and renown but for the sake of seeking nirvāṇa, then even after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will long remain in the world. Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains that awakening there are attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence, yet those attendants disparage one another greatly and quarrel frequently —

then even after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will not long remain in the world.

Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains unsurpassed, perfect awakening as an arhat there are attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence, and those attendants live in harmony, do not disparage one another, and show one another respect — then even after the Tathāgata has passed completely into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will long remain in the world.

Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains unsurpassed, perfect awakening as an arhat there are attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, laymen who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence, and those attendants teach the Dharma for the sake of great nirvāṇa and show one another reverence without quarrelling — yet they grasp at things that have not been properly examined, and moreover proclaim of themselves, "I have attained everything from the fruit of stream-entry up to the fruit of arhatship" — then when the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will not long remain in the world.

Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains unsurpassed, perfect awakening as an arhat there are attendants who understand the profound meaning and greatly faithful laypeople, householders who honour the Dharma of the Buddha with reverence, and those attendants too, for the sake of great nirvāṇa, teach the sūtras and the like, live in harmony, show one another reverence and respect, do not grasp at any things that have not been properly examined, and do not say "I myself have attained the fruit of stream-entry" or even "I have attained up to the fruit of arhatship" — then even though the Blessed One, the Buddha, has passed

completely into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will long remain in the world.

Furthermore, noble son, if from the very moment a Tathāgata first appears and attains unsurpassed, perfect awakening as an arhat the attendants do not claim anything ranging from understanding the profound meaning to having attained arhatship, yet each on his own grasps a separate view and expounds various and sundry divergent positions — and moreover, the venerable ones, even though the Blessed One established everything from the four weighty rules up to the seven rules for settling disputes, along with vows and qualifying exceptions for the sake of sentient beings, and likewise the twelve branches of scriptural teaching — yet say, "I alone understand this matter, having heard it from the Blessed One; you do not understand it. I alone know the Vinaya; you do not know it. I alone know the sūtras; you do not know them" — then when the Blessed One, the Buddha, has passed completely into nirvāṇa, you should know that the Dharma will not long remain in the world.

Noble son, consider the analogy of a skilled physician who both prescribes and withholds milk for patients: for a patient with a bile disorder he prescribes milk, while for a patient with a phlegm disorder he withholds it. In the same way, the Tathāgata, perceiving the root of sentient beings' afflictions, both permits and prohibits. The venerable ones, having heard this matter from the Blessed One in the following way — and so various vows and qualifying exceptions exist for sentient beings, and likewise the twelve branches are similar in that regard — the Blessed One, knowing that the places and times differ and the faculties of sentient beings vary between sharp and dull, therefore in some cases the Tathāgata restricted, and in other cases permitted, and proclaimed both the weighty and the light.

Furthermore, son of good family, as soon as the Tathāgata had first appeared and attained the unsurpassed, perfect awakening of an arhat, the attendants would not say "I have attained stream-entry" through to "I have attained arhatship." And they would not say "The awakened ones, the Blessed Ones, for the sake of sentient beings, prohibited this and permitted that." But the venerable ones would say: "I have heard from the Blessed One this matter, this teaching, and this Vinaya in the following way; let the venerable ones uphold the twelve branches of the Tathāgata's sūtras. If this matter is indeed so, I shall accept it; if it is not so, I shall set it aside." Knowing this, one should understand that even after that awakened Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa, the Dharma will remain in the world for a long time.

Son of good family, at the time when my Dharma is approaching its final decline, the attendants among the hearers will sometimes teach that consciousness exists, and sometimes that consciousness is empty. Sometimes they will teach that an intermediate state between death and rebirth exists, and sometimes that there is no such intermediate state. Sometimes they will teach that the three times exist, and sometimes that the three times do not exist. Sometimes they will teach that the three vehicles exist, and sometimes that the three vehicles do not exist. Sometimes they will teach that all things exist, and sometimes that nothing exists. Sometimes they will teach that sentient beings have a beginning and an end, and sometimes that sentient beings have no beginning and no end. Sometimes they will teach that the twelve links of dependent origination are conditioned phenomena, and sometimes that the twelve links of dependent origination are not conditioned phenomena. Sometimes they will teach that the Tathāgata is subject to the suffering of illness, and sometimes that the Tathāgata is not subject to the suffering of illness. Sometimes they will teach that the Tathāgata did not permit monks to eat ten kinds of meat. What are these ten? Human flesh, snake, wild bull, horse, donkey, dog, lion, pig, fox, and monkey — and that all other meats were permitted. And sometimes they will teach that none whatsoever were permitted. Sometimes they will teach that the Tathāgata did not permit monks to engage in trade in five kinds of things. What are these five? Persons, weapons, alcohol, curds, and grain oil — and that all other things were permitted. Sometimes they will teach that monks were not permitted to go to five kinds of places. What are these five? The butcher's quarter, the snake-seller's quarter, the wine-seller's quarter, the royal palace, and the household of low caste — and that going to other places was permitted. Sometimes they will teach that monks were not permitted to wear woollen robes of the type called kauśeya, while all other garments were permitted. Sometimes they will teach that the Tathāgata permitted monks to keep in store ten hundred thousand gold śrāṅg weight in cloth, food, and bedding, and sometimes that he did not permit this. Sometimes they will teach that nirvāṇa is permanent, blissful, a self, and utterly pure. And sometimes they will teach that nirvāṇa is not the exhaustion of all afflictions, but rather that no other phenomenon exists that can be called nirvāṇa — just as when threads are woven together it is called a garment, and when the garment wears away it is called "no garment," yet there is no separate phenomenon called "no garment" — and that the defining characteristic of nirvāṇa is

likewise similar to this.

Son of good family, at that time and in that age, those among my attendants who teach correctly will be few, and those who teach incorrectly will be many. Those who hold to the true Dharma will be few, and those who hold to a false Dharma will be many. Those who hold to the word of the Buddha will be few, and those who hold to the word of Māra will be many.

Son of good family, at that time there will be in the land of Kauśāmbī two attendants: one will be an arhat, and one will be a monk whose moral discipline is broken. The following of the monk with broken discipline will number five hundred, and the following of the arhat will number one hundred.

The monk with broken discipline declared that the Tathāgata had passed fully into nirvāṇa. "I have heard this matter directly from the Blessed One: whether a Tathāgata has been ordained with the four root precepts or not, if they are broken there is no fault. Even I have now attained the fruit of arhatship and the four kinds of unobstructed wisdom, and yet this very arhat has broken those four root precepts." That an arhat should violate all four of those root principles of Dharma and commit such evil was a wholly unworthy thing for an arhat to say.

When the Tathāgata was present in the world, he declared: "Hold firmly to restraint." After his final passing into nirvāṇa, they say: "Abandon everything." Concerning this, the monks led by the arhat said: "Venerable ones, to say that the Tathāgata has finally passed into nirvāṇa is an unworthy thing to say. We know that the Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and unaltered. Whether the Tathāgata is present in the world or has passed into nirvāṇa, the evil of breaking the four root precepts is equally grave. Therefore it is not fitting to say that an arhat has broken the four roots. Why? If even a stream-enterer does not violate the vows, what need is there to speak of an arhat? If you, venerable ones, say that one has attained the fruit of arhatship, then an arhat does not give rise to the perception of 'I am an arhat.' An arhat teaches only what is virtuous and does not teach what is non-virtuous. Everything that you, venerable ones, have taught is nothing but non-Dharma. Anyone who sees all twelve classes of scripture will know with certainty that those venerable ones are not arhats."

At that time, the followers of the monk with broken discipline took the life of that arhat. And at that time, the evil māra stirred the two factions of the Saṅgha into anger and strife, and in that moment he sorely afflicted those six

hundred monks. Then base and lowly people, speaking here and there, exclaimed with wonder: "The Dharma of the Buddha has declined and is finished!" But in truth, my holy Dharma has not declined. For at that time in that land, one hundred and twenty thousand great bodhisattvas were upholding my Dharma most steadfastly — how then could my Dharma be said to have declined?

Yet at that time, in that age, there was not a single monk in Jambudvīpa who had become my attendant, and so the evil māra with his great fire burned all the sūtras. Whatever remained was stolen by brahmins, who extracted it into summaries and presented it as their own scripture. Thus, before the arising of a new buddha, lesser bodhisattvas drew one another away and became devoted to and attached to the words of brahmins. The brahmins declared, "We possess the Vinaya (monastic discipline)," but in truth the Vinaya does not exist among non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Though the tīrthikas claim to possess a self, bliss, and complete purity, in truth they do not know the meaning of self, bliss, and purity. They took one syllable, two syllables, one word, two words from the Buddha's Dharma and, presenting them, said, "Our scriptures contain meanings such as these."

Then at that time, in the city of Kuśinagārī, at the foot of the śāla trees, a vast and immeasurable assembly heard these words being spoken, and all of them cried out: "The world is empty! The world is empty!"

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then spoke to that great assembly: "Venerable ones, do not weep and be disheartened. The world is not empty, the Tathāgata does not change, does not shift, but abides forever; and so too with the Dharma and the Saṅgha, it is the same."

Then that great assembly, having heard these words spoken, cried out in lamentation and aroused the mind set upon the highest, perfect, and complete awakening.

At that time in Rājagṛha there was a king known as Ajātaśatru. By nature he was wrathful and fierce, delighting in taking the lives of sentient beings, committing in full the four non-virtuous deeds of speech, deeply given over to minds of attachment, aversion, and delusion, seeing only the present moment and blind to the future, relying upon a deeply corrupt retinue, and, clinging through attachment to the five objects of desire of the present, he slew his own father, a man without fault.

Having killed his father thus, remorse arose in his mind, and tormented by grief he cast off his bodily ornaments and his music. Wracked by that mind of remorse, great boils broke out all over his body. The boils were so painful that they were unbearable to the touch, and he thought to himself: "My karma will ripen before long, and the ripening of a hell-being's karma is not far off." Such was his thought.

Then all the physicians of King Ajātaśatru anointed him with medicines of every variety, yet the boils only spread further outward and brought no relief. The king said to his mother: "These boils have arisen from the intention of my mind, not from the four great elements; therefore, there is no remedy by which any being could cure them."

Now at that time a great minister named Sunīdha came to where the king was, and standing to one side spoke these words: "Great King, if your body and mind have become uncomfortable and distressed, tell me — why do you sit thus with a darkened expression, grieving?"

The king said: "How could there be any ease for my body and mind? I have slain my father who was without fault. I had previously heard from wise men that one who commits the five acts of immediate consequence (ānantarya) in the world has no time of liberation from the hell-beings — and having heard that, I have committed boundless, immeasurable, countless transgressions. Since there is no skilled physician who can heal my ailing body and mind, how can there be any ease for body or mind?"

The minister then spoke in verse to say: "Great King, do not give way to excessive grief."

One who dwells always in sorrow
will return again and again to sorrow.
Just as one who loves sleep greatly
will return to sleep ever more deeply,
so too know that attachment and craving,
and great love of drink, are the same.

"As the king has said, it is told that one who commits the five acts of immediate consequence in the world has no time of liberation from the hell-beings — but who has actually experienced and witnessed this, and then reported it as fact to the king? As for what is called 'hell-beings,' it is simply a great many knowledgeable people in the world who have spread that as a saying of their own devising. And as for the king's saying that there is no

skilled physician in the world to heal body and mind — that is not appropriate. At this very moment there is a great physician named Kāśyapa Paripūraka, one who is omniscient, who sees all things, who has attained meditative absorption of sovereign mastery, who has reached the ultimate end of fully pure holy conduct, and who shows to immeasurable and boundless sentient beings the unsurpassable path to nirvāṇa. He is even now teaching the Dharma to those nearby in these words: 'There is no dark karma, and there is no ripening of dark karma; there is no purely white karma, and there is no ripening of purely white karma.

There is neither mixed white-and-dark karma nor a ripening of mixed white-and-dark karma; there is no karma that is supreme, and there is no karma that is inferior.' Such is the teaching of that master of the Dharma who is even now residing in Rājagṛha. Go to that great king's presence. That master will heal both body and mind."

The king spoke: "If the words you have spoken are true and he is truly able to cleanse me of wrongdoing in that way, then I shall go for refuge to him."

Then another minister, one named Essence-Attained, came before the king and spoke these words: "Great King, why has your face gone dark, your mouth dry, your body trembling as though an unprepared soldier who encounters an enemy quivers faintly, and your complexion utterly drained? What has brought you such distress? Is it an illness of the body, or has some affliction come upon the mind?"

The king replied: "What reason do I have not to be sick in body and mind? Benighted by ignorance, lacking the eye of wisdom, I took an unwholesome spiritual friend as my guide, followed in the wake of evil in the manner of one like Devadatta, heeded the words of the wicked, and slew my own father the king — a man innocent of any wrongdoing — though he lived by the true Dharma. I once heard a verse from a learned and wise man of former times, spoken thus:

Whoever, with a mind of ill will
toward their father, their mother,
the buddhas, or those who dwell near them,
performs an act that brings forth evil —
the ripening of that act
is birth in the hell without respite.

For this reason I am utterly terrified, tormented by great suffering, and there is no skilled physician who can heal me."

The minister spoke again: "Great King, do not grieve for the moment. The Dharma has two kinds: the going-forth, and the law of kings. Under the law of kings, slaying one's father may be called an act without respite within this royal domain, yet it does not become a blameworthy sin. For example, there are insects such as the kakala worm that burst through their mother's womb and emerge at birth — it is simply the nature of reality that they are born in this way; though they harm their mother's body, it does not become a sin. The young of deer and other animals are similar. The law of royal sovereignty is likewise by its very nature of this kind, and so a king who slays his father does not thereby incur sin. The law of the going-forth, however, is different: under that law even the killing of a tiny insect in childhood becomes a sin. Therefore, Great King, do not grieve for the moment. And why? Because:

One who constantly gives way to grief
will return again and again to grief.
Just as one who loves sleep
will again fall ever more deeply into sleep —
so too should one understand
great craving and attachment,
and a great fondness for strong drink.

It is not right to say, as the king has said, that there is no skilled physician to heal body and mind. At this very moment there is a great teacher, the son of the brahmin Puṣkarasārin, named Mākandika, who is omniscient, who sees all things, who cherishes all sentient beings as though they were his only child, who has completely abandoned all afflictions, who draws out the poisonous thorns of the three harms from all sentient beings, who alone knows, sees, and realizes all phenomena that all sentient beings do not know, do not see, and do not realize — and he is constantly teaching the Dharma to those nearby in these words: 'The body of every sentient being has seven constituent parts. What are the seven? Earth, water, fire, wind, suffering, pleasure, and the life-force. These seven phenomena are neither emanated nor artificially made, and so they cannot be destroyed. For example, the reed known as íśikā stands eternally and does not move.'"

Mount Meru, the king of mountains, has neither been sent forth nor made by anyone. Just as there is no dispute over whether milk or yogurt is suffering or

pleasure, virtuous or non-virtuous, so too they are not harmed even by a sharp weapon. Why is this? Because the seven constituent elements are empty, they are unobstructed. Life, moreover, cannot be cut. Why is this? There is no killing, no dying, no doing, no experiencing, no explaining, no listening, no understanding, and no teaching.

Constantly proclaiming these teachings, and pacifying all the blameworthy sins of countless sentient beings, that great master currently resides in Rājagṛha. Great King, go to wherever the great master dwells. The mere sight of him will purify all sin.

The king said: If he can truly rid me of my sin in this way, then I shall take refuge in this teaching.

Then another minister, one called Satyadatta, came before the king and addressed him in verse:

Great King, why have you removed all the adornments from your body? Why is your hair upon your head disheveled and bound up so? And why has it come to be like this? Why is the king's body now ill at ease, trembling and shaking, like flowering trees struck violently by the wind?

O King, your face is so deeply clouded and darkened — it is like farmers who have sown their seeds and then grieve when the rains do not fall. But tell me, has this grief arisen in your body or in your mind?

The king said: How could my body and mind possibly be at ease?

Father, the king loved me with the greatest affection and tenderness, and there was no fault of wrongdoing on his part. Yet from the very beginning, when the astrologers were consulted, the astrologers said, "This son of yours, once born, will kill his father" — and though those words were heard, he was nevertheless kept and raised. Then from the wise and learned, I had previously heard it said: "Anyone who lies with his mother in unchaste conduct, or who lies with a nun in unchaste conduct, or who steals the property of the Saṅgha, or who kills one who has aroused the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassed awakening, or who kills his father — such a person will, without any doubt, fall into the avīci hell, the hell of uninterrupted torment." Having heard this, how can my body and mind possibly be at ease?

The great minister spoke: Great King, do not grieve for now. If the killing were of someone earnestly practicing the path of liberation, it would indeed be sinful. But if the killing was for the sake of the king's rule, it does not become a

sin.

Great King, what is not Dharma is called "not Dharma." What is devoid of Dharma is also called "devoid of Dharma" — just as when one has no son, one says "I have no son," and yet when one has a bad son, one also says "I have no son." Thus, though one says "I have no son," in truth it is not the case that there is no son. Or again, just as when there is no salt in a dish, one says "there is no salt," and yet when the salt is not salty, one also says "there is no salt." Or just as when there is no water one says "there is no water," and yet when there is only a little water, one also says "there is no water." Or just as something that ceases from moment to moment is called impermanent, and yet even something that endures for an entire eon is also called impermanent. Or just as when a person experiences suffering one says "there is no happiness," and yet when a person experiences only a slight measure of joy, one also says "there is no happiness." Or just as when one has no power one says "there is no pride," and yet even when one has only a little power, one says "there is no pride." Or just as when night has fallen one says "there is no sun," and yet when the sun is cut off by clouds, one also says "there is no sun."

Great King, even where there exists only a small measure of Dharma, one says "there is no Dharma," and yet in truth it is not that there is no Dharma at all.

Great King, listen to these words I now address to you. In every sentient being there exists what is called residual karma, and through the power of karma they revolve again and again in cyclic existence. If, Great King, your father too possessed this thing called residual karma, then even if the King were to slay him, it would not become a sin.

Great King, for the moment, I pray you put your grief aside. Why is this? Consider:

One who grieves without cease
shall return, and grieve again.
Just as one who loves to sleep
shall return, and sleep the more.
So too with attachment and craving,
and with strong addiction to drink — know it to be the same.

As for what the King has said — that there exists in the world no physician skilled in healing the ailments of body and mind — that cannot rightly be maintained. For at this very moment there dwells in Rājagṛha a great Teacher by the name of Jīvaka, son of Berāta, who is omniscient and all-seeing, whose

wisdom is as profound and vast as the ocean, endowed with great majesty, possessed of great higher knowledge, who draws all sentient beings out from the net of doubt, and who alone knows and sees all phenomena that all sentient beings do not know, do not see, and do not comprehend. He is there right now, residing in Rājagṛha, teaching the Dharma in these very words to his many attendants.

He teaches that among the great multitude of an assembly, if a king of sovereign power were to perform virtuous and sinful actions as he pleased, even if he committed many sins, those sins would not become blameworthy transgressions. For example, when something is consumed by a great fire, there is no question of it being pure or impure — and so too it is with a king. Or consider how the great earth serves as the ground for all things both pure and impure; yet for all that it does, it harbors neither aversion nor delight. So too, Great King, you are like the great earth — there is no such thing as aversion or delight in you. Or as clear water washes both the pure and the impure, and yet holds neither pleasure nor displeasure in doing so, so too, Great King, you are like the water. Or as the wind sweeps through both the pure and the impure, and yet for all it does holds neither pleasure nor displeasure, so too, Great King, you are like the wind. Or consider how when the trees of autumn are cut down, they grow back again in summer — just so, the cutting of those trees does not in truth become a sin. And all sentient beings are like this as well: they pass away from here and are born here again. And because they are born here again, it does not become a sin.

The ripening of the fruits of suffering and happiness for all sentient beings is beyond my control. The karmic ripening of the present moment depends upon causes of the past — there is no ripening in the present moment from a cause of the present moment, and in the future too there will be no ripening of fruit. It is the present fruit itself that is ripening. This is why ordinary people keep moral discipline and undertake diligent effort — it is to reverse the future fruit that would ripen as sin in the present time. Through the keeping of moral discipline one becomes free from defilement. Through freedom from defilement one becomes free from defiled karma. And through the exhaustion of karma, the many sufferings will also be exhausted. Through the exhaustion of the many sufferings, one will be fully liberated.

Go quickly now to that Teacher! Even the illness that causes suffering in body and mind he shall heal, and upon meeting him, your sins too will be completely purified.

The Great King then said: If my sins will indeed be purified in this way, then I shall go to him for refuge.

Then a great minister named Sarvaarthavitta — "Knower of All Matters" — came before the king and spoke these words: Great King, why do you appear downcast and pale like this, without color? You look like a king who has lost his realm, or like a spring that has run dry, or like a pond without lotuses, or like a tree without flowers and leaves, or like a monk who has broken his moral discipline — bereft of splendor. Has your body become afflicted with suffering, or has your mind?

The king replied: How could there be any relief from suffering in my body and mind right now? My father the king loved me with tender affection and was always bringing me every comfort and happiness. Without remembering the kindness of his love for me, I slew my father the king — who was without fault and had done me no wrong. I had previously heard from wise and learned men that if one kills one's father or mother, one will without any doubt experience tremendous suffering for immeasurable aeons. Thus I am certain that before long I shall fall into the Avīci hell — the hell of uninterrupted torment — and there is no refuge that can heal this sin of mine.

The minister replied: Great King, do not grieve for now. Has the king not heard? In former times, a king called Lāmpa killed his father and seized the royal power. And likewise King Bde, King Byilatsina, King Nāhosha, King Kateka, King Byishaka, King Moonlight, King Sunlight, King Luminous, and King Upholder of Many Beings — all of them too killed their fathers and seized royal power, yet not even one of them fell into a hell realm. And kings such as the present King Vaidūrya, King Otana, King Tumpa, King Bya-ba, King Padma, and others — they too killed their fathers and seized royal power, and not one of them grieves over it. Who has ever seen a hell realm, a hungry ghost realm, or a divine realm? Great King, the only two existences that are directly perceptible are the human and the animal. And even those two existences are not born through cause and condition, nor do they die through cause and condition. Since there is no cause and condition in this way, how could there be anything such as virtue and sin? Great King, do not grieve. Why? Consider this verse:

One who is always given to grief
will return again to grief and be reborn into it.
Just as one who is fond of sleep

will in return fall into ever greater sleep —
so too with attachment, craving, and desire,
and with one's fondness for drink: know it to be just the same.

Now, as for what you said, O King — that there is no skilled physician in this world who can heal the illness of body and mind — that is not so. There is at present a great Teacher, the son of Kātyāyana, named Nirgrantha, who is omniscient, who sees all, who is like the great earth, who makes no distinction between gold and mere soil, who holds on his right side a sandal-wood smeared cord and on his left side a stone club and weapons, and yet makes no distinction between the two, whose mind is equal toward both the beloved and the hostile — a true Teacher and skilled physician of the world. Whether he is walking, sitting, dwelling, or lying down, he always holds his mind in meditative absorption without disturbance. That great unperturbed Teacher is right now teaching the Dharma to many attendants in words such as these: Whether I myself have done it, or caused another to do it; whether I myself have killed, or caused another to kill; whether I myself have burned, or caused another to burn; whether I myself have harmed, or caused another to harm; whether I myself have stolen, or caused another to steal; whether I myself have engaged in sexual misconduct, or caused another to do so —

Whether I myself have spoken falsely, or caused another to speak falsely; whether I myself have drunk intoxicants, or caused another to drink intoxicants; whether I myself have killed the people of a single city, a single town, or a single region; whether I have killed all sentient beings with a wheel of swords — even if, on the one hand, one were to give gifts to all sentient beings on the southern banks of the Ganges, and on the other hand were to kill all sentient beings on the northern banks of the Ganges, neither of these two acts would produce sin or merit, for there is no generosity, no moral discipline, no meditative absorption.

This is what that Teacher is now teaching while residing in Rājagṛha. O great king, go at once to that great Teacher. If you meet with him, your sins will be completely purified.

The king said: If my sins would truly be purified in that way, then I shall go for refuge to him.

The Noble Great Sūtra of the Passing into Nirvāṇa. The twenty-sixth fascicle.

Then a minister named Auspicious addressed the great king with these words: O great king, why have you become thus downcast and pallid, like a lamp placed next to the sun, or the moon in daytime, or a king who has lost his kingdom, or one who has sunk into the earth? O great king, at present you have no adversaries opposing you from any of the four directions — why then are you grieving and oppressed by suffering? O great king, is it that your body is in pain, or is it your mind that suffers? The princes always think to themselves, "When will the day come that I become a sovereign king with power over all?" O great king, you have achieved just such an aspiration and have become the wheel-turning king of the central lands, and command many great treasuries of precious things. You enjoy happiness just as you wish — do not be thus overwhelmed by sorrow and suffering.

The king replied: How could I possibly find cause not to grieve? O great minister, consider: a fool who is ignorant, when seized by attachment to food, does not notice even a sharp weapon. He is like one who does not know that poison has been poured into the food. I too am just like that. Consider how a deer, when it sees grass, does not notice a snare. Consider how a mouse, when seized by attachment to food, does not notice a cat. I am just the same: seeing only the pleasures of the present moment, I do not see the ripening of the fruits of non-virtue in the future. Long ago I heard from a learned and wise one these words: Even if three hundred spears were thrust into one's body in a single day, it would be better to bear that than to produce even a moment of ill will toward one's father or mother. As for me, I am in close proximity to the blazing fires of the hells — how could there possibly be any cause for me not to grieve?

The minister spoke again: Who ever told the king that hells exist? That was a lie. Consider: who sharpened thorns, which are sharp by their very nature? Who made the yellow color on a bird's feathers? Water is wet by nature, stone is hard by nature, wind moves by nature, fire is hot by nature — all these things arise of themselves and perish of themselves. Who made them? What is called "hell" has likewise been fabricated by learned and eloquent men who are clever with words. What meaning does the word "hell" have? Tell me, minister.

The minister replied: The syllable "hell" means the place of torment. The syllable "being" means one who is broken.

Having destroyed hell, and since there is no karmic maturation of evil, it is called "the sentient being of hell." Furthermore, the syllable "hell" means "human," and the syllable "being" means "god." Because one who has slain one's father is reborn as a god and a human, the sage called "Basu" teaches it in this way: since by burning one's body one attains the happiness of gods and humans, it is called "hell-being." Furthermore, the syllable "hell" means "life," and the syllable "being" means "long." Thus, since by taking life one's own life becomes long, it is called "hell-being." Therefore, Great King, in truth there is no such thing as a sentient being of hell.

Great King, consider: when a seed of barley is planted, barley grows; when a seed of rice is planted, rice grows. Likewise, if one kills a hell-being, one will again attain birth as a hell-being, and if one kills a human, one will certainly again become a human. Great King, hear the words that I, a proponent of the self, speak. In truth there is no such thing as killing. If there were such a thing as a self, it could not be killed. If there is no self, there is likewise no killing. Why is this? If a self exists, it is permanent, unchanging, and immutable. Being permanent, unchanging, and immutable in this way, there is no killing it — it is fearless, unbreakable, unbound, without aversion, without joy, like space itself. How then could killing it ever become a sin? If, on the other hand, there is no such thing as a self, then all phenomena are impermanent, and being impermanent they perish and cease moment by moment. Since they cease moment by moment, killing and dying also cease moment by moment. If they cease moment by moment in this way, who is there to experience that sin?

Great King, consider: when fire burns wood, no sin accrues to the fire. When an axe cuts wood, no sin accrues to the axe. When a sickle cuts grass, no sin accrues to the sickle. When a sword kills a person, the sword is not a person — if no sin accrues to the sword, why should sin accrue to the person? When poison kills a person, the poison is not a person — if no sin accrues to the poison, why should there be sin for the person? Since all things are of that same nature, if there is in truth no killing, how could sin arise?

Great King, do not grieve. Why? Listen:

One who always gives way to grief
will be reborn again in grief.
Just as one who is fond of sleep
will in turn sleep all the more,
so too with attachment and craving —

and know that love of liquor grows likewise.

O King, just as you have said — the view that in this world there is no wise physician skilled in purifying one's sinful actions is mistaken. At this very moment, the great Teacher, the unconquered one with matted locks, who is omniscient, who sees all, who knows the three worlds, who in a single instant simultaneously perceives world-realms without limit or number — whose hearing is likewise unbounded — who perfectly purifies all the sinful faults of every sentient being, who, like the river Gaṅgā, is utterly free from the stain of fault both inwardly and outwardly, completely pure: this great Teacher, who removes all the sinful actions both inner and outer of every sentient being, is right now teaching the Dharma to his attendants in these words:

Whoever kills all sentient beings, yet has no mind of shame or conscience, will never fall into the hell of sentient beings — just as dust and water do not cling to the sky. But one who possesses shame and conscience will fall into the hell of sentient beings — just as great waters drench all the earth. All sentient beings, too, are fashioned by him who is called the Sovereign of Gods, the one called Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods): if the Sovereign of Gods is pleased, all sentient beings will be happy; if the Sovereign of Gods is displeased, all sentient beings will suffer.

"If the non-virtuous actions and the merit of all sentient beings are likewise made by him who is called the Sovereign of Gods, then why would there be anything that becomes non-virtuous or meritorious?" So they assert. Consider the example of a carpenter: though he makes a mechanical figure of wood that walks, stands, sits, and lies down, the wooden figure itself cannot speak. In the same way, all sentient beings have been fashioned by him called the Sovereign of Gods — the Sovereign of Gods being like the carpenter, and the bodies of all sentient beings being like the mechanical figure. How then, the questioner asks, could there be any action that becomes non-virtuous? The great Teacher who teaches this is presently residing in Rājagṛha. Go quickly to that great king, and if you meet him, all your sins will be completely purified."

The king said: "If it is truly so, that my non-virtuous actions will be purified, then I will go to him for refuge."

Then a minister named Fearless came to where the king was and addressed him thus: "Great king, in this world, foolish and bewildered people in a single day rejoice a hundred times, grow angry a hundred times, sleep a hundred

times, awaken a hundred times, are frightened a hundred times, and weep a hundred times. But for one who is wise and possessed of discernment, there is no such heedlessness. Great king, why do you grieve so deeply? You are like a traveler who has lost his companion, or one who has sunk in a swamp with no refuge, or one tormented by thirst with no water to drink, or one led astray in a wilderness who has lost the path, or one gravely ill with no skilled physician to heal him, or one who has entered the ocean and whose ship has been wrecked, left without refuge. Great king, is your body now in discomfort, or is your mind in distress?"

The king said: "How could there be any relief for body or mind? Through my reliance on an evil companion, and through heedlessly speaking wrongly, I killed my own father the king. I will certainly fall into the hells, and I have no protector or refuge."

The minister said: "Great king, do not grieve in this way. The kingly lineage is the lineage of kings. If one commits an act of killing for the sake of the royal dominion, or for a monk, or for a brahmin, or for the well-being of many beings, there is no sin of non-virtue. Your father the king honored the ascetics but did not honor the brahmins, and because his mind was not at ease, because his mind was not at ease in this way, he was not truly of the kingly lineage. Great king, since you do honor the brahmins, even though you killed the former king, there is no non-virtuous action. Moreover, Great king, what is called 'killing' does not truly exist. What is called killing means severing the life-breath, and what is called the life-breath is the in-breath and out-breath. But since the breath cannot be cut or slain, how could the taking of a life be a sinful non-virtuous action? Great king, do not grieve. Why so? Consider:

One who always grieves
will return again and again to grief.
Just as one who loves sleep
will again and again sleep deeply,
so too with attachment and craving —
know that a fondness for wine is likewise so.

It is not right to say, as the king has said, that there is no skilled physician in the world. Right now the great Teacher, the naked sage (Nirgrantha) Jñātiputra, is omniscient, all-seeing, filled with loving-kindness toward all sentient beings, skilled in knowing the sharp and dull faculties of all beings, and one who fully comprehends whatever skillful means are appropriate. He is

unstained by the eight worldly concerns, and his holy life is supremely pure.

That supremely serene one now teaches the Dharma to his attendants in these words: there is no generosity, there is no virtue, there is no father, there is no mother, there is no present, there is no past, there is no arhat, there is no meditation, and there is no path. All sentient beings, after a hundred thousand eons have passed, will of themselves be liberated from the wheel of birth and death. Those who have committed evil and those who have not — all are alike in this. As an analogy, consider the four great rivers: the Sindhu, the Gaṅgā, the Pakṣu, and the Sītā — all four flow into the great ocean without distinction. So too with all sentient beings: at the time of liberation, all are without distinction.

Such is the teaching of that great Teacher. He now dwells in Rājagṛha. Go quickly to that great king, and when you meet him, your misdeeds will be purified.

The king replied: If my misdeeds are truly to be purified in that way, then I shall go for refuge to him.

At that time the great physician named Jīvaka came before the great king and said to him: Great king, have you slept well?

And at that the king spoke these verses:

Those who are able to cut through completely
all afflictions that defile from every side,
who are unattached to the three worlds —
they will sleep in perfect ease.

One who teaches the profoundly deep meaning
of how to pass beyond sorrow —
that true brahmin
will sleep in supreme ease.

One who has no fault of body,
who has abandoned the four faults of speech,
in whose mind no doubt whatever stirs —
they will sleep in perfect ease.

When body and mind are free from torment,
dwelling in great serenity and bliss,
one will attain unsurpassed happiness
and sleep in supreme ease.

One whose mind is attached to nothing,
who has utterly abandoned resentment,
who is always peaceable and lives without quarrel —
that one will sleep in perfect ease.

One who commits no evil deed,
who possesses a mind of shame and conscientiousness,
and who trusts in karmic maturation —
that one will sleep in perfect ease.

One who honors father and mother,
who does not take the life of even a single sentient being,
and who harbors no thought of stealing another's wealth —
they will sleep in perfect ease.

One who thoroughly tames the sense faculties,
who relies upon a spiritual friend of virtue,
and who has vanquished the four kinds of māra —
they will sleep in perfect ease.

One who sees neither the auspicious nor the inauspicious,
neither happiness nor suffering,
and who, for the sake of the many ordinary beings
who wander on and on through the wandering of saṃsāra,
feels no weariness —
that one will sleep in supreme ease.

Who is it that sleeps in ease?
The Blessed One, the buddha —
having fully realized meditative absorption in emptiness,
his body and mind are utterly still.

Who is it that sleeps in ease?
One endowed with loving-kindness and compassion,
who strives ardently for the realization of no-self
and regards all beings as a parent regards a child.

Sentient beings shrouded in ignorance
do not see the fruit of their afflictions,
and so they forever commit evil deeds —
they will not sleep in ease.

If by one's own body,
or by the body and speech of another,
the ten non-virtuous deeds have been committed —
they will not sleep in ease.

One who, desiring happiness,
says that killing one's father is no fault,
and who turns toward evil companions —
that one will not sleep in ease.

One who has not learned moderation in food,
and who has gone beyond the proper measure of cold drink,
will give rise to the suffering of illness —
that one will not sleep in ease.

If one has deceived the king,
or has lain with another's wife,
or if those who go to remote forest hermitages —
that one will not sleep in ease.

A physician afflicted by illness himself,
who has been cheated and killed by a king who governs his realm justly —
even though all skilled physicians apply their treatments and their mantras
and the like,
my own illness will not be cured.

Why is this? My own father was a king who governed his realm justly, without fault or flaw, yet I deceived him and had him killed. When a fish is pulled out onto dry land, where is the joy in that? When a deer is caught in a snare, there is no feeling of joy. Or it is like a person who knows they will die before long, or a king who has lost his kingdom and fled to a foreign land, or one who hears that a serious illness he has contracted cannot be cured, or one who has broken the law and hears that there is a blameworthy deed to be reckoned with. In just that way do I feel.

In times past I heard from learned and wise teachers that if the actions of body, speech, and mind are not entirely pure, that person will certainly fall into hell. Since I too will certainly fall into hell, how could there be any question of sleeping in ease? And now there is no unsurpassed great physician who dispenses the medicine of Dharma to heal the suffering of my illness.

Jīvaka the physician spoke: Excellent, Great King, excellent! Although the king has committed such a blameworthy deed, the arising of a mind of profound remorse is good. And it is good that you possess a sense of modesty and a sense of shame.

Great King, the awakened Blessed One always teaches as follows: two things that are pure white in nature become a refuge and protector for sentient beings. What are these two? Modesty and shame. Shame means that one does not commit blameworthy deeds oneself. Modesty means that one does not lead others to commit them. Shame means that one feels self-reproach. Modesty means that one confesses and repents before others. Shame means being embarrassed before people. Modesty means being embarrassed before the gods. These are called shame and modesty. One who has neither shame nor modesty cannot be called a human being — they are called an animal. Because one possesses shame and modesty, one shows respect to one's parents and teachers. Because one possesses modesty and shame, one speaks of having fathers and mothers, brothers and sisters. Great King, it is excellent to possess shame and modesty.

Great King, let me now recount what I heard from the awakened Blessed One. A wise person is of two kinds: one who does not commit wrongdoing, and one who, having committed it, feels remorse and confesses. A foolish and deluded person is likewise of two kinds: one who commits wrongdoing, and one who, having committed it, conceals it. Thus, even if one has previously committed wrongdoing, if one later feels remorse and confesses, and having confessed vows through shame and modesty not to commit it again, it is like placing a precious jewel in turbid water until the water becomes clear, or like the moon shining fully when unobscured by clouds and fog — one who commits wrongdoing and then feels remorse is like that.

If the king too feels remorse and confesses, and possesses shame and modesty, then his blameworthy faults will be purified and he will become entirely clean. Great King, there are two kinds of wealth: wealth in cattle, horses, and various kinds of livestock, and wealth in gold, silver, and material riches. However many horses and cattle one may have, they cannot compare to a single precious jewel. Great King, it is the same with sentient beings: there is wealth in wrongdoing and wealth in virtue — however much wrongdoing one has done, it cannot match a single act of virtue.

I have heard from the Blessed One, the buddha, that one who applies the mind with diligence to a single act of virtue will overcome a great multitude of wrongdoings. Great King, consider this: a small vajra (Skt. vajra) can pierce even Mount Meru; a tiny flame can burn everything; a small amount of poison can kill a sentient being. In just the same way, even a modest degree of virtue can overcome great wrongdoing. Though that virtue may be called small, in reality it is great. Why? Because it overcomes great wrongdoing.

Great King, as the Blessed One has taught: concealing wrongdoing is defiled; not concealing it is undefiled. Therefore, to feel remorse and confess is to be undefiled. Accordingly, when one has committed blameworthy actions, one should not conceal those wrongdoings. Not concealing one's wrongdoings causes blameworthy actions to become weakened. And when one confesses with shame and modesty, blameworthy actions will be entirely purified.

Great King, even a small number of drops of water, falling one by one, will fill a great vessel. In just the same way, even a virtuous mind will overcome great blameworthy actions. If blameworthy actions are concealed, those blameworthy actions will arise again and again. But if one feels remorse and confesses with shame and modesty, blameworthy actions will be entirely purified. Therefore, as the Blessed One, the buddha, has taught, those who are wise and possessed of wisdom do not conceal their blameworthy actions.

Great King, it is excellent indeed to have trust in causes, trust in results, and trust in the karmic maturation of actions. Great King, do not grieve. If a sentient being who has committed blameworthy actions conceals them, does not confess, has no sense of shame or modesty, does not see causes and results and the karmic maturation of actions, does not supplicate those who are wise and possessed of wisdom, and does not rely on a spiritual friend — such a person cannot be healed by any physician, however skilled. It is just as when someone has been struck by the disease called kanka: no physician in the world can cure it. Concealing blameworthy actions is like that as well.

Who is it that conceals blameworthy actions? It is a person of wrong craving. And who is a person of wrong craving? It is one who has no trust in causes and results, who has no shame or modesty, who at present has no trust in the karmic maturation of actions, who does not foresee the actions of the future, who does not rely on a spiritual friend, and who does not engage with the teaching of the Blessed One, the buddha. Such a person is called one of wrong craving, and even the Blessed One, the buddha, cannot heal them. Why? Just

as no physician in the world can cure a corpse, so too one of wrong craving is like that — even the Blessed One, the buddha, cannot heal them.

Great King, since you are not a person of wrong craving, it is not right for you to say, "There is nothing that can cure my illness." Let the king know it thus: it is not fitting to say, as the king has said, "My illness cannot be cured." Great King, the son of the pure-food king Śuddhodana of the land of the Śākya, he of the Gautama clan, whose name means "one whose aims are accomplished," who by himself, without being shown by anyone else, awakened through his own knowing and became perfectly and completely awakened in the unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening — whose body is entirely adorned with the thirty-two excellent major marks and the eighty excellent minor marks, who possesses the ten powers and the four fearlessnesses, who is omniscient, who sees all, who is great in loving-kindness and compassion —

who regards all beings with the same loving care as a parent feels for a cherished child, like Rāhu does for his own son; who speaks in accordance with the right moment, knowing it through his knowledge of the capacities of beings endowed with virtue — like a mother cow who never abandons her calf — who does not speak at the wrong time; who speaks truthfully, speaks with complete purity, speaks with utter clarity, speaks meaningfully, and speaks in accordance with the Dharma; who speaks concisely and decisively, and thereby fully eradicates the afflictions of countless sentient beings; who is supremely skilled in the characteristics of the faculties and intentions of ordinary people; who is supremely skilled in whatever skillful means are appropriate; whose wisdom is lofty and steep like Mount Meru; whose breadth and depth are like the ocean; and who, that Blessed One the buddha, possesses vajra-like wisdom — there is simply no ground for saying that the evil karma of any ordinary person could vanquish him and leave him defeated, for he himself shatters all such evil karma.

That buddha is now residing, twelve leagues from here, in the city called Kuśinagara, between a pair of śāla trees. At this very moment he is teaching the Dharma in all its varieties to an immeasurable and countless assembly of bodhisattvas — teaching on that which exists and that which does not exist; the conditioned and the unconditioned; the defiled and the undefiled; the fruits of affliction; pure phenomena; form phenomena and formless phenomena; phenomena that are neither form nor formless; self and what is not self; what is neither self nor not-self; the permanent and the impermanent; what is neither permanent nor impermanent; the blissful and the unblissful; what is

neither blissful nor unblissful; the marked and the unmarked; what is neither marked nor unmarked; annihilation and non-annihilation; what is neither annihilation nor non-annihilation; the mundane and the transcendent; what is neither mundane nor transcendent; vehicle and non-vehicle; what is neither vehicle nor non-vehicle; what is done by oneself and experienced by oneself; what is done by oneself and experienced by another; and what involves no action and no experience.

Great King, whoever hears from the Buddha about the absence of action and the absence of experience will be entirely purified of all their evil karma.

Great King, live on yet a while. When Śakra, the lord of the gods (Indra), is drawing near to the moment of death, five signs appear beforehand. What are they? Stains appear on his robes; the flowers on his crown wither; his body gives off an unpleasant smell; sweat breaks out from his armpits; and he no longer wishes to remain in his seat.

At such a time, if Śakra the lord of the gods, while in solitude, should see any śramaṇa or brahmin, he approaches them and generates the perception of them as a buddha. And when that śramaṇa or brahmin sees Śakra, he makes an aspiration and speaks these words: "Lord of the gods, we take refuge in you!" Hearing this, Śakra realizes the person is not a buddha, and he thinks to himself: "Since this is not a buddha, I myself am powerless to remove these five evil signs."

At that time, a minister named Matsyaśrī spoke to Śakra and said: "Lord of the gods, the king of the gandharvas (celestial musicians) is named Kapulo, and he has a daughter called Subartā. If you grant her to me, I will show you a way to pacify the king's evil signs."

Śakra replied: "The asura king Prahlāda's daughter, Mānoramā, is to become my wife —"

"If you are able to show me the way to pacify my evil signs, then I would give even Mānoramā to you — what need is there to speak of Subartā? Lord of the gods, the Blessed One, a buddha named Śākyamuni, is residing at present in Rājagṛha. Go to wherever he dwells and hear from him what you have not heard before, and the evil signs portending the hour of death will without fail be pacified."

"Son of good family, if the Blessed One, the buddha, is able to pacify them, then let us go to wherever he dwells." So saying, Śakra turned his heavenly

vehicle around and went to Rājagṛha, to Vulture Peak Mountain, to the place where the Blessed One, the buddha, was staying. Bowing his head at the feet of the buddha, he took his seat to one side and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, what is it that binds and fetters gods and humans?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, it is miserliness, attachment, and envy."

He asked again: "From what do miserliness, attachment, and envy arise?"

The Blessed One declared: "They arise from ignorance."

He asked again: "From what does ignorance arise?"

The Blessed One declared: "It arises from heedlessness."

He asked again: "From what does heedlessness arise?"

The Blessed One declared: "It arises from inversion — from perceiving things contrary to their true nature."

He asked again: "From what does inversion arise?"

The Blessed One declared: "It arises from a mind of doubt."

"Blessed One, that the phenomenon of inversion arises from doubt — this is in accord with the word of the noble ones. And why is that? Because doubt arose in my mind, inversion was born: I formed the perception of a buddha and Blessed One regarding someone who was not a buddha and Blessed One. But now, having seen the Blessed One, the buddha, my mind of doubt has been cleansed. With doubt completely cleansed, inversion is exhausted. With inversion exhausted, there is no longer a mind of miserliness, nor indeed a mind of envy."

The Blessed One declared: "You say there is no mind of miserliness and envy — have you now attained the fruit of once-returning, or is the attainment of the fruit of once-returning something you desire? One who has attained the fruit of once-returning has no mind of desire. If there is no mind of desire, why then did you come to me out of concern for your life? A once-returner has no hope in life."

"Blessed One, one who perceives inversely does have hope in life. One who does not perceive inversely has no such hope. As for myself, in truth I have no hope in this life, but I do have hope in the dharmakāya of the Blessed One, the buddha, and in the primordial wisdom of a buddha."

"Kauśika, one who seeks the dharmakāya of a buddha and the primordial wisdom of a buddha will without fail attain them in a future time to come."

Then Śakra, the lord of gods, having heard these words from the Blessed One, found that those very evil signs portending the hour of death had been entirely cleansed. He rose from his seat, bowed his head in homage, circumambulated three times, and with respectful joined palms addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"I have recovered from death. I have recovered my life from its loss. Moreover, having received from the Blessed One, the buddha, the prophecy that I will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, that is what I call recovery and the gaining of life.

"Blessed One, how is it that gods and humans increase and flourish? And how is it that they decline and diminish?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kauśika, through the condition of conflict and strife, gods and humans decline and diminish. Through the condition of deep harmony and concord, they are born and increase."

"Blessed One, if it is through conflict and strife that one declines and is diminished, then from this day forward I will not quarrel with the asuras."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Kauśika, patience is the supreme cause of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening for a buddha, a Blessed One."

With these words, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, prostrated at the feet of the Buddha, touching his crown to the ground, and departed for his abode.

That great king declared that the Tathāgata dispels all evil omens born of non-virtue, and that therefore a buddha is beyond conception.

Moreover, if even a king were to approach him, all blameworthy actions would be completely purified.

Great King, may you live long.

There was a brahmin's son named Ahiṃsaka — "Harmless One" — who, having slain countless sentient beings, was given the name Aṅgulimāla, "Garlanded with Fingers." When he set out to kill again and arose with murderous intent, his body trembled and shook. The trembling of body and mind was born of the condition of having committed the five acts of immediate retribution, and so he would without doubt fall into the hell realms. Yet when he encountered the

Buddha, his body and mind trembled still, and again the intent to kill arose in him. The trembling of body and mind was stirred by the condition of having committed the five acts of immediate retribution, and those who commit the five acts of immediate retribution will without doubt fall into the hell realms. Yet the very moment that man encountered the Tathāgata, the great Teacher, the cause for falling into the hell realms was completely purified, and he aroused the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Therefore the Blessed One, the buddha, is called the unsurpassed physician — unlike the six teachers.

Great King, there was also a prince named Jīvaka. His father the king, enraged, cut off his hands and feet and threw him into a pit. The king's mother, moved by affection, drew him out of the pit and led him to where the Buddha was. The very moment he encountered the Buddha, his hands and feet were restored, and he aroused the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Great King, through meeting the Buddha in just this way, one attains visible and immediate results. Therefore the Blessed One, the buddha, is called the unsurpassed physician — unlike the six teachers.

Great King, on the banks of the Ganges there were five hundred hungry ghosts. For countless years they had not seen a drop of water. When they went to the river's edge, they saw before them a great mass of blazing fire. Tormented by thirst and hunger, they cried out with loud lamentation. At that time the Tathāgata was dwelling at the foot of an udumbara tree in a grove near that very river. Many of those hungry ghosts then came to where the Buddha was and addressed him thus: "We are tormented by hunger and thirst and cannot sustain our lives much longer."

The Blessed One declared: "Why do you not drink from the flowing waters of the Ganges?"

The hungry ghosts replied: "Though the Tathāgata sees it as water, we see it as a great blazing mass of fire."

The Blessed One declared: "The waters of the Ganges river are indeed pure blue and clear — there is truly no fire there. It is your evil karma that has caused your minds to become distorted, so that you perceive it as fire. Let your distorted perception be thoroughly cleared away, and see it as water."

Having so declared, the Blessed One then taught those many hungry ghosts about the faults of miserliness and attachment.

The many hungry ghosts then said: "We are tormented by hunger and thirst, and even though we hear many words of Dharma, we do not have the capacity to retain them."

The Blessed One declared: "Enter the waters of the Ganges river and drink from them as you wish." By the blessing of the Buddha, those hungry ghosts were able to drink the water. Having thus drunk their fill, the Tathāgata then taught them the Dharma in its many aspects. Having heard the Dharma, they gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and, casting off their bodies as hungry ghosts, they attained the body of a god.

"Great King, for this reason the buddha, the Blessed One, is called the unsurpassed physician — he is not like the six teachers. Great King, in the land of Śrāvastī there were five hundred men who were blinded and left sightless by the army of King Prasenajit. They had no opportunity to go to where the Buddha was. The buddha, the Blessed One, out of compassion, went to where those blinded men were and gladdened them, saying: 'Sons of good family, restrain your body and speech with great care, and from this time forward commit no evil.' The moment those many men heard the perfectly clear speech of the Tathāgata from the Buddha, their sight was restored. They joined their palms before the Buddha, paid homage, and addressed the Blessed One thus: 'Blessed One, we understand that the mind of loving-kindness of the buddha, the Blessed One, extends to all sentient beings — not only to gods and humans.' At that time the Blessed One taught them the Dharma, and having heard the Dharma, they gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For this reason the Tathāgata is called the unsurpassed, true physician of the world — he is not like the six teachers.

"Great King, in the city of Śrāvastī there was a merchant's son named Māpham who committed adultery with his mother. By reason of that act and that condition, he also killed his father. Later, when he discovered that his mother was being intimate with another man, he killed his mother too. He befriended an arhat, and then out of shame killed the arhat as well. Having thus killed an arhat, he went to a monastery and requested from the community of monks to go forth from home into homelessness. The community of monks, knowing that he had committed three acts of immediate retribution, did not grant him ordination. Furious at being refused ordination, that very night he took a torch and set fire to the monks' dwelling. Afterward he went to Rājagṛha, came to where the Tathāgata was, and requested ordination from the Tathāgata. The

Tathāgata ordained him, taught him the Dharma, and through that teaching all the heavy sins and misdeeds he had accumulated were purified, and he gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For this reason the buddha, the Blessed One, is called the unsurpassed Teacher — he is not like the six teachers."

Great King, you are by nature wrathful and fierce, and you place your trust in evil companions. And so it was that at that time Devadatta released intoxicated woolly bulls and drove them to charge at the Buddha. Yet the moment those bulls caught sight of the Buddha, they became tame of their own accord. The Buddha, the Blessed One, then stretched out his hand and stroked the bulls on their heads, taught them the Dharma, and through that teaching they gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Great King, even those born in an animal existence — the moment they encountered the Buddha, even the karmic maturation of their animal birth was utterly overcome. How much more need be said for those born in a human lineage? Great King, understand this well: if one encounters the Buddha, even grave and blameworthy sins will be entirely purified.

Great King, before the Buddha, the Blessed One, had manifested unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, immeasurable and innumerable hosts of māras came into the presence of the bodhisattva. At that time, through the power of his patience, the bodhisattva thoroughly subdued the evil-minded māras, taught the Dharma to those māras, and caused them to give rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Such is the power and might of the Buddha, the Blessed One's great qualities.

Great King, in a wilderness hermitage there were many hungry ghosts who slaughtered sentient beings. The Tathāgata, for the sake of the merchant Nordzang, went to that wilderness hermitage where those hungry ghosts dwelled and taught them the Dharma. Having heard the Dharma proclaimed, those hungry ghosts of the wilderness hermitage were filled with delight and joy. The merchant Nordzang offered them to the Buddha, and they gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Great King, in the region of Sershya there was a butcher named Changyanné who each and every day slaughtered countless sheep. Having been seen by Śāriputra, he took the eight precepts for a single day. Through that cause and that condition, upon his death he was reborn as the son of Gömpé Ngawasö,

the Protector of the Northern Quarter.

If even the Tathāgata's attendants possess such great qualities, what need is there to speak of the Buddha, the Blessed One, himself?

Great King, to the north of the region of Khor there was a city called Segma, and there a king named Luwi Chakgya killed his own father in order to seize the kingdom. Having killed his father in this way, a mind of intense remorse arose in him. He renounced the kingdom, came to where the Tathāgata was, and requested ordination. The Blessed One said to him, "Excellent!" and he became a fully ordained monk. His blameworthy sins were entirely purified, and he gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Great King, therefore know that the Tathāgata possesses immeasurable and incalculable great qualities.

Great King, the Tathāgata had a younger brother named Devadatta, who created a schism in the Saṅgha, maliciously drew blood from the Buddha's body, and killed the fully ordained nun named Padmā — thereby committing three acts of immediate retribution. To him also the Tathāgata taught the Dharma in its many forms, and his blameworthy sins were straightaway entirely purified. For this reason the Tathāgata is called the great physician — he is not like the six teachers.

Great King, if you take to heart what I have said, go quickly to where the Blessed One, the Buddha, resides. And even if you do not take it fully to heart, at least reflect on it well.

Great King, the great compassion of the Blessed One, the Buddha, pervades all without exception — he does not teach the sacred Dharma to only one or a few. Because his mind is impartial toward friend and foe alike, he establishes not merely a single person in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, but establishes all beings therein. The Tathāgata is not the teacher of only the fourfold retinue of renunciants — he is the teacher of all: gods, humans, nāgas, hungry ghosts, animals, hell-beings, and every living being throughout the world. For this reason, it is fitting that all sentient beings cultivate the perception of the Blessed One, the Buddha, as their mother and father.

Great King, the Tathāgata does not teach the Dharma exclusively to noble and venerable kings — he also teaches the Dharma to those of low and humble birth, such as Upāli. He did not receive food offerings only from Ubarta and Ananyate — he also accepted food from the poor man Sudarati. He does not

teach the Dharma only to those of sharp faculties, such as Śāriputra — he also teaches the Dharma to those of dull faculties, such as Cūḍapanthaka. He did not grant the going forth only to Mahākāśyapa and those of his kind, who were by nature free of attachment — he also granted the going forth to Nandaka and those like him, who were possessed of strong desire. He did not grant the going forth only to Laṅgulīya Kāśyapa and those like him, whose afflictions were thin and mild — he also granted the going forth even to Sūta, the younger brother of King Ajātaśatru, who had committed blameworthy acts. He did not uproot aversion only through acts of veneration accompanied by respectful service to someone called Jāgama — he also provided refuge even to the Aṅgulimāla, who with malicious intent had caused harm. He does not teach the Dharma exclusively to men endowed with wisdom — he also teaches the Dharma to foolish women who are wanton, even those skilled in the ways of wantonness. It is not only the fourfold assembly of renunciants who attain the fruit of awakening — he also enabled householders to attain the three fruits. He does not teach the meaning of the Dharma only to those like Sūtana, who have completely abandoned bustle and whose minds have become one-pointed — he also teaches the meaning of the Dharma to kings like Rūpasāra and others who govern kingdoms. He does not teach the Dharma only to those who have entirely renounced intoxicants — he also teaches the Dharma to fierce householders utterly drunk on liquor. He does not teach the Dharma only to those like Lipa who are established in meditative absorption — he also teaches the Dharma to the brahmin woman Vāsitā, whose mind was disturbed by the death of her son. He does not teach the Dharma only to his own attendants — he also teaches the Dharma to naked tīrthika ascetics. He does not teach the Dharma only to those in the full bloom of youth at twenty-five years of age — he also teaches the Dharma to those who are bent with old age at eighty years. He does not teach the Dharma only to persons whose faculties are fully ripened — he also teaches the Dharma to those whose roots of virtue are not yet ripened. He does not teach the Dharma only to queens adorned with garlands — he also teaches the Dharma to the snake-seller Padmā. He did not accept only the finest food of eight flavors offered by King Ajātaśatru — he also accepted food mixed with poison offered by the householder Śrīgupta.

Great King, know it in this way: as for Śrīgupta — even though in times long past he had accumulated the karma of having committed acts of immediate retribution, upon meeting the Buddha and hearing the Dharma, he gave rise to

the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Great King, even if one were to give food and clothing for an entire month to all sentient beings, the merit of a single person who, for just one instant, recollects the Buddha would not be matched even by a sixteenth part of that giving.

Great King, even if one were to give a hundred chariots' worth of gold to another person rather than keeping it for oneself, that giving would not match the merit of one who generates the awakening mind and takes a single step in the direction of the Buddha.

Great King, even if one were to give a hundred chariots laden by great white oxen with all manner of precious things from a great realm, along with a hundred women adorned with necklaces and garlands — all that giving would not match the merit of one who generates the awakening mind and takes a single step in the direction of the place where a Buddha dwells. And let that pass for now: even if one were to give, by way of the four kinds of offering materials, to all the sentient beings of this great trichiliocosm of three thousand worlds, the merit of one who generates the awakening mind and takes a single step in the direction of a Buddha would be greater still. Let even that pass: even if a great king were to make gifts to innumerable sentient beings equal in number to the grains of sand in the Ganges river, that giving would not match the merit of one who, from the heart, goes before the Tathāgata between two śāla trees simply to hear the Dharma.

Then the Great King spoke to Jīvaka in these words: "The Blessed One, the Buddha, is by his very nature supremely tame, and so his retinue too is supremely tame — just as a sandalwood grove is surrounded only by sandalwood trees. The Tathāgata is utterly pure, and so his retinue too is utterly pure — just as a great nāga lord is encircled by a retinue of nāgas. The Tathāgata is perfectly peaceful, and so his retinue too is perfectly peaceful. The Tathāgata is free of attachment, and so his retinue too is free of attachment. Since the Buddha is without affliction, his retinue too is without affliction. Yet someone like me — a grievous sinner, deeply stained by disgraceful deeds, utterly soiled and defiled, belonging to the class of hell-beings — how could such a one go into the presence of the Tathāgata? Even if I did go, I fear he would not look upon me and would not deign to speak to me. Though you urge me to go before the Buddha, I am so utterly defiled that not even the slightest wish to go arises in me."

At that moment, from the sky above, this voice was heard:

The unsurpassed Dharma of the Buddha is drawing near its setting.

The river of profound teaching is close to running dry.

The great lamp of the Dharma will not long remain.

The mountain of Dharma is on the verge of toppling.

The boat of Dharma is near to breaking apart.

The bridge of Dharma is close to collapsing.

The palace of Dharma is about to crumble.

The victory banner of Dharma is on the point of falling.

The trunk of Dharma is near to shattering.

The spiritual friend is about to depart.

Great ruin is drawing near.

Sentient beings starved of Dharma will soon arise.

The plague of afflictions is about to break out.

The time of being overwhelmed by great darkness has arrived.

The time of poverty in Dharma is close at hand.

The king of māras rejoices greatly and has cast aside his armor.

The sun of the Buddha is close to setting behind the summit of the great mountain of parinirvāṇa.

Great King, if the Buddha passes away, no one else will be able to heal these disgraceful deeds of the Great King.

Great King, you have committed the shameful deed of the avīci hell, a heinous act without interval. By the force of that karma, you will without doubt fall there.

Great King, the syllable "a" means "without." The syllable "vi" means "interval." Since there is not even a little interval of ease, it is called "without interval."

Great King, if even a single person falls into that hell, their body fills the entire space of eighty thousand leagues, and they experience sufferings of every kind pressing in upon them on all sides without any gap within. If many people fall there, their bodies fill it just the same, each piercing into the others without hindrance.

Great King, in the cold hells, even a brief encounter with a warm breeze is called ease. In the hot hells, even a brief encounter with a cool breeze is called ease. In the hell of revival, merely hearing the words "die and revive" brings one back to life at once. But in the avīci hell, there is no such respite

whatsoever.

Great King, the avīci hell has one gate on each of the four sides. Outside each of these gates there burns a great fire, blazing outward in all four directions, south, north, east, and west. The entire expanse of eighty thousand leagues is encircled by iron walls; above, an iron lattice covers it like a lid; and the ground itself is made of iron. The fire above blazes downward, and the fire below blazes upward, burning in all directions throughout. Great King, just as a fish placed on a hot pan is scorched, so too are those who dwell there.

Great King, if one has committed one act without interval, one experiences a single avīci. If one has committed two acts without interval, one experiences a double measure. If one has committed five acts without interval, one experiences a fivefold measure.

Great King, knowing that I myself will certainly not escape this shameful deed of the king, go quickly to where the Tathāgata dwells. Apart from the Buddha, the Blessed One, there is no other who can be your refuge. I urge you in these words out of affection for you.

At that time, upon hearing those resonant words, the Great King was seized with extreme terror and shuddered; his five limbs trembled like the wood of a water plant. Looking upward, he spoke these words: "There is no visible form — who is it that only a voice is heard?"

"Great King, I am your father, the inner essence, appearing in a form you cannot see. Hear these words that will preserve your life. These are not the words of the six teachers of wrong views."

The moment the king heard those resonant words, he fell unconscious to the ground. Boils broke out across his body, and he became even more fetid and foul-smelling than before. Though he was anointed with cooling medicines, the boils burned all the more fiercely, and there was no sign of life.

This is the twenty-seventh fascicle of the noble great sūtra of the Mahāparinirvāṇa.

At that time, the Blessed One, the Teacher, in his great compassion for King Ajātaśatru (whose name means "he who has no enemy born"), entered the meditative absorption like the moon. Having entered that absorption, he sent forth great rays of light. Those great rays of light, supremely soothing, touched the king's body; the boils on his body healed, and the torment of the fever was entirely stilled. The king, feeling the boils healed and a coolness spreading

through his limbs, spoke these words to the life-restorer:

"In former times, sages used to say: 'When an eon is drawing to its close, three moons appear at once, and at that time all the sickness and suffering of every sentient being is stilled.'"

"That time has not yet come, yet from where did this light arise that, upon touching my body, has cured the suffering of the boils and brought ease to my limbs?"

The life-restorer replied: "This is not the three moons appearing together when an eon is drawing to its close. It is not fire, nor the sun, nor the stars, nor medicine, nor a precious jewel, nor the light of a god."

The king spoke again: "If it is not the light of the three moons, nor of precious jewels and the like, then whose light is this?"

The life-restorer said: "O king, know that this is the light sent forth by the God of gods. This light has no root and no limit; it is neither hot nor cold; it is neither permanent nor cessation; it is neither form nor formless; it has no defining characteristic and lacks no defining characteristic; it is neither blue, yellow, red, nor white. Yet for the sake of liberating sentient beings, it can be seen; it can be described by its defining characteristics; it has a root, it has extent, it has warmth, it has coolness; and there is also blue, yellow, red, and white in it. Yet, great king, even so, in ultimate truth this light is beyond description — from being seen all the way to being blue, yellow, red, or white, none of these truly obtain."

The king then said to the life-restorer: "For what cause and on account of what condition did the God of gods send forth this light?"

The life-restorer replied: "Great king, this present omen of light appears to have been sent out of loving regard for the king. In former times the king declared: 'There is no physician in the world skilled enough to cure diseases of both body and mind.' It is on that account that this light was sent forth — first to heal the king's body, and then to heal the mind as well."

The king asked the life-restorer once more: "Does the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, hold me in such loving regard?"

The life-restorer replied: "Consider, for example, a man who has seven sons. If one among the seven is struck by illness, the parents are not indifferent to any of their children — and yet it is for the sick child that their concern is the greatest. Great king, the Tathāgata is like that. He is not without equal

concern for all sentient beings; and yet for those who are sinful he has especial care. For the indolent the buddha cherishes them with compassion. For those who are not indolent he rests in equanimity. Now who are those who are not indolent? They are the bodhisattvas who abide on the sixth ground.

Great king, the buddha, the Blessed One, makes no distinction on account of a being's class, or whether they are old, young, or in their prime, or poor or rich, or by time, day, month, or star, or by craft, low birth, male servant, or female servant. He takes note only of whatever sentient being possesses a virtuous mind — discerning whether a virtuous mind is present — and if it is, he regards that being with a mind of loving-kindness.

Great king, know that this omen of light is the light that the Tathāgata sent forth upon entering the meditative absorption like the moon."

The king asked: "What is this meditative absorption called 'like the moon'?"

The life-restorer replied: "Consider how moonlight causes all the *udpala* (blue lotus) flowers to open and bloom in brightness. In the same way, the meditative absorption like the moon causes the virtuous mind of all sentient beings to open and bloom — and it is for that reason it is called the meditative absorption like the moon.

Great king, consider further how moonlight brings joy to all travelers. In the same way, the meditative absorption like the moon causes those who journey the path to *nirvāṇa* to give rise to a mind of joy — and it is for that reason it is called the meditative absorption like the moon."

"Great king, consider how moonlight, from the first day of the month through the fifteenth, gradually grows in shape and brightness, waxing until it is full. In the same way, the meditative absorption like the moon causes the wholesome roots planted at the first arising of the awakening mind to grow and expand gradually, and it brings them to complete fulfillment all the way through to the great *nirvāṇa* — and it is for that reason it is called the meditative absorption like the moon.

Great king, consider further how moonlight, from the sixteenth day of the month through the thirtieth, gradually diminishes in shape, color, brightness, and luminosity, waning until it is small. In the same way, wherever the light of the meditative absorption like the moon shines, all afflictions (*kleśas*) there gradually diminish and grow small — and it is for that reason it is called the meditative absorption like the moon.

Great king, consider how in the time of intense heat all sentient beings constantly long for moonlight, and when moonlight falls upon them the heat is gone. In the same way, the meditative absorption like the moon extinguishes all the torment that afflicts sentient beings through the afflictions of desire.

Great king, consider how the full moon is like a king among the many stars, and all sentient beings delight in it and are drawn to it as though to the taste of nectar. In the same way, the meditative absorption like the moon is exactly like that: it is the king of all virtuous qualities, like the taste of nectar, and all sentient beings delight in it and are drawn to it — and it is for that reason it is called the meditative absorption like the moon."

The king then spoke: "I have heard it said that the Tathāgata does not dwell together with, keep company with, or converse with those who are wicked — just as a corpse does not rest in the ocean for even a day, just as a vulture does not linger where there is no water to drink, just as Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), does not dwell together with hungry ghosts, and just as the kuśī bird does not sleep upon a withered branch. Having heard this, I wonder: if the Tathāgata is like that, how am I to see him? And if I were to see him, would my body sink into the earth? When I think about approaching him, it seems to me that the Tathāgata, rather than ever consorting with the wicked, would prefer even a maddened elephant, a lion, a tiger, a wolf, a wildfire, or a venomous snake. With what kind of mind, then, should I go before the Tathāgata?"

Jīvaka replied: "Great king, one who is tormented by thirst swiftly makes for a clean source of water. One who is hungry longs for food; one who is afraid longs for refuge; one who is sick longs for medicine; one who is hot longs for shade; one who is cold longs for fire. In just such a way, it is fitting that the king who longs for the Buddha act accordingly.

Great king, the Tathāgata teaches the sacred Dharma even to those of wrong craving. When that is so, great king, how much more does he look with compassion upon those who are without wrong craving and grant them protection?

The king then spoke: "Jīvaka, I previously heard this said: 'Those with wrong craving are those without faith, who do not listen, who do not take the meaning to heart, and who do not understand the meaning.' If that is so, why would the Tathāgata teach the Dharma at all?"

Jīvaka replied: "Great king, consider someone who is stricken with a severe illness. In a dream, he finds himself sitting in a single-pillared house, eating

butter and oil and the like, smearing them on his body, lying in ashes and eating ashes, climbing a withered and rotting tree, mingling and sleeping with monkeys at intervals, sitting or lying with them, sinking in water, being swamped in muddy swamp, or perhaps on a rooftop or inside a house —

or falling from a high mountain, a tree-top, a yak, a horse, a cow, or a sheep; or wearing blue, yellow, red, or black garments and singing, dancing, and playing; or seeing a crow, a vulture, a fox, or the like; or having one's teeth and hair fall out; or lying naked, smeared with filth, on a heap of refuse, keeping company with a dog; or consorting and sitting with people who have long since died; or walking with arms entwined with them; or wandering over ground swarming with venomous snakes; or dreaming of lying together with a disheveled woman, embracing her with one's arms; or wearing palmyra leaves as garments; or riding a cart drawn by donkeys and traveling southward — having dreamed such dreams, one becomes deeply distressed, and the mind is tormented by misery.

Because one is tormented by such misery, the illness flares up and grows worse. Because the illness has worsened, the family members send for a physician. Now suppose that the messenger sent to fetch the physician is short of stature, has incomplete limbs, lacks the proper faculties, has dust on his head, wears tattered clothing, and brings along a broken-down cart, and says to the physician: 'Please mount this cart at once.' When the skilled physician sees such ill omens and inauspicious signs as these, he thinks: 'This patient will be very difficult to cure.' Yet he also thinks: 'These are indeed inauspicious omens, but let me look to the sun to see whether it may yet be possible or impossible to heal.'

If the patient fell ill on the fourth, sixth, eighth, twelfth, or fourteenth day of the lunar month, the physician thinks it will be difficult to cure. Yet he also thinks: 'Though the day is unfavorable, let me look to the stars to see whether healing is possible or not.' If the stars that are present are Fire, Gold, the Pleiades, Yama, the Tortoise, or the River — and the patient took ill under such stars — the physician thinks it will be difficult to cure. Yet he also thinks: 'The stars are unfavorable; let me look to the season and the time.' If the patient fell ill in autumn or winter, at sunset, at midnight, or at moonset, the physician thinks it will be difficult to cure.

Then he thinks: 'All these many omens are unfavorable. Yet it may still be possible to heal, or it may not. Let me examine the patient himself — if he has

merit, healing is possible; if he has no merit, what use are good omens anyway?' Having reflected thus, the physician sets out along the road in the company of the messenger. As he travels, he thinks: 'If the patient has signs of long life, healing is possible; if signs of short life are encountered, healing is not possible.'

Then, as the two boys sent as his escort quarrel with each other on the road — pulling each other by the topknot, tearing out hair, and throwing clods, stones, weapons, and sticks at each other and striking one another — he may see a torch going out by itself, or see trees being cut, or see a person carrying a hide and walking along the road, or see goods left abandoned on the road, or see someone carrying empty vessels, or see a lone monk walking without a companion, or see a tiger, a wolf, a crow, a vulture, a fox, or the like. Seeing all such things, the physician thinks: 'From the moment the messenger was sent to me until now, everything I have seen along the way is inauspicious — this patient will certainly be extremely difficult to cure.'

Yet he also thinks: 'If I do not go, I will not be known as a skilled physician; but if I do go, healing may not be possible.' And he thinks further: 'Even though all these many omens are inauspicious, nonetheless I will go single-mindedly to attend to the patient.' And so he proceeds along the road. Yet upon hearing the following sounds, healing is not possible. What are they? The sounds of death, of loss, and —

— arising, breaking, shattering, crashing, hissing, falling, coming loose, being carried as a load, burning, and the cry "He will not recover!" — upon hearing these sounds, healing is not possible; there is no hope of refuge or rescue.

Furthermore, upon hearing from the southern direction the cries of birds such as these: a crow, a carrion bird, a heron — or the sounds of a dog, a rat, a fox, a rabbit, or a pig — upon hearing any of these sounds, the physician again thinks to himself: "This patient will be extremely difficult to cure."

Then, upon entering the patient's dwelling and examining the patient, he finds that at times the patient is cold, at times feverish, with all the joints aching severely; the eyes are red with tears streaming from them; there is ringing within the ears; the throat is blocked and painful; the tongue is cracked; the complexion has become extremely dark; the head cannot be held up; the body is wasted and covered in dust; urine and stool are obstructed; the body has suddenly become extremely discolored — now very pale, now very red — and the sound of the breathing is irregular and uneven, sometimes coarse and

sometimes fine; the entire body has become mottled, and strangely the complexion has turned blue and yellow; the belly is swollen and distended, and speech has become unclear. Having observed these conditions, the physician asks the patient's attendant: "What change has come over this patient compared to how he was before?"

The attendant replies: "Great physician, this man, who formerly had faith in and venerated the Three Jewels and the gods, has now changed — his mind has lost all faith. Where before he delighted in generosity, he has now become miserly. Where before his appetite was small, it has now become great. Where before he was gentle and pleasant, he has now become irritable and filled with great aversion. Where before he was exceedingly respectful and paid wonderful reverence to his father and mother, he has now lost all thought of honoring his father and mother."

The physician, upon hearing these words, draws near and smells the patient. He detects a range of scents from the body: the fragrance of blue lotus, or of aloe-wood and various incenses, or the scents of kṛtaka, takkola, tamalā, saffron, and sandalwood — or the stench of burnt flesh, or the odor of fermenting wine and of bile, or a smell like that of burning bones, or the stench of fish, or the smell of vomit. Having detected whatever pleasant fragrance or foul odor the body gives off, he then examines it by touch: whether the body is soft and pliable as silk or as the petals of a lotus flower, or instead hard as stone, or cold as a damp cloth, or hot as fire, or rough as sand.

Thereupon that skilled physician, having perceived these various manifold signs and omens, knows without doubt that this patient will die. Nevertheless, he does not utter the definitive pronouncement "This person will die." Instead, he says to the attendant: "I have some business to attend to today — I will come tomorrow. Whatever the patient desires, do not withhold it from him." Having said this, he returns to his own home. Then, if he is called again and says to the patient's wife: "My work is not yet finished, and moreover the medicine has not yet been prepared" — when a wise and discerning physician says this, he knows without doubt that the patient will die.

Great King, the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, is just the same. Fully knowing the faculties and the inherent natures of those with perverted craving, he nonetheless teaches the Dharma to them as well. Why so? Because if he did not teach the Dharma to them, all foolish and ignoble people would say: "The Tathāgata has no loving-kindness and no great compassion." And they would

say: "One who possesses loving-kindness and great compassion is called omniscient — but if there is no loving-kindness and no compassion, how can one speak of omniscience?" It is for this reason that the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma even to those with perverted craving.

Great King, the blessed buddha, the Blessed One, whenever he sees the sick, always gives the medicine of the Dharma. If the patient does not drink it, it is no fault of the Tathāgata.

Great King, those with perverted craving, when distinguished and analyzed, fall into two kinds.

Those with perverted craving who, in the present time, obtain a root of virtue, and those who will obtain a root of virtue in a future time — knowing which of them, among those with perverted craving, will obtain a root of virtue in the present time, the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma to such a one. And to those who will obtain it in a future time, he also teaches the Dharma. Even when it will bring no benefit in the present time, because it will serve as a cause for a future time, the Tathāgata teaches the way of the Dharma even to those with perverted craving.

Moreover, among those called persons with perverted craving there are also two kinds: those of sharp faculties and those of middling faculties. Those of sharp faculties obtain a root of virtue in the present time. Those of middling faculties will obtain it in a future time. The blessed buddha does not teach the Dharma purposelessly.

Great King, consider this example: a person who has fallen into filth, and a dear and close friend who sees him there, grabs him by the hair and pulls him out. In the same way, when the blessed buddha sees sentient beings falling into the three lower realms, he raises them up and pulls them free by means of skillful means. It is for this reason that the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma to all those with perverted craving.

Then the King said to Jīvaka: "If it is truly the case that the Tathāgata is like that, then I shall look to see whether tomorrow the sun is auspicious and the stars are favorable, and then set out."

Jīvaka replied: "Great King, in what concerns the Dharma of the Tathāgata, there is no such thing as a good or bad sun or stars. Great King, consider this example: when someone is gravely ill, he does not look for a good or bad sun or stars or an auspicious time — a skilled physician is what he seeks. The King

is like one struck by grave illness; it is therefore not proper to look for a good or bad sun or auspicious time when seeking that physician who is the Tathāgata. Great King, consider this further example: sandalwood fire and eraṇḍa fire are alike in the defining characteristic of burning — there is no difference between them. Good and bad suns are just the same. If one goes into the presence of the Buddha, all sins will be purified. Great King, I urge you to go quickly, this very day."

Then the King summoned the minister named Auspicious and spoke these words: "Know this: I am going today into the presence of the blessed Buddha. Swiftly prepare all the necessary articles and requisites for offering." The minister replied: "Great King, excellent, excellent! Whatever articles you wish are all present and ready."

Then King Ajātaśatru, together with his queen, set out with two thousand beautifully adorned chariots and fifty thousand fine, great draft oxen, each of them with three men mounted upon it carrying parasols, banners, flowers, incense, and musical instruments, with every variety of offering articles present and complete. One hundred and eighty thousand cavalry troops and five hundred and eighty thousand people dwelling throughout the middle of the realm also set out as attendants of the King. At that time, the great assembly that filled the space around the city of Kusumapura for twelve leagues all saw from afar King Ajātaśatru coming together with his retinue.

Then the Blessed One declared to the great assembly: "There is no passing beyond a spiritual friend who serves as a proximate cause for the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — the arhatship — of all sentient beings. And why is that? If King Ajātaśatru had not listened to the words of Jīvaka, then on the seventh day of the following month he would certainly have met his death and fallen without doubt into the avīci hell for those without respite. It is therefore the case that there is no passing beyond a spiritual friend when it comes to a proximate cause. When King Ajātaśatru set out along the road, he heard these words:"

In the city of Śrāvastī, a king called Vaidūrya had boarded a ship and was burned while out at sea. The monk Kukari fell alive into the earth and dropped into the avīci hell without respite. A person named Sunakṣata committed many kinds of non-virtue, then came into the presence of the Buddha — and upon hearing those words spoken, that all his sins were thereby purified, King Ajātaśatru spoke to Jīvaka: "Today I have indeed heard two such accounts, yet

whether they are true or not I cannot be certain in my mind. Jīvaka, come here. I would be pleased to ride together with you on a single ox. If I should fall into the avīci hell, see to it that you keep me from falling." And why? "Before this, I heard it said: a person who has attained the path does not go to hell."

Then the Blessed One declared to the great assembly: "Great King Ajātaśatru still harbors a mind of doubt. That mind of his must without fail be resolved."

Then within that assembled retinue, a bodhisattva named Sarvadharmadhara addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has taught, the defining characteristic of all phenomena is indeterminate. That is to say, form is of the nature of indeterminacy, and so on all the way to nirvāṇa — all are of the nature of indeterminacy. If that is so, why then did the Tathāgata determine the mind of King Ajātaśatru?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! I have now indeed determined the mind of King Ajātaśatru. And why is that? If the king's mind were something that could be shattered by doubt, then one should understand that all phenomena likewise have no fixed defining characteristic. Therefore, understand that this very act by which I determined the mind of King Ajātaśatru is itself without fixed determination. Noble son, if the mind of that king were something fixed, then the grave misconduct of his unrelenting transgressions could not be destroyed. Because it is without fixity, that misconduct can be destroyed. For this reason I have determined the mind of King Ajātaśatru."

Then the great king went to the presence of the Buddha at the foot of the śāla tree. Beholding the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent minor marks of the Tathāgata, he perceived him to be like a mountain of pure gold. The Blessed One then projected a voice of eight qualities and called out, "Great King!" At that moment, Ajātaśatru looked around and thought: "Among this great assembly, who is it that bears the name 'Great King'? I am burdened with heavy misdeeds and without virtue — it would be unfitting for the Tathāgata to address me as 'Great King.'" Then the Tathāgata called out once more: "Great King Ajātaśatru!"

When the king heard this, a mind of intense joy arose in him, and he thought: "The Tathāgata has called me today and spoken to me — surely the Tathāgata's great compassion for all sentient beings is perfectly equal and impartial toward all." He then addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, today not even a trace of doubt remains in my mind. I have understood most

deeply that the Tathāgata is truly the unsurpassed Teacher of all sentient beings."

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa said to the bodhisattva Sarvadharmadhara:

The Tathāgata had resolved the mind of King Ajātaśatru. Then King Ajātaśatru addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, even if I were today in the company of Brahmā or of Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), and were paying homage to them together, I would feel no joy in that. But having met the Tathāgata and been spoken to by him with even a single word, I am filled with the greatest delight."

Then King Ajātaśatru made offerings with parasols, banners, flowers, incense, music, and other such things that had been prepared in advance. He prostrated at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him three times to the right, and took his seat to one side.

The Blessed One then spoke to King Ajātaśatru: "Great King, I shall teach you the discourse of the noble Dharma. Listen with great attentiveness and reflection. Foolish, ignoble beings always contemplate this body, holding it to be a permanent thing, in twenty ways. These twenty are as follows: that this body of mine is like a storehouse of accumulations; that it is not without defilement; that roots of virtue are absent in it; that I have not been tamed in this wandering through saṃsāra; that I have fallen into a very deep abyss and am surrounded on all sides by fear; that by whatever means one might see the intrinsic nature of a buddha; that however one cultivates meditative absorption one sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha; that saṃsāra is always suffering, lacking permanence, happiness, self, and purity; that the eight unfree states are difficult to abandon; that one is severely tormented by enemies who harbor resentment; that there is not even a single factor that can turn one back from existence; that one has not been freed from the three lower realms; that one is possessed of various kinds of evil wrong views and non-virtuous conduct; that one has not accumulated the store that transcends the five acts of immediate consequence; that saṃsāra has no end and no ultimate conclusion; that if actions are not performed, results are not obtained; that results produced by one's own actions cannot be experienced by another; that if the cause of happiness is not created, the fruit of happiness does not arise; that even though actions are performed, their results are not lost; and that one is born from the cause of ignorance and dies through the cause of ignorance — along with always engaging in laziness in past, present, and

future. These twenty are the objects of contemplation. Great King, it is with these twenty kinds of contemplation about this body that foolish, ignoble ordinary beings are always engaged. Having contemplated in this way, one will come to have no delight in saṃsāra. Through having no delight in saṃsāra, one will attain insight and calm abiding.

"Then, gradually, one contemplates the mind, the characteristics of arising, the characteristics of abiding, and the characteristics of cessation. Just as one contemplates the characteristics of the mind, arising, abiding, and cessation in sequence, so too with meditative absorption, wisdom, diligence, and moral discipline. Having understood arising, abiding, and cessation, if one thoroughly knows everything from the characteristics of mind through to the characteristics of moral discipline, one will never commit non-virtue and will have no fear of death nor fear of the three lower realms. If one does not contemplate those twenty things with one-pointed mind, laziness and pride will arise, and one will end up committing all manner of non-virtue."

King Ajātaśatru said: "As I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, I formerly committed a great deal of non-virtue because I had not contemplated those twenty things. Having committed a great deal of non-virtue, fear of death and fear of the three lower realms have come upon me. Blessed One, I have deceived myself and committed such a grave wrong. I killed my royal father, who had committed no offense. Whether or not one understands those twenty things, one will inevitably fall into the hell of immediate consequence — this I know for certain."

The Blessed One then declared:

"Great King, since the intrinsic nature and defining characteristic of all phenomena is impermanence and indeterminacy, why do you say that you will certainly fall into the hells?"

King Ajātaśatru then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if indeterminacy is indeed the defining characteristic of all phenomena, then is not the wrong I committed by killing also indeterminate? And if that killing were something determinate, then all phenomena would no longer be indeterminate."

The Blessed One declared: "Great King, excellent, excellent! The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have indeed taught that indeterminacy is the defining characteristic of all phenomena. And since the King himself now knows that the killing is indeterminate, know therefore that killing bears the defining

characteristic of indeterminacy.

"Great King, as you yourself said, you killed your royal father even though he had committed no offense. But as to what is meant by 'father' in this case — what is called 'father' is merely a perception (*saṃjñā*) applied to the five aggregates of a sentient being, a label given by convention and nothing more. Among the twelve sense bases and the eighteen elements, what is there that is 'father'? If form is the father, then the other four aggregates are excluded. If the four aggregates are the father, then form is excluded. And if what is meant by father is something that arises from the combination of what is form and what is not form and then transcends them — that is simply not tenable. Why so? Because what is form and what is not form are by nature incompatible for combination.

"Great King, inferior beings form the wrong perception of 'father' in relation to the aggregate of form. Yet that very aggregate of form is not something that can be killed. Why so? Form has ten aspects, and among those ten aspects form alone can be looked at, grasped, sought, measured, led away, and bound — it can be looked at and bound in this way; yet by its intrinsic nature it does not abide. Because it does not so abide, it cannot be looked at, cannot be grasped, cannot be measured, cannot be led away, cannot be bound. Since the defining characteristic of form is such as this, how can it be killed?

"If form were the father, and if it could be killed and harmed and a sin thereby ripened, then the remaining nine aspects would be excluded. But if those nine are excluded, then there is no sinful wrong at all.

"Great King, form has three aspects: past, future, and present. The past and the present cannot be killed. Why so? The past has already passed. The present ceases moment by moment. It is said that killing is the prevention of what is yet to come. Thus, of the one category of form, some aspects may be killable and some may not. Because some are killable and some are not, there is no determinacy with respect to form. Since there is no determinacy with respect to form, killing too is without determinacy. Since killing is without determinacy, karmic maturation is likewise without determinacy. How then can it be said that one will certainly fall into the hells?

"Great King, the sinful deeds performed by all sentient beings are entirely of two kinds: light and heavy. Those committed through mind and speech are light. Those committed through body, speech, mind, and mentation together are heavy.

"Great King, if something is conceived in the mind, expressed in speech, but not carried out in body, then the karmic maturation of everything so done is light.

"Great King, you did not give the order 'Kill him at once.' You gave the order 'Cut off his feet.' And if, Great King, while standing you had ordered your minister 'Cut off the king's head,' but the minister had carried it out only after sitting down, then even so no sin would accrue. How much less, then, would sin accrue if the King had not given the order at all? If the King does in fact incur sin, then the Blessed One, the Buddha, would also incur sin. Why so? Because your father, King Bimbisāra, was always cultivating roots of virtue directed toward the Buddha, and through this the king attained his royal estate."

If the Blessed One, the Buddha, had not accepted those offerings, your father would never have become king. And if he had not become king, you would have had no kingdom or royal estate to kill him for. If it is sinful for you to have killed your father, then I and all the other Blessed Buddhas would likewise be fitting recipients of sin. But if no sin accrues to the Blessed Buddhas, why should sin accrue to you alone?

Great King, consider the story of King Bimbisāra. Long ago he was roaming in the mountains of Pūrvavideha, having set out in pursuit of a deer that had escaped, and after searching through every stretch of forest and wilderness he found nothing at all — until he came upon a single sage endowed with the five kinds of higher knowledge. Upon seeing this sage, a mind of aversion arose in him: "It is because of this man that the deer has escaped and I have found nothing today." With that thought he chased the sage off the mountain and ordered his attendants to kill him. At the moment of that sage's death, a mind of rage arose in him, and by that anger his supernatural powers were destroyed. Then the sage made this solemn vow: "Though I am without fault, you have killed me through your mind and speech, pressing me with intensity — so in a future time I too shall kill you in just this way, through mind and speech." When the king heard this, remorse arose in his mind, and he performed funeral rites for the sage's body. Yet because the king had acted as he did, sin accrued to him again and again, though not to the point of falling into the hells — how much less, then, would the ripening of a hell result for a king who did not act as he had? If the suffering that Bimbisāra underwent was the ripening of what he himself had done, how could the sin of killing now accrue to the king?

Just as it is said that King Bimbisāra's father was without fault — in what way is it appropriate to say there is no fault? One who is associated with sin will experience the ripening of that sin. One who performs virtuous actions will have no ripening of sinful karma. If your father the king was truly without sin, how could any karma ripen for him? Bimbisāra in the present age is receiving both the fruits of virtue and the fruits of non-virtue. Therefore the previous king is indeterminate. Being indeterminate, the killing too is indeterminate. And if the killing is indeterminate, why insist that he will certainly fall into the hells?

As for sentient beings, there are four types of intoxication and killing: intoxication by desire, intoxication by medicine, intoxication by mantra, and intoxication by the condition of past karma. Great King, even among my own attendants there are those afflicted by these four kinds of intoxication who have committed abundant non-virtue, yet scripture does not declare them to have broken their ethical discipline. Whatever they have done, they will not go to the three lower realms, and if they come back to their senses, one should not say their ethical discipline has been impaired.

As for the king — if he killed his father king out of desire for the kingdom and royal estate, acting from a mind intoxicated by desire, how could sin accrue? Great King, consider the analogy of a man who, intoxicated with ale, kills his mother. When he becomes sober and a mind of deep remorse arises in him, know that karma to be one that will not ripen in its full fruit. The king likewise acted out of intoxication by desire, not with full mindfulness. Since he did not act with full mindfulness, how could a blameworthy sin accrue to him?

Great King, consider further: a magician at a crossroads conjures all manner of illusory forms — men and women, yaks, horses, jewel-handled swords, fine garments and the like — and a foolish, deluded simpleton takes them to be genuine and real.

The wise and discerning one, however, understands that it is not real. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, consider further: a fool mired in delusion takes the sound of an echo to be a genuine voice. The wise and discerning one understands it to be not real. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, consider further: when an enemy approaches by stealth, a person mired in delusion takes him to be a genuine friend drawing near. The wise and discerning one knows him to be a deceiver. Killing is likewise similar: foolish ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, just as when one's own face appears in a mirror, a person mired in delusion takes it to be a real face. The wise and discerning one, through clear understanding, knows it to be not real. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, consider further: a person mired in delusion takes a mirage to be water. The wise and discerning one, through clear understanding, knows it is not water. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, consider further: a foolish person mired in delusion takes a gandharva city to be real. The wise and discerning one, through clear understanding, knows it to be not real. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, consider further: a person mired in delusion takes the experience of enjoyment of the five sense pleasures within a dream to be real. The wise and discerning one, through clear understanding, knows it to be not real. Killing is likewise similar: foolish, deluded ordinary persons take it to be genuinely real, while the Blessed One, the buddha, understands it to be not real.

Great King, I have clearly understood this: from the phenomenon of killing, through the act of killing, the killer, the fruit of killing, and on to liberation itself, there is no blameworthy karma whatsoever.

Great King, why then should sin accrue from the mere knowing of killing? Great King, consider: a person who brews ale — if he does not drink it, he will not become drunk. In the same way, one who draws near to fire will not be burned unless they touch it. The king is likewise in this regard: why should sin accrue from the mere knowing of killing?

Great King, there are some sentient beings who, when the sun rises, commit various kinds of blameworthy sins, and when the moon rises, they rob and steal. If the sun and moon did not rise, they would not commit those sins. Yet although sins are committed through the condition of the sun and moon, no sin truly attaches to the sun and moon themselves. Killing is likewise similar: although things have come to be thus through the king serving as a condition, no sin truly attaches to the king.

Great King, just as in the royal capital sheep are constantly caused to be slaughtered, yet a man who from the very beginning has no mind of fear — why should fear arise in him on account of his father alone?

Great King, just as there is a hierarchy of distinctions between humans and animals, yet in their clinging to life and their dread of losing it the two are no different — why then is it that for the sheep there is no frightened, uneasy mind, yet for his father the king there arises the grief of deep non-virtue?

Great King, worldly beings have become the servants of desire and have lost all freedom. Because they are driven by desire, they perform the act of killing. If there is karmic maturation of that act as its result, then it is desire that becomes the sin. Since the king acts without freedom, why should fault accrue to him?

Great King, consider this: nirvāṇa in its fullness is neither existent nor nonexistent, and yet it is existent. Killing is similar: it is neither existent nor nonexistent, and yet it does come to be existent. For one who possesses shame and moral conscience, it is not existent. For one who lacks shame and moral conscience, it is not nonexistent. The experience of karmic maturation as its result is what is called existent. For one who views things as empty, it is not existent; for one who views things as existent, it is not nonexistent; for one who views things as existent, it is called existent. Why is that? For one who holds the view that things exist, there is karmic maturation as a result. For one who does not hold that view, there is no karmic maturation as a result.

For one who holds the view of permanence, it is not existent; for one who holds the view of impermanence, it is not nonexistent; for one who holds the view that what is permanent is permanent, it is not nonexistent. Why is that? For one who views what is permanent as permanent, there is the result of non-virtuous karma — and therefore it would not be right to say that for one who views what is permanent as permanent it is nonexistent. Thus, while it is neither existent nor nonexistent, it is also not existent.

Great King, what is called a sentient being is the flowing of breath, inner and outer. To cut off that flowing of breath is called killing. Even the Tathāgatas speak of killing in a manner that accords with worldly convention.

Great King, form is impermanent, and what arises in dependence upon form is likewise impermanent. If it arises from an impermanent cause, how could form be permanent? Consciousness is impermanent, and all that arises in dependence upon consciousness, down to the last arising by dependent origination, is impermanent. If it arises from an impermanent cause, how could consciousness be permanent? Being thus impermanent, it is suffering. Being suffering, it is empty. Being empty, it is without self.

If things are impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self, then what kills what? If the impermanent is slain, one attains the permanent nirvāṇa. If suffering is slain, one attains bliss. If the empty is slain, one attains what is true. If the selfless is slain, one attains the true self.

Great King, one who slays the impermanent, the suffering, the empty, and the selfless is like me. I too have slain the impermanent, the suffering, the empty, and the selfless — and if I did not fall into the hells on that account, why should you?

Then King Ajātaśatru, just as the Blessed One had instructed, examined form and contemplated all the way through to consciousness. Having understood it thus, he addressed the Blessed One in these words:

Blessed One, I have now come to understand, for the very first time, that from form to consciousness all is impermanent. Had I understood it thus before, I would not have committed that blameworthy sin.

Blessed One, I had previously heard it said that the awakened ones, the Blessed Buddhas, are always like father and mother to sentient beings. Though I heard those words, I did not understand them with certainty. Now, for the first time, I understand them with certainty.

Blessed One, I had also heard this: Mount Meru, king of mountains, is made of four precious substances, namely gold, silver, lapis lazuli, and crystal.

Though I had heard it said that in whatever direction many birds gather together, they take on a color matching that place, I did not understand it with certainty. Today I have gone into the presence of the Tathāgata, who is Mount Meru, and I have become of matching color. And what is meant by "becoming of matching color"? It means becoming equal in understanding that all

phenomena are impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self.

Blessed One, in this world I have seen a sandal tree growing from the seed of a sandal tree, but I have never seen a sandalwood tree growing from the seed of an eraṇḍa plant. Today, for the very first time, I have seen a sandalwood tree grown from an eraṇḍa seed. The eraṇḍa seed is my own body; the sandalwood tree is the rootless ground of faith in my mind. By "rootless" I mean this: that formerly I had no wish to pay reverence to the Tathāgata, and I had no faith in the Dharma and the Saṅgha — that is what I call "rootless."

Blessed One, had I not encountered the buddha, the Blessed One, I would have experienced boundless suffering in the great hell for immeasurable and countless eons. Today I have come to behold the buddha, and by whatever merit I have gained through beholding the buddha, may all the afflictions and unwholesome minds of sentient beings be destroyed.

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, excellent, great king! I know with certainty that today the unwholesome minds of sentient beings have been destroyed."

The king spoke again: "Blessed One, if through my reflection in this manner the unwholesome minds of sentient beings are destroyed, then even if I were to remain in hell forever and take on great suffering for the sake of sentient beings for immeasurable eons, I would not regard it as suffering."

Then at that time, countless many people of the Middle Country gave rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening (bodhicitta). Because of their giving rise to it so fully, the heavy sin of King Ajātaśatru (the king whose enemy was born with him) became lighter. Then the king and the queen and the ministers and all the others simultaneously gave rise to the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

Thereupon King Ajātaśatru said to his physician Jīvaka: "Jīvaka, without my dying, I have obtained a divine body. Having abandoned a short life, I have come to have a long life. Having abandoned the impermanent body, I have obtained a permanent body. This is what it means to arouse in sentient beings the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. Now I have a divine body, long-lived and permanent; I am close to all the buddhas."

Having spoken these words, he made offerings to the Blessed One with victory banners of many kinds of precious substances, with pennants, parasols, incense, flowers, garlands, and excellent music, and then praised him with

these verses:

That one possessed of utterly true and pure speech,
supremely skilled in word and meaning,
reveals even the essence of the profound and secret
with clarity to the multitudes.

Words vast and boundless beyond measure
he gathers and teaches in brief summary to the assembly.
Endowed with such speech as this,
he is skilled in healing the illness of sentient beings.

Whatever sentient being hears those words —
whether one of faith or one without faith —
comes to understand that it is the speech of a buddha.
The speech of a buddha is gentle,
yet he also speaks words that are rough to the assembly.
Both what is spoken gently and what is spoken roughly
are, in both cases, the ultimate truth.
Therefore I too, here today,
go for refuge to the Blessed One.

The speech of the Blessed One is of one taste,
just as the water of the great ocean is one.
It is called the supreme truth:
there is not a single word in it that is without meaning.

Today the Tathāgata has —
taught immeasurable phenomena,
so that men and women alike, upon hearing them,
may accordingly attain the ultimate truth.
Without cause there is no result;
there is no arising and no cessation.
That is nirvāṇa:
hearing it, one destroys karmic maturation.
The Tathāgata acts as the supremely loving
father and mother of all.
Know that ordinary sentient beings, each and every one,
are the children of the Tathāgata.
With a mind of loving compassion,
the Blessed One has undergone hardship for the sake of the many.

Just as one seized by an evil spirit
acts in many and varied ways while possessed,
so too all the virtue of the three gates of action
by which I today have seen the Blessed One —
whatever merit I have thereby obtained,
I dedicate to unsurpassed awakening.

Whatever merit I have generated today
by making offerings to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha,
by that merit may the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha —
the Three Jewels — dwell in the world forever.

Whatever merit I have obtained here today in this very place,
by that merit may the four māras of all sentient beings
be utterly destroyed.

By my encounter with evil companions,
whatever wrongdoing I have committed in the three times —
all of it I confess here and now in your presence,
and from this day forward I shall commit no more evil.

May all ordinary sentient beings,
having aroused the mind of awakening,
hold in mind with one-pointed thought
all the Victors of the ten directions.

Further, may all sentient beings,
having thoroughly vanquished their many afflictions,
come to perceive the nature of a buddha
just as Mañjuśrī does.

Then the Blessed One said to King Ajātaśatru: "Excellent! Excellent!" Whoever
arouses the mind of awakening is said to be completely adorned with the
maṇḍala of a buddha.

"Great King, long ago you aroused the mind of awakening before the buddha
Viśvabhū. From that time until my appearance in the world, you did not
experience the suffering of falling into hell. Great King, know this: the
awakening mind has immeasurable fruits of that very kind. Great King, from
this day forward you must always strive in the awakening mind. And why is
that? Because through that cause and that condition, immeasurable

unwholesome actions are purified."

Then King Ajātaśatru rose from his seat amid the people of the region of Madhyāntika, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and departed for his palace.

The chapter on divine conduct is as explained in the sūtra called the Array of Various Flowers.

From the Noble Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, this is the seventh chapter, entitled "The Holy Life."

Noble son, what then is the conduct of an infant? Noble son, an infant cannot stand up, sit, come, go, or speak — such is what is called the conduct of an infant. The Tathāgata is similar to that. That the Tathāgata cannot stand up means that the Tathāgata does not rise from the defining marks of all phenomena. That he cannot sit means that the Tathāgata has no attachment to any phenomena. That he cannot come means that the bodily conduct of the Tathāgata is unmoving. That he cannot go means that the Tathāgata has perfected the completion of great nirvāṇa. That he cannot speak means that although the Tathāgata teaches phenomena to all sentient beings, in ultimate truth there is no teaching. And why is that? Whatever teaching there is belongs to conditioned phenomena; but the Blessed One, the Buddha, is unconditioned, and therefore he has no teaching. Furthermore, that he does not speak means: just as an infant, though it utters sounds, does not know how to articulate words clearly, so in ultimate truth there is no speaking. The Tathāgata is similar to this:

"Speaking unclearly" means that the Tathāgatas teach with intention and purpose. And even though they do teach, because sentient beings do not understand, it is said that they do not speak.

Again, "an infant" means that, not knowing words properly, it has not yet fixed upon a single name for a thing. And though it has not fixed upon a single name for a thing due to not knowing words properly, apart from that cause there is no other way by which knowledge of the thing could come about. The Tathāgata is similar to this: because all sentient beings belong to many different classes with different dispositions, words do not agree, yet by teaching each according to their capacity through skillful means, the Tathāgata causes all of them to understand.

Again, "an infant" means that it can only utter the one great syllable. The Tathāgata is likewise, for he teaches the one great syllable — namely, "bha-hva." In this, "hva" signifies the conditioned, and "bha" signifies the unconditioned. That is what is meant by "infant." "Hva" means: I am impermanent. "Bha" means: permanence. And because the Tathāgata teaches permanence, sentient beings who hear it, wishing to say that phenomena are permanent, cut off what is impermanent. That is the conduct of the infant.

Again, an infant does not know suffering and pleasure, day and night, or father and mother. The great bodhisattva (bodhisattva mahāsattva) is likewise: for the sake of sentient beings, seeing no distinction between pleasure and suffering, there is no such thing as day or night; and because one's mind is equal toward all sentient beings, there is no distinction of the characteristic marks of father, mother, or kin.

Again, an infant cannot perform great or minor deeds. The great bodhisattva is likewise: because the bodhisattva does not perform the deeds of cyclic existence, it is said that he does not act. As for "great deeds," these are the five acts of immediate consequence (pārājika), and the great bodhisattva never commits the heavy misdeeds of these five acts of immediate consequence. As for "minor deeds," these are thoughts of the two other vehicles, and the bodhisattva never turns away from the awakening mind and falls into the vehicle of the śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Furthermore, the conduct of a child is this: when an infant cries, the parents give it a yellow willow leaf, saying, "Child, do not cry, do not cry — I will give you gold," and upon seeing this, the infant develops the perception that it is real gold and stops crying. But that willow leaf is not real gold. If an infant sees carved wooden oxen, horses, men, and women, it develops the perception that they are actual men and women, and stops crying. Because it places the perception of men and women upon what are not men and women, it is called an infant.

The Tathāgata is likewise. When sentient beings commit many non-virtuous acts, the Tathāgata teaches that in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three there is permanence, bliss, selfhood, utter purity, beauty, and abundant enjoyment; that within magnificent palaces one enjoys the five objects of desire; and that all the counterparts to the six senses are nothing but bliss and joy. Hearing that such bliss exists, sentient beings give rise to a mind attached to bliss, abandon non-virtue, and strive in the virtuous deeds that lead to the Heaven

of the Thirty-Three. But this is genuine cyclic existence — it is impermanent, without bliss, without self, and not utterly pure. Yet in order to liberate sentient beings, through skillful means he teaches it as permanent, blissful, a self, and utterly pure.

Again, "an infant" means:

If there are sentient beings who feel profound weariness with cyclic existence, the Tathāgata teaches them the two vehicles. Even though, in ultimate truth, the two vehicles have no existence of their own, by reason of the two vehicles one comes to know the faults of cyclic existence and to see the bliss of nirvāṇa. Through seeing in this way, one comes to know for oneself what is to be cut off and what is not, what is true and what is not, what is to be practiced and what is not, what is attained and what is not.

Noble son, just as a toymaker gives rise to the perception of gold regarding something that is not gold, so too the Tathāgata, in a similar way, describes what is not utterly pure as utterly pure. In reality, the Tathāgata has no falsehood, because it is for the purpose of attaining the ultimate. Just as a toymaker perceives something that is neither a cow nor a horse as a cow or a horse, so too, if there are sentient beings who take what is not the path to be the genuine path, the Tathāgata likewise teaches what is not the path as the path. Although what is not the path is not genuinely the path, it is taught as the path because it is capable of generating at least some causes of the path. Just as a toymaker perceives wooden boys and girls as real boys and girls, so too the Tathāgata, in a similar way, though knowing that what is presented lacks the defining characteristics of a sentient being, nonetheless teaches the defining characteristics of sentient beings. In reality, there are no defining characteristics of a sentient being. If the Blessed One, the buddha, were to teach that sentient beings do not exist, all sentient beings would fall into the wrong view of nihilism. Therefore the Tathāgata has declared that sentient beings exist. To impose the perception of a sentient being upon what is a sentient being is to be unable to dissolve the defining characteristics of a sentient being. But whoever dissolves the defining characteristics of a sentient being from within what appears as a sentient being will attain great nirvāṇa. Having thus attained great nirvāṇa, one will no longer weep — and that is called the conduct of an infant.

Noble son, if any man or woman holds, maintains, recites, writes out, liberates others by, or teaches these five conducts, know that such a person will without

doubt attain those five conducts. Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, in accordance with my understanding of the meaning as taught by the Blessed One, I too have without doubt attained those five conducts. The Blessed One declared: Noble son, it is not you alone who have attained those five conducts — right now, within this very assembly, nine hundred and thirty thousand people have likewise attained those five conducts just as you have.

This concludes the eighth chapter of the Noble Sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa, called "The Conduct of a Young Infant."

The Noble Sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa. The twenty-eighth fascicle.

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to the great bodhisattva Sarvadarśī Uttamaśrīrāja: Noble son, if a great bodhisattva practices yoga on this Sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa, that bodhisattva will attain ten qualities — qualities not shared with śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas, inconceivable, such that merely hearing them is a source of wonder and amazement. These qualities are neither inner nor outer, neither difficult nor easy, neither characterized nor uncharacterized, not of the world — they are free from marks and forms, and do not exist anywhere in the world.

What are the ten qualities? As for the first, it has five aspects. What are the five? First, one will come to hear what has not been heard. Second, having heard, it will become of benefit. Third, doubt and vacillation will be decisively cut through. Fourth, there will be no guile or deception in one's wisdom. Fifth, one will understand the profound meaning intended and expressed by the Tathāgata. Those are the five.

Now, what is meant by "one will come to hear what has not been heard"? It is this: the profoundly deep meaning intended and expressed by the Tathāgata — that buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) is present in all sentient beings; that there is no difference between the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha; that the intrinsic nature of the Three Jewels is characterized by permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity; that none of the blessed buddhas ever finally pass into nirvāṇa, for they are permanent, stable, unchanging, and unalterable — and that the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa is neither existent nor nonexistent, neither conditioned nor unconditioned, neither defiled nor undefiled, neither form nor formless, neither name nor nameless, neither characterized nor uncharacterized, neither existent nor nonexistent, neither thing nor no-thing, neither cause nor effect, neither relative nor independent, neither appearance

nor darkness, neither arisen nor unarisen, neither permanent nor impermanent, neither annihilated nor unannihilated, neither a beginning nor an end, neither past nor future nor present, neither aggregate nor non-aggregate, neither sense base nor non-sense-base, neither element nor non-element, neither the twelve links of dependent origination nor other than the twelve links of dependent origination — these and all such profoundly deep matters, expressed with intent, one will come to hear for the first time, having never heard them before.

And furthermore, what else has not been heard before? The four orders of learning belonging to all the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), the learning of grammar, the learning of kingship, the learning of arithmetic and calculation, and so forth; mantras and incantations, medicine and medical analysis, the arts, the eclipse of the sun and moon by the planetary demon, the shifts and movements of the stars, drawing and writing, the learning of prophecy and divination, and all such writings — the hidden meaning of all that learning, which one had not heard before, will now come to be understood through this sūtra.

And furthermore, the profoundly deep meaning intended and expressed — which is absent from the other eleven sūtra collections apart from the very extensive sūtras — will also come to be understood through the occasion of this sūtra. O son of good family, that is what is meant by "one will come to hear what has not been heard."

As for "having heard, it will become of benefit": if one takes up and upholds this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, one will be able to know in full the entire savour of the profoundly deep meanings of the extensive Mahāyāna sūtras. Just as boys or girls see their appearance and form clearly reflected in a bright mirror, so too is this mirror of the Great Nirvāṇa: when a bodhisattva has heard it, the profoundly deep meanings of the Mahāyāna sūtra collections are seen with clarity. And furthermore, just as when someone brings a great lamp into a dark chamber all things become visible, so too is the lamp of the Great Nirvāṇa: when a bodhisattva holds it, even those profound and difficult-to-see meanings of the Great Vehicle become visible. And furthermore, just as when the sun rises with its thousand rays of light it illuminates the deepest darkness in every mountain valley, and all beings see things from a great distance, so too is the sun of the pure wisdom of the Great Nirvāṇa: it illuminates the most profound reaches of the Great Vehicle, and causes the awakening of a buddha to be seen from a far greater distance than the vehicles of the śrāvakas and

pratyekabuddhas. And why? Because one listens to and upholds this supreme sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa.

Noble son, whatever great bodhisattva listens to or upholds this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa in this way will come to understand all the synonyms of the Dharma. And if one writes it down, reads it, recites it, thoroughly absorbs it, expounds it in full to others, and reflects upon its meaning, one will come to understand the meaning of all phenomena in the proper way.

Noble son, one who merely listens to and upholds it will know only the synonyms, and will not realize the meaning itself. But one who writes it down, memorizes it, reads it, recites it, expounds it in full to others, and reflects upon its meaning will come to realize the meaning itself.

Furthermore, noble son, by merely listening to this sūtra one hears that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists, but is unable to see it. But one who writes it down and reads it, recites it, expounds it in full to others, and reflects upon its meaning will come to see it.

By merely listening to this sūtra one will attain generosity, but will not yet see the perfection of generosity. If one writes down this sūtra and recites it, reads it, expounds it in full to others, and reflects upon its meaning, one will come to see all the perfections from the perfection of generosity through to the Perfection of Wisdom.

Noble son, if a great bodhisattva listens to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, one will come to know the Dharma and to know its meaning. When one is endowed with both of these kinds of individual perfect knowledge, one will have fearlessness before all — whether ascetics (śramaṇas), brahmins, gods, māras, Brahmā, or any others of the world — one will be without contradiction in distinguishing and teaching the meaning of the twelve branches of scripture, one will understand things through one's own insight without having heard them from others, and one will draw near to the unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Noble son, this is what is called "being benefited upon hearing." What is called "the cutting off of a doubting mind" has two aspects: doubting words, and doubting meaning. By listening to this sūtra, doubt about words is cut off. By reflecting upon its meaning, doubt about the meaning is cut off.

Furthermore, noble son, doubt has five aspects: doubting whether a buddha definitively passes into nirvāṇa; doubting whether a buddha abides

permanently; doubting whether a buddha is truly real; doubting whether a buddha is truly perfectly pure; and doubting whether a buddha truly has a self. By listening to this sūtra, the doubt about whether a buddha passes into nirvāṇa will be completely resolved. By writing it down, reading it, reciting it, expounding it in full to others, and reflecting upon its meaning, the remaining four doubts will be completely resolved.

Noble son, furthermore, doubt has three aspects: doubting whether śrāvakas exist or do not exist; doubting whether pratyekabuddhas exist or do not exist; and doubting whether buddhas exist or do not exist. By merely listening to this sūtra, all three of these doubts will be eliminated without remainder. By writing it down, reading it, reciting it, expounding it in full to others, and reflecting upon its meaning, one will come to realize that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists in all sentient beings.

Noble son, if any sentient being has not heard this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, they will have many doubting thoughts such as these: whether things are permanent or impermanent, pleasant or unpleasant, perfectly pure or impure, whether there is a self or no self, whether there is a life-force or there is not, whether one is a sentient being or is not, whether things have an ultimate end or do not, whether there is a future time or

a past time, or whether things exist or do not exist, whether something is suffering or is not suffering, whether something is the origin of suffering or is not its origin, whether something is the path or is not the path, whether something is cessation or is not cessation, whether something is Dharma or is not Dharma, whether something is virtue or is not virtue, whether something is empty or is not empty. If one hears this sūtra, all such doubts will be completely resolved.

Furthermore, noble son, if one has not heard this sūtra, still more doubting thoughts will arise. For instance: Is form the self, or is feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness the self? Or does the eye see, or does the self see? And likewise, from the eye up through consciousness — can consciousness know, or does the self know? Does form experience karmic maturation, or does the self experience maturation? And likewise, from form through to consciousness — does consciousness experience karmic maturation, or does the self experience it? Does form pass on to the world beyond, or does the self pass on to the world beyond? And likewise with consciousness. Does saṃsāra have a beginning and an end, or does it have no

beginning and no end? Such are the doubts that arise. If one hears this sūtra, all such doubts and the like will be completely resolved. This is what is called the resolving of doubt and uncertainty of mind.

What is called having no deceit or guile in wisdom? If there is doubt in the mind, all views will be wrong. If ordinary persons have not heard this precious sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, all their views will be wrong. And likewise, right through to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, all their views will be wrong.

In what way are childish ordinary persons said to hold wrong views? They regard defiled phenomena as permanent, pleasant, as a self, and as perfectly pure; and they regard the Tathāgata as impermanent, suffering, impure, and as lacking a self. They view sentient beings, life, a vital force, a seer, and a knower as existing. They grasp at the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception as nirvāṇa. They view the great god who wields sovereignty over the devas as possessing the noble eightfold path. They hold to views of permanence and views of annihilation. All such views are called wrong views.

If a great bodhisattva hears this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa and practices the noble conduct, all those wrong views will be no more.

In what sense do śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas also hold wrong views? When the bodhisattva descended from Tuṣita heaven, they hold that he rode a white elephant and entered the womb of his mother — whose father was Śuddhodana and whose mother was named Māyādevī — and that after ten full months in his mother's womb in the city of Kapilavastu he was born; and that at the time of birth, Śakra (Indra, king of the gods) held him above the ground so that he did not touch the earth, and that the two nāga kings Nanda and Upananda then poured down water to bathe and cool his body;

and that Maṇibhadra, the great king of yakṣas, held aloft a precious jeweled parasol; and that the earth deity (Skt. pṛthivīdevatā) conjured forth lotus blossoms to support his feet; and that he took seven steps in each of the four directions; and that he went to the realm of the gods, where all the gods rose to welcome him; and that the sage Asita took him in his arms and examined his marks; and that after examining the marks Asita was overcome with great suffering, thinking to himself, "I shall die before my time and will not live to see the buddha come to full awakening" — and so was plunged into deep grief; and that he learned writing, arithmetic, archery, navigation, painting, prognostication, and the arts from his teachers; and that he dwelt in the

palace, sporting and enjoying pleasures together with sixty thousand women and consorts; and that when he departed the palace and went for a walk, he saw at the gate of the city of Kapilavastu an old man, bent and decrepit; and that, just as he had seen that, he also saw a renunciant (Skt. śramaṇa) walking along, robed in the dharma-robe; and that after returning to the palace he saw the bodies and forms of the women and consorts as though they were mere skeletons; and that he saw the palace itself as no different from a charnel ground; and that, grown weary of the household, he departed the palace at the dead of night and went to the sages Uḍḍaka Rāmaputra, Ārāḍa Kālāma, and others, and from them he heard teachings on the sense base of infinite consciousness, and the sense bases of neither-perception-nor-non-perception; and that, having heard this, he thoroughly investigated those sense bases and recognized them to be impermanent, suffering, utterly impure, and without self, and so abandoned them; and that he then practiced austerities under a tree for six years; and that even having practiced such austerities he did not attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and that he then bathed in the river called Nairāñjanā, received from a cowherd woman an offering of milk porridge mixed with ghee, accepted it, and proceeded to the seat of awakening, where he tamed the evil māra and attained unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and that from there he went to Vārāṇasī and first turned the wheel of Dharma for the group of five monks, continuing up to his passage into great nirvāṇa here in the city of Kuśinagara — to hold such a view as this is called a wrong view on the part of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

O son of good family, if a bodhisattva, a great bodhisattva, hears, retains, recites, reads, thoroughly assimilates, expounds to others, and takes to heart the meaning of this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, all of those wrong views enumerated above will be entirely dispelled. Moreover, if one writes it down, reads it, recites it, thoroughly assimilates it, teaches it extensively to others, and applies its meaning to mind, one will obtain genuine wisdom and be freed from wrong views.

O son of good family, if a bodhisattva, a great bodhisattva, applies diligent effort to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, then the realization — from the bodhisattva's descent from Tuṣita and birth from his mother's womb through to his passage into great nirvāṇa here in the city of Kuśinagara — that this occurred throughout measureless eons, is called the right view of a bodhisattva, a great bodhisattva.

"Knowing the profound meaning of what the Tathāgata taught with a specific intent" refers to this: in this Great Nirvāṇa it is taught that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature, and that by virtue of this they may confess the four root downfalls, dispel the mind that slanders the sacred Dharma, be entirely purged of the faults of the five acts of immediate retribution, and be freed from the mind of wrong craving — and that thereafter they will attain perfect, complete unsurpassed awakening. This is what is meant by "the profound meaning taught with a specific intent."

O son of good family, furthermore, in what sense is the meaning exceedingly profound?

This, then, is what is meant by "the profound meaning taught with a specific intent": one has confidence that, even though sentient beings are rightly understood to be without a self, the karmic fruits of future actions will not fail to ripen; one understands that although these very five aggregates will without remainder be brought to cessation, wholesome and unwholesome actions will not fail to exist; one understands that although there are many kinds of karma, no agent can be pinpointed; that although there is a destination reached, there is no one who goes; that although there is bondage, there is no bound one; and that although there is nirvāṇa, there is no cessation. This is what is called "the profound meaning taught with a specific intent."

Then the great bodhisattva (bodhisattva), the great being, Universally Illuminating King of Majestic Glory, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, as I understand it, the meaning of the expression 'what was not heard shall come to be heard' that the Blessed One has used does not stand up. Why so? If something exists, it is necessarily a thing that exists. If something does not exist, it is necessarily a thing that does not exist. It is not fitting that what does not exist should arise, nor is it fitting that what does exist should be brought to cessation. In just the same way: what was heard is still called 'heard,' and what was not heard remains not heard. Why then did you say 'what was not heard shall come to be heard'? Blessed One, it is not fitting that what is not heard should come to be heard, and what was previously heard cannot become heard for the first time again. Why? Because it was heard before. Then why did you say 'what was not heard shall come to be heard'? Consider the analogy: if one has arrived, one does not travel; if one is traveling, one has not arrived. Furthermore: once one has been born, one is not being born; what is not being born will not come to be born. Once one has

attained, one does not attain; what is not attained will not come to be attained. Likewise, once one has heard, one does not hear; what is not heard will not come to be heard.

"Blessed One, if what is not heard were to come to be heard, it would follow that all sentient beings, even those who have not attained awakening, would attain it; that those who have not attained nirvāṇa would attain it; and that those who have not seen the buddha-nature would see it. Why then did you say: 'A bodhisattva abiding on the tenth ground has seen the buddha-nature, yet it has not become fully manifest'? Blessed One, if what is not heard were to come to be heard, what did the Tathāgata listen to in former times? If he listened to something, why did you say that the Tathāgata has no teacher who instructs from scripture? And if it is by hearing what was not heard that the Tathāgata attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, then by the same token all sentient beings, by hearing what they had not heard, would also be fit to attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Again, if the Tathāgata could behold the buddha-nature without having heard this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, then all sentient beings likewise, without having heard this sūtra, would be fit to behold the buddha-nature.

"Blessed One, some forms are seen and others are not seen. Sounds are the same: some are heard and others are not heard. But the Great Nirvāṇa is not a form and not a sound, so why did you say it is seen and heard? Blessed One, the past is ceased and therefore cannot be heard; the future has not yet arrived and therefore cannot be heard; and in the very moment of listening in the present, one does not yet call that 'hearing,' for once the sound has ceased after being heard, it has already passed beyond being heard. This Great Nirvāṇa belongs neither to the past, nor to the future, nor to the present — and if it does not belong to the three times, it is beyond all expression."

"If it is beyond expression, it cannot be heard either — so why did you say that a bodhisattva who applies himself diligently to this sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa will come to hear what he has not heard?"

Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva, the great being, the All-Illuminating, Sublime, Glorious King, and declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, you have understood most profoundly that all phenomena are like a magical illusion, like a mirage, like the city of a gandharva, like a drawing made on water — and further, like a bubble on water, like foam, like a plantain trunk — hollow throughout, without essence, not alive, not a self, and

free of suffering and pleasure. This is just as the bodhisattvas dwelling on the ten grounds know and see. Well done!

Then, in that very moment, in an instant, a great radiance appeared within that assembled retinue — not blue, yet seen as blue; not yellow, yet seen as yellow; not red, yet seen as red; not white, yet seen as white; not colored, yet seen as colored; not luminous, yet seen as luminous; not a seeing, yet seen — and this is what is called 'seeing.'

At that time, when that light touched the many members of the assembly, their bodies and minds became supremely blissful, just as when meditators enter the meditative absorption of the Lion King.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Mañjuśrī asked the Blessed One: "From where have these rays of light come?" At that moment the Tathāgata said nothing — he did not reply.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked Mañjuśrī: "By what cause and condition does this light appear to the many in the assembly?" And Mañjuśrī likewise said nothing — he did not reply.

Then the bodhisattva Anantakāya asked the bodhisattva Kāśyapa: "Whose light is this?" The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said nothing — he did not reply.

The bodhisattva Vimalasthitarājakumāra asked the bodhisattva Anantakāya: "By what cause and condition does this light exist among the many in the assembly?" And the bodhisattva Anantakāya likewise said nothing — he did not reply.

In just the same way, the five hundred bodhisattvas questioned one another in this manner, yet not one of them gave any answer.

Then the Blessed One addressed Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, by what cause and condition has this light appeared among all these many in the assembly?"

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, this light is primordial wisdom — and what is called primordial wisdom is something that abides permanently. What abides permanently has no cause and no condition. Why then, Blessed One, did you ask 'By what cause and condition has this light arisen?'

"This light is what is called Great Nirvāṇa — and what is called Great Nirvāṇa is something that abides permanently. What abides permanently did not arise from cause and condition. Why then, Blessed One, did you ask 'By what cause and condition does this light exist?'

"This light is what is called the Tathāgata — and what is called the Tathāgata is something that abides permanently. What abides permanently did not arise from cause and condition. Why then did the Tathāgata speak of cause and condition?

"This light is what is called loving-kindness and great compassion — and what is called loving-kindness and great compassion is something that abides permanently.

What abides permanently did not arise from cause and condition. Why then did the Tathāgata speak of cause and condition?

"This light is what is called recollection of the buddha. And what is called recollection of the buddha is something that abides permanently. What abides permanently did not arise from cause and condition. Why then did the Tathāgata speak of cause and condition?

"This light is what is called the path that is not shared with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. And the path that is not shared with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas is something that abides permanently. What abides permanently did not arise from cause and condition. Why then did the Tathāgata speak of cause and condition?

"Blessed One, there is no such thing as cause and condition. It is by the cause and condition of ignorance ceasing that the lamp of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening blazes forth."

The Blessed One then declared: "Mañjuśrī, without entering into the ultimate — which is the extremely profound meaning of the defining marks of all phenomena — speak and explain in conventional terms."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, to the east of here, beyond world-realms as numerous as the grains of sand in twenty Ganges rivers, there is a buddha-field called the Immovable. The extent of the dwelling place of the buddha who resides there is twenty thousand leagues in breadth. The ground of that realm is made entirely of the seven precious substances, with no earth or gravel — perfectly level and smooth, without ridge or furrow. The trees are made of gold, silver, lapis lazuli, crystal, and the four precious substances, and they perpetually abound with flowers and fruits. If any sentient being is touched by the fragrance of those flowers, the joy and ease of body and mind they experience is like that of monks who have entered the third meditative concentration.

"Surrounding that realm on all sides are three thousand great rivers, whose waters are pure and excellent, endowed with the eight qualities. If any sentient being bathes in those waters, the joy and bliss they attain is like that of monks who have entered the second meditative concentration.

"In those rivers there bloom many varieties of flowers of every kind: utpala, padma, kumuda, puṇḍarīka, fragrant flowers, greatly fragrant flowers, supremely fragrant flowers, the flower called Everlasting, and the flower called Unconquered-by-All-Beings — flowers of many forms and diverse kinds.

"Along the banks of those rivers too there bloom many varieties of flowers, namely: atimukta flowers, campaka flowers, pāṭala flowers, pāśika flowers, mārikā flowers, great mārikā flowers, simārikā flowers, sumanā flowers, yūthikā flowers, dandurikā flowers, Everlasting flowers, Unconquered-by-All-Beings flowers, and so forth.

"The bed of those rivers is spread with golden sand, and along their steps there stand terraces of gold, silver, lapis lazuli, and crystal of many diverse colors, upon which vast numbers of birds of every kind gather. And furthermore, there are immeasurable numbers of tigers, wolves, lions, and other fierce animals and birds, yet they regard one another as if they were their own young.

"In that buddha-field there are none who commit such misdeeds as breaking their root vows, disparaging the holy Dharma, holding wrong views, or committing the five acts of immediate consequence. In that field the temperature is always pleasant; no one is tormented by the suffering of hunger or thirst. There is no attachment, aversion, heedlessness, or jealousy. There is no sun, moon, day or night, or division of time.

Just as it is with the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, the people of that realm too are possessed of radiant light. None among them harbor pride or arrogance. All of them are great bodhisattvas who have attained higher knowledge, endowed with great qualities: they direct their minds toward reverencing and respecting the holy Dharma; they are borne up by the Great Vehicle; they have faith in the Great Vehicle; they are devoted to the Great Vehicle; they guard the Great Vehicle; they are endowed with great wisdom; they have attained the great dhāraṇī; and toward all sentient beings they are invariably filled with heartfelt love and care.

The name of the Blessed One of that realm is Radiance of the Full Moon. He is a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha, endowed with

knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide and charioteer of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One — and wherever he teaches the Dharma, there is not a single sentient being in that buddha-field who fails to hear it. That buddha teaches this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa to the bodhisattva, the great being, called Lapis-Lazuli Radiance. The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, any bodhisattva, any great being, who applies himself diligently to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa shall come to hear everything he has not yet heard." In precisely the same way that the bodhisattva, the great being, All-Illuminating King of Lofty and Glorious Majesty, addressed his question here — with no difference whatsoever — the bodhisattva, the great being, Lapis-Lazuli Radiance addressed his question to the buddha Radiance of the Full Moon. And the buddha Radiance of the Full Moon, having thus declared to the bodhisattva Lapis-Lazuli Radiance, "Son of good family, to the west of here, beyond a number of buddha-fields equal to the grains of sand of twenty Ganges rivers, there exists a world-system called Endurance."

In that world-system there are mountains, crags, ravines, valleys, thickets, and thorn-laden wildernesses filling every direction, and the beings there are perpetually tormented by the suffering of hunger, thirst, cold, and heat. The people of that land show no respect to renunciants (śramaṇas), brahmins, parents, teachers, or spiritual masters. They are attached to what is contrary to Dharma; they desire and cling to what is contrary to Dharma; they engage in conduct that is perverted and wrong; they have no trust in the holy Dharma; their lifespans are exceedingly short; those who commit misdeeds are cut down by the punishment of the king; and the kings, though surrounded by lands and dominions, know no contentment and do not know when enough is enough — they conceive the desire to seize the wealth of others, and through waging war, sudden deaths become many. Because the kings thus conduct themselves unrighteously, the gods of the Four Great Kings who are virtuous grow displeased, and as a result great pestilence arises, grain and crops fail to grow, disease among humans increases greatly, and beings are tormented by immeasurable and manifold sufferings.

In that world, the Blessed One called Śākyamuni — Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed one, guide and charioteer of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, buddha, Blessed One — moved by his exceedingly great compassion, out of loving care for sentient beings, teaches

this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa to a vast assembly gathered beneath the śāla trees in the city of Kuśinagara.

Then the bodhisattva called All-Illuminating King of Lofty and Glorious Majesty likewise, beginning from that very point, addressed his question: "You are no different from him." And that Blessed One likewise declared: "You must go swiftly, and you shall hear it."

The Blessed One — upon the bodhisattva Lapis-Lazuli Light hearing of such matters — together with eighty-four thousand great bodhisattvas (Skt. mahāsattva), came here, and a foretoken appeared beforehand: it was through this cause and this condition that this light arose. Yet one may also call it "cause and condition" — and yet it is not cause and condition.

Then the bodhisattva Lapis-Lazuli Light, together with those eighty-four thousand bodhisattvas, arranged a great many supremely excellent and varied offerings of banners, parasols, flowers, incense, garlands, and music, surpassing all that had come before. They all came to this grove of śāla trees in the city of Kuśinagara and, each with their own offerings and ritual requisites, made offering to the Blessed One. They touched their foreheads to the feet of the Blessed One, joined their palms in reverence, and with devoted homage circumambulated him three times. Having made offering, they took their places to one side.

Then the Blessed One spoke to those bodhisattvas: "Noble sons, have you come here, or have you not come?"

The bodhisattva Lapis-Lazuli Light replied: "Blessed One, in coming there is no arrival, and in not coming there is also no arrival. Because I have realized the meaning of this, there is simply no arrival in any sense. Blessed One, if all formations (Skt. saṃskāra) were permanent, then coming would be without arrival; and since they are impermanent, coming is likewise without arrival. Ordinary persons who hold that there is a fixed, inherent nature of sentient beings — for them there is neither coming nor not coming. Since I myself do not perceive any inherent nature fixed in sentient beings, on what grounds would you ask whether I have come or not come?

Those who are filled with pride see no going or coming, yet in the absence of pride there is also no going or coming. Those who possess clinging see no going or coming, yet in the absence of clinging there is also no going or coming. Those who see the Tathāgata as passing into nirvāṇa ultimately and finally see going and coming as real; those who do not view the Tathāgata as

having passed into nirvāṇa ultimately and finally see going and coming as unreal. Those who have not seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha see going and coming as real; those who have seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha see no going and coming. Those who see śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as having attained nirvāṇa see going and coming as real; those who do not see śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as having attained nirvāṇa see no going and coming. Those who view śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as possessing permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity see going and coming as real; those who do not view them thus see no going and coming. Those who view the Tathāgata as lacking permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity see going and coming as real; those who view the Tathāgata as possessing permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity see no going and coming.

Blessed One, let that matter rest for now. I humbly request that, out of loving care, you open the door and give me this opportunity to ask on one particular point."

The Blessed One replied: "Noble son, now the time has come — ask whatever you wish, and I shall expound the scripture pertaining to each matter and teach it. Why so? Because buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are exceedingly rare to encounter — just as the bloom of the udumbara flower. And the Dharma likewise is exceedingly rare to hear."

Among the twelve branches of scripture, hearing the vast expansive ones is exceedingly rare, and so one must listen with single-pointed mind.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vaiḍūryaprabhā, knowing that an opportunity had been granted and that the teaching would be given, addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, how is it that a bodhisattva, a great being, who cultivates this sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa, comes to hear what has not been heard before?"

The Blessed One then uttered the words "Excellent! Excellent!" and said: "Noble son, today you have resolved to traverse the entire ocean of the Great Vehicle's nirvāṇa without remainder — and I am meeting with a skilled teacher who has thoroughly taught and shown the way. So today I shall skillfully draw out all the nets of your doubts and all the thorns of your uncertainty whatsoever, acting as a great physician. You have not yet become clear about the nature of a buddha — let me cause the lamp of my wisdom to shine. If you wish to cross the great river of saṃsāra, let me become your guide. Generate toward me the perception of a father and mother, and I in turn regard you as I

would my own child. You seek the precious treasure of the sacred Dharma, and since I have it in abundance, now that we have met, receive it as a gift. Listen attentively and examine it well, and I shall expound and teach it in full detail.

Noble son, if you wish to hear the Dharma, the time has now come. If upon hearing the Dharma you give rise to faith, listen with single-pointed mind, and show reverence and respect. Do not seek faults in the sacred Dharma. Do not let your mind dwell on attachment, aversion, or delusion. Do not scrutinize whether the words of the Dharma teacher are good or bad. After hearing the Dharma, do not give rise to pride. Do not do it for the sake of honor, gain, or renown — seek instead the nourishment and benefit of a Dharma that transcends the world. Likewise, do not think: 'Having heard the Dharma, I shall first liberate my own body and only then liberate others.' Do not think: 'I shall first free my own body and only then free others.' Do not think: 'I shall first cause my own body to touch happiness and only then bring happiness to others.' Do not think: 'I shall first pass into nirvāṇa and only then lead others beyond sorrow.' Instead, generate the perception of equality with regard to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Generate the perception that saṃsāra has the defining characteristic of great suffering. Generate the perception that Great Nirvāṇa has the defining characteristics of permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. Accomplish the benefit of others first, and only afterward your own benefit — and this for the sake of the Great Vehicle, not for either of the two lesser vehicles. Do not grasp at the many defining marks of all phenomena, for all phenomena have no fixed abode. Rather than generating the perception of desire regarding all phenomena, always generate the perception of knowing and seeing the Dharma.

Noble son, if you listen to the Dharma with single-pointed mind in just this way, that is what is called 'coming to hear what has not been heard before.'

Noble son, there is hearing the unheard. There is not hearing the unheard. There is not hearing what has been heard. And there is hearing what has been heard.

Noble son, it is just as with the unborn being born, the unborn remaining unborn, the born remaining unborn, and the born being born; and just as with the unattained being attained, the unattained remaining unattained, the attained remaining unattained, and the attained being attained.

'Blessed One, how is it that the unborn is born?' Noble son, abiding on the conventional level, when one issues forth from the womb at the very beginning — that is called the unborn being born. 'How is it that the unborn remains unborn?' Noble son, Great Nirvāṇa has no defining characteristic of birth — that is called the unborn remaining unborn. 'How is it that the born remains unborn?' Noble son, conventionally, at the time of death, that is called the born remaining unborn. 'How is it that the born is born?'"

"Noble son, all ordinary beings are called 'the born being born.' Why is that? Because the continuum of birth is uninterrupted, and because all defiled phenomena arise moment by moment — that is called the born being born. A bodhisattva on the fourth ground is called 'the born remaining unborn.' Why is that? Because they have gained mastery over birth — that is called the born remaining unborn.

Noble son, these are inner phenomena. As for how outer phenomena are the unborn being born, the unborn remaining unborn, the born remaining unborn, and the born being born: Noble son, take the example of a seed — before a sprout has arisen, when the four great elements have assembled and gathered and have been made to function, only then does it come to birth. That is called the unborn being born. How is it that the unborn remains unborn? Take the example of a seed that has rotted, or has not met with the right conditions — something like that is called the unborn remaining unborn. How is it that the born remains unborn? Take the example of a sprout that has arisen but has not yet reached full maturity — one that has been born but not yet matured is called the born remaining unborn. How is it that the born is born? What has grown from a sprout to full maturity is like something already born — yet for what has been born but not yet matured, that maturation still lies ahead. In this way, all defiled outer phenomena are called 'the born being born.'"

Then the great bodhisattva Vaidūryaprabha addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if birth exists within defiled phenomena, is that birth permanent or impermanent? If that birth is permanent, then birth would not exist within defiled phenomena. If that birth is impermanent, then those defiled phenomena would themselves become impermanent. Blessed One, if one were to say that birth itself produces birth, then birth would have no defining characteristic. If something else were capable of producing birth, then for what reason, through what cause and condition, do undefiled phenomena not arise? Blessed One, if before something is born there is no birth, then how can the very designation 'birth' be applied? If there is no birth before a thing is

born, then why did you not say that birth occurs in empty space?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, the unborn being born is inexpressible. The born remaining unborn is inexpressible. The unborn remaining unborn is inexpressible. The born is inexpressible. The unborn is also inexpressible. And yet, in terms of causes and conditions, expression is appropriate.

How is it that the unborn being born is inexpressible? Whatever is said of 'birth' in regard to what has not been born — that too is a birth. Why? Because it also arises through birth. How is it that the born being born is inexpressible? Because it is born on account of birth having occurred, and yet because it is also unborn through that very occurrence of birth, it is inexpressible. How is it that the born remaining unborn is inexpressible? What is called 'having been born' is precisely birth itself — and since birth itself is not a birth, it is inexpressible. How is it that the unborn remaining unborn is also inexpressible? That which is unborn is called nirvāṇa, and nirvāṇa is inexpressible because it is without birth. Why? Because it is attained through cultivation of the path. The born is also inexpressible, because that very birth is without birth. How is it that the unborn is inexpressible? Because there is something to be attained. How is it that expression in terms of causes and conditions is nonetheless appropriate? The twelve phenomena of dependent origination have birth as their cause — and for that reason, expression is appropriate.

Noble son, do not enter too deeply into the meditative absorption of emptiness. Why? Because the faculties of many in the assembly are still untrained."

Noble son, birth in conditioned phenomena is also permanent. Mere duration within impermanence, birth too is impermanent. Duration is also not permanent, for since birth has arisen, duration too is impermanent. Differentiation is also not permanent, for since there is no permanence in phenomena, differentiation too is impermanent. Destruction is also permanent, for what did not exist from the beginning now exists, and hence destruction too is impermanent. Noble son, by reason of intrinsic nature, birth, duration, differentiation, and destruction are all permanent, yet since they cease moment by moment, they cannot rightly be called permanent. Great nirvāṇa is annihilation and cessation, and thus it is to be called impermanent. Noble son, defiled phenomena, not yet arisen, have the intrinsic nature of

arising, and so when caused to arise, they do arise. Undefined phenomena have had no intrinsic nature of arising from the very beginning, and so even when caused to arise, they are unable to arise. Just as fire, having the intrinsic nature of burning, blazes upon meeting its conditions, and just as the eye, having the intrinsic nature of seeing, sees form when the conditions of form, light, and consciousness come together, so too with the arising nature of sentient beings: having had that intrinsic nature from the very beginning, birth occurs from the causal conditions of karma and the union of father and mother.

Then the great bodhisattva Vaiḍūryaprabha and some eighty-four thousand great bodhisattvas, having heard these teachings, rose up into the sky above to the height of seven palm trees, joined their palms in reverence while hovering there, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the Tathāgata has taught us again and again, and through this great nirvāṇa we have heard and realized what we had never heard before. All eighty-four thousand bodhisattvas have now utterly realized the non-arising, arising, and so on of all phenomena. Blessed One, I have realized everything, and the net of doubt has been severed. Yet in the midst of this assembly there is a bodhisattva named Abhaya who wishes to ask and inquire. May the Blessed One grant permission and give him opportunity." Then the Blessed One addressed the bodhisattva Abhaya: "Noble son, ask whatever you wish, and I shall prophesy and explain each matter accordingly."

Then the bodhisattva Abhaya, together with his accompanying sixty-four thousand bodhisattvas all seated together, rose from their seats, arranged their robes, placed their knees on the ground, joined their palms, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what must the sentient beings of this world do in order to be reborn in the unmoving world-realm? And for what reason are the bodhisattvas of that realm endowed with wisdom, magnificent among human beings like a king of yaks, endowed with yogic practice, sharp and swift in wisdom, so that they realize immediately upon hearing?"

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

Those who do not cut the lives of sentient beings,
who thoroughly restrain themselves in ethical conduct and precepts,
and who follow the teachings of the sublime buddha
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not steal the wealth of others,
who constantly give to all,
and who provide lodging for the Saṅgha and for guests
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not seek the wives of others,
who are content with their own spouse,
and who guard the precepts of the bed
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, for the sake of benefit to self or others,
do not falsify out of fear or ill intent,
who restrain their speech and do not speak lies
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not part from virtuous friends,
and who utterly abandon evil companions,
and always speak words of conciliation,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Just as a bodhisattva always abandons harsh words,
so that what is spoken is a delight to hear,
one who does so will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, even in jest and play,
do not speak untimely words,
but speak only what is timely and fitting,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, upon seeing another's gain and good fortune,
always give rise to a mind of rejoicing,
and do not bind themselves in the knot of envy,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not harm sentient beings,
who always give rise to a mind of loving-kindness,
and who through skillful means do not generate evil,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not give rise to the wrong view
that there is no giving, no mother or father,
no past and no future,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who dig wells and provide water along desolate roads,
who plant many food-bearing trees,
and who give food to those who beg,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who make an offering to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha,
even of a single stick of incense or a single lamp,
or even a single flower,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, out of fear or in search of advantage,
or in order to seek merit and virtue,
copy out even a single verse of this sūtra,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, for the sake of merit for the many
and for the benefit of all,
read this holy scriptural teaching for even a single day,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, for the sake of the unsurpassable path,
uphold the eight precepts of moral discipline and restraint
for even the span of a single day and night,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not dwell together with one who has broken the root precepts of
moral discipline
or who has rejected the extensive scriptural teachings,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who give even a single grain of fruit from a tree
to one who is afflicted with illness,
and who serve that person with a joyful mind,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who do not make use of the Saṅgha's wealth,
who carefully guard the property of the Buddha,
and who sweep the dwelling places of the Buddha and the Saṅgha,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who always give rise to a joyful mind
and make even a thumbprint's worth of an image or representation of a
buddha,

will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who, for the sake of this sūtra,
give their own body and precious riches
to a Dharma teacher,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Those who listen to the secret essences of the Blessed One,
or write them down in letters,
or hold them, recite them, or chant them aloud,
will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

Then the great bodhisattva Abhaya addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, from this day forward I have come to understand that by whatever causes and conditions one acts, one will be reborn in that unmoving realm.

The great bodhisattva Sarvaprakāśaśrīrāja had asked out of compassion for the many beings, and through the Tathāgata's thorough exposition and teaching, this came to be of benefit to all — to gods, humans, asuras, gandharvas, garuḍas, kinnaras, and great serpents, and to all the rest.

Then the Blessed One declared to the great bodhisattva Sarvaprakāśaśrīrāja: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, attend to this with great care and listen well. I shall explain and set forth for you the causes and conditions by which one who has not arrived does not arrive, by which one who has not arrived does arrive, by which one who has arrived does not arrive, and by which one who has arrived does arrive.

What are the causes and conditions by which one who has not arrived does not arrive? Son of good family, what is called "not having arrived" is great nirvāṇa.

Ordinary beings have not arrived because, possessed of attachment, aversion, and delusion, the actions of their body and speech are entirely impure; they cling to all things that have not been examined; they violate the four roots; they denigrate the extended sūtras; they perform the deeds of those who cling to wrong craving; and they commit the blameworthy acts of the five heinous crimes without interval. For these reasons this is called "not having arrived, and not arriving."

Son of good family, what then are the causes and conditions by which one who has not arrived does arrive? What is called "not having arrived" is great nirvāṇa. How is it that one arrives there? By utterly abandoning attachment, aversion, and delusion, by abandoning the evil conduct of body and speech, by not clinging to things that have not been examined, by not violating the four roots, by not denigrating the extended sūtras, by not performing the deeds of those who cling to wrong craving, and by not committing the blameworthy acts of the five heinous crimes without interval. For these reasons this is called "not having arrived, and yet arriving."

One who has entered the stream arrives after eighty thousand aeons. One who returns once arrives after sixty thousand aeons. One who is a non-returner arrives after forty thousand aeons. An arhat arrives after twenty thousand aeons. A pratyekabuddha arrives after ten thousand aeons. For these reasons this is called "not having arrived, and yet arriving."

Son of good family, what then are the causes and conditions by which one who has arrived does not arrive? What is called "having arrived" is the twenty-five realms of existence. All sentient beings are perpetually bound by immeasurable afflictions, thoroughly ensnared, and circle round again and again — just as a wheel turns — unable to cast it off. That cannot be called "having arrived." Śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are called "not having arrived" because they have utterly abandoned those realms. Yet because they manifest and appear in these realms for the sake of taming sentient beings, they may also be called "having arrived."

Son of good family, what then are the causes and conditions by which one who has arrived does arrive? What is called "having arrived" is the twenty-five realms of existence. All base and ignoble ordinary beings, along with stream-enterers and those up to the level of once-returner, are called "having arrived, who arrive" on account of the conditions of affliction.

Son of good family, with regard to hearing what has not been heard, it is likewise: there is hearing what has not been heard, there is not hearing what has not been heard, there is not hearing what has been heard, and there is hearing what has been heard.

Now how is it that what has not been heard is heard? Son of good family, "not having been heard" refers to great nirvāṇa. Why is it called "not having been heard"? Because it is not conditioned, it is not a sound, and it is not expressible in words. How then is it heard? It is heard as a name in the

following way: permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. This is called "hearing what has not been heard."

Then the great bodhisattva Sarvaprakāśaśrīrāja addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, if, as the Blessed One has said, great nirvāṇa is not fit to be heard, why did you say that permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity are fit to be heard?

Blessed One, and why is this so? That which has had afflictions cut away is nirvāṇa. If one were not to call what is to be honored "nirvāṇa," then the intrinsic nature of nirvāṇa would have been absent from the beginning and would only now exist. But if, following the conventions of the world, something is absent at first and then comes to exist, it would have the character of impermanence. For example, things such as clay did not exist at first and then came to exist —

— and then ceases to exist; that is what is called impermanent. If nirvāṇa were like that, why did you say that it possesses permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity?

Furthermore, Blessed One, whatever comes into existence through assembled causes is called impermanent. If nirvāṇa were like that, then, since it is the right way of things for what is impermanent to be impermanent, by what cause and condition is it impermanent? It is as follows: the thirty-seven factors of awakening, the six perfections, the four immeasurables, meditation on the skeleton, mindful breathing, the six close placements of mindfulness, the six great dissolutions, and all things of that kind serve as the causes and conditions for accomplishing nirvāṇa, and so they are called impermanent.

Furthermore, Blessed One, conditioned existence is called impermanent. If nirvāṇa were conditioned existence, then it would be right for it to be impermanent as well. For the Blessed One previously declared in scripture: "Śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and all buddhas, the Blessed Ones, can achieve nirvāṇa." For that very reason, it would then be called impermanent.

Furthermore, Blessed One, all phenomena that are subject to investigation are impermanent. And the Blessed One previously declared: "Beholding nirvāṇa, all afflictions are cut through." For that very reason as well.

Furthermore, Blessed One, just as empty space is called permanent because it is equally unobstructed and unimpeded for all sentient beings, if nirvāṇa were equally permanent in that same way, why would it be that some sentient

beings have attained it and others have not? If nirvāṇa were like that — not equal with respect to all sentient beings — then how could it be called permanent?

Blessed One, take for example: there are many hundreds of people, and there is one enemy among them. If that enemy were slain, all those many people would be at ease. But if nirvāṇa were a phenomenon of equality, then it would be right that if one person attains it, all the many people together would attain it. If one person's afflictions are cut through, then all the many people's afflictions together would be cut through. If it is not like that, why is it called permanent?

Take another example: when someone pays honor, makes offerings, performs ceremonies of reverence, and shows respect to a king, a prince, a father and mother, a teacher, and a master, they attain ease and happiness — yet that is not called permanent. If nirvāṇa were like that, it would not be called permanent either. And why is that? For the Blessed One previously declared this in scripture, speaking to Ānanda: "If someone pays reverence to nirvāṇa, all afflictions are cut through and immeasurable happiness is attained." For that very reason, it cannot be called permanent.

Blessed One, if nirvāṇa possesses the names "permanent," "blissful," "self," and "utterly pure," then it cannot be called permanent. But if it lacks them, how can it be properly described at all?

Thereupon the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva, the great being, the king of glory, Samantaprabha Uttungaśrī:

Nirvāṇa itself is not something that was absent from the beginning and has only now come to exist. If nirvāṇa itself had been absent from the beginning and now existed, then it would not be a phenomenon of the undefiled that abides permanently. Whether buddhas arise or do not arise, its intrinsic nature and its characteristic marks abide forever. Because sentient beings are obscured by afflictions, they do not see nirvāṇa, and so they think it does not exist.

Bodhisattvas, great beings, who are practiced in moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom cut through the afflictions and come to see it. Therefore, nirvāṇa is something that abides permanently, and one should understand that it is not the case that it was absent before and now exists at present. For this reason it is called permanent.

Noble son, consider this example: inside a dark room there is a pit containing the seven precious substances in all their variety. People know that these are present, yet because of the dense darkness they cannot see them. A person of wisdom, skilled in means, takes up a great lamp and looks, and everything becomes visible. That person does not think: "The water and the seven precious substances were absent before and have only now come into being." Nirvāṇa is just like that. It has existed from the very beginning; it has not come to exist only now, at this moment. Sentient beings do not see it because they are covered by the darkness of the afflictions. But the Tathāgata, who possesses the primordial wisdom of omniscience, through supremely skilled means has lit the lamp of wisdom so that bodhisattvas may behold the permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity of nirvāṇa. Therefore a person of wisdom should never say of nirvāṇa that it "was absent before and has now come to exist."

Noble son, the argument you have set forth — that nirvāṇa, having been produced through causes, is impermanent — is not acceptable. Why? Because, noble son, the essential nature of nirvāṇa is not birth, not arising, not true, not false, not something born through being made by action, not a phenomenon that is defiled or conditioned, not heard, not seen, not a transgression, not a binding, not characterized by distinct defining marks, not characterized by a single defining mark, not coming, not going, not past, not future, not present, not one, not many, not long, not short, not round, not square, not tapering, not flat, not possessed of defining characteristics, not a perception, not a name, not form, not a cause, not a result, not self, and not belonging to a self.

Because this is so, the crossing beyond sorrow is permanent — it does not change or shift. Yet only when one has adorned oneself by practicing and cultivating wholesome qualities over countless, immeasurable eons does one finally come to see it.

Noble son, consider this example: below the ground there is water possessing the eight excellent qualities, yet it cannot be obtained by just any sentient being. It is only when a wise person performs the work of digging that one finally obtains it. Nirvāṇa is just like that.

Consider also the example of people who are blind: they cannot see the sun and moon. When a skilled physician applies medicine, the sun and moon become bright and visible to them. Yet the sun and moon are not something that was absent before and has now come to exist. Nirvāṇa is likewise: it has

existed from the very beginning; it has not come to exist only now, at this moment.

Noble son, consider this example: those who have committed offenses are bound and cast into prison, and only after a long time do they at last obtain release and go forth, whereupon at home they once again meet their parents, brothers, sisters, children, wife, and relatives whom they had not seen all that while. Nirvāṇa is just like that.

Noble son, your claim that because nirvāṇa depends on dependent origination its phenomenon is also impermanent — that too is not the case. Why? Because, noble son, causes are of five kinds. What are those five? The cause of birth, the cause of assembly, the cause of abiding, the cause of arising and growth, and the cause of duration.

What is meant by the cause of birth? The cause of birth refers to karma, afflictions, and the like, and to the seeds of outer herbs and trees.

What is meant by the cause of assembly? Just as virtuous actions and virtuous intentions come together, and non-virtuous actions and non-virtuous intentions come together —

and non-virtuous actions and non-virtuous intentions come together — likewise, when actions without scriptural transmission and minds without scriptural transmission come together, that is called the cause of assembly.

What is the cause of abiding? Because a pillar stands below, a house does not fall; mountains, water, trees, and all forests abide because of the great earth; and sentient beings abide because there are within them the four great elements and afflictions beyond measure — this is called the cause of abiding.

What is the cause of arising and growth? Sentient beings arise and grow through conditions such as clothing, food, and the like. Just as seeds of the outer world, when not burned by fire and not eaten by insects, will arise and grow; just as śramaṇas, brahmins, and the like arise and grow by relying on teachers and spiritual friends; and just as children arise and grow through the substance of their parents — this is called the cause of arising and growth.

What is the cause of duration? For example, through the power of mantra one cannot be killed by demons or harmed by poison; by relying on a king, thieves cannot prevail. Just as a sprout depends on earth, water, fire, wind, and the like; just as water, a churning staff, and human labor serve as the cause of butter's duration; just as light and visible forms and the like serve as the cause

of duration for consciousness; just as the white and dark reproductive substances of the parents serve as the cause of sentient beings' duration; and just as time and all such factors are likewise called the cause of duration.

Noble son, if the nature of great nirvāṇa is not produced by such five causes, how can it be called a cause of impermanence? Noble son, furthermore, there are two kinds of causes: the cause of production and the cause of manifestation. Just as a potter's wheel is called the cause of production, noble son, so too, just as a lamp and the like illuminate objects in the darkness — this is called the cause of manifestation. Noble son, great nirvāṇa is not produced by the cause of production; it is by the cause of manifestation alone. The cause of manifestation is this: the thirty-seven factors of awakening and the six perfections are called the cause of manifestation.

Noble son, giving is a cause of nirvāṇa, but it is not a cause of great nirvāṇa. The perfection of giving is called a cause of great nirvāṇa. The thirty-seven factors of awakening are a cause of nirvāṇa, but they are not a cause of great nirvāṇa. The limitless and numberless factors of the branches of awakening are called the cause of great nirvāṇa.

May there be auspiciousness.

Here begins the Sūtra section, volume Ta. The Noble Sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa. The twenty-ninth fascicle.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Samantaprabhāsa, the Glorious King of Lofty Majesty, addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, if one gives generously in such a way that it cannot be called the perfection of giving, and, continuing in that same way through to wisdom, if one cultivates wisdom in such a way that it cannot be called the perfection of wisdom — and what would then be designated the perfection of wisdom — and further, what should be called nirvāṇa and what should be called great nirvāṇa?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, when a bodhisattva, a great being, applies himself thoroughly and at great length to great nirvāṇa, he does not hear of giving, he does not see giving, he does not hear of the perfection of giving.

he does not see the perfection of giving, and continuing in that same way through to wisdom: he does not hear of wisdom, he does not see wisdom, he does not hear of the Perfection of Wisdom, he does not see the Perfection of Wisdom, he does not hear of nirvāṇa, he does not see nirvāṇa, he does not

hear of great nirvāṇa, he does not see great nirvāṇa. For a bodhisattva, a great being, who applies himself thoroughly to great nirvāṇa, realizes and sees within the dharmadhātu, and fully attains the defining characteristic of what is perfectly real — empty, utterly without anything, uncompounded, without feeling or cognition — and realizes, as it truly is, the defining characteristic of being without defilement, the defining characteristic of being without activity, the defining characteristic of being like a magical illusion, the defining characteristic of being like a mirage, like a gandharva city, and the defining characteristic of being like space. When at that time a bodhisattva has attained such a defining characteristic, because he is free from attachment, aversion, and delusion, he neither hears nor sees. That is the perfectly real defining characteristic of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Bodhisattvas, great beings, who abide in the perfectly real defining characteristic fully understand: "This is giving, this is the perfection of giving" — and continuing in that way through wisdom — "this is wisdom, this is the Perfection of Wisdom, this is nirvāṇa, this is great nirvāṇa."

Noble son, as to how giving can be giving and yet not be the perfection of giving: when one gives only upon seeing a suppliant, that is called giving — it is not the perfection. When one gives of one's own accord even without a suppliant, that is called the perfection of giving. When one gives only occasionally, at certain times, that is called giving — it is not called the perfection. When one always gives without ceasing, that is called the perfection of giving. When one gives to another and afterwards a mind of regret arises, that is called giving — it is not called the perfection. When one gives without subsequent regret, that is called the perfection of giving.

When a bodhisattva, a great being, generates the four fears regarding wealth and material possessions — such as kings, thieves, water, and fire — and gives with great joy, that is called the perfection of giving. When one gives in hopes of receiving something in return, that is called giving — it is not called the perfection. When one gives with no expectation of return, that is called the perfection of giving.

When one gives out of fear, or for gain, or for fame, or for the sake of one's household, or to sustain one's clan, or to be reborn among the gods, or for the five objects of desire, or out of pride, or out of arrogance, or to cultivate a friend, or in hope of recompense — this is like one who engages in trade, or, noble son, like a person who plants trees in expectation of shade, flowers,

fruit, timber, and the like: whoever gives in such a way, that is called giving — it is not the perfection.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who in this way applies himself thoroughly to great nirvāṇa does not see giving and receiving as real objects, does not see a time, does not see merit or non-merit, does not see a cause, does not see a condition, does not see a ripening result, does not see an agent, does not see a recipient, does not see much, does not see little, does not see purity, does not see impurity, does not disparage the recipient, the self, or material things, does not see what is seen, does not see what is unseen, does not grasp at self or other — and it is on account of the Dharma of always abiding in the vast and expansive great nirvāṇa that he gives, for the benefit of all sentient beings, and

and gives for the sake of happiness, and gives for the sake of completely severing the afflictions of all sentient beings, and he is diligent in giving so that all sentient beings may come to see neither giving, nor receiving, nor material things as real.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: if a man who has fallen into the ocean grasps hold of a corpse, he will be freed from the ocean. When a bodhisattva, a great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, his practice of giving is just like that.

Son of good family, consider another analogy: if a man is placed in a very deep, tightly sealed pit of filth, there is no escape from any other direction, but there is one small opening through which waste flows out — and if he emerges through that, he arrives at a place free from obstruction. When a bodhisattva, a great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, his giving is just like that.

Son of good family, consider another analogy: a woman of high brahmin lineage, seized with terror and having no protector or refuge, takes shelter in and goes for refuge to an outcaste of low birth. When a bodhisattva, a great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, his giving is just like that.

Son of good family, consider another analogy: a sick person, in order to dispel the suffering of illness and attain well-being, eats something impure. When a bodhisattva, a great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, his giving is just like that.

Son of good family, consider another analogy: a brahmin, for the sake of his very life when food is extremely scarce, eats dog flesh. When a bodhisattva, a

great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, his giving is just like that.

Son of good family, within the great nirvāṇa there are such things as: hearing, for immeasurable aeons, what had never been heard before; and the teaching from moral discipline and the perfection of moral discipline all the way through to wisdom and the Perfection of Wisdom — all of this is explained in detail just as in the sūtra known as "The Buddha, the Sūtra of Varied Flowers."

Son of good family, how does it come about that when a bodhisattva, a great being, is diligent in the great nirvāṇa, he hears what has never been heard before? It is through the occasion of this sūtra that the profoundly deep meaning of the twelve branches of scriptural teaching, never before heard, is heard completely and fully. That which previously existed in some slight measure and was heard only by name — now, from this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, its actual meaning is heard for the very first time.

Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, from the twelve branches of scriptural teaching, hear only the names but do not hear the meaning. Now, from this sūtra, they hear it in complete fullness — and this is called "hearing what was never before heard."

Son of good family, all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, from sūtras that declare the buddha to be permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and utterly pure — not coming to an end — and from sūtras concerning the Three Jewels, and sūtras teaching that the buddha-nature has no distinctive defining characteristics, and sūtras concerning the falling away of the four roots, and sūtras denigrating the vast and expansive teaching, and sūtras teaching the misconduct of the five acts without interval, and sūtras teaching that even all those given to wrong craving possess the buddha-nature — from all of these, today, through this sūtra, they hear for the first time what was never before heard. And this is called "hearing what was never before heard."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, the King of Glorious Lofty Universal Illumination addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if those who have broken the four roots, who have denigrated the vast and expansive scriptural teaching, who have committed the misconduct of the five acts without interval, and those given to wrong craving and the like — if all these possess the buddha-nature, why then should they still fall into the hells?"

"Blessed One, if those beings do indeed possess the buddha-nature, why then is it said that they lack permanence, bliss, self, and purity? Blessed One, if one

who has completely severed the roots of virtue is called 'one given to wrong craving,' then at the time of severing the roots of virtue, why was the buddha-nature not severed along with them? And if the buddha-nature were severed, why would it then be called permanent, blissful, self, and pure? Yet if it was not severed, why apply the designation 'one given to wrong craving'? Blessed One, those who have broken the four roots are indeterminate. Those who have denigrated the vast and expansive scriptural teaching, those who have committed the misconduct of the five acts without interval, and those given to wrong craving — these too are indeterminate. But if they were determinate, how could they ever fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? From stream-enterers to pratyekabuddhas, they too are indeterminate. And if those from stream-enterer through pratyekabuddha were determinate, it would be equally unreasonable for them to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Blessed One, if those who have broken the four roots are indeterminate, then so too are those from stream-enterer through pratyekabuddha indeterminate. And if all of these are indeterminate, then the Blessed One, the buddha, is also indeterminate. If the Blessed One, the buddha, is indeterminate, then the essential nature of nirvāṇa is also indeterminate — and so too are all phenomena, down to the last, indeterminate. How so? If those given to wrong craving were to awaken by abandoning the deeds of wrong craving, then the Blessed Ones, the buddhas, having fully passed into nirvāṇa, might equally return once more — which would mean they are the kind who do not enter final nirvāṇa. If things were so, then the nature of nirvāṇa itself would become indeterminate. Since it is indeterminate in that way, and since permanence, bliss, self, and purity are absent, why then would those given to wrong craving and the like attain nirvāṇa?"

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being, the King of Glorious Lofty Universal Illumination: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, you have asked these questions well — out of love and compassion for the world, for the sake of benefit and happiness for measureless sentient beings, for the arousing of awakening mind, and in order that bodhisattvas may rise ever higher and higher. Noble son, you have in the past served and honored measureless Blessed Ones, the buddhas, and in dependence upon those buddhas you have generated the roots of virtue. For a very long time you have cultivated the qualities of awakening and, having defeated and shattered the hosts of Māra, you have worked for the welfare of measureless and boundless

sentient beings and established them all in unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For a very long time you have understood this profoundly deep essential meaning, intended and taught by the Tathāgatas. Among all the past Blessed Ones, the buddhas, as countless as the sands of the Ganges River, measureless and boundless — I have not seen a single one to whom anyone in all the world, whether god or human, ascetic or brahmin, māra or Brahmā, has put these profound and ultimate questions to a Tathāgata as you have done. Now listen well and with great care and close attention, for I shall set it forth and explain it. Noble son, those given to wrong craving are not determinate."

If it were determinate, one given to wrong craving could never attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Because it is indeterminate, attainment is possible. Therefore, if the nature of a buddha has not been cut off, why speak of one as given to wrong craving? As for the cutting off of wholesome roots, noble son, wholesome roots are of two kinds: inner and outer. The nature of a buddha is neither inner nor outer; therefore the nature of a buddha is not cut off. Again, there are two kinds: defiled and undefiled. The nature of a buddha is neither defiled nor undefiled; therefore it is not cut off. Again, there are two kinds: permanent and impermanent. The nature of a buddha is neither permanent nor impermanent; therefore it is not cut off. If it were cut off, it would be fitting that it be regained. If it cannot be regained, it is called "not cut off." What is cut off and then regained — that belongs to one given to wrong craving. The falling away of the four roots is likewise indeterminate. If it were determinate, those who have fallen away from the four roots could never attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Rejecting the extensive scriptural collections is likewise indeterminate. If it were determinate, those who have rejected the sacred Dharma could never attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Committing the fault of the five acts of immediate consequence is likewise indeterminate. If it were determinate, those who have committed the five acts of immediate consequence could never attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Both form and the defining characteristic of form are indeterminate. From scent, taste, and the defining characteristic of tangibles, through the defining characteristic of birth, up to the defining characteristic of ignorance, and including the defining characteristics of the aggregates, elements, and sense sources, the twenty-five modes of existence, the four births, and all phenomena without exception — all are indeterminate.

Noble son, consider the following analogy. A magician conjures, before a great crowd, four kinds of assemblage: a host of chariots, footmen, oxen, and horses; an array of precious ornaments; and towns, cities, villages, mountains, forests, trees, springs, ponds, streams, and wells. Among that crowd, the foolish and ignorant see these illusions and take them all to be real. The wise and discerning know they are not real — they understand that the power of illusion deceives the human eye. Noble son, the same applies to ordinary beings all the way up through śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — to all of them, every phenomenon appears to have a fixed, determinate defining characteristic. Buddhas and bodhisattvas, however, do not regard any phenomenon as having a fixed, determinate defining characteristic.

Noble son, consider another analogy. Foolish people see a summer mirage and think it is water. The wise and discerning do not take that mirage to truly be water — they know the mirage is not real water, that it is something that deceives the human eye, and that it is not in any genuine sense water. All ordinary beings, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are the same in how they see all phenomena — they take them all to be real and genuine. Buddhas and bodhisattvas do not look upon any phenomenon as having a fixed, determinate defining characteristic.

Noble son, here is yet another analogy. When a voice is raised near a cliff and the cliff returns an echo, the ignorant and foolish hear it and take the sound to be real. The wise and discerning know it is not genuinely what it seems — they understand that a mere semblance of sound deceives the ear-consciousness. Noble son, all ordinary beings, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas look upon all phenomena as though they had such fixed, determinate defining characteristics.

Bodhisattvas, having thoroughly understood that all phenomena lack any fixed, determinate defining characteristic, see them under the characteristic of impermanence, under the characteristics of emptiness, peace, and so forth, and under the characteristic of being without arising and ceasing. Therefore bodhisattvas, great beings, see all phenomena under the characteristic of impermanence.

Noble son, yet there are also determinate defining characteristics. What are those determinate characteristics? They are: permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. And where do these abide? In nirvāṇa.

Noble son, the fruit of stream-entry is also indeterminate. Because it is indeterminate in this way, one may attain the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over the course of eighty aeons. The fruit of once-returning is likewise indeterminate. Because it is indeterminate in this way, one may attain the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over the course of sixty aeons. The fruit of non-returning is likewise indeterminate. Because it is indeterminate in this way, one may attain the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over the course of forty aeons. The fruit of arhatship is likewise indeterminate. Because it is indeterminate in this way, one may attain the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over the course of twenty aeons. The awakening of a pratyekabuddha is also indeterminate. Because it is indeterminate in this way, one may attain the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening over the course of ten thousand aeons.

Noble son, now, here in this city of Kuśinagara, the Tathāgata reclines upon a lion throne between the śāla trees, drawing near to his passing into nirvāṇa. Many novices who have not yet attained the fruit of arhatship, together with the greatly powerful Vajrapāṇi and others, give rise to great grief. Gods, humans, asuras, gandharvas (scent-eaters), garuḍas, kinnaras (half-human beings), and great nāgas and others make lavish offerings and magnificent worship. Multitudes of people wrap the body in a thousand lengths of cloth, encase it in a casket of the seven precious substances, fill it with oil of essence, and pile fragrant woods around it; yet when it is lit and burns, neither of two things are consumed by fire. What are those two? Contact with the body itself, and the innermost layer of cloth nearest to it.

It is shown that the relics are to be divided eightfold among all sentient beings. All the śrāvaka attendants declare, "The Tathāgata has passed into complete nirvāṇa." Yet one should understand that the Tathāgata has decidedly not passed into complete nirvāṇa. Why? Because the Tathāgata is permanently abiding, unchanging, and unshifting. Therefore the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa is also indeterminate. Noble son, one should understand the Tathāgata to be indeterminate. For in this way the Tathāgata is not an asura. Why? Because there are four kinds of god (deva): worldly gods, gods by birth, gods of purity, and gods by meaning. Those called worldly gods are like kings. Those called gods by birth are those born anywhere from the gods of the Four Great Kings up to the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Those called gods of

purity are those from stream-entrants up to pratyekabuddhas. Those called gods by meaning are those great beings who are bodhisattvas on the tenth ground. Why is a bodhisattva on the tenth ground called a god by meaning? Because such a one is supremely skilled in the meaning of all phenomena. And what is that meaning? It is seeing all phenomena in the meaning of emptiness.

Noble son, the Tathāgata is not a king.

The Tathāgata is not a king — not from the gods of the Four Great Kings up to the gods of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, and not from stream-entrants up to pratyekabuddhas and bodhisattvas on the tenth ground. Therefore the Tathāgata is not a god.

And yet sentient beings speak of the buddha as the god of gods. Therefore the Tathāgata is not a god, yet is also not a non-god; not a human, yet also not a non-human; not a rakṣasa, yet also not a non-rakṣasa; not a hell-being, not an animal, not a hungry ghost, yet also not a non-hell-being, non-animal, or non-hungry-ghost; not a sentient being, yet also not a non-sentient-being; not a phenomenon, yet also not a non-phenomenon; not form, yet also not non-form; not long, yet also not non-long; not short, yet also not non-short; not a characteristic, yet also not a non-characteristic; not mind, yet also not non-mind; not defiled, yet also not undefiled; not conditioned, yet also not unconditioned; not permanent, yet also not impermanent; not an illusion, yet also not a non-illusion; not a name, yet also not a non-name; not definite, yet also not non-definite; not existent, yet also not non-existent; not nonexistent, yet also not non-nonexistent; not expressible, yet also not inexpressible; not a Tathāgata, yet also not a non-Tathāgata. Therefore the Tathāgata is indefinable.

Noble son, why is the Tathāgata not designated a worldly god? Worldly gods are kings. Since the Tathāgata long ago, over measureless aeons, relinquished the ways of kingship, he is therefore not a king. And why is he not a non-king? Because the Tathāgata was born in the city of Kapilavastu in the household of King Śuddhodana; therefore he is not a non-king either.

Why is the Tathāgata not a god by birth? Because the Tathāgata, from long ago, separated himself from all states of existence; therefore he is not a god by birth. And why is he not a non-god-by-birth? Because he descended from the Tuṣita heaven to Jambudvīpa; therefore the Tathāgata is also not a non-god-by-birth.

Why is the Tathāgata not a god of purity? Because the Tathāgata is not a stream-entrant up to a pratyekabuddha; therefore he is not a god of purity. And why is he not a non-god-of-purity? Because he is unstained by the eight worldly concerns, just as a lotus is unstained by water and dust; therefore the Tathāgata is also not a non-god-of-purity.

Why is the Tathāgata not a god by meaning? Because the Tathāgata is not a bodhisattva on the tenth ground; therefore he is not a god by meaning. And why is he not a non-god-by-meaning? Because the Tathāgata always applies himself to the eighteen emptinesses; therefore the Tathāgata is also not a non-god-by-meaning.

Why is the Tathāgata not a human? Because the Tathāgata long ago, over measureless aeons, completely abandoned human existence; therefore he is not a human. And why is he not a non-human? Because he was born in the city of Kapilavastu; therefore he is also not a non-human.

Why is the Tathāgata not a rakṣasa? Because he harms no sentient being whatsoever; therefore he is not a rakṣasa. And why is he not a non-rakṣasa? Because he appears in emanated forms resembling a rakṣasa and tames sentient beings thereby; therefore he is also not a non-rakṣasa.

Then why is the Tathāgata not a hell-being, an animal, or a hungry ghost?

Because the Tathāgata long ago completely abandoned wrongful views, he is therefore not a hell-being, an animal, or a hungry ghost. And why is he also not a non-hell-being, non-animal, and non-hungry-ghost? Because the Tathāgata, in order to tame sentient beings, has actually appeared even in the three lower realms; therefore he is also not a non-hell-being, non-animal, and non-hungry-ghost.

Why is the Tathāgata not a sentient being? Because long ago he abandoned the intrinsic nature of a sentient being; therefore the Tathāgata is not a sentient being. And why is he also not a non-sentient-being? Because on various occasions he has spoken of sentient beings using their very characteristics; therefore the Tathāgata is also not a non-sentient-being.

Why is the Tathāgata not a phenomenon (dharma)? Because all phenomena have their own individually distinct characteristics, and the Tathāgata is not like that — he is exhausted in a single characteristic; therefore he is not a phenomenon. And why is he also not a non-phenomenon? Because the Tathāgata is the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena; therefore he is

also not a non-phenomenon.

Why is the Tathāgata not form? Because he is not included within the ten sense bases of form; therefore he is not form. And why is he also not a non-form? Because his body is adorned with the thirty-two major marks and eighty excellent minor marks; therefore he is also not a non-form.

Why is the Tathāgata not tall? Because he has completely transcended all form; therefore he is not tall. And why is he also not a non-tall? Because the whole world cannot perceive the mark at the crown of his head; therefore he is also not a non-tall.

Why is the Tathāgata not short? Because long ago he abandoned the affliction of conceit and arrogance; therefore he is not short. And why is he also not a non-short? Because he displayed to the householder Kuśīla a body three cubits tall; therefore he is also not a non-short.

Why is the Tathāgata without characteristics? Because long ago he separated from all characteristics; therefore he is without characteristics. And why is he also not without characteristics? Because he is skilled in and has realised all characteristics; therefore he is also not without characteristics.

Why is the Tathāgata not mind? Because he has the characteristic of space; therefore he is not mind. And why is he also not a non-mind? Because he possesses the mind of Dharma endowed with the ten powers, and because he knows the minds of others as well; therefore he is also not a non-mind.

Why is the Tathāgata not a conditioned phenomenon? Because he is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure; therefore he is not a conditioned phenomenon. And why is he also not an unconditioned phenomenon? Because there is coming and going, sitting and lying down, and because he has also demonstrated passing fully into nirvāṇa; therefore he is also not an unconditioned phenomenon.

Why is the Tathāgata not permanent? Because his body possesses limbs and members; therefore he is not permanent. And why is he also not impermanent? The reason is that he possesses awareness. A permanent thing has no awareness — just as space, for example, has none. Because the Tathāgata possesses awareness, he is therefore not permanent. But then how is he not impermanent? Because he possesses speech. A permanent thing has no speech — it is like space. Because the Tathāgata possesses speech, he is therefore not permanent. He is called impermanent because he has bones and

a lineage. That which has no bones and no lineage is called permanent: space is permanent, and therefore has no bones. The Tathāgata has bones and belongs to a lineage — the lineage of Gautama — and therefore he is impermanent. He is called impermanent because he has father and mother. That which has no father and mother is designated permanent.

Space is permanent, and therefore has no father and mother. The Tathāgata has father and mother, and therefore he is impermanent. He is called impermanent because he possesses the four modes of deportment. That which lacks the four modes of deportment is called permanent: space is permanent, and therefore has no four modes of deportment. The Tathāgata possesses the four modes of deportment, and therefore he is impermanent. That which abides permanently has no fixed location and no fixed direction. Space is permanent, and therefore has no fixed location and no fixed direction. The Tathāgata, by contrast, arose in the eastern land, dwelt in Śrāvastī and at Rājagṛha, and therefore he is impermanent. For all these reasons, then, the Tathāgata is not permanent.

As for the statement that he is not impermanent — this is because birth has been completely severed. Whatever phenomenon is accompanied by birth is called impermanent; whatever phenomenon is without birth is called permanent. The Tathāgata too is without birth, and therefore he is permanent. A permanent phenomenon is without lineage, and whatever phenomenon is accompanied by a lineage is called impermanent. The Tathāgata is without birth and without lineage, and because he is without birth and without lineage, he is permanent. A permanent phenomenon pervades everything everywhere, just as space pervades every place without exception. The Tathāgata likewise pervades everywhere in the same way, and therefore he is permanent. An impermanent phenomenon is such that it exists in this location but not in others. The Tathāgata is not like that — it cannot be said of him that he exists here but not elsewhere — and therefore he is permanent. An impermanent phenomenon sometimes exists and sometimes does not. The Tathāgata is not like that: it is not the case that he sometimes exists and sometimes does not, and therefore he is permanent. A permanently abiding phenomenon has no name-and-form (nāmarūpa). Space is permanent, and therefore has no name-and-form. The Tathāgata likewise has no name-and-form, and therefore he is permanent. A permanently abiding phenomenon has no cause and no result. Space is permanent, and therefore has no cause and no result. The Tathāgata likewise has no cause and no result, and therefore he is permanent.

A permanently abiding phenomenon does not fall within the three times. The Tathāgata likewise does not fall within the three times, and therefore he is permanent.

As for the statement that the Tathāgata is not an illusion — this is because all sentient beings of untruth have been completely severed, and therefore he is not an illusion. As for the statement that he is also not non-illusion — this is because the Tathāgata sometimes projects from this single body into bodies beyond measure, and sometimes gathers those measureless bodies back into one; sometimes he passes unobstructed through mountains and crags; sometimes he walks upon water as upon solid ground; sometimes he sinks into the earth as though into water; sometimes he walks through the sky as upon the earth; sometimes smoke billows from his body and great fires blaze, as from a mighty column of flame; sometimes he sends forth clouds and the sound of thunder, producing awe-inspiring roars; and sometimes he transforms into towns, cities, villages, houses, mountains, forests, and trees; sometimes he makes his body vast, and sometimes he makes it small; and sometimes he displays the form of a man, a woman, a boy, or a girl. For all these reasons the Tathāgata is also not non-illusion.

As for the statement that the Tathāgata is not definite — this is because the Tathāgata displayed passing into complete nirvāṇa beneath the śāla trees in the city of Kuśinagara, and therefore he is not definite. As for the statement that he is also not non-definite — this is because of his permanence, his bliss, his selfhood, and his utter purity, and therefore the Tathāgata is also not non-definite.

The statement that the Tathāgata is not defiled — this is because he has completely severed the three kinds of defilement (āsrava), and therefore he is not defiled. As for what is meant by the three defilements: all the afflictions of the desire realm, excepting ignorance, constitute the defilement of desire. All the afflictions of the form realm and the formless realm, excepting ignorance, constitute the defilement of existence. The ignorance of all three realms constitutes the defilement of ignorance. Because the Tathāgata has completely severed all of these, he is without defilement.

Furthermore, all ordinary beings who are childish and unrefined do not perceive the defilement of existence. Why is it that childish and unrefined ordinary beings do not perceive the defilement of existence? It is because all childish and unrefined ordinary beings are possessed of a mind of doubt

regarding the future, of the following kind: Will a body be obtained in a future time, or will it not be obtained? In the past, did this body exist from the very beginning, or did it not exist from the very beginning? In the present, does this body exist, or does it not exist? If there is something called a self, is it form, or is it not form, or is it both form and not-form, or is it neither form nor not-form? Is it perception, or is it not perception, or is it both perception and not-perception, or is it neither perception nor not-perception? Is this body under another's control, or not under another's control, or both under another's control and yet not under another's control, or neither under another's control nor not under another's control? Is there a life-force but no body, or a body but no life-force, or both a body and a life-force, or neither a body nor a life-force? Are the body and life-force permanent, or impermanent, or both permanent and impermanent, or neither permanent nor impermanent? Were this body and life-force made by a sovereign power, or made by time, or made without a cause, or made by the inherent nature of the world, or made by atoms, or made by what is Dharma and what is not Dharma, or made by a person, or made by afflictions, or made by one's parents? Does the self reside in the mind, or does it reside in the eye, or does it pervade the body? Did it come from somewhere else? Where does it go? Who is it that is born? Who is it that dies? In the past, was the self of brahmin caste, or of royal caste, or of merchant caste, or of low caste? In the future, what sort of caste will one obtain? In former times, was this body of mine male, or female, or an animal? If I were to take a life, would there be a sinful transgression worthy of blame, or, ranging from there being no such blameworthy sin all the way to drinking the soup of the mad, would it be sinful, or would it be without sin? Was it done by oneself, or done by another? Have I experienced the maturation of the result, or will I experience the maturation of the karmic result? — With such a mass of doubt-ridden, view-laden afflictions, measureless beyond counting, the minds of sentient beings are obscured. Conditioned by views of doubt, six kinds of mind arise. What are they? The certainty that a self exists; the certainty that there is no self; the view of self; the view of self and what belongs to self; the absence of self and the view of no-self; and that which is self or made by self, experienced by self, or known by self — these are called wrong views. Because the Tathāgata has, in this way, uprooted from their very base the measureless defilements that accompany such views, he is therefore without defilement.

Son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who practices the noble conduct drawn from the Great Nirvāṇa will utterly sever defilements of just that kind. The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, because they always practice the noble conduct, are therefore without defilement.

Son of good family, an ill-bred youth, because he does not properly restrain the five sense faculties, will come to have three defilements, and, led on by non-virtue, will go to a state of non-virtue. Son of good family, consider the analogy of one who rides an unruly horse that is difficult to control: he is thrown into danger and goes over a precipice. One who cannot properly restrain the five sense faculties is just like that — utterly parted from the virtuous path of nirvāṇa, he goes on toward a state of non-virtue. Consider again the analogy of an intractable, untamed yak upon which someone tries to ride: it does not go as intended, but leaves the town behind and goes off to a desolate place. One who cannot restrain the five sense faculties is just like that — parted from the city of nirvāṇa, he is led into the vast wilderness of saṃsāra.

Son of good family, consider the analogy of a treacherous minister who shows his king nine kinds of evil. The five sense faculties when treacherous are just like that — they constantly display to sentient beings measureless quantities of evil and non-virtue. Son of good family, consider the analogy of an ill-bred youth who will not listen to the words taught by his teachers, his preceptors, and his parents, and who commits every kind of non-virtue. Untamed five sense faculties are just like that — they do not listen to the words taught so well by teachers and preceptors, and they bring about the full completion of wrongdoing.

Son of good family, an ill-bred youth, because he cannot restrain the five sense faculties, is constantly tormented by hell-beings, animals, and hungry ghosts. Others, like wicked men who harm the virtuous, afflict him in the same way. Son of good family, an ill-bred youth who cannot restrain the five sense faculties is scattered and distracted among the five sense objects. Just as herdsmen who do not properly tend their cattle allow them to stray into the fields, so too an ill-bred youth who does not restrain the five sense faculties constantly abides within the realms of conditioned existence and encounters suffering in great abundance.

Son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who is diligent with respect to the Great Nirvāṇa and who practices the noble conduct — in order to attain

all virtuous qualities of the Dharma — always tames the five sense faculties and is utterly fearful of attachment, aversion, delusion, pride, arrogance, and envy. Son of good family, whoever guards the five sense faculties very carefully will find that the mind becomes fully gathered and concentrated. Whoever gathers the mind will also gather the five sense faculties. Consider the analogy of one who protects the king: this is called protecting the kingdom. And whoever protects the kingdom is said to be protecting the king. A bodhisattva, a great being, is similarly like that — if he hears this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, he will attain wisdom. Having attained wisdom, he becomes single-pointed with respect to the five sense faculties, and even should mindfulness wander, it returns to right mindfulness. Why is this so? Because of the wisdom of mindfulness.

Son of good family, a skilled herdsman, if his cattle stray into the fields, drives them back and does not let them graze there. A bodhisattva, a great being, is just like that — by means of guarding and gathering the five sense faculties through the wisdom of mindfulness, he does not let them scatter in all directions.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses the wisdom of mindfulness does not perceive the characteristics of a self, does not perceive the characteristics of self and what belongs to self, does not perceive sentient beings as such, and does not perceive objects of conduct as such. Instead, seeing all phenomena as conforming to the characteristic of the nature of reality, he gives rise to characteristics like those of earth, pebbles, and sand. Just as a house arises from many conditions —

— just as a house that has been severed and demolished has no intrinsic nature, so too sentient beings, when examined, arise from the four great elements and the five aggregates, and therefore have no fixed, definitive characteristic. Because they have no fixed, definitive characteristic, the bodhisattva does not give rise to attachment and clinging toward them. All foolish, ordinary people, seeing sentient beings as truly existent, are born into affliction. A bodhisattva, a great being, who is diligent in the great nirvāṇa sūtra, possessing the wisdom of mindfulness, does not give rise to attachment and clinging toward sentient beings. Furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, who is diligent in the sūtra teaching of the great nirvāṇa, does not become attached to the characteristics of sentient beings; rather, he works with the various characteristics of phenomena. Good son, take the example of a painter who, using many colors, paints images of boys and girls, cattle,

horses, and many other forms. When foolish, unintelligent ordinary people see these, they give rise to the characteristics of boys, girls, and so forth. The painter, however, clearly understands that there are no actual boys or girls or any of the rest. A bodhisattva, a great being, is likewise: by understanding the varied characteristics of phenomena as a single characteristic, he does not give rise to the characteristics of sentient beings. Why is this? Because he possesses the wisdom of mindfulness. Bodhisattvas, great beings, who are diligent in the great nirvāṇa — even if they see a beautiful woman, they never give rise to a mind of desire and attachment. Why? Because they have thoroughly understood characteristics. Good son, a bodhisattva, a great being, understands that the five objects of desire hold no genuine pleasure, no real happiness; they are not stable even for a single moment. They are like a dog gnawing a bare bone, like a torch carried into the wind, like the vessel of a venomous serpent, like something found in a dream, like food set out at a crossroads that all are snatching at, like a piece of meat that every bird in the sky is tearing at, like a bubble on water, like a drawing made on water, like the thread of a loom when its material is exhausted, like a prisoner being led to execution, like a reflected image that does not last long. In these and many other ways, he understands that desire is laden with the most numerous faults. Furthermore, when a bodhisattva, a great being, examines sentient beings, he sees that through the causes and conditions of form, sound, smell, taste, and touch, they have continuously experienced suffering throughout immeasurable, incalculable eons. The bones of each single sentient being, stacked up over the course of one eon, would form a pile greater than Mount Vipula near Rājagṛha. The milk each has drunk would exceed the waters of the ocean. The blood that has flowed from each one's body would exceed the waters of the four oceans. The tears wept by parents, siblings, spouses, children, and relatives at each one's death would likewise exceed the waters of the four oceans. Were one to make tokens four finger-breadths long from all the grasses and trees on this great earth and use them to count one's past parents, their number could not be known. For immeasurable eons, sentient beings have taken birth in hells, in the realms of animals, and as hungry ghosts, experiencing vast suffering beyond any telling or reckoning. It would be easier to reduce this entire great earth to balls the size of juniper berries and count them to their end than it would be to find an end to saṃsāra. When a bodhisattva, a great being, examines all sentient beings in this way, he understands that through the causes and conditions of desire they experience immeasurable suffering. Yet these sufferings — the sufferings of the

conditioning factors of saṃsāra — do not cause the bodhisattva to let the wisdom of mindfulness decline. Good son, take this example: in the world, within a tract of land twenty-five leagues across, filled with a great multitude of people, a king sends one of his ministers carrying a bowl full of sesame oil, and commanded him to pass through all that great multitude of people without spilling even a single drop of the oil. "If you spill even one drop," the king declared, "you will be put to death." A man was then sent behind him carrying a sword. The minister, having received the king's command and taken it deeply to heart, exerted himself with extreme care and walked throughout the midst of that vast assembly. Even though he saw the five objects of desire all around him, his mind constantly held this thought: "If I grow slack and become attached to those pleasures, I will spill this oil, and my life will be forfeit." It was through causes and conditions of fear such as these that he did not spill even a single drop. The bodhisattva, the great being, is likewise: moving through the midst of saṃsāra, he does not lose the wisdom of mindfulness, and because he does not lose it, even though he sees the five objects of desire, no mind of attachment arises in him. Even if he sees a beautiful form, he does not generate the characteristic mark of form as form; he understands it to the extent of the characteristic mark of suffering and the characteristic mark of consciousness. In the same way, he does not apprehend it under the characteristic mark of arising, does not apprehend it under the characteristic mark of cessation, does not apprehend it under the characteristic mark of a cause, but perceives it under the characteristic mark of what has arisen through conditions.

At that time the bodhisattva's five faculties are thoroughly purified. Because the five faculties are thoroughly purified, he is endowed with the guarding of the root of moral discipline. All base and ignoble persons, because their five faculties are not purified, are quite unable to guard it thoroughly — these faculties are called "defiled." The bodhisattva, through thorough severance, is without defilement. The Tathāgata has extracted it by the root and so is beyond defilement altogether. Good son, there is yet another way of fully abandoning defilement: the bodhisattva, the great being, fully abandons wicked defilement out of longing for the buddha-field of the unsurpassable ambrosia. And what is this abandoning? Whoever applies himself diligently to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa — writing it down, holding it, reading it, reciting it, expounding and explaining it, taking its meaning to heart — this is called abandonment. Why is that? Good son, among the twelve branches of scripture

I have not found any other teaching on the full abandonment of wicked defilement as extensive as this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa.

Good son, take this example: when a skilled master teaches his students, any student who listens to his instruction commits no fault. In the same way, the bodhisattva, the great being, who cultivates this supreme and excellent sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa likewise commits no fault.

Good son, take this example as well: in the world there is a noble spell of knowledge, and whoever hears it will not be harmed by any poison for seven years and will not be seized by snakes. Whoever recites it aloud will, for as long as they live, be free from evils of many kinds.

Good son, this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is likewise: if any sentient being hears it even once, entering through the ear, they will not fall into the lower realms for seven eons to come. And if someone writes it down, reads it, recites it, expounds and explains it, or takes its meaning to heart, they will without fail attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening, and will perceive the perfectly pure intrinsic nature of a buddha — just as a wheel-turning king of magical power attains the taste of ambrosia. Good son, this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa possesses immeasurable qualities such as these.

Good son, if someone writes down this sūtra, reads it, recites it, expounds and explains it,

spreads it to others, teaches it, or takes its meaning to heart — that person is truly my close attendant, one who genuinely hears my scriptural transmission. Know that I look upon such a person and hold them in my intention, and understand that one so regarded by me will not pass beyond nirvāṇa without attaining it. Wherever that person resides — in a village, a city, a town, in the mountains, at the foot of a tree, in a hermitage, a dwelling, a house, an upper story, or a vast palace — I too remain there and go nowhere else. I constantly accept their offerings, appearing in emanation as a monk, a nun, a layman, a laywoman, a brahmin, a wandering mendicant, a poor person, a destitute person, or a beggar, and in that form I receive their gifts.

Noble Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, the thirtieth fascicle.

Now, how does the Tathāgata receive such offerings? Good son, if that person, dreaming in the night, sees the form of a buddha, the form of a god, the form of a renunciant, the form of a king or a wheel-turning king, the form of a lion king, a lotus, a flower of the udumbara tree, a great mountain, an ocean, the

sun, the moon, a white bull, a white horse, or the forms of one's parents and the like; or if in the dream one finds flowers, fruit, gold, silver, crystal, lapis lazuli, or other precious jewels; or if one dreams of obtaining the five flavors of cow's milk — at that very time and in that very moment, know that the Tathāgata has accepted the offerings of that person. Upon waking, one will be filled with great joy and happiness, will obtain various desired objects, will be free of ill will, and will become devoted to practicing virtuous qualities.

Good son, this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is capable of accomplishing immeasurable, incalculable, and inconceivable stores of merit such as these. Good son, you should place your trust in my words. If any son or daughter of good family wishes to see me, or wishes to pay me homage, or wishes to see me in a way consonant with the nature of reality, or wishes to attain the meditative absorption of emptiness, or wishes to see the true defining marks, or wishes to cultivate the meditative absorption of courageous conduct and the meditative absorption of the lion king, or wishes to vanquish the eight māras — and the eight māras are: the four māras, together with impermanence, the absence of bliss, no-self, and the absence of perfect purity — or wishes to be born as a human being, or wishes the happiness of the gods: let such a person, upon seeing someone who upholds this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra, who has written it down, reads it, recites it, expounds and explains it, or takes its meaning to heart — let them draw near to that person, approach them, take up residence with them, make supplications and requests, offer veneration, respect, and honor, wash their feet, prepare a seat and a cushion, make offerings with the four kinds of requisites, and do so without reluctance. If that person has come from a great distance, one should go out to meet them for up to ten leagues. For the sake of this sūtra, one should offer all precious wealth held dear. And if one has none, one should even sell one's own body. Why is this? Because this sūtra is as rare to encounter as the flower of the udumbara tree.

Good son, in times long past, through immeasurable, incalculable, and boundless eons beyond reckoning, there was in this world-system called Endurance the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, fully possessed of knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, the knower of the world, the unsurpassed one, the guide and master of persons to be tamed, the teacher of gods and humans —

— a Blessed One, a buddha, arose and taught this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra to a vast assembly. At that time I heard from a spiritual friend that this buddha was

teaching the Great Nirvāṇa to a vast assembly. When I heard this I was filled with great joy, and I thought to make an offering. But having thought to offer, I found I was utterly destitute and had nothing whatsoever. Having tried to sell my body, I found only a trifling sum — not enough to matter. So I turned back homeward, and on the road I met a man and said to him, "If I sell this body of mine, would you buy it?"

He replied, "I have a task that no one else is able to perform. If you are capable of doing it, I will buy you."

I asked him what it was that no one else could do, and he said, "I have a severe illness. Skilled physicians have examined it and say that if I eat three sers of human flesh every day, it will cure me. If you are able to cut three sers of flesh from your body each day and give it to me, I will give you five golden coins."

When I heard these words, my mind was filled with great joy, and I said to him, "Give me the coins and grant me seven days, and after I have done what I need to do, you may do with me as you please."

He replied, "Seven days is too long. If it is truly possible, grant me at least one day."

Good son, at that time I took the coins, went back to where the buddha was, bowed at his feet with my head, and offered and presented everything I had without remainder. Then, with a settled and composed mind, I listened to this sūtra. At that time, because my faculties were dull, though I heard this sūtra, I was able to retain only a single chapter of four lines. And this is what it was:

The passing beyond sorrow of the Tathāgata
is the utter severing of all cyclic existence.
Whoever listens to it with one-pointed mind
will forever obtain immeasurable bliss.

Having retained these verses, I went back to the sick man's house. Good son, at that time, each day I cut three sers of flesh, and yet through the power of meditating on these verses as cause and condition, I did not grow faint. Not for a single day was there any interruption; I gave in this way for a full month. Good son, through that cause and those conditions, the sick man recovered. My own body too became as it was before, free of any wound, without a scar. And when at that time I saw that my body was unharmed, I generated the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. If even a single

verse has such power when one retains it fully, recites it, or proclaims it aloud — how much more need be said? Seeing that this sūtra has such benefit, I aroused an even greater aspiration than before and made this prayer: "May I in a future time attain the awakening of a buddha, and may my name be Śākyamuni."

Good son, through the cause and condition of the power of that single verse, I am today, within a great assembly, able to teach it fully and completely to gods and humans alike. Good son, therefore this Great Nirvāṇa is inconceivable. It is endowed with qualities that are boundless and without limit. This is the very essence spoken with deep intention by the Blessed One, the buddhas. Therefore whoever retains it will abandon and cut off all evil defilements.

As for "evil" — this refers to evil yaks, evil horses, evil cattle, dogs, places harboring vicious and harmful snakes, ground covered with sharp and wicked thorns, filth, precipices and chasms, desolate and dangerous places,

evil foxes and wolves, evil people, evil lands, evil towns, evil households, evil spiritual friends, and the like. If any of these become a cause for defilement, the bodhisattva abandons them. If they do not, he does not abandon them. If they generate defilement, he abandons them; if they do not generate defilement, he does not abandon them. If they lead to unwholesome Dharma, he completely abandons them; if they lead to virtue, he does not abandon them. How does he abandon them? He abandons them always through the method of a mind of solitude, unimpeded as a weapon. Therefore this is called abandonment through a mind of solitude. He abandons unwholesome Dharma in order to bring forth virtue.

The bodhisattva, the great being, understands this body to be like a disease, like a wound, like a swelling, like an enemy, like an arrow piercing the flesh, and understands that this great mass of suffering is the root of all virtue and non-virtue alike. Although this body is impure in this way, the bodhisattva nonetheless cares for it and tends to it. Why is that? Not out of attachment to the body, but for the sake of wholesome Dharma. It is for the sake of nirvāṇa, not for the sake of wandering in saṃsāra. It is for the sake of permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — not for the sake of impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and impurity. It is for the sake of the path of awakening, not for the sake of the path of continued existence. It is for the sake of the one vehicle, not for the sake of the three vehicles. It is for the sake of the sacred

body adorned with the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks — not for the sake of a body up to and including the realm of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. It is for the sake of becoming a king who turns the wheel of Dharma, not for the sake of becoming a wheel-turning monarch.

Good son, the bodhisattva, the great being, must always guard the body. Why is that? If the body is not guarded, one will not be able to sustain life. If life is not sustained, one will be unable to transcribe, retain, read, recite, teach extensively to others, or contemplate the meaning of this sūtra. Therefore the bodhisattva must guard the body most carefully. For this very reason the bodhisattva has come to abandon all evil defilements.

Good son, consider these examples: one who crosses water guards his boat and raft with the greatest care; a traveler who has set out on the road tends most carefully to his good horse and other mounts; a farmer guards his oxen and the like with the greatest care; one who wishes to benefit from poison guards a venomous snake with the greatest care; one who possesses many goods guards against low-caste outcasts; one who goes to battle with enemies guards his fighting men with care; just as one guards fire against the cold; and just as lepers seek potent medicine — in just the same way, the bodhisattva, the great being, though seeing this body as possessed of measureless impurity and utterly filled with it, nonetheless guards and tends to it without neglect or abandonment, in order to uphold this Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra as a dhāraṇī.

The bodhisattva, the great being, when he considers a vicious bull and an evil spiritual friend and the like, sees them as non-dual. Why is that? Because both bring destruction to the body. The bodhisattva, the great being, has no mind of fear and dread toward a vicious bull and the like. But toward an evil companion, he gives rise to a mind of the most intense fear and dread. Why is that? A vicious bull and the like can only destroy the body, but they cannot destroy the mind.

An evil companion can destroy both. A vicious bull and the like can destroy only the body, but an evil companion can destroy boundless virtuous bodies and boundless virtuous minds as well. A vicious bull and the like can destroy only this unclean body, but an evil companion can destroy a purified body and a purified mind. A vicious bull and the like can destroy only a body of flesh, but an evil companion can destroy the Dharma body. If one is killed by a vicious

bull, one does not go to the three lower destinies, but if one is killed by an evil companion, one will without doubt go to the three lower destinies. A vicious bull and the like become an enemy of the body, but an evil companion becomes an enemy of virtuous Dharma. Therefore a bodhisattva must abandon evil companions from afar.

Defilements of this kind are not abandoned by base and ignoble people, and so defilements arise. The bodhisattva abandons them, and so defilements do not arise. If even a bodhisattva is thus free of such defilements, what need is there to speak of the Tathāgata? Therefore these are not defilements for him.

What then is meant by proximity to defilement? All base and ignoble people, for the sake of physical and mental comfort, accept robes, food, bedding, and medicines for illness and the like. Seeking such goods, they commit many kinds of evil and do not recognize their wrongdoing, and so they revolve through the three lower destinies. This is therefore called defilement.

The bodhisattva, the great being, seeing such faults, thoroughly abandons them. If he desires robes and accepts them, it is not for the sake of the body alone but solely for the sake of the Dharma. Not giving rise to pride or conceit, always maintaining a humble mind, it is not for the sake of ornament or wanting fine things, but for the sake of protection from shame, and from heat, cold, wind, driving rain, mosquitoes, gnats, and venomous creatures. When he accepts clothing and food, there is no mind of attachment, and it is not for the body's sake but always for the sake of the holy Dharma. It is not for the sake of weakness but for the sake of sentient beings. It is not for pride and conceit but for the sake of the body and its strength. It is not for the sake of animosity or enemies but to heal the wound of hunger. Even when excellent flavors are obtained, there is no mind of attachment to them. It is the same with accepting lodgings: he does not remain pervasively afflicted by attachment and pride, but makes them a place of awakening. He accepts lodgings in order to overcome the enemies of affliction and as shelter from strong winds and driving rain. In seeking medicine for illness too there is no mind of attachment; it is for the sake of the holy Dharma, not for the sake of sustaining life — rather it is to keep life going for as long as needed.

Son of good family, it is just as when someone afflicted with the disease of ulcers is rubbed with flour and butter, wrapped in cloth, and, because pus and blood have issued forth, medicine is applied to heal the ulcers and one enters a deep chamber to keep off the wind. In just the same way, the bodhisattva,

the great being, regards the body as if it were a wound, covers it with cloth, and because pus oozes from the nine openings he seeks food; for shelter from strong winds and driving rain he accepts lodgings; and to counteract the four kinds of poison he seeks medicine. Thus the bodhisattva accepts the four requisites for the sake of the path to awakening and not for the sake of mere livelihood.

Why is that? The bodhisattva, the great being, thinks to himself: if I do not accept these four requisites, my body will lack support and become unstable. If it becomes unstable, suffering will become unbearable. If suffering becomes unbearable, I will not be able to practice all virtuous Dharma fully and completely.

If one can endure suffering, one will cultivate virtuous Dharma without measure. But if one cannot endure suffering, a mind of aversion will arise toward the experience of pain, and a mind of attachment will arise toward the experience of pleasure. If happiness is sought but not found, ignorance will arise. For these reasons, the foolish and ignoble ordinary person generates defilements from the four requisites. The bodhisattva, the great being, however, through thorough and clear discernment, does not generate defilements. Therefore, if even the bodhisattva is said to be without defilement, how much less can it be said that the Tathāgata possesses defilements — for the Tathāgata is without defilement.

Furthermore, noble son, all foolish and ignoble persons, even while guarding body and mind most carefully, give rise to three kinds of non-virtuous thought. Through these as cause and condition, the afflictions cut off entirely, yet even those reborn in the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception fall back into the three lower realms. Noble son, consider the example of a person who crosses an ocean and, just as the far shore draws near, drowns and dies in the water. The foolish and ignoble ordinary person is just like this: just as the three realms are about to be exhausted, he falls back again into the three lower realms. Why is that? Because virtuous thoughts are absent. And what are virtuous thoughts? They are the six applications of mindfulness. In the foolish and ignoble person, the virtuous mind is weak while the non-virtuous mind blazes fiercely. Because the virtuous mind is weak, the mind of wisdom becomes thin. Because the mind of wisdom is thin, all defilements arise and proliferate.

The bodhisattva, the great being, with the eye of wisdom wholly purified, sees the fault of these three kinds of thought. He understands that these three thoughts, together with their manifold faults, are at all times the enemy of sentient beings across the three vehicles. Through these three thoughts as cause and condition, measureless inferior sentient beings are prevented from seeing the nature of the buddhas, and throughout measureless eons they generate perverted minds of this sort: "The Blessed One, the Buddha, has no permanence, no bliss, no self — only purity exists. The Tathāgata has passed into final nirvāṇa, and as for all sentient beings, there is no permanence, no bliss, no self, and no purity" — and with minds of inversion they declare that permanence, bliss, self, and purity do exist. Again they say: "In reality, not even the three vehicles exist" — yet with perverted minds they declare that the three vehicles do exist. "The one path of truth is the truly true" — yet with perverted minds they declare that not even one truth exists. The three kinds of non-virtuous thought are always and utterly condemned by the buddhas and bodhisattvas. These three kinds of non-virtuous perverted thought always do great harm to oneself and others alike. Because these three thoughts are present, all non-virtues follow without cease, like a shadow that never parts. These same three thoughts become the three thorough afflictions, linking together the endless succession of sentient beings' bondage in saṃsāra.

The bodhisattva, the great being, always reflects thoroughly upon these three thoughts in this way. If, through some cause and condition, a thought of desire arises in the bodhisattva, he does not indulge it and says nothing.

Consider how a man of excellent and fastidious cleanliness will accept nothing that is soiled or impure. Consider how no one grasps a blazing fire with bare hands. By nature, a brahmin does not eat the flesh of cattle. Those who are full will not take inferior food. Just as a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) would not sit on the same seat as the lowest of outcaste birth, so too the bodhisattva, the great being, does not take up or experience the three perverted thoughts. Why is this so?

The bodhisattva reflects in this way: if all sentient beings regard me as a field of merit, how could I possibly engage in these non-virtuous phenomena? If I were to engage in such non-virtuous thoughts, I would be unworthy to be a field of merit for sentient beings. Even if I did not myself declare, "I am a field of merit," sentient beings would, seeing how I conduct myself, say that I am their field of merit. If I were to give rise to non-virtuous thoughts of that kind, I would be deceiving all sentient beings. I was deceived in precisely this way

before, and so I wandered in saṃsāra for immeasurable aeons, falling into the three lower destinies. If I were to receive, with a non-virtuous mind, what a donor offered with faith, I would be condemned and reviled by all gods, humans, and sages endowed with the five higher knowledges. If I were to receive with non-virtuous thoughts what a donor offered with faith, the donor's fruit would become diminished, or the fruit would be rendered meaningless; and if I were to receive with a non-virtuous mind what the donor gave, I would become an enemy to that faithful donor. All donors regard me as they regard their only child. Why then should I deceive them and conceive of them as enemies? For if a donor fails to obtain the fruit, or the fruit becomes diminished, it would always be inappropriate for me even to be called "one who has gone forth" (pravrajita). One who has gone forth should not engage in non-virtue; it is unworthy of that status. If one produces non-virtue, one should not be called one who has gone forth. One who has gone forth is possessed of purity in body and in speech. If one lacks those qualities, one should not be called one who has gone forth.

I have abandoned my father and mother, brothers and sisters, my wife, my children, and all relatives and friends, and I have gone forth and am cultivating the path. This is the time for thoroughly cultivating wholesome thoughts, not a time for cultivating non-virtuous thoughts. It is like a person who enters the ocean to seek jewels and, rather than taking genuine jewels, takes only crystals instead. Or again, it is like someone who abandons sublime music and plays instead in a place of filth and impurity. It is like casting away a precious jewel of a daughter and sleeping with a slave woman. It is like setting aside a vessel of gold and using a clay bowl. It is like abandoning ambrosia and drinking poison instead. It is like abandoning a dear and skilled physician and receiving treatment and drinking medicine from a hostile, ill-natured physician who is one's enemy.

I am just the same: it is as though I have abandoned the taste of Dharma, which is like ambrosia, taught by the great Teacher, the buddha, the Blessed One, and instead am drinking the various kinds of non-virtuous thoughts of Māra.

A human body is exceedingly difficult to obtain, like the udumbara flower, and I have now obtained one. An encounter with a Tathāgata is exceedingly rare, like the udumbara flower, and I have now had that encounter.

To see and hear the pure jewel of Dharma is as rare as a blind tortoise finding a yoke floating upon the water, and I have now heard it. Human life does not linger — it is swifter than a deer on a steep cliff face; here today, it is not certain to remain tomorrow. Why then should I dwell with a scattered, distracted mind in non-virtuous things? Youth, too, does not linger — it is swifter even than a galloping horse. Why then be proud and arrogant on account of it? Just as a hungry ghost (preta) in a wretched state seeks any opportunity to harm a person, so too do the hungry ghosts of the four great elements always seek an occasion to cause me harm. Why, then, should I give rise to non-virtuous thoughts? Like a decaying house on the verge of collapse, my life is just the same — why, then, should I give rise to non-virtue?

I am called a renunciant (śramaṇa). The word "renunciant" means one who reflects upon virtuous thoughts. If I now give rise to non-virtuous thoughts, how can I rightly be called a renunciant? I am called one who has gone forth (pravrajita). The meaning of "gone forth" is one who cultivates the path of virtue. If I now engage in non-virtue, how can I rightly be called one who has gone forth? I am called a brahmin. The word "brahmin" means one who lives the holy life (brahmacarya). If I engage in the non-virtuous, impure thoughts of an unholy life, how can I rightly be called a brahmin? I am also called one of the great warrior-noble class (kṣatriya). "Warrior-noble" means one who has tamed the enemy. If I do not now tame the enemy of non-virtue, how can I rightly be called a warrior-noble? I am also called a monk (bhikṣu). "Monk" means one who conquers the afflictions. If today I have not conquered the afflictions through non-virtuous thoughts, how can I rightly be called a monk?

In this world, these six things are exceedingly difficult to encounter, and I have now encountered them. Why, then, should non-virtuous thoughts be allowed to dwell in the mind? What are the six? They are: the arising of a buddha in the world, which is hard to encounter; the hearing of the holy Dharma, which is difficult; the arising of a mind of urgency and spiritual fear, which is difficult; birth in a central land, which is difficult; obtaining a human body, which is difficult; and possessing all one's faculties intact, which is difficult. Such things, these six, which are so hard to obtain, I have now obtained. Therefore it is improper to give rise to non-virtuous thoughts — so he thought in his mind.

At that time, the bodhisattva who was diligently applying himself to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa was perpetually and vigilantly examining whether diligence itself might be a form of non-virtuous mind. All those of base and

ignoble character, not seeing the fault in such a non-virtuous mind, seize upon the three kinds of thought, and are therefore called defiled, possessed of outflows (āsrava). The bodhisattva, seeing this, does not seize upon them; without attachment, he utterly relinquishes and does not preserve them. Relying upon the noble eightfold path, he expels and utterly cuts them off. Therefore, if even a bodhisattva does not take up outflows, why would anyone say that the Tathāgata possesses outflows? For this very reason, the Tathāgata is not one who possesses outflows.

Son of good family, those of base and ignoble character, when tormented by suffering in body and mind, give rise to all manner of non-virtue. If the body or mind is sick and in pain, they perform all manner of non-virtuous deeds of body, speech, and mind. Having committed non-virtue, they cycle through the three lower destinies and come to experience suffering in its fullness. Why is this? Because those of base and ignoble character, lacking mindfulness and wisdom, give rise to all manner of outflows — and this is called the outflow of mindlessness.

The bodhisattva, the great being, always reflects thus: "In the past, over countless eons, on account of this body and mind, I have performed all manner of non-virtue. Through the causes and conditions of having done so, I have spun deep in cyclic existence, experienced abundant suffering in its fullness in the three lower destinies, and have kept myself far from the path of the three vehicles." Reflecting in this way, that bodhisattva, through those very causes and conditions, gives rise to a profound terror toward body and mind, thoroughly abandons the many forms of non-virtue, and enters earnestly upon the path of virtue.

Son of good family, consider this example. A certain king placed four venomous serpents inside a single vessel and commanded a man to guard them, to bathe them, to rouse them, to wash them, and to perform other such tasks. The king decreed: "If any one of these serpents becomes enraged, I shall have you put to death by the law before a great assembly of people." Upon hearing the king's command, the man was seized with great fear. He abandoned the vessel of serpents and fled. The king then dispatched five men of vile and outcast character, each bearing a sword, to pursue him from behind. The man glanced back, saw the five men coming from behind, and fled all the faster. Then the five men, by a deceitful stratagem, concealed their drawn swords and, feigning closeness and friendship, approached him. One of them said to him, "Come back!" But the man did not trust him, and in order to

hide he went into a certain city. Having entered the city and looked into every house, he saw not a single person; and looking into the earthen jars and other vessels, he found them all empty, with nothing whatsoever inside. Having found neither person nor goods, he sat down on the ground, and from the empty sky a voice rang out: "Son of good family, in this empty city not a single person dwells, and tonight six hostile enemies will come. If you encounter them, you will not escape with your life — why then do you remain idle?" The man, now more terrified than before, rose from that place and set out, and along the road he came upon a great river. The river was extremely fierce, and there was neither boat nor raft; yet out of fear he gathered much grass and wood and fashioned a makeshift raft. He then thought: "If I remain here, I will be harmed by the four venomous serpents, the five vile outcasts, the one who feigned friendship, and the six hostile enemies. Yet if I try to cross this river, the raft may not hold firm and I shall sink into the water and die. But even so, it is better to drown and die than to be tormented by the serpents and enemies." With that thought he launched the grass raft into the water, seated himself upon it, paddled with his hands and kicked with his feet, cut across the current, and arrived safely at the far bank. His mind and heart became at ease, and he was free from fear and terror.

The bodhisattva, the great being, who hears and retains this great sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, should regard the body as like the vessel, should regard earth, water, fire, and wind as like the four venomous serpents — venomous through sight, venomous through touch, venomous through breath, and venomous through ingestion — for all sentient beings who come into contact with any one of those four forms of venom will meet their end. The four great serpents of sentient beings are likewise so: seeing causes one to commit non-virtue, touching causes one to commit non-virtue, associating causes one to commit non-virtue, and consuming causes one to commit non-virtue — and through those causes and conditions, one comes to abandon all virtue.

Furthermore, son of good family, the great bodhisattva contemplates that, just as the four venomous serpents fall into four kinds, so too there are four social classes: the warrior-noble class, the brahmin class, the merchant class, and the outcaste class. Likewise, the serpents of the four great elements have four distinct natures: the nature of solidity, the nature of moisture, the nature of heat, and the nature of movement. Therefore the bodhisattva regards the four great elements and the four venomous serpents as alike in nature.

Furthermore, son of good family, the bodhisattva regards the four great elements as being like the four venomous serpents. How so? The four venomous serpents are ever seeking an opportunity against a person, thinking: "When will I get to be seen? When will I get to be touched? When will my breath be inhaled? When will I get to be eaten?" In the very same way, the venomous serpents of the four great elements are always seeking out the faults and failings of sentient beings. If one is killed by the four venomous serpents, one will never go to the three lower realms. But if one is killed by the four great elements, one will certainly and without doubt go to the three lower realms — there is no question about it. The four venomous serpents, even when well tended and cared for, still think of killing a person. The four great elements are likewise: no matter how constantly one nourishes and serves them, they cause one to commit every kind of non-virtue without exception. If even one of the four venomous serpents becomes enraged, it is capable of killing a person. The nature of the four great elements is just the same: even a slight imbalance in a single great element is capable of killing a person. The four venomous serpents, though they dwell together, each has its own separate mind. The venomous serpents of the four great elements are likewise: though they abide together, each has its own distinct nature. Even if one shows respect to those four venomous serpents, they are hard to approach safely. The venomous serpents of the four great elements are just the same: even if one shows them respect, they are hard to approach safely. If one is seized by the four venomous serpents, a renunciant (śramaṇa) or brahmin or the like may be able to heal one with spells and medicine. But if one is killed by the four great elements, even if renunciants or brahmins and the like were to tend one with the finest spells and medicines, one would not recover. Even those who play with snakes, if struck by the smell of the four venomous serpents, will utterly flee. Buddhas and bodhisattvas are just the same: if they sense the smell of the four great elements, they utterly abandon them. At that moment the bodhisattva generates great fear of the venomous serpents of the four great elements, turns away from them, swiftly flees, and resolves: "I must meditate upon the noble eightfold path."

The "five vile clans" is an analogy for the five aggregates (skandhas). How does the bodhisattva regard the five aggregates as being like five vile clans? The so-called vile clan is one that is forever separated from those who are dear and beloved, and is instead delivered up to enemies and those who bear hatred. The five aggregates are just the same: they cause the great mass of

beings to be attached to and to engage with unwholesome phenomena, and at the same time they cause one to be parted from every wholesome quality without exception.

Furthermore, son of good family, by way of example: the vile clan adorns itself with swords, clubs, bows and arrows, armor, spears, and weapons of every variety, and uses them to harm others. The five aggregates are just the same: thoroughly adorned with mental afflictions, they injure those who are under the sway of delusion and cause them to fall into the various states of conditioned existence. Son of good family, if a member of a vile clan encounters someone who has done wrong, he will kill them. The five aggregates are just the same: accompanied by the faults of complete affliction, they kill without cease. Therefore the bodhisattva fully understands the five aggregates to be like five vile clans.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva fully understands the five aggregates to be like a vile clan. A vile clan has no mind of loving-kindness or affection, and kills both enemies and friends alike. The five aggregates are just the same: lacking any mind of loving-kindness or affection, they kill both the virtuous and the non-virtuous alike. A vile clan harms every person. The five aggregates are just the same: through the mental afflictions, they constantly harm all sentient beings who wander in cyclic existence. Therefore the bodhisattva understands the five aggregates to be like a vile clan.

A vile clan is always accompanied by a mind intent on harm. The five aggregates are likewise always accompanied by a mind intent on harm, being thoroughly bound up with complete affliction. Just as a person on foot, without a sword or weapon and without a servant, will without question be killed by a vile clan, so too sentient beings who are without feet, without weapons, and without a servant will be killed by the five aggregates. Here, "feet" means moral discipline; "sword" means wisdom; and "servant" means a spiritual friend. Without these three, one will be harmed by the enemy that is the five aggregates. Therefore the bodhisattva understands the five aggregates to be like a vile clan.

Furthermore, son of good family, the bodhisattva, the great being, understands the five aggregates to be even worse than a vile clan. Why is that? If a sentient being is slain by a vile clan, that sentient being will not fall into the hells. But if one is slain by the five aggregates, one falls into the hells. For this reason the bodhisattva understands the five aggregates to be worse

than a vile clan.

Having understood this, the bodhisattva makes this solemn pledge: "I would rather dwell together with a vile clan for an entire lifetime than associate with the five aggregates even for a single instant." A vile clan can only harm the foolish and simple-minded of the desire realm. But the enemy that is the five aggregates harms all the noble and ignoble, all the foolish throughout the three realms. A vile clan kills only those who have done wrong. But the enemy that is the five aggregates harms and thoroughly injures all sentient beings, whether they have done wrong or not. A vile clan does not harm the weak, the aged, women, or young children. But the enemy that is the five aggregates harms all sentient beings, whether old or young, whether male or female.

This is what is called the bodhisattva's understanding the aggregates to be worse than a vile clan. Therefore the bodhisattva makes this vow: "I would rather dwell together with a vile clan for an entire lifetime than approach or rely upon the five aggregates even for a single instant."

Furthermore, son of good family: a vile clan harms only others, not oneself. But the enemy that is the five aggregates harms both oneself and others, as well as those of the vile clan itself. From a vile clan one can escape by offering gentle words and precious wealth. But the five aggregates are not like that: even if one flatters them with gentle words and offers precious wealth and the like, there will be no escape. A vile clan does not kill continuously at every moment of the four periods of day and night. But the five aggregates are not like that: at every single instant, moment after moment, they kill sentient beings without ceasing. When a vile clan is spent in one place, there is room to slip away and flee. But the five aggregates are not like that: they pervade every place without exception, and there is nowhere to slip away and flee. A vile clan may kill a person, but once killed, it does not pursue them further. But the five aggregates are not like that: even after killing a sentient being, they pursue that being and never separate from it.

Therefore, a bodhisattva, even if they must dwell together with a vile clan for the whole of their life, would not draw close to the five aggregates even for a single instant. Those who possess wisdom will, through skillful means, gain liberation from the five aggregates. What is meant by skillful means? It is the noble eightfold path, the six perfections, and the four immeasurables. Through such means one becomes completely free, and neither body nor mind will be harmed by the aggregates. Why is this? Because the body is like a vajra, and

the mind is like space — and for that reason it is exceedingly difficult to destroy body and mind. In light of this meaning, the bodhisattva, having understood that the five aggregates are endowed with many forms of non-virtuous phenomena, gives rise to tremendous, profound fear, and applies themselves earnestly to the noble eightfold path. This is like a person who, fearing four venomous snakes and a vile clan of five, enters the path without hindrance and departs.

One who acts like an enemy pretending to be a friend is one driven by attachment. The great bodhisattva, the bodhisattva of vast mind, fully recognizes that defilement arising from desire acts like an enemy feigning friendship. Whoever knows this in such a way cannot be overcome by anything. Whoever does not know it will without fail be harmed. Attachment is just like that. Those beings who, at that time, know its characteristic marks will not experience the suffering of wandering in cyclic existence. If they do not know it, they will revolve through the six classes of beings and experience all manner of suffering without remainder. Why is this? Because the sickness that arises from attachment is extremely difficult to abandon — just as it is difficult to abandon an enemy who feigns friendship. An enemy who feigns friendship is always seeking an opportunity: it separates one from what is dear and agreeable, and delivers one over to what is hated and hostile. Attachment is exactly the same: it keeps beings distant from all virtuous phenomena and draws them close to all non-virtuous phenomena.

In light of this, the great bodhisattva, the bodhisattva of vast mind, fully understands that attachment is like an enemy feigning friendship — for what was not seen comes to be seen, and what was not heard comes to be heard. Ordinary childlike beings may see the faults of cyclic existence, and though they possess wisdom, they are covered by delusion and so, in the end, fail to see. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are similar: though they see, it is as if they do not see; though they hear, it is as if they do not hear. Why is this? Because they are accompanied by the mind of desire. And how is that? Even though they see the faults of cyclic existence, they cannot swiftly proceed to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore, the great bodhisattva, the bodhisattva of vast mind, fully recognizes that this affliction of desire and attachment is like an enemy feigning friendship.

What, then, are the characteristic marks of one who feigns friendship like an enemy? Consider: an enemy, while being untruthful, displays the marks of one who is truthful; while being unsuitable to draw near to or be intimate with,

displays the marks of closeness; while being genuinely non-virtuous, displays the marks of virtue; and while being genuinely unlovely, displays the marks of loveliness. Why? Because such a one is always seeking an opportunity, wishing to cause harm. Desire is just like this: it perpetually deceives all sentient beings — presenting what is untrue as true, what is not close as close, what is non-virtuous as virtuous, and what is unlovely as lovely — and it perpetually deludes everyone and causes them to revolve in cyclic existence.

In light of this, the bodhisattva recognizes attachment as being like an enemy who feigns intimacy. One who feigns intimacy like an enemy — you see their actions of body and speech, but you do not see their mind, and for that reason you are deceived. Desire is just the same: it is nothing but false deception — there is no truth in it at all.

And so all sentient beings have been deceived. One who feigns intimacy like an enemy has a beginning and an end, and is therefore relatively easy to abandon. Attachment (*rāga*) is not like that: having neither beginning nor end, it is extremely difficult to abandon. One who feigns intimacy like an enemy is difficult to recognize from a distance, but easy to recognize when near. Desire is not like that either: even when near it is difficult to recognize — how much more so when far away. For these reasons, the bodhisattva understands attachment as something even worse than an enemy who feigns intimacy.

All sentient beings, through the complete affliction of attachment, have come to be far from great nirvāṇa and close to cyclic existence. They have come to be far from permanence, bliss, selfhood, and perfect purity, and close to impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and the impure.

Therefore, in all the sūtras, I have taught three kinds of stain. Because of ignorance, one does not see the faults and defects in present things, and so one is unable to abandon them. The feigned intimacy of the enemy of attachment can never harm one who is wise and endowed with wisdom. Therefore, the bodhisattva, having thoroughly understood this desire and given rise to great fear, applies earnest effort to the noble eightfold path — just as a person, frightened by one who feigns intimacy while harboring four venomous serpents and five wicked companions, sets out upon the road and does not turn back.

"The empty city" refers to the six sense bases (*āyatana*s). The bodhisattva, the great being, regards the six inner sense bases as empty, devoid of anything whatsoever — like an empty city. Just as a frightened person who enters an

empty city sees not a single person and, looking into every pot and vessel, finds not a single substance — so too the bodhisattva, when he thoroughly examines the six sense bases, finds them empty and devoid of anything whatsoever, and does not find even one truly real substance belonging to a sentient being. Therefore the bodhisattva regards the six inner sense bases as empty, devoid of anything whatsoever, like that empty city.

Noble son, when enemies and thieves look upon that empty city from a distance, the perception of emptiness does not arise in them. Similarly, ordinary, foolish, worldly beings are like this: in regard to the city of the six sense bases, the perception of emptiness does not arise in them. Because the perception of emptiness does not arise, they revolve in cyclic existence and come to experience immeasurable suffering.

Noble son, just as enemies and thieves, upon actually entering that city, give rise from the outset to the perception of emptiness — so too is the bodhisattva: upon examining these six sense bases, the perception of emptiness always arises. Because the perception of emptiness has arisen, he does not revolve in cyclic existence and does not experience suffering. The bodhisattva, the great being, does not fall into error with regard to these six sense bases. Because he does not fall into error, he does not come to revolve in cyclic existence.

Furthermore, noble son, thieves who enter an empty city come to attain pleasure. The thieves of the afflictions are likewise: upon entering into those six sense bases, they come to attain pleasure. And just as thieves dwelling in an empty city have no mind of fear — so too the enemy-afflictions: dwelling within those six sense bases, they have no fear.

Just as that empty city is not harmed by lions, tigers, wolves, and...

just as an empty city is the dwelling place of all manner of fierce and harmful wild beasts, so too are these six inner sense bases: they are the dwelling place of all manner of fierce and harmful wild beasts — the afflictions. Therefore, the bodhisattva fully recognizes that the six sense bases, utterly devoid of anything real, are the dwelling place of all non-virtue.

Furthermore, noble son, the bodhisattva, the great being, recognizes that the six inner sense bases — utterly devoid of anything real — are like that empty city. Why is this? Because they are deceived by what is false: one perceives as existent what is utterly devoid of anything real, one perceives as pleasurable what is truly without pleasure, and one perceives a person where there is truly

no person. The six inner sense bases are likewise: one perceives as existent what is utterly devoid of anything real, one perceives as pleasurable what is truly without pleasure, and one perceives a person where there is truly no person. Only the learned and wise are able to know this truly and as it is.

Furthermore, noble son, an empty city is at times inhabited and at times uninhabited. The six sense bases are not like that — they do not go to either extreme. Why is this? Because they are empty by essential nature. What the learned and wise know of this is not something seen with the eye.

Therefore, having understood that the six inner sense bases are filled with enemies and harms, the bodhisattva does not dwell there at ease but applies himself strenuously to the noble eightfold path — just as a person, fearing four venomous serpents, five villains, one who pretends to be a friend while plotting with treachery, and six thieves, enters upon the path of truth.

The six great enemies are the six outer sense objects. The bodhisattva, the great being, fully recognizes the six sense objects as being like six great enemies. Why is this? Because they plunder all virtuous qualities. Just as six enemies can seize all the wealth, possessions, and precious things of every person, so too the enemies of the six sense objects: they can seize all the wealth of virtue belonging to every sentient being. Just as, if six great enemies were to enter a person's home, they would not distinguish between good and poor goods but would seize everything present and reduce even the very wealthy to poverty — so too the enemies of the six sense objects: if they enter a person's sense faculties, they will plunder all virtuous qualities. Once those virtuous qualities are exhausted and one is impoverished, one commits even the deeds born of wrong craving. Therefore, the bodhisattva fully and correctly recognizes the six sense objects as being exactly like six great enemies.

Furthermore, noble son, when those six enemies set out to plunder, they need something on the inside to assist them. If there is nothing on the inside to assist them, they turn back from there on the spot. The enemies of the six sense objects are likewise: when they set out to plunder virtuous qualities, they need, on the inside, the perceiving and recognizing of sentient beings as real, and the perceiving and knowing of such signs as permanence, pleasure, self, purity, non-emptiness, and so forth. If there is no such grasping at signs as these on the inside, then the hostile enemies of the six sense objects cannot plunder all virtuous qualities. The learned and wise person has no such signs within. The foolish and base, however, do have such things within, and

so the six sense objects continually come to seize the wealth of virtuous qualities. Because one has not guarded well, one is robbed. The guard is wisdom, and those who possess wisdom, having guarded well, are not robbed. Therefore, the bodhisattva understands, without distinction, that the six sense objects are exactly like six great enemies.

Thirty-first fascicle.

Furthermore, noble son, the six great enemies are able to afflict the bodies and minds of others with suffering.

The six sense-object enemies are likewise: they continually afflict the bodies and minds of sentient beings with the three kinds of suffering. The six great enemies can only rob the wealth of the present moment, but the six sense-object enemies always rob all the virtuous wealth of sentient beings across the three times. The six great enemies rejoice when the sun sets. The six hostile sense-object enemies are likewise: they rejoice when dwelling in the darkness of ignorance. The six great enemies can be brought down by kings. The six hostile sense-object enemies are likewise: they can be brought down by buddhas and bodhisattvas. When the six great enemies intend to plunder, they do not discriminate between the good and the well-born, the keen-faceted and the learned, the broadly educated and the young, the venerable and the poor, or the lowly. The six sense-object enemies are likewise: when they intend to rob virtuous qualities, they do not discriminate between anyone from the good and noble down to the poor and lowly. Even if kings were to cut off the limbs of the six great enemies, they could not thereby pacify those enemies' minds. The six hostile sense-object enemies are likewise: even if stream-enterers, once-returners, and non-returners were to sever their own limbs, they could not thereby rob virtuous qualities. Heroic persons can tame and bring down the six great enemies. Buddhas and bodhisattvas are likewise: they can tame and bring down the six great sense-object enemies. Just as nothing can be stolen from one who carries a large and heavy load, sentient beings are likewise: if they have a spiritual friend, the six hostile sense-object enemies cannot rob them. If the six great enemies happen to see a person's wealth, then and only then can they steal or plunder it. The six sense objects are not like that: by merely seeing, knowing, hearing, smelling, touching, or sensing, they can plunder. The six great enemies can only plunder the material wealth of human beings in the desire realm; they cannot plunder what belongs to the form realm and formless realm. The six hostile sense-object enemies are not like that: they can plunder

all the precious virtuous wealth of beings in all three realms. Therefore, the bodhisattva understands the six sense objects as being even more to be scrutinized than the six enemies. Having understood this, one who applies oneself to the noble eightfold path without turning back in confusion is like one who, fearing four venomous serpents, five wicked men, one who feigns friendship while being treacherous, six great enemies, and an empty city, goes forth in fear and sets out on the road. What is called "encountering a great river along the way" is the afflictions. How does the bodhisattva understand the afflictions as being like a great river? Just as a powerful current can carry away and sweep aside even a powerful musk ox, the six currents of the afflictions are likewise: they can sweep away even a pratyekabuddha. Therefore, the bodhisattva understands the afflictions as being like a powerful current. It is called "a river" because it is profound and difficult to fathom its depths. It is called "great" because it has no end. Within it there are many varieties of harmful tangible objects and the like. The great river of the afflictions is likewise: it is called "exceedingly profound" because only buddhas and bodhisattvas can reach its depths. It is called "vast and great" because only buddhas and bodhisattvas can reach its far end. It is called "harmful tangible objects" because it always harms all sentient beings.

Therefore the bodhisattva understands the afflictions as being like a great body of water. The water of a great river can give rise to all grasses, trees, and forests. The water of the great river of the afflictions is likewise: it can give rise to the twenty-five states of existence of sentient beings. Therefore the bodhisattva understands the afflictions as being like a great river.

Consider the analogy: when a person falls into a great river, there is no shame or restraint. Sentient beings are likewise: when they fall into the waters of the afflictions, there is no shame or restraint. When one falls into a great body of water, one loses one's life before ever reaching the bottom. When one falls into the waters of the afflictions, it is the same: without ever touching the bottom, one revolves and revolves through the twenty-five states of existence. What is called "the bottom" here refers to the defining characteristic of emptiness. One should understand that whoever has not applied diligent effort to the defining characteristic of emptiness will never grow distant from the twenty-five states of existence. Because all sentient beings have not applied diligent effort to emptiness and signlessness, they are perpetually swept along by the fierce current of the afflictions.

A great body of water can scatter and destroy the body alone, yet it cannot scatter all virtuous qualities. The great water of the afflictions is not like that: it can destroy all virtuous qualities of both body and mind. A great fierce current can scatter and carry away only the humans of the desire realm, but the great water of the afflictions can scatter and carry away all gods and humans of the three realms. When a person strokes with the hands and kicks with the feet in a great worldly body of water, they can reach the far bank. In the great water of the afflictions, only a bodhisattva, through the boat of the six perfections, can reach the far shore. Just as a great body of water is extremely difficult to cross, the great water of the afflictions is likewise extremely difficult to cross. How is it said to be extremely difficult to cross? It is thus: even up to the bodhisattvas of the tenth ground have not yet crossed to its end — only buddhas have fully crossed to its end. Therefore it is called extremely difficult to cross.

Consider the analogy: when a person is swept away by a great body of water, they are unable to practise even a hair-tip's worth of virtuous qualities. Sentient beings are likewise: when swept away by the waters of the afflictions, they are unable to practise virtuous qualities. Just as people who have fallen into the water and are being carried away can be rescued by those who are powerful, those fallen into the waters of the afflictions who are possessed of wrong craving cannot be rescued even by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, nor even by the Tathāgatas. In the world, a great body of water, when the time of the aeon's end comes and the seven suns blaze, can be dried up. But the great river of the afflictions is not like that: even if śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cultivate the seven branches of awakening, they cannot dry it up.

Therefore the bodhisattva understands the afflictions as being like a fierce torrent. It is as when a certain person, fearing four venomous serpents, five enemies of evil kind, one who feigns closeness while deceiving, and six great foes, abandons an empty city and sets off on the road, only to encounter a great body of water and gather grass to make a raft. The bodhisattva is likewise: fearing the venomous serpents of the four great elements, the evil kind of the five aggregates, the one who feigns closeness that is attachment (rāga), the empty city of the six sense bases, and the hostile enemies of the six objects — arriving at the bank of the waters of the afflictions — and with moral discipline, meditative absorption (samādhi), liberation, the knowledge and vision of liberation, the six perfections,

and by cultivating the thirty-seven factors of awakening (bodhipakṣadharmā), making of them a boat and a raft — relying on that raft to cross the waters of the afflictions — one reaches the far shore, the ultimate destination of nirvāṇa, which is permanent and blissful.

A bodhisattva who cultivates great nirvāṇa reflects in this way: "If I cannot endure such sufferings of body and of mind, I will be unable to liberate all sentient beings from the waters of the afflictions." Thinking thus, even while tormented by such sufferings of body and mind, the bodhisattva practices patience with full composure and acceptance. By taking up the practice of patience, no defilements (āsrava) will arise. If such a bodhisattva is already free of defilements, how much more need it be said that the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are entirely without defilement. Therefore, the Tathāgata must not be said to have defilements.

Then how is it that the Tathāgata is also said to be not entirely without defilements? The Tathāgata always enters into the company of those with defilements — for defilements are the twenty-five modes of existence — and therefore śrāvakas, childish common people, and those of lowly birth say that the Blessed One has defilements. In truth, the buddha Blessed Ones are entirely without defilement.

Good son, by that cause and that condition, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have no fixed defining characteristic. Good son, therefore, even one who breaks the four roots of moral discipline, who maligns the extensive sūtras, or who holds wrong views is not definitively condemned.

Then the great bodhisattva, the great being, the king of radiant and lofty glory, Universally Illuminating Splendid Royal Glory, addressed the Blessed One: "So it is, so it is, just as the Blessed One has declared — all phenomena likewise are without fixed determination. Because they are thus unfixed, one should understand that the Tathāgata has not finally passed into complete nirvāṇa."

"As the Blessed One previously declared, through cultivating great nirvāṇa, a bodhisattva, a great being, comes to understand — among things previously unheard — that there is nirvāṇa and great nirvāṇa. But what, may I ask, is nirvāṇa? And what is that called great nirvāṇa?"

Then the Blessed One said to the great bodhisattva, the great being, the king of radiant and lofty glory, Universally Illuminating Splendid Royal Glory: "Excellent! Excellent! Good son, only a bodhisattva who has attained the dhāraṇī of mindful retention would be able to ask as you have asked.

Good son, in the world, people speak of a lake and a great lake, a river and a great river, a mountain and a great mountain, a land and a great land, a city and a great city, a sentient being and a great sentient being, a king and a great king, a person and a great person, a god and a god among gods, a road and a great road. Nirvāṇa is similar to this: there is nirvāṇa and there is great nirvāṇa.

And what is nirvāṇa? Good son, just as one who is hungry and finds even a little food is said to be at ease — that ease is also called nirvāṇa. Just as a sick person who recovers from illness is said to be at ease — that ease too is called nirvāṇa. Just as one who is frightened and finds refuge and support is said to have attained ease — that ease too is called nirvāṇa. Just as a poor person who finds the seven precious substances is said to have attained ease — that ease too is called nirvāṇa."

Just as one who contemplates a skeleton and thereby finds that desire does not arise is said to have attained ease — that ease too is called nirvāṇa. Yet these nirvāṇas are not to be called great nirvāṇa. Why is that? Because they arise on account of hunger and thirst, illness, fear, and attachment — they are called nirvāṇa, but they are not great nirvāṇa.

Good son, if persons of inferior birth, śrāvakas, and so forth — whether on the level of conventional reality or through the condition of the noble path — sever the afflictions of the desire realm, they are said to have attained ease. That ease too is called nirvāṇa, yet it is not to be called great nirvāṇa. And the severance of afflictions beginning with the first meditative concentration, up through and including the severance of afflictions in the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception — that too constitutes the attainment of ease, and that ease too is called nirvāṇa, yet it is not to be called great nirvāṇa. Why? Because afflictions still arise, and because of the habitual tendencies of existence one is born again.

What then are the habitual tendencies of affliction? Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas possess habitual tendencies of affliction. This is what is meant: they say, "My body, my robes; I go, I come; I speak, I listen" — and further, they say: "The blessed buddhas are completely passed into nirvāṇa, and the nature of nirvāṇa is without self, without bliss, possessing only permanence and perfect purity." That is what is called the habitual tendency of affliction.

There is a difference in defining characteristics among the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Yet some say that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa forever, and that the nirvāṇa attained by śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and the blessed buddhas is equal — there is no difference. For that reason, what is attained by those of the two vehicles is not great nirvāṇa. Why? Because permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity are absent in it. It is great nirvāṇa that possesses permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity.

Good son, consider this example: a place that holds a vast quantity of water is called the ocean. In the same way, great nirvāṇa is called great nirvāṇa because it is the place entered by śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and the blessed buddhas. It gathers together immeasurable virtuous phenomena: the four meditative concentrations, the three meditative absorptions, the eight types of noble individuals, the eight sacred abodes, and the ten universal bases.

Good son, consider another example: a river that even the finest bull-elephant cannot ford is called a great river. Likewise, from śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas up to bodhisattvas of the tenth ground — those who do not see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood — that is called nirvāṇa, not great nirvāṇa. Whoever clearly sees the intrinsic nature of buddhahood — that is called great nirvāṇa. And this great nirvāṇa is fathomable only by the lord of the herd. The lord of the herd is none other than the Blessed One himself.

Good son, a great mountain is one that wrestlers such as the Mahānaga and the elder Dāla and others have long tried to scale and yet cannot ascend. Likewise, that which is not seen by śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and wrestlers such as the Mahānaga — that is called great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, good son, a place where a minor king resides is called a minor city.

A place where a wheel-turning king resides is called a great city. A place where eighty thousand, sixty thousand, forty thousand, twenty thousand, or ten thousand śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas reside is called nirvāṇa. A place where the wheel-turning king who is the sovereign lord of the unsurpassable Dharma resides is called great and complete nirvāṇa. Therefore it is called great nirvāṇa.

Good son, consider this: a person who, upon seeing an army with its four divisions, feels no fear is called a great being. Likewise, if there is a sentient being who feels no fear at the afflicted evil karma that leads along the path of

the three lower destinies, and who, in the midst of those destinies, liberates sentient beings in great numbers — know that such a one has attained great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, one who serves one's parents with reverence, shows respect to ascetics and brahmins, applies oneself diligently to virtuous qualities, speaks only truth, is free from falsehood and deceit, bears with wrongdoers patiently, and is able to give and be generous to the destitute — such a person is called a great being. A bodhisattva is likewise: cherishing all beings with loving-kindness and great compassion, becoming as a father and mother to sentient beings, liberating many beings from the river of cyclic existence, and showing all sentient beings the single path of truth — such a one is called great nirvāṇa.

Good son, what is called "great" is inconceivable. That which is inconceivable cannot be believed in by all sentient beings — therefore it is called great nirvāṇa. It is seen only by buddhas and bodhisattvas, and therefore it is called great nirvāṇa.

Now, why and for what cause and condition is it called "great"? Because its causes and conditions are immeasurable, it has from the very beginning been called great.

Good son, consider: in the world, something made by many causes and conditions is called great. Nirvāṇa is likewise — because it is attained through many causes and conditions, therefore it is called great.

Again, why is it called great? Because within nirvāṇa there exists a great self, it is called great nirvāṇa. In nirvāṇa, since it is without self yet has attained great sovereignty, it is called a great self. And how has it attained great sovereignty? It is the self that has attained the eight sovereignties.

What are the eight? The first is this: from one body manifesting many bodies, and filling with those bodies — as numerous as the finest atoms — the immeasurable world-systems of the ten directions. In reality the body of the Tathāgata is not composed of fine atoms, but by reason of sovereignty it displays bodies as numerous as the finest atoms. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

The second is this: filling the great trichiliocosm with a body no larger than the finest atom. In reality the body of the Tathāgata pervades the entire great trichiliocosm without limit, but by reason of this sovereignty it fills the great

trichiliocosm in this way. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

The third is this: with a body that fills the entire great trichiliocosm, soaring through empty space and travelling beyond buddha-fields as numerous as the grains of sand of twelve Ganges rivers without any obstruction. In reality the body of the Tathāgata has neither heaviness nor lightness, but by reason of sovereignty it acts as if heavy or light. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

By reason of sovereignty, mastery is attained. What, one might ask, is that sovereignty? The Tathāgata abides in perfect one-pointed stillness: without moving, he displays forms and physical characteristics of measureless variety and, each by each, his mind pervades each being ripe for taming. By performing on occasion a single act, the Tathāgata accomplishes the individual purposes of each and every sentient being. Though the body of the Tathāgata always abides in one buddha-field, he causes beings in all other buddha-fields to behold it. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

The fourth is mastery through the faculties. What is it to have mastery through the faculties? Through a single faculty the Tathāgata sees form, hears sound, smells scent, tastes flavor, feels what is tangible, and knows phenomena; yet through the six faculties of the Tathāgata he does not see form, does not hear sound, does not smell scent, does not taste flavor, does not feel what is tangible, and does not know phenomena. By reason of sovereignty, he exercises mastery through the faculties. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

Through sovereignty, all phenomena are attained. In the mind of the Tathāgata there is no perception of having attained anything. Why is that? Because there is nothing that is being acquired. If there were something that existed and one spoke of acquiring it, how could one speak of acquiring what in truth is utterly nonexistent? If the Tathāgata possessed a perception of having attained something, the Tathāgata would not have passed into nirvāṇa. Since there is nothing being acquired, he is said to have passed into nirvāṇa. Through sovereignty, all phenomena are attained; and because all phenomena are attained, this is called the great self.

Through mastery over exposition, the Tathāgata might expound the meaning of a single verse throughout measureless eons and the meaning would never be exhausted. Whether he is teaching moral discipline, meditative absorption, generosity, or wisdom, the Tathāgata at that moment does not think "I am

now expounding" or "the other beings are listening," and he does not even generate the perception of a single verse. In the world, what worldly people call a single verse consists of four lines, and so in conformity with convention he speaks of a single verse. In reality the essential nature of phenomena has never been expounded; yet through sovereignty the Tathāgata expounds it, and because he expounds it, this is called the great self.

The Tathāgata pervades all places, like empty space. The essential nature of space is that it is invisible. Similarly the Tathāgata, in ultimate reality, is equally invisible, yet through sovereignty he causes all to be seen. Such sovereignty is what is called the great self.

Such a great self is called the great nirvāṇa, and for that reason it is called the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, noble son, consider a great treasury of jewels: because it contains wealth in vast quantity and of every variety, it is called a great treasury. The supremely profound treasure of the Tathāgata is just like this: it possesses what is wondrous and marvelous, and since it admits of no diminishment, it is called the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, noble son, an inexhaustible store of riches is called a great treasury. Nirvāṇa likewise is called great because it is without limit.

Furthermore, noble son, because there is great bliss, it is called the great nirvāṇa — for nirvāṇa does not lack bliss. Because of four kinds of bliss, it is called the great nirvāṇa. What are the four? The first is because all sufferings have been cut. Whatever has not cut off suffering is called suffering; and that in which suffering exists cannot be called great bliss. Because suffering has been cut, there is no suffering.

The absence of both suffering and bliss is called great bliss. The intrinsic nature of nirvāṇa is free from both suffering and bliss; and therefore nirvāṇa is called great bliss. For this reason it is called the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, noble son, bliss is of two kinds: that of the foolish common being, and that of the buddhas. The bliss of the foolish common being is impermanent and subject to destruction, and so it is not true bliss. The permanence and bliss of the Tathāgata are free from change and transition; therefore it is called the great nirvāṇa.

Noble son, furthermore, feeling is of three kinds. What are the three? Feeling felt as pleasant, feeling felt as painful, and feeling felt as neither pleasant nor

painful. Even that feeling of neither pleasure nor pain is itself suffering. Nirvāṇa likewise resembles the feeling of neither pleasure nor pain, yet it is called great bliss. Because it is great bliss, it is called the great nirvāṇa.

It is called the great nirvāṇa because it is utterly tranquil. The intrinsic nature of nirvāṇa is utter tranquility. Why? Because it is utterly tranquil through being free from all conditioned phenomena, it is called the great nirvāṇa.

It is called great bliss because of knowing all things. What does not know all things cannot be called bliss. The Blessed One, the buddha, is omniscient, and therefore it is called great bliss. Because it is great bliss, it is called the great nirvāṇa.

It is called great bliss because the body is indestructible. What has a destructible body cannot be called bliss. The body of the Tathāgata is indestructible as a vajra; it is not a body born of affliction, it is not an impermanent body — and therefore it is called great bliss. Because it is great bliss, it is called the great nirvāṇa.

Noble son, among the names given in the world, some have causes and conditions, and some have no causes and conditions.

Those that have causes and conditions are, for example: the monk Śāriputra — because his mother bore the name Śārī, he was named Śāriputra on account of that condition. The nun named Tūlā was born in the region of Tūlā, and so she was named Tūlā after the name of that region. Maudgalyāna is a clan name, and because he was named after his clan, he is called Maudgalya. As for myself, I was born into the lineage of the Gautamas, and therefore I was given the name Gautama. The monk Biṣaka — Biṣaka is the name of a star, and having received his name from that star's name, he is called Biṣaka. Just as one who has six fingers is named Six-Fingers on account of having six fingers. Buddhādatta and Devadatta are named Buddhādatta and Devadatta by reason of the Buddha and of the gods respectively. One born from warmth and moisture is named Born-from-Warmth-and-Moisture by reason of that condition. Birds, for example, are named Kāka, Kukula, and Tsutsula after the sounds they make. Names such as these are names given on account of causes and conditions.

Names with no causes and conditions are like the following: lotus, earth, water, fire, wind, and space. Mandapa is called "a drinking hall" — yet even one who does not drink in a hall is called by this name. Sarvacchādana is called "a snake's hood" — yet in truth it is not a snake's hood, and so this is a

name forcibly imposed without basis in fact. Just as the word Jilabāyi is said to mean "one who drinks butter" — yet in truth this person does not drink butter, and is still called "one who drinks butter"; this too is a name forcibly imposed without any real cause.

O son of noble family, this great nirvāṇa is likewise a name forcibly imposed without causes and conditions.

O son of noble family, consider this: space is not called "great" by virtue of some small measure of space. Nirvāṇa is the same: it is not called "great nirvāṇa" by virtue of some small measure of characteristic. O son of noble family, consider this: that which is immeasurable in Dharma and inconceivable is called "great." Nirvāṇa is likewise: because it is immeasurable and inconceivable in its complete transcendence, it is called "great nirvāṇa." Because it is solely and utterly pure, it is called "great nirvāṇa."

Now, why is it called solely and utterly pure? Utter purity has four aspects. In this regard, the twenty-five modes of existence are called "impure." By their complete severance, one speaks of "utter purity." This very purity is called nirvāṇa. Yet in relation to that nirvāṇa, what is called "existence" — nirvāṇa in truth is not existence at all. The Blessed One, the Buddha, spoke of nirvāṇa as though it were existence, following the ways of the world. Just as worldly people say "father" and "mother" of those who are not in truth father and mother, calling them father and mother even though in truth they are not — nirvāṇa is likewise: following the ways of the world, it was said that the Tathāgata possesses great nirvāṇa.

Purity of action: all those of base family are without nirvāṇa because their actions are impure. The Blessed One, the Buddha, because his activity is utterly pure, is called the utterly and greatly pure one. Because he is greatly and utterly pure, he is called one who has attained great nirvāṇa.

Purity of body: if a body is impermanent, it is impure. The body of the Tathāgata is permanent, and therefore it is called greatly and utterly pure. Because it is greatly and utterly pure, it is called great nirvāṇa.

Purity of mind: if the mind is accompanied by defilements, it is called impure. The Tathāgata is without defilements, and therefore is called greatly and utterly pure. Because he is greatly and utterly pure, he is called great nirvāṇa. These are the four.

O son of noble family, a son or daughter of noble family who has meditated upon this sūtra of great nirvāṇa is said to possess the first of its qualities.

Furthermore, O son of noble family, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, come to possess the second merit from diligently applying themselves to this sūtra of great nirvāṇa? O son of noble family, when a bodhisattva, a great being, diligently applies themselves to this sūtra of great nirvāṇa, they will attain what they had not previously attained, they will see what they had not previously seen, they will hear what they had not previously heard, they will reach what they had not previously reached, and they will know what they had not previously known.

Now, how will they attain what they had not previously attained? It is as follows: they will attain miraculous powers not previously attained. Miraculous powers are of two kinds: outer and inner. The outer kind is shared in common with tīrthikas, non-Buddhist adherents. The inner kind again has two aspects: that common to the two vehicles, and that of the bodhisattva. The miraculous powers attained by a bodhisattva diligently applying themselves to this sūtra of great nirvāṇa are not shared in common with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Why are they not shared in common with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas? It is as follows: the miraculous powers and displays of transformation produced by the two vehicles involve but a single intention and a single act — they do not multiply into many.

A bodhisattva is not like that. With a single intention, the bodhisattva can display a body that is fully perfected across the five pathways of travel. Why is this? Because through the blessing of this sūtra of great nirvāṇa, the bodhisattva has gained power — this is called "attaining what was not previously attained."

And what does it mean to attain now what was not previously attained? It means attaining mastery over the body and mastery over the mind. What exactly does this entail? All ordinary, undisciplined beings lack mastery over body and mind: in some cases, the mind follows after the body, and in other cases, the body follows after the mind.

How is it that the mind follows after the body? Consider those who are drunk from alcohol — since the alcohol is within the body, when the body sways, the mind sways along with it. Likewise, when the body is fatigued, the mind too becomes fatigued. This is what is called the mind following after the body. Moreover, a person whose body is small has a small mind as well, and a great

person whose body is large has a correspondingly large mind. Furthermore, there are those whose body is coarse, and on that account the mind constantly craves smoothness, softness, and pliability. This too is called the mind following after the body.

And how is it that the body follows after the mind? In this way: in going, in coming, in sitting, in lying down, in practicing generosity, in maintaining moral discipline, in cultivating patience, in applying diligence — whoever is overcome by grief has a face that is drawn and wan. Whoever is joyful has a body that is nourished and a complexion that is bright. Whoever is frightened has a body that trembles. Whoever listens to the Dharma with one-pointed attention has a body that is greatly at ease. Whoever beats their breast and weeps has tears and mucus flowing forth. This is what is called the body following after the mind.

A bodhisattva is not like that. Having attained mastery over both body and mind together, this is called "attaining now what was not previously attained."

Furthermore, noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, can display the faculty of the body as though it were a dust mote. With that body, no larger than a mote, the bodhisattva travels unobstructed through buddha-fields as numerous as the measureless and boundless grains of sand of the Gaṅgā river — and yet the mind remains ever still, unmoved from its former abode. This is called the mind not following after the body, and it may also be called "going where one has not gone before."

And what does it mean to go where one has not gone before? All śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are unable to go there. Because the bodhisattva goes there, it is called "going now where none has gone before." All śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do indeed possess miraculous powers, but they are unable to emanate their bodies as though a dust mote and travel through buddha-fields as numerous as the measureless sands of the Gaṅgā. For śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, when the body moves, the mind moves along with it.

A bodhisattva is not like that. Though the mind does not stir, there is nowhere that the body has not reached. This is called a bodhisattva's mind not following after the body.

Furthermore, noble son, a bodhisattva can emanate this body so that it equals the world-system of a great trichiliocosm, and that vast body can enter into a single dust mote — yet the mind at that time does not become

correspondingly small. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can indeed emanate their bodies to the size of a great trichiliocosm, but they cannot cause that enormous body to enter into a dust mote. If they cannot accomplish even such feats as these, how much less can they keep the mind unmoved! This is called a bodhisattva's mind not following after the body.

Furthermore, noble son, a great bodhisattva can, with a single sound, cause all sentient beings throughout the world-system of a great trichiliocosm to hear it in their ears — yet he does not think, "By this sound of mine, let beings throughout all world-systems hear what they had not heard before." Nor did the bodhisattva, from the very beginning, ever say, "By my own effort I will cause beings to hear what they have not heard." If a bodhisattva were to say, "Through my teaching of the Dharma, I will cause beings to hear what they have not heard," one should know that such a person will never attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? The thought "I have taught this so that beings who had not heard it may hear" is a thought rooted in saṃsāra, and all bodhisattvas have utterly exhausted that thought. For this reason, body and mind do not companion one another in the great bodhisattva. Noble son, all immature childish beings have body and mind companioning one another. The bodhisattva is not like that: though he may display a small body for the benefit of sentient beings, his mind does not become small. Why? Because the intrinsic nature of a bodhisattva's mind is always vast, so that even when a great body is displayed, the mind does not become great. How great is the great body? It is like the world-system of a great trichiliocosm. How small is the mind? It engages in the conduct of a small child. This is why the mind does not follow after the body.

Although a great bodhisattva may go without drinking alcohol for measureless hundreds of thousands of aeons, the mind may still be stirred. Though the mind knows no suffering or despair, tears may fall from the eyes. Though there is no genuine fear, the body may tremble violently. Therefore, it should be understood that the bodhisattva, having gained mastery over body and mind, is one in whom body and mind do not companion one another. When a great bodhisattva displays a single body, sentient beings each see it differently from their own vantage point.

Furthermore, noble son, what is it that the great bodhisattva hears — what had not been heard before — through diligent study of the sūtras of the great Mahāparinirvāṇa? The great bodhisattva's prior engagement with the characteristics of sound is as follows: the sounds of camels and oxen, the

sounds of horses, the sounds of chariots, the sounds of human voices, the sounds of conch shells, the sounds of drums, the sounds of flies and insects, the sounds of flutes and other instruments, the sounds of song, and the sounds of weeping — all of these he meditates upon thoroughly. Through sustained and repeated meditation, he comes to hear all the sounds of the hell-beings throughout as many world-systems of a great trichiliocosm as are immeasurable and boundless. Through yet further repeated meditation, he attains a faculty of hearing that is distinct, a faculty of divine hearing that is different from the miraculous ear faculties of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Why? Because attaining the superknowledge of the ear, purified by the second vehicle, depends upon the four great dhyānas of the first dhyāna: relying upon only the first dhyāna one hears only its range, and so it is from the second dhyāna through to the fourth dhyāna. Even hearing simultaneously all sounds that exist in the world-system of a great trichiliocosm, one is still unable to hear the sounds of as many world-systems as there are grains of sand in the Ganges, immeasurable and boundless. Therefore, the bodhisattva's hearing is distinct from the faculty of the ear of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

Through this distinction, what was previously unheard now comes to be heard. Yet even as a sound is heard, the mind has from the very beginning no characteristic of hearing a sound — no characteristic of existence, no characteristic of permanence, no characteristic of bliss, no characteristic of self, no characteristic of purity, no characteristic of ownership, no characteristic of support, no characteristic of agency, no characteristic of being a cause, no characteristic of certainty, and no characteristic of being a result. It is for this reason that bodhisattvas have now heard what was previously unheard.

Then the great bodhisattva (bodhisattva mahāsattva) Universally Illuminating, Sublime King of Glory, spoke in petition: "What the Blessed One has declared — that sounds possess neither the characteristic of certainty nor the characteristic of result — does not appear to me to be so. Why? Because the Blessed One previously declared that if someone hears even a single verse or even a single syllable of this great sūtra of great nirvāṇa, they will without question attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Now, is the attainment of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening not itself the characteristic of certainty and the characteristic of result? Then why has the Blessed One declared that there is no certainty and no result? Again, when one hears an unpleasant sound, malice arises in the mind, and through that malice

one falls into one of the three lower destinies. Is not that very falling into the three lower destinies itself the certain result? Then why has the Blessed One declared that there is no certainty and no result?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, it is good that you have had the boldness to ask in this way. If the Blessed One were to declare that sounds possess the characteristic of certainty and the characteristic of result, that would not be the characteristic of a buddha, a Blessed One — it would be the characteristic of the king of māras, the characteristic of saṃsāra, the characteristic of being far from nirvāṇa. Why? Because everything declared by the Blessed One, the buddha, is without the characteristic of certainty and without the characteristic of result. Noble son, take this example: when one looks at a human face reflected inside a sword blade, looking along the length of it the face appears long, and looking across it the face appears wide. Now if that appearance had the characteristic of certainty, why would the face appear long when looked at lengthwise and wide when looked at crosswise? For this reason, everything declared by the Blessed One, the buddha, is without the characteristic of certainty and without the characteristic of result. Noble son, nirvāṇa is not the result of a sound. If nirvāṇa were the result of a sound, you should understand that nirvāṇa would not be a permanent phenomenon. Noble son, take this example: in the world, phenomena that arise through dependent origination have a cause and therefore also have a result. Where there is no cause, there is likewise no result; and where the cause is impermanent, the result too is impermanent. Why? Because from the cause comes the result, and from the result comes the cause in turn. For this reason, all phenomena are without the characteristic of certainty. If the passing beyond sorrow were born from a cause, then since the cause itself is impermanent the result too would be impermanent. Therefore, the passing beyond sorrow is not born from a cause, and its essential nature is not a result — and for this reason it is permanent. Noble son, for this reason, the essential nature of the passing beyond sorrow has no certainty and no result. Noble son, the passing beyond sorrow may be spoken of as certainty, and it may also be spoken of as result. In what sense is it certainty? Because the nirvāṇa of all buddhas is permanent, blissful, self, and

because it is utterly pure — that is certainty. Because it has no birth, no aging, and no dissolution — that is certainty. Because those who have abandoned wrong craving, those who have broken the four root defeats, those who have slandered the vast sūtras, and those who have committed the five acts of

immediate consequence will, when they relinquish their former mind, without question attain it — and for that reason it is certainty.

Noble son, as for what you said — that if someone hears even a single verse or a single syllable of this sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow they will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — since you have not yet clearly understood the meaning of that statement, listen closely and reflect carefully, for I shall open it up and explain it.

Noble son, if a son or daughter of good family hears even a single syllable or a single verse from the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow, and upon hearing it does not grasp at the characteristic of a syllable, does not grasp at the characteristic of a verse, does not grasp at the characteristic of what has been heard, does not grasp at the characteristic of a buddha, and does not grasp at the characteristic of what has been taught — that is called the characteristic of non-characteristic. And through that characteristic of non-characteristic, one attains unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Noble son, as for what you said — that hearing a harsh sound causes one to go to one of the three lower destinies — that too is not the case. Why? Because it is not the harsh sound itself that causes one to go to the three lower destinies; rather, what causes that is a malicious mind. Why? Because if a son or daughter of good family hears a harsh sound yet does not give rise to a malicious mind, then the condition of the harsh sound does not cause that being to go to the three lower destinies. It is because sentient beings let malicious minds born of affliction spread and multiply that they are born in the three lower destinies — not because of a harsh sound as their condition. If sound possessed the defining characteristic of certainty, then everyone who heard it would be of the type to generate a malicious mind. But in some it arises and in others it does not; therefore you should understand that sound has no defining characteristic of certainty. And because it has no defining characteristic of certainty, even when sound serves as a condition, a malicious mind does not necessarily arise.

A question was put: Blessed One, if sound is not determinate, why would bodhisattvas come to hear what they had not heard before?

Noble son, it is precisely because sound has no defining characteristic of certainty that bodhisattvas who had not previously heard come to hear it now. That is why I said, "what was not previously heard is now heard."

Noble son, in what sense is "what was not previously seen now seen"? Noble son, for a great bodhisattva who applies himself diligently to this sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow, engagement with the characteristics of what formerly appeared is as follows. Through long habituation to the light of the sun, the moon, stars, masses of fire, lamps, jewels, firelight, medicines, and the like, he attains a distinct faculty of the eye — distinct from that of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

In what way distinct? One who has attained the pure celestial eye by means of the two vehicles, if they rely on the eye faculty of the four great kings of the desire realm, cannot see the first dhyāna. If they rely on the first dhyāna, they cannot see anything above it, and downward too they are unable to see as far as their own eye. Even if they see a great deal, they cannot see beyond the world-system of the great trichiliocosm.

But the great bodhisattva, even without having cultivated the celestial eye, sees all bodies possessed of fine form as having the characteristic of a skeleton. He sees as many world-systems as there are grains of sand along the Ganges River, perceiving the characteristics of form in all of them — yet he does not grasp at those appearances as a defining characteristic of form.

He does not grasp at it as the characteristic of permanence, as the characteristic of existence, as the characteristic of substantial reality, as the characteristic of name and letter, of cause and condition, or of seeing. Nor does he say, "This is the characteristic of the eye as something supreme and perfectly pure." Rather, he sees form with the characteristic of dependent origination, and sees it also with the characteristic of what is not dependently originated.

How is it dependently originated? Form is the condition for the eye. Were form not dependently arisen, it would follow that even the most foolish and base among men would not give rise to the perception of seeing form. Therefore form is said to be dependently originated. As for what is meant by "not dependently originated": even though the great bodhisattva perceives form, he does not generate the characteristic of form. Therefore it is said to be not dependently originated.

For this reason, the pure miraculous eye that a bodhisattva obtains differs from what is obtained by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Because it differs in this way, he simultaneously sees all the buddhas presently dwelling in the world-systems of the ten directions — and this is called the bodhisattva's

seeing what was not seen before. Because it differs in this way, he sees things as fine as the subtlest particles, which śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot see. Because it differs in this way, although his own eye sees, it has no characteristic of seeing from the very beginning. He sees with the characteristic of impermanence, and he sees the body of any person as completely filled with the thirty-six impure substances, like a myrobalan fruit placed in the palm of the hand. For this reason it is said that what was not seen before is now seen.

If, the very moment he sees the form and appearance of any sentient being, he recognizes whether that being belongs to the Great Vehicle or to the lesser vehicle — and even from a single touch of clothing he knows the distinguishing characteristic of that person's faculties of virtue and non-virtue — then for this reason what was not known before becomes known now. From a single glance alone, what was previously unknown becomes known. Because he knows in this way, what was not seen before is now seen.

The Thirty-Second Fascicle.

Furthermore, son of good family, how does a bodhisattva know what was previously unknown? The great bodhisattva, even while knowing the minds of attachment, aversion, and delusion in the most foolish and base of people, does not grasp at those minds from the very beginning as having the characteristic of mind or of what arises from mind. He does not grasp at them as having the characteristic of sentient being or of substantial reality, but applies himself diligently to the characteristic of the ultimate, which is empty to its very end. Why is this? Because all bodhisattvas are ever engaged in diligent application to the characteristic of emptiness. By this diligent application to emptiness, what was previously unknown becomes known.

How is it known? He knows the absence of self and the absence of what belongs to a self, and he knows that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature (Skt. *tathāgatagarbha*). Because they possess the buddha-nature, those who harbour wrong craving, if they abandon their former minds, will all come to fully manifest unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. These things śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are unable to know, but a bodhisattva is able to know them — and for that reason it is said that what was previously unknown is now known.

Furthermore, son of good family, how does one come to know what was previously unknown? When the great bodhisattva applies himself diligently to

the noble sūtra-text of the Great Nirvāṇa, he comes to know the birthplaces, family lines, fathers and mothers, brothers and sisters, wives, children, friends, and companions of all sentient beings in the time of the past —

by recalling enemies, one attains in a single instant a distinctive gnosis — a gnosis that surpasses the gnosis of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. How is it surpassing? The wisdom of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas recalls, regarding sentient beings of the past, their family lines, fathers and mothers, relatives, and enemies, and thereby produces the defining characteristics of family, kin, and enemy. A bodhisattva is not like this: although he too recalls past family lines, fathers and mothers, relatives, and enemies, he does not produce the defining characteristics of family, fathers and mothers, kin, enemies, and so forth. Instead, he constantly enters into the defining characteristic of Dharma and the defining characteristic of emptiness and peace. That is what is called the bodhisattva's knowing what was previously unknown.

Furthermore, son of good family, how else does one come to know what was previously unknown? The gnosis of knowing others' minds that the great bodhisattva obtains through applying himself diligently to the noble sūtra-text of the Great Nirvāṇa differs from that obtained by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. How does it differ? When śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas know the minds of humans in a single instant, they do not at that same moment know the minds of hell-beings, animals, hungry ghosts, or gods. A bodhisattva is not like this: in a single instant he knows the minds of all sentient beings throughout the six classes of beings. That is called the bodhisattva's knowing what was previously unknown.

Son of good family, there is yet another distinction in knowing. The great bodhisattva, in a single moment of intention, knows from the very first mind of one who has entered the stream, and knows in succession up to the sixteenth mind. For that reason it is called knowing what was previously unknown. These, then, are what is meant by the great bodhisattva's being endowed with the second quality through applying himself diligently to the Great Nirvāṇa.

Moreover, son of good family, how is it that the great bodhisattva is endowed with the third quality through applying himself diligently to the Great Nirvāṇa? Son of good family, the great bodhisattva who applies himself diligently to the Great Nirvāṇa: even if he relinquishes loving-kindness, he will attain loving-kindness. And the loving-kindness he attains is not conditioned by dependent origination. How is it that one attains loving-kindness even after

relinquishing it? Son of good family, what is called loving-kindness is a conventional truth. The great bodhisattva relinquishes conventional loving-kindness and thereby attains ultimate loving-kindness. Ultimate loving-kindness is not attained through conditions.

Furthermore, how is it that one attains loving-kindness even after relinquishing it? If a loving-kindness is of the kind that can be relinquished, it is called the inferior loving-kindness of common folk. That loving-kindness which is of the kind that can be attained is called the bodhisattva's objectless loving-kindness.

If one relinquishes the loving-kindness of those given to wrong craving, the loving-kindness of those who have broken the four root vows, the loving-kindness of those who slander the extensively proclaimed teaching, and the loving-kindness of those who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, one attains affectionate loving-kindness, the Tathāgata's loving-kindness, the Blessed One's loving-kindness, and loving-kindness free from cause and condition.

Furthermore, how is it that one attains loving-kindness even after relinquishing it? When one relinquishes the loving-kindness shown toward the sexually diminished, the sexually indeterminate, the genderless, the two-gendered, and women; toward those of low birth, butchers, hunters, and those who rear birds and pigs and so forth; and when one relinquishes the loving-kindness of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — one attains the objectless loving-kindness of bodhisattvas, loving-kindness that does not regard anything as a self, loving-kindness that does not regard anything as other, loving-kindness that does not regard anyone as virtuous in ethical conduct, loving-kindness that does not regard anyone as poor in ethical conduct,

one attains compassion that, though perceived as dwelling within oneself, does not regard its object as a sentient being, and that, though there is feeling perceived as suffering, does not regard that suffering as something experienced. Why is this? Because one cultivates the ultimate meaning precisely as it is. This is called possessing the third quality of a bodhisattva, a great being, who is devoted to the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, son of good family, how does a bodhisattva, a great being, who is devoted to the great nirvāṇa come to possess the fourth quality? Son of good family, when a bodhisattva, a great being, is devoted to the great nirvāṇa and possesses the fourth quality, there are ten aspects to that. What

are the ten? They are as follows: being firmly rooted, grounded in a way that is hard to dislodge; generating the perception of being utterly certain of oneself; not discriminating between merit and non-merit; purifying buddha fields; removing what is residual; cutting off the cause of karma; cultivating a purified body; fully recognizing conditions; abandoning enemies; and cutting through the two extremes.

Now, how is one firmly rooted, grounded in a way that is hard to dislodge? In this context, the root is called heedfulness. What is the root of heedfulness? It is the root of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Son of good family, the roots of virtue of all buddhas are heedfulness. Because of heedfulness, other roots of virtue likewise grow and arise in ever-increasing measure. As roots of virtue grow and multiply, they become supreme and distinguished among all virtues.

Son of good family, just as among footprints, the footprint of the great ox is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme and supremely distinguished among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among lights, the light of the sun is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme and supremely distinguished among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among kings, the wheel-turning king is supreme and foremost, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme and foremost. Son of good family, just as among flowing waters, the four great rivers are supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among mountains, Mount Meru, the king of mountains, is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among water-born lotuses, the blue lotus is most excellent, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among flowers born on dry land, the campaka flower is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among beasts of prey, the lion is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it becomes supreme and foremost among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among birds, the king of garuḍas is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it is supreme and most excellent among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among great bodies, the asura king called Rāhu is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it is supreme and most

excellent among all virtuous qualities.

Son of good family, just as among beings — whether two-footed, four-footed, many-footed, or

footless — among all of them the Tathāgata is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it is supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among the many assemblies the Saṅgha of the buddhas is supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it is supreme among all virtuous qualities. Son of good family, just as among all the qualities of the buddhas the quality of great nirvāṇa is the most excellent and supreme, so too the quality of heedfulness is like that: it is the most excellent and supreme among all virtuous qualities.

Son of good family, therefore the root of heedfulness is deep and firm, and exceedingly difficult to uproot. Now, how is it that heedfulness grows and arises ever more and more? It is like this: through heedfulness, the root of faith, the root of moral discipline, the root of generosity, the root of wisdom, the root of patience, the root of learning, the root of diligence, the root of mindfulness, the root of meditative absorption, and the root of spiritual friendship — these and other such roots grow and arise ever more and more. Having thus grown and arisen, they become exceedingly deep and firm, and are most difficult to uproot. It is for this reason that it is said that, through a bodhisattva mahāsattva's earnest application to the great nirvāṇa, the root becomes deep and difficult to uproot.

Now, how does one enter into what is characterized as certainty with respect to the body? One generates a mind of certainty regarding one's own body, thinking thus: this very body of mine will, in the future, certainly and without doubt become a vessel for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening; and the mind too shall be correspondingly free from smallness and weakness, shall not shift and change, shall not be the mind of a śrāvaka or a pratyekabuddha, shall not be the mind of Māra, shall not be a mind seeking one's own happiness or inclined toward saṃsāra, but shall always seek a mind of loving-kindness and compassion for the sake of sentient beings. This is the thought the bodhisattva generates: through this very body of mine, I shall certainly and without doubt, in the future, become a vessel for unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. It is therefore said that the bodhisattva mahāsattva, through earnest application to the great nirvāṇa, generates the perception of certainty regarding his own body.

Now, how is it that the bodhisattva mahāsattva does not conceptually discriminate between a field of merit and what is not a field of merit? Here, what is called a field of merit extends from one who has entered into the austerities of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) all the way up to the buddhas — all of these are called fields of merit. If one thinks to oneself, "These are the true and genuine fields of merit," then one should understand that such a mind is weak and small. The bodhisattva mahāsattva does not regard even a single one among all immeasurable sentient beings as not being a field of merit. Why is that? Because one has thoroughly cultivated undivided mindfulness. One who possesses and has thoroughly cultivated undivided mindfulness sees all sentient beings without distinction as those who guard moral discipline or those who have broken moral discipline, and sees them all as obtaining the perfectly pure fruit of the four kinds of giving taught by the Blessed One, the buddhas. What are the four? They are these: the giver is pure but the recipient is impure; the giver is impure but the recipient is pure; both giver and recipient are pure; and both giver and recipient are impure. How is it that the giver is pure and the recipient is impure? It is like this:

The giver is endowed with moral discipline, extensive learning, and wisdom, and understands that giving exists and that the fruit of giving ripens. The recipient, however, has broken moral discipline, clings to wrong views, and regards giving as nonexistent and its fruit as nonexistent. This is called "the giver is pure and the recipient is impure."

How is it that the recipient is pure and the giver is impure? In that case, the giver has broken moral discipline, clings to wrong views, and regards giving and the ripening of the fruit of giving as nonexistent. The recipient, however, observes moral discipline, possesses extensive learning and wisdom, and understands that giving exists and that the fruit of giving ripens. This is called "the giver is impure and the recipient is pure."

How is it that both giver and recipient are pure? In that case, both giver and recipient observe moral discipline, possess extensive learning and wisdom, and understand that giving exists and that the fruit of giving ripens. This is called "both giver and recipient are pure."

How is it that both are impure? Both giver and recipient have broken moral discipline, hold wrong views, and regard giving and the ripening of the fruit of giving as nonexistent.

If that is so, why should such giving be called "obtaining a perfectly pure fruit"? In that case, since there is neither giving nor fruit, it is not to be called pure. Noble son, one who does not see giving or the fruit of giving is to be understood as not being someone who has broken moral discipline or clung to wrong views. If, like a śrāvaka, one does not see giving or the fruit of giving, that is called having broken moral discipline and clinging to wrong views. But one who does not see giving or the fruit of giving in the manner of a scripture of the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra is called guarding moral discipline and holding right view.

A great bodhisattva who possesses and has thoroughly cultivated undivided mindfulness does not see sentient beings as those who observe moral discipline or those who have broken it, does not see givers or recipients, and does not see the fruit of giving. Therefore it is designated "right view in keeping with moral discipline." For this reason, the great bodhisattva does not conceptually discriminate between a field of merit and what is not a field of merit.

As for how such a bodhisattva purifies a buddha-field: the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to this excellent sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, when liberating sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, utterly relinquishes any intention to take life. That root of virtue he then makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May all sentient beings obtain long life, strength, splendor, and great miraculous power." Through the force of that aspiration, when he attains buddhahood in a future time, all the sentient beings of that buddha-field, however many there may be, will all enjoy long life, be endowed with might and strength, and obtain great miraculous power.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes any intention to take what has not been given. That root of virtue he likewise makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May all the buddha-field grounds, however many there are, become nothing but the seven precious substances, and may sentient beings enjoy and make use of them for themselves and be wealthy and content."

By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, every buddha-field will be nothing but the seven precious substances,

and all sentient beings will enjoy and make use of them for themselves and be wealthy and content.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes any intention toward sexual misconduct. That root of virtue he likewise makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May all sentient beings, however many there are in the buddha-fields, be free from minds of attachment, aversion, and delusion, and may they be free from the suffering of being tormented by hunger and thirst."

By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, all the sentient beings of that field will be free from minds of attachment, aversion, and delusion, and will be entirely free from all suffering caused by being tormented by hunger and thirst.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes any intention to speak falsely. That root of virtue he likewise makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May there always be flowering trees, fruit-bearing trees, and fragrant trees in the buddha-fields, and may all the sentient beings there, however many they are, hear beautiful sounds and melodies."

By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, that field will have flowering trees, fruit-bearing trees, and fragrant trees, and all the sentient beings there will fully and clearly receive the unsurpassed sweet sounds of melody.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes divisive speech. That root of virtue he likewise makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May all the sentient beings, however many there are in the buddha-fields, be in harmony and may they teach one another the sacred Dharma."

Likewise, by the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening, all the sentient beings of that field, however many there are, will be in harmony and will speak words of Dharma.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes harsh speech. That root of virtue he likewise makes common to all sentient beings and makes this aspiration: "May the ground throughout the buddha-fields be as level as the palm of a hand, with no pebbles, no uneven terrain, no thorns of any kind, and may all sentient beings have an even and equanimous mind."

By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, the ground of that field will be level as the palm of a hand, with no pebbles, no uneven terrain, and no thorns, and all the sentient beings there, however many they are, will have an even and equanimous mind.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes idle chatter.

That root of virtue too is made common to all sentient beings, and the aspiration is made: "May every sentient being in the buddha-field, however many there are, be free from the suffering of afflictions." By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, every sentient being dwelling in that field will be free from the suffering of afflictions.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes the mind of jealousy born of desire. That root of virtue too is made common to all sentient beings, and the aspiration is made: "May all sentient beings in the buddha-field be free from the affliction of jealousy born of desire that brings harm, and free from wrong views." By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, all sentient beings in that field will be free from the harm of jealousy born of desire and free from wrong views.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes all harmfulness. That root of virtue too is made common to all sentient beings, and the aspiration is made: "May all sentient beings, however many there are in that buddha-field, cultivate loving-kindness and great compassion, and attain the ground of the only child." By the power of that aspiration, when he

attains complete awakening in the future, all sentient beings, however many there are in that field, will cultivate loving-kindness and great compassion, and will attain the ground of the only child.

Furthermore, noble son, when the great bodhisattva, by diligently applying himself to the Great Nirvāṇa, liberates sentient beings for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, he utterly relinquishes wrong views. That root of virtue too is made common to all sentient beings, and the aspiration is made: "May all sentient beings, however many there are in the buddha-field, attain the Perfection of Wisdom." By the power of that aspiration, when he attains complete awakening in the future, all sentient beings, however many there are in that world-realm, will come to uphold and retain the Perfection of Wisdom. This is called the bodhisattva's purification of the buddha-field.

Now, how does the great bodhisattva remove what remains? There are three kinds of remainders: the remainder that is the fruit of afflictions, the remainder of karma, and the remainder of continued existence.

Noble son, what then is the remainder that is the fruit of afflictions? A sentient being who, through habitual tendencies of attachment, is intimate with those tendencies and thereby ripens that fruit, falls into the hell realms. When they have been released from the hell realms perhaps a hundred times, they are reborn in the abodes of animals — born, for instance, as a pigeon, a sparrow, a crow, a myna bird, a crane, a śārikā bird, a sparrow, a fish, a frog, a monkey, or a deer. Even if they obtain a human body, they are reborn as a dwarf, a person of indeterminate sex, a woman, a hermaphrodite, a person without sex characteristics, or a snake-charmer. If they go forth into renunciation, they will break the first root of moral discipline. This is called the remainder that is the fruit.

Furthermore, noble son, if a sentient being clings with an attached mind to habitual tendencies of aversion —

When the karma of aversion ripens, sentient beings fall into the hells. And when one in a hundred is freed from the hells, they are reborn in bodies such as these: a snake with four kinds of venom — venom in its gaze, venom in its touch, venom in its bite, and venom in its breath — or a lion, a tiger, a wolf, a bear, a brown bear, a rat, a hawk, and the like. If they obtain a human body, they are endowed with twelve kinds of bad conduct. If they go forth into renunciation, their faculties are dull and sluggish, and they will break from the

first root of moral discipline up to as many as five of those roots. This is called the remainder that is the fruit.

Furthermore, noble son, one who performs actions of delusion — when that karma ripens, they fall into the hells. And when one in a hundred is freed from the hells, they are reborn in the abodes of animals — born, for instance, in the bodies of a woolly ox, a pig, a cow, a sheep, a buffalo, a donkey, a louse, a fly, or an ant, and the like. Even if they obtain a human body, they are deaf, blind, mute, hunched, their faculties are incomplete, and they cannot retain the Dharma. If they go forth into renunciation, their faculties are confused and dull, and from one root of moral discipline up to five of those roots will be broken. This is called the remainder that is the fruit.

Furthermore, noble son, one who performs actions of pride and arrogance — when the karma ripens, they fall into the hells. And when one in a hundred is freed from the hells, they are reborn in the abodes of animals — born, for instance, in the bodies of intestinal worms, a mule, a donkey, a dog, or a horse. Even if they are born as a human, they take the bodies of male servants, female servants, paupers, destitute persons, or beggars. If they go forth into renunciation, they will be utterly despised by all sentient beings, and they will break all four roots of moral discipline. This is called the remainder that is the fruit.

These are called the remainders of the karmic maturation of the afflictions.

Now, all these remainders of karmic maturation are entirely removed when the bodhisattva, the great being, applies earnest diligence to the great nirvāṇa.

As for what constitutes the remainder of karma: it is the karma of all those who belong to the lowly lineages, the karma of all śrāvakas, the karma of stream-enterers who take seven more existences, the karma of once-returners who take two more existences, and the karma of non-returners who take rebirth in the form realm. These are called the remainder of karma.

This remainder of karma, too, is entirely removed when the bodhisattva, the great being, applies earnest diligence to the great nirvāṇa.

As for what constitutes the remainder of existence: when an arhat attains the fruit of an arhat, and when a pratyekabuddha attains the fruit of a pratyekabuddha, though there is no more karma and no more affliction, there is still a twofold fruit that comes about — this is called the remainder of existence.

In this way, these three kinds of phenomena that have a remainder are entirely removed when the bodhisattva, the great being, applies earnest diligence to the sūtra collection of the Great Vehicle called the great nirvāṇa. This is what is called the bodhisattva, the great being, removing the remainder of existence.

Now, as for how the bodhisattva cultivates the body of perfect purity: the bodhisattva, the great being, in guarding the moral discipline of refraining from taking life, has five kinds of mind. What are they? The lowest, the middling, the superior, the most superior of the superior, and the superior of the middling. The same should be understood in full all the way up to right view. These fifty kinds of mind are called the first arousal of mind.

One comes to possess fifty minds of unshakeable certainty. Thus the hundred minds being perfectly complete is called possessing a hundred merits, and possessing a hundred merits results in a single major mark. In this way, gradually coming to possess the thirty-two major marks is called the body of perfect purity, and beyond that one accomplishes the eighty minor marks (Skt. *anuvyañjana*).

In the world, sentient beings speak of there being some eighty gods. What are the eighty? The twelve gods of the sun, the twelve great gods, the five great stars, the Seven Sisters, the god called the Horse, the god of travelers on the road, the god called Bharadvāja, the god of merit, the twenty-eight constellations, the god of the earth, the god of wind, the god of water, the god of fire, Brahmā, the god called Rudra, the god called Indra (Śakra), the god called Kumāra, the Hundred-Handed One, the god of great dominion, the god called Vaśala, the god of many sons, the god of the Four Protectors, the god of the unwritten, and the god called Vāsu — these are the eighty.

Having accomplished the eighty minor marks for the sake of sentient beings and being fully adorned with them, this is called the body of perfect purity of the bodhisattva. Why is this so? Because all sentient beings have faith in those eighty gods and follow them. Therefore, when the bodhisattva has accomplished the eighty minor marks, without moving the body, he causes each of those sentient beings to see him in just the form in which they have faith, each according to their own disposition. Having seen him, they develop even greater reverence, and each individually gives rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

For this reason, the bodhisattva, the great being, purifies the body completely.

Noble son, consider this example: when a person is inviting a great king, they first adorn and cleanse the entire dwelling most thoroughly, prepare various kinds of fine food, and only then invite the king to come. In the same way, the bodhisattva, the great being, when inviting the king who turns the wheel of Dharma of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, should first purify the body most thoroughly, and then the unsurpassed king of Dharma will take up residence. For this reason, the bodhisattva, the great being, must accomplish the body of perfect purity.

Noble son, consider this example: when a person drinks ambrosia, the body is purified first. In the same way, the bodhisattva, the great being, when about to drink the ambrosia of the supreme Dharma, the Perfection of Wisdom, must first purify the body with the eighty minor marks.

Noble son, consider this example: when pure water is poured into a vessel of fine gold or silver, it is clear and pure both inside and out. In the same way, the body of the bodhisattva, the great being, being perfectly pure, is just like that: when the water of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening is poured in, it is pure both inside and out.

Noble son, consider this example: a cloth of Vārāṇasī, being very white, is easily dyed when boiled. Why is this? Because it is naturally white and clean. In the same way, because the body of the bodhisattva, the great being, is pure, one quickly attains unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Therefore the bodhisattva, the great being, accomplishes the perfectly pure body.

Now, in what way is the bodhisattva supremely skilled with regard to causes? The bodhisattva, the great being, does not perceive the defining characteristic of form, does not perceive the cause of form, does not perceive the intrinsic nature of form, and does not perceive the extraction of form.

One does not perceive the cessation of form, does not perceive a single defining characteristic, does not perceive distinct defining characteristics, does not perceive the act of seeing, and does not perceive form together with its aspects, nor does one perceive the taking up of form. Why is this? Because one thoroughly understands causes and conditions. Just as form is, so too are all phenomena like that. This is called the bodhisattva being supremely skilled with regard to causes.

Now, in what way does the bodhisattva abandon enemies? All mental afflictions are the enemies of the bodhisattva, and because the bodhisattva,

the great being, constantly abandons them, the bodhisattva is called one who has overcome enemies. A bodhisattva at the fifth ground does not regard mental afflictions as enemies. Why is this? Because it is through the condition of mental afflictions that a bodhisattva has birth, and because one has birth, one goes from one to another benefiting sentient beings. For that reason, they are not to be called enemies. Then what is called an enemy? It is this: the denigration of the extensive sūtras. Although the bodhisattva enters into birth and does not fear the realms of hell-beings, the birthplaces of animals, or the hungry ghosts, the bodhisattva fears only the denigration of the extensive sūtras. For all bodhisattvas there are eight kinds of māra, and these become enemies. When those eight kinds of māra are abandoned, this is called the abandonment of enemies. This is what is meant by the bodhisattva abandoning enemies.

Now, in what way does the bodhisattva abandon the two extremes? What are called the two extremes are these: the twenty-five modes of existence and the afflictions of existence. The bodhisattva constantly abandons the twenty-five modes of existence and the afflictions of existence. This is called the bodhisattva abandoning the two extremes.

These, then, are the four qualities possessed by the bodhisattva, the great being, who has applied diligent effort to the great passing beyond sorrow.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Sarvasamāgamaśrīrāja asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as the Blessed One has declared — that those bodhisattvas who have diligently applied themselves to the great passing beyond sorrow require these ten essential qualities — why then did the Tathāgata cultivate only nine? Why did he not cultivate the thorough purification of the buddha-field?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I too cultivated those ten essential qualities in former times. There is not a single bodhisattva, nor any other Tathāgata, who has not cultivated these ten essential qualities. If the world were so thoroughly filled with filth that there were no place where the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, could appear, then, son of good family, you should not hold the view that the Tathāgatas arise in a filthy world. Such a view is utterly feeble and small-minded. You should now understand it in this way: understand that the present arising is not truly in Jambudvīpa. For example, if someone were to say, 'The sun and moon exist only in this world; in other worlds there is no sun and moon,' those words would be without meaning or

reason. In the same way, if a bodhisattva were to say, 'This buddha-field is foul, wretched, and impure, while other buddha-fields are thoroughly pure and beautifully arrayed,' that too is like this."

Noble son, to the west of this world-system of Endurance, past buddha-fields as numerous as the grains of sand of thirty-two Ganges rivers, there exists a world-system called the Invincible. Why is that field called the Invincible? Because all the objects arranged within it are equal and without distinction — just as the western world-system is called Sukhāvatī and the eastern world-system is called the Full Moon. I shall manifest in that world-system, and for the benefit of sentient beings I have shown the turning of the wheel of Dharma in this world-system of Jambudvīpa. It is not I alone who have shown the turning of the wheel of Dharma in this world-system; all Tathāgatas likewise have turned the wheel of Dharma in this world-system. Therefore, there is not a single buddha, a Blessed One, who has not cultivated those ten things.

Noble son, the bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-kindness), by the power of his aspiration, will in a future time adorn this world-system and make it thoroughly pure. In light of this, no buddha-field of any buddha whatsoever is impure.

Furthermore, noble son, how is it that a bodhisattva, a great being, who diligently applies himself to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa comes to possess five excellent qualities? Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who diligently applies himself to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa comes to possess five excellent qualities through five kinds of things. What are those five? Possessing the sense faculties intact; not being born in a border region; being regarded with esteem by the gods; being constantly honored by gods, māras, ascetics, the warrior caste, and brahmins and others; and remembering one's previous lives.

Through the power of the causes and conditions of this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, a bodhisattva will come to be endowed with these five excellent qualities.

The bodhisattva, the great being, Samantaprabhā Uttamaśrīrāja (Universally Radiant, King of Lofty Glory) asked: "As the Blessed One has said, if a noble son or noble daughter practices generosity, they will come to possess five excellent qualities — then why does the Blessed One say that through the condition of the Great Nirvāṇa one obtains these five qualities?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, these qualities are of different meanings, and I shall now distinguish them and explain them to you. The five qualities obtained through practicing generosity are uncertain, impermanent, impure, not supreme, not distinct, and not undefiled; they serve to establish all sentient beings in happiness, for their benefit and for the sake of affection. Whereas the five qualities obtained through reliance on this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa are certain, permanent, thoroughly pure, supreme, distinct, and undefiled; they serve to establish all sentient beings in happiness, for their benefit and for the sake of happiness.

Noble son, generosity removes hunger and thirst. This sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa frees all sentient beings from the illness of being thoroughly tormented by the twenty-five states of existence. Through the cause of generosity, the stream of cyclic existence is made uninterrupted. Through the Great Nirvāṇa sūtra, cyclic existence is severed and its stream is cut. Through the cause of generosity, low and inferior ordinary beings come to act according to the Dharma."

Through the cause of this Great Nirvāṇa sūtra, one becomes a bodhisattva. Through the cause of generosity, all those tormented by the suffering of poverty and destitution will be freed from it. The Great Nirvāṇa sūtra in its entirety can sever all poverty in wholesome qualities. Through the cause of generosity, the result is one that has a partial aspect. Through the cause of the Great Nirvāṇa sūtra, the attainment of the unsurpassed, genuinely perfect awakening is a result without any partial aspect whatsoever. This is what is called a bodhisattva, a great being, who is endowed with the five qualities by virtue of having applied diligent effort to this Great Nirvāṇa sūtra.

Noble son, how is it that a bodhisattva is endowed with six qualities by virtue of having applied diligent effort to this Great Nirvāṇa sūtra? When a bodhisattva, a great being, has applied diligent effort to the Great Nirvāṇa sūtra, he will attain the vajra-like meditative absorption (samādhi). Abiding in that absorption, he will see all phenomena as utterly disintegrating, seeing them to be: marked by impermanence and instability, to be causes of destruction and fear, to be seized by the suffering of illness, to be ceasing and perishing moment by moment, to be without genuine truth, to be entirely within the domain of māra, and to be without any fixed object of apprehension.

The bodhisattva, the great being, while abiding in that meditative absorption and practicing generosity toward sentient beings, does not truly perceive even

a single sentient being. And in the same way, his striving from the perfection of moral discipline all the way through to the Perfection of Wisdom for the sake of sentient beings should be understood to be equally extensive. For if a bodhisattva were to apprehend even a single sentient being as truly existent, he would never fully perfect the perfections from generosity through to the Perfection of Wisdom.

Noble son, consider this example: wherever a vajra strikes, there is nothing that does not crack or shatter, yet the vajra itself never breaks or disintegrates. In the same way, there is nothing the vajra-like meditative absorption strikes that does not disintegrate, yet that very meditative absorption can never itself be destroyed.

Noble son, just as the vajra is supreme among all precious gems, so too the attainment of the vajra-like meditative absorption by a bodhisattva, a great being, is similar in this respect: it becomes the sovereign of all meditative absorptions. Why? Because when a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivates that meditative absorption, all other meditative absorptions are gathered into it.

Noble son, just as a wheel-turning king exercises sovereignty over all minor kings, so too the vajra-like meditative absorption exercises sovereignty over all meditative absorptions.

Noble son, consider this example: if a person becomes an enemy of an entire region, everyone will despise him. And if someone slays that enemy, all people of the world will sing his praises without exception. In the same way, the vajra-like meditative absorption is similar: when a bodhisattva cultivates it, he becomes capable of vanquishing the enemies of all sentient beings. Therefore it becomes the queen of all meditative absorptions.

Noble son, consider this example: a person of tremendous physical strength, beyond what anyone else can overcome, yet who is subdued by the strength of another — that other person will be praised by everyone without exception. In the same way, through the power of the vajra-like meditative absorption, even the most difficult-to-tame phenomena can be tamed. For this reason, all meditative absorptions are gathered into it.

Noble son, consider this example: if a person bathes in the ocean, know that that person has bathed in all the waters of rivers, springs, and ponds.

In the same way, when a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivates the vajra-like meditative absorption, know that this is the cultivation of all other meditative

absorptions.

Noble son, consider this example: on a fragrant mountain there is a spring called "the unheated spring." The water of that spring is endowed with eight excellent qualities. If someone drinks from it, all the sufferings of illness are entirely removed. In the same way, the vajra-like meditative absorption is endowed with the eight limbs of the noble path, and when a bodhisattva cultivates it, the wounds and heavy ailments of the afflictions are cut away.

Noble son, consider this example: if someone makes an offering to a great sovereign lord, know that by doing so that person has made an offering to all the gods. In the same way, cultivating the vajra-like meditative absorption is to be understood as the cultivation of all meditative absorptions.

Noble son, if a bodhisattva who is perfectly established in the vajra-like meditative absorption looks upon all phenomena without obstruction — just as one would see a myrobalan fruit placed in the palm of one's hand — even though a bodhisattva sees in this way, no perception of "I see all phenomena" arises.

Noble son, consider this example: if a person sits at a crossroads, that person will see sentient beings coming, going, sitting, and lying down. In the same way, through the vajra-like meditative absorption one sees all phenomena arising, ceasing, appearing, and passing away.

Noble son, consider this example: if a person ascends a high mountain and looks in every direction, everything is seen with clarity. In the same way, the vajra-like meditative absorption is like that mountain: when a bodhisattva ascends it and looks upon all phenomena, there is nothing that is not clearly seen.

Noble son, consider this example: the fine and beautiful droplets of summer rain leave no gap between them, and when a person of keen eyesight looks, everything is seen with clarity. In the same way, when a bodhisattva obtains the pure eye of the vajra-like meditative absorption, in every world-system in the eastern direction — however many there may be — all their destructions and completions are seen without obstruction and with full clarity; and the same is true of the ten directions likewise.

Noble son, consider this example: if seven suns were to rise simultaneously over Mount Yugamdhara, all the trees and forests of that mountain would be burned. In the same way, when a bodhisattva cultivates the vajra-like

meditative absorption, all the dense thickets of afflictions are pacified.

Noble son, consider this example: the vajra can shatter all things that exist in the realm of existence, yet no perception arises in it of thinking "I have shattered this." The vajra-like meditative absorption is just the same: when a bodhisattva has cultivated it and has overcome all afflictions, no perception arises of thinking "I have now overcome all afflictions entirely."

Noble son, consider this example: the great earth bears all things that exist in the realm of existence, yet no perception arises in it of thinking "I have held these by my own power." Fire does not give rise to the perception "I have burned." Water does not give rise to the perception "I have performed the work of moistening." Wind does not give rise to the perception "I have performed the work of stirring." Space does not give rise to the perception "I have performed the work of containing." And nirvāṇa does not give rise to the perception "I have drawn sentient beings beyond sorrow." The vajra-like meditative absorption is just the same: though it removes all afflictions entirely, from the very beginning there is no mind that thinks "I have removed them."

If a bodhisattva abides in the vajra-like meditative absorption, in a single instant they emanate forms without number and without measure that resemble those of the Tathāgata, filling all the buddha-fields of the ten directions to the very number of grains of sand in the Ganges River. And yet, though that bodhisattva performs such manifest emanations, they have no mind of pride or arrogance. Why is that? The bodhisattva always thinks: "No other meditative absorption can display such miraculous powers — only the one who abides in the vajra-like meditative absorption is able to display them." It is with this thought that they remain.

When the great bodhisattva abides in that vajra-like meditative absorption, they have the power, in a single instant, to journey to buddha-fields in the ten directions to the very number of grains of sand in the Ganges River and then return to their dwelling place — yet they do not have the perception "I am capable of this." Why? Because of the cause and condition that is that meditative absorption.

When the great bodhisattva abides in the vajra-like meditative absorption, they are able, in a single instant, to sever all the afflictions of sentient beings in world-systems throughout the ten directions, as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges River — and yet they do not have the perception "I have

severed the afflictions of sentient beings." Why? Because of the power of the cause and condition that is that meditative absorption.

Abiding in that vajra-like meditative absorption, a bodhisattva utters a single sound, and all sentient beings individually understand things just as they are. They display a single form, and all sentient beings individually perceive the marks of forms in their variety. They remain in a single place, their body utterly still, and sentient beings, wherever they may dwell in any direction, each see them present in their own direction. They teach a single Dharma — whether pertaining to an element (dhātu) or a sense base (āyatana) — and all sentient beings each hear it as though knowing it beforehand.

When a bodhisattva abides in such a meditative absorption, though they perceive sentient beings, from the very beginning there is no mind that grasps at sentient beings as a defining mark. Though they perceive men and women, there is no mind that grasps at maleness and femaleness. Though they perceive phenomena of form, there is no defining mark of form. And so too, through to consciousness: though they perceive consciousness, there is no defining mark of consciousness. Though they perceive day and night, there is no defining mark of day and night. Though they perceive all things, there is no defining mark of anything at all. Though they perceive all the afflictions that arise through involvement, there is no defining mark of any affliction. Though they perceive the noble eightfold path, there is no defining mark of the noble eightfold path. Though they perceive awakening, there is no defining mark of awakening. Though they perceive nirvāṇa, there is no defining mark of nirvāṇa. Why? Noble son, because all phenomena are, from the very beginning, without defining marks — and through the power of that meditative absorption, the bodhisattva sees all phenomena just as they are: without defining marks from the very beginning.

Why is it called the vajra-like meditative absorption? Noble son, consider: when a vajra is placed in sunlight, its color is not fixed as any single hue. In just the same way, when the vajra-like meditative absorption is placed within a great multitude, it cannot be determined as having a single, fixed character. It is for that reason that it is called the vajra-like meditative absorption.

Noble son, consider again: a vajra is beyond any price that all beings in the world might set upon it. In just the same way, whatever qualities the vajra-like meditative absorption possesses cannot be measured or gauged by all gods and humans together. It is for that reason that it is called the vajra-like

meditative absorption.

Noble son, consider: if a poor man were to find a precious vajra-gem, it would relieve him of the sufferings of poverty and destitution, and —

he would be freed from all the harm of māras and wrong views. In just the same way, when a bodhisattva, a great being, attains that meditative absorption, he too is freed from the suffering of mental afflictions and from all the harm of māras and wrong views. It is for that reason that it is called the vajra-like meditative absorption. This, then, is what is meant when it is said that a bodhisattva who applies himself diligently to the great nirvāṇa possesses the sixth quality.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa, the thirty-third fascicle.

Furthermore, noble son, how is it that a bodhisattva, a great being, who applies himself diligently to this noble sūtra of the great nirvāṇa comes to possess seven qualities? Noble son, when a bodhisattva, a great being, applies himself diligently to this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, he reflects: "What are the qualities of Dharma that serve as proximate causes for the great nirvāṇa?" He then understands that these four qualities of Dharma serve as proximate causes for the great nirvāṇa. It is not the case that practising all manner of austerities serves as the proximate cause for the great nirvāṇa. And why not? Beyond these four qualities of Dharma there is simply no ground on which one could transcend into nirvāṇa. What are the four? They are these: attending upon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra); listening to the Dharma with a one-pointed mind; applying oneself diligently to its meaning after having heard it; and practising exactly in accordance with what is true.

Noble son, consider the example of a person afflicted by bile, phlegm, and many diseases, or tormented by hunger. That sick person goes to a skilled physician, and the physician teaches him the proper treatment for the illness. The patient listens with a one-pointed mind and follows the prescribed treatment, taking the medicine correctly. His illness is cured and his body becomes well.

In this analogy, the sick person is like the bodhisattva. The skilled physician is like the spiritual friend. The physician's teaching of the proper treatment is like this extensive sūtra. Listening carefully to and retaining the physician's taught treatment is like applying oneself diligently to the meaning of this extensive sūtra. Administering the medicine in accordance with the treatment is like correctly practising the thirty-seven factors of awakening

(bodhipākṣikadharmas) exactly as they truly are. The curing of the illness is like the cessation of the mental afflictions. Attaining wellbeing is like attaining the permanence, bliss, selfhood, and utter purity of nirvāṇa.

Noble son, consider further the example of a king who, wishing to govern his realm according to the Dharma and to bring happiness to his subjects, asks his wise ministers what course of action would be best. The ministers then explain to him the principles of governance by which former kings had ruled their realms. The king hears this, and with a one-pointed mind places his trust in it. Governing his realm according to those very principles, his enemies are vanquished, and thereby his subjects attain happiness and are freed from harm.

In this analogy, the king is like the bodhisattva. The wise ministers are like the spiritual friend. The wise ministers' exposition to the king of the principles of governance is like the twelve branches of scripture (dvādaśāṅgadharmas). The king's hearing this and with a one-pointed mind placing his trust in it and acting accordingly is like bodhisattvas, with one-pointed minds, reflecting upon and diligently applying themselves to the profound meaning of the twelve branches of scripture. The governing of the realm in accordance with the Dharma is like bodhisattvas diligently practising exactly and truly in accordance with the Dharma of the six perfections — and this they do for the sake of diligent application to the six perfections.

The elimination of enemies is like bodhisattvas utterly abandoning all the enemies of afflictive mental afflictions. The attainment of happiness is like bodhisattvas attaining the permanence, happiness, selfhood, and perfect purity of nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, consider this example: a man afflicted with a severe case of leprosy had a dear and close friend who said to him, "If you were to go to the foot of Mount Meru, all your diseases would be cured. Why? Because there is an excellent medicine there, like the nectar of immortality, and if it is drunk, there is no disease that cannot be healed." The man then placed his trust in this, went to the foot of that mountain, gathered the medicine that was like nectar, and ate it. His disease was cured and his body became well and comfortable.

The severe leprosy is like base and ignoble afflictions. The dear and close friend is like great bodhisattvas (bodhisattva-mahāsattvas). The wholeheartedness of faith is like the minds of the four immeasurables. Mount

Meru is like the noble eightfold path. The taste of nectar is like the nature of buddha. The healing of the leprosy is like freedom from afflictions. The attainment of happiness is like attaining the permanence, happiness, selfhood, and perfect purity of nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, consider this further example: a teacher who has students of keen faculties teaches them day and night without ever growing weary. In the same way, bodhisattvas too, whether sentient beings have faith or do not have faith, teach without ceasing and without ever growing weary.

O son of good family, a spiritual friend (Skt. kalyāṇamitra) is one who has profound trust in buddhas, bodhisattvas, pratyekabuddhas, and śrāvakas. Why is such a person called a spiritual friend? A spiritual friend is one who causes sentient beings to abandon the ten non-virtues and to practise the ten virtues — it is for that reason such a person is called a spiritual friend. Again, a spiritual friend is one who teaches the Dharma exactly as it is and who practises in accord with exactly what has been taught. How does one teach the Dharma as it is and practise in accord with what has been taught? It is like this: because one does not take life oneself, one teaches others not to take life; because one oneself diligently applies to right view, one leads others to diligently apply to right view — and so on up through the full range of virtues. One who acts in this way is called a genuine spiritual friend. Because one diligently applies oneself to awakening, one leads others to diligently apply themselves to awakening — it is for that reason such a person is called a spiritual friend. Because one cultivates faith, moral discipline, generosity, extensive learning, and wisdom oneself, one leads others to cultivate faith, moral discipline, generosity, extensive learning, and wisdom — it is for that reason such a person is called a spiritual friend. A spiritual friend is so called because of the presence of virtuous qualities. What are those virtuous qualities? It is this: whatever one does, one does not apply it to one's own benefit and comfort; rather, one is ever engaged in bringing sentient beings to happiness; and even upon seeing the faults of others, one does not speak of their failings but speaks only and always of virtuous qualities. It is for that reason such a person is called a spiritual friend.

O son of good family, consider the analogy of the moon: from the first day of the lunar month up through the fifteenth day it steadily and visibly waxes. In the same way, a spiritual friend likewise causes the students they guide to gradually grow distant from non-virtuous qualities and to give rise to virtuous qualities.

O son of good family, if anyone relies upon a spiritual friend, they will come to possess moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge and vision of liberation — even those they did not have before.

Those not yet complete will arise and grow. Why is that? Because of drawing near to a spiritual friend. Through the condition of such nearness, one will come to understand even the very deep meaning of the twelve branches of scriptural teaching. Listening to the very deep meaning of those twelve branches of scriptural teaching is called listening to the Dharma. That very listening to the Dharma is called the extensive sūtras of the Great Vehicle. Listening to those extensive sūtras is called genuinely listening to the Dharma. Genuinely listening to the Dharma means listening to the sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, in which one hears that within the great nirvāṇa there exists the nature of the buddha, and that a Tathāgata does not pass beyond nirvāṇa finally and completely. Therefore it is called one-pointedly listening to the Dharma. One-pointedly listening to the Dharma is called the noble eightfold path, and by means of the noble eightfold path, attachment, aversion, and delusion are cut through. Therefore it is called listening to the Dharma. Listening to the Dharma is called the eleven emptinesses, and by those emptinesses one does not look upon any phenomenon as having a defining mark. Listening to the Dharma is called first arousing the mind: from the cause of first arousing the mind one will attain, step by step, the unsurpassed awakening mind of a perfect arhat — that is, the fully and perfectly enlightened awakening mind — all the way through to great nirvāṇa. Yet great nirvāṇa is not attained merely by hearing; it is attained through thorough cultivation in meditation.

O son of good family, consider the analogy of a sick person: merely by hearing the name of a physician's treatment and medicine, the illness will not be cured, but it will be cured by actually drinking the medicine. In the same way, merely by listening to the twelve profound factors of dependent origination, all afflictions will not be cut through; they will be cut through by applying the mind one-pointedly and exerting oneself earnestly. That is called earnest application of the mind.

Furthermore, why is it called earnest application of the mind? It is as follows: there are three kinds of meditative absorption — the meditative absorption of emptiness, the meditative absorption of signlessness, and the meditative absorption of wishlessness. Among these, emptiness means not seeing even a

single truth in the twenty-five modes of existence. Wishlessness means not wishing for or seeking anything among the twenty-five modes of existence. Signlessness means freedom from ten signs: the sign of form, the sign of sound, the sign of smell, the sign of taste, the sign of touch, the sign of arising, the sign of abiding, the sign of cessation, the sign of the masculine, and the sign of the feminine. Thus, cultivating these three kinds of meditative absorption is what is called earnest application of the mind on the part of a bodhisattva.

Now, what does it mean to conduct oneself in accord with the Dharma? To conduct oneself in accord with the Dharma means to practise from the perfection of generosity through to the Perfection of Wisdom, to be skilled in the true defining marks of the five aggregates, the sense bases, and the elements, and to understand that śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and the blessed buddhas alike pass into nirvāṇa together in harmony along a single path. The word "Dharma" refers to that which is permanent, blissful, self, utterly pure, unborn, unaging, undiseased, undying, free from hunger, free from thirst, without suffering and affliction, undeclining, and unceasing.

O son of good family, to know the very deep meaning of the great nirvāṇa is to know that a blessed buddha does not pass away into final and complete nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, the true and genuine spiritual friend is none other than bodhisattvas and blessed buddhas. Why is that? Because they constantly guide others by means of three kinds of steering. What are the three? Always speaking gently, always being firm, and mixing gentleness with firmness together. For this reason, bodhisattvas and blessed buddhas are genuine spiritual friends.

Furthermore, O son of good family, buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends because they are great physicians. Why? Because they know the illness and know the medicine, and they give medicine according to the nature of the illness. Consider, for example, a skilled physician expert in the eight branches of medical knowledge, who first examines the defining marks of disease. There are three such defining marks: wind, bile, and phlegm. For one afflicted with a wind disease, he gives butter. For one afflicted with a bile disease, he gives sugar. For one afflicted with a phlegm disease, he administers broth. In this way, knowing the defining marks of the illness and giving the appropriate medicine so that the patient recovers — this is what it

means to be a skilled physician. Likewise, buddhas and bodhisattvas know that the foolish, immature ordinary beings of this world have three kinds of illness. What are the three? Attachment, aversion, and delusion. To those afflicted with the illness of attachment, they teach contemplation on the skeleton. To those afflicted with the illness of aversion, they teach contemplation on loving-kindness and compassion. To those afflicted with the illness of delusion, they teach contemplation on the twelve links of dependent origination. For this reason, buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends.

O son of good family, just as a great vehicle is so called because it conveys beings to ease and liberation, so too buddhas and bodhisattvas liberate all sentient beings from the great conflagration of saṃsāra — and for this reason they are called spiritual friends.

Furthermore, O son of good family, through the condition of buddhas and bodhisattvas, all sentient beings come to fully complete the practice of the roots of virtuous Dharma. O son of good family, consider the snow mountain, which is the abode of many excellent and supreme medicinal herbs. Likewise, buddhas and bodhisattvas are the abode of all roots of virtue. For this reason they are called spiritual friends.

O son of good family, on the snow mountain there is a supreme fragrant herb called Vāha. If certain people see it, they gain immeasurable lifespan and are freed from the suffering of illness. The four malevolent ones cannot harm them. If someone touches it, they gain long life and complete one hundred and twenty years. If someone calls it to mind in recollection, they remember their former lives. Why is this? Because of the power and strength of that medicine. Likewise, whoever sees a buddha or a bodhisattva has all their afflictions utterly severed, and the four māras cannot disturb them. Whoever touches them does not die suddenly at an untimely moment. They are unborn, they do not die, they do not decline, they do not perish. "Touching" here means hearing the sublime Dharma from a buddha. Whoever calls them to mind in recollection attains unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Therefore buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends.

O son of good family, consider the fragrant mountain lake called Anavatapta. From that lake flow four great rivers. What are the four? The Gaṅgā, the Sindhu, the Sītā, and the Vakṣu.

Worldly people say this: "Whoever has committed blameworthy deeds and bathes in those four great rivers will be purified of many blameworthy and sinful acts." Know that what they say is not true. Then what, one may ask, are the truths they have failed to understand? It is this: buddhas and bodhisattvas are the true ones. Why? Because whoever venerates and honors them will be purified of all their many blameworthy and sinful deeds. Therefore buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends.

Furthermore, O son of good family, consider the great earth: all the medicinal herbs and forests, the crops, the sugarcane, the flowers, the fruits, and so forth that have grown upon it become withered and are on the verge of drying out. Then the nāga kings Nanda and Upananda, moved by compassion for sentient beings, arise from the ocean and release a rain of nectar, whereupon all the medicinal herbs, forests, crops, and trees become moist and grow again. In the same way, when the wholesome roots of all sentient beings are on the verge of exhaustion, buddhas and bodhisattvas arouse great compassion and release a rain of nectar from the ocean of wisdom, endowing all sentient beings with the tenfold path of virtue. Therefore buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends.

O son of good family, consider a skilled physician, expert in the eight branches of medicine. When he sees patients, he does not look to their family lineage, their good or bad qualities, their wealth, their jewels, or anything of that sort — he heals them all. And so he becomes renowned throughout the world as a great and skilled physician. In the same way, when buddhas and bodhisattvas see the disease of affliction in sentient beings, they do not look to family lineage, good or bad qualities, wealth, jewels, or anything of that sort. With minds of loving-kindness and compassion they teach the Dharma to all. When sentient beings hear it, the disease of their afflictions is purified. Therefore buddhas and bodhisattvas are called spiritual friends.

By relying on a spiritual friend in this way, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa, the thorough passing beyond sorrow. How, one may ask, does a bodhisattva draw near to the great nirvāṇa through the condition of hearing the Dharma? It is like this: for the sake of hearing the Dharma, all sentient beings come to be endowed with the faculty of faith. Having come to be endowed with the faculty of faith, they grow devoted to the practice of generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom. They then attain a stream of results, beginning with the fruit of stream-entry up through the fruit of buddhahood. Therefore one should

understand that it is through the power of hearing the Dharma as its cause that one comes to attain virtuous qualities.

O son of good family, consider a householder who has a single son. He sends that son off to trade in another land in search of what is needed, and after pointing out which roads along the way are safe and which are dangerous, he says to him: "If you meet a serpent-woman, do not draw close to her, do not become attached to her. If you draw close or become attached, you will lose both body and life, and your wealth and jewels and all the rest will be lost as well. Do not seek out evil and unruly companions." The son heeded his father's counsel, and as a result he was happy in body and mind and obtained wealth and jewels in great abundance. In the same way, the bodhisattva, the great being, when teaching the Dharma to sentient beings, shows to those sentient beings and the four kinds of retinue which paths are safe and which are dangerous.

The members of the retinue, having heard the Dharma, abandoned all non-virtue and came to be endowed with virtuous qualities. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, they drew near to the great nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, consider this example: when one looks into a clear mirror, no face fails to appear. In the same way, when someone looks into the clear mirror of hearing the Dharma, they see without any obscuring film both virtue and non-virtue with perfect clarity. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, they draw near to the great nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, consider this example: merchants setting out for an island of jewels do not know the way. One person shows them the road, and following the directions they were given, they reach the island of jewels and obtain jewels beyond counting. In the same way, all sentient beings, setting out for the virtuous realm to gather the jewel of awakening, do not know which roads lead to liberation and which do not. The bodhisattvas show the way, and the sentient beings, following as they were shown, arrive at the virtuous realm and obtain the jewel of the great, unsurpassed nirvāṇa. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, they draw near to the great nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, consider this example: a drunken bull elephant, wishing to kill many, is brought under control the moment an elephant trainer inserts a great iron hook into its temple — and from that instant it is tamed and no longer harbors the intention to harm. In the same way, all sentient beings, intoxicated by attachment, aversion, and delusion, engage in a great deal of

non-virtue. The bodhisattvas insert the iron hook of hearing the Dharma and hold it firm, causing the intention to commit non-virtuous acts to cease arising. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, they draw near to the great nirvāṇa.

It is for this reason that throughout all the sūtra collections I have declared to my attendants that if with one-pointed mind they hear and hold the twelve branches of the sūtra collection, they will be free from the five obscurations and will cultivate the seven limbs of awakening. Through cultivating the seven limbs of awakening they will draw near to the great nirvāṇa. Through hearing the Dharma, those who have entered the stream will be freed from fears.

Why is this? Because the householder Śkyabmed (a man without refuge) was stricken by severe illness and his mind was overwhelmed with terror and misery. Śāriputra then set forth the four qualities of a stream-enterer and spoke of ten kinds of inspiration, and upon hearing this the man became free from fear. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

Why is this? Because it is the Dharma-eye that is opened. In the world there are three kinds of people: those without eyes, those with one eye, and those with two eyes. Those without eyes are those who never hear the Dharma at all. Those with one eye are those who hear the Dharma for just a moment yet whose mind does not rest upon it. Those with two eyes are those who listen and retain with one-pointed mind and who act in accordance with what they have heard. It is by hearing the Dharma that one comes to know there are these three kinds of people in the world. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, in former times when I was residing in the city of Kuśinagara, Śāriputra was stricken by illness. At that time I summoned the monk Ānanda and taught the Dharma in full. Then Śāriputra, having received such a gift, said to his four disciples: "Carry this seat of mine and let us go into the presence of the Buddha — I wish to hear the Dharma." His four disciples then carried him, and he went to where I was abiding and heard the Dharma.

Through the force of hearing the Dharma, suffering was purified and the body became at ease. Thus, through the condition of hearing the Dharma, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

How is it that through the condition of a bodhisattva's contemplation one draws near to the great nirvāṇa? It is like this: through the condition of such

contemplative reflection, the mind is fully liberated. Why is that? It is because all sentient beings are perpetually bound by the five objects of desire and become liberated through reflection that draws the mind away from them. Thus, through the condition of contemplation, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, O son of good family, all sentient beings are perpetually misled by four aspects of phenomena — permanence, pleasurableness, self, and purity — and, through contemplating these, they perceive all phenomena as impermanent, suffering, selfless, and impure. Having seen in this way, the four inverted views are severed. Thus, through the condition of contemplation, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, O son of good family, all phenomena have four characteristics (lakṣaṇa). What are those four? The characteristic of birth, the characteristic of aging, the characteristic of illness, and the characteristic of cessation. By these four characteristics, all ordinary persons of inferior lineage, up to and including stream-enterers (srotāpanna), are thoroughly afflicted. Yet one who contemplates with single-pointed mind does not give rise to affliction even when encountering those four aspects. Thus, through the condition of contemplation, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, O son of good family, none of the wholesome qualities are attained by others without contemplation. Why is that? Even if one were to listen to the Dharma with single-pointed mind for immeasurable, innumerable, and boundless eons, if one does not contemplate, one will never attain the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Thus, through the condition of reflection in the mind, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, O son of good family, if any sentient being places unwavering and unaltered faith in the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, and pays them honor and respect — that being too, through the condition of single-pointed mental engagement, should be understood to have severed all afflictions. Thus, through the condition of mental engagement, one draws near to the great nirvāṇa.

How does a bodhisattva cultivate in accordance with the Dharma? O son of good family, one who abandons all unwholesome phenomena and applies oneself diligently to wholesome phenomena — this is called a bodhisattva's cultivation in accordance with the Dharma.

Again, how does one cultivate in accordance with the Dharma? By seeing all phenomena as empty, objectless, impermanent, suffering, selfless, and impure — and, because of seeing them in this way, never breaking one's vows of moral discipline even at the cost of body and life. This is called a bodhisattva's cultivation in accordance with the Dharma.

Furthermore, how does one cultivate in accordance with the Dharma? Cultivation has two aspects: authentic and inauthentic. The inauthentic is this: not knowing the defining characteristics of nirvāṇa, the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, truth itself, and space — this is called inauthentic cultivation. The authentic is this: knowing the defining characteristics of nirvāṇa, the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, truth itself, and space — this is called authentic cultivation.

Now, how does one know the defining characteristics of nirvāṇa? The defining characteristics of nirvāṇa have eight aspects. What are those eight? Exhaustion, the characteristic of virtue, truth, authenticity, permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — that is nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, there are another eight aspects. What are those eight? Liberation, an intrinsically virtuous nature, inauthenticity, untruth, impermanence, suffering, no-self, and utter impurity.

Furthermore, there are another six defining characteristics. What are those? Liberation, an intrinsically virtuous nature, untruth, inauthenticity, bliss, and utter purity.

Now, if any sentient being relies upon the conventional path and cuts through afflictions, the nirvāṇa that is the cutting of afflictions has eight aspects — yet that liberation is untrue. Why? Because it is impermanent. Being impermanent, it lacks truth. Lacking truth, it lacks authenticity, for even though the afflictions have been cut, they can arise again. Impermanence, no-self, suffering, and utter impurity — these are what are called the eight aspects of the liberation that is nirvāṇa.

Then, how are there six defining characteristics? Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, because they have cut through afflictions, are called liberated; yet because they do not attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening (bodhi), they are called untrue. Being untrue in this way, they are called inauthentic. Because in a future time they will come to attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, they are called impermanent.

Because they have attained the noble eightfold path (Skt. āryāṣṭāṅgamārga), which is without defilement, they are called blissful and utterly pure.

O son of noble family, one who knows this in this way is said to know nirvāṇa, and is said to know the defining characteristics of the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, of the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, truth itself, and space.

Now, how does a bodhisattva know the intrinsic nature of the buddhas? The intrinsic nature of the buddhas has six aspects. What are those six? Permanence, utter purity, truth, virtue, being something that will be seen, and authenticity. Furthermore, there are seven aspects: the first is that it will be known, and the remaining six are as before. This is called a bodhisattva's knowing the intrinsic nature of the buddhas.

How does a bodhisattva know the defining characteristics of the Tathāgata? In this context, what is called "the Tathāgata" is: the characteristic of feeling, the characteristic of virtue, permanence, bliss, self, utter purity, liberation, truth, authenticity — one who is fit to show the path. This is called a bodhisattva's knowing the defining characteristics of the Tathāgata.

How does a bodhisattva know the defining characteristics of the Dharma? In this context, knowing the Dharma means knowing: virtue and non-virtue, permanence and impermanence, bliss and suffering, self and no-self, utter purity and utter impurity, knowing and not knowing, awareness and ignorance, truth and untruth, what is to be cultivated and what is not to be cultivated, what is a teacher and what is not a teacher, what is authentic and what is inauthentic. Knowing all these is called a bodhisattva's knowing the defining characteristics of the Dharma.

How does a bodhisattva know the defining characteristics of the Saṅgha? What is called the Saṅgha has the characteristics of permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity; it is fit to display the defining characteristic of one who is a learner; it is virtuous, authentic, and yet untrue. Why? Because all śrāvakas will attain the awakening of a buddha. What then is truth?

knowing the essential nature of phenomena. Knowing all of this is called a bodhisattva's knowing the defining characteristics of the Saṅgha.

How does a bodhisattva know the authentic defining characteristics? What are called the authentic defining characteristics are: permanence and impermanence, bliss and suffering, self and selflessness, utter purity and utter impurity, virtue and non-virtue, existence and non-existence, nirvāṇa and

what is not nirvāṇa, liberation and non-liberation, knowing and not knowing, annihilation and non-annihilation, understanding and ignorance, cultivation and non-cultivation, seeing and not seeing — these are called the authentic defining characteristics. Nirvāṇa, the intrinsic nature of a buddha, the Tathāgata, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and space are not among them. For it is through the condition of cultivating the great nirvāṇa in just this way that a bodhisattva comes to understand the distinctions among the defining characteristics of nirvāṇa, the intrinsic nature of a buddha, the Tathāgata, the Dharma and the Saṅgha, the authentic, space, and so forth.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who cultivates the sacred sūtra of the great, complete nirvāṇa does not see space. Why is that? Although buddhas and bodhisattvas possess five eyes, they do not see it with those; it is seen only with the eye of wisdom. And even what is seen with the eye of wisdom is called seeing by virtue of not seeing any phenomenon whatsoever. If space is said to be that in which no thing of any kind exists, then space would be something authentic. But if it were authentic, it would be permanently non-existent, and being permanently non-existent, it would also lack bliss and utter purity.

Noble son, the empty is a phenomenon of non-existence; it is called empty because it is a thing that has the character of non-existence. It is like calling something empty in the world when no thing whatsoever is present in it. In the same way, the intrinsic nature of space is also called space because no thing whatsoever is present in it. Noble son, both the intrinsic nature of sentient beings and the intrinsic nature of space are alike in having no authentic intrinsic nature. Why? Because some people say: if existing things were made absent, it would become empty. But space is not, in truth, something that can be made. Why? Because there is nothing there at all. And because there is nothing at all, one should understand that emptiness too is absent. If the intrinsic nature of space were something that could be made, it would be impermanent, and what is impermanent should not be called space.

Noble son, for example, worldly people say: space is without form, without obstruction, permanent, unchanging, and unaltering. That is why in the world space is spoken of as the fifth of the great elements. Noble son, but in truth space has no intrinsic nature; it is merely designated space because it appears, and in truth space does not exist. It is like conventional truth, which has no intrinsic nature of its own, yet has been taught as conventional truth for the sake of sentient beings.

Noble son, the essential nature of nirvāṇa is similar in this respect: although it has no fixed abode, it is called nirvāṇa because it is the abode in which all Tathāgatas sever the afflictions. Nirvāṇa itself is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. Nirvāṇa is bliss, yet it is not the experience of bliss in the ordinary sense; it is the supreme, peaceful, and sublime bliss. The Blessed One, the buddha, has two kinds of bliss: the bliss of complete peace and the bliss of full awareness. Within the intrinsic nature of the authentic defining characteristics, there are three kinds of bliss: the bliss of experience, the bliss of complete peace, and the bliss of full awareness.

The intrinsic nature of a buddha is a single bliss: the bliss of attaining the unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

Then the great bodhisattva Samantaprabha, Glorious King of the Lofty and Sublime, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, it is not proper to call that abode in which the afflictions are severed nirvāṇa."

"Why is that?" he continued. "From the time the Tathāgata first became fully and completely awakened until he came to the banks of the river Hiraṇyavatī, at that very time the king of māras, together with his retinue, appeared before the Blessed One and said: 'Blessed One, the time has come to pass into nirvāṇa — why do you not pass into nirvāṇa?' The Blessed One replied to the king of māras: 'I will not pass into nirvāṇa, because as yet I have no attendants who are learned, who hold moral discipline and vows, whose faculties are clear and whose wisdom is keen, and who are capable of working for the benefit of sentient beings.'

"But if the very abode in which the afflictions are severed were nirvāṇa, then since bodhisattvas have severed the afflictions since immeasurable aeons, why would nirvāṇa not be attributed to them? Since both have that abode of severed afflictions, why does it apply to the blessed buddha but not to bodhisattvas?

"And if severing the afflictions is not nirvāṇa, then why did the Tathāgata formerly say to the brahmin Jyotiṣka: 'This very body of mine is nirvāṇa'?

"Furthermore, once when the Tathāgata was residing at Vaiśālī, māra again made this request: 'In former times, Tathāgata, you declared that you would not pass into nirvāṇa because you had no attendants who were learned, who upheld moral discipline, whose wisdom was clear and whose faculties were keen, and who were capable of working for the benefit of sentient beings. But

now such persons do exist — so why do you say you will not pass into nirvāṇa?'

"At that time the Tathāgata replied to the king of māras: 'Do not form the perception of something obstructed by form. In three months from now, I will pass completely into nirvāṇa.'

"Blessed One, if the passing away of the body is not nirvāṇa, why did the Tathāgata say: 'In three months from now I will pass completely into nirvāṇa'?

"Blessed One, if the severing of afflictions itself were nirvāṇa, then since the Tathāgata first became fully and completely awakened in essence at the foot of the Bodhi tree and thereby overcame the afflictions — if that itself were nirvāṇa — why did he say: 'In three months from now I will pass completely into nirvāṇa'?

"And Blessed One, if he had already passed into nirvāṇa at that time, why did he say at the midnight hour to the śāla trees of the great forest in the city of Kuśinagara: 'I will now pass completely into nirvāṇa'?

"The Tathāgata is one who speaks truthfully — how then did he utter those words that appear untrue?"

Then the Blessed One replied to the great bodhisattva Samantaprabha, Glorious King of the Lofty and Sublime:

"Son of good family, because it has been said that the Tathāgata possesses a long and broad tongue, you should understand that from immeasurable aeons the Tathāgata has been free from untrue words. Everything whatsoever that is spoken by all buddhas and bodhisattvas is carefully considered speech — it is not untrue.

"Son of good family, just as you have said, it is true that the sinful māra formerly petitioned me to pass into nirvāṇa. But son of good family, the king of māras does not know the authentic and true defining characteristics of what nirvāṇa definitively is. Why is that?"

The sinful māra thinks in his mind: "If the Tathāgata sits in silence, speaking nothing and doing nothing for the benefit of sentient beings, that is nirvāṇa." Son of good family, consider this analogy: when worldly people see someone who is silent and doing nothing, they say, "That person is no different from a corpse." In the same way, the sinful māra thinks: "The very fact that the Tathāgata does nothing for the benefit of sentient beings and speaks nothing — that itself is the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, the Tathāgata has not taught the defining characteristics of the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha as undifferentiated from one another. Rather, he has taught only that two qualities — abiding permanently and being completely pure — are undifferentiated among them. Son of good family, the Tathāgata has not taught a buddha, the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and nirvāṇa as sharing undifferentiated defining characteristics. Rather, he has taught only that being utterly lasting and permanent, changeless and immovable — these alone are undifferentiated among them.

Son of good family, at that time and on that occasion all my śrāvaka attendants will fall into dispute. Just as the monks of the region of Kauśāmbī who were of bad conduct acted contrary to my word, broke their vows of moral discipline, and took unstipulated goods — so they will seek gain and fame by praising themselves before householders, saying: "I have attained the undefiled. What have I attained, you ask? I have attained everything from the fruit of stream-entry up to the fruit of arhatship." And they will disparage others. They will show no respect for the Buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, moral discipline, or their preceptors. When you tell me, "Such-and-such an article the Buddha permitted to be held," or, "Such-and-such articles the Buddha did not permit to be held" — even if I myself should say, "Such-and-such articles I have not truly permitted," they will contradict my word and say, "Such-and-such articles were truly permitted by the Buddha." Those of bad conduct will not trust my word. Because of them, do not think to yourself that I bear a grudge against the sinful māra. I have declared: "In three months' time I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, because of those monks of bad conduct, the śrāvaka attendants who are engaged in the trainings will neither see my body nor hear my Dharma, and so they will say, "The Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa." But the bodhisattvas, seeing my body and constantly hearing Dharma from me, will not say that I have passed fully into nirvāṇa. Although the śrāvaka attendants say, "The Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa," I have not truly passed into nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, if among my śrāvaka attendants there is one who says, "The Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa," know that such a person is not truly my attendant. He is a companion of māra, one of wrong views, one who is evil, one who does not hold correct views. But whoever says, "The Tathāgata has not passed into nirvāṇa" — that person alone is my true attendant; know him

to be no companion of māra, not one of wrong and evil views.

Son of good family, I have never once encountered any of my attendants saying that the Tathāgata, while dwelling without speaking and without acting for the benefit of sentient beings, has thereby passed fully into nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a householder has many children. If that householder has gone away to another place and not yet returned, the children think their father has died —

yet the householder has not died — the children, deceived by a wrong perception, give rise to the perception of death. In just the same way, the śrāvaka attendants, not seeing me, think: "The Tathāgata has passed fully into nirvāṇa between the sal trees in the city of Kuśinagara." I have not truly passed fully into nirvāṇa, yet the śrāvaka attendants give rise to the perception of nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: when a bright lamp is covered by something, those who do not know think the lamp has died, and because they do not know that the glory of its light has not truly died, they give rise to the perception of death. In just the same way, the śrāvaka attendants are like that: though they possess the eye of wisdom, it is obscured by the afflictions, their minds have become inverted, and not seeing the true body they give rise to the perception of absence and of passing — yet I have not truly passed into nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a blind person does not see the sun and moon. Because they do not see them, they do not know the marks of day and night, of light and darkness. Because they do not know them, they say, "The sun and the moon do not truly exist." Yet it is precisely because the blind person cannot see them that they exist — truly the sun and moon are there — and because they cannot be seen, a wrong perception arises and one says, "There is no sun or moon." In just the same way, the śrāvaka attendants are like that blind person: not seeing the Tathāgata, they think the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa — but the Tathāgata has not truly passed into nirvāṇa. With wrong perception they give rise to such a thought.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: when clouds and mist obscure the sun and moon, those who are foolish and do not understand say, "There is no sun or moon." The sun and moon truly exist, but because they are fully covered, sentient beings cannot see them. In just the same way, the śrāvaka attendants are like that: obscured by many afflictions, the eye of wisdom is

veiled, and not seeing the Tathāgata they say, "The Tathāgata's life has ended."

Son of good family, consider this analogy: when the sun sets over Jambudvīpa, it is obscured by the dark mountains and sentient beings cannot see it — yet the sun's own nature has not truly set. Because sentient beings cannot see it, they give rise to the perception of setting. In just the same way, the śrāvaka attendants are like that: obscured by the mountain of the afflictions, they cannot see my body, and because they cannot see it they give rise to the perception that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa. I have not truly passed into nirvāṇa.

Therefore, when I was in Vaiśālī, I declared to the evil māra: "From this day, in three months I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa." Son of good family, the Tathāgata had foreseen beforehand that three months hence the roots of virtue of the bodhisattva Kāśyapa would ripen, and that he would come forth from the fragrant mountain of Gandhamādana and appear in my presence. Therefore I declared to the evil māra: "From this day, in three months I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, furthermore, five hundred men of great power would, in three months, give rise to the mind set upon the unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening — and therefore I declared to the evil māra: "From this day, in three months I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, Cunda and the five hundred Licchavīs, and the maiden Ambā — in three months they too would give rise to the mind set upon the unsurpassable awakening,

and their roots of virtue would be fully ripened — and therefore I declared to the evil māra: "From this day, in three months I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, there was one called Sundaraka, a follower of the naked non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and others. For twelve years I had taught him the Dharma, yet he had no faith in me and no trust. I knew that in three months the root of his wrong views would be severed — and therefore I declared to the evil māra: "From this day, in three months I shall pass fully into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, why, and for what reason, had I previously declared to the evil māra on the banks of the Nairāñjanā River: "Since I have no attendant of great learning, I shall not pass fully into nirvāṇa"? It was because at that time I was contemplating turning the wheel of Dharma for the group of five monks in

Vārāṇasī. It was for those five monks, namely Yaśa, Pūrṇa, Vimāla, Gavāṃpati, and Subāhu. It was also for the fifty householders led by Drakpo. It was also for the countless gods and humans led by the king of Madhyadeśa named Rūpasāra. It was also for Uruvelā Kāśyapa together with his retinue of five hundred monks, and for Nadī Kāśyapa and Gayā Kāśyapa together with their five hundred kinsmen and attendants. And it was in order to turn the wheel of the sublime Dharma for Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, and the twelve hundred and fifty monks and others — for all of these that I declared to the evil māra: "I shall not pass into nirvāṇa."

Son of good family, there is such a thing as nirvāṇa, but it is not great nirvāṇa. How is it that nirvāṇa is not great nirvāṇa? When one has severed the afflictions without having seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha, that is called nirvāṇa — but it is not great nirvāṇa. Because one has not seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha, permanence is absent and selflessness remains, though there is bliss and utter purity. Therefore, although the afflictions have been severed, it is not to be called great nirvāṇa. Whoever has seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha and has severed the afflictions — that is called great nirvāṇa. Because one has seen the intrinsic nature of a buddha, there is permanence, self, bliss, and utter purity. Therefore such a severing of the afflictions is called the great and complete nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, what is called the "sorrow" in nirvāṇa refers to what weaves and entangles. The meaning of not being woven and entangled is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to what covers and obscures. The meaning of not being covered and obscured is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to going and coming. The meaning of not going and not coming is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to grasping and taking up. The meaning of not grasping is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to uncertainty and indeterminacy. Certainly being free of all uncertainty is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to the new and the old. The meaning of there being no new and old is nirvāṇa. Again, "passing" refers to obscuration. The meaning of being free of obscuration is nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, the disciples of the school called Ūrukakabila say that "passing" means characteristic marks, and that the meaning of being without characteristic marks is nirvāṇa. Son of good family, "passing" refers to existence and being. The meaning of there being no such existence is nirvāṇa.

"Passing" refers to accumulation, and the meaning of there being no accumulation is nirvāṇa. "Passing" refers to suffering, and the meaning of there being no suffering is nirvāṇa. Son of good family, cutting off afflictions is not called nirvāṇa; rather, not giving rise to afflictions at all is what is called nirvāṇa. Son of good family, the Buddha, the Blessed One, does not give rise to afflictions, and therefore is called nirvāṇa.

One who possesses wisdom and is unobstructed with respect to all phenomena is called a Tathāgata. The Tathāgata is not a child of low birth, nor a śrāvaka, nor a pratyekabuddha, nor even a bodhisattva — the Tathāgata is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The wisdom of the Tathāgata's body, speech, and mind is unobstructed throughout all world-systems, immeasurable, innumerable, and boundless in extent, and therefore is called space. The Tathāgata abides permanently, neither changing nor shifting, and therefore is called the characteristic mark of what is true and real. It is for this reason that the Tathāgata does not ultimately pass into complete nirvāṇa. This is what is meant by possessing the seven qualities of a bodhisattva, a great being, who applies himself diligently to this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, you ask how it is that a bodhisattva, a great being, who has applied himself diligently to this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa comes to possess eight qualities. Son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who applies himself diligently to the Great Nirvāṇa does so by: cutting off five things; abandoning five things; cultivating six things; thoroughly meditating on five things; carefully guarding one thing; drawing near to four things; having faith in and inclining toward one true thing; and attaining thorough liberation of mind and thorough liberation through wisdom.

Son of good family, how does a bodhisattva cut off five things? They are the five aggregates: form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. What is meant by "aggregate"? The aggregates are that which perpetuates sentient beings' uninterrupted flow in cyclic existence, that from which one never separates — the heavy burden; they are that which disperses and accumulates, belonging to the three times, and yet however one examines them, they cannot be found as an object. These are called aggregates.

A bodhisattva, a great being, may perceive the aggregate of form, yet does not regard it as a characteristic mark. Why is that? Because even when the intrinsic nature of the ten aspects of form is examined, it cannot be found as an object. It is spoken of as "aggregate" only for the sake of the world. There

are one hundred and eight feelings, and though one perceives the aggregate of feelings, from the very beginning there is no characteristic mark of feeling. Why is that? Because, although there are one hundred and eight feelings, they have no true or definitive meaning, and therefore a bodhisattva does not perceive a real aggregate of feeling. In the same way, perception, formations, and consciousness are also like this. A bodhisattva, a great being, thoroughly understands that the five aggregates are the root from which afflictions arise, and therefore cuts them off through skillful means.

Son of good family, how does a bodhisattva abandon five things? They are the five kinds of wrong view. What are the five? The view of the perishable collection (*ātmagrāha*, the view that the aggregates constitute a self), extreme views, wrong views, the conceit of moral discipline and conduct, and the conceit of views. Through these five kinds of wrong view as conditions, sixty-two views arise, and through those views as conditions one circles in cyclic existence without interruption.

Therefore the bodhisattva is heedful and does not draw near to them.

Now, how is a bodhisattva to be endowed with six things? They are the six recollections (*anusmṛti*) held close. What are the six? Recollection of the Buddha, recollection of the Dharma, recollection of the Saṅgha, recollection of the gods, recollection of generosity, and recollection of moral discipline. These constitute the bodhisattva's endowment with six things.

How does a bodhisattva thoroughly cultivate five things? They are the five kinds of meditative absorption (*samādhi*). What are the five? The meditative absorption of knowing, the meditative absorption of peace, the meditative absorption of touching bodily and mental rapture, the meditative absorption without rapture, and the meditative absorption of courageous advance. When these five kinds of meditative absorption are cultivated, one draws near to the great *nirvāṇa*. Therefore a bodhisattva thoroughly cultivates them with a mind of diligent effort.

How does a bodhisattva guard one thing? It is the awakening mind. The bodhisattva, the great being, constantly guards the awakening mind with diligent effort. Just as a worldly person guards an only child, just as one guards the single eye that remains, just as a caravan leader guards those who travel through the great wilderness, so too does a bodhisattva guard the awakening mind. By guarding the awakening mind in this way, one attains unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. And having attained unsurpassed, perfect,

and complete awakening, one is endowed with permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity. That itself is the unsurpassed great nirvāṇa. Therefore the bodhisattva thoroughly guards this one thing.

How does a bodhisattva draw near to four things? They are the four immeasurable minds. What are the four? Great loving-kindness, great compassion, great joy, and great equanimity. Through these four minds one gives rise to the awakening mind for as many sentient beings as there are, boundless and without limit. Therefore the bodhisattva draws near to them with single-pointed mind.

What is the one right thing in which a bodhisattva places faith and toward which the bodhisattva inclines? Here the bodhisattva understands that all sentient beings travel by a single path. That single path is none other than the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna). Buddhas and bodhisattvas have divided it into three aspects for the sake of sentient beings. Therefore the bodhisattva places faith, inclines toward it, and does not act contrary to it.

What is meant by the bodhisattva's mind being supremely liberated? Because the minds of attachment, aversion, and delusion have completely ceased, it is called the supreme liberation of the bodhisattva's mind.

What then is the supreme liberation of the bodhisattva's wisdom? Because the bodhisattva, the great being, is unobstructed with respect to all phenomena, it is called the supreme liberation of the bodhisattva's wisdom. Through the condition of this liberation of wisdom, what was not previously heard comes to be heard, what was not previously seen comes to be seen, and what was not previously reached comes to be reached.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Sarvadarśī (Glorious King of Lofty Radiance) addressed the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, what the Blessed One has taught — calling it 'the supremely liberated mind' — that is not actually the case. Why so? Because from the very beginning the mind has never been bound. How is that? The intrinsic nature of mind is not one of attachment, aversion, or..."

delusion that the mind could be bound by affliction. If from the very beginning the mind has never been bound, why then did the Blessed One speak of 'the supremely liberated mind'?

"Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of mind is not bound by the affliction of attachment, then by what cause and by what condition could it become

bound? Consider the analogy of a horn: since from the very beginning it has not had the characteristic of milk, no matter how much effort one applies, milk cannot possibly come from it. The breast of a nursing mother is not like that — even with little effort, milk flows abundantly. In the same way, if from the very beginning the mind has no attachment, how could attachment exist in it now? And if attachment did not exist from the very beginning but arose only later, then buddhas and bodhisattvas, who likewise never had the characteristic of attachment from the very beginning, should also come to have it later. But that is untenable.

"Blessed One, consider another analogy: a barren woman has not had the characteristic of giving birth from the very beginning. No matter how much effort she makes, no matter how many causes and conditions she accumulates, it is impossible that she could give birth to a child. In the same way, if the mind has not had the characteristic of attachment from the very beginning, then even when it encounters many conditions, it is impossible for attachment to arise.

"Blessed One, just as green wet wood, no matter how it is rubbed, will not produce fire, so too the mind is like that: if no matter how it is rubbed attachment does not arise in it, how could the affliction of attachment bind the mind?

"Blessed One, just as sand, no matter how it is pressed, will yield no oil, so too the mind is like that: no matter how it is pressed, attachment does not arise in it. Therefore, since attachment and mind are distinct from each other, even if an affliction is present, how could it adhere to the mind?

"Blessed One, just as if one were to drive a peg into empty space there would be no surface for it to cling to, in the same way the implanting of attachment in the mind is like that: through causes and conditions of every kind, attachment cannot bind the mind.

"Blessed One, if one says the mind is 'liberated' because it is without attachment, why then do buddhas and bodhisattvas not remove thorns from the sky? Blessed One, the past mind is not called 'liberated,' and the future mind is likewise not liberated. The present mind does not co-arise with awakening. So in which moment's mind does one speak of obtaining liberation?

"Blessed One, just as a lamp that has already gone out cannot dispel darkness, and a lamp yet to be lit also cannot dispel darkness, and the present lamp too

cannot dispel darkness — why so? Because light and darkness do not exist at the same time. In the same way, if the mind is also like that, why did the Blessed One speak of the mind as liberated?

"Blessed One, attachment does exist. If it did not exist, it would make no sense for attachment to arise upon seeing a woman. But if it does arise through the condition of seeing a woman, then one must recognize that attachment genuinely exists. Since attachment does exist, one falls into the stream of the three lower destinies.

"Blessed One, consider that some people, upon seeing even a painted image of a woman, give rise to attachment, and having given rise to attachment they incur various moral faults. If attachment did not exist from the very beginning, why should the mere sight of a painting give rise to attachment? And if the mind is without attachment, why did the Tathāgata teach that the bodhisattva attains liberation of mind? If the mind has no attachment, then why does attachment arise upon seeing a sign but not arise when no sign is seen?

"I see at present the karmic maturation of evil deeds ripening, and from this I affirm that attachment exists; and that aversion and delusion exist is likewise the same. Blessed One, consider that sentient beings possess a body and yet no self truly exists, yet foolish and ignoble people perceive a self. Now, even though the perception of clinging to a self exists, if one does not fall into the three lower destinies on account of it, then why should one who has attachment generate the perception of a woman upon encountering a woman's sign, and thereby fall into the three lower destinies?

"Blessed One, consider that fire arises through friction. If the intrinsic nature of fire does not exist within any of its causes, then from what cause and condition did it arise? Blessed One, attachment is just like that. Attachment does not exist within form; it does not exist within smell, taste, or tangible objects; nor does it exist within mental phenomena. If that is so, then why does attachment arise from form, smell, taste, tangible objects, and mental phenomena? If attachment does not exist within the many causes, then why does attachment arise in sentient beings alone, while it does not arise in buddhas and bodhisattvas?

"Blessed One, mind too is indeterminate. If mind were something determinate, there would be no attachment, aversion, or delusion. But if it is indeterminate, then the Tathāgata has taught that one can attain liberation of mind. Attachment is likewise indeterminate. But if it is indeterminate, why should it

cause rebirth in the three lower destinies? Therefore both attachment and its object are indeterminate. Why is that? Because when one focuses on a single form, some develop attachment, some develop aversion, and some develop delusion. Therefore both attachment and its object are indeterminate.

"If both are indeterminate, then why did the Tathāgata teach that if a bodhisattva applies himself to great nirvāṇa, the mind will attain liberation?"

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Samantaprabhāsaśrīrāja:

"Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, the mind is not bound by the total affliction of attachment; nor is it unbound; nor is it liberated; nor is it unliberated; it is not existent; it is not nonexistent; it is not present; it is not past; it is not future. Why is that? Son of good family, because all phenomena are without intrinsic nature.

"Son of good family, certain non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say this: 'From the assembly of causes and conditions a result arises.' If the conditions had from the very beginning no intrinsic nature of arising, yet a result were still to arise from them, then space, which has never arisen, should likewise be capable of producing a result. But space does not arise because it is not a cause. It is because the conditions contain from the very beginning the intrinsic nature of the result that a result arises from their assembly.

"How is that? Consider this example. When Devadatta builds a wall, he employs clay and earth; he does not employ paint. When he paints a picture, he employs paint; he does not employ grass and wood. When he weaves cloth, he employs thread; he does not employ clay and wood. When he constructs a house, he employs clay and wood; he does not employ thread. From each of these assembled materials a particular result arises — and this shows that the intrinsic nature of each result is certainly already present within its cause. Since a result arises, the intrinsic nature is without doubt present within the cause.

"If intrinsic nature did not exist, it would follow that from any one thing all things whatsoever could arise and come forth. Moreover, since in such assemblies it is possible to add more and possible to remove some, there is without doubt a result present from the very beginning within those causes. If there were no result, then no one would assemble or separate them, and nothing would come forth."

Space, by contrast, neither assembles nor separates, and therefore all things are able to arise and come forth from it. Thus it is because a cause exists that the seed of the nyagrodha tree resides within the nyagrodha tree, that the essence of butter is present within milk, that cloth comes forth from thread, and that clay is present within a lump of earth. Noble son, all the benighted Vaiśeṣikas, blinded by ignorance, explain the matter in this way: "Attachment means fixation; the mind is of the nature of desire," they say.

They also say this: in the mind of a benighted Vaiśeṣika there is both a nature of attachment and a nature of liberation. When it meets with the condition of attachment, a mind of attachment arises; when it meets with the condition of liberation, a mind of liberation arises. So they say, but this is not the correct meaning.

Furthermore, some benighted Vaiśeṣikas say: there is no result within any cause at all. A cause has two aspects: subtle and gross. The subtle is permanent; the gross is impermanent. From the subtle cause comes the gross cause, and from that gross cause comes the result. Because the gross is impermanent, the result too is impermanent — so they explain.

Noble son, still other benighted Vaiśeṣikas say: the mind has no cause, and attachment too has no cause; it is through time that a mind of attachment arises. These and others like them do not know the causes and conditions of the mind, and so they circle through the six classes of beings, fully taking on birth and death again and again.

Noble son, consider the example of a dog tethered on a leash to a pillar: it circles the pillar endlessly and cannot break free. In just the same way, all those benighted Vaiśeṣikas and all common individuals are like that dog — bound to the pillar of saṃsāra by the leash of ignorance, they circle through the twenty-five existences and cannot break free.

Noble son, consider further: just as someone who has fallen into a pit of filth climbs out and then goes back in again; just as a sick person, having recovered, returns to the very causes of illness; just as someone who has gone to a remote wilderness turns back from leaving saṃsāra; just as one who has been washed clean smears himself again with mud and excrement — all the benighted Vaiśeṣikas are likewise. They are liberated from the sense base of nothingness, yet because they are not liberated from the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, they return once again to the three lower destinies.

Why is this so? All the benighted Vaiśeṣikas attend only to results and give no thought to dependent origination. Just as a dog bites the stone rather than the one who threw it, so too all those benighted common individuals attend only to results and give no thought to causes and conditions. Because they give it no thought, they return from the state of non-perception and fall once more into the three lower destinies.

Noble son, buddhas and bodhisattvas do not teach in a one-sided, decisive way — asserting definitively that the result is present within the cause, or that it is not present, or that it is both present and not present, or that it is neither present nor absent. Whoever says, "The result is from the beginning definitively present within the cause," or "It is definitively absent," or "It is both present and absent," or "It is definitively neither present nor absent" — know that such a person is an ally of Māra, belongs to the faction of Māra, and is one in whom craving still exists. Such a being, existing in that state, cannot sever the bonds of saṃsāra, for they do not know the defining mark of the mind and the defining mark of attachment.

Noble son, buddhas and bodhisattvas teach the path of the Middle Way. Why? Because all phenomena are not existent —

— nor are they non-existent, yet neither is determinately the case. How so? Through the eye, form, appearance, mind, and the condition of mentation, consciousness arises. Yet that consciousness does not definitively reside in the eye, nor does it reside within form, appearance, mind, or mentation, nor does it reside in between. It is not existent, and it is not non-existent. Because it arises from dependent origination, it is said to be existent. Because it has no intrinsic nature, it is said to be non-existent. Therefore the Tathāgata teaches that all phenomena are neither existent nor non-existent.

Noble son, buddhas and bodhisattvas will never declare that the mind definitively possesses a pure intrinsic nature, nor that the mind definitively lacks a pure intrinsic nature — because neither a pure mind nor an impure mind has fixed abiding. Because attachment arises from conditions, it is not non-existent. Because attachment has no intrinsic nature from the very beginning, it is not said to be existent.

Noble son, because of dependent origination, the mind of attachment arises, and because of dependent origination, the mind is liberated. Noble son, dependent origination has two aspects: that which follows the course of saṃsāra, and that which follows the course of nirvāṇa.

Noble son, because of dependent origination, the mind arises together with attachment — and there is also the cessation of that mind together with attachment. There is also the mind arising together with attachment without cessation together with attachment. There is also the cessation of attachment without the mind arising together with attachment. And there is also neither arising together with attachment nor cessation together with attachment.

How then does the mind arise together with attachment and also cease together with attachment? Noble son, if a foolish, undisciplined person applies effort to the mind of attachment without having cut off the mind of attachment, that is called the mind arising together with attachment and ceasing together with attachment. All sentient beings, having not cut off the mind of attachment, have the mind arising together with attachment, and the mind ceasing together with attachment. As an analogy, all sentient beings of the desire realm have the fortune of the first dhyāna. Whether they have cultivated it or not, they always possess it, and when they encounter the proper condition, they will attain it. The condition referred to here is the aeon of fire. In the same way, all foolish and undisciplined persons — whether they have cultivated it or not — have the mind arising together with attachment and ceasing together with attachment. Why? Because attachment has not been cut off.

How then does the mind arise together with attachment without ceasing together with attachment? The close-dwelling śrāvakas have the mind of attachment arise through cause and condition. Because they fear the mind of attachment, they cultivate the contemplation of the skeleton. That is called the mind arising together with attachment without ceasing together with attachment. Moreover, there is yet another case of the mind arising together with attachment without ceasing together with attachment. As an analogy, śrāvakas who have not yet attained the four fruits have the mind of attachment arise through cause and condition. When they attain the four fruits, the mind of attachment ceases. That is called the mind arising together with attachment without ceasing together with attachment. When a bodhisattva, a great being, attains the immovable ground, the mind arises together with attachment but does not cease together with attachment.

Now, how is it that the mind does not arise together with attachment and yet ceases together with attachment? If a bodhisattva, a great being, has cut off the mind of attachment, yet for the sake of sentient beings still displays the appearance of having attachment — and by so displaying it, immeasurable

and boundless sentient beings are stirred to strive after wholesome Dharmas and bring them to complete fulfillment — that is called the mind not arising together with attachment yet ceasing together with attachment.

Now, how is it that the mind does not arise together with attachment and does not cease together with attachment? Apart from arhats, pratyekabuddhas, Tathāgatas, and bodhisattvas who have attained the immovable ground, all other bodhisattvas do not have the mind arise together with attachment, yet neither does the mind cease together with attachment.

Therefore, whether the intrinsic nature of mind is utterly pure or not utterly pure cannot be definitively settled for buddhas and bodhisattvas alike. O son of good family, mind is not connected with the thorough affliction of attachment; it is not connected with aversion, nor with delusion.

O son of good family, consider the following: the sun and moon are obscured by mist, dust, clouds, fog, the eclipse-demon (Rāhu), and so forth, and on account of this sentient beings cannot see them. Although they cannot be seen in that way, the intrinsic nature of the sun and moon is not connected with those five obscurations. Mind is similar: because, on account of certain causes and conditions, the thorough affliction of attachment arises, it is said that the mind of a sentient being is connected with attachment — yet the intrinsic nature of mind is not truly connected with it. That mind which is a mind of attachment has the intrinsic nature of attachment. That which is without attachment has the intrinsic nature of non-attachment. A mind without attachment does not become a mind with attachment, and a mind thoroughly afflicted by attachment does not become a mind without attachment. O son of good family, therefore the thorough affliction of attachment cannot penetrate or invade mind. Since buddhas and bodhisattvas have utterly destroyed the thorough affliction of attachment, it is said that they attain the liberation of mind. As for all ordinary, inferior sentient beings, through causes and conditions the thorough affliction of attachment arises, and through causes and conditions the mind becomes liberated.

O son of good family, consider this example: at a place on a steep rocky mountain, neither humans nor monkeys can go. At certain places, monkeys can go but humans cannot. At yet other places, both monkeys and humans can go.

O son of good family, at a place accessible to both humans and monkeys, hunters coat a flat board with pitch and catch monkeys in this way. The

monkey, curious and not cautious, reaches out its hand and tastes the pitch. The hand touches it and becomes stuck. Wanting to free the hand, it kicks with its foot, and the foot too becomes stuck. Wanting to free the foot, it grabs with its teeth, and the mouth too becomes stuck. In this way all five limbs are trapped. The hunters then place it on a carrying pole, haul it away, and bring it home.

Likewise, the steep rocky mountain is an analogy for buddhas and bodhisattvas attaining the true path. The monkey is an analogy for foolish, inferior ordinary persons. The hunter is an analogy for the wicked māra (Māra). The pitch is an analogy for the thorough affliction of attachment. The fact that neither human nor monkey can escape from that place is an analogy for inferior ordinary persons and wicked Māra together having no escape. The monkey escaping while the human does not is an analogy for those tīrthikas (non-Buddhists) endowed with wisdom who cannot be bound even by the five objects of desire associated with wicked Māra and the like.

The fact that both the human and the monkey escape is an analogy for inferior ordinary persons and wicked Māra dwelling perpetually in cyclic existence and being unable to engage in earnest practice. The fact that inferior ordinary persons, being bound by the five objects of desire, are easily carried off by wicked Māra is an analogy for the hunter catching the monkey, loading it on his back, and returning home.

Noble son, consider this example: a king dwelling in his own realm finds both body and mind at ease. But if he were to go into another's territory, many sufferings would arise. In the same way, all sentient beings are like this: if they remain in their own domain, they are perfectly at ease; but if they dwell in another's domain, they will encounter wicked Māra and experience many sufferings. What is called "one's own domain" is the four foundations of mindfulness. What is called "another's domain" is the five objects of desire.

Now, in what way does one come to belong to the camp of Māra? Some sentient beings regard the impermanent as permanent, and the permanent as impermanent. They regard what is suffering as pleasurable, and what is pleasurable as suffering. They regard what is thoroughly pure as impure, and what is impure as thoroughly pure. They regard what is without self as having a self, and what has a self as being without self. They regard what is not true liberation as liberation, and what is true liberation as not liberation. They regard what is not a vehicle as being a vehicle, and what is a vehicle as not

being a vehicle. Those who hold such views are said to be bound by Māra. To be bound by Māra is to have an untrained mind.

Furthermore, noble son, whoever regards all phenomena as truly existent and holds their individual defining characteristics to be fixed — when such a person sees form, they grasp at the defining characteristic of form; and so on up through consciousness, grasping at the defining characteristic of consciousness. They see a man and grasp at the defining characteristic of a man. They see a woman and grasp at the defining characteristic of a woman. They see the sun and grasp at the defining characteristic of the sun. They see the moon and grasp at the defining characteristic of the moon. They see a year and grasp at the defining characteristic of a year. They see the aggregates and grasp at the defining characteristics of the aggregates. They see the sense bases and grasp at the defining characteristics of the sense bases. They see the elements and grasp at the defining characteristics of the elements. Such a way of seeing is called being bound by Māra, and to be bound by Māra is to have an untrained mind.

Furthermore, noble son, whoever regards the self as form, regards the self as containing form and form as contained within the self, and regards form as belonging to the self — and continuing in this way through to consciousness, regards the self as consciousness, regards consciousness as containing the self and the self as containing consciousness, and regards consciousness as belonging to the self — such a view is being bound by Māra and belonging to the camp of Māra. Such a person is not my close attendant.

Noble son, those who are close attendants of my śrāvakas abandon the twelve branches of scripture and instead study the many texts and treatises of the tīrthikas. Without cultivating the peaceful path of renunciation, they pursue nothing but the worldly activities of householders. What does it mean to pursue the activities of a householder? It means keeping all manner of goods without discernment — that is, male servants and female servants, fields and houses, draft oxen and horses and carts, female buffaloes and donkeys, fowl and dogs and monkeys and pigs and sheep, and various grains and produce. They abandon their preceptors and the Saṅgha, rely on laypeople, act in contradiction to the noble Dharma, and say to those lay persons: "The Buddha permitted monks to keep all manner of goods without discernment." To say such a thing is to do nothing but the work of a householder.

Furthermore, some close attendants do not act for the sake of nirvāṇa, but rather —

for the sake of gain and renown, they may listen to the twelve branches of scripture, yet they treat the Saṅgha's common wealth, the Saṅgha's rosaries, and its requisites and food as though these were their own. They are envious and miserly toward others who receive gain and renown. They ingratiate themselves with kings and princes, making prophecies for them, reading auspicious and inauspicious omens, consulting the stars, performing divinations with owls, examining markings, playing dice, and engaging in amusements of every kind. They frequent nuns and the wives of others, support two novices, and constantly frequent the homes of butchers, hunters, and liquor-sellers, and the dwellings of low-caste outcastes. They engage in all manner of commercial deceit, process their own food by hand, travel as messengers to other regions, and go so far as to perform the work of message-carrying. Those who act in such ways should be understood to be the retinue of māra — they are not my true close attendants.

On account of those causes and those conditions, the mind arises together with attachment and ceases together with attachment; and from attachment onward, up to and including delusion, the mind arises together with these afflictions and ceases together with them.

O son of noble family, on account of those very causes and conditions, the intrinsic nature of mind is neither pure nor impure. That is why I have taught that the mind attains liberation.

One who does not take up or keep any goods without discernment, and who, for the sake of great nirvāṇa, upholds and preserves the twelve branches of scripture, reads them aloud, recites them, writes them down, expounds them, and explains them — such a person is truly my close attendant and will not fall within the domain of the sinful māra. Know that this is the cultivation of the thirty-seven factors of awakening (bodhipākṣikadharma).

One who cultivates in this way does not arise together with attachment, and does not cease together with attachment. Such a person should be understood to be a bodhisattva possessed of eight qualities by virtue of diligently practicing this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa of the complete liberation of bodhisattvas.

Furthermore, O son of noble family, in what way does a great bodhisattva who diligently practices this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa come to be possessed

of nine qualities? O son of noble family, a great bodhisattva who diligently practices this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa need only generate five things at the outset, and all the rest will be accomplished. What are those five? They are as follows: faith, mental solitude, moral discipline, reliance on a spiritual friend, and extensive learning.

And what, in this context, is faith? A great bodhisattva trusts in the Three Jewels, trusts in the existence of the result of generosity, trusts in both kinds of solitude, and trusts that apart from the path of the single vehicle there is no other path — that buddhas and bodhisattvas have divided it into three aspects for the sake of enabling sentient beings to swiftly attain liberation. One also trusts in ultimate truth and trusts in skillful means. This is what is called faith. Faith of this kind cannot be destroyed by any ascetic or brahmin, any god, māra, Brahmā, or any sentient being whatsoever. Through the condition of that faith, one attains the noble nature. Whether one's giving is much or little, all of it becomes proximate to great nirvāṇa, and one does not fall back into saṃsāra. Likewise, moral discipline, extensive learning, and wisdom are similar in this regard. This is what is called faith.

Even though one possesses such faith, not perceiving things in the manner described is what is called a bodhisattva possessing the substance of cultivating the great nirvāṇa of bodhisattvas.

Now, what is meant by mental solitude? The bodhisattva, the great being, establishes a mind of straightforwardness toward all sentient beings. It is true that all sentient beings, when they encounter the right causes and conditions, give rise to deceit and cunning; but the bodhisattva is not like that. Why? Because he is supremely skilled in understanding that all phenomena arise through dependent origination.

Even though the bodhisattva, the great being, sees all the faults and defects in sentient beings, he does not speak of them. Why? Because he fears that afflictions may arise; and if afflictions do arise, one will fall into the lower realms. If the bodhisattva sees even a small virtue in sentient beings, he praises and extols it. What is that virtue? It is the very intrinsic nature of a buddha. By praising the intrinsic nature of a buddha, awakening mind toward unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening will arise in all sentient beings.

Thereupon, the bodhisattva, the great being, Samantaprabha Uttamatejaśrīrāja addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One,

as the Blessed One has said, by the bodhisattva, the great being, praising the intrinsic nature of a buddha, as many sentient beings as there are will generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening — I submit that the meaning intended cannot be quite as stated. Why? When the Tathāgata first opened the sūtra teachings of great nirvāṇa, he taught three kinds of sentient beings. What are they? There is the patient who swiftly recovers when he meets a skilled physician, good medicine, and a nursing attendant; the patient who, if those are absent, will never recover, and will also not recover whether he meets them or not; and the patient who will recover whether he meets them or not. These are the three kinds the Teacher taught. In the same way, if all sentient beings meet a spiritual friend and hear the sublime Dharma from a buddha or a bodhisattva, they will generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Those who will not generate it if they do not meet such a friend are the following: stream-enterers (srotāpannas), once-returners (sakṛdāgāmins), non-returners (anāgāmins), arhats, and pratyekabuddhas. Those who meet a spiritual friend and hear the sublime Dharma from a buddha or a bodhisattva, yet are still unable to generate awakening mind, and likewise are unable to generate it even without meeting such a friend, are those with wrong craving. And those who generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening whether they meet such a friend or not — these, the Teacher declared, are bodhisattvas. Since there are those who generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening whether they meet such conditions or not, I respectfully submit that the statement made by the Blessed One — that by the Tathāgata's praising the intrinsic nature of a buddha, sentient beings generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening; and that whether they meet a spiritual friend or not, and whether they hear the Dharma from a buddha or a bodhisattva or not, they will not generate the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening — that statement also seems not to be quite as intended. Why? Because all of them too are destined to attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening."

Those with wrong craving, too — whether they hear of the intrinsic nature of a buddha or not — all will attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Blessed One, in the same way that you have stated that those called "persons with wrong craving" have cut off the root of virtue — that statement also seems not to be quite as intended. Why? Because the intrinsic nature of a buddha has not been cut off. Since the intrinsic nature of a buddha

is a phenomenon that cannot be cut, why then did the Blessed One declare that the root of virtue has been cut off?

Just as previously the Blessed One, in teaching the twelve branches of scripture, declared that virtue is of two kinds — permanent and impermanent — permanent virtue cannot be cut, and impermanent virtue can be cut. If, because impermanent virtue can be cut, sentient beings fall into hell, why then is permanent virtue, which cannot be cut, not also reversed? If, because the intrinsic nature of a buddha cannot be cut, one is not a person with wrong craving — then why did the Tathāgata speak of persons with wrong craving?

Blessed One, if the awakening mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening arises through the condition of the intrinsic nature of a buddha, then why did the Tathāgata teach sentient beings the twelve branches of scripture at length?

Blessed One, consider this analogy: the four great rivers all arise from the lake called Anavatapta (the Unheated Lake). There is no situation in which a human being, a god, or a fully awakened buddha could cause those great rivers not to flow into the ocean and instead to flow back to their place of origin. The awakening mind is similar. Because the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present, whether one hears the teaching or not, whether one keeps moral discipline or not, whether one practises generosity or not, whether one engages in conduct or not, whether gnosis is present or not — all will attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Blessed One, consider also this analogy: from the mountain called Udayana, the sun rises and travels to its midpoint in the sky. There is no situation in which that sun would think, "I will not go to the west; I will turn back and go east again." The intrinsic nature of a buddha is similar. Even without hearing, without keeping moral discipline, without practising generosity, without engaging in conduct, without gnosis — there is no situation in which unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening would not be attained.

Blessed One, in the same way that the fully awakened Blessed One has stated that the intrinsic nature of cause and result is neither existent nor non-existent — that statement too seems not to be quite as intended. Why? Just as, if the intrinsic nature of yoghurt were not present within milk, yoghurt too would not be present; and if the intrinsic nature of a nyagrodha tree's (the banyan's) growth to five fathoms in height were not present within its seed, it would not grow into a tree five fathoms tall — in the same way, if the seed of the tree of

unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening were not present within the intrinsic nature of a buddha, how could the tree of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening ever grow? Therefore, how can the statement that cause and result are neither existent nor non-existent be taken as meaningful?

Then the Blessed One declared, "Excellent! Excellent!" and continued to teach:

Son of good family, in the world there are two kinds of people who are as extremely rare as the udumbara flower. Who are they? One who does not commit non-virtuous acts, and one who, having committed a blameworthy wrong, feels remorse — such people are extremely rare.

There are also two kinds of people: those who are ungrateful, and those who are grateful.

There are also two kinds of people: those who listen to Dharma they have not heard before, and those who do not forget what they have already heard.

There are also two kinds of people: those who are innovators and

those who preserve the old ways. There are also two kinds of people: those who delight in hearing the Dharma, and those who delight in teaching the Dharma. There are also two kinds of people: those who are skilled in questioning, and those who are skilled in answering. You are skilled in questioning, and the Tathāgata is skilled in answering. Son of good family, through the condition of skilled questioning, the unsurpassed wheel of Dharma is turned — and thereby the trunk of the twelve links of dependent origination is dried up, beings are freed from the vast and boundless river of cyclic existence, the armies of Māra, the king of evil, are overcome, and the victory banner raised by the evil one is brought low.

Son of good family, earlier I described three kinds of sick people. You asked what it means that a patient will recover whether or not he encounters a skilled physician, good medicine, and a nurse. This is to be understood as follows: what applies regardless of whether those conditions are present refers to a person whose lifespan has a definite measure. What does this mean? It means a person who, throughout innumerable lifetimes, has practiced the three kinds of virtue — superior, middling, and lesser. Because they have practiced these three kinds of virtue, their lifespan has become definite. Just as the people of the northern continent Uttarakuru, whose lifespan is a full thousand years, if they fall ill, will recover whether or not they encounter a skilled physician, good medicine, nurses, and so forth — this is because they

have attained a definite lifespan.

Son of good family, as for the meaning of my earlier statement that a sick person who encounters a skilled physician, good medicine, and a nurse will recover, but if they do not encounter them will not recover — this applies to a person whose lifespan is not yet fixed. Though their life is not yet exhausted, they may suddenly meet death through any one of nine causes and conditions. What are these nine? Eating food one knows to be disagreeable; eating in excess; eating again before the previous meal has been digested; not evacuating the bowels and bladder at the proper time; not heeding the physician's instructions when ill; not following the nurse's directions; taking an emetic and then straining to suppress the vomiting; being struck in the night by a fierce possessing spirit; and engaging in sexual misconduct with carelessness. For someone who falls ill through such conditions, it is said that if they encounter a physician and medicine they will recover, and if they do not encounter them they will not.

Son of good family, as for the meaning of my earlier statement that a person will not recover whether they encounter medicine and the rest or not — this applies to a person whose life is exhausted. If a person's life is spent, they will not recover whether they encounter a physician and the rest or not. Why? Because their life is exhausted. For this reason I said that such a sick person will not recover whether or not they encounter medicine, a physician, and the rest.

Sentient beings are similar to this. One who has generated the awakening mind will meet a spiritual friend — a buddha or bodhisattvas — and will question and listen to this profound Dharma; yet even without meeting such a one, all will be accomplished. Why? Because the awakening mind has been generated — just as the people of Uttarakuru have a definite lifespan.

As I have taught, from the level of a stream-enterer all the way to that of a pratyekabuddha: if one hears profound Dharma from a spiritual friend — a buddha or bodhisattvas — the awakening mind oriented toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening will arise. But if one has not met buddhas and bodhisattvas and has not heard this profound Dharma, the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening will not arise.

Just as a sick person whose life will be cut short suddenly by a conjunction of nine causes and conditions will recover if they meet a physician, but will not recover if they do not — so too, I have said: if one meets buddhas and

bodhisattvas and hears the profound Dharma, the awakening mind will arise; but if one does not meet them, it will not arise.

Now, as I stated above, one might ask: what is the meaning of the statement that the awakening mind may or may not arise whether or not one meets a spiritual friend — a buddha or bodhisattvas — and hears the profound Dharma? Noble son, those who hold wrong craving (log sred can), even if they meet a spiritual friend, a buddha or bodhisattvas, and hear the profound Dharma — or even if they do not hear it — will not abandon the mind of wrong craving. Why? Because they have severed the wholesome Dharma. Those who hold wrong craving will not attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Why? Because if they were to generate the awakening mind, they would not be called holders of wrong craving.

Noble son, it has been said that through certain causes and conditions even a holder of wrong craving may attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — yet a holder of wrong craving will not truly attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. It is just like one whose life-force is exhausted: even if they meet medicine, a skilled physician, and a nursing attendant, they will not recover. Why? Because their life is spent.

Noble son, the word wrong refers to faith, and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has faith yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not faith, nor do sentient beings possess it; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to skillful means, and the word craving refers to their absence. Because one has skillful means yet lacks them, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not the cultivation of skillful means, nor do sentient beings possess this; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to diligence, and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has diligence yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not diligence, nor do sentient beings possess it; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to mindfulness, and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has mindfulness yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not mindfulness, nor do sentient beings possess it; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to meditative absorption (samādhi), and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has meditative absorption yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not meditative absorption, nor do sentient beings possess it; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to wisdom, and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has wisdom yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not wisdom, nor do sentient beings possess it; since they do not possess it in that way, how could it be severed?

The word wrong refers to impermanent virtue, and the word craving refers to its absence. Because one has impermanent virtue yet lacks it, one is called a holder of wrong craving. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is neither impermanent nor virtue nor non-virtue. Why? Because wholesome Dharma is obtained through skillful means, whereas the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not obtained through skillful means; therefore it is not virtue. And why is it not non-virtue? Because it is the fruit obtained from virtue.

The fruit of virtue is unsurpassable perfect awakening. Furthermore, what is called wholesome Dharma is obtained upon taking birth. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is not obtained upon taking birth; therefore it is not virtue. Because the wholesome Dharma obtained at birth is severed, one is called a holder of wrong craving.

Noble son, you have said: "If those with wrong craving possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, why are they not turned back from the misdeeds of the hells?" Noble son, whether or not those with wrong craving possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha — it is only through skillful means that it will first come to be seen. Because it is seen in that way, unsurpassable perfect awakening is attained.

If those with wrong craving do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, how could they be turned back from the misdeeds of the three lower destinies? Noble son, if those with wrong craving place their trust in the existence of the intrinsic nature of a buddha, they will not go to the three lower destinies — and know that they are no longer holders of wrong craving. It is precisely because they do not place their trust in the existence of the intrinsic nature of a buddha that they fall into the three lower destinies. Because they fall into the three lower destinies, they are called holders of wrong craving.

Noble son, to continue with what you said — that if milk lacks the intrinsic nature of yogurt, it would be unreasonable for yogurt to arise from it; and that if the seed of the nyagrodha tree lacks the intrinsic nature of a tree five fathoms tall, it would be unreasonable for a tree five fathoms tall to grow — such things are said only by the foolish. A wise and discerning person would never utter such words. Why? Because there is no intrinsic nature of that kind.

Noble son, if the intrinsic nature of yogurt were already present within milk, it would be reasonable that it should not depend on many causes and conditions. Noble son, if water and milk are mixed together and pressed, even after a month no yogurt will form. But if a single drop of the juice of the plant called śimbikā is added as a fermenting agent, yogurt will form at once. If the intrinsic nature of yogurt were present from the very beginning, why would it depend on so many causes and conditions?

In just the same way, the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings comes to be seen only through many causes and conditions, and through many causes and conditions it becomes unsurpassable perfect awakening. That which is attained in dependence on many causes and conditions has no intrinsic nature of its own. It is precisely because it has no intrinsic nature of its own that it becomes unsurpassable perfect awakening.

Therefore, son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, always praises the virtues of others and does not speak of their faults. This is called an upright mind.

Furthermore, son of good family, how does a bodhisattva have an upright mind? A bodhisattva, a great being, never commits a transgression. If a transgression does occur, that very moment he confesses and acknowledges it before an abbot or a teacher, concealing nothing. With a sense of moral shame and conscientious dread, he reproaches himself and vows not to do it again. He generates the perception that what is light is in fact heavy. If someone asks about it, he answers truthfully: "I have indeed transgressed." If asked whether that transgression is good or bad, he answers: "Bad." If asked whether it is virtuous or non-virtuous, he answers: "Non-virtuous." If asked whether that transgression bears the fruit of virtue or the fruit of non-virtue, he answers: "It is truly not the fruit of virtue." If asked who committed this transgression — was it committed by the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha? — he answers: "It was not committed by the Buddha, the Dharma, or the Saṅgha; I myself committed it, and moreover it was done through the accumulation of

afflictions." Because his mind is thus upright, he has confidence that the buddha-nature exists. Because he has confidence that the buddha-nature exists, he should not be called one of wrong craving. Because his mind is thus upright, he is called a companion of the Buddha. Even if sentient beings offer him robes, food, lodging, bedding, and medicines for illness, he should not think "this is too much" even if he receives ten million of any one of these things. This is called the upright mind of a bodhisattva.

How then does a bodhisattva uphold moral discipline? A bodhisattva, a great being, does not maintain the vow of moral discipline for the sake of being reborn as a god, nor for the sake of destruction — nor has he undertaken it all the way down to the vow of dogs, the vow of birds, the vow of cattle, or the vow of peacocks. He does not break moral discipline, he does not degrade moral discipline, he does not hold moral discipline to be advantageous in a calculating way, he does not practice a mixed moral discipline, and he does not practice the moral discipline of śrāvakas. Rather, he receives and holds the moral discipline of a bodhisattva, a great being, and the discipline of the Perfection of moral discipline. The fact that, even after full ordination, neither pride nor arrogance arises in him — this is called the bodhisattva's possession of the three components of the discipline of the vow of great parinirvāṇa.

How then does a bodhisattva attend upon a spiritual friend? A bodhisattva, a great being, always shows sentient beings the path of virtue and does not show them the path of non-virtue, teaching that the path of non-virtue does not bear the fruit of virtue. Son of good family, I am the true spiritual friend of all sentient beings, and I am able to cut away all the evil views of the brahmin Pūraṇa Kāśyapa. Son of good family, if there is a sentient being who pays respect and homage to me, then even if the causes and conditions for falling into hell exist in that sentient being, he will be reborn as a god. Just as those such as the caterpillar and the like, who by their very nature are destined to fall into hell — because they catch sight of me, the causes and conditions for falling into hell are purified, and they are reborn as gods of the form realm. Even if one were like Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana and their companions, one should not be called a true spiritual friend of sentient beings. Why is that? Because one produces the cause for wrong craving in the mind of sentient beings.

Son of good family, long ago when I was dwelling in the land of the yellow-robes, I had two attendants who served Śāriputra. One I set to contemplating a skeleton, and the other I set to contemplating the breath.

Yet even after many years had passed, neither of the two attained meditative absorption. Failing to attain it in this way, they gave rise to the wrong view that there was also no nirvāṇa, and also no undefiled phenomena. They reasoned: "If such things existed, we of all people would have attained them — for we hold and guard the scriptural transmission of the teaching most scrupulously."

When I saw that those two monks were generating minds of wrong view, I called out to Śāriputra and said these words: "You have not taught well. Why have you confused those two disciples and taught them the Dharma incorrectly? Your two disciples are of different kinds — one is a washerman and the other is a goldsmith. It is fitting to teach the goldsmith the contemplation of the breath, and it is fitting to teach the washerman the contemplation of the skeleton. Because you taught them incorrectly, wrong unwholesome thoughts arose in those two people." At that time I taught those two people exactly the right Dharma appropriate to each of them, and upon hearing it, both of them attained the fruit of arhatship.

Therefore I am a true spiritual friend of all sentient beings, whereas Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana and their companions are not. If there are sentient beings whose afflictions are extremely heavy, when they encounter me I cut through those afflictions by means of skillful means. Take my younger brother Nanda, for example, who was burdened with extremely heavy attachment — I severed it entirely through many varieties of supremely skillful means. Aṅgulimāla was burdened with extremely heavy aversion — by catching sight of me, his aversion was pacified. King Ajātaśatru was burdened with extremely heavy delusion — by catching sight of me, his deluded mind was removed. The householder Yikaskalpa had accumulated masses of afflictions over countless aeons — by catching sight of me, all of those were at once exhausted and stilled. Even if base and vicious people attend me and remain close to me, by the causes and conditions of that, all gods and humans come to honor and revere them. Śirikubata, whose wrong view was extremely virulent, caught sight of me and was freed from wrong view; and through the condition of seeing me, the causes for rebirth in hell were blocked and he was set instead on the causes for rebirth as a god. Just as someone known as a malicious breath-stealer was near to drawing his last breath at the moment of death, upon catching sight of me his life was lengthened once more. Take as another example Kauśika, whose mind had become confused and disturbed — through the condition of seeing me, his mind was restored to its former clarity. The

vicious Gautama's son Kreka habitually performed unwholesome deeds — by catching sight of me, he abandoned those deeds. Both the monk Candanadāsa and the monk Tṛṇaknot, even when their bodies and lives were nearly spent because of seeing me, did not break their vows of moral discipline.

Seeing it in this light, it is said that a monk who teaches half of the holy life like Ānanda becomes a spiritual friend. But I do not teach it that way. It is rather said that one who perfectly fulfills the holy life in its entirety becomes a spiritual friend. Therefore, a bodhisattva who meditates on the great nirvāṇa is said to attend a spiritual friend.

Now, in what sense is a bodhisattva said to be endowed with great learning? A bodhisattva, a great being, who for the sake of the great nirvāṇa writes out, reads aloud, recites, analyzes, and teaches the twelve branches of scriptural teaching is called a bodhisattva endowed with great learning. But setting aside the other eleven branches of scripture, one who holds, reads aloud,

recites, analyzes, or teaches it is also called a bodhisattva endowed with great learning. Setting aside the other twelve branches of scripture, one who holds, writes out, recites, reads aloud, analyzes, or teaches this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is also called a bodhisattva endowed with great learning. Setting aside even this sūtra, one who holds even a single four-line verse is also called a bodhisattva endowed with great learning. And setting aside even that verse, if one holds the meaning that the Tathāgata abides forever, that his nature is unchanging and unwavering, that bodhisattva too is called one endowed with great learning. Setting aside even that, if one knows that the Tathāgata never truly teaches the Dharma in a conventional sense, that too is called being endowed with great learning as a bodhisattva. Why is that? Because the Dharma has no intrinsic nature. Even though the Tathāgata teaches all phenomena, he forever says nothing whatsoever. That is what is meant by a bodhisattva being endowed with great learning through meditating on the great nirvāṇa.

Noble son, if any noble son or noble daughter who seeks the great nirvāṇa is endowed with these five qualities, they will do what is difficult to do, endure what is difficult to endure, and give up what is difficult to give up.

How is it that a bodhisattva does what is difficult to do? If someone hears it said that by eating a single sesame seed one will attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening (Skt. anuttarasamyaksambodhi), and trusting in those words, one steadfastly eats just one sesame seed throughout

immeasurable and boundless aeons, that is a bodhisattva doing what is difficult to do. If someone hears it said that by leaping into fire one will attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and throughout immeasurable aeons one enters a mass of fiercely blazing fire in the Avīci hell, that is called a bodhisattva doing what is difficult to do.

How is it that a bodhisattva endures what is difficult to endure? If someone hears it said that by experiencing suffering of the kind caused by being struck with fists, clubs, swords, and stones, one will thereby attain the great nirvāṇa, and throughout immeasurable and boundless aeons one undergoes all such experiences without regarding them as suffering, that is called a bodhisattva enduring what is difficult to endure.

How is it that a bodhisattva gives up what is difficult to give up? If someone hears it said that by giving to others one's lands, cities, wife, children, head, eyes, feet, and brain one will attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, and throughout immeasurable and boundless aeons one gives away one's lands, cities, wife, children, head, eyes, feet, brain, and all other possessions, that is called a bodhisattva giving up what is difficult to give up. Yet even while doing what is difficult to do, enduring what is difficult to endure, and giving up what is difficult to give up, the bodhisattva does not entertain the perception of thinking: "I have done this."

Noble son, consider, for example, parents who have a single beloved child, greatly cherishing it, nourishing and caring for it in timely fashion with fine clothing and delicious food, making sure it lacks for nothing. Even if that child should develop a mind of contempt toward its parents and abuse them with harsh words, the parents, because of their love, do not give rise to anger or displeasure, and do not think: "I gave this child clothing and food." A bodhisattva, a great being, is just like that: he regards all sentient beings as he would his only child. If the child falls ill, the parents too fall ill, and with medicine and physician they strive with all their effort to heal the sickness. Once the child is healed, they do not think: "I have cured my child's illness." A bodhisattva is just like that.

Seeing that sentient beings are tormented by the sickness of affliction, he teaches the Dharma with a mind of loving-kindness. Through hearing the Dharma, their afflictions are thoroughly severed. Yet having severed those afflictions, he does not think: "I have severed the afflictions of sentient beings." For if he were to think in that way, he would never attain

unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Thus he holds no thought such as: "I have taught Dharma to even a single sentient being and severed their afflictions." A bodhisattva, a great being, neither resents nor cherishes sentient beings. Why is that? Because he thoroughly cultivates meditative absorption in emptiness. A bodhisattva who has cultivated meditative absorption in emptiness — toward whom would he generate aversion, and toward whom would he generate affection? Noble son, consider this example: if a forest is burned by fire, cut down by people, or swept away by water, the trees of that forest do not resent anyone, nor do they generate delight in anyone. A bodhisattva, a great being, is just the same: he has neither resentment toward nor delight in any sentient being. Why is that? Because he cultivates meditative absorption in emptiness.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Vairocana (the Radiant, Sublime, Glorious King) addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, are all phenomena empty by their intrinsic nature, or do they become empty through the cultivation of emptiness? If they are empty by intrinsic nature, it would be unreasonable to say that one first sees emptiness through the cultivation of emptiness. Yet the Blessed One has declared that by cultivating emptiness one sees emptiness. On the other hand, if they are not empty by intrinsic nature, then no matter how much one cultivates emptiness, they would not become empty."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, all phenomena are empty by their intrinsic nature. Why is that? Because the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is not to be apprehended as an object. Noble son, the intrinsic nature of form is not to be apprehended as an object. What then is the intrinsic nature of form? What is called 'form' is not earth, water, fire, or wind, nor is it something other than earth, water, fire, and wind. It is not blue, yellow, red, or white, nor is it something other than blue, yellow, red, and white. It is neither existent nor nonexistent. Why then does one speak of form as having an intrinsic nature? Because the intrinsic nature is not apprehensible as an object, it is said to be empty. All phenomena are likewise. Because of the unbroken continuity of their similar defining marks, the childish, stupid, and foolish, seeing this, declare that the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is not empty and not at peace. A bodhisattva, a great being, because he is endowed with five qualities, sees the intrinsic nature of phenomena as primordially empty and at peace. Noble son, if any ascetic or brahmin sees the intrinsic nature of all phenomena as not empty, they are not true ascetics, not true brahmins; they will not attain

the Perfection of Wisdom, they will not pass fully into nirvāṇa, and they will not see buddhas and bodhisattvas face to face. Know them to be members of Māra's following. Noble son, all phenomena are empty by their intrinsic nature, and a bodhisattva who cultivates emptiness sees all phenomena as empty. Noble son, because all phenomena are impermanent by their intrinsic nature, they will be ceased by cessation. If they were not impermanent, they would not be ceased by cessation. Conditioned phenomena have the defining mark of arising, and therefore they will arise through arising; they have the defining mark of ceasing, and therefore they will be ceased by cessation. Because all phenomena have the defining mark of suffering, they are made to suffer by suffering."

Noble son, consider the following examples. Salt has the defining mark of saltiness, and therefore it makes other things salty. Sugar cane has the defining mark of sweetness, and therefore it makes other things sweet. Fermented drink has the defining mark of sourness, and therefore it makes other things sour. Pepper has the defining mark of heat, and therefore it makes other things hot. The fruit āmalaka has the defining mark of astringency, and therefore it makes other things astringent. The fruit āmra has the defining mark of bitterness, and therefore it makes other things bitter. Poison has the defining mark of causing death, and therefore it makes other things deadly. But the antidote elixir has the defining mark of preventing death, and therefore, even when mixed with other things, it can prevent death. A bodhisattva who cultivates emptiness is just like this: because of having cultivated emptiness, he sees all phenomena as tranquilly empty by their intrinsic nature.

Then the bodhisattva and great being, the majestic king Kun-du Nangwa Tobtsün, spoke to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if cultivating the meditative absorption of emptiness were such that it causes what is not empty by nature to become empty, then that meditative absorption would not be virtuous and not be excellent — its very nature would be perverted. If the meditative absorption of emptiness sees only emptiness, and if emptiness is a non-existent phenomenon, then what and how could anything at all be seen?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, if that meditative absorption of emptiness sees phenomena that are not empty, then since emptiness has not been thoroughly pacified, it is not a perversion. Just as salt causes what is not salty to become salty, that meditative absorption of emptiness likewise causes what is not empty to be seen as empty.

Noble son, attachment has existence as its defining mark, not emptiness. If attachment were empty, it would be unreasonable for sentient beings to fall into hell through the condition of desire. And if sentient beings do fall into hell, how could the intrinsic nature of attachment be empty?

Noble son, form has existence as its intrinsic nature. And what is this intrinsic nature? It is none other than inversion — mistaken perception. Through inversion, attachment arises in sentient beings. If the defining mark of form were not a mistaken inversion, how could attachment arise in sentient beings? Because attachment does arise in this way, the intrinsic nature of form is not non-existent. Therefore, cultivating the meditative absorption of emptiness is not a perversion.

Noble son, all vulgar and debased people, when they see a woman, generate the defining mark of womanhood. A bodhisattva is not like that. Even when seeing a woman, the defining mark of womanhood does not arise in him. Since that defining mark of arising does not arise, attachment does not arise. Because attachment does not arise, it is not a perversion. Yet because worldly people see a woman there, the bodhisattva too, following along with them, will describe her as a woman. If, however, upon seeing a man one were to say 'that is a woman,' that would be a perversion. Therefore, as I have explained, the Blessed One spoke these words:

O brahmin, if you call the day 'night,' that is a perversion. If you call the night 'day,' that too is a perversion. Take the day to have the defining mark of day, and do not call the night's defining mark a perversion.

Noble son, all bodhisattvas who dwell on the nine grounds see phenomena as having an intrinsic nature. Because they see in this way, they do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha. But if one sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha, why does one not see the intrinsic nature of all phenomena? It is because when one has cultivated the meditative absorption of emptiness, the intrinsic nature of phenomena is not seen. Because it is not seen in that way, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is seen. Buddhas and bodhisattvas have spoken of two modes: phenomena having intrinsic nature, and —"

phenomena having no intrinsic nature. For sentient beings, phenomena are said to have intrinsic nature; for noble ones (āryas), phenomena are said to have no intrinsic nature. Those who are not empty cultivate the meditative absorption of emptiness (samādhi) in order to see the empty nature of phenomena, and by doing so they come to see emptiness. And those who are

already without intrinsic nature also become empty through cultivating emptiness. Therefore, through cultivating emptiness, one sees emptiness.

Noble son, you may ask: if what is seen as empty is a phenomenon that does not exist, then how can anything be seen at all, and what is there to see? Noble son, it is exactly so: a bodhisattva, a great being, does not in truth see anything at all. Not seeing anything at all means there is nothing whatsoever. That nothing whatsoever is all phenomena. A bodhisattva, a great being, who cultivates the great nirvāṇa does not see anything in all phenomena. Whoever has something that is seen does not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Such a one cannot fully cultivate the Perfection of Wisdom and cannot attain the great nirvāṇa. Therefore a bodhisattva sees all phenomena as having no intrinsic nature.

Noble son, a bodhisattva does not see emptiness by virtue of the condition of seeing a meditative absorption. Rather, the Perfection of Wisdom is empty, the perfection of meditative concentration (dhyāna) is empty, the perfection of diligence is empty, the perfection of patience is empty, the perfection of moral discipline is empty, the perfection of generosity is empty. Form is empty, the eye is empty, consciousness is empty, the Tathāgata is empty, nirvāṇa is empty. Therefore the bodhisattva sees all phenomena as utterly empty.

For this reason, when I was residing in the city of Kapilavastu, I said to Nanda: "Nanda, do not grieve, do not lament, do not wail." And Nanda replied: "Blessed One, if all my attendants and relatives have died, how am I not to grieve? The Tathāgata was born in this very city along with me, and all who belong to the Śākya clan are close kin to me. How is it that the Tathāgata alone does not grieve, and even appears with his complexion more radiant than before?"

Noble son, I then spoke to him in this way: "Nanda, you see the city of Kapilavastu as truly and really existing, whereas I see it as empty, peaceful, and utterly without anything. You see all the Śākya clan as your close kin, whereas I, through cultivating emptiness, see nothing whatsoever. It is for that cause and condition that grief and suffering arise in you, whereas my complexion has grown more radiant than before. Buddhas and bodhisattvas, because they have cultivated the meditative absorption of emptiness in this way, do not give rise to grief."

This constitutes the ninth quality belonging to a bodhisattva who diligently applies himself to the sūtra of the great nirvāṇa.

Noble son, you ask: in what way does a bodhisattva who diligently applies himself to this holy sūtra of the great nirvāṇa come to possess the tenth and last of the inner qualities? Noble son, a bodhisattva cultivates the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening (bodhipākṣika dharmas), enters into the great nirvāṇa's qualities of permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity, and for the sake of all sentient beings elucidates and teaches the sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, fully revealing the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Whether it be a stream-enterer (srotāpanna), a once-returner (sakṛdāgāmin), a non-returner (anāgāmin), an arhat, a pratyekabuddha (solitary buddha), or — or bodhisattvas who place their trust in those words, all of them will enter into the great nirvāṇa. Whoever does not place their trust in them will continue to wander in saṃsāra.

Then the great bodhisattva, the mahasattva Samantabhadra (Samantaprabhā), the Glorious King on High, addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Blessed One, what of those sentient beings who show no respect for this sūtra?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, after my passing into nirvāṇa, there will be monks who are attendants — deluded, their moral discipline destroyed, fond of quarrelling, who have abandoned the twelve branches of scripture and recite and read the various scriptural works of non-Buddhist tīrthikas and worldly compositions and verses. Carrying without examination all manner of things, they will declare, 'The Buddha has permitted this.' Such people are like sandalwood being traded for inferior wood, like gold being traded for a leather bag, like silver being traded for weeds, like silk being traded for coarse woolen cloth, and like nectar being traded for poison.

How is it that sandalwood is traded for inferior wood? My attendants, for the sake of gain and fame, teach this nirvāṇa sūtra and the Dharma to householders, but the householders, swollen with pride, have no wish to listen. The monks seat the householders in a higher position and themselves sit below, and even when served with abundant and varied fine food and drink, still cannot get the householders to listen. This is what is called trading sandalwood for inferior wood.

How is it that gold is traded for a leather bag? The leather bag is a simile for form, sound, smell, taste, and touch. Gold is a simile for moral discipline. My attendants, on account of attachment to form and the like, violate and break their moral discipline. This is what is called trading gold for a leather bag.

How is it that silver is traded for weeds? Silver is a simile for the ten virtues. Weeds are a simile for the ten non-virtues. My attendants abandon the ten virtues and practice the ten non-virtues. This is what is called trading silver for weeds.

How is it that silk is traded for coarse woolen cloth? Coarse woolen cloth is a simile for being without moral shame and without moral dread. Silk is a simile for possessing moral shame and moral dread. My attendants cast aside moral shame and moral dread and conduct themselves without moral shame or moral dread. This is what is called trading silk for coarse woolen cloth.

How is it that nectar is traded for poison? Poison is a simile for all manner of gain and fame. Nectar is a simile for the undefiled dharmas. My attendants, for the sake of gain and fame, extol themselves to householders, declaring, 'I have attained the undefiled.' This is what is called trading nectar for poison.

It is on account of such corrupt monks as these that this supreme sūtra of the great nirvāṇa has come to be widely disseminated throughout Jambudvīpa. Yet at that very time some attendants will write out this sūtra, preserve it, read it, recite it, explain it, and propagate it — and those corrupt monks will kill them. Those corrupt monks will then gather together and lay down these strict rules: 'If anyone writes out this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa, preserves it, reads it, recites it, opens it, or teaches it, none of us shall live together with that person, sit together with that person, or speak with that person. Why? Because this nirvāṇa sūtra was not spoken by a buddha — it was composed by those of wrong view. Wrong view has six teachers, and this is a sūtra of the six teachers, not a sūtra of a buddha.' How so? 'The buddhas teach that all phenomena are impermanent, selfless, without bliss, and without perfect purity.' They therefore claim that if one were to say that phenomena are permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and perfectly pure —

Why, then, should this be called a sūtra spoken by a buddha? The buddhas and bodhisattvas permit their attendants to carry all manner of various material goods, whereas the six teachers permit their attendants to carry no material goods at all. So why should this be called the authentic Dharma of a buddha? The buddhas and bodhisattvas have not prohibited their attendants from consuming the five kinds of choice dairy products derived from cow's milk, nor flesh, nor similar things. The six teachers, however, permit their followers to consume none of the five kinds of salty preparations, nor the five kinds of dairy flavors, nor oil, nor blood, nor the like. Since they prohibit the

consumption of those things, it is not proper to call their teaching the true Dharma of a buddha.

Furthermore, the buddhas and bodhisattvas have taught the three vehicles, whereas this sūtra teaches only a single vehicle, that of great nirvāṇa. How, then, should this be called the authentic Dharma of a buddha? The buddhas have declared that they pass into nirvāṇa at the end, yet this sūtra teaches that the buddhas are permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and perfectly pure — and that they do not pass away into nirvāṇa. Therefore this sūtra does not fall within the category of the twelve branches of scripture; it was spoken by Māra, not spoken by a buddha.

Son of good family, those people are indeed my attendants, and yet they are unable to have faith in and inclination toward this sūtra of great nirvāṇa. Son of good family, if at that time any sentient being has faith and confidence in even half a verse of this sūtra, know that such a person is truly my genuine attendant. Through the condition of such faith, one perceives the nature of a buddha and passes into nirvāṇa. Through the condition of that faith, one perceives the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and just as the Blessed One has declared, one too will attain great nirvāṇa.

This is called a bodhisattva who is endowed with the ten qualities arising from earnest application to nirvāṇa and to this holy sūtra.

This is the tenth chapter, the chapter of thorough inquiry by the bodhisattva Samantaprabha Uttamaśrī Mahārāja, from the noble Sūtra of Great Nirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One addressed the entire vast assembly and declared: Sons of good family, suppose someone were to question you thus: Is there a buddha or is there no buddha? Is there Dharma or is there no Dharma? Is there a Saṅgha or is there no Saṅgha? Is there suffering or is there no suffering? Is there an origin of suffering or is there no origin of suffering? Is there cessation or is there no cessation? Is there a path or is there no path? Is there truth or is there no truth? Is there a self or is there no self? Is there suffering or is there no suffering? Is there perfect purity or is there no perfect purity? Is there permanence or is there no permanence? Is there a vehicle or is there no vehicle? Is there an intrinsic nature or is there no intrinsic nature? Are there sentient beings or are there no sentient beings? Is there continued existence or is there no continued existence? Is there what is correct or is there nothing correct? Is there a cause or is there no cause? Is there a result or is there no result? Is there an agent or is there no agent? Is there karma or is there no

karma?

Is there karmic maturation or is there no karmic maturation? If you are in doubt about any of these, ask me whatever you wish, and I will analyze each of those points and explain them to you. O noble son, whether a god, a human, a māra, a Brahmā, a monk, a brahmin, or anyone else asks me, there is nothing I cannot answer.

Then, from within that assembled retinue, a bodhisattva named Lion's Roar rose from his seat, arranged his robe, bowed his head to the feet of the Buddha, knelt with his right knee on the ground, joined his palms, and addressed the Blessed One in these words: Blessed One, I too have been thinking that I would like to make a request, and it is wonderful that the Tathāgata, out of great compassion, has opened this opportunity to ask.

Then the Blessed One declared to the great assembly: O noble sons, you should show this bodhisattva the highest honor, reverence, and respect, and offer him incense, flowers, music, garlands, parasols, victory banners, robes, food, drink, bedding, medicines for illness, and dwellings, and you should go out to welcome him and escort him on his way. Why is this? Because this one has planted roots of virtue before the buddhas of the past, and by virtue of that merit he now, before my very eyes, roars the lion's roar.

O noble sons, just as the lion king, knowing his own strength, the sharpness of his fangs and claws, plants his four paws firmly on the ground, and even while dwelling in his mountain cave, lashes his tail and lets out his roar — know that one endowed with such qualities is capable of roaring the lion's roar. The true lion king, early in the morning, emerges from his lair, stretches himself, surveys the four directions, and for eleven purposes roars his great roar. What are those eleven? They are: to destroy those who falsely pretend to be lions without truly being lions; to awaken his own power and prowess; to purify his domain; to let his cubs know their abode; to free the many animals from their state of fear; to awaken those who are sleeping; to rid all the lazy beasts of their laziness; to make the beasts circle around him and take refuge in him; to tame the great musk elephants; to instruct his cubs; and to adorn all his retinue — these are the eleven.

When all the beasts hear the lion's roar, those born of the water plunge to the depths; those who walk on dry land flee into their holes; those who fly fall to the ground; and even the great musk elephants lose control of themselves and flee.

O noble sons, even if a fox were to walk behind a lion for a hundred years, it still could not roar the lion's roar. But lion cubs who have reached three years of age are able to roar just as the lion king does.

O noble sons, likewise the Tathāgata, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha, endowed with the fangs and claws of wisdom, the four legs of supernatural power (ṛddhi), the body in which the six perfections are fully complete, the ten powers of a hero's strength, the tail of great compassion, and dwelling in the perfectly purified lair of the four meditative concentrations, roars the lion's roar for the sake of sentient beings, utterly vanquishing the armies of Māra, revealing the ten powers to the great assembly, elucidating the domain of a buddha's activity, and acting as protector and refuge for those who hold wrong views. He arouses enthusiasm in those who are afraid of saṃsāra, awakens sentient beings who are oppressed by the sleep of ignorance,

causes those who practice non-virtuous phenomena to give rise to a mind of remorse. He causes sentient beings who hold wrong views to understand, through repeated and thorough teaching, that the teachings of the six teachers are not the lion's roar. He crushes the pride of Kāśyapa the Perfector and others like him. He causes those of the two vehicles to give rise to a mind of remorse. He causes bodhisattvas on the fifth ground and above to give rise to great power and great mind. And in order that the four assemblies of right view may be without fear before the four factions of wrong view, he emerges from the innermost lair of the domain of the noble ones, the domain of Brahmā, and the domain of the gods, stretches himself wide, and roars in order to crush the pride, arrogance, and related afflictions of all sentient beings. He gazes in all four directions in order to cause wholesome phenomena to arise in all sentient beings. He plants his four paws firmly on the ground in order that all sentient beings may attain the four discriminating knowledges (pratisaṃvid). He roars the lion's roar in order to establish all sentient beings in the perfection of moral discipline. To roar the lion's roar is to declare with certainty to all sentient beings that the buddha-nature exists within them, and that the Tathāgata abides permanently, unchanging and unaltering. Sons of good family, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, even if they were to follow in the footsteps of the Blessed One the Buddha for hundreds and thousands of immeasurable and incalculable aeons, would still be incapable of roaring the lion's roar. Know that if a bodhisattva on the tenth ground applies himself diligently to all three aspects of conduct, that is what it

means to roar the lion's roar. Sons of good family, the bodhisattva, the great being Lion's Roar, has now been considered to have proclaimed the great lion's roar. Therefore, honor him, serve him, and revere him with an elevated mind.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being Lion's Roar: "Son of good family, if you have questions, ask whatever you wish."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Lion's Roar, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the buddha-nature? What is meant by the term 'buddha-nature'? And what, further, is meant by 'permanence,' 'bliss,' 'self,' and 'perfect purity'? If the buddha-nature is present in all sentient beings, why is it not seen? In the presence of the buddha-nature in all sentient beings, in what Dharma does a bodhisattva on the tenth ground abide such that he does not see it clearly? And in what Dharma does a buddha abide such that he does see it clearly? With what kind of eye does a bodhisattva on the tenth ground fail to see it clearly? And with what kind of eye does a buddha see it clearly?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family! Whoever asks a question for the sake of the Dharma will come to possess both accumulations. What are the two? The accumulation of wisdom and the accumulation of merit. If a bodhisattva possesses both of those accumulations, he will know the buddha-nature. And from knowing what is meant by 'buddha-nature,' he will know all the way through to what kind of eye a bodhisattva on the tenth ground sees with, and with what kind of eye the Blessed Buddha sees."

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar then asked: "Blessed One, what is the accumulation of wisdom? What is the accumulation of merit?"

"Son of good family, the accumulation of wisdom is as follows:

from the first ground through to the tenth ground, that is called the accumulation of wisdom. The accumulation of merit is as follows: from the perfection of generosity through to, but not including, the Perfection of Wisdom. Furthermore, son of good family, the accumulation of wisdom refers to buddhas and bodhisattvas. The accumulation of merit refers to śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas on the ninth ground. Furthermore, son of good family, the accumulation of merit is conditioned, defiled, bound up with existence, productive of results, obstructed, and impermanent — it is the characteristic of the immature and inferior. The accumulation of wisdom is

unconditioned, undefiled, free from existence, without results, unobstructed, and permanently abiding.

Son of good family, it is because you possess these two kinds of accumulation that you became bold enough to ask about this profoundly deep matter. And it is because I too possess these two kinds of accumulation that I was able to answer when this matter was asked of me.

The great bodhisattva Lion's Roar then said: "Blessed One, if it is improper to ask of a bodhisattva who possesses these two accumulations whether things are one or two, then why did the Blessed One reply in terms of one and two?"

"Why do you ask?" responded Lion's Roar. "Because all phenomena are neither one nor two. Oneness and twoness are the defining characteristic of the immature and inferior."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if a bodhisattva lacked these two accumulations, he would not know whether things are one or two. A bodhisattva who possesses these two accumulations does know whether things are one or two. Yet the point that there is no such thing as 'one' or 'two' with regard to phenomena is not quite right either. Why? If there were neither one nor two, how could one speak of all phenomena as being neither one nor two?"

Son of good family, what is called 'oneness and twoness as the defining characteristic of the immature and inferior' — that refers to a bodhisattva on the tenth ground, and not to the immature and inferior. Why? Because 'one' is nirvāṇa, and 'two' is saṃsāra. Why is 'one' called nirvāṇa? Because it is permanent. Why is 'two' called saṃsāra? Because it is bound up with craving rooted in ignorance. Yet nirvāṇa, which is permanent, is not the defining characteristic of the immature and inferior, and saṃsāra is likewise not the defining characteristic of the immature and inferior. It is for this reason that possessing the two accumulations constitutes the asking and answering of the question.

Son of good family, listen carefully now to how the question of what is meant by 'the buddha's intrinsic nature' is to be examined, and I will analyze it and explain it to you.

Son of good family, what is called 'the buddha's intrinsic nature' is ultimate emptiness. Ultimate emptiness is what is called wisdom. With regard to this, 'emptiness' means seeing neither emptiness nor non-emptiness. One who

possesses wisdom sees all of the following: empty and non-empty, permanent and impermanent, suffering and bliss, self and no-self. What is called 'empty' is all of saṃsāra. What is called 'non-empty' is complete nirvāṇa. Up through no-self is saṃsāra. What is called 'self' is complete nirvāṇa.

To see everything as empty while not seeing what is non-empty — that is not to be called the Middle Path. To see everything only up through no-self without seeing the self — that is not to be called the Middle Path. What is called the Middle Path is the buddha's intrinsic nature.

Because of that, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is permanent and without change. Yet because it is covered by ignorance, no sentient being has been able to see it. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas see everything as empty — they do not see the non-empty — and they see everything up through no-self, yet they do not see the self. Therefore they have not attained ultimate emptiness. Because they have not attained ultimate emptiness, they do not travel the Middle Path. Because they do not travel the Middle Path, they do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Son of good family, there are three modes of seeing the Middle Path: practicing with definite bliss, practicing with definite suffering, and practicing with both definite suffering and bliss. What is called practicing with definite bliss is this: a great bodhisattva, out of compassion for all sentient beings, may dwell in the Avīci hell, yet experiences it as though touching the bliss of the third meditative concentration. What is called practicing with definite suffering refers to the ignorant and base. What is called practicing with both definite suffering and bliss refers to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas arouse the perception of the Middle Path with respect to both suffering and bliss — and for that reason, although the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists, they do not see it.

You have asked: "What sort of thing would you say the intrinsic nature of a buddha is?" Son of good family, what is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha is the seed of the Middle Path of the unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening of all buddhas — arhat, perfectly and completely awakened.

Furthermore, son of good family, the path has three grades: superior, middling, and inferior. What is called inferior is the Brahmā gods who, in error, view what is impermanent as permanent. What is called superior is to see saṃsāra, which is impermanent, as permanent in error, while improperly superimposing impermanence onto the Three Jewels, which are in fact

permanent. Why is it called superior? Because it leads to the attainment of the supreme, unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. What is called middling is ultimate emptiness — seeing the impermanent as permanent and seeing the permanent as impermanent. Ultimate emptiness should not be called inferior. Why? Because it is unseen by all the ignorant and base. Nor should it be called superior. Why? Because it is not the highest. The path traversed by all buddhas and bodhisattvas is neither superior nor inferior — and for that very reason it is called the Middle Path.

Furthermore, son of good family, the first extreme of saṃsāra has two aspects: ignorance and craving. Between these two arises the suffering of birth, aging, sickness, and death — and that is what is called the Middle Path. It is called the Middle Path because, by means of that Middle Path, saṃsāra will be utterly destroyed.

Thus the Dharma of the Middle Path is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Therefore the intrinsic nature of a buddha is permanent, blissful, a self, and utterly pure. Because sentient beings do not see it, it appears to them as impermanent, as suffering, as no-self, and as not utterly pure. In truth, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not impermanence, not suffering, not no-self, and not absence of purity.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: in the house of a poor man there is a treasure of jewels, yet because he does not see it, by reason of that non-seeing he has no permanence, no bliss, no self, no complete purity. A spiritual friend comes to him and says: "In your house there is a treasure of gold and jewels — why then are you poor and afflicted, impermanent, without bliss, without self, and without purity?" And by skillful means that friend causes him to see it.

When he sees it, that man gains permanence, bliss, self, and complete purity. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is just like that: sentient beings do not see it. Because they do not see it in this way, there is no permanence, no bliss, no self, no complete purity. The spiritual friends who are buddhas and bodhisattvas teach it through various skillful means and cause it to be seen. Once sentient beings have thus come to see it, they attain permanence, bliss, self, and complete purity.

Furthermore, son of good family, there are two kinds of view that sentient beings give rise to: eternalism and annihilation. Those two views are not called the Middle Way path. The absence of both eternalism and annihilation — that

is called the Middle Way path. Freedom from both eternalism and annihilation is the wisdom that realizes the twelve links of dependent origination. The wisdom that realizes in this way is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Although the two vehicles do realize dependent origination's twelve links, this is not called attaining the intrinsic nature of a buddha. One may indeed perceive the intrinsic nature of a buddha, yet because sentient beings are thoroughly covered over by ignorance they do not see it — just as a hare and a horse cannot cross the river of the twelve links of dependent origination. Why is that? Because they do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Son of good family, the wisdom that realizes the twelve links of dependent origination is the seed of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. It is for this reason that the twelve links of dependent origination are called the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: ghee becomes the cause of bile disease. Why? Because it becomes a cause and condition for bile disease. The twelve links of dependent origination are similar to that. Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha has a cause, a cause of the cause, a result, and a result of the result. "Having a cause" refers to the twelve links of dependent origination. "The cause of the cause" refers to wisdom. "Having a result" refers to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. "The result of the result" refers to unsurpassed great nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: conditioned by ignorance, formations are the result; conditioned by formations, consciousness becomes the result. Thus the essential nature of ignorance is both a condition and a condition of the condition. Consciousness too is both a result and a result of the result. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is similar to that.

Son of good family, it is for this reason that the twelve links of dependent origination neither arise nor cease, are neither eternal nor annihilated, neither one nor two, neither coming nor going, neither cause nor result.

Son of good family, that which is a cause but not a result is like the intrinsic nature of a buddha. That which is a result but not a cause is like great nirvāṇa. That which is both a cause and a result is like the phenomena born from the twelve links of dependent origination. That which is neither cause nor result is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha — and because it is neither cause nor result, it is permanently unchanging and unmoving.

It is for this reason that I have declared in the sūtras that the twelve links of dependent origination have a profoundly deep meaning that is beyond knowing, beyond seeing, and beyond conceiving.

It is the domain of buddhas and bodhisattvas, and it is not known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Why is it said that the meaning is profoundly deep? The profound depth lies in this: although the karma and conduct of sentient beings are neither permanent nor annihilated, the result nonetheless ripens; although karma ceases moment by moment, nothing is lost; although there is no agent, the karma that has been performed exists; although there is no experiencer, the ripening of results occurs; although there is no cessation of experience, the result neither perishes nor is lost; no one can think about the arising of all sentient beings and come to know it by inference; although it accompanies the twelve links of dependent origination, it is neither known nor seen; and because it is neither seen nor known, there is no beginning and no end. Even a bodhisattva on the tenth ground sees only the beginning but does not see the end, whereas a blessed buddha, a Bhagavān, sees both beginning and end. It is for this reason that the Tathāgatas clearly perceive the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

O son of good family, it is because all sentient beings do not see the twelve links of dependent origination that they revolve thoroughly in cyclic existence. O son of good family, just as a silkworm spins a cocoon, is born within it of itself, and dies within it of itself, so too all sentient beings are like this: because they do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, they perform afflicted karma of their own accord, and like one struck by a club they revolve thoroughly in cyclic existence.

O son of good family, it is therefore that I have declared in all the sūtras: if one sees the twelve links of dependent origination, one sees the Dharma; and if one sees the Dharma, one sees the buddha. The word "buddha" refers to the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Why so? Because that very intrinsic nature is the nature of all buddhas.

O son of good family, the investigative wisdom (Skt. vicārajñāna) that examines the twelve links of dependent origination has four levels: the least, the middling, the excellent, and the most excellent. The least investigative wisdom does not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha; because it does not see it, one attains the path of the śrāvakas. The middling investigative wisdom

does not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha; because it does not see it, one attains the path of the pratyekabuddhas. The excellent investigative wisdom does not see it clearly; because it is not seen clearly, one abides on the ten grounds. The most excellent wisdom sees it clearly; through seeing it clearly, one attains the path of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

It is therefore that the twelve links of dependent origination are called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is the emptiness of ultimate truth. The emptiness of ultimate truth is the middle path. The middle path is the buddha. And the buddha is called nirvāṇa.

The thirty-sixth fascicle.

Then the great bodhisattva, the great being Lion's Roar, addressed the Blessed One thus: Blessed One, if there is no difference between a buddha and the intrinsic nature of a buddha, what is the point of all sentient beings striving on the path?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, your question does not quite hit the mark. Although there is no difference between a buddha and the intrinsic nature of a buddha, sentient beings do not possess it. O son of good family, consider this example: suppose a person is killed not through malicious intent, yet after killing, remorse arises, and they perform virtuous deeds of the three paths — yet they are still called a hell-being. Why? Because that person will inevitably fall into hell. That person does not possess the aggregates, elements, or sense bases of a hell-being — and yet they are called a hell-being.

O son of good family, it is therefore that I have declared in all the sūtras: one who sees a being practicing virtuous Dharma is said to see a god.

One who sees a being practicing non-virtue is said to see a hell-being. Why? Because they will inevitably experience karmic maturation.

O son of good family, because all sentient beings will without fail attain unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, it has been declared that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature. And yet all sentient beings do not actually possess the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks. It is for that reason that I have spoken these verses in this sūtra:

What has a beginning does not exist now.

What has no beginning exists now.

All phenomena of existence throughout the three times

have no fixed abode of such a kind.

O son of good family, what is called "existence" has three aspects: future existence, present existence, and past existence. With respect to these, because all sentient beings will possess unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening in the future, this is called the buddha-nature. Because all sentient beings presently have all-pervasive afflictions, they do not presently possess the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks. As for those sentient beings who, in past time, cut off their afflictions — they now behold the buddha-nature. It is for this reason that I have always declared that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature, extending even to those of wrong craving: even they possess the buddha-nature.

Even though those such as the wrongly craving lack virtuous phenomena, the buddha-nature itself is virtuous, since it will come to exist in the future. Therefore, even those with wrong craving and so forth possess the buddha-nature. Why? Because even those with wrong craving will without fail realize unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

O son of good family, consider this example: in someone's household there is milk and curds. Another person asks, "Do you have butter?" And the reply comes, "I do." Now, curds are not actually butter — and yet one says there is butter, because through skillful means it will without fail be obtained. Sentient beings are likewise: all have mind. Whoever has mind will without fail attain unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. It is for this reason that I have always declared that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature.

O son of good family, perfection has two kinds: the perfection of arrangement and the perfection of the ultimate. Furthermore, there is the worldly perfection and the supramundane perfection. Of these, the perfection of arrangement is the six perfections (pāramitās). The perfection of the ultimate is all sentient beings' attainment of the single vehicle. The single vehicle is what is called the buddha-nature. It is therefore that I have declared: all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature; all sentient beings possess the single vehicle — yet, obscured by ignorance, they do not see it.

O son of good family, consider this example: the ripened fruit experienced in the Thirty-Three Heaven is beyond the sight of these obscured sentient beings here in the northern continent of Unpleasant Sound. The buddha-nature is likewise: because it is obscured by the afflictions, sentient beings do not see it.

Furthermore, O son of good family, what is called the buddha-nature is the meditative absorption of heroic progress (*śūraṃgama samādhī*). In its intrinsic nature it resembles the essence of butter, and it is therefore the mother of all buddhas.

Through the power of the meditative absorption of heroic progress, the Tathāgatas have become permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and utterly pure. Although the meditative absorption of heroic progress is present in all sentient beings, they do not see it because they have not cultivated it, and therefore they have not attained unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

O son of good family, the meditative absorption of heroic progress has five names. It is called the meditative absorption of heroic progress; it is also called the Perfection of Wisdom; it is also called the vajra-like meditative absorption; it is also called the meditative absorption of the lion's roar; and it is also called the intrinsic nature of the buddhas. In each context, according to what qualities are present, the name is applied accordingly.

O son of good family, how is it that a single meditative absorption comes to receive so many different names? Consider: in the context of meditative concentration, it is called the four dhyānas; in the context of the faculties, it is called the faculty of meditative absorption; in the context of the powers, it is called the power of meditative absorption; in the context of the factors of awakening, it is called the factor of awakening that is meditative absorption; in the context of the noble path, it is called right meditative absorption; in the context of a person's eight contemplations, it is called the contemplation of meditative absorption. In just the same way, the meditative absorption of heroic progress is analogous to all of these.

O son of good family, all sentient beings are endowed with three grades of meditative absorption. What are the three? The superior, the middling, and the inferior. The superior is the intrinsic nature of the buddhas; therefore it is said that the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is present in all sentient beings. The middling is that all sentient beings are endowed with the first dhyāna: if the conditions are met, they will fully cultivate it; but if the conditions are not met, they will not fully cultivate it. The conditions are of two kinds: the aeon of fire, and the utter elimination of the afflictions of the desire realm. Therefore it is said that all sentient beings are endowed with the middling meditative absorption. The inferior meditative absorption is the mind-arisen meditative absorption of the ten great bodhisattva grounds; therefore it is said that all

sentient beings are endowed with the inferior meditative absorption.

The intrinsic nature of the buddhas is present in all sentient beings, but because it is completely covered over by the afflictions, they are unable to see it. A bodhisattva on the tenth ground does see the one vehicle, yet does not know the Tathāgata as one who permanently abides. Therefore, although a bodhisattva on the tenth ground sees the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, it has not become fully clear to them.

O son of good family, the word heroic means having reached the end of all things. The word progress means to rely upon. Because one relies upon the end of all things, it is called heroic progress. Therefore the meditative absorption of heroic progress is called the intrinsic nature of the buddhas.

O son of good family, once upon a time I was dwelling on the bank of the Ganges river and I spoke to Ānanda, saying: "I am about to bathe. Please take my robe and rub in the washing powder, then set it out." When I entered the water, all beings who move through the sky, through water, or across the land came and looked upon me. At that time some five hundred wanderers gathered on the riverbank and came into my presence, saying to one another: "How did this one attain a body like vajra? If this Gautama does not teach the annihilationist view, we offer him our scriptures and our ethical precepts." O son of good family, at that time I, knowing the minds of those wanderers through the gnosis that perceives the minds of others, understood their intentions, and spoke to them thus:

"Why do you think I am teaching the annihilationist view?" The wanderers then asked: "Gautama, in all your sūtras you have declared that all sentient beings are without self. If you say they are without self, why is this not the annihilationist view? If there is no self, who would uphold moral discipline, and who would transgress it?"

The Blessed One declared: "I have never said that all sentient beings are without self. I have always said that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature. Is not that very buddha-nature itself a self? For that reason I do not teach the annihilationist view. Because all sentient beings do not see the buddha-nature, they lack permanence, lack selfhood, lack bliss, and lack perfect purity. Whoever speaks in those terms — that one is said to be teaching the annihilationist view."

Upon hearing at that moment that the buddha-nature itself is the self, all those wanderers aroused the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete

awakening, and right then, going forth into renunciation, they applied themselves diligently to the path of awakening. All beings moving through the sky, through water, and across the land likewise aroused the mind of unsurpassable awakening. Having thus aroused that mind, they at that same moment abandoned those very bodies.

O son of good family, the buddha-nature, in ultimate truth, is not a self; it is called "self" for the sake of sentient beings. O son of good family, because cause and condition exist, the Tathāgata has spoken of a self with respect to what is actually selfless — yet in ultimate truth there is no self. Though he speaks thus, it is not a falsehood. O son of good family, likewise, because cause and condition exist, what has a self is explained as selfless; and though in ultimate truth a self exists, it is spoken of as selfless for the sake of the world — yet that too is not a falsehood. The buddha-nature is indeed without self, and the Tathāgata's teaching of "selfless" with respect to it is because it is permanent. The Tathāgata is indeed a self, and teaching it as "selfless" is because sovereignty has been attained.

Then the great bodhisattva Śiṃhaghoṣa asked: "Blessed One, if all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature, like a great vajra-force, why is it that all sentient beings do not see it?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, consider visible forms — blue, yellow, red, white, long, short, and various others. They exist and can be apprehended, yet a blind person does not see them. Because a blind person does not see them, it does not follow that these forms — blue, yellow, red, white, long and short in shape — do not exist. Why so? Because even though a blind person does not see them, someone with eyes does not fail to see them. The buddha-nature is just like that: even though all sentient beings do not see it, a bodhisattva of the tenth ground sees a portion of it, while the Tathāgata beholds it without remainder. What the bodhisattva of the tenth ground sees of the buddha-nature is like a form seen in darkness, while the Tathāgata beholds it as a form seen in full daylight.

"Son of good family, consider also one with cataracts, who cannot see forms clearly. When a skilled physician treats the eye, by the power of that medicine one comes to see clearly. The bodhisattva of the tenth ground is similar: though the buddha-nature is seen, it is not seen clearly. By the power of the meditative absorption called Heroic Advance (śūraṃgama-samādhi), one comes to see it fully and clearly.

"Son of good family, there are those who perceive all phenomena as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss, and lacking purity, and who perceive all that is not the Dharma as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss,

and lacking purity — those who see in this way do not see the buddha-nature. Here, "all phenomena" refers to saṃsāra. "What is not all phenomena" refers to the Three Jewels. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas see all phenomena as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss, and lacking purity, and they likewise see all that is not Dharma as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss, and lacking purity. Because they see in this way, they do not see the buddha-nature.

The bodhisattva of the tenth ground sees all phenomena as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss, and lacking purity, yet sees in all that is not Dharma only a partial glimpse of permanence, selfhood, bliss, and purity. Because of seeing in this partial way, it is said that such a one sees only one tenth of it.

The Blessed One, the buddha, sees all phenomena as lacking permanence, lacking selfhood, lacking bliss, and lacking purity, and sees in all that is not Dharma permanence, selfhood, bliss, and purity in full. Because of seeing in this way, the Blessed One sees the buddha-nature as clearly as a myrobalan fruit held in the palm of the hand. It is for this reason that the meditative absorption called Heroic Advance (śūraṃgama-samādhi) is said to be the ultimate.

Son of good family, consider the moon on the first day of the month: though one cannot see it, it is not right to say it does not exist. The buddha-nature is similar: though it is not seen by all who are foolish and undeveloped, it is not right to say that the buddha-nature does not exist in them.

Son of good family, the buddha-nature is as follows: the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, great compassion, and the three foundations of mindfulness — all three of these aspects are present in every sentient being, yet they will first become visible only when the afflictions are thoroughly overcome. Those who have wrong craving will, only when that wrong craving is thoroughly overcome, come to attain the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, great compassion, and the three foundations of mindfulness. It is for this reason that I have always declared that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature.

Son of good family, these twelve links of dependent origination are equally present in all sentient beings — both inner and outer. What are the twelve? The affliction of the past is ignorance. The karma of the past is formations. The consciousness at the very first moment of entering the womb in the present time is consciousness. Having entered the womb, while the five limbs and four faculties are not yet complete, that is name-and-form. While one possesses the four faculties but contact cannot yet be spoken of, that is the six sense sources. The inability to distinguish between suffering and pleasure is called contact. Attachment clinging to a single object is called feeling. Attachment to the five sense pleasures is called craving. Attachment-desire for inner and outer things is grasping. The production of bodily, verbal, and mental karma through inner and outer things is becoming. The consciousness of the present time is birth in the future. The name-and-form, the six sense sources, contact, and feeling of the present time are aging, sickness, and death in the future. These are called the twelve links of dependent origination.

Son of good family, although all these twelve links of dependent origination are present in every sentient being, when one is still in the embryonic state, not yet fully formed, at the time of death in that state the twelve links of dependent origination are not present. From the moment of birth until death and aging, one is possessed of all twelve. As for sentient beings in the form realm, although there is no threefold feeling, no threefold contact, no craving, no aging, and no death, they are nonetheless said to possess all twelve.

As for sentient beings in the formless realm, although form is absent and the links from form through to aging and death are lacking, they are nonetheless said to possess all twelve aspects. This is because they are certain to attain them. Therefore it is said that all sentient beings equally possess the twelve links of dependent origination.

Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is similar to this. Because all sentient beings are certain to attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, I have therefore declared that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Son of good family, in the Himalayas there is a certain grass called bzodpa. If cows eat it, the essence of butter arises. There is another grass such that if cows eat it, no essence of butter arises. Now although the essence of butter does not arise from the latter, it would be wrong to say that bzodpa grass does not exist in the Himalayas. In the same way, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is

to be understood likewise. The Tathāgata is like the Himalayas. The great and complete nirvāṇa is like the bzodpa grass. The twelve divisions of scripture are like that other grass. Whatever sentient being hears, retains, or inquires into this complete nirvāṇa will behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Although one has not heard that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists from within the twelve divisions of scripture, it would still be wrong to say that the intrinsic nature of a buddha does not exist.

Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is form, and yet it is not form. It is not form, and yet it is not non-form either. It has characteristics, and yet it is without characteristics. It is without characteristics, and yet it is not without characteristics either. It is one, and yet it is not one. It is not one, and yet it is not non-one either. It is not permanent and it is not annihilated. It is not non-permanent, and it is not non-annihilated either. It exists, and yet it does not exist. It neither exists nor is it non-existent. It is exhausted, and yet it is not exhausted. It is neither exhausted nor non-exhausted. It is a cause, and yet it is also a result. It is neither a cause nor is it non-result. It is not a meaning, and being not a meaning it is not non-meaning either. It has letters, and yet it is without letters. It is without letters, and yet it is not without letters either.

Now, in what sense is it said to be form? It is the vajra-like body. In what sense is it not form? It is the eighteen unshared qualities, which are immaterial. In what sense is it neither form nor non-form? It is the absence of any fixed defining characteristic with respect to both form and non-form.

In what sense does it have characteristics? It has the thirty-two major marks. In what sense is it without characteristics? The marks are not manifest to any sentient being. In what sense is it neither with characteristics nor without characteristics? It is the state in which neither the marks nor their absence is determinate.

In what sense is it one? All sentient beings belong to a single vehicle. In what sense is it not one? Three vehicles have been taught. In what sense is it neither one nor non-one? It is the countless Dharma categories.

In what sense is it not permanent? It is seen to arise from conditions. In what sense is it not annihilated? It is free from the view of annihilation. In what sense is it neither non-permanent nor non-annihilated? It is the absence of any beginning or final extremity.

In what sense does it exist? All sentient beings exist. In what sense does it not exist? It is seen through skillful means. In what sense is it neither existent nor non-existent? It has the defining characteristic of space.

In what sense is it exhausted? It is the attainment of the power of the meditative absorption called the Heroic March (sūraṃgama). In what sense is it not exhausted? It is that which is not permanent. In what sense is it neither exhausted nor non-exhausted —

it has the defining characteristic of the exhaustion of all things, and is thus cut off. What is the cause? The cause is thorough understanding. What is the result? The result is that which becomes inescapable. What is that which is neither cause nor result? It is permanence. What is the meaning? The meaning is that it gathers all aims without obstruction. What is the non-meaning? It is that which cannot be expressed. What is that which is neither non-meaning nor not non-meaning? It becomes empty at the extreme end. What is called a syllable? It is that which has been designated by name. What is the non-syllable? It is that which has not been designated by name. What is that which is neither non-syllable nor not non-syllable? It is the cutting off of all syllables. What is that which is neither suffering nor happiness? It is the cutting off of all feeling (vedanā). What is the non-self? It is that which has not come to be endowed with the eight powers. What is that which is also not non-self? It is permanence. What is that which is neither non-self nor not non-self? It is that which is unmade and unexperienced. What is called emptiness? It is ultimate emptiness. What is the non-empty? It is permanence. What is that which is neither non-empty nor not non-empty? It is that which has become the fruit of virtuous phenomena.

Son of good family, know this: if anyone who has taken to heart and understood these meanings of the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra perceives the intrinsic nature of a buddha, that nature is inconceivable, and it is the domain of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones; it is not known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not the aggregates, the elements, or the sense sources. It is not something that exists from a beginningless time up to the present. It is not something that, having come into existence, later ceases to be. It is seen by sentient beings through causes and conditions of virtue. Just as when black iron is burned in fire it turns red, and when removed and cooled it turns black again, and yet that black color is neither within nor without but has arisen from causes and conditions — so too

is the intrinsic nature of a buddha: when the fire of the afflictions of all sentient beings is absent, it is seen and heard. Son of good family, just as when a seed has ceased a sprout arises, and the defining characteristic of that sprout is neither within nor without — and so it is likewise all the way up through the flower and the fruit — for they have come to exist from conditions. Son of good family, this sacred scriptural collection of the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra is endowed with immeasurable qualities, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha is likewise endowed with immeasurable and innumerable qualities.

Then the great bodhisattva Lion's Roar addressed the Blessed One: Blessed One, when a bodhisattva is endowed with the Dharma attributes, the seeing of the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not made clear. But when the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are endowed with those same Dharma attributes, they behold it with perfect clarity.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, when a bodhisattva is endowed with ten Dharma attributes, although he sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha, it is not clear. What are the ten? Wanting little, knowing contentment, being thoroughly pacified, diligence, right mindfulness, right meditative absorption (samādhi), right wisdom (prajñā), liberation, being praised on account of liberation, and ripening sentient beings through the Great Nirvāṇa.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, what is the difference between wanting little and knowing contentment?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, wanting little is not seeking and not taking.

Knowing contentment is this: even when one obtains little, one feels no distress, and the mind harbors no thoughts of harm toward those in one's company. Wanting little means having few desires. Knowing contentment means that, for the sake of the meaning of the Dharma, one's mind is free from being tormented by grief.

Son of good family, desire has three forms: base desire, great desire, and desire for desire.

As for base desire: if a monk gives rise to thoughts of desire such as these — "How might I become the leader over all my many followers, so that the entire Saṅgha of monks becomes my retinue? How might my retinue of four groups offer me worship, service, reverence, and praise? How might everyone who has previously heard me teach the Dharma to those four groups place their

trust in my words and hold them fast? How might kings, ministers, and householders all pay me honor? How might I obtain in abundance robes, alms, bedding, medicines for illness, fine dwellings, and the like?" — this is samsaric desire, and it is called base desire.

What then is so-called great desire? If a monk, out of desire for gain and fame, thinks to himself that his four-group retinue will come to know that he has attained from the first bodhisattva ground up through the tenth ground, or that he has attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, or that he has attained the fruit of an arhat up through the fruit of a stream-enterer, or that he has attained from the four dhyānas up through unobstructed primordial wisdom — this is called great desire.

What then is so-called desire for desire? If a monk, out of desire for gain and fame, aspires to be reborn as a Brahmā deity, or in the ranks of Māra, or as a great lord, or as a wheel-turning king, or to be born into the warrior caste or the brahmin caste and thereby attain power — this is called desire for desire.

Not living by any of these three base desires is what is called wanting little.

Desire refers to the twenty-five modes of existence. The absence of those twenty-five modes of existence is called wanting little. Not seeking future objects of desire is wanting little; having obtained something and yet feeling no attachment to it is knowing contentment.

Not seeking gain and fame is wanting little. Having obtained something and yet not accumulating more is knowing contentment.

Son of good family, there are cases where one who wants little is nonetheless not said to know contentment, and cases where one who knows contentment is nonetheless not said to want little. There are those who both want little and know contentment, and there are those who know contentment in nothing and whose desire is abundant.

In this regard: the stream-enterer has wanting little. The pratyekabuddha knows contentment. The arhat both wants little and knows contentment. Bodhisattvas are those who neither truly want little nor know contentment.

Son of good family, wanting little and knowing contentment together have two aspects: wholesome and non-wholesome. The non-wholesome kind belongs to ordinary persons who are like empty vessels. The wholesome kind belongs to noble ones and bodhisattvas. All noble ones, even when they have attained the path and its fruit, do not say "I have attained it." Because they do not say

so, their minds remain undisturbed — and that is called knowing contentment.

Son of good family, this being so, if a bodhisattva, a great being, wishes to cultivate the Mahāyāna sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa (parinirvāṇa) and to see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, he must apply himself diligently to wanting little and to knowing contentment.

Now, what is thorough pacification? Pacification has two aspects.

The two aspects are: pacification of mind and pacification of body. Pacification of body means never committing any of the three kinds of physical non-virtue. Pacification of mind means never committing any of the three kinds of mental non-virtue. That is what is called pacification of body and mind.

Again, pacification of body means not relying upon the four kinds of wrong retinue, and having no attachment to the objects and affairs that such a retinue brings about. Pacification of mind means never being stained by attachment, aversion, or delusion. That is what is called pacification of body and mind.

Among monks, some have a pacified body but an unquiet mind; some have a pacified mind but an unquiet body; some have both body and mind pacified; and some have neither body nor mind pacified.

One whose body is pacified but whose mind is not is a monk who perseveres in meditative concentration to the very end, and who has abandoned the four kinds of wrong retinue, yet whose mind is constantly occupied with attachment, aversion, and delusion — this is called having a pacified body but an unquiet mind.

One whose body is not pacified but whose mind is is a monk who, though he associates with and relies upon the four kinds of wrong retinue and upon kings and ministers, has utterly cut off attachment, aversion, and delusion — this is called having a pacified mind but an unquiet body.

Those who have both body and mind pacified are buddhas and bodhisattvas. Those who have neither body nor mind pacified are lowly, ignoble ordinary beings. Why so? Because such lowly, ignoble ordinary beings are utterly incapable of contemplating impermanence, the absence of happiness, selflessness, and the absence of purity. For that very reason, such lowly, ignoble ordinary beings are incapable of conducting themselves purely in the actions of body, speech, and mind. Those who hold wrong views, those who have broken the four root precepts, and those who have committed one of the

five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya) — such persons likewise cannot be called possessors of pacified body and mind.

Now, what is diligence? A monk who, wishing to purify the actions of body, speech, and mind entirely, abandons all non-virtuous actions and cultivates all virtuous actions — this is called diligence. Such diligence, moreover, abides in the six close applications of mindfulness. What are the six? They are: mindfulness of the Buddha, mindfulness of the Dharma, mindfulness of the Saṅgha, mindfulness of ethical conduct, mindfulness of generosity, and mindfulness of the gods. This is what is called the right close application of mindfulness.

One who is endowed with the right close application of mindfulness and thereby attains meditative absorption — that is called right meditative absorption (samādhi). One who, having attained right meditative absorption, comprehends all phenomena as if they were like space — that is called right wisdom. One who, endowed with right wisdom, abandons all the afflictions — that is called liberation. And one who, having attained liberation, praises the qualities of liberation to all sentient beings and declares that liberation is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting — that is called praising the qualities of liberation. Liberation is the unsurpassed great nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, great nirvāṇa is that which extinguishes the fire of all afflictions. Again, nirvāṇa is also called a support and a resting place, because it gives shelter from the fierce winds and rains of affliction. Again, nirvāṇa is called a protector and a refuge, because it causes one to pass beyond all fears. Again, nirvāṇa is called an island, because the four great floods cannot sweep one away. What are the four floods? The flood of desire, the flood of existence, the flood of views, and the flood of ignorance. For this reason, nirvāṇa is called an island. Again, nirvāṇa is called the ultimate refuge.

Why is it called the ultimate refuge? Because through it one attains all lasting happiness.

Even when a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses these ten qualities of Dharma, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is still not seen clearly. Furthermore, O son of good family, there are four qualities by which one who has gone forth fails to attain the four fruits of the renunciant life. What are the four? They are four base desires: the desire for robes, the desire for food, the desire for bedding and seats, and the desire for existence. These are the four base desires, which are the sickness of one who has gone forth. A good

medicine of four kinds is able to cure that sickness. What are they? Wearing robes of cast-off rags cures the base desire of a monk for robes. Living on alms cures the base desire for food. Dwelling at the foot of a tree cures the base desire for bedding and seats. Pacification of body and mind cures the base desire of a monk for existence. By these four medicines eliminating these four sicknesses, this is called the noble conduct. Thus the noble conduct is called having few desires and knowing contentment.

In peace there are four kinds of happiness. What are the four? The happiness of going forth, the happiness of peace, the happiness of cessation, and the happiness of complete fulfillment. Attaining these four kinds of happiness is called peace. Because one possesses the four diligences, it is called diligence. Because one possesses the four close applications of mindfulness, it is called right close application of mindfulness. Because one possesses the four meditative concentrations, it is called right meditative absorption. Because one sees the four noble truths, it is called right wisdom. Because all afflictions are utterly severed, it is called liberation. Because all the faults of affliction are condemned, it is called the praise of liberation.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses these ten qualities of Dharma and abides in them does indeed see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, yet it has not become clear.

Furthermore, O son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, upon hearing this sūtra, draws near to it and applies himself diligently. Relinquishing all worldly possessions is called having few desires. After going forth, not giving rise to a mind of regret is called knowing contentment. Knowing contentment, dwelling in solitude and abandoning crowds is called peace. One who does not know contentment takes no delight in solitude. One who knows contentment always delights in solitude and peace, and while constantly dwelling in a place of solitude and peace, thinks to himself: all people of the world consider me to have attained the fruit of the renunciant life, yet I have not truly attained it — why then should I deceive others? Having thought thus, striving diligently to cultivate the fruit of the renunciant path is called diligence. Drawing near to and cultivating great nirvāṇa is called right close application of mindfulness. Inclining toward and engaging in divine conduct is called right meditative absorption. Abiding in that meditative absorption, seeing rightly and knowing rightly is called right wisdom. Through seeing and knowing rightly, becoming free from bondage to all afflictions is called liberation. A bodhisattva of the tenth ground proclaiming the qualities of nirvāṇa for the sake of sentient

beings is called the praise of liberation.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in and is endowed with those ten qualities of Dharma does indeed see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, yet it has not become clear.

Furthermore, O son of good family, having few desires means: whether a monk dwells in solitude sitting upright without lying down, or abides at the foot of a tree —

or dwells in a charnel ground, or dwells in an unsheltered place, or sits upon a mat of grass and goes on alms-round, being content with however much he receives; or who uses only one seat, or does not eat more than one meal, or possesses only the three robes, or carries nothing but rags gathered from charnel grounds — this is having few desires. When one who practices in such a way does not give rise to a mind of regret, that is contentment. Cultivating meditative absorption in solitude is peace. Not abandoning the awakening mind of unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening even after attaining the fourth fruit is diligence. Keeping the mind one-pointedly upon the Tathāgata as permanent, unchanging, and unmoving is the establishment of right mindfulness. Cultivating the eight liberations is right meditative absorption. Attaining the four thorough analytical knowledges is right wisdom. Being free from the seven underlying tendencies is liberation. Proclaiming the qualities of nirvāṇa by saying that great nirvāṇa is free from ten characteristics — that is the praise of liberation.

What are those ten characteristics? They are: birth, aging, illness, death, form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and impermanence. To be free from these ten characteristics is what is called great nirvāṇa.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in and is endowed with those ten qualities of Dharma does indeed see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, yet it has not become clear.

Furthermore, O son of good family, having many desires for gain and fame means: attending upon kings, ministers, the warrior caste (kṣatriya), brahmins, the lowest caste, and the merchant caste, and saying, "I have attained everything from the fruit of stream-entry up to the fruit of arhatship." And for the sake of gain and fame, in all four modes of conduct, even down to the act of urinating and defecating, whenever one sees a donor one makes obeisance, goes forth to meet them, and flatters them. To overcome such base desires is having few desires. Although the afflictions have not yet been fully

purified, to act in conformity with the deeds of the Tathāgata is contentment.

O son of good family, these two qualities of Dharma are the proximate cause and condition for mindfulness and meditative absorption. Those who share the same preceptors and masters will constantly praise them, and I too have always praised throughout all the sūtras the qualities of these two qualities of Dharma. Whoever is endowed with these two qualities of Dharma has drawn near to the gateway of great nirvāṇa and to the five kinds of well-being. This is peace. The restraint of moral discipline is diligence. Possessing conscience and shame is right mindfulness. Not perceiving the characteristics of mind is right meditative absorption. Not seeking the cause of the intrinsic nature and defining characteristics of phenomena is right wisdom. The thorough cutting off of afflictions through the absence of defining characteristics is liberation. Praising the sūtras of the complete parinirvāṇa is what is called the praise of liberation.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, who abides in those ten qualities of Dharma does indeed see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, yet it has not become clear.

O son of good family, you asked: with what kind of eye does a bodhisattva of the tenth ground see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood without it becoming clear, and with what kind of eye does the Blessed One, a buddha, see it with full clarity? O son of good family, seeing with the eye of wisdom is unclear. Seeing with the buddha-eye is clear. Practicing the conduct of awakening is unclear. The absence of any such conduct is clear. Because of abiding on the tenth ground, one sees, yet it is not clear. Because of neither abiding nor moving, it has become clear.

A bodhisattva, a great being, sees through the condition of wisdom, and that seeing is unclear. The Blessed One, a buddha, sees with full clarity by having severed cause and result, and omniscience is called the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. A bodhisattva of the tenth ground is not called omniscient, and therefore, though he sees, it has not become clear.

O son of good family, there are two kinds of seeing: seeing with the eye, and seeing through hearing. The Blessed One, a buddha, sees the intrinsic nature of buddhahood with the buddha-eye, as one sees an āmalaka fruit lying in the palm of one's hand. A bodhisattva of the tenth ground sees the intrinsic nature of buddhahood only through hearing, and therefore it has not become clear. A bodhisattva of the tenth ground knows with certainty that he himself will

undoubtedly attain unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, yet he does not know that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is present in all sentient beings.

O son of good family, furthermore, seeing with the eye means that the Blessed One, a buddha, and bodhisattvas of the tenth ground see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. And seeing through hearing means that all sentient beings and those up through the ninth ground see the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. If, upon hearing that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is present in all sentient beings, a bodhisattva does not give rise to a mind of faith, that is not called seeing through hearing.

O son of good family, if any son of good family or daughter of good family wishes to see the Tathāgata, they should uphold, memorize, read aloud, recite, transcribe, expound, and thoroughly contemplate the twelve branches of scripture.

The bodhisattva, the great being, Lion's Roar then asked: Blessed One, if all sentient beings do not seek the defining characteristic of the Tathāgata's mind, how could they come to seek it through investigation?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, if all sentient beings, who do not truly know the defining characteristic of the Tathāgata's mind, wish to realize and know it, they will come to know it through two kinds of causes and conditions. What are these? Seeing with the eye, and seeing through hearing.

Seeing all the bodily activities of the Tathāgata, however many there may be, is the Tathāgata — and that is called seeing with the eye. If one realizes the activities of the Tathāgata's speech, one should understand that to be the Tathāgata — and that is called seeing through hearing.

Seeing that his form and appearance are incomparable, unlike those of all sentient beings, one should understand that to be the Tathāgata — and that is seeing with the eye. Hearing his supremely exalted, most excellent voice, unlike the voices and tones of sentient beings, one should understand that to be the Tathāgata — and that is seeing through hearing.

Examining whether the Tathāgata performs miraculous deeds for the sake of sentient beings or for the sake of gain and fame, and seeing that he does so for the sake of sentient beings and not for gain and fame — one should understand that to be the Tathāgata, and that is seeing with the eye. When the Tathāgata, through the gnosis that knows the minds of others, attends to

sentient beings, examining whether he teaches the Dharma for the sake of gain and fame or for the sake of sentient beings, and seeing that it is for the sake of sentient beings and not for gain and fame — one should understand that to be the Tathāgata, and that is seeing through hearing.

Examining how the Tathāgata came to possess this body, and for what reason he took on this body —

— and for whose sake he took on this body — is seeing with the eye. Understanding how the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma, for what reason he teaches the Dharma, and to whom he teaches the Dharma — that is seeing through hearing.

When he is harmed by unwholesome acts of body yet does not become angry — one should understand that to be the Tathāgata, and that is seeing with the eye. When he is harmed by unwholesome acts of speech yet does not become angry — one should understand that to be the Tathāgata, and that is seeing through hearing.

He in whose case the bodhisattva, immediately after birth, took seven steps in each of the ten directions; in whose case the yakṣa kings Mañibhadra and Pūrṇabhadra held parasols and banners in offering and roused countless and boundless world-systems, while a golden-hued radiance blazed and shimmered, filling the empty sky; in whose case the nāga kings Nanda and Upananda used their miraculous power to bathe the bodhisattva's body; in whose case the forms of the gods of the world came to receive him and make obeisance; in whose case the sage Asita joined his palms in reverence and paid homage; in whose case the desire for the pleasures of youth was abandoned like spittle; who was not deceived by worldly joys; who, having gone forth from home into homelessness, delighted at the end in cultivating the path; who, in order to demolish wrong views, practiced austerities for six years; who remained equal and even toward all sentient beings without duality; whose mind ever abided in meditative absorption, undisturbed from the very beginning, without distraction; whose body was beautifully adorned with the major and minor marks; in whose presence, wherever he went, the sounds of drums and cymbals arose in harmony of themselves; upon whose body, though clothing touched it with four fingers' breadth, it did not fall; who, when walking, gazed directly ahead and did not look to the right or left; who did not hastily swallow what was placed in his mouth; at whose seat, when he rose from where he had been sitting, the grass was neither stirred nor

disturbed; and who, though he went to teach the Dharma in order to tame sentient beings, was seen to be utterly without pride — seeing all this is seeing with the eye.

Now, when the bodhisattva had taken those seven steps and then said, "This body of mine is the last of inner existences," and when the sage Asita joined his palms and spoke thus: "Great King, know this: the prince Siddhārtha will without any doubt attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — he will not remain a householder and become a wheel-turning king. Why is that? Because the marks are clearly manifest. The marks of a wheel-turning king are not clearly manifest, whereas the marks of the prince Siddhārtha are supremely clear — therefore he will assuredly attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening." And when, having seen old age, sickness, and death, the prince then thought thus: "All sentient beings are deeply pitiable — they go about always accompanied by birth, aging, sickness, and death such as this, and through not understanding they endure suffering without end. I must put a stop to this." He then went to the sage Ālāra, who possessed the five superknowledges, trained in the meditative absorption of nothingness, and attained it — but afterwards saw its faults. Then again he went to the sage Udraka, trained in the meditative absorption of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, attained it, but understood that this too was not nirvāṇa but a condition of cyclic existence. For six years he practiced austerities, yet obtained nothing at all, and then spoke thus: "Even having practiced these austerities, it is pointless — I have obtained nothing whatsoever. If there were something genuine, it would be fitting that I attain it. Since I have not attained anything, judging from the fact that I have obtained nothing, this is the path of wrong view, not the path of what is right." And having said this —

After attaining complete awakening, the Brahmā King made this request of the Tathāgata: would the Tathāgata be pleased to open wide the gates of Dharma for sentient beings with the unsurpassed elixir of his teaching? The Blessed One then spoke to the Brahmā King thus: "All sentient beings are perpetually veiled by the obscuration of affliction, and are therefore unable to take hold of the words of my sacred Dharma." The Brahmā King again implored: "Blessed One, among all sentient beings there are three kinds — those of sharp faculties, those of middling faculties, and those of dull faculties. Those of sharp faculties will be able to receive and hold what is taught and explained. May you please teach and expound." The Blessed One declared: "Great King,

attend to this with very great care and listen well. I shall open the gates of the elixir for all sentient beings." Having said this, at the city of Vārāṇasī he turned the wheel of the sacred Dharma in full and taught the path of the Middle Way.

And what is that? The Middle Way is this: although all the afflictions of sentient beings have not been overcome, it is not the case that they cannot be overcome; yet neither have they been overcome, nor do they remain un-overcome — that is the Middle Way. No sentient being has yet been liberated, yet it is not that none will be liberated — that is the Middle Way. Not everything is accomplished, yet not everything is unaccomplished — that is the Middle Way. Whatever one teaches, one does not grasp oneself as the teacher nor grasp others as the students — that is the Middle Way. Teaching is not done for the sake of gain, yet it is not the case that no fruit will be obtained — that is the Middle Way. Words that are correct, words that are true, words that are timely, words that are straight, and words that say nothing meaningless — understanding such supreme and sacred Dharma as this is what is seen through hearing. Son of good family, the defining characteristic of the Tathāgata's mind is not something that is seen. If any son of good family or daughter of good family wishes to see the Tathāgata, they should abide in two things: cause and condition.

Then the great bodhisattva Śiṃhaghoṣa again addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, you taught earlier that four types of persons are comparable to the fruit of the mango tree. Now, there are some persons whose conduct is refined but whose mind is not genuine; some whose mind is refined but whose conduct is not genuine; some whose mind is refined and whose conduct too is genuine; and some whose mind is not refined and whose conduct also is not genuine. How shall the first two types be known? Even if one abides in the two ways you, Blessed One, have described, one will not come to know them."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, excellent! Son of good family, those two types of persons are indeed, in truth, as difficult to know as in the simile of the mango fruit. Because they are so difficult to know, I have taught in the sūtras that one should dwell together with them. If, even while dwelling together, one does not know, then one should associate with them for a long time. If, even after long association, one does not know, then one should examine with wisdom. If one still does not comprehend even through wisdom, then one should examine very thoroughly. Through thorough examination one will come to know whether they uphold moral discipline or whether their moral discipline

is impaired. Son of good family, if one possesses these four qualities — dwelling together, long association, wisdom, and thorough examination — one will come to know whether a person upholds moral discipline or whether their moral discipline is impaired.

Son of good family, there are two kinds of moral discipline, and correspondingly two kinds of guarding it. What are they? Discipline that is perfected, and discipline that is not yet perfected. There are also cases of upholding discipline through cause and condition, and so the wise and discerning person should examine whether someone's vow of moral discipline is being upheld as perfected discipline for the sake of gain and fame."

Son of good family, the moral discipline of the Tathāgata is called perfected discipline because it is free from cause and condition. For this reason, even when unwholesome sentient beings harm and injure a bodhisattva, no mind arises in that bodhisattva that is obstructed by aversion. Therefore a Tathāgata is said to be endowed with the holding of perfected discipline.

Son of good family, once in a former time I was residing with five hundred attendants including Śāriputra in the city of Campā in the central land. A hawk seized a dove, and the dove, utterly terrified, took shelter in the shadow of Śāriputra and trembled like a tree in the wind. When it moved into my shadow, however, its body and mind became at ease and it became free of fear. Know therefore that because the shadow of a buddha, the Blessed One, possesses such power, one who abides in it is a holder of perfected discipline. Son of good family, if even śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas cannot be attained through discipline that is not yet perfected, what need is there to speak of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?

Furthermore, there are two kinds: discipline held for the sake of gain, and discipline held for the sake of the sacred Dharma. Know that one who holds discipline for the sake of gain does not, through that discipline, behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata. Though such a person hears the name of the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata, one should not say that hearing constitutes seeing. But know that one who holds discipline for the sake of the sacred Dharma does behold, through that discipline, the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata. That may be called seeing with the eye, and it may also be called seeing through hearing.

Furthermore, there are two kinds: that which is hard to dislodge because the root is deep, and that which is easy to shake because the root is shallow.

Cultivating emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness in meditation is called hard to dislodge because the root is deep. If one does not apply oneself to these three kinds of meditative absorption, then even while practicing and cultivating, one will come to twenty-five existences — this is called easy to shake because the root is shallow.

The thirty-seventh fascicle.

Furthermore, there are two kinds: discipline practiced for one's own sake, and discipline practiced for the sake of sentient beings. One who practices for the sake of sentient beings beholds the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata.

As for the vow of moral discipline, there are also two kinds: discipline that is a restraint by intrinsic nature, and discipline that is a restraint through the condition of another. As for the former, one who has undertaken discipline without it ever being broken throughout immeasurable births — even if the country is in turmoil, even if one encounters an unwholesome spiritual friend, even if one encounters an evil age and hears perverse and corrupt teachings, or even if one dwells alongside wrong views — in that situation, though there be no ceremony of undertaking discipline, one is restrained just as one was at the very beginning of undertaking it, without impairment. This is called discipline that is a restraint by intrinsic nature. As for one who attains discipline through approaching a preceptor and the Saṅgha, making the request, and performing the fourfold act — that discipline, received through the condition of the preceptor, the master, fellow students, and the spiritual friend, who correct and instruct one, knowing what is to be done and what is not to be done through listening to the Dharma, through expounding it, and through knowledge of all proper conduct — this is called discipline that is a restraint through the condition of another.

Son of good family, one who is restrained by intrinsic nature beholds the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata with the eye; and this may also be called seeing through hearing.

As for moral discipline, there are also two kinds: the discipline of a śrāvaka, and the discipline of a bodhisattva.

From the first arousing of the awakening mind up to unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening, it is called the discipline of a bodhisattva. That which is attained from the contemplation of bare bones up to the fruit of arhatship is called the discipline of a śrāvaka. And here one should understand that

whoever upholds the discipline of a śrāvaka does not behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the Tathāgata. Whoever upholds the discipline of a bodhisattva, one should understand, does attain unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening, and does behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha, the Tathāgata, and nirvāṇa.

The bodhisattva Simḥasvara then asked: Blessed One, for what cause and by what condition does one take up and become bound by moral discipline?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is in order to have a mind free of regret. And why is there no regret? Because one experiences happiness. And why does one experience happiness? Because one has thoroughly abandoned. And why does one thoroughly abandon? Because one is supremely at ease. And why is one supremely at ease? Because one is a yogi engaged in meditative concentration. And why is one engaged in meditative concentration? Because one knows and sees correctly. And why does one know and see correctly? Because one sees the faults of saṃsāra. And why does one see the faults of saṃsāra? Because the mind is without attachment. And why is the mind without attachment? Because one attains liberation. And why liberation? Because one attains the great unsurpassed nirvāṇa. And why does one attain the great nirvāṇa? Because one attains permanence, happiness, self, and utter purity. And why permanence, happiness, self, and utter purity? Because one attains the state of neither arising nor ceasing. And why neither arising nor ceasing? Because one beholds the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Therefore the bodhisattva upholds moral discipline that is utterly pure and perfected through intrinsic nature.

Son of good family, monks who are bound by the discipline of moral precepts do not deliberately seek or aspire after a mind free of regret, yet they naturally attain a mind free of regret. Why is this? Because the nature of reality is such that it becomes so. Happiness, thorough abandonment, supreme ease, correct knowledge and vision, seeing the faults of saṃsāra, a mind without attachment, liberation, nirvāṇa, permanence, happiness, self, utter purity, neither arising nor ceasing, and beholding the intrinsic nature of a buddha — these they do not deliberately seek, yet they come to attain them spontaneously. Why is this? Because the nature of reality is such that it becomes so.

The bodhisattva Simḥasvara then asked: Blessed One, if from the cause of moral discipline one attains the fruit of a mind free of regret, and from the

cause of liberation one attains the fruit of nirvāṇa, then if there is no cause for moral discipline, there is likewise no fruit for nirvāṇa. That which has no cause is called permanent. If nirvāṇa has no cause, then surely it is impermanent. If it is so, then nirvāṇa would have come into existence from a state of prior non-existence. If something comes into existence from a state of prior non-existence, it would be impermanent — just like a butter lamp. And if nirvāṇa is like that, for what reason does one designate it as self, as happiness, and as utterly pure?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, excellent, excellent! Because you have planted roots of virtue before countless buddhas, you have the confidence to ask the Tathāgata about these profound matters. Son of good family, because you have not lost the memory of former times, you have posed this question in just this way.

I recall that in the past, an immeasurable number of eons ago, a Tathāgata named Suprāpta appeared in the world in the land of Śerakya. At that time, that Tathāgata taught this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa for thirty million years, and both you and I were gathered in that assembly. When I asked that Blessed One about these very matters, the Blessed One at that time entered into meditative absorption (samādhi) for the sake of sentient beings, and so did not explain this point.

Excellent, O great being! Recall that former situation well, hold it deeply in mind, and listen steadily — I shall explain it to you fully.

Moral discipline (śīla) also has a cause. What is that cause? It is the hearing of the holy Dharma. The hearing of the holy Dharma also has a cause. What is that cause? It is reliance upon a spiritual friend. Reliance upon a spiritual friend also has a cause, and that cause is a mind of faith. The mind of faith also has a cause. That cause has two aspects: the hearing of the Dharma and the contemplation of its meaning.

Son of good family, the mind of faith arises from the cause of hearing the Dharma, and the hearing of the Dharma also arises from the cause of a mind of faith. These two phenomena become cause and effect in mutual relation: each serves as cause, each serves as cause of a cause, each serves as result, and each serves as result of a result.

Son of good family, consider the analogy of a Nirgrantha (a Jain ascetic) who places a pot on a tripod of three sticks: each stick is the cause of the others, and the fruit of each is the others — they cannot be separated out individually.

Son of good family, just as ignorance is a condition for formations, and formations are in turn a condition for ignorance — so ignorance and formations become cause, and cause of cause, and result, and result of result — likewise, all the way through to birth, which is a condition for old age and death, and old age and death in turn a condition for birth. Birth and old age-and-death thus become cause, and cause of cause, and result, and result of result.

Son of good family, birth and the phenomena that are produced cannot arise of themselves. Because they do not arise of themselves, they arise through being generated by birth. Birth does not arise of itself; it arises through the power of what generates it. Therefore both births become cause, and cause of cause, and result, and result of result.

Son of good family, the mind of faith and the hearing of the Dharma are similar to this.

Son of good family, that which is result and yet is not cause — that is the Great Nirvāṇa. Why is it called a result? Because it is the unsurpassed result, the fruit of the ascetic and the brahmin. It is called a result because it severs cyclic existence (saṃsāra) and because it has overcome the afflictions. It is called a result because all afflictions have been utterly repudiated. The afflictions are spoken of as that which is defective.

Son of good family, nirvāṇa has no cause; its essential nature is simply result. Why is that? Because it is without arising and without cessation, without agency, neither compounded (saṃskṛta) nor uncompounded (asaṃskṛta), permanent and unchanging, without location, and without beginning or end.

Son of good family, if nirvāṇa had a cause, one could not call it nirvāṇa. The word "fully" (parinirvāṇa) refers to what pertains to a cause; the word "nirvāṇa" refers to the absence thereof. Because nirvāṇa has no cause, it is called "complete nirvāṇa" (parinirvāṇa).

The bodhisattva Śiṃhanāda then posed this question: As the Blessed One has declared that nirvāṇa has no cause — that statement does not seem right to me. If one says "there is no," this meaning connects with six implications. What are those six? One says "there is no" in the sense that it does not exist by virtue of coming...

One says "there is no" in the sense that, just as all phenomena lack a self and what belongs to a self, so too there is an absence of anything in between — as when worldly people say of the ocean "there is no water" or "there is no sun or

moon." One says "there is no" in the sense of scarcity — as when worldly people say of food that is not salty "there is no saltiness," or of a sweet liquid that has little sweetness "there is no sweetness." One says "there is no" in the sense of not having experienced something — as when a person of low birth has not experienced the Dharma of a brahmin and says "there is no brahmin Dharma." One says "there is no" in the sense of holding to bad and non-virtuous Dharma — as when worldly people who hold to sinful, non-virtuous Dharma are said not to be renunciants (śramaṇas) or brahmins, so people say "there are no renunciants or brahmins." One says "there is no" in the sense of the absence of a counterpart — as when, because white is absent, one says "it is black," or because light is absent, one says "there is no light." Nirvāṇa, O Blessed One, is similar to these: something does exist, yet because it has no cause, one speaks of "nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One then declared: Son of good family, you have spoken in six modes — yet to find an analogy for passing beyond sorrow among them, one should not take a simile for non-existence; rather, one should take the simile of the absence of something in between. Son of good family, the essential nature of nirvāṇa is indeed something that exists — like, for example, the absence of self and what belongs to self. Son of good family, worldly phenomena cannot rightly be compared to nirvāṇa, and therefore the similes of those six things are not fitting illustrations. Son of good family, all phenomena are without self, yet this nirvāṇa truly does have a self. It is for this reason that, although nirvāṇa has no cause, its essential nature is itself a fruit. What is a cause but not a fruit is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha, because it is not born from a cause. What is a cause but not a fruit is called "not a fruit" in the sense that it is not the fruit of a monk — that is why it is called "not a fruit." It is called "a cause" because it illuminates causes.

Son of good family, causes are of two kinds: the cause of arising and the cause of illumination. Of these, what brings phenomena into being is the cause of arising. What makes things manifest through the light of a lamp is called the cause of illumination. Thorough affliction is the cause of arising. The parents of sentient beings are the cause of illumination. Seeds and the like are the cause of arising. Earth, water, manure, and the like are the cause of illumination. Again, the cause of arising is this: through the six perfections one attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. The cause of illumination is this: through the intrinsic nature of a buddha one attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Further, the cause of illumination is: the six

perfections and the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Further, the cause of arising is: the meditative absorption called "the courageous advance" attaining unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Again, the cause of illumination is: the noble eightfold path attaining unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Again, the cause of arising is: the six perfections of a mind of faith.

The bodhisattva *Simhanāda* then posed this question: Blessed One, in accordance with what the Blessed One has taught — what is the meaning of "seeing the Tathāgata" and "seeing the intrinsic nature of a buddha"? Blessed One, the body of the Tathāgata has no marks or form. It is not long. It is not short. It is not white. It is not black. It has no directions or boundaries.

It does not abide in the three realms. It does not possess the characteristics of conditioned things. It is not known through visual consciousness. If the intrinsic nature of a buddha is likewise, how could it be seen?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the body of a buddha has two aspects: the permanent and the impermanent. Of these, the impermanent is what is called "seeing with the eye" — that is, the form manifested through skillful means in order to liberate all sentient beings. The permanent is also called "seeing with the eye" and "seeing through hearing" — that is, the Tathāgata's body of liberation.

The intrinsic nature of a buddha also has two aspects: what is seen and what is not seen. Of these, what is seen pertains to the tenth-ground bodhisattvas and to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. What is not seen pertains to all sentient beings. "Seeing with the eye" means that the tenth-ground bodhisattvas and the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, behold with their vision the intrinsic nature of a buddha present in sentient beings. "Seeing through hearing" means that all sentient beings and the ninth-ground bodhisattvas hear that the intrinsic nature of a buddha and the body of the Tathāgata exist.

This too has two aspects: what has form and what is without form. Of these, what has form is the liberation body of the Tathāgata. What is without form is the Tathāgata's complete relinquishment of all form and characteristics.

The intrinsic nature of a buddha also has two aspects: what has form and what is without form. Of these, what has form is unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. What is without form arises from the most inferior worldly beings all the way up through the tenth-ground bodhisattvas — and it is called "without form" because it is not clearly seen even by the tenth-ground bodhisattvas.

Son of good family, again the intrinsic nature of a buddha has two aspects: what has form and what is without form. Of these, what has form pertains to buddhas and bodhisattvas. What is without form pertains to all sentient beings. What is seen with the eye is form. What is seen through hearing is without form. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is neither inner nor outer. Although it is neither inner nor outer, it is not nonexistent and it is not empty; therefore it is said that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

The bodhisattva Siṃhanāda then posed this question: Blessed One, as the Blessed One has taught — just as cream is present within milk, so in all sentient beings there is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, as mighty as a vajra, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha is like the pure essence of butter. If that is so, why has the Blessed One declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is neither outer nor inner?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, I did not say that cream exists within milk as such; rather, I said that cream exists because cream comes from milk.

He asked: Blessed One, do all phenomena that are subject to birth exist separately at their own respective times?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, when milk exists there is no cream, nor butter, nor clarified butter, nor the essence of butter — and yet because all sentient beings cling to it as milk, I said that cream does not exist within milk. If something does exist, why would a skilled person not give it two names, as in the case of one who is called both a goldsmith and a blacksmith? Therefore, at the time of cream, neither milk nor butter nor clarified butter nor the essence of butter is present. So too, sentient beings hold that since cream is not milk, butter, clarified butter, and the essence of butter do not exist within it. One should understand it in that same way, extending the analysis all the way through to the essence of butter.

Son of good family, causes have two aspects: the true cause and —

the cause-as-condition. Of these, the true cause is illustrated by how cream arises from milk. The cause-as-condition means that because cream arises from milk through conditions such as warmth and impurity, one speaks of the intrinsic nature of cream as being present within milk.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of cream is not present within milk, that would seem to be like its not being present in a horn either — so why does cream not arise from a horn?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, cream does arise from a horn as well. Why is that? I have taught the cause-as-condition as having two aspects: impurity and warmth. The intrinsic nature of a horn, by reason of its impurity, is what causes it to become cream.

Lion's Roar said: Blessed One, if cream can arise from a horn, why is it that those who seek cream desire milk and do not desire a horn?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, that is precisely why I have explained the two kinds of cause: the true cause and the cause-as-condition.

Lion's Roar said: If the intrinsic nature of cream has never been present within milk from the beginning and is present now, then since a mango tree likewise has never been present within milk from the beginning, both are equally absent — so why does a mango fruit not arise from it?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, a mango tree too would grow from milk. If milk were poured at the base of a tree, within a single night five cubits of growth would arise. For that very reason I have taught the two kinds of cause.

Son of good family, if all phenomena arose from a single cause, one could equally object: why does a mango tree not arise from within milk? Son of good family, take the example of the four great elements: they are the cause and condition for all material form, yet they differ from and are incompatible with the defining characteristics of each individual material form — each is distinct and separate. For that very reason, a mango tree does not arise from milk.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has taught — the true cause and the cause-as-condition, these two kinds of cause — what is the cause for the intrinsic nature of buddhahood within sentient beings?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood within sentient beings also has two kinds of cause: the true cause and the cause-as-condition. Of these, the true cause is sentient beings themselves. The cause-as-condition is the six perfections (pāramitās).

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar said: Blessed One, I hold that the intrinsic nature of cream is definitely present within milk. Why do I say this? I observe that in the world, those who seek cream seek out milk and never seek out water —

therefore I hold that the intrinsic nature of cream is present within milk.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, what you are asking is not quite the right way to put it. Why? Consider someone who wishes to see their own face reflected and so looks into a sword blade.

Lion's Roar said: Blessed One, by that reasoning, the intrinsic nature of cream must be present in milk — for if one's reflection were not present within the sword blade, why would one look into it?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if one's reflection were definitely and truly present within the sword blade, then why is it that when one holds the blade upright one sees a long face, and when one holds it sideways one sees a wide face? If it were truly one's own face, why would it appear elongated? And if it were some other face, why would one say "the reflection of my own face"? And if, through the condition of one's own face, one were seeing another's face, why does one not see the reflection of a horse's or a donkey's face?

Lion's Roar said: Blessed One, it is because the eye's light reaches there that one sees one's face elongated in the water.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the eye's light does not truly reach there. Why is that?

Because one sees both near and far simultaneously and all at once, yet between those two points one sees no object whatsoever. Son of good family, if it were the case that the eye's light travels there and thereby enables seeing, then when all sentient beings look, why do they not burn up? And if someone at a great distance sees a white object and is uncertain whether it is a goose, a flag, a person, or a tree, that would be unreasonable. If the eye's light truly travels there, then why does one see the contents inside a crystal, and the fish and stones inside a spring? And if seeing occurs without the light traveling there, then why does one see objects inside a crystal and yet fail to see forms on the other side of a wall? Therefore the idea that one sees at a distance because the eye's light travels there is not so.

Son of good family, just as you said: if yogurt already existed within milk, why would those who sell milk take only the price of milk and not the price of yogurt? Those who sell mares take only the price of the mare and not the price of the foal. Son of good family, people in the world take a wife because they have no son. If a wife becomes pregnant one would not say she has a

daughter. And it is not right to say one takes a wife because a daughter already has the nature of a son. Why is that? If the nature of a son existed, it would follow that a brother also exists. If a brother exists, he would become a sibling. Why is that? Because they come from the same womb. Therefore I have taught that a daughter does not have the nature of a son.

If the nature of yogurt existed within milk, why would it not simultaneously possess all five tastes at once? If the defining characteristic of a nyagrodha tree growing to a span of five fathoms existed within the seed, why would the distinct shapes and forms of the sprout, trunk, branches, leaves, flowers, fruit, and so forth not appear all at once simultaneously? Son of good family, when milk, at the stage of being milk, is distinct in form, distinct in taste, distinct in result — all the way through to the essence of butter — how can one say that the nature of yogurt exists within milk?

Son of good family, consider a person who says, "I shall drink butter tomorrow," and says even today, "I have already drunk it." Likewise, whoever says, "The nature of yogurt is definitely present in milk," is just the same.

Son of good family, consider a person who, using a pen, paper, ink, and so forth, produces written letters. There were originally no letters in the paper. Because they did not exist from the beginning, they come to be produced in dependence on conditions. If something existed from the beginning, many causes and conditions would be unnecessary. Consider blue and yellow pigments mixed together: they become green pigment. Neither of those two pigments originally had the nature of green. If it existed from the beginning, what would be the need to mix them?

Son of good family, consider that sentient beings are sustained by means of food. Truly, within food there is no life. If life were inherently existent therein, then even before the food is eaten, the food itself would be life.

Son of good family, because all phenomena are without inherent nature from the outset, contemplating that point he spoke these verses:

What has no beginning exists now.

What has a beginning does not exist now.

All phenomena of existence throughout the three times —
there is no fixed abiding of that kind.

Son of good family, all phenomena arise through causes and conditions and cease through causes and conditions.

Son of good family, if the nature of a buddha existed within sentient beings, it would follow that all sentient beings right now would possess the body of a buddha just as I do. The buddha-nature of sentient beings does not decay, does not deteriorate, cannot be seized, cannot be grasped, cannot be bound, cannot be designated —

just as empty space exists within sentient beings. Because it is unobstructed, empty space exists within all sentient beings, yet none of them individually sees their own empty space. If empty space did not exist within sentient beings, there would be no going and coming, no moving and staying, no sitting and lying down, and no birth or growth. For that reason I declared in the sūtras that the expanse of space exists within all sentient beings. That very expanse of space is what is called empty space. The intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings is similar to this — just as a precious jewel, it is seen to a small degree by bodhisattvas of the tenth ground. Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings is the domain of the buddhas; it is not something known by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. Because all sentient beings do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, they are perpetually seized upon by afflictions and wander in cyclic existence. Through seeing the intrinsic nature of a buddha, one is no longer bound by all-pervading afflictions; one is fully liberated from cyclic existence and attains the great nirvāṇa.

The bodhisattva Simhaghoṣa (Lion-Voice) then asked: Blessed One, the existence of the intrinsic nature of a buddha within all sentient beings is comparable to the existence of the intrinsic nature of yogurt within milk. If the intrinsic nature of yogurt did not exist within milk, then why did the Blessed One speak of two kinds of cause — the cause of reality and the conditioning cause? The conditioning cause consists of warmth and ferment. Space is without intrinsic nature, and so has no conditioning cause.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if the intrinsic nature of butter were definitively present within milk, what need would there be for conditioning causes?

The bodhisattva Simhaghoṣa replied: Blessed One, it is precisely because the intrinsic nature is present that a conditioning cause is sought. And why? In order to make it manifest. The conditioning cause is a cause of making visible. Blessed One, consider: when objects are already there in the darkness, one lights a lamp in order to see them. If they were not there from the beginning, what would the lamp illuminate? In the same way, because clay is present in

the earth, a person, water, a wheel, a cord, and a stick are causes of making visible. The fruit of the banyan tree likewise has earth, water, and dung as causes of making visible. Similarly, in the case of milk, warmth and ferment become causes of making visible. Therefore, although the intrinsic nature is present from the very beginning, it depends on causes of making visible, and through them it becomes seen. For that reason it is evident that yogurt has been present in milk from the very beginning.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if there were definitely an intrinsic nature of yogurt present in milk, that very thing would become a cause of making visible. But if it were itself a cause of making visible, what need would there be to make it visible in the first place? Son of good family, if that cause of making visible were self-luminous by its very nature, it would be fitting that it always illuminated itself. And if it does not illuminate itself, it cannot illuminate others. To say that the cause of making visible has two natures — illuminating itself and illuminating others — is not the case. Why? How could what is one thing as a cause of making visible become two? If it became two, milk too would become two. And if milk does not have a twofold nature, why should that which is solely a cause of making visible become two?

Simhaghoṣa replied: Blessed One, just as worldly people speak of "self" and "other," so too the cause of making visible is of that same kind — it illuminates both self and other.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if the cause of making visible were as you say, it should not be called a cause of making visible at all. Why? Number counts forms of self and other, and so the word "eight" is used — that is the essential nature of form. Yet for the self there is no defining characteristic of a cause of making visible. Because there is no defining characteristic of illumination, it is by the power of the intrinsic nature of wisdom that self and other come to be counted. Therefore the cause of making visible cannot illuminate the self, and it cannot illuminate others either.

If the buddha-nature exists in all sentient beings, why would it be necessary to accumulate an immeasurable store of merit? If that accumulation were the cause of making visible, it would be comparable to the destruction of curds. And if one were to hold that the result is necessarily present in the cause, then moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom could not arise and grow. For I myself have seen that in the world, people who previously had no moral discipline, no meditative absorption, and no wisdom have received instruction

from a preceptor and have, from the very beginning, arisen and grown directly. If what the preceptor teaches were the cause of making visible, then at the very moment of receiving instruction from the preceptor there would be no moral discipline, no meditative absorption, and no wisdom in the one being instructed. And if something were truly a matter of illumination — such that what does not yet exist would become illuminated — why should it be the case that moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom arise and grow only after illumination has occurred?

Simhaghoṣa asked: Blessed One, if there is no cause of making visible, why should the names "milk" and "curds" be assigned?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, there are three kinds of reply to an objection raised in debate. The first is a consequential reply: just as was said before — "What then is moral discipline? From the absence of remorse up to the attainment of great nirvāṇa." The second is a reply of silence: just as when a wanderer came to me and asked, "Is what is called 'self' permanent?" — at that time I said nothing. The third is a reply of doubt, such as the question posed here in this sūtra: "If the cause of making visible were to become two, why is there no duality in milk?" — these are the three.

Son of good family, I have now given a consequential reply: just as people in the world say, "If there is milk, without doubt curds exist, and therefore both milk and curds exist" — and they assign these names accordingly — so too with the buddha-nature: if there are sentient beings, there is buddha-nature, because it will be seen later.

Simhaghoṣa said: Blessed One, what the Blessed One has stated does not seem right to me. Why? The past has ceased, and the future has not yet arrived — so how can one speak of it as existing? If one says that what has not yet arrived exists, that too is untenable. It is like people in the world who, seeing that there is no child, say "There is no child." Since sentient beings do not possess the buddha-nature, why does the Blessed One say that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the past is to be called "existent." Consider, for example, a shoot that sprouts from the seed of a sour fruit-tree and brings forth fruit: the shoot too begins sweet, and yet from that point until the fruit appears it is just so — it ripens and becomes sour. Son of good family, the sour taste is not present in the seed, the shoot, or the period up to the fruit's arising; it arises from the color, form, and substance of the

fruit. Thus that sour taste, though absent from the beginning, has now come into being.

In this way, though absent from the beginning, it comes to exist now — yet this does not mean it lacks a beginningless cause. In this way, too, the seed from the beginning is something past, and yet it is called "existent." For this reason, the past is also called "existent."

Now, in what way is the future called "existent"? Consider, for example, a person who ploughs a field of sesame, and another person asks, "Why are you ploughing this? What is the point?" The ploughman replies, "There is oil here." Truly, the oil is not yet there — and yet, once the sesame ripens, the grain is gathered, pressed, pounded, and squeezed, and only then does the oil appear for the first time. Therefore, one should understand that this man is not speaking falsely. For this reason, the future too is called "existent."

Furthermore, in what way is the past called "existent"? Son of good family, consider a man who secretly slandered the king, and many years passed. Then the king came to hear of it, and upon hearing it asked him, "Why did you slander me?" The man replied, "Great King, I did not slander you." "And why not?" "Because the slander that was spoken has already ceased." The king said, "Both I and the slander exist right now — why then do you say it has ceased?" And on account of that cause and condition, the man's body and life were destroyed. Son of good family, though those two things — the king and the slander — were no longer truly present, the result was nonetheless not absent. For this reason, the past too is called "existent."

And once more, in what way is the future called "existent"? Consider a man who went to a potter's place and asked, "Do you have any pots?" The potter replied, "I have pots." In truth, the potter has no pots at that very moment — but because the clay is there, he says, "I have pots," and one should understand that he is not speaking falsely in saying so. For this reason, just as curds exist within milk, so too does the nature of buddhahood exist within sentient beings. If one wishes to see the nature of buddhahood, one must examine with great care the time, the measure, the shape, and the form. Therefore, my saying that the nature of buddhahood exists in all sentient beings is not untrue.

Lion's Roar then asked: If the nature of buddhahood were not present in all sentient beings, how could they attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening? If sentient beings can attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete

awakening through the cause of truth, then the cause of truth is precisely this: the nature of buddhahood. Blessed One, if the nyagrodha tree were not present in the fruit of the nyagrodha, why would it be called the fruit of the nyagrodha and not the fruit of the khadira? Blessed One, consider how it is not fitting to designate the lineage of Gautama as the lineage of Ātreya, nor to designate the lineage of Ātreya as the lineage of Gautama. In the same way, it is not fitting to call the fruit of the nyagrodha the fruit of the khadira, nor the fruit of the khadira the fruit of the nyagrodha. Just as the Blessed One is none other than one of the lineage of Gautama, so too is the nature of buddhahood in sentient beings like that. Therefore, I hold that the nature of buddhahood is present in all sentient beings.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the meaning that "the nyagrodha is present in the fruit" is not appropriate. If it were truly present, why is it not seen?

Son of good family, consider: things of the world, owing to the presence of causes and conditions, appear as though absent. What are these causes and conditions? They are as follows: not being seen because of distance, as in the tracks of birds in the sky; not being seen because of proximity, as in the dirt in one's own eye; not being seen because of deterioration, as in a root that has rotted; not being seen because of distraction of perception, as in a mind that is not one-pointed; and not being seen because of subtlety —

as with subtle particles; not being seen because of being obscured, as when stars are covered by clouds; not being seen because of the multitude, as when sesame is inside a heap of grain; and not being seen because of intermixture, as when sesame is placed within a heap of sesame.

Now, the nyagrodha tree is unlike those eight types of causes and conditions. If it were truly present, why is it not seen? If one says it is not seen because of subtlety or because of being obscured — that account, too, is untenable. Why? Because the characteristic mark of a tree is that it is gross. If it were by nature subtle, how could it grow? And if it were not seen because it is obscured, then it would follow that it is never seen at all. Since a previously gross nature was absent and yet now it is seen to be gross, that grossness has never had inherent existence from the beginning. Since what was previously unseen lacked any inherent nature, and yet now comes to be seen, that seeing likewise has no original inherent existence. And the fruit is the same: from the beginning the tree was absent, and that it should come to exist now involves

no fault.

The bodhisattva Simhaghoṣa asked: The Blessed One has taught two kinds of causes — a cause of truth and a cause of manifestation. In that regard, earth, water, and warmth are what function as the cause of manifestation for the nyagrodha fruit, and thus it grows from subtle to gross.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if it truly existed from the beginning, what need would there be for a cause of manifestation? And if it had no inherent existence from the beginning, what is there to manifest? Consider: if the nyagrodha has no inherent grossness from the beginning, and yet through a cause of manifestation it comes to arise as gross, then since both the seed and the tree seem equally absent, why does the khadira tree not grow from that seed?

Son of good family, if it were the case that the subtle is not seen but the gross is seen, then — just as a single particle is not seen but when many particles are gathered together they come to be seen — by the same logic, the gross fruit should be seen as well. And why? Because there is a sprout, a trunk, flowers, and fruit — and within each single fruit there are immeasurable seeds, and within each single seed there are immeasurable trees. It is for this reason that it is called "gross," and it is because it has thus become gross that it comes to be seen.

Son of good family, if the growth of the nyagrodha tree were due to an inherent nature of the nyagrodha seed truly present in the seed, then by eye one would see that seed being burned. And in that case, the nature of burning would likewise have existed from the very beginning. But if burning existed from the beginning, it would not be right for the tree to grow at all. Moreover, if all phenomena were arising and ceasing from the beginning, why would it be that one arose earlier and another ceases later — that they do not occur simultaneously? For these reasons, one should understand that there is no inherent nature.

The bodhisattva Simhaghoṣa asked: Blessed One, if, despite the nyagrodha fruit's having no inherent nature of a tree from the beginning, the tree comes to grow — and since both the tree and the seed seem equally absent — why does oil not come from that fruit?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, oil does in fact come from it. Though inherent nature is absent from the beginning, it comes to exist through causes and conditions.

Siṃhaghoṣa asked: Then why is it not called sesame oil?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, because it is not sesame. Son of good family, consider: through the condition of friction fire arises, and through the condition of water moisture arises — both arise from conditions, yet neither produces the other. The nyagrodha fruit and sesame oil are just the same: both arise from conditions, but the one does not produce the other. The nature of the nyagrodha fruit is beneficial for disorders of phlegm, while the nature of sesame oil is beneficial for disorders of wind.

Son of good family, consider: through the causes and conditions of the sugarcane plant, both sugar crystals and raw sugar arise. Thus from a single cause,

their colors and potencies are distinct. Sugar crystals are beneficial for disorders of bile, while raw sugar is beneficial for disorders of phlegm.

The bodhisattva Siṃhadhvaja then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, just as milk has no intrinsic nature of curd, sesame has no intrinsic nature of oil, the nyagrodha fruit has no intrinsic nature of wood, and clay has no intrinsic nature of a vessel — in the same way, if all sentient beings lack an intrinsic nature of buddhahood, then the statement made previously by the Blessed One, that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood and will therefore attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, is not tenable.

"Why so? Because gods and humans have no fixed intrinsic nature, and precisely because they lack such a fixed nature, a human can become a god and a god can become a human. Yet even that transformation occurs through the condition of karma, not through any intrinsic nature. Likewise, a bodhisattva, a great being, also attains unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through the condition of karma.

"Furthermore, if all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, for what cause and through what condition do those of wrong craving (mithyātrṣṇā), having severed the roots of virtue, fall into the hells? If the awakening mind were itself the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, it would follow that those of wrong craving could not cut it — which is reasonable. But if it could be cut, then it would be improper to call the intrinsic nature of buddhahood permanent. And if it is not permanent, one should not call it the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Again, if all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, why do we speak of first arousing the mind of awakening, of those who fall back, and of those who are irreversible? One who falls back, it must be held, is a person who lacks the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Blessed One, the way in which great bodhisattvas, noble great beings, arrive with single-minded resolve at unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening is this: through great loving-kindness and great compassion, seeing the afflictive faults of birth, aging, and death, they contemplate the freedom from those very afflictions of birth, aging, and death in great nirvāṇa. Trusting in the Three Jewels and in the karmic maturation of the fruits of action, they take up moral discipline and the training in vow-keeping and other such Dharmas — it is this that we call the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"If, beyond such Dharma, there existed some intrinsic nature of buddhahood, what use would there be for causes and conditions? Blessed One, milk does not have the property of becoming curd and butter without conditions — what depends on causes and conditions requires, in the case of milk, the human effort, the water, the vessel, the churning stick, and the cord. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is likewise similar: it is unreasonable to attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening apart from causes and conditions.

"If such a nature were definitively present, why would yogins (yogins), upon seeing the sufferings of birth, aging, sickness, death, and so forth, and the suffering of the three lower destinies, give rise to a mind of turning away from them? And it would follow that they need not cultivate the six perfections (pāramitās) in order to attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Milk does not become curd without conditions, and without the cause of the six perfections there can be no attainment of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. For these reasons, sentient beings do not possess an intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Moreover, regarding what the Blessed One stated earlier: the Saṅgha Jewel is permanent. If it is permanent, it is not impermanent."

If it is not impermanent, how then can one attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening? And if the Saṅgha is permanent, why did you say that all sentient beings possess an intrinsic nature of buddhahood?

"Blessed One, if sentient beings have never from the beginning had the awakening mind, and have never from the beginning had the mind of

unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and if these arise only afterward, then the intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is likewise such: it would arise afterward from what was not present at the beginning. For this reason, all sentient beings do not possess an intrinsic nature of buddhahood."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, you have long understood the meaning of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, and now you have asked thus on behalf of sentient beings — well done. All sentient beings truly do possess an intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"As for what you said — that if sentient beings possessed an intrinsic nature of buddhahood it would be unreasonable for the mind of awakening to have arisen at a first moment — son of good family, mind is not the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Why? Because mind is impermanent, whereas the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is permanent.

"As for what you said — 'why is there a mind of turning away?' — there is in truth no turning away with respect to mind itself. If mind turned away from mind, one would never attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; it is called 'non-returning' because what is attained is offered up and does not turn back. The awakening mind is not in truth the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Why? Because beings with wrong craving, having severed the root of virtue, fall into hell. If the awakening mind were the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, those with wrong craving would not be called beings with wrong craving. Nor can the awakening mind be called impermanent. Therefore, you should understand with certainty that the awakening mind is not in truth the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Son of good family, as for what you said — that if the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exists, it must depend on conditions just as milk becomes curd — that too is not so. Why? Just as milk becomes butter through five kinds of cause, so too is it with the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. For example, in stone there is gold, there is silver, there is copper, there is iron; though these appear to abide alike in the four great elements, each arises from a single essence under a single name, and each requires many causes and conditions. These come to arise in the first instance from the merit of sentient beings and from the work done by human effort. Therefore one should understand that from the beginning there is no intrinsic nature of gold. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is not called 'buddha'; it is only when the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is perceived through the assembly of many

causes and conditions of merit that one will for the first time attain buddhahood.

"As for what you said — that if sentient beings possess an intrinsic nature of buddhahood why do they not attain it — that too is not so. Why? Because the causes and conditions have not yet assembled.

"Son of good family, for this reason I have taught two kinds of genuine cause: the cause of truth, which is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself, and the conditional cause, which is the arousal of the mind of awakening. By means of these two — cause and condition — one attains unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, just as gold comes forth from stone."

"Son of good family, you have said this: 'Since the Saṅgha is permanent, no sentient being lacks an intrinsic nature of buddhahood.' Son of good family, the word 'Saṅgha' means harmony, and harmony is of two kinds: conventional harmony and ultimate harmony. Conventional harmony is the Saṅgha of śrāvakas. Ultimate harmony is the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas. The conventional Saṅgha is impermanent, but the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is permanent. Just as the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is permanent, so too the ultimate Saṅgha is like it.

"Furthermore, there is this understanding of the Saṅgha: it is harmony with the Dharma. Harmony with the Dharma means the twelve branches of scriptural teaching. Because the twelve branches of scriptural teaching are permanent, I have therefore declared that the Dharma and the Saṅgha are permanent.

"Son of good family, the Saṅgha is called harmony, and that which is harmony is the twelve links of dependent origination. Because the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is present within the twelve links of dependent origination, just as the twelve links of dependent origination are permanent, so too the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is like them. For this reason I have declared that the Saṅgha possesses the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Again, 'Saṅgha' means the harmony of all buddhas. For this reason too I have declared that the Saṅgha possesses the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

"Son of good family, you have asked with great earnestness: 'If sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, why are there those who are reversible and those who are irreversible?' Listen carefully and well — I shall explain and set this forth in full.

"Son of good family, bodhisattvas, great beings, are made reversible from awakening by thirteen qualities. What are the thirteen? They are these: a mind of faithlessness; a mind that makes no effort; a mind of doubt; attachment to body and material possessions combined with miserliness; generating great fear toward great nirvāṇa, thinking 'How could sentient beings ever be fully liberated?'; the absence of a patient mind; an untamed mind; a mind tormented by grief; dishonesty; heedlessness; contempt for one's own body; the view that one is unable to uproot the afflictions; and lack of inclination to enter into the qualities of awakening. Son of good family, these thirteen qualities cause bodhisattvas to turn back from awakening.

"Furthermore, these six qualities destroy the mind of awakening. What are the six? They are: miserliness toward the Dharma; generating unwholesome thoughts toward sentient beings; relying on unwholesome spiritual friends; failing to undertake diligent effort; praising oneself and being arrogant; and engaging in worldly activities. These six qualities are what destroy the mind of awakening.

"Son of good family, some people, upon hearing that the buddha, the Blessed One, is the teacher of gods and humans, supreme among all sentient beings, incomparable, surpassing śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, who with the eye of Dharma sees the Dharma clearly without obstruction, and who liberates all sentient beings from the ocean of afflictions — upon hearing this, they generate a great aspiration and solemn resolve, thinking: 'If such a being as this exists in the world, then I too shall attain this.' Moved by that cause and that condition, they arouse the mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Or others arouse the mind aimed at awakening because they have been shown the way by another. Or again, others hear that a bodhisattva, after practicing austerities for immeasurable eons, at last attains unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and —"

upon hearing this, one thinks: 'If I am unable to practice such austerities as these, how shall I ever attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?' And for that reason one turns back.

The thirty-eighth fascicle.

Noble son, there are also these five qualities of Dharma by which one turns back from the awakening mind. What are the five? They are: delight in going forth into the teachings of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas); failure to cultivate the mind of great loving-kindness; delight in seeking faults in those who teach the

Dharma; constant delight in cyclic existence; and, with regard to the twelve branches of scripture (sūtra-piṭaka) — receiving, reading, reciting, copying, expounding, and explaining them — having no inclination to do so. These are the five qualities leading to turning back from the awakening mind.

Furthermore, there are these two qualities of Dharma by which one turns back from the awakening mind. What are the two? They are: attachment to and fixation upon the five objects of desire, and failure to pay homage, reverence, and honor to the Three Jewels. Through these and many other conditions of this kind, one turns back from the awakening mind.

Now, what is meant by a mind that does not turn back? There are those who, upon hearing that a Tathāgata liberates sentient beings from birth, aging, illness, and death, and that through diligent effort that depends on no one else, one attains unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — having heard this, they think: 'If there is a path to awakening to be obtained, then I too, by exerting myself with utmost diligence, shall without fail obtain it.' Moved by that cause and that condition, they arouse the mind set upon awakening, and then — whether the merit they have accumulated is great or small — they dedicate it all to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. And they make this solemn aspiration: 'May I always pay reverent service to the buddhas and to the attendants of the buddhas. May I always hear the profound Dharma and be endowed with the five sense faculties. And even if I am tormented by suffering, may I never lose this mind.' They further aspire: 'May the buddhas and the attendants of the buddhas always hold me in their compassionate regard. May I be endowed with the five roots of virtue. And if sentient beings cut my body, or sever my limbs, hands, feet, head, eyes, or any part of my body, may I arouse toward them a mind of great loving-kindness, and may I rejoice, thinking: Those people have caused the causes of my awakening to arise and increase. If they had not done so, through what condition would I come to fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening?' And they make this great aspiration. They also aspire thus: 'May I not be born with indistinct or doubled marks, nor take on a woman's body. May I not be subject to another's dominion. May I not meet with an evil lord. May I not be dominated by an evil king. May I not be born in a bad land. Even if I obtain a fine and beautiful body, may I be of noble lineage and possess abundant wealth and precious things, yet not be made arrogant by possessing them. May I always hear the twelve branches of scripture, uphold them, read them, recite them, copy them, expound and explain them. And when I expound and

explain them to sentient beings, may those who hear me have faith and receive my teaching, may they grow perfectly clear-minded and free of doubt, and may they never give rise to ill-will toward me. Even if I have heard little, may I come to know much. Even if I have heard much, may I not be without understanding of the meaning. May my mind incline to teach and not turn toward a mind that withholds teaching. May the actions of my body, speech, and mind not be mixed with wrongdoing and non-virtue. And may I bring happiness to all sentient beings.'

May the moral discipline of my body and the wisdom of my mind become as unshakeable as a mountain. May I never be timid about my body, my life, or my possessions for the sake of upholding the supreme holy Dharma. May I never perform meritorious deeds with goods that have not been properly examined. May I sustain myself by right livelihood and be free of any mind of deceit and guile. May I always be mindful of kindness shown to me, and may I repay even the smallest kindness generously. May I become skilled in the practical arts of the world. May I become skilled in the languages of sentient beings in every direction. When reading, reciting, or writing the twelve branches of the sūtra collections, may I never be lazy or negligent. If there are sentient beings who take no delight in hearing, may I bring it about that all of them delight in hearing. May my speech be gentle and tender, and may I never utter words of non-virtue. May I reconcile those who are in conflict. For those who are in grief and fear, may I dispel their grief and fear. In times of famine, may I become satisfaction and sufficiency. In times of illness and epidemic, may I become a king of physicians, freely supplying whatever medicines, wealth, and precious things are needed as conditions for curing illness, and may all diseases be removed. In an age of weapons, may I possess great power and strength, and may harm and violence be decisively cut off. May I cut away the many and varied fears of sentient beings — such as the fear of death, of imprisonment, of beatings, of water, of fire, of kings, of thieves, of poverty, of the breakdown of law, of ill-repute, of the lower rebirths, and all such fears as these — may I eliminate them entirely. May I show profound reverence to my parents, my preceptor, and my teachers. Toward those who harbor grudges and hatred toward me, may I give rise to a mind of great loving-kindness. May I always cultivate the six close placements of mindfulness, the various categories of meditative absorption on emptiness, the twelve links of dependent origination, insight into arising and cessation and the like, the counting of the in-breath and out-breath, the conduct of the

gods, the conduct of Brahmā, the conduct of the noble ones, the vajra-like meditative absorption, and the heroic march meditative absorption and so forth.

In places where the Three Jewels are absent, may I myself attain a fully pacified mind, and even if my body and mind experience great afflictions, may I never lose the unsurpassed awakening mind, bodhicitta. May I never be content with the minds of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. In places where the Three Jewels are absent, may I always go forth into the teachings of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), so as to demolish wrong views, and without becoming accustomed to their teachings, may I attain mastery over the Dharma and mastery over my mind. May I clearly see the faults of conditioned phenomena. Just as a living creature with its life at stake fears the abandonment of the body, may I feel that same fear regarding the fruits of the two paths — my own and the vehicle. Just as sentient beings are drawn by longing toward the pleasures of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, may I, for the sake of sentient beings, feel that same longing for the three lower rebirths. Even for the sake of a single sentient being, should I experience the sufferings of the hells for measureless eons, may I never give rise to a mind of regret. When I see others gaining possessions, may I not give rise to envy, but just as I rejoice when I myself attain happiness, may I always rejoice likewise. Should I encounter the Three Jewels, may I offer to them in full with food and drink, beverages, bedding, lodgings, medicines for illness, lamps, flowers, incense, music, parasols, banners, the seven kinds of precious things, and all manner of offerings.

Should you take up the moral discipline of a buddha, guard it with utmost firmness and never give rise to the characteristic of its decay. Should you hear of the arduous practices of bodhisattvas, rejoice in them wholeheartedly and never give rise to a mind of regret. Remembering the things of your former lives, never act through karma of attachment, aversion, or delusion. Do not accumulate causes and conditions in hope of a ripening result. Do not become attached to and fixated on present happiness. Such is the vow to be taken.

Son of good family, one who takes such a vow as this is also called a bodhisattva who never turns back from or loses the awakening mind. Such a one is also called one who has the six perfections — one who directly perceives the Tathāgata and the intrinsic nature of a buddha, who is skilled in taming sentient beings, who liberates from saṃsāra, and who holds and guards the supreme Dharma that is unsurpassed.

Son of good family, for this reason, the irreversible mind should not be called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Son of good family, because you possess an irreversible mind, it would not be right to say that all sentient beings are without the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Take this as an example: two men hear that in another region there is a mountain of the seven precious things, and that there are fine springs upon it with delicious water. Whoever went there would be freed from poverty and want, and whoever drank of that water would live long, for a full thousand hundred years. Yet they also hear that the road is long and dangerous, with many obstacles. And so the two men, both contemplating whether to go, one of them made ready all the provisions for the journey and set out. The other set out with nothing whatsoever, empty-handed.

As they traveled along the road together, they met a man laden with many of the seven precious things. Both men then asked him: "Good sir, is there truly a mountain of the seven precious things in that land?" He replied: "It truly exists — I do not lie. I myself obtained precious things there and drank of the water. However, the road is dangerous and desolate, with bandits and robbers abroad; there are many hardships and thorns, little water and no grass. Of several hundred going out, very few actually arrive." Hearing him say this, one of the two felt regret and said: "The road is long, the obstacles are exceedingly many, and countless have set out but only one or two have ever arrived. How could I ever get there? My livelihood is adequate as it is. If I set out and fail to reach it, I will lose body and life. And if I lose body and life, where will that long life and happiness be?" And so he spoke. The other said: "Others have managed to arrive — if they can, so can I. If I reach the far side, I will gather precious things to my heart's content and drink of the fine spring. And if I do not escape, then I will pay for it with my life." And so he spoke.

Then the two men parted: one turned back in regret, and the other set forth and went. The one who set forth arrived at the mountain, took many precious things, drank his fill of the water as he wished, and returned with an abundance of precious things. He gave to his parents in full, and satisfied all his friends and companions with what remained. At that time, the one who had turned back in regret, seeing all these things, felt his mind deeply tormented. He thought: "Even he who went has returned — so why do I sit here?" And so he too set out and went.

In this simile, the mountain of the seven precious things is like the great nirvāṇa. The sweet water is like the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The two men are like two bodhisattvas who first gave rise to the mind of awakening.

The difficult road is like saṃsāra. The man met along the road is like the Blessed One, the buddha. The bandits and robbers are like the four māras. The grief and thorns are like the mental afflictions. The absence of water and grass is like not cultivating the path to awakening. The one who turned back is like a bodhisattva who turns back. The one who set out and went is to be understood as the simile for a bodhisattva who does not turn back.

O son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings abides permanently and does not change. Just as it would be wrong to say, on account of the difficulty of the road, that the road itself is impermanent because one turned back in regret, so too is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. O son of good family, there is no turning back on the path to awakening.

O son of good family, consider how the one who had turned back, upon seeing his companion having obtained many precious things, having gained dominion through power and strength, having cared for his parents, having given sufficiently to his friends and companions, and having enjoyed great happiness — felt his mind deeply tormented and, setting out to enter the road, not sparing his body or his life, enduring great hardship and many obstacles, arrived at the mountain of the seven precious things. The bodhisattva who does not turn back is just like that.

O son of good family, since all sentient beings will without fail attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, for that very reason I have declared across all the sūtras — from the five acts of immediate consequence (anantarya), through the four root defeats, and on up to those of perverted craving — that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Siṃhaghoṣa (Lion's Roar) then asked: Blessed One, how is it that a bodhisattva turns back and how is it that a bodhisattva does not turn back?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, a bodhisattva who accomplishes the karmic causes and conditions for the thirty-two marks of a Tathāgata — such a one is called one who does not turn back; such a one is also called a great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva; such a one is called immovable and unchanging; such a one is called one who has affectionate love for all sentient beings; such a one is called one who is superior to all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; and such a one is called a non-returner.

O son of good family, a great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who is unwavering in the restraint of moral discipline, whose mind is steadfast in generosity, and who abides in words of truth like Mount Meru — through the karmic cause and that condition, such a one obtains the mark of flat, even soles on the feet, like a box with a flat lid. O son of good family, a great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who from childhood — even in lives as animals — honors and makes offerings to parents, preceptors, teachers, and spiritual mentors with material goods obtained in accordance with the Dharma — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of wheels on the soles of the feet, complete with a thousand spokes.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who does not take life, who does not take what is not given, and who always generates joy toward parents, preceptors, and spiritual mentors — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains three marks: slender and long fingers on the hands, long heels on the feet, and an upright body with four equal sides. These three marks share one karmic cause.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who gathers sentient beings by means of the four ways of gathering — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of webbed fingers, resembling the king of geese.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who personally takes up a cloth and washes the bodies of parents, preceptors, and spiritual mentors when they are afflicted by illness, and who massages the limbs of their body — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of soft hands and feet.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who upholds moral discipline, listens to the Dharma, and —

— who gives generously without growing weary: through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of joints and limbs that are proportionate and even, and bodily hairs that turn upward.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who listens to the Dharma with single-pointed mind and teaches the sacred Dharma — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of calves like those of the king of deer.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who never arouses a mind of harm toward any sentient being; who is content in food and drink and always delights in giving generously; and who tends to the sick and gives medicine — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a body perfectly

proportioned like the nyagrodha tree, and arms that, when standing, extend past the knees, along with the mark of a fleshy crown-protrusion and a crown-protrusion that is invisible when looked upon.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who, upon seeing those who are frightened, becomes their protector and refuge, and upon seeing those who are naked, gives them clothing — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of the male organ retracted within a sheath.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who keeps close company with those who are wise and relinquishes those who are deluded; who is skilled in asking questions and giving answers; who corrects the path of wayfarers and sweeps the road — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of skin that is fine and supple, and bodily hairs that coil to the right.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who always gives robes, food, bedding, medicines for illness, incense, flowers, and lamps — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a body whose complexion is like gold, ever radiant and lustrous.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who gives generously, who is able to bestow an abundance of wealth without reservation, and who makes no distinction between those who are fields of merit and those who are not — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of the seven fully rounded prominences.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who, when giving generously, does not give rise to a mind of doubt — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a beautiful, melodious voice.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who seeks in accordance with the Dharma and gives generously: through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of full and even collarbones, an upper body like that of a lion, and forearms and shoulders that are proportionate and long.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who thoroughly abandons divisive speech, harsh words, and a mind of aversion — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of forty teeth that are white and even, with fine rows of teeth.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who arouses loving-kindness and great compassion toward all sentient beings — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of possessing two canine teeth.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who makes the aspiration, "I shall give freely and according to the wishes of all those who come to beg, giving whatever they desire," and who always gives in this way to those who come seeking — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of lion-like cheeks.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who gives to sentient beings whatever food they desire, each according to their wish — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of possessing, among all tastes, the supreme taste.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who personally practices the ten virtuous actions and also teaches them to others — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a tongue that is long and broad.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who does not speak of the faults of others and does not disparage the sacred Dharma — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a voice like that of Brahmā.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who, upon seeing enemies and those who hate, arouses a mind of joy — through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of eyes that are deep blue, like collyrium.

A great being, a bodhisattva-mahāsattva, who does not conceal the good qualities of others but proclaims them everywhere —

through that karmic condition, such a one obtains the mark of a white curl of hair between the brows.

O son of good family, when a bodhisattva-mahāsattva thus accomplishes the karmic causes and conditions of the thirty-two marks, the awakening mind becomes irreversible.

O son of good family, all sentient beings are inconceivable, the domain of activity of the buddhas is inconceivable, the karmic result is inconceivable, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha is inconceivable. Why is this? Because these four things are permanent, and because they are permanent, they are inconceivable. Because all sentient beings are obscured by mental afflictions, they are called "permanent." When those permanent afflictions are cut, one is called "impermanent."

If all sentient beings are permanent, why must the noble eightfold path be cultivated? It is because many sufferings are cut. If many sufferings have been cut, that is called "impermanent." Whatever experiences happiness, that is

called "permanent." Therefore I have taught that because all sentient beings are entirely obscured by mental afflictions, they do not see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and not seeing it in that way, they do not pass beyond suffering.

Simḥasvara then asked: O Blessed One, as the Blessed One has taught, all phenomena have two kinds of cause — a cause of truth and a cause of conditions. Through these two kinds of cause, there is neither bondage nor liberation. The five aggregates arise and cease moment by moment. If they arise and cease in this way, who would be bound or liberated? O Blessed One, the five aggregates of this present life give rise to the five aggregates of the next life. These aggregates do not pass over to become other aggregates, since these aggregates cease of themselves. Though they do not pass over, the arising of subsequent aggregates is possible — just as a sprout arises from a seed as its cause. The seed does not enter into the sprout, and yet, though it does not enter, the sprout arises. If sentient beings are likewise, how can there be bondage and liberation?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, attend carefully and reflect well upon this, and I shall explain and teach it to you.

O son of good family, consider a person who is experiencing the suffering of dying. Surrounded by relatives and friends, who are lamenting, that person, terrified, does not know what refuge or support there is. Though the five consciousnesses are present, nothing is perceived; every limb and joint trembles and stirs, yet there is no power to stir. As the whole body grows cold and the warmth is nearly exhausted, the characteristics of the karmic maturation of virtue and non-virtue practiced in the past come into view.

O son of good family, consider how, when the sun draws near to setting, all the shadows of mountains and mounds appear to the east — they have no nature of going westward. Just so, the karmic result of sentient beings is the same: when these aggregates cease, a continuity of another set of aggregates arises, just as when a lamp is lit, darkness ceases, and when a lamp is extinguished, darkness arises.

O son of good family, consider how, when a seal carved from wood is pressed onto clay, a design appears from the meeting of seal and clay. The design of the wooden seal has not transferred onto the clay, nor has the design arisen from within the clay itself, nor has it come from elsewhere — yet by the condition of the seal, the design has arisen. Just so, when the present aggregates have ceased, an intermediate-state being has not yet been born;

the present aggregates do not themselves become the intermediate-state being, nor does the intermediate-state being arise on its own, nor does it come from elsewhere — rather, the intermediate-state being is born from the cause of the present aggregates.

Just as when a seal is pressed into wax, the instant the seal is removed the impression appears — the name is the same, yet the times are distinct — so too, I have declared that the intermediate-state being formed from the five aggregates is not seen with a fleshly eye but with a miraculous eye.

The intermediate-state being formed from the five aggregates is sustained by three kinds of nourishment: nourishment of intention, nourishment of contact, and nourishment of consciousness. This intermediate-state being formed from the five aggregates is of two kinds: the fruit of virtuous karma and the fruit of non-virtuous karma. One who bears the cause of virtuous karma inclines toward the virtuous. One who bears the cause of non-virtuous karma inclines toward the non-virtuous.

When father and mother meet and perform the act of union, one proceeds to a place of birth in accordance with whatever karma one has created. Toward the mother, desire arises; toward the father, aversion arises. When the father's semen appears, one grasps it as one's own, and seeing it, one becomes pleased and gives rise to great joy. It is in this way, through three causes and conditions of affliction, that the moment the intermediate-state aggregates dissolve, the subsequent aggregates arise — just as when a seal is pressed into wax, the instant the seal is lifted an impression appears.

At the time of birth, the sense faculties may be complete or incomplete. One whose sense faculties are complete sees form and desire arises. When that desire arises, it is called craving. The ignorance that produces desire through delusion is called ignorance. Through the two causes and conditions of attachment and ignorance, one sees all objects in an inverted manner: what is impermanent is seen as permanent, what is without self is seen as having a self, what is painful is seen as pleasurable, and what is utterly impure is seen as utterly pure. Because of these four inversions, one performs virtuous and non-virtuous actions. Affliction thus becomes karma, and karma in turn becomes affliction — and that is what is called bondage. It is by this process that the arising of the five aggregates is so called.

But if that person were to attend upon a buddha, or a close attendant of a buddha, or a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra), he or she would come to hear the

twelve divisions of the scriptural collection. Having heard the Dharma in this way, one reflects upon the domain of virtue. Through reflecting upon the domain of virtue, one attains great wisdom. What is called great wisdom is right wisdom and right vision. Through attaining wisdom and vision, a mind of deep remorse toward saṃsāra arises. When that mind of remorse has arisen, delight and enthusiasm do not arise. Because delight and enthusiasm do not arise, the mind of attachment is destroyed. When the mind of attachment is destroyed, one cultivates the noble eightfold path. Through cultivating the noble eightfold path, saṃsāra comes to an end. When saṃsāra is no more, this is called attaining complete liberation — just as fire, when it meets no wood, is called ceased. Through the cessation of saṃsāra, this is called nirvāṇa. It is by this process that the cessation of the five aggregates is so called.

Siṃha asked: Without thorns, what is there to pick out of the sky? Without there being any bondage in the aggregates, by what is one bound?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the five aggregates are bound by the iron shackles of affliction. Beyond the five aggregates there is no other affliction, and beyond the afflictions there is no other thing called the five aggregates. Son of good family, just as pillars support a house — there are no pillars apart from the house, and no house apart from the pillars — so too the five aggregates of a sentient being are just like that: because afflictions exist, this is called bondage; because afflictions are absent, this is called liberation.

Son of good family, a fist, a palm, and a knot — and so forth, these three — arise and cease through coming together and coming apart. Apart from that, there is no other phenomenon.

The five aggregates of a sentient being are just like that: because afflictions exist, this is called bondage; because afflictions are absent, this is called liberation.

Son of good family, it has been taught that sentient beings are bound by name-and-form (nāmarūpa). If name-and-form were to cease, there would be no such thing as a sentient being. Beyond name-and-form there is no other sentient being, and beyond the sentient being there is no other thing called name-and-form. Name-and-form binds the sentient being, and the sentient being in turn is said to bind name-and-form.

Then Siṃhasvara spoke: Blessed One, just as an eye does not see itself, a finger does not point to itself, a sword does not cut itself, and a feeling does not feel itself — why then does the Blessed One say that name-and-form binds

name-and-form?

The answer is this: what we call name-and-form is precisely the sentient being, and the sentient being is precisely name-and-form. If name-and-form binds the sentient being, then it is name-and-form that binds name-and-form.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, when two hands are clapped together, no other phenomenon apart from those two comes and joins in. Name-and-form is just like that. For this very reason I say that name-and-form binds the sentient being, and if name-and-form is abandoned, liberation is attained — and so I say that the sentient being is liberated.

Simhasvara asked: Blessed One, if bondage is said to consist in the presence of name-and-form, then since arhats have not abandoned name-and-form, are they still bound?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, liberation is of two kinds: the cutting of the seed, and the cutting of the fruit. The cutting of the seed means the cutting of the afflictions. Arhats have cut the afflictions; with the afflictions utterly purified and exhausted, they cannot be bound any further by affliction at the level of the seed. Yet because the fruit has not been cut, they are said to be bound by the fruit. Arhats do not see the buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha), and because they do not see it they do not attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. For this reason it is appropriate to say that they are bound by the fruit, but not appropriate to say that they are bound by name-and-form.

Son of good family, consider a butter lamp: as long as the butter is not exhausted, the light will not go out, but if the butter is exhausted, it will certainly be extinguished. Son of good family, the butter is the analogy for the afflictions, and the butter lamp is the analogy for sentient beings. All sentient beings, sustained by the butter of affliction, do not pass into nirvāṇa. If that butter is exhausted, they pass into nirvāṇa.

Simhasvara said: Blessed One, a butter lamp and its butter have distinct defining characteristics — a sentient being and the afflictions are not like that. The sentient being itself is the affliction, and the affliction itself is the sentient being. The sentient being is the five aggregates, and the five aggregates are the sentient being. The five aggregates themselves are the afflictions, and the afflictions themselves are the five aggregates. If that is so, why does the Blessed One take the butter lamp as an analogy?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, analogies are of eight kinds: the analogy that is inclined toward the point, the analogy that is inverted, the analogy that is direct, the analogy that is not quite fitting, the earlier analogy, the later analogy, the analogy that spans earlier and later, and the all-encompassing analogy.

Of these, what is the inclined analogy? As is taught in a sūtra: when a great rain falls, every hollow vessel is filled; every small ditch is filled by the hollow vessels filling; every large channel is filled by the small ditches filling; every small spring is filled by the large channels filling; and every great spring is filled by the small springs filling.

Every great spring fills the small pond; every small pond fills the great pond; every great pond fills the small river; every small river fills the great river; every great river fills the great ocean. In just the same way, the rain of the Dharma of the Tathāgata completely fills the moral discipline of sentient beings. When moral discipline is completely filled, the mind free of regret is completely filled. When the mind free of regret is completely filled, great joy is completely filled. When great joy is completely filled, seclusion is completely filled. When seclusion is completely filled, ease and happiness are completely filled. When ease and happiness are completely filled, meditative absorption is completely filled. When meditative absorption is completely filled, right knowledge and vision are completely filled. When right knowledge and vision are completely filled, disenchantment is completely filled. When disenchantment is completely filled, utter revulsion is completely filled. When utter revulsion is completely filled, liberation is completely filled. When liberation is completely filled, nirvāṇa is completely filled. That is the inclined analogy.

Now, what is the inverted analogy? The source of the great ocean is the great river. The source of the great river is the small river. The source of the small river is the great lake. The source of the great lake is the small lake. The source of the small lake is the great spring. The source of the great spring is the small spring. The source of the small spring is the great channel. The source of the great channel is the small channel. The source of the small channel is the great hollow vessel. The source of the great hollow vessel is the great rain. The source of nirvāṇa is liberation. The source of liberation is utter revulsion. The source of utter revulsion is disenchantment. The source of disenchantment is right knowledge and vision. The source of right knowledge and vision is meditative absorption. The source of meditative absorption is

ease and happiness. The source of ease and happiness is complete renunciation. The source of complete renunciation is the mind of joy. The source of the mind of joy is freedom from regret. The source of freedom from regret is the keeping of moral discipline. The source of the keeping of moral discipline is the rain of Dharma. That is the inverted analogy.

Now, what is the direct analogy? As it is taught in a sūtra: the nature of the mind of sentient beings is like a monkey. The nature of a monkey is to release one thing and grasp another. The nature of sentient beings is likewise: because of attachment to forms, sounds, smells, tastes, textures, and mental phenomena, there is not a single moment of remaining still. That is the direct analogy.

Now, what is the analogy that is not quite fitting? It is this: I formerly addressed King Prasenajit with these words: "Great King, trustworthy and close companions come to you from all four directions and say: 'Great King, from the four directions four great mountains are coming, threatening to crush and harm the king's people.' If such a thing were to come, what wisdom would you apply?" The king replied: "Blessed One, if such a thing were to occur, there would be no place of escape.

"With one-pointed mind I shall observe moral discipline and practice generosity alone." Having said this, I gave him the response: "Excellent!"

Great King, when I spoke of the four great mountains, I was referring precisely to birth, aging, sickness, and death among sentient beings. Since birth, aging, sickness, and death are always coming to harm and afflict sentient beings, why should the Great King not practice moral discipline and generosity? The king asked: "Blessed One, if one observes moral discipline and practices generosity, what fruit does one obtain?" I declared to him: "Great King, one will come to experience abundant pleasurable enjoyments among gods and humans." The king asked: "Blessed One, if the nyagrodha tree were to observe moral discipline and practice generosity, would it too experience the pleasurable enjoyments of gods and humans?" I declared to him: "Great King, the nyagrodha tree is not capable of observing moral discipline or practicing generosity. But if it were capable, then the happiness it would experience would likewise be no different."

That declaration is the analogy that is not quite fitting.

Now, how is the earlier analogy fitting? Throughout all the sūtras I have stated, for example, that when a certain person, seized by attachment to a beautiful

flower, goes to pluck it, he is swept away by the current. Sentient beings are just like that: seized by attachment to the five objects of desire, they are swept away by the current of birth, aging, sickness, and death. That is the earlier analogy.

And how is the later analogy fitting? From the sūtra of Dharma-words, these verses were spoken:

Do not scorn a small and minor evil
thinking it cannot do harm.
Even drops of water dripping slowly
will fill a great vessel to the brim.

That is the later analogy.

And how is the analogy that fits both earlier and later? Consider, for example, a plantain tree that dies as soon as it has borne fruit, or a fool who has found a means of sustenance: in just the same way, a pregnant she-mule does not long survive. That is the analogy that fits both earlier and later.

And how is the all-pervasive analogy? From a sūtra I have stated: In the Heaven of the Thirty-Three there is a tree called Pāricittra. Its roots descend into the earth for some fifty leagues. Its height is one hundred leagues. Its branches and leaves spread out to cover some fifty leagues in the four directions. When its leaves ripen, they turn yellow, and the gods, upon seeing this, give rise to minds of joy. Before long, the leaves fall, and when they fall, great joy arises once more. Before long, the branches change color, and when the branches change color, joy arises again. Before long, after the change of color, buds appear, and when the buds appear, joy arises. Before long, from the buds, shoots grow, and upon seeing them, there is great joy. Before long, the shoots open into blossoms, and when they have opened, their fragrance spreads for some fifty leagues, and their radiance shines out for some eighty leagues. At that time, for the duration of three summer months, the gods take delight and enjoy themselves in perfect happiness beneath that tree.

Sons of good family, my attendants are just like that. The leaves turning yellow is like my attendants wishing to go forth into renunciation. The leaves falling is like my attendants shaving head and beard. The change of color is like my attendants requesting ordination, performing the fourfold act, and receiving full ordination. The appearing of buds is like my attendants generating the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. The arising of shoots is like the bodhisattvas of the ten grounds seeing the

buddha-nature. And the opening of blossoms is like a bodhisattva attaining unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

The fragrance of the blossoms is like the moral discipline and restraint of innumerable sentient beings in the ten directions. The radiant light is like the unobstructed marks of the Tathāgatas spreading throughout the ten directions. The three months of the rainy season are like the three meditative absorptions. The gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three enjoying happiness is like the Tathāgatas attaining the permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity of great nirvāṇa. This is the example of all-pervasiveness.

O son of good family, the examples shown here are not exhaustive — they are taken up only in part, or in many, or if necessary all together. In this regard, the face of the Tathāgata being like the full moon is an example of taking a partial illustration.

O son of good family, take for example a person who has never seen milk before and asks another what milk is like. The other says it is like water, like honey, and like a conch shell — water for its characteristic of wetness, honey for its characteristic of sweetness, and the conch shell for its characteristic of color. Even so, although three examples have been given, the actual nature of milk remains unknown.

O son of good family, it is just the same with the examples I have given for sentient beings using the lamp. O son of good family, beyond the far bank of a river there is no river — and so it is with sentient beings. Beyond the relinquishment of the five aggregates, there are no other sentient beings. O son of good family, just as beyond the box, the rim, the axle, the hub, and the spokes there is no other chariot, so too it is with sentient beings.

O son of good family, if you wish to understand in accordance with the analogy of the lamp, listen and reflect carefully, and I shall explain it to you. In that analogy, the wick is the example for the twenty-five existences. The oil is the example for craving. The light is the example for wisdom. The dispelling of darkness is the example for the destruction of ignorance. The warmth is the example for the noble path. When the oil is exhausted, the light and the flame cease; and when a sentient being's existences are exhausted, the buddha-nature will be seen. At that point, name and form exist, yet they do not bind; one dwells within the twenty-five existences, yet the existences do not defile.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, if the five aggregates of sentient beings are empty and utterly non-existent, who receives the transmission and who accumulates the provisions for awakening?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, in every sentient being there exists a mind of mindfulness, a mind of wisdom, a mind of arousal, a mind of undertaking diligent effort, a mind of faith, and a mind of meditative absorption. Minds such as these arise and cease moment by moment, but because each successive one of the same kind succeeds the one before without interruption, this is what is called accumulating the provisions for awakening.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, if such phenomena as these cease moment by moment, and if it is by one continuous stream of similar moments succeeding one another — which are themselves ceasing moment by moment — that there is an uninterrupted continuity, how then can provisions be accumulated?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, just as the lamp ceases moment by moment and yet its light dispels darkness, so too with mindfulness and the other such phenomena — it is just the same. O son of good family, just as the food eaten by sentient beings ceases moment by moment and yet the hungry are satisfied, or just as excellent medicine ceases moment by moment and yet cures illness, or just as the light of the sun and moon ceases moment by moment and yet is able to grow all herbs, trees, and forests — so too it is with these.

O son of good family, you have asked: if cessation occurs moment by moment, how then can birth take place? Birth takes place because the mind-stream is unbroken.

O son of good family, just as those who recite texts cannot pronounce all the syllables of the recitation at once — the first syllable cannot travel to the middle, and the middle syllable cannot travel to the last — yet because names, letters, mind, and perception all cease moment by moment and yet have been practiced over a long time, everything comes to be known. O son of good family, just as a goldsmith who begins training from youth until old age proceeds through moment-by-moment cessation, and though the earlier and later moments do not intermingle, yet through long training he becomes ever more skilled in his craft — and so is called a skilled goldsmith — so too it is exactly the same with reading and recitation.

O son of good family, just as no one commands a seed, "You, produce a sprout!" — yet by the nature of reality a sprout arises of itself. And though no one commands a flower, "You, produce fruit!" — yet by the nature of reality fruit arises of itself — so too it is exactly the same with sentient beings accumulating the provisions for awakening.

O son of good family, just as the method of counting is such that one never passes to two as one, nor two passes to three as two — cessation occurs moment by moment — yet one can reach as far as a thousand and ten thousand. So too it is exactly the same with sentient beings accumulating the provisions for awakening.

O son of good family, just as a flame ceases moment by moment, and yet the earlier flame that ceases never says to the later flame, "I have gone out — you now arise and dispel the darkness." So too it is just the same.

O son of good family, just as a newborn calf suckles at the breast at once, and no one teaches it the understanding of how to suckle — cessation occurs moment by moment — yet from the initial hunger it comes to be satisfied. Therefore one should understand that it is improper to take an equal thing as one's objection. If they were identical, birth as something distinct would be unreasonable. And just so it is the same with sentient beings accumulating the provisions for awakening. From the very beginning there is no leaping progressively upward as such, yet because one cultivates over a long time, all afflictions come to be destroyed.

Lion's Roar then asked: O Blessed One, as the Blessed One has taught — those who have attained the fruit of stream-entry (Skt. *srotāpattiphala*), even if born in a wretched realm, maintain moral discipline: they do not kill, they do not steal, they do not engage in sexual misconduct, they do not speak divisive speech or harsh words, and they do not drink alcohol. Now just as the aggregates of one who has entered the stream cease here and do not proceed to a wretched realm, should the accumulation of the provisions for awakening not also be the same — that is, should it not proceed to a wretched realm either? But if they are indeed alike, then why is such a person not born in a pure realm? And if the aggregates of the wretched realm are not the aggregates of the stream-enterer, then why is it that they do not commit evil deeds?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, a stream-enterer, even though born in a wretched realm, does not lose the name "stream-enterer."

Because the aggregates are not identical, I gave the simile of the calf. A stream-enterer, though born in a wretched realm, does not commit evil deeds by virtue of the power of awakening.

O son of good family, just as on a fragrant mountain where the king of lions dwells, every bird that flies and every beast that roams the earth will not run onto that mountain — they cannot bear to be near it. And even if the king of lions goes to a snow mountain, every flying bird and every beast that dwells and moves there cannot bear its presence. So too is the stream-enterer: even though he may not be diligent with respect to awakening, by the power of awakening he commits no unwholesome deed whatsoever.

O son of good family, just as when a person drinks ambrosia —

that ambrosia ceases moment by moment, yet by its power the person lives long and becomes free from birth and death.

O son of good family, take the example of the excellent medicine on the king of mountains, Mount Meru, called Laṅkali. When someone takes it, it ceases moment by moment, yet by the power of that medicine one encounters no suffering of illness.

O son of good family, take the example of a wheel-turning king: in the place where he resides, even when the king is absent, no one can bear to draw near. Why is that? It is by the power and blessing of the king. The stream-enterer is likewise: even though he may be born in a bad realm and may not be diligent with respect to awakening, by the power of awakening he commits no unwholesome deed.

O son of good family, these aggregates of the stream-enterer cease here, and though one is born with other aggregates elsewhere, the aggregates of the stream-enterer are not lost. O son of good family, it is just as when people, wishing for trees, fruit, and crops, plant seeds with dung and do many things such as watering and so forth: before the fruit and crops are obtained, the seed rots away — yet through the power of the seed, the tree and its fruit are obtained. The aggregates of the stream-enterer are just the same.

O son of good family, take the example of a very wealthy man who has only one son. That son had a child of his own in a previous life, but that grandchild was living in another region. When the man died, his heir heard the news, returned, and gathered all the wealth and possessions. Those possessions had not been made by this heir himself, yet no one refused to hand them over

when he came to collect and gather them. Why is that? It is because they are of one bloodline. The aggregates of the stream-enterer are just the same.

Siṃha asked: How should we understand the verse that the Blessed One taught, which says:

Whatever monk cultivates moral discipline,
meditative absorption, and wisdom,
know him to be one who will not turn back,
going ever closer to nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, how is one to cultivate moral discipline? How is one to cultivate meditative absorption? How is one to cultivate wisdom?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, if someone undertakes moral discipline and keeps it for their own benefit, or out of desire for the pleasures of gods and humans, and not for the sake of liberating all sentient beings or protecting the supreme Dharma — or if one keeps it merely for the sake of gain and fame, or out of fear of the three lower realms, or out of desire for long life, good complexion, strength, happiness, unobstructed confidence, or out of fear of kings, fear of ill repute, or for the sake of worldly affairs — that is not called cultivating moral discipline.

O son of good family, what then is genuine cultivation of moral discipline? It is when one undertakes moral discipline and keeps it for the sake of liberating all sentient beings, or for protecting the supreme Dharma, or to rescue those not yet rescued, to free those not yet freed, to give refuge to those without refuge, to bring those who have not passed beyond sorrow to complete nirvāṇa — and when keeping it in this way, one does not regard it as moral discipline, does not regard it as the defining characteristic of moral discipline, does not regard it as something to be grasped, does not regard it as bringing about the ripening of a result, and does not entertain thoughts of fear or of failure. O son of good family, keeping it in just that manner is called cultivating moral discipline.

As for how one is to cultivate meditative absorption: when cultivating meditative absorption, if one does so for one's own liberation or for the sake of gain and fame, and not for the sake of sentient beings or for protecting the Dharma — if one looks upon attachment, the faults of impure food and the like, upon men and women and so forth, upon the impurities that flow from the nine bodily openings, upon conflict and strife —

striking and beating one another, harming and killing one another — and cultivates meditative absorption on account of such things, that is not to be called the thorough cultivation of meditative absorption.

O son of good family, what then is it to cultivate meditative absorption rightly? If one cultivates meditative absorption thoroughly for the sake of sentient beings — whether in order to attain a mind of equanimity toward all sentient beings, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the Dharma of non-regression, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the noble Dharma, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the Great Vehicle, or in order to guard and uphold the unsurpassable Dharma, or in order to ensure that sentient beings do not turn back from the awakening mind, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the heroic stride samādhi, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the vajra-like samādhi, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain dhāraṇī, or in order to cause sentient beings to attain the four analytical knowledges, or in order to cause sentient beings to behold the nature of buddha — and while practicing in that way one does not regard the meditative absorption as an object, does not regard the defining characteristics of meditative absorption as an object, does not regard the act of cultivating as an object, and does not regard the karmic maturation of its result as an object — O son of good family, one who cultivates in that manner is said to be thoroughly cultivating meditative absorption.

Now, as for how one is to cultivate wisdom: if one cultivates in the following manner — thinking, "If I were to cultivate wisdom, I would attain liberation and escape from the three lower realms; but then who would be capable of acting for the benefit of all sentient beings? Who would be able to liberate beings from saṃsāra? The arising of buddhas in the world is as rare as the udumbara flower. Therefore, right now I shall cut off all afflictions and shall diligently cultivate wisdom in order to attain the fruit of liberation; I shall swiftly sever the afflictions and swiftly attain liberation" — cultivating in that manner is not to be called cultivating wisdom.

Then what is true cultivation? The one endowed with wisdom, having closely examined sentient beings who are tormented by the suffering of birth, aging, and death, obscured by ignorance, not knowing how to cultivate the unsurpassable and perfectly correct path — makes this aspiration: may I, with this very body, become the surety (Skt. pratibhū) for those sentient beings in their experience of great suffering. And may all the deeds performed by sentient beings through minds steeped in poverty, in being the lowest of all, in

the collapse of moral discipline — all the deeds done through attachment, aversion, and delusion — be gathered upon my own body. And may all sentient beings not take birth in the stream of desire, and may they not be bound by name and form, and may they not be ensnared. And may all sentient beings be swiftly liberated from saṃsāra, so that I alone remaining holds no sorrow for me. And may all sentient beings attain unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening — making such aspirations and cultivating in that way, one does not regard wisdom as an object, does not regard the defining characteristics of wisdom as an object, does not regard the act of cultivating as an object, and does not regard the karmic maturation of its result as an object. Cultivating in that manner is called thoroughly cultivating wisdom.

O son of good family, one who cultivates moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom in this way is called a bodhisattva. One who is unable to cultivate moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom in this way is called a śrāvaka.

The thirty-ninth section.

Furthermore, O son of good family, how is one to cultivate moral discipline?

One who is able to sever the sixteen corrupt modes of conduct of all sentient beings is said to be cultivating moral discipline. What are these sixteen? They are as follows: raising lambs to maturity and selling them to others for the sake of gain; buying them and slaughtering them for the sake of gain; raising piglets to maturity and selling them to others for the sake of gain; buying them and slaughtering them for the sake of gain; raising calves to maturity and selling them for the sake of gain; buying them and slaughtering them for the sake of gain; raising birds to maturity and selling them for the sake of gain; buying them and slaughtering them for the sake of gain; fishing; hunting; poaching; butchering; fowling; slander; serving as a keeper of prison stocks; and casting spells upon nāgas. Definitively cutting off these sixteen kinds of harmful actions of sentient beings is called cultivating moral discipline.

And how is one to cultivate meditative absorption? It is by cutting off all worldly meditative absorptions. The following are examples of such worldly absorptions: the bodiless meditative absorption, in which one arises in the mistaken notion that sentient beings who are in nirvāṇa have passed beyond existence; the meditative absorption of mind with infinite becoming; the meditative absorption of the aggregate of the world's purity; the meditative absorption of the world's end; the meditative absorption of the world's

annihilation; the meditative absorption of the world's inherent nature; the meditative absorption of the world's person; and the meditative absorption of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Absorptions such as these give rise to the mistaken notion that sentient beings are in nirvāṇa, that they have passed beyond sorrow. Definitively cutting off those meditative absorptions that give rise to such mistaken notions is called thoroughly cultivating meditative absorption.

And how is one to cultivate wisdom? It is by demolishing all the wrong views of the world. All sentient beings have wrong views. They are as follows. Some say: form is the self, and it also belongs to the self; the self exists within form, and form exists within the self — and in the same way they speak up through consciousness. Some say: the self is permanent; even when form ceases, the self still exists. Some say: form itself is the self, so when form ceases the self too ceases. And some say: there is an agent, which is the self, and feeling is form. And some say: the agent is form, and feeling is the self. And some say: there is neither agent nor feeling — things arise by themselves and cease by themselves, not through cause and condition. And some say: there is neither agent nor feeling — all is done by one called the Lord of All. And some say: there is neither agent nor feeling — all is done by time. And some say: there is neither agent nor feeling — sentient beings are simply a name for the five great elements such as earth and so forth. O son of good family, one who demolishes all these wrong views of all sentient beings is said to be cultivating wisdom.

O son of good family, through cultivating moral discipline the body becomes pacified. Through cultivating meditative absorption the mind becomes pacified. Through cultivating wisdom the mind of doubt is overcome. And when the mind of doubt is overcome, one comes to thoroughly cultivate awakening. Through cultivating awakening one comes to see the nature of a buddha. Through seeing the nature of a buddha one attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Through attaining unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening one attains the supreme great nirvāṇa. Through attaining the supreme great nirvāṇa one severs all the afflictions of saṃsāra of all sentient beings, all existence, all realms, and all pleasures. Having severed from saṃsāra all the way through to severing pleasure, one attains permanence, bliss, self, and

purity — one attains the Dharma of complete purity.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has taught that what neither arises nor ceases is called great nirvāṇa — birth, too, in the same way, neither arises nor ceases, so why is birth not also called nirvāṇa?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, it is just as you say. It is exactly so. Just as you have stated, birth neither arises nor ceases. Yet it has no beginning and no end.

Siṃhaghoṣa asked: Blessed One, the phenomena of saṃsāra also have no beginning and no end. If they have no beginning and no end, they would be permanent. And if something is permanent, it would be nirvāṇa. So why then is saṃsāra not designated as nirvāṇa?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, the phenomena of saṃsāra have cause and effect. Because they possess cause and effect, they are not designated as nirvāṇa. Why is that? Because in the essential nature of nirvāṇa there is no cause and no effect.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, even nirvāṇa, according to a verse the Blessed One himself has spoken, has cause and effect — namely:

From a cause one is born as a god in the higher realms.

From a cause one falls into the lower realms.

From a cause one attains nirvāṇa.

Therefore everything has a cause.

And furthermore, the Blessed One previously declared to the monks: I shall teach the path and the fruit of the śramaṇa life. The śramaṇa life means fully and perfectly practicing moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom. The path is the noble eightfold path. And the fruit of the śramaṇa life is nirvāṇa.

Blessed One, is not that nirvāṇa itself a fruit? Why then did you say that in the essential nature of nirvāṇa there is no cause and no effect?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, when I spoke of the cause of nirvāṇa, what I meant is this: the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The intrinsic nature of a buddha does not produce nirvāṇa by generating it from itself. Therefore I have said that nirvāṇa has no cause. It is called a great fruit because it vanquishes the afflictions. And it is said to have no fruit because it is not born from the path. Therefore nirvāṇa has neither cause nor fruit.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, does the intrinsic nature of a buddha that belongs to all sentient beings exist as something common to all, or does it

exist in each individually? If it is common to all, then when one being attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, all sentient beings should equally attain it as well. It is as if twenty persons shared a single enemy: if one of those persons eliminates that enemy, the remaining nineteen would equally be freed of that enemy. In the same way, if the intrinsic nature of a buddha is shared in common, when one attains it, all others should attain it too. But if it exists individually in each, then it would be impermanent. Why? Because it could then be counted and enumerated. The Blessed One has indeed taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is neither one nor many. If it existed individually in each, it would not be right to say that the Tathāgatas are equal to one another; nor would it be right to say that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is like space.

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is neither one nor many, and yet the buddhas are equal to one another and like space — and it exists equally in all sentient beings.

If someone cultivates the noble eightfold path, they will come to see it clearly. Son of good family, there is a grass called "patience grass" in the Himalayas: if a cow eats it, it becomes the essence of butter. The intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is like that.

Siṃhaghoṣa asked: Just as the Blessed One has spoken of "patience grass" — is it consumed by one cow or by many? If it is consumed by one, then when one seeking it has consumed it, it is exhausted. If it is many, then, as you have said, the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is like that. Yet as the Blessed One has declared — that whoever cultivates the noble eightfold path will see the intrinsic nature of a buddha — that does not seem right. Why? If the path, too, is consumed by one, like patience grass it would seem to be used up; and if it were used up, then one person's cultivation of it would leave others without any share. If, on the other hand, the path were many things, how could one speak of perfectly cultivating it completely as the wisdom of omniscience?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, consider how all sentient beings travel without obstruction along a level and pleasant road. Along that road there is a shady tree, exceedingly cool in its shade. Travelers rest beneath it and take their ease; yet that shade of the tree remains always present — it does not change and perish, and no one can carry it away. The road in that simile stands for the noble path. The shade stands for the intrinsic nature of a

buddha.

Son of good family, consider a great city with a single gate: many beings pass in and out through it, and no one can interrupt them or demolish it and carry it away. Son of good family, consider a great bridge along which many people pass: no one can interrupt or block them, and no one can destroy it and carry it away. Son of good family, consider a skilled physician who heals all illnesses everywhere: no one can stop him and say, "Heal this one; abandon that one." In just the same way the noble path and the intrinsic nature of a buddha are like that.

Simhaghoṣa said: Blessed One, the similes you have given do not quite fit the point. Why? If someone who has not walked the road before is timid going forward, why should it be said that there is no obstruction? In the same way, others too experience timidity. If the noble path and the intrinsic nature of a buddha are like those things, then when one person cultivates the path, it would seem fitting that others would experience timidity.

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, when you say that what I have said lacks meaning, know that the simile of the road I used was only a partial simile — not a complete one. Son of good family, a worldly road can be interrupted and obstructed, and because near and far are distinct for it, it is not fully analogous. The undefiled path is not like that: it does not interrupt sentient beings, it is level and without duality, and there is no occasion for timidity in it — near and far are distinct for worldly roads but not for this. This genuine path is the cause of the illumination of the intrinsic nature of a buddha in all sentient beings, not the cause of its arising. This is like how the light of a lamp illuminates objects without creating them.

Son of good family, all sentient beings equally have formations conditioned by ignorance. Because ignorance conditions the formations of one person, one cannot block those formations and then say that others have none; all sentient beings have formations conditioned by ignorance. Therefore it is taught that the twelve links of dependent origination are present equally in all.

In the same way, when sentient beings cultivate the undefiled path, this equally severs all afflictions of sentient beings, all four modes of birth, all the elements, and all the routes of continued existence. It is for this reason that it is called "equal." Whoever fully absorbs this path knows and sees both this side and the further shore, and is without obscuration. Therefore it is called the wisdom of omniscience.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, sentient beings do not all have bodies of the same kind. Some have the bodies of gods, some have human bodies, some have the bodies of animals, hungry ghosts, or hell-beings. Since these bodies are distinct and not one, why do you teach that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is one and the same?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, consider an example. If someone were to put poison into milk, the poison would be present all the way through to the essence of butter. One does not call the milk butter, nor does one call the butter milk, yet from milk through to the essence of butter, each stage has its own name and characteristic mark, but the nature of the poison is never lost, and it pervades all five stages of flavor. Even without poison being added to the essence of butter, if one were to drink that essence of butter, it would still cause death. In the same way, the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings circulates through the five paths as they transmigrate, and although they assume bodies that are different from one another, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is one, permanent, and unchanging.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, among the sixteen great territories there are six great cities: Śrāvastī, the city of Kuśinagarī, the city of Campā, Vaiśālī, the city of Śrāvaka, and Rājagṛha. These six cities are the greatest in the world. Why then, passing those by, did the Tathāgata go to this city of Kuśinagara, which is at the very border of the territory, utterly poor and ugly, a place of destitution and misery, to pass into nirvāṇa?

The Blessed One declared: It is improper to say of this city of Kuśinagara that it is at the border of the territory, poor, and destitute. Rather, it is fitting to say that it is supremely adorned with the highest and most excellent qualities. Why so? Because it is the place where buddhas and bodhisattvas dwell. Son of good family, just as if a king were to visit even a humble house, that house becomes most beautifully adorned, is considered meritorious, and one must offer praise saying, "How wonderful that the king has come here!" Son of good family, just as a person afflicted by a severe illness might send for an inferior medicine, and if that medicine heals the disease, one would rejoice in it and call it supreme and excellent, praising it by saying, "This medicine has cured my illness!" Son of good family, just as someone who has boarded a vessel and entered the ocean, and whose boat breaks apart, leaving them without refuge or support, might grasp hold of a human corpse and reach the far shore, and would then rejoice greatly in it and offer praise, saying, "Through meeting you I have been brought to safety!" — in just the same way this city

of Kuśinagara is the place where buddhas and bodhisattvas walk and dwell. Why then should one say it is a miserable border town, ugly, destitute, and wretched?

Son of good family, I call to mind the past. In ages gone by — as many as the sands of the Ganges rivers — in a kalpa called Excellent Wisdom, there was at that time a wheel-turning king of the lineage of Kauśika, possessed of the seven precious treasures and complete with a thousand sons. That king was the first to build this city. All around it, a moat of water twelve leagues in breadth surrounded it as a girdle, and it was beautifully adorned with the seven precious treasures.

At that time in that land there were very many rivers, and all their waters were exceedingly clear, gentle, and sweet. There were, for example, the river called Jīlanaśana, the river called Ilapatī, the river called Hilenaśana, the river called Isomatī, the river called Bāviśana, and so on — some five hundred rivers in all. Along both the near and the far banks of those rivers the trees were exceedingly numerous, and they were filled with abundant blossoms and fruits. At that time the human lifespan was immeasurable. After a hundred years had passed, the wheel-turning king spoke and said these words: "Even as the Blessed One has taught — all phenomena are impermanent. Whoever practises the teaching of the ten virtues will cut through the great suffering of impermanence." Then, when all the people heard him speak those words, everyone took up the practice of the ten virtues. At that time I heard the name of the Buddha, and grasping the ten virtues as a dhāraṇī (a holding formula), I held them firmly in mind and cultivated them in meditation, and in that very moment the awakening mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening was born in me for the first time. Having aroused that mind, through those very teachings I showed to countless, immeasurable sentient beings that all phenomena are impermanent — arising and passing away, shifting and changing. Therefore, even now, in this very place, I continually teach: "All phenomena are impermanent — shifting and passing away; only the body of a buddha has the quality of permanence." From that time onward I have been proclaiming this, and bearing in mind the causes and conditions of my former conduct, it is for the sake of repaying the kindness of this very land that I am passing into nirvāṇa here today. It is for this reason that I have declared in all the sūtras that those included in my retinue are repaying a kindness.

Furthermore, son of good family, in the distant past, when the lifespan of sentient beings extended for incalculable kalpas, the city bore the name Kośavarī, and the moat encircling it on all sides was fifty leagues in breadth. At that time in Jambudvīpa this city was situated on its outskirts, so close to the edge that one could leap from rooftop to rooftop and pass from one part to another in a single bound. At that time there was a wheel-turning king called Magnificent Radiance, possessed of the seven precious treasures, complete with a thousand sons, and sovereign over the four continents. His regent son, having devoted his mind to the sublime Dharma, came to full realization as a pratyekabuddha. Then the wheel-turning king, seeing that his royal son and regent had achieved realization as a pratyekabuddha — his deportment supremely beautiful and his miraculous powers extraordinary — seeing such things, he cast aside the affairs of kingship as though spitting out saliva, went forth into homelessness, and here at the root of the śāla tree he cultivated the mind of loving-kindness for eighty thousand years. He likewise cultivated the minds of compassion, joy, and equanimity, each for eighty thousand years. Son of good family, do you think that the king called Magnificent Radiance at that time and in that age was someone other than myself? That was I. Therefore even now I rejoice always in resorting to those four qualities of Dharma. Those four qualities of Dharma are precisely what is called meditative absorption.

Son of good family, for this very reason, the body of a Tathāgata is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. Son of good family, by that cause and through that condition I too, at the city of Kuśinagara, enter into meditative absorption at the root of the śāla tree. Son of good family, among those countless kalpas that I call to mind, at that time and in that age, this city was called Kapilavastu, and the king there was named Pure Food. That king's queen was called Celestial Beauty. The king's son was called Accomplished Goal. At that time, without having been taught by any teacher, through his own reflection that prince attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

There were two chief attendants: one was Śāriputra, and one was Mahāmaudgalyāyana. The personal attendant was named Ānanda. At that time, the Blessed One taught this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa at the root of the śāla tree, and I was among the assembly gathered there. At that time I heard it proclaimed that all sentient beings possess the nature of a buddha. Having heard such matters, I became irreversible from awakening and made this aspiration: "In the future, at the time when I myself attain complete and

perfect awakening, may my parents, the name of my land, my chief attendants, my personal attendant, and the teacher who expounds the Dharma all be just as those of this present Blessed One." Having made that aspiration, by that cause and through that condition I too now teach and expound this sūtra of the great nirvāṇa here.

Son of good family, long ago, after I had gone forth but before I had attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, King Rūpasāra sent a messenger with these words: "Prince Accomplished Goal, if you were to become a wheel-turning king, I would serve you as your minister. But if you have no love for the household life and instead attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, then please come first to this royal city, teach the Dharma, liberate all sentient beings, and be pleased to accept my offerings." At that time I said nothing but granted his request.

Son of good family, after I first attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, I was traveling toward the land called Karka. At that time, on the bank of the river called Terrifying, there was a brahmin of the lineage of Kāśyapa who, together with five hundred disciples, was practicing the path to unsurpassed awakening on the bank of that river. I went there specifically to teach the Dharma for their sake, and Kāśyapa said to me this: "Gautama, I am old and have reached one hundred and twenty years of age. All the people of the central land of Campā, as well as King Rūpasāra and the rest, think that I have attained the fruit of arhathood. If people were to hear the Dharma from you, they would all develop wrong views and say that the venerable Kāśyapa is not an arhat. Gautama, please depart quickly to another place. If these people come to know that Gautama's qualities surpass mine, then we and those like us will no longer be able to obtain our livelihood."

I then said to them: "Kāśyapa, if you show me no respect and bear me no aversion, then stay for one night, and when you rise in the morning you may go before me." Kāśyapa replied: "Gautama, my mind harbors no other intention — I am indeed pleased with you — but in this place of mine there lives a nāga (nāga) that is extremely wrathful and fierce, and I fear it may do you harm." I replied: "Kāśyapa, among those that are poisonous, the most venomous are none other than the three poisons, and since I have cut those away, I have no fear of the world's poisons." Kāśyapa replied again: "Very well then, since you have no fear, please remain and we shall see."

Son of good family, at that time I displayed eighteen miracles for the sake of Kāśyapa, exactly as described in the sūtras. Then Kāśyapa, together with his five hundred attendants, having seen and heard such things, attained the fruit of arhathood. Kāśyapa had two younger brothers: one was called River Kāśyapa and one was called Lake-Reed Kāśyapa. Each of them likewise had about five hundred attendants, and they too all attained the fruit of arhathood.

At that time, upon hearing these things, the six teachers of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who were in Rājagṛha, together with their retinues, conceived great ill-will toward me. So that I might not go back on my promise, I went to Rājagṛha as the king had requested. Before I had even arrived, the king came out to meet me with a retinue of countless hundreds of thousands, and I taught the Dharma there. At that very moment, upon hearing the teaching, some eighty-six thousand gods of the desire realm (kāmadhātu) generated the mind of unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. Of those who had gone as servants and attendants of King Bimbisāra, about one hundred and twenty thousand attained the fruit of stream-entry. Beyond that, immeasurable numbers of sentient beings came to possess minds of patience. Remaining within the city, I also sent forth two hundred and fifty people, together with their retinues, including Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana, in the going-forth of renunciation (pravrajyā). Having relinquished their former minds, they came to train on the path. I stayed there at that time and accepted the king's offerings. The six non-Buddhist teachers then gathered their retinues and departed for the land of Śrāvastī.

Now, at that time, in that same region, a householder named Anāthapiṇḍada had come to Rājagṛha in order to obtain a bride. Having arrived at Rājagṛha, he was staying there at the house of a householder named Sañjaya. In the middle of the night, that householder rose and said to his attendants: "Come now, quickly, adorn the house and hang up banners, and prepare excellent food and drink." When Anāthapiṇḍada heard these words, he thought to himself: "Is this a wedding feast, a musical celebration, or perhaps a reception for King Bimbisāra, the ruler of the central lands?" Thinking this, he went over and asked: "Great householder, is this for a wedding feast, or for a musical celebration, or is it because you are receiving King Bimbisāra, the ruler of the central lands? Why all this bustle and urgent work?" The householder replied: "It is none of those things. Householder, tomorrow I am receiving a buddha, the unsurpassable King of Dharma." When Anāthapiṇḍada first heard the word "buddha," his entire body was suffused with a tingling rapture, and he asked

again: "What is meant by the word 'buddha'?" The householder said: "Have you not heard? In the land of the yellow-robed ones, one of the Śākya clan, named Siddhartha, of the Gautama lineage, whose father is called Śuddhodana — though not long after his birth the astrologers declared without any doubt that he would certainly become a wheel-turning king, as clear as an āmra fruit resting in the palm of one's hand, he felt no inclination for that, and so went forth from home into homelessness, and through his own insight, without a teacher, attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. He is one in whom attachment, aversion, and delusion are utterly exhausted; who abides always, unchanging, unshifting, unborn, and unceasing; who is free from grief and fear; whose mind is equal toward all sentient beings, as a parent gazes upon an only child; whose many bodies and minds are supreme above all; who, though surpassing all, has no conceit or arrogance; whose mind is non-dual with respect to anointing and censure; who comprehends all things through wisdom; who is unobstructed with regard to phenomena; and who is endowed with the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, the five wisdoms, meditative absorption, great loving-kindness, great compassion, and the three foundations of mindfulness — it is for these reasons that he is called a 'buddha.' He is graciously coming tomorrow, and that is why I am so busy I have no time even to talk." Anāthapiṇḍada said: "Excellent!"

"Where does this great being, the buddha possessed of unsurpassed qualities, currently abide?" The householder replied: "At present he dwells in a great pavilion in the Kalandakanivāpa grove, here in Rājagṛha." Then Anāthapiṇḍada fixed his mind one-pointedly on the Buddha, recollecting and bearing in mind the ten powers, the four kinds of fearlessness, the five wisdoms, meditative absorption, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the three foundations of mindfulness, and all his qualities. As he recollected in this way, a great radiant light blazed and shone forth like the sun, and he set out in the direction from which the light had come. When he reached the city gate, by the blessing of the Blessed One the gate opened of itself.

Upon passing through the gate he came upon a shrine to a worldly deity standing along the road. Anāthapiṇḍada paid homage to it with reverence, but in a moment it disappeared entirely. A feeling of fear and dread arose in him and he turned back toward home, but when he reached the city gate again, a deity addressed Anāthapiṇḍada with these words: "O man, if you were to proceed into the presence of the Tathāgata, you would obtain abundant benefit and happiness." Anāthapiṇḍada said: "What do you mean by 'benefit

and happiness'?" The deity replied: "Householder, suppose someone were to give to a single person a hundred fine horses adorned with genuine jewels, a hundred fragrant bulls, a hundred jewelled chariots, a hundred men cast in gold, a hundred beautiful young women wearing garlands and adorned with jewels, fine and excellent mansions and great pavilions with carved relief decoration, a hundred golden bowls filled with silver coins and a hundred silver bowls filled with golden coins — and were to give such gifts in like manner to every last person in Jambudvīpa. The merit thereby obtained would not equal even a single step taken by one who sets out to go into the presence of the Tathāgata."

Anāthapiṇḍada said: "Son of good family, who are you who speaks like this?" The deity replied: "Householder, I am the son of the brahmin Gyaltsen. In times past I was also your spiritual friend. Formerly, when I beheld Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana and joy arose in my mind, I followed in their wake and became the son of the guardian of the North, the Lord of Rest, and I constantly guard this city of Rājagṛha. Because joy arose in me toward Śāriputra and the others and I paid homage to them, through that cause and that condition I obtained such an excellent and noble body. What then need be said of beholding the Tathāgata, the great Teacher, and making offerings and paying homage to him?"

Householder Anāthapiṇḍada, upon hearing these words, turned back onto the road and came to where I was, and with the crown of his head he paid homage at my feet. I then taught him the Dharma as it is, and upon hearing it, the householder attained the fruit of stream-entry. Having attained that fruit, he further made this entreaty: "May the Tathāgata, out of great compassion, be pleased to accept a modest offering from me and proceed to Śrāvastī." At that time I asked the householder: "Is there a pavilion in your land of Śrāvastī large enough to accommodate me?" Anāthapiṇḍada replied: "If the Blessed One out of loving kindness will definitely consent to come, then I shall gather whatever I have and arrange a suitable dwelling." Son of good family, at that time I said nothing and consented to come.

The householder Anāthapiṇḍada, knowing that consent to come had been given, addressed me with these words: "I have never before done anything of this kind. Would the Tathāgata be pleased to send Śāriputra to show me what procedures I should follow?" I granted his request accordingly, and Śāriputra and Anāthapiṇḍada together boarded a single carriage and set out for Śrāvastī. By the power of my blessing they reached the place within a single

day.

Then Anāthapiṇḍada said to Śāriputra: "Venerable one, outside this city there is a site that is neither too near nor too far away, with springs, pools, good shade trees, groves, flowering trees, and many fruit trees in great abundance — a thoroughly pure and secluded place. I ask you to examine it. I shall build a monastery there for the Buddha, the Blessed One, and the Saṅgha of monks."

Śāriputra replied: "This Jeta Grove is neither too near nor too far away; it is thoroughly pure and secluded, with springs, flowing streams, flowering trees, and many fruit trees — whatever is needed is there at hand. Examine this site and raise a monastery."

When Anāthapiṇḍada heard these words, the great householder went to where Prince Jeta was and spoke to him thus: "I am building a dwelling for the sake of the unsurpassed king of Dharma. Your grove has been selected. If I wish to purchase it from you, will you sell it to me?"

Jeta replied: "Even if you were to fill every inch of ground with nothing but gold, I would not sell it."

Anāthapiṇḍada said: "Excellent, Jeta! The ground itself shall be mine to dispose of — spread out the gold."

Jeta said: "I am not selling my grove — why then do you say 'spread out the gold'?"

Anāthapiṇḍada said: "If you are not satisfied with this, let us go before a judge to settle the matter."

The two householders went before a judge, and the judge ruled that the ground was under the authority of Anāthapiṇḍada, and that Jeta was to spread out the gold. Then carts and horses were loaded with gold, and it was laid out across the ground. By the end of one day, only a stretch of five hundred paces remained uncovered by gold.

Jeta said: "Householder, if you have any regret, you may withdraw."

Anāthapiṇḍada replied: "I am content to draw from the full treasury of gold. I have no regret in my heart."

Jeta then reflected: "The Tathāgata, the king of Dharma, teaches the perfectly unsurpassed and sublime Dharma — pure and completely free of attachment. And this man has spared no precious wealth for his sake." Thinking thus, he said to Anāthapiṇḍada: "The remaining portion that has not yet been covered

— no gold is needed from you. I myself shall build a gatehouse for the Blessed One, so that the Tathāgata may always walk to and fro."

Then the householder Jeta built the gatehouse. The householder Anāthapiṇḍada, within the span of seven days, built three hundred large dwelling halls, sixty-three meditation cells, warm winter quarters, cool summer quarters each in their number, bath-houses, foot-washing rooms, and the places for sweeping the grounds of both the larger and smaller latrines — every one of them fully equipped. When everything was done, he took up a golden vessel and, standing at a distance to one side toward Rājagṛha, proclaimed these words: "All the offerings have been arranged."

"O Tathāgata, compassionate one, please accept this dwelling for the sake of all sentient beings." Such were the words he spoke.

Now at that time, knowing the intention of that householder through his own mind, I set out with my retinue from Rājagṛha — in the time it takes a strong man to extend and draw back his arm — and arrived at the Jeta Grove in Śrāvastī, at the great dwelling hall of Anāthapiṇḍada. Having arrived, the householder Anāthapiṇḍada presented to me all the offerings he had arranged. I accepted them at that very time and remained there in that place.

Then the six teachers of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), their minds seized by jealousy, assembled together and went to the court of King Prasenajit, where they spoke these words:

"Great King, be pleased to understand this: the peace and happiness that prevail throughout your royal domain are due to our presence here as those who have truly gone forth. That is why we now reside here. The Great King governs by righteous Dharma and protects his subjects from harm. Yet this ascetic Gautama has spent only a short time here studying, and he knows nothing at all. Puffed up with pride in his royal lineage, he shows no respect to those who were established in this land before him, or to those of genuine merit. If he is of royal lineage, it would be fitting for one who has governed the affairs of subjects, even upon going forth, to show respect to elders. Great King, please listen well. The ascetic Gautama was not born of a true royal lineage. If the ascetic Gautama had a father and mother, why did he steal away the parents of others? Great King, in our scriptures it is said: 'After a thousand years have passed, there will appear a wicked omen full of deceit.' That very one is none other than this ascetic Gautama. The ascetic Gautama has no father and no mother. If he did have parents, why would he teach that

all phenomena are impermanent, suffering, selfless, empty, without agent, and without one who grasps? He is a deceiver and a fraud who misleads sentient beings. The deluded will believe him, but those with wisdom will reject him.

Great King, what is called a king is the father and mother of all subjects. He is like a scale, like the earth, like the wind, like fire, like a road, like a river, like a bridge, like a lamp, like the sun, like the moon — he judges in accordance with Dharma, impartially, free from love and hate.

This ascetic Gautama does not provide us with our livelihood; wherever we go, he follows on our heels and will not leave us be. Great King, allow us to compete with Gautama in displays of miraculous power. If he wins, we will submit to his authority; if we win, please place him under ours."

The king replied: "Venerable ones, you each have your own practices to follow and your own places to dwell. I know for certain that the Tathāgata does no harm to any of you."

The six teachers asked: "How does he do no harm? This ascetic Gautama bewilders people with his Dharma of illusions, so that brahmins and all the rest have gone to him for refuge, and all are exhausted. If the king permits a contest of miraculous power between us, the king's fair name will ring out in all eight directions. If you do not permit it, your name will everywhere be known as an ill one."

The king replied: "Venerable ones, it is because you do not know how very great the Tathāgata's miraculous power truly is that you wish to compete with him. If you truly understood, I suspect you would not dare attempt it."

He continued: "Great King, have you already been deceived by the ascetic? Great King, for the moment, be patient — and do not revile us."

"Better that it be accomplished than merely spoken of to no purpose." The king then said, "Very well! Excellent!" and with that, the six teachers departed together with their retinues, greatly pleased.

At that time, King Prasenajit, together with his retinue, came into my presence, and with full reverence bowed his head to the ground in homage, circumambulated me three times to the right, and stationed himself to one side. He then addressed me in these words: "Blessed One, the six teachers of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) came before me and requested permission to contest in miraculous power. Without deliberating carefully, I granted

permission. Blessed One, please forgive me."

The Blessed One declared: "Well done, Great King! Well done! Have lodgings constructed in this other place as well. And why is that? If they are to contest with me in miraculous power, an even greater multitude will come streaming here from those assemblies, and this place will be too cramped to hold them." "Noble son, at that time, for the sake of the six teachers of the non-Buddhists, I displayed wondrous and extraordinary miracles and magical displays from the first day of the month through the fifteenth.

At that very time, immeasurable numbers of sentient beings generated the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Immeasurable numbers of sentient beings came to hold faith in the Three Jewels without any doubt. Immeasurable numbers from the retinues of the six teachers shattered their minds of wrong view and went forth into renunciation within the true Dharma. Immeasurable numbers of sentient beings attained a mind of non-return from awakening. Immeasurable numbers of sentient beings attained the various categories of dhāraṇī samādhi. Immeasurable numbers of sentient beings attained everything from the fruit of stream-entry through to the fruit of arhatship.

At that time the six non-Buddhist teachers were utterly mortified and ashamed. They all went together to a city called Cīta. Having arrived there, they taught perverse doctrines to all the people living there and won them over, and proclaimed abroad: 'The ascetic Gautama teaches nothing but emptiness.' Noble son, at that time I ascended to the Heaven of the Thirty-Three for the sake of my mother and, at the foot of the Pāricitra tree, entered into the proper posture and taught the Dharma. Then the six teachers, with minds full of delight, proclaimed: 'Excellent! That deceiver Gautama has now disappeared!' and drew yet further immeasurable, innumerable sentient beings into wrong view.

Thereupon, King Śuddhodana, King Prasenajit, the four-fold retinue (parṣad), and others addressed the son of Maudgala in these words: "Venerable one, wrong views are arising and spreading here in Jambudvīpa, and even those who have been a refuge of deep care for sentient beings are falling into great darkness. Venerable one, you must ascend to the heavens above and address the Blessed One thus: 'Blessed One, we reverently bow before you and say this: just as a newborn calf, before it has grown, will surely perish if it does not drink its mother's milk — we and all sentient beings are in just such a state.

Out of compassion for all sentient beings, please, Tathāgata, be so gracious as to return here once more.'"

Then Maudgalyāputra, without uttering a word, ascended to the heavens above — as swiftly as a strong man might stretch out his bent arm — and came into the presence of the Blessed One and addressed him thus: "In Jambudvīpa, the four-fold assemblies long with thirst, as though parched, to hear the Dharma from the Tathāgata. King Śuddhodana,

King Senavardhana and the fourfold assembly and their retinues prostrated at his feet and spoke these words: "All the sentient beings that dwell in this Jambudvīpa have fallen into wrong views and those views are spreading and growing; they wander in deep confusion as though lost in darkness, and are greatly worthy of compassion. It is as with a newborn calf: if it has not long been born and does not drink its mother's milk, it will surely perish. We and all beings are in just that same condition. Therefore, Tathāgata, for the sake of sentient beings, please be so gracious as to return once more to Jambudvīpa."

The Blessed One declared: "Maudgalyāputra, go back to Jambudvīpa quickly and say this to the kings and to the fourfold assembly: 'In seven days from now I shall return. I go to the land of Citā on account of the six teachers.'" Then, when seven days had passed, he came to the land of Citā, surrounded by Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, by Brahmā, by the gods of Māra's realm, by immeasurable and countless divine sons, and by all the gods of Śuddha's retinue, and proclaimed these words with a great lion's roar: "It is only in my Dharma that there are ascetics and brahmins for whom all phenomena are impermanent, without self, nirvāṇa, and peace — free from every blemish and fault. In the Dharma of others there is no basis whatsoever for the claim that their ascetics and brahmins know permanence, self, or nirvāṇa."

At that time, immeasurable and boundless sentient beings aroused the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Then the six teachers of the non-Buddhists said to one another: "If our Dharma has no ascetics, brahmins, and the like, how will those who dwell in the world come to revere it?" And having said this, the six teachers went together to the city of Vaiśālī.

Noble son, there was a time when I was dwelling in the Āmra Grove of the city of Vaiśālī. A woman named Āmrapālī learned that I was dwelling there and thought to herself that she would go into my presence. At that time I spoke to the monks: "Monks, examine the establishment of mindfulness closely,

cultivate wisdom, and do not be slothful in whatever you cultivate." Now, how does one examine the establishment of mindfulness? If a monk examines the inner body and does not find therein a self or what belongs to a self, examines the outer body and the body that is both inner and outer and does not find a self or what belongs to a self, and similarly examines feeling, mind, and phenomena — this is called the establishment of mindfulness. And how does one cultivate wisdom? If a monk sees suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path just as they actually are — this is called the cultivation of wisdom. And what is the mind free of sloth? If a monk recollects the Buddha, recollects the Dharma, recollects the Saṅgha, recollects moral discipline, recollects generosity, and recollects the gods — this is called a monk's mind free of sloth.

At that time, the woman Āmrapālī came into my presence, prostrated with her head at my feet, circumambulated three times to the right, made offerings, and sat to one side. Noble son, I then taught her the Dharma as it truly is. Having heard the Dharma, that woman aroused the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Then, at that same time, about five hundred young Licchavī men came into my presence, prostrated with their heads at my feet, circumambulated three times to the right, made offerings, and stood to one side. I then taught the Dharma to those young Licchavī men just as it truly is.

Noble sons, heedlessness ripens five kinds of fruit. What are the five? One has no power over one's own wealth; one's reputation becomes ill-famed; one takes no pleasure in giving to the poor; one does not wish to see the four kinds of retinue; and one does not attain the body of the gods.

Noble sons, from the cause of heedfulness, both worldly and supramundane Dharmas arise. Therefore, whoever desires unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening must strive in the qualities of heedfulness.

As for heedlessness, there are also thirteen further fruits that ripen from it. What are the thirteen? One is inclined to engage in worldly activities; one is inclined to speak meaningless words; one is inclined to sleep for a long time; one is inclined to talk about worldly things; one is constantly inclined to associate with unwholesome spiritual companions; one is lazy and inclined to idle behavior; one is always despised by others; whatever one hears, one immediately forgets it; one delights in dwelling in remote borderlands; one is unable to tame the sense faculties; one does not know moderation in food;

one has no inclination toward truth; and one holds incorrect views. These are the thirteen.

Noble son, though a heedless person may be near a buddha and close to a buddha's presence, they should be called one who is utterly far away.

The Licchavīs then said: "We acknowledge that we have been heedless. And why? If we had not been heedless, the Tathāgata, the king of Dharma, would not have come to our land." At that moment, in the midst of the great assembly, a brahmin's son by the name of Ajita spoke to the Licchavīs and said: "Excellent! Excellent! Just as you have said. The king Rūpasāra obtained great benefit and happiness, and thus the Blessed One, the Buddha, came to that land. Just as the finest lotus born from a great lake, though born within the water, is not stained by the water — so too, young Licchavīs, though the Buddha came to that land, he is not stained by the phenomena of the world. The Blessed Buddhas have neither arising nor entering, yet for the sake of sentient beings they appear in the world and are not obscured by worldly phenomena. People deceive themselves: attached and clinging to the five desirable objects, not knowing to take refuge in the Tathāgata — such people are called heedless. But it is not right to say that the Buddha is heedless because he appears and dwells in the midst of the world. Why? Because the Blessed Buddhas are like the sun and moon: they do not appear in the world for the sake of one or two."

When those Licchavīs heard these words, they aroused the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and said: "Excellent! Excellent! The young Ajita has spoken the sublime Dharma of the utterly unconquered."

Then those Licchavīs, each one removing an upper garment, offered it to Ajita. Ajita accepted them and then offered them to me, saying: "Blessed One, these garments I have received from the Licchavīs. May the Tathāgata, out of loving compassion for sentient beings, please accept this offering I present." At that time, I accepted them out of loving compassion for the young Ajita.

Then all the Licchavīs together, pressing their palms together, addressed me thus: "Tathāgata, you have come to this land at this time according to the proper way. Will you please accept a little of our offerings?" I said nothing at that time, and by my silence I granted the Licchavīs what they had requested.

Then, upon hearing what had befallen those six teachers, they — the teachers together with their retainers — departed for the town of Śerkyā. I too then went to Śerkyā and sat down on the bank of a river called Kluṇḍpa.

Now in Śerkyā there lived a householder named Ratnakīrti who was extremely attached to and captivated by the five sensual pleasures, and who did not understand impermanence. When I went to him, by his own attainment of the teaching of reflection upon the skeleton, he came to see his house, his home, his wife, and all his possessions as skeletons. Terror arose in his mind, and as though confronted by a sword, a venomous snake, a thief, or fire, he rushed out of his house and came before me. Along the way, right there on the road, he spoke these words: "Ascetic Gautama, I am now gripped by terror, as though driven by an enemy. I pray that you grant me refuge." Then the Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are happiness itself — they hold no fear." The householder replied: "If the Three Jewels hold no fear, may I too attain that fearlessness." Having spoken thus, he petitioned me for the going forth, and I granted it.

At that time, the householder had fifty friends. Hearing that Ratnakīrti, overcome by weariness with desire, had gone forth, they too joined together and went forth. Upon hearing this, the six teachers went on to the great city of Campā. Then all the people of Campā made offerings and paid homage to the six teachers and their retinues, and they did not even hear the names of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Many people came to commit deeply non-virtuous deeds. At that time I traveled to the city of Campā for the sake of sentient beings.

In that city there lived a householder whose lineage was on the verge of dying out. Wishing for a son, he was making offerings to the six teachers. Later his wife became pregnant, and when the householder learned of it, he went to the six teachers and with a joyful heart asked them: "Is the child in my pregnant wife's womb a boy or a girl?" They looked and declared with certainty: "Without a doubt, a girl will be born." When the householder heard this, he was tormented by grief and became unhappy. Then a friend of his came to him and asked why he was so afflicted with sorrow. The householder replied: "My wife is pregnant, but I did not know whether it would be a boy or a girl, so I asked the six teachers. They looked and said that without a doubt, according to their reading of the signs, a girl would be born. Hearing that, I am distressed — I am an old man grown aged, with wealth beyond counting, and if there is no son to inherit it, there is no one to whom it can be entrusted. That is why I am unhappy." His friend replied: "You are ignorant! Have you not heard before? The two brothers of the river Kāśyapa — did they go to the Buddha or to the six teachers? If the six teachers were omniscient, why would Kāśyapa have left

the six teachers and gone to the Buddha? Moreover, did not Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, and the like, and kings such as Bimbisāra and others, and royal queens, and householders from every land who distribute food to the unprotected — did not all of these go over to the Buddha's side rather than remain with the six teachers? And did not the Tathāgata tame even such beings as the hungry ghost of the remote hermitage, King Ajātaśatru, the maddened bull that guarded a treasure hoard, and Aṅgulimāla — he who had so intensely spread non-virtuous thoughts and was restrained before he could kill?"

"Householder, the Blessed One the Buddha is called 'buddha' because he knows and sees all phenomena without obstruction. He is called 'Tathāgata' because all his speech is free from duality. He is called 'arhat' because he has overcome all afflictions. What the Blessed One has declared is beyond duality. If the six teachers are not like this, how can one place trust in them? The Tathāgata is dwelling here right now. If you truly wish to understand, go into the presence of the Buddha." So the householder said.

Then that man accompanied the householder, came into my presence, bowed his head to my feet, circumambulated to the right three times, pressed his palms together, placed his knees upon the ground, and addressed me with these words: "Blessed One, you look upon all sentient beings with equanimity and without duality, seeing both enemy and friend with the same characteristic. Yet I am bound by the afflictions arising from craving, and so I have not become non-dual toward enemy and friend. Because of this, I had thought to petition the Tathāgata, the Blessed One, but shame and fear overcame me and I did not dare to ask. Blessed One, now concerning my pregnant wife — the six teachers looked at her and declared with certainty that a daughter would be born. How does that matter stand? What is the truth of it?"

The Blessed One declared: "Householder, the child that your wife carries in her womb is certainly a boy, and when he is born he will be endowed with immeasurable merit."

Then, upon hearing me speak those words, the householder was filled with great joy and returned home. At that moment the six teachers heard that I had prophesied with certainty that a meritorious son would be born to that householder's wife, and jealousy arose in their minds. They mixed poison into a mango fruit, came to the householder, and said to him: "Gautama has made

a very fine prediction. For the birth of your wife's child, have her drink this medicine — if she takes this medicine, the child will be excellent, handsome, and free from illness." The householder, delighted, took the poison, gave it to his wife, and she drank it. The moment she drank it, she died.

Then the six teachers, rejoicing, proclaimed throughout every city and marketplace in a loud voice: "The ascetic Gautama prophesied that that householder's wife would certainly give birth to a boy endowed with incomparable merit — yet instead the child was not born and the mother has died!" So they announced.

Then that householder's faith in me was shaken, and following worldly custom, he placed her body in a coffin, carried it outside the city, piled up dry wood, and set it alight to burn.

I, seeing these events with my divine eye, commanded Ānanda: "Ānanda, put on my robe. We are going to crush a wrong view." Then I commanded the spirit-lord of hungry ghosts, whose name was Jewel Pātala (Ratnpātala), as follows: "The Tathāgata is now going to the charnel ground. Go quickly, level the ground, sweep it and wipe it clean with banners, set up a lion throne, and strew the earth thickly with flowers and fine incense."

Then the six teachers, seeing me coming from a distance, said to one another: "Is the ascetic Gautama going to the charnel ground to eat flesh, or what?"

At that time, those lay practitioners who had not yet obtained the Dharma eye were each filled with shame and embarrassment, and they said to me: "The householder's pregnant wife has passed away, Blessed One. Please do not go there."

Then Ānanda said to those people: "All of you wait a moment —"

"The Tathāgata will very soon open and reveal the vast domain of buddha conduct." So they spoke.

I then went there, took my seat upon the lion throne, and the householder addressed me with these words: "Since the Blessed One's speech is entirely without duality — when even the mother has died, how can a child be born?"

I then said this to that householder: "At that time you should not have asked about the length or shortness of the mother's life. You should have asked only this: is the child in the womb male or female?"

The Blessed One, whose speech is entirely without duality, declared: "Therefore, without any doubt, a son will be obtained."

At that moment a fire blazed up around the corpse, the belly split open, and from within it a child emerged — just as a newborn lotus rests upon the water, so too a child appeared there within the fire.

When the six teachers saw this, they said: "Gautama is a trickster, clever at illusions."

When the householder saw it, he was filled with joy, and he taunted the six teachers: "If this is illusion, why do you not do the same yourselves?"

Then I said to the midwife: "Go into the fire and bring that child out."

As the midwife was going into the fire, the six teachers seized her and said to her: "Ascetic Gautama's illusionists are not always capable — some times they can, and some times they cannot. If you go in, you will die. Do not trust those words."

The midwife replied: "Even if the Tathāgata were to say, 'Enter the smoldering fires of hell,' I would not be burned. What need is there to speak of ordinary fire?" And with those words she entered into the mass of flames.

Upon entering, as though stepping into cool water, she took the child in her arms, came back to my presence, and gave the child to me.

I received the child and then said this to the householder: "For all sentient beings the measure of life is not fixed — it is like a bubble on water. If a sentient being has the karmic fruit of very strong attachment to life, then fire cannot burn him and poison cannot kill him. This too is the karmic fruit of the child himself; it is not something I have done."

The householder then said: "Excellent. Blessed One, if this child is to live out his lifespan, may the Tathāgata please give him a name."

The Blessed One declared: "Householder, since this child was born from within the smoldering fire, his name shall be Śute — let him be called Śute."

Then, having witnessed my miraculous powers and emanations, immeasurable numbers of sentient beings in that entire assembly gave rise to the mind aimed at unsurpassed and perfect awakening.

At that time the six teachers, finding no place to reside in any of the six great cities, were utterly humiliated, and came — their heads bowed — to this city of Kuśinagara. Having arrived, they proclaimed: "Know this, all you common

people: the ascetic Gautama is a great master of illusion who has deceived everyone and spread through the six great cities. He is like a conjuror who creates assemblies of chariots, assemblies of horses, assemblies of cattle, and assemblies of infantry. Moreover, just as a conjuror creates islands, cities, houses, rivers, lakes, trees, and the like, so too is Gautama the ascetic — he conjures by illusion the bodies of kings. Sometimes, for the sake of teaching the Dharma, he appears in a brahmin's body, sometimes in an ascetic's body, sometimes in the bodies of men and women, sometimes in a great body and sometimes in a small body, sometimes in the bodies of animals and hungry ghosts, and sometimes he expounds the absence of permanence."

Sometimes he expounds permanence, sometimes he expounds suffering, sometimes he expounds bliss, sometimes he expounds the existence of a self, sometimes he expounds selflessness, sometimes he expounds the existence of complete purity, sometimes he expounds the absence of complete purity, sometimes he expounds existence, and sometimes he expounds non-existence. Because none of these are true, they are to be called illusion.

Just as fruit is obtained from a seed as its cause, so too is Gautama the ascetic: he was born of the goddess Māyādevī. If the mother herself is an illusion, how could the son be otherwise? Gautama the ascetic has no genuine knowledge and no genuine vision. Brahmins who practice austerities for many years and maintain ethical conduct still have no genuine knowledge and genuine vision — so how then could Gautama, who trained for only a short time in youth and did not even practice austerities, have genuine knowledge and genuine vision? If even one who practices austerities for seven full years does not attain manifold vision, what need is there to speak of less than six years? Only the foolish and the ignorant believe what he says. Just as a great conjuror deceives the simple-minded, so too is Gautama the ascetic.

O son of good family, those six teachers thus aroused malicious views in sentient beings throughout this city. O son of good family, seeing this, I, with great compassion, gathered the bodhisattvas and great bodhisattvas of the ten directions, filled this grove for a full forty leagues, and today here I shall roar the great lion's roar.

O son of good family, though one may speak at length in an empty place, that is not called roaring the lion's roar. But when it is proclaimed in the midst of a great assembly of the wise and the discerning, that is what is called roaring the great lion's roar.

Now, roaring the lion's roar does not mean expounding that all phenomena are impermanent, suffering, selfless, and utterly impure. It means expounding only that the Tathāgata is permanent, blissful, a self, and utterly pure.

Then the six teachers spoke again, saying: "Gautama, if you have a self, then we too have a self. What is called 'self' is the self of what is seen. Gautama, just as one sees an object through an aperture, so too is the self — the seeing is like an eye, the seeing is like a self."

The Blessed One then declared to the six teachers: "To say that what is seen is the self — that is not the correct meaning. Why? Because in the analogy you have offered, that through an aperture one sees, when a person looks through a single aperture all six sense faculties function. If there were necessarily a self that sees by means of the eye-faculty as its condition, then why is it that through a single aperture all six sense objects are not cognized simultaneously? If a single sense faculty cannot see all six objects at the same time, then what is seen is devoid of self. Furthermore, in the analogy of the aperture, no matter how long one looks through it — even for a hundred years — what is seen remains undifferentiated and the same. If the eye-faculty were also like that, then even when one grows old and the faculties decline, what is seen should logically remain the same and undifferentiated. Moreover, because the eye and the aperture are distinct, inner and outer things are seen. If the eye-faculty is like that, then it should logically be possible to see both inner and outer simultaneously and all at once. If one cannot see both, can it be maintained that a self exists?"

The six teachers said: "Gautama, if there is no self, then who is it that sees?"

The Blessed One declared: "What is called 'seeing' is a convergence of four things: form, appearance, mind, and the eye and the other sense faculties. And in that, in ultimate reality, there is neither a seeing nor a grasping at seeing. It is sentient beings who are confused that speak of grasping at seeing.

Because of this, all sentient beings see in a distorted way. Buddhas and bodhisattvas, however, see correctly. As for the six teachers: if one were to assert that form is a self, that too is not the case. Why? Because form is not, in ultimate reality, a self. If form were the self, there would be no such thing as an unpleasant bodily appearance. And why should the four social classes be distinguished from one another rather than all being subsumed into a single brahmin caste? Why should one be subject to another's power and lack power of one's own? Why should the sense faculties deteriorate and become

impaired? Why should one not simply take on a divine body, but instead take on the various kinds of bodies found among hell-beings, animals, hungry ghosts, and the rest? Looking at the fact that things do not turn out as one wishes, one must inescapably recognize that there is no self.

Because there is no self, things are said to be impermanent. Because they are impermanent, they are suffering. Because they are suffering, they are empty. Because they are empty, they are distorted. And because they are distorted, all sentient beings revolve thoroughly in saṃsāra. The same applies equally to feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

The Blessed One, the Buddha, has severed completely the bonds of form through to the bonds of consciousness, and therefore is called permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. Furthermore, form is dependently originated, and whatever is dependently originated is said to be without self. Whatever is without self is said to be empty and suffering. The body of the Tathāgata does not arise through dependent origination. Because it is not dependently originated, it is said to possess a self. Whatever possesses a self is said to be permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure.

The six teachers then asked again: "Gautama, from form through to consciousness, none is a self; and what is called a self, being all-pervasive, is like empty space."

The Blessed One declared: "If there were something that existed as all-pervasive, it would be illogical to say 'I saw it before.' For if it was seen before, then that seeing was absent earlier and becomes apparent later. If it was absent earlier and present later, then it is called impermanent. And if it is impermanent, why call it all-pervasive? If it were all-pervasive, it would follow that it should be fully present in body throughout all five paths of rebirth. If it were present as a body in each of those, it would follow that karmic maturation should be experienced separately in each one. But if maturation is experienced separately, why do you say one becomes a god or a human? And this that you call 'all-pervasive' — is it one or many? If that self is one, then the very names of father, son, kinsman, and enemy would not exist. If that self is many, it would follow that the five sense faculties of all sentient beings are equal, and that karma and its results would likewise all be equal. If that were the case, why would one speak of any distinction between having complete sense faculties and incomplete ones, between virtuous and non-virtuous action, between the deluded and the wise?"

The six teachers replied: "Gautama, the self of sentient beings is boundless and limitless, while Dharma and non-Dharma admit of degrees. Sentient beings who practice Dharma obtain a good body, and those who practice non-Dharma obtain a poor body. For this reason the karmic fruits of sentient beings are not without distinction."

The Blessed One then declared to the six teachers: "If Dharma and non-Dharma are as you say, then that self is not all-pervasive. But if that self were all-pervasive, it would follow that it permeates everything entirely. If it permeates everything entirely, then even a person who practices virtue would have sin present,

and a person who commits sin would likewise have virtue present. If it is not so, why call it all-pervasive?"

The six teachers replied: "Gautama, consider this example: even if a hundred thousand oil lamps are placed inside a single room, each shines separately, and none obstructs the other. The self of sentient beings is just like that — those who practice virtue and those who commit sin do not intermingle with one another."

The Blessed One declared: "The meaning of your claim that the self is like an oil lamp is not so. Why? Because the light of an oil lamp arises from conditions: when the lamp is born, the light too is born. The self of sentient beings is not like that. The light arises from the oil lamp and dwells in a distinct location. The self of sentient beings, though it arises from the body, does not dwell in a distinct location. Furthermore, the light of an oil lamp coexists with darkness. Why? Consider this: if a single oil lamp is placed outside a dark room, the room does not become bright; but if the lamp is placed inside, it does become bright. If the first lamp had already dispelled the darkness, there would be no need for a second lamp. Yet if a second lamp is needed, it is evident that the prior light was coexisting with the darkness."

The six teachers asked: "Gautama, if there is no self, who then will perform virtue and non-virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: "If it is that self which acts, would it be appropriate to call it permanent? But if it is permanent, why does it sometimes perform virtue and sometimes perform non-virtue? If there are times of performing virtue and times of performing non-virtue, how can you say the self is boundless? If it is the self that acts, why does it engage in the phenomena of non-virtue? If that self truly acts and truly knows, why would doubt arise in

sentient beings that there is no self? Therefore, in the teaching of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), there is assuredly no self. What is called 'self' is the Tathāgata. Why? Because his body is boundless and free from the net of doubt, and because he neither acts nor grasps, he is called permanent. Because he neither arises nor ceases, he is called bliss. Because he is free from the stain of mental afflictions, he is called utterly pure. Because he is free from the ten defining characteristics, he is called empty. Therefore the Tathāgata is permanent, bliss, self, utterly pure, empty, and without marks."

The non-Buddhists said: "If you, Gautama, teach that the Tathāgata is permanent, blissful, self, utterly pure, and without marks, then we recognize that the Dharma taught by Gautama too is not empty. Therefore we shall receive it with bowed heads and hold it as a dhāraṇī." Having said this, at that very moment countless non-Buddhists went forth into renunciation with minds of faith in the teaching of the Buddha.

"O son of noble family, it was for that cause and by that condition that I proclaimed here, at the foot of these sāla trees, a great lion's roar. That very proclamation of the lion's roar is what is called nirvāṇa.

O son of noble family, the pair of sāla trees to the east: by overcoming impermanence, they bring about the attainment of permanence. The pair of trees in the north: by overcoming that which is not utterly pure, they bring about the attainment of utter purity.

O son of noble family, the sentient beings dwelling here guard the sāla grove for the sake of the sāla trees, and do not allow outsiders to break off and cut branches, leaves, and the like. In the same way, I too am like that: for the sake of four qualities of Dharma, I have caused my attendants to guard the Buddha's Dharma. What are those four? Permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity."

These four pairs of trees are guarded by four kings, and it is in order that those four kings may guard and uphold my Dharma that I pass into final nirvāṇa here. O son of noble family, the sāla trees blossom and bear fruit at all times, and they bring benefit at all times to immeasurable sentient beings. I too am like that: I bring benefit to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. In this analogy, the flower stands for self, and the fruit stands for bliss. For this very reason I have entered the meditative absorption of complete peace here between the sāla trees. The meditative absorption of complete peace is nothing other than great nirvāṇa.

Siṃhanāda then asked: "Blessed One, why does the Blessed One pass into nirvāṇa in the middle month of spring?"

The Blessed One replied: "O son of noble family, the middle month of spring is called spring because in the spring months all living things grow and all seedlings take root, flowers and fruits blossom fully, all rivers flow freely, and the milk of all animals increases. At that time many sentient beings give rise to the perception of permanence. In order to dispel sentient beings' notion of permanence, all phenomena are taught to be impermanent, while the Tathāgata alone is taught to abide permanently, unchangingly. O son of noble family, among the six seasons, winter is when everything is dry and all is joyless, while summer is when all is lush and everything delights and clings. In order to dispel sentient beings' worldly bliss, permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity are taught. The Tathāgata is likewise: in order to dispel worldly notions of self and worldly notions of purity, the Tathāgata teaches true self and utter purity. In this analogy, the middle month of spring stands for the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata in its twofold aspect. The joylessness of winter stands for the sadness of the wise and discerning who take no delight in the Tathāgata passing into impermanence and final nirvāṇa. The joy of summer stands for the admiring faith of the wise and discerning in the Tathāgata as permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. The seedlings stand for the example of all sentient beings who, having heard the Dharma, rejoice and thereby plant wholesome roots of virtue in their minds directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. The rivers stand for the example of the great bodhisattvas from all ten directions who gather in my presence to inquire about and uphold this sūtra of great nirvāṇa. The increase of milk in all animals stands for the example of my attendants giving rise to wholesome roots of virtue. The flowers stand for the example of the seven branches of awakening. The fruits stand for the example of the four fruits. For this very reason I pass into final nirvāṇa in the middle month of spring."

Siṃhanāda then asked: "From the Tathāgata's birth onward — through the going forth, the full awakening, and the turning of the wheel of Dharma — all of these were associated with the eighth day of the month. Why then is the final nirvāṇa alone associated with the fifteenth?"

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! O son of noble family, just as on the fifteenth day the moon rises full and without blemish, so too the buddha, the Blessed One, is like that: in the final nirvāṇa there is no decrease and no blemish. Therefore I pass into final nirvāṇa on the fifteenth. O son of

noble family, on the night of the fifteenth day, when the moon is full, it serves eleven purposes. What are those eleven? It dispels darkness. It enables sentient beings to see the path and what is not the path. It enables sentient beings to see the wrong path and the right path. It dispels the torment of heat and brings about the attainment of cool comfort. It defeats the pride and arrogance of fireflies.

It calms the perception and the mind of all things that are containers. It dispels from sentient beings the fearful mind caused by ferocious wild beasts. It causes the blue lotus (utpala) to open. It closes the petals of the day-blooming lotus. It arouses in travelers the intention to set out on the road. And it causes sentient beings to take pleasure in the fivefold sense-enjoyments and to be touched by great ease.

O son of noble family, in just the same way, the moon of the Tathāgata is like that: it vanquishes the great darkness of ignorance; it reveals the right path and the wrong path; it shows the misery of the path of saṃsāra; it opens and reveals the bliss of the path of nirvāṇa; it abandons the torment of attachment, aversion, and delusion; it overcomes the ignorance of non-Buddhists; it vanquishes the thief of all-pervasive mental affliction; it dispels the mind obscured by the five fears; it opens the mind of sentient beings to generate roots of virtue; it covers over the minds of sentient beings stirred by the fivefold sense-desires; and it urges all sentient beings to enter into the great nirvāṇa, and causes them to delight in the conduct of complete liberation. For these reasons, I pass into final nirvāṇa on the fifteenth day — yet truly I do not pass into nirvāṇa.

My foolish and wicked attendants will think, "The Tathāgata has passed into final nirvāṇa." This is like a woman who has many children, and their mother, separated from her children, goes away to another land. While she has not yet returned, each of the children says, "My mother has died." Yet in truth the mother has not died.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar then asked: "Blessed One, what kind of monks will adorn these śāla trees?"

The Blessed One replied: "O son of noble family, if a monk memorizes, recites, chants, corrects the written letters of, understands the profound meaning of, and then teaches to others the twelve branches of sūtra teaching — such a monk is virtuous at the beginning, virtuous in the middle, and virtuous at the end, and teaches the holy life for the benefit of immeasurable sentient beings.

Such a monk as this will greatly adorn the śāla trees.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar asked: "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, is it the monk Ānanda himself?"

"Just so, O son of noble family. And why is that? The monk Ānanda memorizes, recites, and chants the twelve branches of sūtra teaching, and he also reveals and teaches their excellent words and ultimate meaning to others. Just as water is poured from one vessel into another, so too is the monk Ānanda: just as he has heard it from the Buddha, so he teaches it to others."

"O son of noble family, if a monk, having obtained the pure divine eye, sees the entire billion-world great universe of the ten directions as clearly as a mango placed in the palm of one's hand — such a monk as this will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar asked: "Blessed One, if that is so, then it is the monk Anuruddha himself. And why is that? The monk Anuruddha, with his unobstructed divine eye, sees with complete clarity and without impediment all that exists within the billion-world great universe, even down to beings in the intermediate state between the five aggregates."

"O son of noble family, if a monk has few desires, is content, delights in ease, applies himself with great diligence, and cultivates mindfulness, meditative absorption, and wisdom — such a monk as this will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar said: "Blessed One, if that is so, then it is the monk Kāśyapa himself. And why is that? The monk Kāśyapa cultivates to the highest degree the qualities of having few desires, contentment, and so forth."

"O son of noble family, if a monk, for the sake of benefiting sentient beings, with respect to gain and —

not for the sake of fame or reputation — the meditative absorption of non-contention, the conduct of the noble ones, and the practice of dwelling in emptiness: a monk of this kind will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar said: "Blessed One, if that is so, then it is none other than the monk Subhūti himself. And why is that? Subhūti is skilled in the meditative absorption of non-contention, the conduct of the noble ones, and the practice of dwelling in emptiness."

"O son of noble family, if a monk cultivates supernatural power and in a single instant displays various forms of miraculous transformation — and from a single mind and a single meditative absorption manifests the two fruits of water and fire — such a monk will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar said: "Blessed One, if that is so, then it is none other than the monk Mahāmaudgalyāyana himself. And why is that? Mahāmaudgalyāyana is skilled in displaying supernatural powers and miraculous transformations without limit."

"O son of noble family, if a monk cultivates great wisdom, sharp wisdom, swift wisdom, liberating wisdom, profoundly deep wisdom, vast wisdom, boundless wisdom, undefeated wisdom, and authentic wisdom — and is endowed with this supreme faculty of wisdom, and harbors no partial thoughts distinguishing between enemies and friends — and upon hearing that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa and is impermanent, remains free of grief and abides steadily without passing away, and upon hearing that he will not pass beyond sorrow, feels no joy — such a monk will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar said: "Blessed One, if that is so, then it is none other than the monk Śāriputra himself. And why is that? Śāriputra is endowed with great wisdom in all its forms."

"O son of noble family, if a monk teaches that all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature — a body like a vajra, boundless and without limit, permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure — and that, with body and mind unobstructed, one attains the eight masteries: such a monk will also greatly adorn the śāla trees."

Lion's Roar said: "Blessed One, if that is so, then the Tathāgata alone is truly that. And why is that? The body of the Tathāgata is a body like a vajra — boundless, without limit, permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. His body and mind are unobstructed, and he is endowed with the eight masteries. The Blessed One alone will adorn the śāla trees. If he were not to remain, they would not be beautiful. Therefore, out of great compassion, wishing to adorn them perfectly, I aspire that he always remain in this grove of śāla trees."

The Blessed One declared: "O son of noble family, the essential nature of all phenomena is such that there is no fixed place of abiding. Why then do you speak of wishing the Tathāgata to remain? O son of noble family, what is called 'abiding' is a characteristic of form, for it is called abiding because it arises from causes. That which is without cause and condition is called the

abiding of non-abiding. Since the Tathāgata has severed all bonds of form, why do you speak of wishing the Tathāgata to remain? Understand that the same applies equally to feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. O son of noble family, what is called 'abiding' is what is called pride — because of pride one is not liberated. Since one who is not liberated is said to abide, in whom does pride exist, and from where has it come?"

Therefore it is called the abiding of non-abiding. Since the Tathāgata has utterly severed all pride, why do you speak of wishing the Tathāgata to remain? Abiding is a conditioned phenomenon, and since the Tathāgata has utterly severed all conditioned phenomena, he does not abide. Abiding is a phenomenon of emptiness, and since the Tathāgata has utterly severed such phenomena of emptiness, he has attained permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — so why do you speak of wishing the Tathāgata to remain? Abiding is the twenty-five existences, and since the Tathāgata has utterly severed the twenty-five existences, why do you speak of abiding? Abiding is all ordinary beings who are foolish and lowly. Noble ones have neither going, nor coming, nor abiding, and since the Tathāgata has utterly severed even the very characteristics of going, coming, and abiding, why do you speak of abiding?

Now, non-abiding is the body that is boundless. Since the body is boundless in just this way, why do you speak of wishing the Tathāgata to remain in the śāla grove? For if he were to remain in this grove, his body would become one that has limits; and if it had limits, it would become impermanent. Since the Tathāgata is permanent, why do you speak of abiding? Again, non-abiding is empty space. Since the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata is like empty space, why do you speak of abiding? Again, what is called non-abiding is the vajra-like meditative absorption (samādhi). The vajra-like meditative absorption destroys all stations of abiding, and since the Tathāgata himself is the vajra-like meditative absorption, why do you speak of abiding? Again, non-abiding is what is called illusion. Since the Tathāgata is like an illusion, why do you speak of abiding? Again, non-abiding is the absence of beginning and end. Since the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata likewise has no beginning and no end, why do you speak of abiding? Again, non-abiding is the boundless dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. Since the Tathāgata is the very boundless dharmadhātu, why do you speak of abiding? Again, what is called non-abiding is the meditative absorption called the Courageous March. Through the meditative absorption of the Courageous March one knows all phenomena to be without attachment; and because there is no attachment, it

is called the Courageous March. Since the Tathāgata is endowed with the meditative absorption of the Courageous March, why do you speak of abiding? Again, non-abiding is called the power of knowing what is possible and what is not possible. Since the Tathāgata is endowed with the power of knowing what is possible and what is not possible, why do you speak of abiding? Again, what is called non-abiding is called the perfection of generosity. If there were abiding in the perfection of generosity, one could not proceed all the way to the perfection of moral discipline and through to the Perfection of Wisdom. Therefore the perfection of generosity is called non-abiding, and since the Tathāgata likewise does not abide anywhere up to and through the Perfection of Wisdom, why do you speak of always wishing him to remain in the śāla grove? Again, non-abiding is called the cultivation of the four foundations of mindfulness. If the Tathāgata were to abide in the four foundations of mindfulness, he would be unable to attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — and therefore it is called the abiding of non-abiding. Again, non-abiding is called the boundless realm of sentient beings. Even though the Tathāgata reaches the boundless realm of all sentient beings, he does not abide. Again, what is called non-abiding is this: the absence of support and ground is called having nothing whatsoever. Having nothing whatsoever is called non-arising. Non-arising is called the absence of death. The absence of death is called the absence of marks. The absence of marks is called the absence of bondage. The absence of bondage is called the absence of attachment. The absence of attachment is called freedom from defilement.

Freedom from defilement is virtue. Virtue is the unconditioned. The unconditioned is the great nirvāṇa — permanent nirvāṇa. Permanence is the self. The self is perfect purity. Perfect purity is called bliss. Permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity — these are the Tathāgata.

Son of good family, consider this example: space does not abide in the east, the south, the west, the north, the four intermediate directions, above, or below. Likewise the Tathāgata does not abide in the east, the south, the west, the north, the four intermediate directions, above, or below.

Son of good family, there is no basis whatsoever for the claim that one who acts with non-virtue of body, speech, and mind could obtain the fruit of virtue. Equally, there is no basis for the claim that one who acts with virtue of body, speech, and mind could obtain the fruit of non-virtue. There is no basis for the claim that an ignoble person sees the nature of a buddha while a bodhisattva on the tenth ground does not. There is no basis for the claim that those who

hold wrong craving, those who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, those who have slandered the vast and expansive sūtras, or those who have broken the four root precepts could attain unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening. There is no basis for the claim that a bodhisattva, a great being, on the sixth ground could fall into the three lower realms through the causes and conditions of affliction. There is no basis for the claim that a bodhisattva, a great being, could truly attain unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening in a woman's body. There is no basis for the claim that one who holds wrong craving could say of the Three Jewels, which are permanent, "They are impermanent," while the Tathāgata dwells in the city of Kuśinagara.

Son of good family, they say the Tathāgata has today entered the profound sanctuary of great meditative absorption here in this city of Kuśinagara and has passed into complete nirvāṇa because sentient beings cannot see him.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: For what reason did the Tathāgata enter the profound sanctuary of meditative absorption?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, it was in order to liberate all sentient beings; in order to cause roots of virtue not yet generated to be generated; in order to cause roots of virtue already generated to grow and expand; in order to ripen wholesome fruits not yet ripened; in order to lead what has ripened into unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening; in order to engender reverence for the ripening of wholesome Dharma; in order to free the heedless from heedlessness; in order to preach the Dharma alongside those like Mañjuśrī the youthful, who are like great elephants scented with perfume; in order to inspire those who delight in reading and reciting to be deeply devoted to meditative absorption; in order to tame sentient beings through noble conduct, pure conduct, and divine conduct; in order to contemplate the profound essence of the unmixed Dharma; in order to chastise heedless attendants — for if the Tathāgata were ever at rest and delighting in meditative absorption, would you not grow heedless in your afflictions? — in order to chastise unsuitable monks who carry the eight types of unexamined possessions, who have many desires, and who know no contentment; and in order to engender reverence in sentient beings who have heard the Dharma of meditative absorption and the like. For these reasons and conditions did he enter the profound sanctuary of meditative absorption.

Siṃhaghoṣa then said: Blessed One, the meditative absorption free of characteristics is called the great nirvāṇa. Should it therefore be called nirvāṇa that is free of characteristics, or is it designated as free of characteristics for some other reason?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, it is because it is free of ten kinds of characteristics. What are the ten? They are as follows: the characteristic of form, the characteristic of sound, the characteristic of taste, the characteristic of smell, the characteristic of touch, birth, abiding,

decay, the characteristic of what is born, and the characteristic of femininity — these ten. To be free of such characteristics is what is called "free of characteristics."

Son of good family, whoever is attached to characteristics will give rise to delusion. Through delusion, craving arises. Through craving, bondage arises. Through bondage, one takes on birth. Through birth, one comes to death. Through death, one is impermanent. Whoever is not attached to characteristics does not give rise to delusion. Through the absence of delusion, there is no craving. Through the absence of craving, there is no bondage. Through the absence of bondage, one does not take on birth. Through not taking on birth, there is no death. Through the absence of death, one is called permanent. For this reason, nirvāṇa is permanent.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, by what means do monks sever these ten kinds of characteristics?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, if a monk repeatedly cultivates three kinds of characteristics, he will sever the ten kinds of characteristics. These are as follows: repeatedly cultivating the characteristic of meditative absorption, repeatedly cultivating the characteristic of wisdom, and repeatedly — at appropriate times — cultivating the characteristic of equanimity. These are called the three characteristics.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, what exactly are the characteristics of meditative absorption, wisdom, and equanimity? If what is called "the characteristic of meditative absorption" is simply meditative absorption itself, then since all sentient beings already possess meditative absorption, what would be the point of being told to cultivate it? And if meditative absorption means the mind being focused on a single object, and if focusing on a different object were also called meditative absorption, then if one had not entered into many absorptions, would one not be omniscient? And if one were not

omniscient, why would it be called meditative absorption? On the other hand, if meditative absorption is attained by one mode of conduct, then another mode of conduct would not be meditative absorption. If it is not meditative absorption, then one is not omniscient. And if one is not omniscient, why call it meditative absorption? In just the same way, the two characteristics of wisdom and equanimity are equally problematic.

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, it is not as you say — that meditative absorption means the mind focusing on a single object, and that focusing on another object is therefore not meditative absorption. Why? Because another object of focus is also just a single object, and the same holds for formations. Likewise, it is also not the case that sentient beings possess meditative absorption from the very beginning and therefore have no need to cultivate it. Why? Because what is called meditative absorption refers to virtuous meditative absorption, and since it is not present in all sentient beings without qualification, how could one say there is no need to cultivate it?

Thus, resting in virtuous meditative absorption and then discerning all phenomena is called the characteristic of virtuous wisdom. Not perceiving the characteristics of meditative absorption and wisdom as distinct from one another is called the characteristic of equanimity.

Furthermore, son of good family, if one grasps form as a characteristic and does not discern it under the characteristics of permanence or impermanence, that is called meditative absorption. Discerning form under the characteristics of permanence and impermanence is called the characteristic of wisdom. Discerning all phenomena equally through meditative absorption and wisdom together is called the characteristic of equanimity.

Son of good family, just as a well-yoked chariot travels at a swift and proper pace — and traveling at that swift and proper pace is what is called the characteristic of equanimity —

So too is the bodhisattva: if meditative absorption predominates, let him cultivate wisdom; if wisdom predominates, let him cultivate meditative absorption. When meditative absorption and wisdom are equal in measure, that is called equanimity.

Son of good family, a bodhisattva on the tenth ground has the greater measure of the power of wisdom and a lesser measure of the power of meditative absorption; therefore the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not clearly seen. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have the greater measure of the power

of meditative absorption and a lesser measure of the power of wisdom; therefore the intrinsic nature of a buddha is not seen. The blessed buddhas, the Bhagavāns, have meditative absorption and wisdom in equal measure, and so they clearly behold the intrinsic nature of a buddha — just as an āmalaka fruit placed in the palm of the hand is plainly seen. Beholding the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called the characteristic of equanimity.

Calm abiding is also called restraint, because it restrains all afflictions entirely. Calm abiding is also called taming, because it tames the faculties from non-virtue. Calm abiding is also called pacification, because it pacifies the three doors of body, speech, and mind. Calm abiding is also called complete abandonment, because it completely abandons the five objects of desire for sentient beings. Calm abiding is also called purification, because it purifies attachment, aversion, and delusion. For these reasons it is called the characteristic of meditative absorption.

Insight is also called seeing correctly, and also called seeing directly, and also called being able to see, and also called seeing pervasively, and also called seeing progressively, and also called seeing characteristics as distinct — all of this is what is called wisdom. Equanimity is also called evenness, and also called non-contention, and also called non-conceptuality, and also called non-engagement — all of this is what is called equanimity.

Son of good family, calm abiding has two aspects: worldly and transcendent. Again, it has two aspects: accomplished and unaccomplished. Of these, the accomplished belongs to buddhas and bodhisattvas; the unaccomplished belongs to śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and so forth. Again, there are three degrees: inferior, middling, and superior. Of these, the inferior belongs to those of low capacity and low conduct; the middling belongs to śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; the superior belongs to buddhas and bodhisattvas. Again, there are four aspects: erroneous, stationary, progressively ascending, and capable of benefiting others. Again, there are five aspects: these are the meditative absorptions of the five wisdoms. What are the five? The meditative absorption without food, the meditative absorption without fault, the meditative absorption of one-pointed mind with body and mind completely purified, the meditative absorption in which both cause and result are blissful, and the meditative absorption of continuous mindfulness.

Again, there are six aspects: the meditative absorption contemplating a skeleton, the meditative absorption of loving-kindness, the meditative

absorption contemplating the twelve links of dependent origination, the meditative absorption of counting the breath, the meditative absorption of subsequent recollection of what the mind has contemplated, and the meditative absorption contemplating arising and cessation.

Again, there are seven aspects: these are the seven branches of awakening — the branch of awakening that is mindfulness, the branch of awakening that is investigation of phenomena (Skt. *dharmavicaya*), the branch of awakening that is diligence, the branch of awakening that is joy, the branch of awakening that is pliancy, the branch of awakening that is meditative absorption, and the branch of awakening that is equanimity.

Again, there are seven aspects: the meditative absorption of the stream-enterer, the meditative absorption of the once-returner, the meditative absorption of the non-returner, the meditative absorption of the arhat,

the meditative absorption of the pratyekabuddha, the meditative absorption of the bodhisattva, and the meditative absorption of all the omniscient Tathāgatas.

Again, there are eight aspects, namely the eight liberations. They are as follows: the meditative absorption of liberation through perceiving forms by means of form; the meditative absorption of liberation through perceiving external forms while being without the characteristic of internal form; the meditative absorption of liberation through realization with the body; the meditative absorption of liberation through the sense base of infinite space; the meditative absorption of liberation through the sense base of infinite consciousness; the meditative absorption of liberation through the sense base of nothingness; the meditative absorption of liberation through the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception; and the meditative absorption of liberation through the cessation of feeling and perception.

Again, there are nine aspects: the nine successive absorptions, namely the four meditative concentrations, the four formless states, and the meditative absorption of the cessation of feeling and perception.

Again, there are ten aspects: the ten totality absorptions. They are as follows: the meditative absorption in which everything is earth; the meditative absorption in which everything is water; the meditative absorption in which everything is fire; the meditative absorption in which everything is wind; the meditative absorption in which everything is blue; the meditative absorption in which everything is yellow; the meditative absorption in which everything is

red; the meditative absorption in which everything is white; the meditative absorption of infinite space; and the meditative absorption of infinite consciousness; and the meditative absorption of nothingness.

Furthermore, there are innumerable others, pertaining to the buddhas and bodhisattvas. Noble son, these are called the defining characteristics of meditative absorption.

Noble son, wisdom has two aspects: worldly and transcendent. Again, it has three aspects: wisdom, insight, and gnosis. What is called wisdom belongs to all sentient beings. What is called insight belongs to all noble ones. What is called gnosis belongs to the buddhas and bodhisattvas. Furthermore, wisdom has the defining characteristic of discrimination. Insight has the defining characteristic of the general. Gnosis has the defining characteristic of having overcome characteristics.

Again, there are four aspects: namely the four noble truths.

Noble son, for three reasons one cultivates calm abiding. What are the three? In order to eliminate heedlessness, in order to be established in great gnosis, and in order to attain mastery over the faculties.

Furthermore, for three reasons one cultivates insight. What are the three? In order to contemplate the ripening of non-virtuous karmic results in cyclic existence, in order to generate and increase the roots of virtue, and in order to overcome all afflictions.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, if, as it is taught in the sūtras, afflictions are overcome through insight, then what need is there to cultivate calm abiding?

The Blessed One declared: Noble son, your understanding of the statement that afflictions are overcome through insight is not what it actually means. Why? Because when wisdom is present there are no afflictions, and when afflictions are present there is no wisdom. If that is so, how can one say that insight overcomes afflictions? Noble son, take for example: when there is light there is no darkness, and when there is darkness there is no light. There is simply no situation in which one could say that light dispels darkness. Noble son, what then is wisdom and what are afflictions, such that one could say wisdom dispels afflictions? Since neither exists in that way, there is also nothing to overcome.

Noble son, to say that wisdom overcomes afflictions — does this mean that it overcomes them once it has gone somewhere,

or does it overcome them without having gone there? If it overcomes them without having gone there, then even foolish, common people of the lowest sort would qualify as having overcome them. If, on the other hand, it overcomes them after having gone there, then the preceding moment ought to be what overcomes them. If the preceding moment does not overcome them, then the subsequent moment does not overcome them either. If the moment just before arriving were to overcome them at the very instant of arriving, then that moment itself would still be one that has not yet arrived — so why say that wisdom overcomes them? And if one says they are overcome by both the arrived and the not-yet-arrived, that too is not how it is.

Furthermore, regarding the claim that insight overcomes afflictions — does insight overcome them alone, or does it overcome them with the aid of companions? If it can overcome them alone, why would a bodhisattva cultivate the noble eightfold path? If they are overcome with the aid of companions, then understand that they are not overcome by insight alone. And if insight alone cannot do it, then companions cannot do it either — just as when one blind person cannot see form, many blind people assisting one another still cannot see form; insight is the same as that.

Noble son, consider how earth's intrinsic nature is solidity, water's intrinsic nature is wetness, fire's intrinsic nature is heat, and wind's intrinsic nature is movement. In this way, from earth's intrinsic nature of solidity to wind's intrinsic nature of movement, none of these is produced by causes and conditions — by their intrinsic nature they are just so. Likewise the afflictions of the four great elements are the same: they are severed by their intrinsic nature. If they are severed in that way, why say that wisdom severs them?

For this reason, insight cannot definitively overcome afflictions. Noble son, take for example how the intrinsic nature of salt is saltiness and thereby makes other things different from itself salty as well, how the intrinsic nature of honey is sweetness and thereby makes other things different from itself sweet as well, and how the intrinsic nature of water is wetness and thereby makes other things different from itself wet as well. To say that wisdom, because it negates characteristics, causes phenomena to be negated — that is not how it is. Why? Because if phenomena have no negation in them, how can wisdom forcibly negate them? To say that wisdom negates other phenomena

the way salt by its saltiness makes things different from itself salty — that too is not how it is. Why? Because the intrinsic nature of wisdom is to cease moment by moment. If it ceases moment by moment, why say that it negates other, distinct phenomena? For this reason, afflictions are not overcome by the intrinsic nature of wisdom.

Noble son, there are two kinds of cessation for all phenomena: cessation by intrinsic nature, and cessation at the end. Since cessation is by intrinsic nature, why say that wisdom brings about cessation?

If one says that wisdom can burn up afflictions, just as fire burns up material things — that too is not how it is. Why? When fire burns up material things, even ash remains. If wisdom were like that, what remains ought to be like ash. And when an axe cuts wood, the trace of the cut still appears. If wisdom were like that, what would be visibly manifest?

If wisdom could abandon afflictions, then those afflictions — like non-Buddhists who are not found in the six great cities yet appear to be in the village of Kuśāgra — would fittingly appear elsewhere. Since those afflictions do not appear elsewhere in that way, understand that wisdom cannot abandon them.

Noble son, all phenomena are individually empty by their intrinsic nature. No one can generate them and no one can negate them. Arising is one thing and ceasing is another, and neither has been made by anyone.

Noble son, whoever cultivates meditative absorption attains such correct knowledge and correct vision. For that reason, I declared in a sūtra: "If a monk cultivates meditative absorption, he sees the characteristic of the arising and ceasing of the five aggregates."

Noble son, if one does not cultivate meditative absorption, one will not even know the things of the world — to say nothing of what transcends the world. If there is no meditative absorption, it is like falling into a chasm when walking on a smooth road. Even when the mind is focused on one thing, one speaks different words with the mouth and hears different things with the ears, and understands meanings that differ from what the mind intends. Even when one intends to write one letter, the hand writes a different one. Just as a foot steps elsewhere when one is walking in another direction — so it is without meditative absorption.

If one cultivates meditative absorption, everything from great benefit all the way to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening will be accomplished.

Noble son, a bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses two qualities is able to accomplish great benefit. What are the two? Meditative absorption and wisdom.

Noble son, it is like this: just as a stiff rope snaps when pulled hard, so too does a bodhisattva, a great being, who cultivates these two qualities meet the same fate — that is, the opposing forces give way. Noble son, just as a hard tree is easier to uproot if it is first shaken and only then pulled out, so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom: first meditative absorption shakes it loose, then wisdom pulls it out.

Just as when washing clothes one first scours them with ash and then rinses them with clean water so that they become clean — so too with the bodhisattva's wisdom and meditative absorption.

Noble son, just as one first reads and recites aloud, and then afterwards understands the meaning — so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom.

Noble son, it is like a brave warrior who first dons armour and takes up weapons, and then meets the enemy on the battlefield and defeats them — so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom.

Noble son, it is like a smith who pours gold into a mould and it melts just as desired — so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom.

Noble son, it is like looking at the reflection of one's own face in a bright, clear mirror — so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom.

Noble son, just as one first levels the ground and then sows the seed, and just as one first receives the scriptural transmission from a master and then reflects on the meaning — so too with the bodhisattva's meditative absorption and wisdom. For that reason, if a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivates these two qualities, great benefit will be obtained.

Noble son, if a bodhisattva, a great being, cultivates these two qualities, the five faculties become pliant and serviceable, and one becomes able to endure many forms of suffering: hunger, thirst, cold, heat, beating, burning, reviling, being eaten by fierce predators, being bitten by insects and stinging creatures, and all other such suffering. One always gathers the mind and maintains heedfulness. For the sake of gain and fame one does not engage in conduct contrary to the Dharma. One is not stained by sudden afflictions. One is not deceived by any distorted views. One always completely abandons all

thoughts of non-virtue. And, in order to accomplish benefit for sentient beings without long delay, one will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

This is the forty-first fascicle.

Son of good family, when a great bodhisattva cultivates those two qualities, the fierce winds of the four perverted views cannot stir him — just as the four winds, even blowing together, cannot move Mount Meru, the king of mountains. Just as the victory banner of Śakra (Indra, king of the gods) cannot be moved, so too he cannot be moved by the teachers of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). He cannot be deceived by the various fraudulent tricks of the mistaken. He constantly enjoys the highest and most sublime happiness. He understands the profound meanings that the Tathāgata intended and taught. He neither delights in pleasure nor grieves over suffering. All gods and humans pay him reverence, honor, and praise. He sees clearly what is saṃsāra and what is not saṃsāra. He is skilled in the dharmadhātu and in the defining characteristics of phenomena. And he comes to know that within the body there exist phenomena of permanence, happiness, self, and perfect purity. This is called the happiness of complete nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, the defining characteristic of meditative absorption (samādhi) is called the meditative absorption of emptiness. The defining characteristic of wisdom is called the meditative absorption of wishlessness. The defining characteristic of equanimity is called the meditative absorption of signlessness.

Son of good family, if a great bodhisattva is skilled in knowing the right time and the wrong time for meditative absorption, for wisdom, and for equanimity, this is called a great bodhisattva practicing the path of awakening.

Siṃha (Lion) then asked: Blessed One, how does a bodhisattva seek out what is the right time and what is the wrong time?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if a great bodhisattva has generated great arrogance on account of experiencing happiness, or has generated arrogance on account of teaching the Dharma, or on account of beginning to apply diligence, or on account of being skilled in knowing the meaning and in asking and answering questions, or on account of associating with evil companions, or on account of giving precious wealth, or on account of being honored by people of great lineage and noble standing in the world — then at that time he should know not to cultivate wisdom, but to cultivate

meditative absorption. This is called a bodhisattva knowing the right time and the wrong time.

If a bodhisattva, having undertaken diligent effort, has generated a mind of regret because he has not yet attained the nirvāṇa of benefit and happiness, or because his faculties are dull and he cannot tame the five faculties, or because the mass of defilements has grown thick and dense and he has come to doubt and to transgress in regard to moral discipline and the Vinaya — then at that time he should know not to cultivate meditative absorption, but to cultivate wisdom. This is called a bodhisattva knowing the right time and the wrong time.

If a bodhisattva finds that his portions of meditative absorption and wisdom are unequal, he should know that that is not the time to cultivate equanimity. If they are equal, then one should cultivate it. This is called a bodhisattva knowing the right time and the wrong time.

Son of good family, if a bodhisattva is cultivating meditative absorption and wisdom and afflictions arise at that time, he should not then cultivate equanimity. Instead he should know to read, recite, copy in writing, and teach to others the twelve branches of the scriptural collections, and to cultivate mindfulness of the Buddha, mindfulness of the Dharma, mindfulness of the Saṅgha, mindfulness of moral discipline, mindfulness of the gods, and mindfulness of generosity. This is called cultivating equanimity.

Son of good family, when a bodhisattva cultivates those three defining characteristics of phenomena, he thereby attains nirvāṇa — the great passing beyond sorrow that is without defining marks.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, because great nirvāṇa lacks ten defining marks, may it be called "nirvāṇa without defining marks"? And because of that, may it be said to be: unborn, unarisen, unconditioned, a support, an island, a protector, a refuge, supreme ease, cessation, nirvāṇa, peace, free from the suffering of illness, and free from existence?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, because it is without cause and condition, it is called unborn. Because it is unborn, it is called unarisen. Because nothing has been made or fabricated, it is also called unconditioned. Because it does not enter into the five views, it is called a support and a foundation. Because it is free from the four desires, it is called an island. Because it tames sentient beings, it is called a protector and a refuge. Because it has conquered the enemy of affliction, it is called ease. Because the fire of

affliction has been extinguished, it is called cessation. Because it is free from conceptual thought, it is called nirvāṇa. Because busyness and agitation have been abandoned, it is called peace. Because death has been utterly cut off, it is called free from illness. Because all is absent, it is called free from existence.

Son of good family, if a bodhisattva — a great bodhisattva — reflects in that way, he will come to see clearly the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great bodhisattva, possesses the qualities of the Dharma, will he then see everything from nirvāṇa without defining marks all the way to the absence of existence?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if a bodhisattva, a great bodhisattva, possesses ten qualities of the Dharma, he will see everything from nirvāṇa without defining marks all the way to the absence of existence. What are the ten?

The first is possessing a mind of faith. How does one possess a mind of faith? One believes that the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are permanent, and one believes that the buddhas of the ten directions too reveal this through skillful means, and one believes that all sentient beings — even those of wrong craving — possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Yet one does not believe that the Tathāgata is subject to birth, aging, illness, death, and ascetic hardship; that Devadatta truly caused a schism in the Saṅgha; that blood was drawn from the body of the Tathāgata; that the Tathāgata will ultimately pass beyond sorrow into final nirvāṇa; or that the sacred Dharma will entirely come to an end. This is called a bodhisattva possessing a mind of faith.

The second is possessing pure moral discipline. How does one possess pure moral discipline? Son of good family, if a bodhisattva claims that his own moral discipline is pure, yet when he sees a woman he speaks words of flattery or playful flirtation even without physical contact — that bodhisattva is one characterized by attachment, and he thereby impairs his pure moral discipline, disgraces his claim to celibate conduct, and blemishes his discipline. He is not to be called one possessing pure moral discipline.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva may claim that his moral discipline is pure and may refrain from touching a woman's body and from speaking words of flattery or play, yet while outside some retreat or shelter, if upon hearing the sounds of a woman's ornaments, garlands, and necklaces, and upon hearing various feminine voices, he gives rise to a mind of attachment — that bodhisattva too is one characterized by attachment.

He thereby impairs his pure moral discipline, disgraces his claim to celibate conduct, and blemishes his discipline. He is not to be called one possessing pure moral discipline.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva may claim that his moral discipline is pure and may refrain from touching a woman's body and from speaking words of flattery or play, and may not listen to sounds or voices — yet if upon seeing men following after women, or women following after men, he gives rise to attachment, that bodhisattva too is one characterized by attachment. He thereby impairs his pure moral discipline, disgraces his claim to celibate conduct, and blemishes his discipline. He is not to be called one possessing pure moral discipline.

Furthermore, a bodhisattva may claim that his moral discipline is pure, may not touch a woman, may not speak words of flattery or play, may not listen to sounds or voices, and may not look upon men and women keeping company with one another — yet if he is attached to and delights in the five objects of desire of the gods of the higher realms, that bodhisattva too is one characterized by attachment. He thereby impairs his pure moral discipline, disgraces his claim to celibate conduct, and blemishes his discipline. He is not to be called one possessing pure moral discipline.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva who holds pure moral discipline does so not for the sake of moral discipline itself, not for the sake of the perfection of moral discipline, not for the sake of sentient beings, not for the sake of benefit and happiness, not for the sake of being a bodhisattva, not for the sake of nirvāṇa, and not for the sake of śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. Rather, a bodhisattva who guards moral discipline solely for the sake of the unsurpassed and ultimate goal — he alone is to be called one possessing pure moral discipline.

He relies upon a spiritual friend. In this context, a spiritual friend is one who teaches faith, moral discipline, great learning, generosity, and wisdom, and by whom others will be led to practice — such a one is called a spiritual friend of a bodhisattva.

He delights in quietude. In this context, quietude means this: through the stilling of body and mind, to realize the profound dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena, of all dharmas — this is called quietude.

He is endowed with diligence. In this context, diligence means this: when, with one-pointed mind, one is contemplating the Four Noble Truths of the āryas, even if fire were blazing upon the crown of one's head, one does not abandon that contemplation — this is called diligence.

He is endowed with the close establishment of mindfulness. In this context, the close establishment of mindfulness means this: recollection following upon the Buddha, recollection following upon the Dharma, recollection following upon the Saṅgha, recollection following upon moral discipline, and recollection following upon generosity — these are called the close establishment of mindfulness.

He speaks gently. In this context, gentle speech means this: speaking words that are true, words that are excellent, words that are harmonious and pleasing, words that are timely, and words that are correct — this is called gentle speech.

He is endowed with the protection of the Dharma. In this context, protecting the Dharma means this: always delighting in and being devoted to teaching, reading, reciting, and writing down the sacred Dharma; taking its meaning to heart; and widely opening it up, teaching it, and causing others to assimilate it; and likewise, when one sees others copying it in writing, opening it up and explaining it, reading and reciting it, praising and extolling it, and taking its meaning to heart — then to provide them with the requisites of livelihood, namely, to offer robes, food, bedding, and medicines for illness and the like;

And not to begrudge one's body and life for the sake of protecting the Dharma — this is called protecting the Dharma.

When a bodhisattva, a great being, sees someone who shares the same training and the same moral discipline yet is in need and destitute, that bodhisattva takes from others an alms bowl, exchanges robes of a different color, acts as a nurse, and then gathering robes, food, bedding, and lodging and the like, gives them as gifts. Such a one is endowed with wisdom.

Now, what is called wisdom is this: to view the Tathāgata as permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and perfectly pure; to view all sentient beings as possessing the nature of a buddha; and to discern the twofold characteristic of phenomena — namely, to discern phenomena as: empty and not empty; permanent and impermanent; blissful and without bliss; self and selfless; perfectly pure and not perfectly pure; distinct phenomena that can be distinguished and distinct phenomena that cannot be distinguished; distinct

phenomena that arise from conditions and distinct phenomena that are perceived as arising from conditions; distinct phenomena that have issued as a result from conditions, and distinct phenomena that have not issued as a result from conditions — one who discerns in this way is called endowed with wisdom.

O son of good family, a bodhisattva who possesses these ten qualities is called one who clearly sees the signless nirvāṇa.

Siṃhaghoṣa then asked: Blessed One, what is the meaning of what the Blessed One previously declared to Cunda: "You have seen the nature of a buddha; you will attain the great parinirvāṇa and will awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening"?

The Blessed One replied: It is taught in the sūtras that if one gives to an animal, one will obtain a hundredfold karmic maturation. If one gives to one who holds wrong views, one will obtain a thousandfold karmic maturation. If one gives to one who guards moral discipline, one will obtain karmic maturation on the order of a hundred thousand. If one gives to a non-Buddhist adherent (tīrthika) who has cut off afflictions beyond measure, one will obtain karmic maturation beyond measure. If one gives to those who have reached the four directions — that is, who have attained the four fruits — and to pratyekabuddhas, one will obtain karmic maturation beyond measure. The merit and the karmic maturation obtained from giving to non-regressing bodhisattvas, to great bodhisattvas who are obstructed by but one more life, and to the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, is immeasurable, unbounded, inexpressible, and inconceivable.

Now, noble Cunda, if one were to experience such ripening of merit, one should not stop short of that ripening — for at some point in time one will attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Furthermore, Blessed One, it is taught in the sūtras that if someone performs virtuous and non-virtuous actions with a pure intention, the result will without fail ripen as a fruit — whether in the present life, or in future lives, or in this very life itself. Likewise, Cunda performed virtue from a pure intention, and that action will without fail ripen and be experienced as a fruit.

But if the fruit must certainly be experienced, how will unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening be attained? And how will one come to see the nature of a buddha?

The Blessed One replied: It is taught in the sūtras that if one gives to these three kinds of beings — the sick, one's parents, and the buddhas, the Blessed Ones — one experiences fruit that is inexhaustible.

And again, from the sūtras, the Blessed One declared to Ānanda: if all sentient beings were without karma in the desire realm, the form realm, and the formless realm, they would attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Again, the Blessed One spoke the following verse from the Sūtra of the Words of the Dharma:

Though one flee to the expanse of sky,
to the ocean, to mountains, or to cliffs,
to whatever region, wherever one may go,
one cannot escape from karma that has been done.

Then Ma-'aggapa asked further: Blessed One, I personally recall that through the gift of a single meal offered in a former life, I did not fall into any of the three lower destinies for eighty thousand eons. Blessed One, if even the gift of a single meal brings a karmic fruit of such ripening, what need is there to say that Cunda, having given with a mind of faith to a buddha, will come to possess the perfection of generosity? Blessed One, if one did not wish for the ripened fruit of virtuous karma to be exhausted, how would one exhaust the fault of disparaging the extensive sūtras, the transgression of the five acts of immediate consequence, the loss of the four root precepts, and the fault of perverse craving? And if it cannot be exhausted, one will behold the nature of a buddha and attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, by means of two things a person attains immeasurable and boundless qualities, beyond reckoning and beyond expression. He dries up the swamp of saṃsāra, tames māra and those who oppose the teaching, lays low the victory banner of māra, and turns the Tathāgata's unsurpassed wheel of Dharma. What are these two? Skill in asking questions and skill in giving answers.

Son of good family, among the ten powers of a buddha, the power of karma is supreme. Son of good family, the reason these words were spoken was to discipline those sentient beings who minimize the causes of karma and lack trust in it. Son of good family, among all karma that has been done, some is light and some is heavy. And within these two, light and heavy, each again has two kinds: determinate and indeterminate.

Son of good family, some say that non-virtuous karma has no fruit. But if the fruit of non-virtuous karma were certainly fixed, why did the one called "the Breath-stealer of Evil Lineage" take birth as a god in the higher realms and attain the fruit of liberation through an ornament on his finger? For this reason there are those who say: among karma that has been performed, there is karma that will certainly yield fruit and karma that will certainly not yield fruit. In order to cut off wrong views, the sūtras declare: there is no karma that has been performed which will fail to yield fruit.

Son of good family, karma that is heavy can also become light, and karma that is light can also become heavy. Yet this does not apply to all beings universally; it is to be distinguished between those who are foolish and those who are wise. Therefore not all karma will certainly yield its fruit; and although it is not certain, it is also not the case that fruit will not be obtained.

Son of good family, all sentient beings are of two kinds: those with wisdom and those possessed of delusion. One with wisdom, through the power of wisdom, can experience even the very heavy karma of a hell-being as something slight in this very life, and thereby be liberated. One possessed of delusion, through light karma in this very life, will experience heavy karma of a hell-being.

Siṃha asked: Blessed One, if that is so, then pure brahmacarya (the holy life of celibacy) and the fruit of liberation would also be undesirable.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if all karma were to yield its fruit with certainty, then it might be said that the holy life and liberation are unnecessary. But because it is indeterminate, one must cultivate the fruit through the holy life and through liberation. Son of good family, if one abandons all non-virtuous karma, one obtains the fruit of virtue. If one abandons virtuous karma, one obtains the fruit of non-virtue.

If all karma were to yield its fruit with certainty, there would be no need to cultivate the noble path. And if the noble path is not cultivated, liberation will not be attained. Therefore, noble ones cultivate the path in order to destroy determined karma and to interrupt its ripening, and in order to prevent the fruit of indeterminate karma from ripening at all. If all karma were to yield its fruit with certainty, the noble path would become unnecessary; and beyond abandoning the cultivation of the noble path, there would be no other way to attain liberation. Nor would it make sense to say that one could attain nirvāṇa without having attained liberation.

Son of good family, if all karma were to yield its fruit with certainty, then one who had performed only virtuous karma in a single lifetime would experience happiness forever, and one who had performed grave non-virtuous karma in a single lifetime would experience immense suffering forever. If the fruits of karma worked in that way, there would be no path to cultivate, no liberation, and no nirvāṇa. It would likewise follow that a person would always remain a person, and a brahmin would always remain a brahmin. And if that were so, there would be no high or low births, a person would always be reborn as a person, and a brahmin would always be reborn as a brahmin. Karma performed in youth would be experienced in youth — at the appropriate time — and it would make no sense for it to be experienced in old age. Non-virtuous acts performed in old age, which lead to falling into hell, could not reasonably be experienced through the body born immediately into hell; rather, it would follow that they should only be experienced from old age onward. Furthermore, if those who refrained from killing in old age did not experience that karma in their prime, how could they grow old at all? This is because karma does not become nonexistent. And if karma does not become nonexistent, then it follows that the cultivation of the path and nirvāṇa would not exist.

Son of good family, karma is of two kinds: determinate and indeterminate. Determinate karma is itself of two kinds: that which is certain as to its ripening, and that which is certain as to its time. Among these, some karma is certain as to its ripening but uncertain as to its time, and is experienced when the proper conditions are met. Some karma is experienced in any of the three times: experienced now in this present life, experienced in the future, or experienced later still.

Son of good family, when one performs virtuous or non-virtuous karma with a resolute mind, and having done so generates a mind of deep faith, rejoices, and vows, "May I always make offerings to the Three Jewels" — such karma is determinate.

Son of good family, the virtuous roots of a person of wisdom are deep and firm and difficult to disturb, and so even grave karma can be made lighter. For a person of delusion, non-virtue is deep and dense and solid, and so even light karma can ripen into a heavy result. For these reasons, one should not say that all karma is determinate.

Although a great bodhisattva has no karma that would lead to the hells, he makes aspirational prayers to be born in hell for the sake of sentient beings. Son of good family, in former times, when the lifespan of beings was a hundred years, I saw beings — as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges River — experiencing suffering in the hells. Upon seeing them, I aroused a great resolve and took birth in the form of a hell-being. Although the bodhisattva at that time truly had no such karma, for the sake of sentient beings he took on the ripening of hell. I then remained in hell for countless years, widely opening and teaching the twelve branches of scripture to sinful beings.

Having heard the teaching, those beings broke the karmic maturation of their non-virtue and emptied even the hells of sentient beings — all except those possessed of inverted craving. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Furthermore, son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon, I saw countless sentient beings — beyond all measure — who had been born in the animal realm and were experiencing the fruits of non-virtuous karma. Seeing them, I again aroused a great resolve in order to teach the Dharma to those beings and liberate them. And so, at various times, I took on the bodies of a deer, a stag, a bear, a vulture, a monkey, a nāga, a snake, a garuḍa, a fish, a frog, a fox, a rabbit, an ox, a horse, and other such forms. Son of good family, although the great bodhisattva truly had no such wicked animal karma, through the power of great resolve he took on those bodies for the sake of sentient beings. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Furthermore, son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon, countless and boundless sentient beings were born as hungry ghosts (pretas). Their food was vomit, grease, flesh, pus, blood, excrement, urine, saliva, and mucus; and for a lifespan lasting hundreds of thousands of immeasurable tens of thousands of years, they had never even heard the word for water, let alone seen it with their eyes or drunk it. If they perceived water from afar and tried to draw near, the moment they arrived it would turn to fire, or to pus and blood. And even if it did not transform, many men with swords and spears would stand guard and not allow them to approach. If rain fell upon their bodies it would turn to fire. Such is the karmic maturation of the fruit of non-virtue. Yet the great

bodhisattva, although he truly had no such fruit of non-virtuous karma, aroused a great resolve and took on such bodies in order to bring sentient beings to liberation and to the attainment of liberation. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon, I was born into the household of a butcher, killing birds, pigs, oxen, and sheep, scattering the implements of a hunter, wielding fishing nets and the like — born into the house of a debased family — and I acted as a thief and a brigand. Yet the bodhisattva truly had no such karma. Rather, through the power of great aspirational prayer, he took on such a body in order to liberate sentient beings and bring them to the attainment of liberation. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon, I was also born in the remote borderlands, performing many acts of attachment, aversion, and delusion, engaging in conduct contrary to the Dharma, having no faith in the Three Jewels or in the karmic maturation of the fruits of future lives, and showing no respect to parents, relatives, elders, or teachers. Son of good family, although the bodhisattva at that time truly had no such karma, through the power of great aspirational prayer he took birth in such a place in order to liberate sentient beings. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon, I also took on a female body, a degraded body, a body dominated by attachment, a body dominated by aversion, a body dominated by delusion, and

a body dominated by envy, a body dominated by fear, an illusory body, a deceitful body, a body that was loose and dissolute, and a body that was bound and constrained. Son of good family, although the bodhisattva at that time truly had no such karma, through the power of great aspirational prayer he took birth in such a place in order to liberate sentient beings. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon I also experienced a body as a hermaphrodite, a body without sex, a body of uncertain between two sexes,

and a body uncertain even as to a single sex. Son of good family, although the great bodhisattva truly had no such non-virtuous karma of the body, through the power of great aspirational prayer he took birth in such a place in order to liberate sentient beings. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma of the body in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, in this Fortunate Aeon I also placed my trust in the doctrine of the naked tīrthikas, coming to hold a view in which there is no giving, no sacrifice, no fruit of giving and sacrifice, no virtuous and non-virtuous karma, no karmic maturation ripening from virtuous and non-virtuous karma, no present time and no future time, no this shore and no further shore, no noble ones, no emanation body, no path, and no nirvāṇa. Son of good family, although the bodhisattva truly had no such non-virtuous karma, through the power of great aspirational prayer he entered into that doctrine of wrong view in order to liberate sentient beings. This is what is meant by saying that the great bodhisattva does not experience non-virtuous karma in the present, the future, or thereafter.

Son of good family, I recall that in the past, when Devadatta and I were both merchants, each of us had a following of five hundred traders. Desiring to acquire wealth, they set out to sea to obtain precious jewels, and by the force of non-virtuous karma they were suddenly struck by a fierce storm. The ship was wrecked, and all our companions perished. At that time, Devadatta and I, through the fruit of our having refrained from taking life, were long-lived, and the wind carried us to dry land. Then Devadatta, stricken with longing and attachment to the wealth and jewels, was tormented by the great pain of grief and broke into loud weeping. At that point I said to him, "Do not weep." Devadatta replied to me with these words: "Listen well and consider. For example, suppose a poor and destitute man goes to a charnel ground and, grasping a corpse by the hand, says: 'Give me the ease of death; I will give you this life of poverty and destitution.' The corpse then rises, sits up, and says to the poor man: 'Son of good family, I have no wish for the life of poverty and destitution. I am supremely at ease right now, so I have no desire for a life of poverty and destitution in exchange for the ease of death.' I am in just that same situation — I have no ease of death to offer, and I am poor besides, so how could I not weep?" I too then roused my spirits and said: "Do not grieve. I have two jewels of immeasurable value; I will give you one." And so I gave him one, saying furthermore: "Whoever has the means and power may well obtain

this jewel, but if one lacks that power, one will not obtain it." At that time I was exhausted, and I sat down to rest at the foot of a tree and fell asleep.

Devadatta, his mind overcome with craving for the other jewel, harbored ill will toward me. He gouged out my eyes, stole the jewel, and fled. At that moment, crying out in pain from my eyes, I wept and lamented. A young woman came up to me and asked: "Young man, why are you weeping like this?" I told her the whole story in detail. After hearing what I said, she asked me: "What is your name?" I replied: "My name is Truthspeaker." The young woman said: "Whether your name is truly Truthspeaker or not, how can that be known?" Then I made this oath: "If I harbor any ill will toward Devadatta, may my eyes remain forever blind just as they are now. If I do not, may my eyes be restored." The moment I said this, my eyes became just as they had been before.

Noble son, this is a teaching on the immediate karmic ripening of a bodhisattva, a great being, in the present time.

Noble son, I remember with direct recollection that in a time long past, I was born in the home of a brahmin in a city called Putana, in the southern land of Vetāla. At that time there was a king named Kalāpu — wrathful and fierce, seized by pride, in the full vigor of youth and handsome in appearance, attached to and infatuated with the five objects of desire. At that time I was dwelling outside that city, practicing yoga for the sake of liberating sentient beings. Then the king, during the summer season when the flowers were in bloom, went outside the city together with his retinue of consorts and princes, purifying himself with incense at the foot of a tree, sporting with the five pleasures. The royal daughters and princes left the king and went off to play, and they came to where I was. I was there teaching the Dharma to cut off their attachment to desire. The king came following after them, and seeing me, ill will arose in him, and he questioned me as follows: "Have you attained the fruit of arhatship?" I replied: "I have not." He asked again: "Have you attained the fruit of non-returning?" I replied: "I have not." He asked again: "If you have not attained those two fruits, and you possess desire and afflictions, why do you, in your negligence, gaze upon my consorts?" I said: "Great King, understand it thus: although I have not yet cut off the arising of afflictions from desire outwardly, inwardly my mind is genuinely free of attachment." The king said: "Fool! Even the forest sages who breathe air and eat only wild fruits — when they see many beautiful forms, desire arises in them. You are in the prime of youth, and desire has not been cut off in you — how much more

would you not become attached upon seeing many beautiful forms?" I replied: "Great King, being free of attachment upon seeing forms does not depend on breathing air and eating fruit. It comes about through the power of one-pointed meditation focused on impermanence and impurity." The king said: "If one disparages and reviles others, can that be called purity of moral discipline?" I said: "Great King, one who speaks with a mind of envy reviles another. If I have no envy in my mind, why would I revile?" The king said: "Venerable one, what is moral discipline?" I replied: "Great King, patience is what is called moral discipline." The king said: "If patience is moral discipline, then if I cut off your ears and you endure it, I will know you to be one who guards moral discipline." Having said this, he cut off my ears. At that moment my complexion did not change. The king's ministers, seeing what had occurred, said to the king: "Your Majesty, it is not right to harm this noble person." The king said to his ministers: "How do you know this is a noble person?" The ministers replied: "We know it because, in experiencing suffering, his complexion did not change."

The king said again: "Whether the complexion changes or not must be put to the test." Having said that, he cut off the nose and all the hands and feet.

At that time the bodhisattva, having cultivated loving-kindness and compassion for countless and immeasurable lifetimes, and having generated a mind of tender affection for sentient beings in suffering, the four guardian kings, enraged at what had occurred, sent down a rain of stones and gravel from the sky. Seeing this, the king was seized with fear. He knelt upon the ground and, wishing to repent out of heartfelt concern, offered this entreaty.

I replied: "Great King, in my mind there is no anger, and there is no attachment either."

The king said: "How can you know that there is no anger in your mind?"

Then I uttered this aspiration: "If I am truly without anger, may this body of mine become as it was before." And at that very instant the body became as it was before.

This illustrates the immediate, visible fruition of karma within this very life for a great bodhisattva, a great being.

O son of good family, just as the result of virtuous karma ripens in the future, in a later time, so too should one understand non-virtuous karma in the same way. When a great bodhisattva, a great being, attains unsurpassed perfect

and complete awakening, the results of all karma ripen and become directly manifest. As for the direct and visible ripening of evil non-virtuous karma: it is like a king who, on account of non-virtuous deeds, has stones and gravel fall from the sky, or like one who points out a she-bear to a hunter, or like one who points out a deer with the coloring of jewels to a hunter, and whose hand then falls off — this is what is called the directly manifest ripening of the result of non-virtuous karma.

Ripening in the future refers to one who holds wrong views and who has incurred the four defeats and committed the five actions of immediate retribution. Later ripening refers to how those of moral discipline aspire: "In the future, may I obtain a body endowed with such complete purity of moral discipline. If beings are able to live for one hundred and eighty years, may I then become a wheel-turning king and accomplish the welfare of sentient beings."

O son of good family, if all karma were to ripen with certainty right now, in direct and immediate manifestation, then there would be no future ripening and no subsequent ripening. The karma cultivated by a great bodhisattva, a great being, for the thirty-two marks of a great person does not ripen directly and immediately in the present. Karma that does not ripen in these three modes of ripening is called indeterminate.

O son of good family, if someone were to say that all karma certainly and without exception ripens, then there would be no holy life, no liberation, and no nirvāṇa. Know that such a person is not an intimate follower of mine, but belongs to the retinue of Māra.

As for this matter, there is karma that is determinate and karma that is indeterminate. The determinate is that which ripens in the present, ripens in the future, or ripens subsequently thereafter. The indeterminate is that which, upon meeting with a condition, is experienced, and which, upon not meeting with a condition, is not experienced. One who teaches this understanding is one for whom holy life, liberation, and nirvāṇa exist — therefore such a one is truly an intimate follower of mine and does not belong to the retinue of Māra.

O son of good family, for all sentient beings the paths of indeterminacy are many, while the paths of certainty are few. It is for this reason that there is value in applying oneself to the path. Because one applies oneself to the path, even weighty karma can be lightened.

The path of indeterminacy is not something experienced in a future time.

O son of good family, persons are of two kinds. What are they? There is the kind who causes what is indeterminate to ripen as determinate; who causes a ripening that is presently occurring to ripen instead in the future; who causes a light ripening to become heavy; and who causes what was fitting to be experienced in a human birth to be experienced instead in hell. And there is the kind who causes what is fully determinate to become indeterminate; who reverses what was fitting to ripen in the future and causes it to ripen in the present instead; who causes a heavy ripening to become light; and who causes what was fitting to be experienced in hell to be experienced in a human birth. Of these two kinds of person, one is possessed of delusion and one is possessed of wisdom. The one possessed of wisdom makes karma light; the one possessed of delusion makes it heavy.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people who have transgressed the law of a king. The one of high position and great connections, even if the offense committed is grave, will have it reduced. The one of low position and few connections, even if the offense is minor, will have it made greater. The one possessed of delusion and the one possessed of wisdom are just like this: for the one possessed of wisdom, because wholesome karma is abundant, even heavy karma becomes light; for the one possessed of delusion, because wholesome karma is scarce, even light karma becomes heavy.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people: one is highly skilled at swimming, and one is a poor swimmer with little skill. If both fall into a bog, the skilled one will emerge, while the unskilled one will sink.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people who have drunk poison. One possesses the power of mantras and the antidote of medicine; the other possesses neither. The one who has mantras and medicine is not overcome by the poison. The one who has neither mantras nor medicine dies the moment it is drunk.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people who have drunk a great deal of alcohol. One has a strong digestive fire, and one has a weak digestive fire. The one with strong digestive fire is able to digest it. The one with weak digestive fire falls ill.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people imprisoned by a king. One is possessed of wisdom and skillful means, and one is dull-witted and bad. The one possessed of wisdom and skillful means is freed

immediately. The dull-witted and bad one has no time of liberation.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people traveling a dangerous road. One has eyes, and one is blind. The one with eyes passes through safely, while the blind one falls into an abyss.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people who have drunk alcohol. One has eaten a large meal beforehand, and one has eaten little. The one who ate little, even having drunk, comes to no harm. The one who ate a large meal falls ill after drinking.

O son of good family, consider as an example two people who have gone into battle. One is equipped with armor and weapons, and the other has nothing at all. The one equipped with armor and weapons will subdue the enemy, while the one with nothing cannot even save himself.

And again, consider two people whose clothes are soiled by something unclean. One washes immediately upon noticing it, and the other notices but does not wash. The garment of the one who washed is clean. For the one who did not wash, the defilement grows ever greater with time.

And again, consider two people who both ride a horse-drawn carriage. One has a srogśing and the other does not. The one with the srogśing travels at will, while the one without it cannot move from where it stands.

And again, consider two people who have gone into a vast wilderness. One has provisions and companions, and the other has none. The one with provisions and companions crosses through the wilderness, while the one who went empty-handed cannot cross. And again, consider two people who have been overcome by famine —

One has a treasure of jewels, and the other does not. The one who has the jewel-treasure, even when ruined, feels no sorrow, whereas the one without the treasure is consumed by grief. It is just the same with the one who is deluded and the one who is wise: the one who possesses the treasure of virtue experiences even heavy karma as something light, while the one who lacks that treasure experiences even light karma as heavy.

The bodhisattva Siṃhaghosa then asked: "Blessed One, you have declared that not all karma will necessarily yield its fruit, and that not all sentient beings will necessarily experience the result. Why, then, did the Blessed One say that sentient beings whose present ripening is light will experience the heavy ripening of the hells, while those whose ripening of the hells is heavy will

experience it as light in this very life?"

The Blessed One replied: All sentient beings are of two kinds — the wise, who have wisdom, and the foolish, who are deluded. Those who cultivate body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom are the wise. Those who do not cultivate body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom are called the deluded.

How is it that one does not cultivate the body? Not gathering in the five sense faculties is not cultivating the body. Not upholding the seven aspects of pure moral discipline is not cultivating moral discipline. Not taming the mind is not cultivating the mind. Not engaging in the practice of the noble ones is not cultivating wisdom.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means lacking the essential nature of pure moral discipline. Not cultivating moral discipline means carrying eight kinds of substance that have not been examined. Not cultivating the mind means being unable to cultivate the three kinds of defining marks. Not cultivating wisdom means not practicing the holy life.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means: not reflecting on the body, not reflecting on form, not reflecting on the defining marks of form, not reflecting on the defining marks of the body, not knowing what arises from the body, not knowing how the body passes on from here to elsewhere, and grasping at what is not the body as bearing the marks of body, and grasping at what is not form as bearing the marks of form, while clinging to self, to body, and to what arises from the body — this is called not cultivating the body.

Not cultivating moral discipline means: taking up inferior moral discipline is not to be called cultivating moral discipline. Holding to peripheral ethical codes, to moral discipline that benefits only oneself, and to moral discipline merely for self-restraint — without benefiting all sentient beings, and not for the sake of guarding the supreme sacred Dharma — but rather in order to be born as a god in the higher realms and to enjoy the pleasures of the five desirable objects: this is not to be called cultivating moral discipline.

Not cultivating the mind means: when the mind is disturbed and distracted, being unable to protect one's own domain with single-pointed attention. What is meant by "one's own domain" is this: the four applications of mindfulness (*smṛti*). What is not one's own domain is this: the five objects of desire. Whoever is unable to cultivate the four applications of mindfulness is not to be called one who cultivates the mind. Whoever does not guard the mind against non-virtuous actions is not to be called one who cultivates wisdom.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means being unable to clearly recognize that this body is impermanent, unstable, unreliable, disintegrating and ceasing moment by moment, and that it is the domain of Māra. Not cultivating moral discipline means lacking the perfection of moral discipline. Not cultivating the mind means lacking the perfection of meditative concentration.

Not cultivating wisdom means lacking the Perfection of Wisdom.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means being attached to one's body, to what belongs to oneself, and to the idea that one's body is permanent and unchanging. Not cultivating moral discipline means committing the ten non-virtuous actions for the sake of one's body. Not cultivating the mind means being unable to withdraw the mind from non-virtuous actions. Not cultivating wisdom means that, because the mind is not withdrawn, one is unable to discern wholesome from unwholesome phenomena.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means failing to cut through the view of self. Not cultivating moral discipline means failing to cut through conceit about one's moral discipline. Not cultivating the mind means acting out of attachment and aversion and thereby going to a hell realm.

Furthermore, not cultivating the body means being unable to examine sense objects clearly, and so treating everything as an enemy without cause.

Noble son, consider this analogy: if an enemy constantly follows a person and seeks an opportunity to strike, a wise person, perceiving this, always remains single-pointedly vigilant. If one is not vigilant, one will be harmed by that enemy. In just the same way, all sentient beings must constantly tend their bodies with drink, food, warmth, and cold in proper measure. If they do not so tend them and remain vigilant, the body will deteriorate and fall apart.

Noble son, consider further: a brahmin devoted to the fire god (Agni) may continually offer incense and flowers, sing praises, prostrate, and make offerings and acts of service for a hundred years, and yet the moment he touches the fire, his hand will be burned. However much he has worshipped that fire, it cannot repay even an instant's worth of gratitude for such veneration. All sentient beings are just like that. Though for many years one has nourished the body with incense, flowers, garlands, clothing, food, bedding, and medicines for illness, if it encounters causes of non-virtue from within or without, it will crumble and perish, without giving the slightest thought to the kindness of all the clothing and food with which it was

sustained.

Noble son, consider this analogy: a king keeps four venomous serpents, places them in a single container, and assigns one person to tend them. If any one of those four venomous serpents becomes enraged, it will kill the person. Out of fear, that person constantly seeks food for them and feeds them at the proper times. The four great elements in the bodies of all sentient beings are just like this: if any one of the four great elements turns against the body, the body will be destroyed.

Noble son, consider this analogy: when a person falls ill, they earnestly seek medicine and a physician, and carry out the proper procedures for treating the illness. If the illness is not properly cured, death is certain. The bodies of all sentient beings are just the same: one must never be heedless in withdrawing and steadying the mind. If one is heedless, the body will disintegrate and perish.

Noble son, consider this analogy: an unfired clay vessel cannot withstand wind, rain, blows, being dropped, or being pressed upon. The bodies of all sentient beings are just the same: they cannot endure hunger, thirst, cold, heat, wind, rain, blows, binding, or abuse.

Noble son, consider this analogy: when an abscess swells, one must always be careful and not allow it to be touched. If it is touched even once, it causes tremendous pain and suffering. The bodies of all sentient beings are just the same.

Noble son, consider this analogy: when a she-monkey is pregnant, she becomes entirely preoccupied with her own body. Just so, when the bodies of all sentient beings are afflicted by disorders of wind and phlegm internally, they experience suffering.

Noble son, consider this analogy: when a fruit forms on a water-tree, it immediately begins to shrivel and dry. The bodies of all sentient beings are just the same.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as a water-tree has no heartwood, the bodies of all sentient beings are just the same.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as a snake and a mongoose always harbor harmful intentions toward one another, the four great elements of a sentient being's body are just the same.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as the king of geese takes no delight in a charnel ground, a bodhisattva is just the same — holding no attachment or fondness for the charnel ground of the body.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as one of base lineage who performs the deeds of a base lineage for seven generations in succession comes to be despised by all, the seed of the body is just the same — its seed arising from semen and blood, it is ultimately impure. Being thus impure, it is thoroughly censured by buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Noble son, this body is utterly unlike Mount Mālaya, for on it sandalwood, utpala flowers, pundarīka, campaka, mālikā, and pāriśāka do not grow. Through its nine openings it perpetually leaks blood, pus, and filth. It arose in a place rank with stench, it is repellent and fit to inspire dejection, and it dwells always in the company of worms.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as a corpse placed within the enclosure of a fine, pure pleasure garden does not render that garden pure, and all people abandon it and no thought of attachment arises, so too the element of form is just the same — though pure and excellent in itself, because a body is present, buddhas and bodhisattvas utterly renounce it.

Noble son, one who cannot contemplate the body in this way should not be called one who cultivates meditation on the body.

As for not cultivating meditation on moral discipline: Noble son, whoever recognizes that moral discipline is the threshold of the stairway to all wholesome phenomena, and the very root of all wholesome phenomena — just as the great earth is the place from which all trees and forests grow — and that it goes first among all wholesome roots, just as a merchant goes first among all traders, should understand that moral discipline is the victory banner of all wholesome phenomena, like the raising of Śakra's victory banner. Moral discipline severs, once and for all, every unwholesome action and the actions leading to the three lower destinies. It heals the disease of non-virtue, like a medicinal tree. Moral discipline is like a provision of supplies for one traversing the rough road of saṃsāra. Moral discipline is the weapon and armor for vanquishing the enemy of affliction. Moral discipline is the mantra (vidyā) that renders the venomous serpent of affliction harmless. Moral discipline is like a bridge that liberates from the practice of unwholesome actions. One who cannot contemplate this should not be called one who cultivates meditation on moral discipline.

As for not cultivating meditation on the mind: the mind is distracted, agitated, changeable, difficult to grasp, and difficult to tame — wandering in all directions like an unruly dzo-bull. Moment to moment it is swift, like a flash of lightning. The mind is turbulent and will not stay still, like a monkey. The mind is like an illusion or a mirage, and is the root of all non-virtue. The five objects of desire are insatiable, like fire meeting wood. The mind is like an ocean, able to receive all rivers. The mind is like Mount Mālaya — a place where many grasses and trees grow — yet it cannot be contemplated and brings harm through attachment to the deceptions of false saṃsāra, just as fish are caught by a hook. That karma perpetually follows after whatever comes first is like the way that when a mother fish goes ahead, the young follow after her. Being attached to the five objects of desire and feeling no aspiration for nirvāṇa is like the way that when a bee has eaten honey it does not look toward the grass until it reaches the point of death. Attached to present pleasure and giving no thought to future harm —

Just as a calf is so attached to its mother cow that even when beaten with a stick it feels no fear, so does one circle and rush through the twenty-five modes of existence. That one is never satisfied in seeking what ought not be sought is like the way that foolish and stupid people seek fire that does not burn. That one always delights in saṃsāra and takes no delight in liberation is like the way the insect called the tree-clinging grub is attached to the crumbling of wood. That one craves and is attached to the foul-smelling stench of the deceptive wheel of existence is like the way prisoners delight in the warden's daughter, or like the way a pig is attached to filth. One who is unable to reflect in this way is said to be one who does not cultivate the mind.

As for not cultivating wisdom: to be unable to reflect that wisdom, with its great power and strength like that of Garuḍa flying through the sky, destroys all evil karma; that like sunlight it dispels the darkness of ignorance; that it tears out from the root the very roots of the tree of the aggregates, like the power of a violent river sweeping everything away; that it burns up wrong views like the power of a blazing fire; and that wisdom is the root of all virtuous phenomena and the mother and seed of all buddhas and bodhisattvas — such a one is not to be called one who cultivates wisdom.

Noble son, if in regard to the ultimate one views the body, the defining characteristics of the body, the cause of the body, the result of the body, the aggregates of the body, the first body, the second body, this body, the body of the other shore, the cessation of the body, the evenness of the body, and the

cultivation of body by means of body — that is not to be called the cultivation of the body.

Noble son, whoever views moral discipline, the defining characteristics of moral discipline, the cause of moral discipline, the result of moral discipline, superior moral discipline, middling moral discipline, inferior moral discipline, the accumulation of moral discipline, the first moral discipline, the second moral discipline, this moral discipline, the moral discipline of the other shore, the cessation of moral discipline, the evenness of moral discipline, the cultivation of moral discipline by means of moral discipline, and the perfection of moral discipline — that is not to be called the cultivation of moral discipline.

Whoever views mind, the defining characteristics of mind, the cause of mind, the result of mind, the accumulation of mind, mind, what arises from mind, the first mind, the second mind, this mind, the mind of the other shore, the cessation of mind, the evenness of mind, the cultivation of mind by means of mind, superior mind, middling mind, inferior mind, the non-virtuous mind, and what is to be regarded as a non-virtuous mind — that is not to be called the cultivation of mind.

Noble son, whoever views wisdom, the defining characteristics of wisdom, the cause of wisdom, the result of wisdom, the accumulation of wisdom, the first wisdom, the second wisdom, this wisdom, the wisdom of the other shore, the cessation of wisdom, the evenness of wisdom, superior wisdom, middling wisdom, inferior wisdom, dull wisdom, sharp wisdom, and the cultivation of wisdom by means of wisdom — that is not to be called the cultivation of wisdom.

Noble son, one who does not cultivate body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom will, even through a small non-virtuous action, arrive at a great karmic maturation of non-virtue. Out of fear of this, one should always think: "I, a sentient being, belong to hell and accordingly carry out the conduct of a hell-being." And even upon hearing a wise and discerning person teach the sufferings of the hells, one should always think: just as iron strikes iron, stone strikes stone, wood strikes wood, and insects that delight in fire resemble fire — in the same way the very body of a hell-being is commensurate with hell itself.

Thinking in this way — that a sentient being is commensurate with hell itself — one reflects: "What is there in the nature of things that is not suffering?" Just as a fly becomes stuck in mucus and cannot get free, so too it is the same for

that being: one cannot get free even from a small non-virtue, and from the very beginning there is no mind of remorse. One cannot practice virtue, and having been tainted by faults, even the previously accumulated virtuous karma is stained by non-virtue. The karmic maturation that would fittingly be experienced in the present time is thereby altered, and the fruit of non-virtue in the hells becomes exceedingly heavy.

Noble son, just as when a small amount of salt is put into a small vessel with only a little water, the taste becomes so salty it is extremely difficult to drink — so too is the karma of that person's non-virtue.

Noble son, consider the example of a person who owes a single coin to another and, being unable to repay even that debt, is bound tightly and must endure great suffering — so too is the karma of that person's non-virtue.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar (Siṃhanāda) asked: "Blessed One, for what reason does a karmic maturation that would fittingly be experienced in the present become experienced in the hells?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, when any sentient being possesses these five things, a present-life karmic maturation will come to be experienced in the hells instead. What are the five? Being deluded; having few roots of virtue; having heavy non-virtuous karma; having performed no complete remorse; and not engaging in one's former virtuous karma.

"Again, there are five more: engaging in non-virtuous actions; lacking the wealth of moral discipline; abandoning the roots of virtue; not cultivating body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom; and relying on unwholesome spiritual friends. Noble son, for these reasons the ripened fruit of present-life karma comes to be experienced as the heavy karmic maturation of the hells.

Lion's Roar asked: "Blessed One, what persons are there who alter a heavy karmic maturation of the hells so that it is experienced lightly in the present life?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, whoever cultivates body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom, and — as explained above — realizes that all phenomena are like space: not regarding wisdom as wisdom, not regarding what possesses wisdom as possessing wisdom, not regarding delusion as delusion, not regarding what possesses delusion as possessing delusion, not regarding meditation as meditation, not regarding what is meditating as meditating — such a one is called a person of wisdom. Through cultivating

body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom, such a person experiences the heavy ripened fruit of the hells lightly in the present life. Even if such a person has performed deeply heavy non-virtuous karma, they think: 'My karma is very heavy, yet I need not think I am incapable of even a little virtuous action.' This is how it is:

Just as a hundred packs of cotton wool have no weight equivalent to even a single tola of pure gold; or just as a full bowl of salt poured into the river Ganges does not make it salty, and those who drink from it do not notice the salt; or just as a very wealthy person to whom another owes even hundreds of thousands of jewels cannot be bound tightly and made to suffer by anyone — or just as a great musk elephant, having snapped the iron hook used to guide it, is able to go wherever it pleases — so too is the person of wisdom. Such a person always thinks: 'My power of virtue is great, and since non-virtuous karma is weak, if I confess and acknowledge my misdeeds, the negativity will be purified; and if I cultivate wisdom, the power of wisdom will grow great and the power of ignorance will become small.' With this in mind, one relies upon a virtuous spiritual friend, becomes familiar with the correct view, and holds the twelve branches of the sūtras by heart.

One reads them, recites them, writes them down and teaches them to others; and when one sees others who are memorizing, reading, reciting, copying, or teaching them to others, one gives rise to a mind of reverence. One makes offerings of robes, food, lodging, bedding, medicine for illness, flowers, and incense, and renders homage and service. Wherever one goes, one speaks of the good qualities of that place and does not speak of its faults. One makes offerings to the Three Jewels, and through supreme confidence — drawn from the vast and extensive sūtra on nirvāṇa — that the Tathāgata is permanent, unchanging, and unaltering, and that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all sentient beings, one now experiences, even in the present moment, the lightening of the heavy karmic maturation of the hell realms.

Noble son, for this reason not all karma necessarily bears fruit, and not all sentient beings necessarily experience it.

The bodhisattva Simhanāda then asked: Blessed One, if all karma necessarily comes to have a lighter result, and since all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha they will come to cultivate the noble eightfold path — then by what cause and condition have not all sentient beings already fully attained nirvāṇa? Blessed One, if all sentient beings possess the intrinsic

nature of a buddha and will assuredly attain unsurpassed complete awakening, then what is the use of cultivating the noble eightfold path? Blessed One, this sūtra says that just as a sick person, if properly treated with medicine, a physician, a nurse, and care suited to the illness, will be cured of that sickness — so too it is with all sentient beings: by hearing the Dharma from śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, Tathāgatas, bodhisattvas, and virtuous spiritual friends, and by cultivating the noble path, or even if one does not encounter them, or has not heard it, or has not cultivated the path, one will still attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? Because the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present. Blessed One, just as the sun and moon cannot be prevented from reaching a mountain range, just as the four great rivers cannot be stopped from reaching the ocean, and just as those with wrong craving cannot be prevented from going to the hell realms — so too with all sentient beings: there is no one who can prevent them from going toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Why is that? Because the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present. Blessed One, for this reason it seems that all sentient beings, without needing to cultivate the path, will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening through the power of the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and are therefore not at all dependent on the power of cultivating the noble path. Blessed One, if even those with wrong craving, those who have broken the four defeats, and those who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution cannot attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — if one must cultivate the path — then since they are certain to attain it through the intrinsic nature of a buddha, it would not be that they attain it through cultivating the path. Blessed One, consider a magnet: though it is not close to iron, by its power it holds the iron. The intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is just like that — and therefore there is no need to strive on the noble path.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, consider this: seven kinds of people are bathing on the bank of the Ganges river, or they have entered the water out of fear of an enemy, or to gather flowers. Of these, one, the moment he enters the water, sinks.

Why is that? It is because such a person is weak, with no strength or skill, not having learned to swim. Of these seven, one enters the water and sinks, but having sunk, rises back up again — and having risen, sinks once more. Why is that? Because of great physical strength, he is able to sink and then rise; yet because he has not learned to swim, having risen he sinks once more. Of

these, one sinks and then rises, and having risen, does not sink again. Why is that? Though his body is heavy so that he sinks, because of his great strength he rises back up; and because he has learned to swim, he does not sink again. Of these, one enters the water and sinks; having sunk, he rises back up; and having risen, he pauses and looks in all four directions. Why is that? Though his body is heavy so that he sinks, because of his great strength he comes back up; and because he has learned to swim, he stays there — yet not knowing the way out, he looks in all four directions. Of these, one enters the water and sinks; having sunk, he rises back up again; having risen, he pauses; and having paused, he looks in all four directions; and having looked, he sets off. Why is that? Out of fear. Of these, one enters the water and sets off; and when he reaches the bottom he stays there. Why is that? Because he is watching to see whether enemies are near or far. Of these, one reaches the far bank and climbs a high mountain; freed from enemies, he is without fear and becomes utterly at ease.

Noble son, the great river of saṃsāra is just like that, and there are seven kinds of people in it. They too, out of fear of the enemy that is mental affliction, think to cross the great river of saṃsāra, and so they go forth from home into homelessness. They shave their hair and beards and clothe their bodies in the Dharma robes. Having thus gone forth, they associate with companions in non-virtue, listen to their words, and take hold of these wrong teachings: the body of a sentient being is constituted by the five aggregates (skandhas), and the five aggregates are the five great elements; if a sentient being dies, the five great elements are permanently cut off; and if the five great elements are permanently cut off, why bother cultivating virtuous and non-virtuous actions? They therefore declare: understand that there is no virtue, no non-virtue, and no karmic maturation of the virtuous and the non-virtuous. One who holds such a view is called one of perverted craving. One of perverted craving is called one who severs all virtuous roots. Because the virtuous roots are severed, such a person sinks in the river of saṃsāra and cannot rise back out. Why is that? Because of the weight of non-virtuous karma and the absence of the power of faith — such a person is like the first of the people at the Ganges river.

Noble son, those of perverted craving, through six causes and conditions, sink into the three lower states and cannot rise back out. What are the six? They are as follows: a blazing mind of non-virtue; not seeing the next world; delighting in the pursuit of mental afflictions; abandoning the roots of virtue;

being blocked and cut off by non-virtuous karma; and relying on companions in non-virtue.

Furthermore, through five kinds of actions, one sinks into the three lower states. What are the five? Acting improperly toward monks; acting improperly toward nuns; forcibly making use of the Saṅgha's property; acting improperly toward one's mother; and, with respect to a divided community of five members of the Saṅgha, generating the thought that what is not proper is proper and what is proper is not.

Furthermore, through five kinds of actions one falls into the three lower states. What are the five? Constantly teaching that virtuous and non-virtuous actions have no result; taking the life of a sentient being who has generated the awakening mind of bodhicitta; slandering one who teaches the Dharma; declaring that what is Dharma is not Dharma and what is not Dharma is Dharma; and listening to the Dharma for the purpose of finding fault with it.

Furthermore, through three kinds of actions one sinks into the three lower states. What are the three?

Saying that the Tathāgata is impermanent and therefore ceases, saying that the sacred Dharma is also impermanent and therefore changes and passes away, and saying that the Saṅgha Jewel will come to an end — on account of these three one constantly sinks into the three lower states.

That person, even while desiring to cross over the great river of saṃsāra, has cut off the roots of virtue and therefore, having sunk, cannot emerge. Now, what is meant by "emerging" is this: by attending upon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra) one attains a mind of faith. A mind of faith means: trusting in generosity and in the fruit of generosity; trusting in virtue and in the fruit of virtue; trusting in non-virtue and in the fruit of non-virtue; and trusting that saṃsāra is suffering, impermanent, and subject to destruction. That is what is called faith.

Because one possesses a mind of faith, one dwells in pure moral discipline and holds dhāraṇīs, reciting them, chanting them, writing them down, expounding and explaining them. One practises generosity constantly and cultivates wisdom. Yet, because one's faculties are dull, if one encounters a spiritual friend of unwholesome kind, one does not cultivate body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom, and one takes hold of wrong teachings. Moreover, if in an evil age one is born in a bad region, the roots of virtue are cut. Because the roots of virtue are cut, one sinks continuously into saṃsāra. Such a person is

like the second person on the river Gaṅgā.

Of those persons, the one who desires to cross the great river of saṃsāra, yet has cut the roots of virtue and therefore sunk — because that one attends upon a spiritual friend, this is called "emerging." The Tathāgata is omniscient; he does not change and does not become impermanent; for the sake of sentient beings he teaches the unsurpassed Dharma. All sentient beings possess buddha-nature. The Tathāgata, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha are not subject to cessation — having faith and confidence in this, one who still holds wrong cravings believes: "Unless I abandon these teachings, I shall never attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; but if I utterly relinquish them, I shall attain it from the very beginning." With such a mind of faith and confidence one cultivates pure moral discipline, and having cultivated pure moral discipline, one holds the twelve branches of scripture as dhāraṇīs, reciting, chanting, writing, and analyzing them, and teaches them extensively to all sentient beings. One delights in generosity and cultivates wisdom. In this way, because one's faculties are sharp, one comes to have faith and wisdom firmly established, and with a mind free from turning back — such a person is like the third person on the river Gaṅgā.

Of those persons, the one who desires to cross the great river of saṃsāra, yet has cut the roots of virtue and therefore sunk there — because that one attends upon a spiritual friend and possesses a mind of faith, this is called "emerging." Because one possesses a mind of faith, one holds the twelve branches of scripture as dhāraṇīs, reciting, chanting, writing, and analyzing them, and teaches them extensively to all sentient beings. One delights in generosity and cultivates wisdom. Thus, because one's faculties are sharp and one comes to rely on faith and wisdom, with a mind free from turning back one looks toward the four directions. What is meant by "looking toward the four directions" is the four fruits of the ascetic life — just as with the fourth person on the river Gaṅgā. Of those persons, the one who desires to cross that great river of saṃsāra, yet has cut the roots of virtue and therefore sunk there — because that one attends upon a spiritual friend and possesses a mind of faith, this is called "emerging." Because one possesses a mind of faith, one holds the twelve branches of scripture as dhāraṇīs, reciting, chanting, writing, and analyzing them, and teaches them extensively to all sentient beings.

One delights in generosity and cultivates wisdom. In this way, because the faculties have become sharp, faith and wisdom grow firm, and the mind of turning back is no more. Because there is no turning back, one leaps ever

higher. That leaping ever higher is the pratyekabuddha. Although that one has liberated oneself, it is not so for all sentient beings — and therefore this is called "going." It is comparable to the fifth person on the river Gaṅgā. Of those persons, the one who desires to cross that great river of saṃsāra, yet has cut the roots of virtue and therefore sunk there — because that one attends upon a spiritual friend and comes to possess a mind of faith, this is called "emerging." Because one possesses a mind of faith, one holds the twelve branches of scripture as dhāraṇīs, reciting, chanting, writing, and analyzing them, and teaches them extensively to all sentient beings. One delights in generosity and cultivates wisdom. In this way, because the faculties have become sharp, faith and wisdom grow firm, and the mind of turning back is no more. Because there is no turning back, one leaps ever higher — advancing until one reaches the very bottom. Having reached the bottom, one remains there and does not move on. "Remaining there and not moving on" means this: the bodhisattva, in order to liberate sentient beings, deliberately engages with afflictions. This is comparable to the sixth person on the river Gaṅgā. Of those persons, the one who desires to cross that great river of saṃsāra, yet has cut the roots of virtue and sunk there — because that one attends upon a spiritual friend and comes to possess a mind of faith, this is called "emerging." Because one possesses a mind of faith, one holds the twelve branches of scripture as dhāraṇīs, reciting, chanting, writing, and analyzing them, and teaches them extensively to all sentient beings. One delights in generosity and cultivates wisdom. In this way, because the faculties have become sharp, faith and wisdom grow firm, and the mind of turning back is no more. Because there is no turning back, one leaps ever higher. By leaping ever higher, one arrives at the farther shore — ascending a great mountain, one abandons fearful enemies and comes to experience many joys. Noble son, "arriving at the farther shore" signifies the Tathāgata. "Experiencing joy" signifies the buddha's permanence. "Dwelling on the high mountain" is the simile for the great, complete nirvāṇa.

Noble son, just as all those persons on the river Gaṅgā possessed hands and feet yet were unable to cross, so too are all sentient beings. Although there truly exist the Jewel of the Buddha, the Jewel of the Dharma, and the Jewel of the Saṅgha, and although the Tathāgata has taught the sūtra of all phenomena — the noble path with its eightfold branches — and great complete nirvāṇa, still sentient beings are unable to attain it. You should understand that this is not a fault of mine, nor a fault of the noble path; it is a

fault arising from the flaws and afflictions of sentient beings themselves. It is for this reason that all sentient beings have not attained nirvāṇa.

Noble son, consider, for example, a skilled physician who, having understood the nature of a disease, prescribes medicine. If the patient does not drink it, the fault is not the physician's. Noble son, if a single patron were to give all his wealth to everyone, and some refused to accept it, the fault would not be the patron's. Noble son, consider the sun rising: even the deepest crevices are illumined, yet if a blind person does not see the path, the fault is not the sun's.

Noble son, consider, for example, how the waters of the Ganges river can satisfy the thirst of many. Yet if the thirsty do not drink, the fault is not the water's.

Noble son, consider, for example, how the great earth brings forth all fruits equally and without distinction. Yet if a farmer does not till the soil, the fault is not the earth's.

Noble son, in just the same way, the Tathāgata extensively expounds and teaches the twelve branches of scripture to all sentient beings without exception. If sentient beings do not take it up, the fault is not the Tathāgata's.

Noble son, whoever cultivates the path will attain the unsurpassed, utterly complete awakening of an arhat.

Noble son, your assertion that because all sentient beings possess the buddha-nature they will therefore attain the unsurpassed, utterly complete awakening — just as iron is drawn to a magnet — that much is excellent, well said. However, your further assertion that by the power of having the buddha-nature as their cause they will attain unsurpassed, utterly complete awakening and therefore need not cultivate the noble path — that meaning is not so.

Noble son, consider, for example, a person who, having gone to a solitary wilderness, is tormented by thirst and comes upon a well. The well is very deep, and though the water cannot be seen, one knows with certainty that it is there. Only after that person, by means and effort, has sought a vessel and a rope and lowered them does the water at last come into view. The buddha-nature is just like that: it is present in all sentient beings, yet only by cultivating the undefiled noble path does one at last come to see it.

Noble son, just as when sesame seeds are present, oil too will come to be seen — yet if the methods are abandoned, it will not be seen — so too with

sugarcane, it is the same.

Noble son, consider, for example, how the gods of the Thirty-Three Heavens and the Dharma of Uttarakuru exist, yet without the power of virtuous karma or supernatural ability, one cannot see them. Just as the roots of grass beneath the ground and the water beneath the earth are hidden under the soil and cannot be seen, the buddha-nature in sentient beings is likewise: if the noble path is not cultivated, it will not be seen.

Noble son, consider how in the world a sick person might meet a good nurse, fine medicine, and a skilled physician, and medicine might be administered exactly according to the nature of the disease — or even if they do not meet such conditions, they may recover. Noble son, it is on that same point that I have taught these matters to bodhisattvas on the sixth ground.

Noble son, consider, for example, how space is neither inside all sentient beings nor outside them nor both inside and outside, and for that reason is without obstruction. The buddha-nature in sentient beings is just like that.

Noble son, consider, for example, how a person's wealth may reside somewhere else and not be at hand, yet that person has power to use it at will. And if someone were to ask whether it is truly theirs, the answer would be: "I have power over it" — and why? Because it is assuredly under their command. The buddha-nature in sentient beings is just like that: it is neither here nor there, and yet, because it is something they are certain to obtain, it is said to be present in all.

Noble son, consider, for example, how the virtuous and non-virtuous karma performed by sentient beings is neither inside nor outside. And in that way the intrinsic nature of karma neither simply exists nor simply does not exist; it is not something that has been present from beginningless time until now; it does not arise without cause; it is not the case that the one who acts experiences the result; nor is it the case that the one who acts causes another to experience it; nor does one person's act cause another person to experience its result; yet neither is there no acting nor no experiencing. Rather, when the right time and conditions have gathered, the result ripens —

The intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings is likewise thus: it has no beginning, nor does it presently exist; it is not inside, it is not outside; it does not exist, it does not not-exist; it is not here, it is not elsewhere; it has not come from somewhere else; nor is it without cause; nor is it seen by all sentient beings. Bodhisattvas, however, will come to see it when the right time

and conditions have gathered. As for what "the right time" means: it is this — when a bodhisattva, a great being on the tenth ground, is cultivating the Noble Eightfold Path and has attained a mind of equanimity toward all sentient beings, then and there that sight arises. Such a one is not to be called a child.

Good son, as for your saying "this is like a lodestone attracting iron" — that is not the right way to understand it. Why? Because the stone does not grasp the iron. And why is that? Because there is neither mind nor karma. Good son, because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise; because distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease. There is no one who creates and no one who destroys.

Good son, consider, for example, how a spark cannot burn wood all by itself, yet once fire has arisen and the wood has broken apart, it is called burning. Good son, consider how the sunflower turns to follow the sun: the sunflower has no intention to bow, no consciousness, no karma, yet by virtue of the characteristics of distinct phenomena, it naturally rotates and turns. Good son, consider how the trumpet tree grows when the sound of thunder is heard: that tree has no ears, no mind, no mental consciousness, yet because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise, and when distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease. Good son, consider how when a woman touches an Aśoka tree, flowers spring forth: that tree has no mind, no feeling of being touched, yet because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise, and when distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease. Good son, consider how a tamarind tree, when watered and fertilized with teeth-dust, bones, and scum, bears better and more abundant fruit: that tamarind tree has no mind and no sense of touch, yet because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise, and when distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease. Good son, a lodestone attracting iron is likewise: because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise, and when distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease. The intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings is similarly so: it cannot take up unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening by means of grasping.

Good son, ignorance cannot take up the formations, nor can the formations take up consciousness, yet through the condition of ignorance arise the formations, and through the condition of the formations arises consciousness — this is how it is called. Whether or not a buddha is present, the dharmadhātu (basic space of phenomena) abides always.

Good son, if one says "the intrinsic nature of a buddha abides within sentient beings" — good son, a permanent phenomenon has no fixed abode; if it had a fixed abode, it would become impermanent. Good son, the twelve links of dependent origination have no fixed abode where they permanently reside. If there were a fixed abode where they reside, the twelve links of dependent origination could not be called impermanent. Likewise, the dharmakāya (truth body) of the Tathāgata has no fixed abode; nor do the dharmadhātu, the sense base of phenomena, the aggregate of phenomena,

space too has no fixed abode where it permanently resides. The intrinsic nature of a buddha likewise has no fixed abode where it permanently resides.

Good son, consider this example: the four great elements are equal in power. All share the same characteristics — solidity, heat, moisture, movement, lightness, heaviness, red, white, yellow, and black — yet the four great elements have no activity of their own. Just as, through the realm of distinct phenomena, they are individually distinct from one another, so too the intrinsic nature of a buddha is like that: through the realm of distinct phenomena, when the right time is encountered, it is seen for the very first time.

Good son, it is said that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha because they cannot turn back from it. Because they cannot turn back from it, because they will come to possess it, because they will certainly attain it, because they will certainly come to see it — for all these reasons, it is said that all sentient beings have the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Good son, here is an example. A certain king commanded one of his great ministers: "Bring a woolen ox and show it to the blind." The great minister, following the royal command, gathered the blind people together and displayed the woolen ox to them, and each of them felt it with their hands. The minister then reported back to the king, saying, "I have shown it to them." The king then summoned the blind people and asked each of them, "Did you see the woolen ox?" Each of the blind people replied, "I saw it." The king asked, "What does the woolen ox look like?" One blind person who had touched its teeth said, "The woolen ox is like mustard seed." One who had touched its ear said, "The woolen ox is like a sieve." One who had touched its head said, "The woolen ox is like a stone." One who had touched its nose said, "The woolen ox is like a plow beam." One who had touched its leg said, "The woolen ox's form is like a mortar." One who had touched its back said, "The woolen ox is like a

throne." One who had touched its belly said, "The woolen ox is like a clay vessel." One who had touched its tail said, "The woolen ox's form is like a rope."

Good son, those blind people did not speak of the actual thing that a woolen ox is — yet neither did they speak of something other than it. If those things they described were not the woolen ox, then beyond what they set aside there would be no other woolen ox.

Good son, the king is an example for the Tathāgata, the omniscient one. The great minister is an example for the great Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, so vast and complete. The woolen ox is an example for the intrinsic nature of a buddha. The blind people are an example for sentient beings in their ignorance.

When those sentient beings hear what the Buddha has taught, some say this: "Form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so? Because form, though it ceases, is one thing succeeding another without interruption, and through this the supreme form of the Tathāgata attains the thirty-two excellent marks, and the form of the Tathāgata is permanent and unceasing. Therefore form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha." They give this example: just as genuine gold, however it is fashioned, retains a color that is stable and unchanging — whether it is made into a bracelet, shaped like a snake, or beaten flat — the yellow color has not changed from the very beginning. Likewise, although the shape of the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is impermanent, form itself is permanent; therefore they say, "Form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

Others say this: "Feeling (vedanā) is the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so?"

Through the cause and condition of feeling, one attains the genuine bliss of the Tathāgata. The feeling of the Tathāgata is, in the end, feeling in the ultimate sense. Although the intrinsic nature of feeling in sentient beings is impermanent, each feeling succeeds the last in an unbroken stream, and through this continuity one attains the permanent feeling of the Tathāgata. The example given is this: the human bone called the kauśika — the human being is impermanent, yet the bone is permanent, remaining unchanged for a thousand eons. Likewise, the intrinsic nature of the buddha in sentient beings is similar to this; therefore they say, "Feeling is the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

Others say this: "Perception is the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so?" Through the cause and condition of perception, the true perception of the Tathāgata is obtained. Now, the perception of the Tathāgata is a perception that is without perception. This perception-without-perception does not perceive sentient beings as sentient beings, does not perceive them as female or male, does not perceive form, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness — it is not perception, it is the cessation of perception. Although the perceptions of sentient beings are impermanent, perception succeeds perception in sequence, one after another, in an unbroken stream, and through this continuity the everlasting and permanent perception of the Tathāgata is attained. Noble son, the example is this: it is like the twelve links of dependent origination of sentient beings — while sentient beings cease, the twelve links of dependent origination are as it were permanent. The intrinsic nature of the buddha in sentient beings is similar to this; therefore they say, "Perception is the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

Others say this: "Formations are the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so?" Formations are what is called the life-breath of living beings, and through the cause and condition of this vital life-breath, the Tathāgata's bodily life comes to abide permanently. Although the vital life-breath of sentient beings is impermanent, the living life-breath succeeds the last in sequence, one after another, in an unbroken stream, and through this continuity the genuine and permanent bodily life of the Tathāgata is attained. Noble son, the example is this: just as listening to the twelve branches of scriptural teaching, and expounding them, and both together are impermanent, yet the sūtras themselves abide permanently, unchanged — the intrinsic nature of the buddha in sentient beings is similar to this; therefore they say, "Formations are the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

Others say this: "Consciousness is the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so?" Through the cause and condition of consciousness, the equanimous mind of the Tathāgata is attained. Although the mental consciousness of sentient beings is impermanent, each consciousness succeeds the last in an unbroken stream, and through this continuity the genuine and permanent mind of the Tathāgata is attained. The example is this: it is like dyeing cloth with fire — although the fire is impermanent, the dyeing is not impermanent. The intrinsic nature of the buddha in sentient beings is similar to this; therefore they say, "Consciousness is the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

Others say this: "Apart from the aggregates there exists something called a self, and that self is the intrinsic nature of a buddha — why so?" Through the cause and condition of what is called the self, one attains the eight masteries of the Tathāgata. Certain non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say that what goes, what comes, what sees, what hears, sorrow, joy, and speech — all of these are the self. Although the defining characteristics called the self in that sense are impermanent, the genuine self of the Tathāgata is permanent.

Son of good family, consider this example: the aggregates, the sense sources, and the elements are impermanent, yet the name applied to them is permanent — and the intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings is similar to that. Son of good family, just as blind people, each one separately describing the form of an elephant, do not hit upon it directly, yet what they describe is not other than the elephant — so too with those who describe the intrinsic nature of a buddha: it is not the six phenomena, yet it is not other than the six phenomena either. Son of good family, therefore the intrinsic nature of a buddha within sentient beings has been taught thus: it is not form, nor is it other than form; and so on up through — it is not the self, nor is it other than the self.

Son of good family, non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) do speak of a self existing, yet there is in truth no such thing as a self. What is called the self of sentient beings refers to the five aggregates themselves; beyond the aggregates there is no separate self to be found elsewhere. Son of good family, consider how a lotus comes into being from the assembly of stalk, leaves, petals, and stem — beyond those, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called a lotus. The self of sentient beings is similar to this. Son of good family, consider how from the assembly of walls, grass, and timber there comes to be what is called a house — beyond those, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called a house. Consider how from the assembly of acacia trees, palāśa trees, nyagrodha trees, udumbara trees, and the like there comes to be what is called a grove — beyond those, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called a grove. Consider how from the assembly of chariots, elephants, horses, and infantry there comes to be what is called an army — beyond those, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called an army. Consider how from the assembly of five colors of Kashmiri silk there comes to be what is called a carpet — beyond those, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called a carpet. Consider how from the assembly of the four social classes there comes to be what is called a great assembly — beyond those, once they are

set aside, there is no other thing called a great assembly. The self of sentient beings is similar to all of these: beyond the five aggregates, once they are set aside, there is no other thing called a self.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata abides permanently and is therefore called a self. The dharmakāya of the Tathāgata is boundless, unobstructed, neither arising nor ceasing, and has attained the eight masteries — and therefore is called a self. As for sentient beings, they do not in truth possess a self or what belongs to a self of that kind. Because they will ultimately and without fail attain ultimate emptiness, it is called the intrinsic nature of a buddha.

Son of good family, great loving-kindness (*maitrī*) and great compassion (*karuṇā*) are called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Why is this? Because great loving-kindness and great compassion follow a bodhisattva always, like a shadow, and because all sentient beings will ultimately and without fail attain great loving-kindness and great compassion — therefore it is taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. Great loving-kindness and great compassion are called the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha is what is called the Tathāgata.

In relation to this, great joy and great equanimity are also called the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Why is this? Because if a bodhisattva, a great being, does not abandon the twenty-five modes of existence, he cannot attain unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening — and because all sentient beings will ultimately attain these, it is taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. Great joy and great equanimity are called the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is what is called the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called great faith of mind. Why is this?

Through the mind of faith, bodhisattvas, great beings, will perfectly complete the perfections from generosity (*dāna*) all the way through the Perfection of Wisdom. And because all sentient beings will ultimately and without fail attain the great mind of faith, it is taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. The mind of faith itself is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is the Tathāgata.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called the ground of the only child. Why is this? Through the causes and conditions of the ground of the only child, a bodhisattva attains a mind of equality toward all sentient beings; and

because all sentient beings will ultimately and without fail attain the ground of the only child, the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. The ground of the only child is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is the Tathāgata — so it is taught.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called the power of the fourth ground. Why is this? Through the causes and conditions of the power of the fourth ground, a bodhisattva comes to work for the benefit of all sentient beings; and because all sentient beings will ultimately and without fail attain the power of the fourth ground, the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. The power of the fourth ground is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is the Tathāgata — so it is taught.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is the twelve links of dependent origination. Why is this? Because of the twelve links of dependent origination, the Tathāgata abides forever. And because all sentient beings will without fail attain those twelve links of dependent origination, the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings. The twelve links of dependent origination are the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is the Tathāgata — so it is taught.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called the four kinds of individual perfect knowledge. Why is this? Through the causes and conditions of the four kinds of individual perfect knowledge, one expounds words and meanings without obstruction. Because there is no obstruction with respect to words and meanings, one comes to work for the benefit of sentient beings. Therefore the four kinds of individual perfect knowledge are the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha itself is the Tathāgata — so it is taught.

Furthermore, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is called the crown-of-the-head meditative absorption (uṣṇīṣa samādhi). Why is this? When that absorption is cultivated, all buddha qualities become gathered together. Therefore the crown-of-the-head meditative absorption is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Even a bodhisattva of the tenth ground, though cultivating this absorption, does not perfect it completely; they do perceive the intrinsic nature of a buddha, yet it does not become fully clear. And because all sentient beings will ultimately and without fail attain it, it is taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings.

O son of good family, just as all sentient beings will without fail attain the various kinds of qualities enumerated above, it is taught that the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings.

O son of good family, if I were to declare that form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, sentient beings, the moment they heard it, would generate a mistaken view. On account of that mistaken view, at the end of their lives they would fall into the Avīci hell, the hell of uninterrupted torment. Because a Tathāgata's teaching of the Dharma is for the purpose of cutting off [rebirth in] the hells for sentient beings —

it is for that reason that he does not declare that form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and likewise down through consciousness he does not so declare.

O son of good family, if sentient beings were to understand the intrinsic nature of a buddha with perfect clarity, there would be no need to cultivate the path. A bodhisattva of the tenth ground, having meditated on the noble eightfold path, still sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha only slightly — what need is there to speak of seeing it without meditation? O son of good family, when bodhisattvas such as Mañjuśrī, having meditated on the noble path for immeasurable and boundless aeons, only then first see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, how could śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas see it?

If sentient beings wish to see the intrinsic nature of a buddha with complete clarity, they should, with single-pointed mind, hold fast to this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa (Skt. mahāparinirvāṇa), read it, recite it, write it out, copy it for distribution, explain it, make offerings to it, perform ritual service to it, and honor it. And if they see others holding it, reading it, and honoring it in all these ways, they should offer fine lodgings, clothing, bedding, and medicines for illness; they should praise such persons, prostrate to them, and speak well of them.

O son of good family, whoever in times past served and made offerings to buddhas as countless and boundless as there are — and thereby brought forth a great root of virtue — only then comes first to hear even the mere name of this sūtra. O son of good family, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is inconceivable; the Three Jewels — the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha — are likewise inconceivable. That the intrinsic nature of a buddha exists within all sentient beings, and yet that they are unable to know it, is also inconceivable. The qualities of the Tathāgata — permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity — are also inconceivable. And that all sentient beings should

have faith in this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is likewise inconceivable.

The bodhisattva Lion's Roar (Skt. *Siṃhanāda*) said: Blessed One, you have declared that it is inconceivable that all sentient beings should have faith in this sūtra. Yet in this very assembly there are eighty-five million sentient beings in whose minds no faith in this sūtra arises. How then can it be called inconceivable that there is faith in this sūtra?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, those very sentient beings too will in a future time come to have confidence in this sūtra, will see the intrinsic nature of a buddha, and will attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

The noble Great Sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa (Skt. *Mahāparinirvāṇamahāsūtra*). The forty-third fascicle.

Lion's Roar asked: Blessed One, how will irreversible bodhisattvas know with certainty that they themselves truly possess the mind of irreversibility?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, bodhisattvas, great beings, can know this by examining themselves with the mind of one who practises austerities. That is to say: going without food, eating no more than one sesame seed per day, and continuing thus for seven days; then progressing through beans, or lentils, or hemp seeds, or white mustard seeds, each for seven days in turn, eating no more than one small grain per day — when, eating one small grain each day, one thinks, "This austerity is of no benefit, it serves no purpose," yet one further thinks, "Even though it serves no purpose, if I practise in this way and still do not act for the sake of benefit, what need is there to speak of it?" — and so, even knowing it serves no purpose, one perseveres in the practice and endures —

one will without fail attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. During all those days of practising austerities, the wasting and withering of the flesh and skin of the body is like freshly pressed sesame pulp left out in the sun. The sunken hollows of the eyes are like stars in a deep well. The body, all its flesh consumed, showing nothing but sinews and veins, is like a ruined thatched hut. The vertebrae of the spine standing out in plain view are like a knotted rope cast down. The place where one sits is like a horse's hoof-print, for when one sits one falls forward onto one's face, and when one rises one falls backward onto one's back. Yet even enduring such suffering that serves no beneficial purpose, one does not turn back from the awakening mind.

Good son, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, in order to destroy suffering and bestow happiness, gives away all outer and inner possessions, and surrenders body and life itself as freely as one would give away grass. That bodhisattva who places no value on body and life knows with certainty that he possesses a mind that will not turn back, and he understands with certainty that he will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva, for the sake of the Dharma, lights a human lamp from his own body: he wraps his body in cloth, smears it with oil, and sets it alight. When the bodhisattva in that moment endures such great suffering, he speaks thus to reproach his own mind: "This suffering does not amount to even a hundredth or a thousandth part of the suffering of the hell-beings. You have already endured great suffering that serves no beneficial purpose throughout hundreds of thousands of incalculable aeons. If you cannot endure even this small suffering, how will you go to liberate the sentient beings who are suffering in the hells?" When the bodhisattva, the great being, reflects in this way, he feels no physical pain, and his mind neither turns back nor wavers nor is disturbed. At that moment the bodhisattva comes to understand with certainty that he will himself attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Good son, even though at that time the bodhisattva still has afflictions and has not yet cut through them, yet for the sake of the Dharma he gives to sentient beings the limbs of his body — his head, his hands, his feet, his eyes, his legs, his flesh, and his blood — driving iron nails into his body, leaping from cliffs, and leaping into fire. Though the bodhisattva at that time endures immeasurable suffering of this kind, if his mind does not turn back and does not waver or change, then that bodhisattva himself understands with certainty that he possesses a mind that will not turn back and that he will surely attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

Good son, the bodhisattva, the great being, in order to destroy the suffering of all sentient beings, makes the aspiration to be born in the body of a very great animal, and gives that body's flesh and blood to sentient beings. When those sentient beings come to take from him, so that they may give rise to a mind of loving-kindness and compassion toward them, the bodhisattva at that time does not breathe, making himself as if dead, so that there arises in him no thought of doubt as to whether those who take the flesh might be killed by his death. In this way, though the bodhisattva is born in an animal realm, he never engages in the actions of animal existence. Why is that?

Noble one, because the bodhisattva has attained the mind of non-regression, he never at any time performs the actions of the three lower realms. And though in future times the bodhisattva, the great being, is not destined to experience even the slightest fruit of a wretched rebirth, by the power of his great aspiration he experiences those things for the sake of sentient beings.

Here is an analogy. A sick person possessed by a hungry ghost becomes invisible to ordinary sight, yet through the power of a knowledge-mantra he becomes visible again, and at times speaks, at times rejoices, at times grows angry, at times scolds, at times strikes, at times weeps, at times laughs. In just the same way, the future actions of the three lower realms performed by the bodhisattva, the great being, are like that.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, has taken birth in the body of a bear, he always teaches the sacred Dharma to sentient beings. At times he takes birth in the body of a crow, a magpie, or a parrot, and teaches the sacred Dharma to sentient beings. In order to teach the sacred Dharma to sentient beings, he also takes birth as a cat, a deer, a rabbit, a yak, a sheep, a monkey, a white dove, a garuḍa bird, a nāga, and a snake. Thus, experiencing many animal bodies in this way, he never performs the deeds of the animal realm; rather, while always born in the animal realm, he teaches the Dharma to others, so that they may quickly be liberated from their animal bodies and come to hear the Dharma. Although the bodhisattva at that time experiences animal bodies in this way, since he does not perform the deeds of wretched rebirth, one should therefore understand with certainty that he possesses the mind of non-regression.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, sees sentient beings threatened by famine, he is born in the immeasurably vast body of a tortoise or a great fish, and makes this aspiration: "May all sentient beings cut and eat the flesh of my body; may it grow back again after being cut; and through the condition of having eaten my flesh, may they be freed from the suffering of hunger and thirst, and may all of them give rise to the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening." Furthermore, the bodhisattva makes this aspiration: "All those who, through the condition of having eaten my flesh, have been freed from hunger and thirst — may all of them in future lives, throughout twenty-five existences, be swiftly freed from every fault of hunger and thirst."

When the bodhisattva, the great being, thus experiences suffering, one should understand with certainty that his non-regressive mind will attain unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Furthermore, when a bodhisattva witnesses a time of widespread sickness and sees beings tormented by disease, he thinks: "Just as a sick person who takes any part of the king of medicinal trees — whether root, trunk, branch, leaf, flower, fruit, or bark — is healed of illness, so too may my body become like that: may all those who hear my voice, touch my body, or eat my flesh and blood — down to eating my feet and my head — be cured of their sicknesses. May sentient beings who eat my flesh not give rise to malicious thoughts, but think of it as they would eating a child's flesh, and having been cured of their illnesses through me, may they receive the teaching of Dharma; and having heard it, may they have faith, retain it, and teach it to others as well." Thus does he make his aspiration.

Noble one, thus it is that the bodhisattva, though still accompanied by afflictions —

though the body experiences suffering, the mind does not turn back, waver, or change — one should know this to be a mind of definitive non-return, and that such a one will attain unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening.

Furthermore, noble one, should sentient beings be struck down by hungry ghosts and fall ill, the bodhisattva, upon seeing them, immediately makes this aspiration: "May I too become a body of hungry ghosts — a vast body, a body endowed with radiance, a body surrounded by a great retinue — so that, the instant those beings hear me, they may be healed of their sicknesses." Thus does he make his aspiration.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, practices austerity for the sake of sentient beings, though he is still accompanied by afflictions, his mind does not falter.

Noble one, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, though practicing the six perfections (pāramitās), does not place his hope in the fruits of the six perfections. When he applies himself diligently to the supreme six perfections, he makes this aspiration: "May I give the gift of the six perfections to each and every sentient being. And may each and every sentient being, having received my gift, all attain unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. May I myself become the six perfections, practicing austerity and experiencing many sufferings — and even when experiencing those sufferings, may I never turn

back from the awakening mind." Noble one, when the bodhisattva, the great being, has come to bear such characteristics, this is called the characteristic mark of non-return from awakening.

Noble one, furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, is called inconceivable. Why is that? The bodhisattva, the great being, knows full well that saṃsāra has exceedingly many faults and defects, and that great nirvāṇa has great qualities — and yet, for the sake of sentient beings, he remains in saṃsāra. Because his mind does not turn back from experiencing suffering in all its many forms, the bodhisattva is called inconceivable.

Noble one, the bodhisattva, the great being, does not arouse compassion and loving-kindness merely because he has been prompted by causes and conditions, nor does he seek gratitude for what he has done. He perpetually bestows benefit upon others. And even though he gives in this way, because he has no thought of expecting anything in return, he is called inconceivable.

Noble one, ordinary sentient beings practice austerity for the sake of benefit to themselves. The bodhisattva, the great being, practices austerity for the sake of benefit to others — and that is also of benefit to himself — and therefore he is also called inconceivable.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva, the great being, though accompanied by afflictions, in order to dissolve the distinction between enemy and friend, experiences much suffering, yet applies himself diligently to a mind of equanimity. For that reason he is called inconceivable.

Furthermore, when the bodhisattva encounters sentient beings who are wicked and unwholesome, he may mock them, speak to them with gentle words, drive them away, or, at times, place them in equanimity. To one who is naturally given to anger, he shows even gentle speech. To one who is arrogant, he displays great arrogance openly — yet in truth, within his own mind there is no arrogance whatsoever. This is called the bodhisattva's inconceivable skillful means.

Furthermore, when the bodhisattva, the great being, though accompanied by afflictions, has neither material goods nor wealth, and though many come to beg of him, his mind is free of clinging — this too is called the bodhisattva's inconceivable quality.

Furthermore, when a buddha appears in the world, the bodhisattva, knowing the qualities of a buddha, takes birth for the sake of sentient beings in bodies

on the outskirts where there is no buddha — experiencing a body such as that of one who is blind, or lame, or mute, or simple-minded. This too is called the bodhisattva's inconceivable quality.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva, fully comprehending whatever faults and defects sentient beings have, mingles with those beings in order to free them. Though he conducts himself in harmony with them in this way, he is not stained by the taint of their faults. This too is called the bodhisattva's inconceivable quality.

Furthermore, the bodhisattva understands and discerns that there is no defining mark of a sentient being, no affliction that takes hold, no striving on the path, no abandoning of afflictions, no striving toward awakening, no conduct of awakening, no spontaneously accomplished conduct of awakening, no experience of suffering, and no overcoming of suffering — yet, for the sake of sentient beings, he nevertheless overcomes suffering and engages in the conduct of awakening. This too is called inconceivable.

Furthermore, noble son, that the bodhisattva takes birth in the highest heaven of the desire realm, the Tuṣita heaven, as the inner and final rebirth of his body — this too is called the bodhisattva's inconceivable quality. Why is that? The Tuṣita heaven is the supreme abode within the desire realm. The gods of the lower heavenly levels conduct themselves heedlessly. The gods of the higher heavenly levels are subdued in their faculties; therefore the gods of Tuṣita are called the highest. Through the practice of generosity and moral discipline, one is reborn in the higher and lower heavens. Through cultivating meditative absorption together with generosity and moral discipline, one is reborn as a god in Tuṣita. All bodhisattvas utterly condemn conditioned existence, and though they have overcome conditioned existence and do not perform the deeds of a Tuṣita god, they are nonetheless reborn as gods in Tuṣita. Why is that? Because even if the bodhisattva is reborn into another existence, he will work for the benefit of sentient beings. Although he has no wish to be reborn in the desire realm, he is born into the desire realm. Therefore this is called inconceivable.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, is reborn as a god in Tuṣita, he becomes supreme in these three things: in length of life, in physical appearance, and in renown. Although the bodhisattva, the great being, harbors no expectation regarding length of life, physical appearance, or renown, he becomes supreme in these beyond all others. By the force of the

bodhisattva's aspiration toward complete nirvāṇa, and through those very causes and conditions, he becomes supreme. Therefore this is called inconceivable.

Even though the bodhisattva, the great being, has thus become supreme among the gods in these three things, the sons of the gods do not give rise toward that bodhisattva any thought of aversion, any thought of envy, or any thought of pride; they always give rise to a mind of joy. And because the bodhisattva himself harbors no pride toward the gods, this is called inconceivable.

Although the bodhisattva, the great being, has not performed any deeds to secure length of life, by virtue of his lifespan reaching its full measure among those gods, his length of life is said to have become supreme. Although he has not performed any deeds to attain a beautiful form, he comes to dwell in a body of excellent appearance, and through the brilliance of his radiance shining everywhere, his form is said to have become supreme. The bodhisattva, the great being, though dwelling in the divine palace, is not attached to the five objects of desire; he engages only in the work of Dharma, and his renown spreads in all ten directions.

Therefore it is said to be supremely renowned, and that is what is called inconceivable.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, descends from Tuṣita Heaven, the great earth shakes in six ways — and that too is what is called inconceivable. Why is that? When the bodhisattva descends from the heavens, all the gods of the desire realm and the form realm pay him honor and escort him, and raising a great cry, they praise the bodhisattva with the utmost intensity — so that even the force of the breath from their mouths causes the earth to tremble. Furthermore, the bodhisattva is like a king of the finest herd among humans. The king of the finest herd among humans is called the king of the nāgas. When the king of the nāgas first enters the womb, certain nāga kings who dwell beneath the earth are gripped by fear, while others are filled with joy — and the great earth shakes in six ways. Therefore that too is called inconceivable.

The bodhisattva, the great being, knows the moment of entering the womb, the moment of dwelling therein, and the moment of emergence. He perceives his father and mother as utterly pure, completely unstained — beholding them as though they were the hair of Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, or a blue

precious jewel. Therefore that too is called inconceivable.

O son of good family, this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa is likewise inconceivable. O son of good family, consider: the great ocean has eight inconceivable qualities. What are these eight? It shelves gradually; it is deep and its depths are vast; it has one single taste, the taste of salt; it does not transgress its shoreline boundary; it holds many precious things; it has become the dwelling place of many sentient beings; it does not retain a corpse; and though it receives all rivers and the rain of great clouds, it neither increases nor decreases. These are the eight.

O son of good family, as regards the quality of shelving gradually, there are three factors: the force of the merit of all sentient beings, the movement of wind in its direction, and the flow of rivers. And with respect to neither increasing nor decreasing as well, there are three such factors for each. In exactly the same way, this sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa also has eight inconceivable qualities.

What are they? Shelving gradually: this sūtra sets forth and teaches, from the five precepts of moral discipline, the ten precepts of moral discipline, the two hundred and fifty precepts of moral discipline, the moral discipline of the bodhisattva, the fruit of stream-entry, the fruit of once-returning, the fruit of non-returning, the fruit of arhathood, the fruit of the pratyekabuddha, the fruit of the bodhisattva, and up to the fruit of unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. These teachings are called gradual shelving — and therefore this sūtra is called the one that shelves gradually.

Deep with vast depths: the Blessed One, the Buddha, is unborn and unceasing; there is no attaining of unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening; there is no turning of the wheel of Dharma; there is no receiving of alms; there is no act of generosity — and therefore there is permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity, and all sentient beings possess the nature of buddha. The nature of buddha is not form, nor is it other than form; it is not feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness, nor is it other than consciousness. It is fit to be regarded as permanent; it is not a cause produced by conditions that generate illumination; from stream-entry all the way through to the pratyekabuddha, even upon attaining unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, there is no affliction and there is no abiding.

Yet even though there is no affliction, one should not say "it is permanent" — therefore it is called profound.

Furthermore, what is "most profound" is this: throughout this sūtra, in various passages it teaches that there is a self, and in various passages it teaches that there is no self; in various passages it teaches permanence, and in various passages it teaches impermanence; in various passages it teaches utter purity, and in various passages it teaches that things are not utterly pure; in various passages it teaches bliss, and in various passages it teaches suffering; in various passages it teaches emptiness, and in various passages it teaches that things are not empty; in various passages it teaches that all things exist, and in various passages it teaches that all things do not exist; in various passages it teaches three vehicles, and in various passages it teaches a single vehicle; in various passages it teaches that the five aggregates themselves are the intrinsic nature of a buddha — referring to the vajra-like meditative absorption (samādhi), the meditative absorption of the middle path and courageous advance, the twelve links of dependent origination, ultimate emptiness, loving-kindness and compassion, joy, equanimity, the gnosis that crowns all sentient beings, faith of mind, faculties, powers, and the gnosis unobstructed with respect to all phenomena. Because the buddha-nature exists and yet has not been definitively taught, it is called "profound."

What is meant by "of one taste" is this: the buddha-nature exists in a way that is concordant for all sentient beings — concordant in that the vehicle is one, concordant in that liberation is singular, the cause is one, the fruit is one, and concordant in that the flavor is one. Because all will attain permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity, it is called "of one taste."

What is meant by "not transgressing the boundary of the grade" is this: from this sūtra, where it is prescribed as a rule that monks shall not retain eight unexamined things, any one who has become my attendant and who holds, grasps, reads, recites, copies in writing, expounds, and teaches this noble sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa — even should body and life be lost, that person will not let moral discipline deteriorate. This is what is meant by "not transgressing the boundary of the grade."

"Of many kinds of jewels" means that this very sūtra is a treasure of immeasurable jewels. "Treasure" here refers to: the four establishments of mindfulness, the four genuine abandonments, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven branches of awakening, the noble eightfold path, the conduct of an ordinary child, the conduct of a noble one, the conduct of Brahmā, the conduct of the gods, the means for many virtues, the buddha-nature of sentient beings, the qualities of

bodhisattvas, the qualities of Tathāgatas, the qualities of śrāvakas, the qualities of pratyekabuddhas, the six perfections, immeasurable meditative absorptions, and immeasurable gnosis and wisdom — these constitute the treasure of jewels.

"The abode of great beings" — a great being is a buddha or a bodhisattva; they are called great beings because their gnosis and wisdom are great. Because the body is great, the mind is great; because the mind is great, the array is great; because the array is great, those to be tamed are many; because skillful means are great; because the teaching of Dharma is great; because might and power are great; because the maṇḍala of the retinue is great; because miraculous powers are great; because loving-kindness and compassion are great; because there is no change whatsoever; because there is no obstruction with respect to all sentient beings; and because all sentient beings can be accommodated — for all these reasons it is called "the abode of great beings."

As for "corpse" and "not remaining" — a corpse refers to one who harbors perverted craving, one whose four root defeats have deteriorated,

— who has committed any of the five acts of immediate retribution, who has reviled the vast sūtra collections, who has taught what is not the Dharma as if it were Dharma, who has taught the Dharma as if it were not the Dharma, who keeps eight things without proper examination, who acts according to their own pleasure with the property of the buddhas and the wealth of the Saṅgha, and who behaves improperly toward monks and nuns — such a one is what is called "a corpse." This sūtra of thorough nirvāṇa likewise does not keep company with a corpse, because it is thoroughly separated from all such things. That is what is meant by "not remaining."

As for "neither increasing nor decreasing" — it is so because it is boundless; because it has no beginning and no end; because it is without form; because it is not the product of effort; because it abides permanently; because it neither arises nor ceases; because it is equal and impartial toward all sentient beings; and because the defining marks of all things are consistent in being but a single mark. Therefore it neither increases nor decreases.

For all these reasons, this sūtra is like a great ocean, endowed with eight inconceivable qualities.

Lion's Roar then asked: Blessed One, if the Tathāgata is said to be profound because he neither arises nor ceases, then every ordinary person has four

modes of birth: birth from an egg, birth from heat and moisture, birth from a womb, and miraculous birth. All four modes of birth are to be found even among human beings. For example, the monk Śāla, and Upaśīpala, and the laywoman Nīkalā's mother, and the laywoman Nikutā's mother, and the laywoman Phaṃśalā's mother — each of these had five hundred and five hundred children, and all were born from a single egg. Therefore there is also birth from an egg among humans. As for birth from heat and moisture, just as the Blessed One has taught — when the bodhisattva practised in former times, there was one called the king born from the crown of the head, and one called the king born from the arm; and just now you spoke of the maiden born from the mango tree, and the maiden born from the kabittha tree. Therefore birth from heat and moisture also exists among humans. When the cosmic age (kalpa) was first forming, all sentient beings were born miraculously. Since the Blessed One, the buddha, is endowed with the eight masteries, why was he not born miraculously?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, all sentient beings are born through four modes of birth. Having heard the noble Dharma, those who were formerly born from eggs and born from heat and moisture will no longer be so reborn. Son of good family, when the cosmic age was first forming, all sentient beings were born miraculously; yet at that time, no buddha had come into the world. Son of good family, if sentient beings are afflicted by illness, a physician and medicine are needed. When the cosmic age was first forming, all sentient beings were born miraculously; and though they had afflictions, the disease of those afflictions had not yet arisen — therefore the Tathāgata did not come into the world. Son of good family, the sentient beings of the first-formed cosmic age had not yet become suitable vessels, in body and mind, for the teaching — therefore the Tathāgata did not come into the world. Son of good family, the lineage of the Blessed One, the buddhas, together with his retinue and parents, is supremely noble, so that all who hear him teach the Dharma place their trust in him. Therefore the Tathāgata is not born miraculously. Son of good family, all sentient beings may perform in their role as children what belongs to a father, and may perform in their role as father what belongs to a child. If the Blessed One, the buddha, were born miraculously, he would have no parents. If he had no parents, how could he perform the many virtuous deeds for the sake of all ordinary persons? Therefore the Tathāgata is not born miraculously.

Son of good family, there are two kinds of guarding of the sacred Dharma taught by the buddha: inner and outer.

The inner guarding is moral discipline. The outer guarding is spiritual friends and one's retinue. If the Blessed One, the buddha, were born miraculously, there would be no outer guarding. Therefore the Tathāgata does not wish for a miraculously born body.

Son of good family, some persons, proud of their lineage, give rise to arrogance. In order to crush that arrogance of theirs, the Tathāgata is born into a noble lineage — he does not wish for a miraculously born body. Son of good family, the Blessed One, the buddha, truly has a father and a mother: his father is called Pure Rice and his mother is called Heavenly Beauty. Yet if one were to say that those sentient beings are illusions, how could a miraculously born body be desired? And if a miraculously born body were assumed, from what would the many relics arise? The Tathāgata, for the benefit of sentient beings, causes his body to be broken into fine relics so that all may make offerings to them. Therefore the Tathāgata does not wish for a miraculously born body. Since all buddhas do not wish for a miraculously born body, why should I alone assume one?

Then the bodhisattva Śiṃhaghoṣa joined his palms together, knelt on his right knee, and praised the Blessed One with these verses:

The Tathāgata is a mass of virtues beyond all measure;
though I cannot set them forth in full,
for the sake of ordinary persons I shall speak of them in part —
out of love, I speak: may it please you to listen.

Ordinary persons wander in the darkness of ignorance
and come to experience suffering in its endless and manifold forms;
because the Blessed One has freed them from that,
throughout all the world he is renowned as the one of great compassion.

Because ordinary persons revolve around the causes of saṃsāra,
thoroughly corrupted by heedlessness, they are without happiness;
because the Tathāgata has fully bestowed happiness upon them,
the continuum of their revolving through saṃsāra has been utterly severed.

Because the Tathāgata has given happiness to all,
I myself feel no attachment to or longing for any happiness whatsoever.

Having practiced every hardship for the sake of ordinary persons,
he has come to be venerated by all the world with its gods.

When he sees others experiencing suffering, his body trembles —
yet even entering into hell with sentient beings, he feels no pain.
He has undergone great suffering for the sake of sentient beings;
thus he is victorious over all, and his measure surpasses reckoning.

The Tathāgata practiced austerities for the sake of sentient beings,
and fully perfected the six perfections (pāramitās).
His mind, though dwelling amid the winds of wrong views, is unmoved —
thus he is born as an utterly victorious person in the world.

Ordinary persons all desire happiness,
yet they do not know what it is that brings happiness about;
because the Tathāgata has taught it and they have come to meditate upon it,
it is as when parents cherish an only child.

The Blessed One, seeing sentient beings afflicted by the illness of mental
afflictions,
is like a mother to a suffering, sick child;
ever intent on the means to eliminate the illness of the afflictions,
therefore this body of his has been placed under the power of others.

Although all sentient beings undergo manifold sufferings,
by a mind turned upside down they take those sufferings to be happiness.
The Tathāgata has spoken truly of both happiness and suffering —
thus everywhere he is renowned as the one of great compassion.

Though all the world dwells in the vestibule of ignorance,
the bill of the wisdom that lays it bare and destroys it has no mouth —
the beak of the Tathāgata's gnosis has broken all of it completely —
therefore he is the eldest son among those who are to become supreme.

Because the three worlds have neither seized nor gathered him in,
he has no name; there is no conventional designation assigned by those
above.

Because he has accomplished and realized the aim of complete nirvāṇa,
the Blessed One is renowned as the One of Great Intelligence.

Though sentient beings are swept away and submerged by the river of
conditioned existence,
and through the thorough blindness of ignorance do not know the path of

escape —

the Tathāgata, himself liberated, liberates others;
therefore the Tathāgata is renowned as the Ferryman.

Because he knows all that becomes cause and effect,
he likewise realizes profoundly the work of exhaustion and cessation.
By dispensing medicine for sentient beings tormented by illness,
he is renowned throughout the world as the King of Physicians.

Non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) who follow wrong views engage in austerities,
claiming that through such conditions the highest happiness is obtained.
What the Tathāgata has taught as true happiness
will most certainly be experienced as happiness by all sentient beings.

The Tathāgata has demolished the path of wrong going,
and excellently reveals to all sentient beings the path of true reality.
Those who travel that excellent path will find happiness —
therefore the Blessed One is renowned as the Caravan Leader.

It is not made by self, nor made by another,
nor made in common, nor made by cause and condition —
what the Tathāgata has taught concerning the experience of suffering
is supreme above all the assertions of the non-Buddhists.

From the complete perfection of moral discipline, meditative absorption, and
wisdom,
he teaches that very nature of phenomena to all ordinary persons.
When performing the gift of Dharma, there is no miserliness —
therefore the Blessed One is loving-kindness without object.

Since there is no loving-kindness and no cause and condition either,
one obtains a ripening that is without cause, condition, or fruit.
Therefore all the wise and discerning
call the Tathāgata the One Without Expectation.

Though he always dwells in the company of the heedless conduct of the world,
through heedlessness toward the body he is not at all defiled.
Therefore he is called the Inconceivable,
and is not defiled even by the eight worldly concerns.

The buddha, the Blessed One, is without attachment and without aversion —
therefore his mind is always perfectly equanimous.

May the one called Lion's Roar praise his great compassion
and may the measureless lion's roar resound!

This is the eleventh chapter, being the complete inquiry by the bodhisattva called Lion's Roar, from the noble Great Sūtra of Complete Nirvāṇa (Skt. Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra).

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: The Tathāgata is compassionate toward all sentient beings: those who are untamed he tames; those who are impure he purifies; those who have no protector or refuge, him he makes their protector and refuge; and those who are not fully liberated he liberates — and being thus endowed with eight qualities of mastery, he is like a great physician, a king of medicine. Yet, Blessed One, the monk called Auspicious Star was a son born in the time when you, the Blessed One, were acting as a bodhisattva. He went forth into renunciation, maintained, retained, recited, chanted, analyzed, expounded, and explained the twelve categories of scriptural teaching, overcame the afflictions of the desire realm, and attained the four meditative concentrations. Why then did the Tathāgata prophesy that the monk Auspicious Star is one of perverted craving, the very last of all, and that even though he dwells in the hells for an entire aeon he cannot be healed?

"Why then did the Tathāgata first teach the noble Dharma, yet not afterward cause Auspicious Star to become a bodhisattva? If the Buddha, the Blessed One, was not to become a refuge and protector for Auspicious Star, on what basis does one speak of his possessing great compassion and supreme skillful means?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, consider a father and mother who have three sons. The eldest serves and honors his parents, and with his sharp faculties, once he has undertaken any worldly task, he masters it swiftly. The middle son neither accords with his parents' wishes nor has any mind for service or respect, yet with his sharp faculties, once he undertakes worldly tasks, he masters them swiftly. The youngest acts contrary to his parents' wishes, has no mind for service or respect, is dull in his faculties, and lacks understanding. If the parents are to train and educate these children, they first send into training the son whom they had trained before, the one whom they love and hold dear."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, they would first train the one who does not act contrary to his parents' wishes, who serves and honors them,

and who masters worldly tasks swiftly once he undertakes them. Then after him, the middle son and the youngest would also be taught. Though those two younger sons have no mind for service and respect, still, out of loving-kindness, they are enrolled among the students being taught."

"Son of good family, the Tathāgata is precisely like this. As for the three sons: within the category of sons, the eldest is an analogy for the bodhisattva; the middle son is an analogy for the śrāvaka; the youngest is an analogy for one of perverted craving. From among the twelve categories of scriptural teaching, I previously taught the very subtle and profound meanings to the bodhisattvas. The meanings that are less profound I taught to the śrāvakas. The worldly meanings I taught to those of perverted craving, and to those who commit the five crimes of immediate retribution, not for their immediate benefit in the present moment, but out of loving care, so that virtue may bear fruit for them in a future life.

"Son of good family, consider this: there are three kinds of field. A field where the soil is easy to work, and which has no rocks, gravel, weeds, or thorn-bushes, will yield a hundredfold. A field that has no sand, gravel, stones, weeds, or thorn-bushes, yet whose soil is difficult to work and which has not been properly irrigated, will yield only half a crop. A field where the soil is also difficult to work and which has many rocks, gravel, and thorn-bushes, so that weeds grow abundantly, will, if one plows it, yield no more than what was sown."

"Son of good family, when summer comes and it is time to plow, which field do the farmers plow first?"

The reply: "Blessed One, they first plow the excellent field, then afterward plow the other two kinds in order. Of these, the first is an analogy for the bodhisattva; the middle is an analogy for the śrāvaka; the last is an analogy for the one of perverted craving.

"Son of good family, consider this: a person has three vessels — one that is uncracked and intact, one that leaks, and one that is broken. If milk, curds, water, or butter are to be poured inside a vessel, into which one would one pour first?"

The reply: "Blessed One, one would first pour into the uncracked vessel, then into the leaking one, and then into the broken one as well. The uncracked and pure vessel is an analogy for the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas; the leaking vessel is an analogy for the Saṅgha of śrāvakas; the broken vessel is an analogy for one

of perverted craving.

"Son of good family, consider this: three sick persons come before a physician. One is easy to heal; one is difficult to heal; one cannot be healed. Son of good family, among those three patients, which one does the physician treat first?"

The reply:

"Blessed One, one would first treat the one who is easy to heal, and after that, treat the other two as well. Why so? Out of love and affection. The one who is easy to heal is an analogy for the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas; the one who is difficult to heal is an analogy for the Saṅgha of śrāvakas; the one who cannot be healed is an analogy for one of perverted craving — for even if no virtuous fruit arises in the present moment, out of love and affection one plants the seed of virtue for the world to come.

"Son of good family, consider this: a great king has three horses. One is very well-trained and powerful. One is untrained yet powerful. One is neither trained nor untrained, but aged and without strength. If the king wishes to ride, which does he mount first?"

The reply: "Blessed One, he would first mount the one that is well-trained and powerful, and after that ride the other two as well. The well-trained and powerful one is an analogy for the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas; the untrained one is an analogy for the Saṅgha of śrāvakas; the untrained and aged one is an analogy for one of perverted craving — for even though it cannot serve any benefit in this present life, out of love and affection one plants the seed of future virtue for the world to come.

"Son of good family, consider this: a great patron resolves to give to three types of persons. One is of noble lineage, with sharp faculties, and endowed with moral discipline. One is of middling lineage, with dull faculties, yet endowed with moral discipline. One is of the lowest lineage, with dull faculties, and not endowed with moral discipline. Son of good family, to which of these three does the great patron give first?"

The reply: "Blessed One, one would first give to the one of noble lineage, with sharp faculties and endowed with moral discipline, and after that give to the other two as well. The first is an analogy for the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas; the next is an analogy for the Saṅgha of śrāvakas; the last is an analogy for one of perverted craving.

"Son of good family, just as the lion, king of beasts, when slaying a great musk elephant, brings to bear his full strength and power, and when slaying a rabbit does likewise — he does not use merely a small breath — so too the Blessed One the buddha is just like that: in teaching the Dharma to bodhisattvas and to those of perverted craving alike, his effort is without distinction between the two.

"Son of good family, once in former times, when I was residing in Rājagṛha, the monk Śubhakarā (Legs pa'i skar ma) served as my attendant. At that time, in the first part of the night, I was teaching the holy Dharma to Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods. Since my attendant was obliged to inform me of the time, on that occasion I was detained at length, and the monk Śubhakarā conceived ill will toward me. Now at that time in Rājagṛha, small children were crying, and could not be quieted. Their parents, wishing to frighten them into silence, threatened: 'If you do not stop crying, we will hand you over to the hungry ghost Bakula.' And with that threat the crying would cease. At that time the monk Śubhakarā threatened me in just this way, saying: 'Please go quickly to your dwelling — the hungry ghost Bakula is coming!' I then declared to him: 'You utter fool — have you not heard that the Blessed One the buddha knows no fear?' At that, Śakra, lord of the gods, addressed me thus:"

"Blessed One, will a person such as this find a place within the buddhas' Dharma?" Having asked this, I declared to him: "Kauśika, this person too finds a place within the buddhas' Dharma, and because the nature of a buddha is present within him, he will attain the unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

Now, I taught the sacred Dharma to the monk Śubhakarā, yet he had not the slightest mind of faith or receptivity toward it.

Noble son, once upon a time, when I was dwelling in the city called Śīpā in the land of Kāśī, the monk Śubhakarā was serving as my attendant. At that time, as I was minded to go into that city for alms, an immeasurable number of sentient beings dwelling there longed to see me, burning with thirst as it were in their devotion. The monk Śubhakarā, wishing to sweep behind me as I walked and to make me invisible to them, and being unable to make me invisible, caused many sentient beings to give rise to unwholesome thoughts.

At that time, as I entered the city, I saw before the door of a tavern a naked man who had stripped his body bare and was eating grass. The monk Śubhakarā saw him too and said to me: "Blessed One, if there were an arhat in

this world, this man would be the foremost among them. Why so? Because this man has no cause and no effect." I replied to him: "You fool — have you not heard that an arhat does not drink alcohol, does not harm others, does not deceive those around him, does not take what is not given, and does not engage in sexual misconduct? This man has even killed his own parents and eats grass — how could he be called an arhat? This man, immediately upon leaving the body, will without doubt fall into the avīci hell, the hell of uninterrupted torment. An arhat is one who has utterly cut off the three lower destinies — why do you call this man an arhat?"

Śubhākara then responded: "It is possible for the four great elements to change, yet there is no basis for saying that this man will fall into the avīci hell." I said to him: "You fool — have you not heard that the Blessed One, the buddha, speaks the truth without duality?" And so, though I taught the sacred Dharma to Śubhākara in this way, there was not the slightest mind of faith or receptivity in him toward it.

Noble son, I was also at one time dwelling in Rājagṛha together with the monk Śubhākara. At that time in Rājagṛha there was a naked ascetic called Duḥkhabhava — "Born-of-Suffering" — who constantly proclaimed: "The afflictions of sentient beings have no cause and no condition, and the liberation of sentient beings likewise has no cause and no condition." At that time the monk Śubhākara again said to me: "Blessed One, if there were an arhat in this world, this naked ascetic called Duḥkhabhava would be the foremost." I replied: "You fool — Duḥkhabhava the naked ascetic is not a true arhat, nor has he been liberated through the awakening of an arhat."

Śubhākara then said to me: "Why does an arhat harbor envy toward an arhat?" I replied: "You fool — I have no envy toward any arhat. It is you yourself who have given rise to a wicked wrong view that will bring you to ruin. Look at your claim that this naked ascetic is an arhat — within seven days he will be struck by an illness of indigestion and will die of it, his belly distended."

After death he would also be reborn as a hungry ghost that feeds on vomit. His corpse would be lifted by fellow students and carried off to the charnel ground.

At that time Śubhākara went to where Duḥkhabhava the naked ascetic was lying ill and said to him: "Venerable one, do you know? The ascetic Gautama has now prophesied that within seven days you will be struck by an illness of indigestion, that your belly will be distended, and that you will die of it; and that after death you will be reborn as a hungry ghost that feeds on vomit, and

that your fellow students and your fellow disciples will lift your corpse and carry it off to the charnel ground."

Having heard this prophecy, the venerable one thought very carefully about every possible means to prevent it from coming true, and resolved by whatever means to make the ascetic Gautama out to be a liar. At that time, Duḥkhabhava, having heard Śubhākara speak those words, refused to eat, and from the first day through the sixth day ate absolutely nothing. When the seventh day had passed in full, he ate some raw sugar. After eating the raw sugar, he drank cold water. The moment he drank the cold water, his belly became distended and he died. After his death his fellow students lifted his corpse and carried it off to the charnel ground; and having become a hungry ghost that feeds on vomit, he remained beside the corpse.

The monk Śubhākara, having heard that things had turned out in this way, went to the charnel ground where the corpse lay. When he arrived there, he saw that the body of Duḥkhabhava had become the body of a hungry ghost that feeds on vomit and was crouching beside the corpse.

The Noble Great Sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa. The forty-fourth fascicle.

Śubhākara said: "Are you dead?" Duḥkhabhava replied: "I am dead." He asked: "How did you die?" He replied: "I died of a distended belly." He asked: "Then who brought your corpse here?" He replied: "Fellow students brought it." He asked: "And where did they bring it?" He replied: "You fool — do you not know this is a charnel ground?" He asked: "And what kind of body have you obtained?" He replied: "I have become a body that feeds on vomit."

Duḥkhabhava continued: "Śubhākara, listen well. The Tathāgata speaks what is wholesome, speaks what is true, speaks at the proper time, speaks what is meaningful, speaks in accordance with the Dharma. Śubhākara — since the Tathāgata spoke in such a truthful way, why did you not believe it at the time? Any sentient being who does not believe what the Tathāgata has truthfully declared will experience a body like mine."

At that time Śubhākara came to where I was and addressed me thus: "Blessed One, the naked ascetic Duḥkhabhava has passed away and been reborn as a god among the thirty-three." I said to him: "You fool — an arhat has no place of rebirth; so why do you say that Duḥkhabhava has been reborn as a god among the thirty-three?" He replied: "It is just as the Blessed One said: the naked Duḥkhabhava was not truly reborn as a god among the thirty-three — he has

become a hungry ghost that feeds on vomit." I said to him: "You fool — everything the Blessed Buddha has declared is without duality; there is no basis for saying that what the Tathāgata has declared admits of duality."

The Blessed One then declared: Śubhākara said: "Even though the Tathāgata spoke those words at that time, I myself did not have faith in them."

Noble son, I always taught the holy Dharma to the monk Śubhākara, and yet not even this much arose in him — a mind that had faith and took it to heart. Noble son, the monk Śubhākara, while reciting and intoning the twelve branches of scripture,

although he had attained the four meditative concentrations, he understood not even the meaning of a single verse, a single phrase, or a single syllable from his youth. By associating with a spiritual friend who was evil and unwholesome, he lost even the four meditative concentrations. When the concentrations were lost, he gave rise to wrong views, saying: "There is no buddha, there is no Dharma, there is no nirvāṇa. The ascetic Gautama was supremely skilled in the rites of astrology and sign-reading, and so he came to know the minds of others." At that time I declared to the monk Śubhākara the following: "The Dharma I have taught and proclaimed is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end, of excellent meaning, of excellent wording, unmixed, complete and perfect, the conduct of purity, thoroughly pure." And yet the monk Śubhākara said to me: "Although the Tathāgata has taught the Dharma to me, in ultimate truth there is neither cause nor effect." Noble son, if you do not place trust in this matter as it has been described, then know that the monk Śubhākara is even now sitting on the bank of the river Nairāñjanā — go there and ask him directly. Thereupon the Tathāgata, accompanied by Kāśyapa, went to where Śubhākara was. When the monk Śubhākara saw the Blessed One approaching from afar, he gave rise to an unwholesome state of mind. Having given rise to that unwholesome mind, right then and there he fell headlong into the avīci hell, the realm of uninterrupted torment.

Noble son, the monk Śubhākara entered the teaching of the Buddha and received incalculable heaps of precious jewels, and yet he obtained nothing at all. Because of his heedlessness, because of his association with an evil spiritual friend, from his youth he did not obtain even the slightest benefit of a single teaching. It is just like a man who enters the ocean and beholds many heaps of precious jewels, yet through the power of laziness fails to take any in

hand. Or again, like one who enters the ocean and beholds heaps of precious jewels, yet dies or is slain by a vicious demon — so too was the monk Śubhākara. He entered the teaching of the Buddha, yet was slain by an evil spiritual friend, like a vicious demon. Noble son, for this reason the Tathāgata, out of compassionate love, declared that the monk Śubhākara was heedless.

Noble son, toward one who was formerly poor, one may feel a compassionate thought, yet that compassion does not reach its fullest depth. But toward one who formerly possessed wealth and resources, and later has lost them and fallen into poverty — toward such a one compassion is indeed most profound. So too it is with the monk Śubhākara: he upheld, preserved, recited, and read aloud the twelve branches of scripture, and had attained the four meditative concentrations — to have then fallen from those concentrations is cause for the deepest compassion. Thus I have declared that the monk Śubhākara is utterly heedless. Because of his heedlessness he completely severed all roots of virtue, and so whoever sees or hears of him as one who has become an object of fault in my presence — toward such a one, without exception, a mind of most profound compassionate love must arise, just as compassion arises upon seeing someone who once possessed wealth and resources later seen without them.

For many years I dwelt together with Śubhākara, and throughout that time he continuously gave rise to unwholesome states of mind toward me. Having given rise to those unwholesome minds, he never abandoned his wrong views.

Son of good family, if from the very beginning I saw not even a hair's tip of a root of virtue in Śubhākara, then he would be one holding a wrong view that has utterly severed all roots of virtue, and he would dwell in the hell realm for an entire aeon — this is what scripture teaches. Because he speaks declaring that there is no cause, no result, and no karmic action, he is one holding a wrong view that has utterly severed all roots of virtue, and scripture prophesies that he will dwell in the hell realm for an aeon.

Son of good family, consider this example: a man has fallen into a pit of filth, and a friend, thinking to draw him out, reaches down and grasps him by the hair. If he can take hold of the hair, he then pulls him out. But if he cannot grasp the hair and nothing appears to grip at all, his intention to pull the man out subsides. I am like this as well: having searched for whatever little root of virtue existed in Śubhākara and having found none whatsoever, had I then undertaken to rescue him, he would at all times have had not even a hair's tip

of a root of virtue, and so he would not have been rescued from the hell realm.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, Tathāgata, for what reason did you prophesy that Śubhākara would fall into the Avīci hell realm?"

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, the monk Śubhākara had many spiritual friends and a large retinue. All of those followers of Śubhākara were arhats, and because they held him to be one who had attained the fruit of awakening, in order to destroy that wrong view they harbored toward him, it was prophesied that Śubhākara, through heedlessness, would fall into the hell realm.

Son of good family, you should know that what the Tathāgata has spoken is truly and without exception non-dual. Why? Because if the Tathāgata has prophesied that someone will fall into the hell realm, there is no instance of that person not falling into the hell realm. The prophecies of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, on the other hand, are of two kinds: some are true, and some are false. For example, when Maudgalyāyana was dwelling in the central lands, he prophesied to all the people of that region, "In seven days rain will fall," but afterward no rain fell. He prophesied to a young pregnant woman, "A white calf will be born," but a spotted calf was born instead. He prophesied, "A boy will be born," but afterward a girl was born.

Son of good family, the monk Śubhākara constantly proclaimed to countless sentient beings in every respect: "There is no fruit of either virtue or evil." At that time, all roots of virtue were utterly severed, without so much as a hair's tip remaining. Son of good family, I knew from the beginning that the monk Śubhākara had no roots of virtue, and yet I dwelt together with him for a full twenty years and shared life in common with him. If I had completely abandoned him and not kept him near, left or right, then that Śubhākara would have led countless sentient beings into sinful and non-virtuous actions. This is what is meant by the Tathāgata possessing the power of omniscient knowledge.

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, why is it said that one with wrong views lacks virtuous qualities?"

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is because one with wrong views has utterly severed all roots of virtue. While all sentient beings possess the five faculties beginning with faith, in one with wrong views these are entirely severed. Therefore, even killing a worm incurs a fault, yet killing one with wrong views incurs no fault of wrongdoing.

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, is it because one with wrong views lacks virtuous qualities that they are called one with wrong views?"

The Blessed One declared: It is exactly so. It is exactly so.

Kāśyapa asked:

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, virtue in all sentient beings has three aspects: past, future, and present. If one with wrong views has not severed the future virtuous Dharma, then why is it said that their virtuous Dharma is severed and they are called one with wrong views?"

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, severance has two aspects: being blocked in the present, and the future being obscured by the present obscuration. Because those with wrong views possess both kinds of severance, I have declared that they have utterly severed their roots of virtue.

Son of good family, consider this analogy: a person who has fallen into a cesspit is visible only up to a single hair-tip. Though a single hair-tip has not yet sunk, that single hair-tip is not enough to support the body. Those with wrong views are likewise. In the future there may exist a root of virtue, yet they will not be freed from the suffering of the hell-beings. Though they may be liberated at a future time, in the present there is nothing whatsoever to be done, and so they cannot be liberated now. They will, however, be liberated through the cause and condition of the intrinsic nature of the buddhas. The intrinsic nature of the buddhas is neither past, nor future, nor present; therefore the intrinsic nature of the buddhas cannot be severed. Just as no sprout can grow from a rotted seed, those with wrong views are similar in that respect.

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if those with wrong views have not severed the intrinsic nature of the buddhas, and if the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is itself virtuous, why then is it said that they have severed all virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, any sentient being who presently possesses the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is not to be called one with wrong views — just as there is a conventional designation of a self applied to sentient beings in the world. If the intrinsic nature of the buddhas were permanent, it would be outside the three times; but if it fell within the three times, it would be called impermanent. Since the intrinsic nature of the buddhas will be seen at a future time, I have declared that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of the buddhas. Therefore it is seen to some small

degree by a bodhisattva of the tenth ground who is endowed with the most excellent array of qualities.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is permanent, like the sky, why has the Tathāgata called it future?"

If the Tathāgata declares that those with wrong views lack virtuous Dharma, does not loving-kindness and affection arise in one who shares the training, or shares the teacher, or the father, or the mother, or friends and companions, or the wife, or the children of one with wrong views? And if it does arise, is that not itself virtue?

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, that was very well asked. The intrinsic nature of the buddhas is like the sky — it is neither past, nor future, nor present. All sentient beings also have a body of three aspects: past, future, and present. Since sentient beings will see the intrinsic nature of the buddhas in the future through karma of perfect purity and excellence of array, I have therefore spoken of the intrinsic nature of the buddhas as future.

Son of good family, for the sake of ordinary persons I have at certain times declared that the cause is the fruit, and at other times I have declared that the fruit is the cause. Therefore, in the sūtras it is said that food is life, and seeing form is touch" — just so, because the body will become perfectly pure in the future, it is spoken of as the intrinsic nature of the buddhas.

The questioner asked: Blessed One, if the matter is as the Blessed One has declared, then why did you say that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of the buddhas?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, although the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is not present in sentient beings at this present time, it is not fitting to say it is absent. For example, although sky is not present in the present moment, it is not fitting to say it is absent. All sentient beings are impermanent, yet the intrinsic nature of the buddhas is permanent, unchanging, and unwavering. Therefore I have declared in this sūtra that the intrinsic nature of the buddhas in sentient beings is neither within nor without — like the sky, it is neither within nor without. If sky had an inside and an outside, it would not be fitting to call it one or permanent, nor would it be fitting to say it exists in all places. Sky is neither within nor without, and yet it is present in all sentient beings; the intrinsic nature of the buddhas in sentient

beings is likewise the same.

As for what you say — that those with wrong craving possess virtuous phenomena — that is not the meaning. Why? Because for those with wrong craving, all actions of body, speech, and mind, actions of taking, actions of giving, actions of seeking, actions of knowing, and all other such actions are entirely wrong actions. Why is that? Because they hold no hope in cause and result.

Son of good family, consider this example: just as the āruṇa plant passes through sprout, leaf, trunk, branch, flower, and fruit — like the whiteness of snow throughout all of these — so too are the non-virtuous actions of those with wrong craving like that throughout.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata possesses the power of knowing the faculties of beings; therefore he knows with great precision the sharp, middling, and dull faculties of all sentient beings. He thoroughly understands which sentient beings will decline from middling to dull faculties, which will rise from middling to sharp, which will decline from sharp to middling, and which will fall from middling to dull. Therefore there is no certainty regarding the faculties of sentient beings. Because there is no certainty, some, having cut the root of virtue, will be reborn again. If the faculties of sentient beings were fixed, then from the very beginning there would be no cutting, and having cut they would not be reborn — yet it is declared that those with wrong craving fall into a hell realm for the duration of an entire eon, which would be contradictory.

Son of good family, therefore the Tathāgata has declared that all phenomena lack any defining characteristic that is fixed.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, the Tathāgata possesses the power of knowing the faculties. If he knew that the monk Suvarṇakāra had entirely severed the root of virtue, then why did he grant him the going forth?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, long ago when I myself went forth, I permitted my younger brothers Nanda, Upananda, Devadatta, and my son Rāhula, and all the others to go forth after me and to apply themselves diligently to the path. If I had not let Suvarṇakāra go forth, he would have gained a royal means and, being endowed with might and power, would have entirely destroyed the Dharma of the buddhas. For this cause, by this condition, I let him go forth and permitted him to apply himself diligently to the path. Son of good family, even if the monk Suvarṇakāra had not gone

forth, he would still have cut the root of virtue and for incalculable lifetimes would have been deprived of benefit and happiness.

Now, having gone forth, even though he had cut the root of virtue, he would keep moral discipline, show reverence to elders, teachers, and those endowed with good qualities, and would cultivate the meditative concentrations, training in them from the first through to the fourth. This, too, is called a wholesome cause. And from that wholesome cause, wholesome phenomena would arise. When wholesome phenomena have arisen, he would apply himself diligently to awakening. And having applied himself diligently to awakening, he would attain the unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening. For this reason, I permitted the monk Suvarṇakāra to go forth. Son of good family, had I not permitted the monk Suvarṇakāra to go forth while keeping his moral discipline, it could not be said that the Tathāgata is endowed with the ten powers.

Son of good family, when a sentient being possesses roots of virtue yet is also endowed with unwholesome phenomena, and when that person is possessed of both, I understand that before long he will completely sever the root of virtue and come to be possessed of the root of non-virtue. Why is this? Because such a being does not rely on a spiritual friend, does not listen to the sacred Dharma, applies his mind to what is unwholesome, and does not apply his mind properly. For this cause, by this condition, he cuts the root of virtue and comes to be possessed of the root of non-virtue.

Son of good family, furthermore, the Tathāgata sees that if that same person, at the present time or in time to come, whether in youth, in the prime of life, or in old age, were to rely on a spiritual friend and were to hear and hold the sacred Dharma of suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path, then his root of virtue would arise again.

Son of good family, consider this example: near a town there is a sweet spring endowed with eight excellent qualities. If those who are thirsty and tormented by heat were to head toward that spring, then a wise and discerning person would have no doubt that those tormented by thirst would certainly reach the spring. Why? Because there is no other way. The Blessed One, the buddha, regards ordinary beings in exactly the same way. Therefore the Tathāgata is said to be endowed with the power of knowing the faculties.

Then the Blessed One took up a little handful of earth and placed it on his fingernail, and asked Kāśyapa: "Which is more, the earth of the world-realms

of the ten directions, or the earth I have placed on my fingernail?"

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, the earth upon the fingernail is not to be compared with the earth of the world-realms of the ten directions."

Son of good family, obtaining a human body from a human body, leaving behind the bodies of the three lower destinies to obtain a human body with its faculties complete, being born in a central land, applying oneself diligently to awakening with genuine faith, and then, having applied oneself diligently to awakening, applying oneself diligently to the genuine path, and then, having applied oneself diligently to the genuine path, attaining liberation, and then, having attained liberation, passing beyond sorrow — this is comparable to the earth placed upon the fingernail.

Falling from a human body into the three lower destinies, passing from the three lower destinies into yet another body of the three lower destinies, having faculties that are incomplete, being born in a border region, placing one's trust in wrong and evil views, and applying oneself diligently to the path of evil views so that one does not attain liberation, the permanence and bliss of passing beyond sorrow — this is comparable to the earth of the world-realms of the ten directions.

Son of good family, keeping moral discipline in its full purity, being free of laziness through diligence, not transgressing the four root precepts,

not committing the five acts of immediate retribution, not misappropriating the property of the Saṅgha, not engaging in actions born of wrong craving, not cutting the roots of virtue, and placing one's trust in the sūtras of nirvāṇa and the like — this is comparable to the earth of the palm of the hand.

Allowing one's moral discipline to degenerate through laziness, transgressing the four root precepts, committing the offenses of the five acts of immediate retribution, freely misappropriating the property of the Saṅgha, engaging in actions born of wrong craving, cutting the roots of virtue, and not placing one's trust in these sūtras — this is comparable to the earth of the world-realms of the ten directions.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata is supremely skilled in understanding the superior, middling, and inferior faculties of all sentient beings. Therefore the Tathāgata is said to be possessed of the power of being skilled in the five faculties.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, since the Blessed One is possessed of the power of being skilled in the faculties, he knows fully all distinctions of superior, middling, inferior, sharp, and dull among the faculties of all sentient beings. He knows the faculties of sentient beings of the present time and also the faculties of sentient beings of the future. After the Blessed One has passed completely into nirvāṇa, those sentient beings will speak in the following ways.

Some will say that the Tathāgata has passed completely and finally into nirvāṇa. Some will say that he has not finally passed completely into nirvāṇa. Some will say that a self exists. Some will say that no self exists. Some will assert that the five aggregates exist. Some will assert that the five aggregates do not exist. Some will assert that there is return. Some will assert that there is no return. Some will say that the body of the Tathāgata is conditioned. Some will say that the body of the Tathāgata is unconditioned. Some will say that the twelve links of dependent origination are conditioned phenomena. Some will say that the twelve links of dependent origination are unconditioned. Some will say that mind is permanent. Some will say that mind is impermanent. Some will say that the pleasures of the five sense desires obstruct the noble path. Some will say that they do not obstruct it. Some will say that the supreme worldly dharma belongs to the desire realm alone. Some will say that it belongs to all three realms. Some will say that generosity is nothing but a mental action. Some will say that it is the five aggregates themselves. Some will assert that there are three unconditioned phenomena. Some will assert that there are no three unconditioned phenomena. Again, some will say that form is something made. Some will say that there is no made form. Some will assert that there is form that is not made. Some will assert that there is no form that is not made. Some will assert that mind-arisen phenomena exist. Some will assert that mind-arisen phenomena do not exist. Some will assert that there are five modes of existence. Some will assert that there are six modes of existence. Some will say that a lay practitioner can perfectly fulfil the eight precepts. Some will say that they can be fulfilled even without perfecting them. Some will say that even though a monk has broken the four root precepts, his monastic discipline still exists. Some will say that it does not exist. Some will say that stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, and arhats all attain manifest awakening. Some will say that they do not attain manifest awakening. Some will say that the nature of a buddha exists within sentient beings. Some will say that the nature of a buddha is other than

sentient beings."

Some will say that the nature of a buddha exists in all beings without exception, including those who have broken the four root precepts, committed the five acts of immediate retribution, and fallen into wrong craving and the like. Some will say that it does not exist. Some will say that buddhas exist in the ten directions. Some will say that buddhas do not exist in the ten directions. If the Tathāgata possesses the power of knowing the faculties of beings, why then has he not spoken definitively on these matters?

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Kāśyapaputra: Son of good family, this matter is not known through eye-consciousness, nor through any of the remaining forms of consciousness up to and including mind-consciousness. It can be known through wisdom. To one who is learned and possessed of wisdom, I have spoken without duality, and such a person understands that I have spoken without duality. To one without wisdom, I have spoken in an indefinite way, and that person without wisdom understands that I have spoken in an indefinite way.

Son of good family, all the virtuous teachings of the Tathāgata are spoken for the purpose of training sentient beings. Consider a skilled physician: every branch of his medical art and practice is directed toward healing all those who are afflicted with illness.

Son of good family, the Buddha, the Blessed One, expounds a single teaching in two aspects, and a single Dharma name in innumerable names, and a single meaning in innumerable names, and innumerable meanings in immeasurable names — for the sake of a given field of beings, for the sake of a given time, for the sake of those who speak to others, for the sake of showing it to non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), and for the sake of the varying capacities of beings.

As to how a single name is expounded in innumerable names: nirvāṇa, for example, is called nirvāṇa; it is also called birthlessness; it is also called non-arising; it is also called non-action; it is also called the unconditioned; it is also called the going for refuge; it is also called ground and support; it is also called complete liberation; it is also called luminous radiance; it is also called the lamp; it is also called the ultimate; it is also called fearlessness; it is also called the irreversible; it is also called the abode of bliss; it is also called peace; it is also called signlessness; it is also called non-duality; it is also called the single conduct; it is also called perfect coolness; it is also called the absence of darkness; it is also called unobstructedness; it is also called

freedom from conflict; it is also called the great expanse; it is also called clarity and freshness; it is also called auspiciousness. This is how a single name is unfolded into innumerable names.

As to how a single referent is expounded in innumerable names: consider Śakra, the lord of the gods. He is called Śakra; he is also called Kauśika; he is also called Vāsava; he is also called Purandara; he is also called Maghavān; he is also called Indra; he is also called the Thousand-Eyed; he is also called the husband of Śacī; he is also called Vajra; he is also called the Crest Jewel; he is also called the Jewelled Victory Banner. This is what is meant by a single referent being expounded in innumerable names.

As to how innumerable referents are expounded in innumerable names: consider the Blessed One, the Buddha. He is called Tathāgata — a distinct meaning, a distinct name. He is also called arhat — a distinct meaning, a distinct name. He is also called the Perfectly and Fully Awakened One — a distinct meaning, a distinct name. He is also called the Ferryman; he is also called the Caravan Leader; he is also called Buddha, the Awakened One; he is also called One Endowed with Knowledge and Conduct; he is also called the Lion King; he is also called the Wandering Ascetic (śramaṇa); he is also called the Brahmin; he is also called the Peaceful One; he is also called the Great Benefactor; he is also called the Perfected One; he is also called the Great King of Physicians;

He is also called the Great King of Bulls; he is also called the Great King of Nāgas; he is also called the Giver of Eyes; he is also called the Greatly Powerful One; he is also called the One of Great Fearlessness; he is also called the Assembly of Precious Ones; he is also called the Merchant; he is also called the One Who Has Attained Liberation; he is also called the Great Person; he is also called the Teacher of Gods and Humans; he is also called the Great White Lotus; he is also called the Solitary One Without Companions; he is also called the Great Field of Merit; he is also called the Ocean of Wisdom; he is also called the One Without Characteristics; he is also called the One Endowed with the Eight Gnoses — all of these are distinct meanings and distinct names. Noble son, this is called "the exposition of countless names from countless meanings."

Furthermore, there is also an exposition of countless names from a single meaning. What is that? For example, the aggregates (skandhas) are also called "aggregates"; they are also called "the inverted"; they are also called

"the true"; they are also called "the four applications of mindfulness"; they are also called "the four defilements"; they are also called "the bases of the four consciousnesses"; they are also called "the conditioned"; they are also called "the path"; they are also called "time"; they are also called "sentient beings"; they are also called "conventional"; they are also called "ultimate"; they are also called "the cultivation of body, ethical conduct, and mind"; they are also called "cause and result"; they are also called "mental affliction"; they are also called "liberation"; they are also called "the twelve links of dependent origination"; they are also called "śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas"; they are also called "hell-beings, hungry ghosts, animals, humans, and gods"; they are also called "past, future, and present." This is the exposition of countless names from a single meaning.

Noble son, the Buddha, the Blessed One, for the sake of sentient beings teaches the extensive from the condensed, and teaches the extensive in condensed form. He teaches the ultimate as the conventional, and teaches the conventional phenomena as the ultimate.

How, then, does he teach the extensive from the condensed? For example, just as I have explained to the monks the twelve links of dependent origination — and what are those twelve links of dependent origination? They are, it was said, "cause and result."

How, then, does he teach the condensed in an extensive way? For example, just as I have explained to the monks today suffering, its origin, its cessation, and the path. Therein, suffering is this: the immeasurable sufferings. The origin is this: the immeasurable mental afflictions. Cessation is this: the immeasurable liberations. The path is this: the immeasurable skillful means.

How, then, does he teach the ultimate as conventional? For example, just as he declared to the monks, "This body of mine is subject to aging, sickness, and death."

How, then, does he teach the conventional as ultimate? For example, just as when he said to Kauṇḍinya, "Because you have heard the meaning of the Dharma, you are named Kauṇḍinya" — since he knew the person as they were, the mind as it was, and the time as it was, the Tathāgata is therefore said to be endowed with the power of knowing the faculties.

Noble son, if I were to explain those meanings definitively and precisely in every case, then I could no longer be called a Tathāgata endowed with the power of knowing the faculties. Noble son, wise men know that a load of

fragrant bull's wool is not something a donkey can carry. The modes of conduct of all sentient beings are without number, and therefore the Tathāgata has taught the Dharma in countless forms and varieties. Why is that? Because sentient beings have many kinds of mental afflictions. If the Tathāgata were to teach a single mode of conduct, then he could not be called the Tathāgata endowed with the power of knowing the faculties.

For this reason, in other sūtras I have explained that it is not fitting to teach five types of Dharma to five types of sentient being. To one who lacks faith, genuine faith is not to be praised. To one of poor moral discipline, restraint of ethical conduct is not to be praised. To one who is miserly, generosity is not to be praised. To one who is lazy, extensive learning is not to be praised. To one who is deluded, wisdom is not to be praised.

Why is that? If wise persons were to teach those five things to those five types of individual, such teaching would merit neither the name of being endowed with the power of knowing the faculties, nor the name of having compassion for sentient beings. Why? Because those five types of individual, upon hearing those five things, would give rise to minds of faithlessness, ill will, and anger. Through that cause and that condition, the fruit of suffering would ripen for them across countless lifetimes. Therefore one could not be called compassionate toward sentient beings or endowed with the power of knowing the faculties.

For this reason, in an earlier sūtra I said to Śāriputra: "Do not teach the Dharma at length to one of sharp faculties, and do not teach the Dharma in brief summary to one of dull faculties." Śāriputra then replied: "Blessed One, it is because of compassion that I taught it. It was not through being endowed with the power of knowing the faculties."

Noble son, teaching the Dharma in full detail or in brief summary belongs to the domain of a buddha. It is not something understood by śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. Noble son, what you said — that after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, his close attendants will each explain things separately and in different ways — these are persons who, through wrong understanding, have not obtained the correct view. Therefore they are unable to benefit either themselves or others.

Noble son, those sentient beings are not uniform in their intrinsic nature, their conduct, their faculties, their objects of engagement, or their spiritual friends. Therefore the Tathāgata has taught them the Dharma in its many modes and

varieties. It is for this cause and through this condition that the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the ten directions and the three times also open and teach the twelve branches of scriptural teaching for the sake of sentient beings. Noble son, the Tathāgata's teaching of these twelve branches of scripture was not for his own benefit but for the benefit of others. Therefore the fifth power of the Tathāgata is called the power of knowledge.

By reason of these two powers, the Tathāgata fully discerns: this one severs the roots of virtue in this life; this one severs the roots of virtue in a future life; this one attains liberation in this very life; and this one will attain liberation in a future life. Therefore the Tathāgata is called the great power unsurpassed by any.

Noble son, whoever says "The Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa forever" or "The Tathāgata never passes into nirvāṇa" — such a person says so because they do not understand the intention of the Tathāgata.

Noble son, in the fragrant sandalwood forest there dwelt thirty-eight thousand sages. All of them had, in times past, generated roots of virtue under the buddha Kāśyapa, yet they had not entered the correct path, paid homage to the buddhas, or listened to the sacred Dharma. For the sake of those sages, the Tathāgata declared to Ānanda: "Three months from now I shall pass completely into nirvāṇa." When the gods heard those words, the news spread from one to another and it became known throughout the fragrant sandalwood forest.

When the sages heard this, a mind of deep remorse arose in them and they said: "Why were we born as human beings yet failed to pay homage to a buddha? The arising of the blessed buddhas in this world is as rare as the udumbara flower. Let us go now into the presence of the Blessed One and listen to the sacred Dharma." And so they spoke.

Noble son, at that time thirty-eight thousand sages came into my presence, and I taught the Dharma to them just as it needed to be taught. "O great beings, form is impermanent. Why so? Because the causes and conditions of form are impermanent. If form arises from impermanent causes, can form possibly be called permanent?" The teaching should be understood to extend in the same way through to consciousness. Having heard those teachings, the sages attained the fruit of arhatship in that very instant.

Noble son, in the city of Kuśinagara there lived some thirty thousand wrestlers who were independent and ungoverned, and they were drunk with pride and

arrogance over their bodies, their strength, their long lives, and their wealth. Noble son, in order to tame those wrestlers, I said to the son of Maudgala: "Subdue those wrestlers." Then, following my word, the son of Maudgala employed many and various skillful means for five years, yet not a single wrestler was tamed or persuaded to listen to the Dharma.

Then, for the sake of those wrestlers, I declared to Ānanda: "Three months from now I shall pass completely into nirvāṇa." Noble son, when those wrestlers heard these words they assembled and prepared the road. Three months passed, and at that time I traveled from Vaiśālī to the city of Kuśinagara. When I had gone about half the way, I saw from afar that the wrestlers had assembled, and I emanated the form of a monk, went in among all the wrestlers, and said: "Fellows, what are you doing?" When the wrestlers heard these words they were all enraged and said: "Monk, how dare you call us fellows?" I replied: "You are fellows indeed — some thirty thousand of you assembled, straining with all the strength you have, yet unable to move even this little stone. Is 'fellows' not the right word for you?" The wrestlers said: "If you call us fellows, then we know you must be a great man."

Noble son, at that point I lifted the stone with my two toes. When the wrestlers saw such a thing, they generated the perception of themselves as weak, inferior, and worthless, and then said again: "Monk, can you cast this stone to one side of the road?" I replied: "Fellows, why are you preparing this road?" The wrestlers said: "Monk, do you not know? The Tathāgata Śākyamuni is coming along this road on his way to pass completely into nirvāṇa in the sal grove — that is why and on that account we are preparing the road." Then I praised them: "Excellent! Excellent! Fellows, since you have thus generated a wholesome mind, I will make this stone disappear for your sake." Saying this, I took the stone in my hand and hurled it until it reached the pinnacle of existence.

Then, when the wrestlers saw the stone touch the sky, they were all filled with fear and terror and fled in the four directions, whereupon I said: "Wrestlers, do not generate a mind of fear and terror — do not scatter and run away." The wrestlers said: "Monk, if you would be our refuge, then we shall be at peace."

Then I took the stone and placed it in the palm of my right hand. The wrestlers, seeing this, felt joy arise in their minds and said: "Monk, is this stone permanent or impermanent?" Thereupon I blew on that stone with a single breath from my mouth and turned it to dust. When the wrestlers saw this, they

said to the monk, "This stone is impermanent," and a mind of shame and deep regret arose in them, and they were struck with remorse, thinking: "Why did we take pride in our form, our strength, our lifespan, and our wealth, and generate minds of conceit and arrogance?" Knowing their minds, I sent forth a magical body, assumed an ordinary appearance, and taught the Dharma. When the wrestlers saw this, every one of them generated a mind of awakening.

Noble son, in the city of Kuśanagara there was a craftsman named Cunda who had made a great vow before the buddha Kāśyapa: "When the Tathāgata Śākyamuni passes into nirvāṇa, I will offer the last meal from within my household." For this reason, while I was in Vaiśālī, I summoned the monk Upavāna and declared: "Noble son, three months from now I shall pass into nirvāṇa at the foot of a tree in the city of Kuśanagara. See to it that Cunda is informed."

Noble son, in Rājagṛha there was a wandering ascetic (ṛṣi) of the five higher knowledges named Subhadra, one hundred and twenty years of age, who constantly proclaimed: "I am omniscient," and harbored great pride. In a former time he had planted roots of virtue before immeasurable buddhas. In order to tame him, I told Ānanda: "Three months from now I shall pass into nirvāṇa," and declared this aloud. When Subhadra heard this, he came to where I was and generated a mind of faith and reverence. I taught him the Dharma in its many aspects, and upon hearing it he attained the undefiled.

Noble son, Prince Ajātaśatru, son of King Bimbisāra, through conditions of evil influence from Devadatta, developed an evil mind and brought about the killing of his royal father — yet he found no opportunity to harm me. Devadatta, that wicked one, had also through the condition of his past karma generated an unwholesome mind toward me and, wishing to harm me, cultivated the five higher knowledges and quickly attained them. He then became an intimate friend and companion of Prince Ajātaśatru, and for the sake of the prince displayed all manner of miraculous powers — entering through solid walls and emerging through doors, entering through doors and emerging through solid walls, and at times appearing in the forms of elephants, horses, cattle, sheep, men, and women. When Prince Ajātaśatru saw all of this, a mind of faith, joy, and delight arose in him. On account of this he made offerings with many kinds of offering substances, and then said: "Noble teacher, I wish to see the Mandārava flowers." Thereupon Devadatta ascended to the Heaven of the Thirty-Three and solicited flowers from those

gods. But because Devadatta's merit was exhausted, not one of them gave him any. Having thus failed to obtain the flowers, he thought: "What fault would there be if I, with no one to give them to me, were to take the Mandārava tree for myself?" Drawing near and reaching out to take it, his supernatural powers instantly vanished. He found himself looking back to see his own body sitting in Rājagṛha, and a mind of shame and embarrassment arose, so that he was unable to face Prince Ajātaśatru. Then he thought: "Now let me go to where the Tathāgata is and muster a large retinue."

He thought: "If the Buddha grants this, I myself will be in charge of teaching the Dharma as I please to Śāriputra and the others." Then Devadatta came to where I was and said: "Tathāgata, entrust all these great multitudes to me. I will teach them the Dharma in many different ways and tame them."

I declared: "Fool! Śāriputra and the others are sharp in their faculties and endowed with great wisdom, and even though the whole world holds them in esteem, I would not entrust the great multitudes to them — what need is there to speak of entrusting them to you, a deluded wretch who eats filth?"

At that, Devadatta's mind grew worse toward me than before, and he said: "Gautama, you may be taming many followers now, but by the very nature of reality I see that before long you will be no more." Having said those words, the great earth shook in six ways, and right at Devadatta's feet the ground split open and a violent wind rushed out, swirling up dust and the like and covering him with it. When Devadatta saw such an evil omen, he said: "If this body of mine is inevitably destined to fall into the Avīci hell in this very life, then I must take revenge on my great enemy." So saying, he went to where King Ajātaśatru was.

The moment Ajātaśatru saw him, he asked: "Noble one, why do you look so pale and without any lustre?" Devadatta replied: "Am I not always like this? Do you not know?" Ajātaśatru said: "Tell me the cause and condition of what you have in mind." Devadatta said: "I am very close to you, and when the people of the land speak ill of you to me, I take it amiss. Is there any pleasant news for me to hear?"

Prince Ajātaśatru said: "What ill things do the people of the land say about me?" Devadatta replied: "The people of the land speak ill of you by calling you Ajātaśatru." Ajātaśatru said: "How did I come to be given the name Ajātaśatru?" Devadatta replied: "When you were born, all the astrologers said: 'Once this child is born, he will kill his royal father.' For that reason all the

people of the land gave you the name Ajātaśatru. All the palace retinue call you Sudarśana in order to guard your feelings. When Queen Vaidehī heard this, the moment you were born she threw you from a great height, and one of your fingers was broken. Because of that cause and condition, people also gave you the name Bārāruce."

He went on: "When I heard them speak so, I felt displeasure arise, yet I was unable to say anything to you about it." Then Devadatta instructed him by various evil means to kill his royal father the king, saying: "If you kill your royal father, I too will kill the ascetic Gautama."

Prince Ajātaśatru went to the two great ministers known as Praśānta and asked them: "Great ministers, why have I been given the name Ajātaśatru?" The great ministers then gave the same account of how the name was given in former times as Devadatta had given. Upon hearing this, Prince Ajātaśatru conferred with the great ministers, seized his royal father, surrounded him with four armies outside the city, and set out.

When Queen Vaidehī heard of this, she went to where the king was, but the guards blocked her and would not let her see him. Then the queen's mind filled with anger and she scolded the guards.

This is the forty-fifth fascicle of the Noble Great Sūtra of Complete Nirvāṇa (Skt. Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra).

Then the guards went to the king and asked the queen's request to visit the royal father, and then asked the prince whether it was permitted or not.

When the prince heard this, he became even more enraged. He went to where his mother was, seized her by the hair, drew his sword, and was about to strike her down. At that point Jīvaka spoke up, saying: "Great King, even for the gravest offenses committed since the world began, no woman has ever been put to death by royal punishment — how much less your own royal mother?" Prince Ajātaśatru heard Jīvaka's words and refrained from killing her. But he cut off the royal father's clothing, bedding, food, and medicine for his illness, and after seven days had passed the royal father died.

When Ajātaśatru saw that his royal father had died, remorse arose in his mind. As he went to two of his great ministers, they spoke various perverse and unwholesome words, saying: "Great King, none of your actions are blameworthy. Why should you give rise to remorse today?" Jīvaka then spoke again: "Great King, please understand this: an action such as this carries two

kinds of grievous wrongdoing — killing one's royal father, and killing a stream-enterer (Skt. *srotāpanna*). For a wrong of that kind, there is no one other than the Blessed One who has the power to purify such an action." Ajātaśatru said: "The Tathāgata is perfectly pure and without stain. I am a sinful person — how could he bear to look upon me?" Noble son, having known of this situation, I declared to Ānanda that I would pass into complete *nirvāṇa* after three months had elapsed.

When Ajātaśatru heard this, he came to where I was. I taught the Dharma, and his heavy wrongdoing became lighter, and he also attained irreversible faith. Noble son, my attendants, hearing me say this, did not understand my intention and said: "The Tathāgata has long since passed into *nirvāṇa*." Noble son, there are two kinds of *bodhisattva*: those who are genuine and endowed with real meaning, and those who bear the name only as a superficial designation. Among these, a *bodhisattva* who bears the name only as a superficial designation, upon hearing me say "I will pass into complete *nirvāṇa* in three months," gives rise to a mind of complete despondency and says: "If the Tathāgata himself is impermanent and does not abide, what should we do? Why, on account of such a state of affairs, must we go on experiencing for countless lifetimes the great suffering of affliction? Even the Blessed One, the Buddha, possessing immeasurable merit, could not defeat the *māra* of death — so how could we ever be capable of it?" Noble son, for that reason I told those *bodhisattvas*: "The Tathāgata is eternally abiding, unchanging, and unshifting." Noble son, my attendants, hearing me say this, did not understand my intention and declared with certainty: "The Tathāgata will ultimately never pass into *nirvāṇa*." Noble son, certain sentient beings, having produced a nihilistic view, say: "After the death of the body, there is nothing whatsoever that all sentient beings experience of virtuous or non-virtuous karma." For their sake I declared: "The ripened fruit of virtuous and non-virtuous karma is truly and genuinely experienced." How is its existence demonstrated? Noble son, in a past age there was in a city called Kuśāgranagara a king named Sudarśana. For eighty-four thousand years he lived as a youth, for eighty-four thousand years he served as regent, and for eighty-four thousand years he reigned as king. While dwelling in seclusion, he thought to himself: "Sentient beings, because of meager merit, have short lives in their rebirths, and

the four enemies are always following close behind, yet they neither know nor feel it, and go about in heedlessness. Therefore I shall go forth and cultivate the path to awakening, and cut these four enemies — birth, old age, sickness,

and death — entirely away." With this thought in mind, he declared to his ministers: "Outside the city, build me a palace of the seven precious substances." When the palace was built, he declared to his ministers, his inner counselors, his princes, and his kinsmen: "Know this: I am thinking of going forth. Do you give your consent?" Then all the chief ministers, kinsmen, and the rest replied: "Excellent! Great King, now the time has come." Thereupon King Sudarśana, in the company of a single attendant, dwelt in that palace for eighty-four thousand years and cultivated the mind of loving-kindness (*maitrī*). Through that cause, for eighty-four thousand years he was successively made a wheel-turning king. After that, for thirty lifetimes he was made Śakra, lord of the gods. And for countless lifetimes he was made a petty king. Noble son, do not think that Sudarśana of that time and age was someone else: he was none other than myself as I am today. Noble son, when my attendants heard me speak in this way, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively declared that self and what belongs to self exist." Again, at another time I declared to sentient beings: "What is called 'self' is intrinsic nature — namely, the twelve inner and outer causes and conditions, dependent origination, the five aggregates of sentient beings, mind, the elements, the merit of the world, the power of karma, and the world governed by a divine sovereign — all of this is called 'self.'" When my attendants heard me speak in this way, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively declared that a self exists." Noble son, yet at another time a certain monk came to where I was and asked: "Blessed One, what is this thing called 'self'? Who or what is this 'self'? And by what condition is it called 'self'?" Then I declared to that monk: "Monk, self and what belongs to self do not exist. That which is said not to exist was not present from the very beginning, yet exists now. What exists will later come not to exist. Even at the first moment of birth it came from nowhere, and when it ceases later it goes nowhere. The fruit of karma exists, yet it was not made by anyone. There are no aggregates that are relinquished, and no aggregates that are taken up. The thing you asked about — 'what is this self?' — that is suchness itself. The thing you asked — 'who is this self?' — that is karma. The condition by which it is called 'self' is existence." "Monk, just as when two hands clap together a sound arises between them, so too is the self: through the connected cause of mind, karma, and existence, the three, it is called 'self.' Monk, the form of all sentient beings is not the self. The self is not found within form, nor is form found within the self — and so on likewise through to consciousness. Monk, even those who assert the existence of a self, such as the non-Buddhists

(tīrthikas), do not posit it as something other than the aggregates. There is no such ground as claiming that a self exists beyond the aggregates once the aggregates have been set aside. The formations of all sentient beings resemble a magical illusion and a mirage. Monk, the five aggregates are impermanent, devoid of happiness, selfless, and utterly impure."

Noble son, at that time an immeasurable number of monks attained the fruit of arhatship by realizing that these five aggregates are without self and without what belongs to a self.

Noble son, when my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught the absence of self."

Noble son, I also said in a sūtra: "This body was taken up from the conjunction of three things." That is to say, the body is taken up through the coming together of father, mother, and the intermediate-state aggregates.

I also said: "The person who is a once-returner will directly realize nirvāṇa — or, if the five aggregates of the intermediate state exist, will pass beyond sorrow in the intermediate state." This too means: having complete and clear faculties in the intermediate-state aggregates is the result of former karma, just as clarified butter is the essence of butter.

Noble son, I once said: "The intermediate-state aggregates of sinful sentient beings are like coarse chaff in the world. The intermediate-state aggregates of beings who are purely virtuous are like white fine cotton cloth from the land of the Śakas." When my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that the intermediate-state aggregates exist."

Noble son, I also said to sentient beings who had committed the boundless misdeeds (Skt. ānantarya): "Having committed the five boundless misdeeds, such sentient beings fall into the hell of boundless retribution." I also said: "The monk called Kumārutsika, immediately upon leaving this body, fell without obstruction into the hell of boundless retribution." I also said to the wanderer Vatsīputra: "Wanderer, if the five aggregates of the intermediate state exist, then the six realms of existence also exist." I also said: "For sentient beings of the formless realm, there are no intermediate-state aggregates." When my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that the intermediate-state aggregates do not exist."

Noble son, I have also taught in sūtras that regression exists. Why so? Because the immeasurable number of monks who are lazy and given to indolence do not apply themselves to awakening — and for their sake, five kinds of regression were taught: delight in many activities, fondness for worldly gossip, fondness for sleep, fondness for associating with householders, and fondness for wandering about. Through these causes and conditions, monks come to regress.

Furthermore, there are two kinds of conditions for regression: inner and outer. A person who is an arhat has abandoned the inner conditions, but has not abandoned the outer conditions; through outer conditions, afflictions arise. Because afflictions arise, regression and deterioration occur.

There was also the monk called Kuta, who regressed as many as six times; but each time he returned, he cultivated the mind of conscience and shame, and in the end, at the seventh time, he attained it. After attaining it, fearing that he might regress again, he drew a sword and took his own life.

I also spoke at various times of the occasion of liberation, and at other times of the six types of arhat and so forth. When my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that regression exists."

Noble son, it is also said in a sūtra:

Just as burnt wood cannot become wood again, and just as a broken pot can no longer serve as a pot, so too with mental afflictions: once an arhat has completely severed them, they will not arise again. This is what was declared.

It is also taught that there are three causes for the arising of mental afflictions in sentient beings: afflictions that have not been severed, the causes and conditions of those afflictions that have not been severed, and unwholesome mental engagement. An arhat, however, has neither causes nor conditions, and because the afflictions have been severed, there is no unwholesome mental engagement either.

Noble son, when my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that there is no regression."

Noble son, I also taught in a sūtra that the body of the Tathāgata is of two kinds: the birth body and the dharmakāya. Of these, the birth body is the body magically emanated through skillful means. Of that body, it is not right to say

that there is birth, aging, illness, death, tallness, shortness, darkness, whiteness, this or that, one in training, or one beyond training. When my attendants heard me speak thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that the body of a buddha is a conditioned phenomenon."

The dharmakāya, on the other hand, is permanent, blissful, a self, and perfectly pure, and is entirely without birth, aging, illness, and death. It is neither white nor black, neither tall nor short, neither this nor that, neither one in training nor one beyond training. Whether or not a buddha appears in the world, it abides always, changeless and unaltered. When my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that the body of a buddha is an unconditioned phenomenon."

Noble son, I also taught in a sūtra the twelve links of dependent origination: from ignorance arise formations; from formations arises consciousness; from consciousness arise name-and-form; from name-and-form arise the six sense bases; from the six sense bases arises contact; from contact arises feeling; from feeling arises craving; from craving arises grasping; from grasping arises existence; from existence arises birth; and from birth arise aging-and-death, and the sorrow that follows in their wake.

When my attendants heard those words, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has definitively taught that the twelve links of dependent origination are conditioned phenomena."

I also spoke at one time to the monks, declaring: "Whether or not buddhas appear in the world, the twelve links of dependent origination are such that their intrinsic nature and defining characteristics abide always."

Noble son, among the twelve links of dependent origination, there are those that did not arise from conditions, those that arose from conditions yet are not themselves the twelve links of dependent origination, those that both arose from conditions and are the twelve links of dependent origination, and those that neither arose from conditions nor are the twelve links of dependent origination.

Of these, the twelve links of dependent origination that did not arise from conditions are the twelve links as they exist in the future. The twelve links that arose from conditions yet are not the twelve links of dependent origination are the five aggregates of an arhat.

Those that both arose from conditions and are the twelve links of dependent origination are as follows: the twelve links of dependent origination together with the five aggregates of foolish, common, ordinary beings. Those that neither arose from conditions nor are the twelve links of dependent origination are, as was declared, space and nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the unconditioned is definitely to be included within the twelve links of dependent origination."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "When all sentient beings abandon this body formed by virtuous and non-virtuous karma, it dissolves and disperses into just those four great elements. One who has performed only virtue will have the mind's formations arise in their highest form. One who has performed only non-virtuous karma will have the mind's formations arise in their lowest form." Son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that mind is definitely permanent."

Son of good family, I once spoke these words to the great king Rūpasāranemi: "Great king, understand it thus: form is impermanent. Why is that? Because it arises from an impermanent cause. Since form arises from an impermanent cause, why would a wise and discerning person speak of it as permanent? If form were permanent, it would not disintegrate and cease, and it would make no sense for sufferings to arise. But we see this form disperse, cease, break apart, and disintegrate. Therefore, understand that form is impermanent. And likewise, up through consciousness, all are the same." Son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that mind is definitely subject to annihilation."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "Though my attendants hold eight categories of uninspected goods such as incense, flowers, gold, silver, precious jewels, wives, sons, male servants, female servants, and the like, they attain the path of truth. And having attained the path of truth, they do not give them up." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that if one indulges in the five sense pleasures, it will definitely not become an obstacle to the noble path."

Furthermore, at one time I declared: "There is no basis on which a householder can attain the path of truth." Son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that if one indulges in the five sense pleasures it will definitely become an obstacle to the path of truth."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "One who has abandoned the afflictions but has not yet attained liberation is comparable to one practicing the supreme worldly Dharma in the desire realm." Son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the supreme worldly Dharma exists only in the desire realm."

And I also declared: "Heat, summit, forbearance, and the supreme worldly Dharma exist from the first meditative concentration up through the fourth meditative concentration."

Son of good family, when my attendants heard those words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that those phenomena exist in the form realm."

And I also declared: "Non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), having previously abandoned the afflictions of the fourth meditative concentration, then cultivate heat, summit, forbearance, and the supreme worldly Dharma, and thereby realize the Four Noble Truths and attain the fruit of non-returner." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the supreme worldly Dharma exists in the formless realm."

Son of good family, I also declared in a sūtra: "Of the four kinds of generosity, three are pure. In this regard, the giver has faith in cause, result, and the act of giving, while the recipient has no such faith in cause, result, and the act of giving. Or the recipient has faith in cause, result, and the act of giving, while the giver has no such faith in cause, result, and the act of giving. Or both giver and recipient have faith. Or both giver and recipient have no faith. Of these four kinds of generosity, the first three are pure." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that generosity is mind alone."

Son of good family, I also declared at one time: "When giving is performed, five kinds of things are given: the gift of appearance, the gift of strength, the gift of happiness, the gift of life, and the gift of eloquence. Through this, the

giver will obtain five kinds of karmic maturation as fruit." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Buddha has declared that generosity itself is the five aggregates (skandhas)."

Son of good family, I declared at one time: "Nirvāṇa is the complete and total exhaustion of the afflictions, ceased utterly without remainder — just as a fire, when it has died, has no nature of arising again, so too is nirvāṇa. What is called empty space is simply the absence of anything whatsoever. Just as in the world the absence of anything whatsoever is called empty space — and it is the absence of anything whatsoever, not a cessation brought about by the condition of wisdom — so if something existed, it would be fitting that causes and conditions also exist. If causes and conditions exist, it would be fitting that exhaustion and cessation exist. Since that is not the case, there is no exhaustion and no cessation." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Blessed One has declared that the three kinds of unconditioned phenomena do not exist."

Son of good family, I once addressed Maudgalyāyana with these words: "Maudgalyāyana, nirvāṇa is a verbal designation. It is the footprint of the path. It is the ultimate abode. It is fearlessness. It is the great Teacher. It is the great fruit. It is ultimate wisdom. It is great patience. It is unobstructed meditative absorption. It is the great dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. It is a taste that is rare and wondrous to encounter. Maudgalyāyana, if it were said that nirvāṇa does not exist, why then have I declared that those who denigrate it fall into the hells?" When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that nirvāṇa exists."

And again at one time I addressed Maudgalyāyana with these words: "Maudgalyāyana, from the eye, which is without essence, through to the body — all are without essence."

"In this way, being empty of essence is called emptiness. Food and the like, which transform and are digested, as well as all sounds — these too are called empty." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Buddha has declared that space, which is empty, and the unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) certainly exist."

And again at one time I addressed Maudgalyāyana with these words: "Maudgalyāyana, understand this: when someone abides in forbearance

without having attained the fruit of stream-entry, the immeasurable karmic maturations of the three lower destinies that have been cut off are not halted through the condition of wisdom (jñāna)." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Buddha has declared that these maturations are not halted through the condition of wisdom."

O son of good family, I also once explained the intermediate state to a monk named Barpa. I declared: "If a monk reflects on form as past or future or present, near or far, gross or subtle, form of such kinds is not a self and does not belong to a self. If a monk understands this, he is able to cut off existence in the form realm." The monk Barpa then asked: "What is meant by form and what by name?" I declared: "The four great elements are form. The four remaining aggregates are name." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that form is definitively the four great elements."

O son of good family, I also declared: "Just as a reflection appears through the condition of a mirror, form is similar: through the condition of the four great elements there appear, in this way, the gross and the subtle, the coarse and the smooth, the blue, the yellow, the red, the white, the long, the short, the square, the round, the tranquil, the light, the heavy, the cold, the hot, hunger, thirst, smoke, clouds, and concave forms as well — and this is conditioned form (saṃskṛta), and it is therefore like an echo." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the four great elements are conditioned form, and that certain of the four great elements are without conditioned form."

O son of good family, long ago at one time the son of the king of the Awakening Tree said: "If a monk who holds the vow of moral discipline gives rise to a non-virtuous thought, at that moment his monastic moral discipline has become impaired." At that time I addressed the son of the king of the Awakening Tree and declared: "Moral discipline has seven aspects: there is form that is non-manifest (avijñapti), arising from body and speech. Even if, through the condition of non-manifest form, the mind abides in non-virtue or in what is doctrinally indeterminate, it is not to be said that the moral discipline is impaired — it is the guarding of moral discipline. For what cause and condition is non-manifest form called non-manifest? Because a distinct form, through the condition of another distinct form, does not become the cause and effect of yet another distinct form." When my attendants heard these words spoken

thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Buddha has declared that non-manifest form exists."

O son of good family, in other sūtras I have declared: "What is called moral discipline is the restraint of non-virtuous phenomena (dharmas).

If one does not commit non-virtue, that is the guarding of moral discipline." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that non-manifest form does not exist with certainty."

O son of good family, in other sūtras I have declared: "From the noble aggregate of form through to the aggregate of consciousness, these arise from the cause and condition of ignorance. All foolish and ignoble beings likewise arise through craving that springs from ignorance. One should understand that this very craving is ignorance. Because grasping arises from craving, one should understand that this very grasping is ignorance and craving. Because becoming arises from grasping, one should understand that this very becoming is ignorance, becoming, and grasping. Because feeling arises from becoming, one should understand that this very feeling is formations and becoming. From the cause of feeling there arise name-and-form, ignorance, craving, grasping, becoming, formations, feeling, contact, consciousness, and the six sense bases and so forth. Therefore feeling is the twelve links of dependent origination." When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that phenomena do not arise from mind."

O son of good family, in other sūtras I have declared: "From the eye, form, appearance, and defiled desire, eye-consciousness arises. What is called defiled desire is ignorance; when one seeks by the nature of desire, that is called craving. Through the condition of craving there is grasping; grasping is karma. Through the condition of karma there is consciousness; through the condition of consciousness, name-and-form; through the condition of name-and-form, the six sense bases; through the condition of the six sense bases, contact; and through the condition of contact, there arise perception, feeling, aspiration, faith, diligence, meditative concentration, and wisdom. Although these phenomena arise through the condition of feeling, they are not feeling." O son of good family, when my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that phenomena arising from mind do exist."

O son of good family, in some contexts I have declared that there is only one existence; in other contexts I have declared two existences, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, and ten, up to twenty-five. When my attendants heard these words spoken thus, not understanding my intention, they said: "The Tathāgata has declared that there exist five cravings and six existences."

O son of good family, once in the past, when I was dwelling in the land of the Śākya, in the Nyagrodha Grove, a man named Śākya Mingchen came to where I was and asked: "How does one become a lay practitioner?" I declared: "Whatever son or daughter of good family who is endowed with the sense faculties and has gone for refuge in the Three Jewels is called a lay practitioner." Śākya Mingchen then asked: "Blessed One, how is one called a one-sided lay practitioner?" I declared: "Śākya Mingchen, whoever has taken the three refuges and undertaken one precept is called a one-sided lay practitioner."

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the moral discipline of a layman is acceptable even without possessing all the precepts."

Son of good family, once I was dwelling on the bank of the Ganges, and at that time Kātyāyana came to where I was and said: "Blessed One, if one were to bestow upon a sentient being even a single canopy of the Dharma of the training's limbs — for a single day, a single moment, or even just an instant — would that being thereby receive a limb of the training?" I declared: "That monk would indeed obtain virtue, but one should not say that he has obtained a limb of the training."

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that if one possesses the eight limbs of the training, then one has received the eight precepts of discipline."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "If a monk transgresses the four root precepts, he is no longer to be called a monk. He is called one who has broken the monk's vows, one who has lost and ruined the monkhood, one in whom the sprout of the fruit of virtue will not grow — just as a burned seed will not produce fruit, and just as a palmyra tree whose crown has been cut will not produce new growth. A monk who has transgressed the four root precepts is likewise."

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that if monks transgress the four

root precepts, their monastic discipline is thereby ruined."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra to Cunda: "There are four kinds of monks. What are they? One who has reached the culmination of awakening, one who teaches awakening, one who receives awakening, and one who defiles awakening. Among these, the one who defiles awakening is one who has transgressed the four root precepts."

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that even if monks transgress the four root precepts, their discipline itself is not ruined."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra that monks have one vehicle, one path, one conduct, and one focus. From that single vehicle through to the single focus, by means of these they bring about great peace for sentient beings, cutting through all bondage, sorrow, suffering, and the causes of suffering, and they lead all sentient beings to pass through existence together as one.

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that all of these, from stream-enterers to arhats, have fully and directly awakened."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "A stream-enterer is reborn at most seven times among gods and humans and then passes fully into nirvāṇa. A once-returner is born once more among gods and humans and then passes fully into nirvāṇa. As for the non-returner, there are five kinds, ranging from one who passes fully into nirvāṇa at an intermediate stage to one who does so at the final stage. As for the arhat, there are two kinds: the present and the future. The present arhat severs the five aggregates of affliction, and the future arhat also severs the five aggregates of affliction."

Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that from the stream-enterer through to the arhat, none of them obtain direct and complete awakening."

Son of good family, I declared in a sūtra: "The nature of a buddha is endowed with six qualities: permanence, authenticity, truth,

wholesomeness, purity, and vision." Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings exists somewhere apart from those sentient beings."

Son of good family, I then declared in another sūtra: "The intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is like space. Space is not past, not future, not present; it is neither inner nor outer. Just as form, sound, smell, taste, and touch are all encompassed within it, so too the intrinsic nature of a buddha is like that." Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings exists somewhere apart from those sentient beings."

Son of good family, I then declared in yet another sūtra: "The intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings is comparable to a treasure of jewels in the house of a poor woman, to the precious wish-fulfilling jewel that is the immediate wealth of a powerful man, and to the spring of pure water belonging to a wheel-turning king." Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings exists somewhere apart from those sentient beings."

Son of good family, I then declared in yet another sūtra: "Even in those who have violated the four root precepts, who hold wrong views, who have rejected the extensive sūtras, and who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present. Whether or not those sentient beings possess wholesome phenomena, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is itself wholesome." Upon hearing these words spoken thus, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that the intrinsic nature of a buddha in sentient beings exists somewhere apart from those sentient beings."

Son of good family, I then declared: "Sentient beings themselves are the intrinsic nature of a buddha. Why is this? Because beyond and apart from sentient beings, there is no one who attains unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. Therefore, just as I taught the example of the wool-bearing ram to King Conqueror-of-Armies, and just as when the blind describe the characteristics of a wool-bearing ram they do not grasp the ram itself, yet what they describe is not something other than the ram — in the same way, those who say that, throughout the range of sentient beings from form to consciousness, all of this is the intrinsic nature of a buddha are similar to those blind men. It is not the intrinsic nature of a buddha, yet it is not something other than the intrinsic nature of a buddha either. Just as I taught the nine similes of the garment to that king, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is

like that."

Son of good family, upon hearing me declare this, my attendants, not understanding my intention, explain it in various ways. Like a blind man inquiring about milk, some explain that the intrinsic nature of a buddha is present in all — in those who have violated the four root precepts, who have rejected the extensive sūtras, who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, who hold wrong views, and so forth — each on account of its own particular causes and conditions. Others explain that it is not present in those beings.

Son of good family, in all the sūtra collections I have declared: "It never occurs that a single person arises in the world who brings benefit to many people and that two wheel-turning kings appear in one realm, or that two buddhas appear in a single world system. It never occurs that eight protectors exist in a single four-continent world, nor that two exist anywhere from that up through the realm of the gods who make use of others' emanations."

I have declared that in Jambudvīpa, the hell of unrelenting torment (avīci) reaches upward to the very summit of existence. Having heard me speak those words, my attendants, not understanding my intention, said: "The Tathāgata has declared that there are no buddhas in the ten directions." Yet in the sūtra collections of the Great Vehicle it is declared that buddhas do exist in the ten directions.

Son of good family, a dispute of this kind lies within the domain of the Blessed One's own experience; it is not something śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas can know. Even if someone were to generate doubt regarding this matter, it would still be possible to eliminate afflictions beyond measure — afflictions as vast as Mount Meru. Yet if one generates certainty about it in an unquestioning way, that is what is called attachment and clinging.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is meant by 'attachment and clinging'?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, if a person, having heard something from another or having looked into the sūtras himself and seen something, or having followed what another has taught, is unable to let go of the objects to which he clings — that is called attachment and clinging."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, is such attachment and clinging wholesome?"

"It is not wholesome."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, such attachment and clinging should not be called wholesome. Why? Because it is incapable of cutting the net of doubt."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if a person has had no doubt from the very beginning, why speak of being unable to cut the net of doubt?"

The Blessed One replied: "What is free of doubt — that is what is called doubt."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, when someone who has entered the stream declares, 'I will not fall into the three lower destinies' — is that also attachment and doubt?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, that is to be called certainty; it is not right to call it doubt. Why? Son of good family, consider the example of a person who has previously seen both a human being and a tree. Later, walking along at night, he sees a stump from a distance and thinks, 'Is that a person or a tree?' — and doubt arises.

Son of good family, just as someone who has previously seen both a monk and a wandering ascetic (*parivrājaka*), and later, at one moment, sees a monk from a distance on the road, thinks, 'Is that a monk or a wandering ascetic?' — and doubt arises.

Son of good family, in the same way, someone who has previously seen both a bull and a water buffalo, and later sees an animal from a distance, thinks, 'Is that a bull or a water buffalo?' — and doubt arises.

Son of good family, when all sentient beings have previously seen two different kinds of things, doubt arises afterward. Why? Because the mind has not understood them.

If I had spoken of a stream-entrant both falling into the three lower destinies and not falling into the three lower destinies, why would doubt arise in the mind? Since I have not said that, why would doubt arise?"

Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, as the Blessed One has stated, it follows that seeing something beforehand leads to doubt afterward. Yet there is also something that gives rise to doubt without one having seen two different things — and what is that? It is *nirvāṇa*.

Blessed One, for example, if a person encounters a turbid stream in his path, he wonders from having seen water before, 'Is this water deep or shallow?' But if he has never seen it before, why would doubt arise?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what is called nirvāṇa is the cutting off of suffering. What is not nirvāṇa is suffering. There are two ways in which all sentient beings see things: seeing them as suffering and seeing them as not-suffering.

What is meant by 'suffering' and 'not-suffering'? Hunger, thirst, cold, heat, anger, joy, illness —"

— happiness, old age, youth, birth, death, bondage, freedom, separation from loved ones, encounter with enemies. Sentient beings see these things and sometimes wonder when they will be free from things afflicted by such suffering. Because of this, sentient beings give rise to doubt about nirvāṇa. Now, the meaning of your question — 'Why would that person who has never seen a turbid stream doubt it?' — is not quite as you supposed. Why is that? Because that person had previously seen such a thing in another place; therefore, even without having gone there before, doubt arises in him about it."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, just as you have said, doubt is attachment, and attachment is doubt — then what is to be done about that?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is to be applied to those who have cut the root of virtue."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, who are those who will cut the root of virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, those who, though their wisdom is clear and their faculties are sharp, abandon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra) who is skilled in making distinctions, do not listen to the sacred Dharma, are of unwholesome intention, and do not abide properly — these are the ones who will cut the root of virtue. Having abandoned those four things, they think to themselves: 'As for generosity and material goods, there are none whatsoever.' Why? Because generosity means giving away wealth. If there were karmic maturation of a fruit from generosity, then the giver of generosity would always be destined to remain in poverty. Why? Because seed and fruit are alike; therefore they claim there is no cause and no fruit. To speak in this way of there being no cause and no fruit is what is called cutting the root of virtue.

Again, they think: 'The giver, the receiver, and the material gift — these three are impermanent; they do not abide, they do not remain. If they do not abide

and do not remain, how can one say that this is giving, this is receiving, this is the material gift? If there is no receiving either, how could any fruit ripen?' Thinking in this way, they claim there is no cause and no fruit. Know that to speak in this way of there being no cause and no fruit is to cut the root of virtue.

Again, they think: 'When a gift is given, there are five aspects of the thing given. Even if the recipient then acts virtuously or acts non-virtuously, the karmic maturation of virtue or non-virtue will not ripen for the giver. Just as in worldly affairs a fruit arises from a seed and that fruit in turn becomes a seed again — the cause is the giver and the fruit is the recipient — even so, the recipient, through his virtuous or non-virtuous conduct, is not able to bring about the attainment of the giver.' Thinking in this way, they claim there is no cause and no fruit. Know that to speak in this way of there being no cause and no fruit is to cut the root of virtue.

Again, they think: 'The object of giving does not exist. Why? Because the object of giving is not taught in scripture. Since it is not taught in scripture, how could a virtuous fruit ripen? That for which there is no fruit of virtue or non-virtue is what is not taught in scripture. Since the object is not taught in scripture, one should understand that there is no ripening of a fruit of virtue or non-virtue.'

"Therefore there is no giving, and there is no cause and no fruit" — so they think. Know that to speak in this way, after thinking in such a manner, of there being no cause and no fruit, is to cut the root of virtue.

Again, they think: "Giving is mind. If it is mind, it is invisible and without an equal and is therefore not a material phenomenon. If it is not a material phenomenon, what is there even in the act of giving? Therefore there is no giving, no cause, and no fruit." Know that whoever speaks in this way of there being no cause and no fruit has cut the root of virtue.

Again, the giver thinks: "If I give for the sake of an image of a buddha, or an image of a god, or for the span of a life, or for deceased parents, there is no one who receives. If there is no receiver, it follows that there is no karmic ripening of a fruit. If there is no karmic ripening of a fruit, there will be no cause. If there is no cause, there will be no fruit" — so they think. Know that to speak in this way, after thinking in such a manner, of there being no cause and no fruit, is to cut the root of virtue.

Again, they think: "There is no father and there is no mother. If one says that both parents are the cause of a sentient being and that a sentient being is born, then by that reasoning beings should be born continuously without interruption, without ever ceasing. Why? Because the cause is always present. Since birth does not occur continuously in that way, one should understand that parents do not exist" — so they think.

Again, they think: "There is no father and there is no mother. Why? Because if the body of a sentient being existed through the condition of its parents, it would follow that even in a single individual there would be the characteristics of both male and female. Since neither is the case in that way, one should understand that sentient beings do not arise through the condition of parents."

Again, they think: "Sentient beings do not arise through the condition of parents. Why? Because one sees sentient beings existing who are unlike their parents — unlike them in body, in form, in mind, in manner of conduct, in gait, and in posture. Therefore parents are not the cause of sentient beings" — so they think.

Again, they think: "Throughout the entire world there are four modes of non-existence. First, non-existence prior to birth — just as when clay is still a lump, pottery and the like do not yet exist. Second, non-existence after cessation — just as when pottery has shattered, it no longer exists. Third, mutual non-existence — just as an ox is not a horse, and a horse is not an ox. Fourth, absolute non-existence — just as the horn of a rabbit, or the hair of a tortoise. The parents of sentient beings are likewise non-existent, comparable to these four modes of non-existence. If one says that parents are the cause of sentient beings, then when the parents die, the children should also die. Therefore parents are not the cause of sentient beings" — so they think.

Again, they think: "If one says that parents are indeed the cause of sentient beings, then from the cause of parents sentient beings should always and invariably be born. Yet that is not so, for there are also beings who are born miraculously and beings who are born from warmth and moisture. Therefore one should understand that sentient beings do not arise from the cause of parents" — so they think.

Again, they think: "Sentient beings exist by their own intrinsic nature and do not arise from the cause of parents. For example, just as a peacock, upon hearing the sound of thunder, becomes pregnant in the womb, and just as the blue hummingbird becomes pregnant by drinking the tears of the male bird,

and just as some birds become pregnant upon seeing the dance of the male bird — in the same way, sentient beings arise by their own nature" — so they think. Know that when one thinks in this way and has not met a spiritual friend (Skt. kalyāṇamitra), this too is the cutting of the root of virtue.

Again, they think: "Throughout the entire world there exist virtue and —"

there are no results of non-virtue — so they think. Why do they think so? Among sentient beings, some who practice the ten virtues and delight in giving, who strive earnestly after merit, are nonetheless tormented in the prime of their youth by illness and the like, their bodies afflicted, losing their lives or their wealth and possessions, and crushed by much grief and suffering. On the other hand, some who practice the ten non-virtues — who act from attachment, envy, and laziness, who are indolent and do not practice virtue — nonetheless enjoy physical comfort, are free from illness, live long lives, possess abundant wealth and precious goods, and are not crushed by grief and suffering. Therefore, they think: "We understand that there are no results of virtue or non-virtue."

Again, they think: "I have previously heard it said by noble ones (āryas) that some people, even though they have practiced virtue, fall into the three lower destinies after death, and there are many such cases; while some, even though they have practiced non-virtue, are reborn after death as gods in the higher realms or as humans." Having heard this, they think: "Therefore, we understand that there are no results of virtue or non-virtue."

Again, they think: "All noble ones speak in two contradictory ways. Some say that killing a living being ripens as the result of virtue; others say that killing a living being ripens as the result of non-virtue — they speak in two different ways. Therefore we understand that what the noble ones have said is not definitive. If even the noble ones have not spoken definitively, why should I speak definitively? Therefore we understand that there are no results of virtue or non-virtue" — so they think.

Again, they think: "There are no noble ones anywhere in the entire world. Why? If noble ones were to attain the true path, then while all sentient beings still possess afflictions, those who cultivate the true path would have both the true path and afflictions existing simultaneously and at the same time. But if they coexist simultaneously, the true path would be unable to uproot all the afflictions. On the other hand, if one cultivates the true path in the absence of afflictions, that true path would be unnecessary. Therefore, when afflictions

are present, the path cannot destroy them; and when afflictions are absent, the path is not needed at all. Therefore we understand that there are no noble ones anywhere in the entire world" — so they think.

Again, they think: "The twelve links of dependent origination — from formations arising conditioned by ignorance, all the way through to old age and death arising conditioned by birth — exist equally and alike in all sentient beings. The noble eightfold path (Skt. *āryāṣṭāṅgamārga*) likewise, since its nature is equally the same, must be of a similar kind. If one person attains it, then all should attain it; and if one person cultivates it, all should be able to cease their suffering. Why? Because the afflictions are equally and uniformly present. Yet looking at those who do not attain it right now, we think: there is no true path" — so they think.

Again, they think: "Noble ones too have characteristics in common with the basest of ordinary people: eating food, walking, standing, sitting, lying down, sleeping, feeling joy, laughing, feeling hunger and thirst, feeling cold and heat, feeling grief and fear. If noble ones equally share these things with the basest of ordinary folk, then they have not attained the noble path. And if they have attained the noble path, then all such characteristics should have been definitively cut off. Since those characteristics have not been cut off, we understand that there is no path" — so they think.

Again, they think: "Noble ones too have bodies, and they enjoy and indulge in the pleasures of the five desired objects; they feel proud; they even strike and beat others; they feel envy and arrogance toward others; they experience suffering and happiness; and they perform virtuous and non-virtuous actions. For these causes and conditions, we understand that there are no noble ones."

Again, they think: "One who possesses loving compassion is called a noble one. But what is the cause and condition for being called a noble one? One is called a noble one by reason of the path. If it were the intrinsic nature of the path to be compassionate, then by that very nature all sentient beings would become compassionate, and it would be unreasonable to make it depend on cultivation. If compassion is not intrinsically present, then why would noble ones become compassionate by reason of having attained the noble path? Therefore we understand that in this world there is no noble path" — so they think.

Again, they think: "The four great elements do not arise from conditions; they exist equally in all sentient beings. The intrinsic nature of the four great

elements does not discriminate, thinking 'I will move into this sentient being but not into that one.' If the noble path existed and things were by nature as claimed, then since they are not presently so, we understand that in this world there are no noble ones" — so they think.

Again, they think: "If there were only one nirvāṇa for all noble ones, then we understand there are no noble ones. Why is that? Because it is without a referential object. A phenomenon that abides permanently is, by its very nature of reality (dharmatā), without a referential object, and is beyond acceptance or rejection. If noble ones were to transcend sorrow in great numbers, it would become impermanent. Why? Because it would be something that can serve as a referential object. If nirvāṇa were just one and completely exhausted, then when one person attained it, it would follow that everyone should attain it simultaneously. If nirvāṇa were many, it would be finite. If it were finite, how could one designate it as permanent? Now, if someone were to say: 'The essential nature of nirvāṇa is one, but liberation is many — just as under one umbrella there can be many spokes' — that too is not the case. Why? Because each person attains it individually, not all at once; therefore it is finite, and hence also impermanent. If it is impermanent, how can it be called nirvāṇa? If there is no nirvāṇa, who would become a noble one? Therefore we understand there are no noble ones" — so they think.

Again, they think: "The noble path is not attained through dependent origination. If the noble path were attained through dependent origination, why have not all beings become noble ones? If not all are noble ones, then we understand that noble ones and the noble path do not exist" — so they think.

Again, they think: "There are two causes and conditions for the right view that belongs to the noble path. What are they? Hearing the Dharma from another, and engaging in inner mental reflection oneself. If these two causes and conditions themselves arose from conditions, then what arises from conditions would itself also arise from conditions, and thus each giving rise to the next, one would fall into the fault of an infinite regress. If these two things did not arise from conditions, then why have not all sentient beings attained it?" — so they think. "Whoever conceives of it in that way cuts off the wholesome root at that very moment."

"Son of good family, if a sentient being views things in such a way — utterly denying cause and effect — that person cuts off the five roots beginning with faith. Son of good family, cutting off the wholesome root does not occur

through being lowly, weak, or dull and confused of faculty; it does not occur through being born as a god or in one of the three lower realms. The same is true of one who creates a schism in the Saṅgha."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, at what time will the wholesome root of such a person grow back?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, for that person the wholesome root will grow back at the time of two moments:

the first being when one first falls into hell, and the second when one emerges from hell.

Son of good family, virtue has three aspects: past, present, and future. Of these, the past, by its very nature, has already ceased, so the cause has come to an end and is exhausted; yet the karmic ripening of its fruit has not yet matured. Therefore one does not say that the fruit of the past has been cut. What is called "cutting" is the cutting of the cause across all three times.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if cutting the cause across all three times is what is called 'cutting the wholesome root,' then in one whose wholesome root has been cut, is there still the intrinsic nature of buddhahood? If there is, does that intrinsic nature of buddhahood belong to the past, the present, or the future, or does it pervade all three times? If it belongs to the past, how can it be called permanent? The intrinsic nature of buddhahood would have to be permanent, and therefore it cannot belong to the past. If it belongs to the future, again how can it be permanent? And yet the Blessed One has taught that all sentient beings will certainly attain it. If it is certainly to be attained, why speak of it as having been cut? If it belongs to the present, again how can it be called permanent? And why did the Blessed One say it will be seen with certainty? For the Tathāgata has also taught that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood has six aspects: permanence, authenticity, truth, virtue, purity, and being fit to be seen. If one whose wholesome root has been cut still possesses the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, it would be improper to speak of them as having their wholesome root cut. But if there is no intrinsic nature of buddhahood in them, why did the Blessed One teach that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is present in all sentient beings? And if it is both present and yet can be cut, why did the Blessed One declare it to be permanent?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, a buddha, a Blessed One, answers questions asked for the sake of sentient beings in four ways. What are

these four? A definitive answer, a differentiated answer, an answer given exactly in accordance with how the question was asked, and setting the question aside without answering it.

Son of good family, what then is a definitive answer? If one asks, 'Does a person who commits evil deeds obtain a virtuous fruit or a non-virtuous fruit?' the definitive reply is: 'They obtain a non-virtuous fruit.' Likewise for virtue in the same manner. If one asks, 'Does the Tathāgata possess the gnosis of omniscience, or not?' the definitive reply is: 'The Tathāgata is omniscient.' If one asks, 'By whom are the Dharma qualities of a buddha thoroughly purified?' the definitive reply is: 'They are thoroughly purified.' If one asks, 'Do the close attendants of a buddha abide in accordance with the Dharma?' the definitive reply is: 'They do indeed abide in accordance with the Dharma.' This is called a definitive answer.

What is a differentiated answer? It is as when I taught the Four Noble Truths. What are the four? Suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path. Of these, what is the truth of suffering? Because there are eight kinds of suffering, it is called the truth of suffering. What is the truth of the origin of suffering? Because there is a cause of the five aggregates, it is called the truth of the origin. What is the truth of cessation? The utter and complete cessation of attachment, aversion, and delusion without remainder is called the truth of cessation. What is the truth of the path?

The thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening are the truth of the path — this is what is called a differentiated answer.

Now, what is an answer that corresponds exactly to the question asked? It is as when I taught that all phenomena are impermanent. When someone asks, "For the sake of what phenomenon did the Blessed One, the Buddha, teach impermanence?" the Tathāgata answers: "It is because of conditioned phenomena that I taught impermanence." The teaching of no-self is the same.

Again, as when I taught that all phenomena are ablaze: if another person asks, "For the sake of what did the Tathāgata teach that all phenomena are ablaze?" the Tathāgata answers: "It is because of attachment, aversion, and delusion that the Tathāgata taught that all phenomena are ablaze." This is what is called an answer that corresponds to the question.

Noble son, the ten powers of the Tathāgata, the four fearlessnesses, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the three foundations of mindfulness, and the eighty thousand varieties of meditative absorption such as the absorption

of courageous advance and the like; the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor excellent features; the thirty-five thousand varieties of meditative absorption such as the five mudrās of gnosis and the like; the four thousand five hundred varieties of meditative absorption such as the vajra-like absorption and the like; and the immeasurable and boundless varieties of meditative absorption of skillful means — these and all such phenomena are the intrinsic nature of the Tathāgata's buddhahood.

Now, that intrinsic nature of buddhahood is endowed with seven qualities: permanence, selfhood, bliss, utter purity, authenticity, truth, and virtue. This is what is called a differentiated answer.

Noble son, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a bodhisattva who is bound by a single birth is endowed with six qualities: permanence, utter purity, authenticity, truth, virtue, and partial vision. This too is what is called a differentiated answer.

When the question was asked, "Does the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exist within one who has previously severed the roots of virtue?" — the answer is that the Tathāgata's intrinsic nature of buddhahood is indeed present, and the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the bodhisattva bound by a single birth is also present. Because both of these intrinsic natures of buddhahood are obscured with respect to what is yet to come, they are said not to exist. Because they are ultimately and without fail to be attained, they are said to exist. This is what is called a differentiated answer.

The Tathāgata's intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither past, nor present, nor future. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the bodhisattva bound by a single birth, because it is seen partially in the present and in the time to come, is called present; and because it is not seen completely, it is called future.

From before the Tathāgata's attainment of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood may be called past, present, and future; but the fruit is not the same in this respect — for there is that which belongs to the three times, and there is that which does not belong to the three times. The causes of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the bodhisattva bound by a single birth are past, present, and future, and the fruit likewise corresponds to these. This is what is called a differentiated answer.

The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a bodhisattva on the ninth ground is sixfold: permanence, virtue, authenticity, truth, utter purity, and visible presence. In this way, the causes of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood are

past, present, and future, and the fruit is likewise — this too is what is called a differentiated answer.

The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a bodhisattva from the eighth ground down to the sixth ground is fivefold: authenticity, truth, utter purity, virtue, and visible presence. Here too, because it serves as the cause of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, it is past, present, and future, and the fruit likewise corresponds to these. This too is what is called a differentiated answer.

The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a bodhisattva from the fifth ground down to and including the first ground is fivefold: authenticity, truth, utter purity, visible presence, virtue, and non-virtue.

Son of good family, that fifth intrinsic nature of buddhahood, the sixth intrinsic nature of buddhahood, and the seventh intrinsic nature of buddhahood exist because they are infallibly attained through roots of virtue not having been severed. This too is what is called a differentiated answer.

Now, if someone were to ask, "Does one who has severed roots of virtue definitely possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, or does one who has severed roots of virtue definitely not possess the intrinsic nature of buddhahood?" — to that question, one simply sets it aside and does not give an answer.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as I have understood it, 'setting aside and not answering' means this: that the Tathāgata has set aside and not answered a question for which an answer was given — for what reason and by what condition has he done so?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, I did not say that I had 'set aside and not answered' what I set aside and did not answer. Son of good family, there are two kinds of setting-aside-without-answer: refutation and non-attachment. It is for that reason that it is called a setting-aside-without-answer."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has explained — how is it that the cause is said to be past, present, and future, and likewise the fruit is past, present, and future, and yet also not past, present, and future?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, the five aggregates are of two kinds: as cause and as fruit. The five aggregates as cause are past, present, and future. The five aggregates as fruit are past, present, and future, and yet

also not past, present, and future.

"Son of good family, all the afflictions arising from ignorance are the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Why? Because they become the cause of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. From the afflictions — ignorance, formations, and the rest — one attains the five aggregates of virtue, and therefore they are called the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. From the five aggregates of virtue one will attain unsurpassed, completely perfect awakening. That is why I previously taught in a sūtra that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is like blood and milk mingled together. What is called 'blood' refers to the afflictions — ignorance, formations, and the rest. What is called 'milk' refers to the five aggregates of virtue. Thus I taught that from the afflictions and from the five aggregates of virtue, one attains unsurpassed, completely perfect awakening. Just as the body of a sentient being arises from semen and blood, so too is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood like that.

"The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a stream-enterer (Skt. *srotaāpanna*) and a once-returner — who have cut off afflictions to a small degree — is comparable to milk. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a non-returner (Skt. *anāgāmin*) is comparable to yogurt. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of an arhat is comparable to butter. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood from a pratyekabuddha up to a bodhisattva on the tenth ground is comparable to clarified butter."

The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of a Tathāgata is comparable to clarified butter's essence. Son of good family, it is not seen because it is obscured by present afflictions.

For example, there is a grass called "cattle-resistant" that grows on fragrant mountain slopes, and all cattle refuse to eat it. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood is likewise. This constitutes a detailed and well-answered reply.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if the intrinsic nature of buddhahood has five, six, or seven aspects and something of it exists in the future — may it be said that a person whose roots of virtue have been severed also possesses the intrinsic nature of buddhahood?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, just as sentient beings have past karma, and due to that karma a result ripens for them in this present life, so too future karma, not yet having arisen, has not yet produced its result. There are present afflictions, and if those afflictions were absent, all sentient beings would straightaway perceive the intrinsic nature of buddhahood

directly. Therefore, although a person whose roots of virtue have been severed has indeed had those roots severed by the condition of present-moment afflictions, through the power of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood that pertains to the future, the roots of virtue will arise again."

Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, how would the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the future produce roots of virtue?"

"Son of good family, consider a lamp or the sun: even though they have not yet appeared, they are capable of illuminating darkness. In just the same way, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the future brings forth the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of the future within sentient beings. This constitutes a detailed and well-answered reply."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, if the five aggregates are the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, why did you say that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of sentient beings is neither within nor without?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, why have you become confused in this way? Did I not previously say that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood of sentient beings is the Middle Way?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, I myself am not confused. Yet sentient beings are unable to understand this Middle Way, and it is for their sake that I asked in this manner."

"Son of good family, what sentient beings do not understand is precisely the Middle Way. Regarding it, there is both understanding and non-understanding. Son of good family, in order to make what sentient beings do not understand into something they can understand, I have said that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither within nor without. Why so? Because among sentient beings who are ordinary, childish persons, some say: 'The intrinsic nature of buddhahood abides within the five aggregates, just as fruit exists within a vessel.' Others say: 'It exists apart from the aggregates, like empty space.' It is for this reason that the Tathāgata has taught the Middle Way. The intrinsic nature of buddhahood of sentient beings is not the six inner sense bases, nor is it the six outer sense bases; what arises from the meeting of inner and outer is called the Middle Way. Therefore the Tathāgata has said: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself is the Middle Way."

That which is neither within nor without is called the Middle Way. This constitutes a detailed and well-answered reply.

"Furthermore, son of good family, how is it that it is neither within nor without? Son of good family, some say: 'The intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself is a tīrthika view.'"

Why is this so? Because a bodhisattva, a great being, cuts through the afflictions produced by tīrthika teachings over immeasurable eons, thoroughly tames the mind, acts for the benefit of sentient beings, and thereby attains the unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is itself a tīrthika view.

Others say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is entry into the inner training. Why is this so? Because even if a bodhisattva were to practice tīrthika teachings for immeasurable eons, if the inner Dharma were abandoned, one could not attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself is entry into the inner training.

For this reason, in order to turn back from both extremes, the Tathāgata has declared: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither within nor without, and yet it is both inner and outer. That is called the Middle Way.

Furthermore, son of good family, some say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself is the vajra-like body of the Tathāgata, adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor excellent features. Why? Because it is infallible. Others say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is the ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the three close mindfulnesses, the heroic march meditative absorption, and all other meditative absorptions. Why? Because from those absorptions there arises the vajra-like body adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor excellent features.

Therefore, in order to turn back from both extremes, the Tathāgata has declared: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither within nor without, and yet it is both inner and outer. That is called the Middle Way.

Furthermore, son of good family, some say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is profound mental engagement within. Why? Because without that profound inner mental engagement, one cannot attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is profound mental engagement within.

Others say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is hearing the Dharma from another. Why? Because it is through hearing the Dharma from another that

profound inner mental engagement arises; if the Dharma were not heard, mental engagement would not arise. Therefore, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is hearing the Dharma from another.

For this reason, in order to turn back from both extremes, the Tathāgata has declared: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither within nor without, and yet it is both inner and outer. That is called the Middle Way.

Furthermore, son of good family, some say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is outer — it is the perfection of generosity. Through the perfection of generosity, unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening is attained. Therefore, they say, the perfection of generosity is the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Others say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is inner — it is the remaining five perfections. Why? Because one understands that apart from those five things, beyond them, there is nothing to be called the cause and result of the intrinsic nature of buddhahood. Therefore, they say, the five perfections are the intrinsic nature of buddhahood.

Therefore, in order to turn back from both extremes, the Tathāgata declared: "The intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither inner nor outer, yet it is both inner and outer." This is called the Middle Path.

Furthermore, noble children, some say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood abides within, and is comparable to the precious jewel in the forehead of the mighty being Mahābala. Why is this? Because permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity are likened to a jewel. Therefore, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exists within.

Others say this: the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exists without, and is comparable to a treasure of jewels beneath the house of a poor man. Why is this? Because it is to be seen through skillful means. Likewise, they say, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exists outside sentient beings and is to be seen through skillful means.

Therefore, in order to turn back from both extremes, the Tathāgata declared: "The intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither inner nor outer, nor is it both inner and outer." This is called the Middle Path.

Noble children, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is neither existent nor nonexistent. Why is this? The intrinsic nature of buddhahood does exist, yet it is not like empty space. Why? Because the empty space of the world cannot be apprehended as an object even by applying limitless skillful

means, whereas the intrinsic nature of buddhahood can be apprehended as an object. Therefore, although it exists, it is not comparable to empty space.

The intrinsic nature of buddhahood does not exist in the way ordinary things do, yet it is not comparable to a rabbit's horn. Why? Because the hair of a tortoise and the horn of a rabbit cannot be brought into being even by limitless and manifold skillful means, whereas the intrinsic nature of buddhahood can be brought into being. Therefore, although it does not exist, it is not comparable to a rabbit's horn.

Therefore, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither existent nor nonexistent, nor is it both existent and nonexistent.

In what sense is it existent? Because it is present in all beings and cannot be cut off or negated by sentient beings. Like the flame of a lamp, it will be attained, all the way up to the realization of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. Therefore it is called existent.

In what sense is it nonexistent? Because at this present time, in all sentient beings, permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity — all the qualities of buddhahood — are not yet present. Therefore it is called nonexistent.

The union of existence and nonexistence is called the Middle Way. Therefore the Blessed One declared: "The intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is neither existent nor nonexistent."

Noble children, suppose someone were to ask: "Is the fruit present within the seed or not?" One should answer both yes and no. Why? Because apart from the seed, the fruit will not arise; therefore one says it is present. And because no sprout has yet emerged from the seed, one says it is not present. Thus one may say both that it exists and that it does not exist. Why? The two differ in time, but their essential nature is one.

In the same way, the intrinsic nature of buddhahood in sentient beings is like that. To say that the intrinsic nature of buddhahood exists somewhere other than in sentient beings is not tenable. Why? Because sentient beings themselves are the intrinsic nature of buddhahood, and the intrinsic nature of buddhahood itself is sentient beings. It is simply that, owing to the difference in time, there is what we call purified and what we call unpurified.

Son of good family, if someone were to ask, "Can a seed produce a fruit, or is the fruit unable to be produced?" one should reply: "It both is produced and is not produced."

A question was posed: Blessed One, what is the meaning of worldly people saying, "Cream is present in milk"?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, whoever says "Cream exists in milk" — that is attachment. Whoever says "Cream does not exist" — that is speaking falsely. Apart from those two positions, one may certainly say both that it exists and that it does not exist. Why say that it exists? Because cream arises from milk: milk is the cause, cream is the result — therefore one says it exists. How then does one say it does not exist? Because their shape and taste are different, and their manner of drinking and use is different. For a fever disease, milk is given; for a diarrheal disease, cream is given. Milk gives rise to disorders of cold; cream provokes disorders of heat.

Son of good family, if someone says "The intrinsic nature of cream exists within milk" — then milk itself would be cream, and cream itself would be milk, and their intrinsic nature would be one. In that case, by what cause and conditions would milk appear first and cream not appear first? If there are causes and conditions, why did not everyone in the world say so from the very beginning? And if there are no causes and conditions, why did cream not appear right from the start? Since cream did not appear at the very beginning, who established the sequence of milk, cream, butter, clarified butter, and the essence of butter? Therefore, one should understand that cream has no beginning yet exists now. But if something has no beginning yet exists now, it would become a thing belonging to the category of impermanence.

Son of good family, if someone says, "Cream arises from milk because the intrinsic nature of cream is present in milk, whereas cream does not arise from water and grass because the intrinsic nature of cream is not present in water and grass" — that too is not the case. Why? Because the intrinsic nature of milk and cream is also present in water and grass. In what sense? It is because milk and cream arise from water and grass. Whoever says "The intrinsic nature of cream is definitely present in milk, but not in water and grass" — that person is speaking falsely. Why is it called speaking falsely? Because the mind is not in accord with reality.

Son of good family, if someone says "Cream definitely exists within milk," then since it would follow that milk could likewise arise from within cream, by what cause and conditions does cream arise from milk but milk does not arise from cream? If there are no causes and conditions, then cream is to be understood as having no beginning yet existing now. Therefore the wise say: "The intrinsic

nature of cream within milk is neither present nor absent."

Son of good family, for this reason, if the Tathāgata, in this sūtra, says "The intrinsic nature of buddhahood definitely exists in all sentient beings," that is attachment. If one says "It does not exist," that is speaking falsely. Those who are wise and endowed with wisdom should say: "The intrinsic nature of buddhahood is neither present nor absent."

Son of good family, from the assembly of four factors, visual consciousness arises. What are the four? The eye, form, light, and attention. The intrinsic nature of visual consciousness is not the eye, is not form, is not light, and is not attention — yet it arises from their assembly. In this way, visual consciousness has no beginning yet has come to exist now. Having existed, it will later cease to exist. Therefore one should understand that there is no such thing as a primordially existing intrinsic nature. In the same way, the intrinsic nature of cream within milk is like that as well.

If someone were to say, "Since the intrinsic nature of cream is absent in water, cream cannot arise from water — therefore the intrinsic nature of cream must certainly exist within milk," that too is not tenable. Why is that? Son of good family, all phenomena have different causes and different results. Not all results arise from a single cause, nor do all results come from a single cause. Son of good family, because visual consciousness arose from those four factors, it does not follow that auditory consciousness also arises from those same four factors. Son of good family, without the proper method, it is impossible for milk to become cream, or for butter to arise from cream. Seeing that this is impossible, skillful means are necessary. Son of good family, those who are skilled in means do not look, beyond the application of method, for milk having already become cream, nor do they look, all the way up to butter, for it having already become butter beyond the application of method. Son of good family, therefore I have taught in this sūtra that when a cause arises, a phenomenon exists, and when a cause ceases, a phenomenon does not exist.

Son of good family, consider the defining characteristic of salt: salt makes everything that is not salty become salty. If things that are not salty had the intrinsic nature of salt from the very beginning, why would people in the world go searching for salt? And if it were altogether absent from the beginning, then one would understand that what was absent from the beginning has come to exist now. Perhaps it is that through other conditions salt-tastiness comes about, and someone were to say, "All things that are not salty possess the

intrinsic nature of salt — it is simply that, being present in too small a quantity, it is not perceived; and because that intrinsic nature exists in some measure, salt makes things salty. If there were no intrinsic nature from the beginning, then even when salt exists, things would not become salty — just as, because the seed itself possesses the four great elements, through the condition of the four outer great elements a sprout, a stalk, branches, and leaves arise; the intrinsic nature of salt is similar to that." If one were to say this, that too is not tenable. Why is that? If the intrinsic nature of salt existed from the beginning in things that are not salty, then logically those non-salty things should also possess a portion of non-saltiness. If salt were to have in that way two intrinsic natures, why would it be necessary to use non-salty things at all? Therefore one should understand that salt does not have two intrinsic natures from the very beginning, and that just as with salt, so too is everything that is non-salty.

If someone were to say, "Through the power of the outer four great elements, the inner four great elements arise," that too is not tenable. Why is that? This is not skillful means but rather a teaching given in sequential order. Just as no phenomenon — from milk becoming cream all the way to butter — comes to be accomplished without method, so too the four great elements are like that. If the outer four great elements arose, why is it not seen that from the inner four great elements the outer four great elements arise in turn? It is like the tree fruit called śīrīṣa — though it is without density and without any solid core, when the Pleiades rise and the sky clears, a fruit of five finger-breadths grows. Yet that fruit did not truly arise from the outer four great elements alone.

Son of good family, just as I have taught the twelve branches of scripture, some were taught in accordance with my own intent, some were taught in accordance with the intent of others, and some were taught in accordance with the intent of both myself and others. How is it that some were taught in accordance with my own intent? It is like the occasion when five hundred monks asked Śāriputra (Śāriputra, the foremost disciple in wisdom): "Venerable one, what did the Blessed One teach as the cause of the body?" Śāriputra replied —

"Venerable one, since you have each attained perfect liberation, why do you ask such a question out of knowledge of one's own kind?" Among those monks, some spoke thus: "Venerable one, before I had attained perfect liberation, I thought: 'Ignorance is the cause of the body.' Attending to it in that way, I attained the fruit of arhathood." Others spoke thus: "Venerable one,

before I had attained perfect liberation, I thought: 'Craving and ignorance are the cause of the body.' Attending to it in that way, I attained the fruit of arhathood." Still others thought: "Formations, consciousness, name-and-form, the six sense bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, eating, sustaining, and the five objects of desire — these are the cause of the body."

Then those five hundred monks, each having spoken according to their own understanding, went to where the Blessed One was. They paid homage at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated him three times to the right, and having done so, stood to one side. Each of them presented to the Blessed One what they had understood. Then Śāriputra asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, which of these monks speaks correctly, and which does not?" The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, excellent! Excellent! Not a single one of the monks has spoken incorrectly." Śāriputra asked: "Blessed One, what is the Blessed One's intended meaning?" The Blessed One declared: "Śāriputra, I taught that parents are the cause of the body for the sake of sentient beings of the desire realm. That sūtra teaching was spoken in accordance with my own intent. Now, how is it that some teachings were spoken in accordance with the intent of others? For example, a householder named Pāla came to where I was and said: 'O Gautama, do you know illusion? If you know illusion, then illusion is something great. If you do not know illusion, then you do not possess the wisdom of omniscience.' I said: 'Householder, would you call someone who knows illusion an illusionist?' The householder replied: 'Excellent! Excellent! One who knows illusion is indeed called an illusionist.' The Blessed One declared: 'Householder, do you know that in Śrāvastī there is a king called Prasenajit (Prasenajit, the great king who fully defeats his enemies), and that there is one called Dūṣita (Breath-stealer of the base-born)?' The householder said: 'Gautama, I have known this from before.' The Blessed One declared: 'If you have known it from before, would it be fitting to call you base-born?' The householder said: 'Gautama, I know full well that he is base-born, yet this body of mine is not base-born.' The Blessed One declared: 'Householder, if, though knowing him to be base-born, you count yourself as not base-born, then why, when I know illusion, should I become an illusionist? Householder, in truth I know illusion; I know the cause of illusion; I know the karmic maturation of illusion; I know the craft of illusion; I know killing; I know the killer; I know the karmic maturation of killing; I know everything from liberation through killing down to wrong view; I know the person of wrong view; I know the karmic maturation of wrong view; and I know the liberation from wrong view.

Householder, if I were to say of what is not illusion that it is illusion, or of what is not wrong view that it is wrong view, I would thereby incur measureless blame and sin.' The householder said:"

"Gautama, if what you have said is so, then I have incurred great wrongdoing. I offer you now everything I possess. And let not what I have just said be heard by King Prasenajit, the Conqueror of Armies."

The Blessed One declared: "Householder, because of that wrongdoing you will not merely lose your wealth — because of it you will fall into the three lower destinies."

At that, when the householder heard the name of the three lower destinies, a mind of terror and dread arose in him, and he addressed the Blessed One thus: "Noble one, if through losing my senses today I have incurred great sin, the noble one is omniscient, and since you thoroughly know how liberation is attained, how shall I be liberated from rebirth in the hells, among the hungry ghosts, and among the animals?"

Thereupon the teaching of the Four Noble Truths was given to him on that very occasion. Having heard it, the householder attained the fruit of stream-entry, and a mind of shame and conscience arose in him. He said: "Out of my confusion I called what is not illusion an illusion to the Blessed One. Today I confess and repent before the Blessed One, and I take refuge in the Three Jewels."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent!" And he added: "This is called speaking in accordance with the minds of both oneself and others. Now, what is it to speak in accordance with the minds of both oneself and others? Just as I have taught, if the wise and learned of the entire world say that there are such things, I too say there are. If the wise and learned of the world say that the pleasures of the five objects of desire are impermanent, suffering, and selfless, and should be cut off, I too say that there are such things. If the wise and learned of the world say that in the pleasures of the five objects of desire there is no permanence, no happiness, no self, and no place of perfect purity, I too say that likewise there is no such place. This is called speaking in accordance with the minds of both oneself and others.

"Noble one, when I said that a bodhisattva on the tenth ground sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha only partially, that is called speaking in accordance with the minds of others. Why is it said that only a partial seeing occurs? It is because a bodhisattva on the tenth ground has attained three

thousand categories of Dharma such as the meditative absorption called Courageous Progress and the like, and thus knows that I have actualized unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — yet does not see that all sentient beings will without fail attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Therefore it is said that a bodhisattva on the tenth ground sees the intrinsic nature of a buddha only from one direction, and only partially.

"Noble one, when I constantly say that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, that is called speaking in accordance with my own mind. That all sentient beings are not annihilated and not extinguished, and will attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — this is spoken in accordance with my own mind. That all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha but do not see it because it is completely covered by afflictions — I too have said this very thing, and you too should teach this. This is called speaking in accordance with both one's own mind and the minds of others."

This is the forty-seventh fascicle of the noble Great Sūtra of the Passage into Nirvāṇa.

"Noble one, the Tathāgata has at certain times taught innumerable Dharmas with a single expression, just as it is said in the sūtras: 'The cause of all pure conduct is a spiritual friend.' Although the causes of all pure conduct are beyond count, all of them are included within the teaching on the spiritual friend."

Just as I have declared: "The cause of all non-virtue is wrong view" — although the causes of all non-virtuous conduct are beyond count, all of them are included within the teaching on wrong view.

Likewise, it has been declared: "The cause of unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening is a mind of faith" — although the causes that lead to awakening are beyond count, all of them are included within the teaching on a mind of faith.

Noble one, although the Tathāgata has declared the innumerable Dharmas he has taught to be the nature of a buddha, even so, they are none other than the aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources.

Noble one, in the Dharma that the Tathāgata has taught for the sake of sentient beings, there are seven kinds of expression: the causal expression, the resultant expression, the causal-and-resultant expression, the expression

by simile, the expression of what is unreasonable to assert, the expression that is universally current in the world, and the wish-fulfilling expression.

What then is the causal expression? It is a statement of a future result on the basis of a present cause. For example, I have declared: "Noble one, do you see this? Know that any sentient being who takes delight in killing — up to and including one who takes delight in wrong view — is a being of the hells. And know that any sentient being who takes no delight in killing — up to and including one who takes no delight in wrong view — is a god or a human." That is the causal expression.

What then is the resultant expression? It is a statement of a past cause on the basis of a present result. Just as it is said in the sūtras: "Noble one, consider what you observe: a sentient being who is poverty-stricken, ugly in complexion, and lacking in radiance — know for certain that such a one has a mind tainted by the stain of broken moral discipline, a mind of aversion, and a mind devoid of a sense of personal shame and a sense of social conscience. And if a sentient being is wealthy and very prosperous, endowed with fine faculties, possessed of majesty and self-mastery — know for certain that such a one has moral discipline, generosity, and diligence, possesses a sense of personal shame and social conscience, and is free of jealousy and aversion." That is the resultant expression.

What then is the causal-and-resultant expression? It corresponds to what is stated in the sūtras: "Noble one, the six sense sources of sentient beings in the present, and what is felt by those sense sources, are the result of past karma — and the Tathāgata has also declared this to be karma." That karma, through its conditions, yields a future result. That is the causal-and-resultant expression.

What then is the expression by simile? Just as, for example, the lion, king of beasts, is taken as a simile for my body — so too are the following used as similes in the sūtra texts: the great king of wild yaks, the great king of nāgas, the citron tree, the heap of the seven precious substances, the ocean, Mount Meru, the great earth, the great rain, the ship's captain, the caravan leader, one who tames persons, the greatly powerful, the finest of horses, the brahmin, the ascetic, the great city, the palmyra tree, and simile sūtras of that kind. Those are expressions by simile.

What then is the expression of what is unreasonable to assert? In the sūtras I have said such things as: "Heaven and earth will come to collide; a mountain

will come from the four directions to utterly defeat a king's army." And as has been said to the laywoman Khrisnaśāla's mother: "If this śāla tree were able to keep the eight precepts, it would experience the happiness of gods and humans." And also: "A bodhisattva on the tenth ground may still have a mind that turns back" — statements such as these are acceptable as figures of speech; but one should not say "The Tathāgata has two kinds of expression," just as one should not say "A stream-enterer (Skt. *srotāpanna*) falls into one of the three lower destinies" —

— the statement that "a bodhisattva on the tenth ground may still have a mind that turns back" is an expression that is wrong to say.

Now, what are expressions that extend worldly usage? As the Blessed One has taught: birth, woman, great, small, going, coming, sitting, lying down, a chariot, a vehicle, a residence, a house, a pot, a garment, a sentient being, permanence, happiness, self, complete purity, an army, a forest, a village, a city, the Saṅgha, an illusion, assembly, and dispersal — these are expressions that extend worldly usage.

What then are expressions of intentional meaning? As when I have reprimanded someone who has broken a vow, and through my remorse they have come to maintain their ethical vows; and as when, by praising a stream-enterer, ignoble persons have given rise to a virtuous mind; and as when, by praising a bodhisattva, sentient beings have given rise to the mind of awakening; and as when the suffering of the three lower destinies has been described in order to inspire the cultivation of virtuous qualities; and as when all conditioned phenomena have been described as "burning" on account of the nature of conditioned things; and as when — similar to no-self, in order to prevent all carelessness and heedlessness — it has been taught that all sentient beings possess the nature of a buddha: these are to be called expressions of intentional meaning.

Son of good family, there is further a mode of speech in which the Tathāgata speaks by associating his own intention with a statement. The nature of a buddha as a Tathāgata is twofold: what is present and what is absent.

What is present is as follows: the thirty-two major marks and eighty excellent minor marks, the ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, the three foundations of mindfulness, great loving-kindness, great compassion, the meditative absorption known as the heroic march (*sūraṃgama*) and countless other absorptions, the vajra-like absorption and countless others, the absorption of

skillful means and countless others, the absorption of the five gnoses and countless others — all of this is what is meant by "what is present."

What is absent is as follows: the Tathāgata's past virtuous actions and non-virtuous actions, the indeterminate, karma, cause, effect, karmic maturation, mental affliction, the five aggregates, and the twelve links of dependent origination — all of this is what is meant by "what is absent."

Son of good family, just as there are the categories of "what is present" and "what is absent," so too the Tathāgata speaks in terms of pairs: virtue and non-virtue, defiled and undefiled, worldly and supramundane, noble and ignoble, conditioned and unconditioned, correct and incorrect, peaceful and unpeaceful, contentious and non-contentious, being of the realm and not being of the realm, afflicted and unafflicted, grasped and ungrasped, prophesied and unprophesied, existent and non-existent, the three times and not the three times, time and non-time, permanent and impermanent, self and no-self, happiness and the absence of happiness, completely pure and incompletely pure; form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness, and what is not form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness; inner sense bases and what are not inner sense bases, outer sense bases and what are not outer sense bases,

the twelve links of dependent origination, and what is not the twelve links of dependent origination — these are said to be the presence and absence of the intrinsic nature of a buddha in a Tathāgata. And it is the same, all the way through, for the presence and absence of the intrinsic nature of a buddha in one who holds wrong craving.

Son of good family, although I have declared that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, sentient beings do not understand that this is a statement the Tathāgata made in accordance with his own intention. Son of good family, even a bodhisattva with only one more birth to go before awakening is unable to understand these words — how much less could those of the two vehicles or other bodhisattvas understand them?

Son of good family, once upon a time in the past I was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain, and when I engaged in a teaching on conventional truth with the bodhisattva Maitreya, even the five hundred hearers headed by Śāriputra were unable to know or comprehend those things. How much less could they comprehend the ultimate truth that transcends the world?

Son of good family, there are aspects of the intrinsic nature of a buddha that are present in those who hold wrong craving and absent in those who have roots of virtue. There are aspects of the intrinsic nature of a buddha that are present in those who have roots of virtue and absent in those who hold wrong craving. There are aspects of the intrinsic nature of a buddha that are present in both. And there are aspects of the intrinsic nature of a buddha that are absent in both.

Son of good family, among those who are my attendants, whoever understands the meaning of those four categories of statements should not be asked with certainty whether the intrinsic nature of a buddha is definitely present or definitely absent in one who holds wrong craving.

The statement that all sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha is a statement the Tathāgata made in accordance with his own intention. If even the Tathāgata made it in accordance with his own intention, why do sentient beings take it as a one-sided view?

Son of good family, consider the seven kinds of beings living in the waters of the Gaṅgā river: those that are always submerged, those that rise for a moment and then submerge again, those that rise and remain at the surface, those that rise and look in all four directions, those that look all around and then move on, those that move on and then rest, and those that travel both in water and on dry land.

Among these, those that are always submerged are the great fish who, through the maturation of great non-virtuous karma, have such heavy bodies that they remain in the depths of the water and therefore are always submerged. Those that rise for a moment and then submerge again are the great fish who, through the maturation of non-virtuous karma, have heavy bodies and dwell not far below the surface; for a brief instant they perceive the light of day, but on account of that flash of light they rise for only an instant, and because of the heaviness of their bodies they submerge once more. Those that rise and remain are the fish called Dvividya, who dwell in the shallower water and delight in seeing the light of day. Those that rise and look in all four directions are the fish called Tsakgu, who look in all four directions in search of food. Those that look all around and then move on are those fish called Tsakgu who, seeing whatever food appears in the distance, think "that is food" and swim swiftly toward it — that is what is meant by looking and then moving on. Those that move on and then rest are those fish that, having gone to that

place, find something fit to eat and then stop — that is what is meant by moving on and then resting. Those that travel both in water and on dry land are tortoises.

Son of good family, within the great sacred river of the great, complete nirvāṇa there are likewise seven kinds of beings, from the always submerged to the seventh, and in between some are submerged and some emerge. Among these, the always submerged are those who, reading this sūtra of the great complete nirvāṇa, conclude that the Tathāgata abides permanently without change or alteration, and that therefore, being permanent, blissful, self, and completely pure, he will ultimately never pass into nirvāṇa. All sentient beings possess the intrinsic nature of a buddha, they say — including those who hold wrong craving, and

those who commit the grave offense of scorning the extensive sūtra, who commit the five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya), and who violate the four root precepts — all of these, they declare, will without fail attain complete awakening. And hearing it taught that stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, arhats, and pratyekabuddhas will all without fail arrive at unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, no faith arises in their minds. Thinking to themselves, they speak these words: "This sūtra of the great complete nirvāṇa is a tīrthika text — it was not taught by the Buddha." Having said this, they part from their virtuous spiritual friends and do not hear the sacred Dharma. And even if they happen to hear it occasionally, they are unable to take it to heart. And even if they do take it to heart, they do not attend to it virtuously. Not attending to it virtuously, they come to dwell in non-virtuous phenomena.

Dwelling in non-virtuous phenomena has six aspects: non-virtue, the absence of virtue, the defiling of Dharma, the generation of further existence, being tormented by afflictions, and the experience of the results of non-virtue. This is called "submersion."

As for how one is submerged: having no virtuous mind, perpetually engaging in non-virtue, and not diligently applying the antidotes — this is called submersion.

Now, "non-virtue" means acting in ways that are condemned by noble ones, that give rise to a mind of fear, that are abandoned by virtuous spiritual friends, and that are of no benefit to sentient beings — for these reasons it is called non-virtue.

"The absence of virtue" means producing an incalculable quantity of the results of non-virtue, being perpetually overpowered by ignorance, associating with and befriending the wicked, having no means by which to apply diligence to virtue, and having a mind that has become thoroughly inverted and is forever in error — for these reasons it is called the absence of virtue.

"The defiling of Dharma" means perpetually defiling body and speech, defiling the purity of sentient beings, generating unwholesome karma, and abandoning virtuous phenomena — for these reasons it is called the defiling of Dharma.

"The generation of further existence" means that when one has fully accomplished the three qualities mentioned above, one is born in the hells, in the realm of animals, or among hungry ghosts; and not applying diligence to the qualities of liberation, one feels no weariness toward the actions of body, speech, and mind that perpetuate existence — this is called the generation of further existence.

"Being tormented by afflictions" means that when one has fully accomplished the four qualities mentioned above, body and mind become afflicted. It is called torment because one abandons peace. It is called torment because one experiences the karmic maturation of the hell realms. It is called torment because sentient beings are scorched. It is called torment because all virtuous phenomena are scorched. Noble son, the mind of faith is cool and satisfying — it is called torment because one is deprived of it.

"The experience of the results of non-virtue" means that when one has fully accomplished the five qualities mentioned above, at death one falls into the hells, into the realm of animals, or into the realm of hungry ghosts. Noble son, there is yet another way in which the experience of the results of non-virtue is described — through three aspects of non-virtuous things. What are the three? Afflictions that are non-virtuous, karma that is non-virtuous, and karmic maturation that is non-virtuous — this is called the experience of the matured result of non-virtue.

Noble son, when a person possesses the six qualities described above, they cut the roots of virtue. They commit the five acts of immediate retribution, they destroy the restraint of the four root precepts, they slander the Three Jewels, they use the wealth of the Saṅgha willfully for themselves,

they perform various non-Dharmic acts. Through those causes and those conditions, they sink into the Avīci hell — the hell of immediate retribution —

and the body they experience there extends to some eighty-four thousand leagues in size. The karma of their body, speech, and mind is so heavily weighted that they are unable to arise from it. Why is that? Because the mind is unable to generate any virtuous Dharma. Even though countless Tathāgatas appear in the world, such beings neither see nor hear them. They are therefore compared to the great fish of the Ganges river that has sunk — this is called "sinking."

Noble son, I have said that those who possess false craving always sink. Yet there are also those who always sink but do not possess false craving. Who are they? Those who practice the virtue of generosity and keeping moral discipline for the sake of continued existence — they too are called "those who always sink."

Noble son, through these four kinds of virtuous acts, the fruit of non-virtue is obtained. What are the four? Reading and reciting sūtras and texts out of a wish to be considered superior to others; holding the vow of moral discipline for the sake of gain and renown; practicing generosity in order to exercise power over others; and focusing the mind one-pointedly for the sake of the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Through these four virtuous things, the ripening of the fruit of non-virtue comes about. Those who act through these four kinds of things are said to rise up from sinking, only to sink again. Why do they sink? Because they are attached to the three realms of existence. Why do they rise? Because they see the light of appearance. The light of appearance is: learning, moral discipline, generosity, and meditative absorption. Why do they sink again? Because they harbor wrong views and cultivate pride. Therefore I have spoken these verses in the sūtra:

Whatever sentient being, attached to existence,
performs virtuous and non-virtuous karma through that existence —
such a one is led astray from the path of nirvāṇa,
arising for a moment, then sinking again.

Those who wander in the dark ocean of saṃsāra,
even if freed for a time, still bear afflictions with them;
and so they gather the fruit of non-virtue once more,
arising for a moment, then sinking again.

Noble son, just as the great fish, upon seeing the light of appearance, rises for a moment yet sinks again because of the heaviness of its body, so too are both the foregoing types of individuals.

Noble son, if anyone is attached to the three realms of existence, that is called "sinking." If, upon hearing this sūtra of great complete nirvāṇa, one generates a mind of faith, that is called "arising." By what cause and through what condition is it called "arising"? Having heard this sūtra, one abandons all non-virtuous phenomena and cultivates virtuous phenomena — this is called "arising." Yet although faith is present, one cannot be said to possess it fully. By what cause and through what condition is one said not to fully possess faith? Because that individual has faith that great complete nirvāṇa is permanent, blissful, self, and perfectly pure, yet claims that the body of the Tathāgata is impermanent, devoid of bliss, without self, and impure. Regarding the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa, there are two kinds: conditioned and unconditioned. The conditioned nirvāṇa lacks permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity. The unconditioned nirvāṇa possesses permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity. Such a person has confidence that buddha-nature exists in sentient beings, yet does not have certainty that it exists in all — therefore they are said not to fully possess faith.

Noble son, faith is of two kinds: faith and seeking.

That person possesses faith, yet is unable to seek and strive — nonetheless, they should not be called one who does not fully possess faith.

Again, there are two kinds: faith born from hearing, and faith born from reflection. If one's faith is born from hearing but not from reflection, one is said not to fully possess faith.

Again, there are two kinds: faith that awakening exists, and faith that attaining it is possible. If one's mind has faith that awakening exists yet does not have confidence that attaining it is possible, one is said not to fully possess faith.

Again, there are two kinds: faith in what is correct, and faith in what is wrong. One who says that cause and result exist, and that the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha exist — that is faith in what is correct. One who says that cause and result do not exist, that the defining marks of the Three Jewels are different from one another, and who places confidence in wrong views such as those of Kāśyapa the Perfector and the like — that is called faith in what is wrong. If a person has faith in the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, yet does not have confidence that the defining marks of the Three Jewels are one, and has faith that cause and result exist yet does not have confidence that attainment is possible — such a person is said not to fully possess faith. One who does not fully possess faith is likewise not one who fully possesses moral

discipline.

If one asks by what cause and condition they are said not to fully possess it — it is because they lack the cause that they do not fully possess moral discipline.

And if one asks further why they are said not to fully possess it — moral discipline is of two kinds: the moral discipline of ritual observance, and the moral discipline that is genuine ethics. One who possesses only the moral discipline of ritual observance and does not possess the moral discipline that is genuine ethics is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Again, there are two kinds: the moral discipline of commission and the moral discipline of refraining. One who possesses only the moral discipline of commission and does not possess the moral discipline of refraining is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Again, there are two kinds: obtaining right livelihood through body and speech, and not obtaining right livelihood through body and speech. One who does not obtain right livelihood through body and speech is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Again, there are two kinds: the moral discipline that seeks existence, and the moral discipline that relinquishes it. One who possesses only the moral discipline that seeks continued existence and does not possess the moral discipline that relinquishes it is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Again, there are two kinds: the moral discipline oriented toward existence, and the moral discipline oriented toward awakening. One who possesses only the moral discipline oriented toward existence and does not possess the moral discipline oriented toward awakening is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Moral discipline is again of two kinds: virtuous moral discipline and non-virtuous moral discipline. Virtuous conduct of body, speech, and mind constitutes virtuous moral discipline. The vow of the cow and the vow of the dog constitute non-virtuous moral discipline. One who has confidence that those two disciplines yield virtuous results is said not to fully possess moral discipline.

Thus, one who does not fully possess these two things — the substance of faith and moral discipline — will also not be one who applies diligence to extensive learning. As for how one does not fully possess learning: among the twelve

branches of scripture spoken by the Tathāgata, one who has faith in six branches but not in the other six is said not to fully possess learning. Likewise, even one who holds six scriptural branches yet is unable to read them, recite them, teach them to others, or render benefit — such a person is said not to fully possess learning. And further, even one who holds six scriptural branches yet does so for the sake of disputation —

— or who holds six scriptural branches in order to triumph over others, or for the sake of gain and fame, or who grasps, reads, recites, and expounds them for the sake of continued existence in the round of becoming — such a person is said not to fully possess learning.

Son of good family, I have now explained what it means to possess learning as described in the sūtras. What, then, does it mean to possess it? If a certain monk reveres, with body, speech, and mind, his preceptors, teachers, and those who are virtuous — if he pays them homage in this way — then those teachers will come to feel a mind of loving-kindness toward him, and through that condition they will teach him the sūtras and the Dharma. He in turn will hold them with one-pointed mind, reciting and familiarizing himself with them. Through holding, reciting, and growing familiar with them, he will attain wisdom. Having attained wisdom in this way, he will apply it with great diligence and will abide in accordance with the Dharma. Having applied it with great diligence and abided thus, he will attain the genuine meaning. Having attained the genuine meaning, his body and mind will become secluded. When body and mind have become secluded, a mind of joy will arise. Through the condition of that joyful mind, he will attain the mind of meditative absorption. Because he has attained the mind of meditative absorption, he will attain right knowledge and vision. Having attained right knowledge and vision, a mind of disenchantment with all states of becoming will arise. Through disenchantment with all states of becoming, he will attain complete liberation. One who lacks all such qualities as these is said not to fully possess attainment.

One who lacks all three of those qualities will likewise not fully possess generosity. Now, generosity is of two kinds: material generosity and the generosity of Dharma. Such a person may indeed practise material generosity, yet he seeks continued existence in the round of becoming. He may practise the generosity of Dharma, yet he will not possess it fully — and why is that? Fearing that others might surpass him, he withholds and does not teach everything: this is said to be not fully possessing generosity. Both material

generosity and the generosity of Dharma each have two forms: noble and non-noble. The noble one, having given, places no hope in the ripening of a fruit as result. The non-noble one, having given, hopes for the ripening of a fruit as result. The noble one practises the generosity of Dharma in order to cause the Dharma to flourish. The non-noble one practises the generosity of Dharma in order to cause continued becoming to flourish — just as practising material generosity in order to cause material gain to increase, and practising the generosity of Dharma in order to cause the states of becoming to increase, is called not fully possessing generosity.

Furthermore, such a person holds six branches of scripture, and provides the needs of those who hold the Dharma, yet does not provide the needs of those who do not hold the Dharma — therefore this too is called not fully possessing generosity.

In this way, a person who lacks those four qualities described above will also not fully possess diligence in wisdom. The defining characteristic of wisdom is discernment by its intrinsic nature. Such a person fails to discern whether the Tathāgata is permanent or impermanent, and is unable to comprehend it. Moreover, in the sūtra of the Tathāgata's complete nirvāṇa it is declared: "The Tathāgata is complete liberation; complete liberation is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata himself is nirvāṇa; nirvāṇa itself is complete liberation." He neither discerns nor is able to comprehend the distinctions among these meanings. The perfectly pure life itself is the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata himself is loving-kindness, compassion, equanimity, and joy. Loving-kindness, compassion, equanimity, and joy are themselves complete liberation.

Complete liberation itself is complete nirvāṇa. Complete nirvāṇa itself is the four immeasurables." These meanings too — the inability to discern their distinctions — is what is called lacking wisdom.

Furthermore, what one is unable to distinguish is this: the intrinsic nature of a buddha is itself the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata himself is all the unmingled qualities. The unmingled qualities themselves are liberation. Liberation itself is complete nirvāṇa. Complete nirvāṇa itself is the unmingled qualities. These meanings too — the inability to discern their distinctions — is what is called lacking wisdom.

Yet another thing one is unable to distinguish is the Four Noble Truths: suffering, its origin, its cessation, and the path. Because one does not discern the distinctions among the Four Noble Truths, one does not know the conduct

of the noble ones. Not knowing the conduct of the noble ones, one does not know the Tathāgata. Not knowing the Tathāgata, one does not know the Tathāgata's liberation. Not knowing liberation, one does not know nirvāṇa. For these reasons one is called lacking wisdom.

Ordinary beings who lack the five things mentioned above do so for two reasons: they give rise to wholesome qualities, and they give rise to unwholesome qualities. How does one give rise to unwholesome qualities? Such a person, not seeing that the self is without inherent selfhood, generates a mind that clings to possessing a self. Within a community of those under equal training, one thinks, "I am the best." For that reason, one associates with companions of like mind who are unwholesome. Through such association, one will come to hear teachings that are further lacking. Having heard them, the mind becomes delighted and attached. One generates pride and arrogance and falls into widespread heedlessness. Through the condition of heedlessness, one becomes attached to associating with householders and to discussing and listening to the affairs of the household life, and one abandons the pure qualities of the renunciate life. Through that cause and that condition, unwholesome qualities are produced. Because unwholesome qualities are produced, one generates impure actions through the three doors of body, speech, and mind. Through the complete impurity of these three kinds of action, one produces rebirth in the hells, in the realm of animals, and in the realm of hungry ghosts. This is called: arising in a moment and then fading away.

As for the beings whose qualities are called "arising in a moment and then fading away," they are the following: the god Devadatta, the monk Kokālika, the monk Āṇśu, the monk Supraṭiṣṭhita, the monk Tīsa, the monk Karmagupta, the nun Maitreyī, the nun Āraṇyikā, the nun Diśā, the nun Mānā, the householder Suparīśuddha, the layman Bhavārthin, the Śākya Śāli, the householder Balendra, the laywoman Yaśomatī, the laywoman Ābhā, the laywoman Priyā, the laywoman Gaṇadāsā, and the laywoman Ghaṇṭā — these and others like them are called "arising in a moment and then fading away." It is like a great fish that rises up on seeing the light, but sinks back down because of the weight of its body.

By contrast, those of lesser station among such persons, recognizing that their own view and conduct are lacking, and recognizing that they are indeed lacking in this way, seek out and rely upon a spiritual friend (kalyāṇamitra). By relying on a spiritual friend, they become eager to ask about what they have

not yet heard. Having heard, they become eager to retain it. Having retained it, they take joy in reflecting upon it carefully. Having reflected carefully, they come to abide in accordance with the Dharma. Abiding in accordance with the Dharma, they cause wholesome qualities to increase.

Because wholesome qualities thus increase, they never decline. This is called abiding.

Who are those that abide in the Dharma of the buddhas? They are as follows: Śāriputra and Mahāmaudgalyāyana; the five including Ājñāta-Kauṇḍinya; the five monks including Yaśas; Anurāddha; young Kāśyapa; Mahākāśyapa; Kāśyapa of the Ten Powers; the nun Skye-dgu'i-bdag-mo; the nun Pāṭali-flower; the nun Damma; the nun Paramārtha; the nun Buddhi-mother; the nun Pāṭalā; the nun Purity; the nun Irreversible; King Bimbasāra; the householder Ugra; the householder Anāthapiṇḍada; the great Śākya-name; the poor Anātha-food-giver; the householder Son-of-Śreṣṭhin; the householder Yaśas; the householder Endowed-with-All; the minister Siṃha; the householder Upāli; the householder Sword; the laywoman Fearless; the laywoman Virtuous-Dweller; the laywoman Dharma-Devoted; the laywoman Courageous; the laywoman God-Given; the laywoman Well-Born; the laywoman Form-Endowed; the laywoman She-Who-Obtained-the-Best-of-Herds; the laywoman Solitary; and the laywoman Mahāsinā and others — these monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen are all called those who abide.

Why are they called those who abide? Because they are devoted to always beholding the luminous light of virtue. By that cause and that condition, whether a buddha has appeared in the world or has not appeared, those persons never commit evil deeds. Therefore they are called those who abide. Just as the fish called the nyadibid, out of its delight in beholding the light, neither sinks nor disappears, so too are they like that. For this reason I have spoken these verses from the sūtras:

One who is skilled in discerning the meaning,
who with one-pointed focus earnestly seeks the fruit of the ascetic life,
and who utterly scorns all conditioned existence —
such a one is called one who abides in accordance with the Dharma.

One who makes offerings to the boundless Blessed One
will, for countless births, cultivate the path.

If one enjoys the pleasures of the world yet remains heedful,
such a one is called one who abides in accordance with the Dharma.

One who relies on a spiritual friend and listens to the sacred Dharma, who takes it to heart and abides in accordance with the Dharma, who is devoted to beholding the rays of light and cultivates the path — such a one will attain the blissful state of full liberation.

Noble child, for one who lacks wisdom there are five things. Once such a person recognizes this, he seeks out a spiritual friend. That spiritual friend in turn examines which is greatest among attachment, aversion, delusion, and conceptual thought. If attachment predominates, he teaches the Dharma of contemplating the impure. If aversion predominates, he teaches the Dharma of loving-kindness. If delusion predominates, he teaches dependent origination. If conceptual thought predominates, he teaches the counting of the breath. If attachment to the view of self predominates, he teaches the eighteen elements and so forth.

Having heard this, the student then grasps it with a one-pointed mind. Having grasped it with the mind, he applies himself diligently in accordance with the Dharma. Through diligent practice in accordance with the Dharma, he gradually attains the four close applications of mindfulness, and he comes to contemplate the body, feelings, mind, and mental phenomena. Having thus contemplated them, he gradually comes to investigate the twelve links of dependent origination. Having thus investigated them, he attains the quality of warmth.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the quality of warmth is present in all sentient beings. Why is that? Just as the Blessed One has declared that a sentient being is so called because three phenomena have come together — vitality, warmth, and consciousness — therefore, since warmth has from the very beginning been present in all sentient beings, why has the Tathāgata taught that the quality of warmth arises through the condition of a spiritual friend?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, when you say that the quality of warmth exists, it exists in all beings, right up to and including those with wrong craving. But as for how I have taught the quality of warmth: it is first obtained through the condition of skillful means, and what has been without beginning now becomes presently possessed. Therefore, since it has not been there from the very beginning in all sentient beings, it is not fitting for you to say that all sentient beings possess the quality of warmth.

"Son of good family, moreover, this quality of warmth is a phenomenon of the form realm; it is not found in the desire realm. If you were to say it exists in all sentient beings, then it would follow that it also exists in the sentient beings of the desire realm — but seeing that it is absent in the desire realm, you should understand that it does not exist in all beings without exception.

"Son of good family, it exists in the form realm, yet not in all beings. Why? Because it is present in my attendants but not in non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Therefore it does not exist in all sentient beings.

"Son of good family, all non-Buddhists contemplate only six kinds of conduct. My attendants, however, possess sixteen kinds of conduct, and these sixteen kinds of conduct are not present in all sentient beings."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, regarding what you have called the quality of warmth — how is it to be understood as warmth? Is it warm by its own intrinsic nature, or does it become warm through the power of another?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, this quality of warmth is warm by its own intrinsic nature; it does not become warm through the power of another."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said: "Blessed One, you have previously stated that the two — Aśvaka and Puṇarvasu — did not possess the quality of warmth. Why is that? Because they lacked a mind of faith in the Three Jewels, it is said they did not possess warmth. Therefore I would submit that faith itself is the quality of warmth."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, faith is not the quality of warmth. Why? Because warmth is subsequently obtained through the condition of a mind of faith.

"Son of good family, what is called the quality of warmth is wisdom. Why? Because it is the comprehension of the Four Noble Truths. This is why it is called the sixteen kinds of conduct — the conduct itself is wisdom.

"Son of good family, as to what cause and what condition make it called warmth: what is called warmth has the defining characteristic of the fire of the eight branches of the noble path, and therefore it is called warmth.

"Son of good family, consider this analogy: when fire is kindled by friction, warmth arises first, then fire appears, and afterwards smoke arises. The undefiled path is likewise: what is called warmth therein corresponds to the

sixteen kinds of conduct; what is called fire corresponds to something like the fruit of stream-entry; and smoke corresponds to the cutting off of all afflictions through the cultivation of the path."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, this quality of warmth is indeed a phenomenon of existence, and it is also a conditioned phenomenon. Because its karmic maturation, through the condition of the form realm, results in the obtaining of the five aggregates — for this reason it is called a phenomenon of existence."

"And because of its cause and its condition it is also called 'conditioned.' If it is conditioned, how can it serve as the defining mark of the undefiled path?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is just so. It is just as you have said. Son of good family, although this quality of warmth is indeed a conditioned phenomenon and a phenomenon of existence, conditioned and existential phenomena are also capable of destruction — and it is for that reason that it comes to serve as the defining mark of the undefiled path. Son of good family, just as someone who rides a wild horse both loves it and yet bends it to his will, the mind of warmth is similar: it takes rebirth for the sake of existence, and for the sake of rebirth it comprehends the formations. Therefore, although it is a phenomenon of existence and is conditioned, it nonetheless also comes to serve as the defining mark of the true path.

The number of persons who have attained the quality of warmth is seventy-three. Of these, the desire realm comprises ten kinds: persons possessed of all afflictions who cut away one part, and so on up to those who cut away nine parts. From the first dhyāna up through the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, it is likewise. These are called the seventy-three kinds. Persons who have attained the quality of warmth will not cut off the root of virtue, will not commit any of the heinous acts without interval, and will not transgress the four root precepts of moral discipline.

There are, however, two varieties: those who have encountered a virtuous spiritual friend, and those who have encountered an unwholesome spiritual friend. Of these, encountering an unwholesome spiritual friend arises for an instant and then subsides once more. Encountering a virtuous spiritual friend is like looking out in all four directions. This looking in all four directions is called the summit quality (Skt. mūrdhāna). Although the intrinsic nature of the summit quality is not the five aggregates as such, it takes the Four Noble Truths as its object — and for that reason it is called looking out in all four

directions. Having thus attained the summit quality, one then gradually attains patience. That patience too is similarly not the five aggregates as such in its intrinsic nature, yet it takes the Four Noble Truths as its object, and through it one gradually attains the highest worldly quality (Skt. *laukikāgradharma*). The intrinsic nature of that quality likewise is not the five aggregates, yet it takes the Four Noble Truths as its object, and through it one gradually attains the quality of patience toward suffering. The intrinsic nature of that patience is wisdom, and it takes a single truth as its object. In this way, through the quality of patience, one takes a single truth as its object and sees it; the afflictions to be abandoned by seeing are cut off, and thereby one attains the fruit of stream-entry. This is called looking out in all four directions, and here the four directions refer to the Four Noble Truths."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in keeping with what the Blessed One previously taught — that the stream-enterer's complete severing of afflictions is like a lake four leagues wide and four leagues deep filled with water, while what remains is like a single drop of dew on the tip of a hair — why was it said that when these three, namely the view of self, the view of taking what is not a cause as a cause, and the defilement of doubt, are cut off, one has entered the stream? Blessed One, for what cause and through what condition does a stream-enterer come to look out in all four directions? And again, for what cause and through what condition is one called a stream-enterer? And again, for what cause and through what condition is a stream-enterer like what is called a small fish?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, although a stream-enterer has cut off immeasurable numbers of afflictions,

all the afflictions cut off by every stream-enterer are contained within these three aspects. Son of good family, consider the analogy of a great king who, when he walks or travels, is accompanied by an army of four divisions, yet people of the world say simply, 'The king has come,' or 'The king has gone.' Why? Because in the world he is to be honored. These three afflictions are just like that. And why are they called 'weighty'? They are called weighty because all sentient beings continually give rise to them, and because they are subtle and difficult to discern with wisdom. These three afflictions are extremely difficult to cut off because they become the cause of all afflictions, and because they become the cause, as their antidote, of moral discipline, meditative absorption, and wisdom.

Son of good family, when certain sentient beings hear it said that a stream-enterer has entirely cut off an immeasurable number of afflictions, a mind of turning back arises in them, and they say, 'How can a sentient being cut off such an immeasurable number of afflictions?' For that reason the Tathāgata, through skillful means, taught this in three aspects.

As for what you asked — for what cause and through what condition does a stream-enterer look out in all four directions — son of good family, a stream-enterer, having thoroughly examined the Four Noble Truths, attains four kinds of things. What are they? Abiding on the firm path, complete investigation, seeing correctly just as things are, and the ability to defeat the great enemy. Of these, the firm path is the stream-enterer itself. It is called abiding on the firm path because no one can dislodge one from the five faculties. Complete investigation means scrutinizing all internal and external afflictions. Seeing correctly just as things are is the wisdom of patient acceptance. Defeating the great enemy refers to the four inversions.

As for what you asked — for what cause and through what condition is one called a stream-enterer — son of good family, 'stream' refers to what is undefiled. 'Entered' means cultivated. Because one cultivates the undefiled, one is called a stream-enterer.

Son of good family, furthermore, 'stream-enterer' means 'one who flows.' There are two kinds of flowing: flowing downward and flowing upward. Because one flows upward, one is called a stream-enterer.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: "Blessed One, if that is the meaning, why are those who return once, those who never return, and arhats not also called stream-enterers?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, from stream-enterer all the way up to a buddha, all may also be called stream-enterers. For if there were no stream-entry in the progression from once-returner to buddha, how could a once-returner be designated all the way up to a buddha? For every sentient being, there are two kinds of name: the old name and the name newly assigned. In one's base and inferior time, there exists a worldly name. Having attained the path, a new name is assigned, and so one is called a stream-enterer. Because it was attained first, one is called a stream-enterer; because it is attained afterward, one is called a once-returner. That very same one may also be called a stream-enterer and also a once-returner, and so it is designated all the way to 'buddha.'

Son of good family, there are two aspects of a stream-enterer: liberation and nirvāṇa. Because all noble ones possess both of these two aspects, they may be called stream-enterers and

once-returner all the way through to buddha, it is the same. Son of good family, a bodhisattva too may be called a stream-enterer. Why is that? A bodhisattva possesses the gnosis of exhaustion and the gnosis of non-arising. Since a stream-enterer likewise seeks those two aspects of gnosis, it is fitting to designate a stream-enterer as a bodhisattva as well. It is also fitting to call a stream-enterer a buddha. Why is that? Because one genuinely sees the path and completely severs the afflictions; because one becomes a cause and result of perfect and complete awakening; and because one is in accord with the path of perfect and complete awakening, whether mixed or unmixed with it. From once-returner through to arhat, it is the same.

Son of good family, a stream-enterer has two aspects: sharp faculties and dull faculties. One with dull faculties goes back and forth between gods and humans up to seven times. Among those with dull faculties there are further five varieties: some go back and forth six times, some five, some four, some three, and some two. One with sharp faculties will, in the present life itself, attain everything from the fruit of stream-entry through to arhat.

Son of good family, you asked why the example taken for a stream-enterer is the fish called tsak-gu. It is because that fish has four qualities. What are they? It is light because its bones are fine; it is light because it has fins; it delight in seeing the light of luminosity; and it holds on firmly.

A stream-enterer likewise has four qualities. The fineness of bone is an example for the thinness of the afflictions. Having fins is an example for insight and calm abiding. Delight in seeing the light of luminosity is an example for seeing the path. Holding on firmly means this: having heard the Tathāgata teach impermanence, suffering, selflessness, and impurity, one holds steadfastly and does not abandon it. For example, when the king of māras conjured an appearance resembling the form of a buddha, the householder named Dragshul saw it and was struck with fear. The māra, seeing that the householder's mind was shaken, said to him: "What I taught before as the Four Truths was not correct. Now I will teach you, for the first time, five truths, six aggregates, thirteen sense bases, and nineteen elements." But the householder, having heard this, examined all the defining characteristics of the Dharma and found that such a meaning was absent

there. Therefore, he held his mind unshaken and immovable. It is like that.

Here ends the forty-eighth fascicle of the noble Great Sūtra of the Parinirvāṇa.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One and said: Blessed One, is one called a stream-enterer because one previously attained the path, or is one called a stream-enterer because one attained the first fruit? If one is called a stream-enterer because one previously attained the path, then why is one who has attained the Dharma of patient acceptance of suffering not called a stream-enterer but rather called one who is approaching? And if one is called a stream-enterer because one attained the first fruit, then when a non-Buddhist has previously cut off the afflictions, gone to the sphere of nothingness, cultivated the undefiled path, and attained the fruit of non-return, why would that person not be called a stream-enterer?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, one is called a stream-enterer because one has attained the first fruit. As for your question — why should one who is a non-Buddhist and who has previously cut off the afflictions, gone to the sphere of nothingness, cultivated the undefiled path, and attained the fruit of non-return not be called a stream-enterer —

Son of good family, this is why one who has attained the first fruit is called a stream-enterer — for at that time such a person is possessed of eight wisdoms and sixteen modes of conduct. Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, one who has attained the fruit of non-return is likewise possessed of eight wisdoms and sixteen modes of conduct, so why is that person not called a stream-enterer?

Son of good family, the sixteen modes of defiled conduct are of two kinds: mixed and unmixed. The sixteen modes of undefiled conduct are likewise of two kinds: those oriented toward the fruit and those in which the fruit has been attained. The eight wisdoms are likewise of two kinds: those oriented toward the fruit and those in which the fruit has been attained. The stream-enterer has abandoned the sixteen mixed modes of conduct and attained the sixteen unmixed modes of conduct; has abandoned the eight wisdoms oriented toward the fruit and attained the eight fruits of wisdom. The non-returner is not like this. Therefore, one who has attained the first fruit is called a stream-enterer.

Son of good family, the stream-enterer focuses on the Four Noble Truths. The once-returner focuses on just the single truth of oneness. Therefore one who has attained the first fruit is called a stream-enterer. By virtue of that cause and that condition, the analogy of the fish is given. One who "goes about

looking in every direction" is the once-returner. One who "diligently applies oneself to the path with single-pointed focus" does so in order to cut through attachment, aversion, delusion, and pride — just as a fish looks in every direction in search of food. "Remaining, having ceased from going about" is like the non-returner who, having found food, stays still.

Now, the non-returner is briefly of two kinds: one who attains the fruit of non-return in the present life and then, having applied even greater diligent effort, attains the fruit of arhatship; and one who, having become attached to the peaceful meditative absorption of the form realm and the formless realm, does not take up aggregates in the desire realm — and is therefore called a non-returner.

Furthermore, the non-returner is of five kinds: one who attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state; one who attains nirvāṇa after taking a body; one who attains nirvāṇa through exertion; one who attains nirvāṇa without exertion; and one who attains nirvāṇa through the supreme stream.

Again, there are six kinds: one who attains nirvāṇa in the present life, and then the preceding five. Again, there are seven kinds: one who attains nirvāṇa in the formless realm, and then the preceding six.

As for those who attain nirvāṇa through exertion, there are two kinds: those who take two births and those who take four births. Of these, one who takes two births is of sharp faculties, and one who takes four births is of dull faculties.

Again, there are two kinds: those who have great diligence but lack the meditative absorption of mastery, and those who are lazy but possess the meditative absorption of mastery.

Again, there are two kinds: those who possess the meditative absorption of diligence, and those who possess neither of the two.

Son of good family, beings of the desire realm and the form realm have two kinds of karma: karma of activity and karma of birth-taking. One who attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state has only karma of activity and lacks karma of birth-taking. Therefore that person is called one who attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state — having cast off the aggregates of the desire realm, and because of sharp faculties, attaining nirvāṇa without having gone to the form realm. That is what is called attaining nirvāṇa in the intermediate state.

The non-returner has four kinds of intention: one who is neither in training nor beyond training; one who is in training; one who is beyond training; and one who attains nirvāṇa while being neither in training nor beyond training.

Now, how is it that one attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state?

Son of good family, of the four types of intention of the non-returner, two attain nirvāṇa and two do not attain nirvāṇa. Therefore the latter are called those who attain nirvāṇa in the intermediate state. As for those who attain nirvāṇa having taken up the aggregates, there are two kinds: those with the karma of activity and those with the karma of rebirth. Such a person casts off the aggregates of the desire realm, takes up the aggregates of the form realm, and through diligent application to the path, attains nirvāṇa at the end of life.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, if one who has reached the end of life is said to attain nirvāṇa, then why did you say that one attains nirvāṇa having taken up the aggregates?

The Blessed One replied: Son of good family, having taken up the aggregates, that person cuts off the afflictions of all three realms from the very beginning. Therefore it is said that one attains nirvāṇa having taken up the aggregates.

Son of good family, one who attains nirvāṇa through conduct is one who applies diligence to the path continuously, who, through the force of conditioned meditative absorption, completely cuts off the afflictions and attains nirvāṇa — this is called attaining nirvāṇa through conduct.

One who attains nirvāṇa through boundless conduct is one who, knowing that nirvāṇa is certain to come, becomes complacent for that very reason. Yet that person too, through the force of conditioned meditative absorption, attains nirvāṇa at the end of life. Therefore this is called attaining nirvāṇa without conduct.

As for what is called attaining nirvāṇa through a continuous stream: one who has attained the fourth dhyāna arises in the mind of joy belonging to the first dhyāna, and through the condition of that, is reborn in the first dhyāna. The stream has two kinds: the stream of affliction and the stream of the path. Through the stream of the path, at the end of life, the mind of joy arises with respect to the second dhyāna, and through the condition of joy, one is reborn in the second dhyāna. Likewise it continues in the same way up through the fourth dhyāna.

Within the fourth dhyāna itself there are also two kinds: those who proceed to the formless realm, and those who proceed to the five pure abodes. Of these two likewise, one delights in meditative absorption and one delights in wisdom. One who delights in wisdom proceeds to the five pure abodes. One who delights in meditative absorption proceeds to the formless realm.

Of these two likewise, one cultivates the fourth dhyāna with five distinctions and one does not cultivate it. What are the five? The lowest, the middling, the superior, the middling-superior, and the supreme-superior. Of these, one who cultivates the supreme-superior dwells in the heaven of Akaniṣṭha. One who cultivates the middling-superior dwells in the heaven of Sudarśana. One who cultivates the superior dwells in the heaven of Sudṛśa. One who cultivates the middling dwells in the heaven of Atapa. One who cultivates the lowest dwells in the heaven of Avṛha.

Of these two likewise, one delights in discourse and one delights in stillness. One who delights in stillness proceeds to the formless realm. One who delights in discourse dwells in the five pure abodes.

Again there are two kinds: one who cultivates dhyāna through familiarity and one who does not cultivate through familiarity. One who cultivates dhyāna through familiarity proceeds to the five pure abodes. One who does not cultivate through familiarity is reborn in the formless realm, attains nirvāṇa at the end of life, and this is called attaining nirvāṇa through a continuous stream.

One who wishes to proceed to the formless realm is unable to cultivate the four dhyānas and the five distinctions. One who cultivates the four dhyānas and the five distinctions does not engage in the formless absorptions.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked:

"Blessed One, is one who attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state a person of sharp faculties? If one is of sharp faculties, why does one not pass into nirvāṇa in the present time? And why does intermediate nirvāṇa exist in the desire realm but not in the form realm?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the present time such a person is unable to cultivate the path because the four great requisites are wanting. Monks, when those four great requisites — lodging, alms food, robes, bedding, and medical supplies and other necessities for illness — are lacking, one will not pass into nirvāṇa in the present time.

Son of good family, I shall tell you of a former time when I was dwelling in the great hall called An, in Śrāvastī. A monk came to where I was and said this: 'Blessed One, though I have constantly cultivated the path, I have not been able to attain any fruit from stream-entry up through the fruit of arhatship.' At that time I declared to Ānanda: 'You shall provide this monk with all his needs.'

Then Ānanda took that monk to the pleasure garden of Anāthapiṇḍada — the giver of food to the shelterless — and gave him a fine lodging. Then that monk said to Ānanda: 'Noble one, please have my lodging thoroughly purified and adorned with the seven precious substances, and have it decorated with silk crowns, banners, parasols, and the like.' Ānanda said: 'In the world a renunciant is called a pauper — where would I obtain all of that?' The monk replied: 'Noble one, if you will provide those things for me, good and well. If you will not provide them, I shall return to where the Blessed One is.'

Then Ānanda went to where the Blessed One was and spoke thus: 'Blessed One, that monk asks me for ornaments of the seven precious substances, crowns, banners, parasols, and various other such things. What am I to do?' At that time I again declared: 'Ānanda, go and provide that monk with all the necessary requisites according to his wish.'

Then Ānanda went back and provided all the requisites for that monk in full. Having received them, the monk cultivated with one-pointed concentration, and before long he attained every fruit from stream-entry up through the fruit of arhatship.

Son of good family, innumerable sentient beings fail to attain nirvāṇa because, being distracted and confused by the effort involved in fully attaining nirvāṇa, their minds become agitated. Son of good family, there are also sentient beings who, out of delight in performing many beneficial acts for beings, become so occupied that they do not attain meditative absorption, and thus have not attained nirvāṇa in the present time.

Son of good family, as for your question — why and through what causes and conditions intermediate nirvāṇa exists within the desire realm after abandoning the aggregates of the desire realm, but not in the form realm: son of good family, for that person the afflictions of the desire realm have two kinds of causes and conditions for conceptual elaboration — internal and external. In the form realm there are no external causes and conditions. In the desire realm there are two types of craving mind — craving for desire and craving for form. Having understood these two cravings, the mind condemns

them with full concentration, and having condemned them thus, one passes fully into nirvāṇa. The way in which the gross afflictions of the desire realm are condemned is as follows: attachment, aversion, shamelessness, and lack of conscientiousness — through those causes and those conditions, one attains the passing into nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, the nature of the path of the desire realm is courageous. Why is that?"

It is for the sake of attaining the four fruits. Therefore, intermediate nirvāṇa exists in the desire realm but not in the form realm. O son of good family, concerning intermediate nirvāṇa, there are three types according to the sūtras: superior, middling, and inferior.

The superior is to pass fully into nirvāṇa while abandoning the aggregates (skandhas) and without having separated from the desire realm. The middling is to pass fully into nirvāṇa immediately upon separating from the desire realm, without having gone to the form realm. The inferior is to pass fully into nirvāṇa after separating from the desire realm and drawing close to the form realm at the very beginning — like a small fish that stays in place having obtained food; that person is similar to it. When asked how one stays in place: one stays because one has taken up the aggregates in the form realm and the formless realm. One stays because one does not take a body as a god or human of the desire realm, or as a hell-being, or in an animal birth, or as a hungry ghost. One stays because, having cut off all the immeasurable afflictions entirely, a small remainder is left behind.

Furthermore, when asked for what cause and by what condition one is said to stay in place: one stays because, though pressed, one does not perform deeds that accord with base conduct. One stays because, having no fear for oneself, one does not cause fear in others. One stays because one abandons the craving of both attachment and aversion.

O son of good family, having reached the further shore is an analogy for the arhat, the pratyekabuddha, the bodhisattva, and the buddhas — just as a turtle is able to go both in water and on dry land. When asked for what cause and by what condition the turtle is taken as an analogy: it is because the turtle is able to exercise the five limbs with great skill. Likewise, from arhats up through the buddhas, they take the turtle as an analogy because they too are able to exercise the five faculties with great skill. As for "water" and "dry land": water is an analogy for the world, and dry land is analogous to that which

transcends the world. Those noble ones (āryas) likewise, having fully understood all the afflictions of sin and non-virtue and having gone to the further shore, are taken as examples from the ability to go both in water and on dry land.

O son of good family, just as in the great river Gaṅgā there are seven kinds of sentient beings — fish, turtles, and others each given their own separate names — yet none of them is other than water; likewise, within the great and sublime nirvāṇa, from those with distorted craving up through the buddhas, they are given their own separate names, yet none of them is other than the water of the buddha's intrinsic nature.

O son of good family, the virtue or non-virtue, the path of skillful means, the path of liberation, the path of gradual entry, the causes, or the fruits of those seven kinds of sentient beings — all of it is the intrinsic nature of a buddha. This is a statement that the Tathāgata spoke having applied it to his own mind.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, to whatever extent there is a cause, there will also be a fruit. If there is no cause, there is no fruit either. Nirvāṇa is called a fruit, yet for something permanent there is no cause. If there is no cause, how can it be called a fruit? That nirvāṇa itself is also called a śramaṇa (a contemplative), and it is also called the fruit of the śramaṇa. Then what is meant by "śramaṇa," and what is the fruit of the śramaṇa?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, throughout the entire world there are seven kinds of fruit. What are they? The fruit of skillful means, the fruit of repaying kindness, the fruit of rendering homage and service, the residual fruit, the fruit of equality,

the fruit of karmic maturation, and the fruit of abandonment. Now, as for the fruit of skillful means: just as people in the world speak of gathering many sheaves of grain together and say, "We have obtained, one from the other, the fruit of skillful means," what is called the fruit of skillful means is itself what is called the fruit produced by action. For that fruit there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is the seed. The distant cause is water, manure, and human labor. That is what is called the fruit of skillful means.

As for the fruit of repaying kindness: just as when worldly people make offerings to their parents, and the parents say, "We have received the repayment of the kindness of having raised this child," it is called the fruit

because the child has repaid the kindness. For that fruit too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is the virtuous karma previously performed by the parents. The distant cause is that a child possessed of dignity and grace is born. That is what is called the fruit of repaying kindness.

As for the fruit of rendering homage and service: for example, when someone renders homage and service to a spiritual friend, they will attain fruits ranging from the fruit of stream-entry all the way up to the fruit of the arhat. They then say, "I have obtained the fruit of having rendered homage and service." For that fruit too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is a mind of faith. The distant cause is the spiritual friend. That is what is called the fruit of rendering homage and service.

As for the residual fruit: just as, through the cause of not taking life, one enjoys long life in the third rebirth — that is the residual fruit. For that fruit too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is the purification of body, speech, and mind. The distant cause is the extension of the lifespan. That is what is called the residual fruit.

As for the fruit of equality: this refers to the world as a container vessel. For that fruit too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is sentient beings conducting themselves in the ten virtuous actions. The distant cause is the third cosmic age. That is what is called the fruit of equality.

As for the fruit of karmic maturation: when an individual obtains a perfectly pure body, they perform perfectly pure actions of body, speech, and mind — this is comparable to one saying, "I have obtained the fruit of karmic maturation." For that fruit too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is the present perfect purity of body, speech, and mind. The distant cause is the perfect purity of body, speech, and mind in the past. That is what is called the fruit of karmic maturation.

As for the fruit of abandonment: through complete nirvāṇa, the mental afflictions are abandoned. All virtuous karma is the cause of nirvāṇa. For that too there are two kinds of cause: the proximate cause and the distant cause. The proximate cause in this case is the three doors of liberation. The distant

cause is the cultivation of virtuous phenomena across countless births. That is what is called the fruit of abandonment.

O son of good family, just as it is explained that for phenomena within the world there exists a cause of arising and also a cause of manifestation, so too it is explained that for phenomena which transcend the world there likewise exists a cause of arising and also a cause of manifestation.

O son of good family, the three doors of liberation and the thirty-seven factors of awakening (bodhipakṣadharmā) are the cause for the non-arising of all afflictions, and they also serve as the cause of the manifestation of nirvāṇa. O son of good family, when the afflictions are abandoned, nirvāṇa is thereupon seen clearly and directly. Therefore, with regard to nirvāṇa, there exists only a cause of manifestation, and there is no cause of arising.

O son of good family, you ask: what is it that is called a śramaṇa, and what is it that is called the fruit of a śramaṇa? O son of good family, what is called a śramaṇa is the noble eightfold path. What is called the fruit of a śramaṇa is the complete cutting off of attachment, aversion, and delusion by means of the noble path. These, then, are what are called the śramaṇa and the fruit of the śramaṇa.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, for what cause and by what condition is the noble eightfold path called the path of a śramaṇa?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, worldly people call virtue something that does not satisfy, and they call the practice of refinement a path. Thus that path cuts through everything that does not satisfy and cuts through all false paths. For this reason, the eight branches of the noble path are called śramaṇa. And because the fruit is obtained from that path, it is called the fruit of the śramaṇa.

O son of good family, furthermore, just as one who in the world delights in solitude is called a śramaṇa, so too that path is similarly called śramaṇa because the yogins, having abandoned non-virtuous wrong livelihood and all such faults of body, speech, and mind, thereby attain delight in the peaceful solitude.

O son of good family, furthermore, just as in the world one who elevates the lowest among human beings to the highest among human beings is called a śramaṇa, so too that path is similarly called śramaṇa because it elevates the lowest among human beings to the highest among human beings.

O son of good family, an arhat who cultivates that path will attain the fruit of a śramaṇa, and for that reason is called one who has gone beyond, one who is perfected. What is called the fruit of an arhat is the state beyond training, which comprises five limbs of the dharmakāya: moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge and vision of liberation. By means of those five limbs one becomes fully perfected, and therefore this is called having gone beyond, having arrived at the far shore.

Having thus gone beyond, one declares: "My births are exhausted. The holy life is fulfilled. What had to be done has been done. I will not take on another existence." O son of good family, that arhat declares "My births are exhausted" because the causes of birth in all three times have been completely severed. He declares "My births are exhausted" because the body of the five aggregates (skandhas) of the three realms has been cut off. He declares "The holy life is fulfilled" because the holy life has reached its final culmination. He also declares "The holy life is fulfilled" because he has relinquished the path of training. He declares "What had to be done has been done" because what was sought from the very beginning has now been obtained. He also declares "What had to be done has been done" because, having cultivated the path, the fruit has been obtained. He declares "I will not take on another existence" because, having obtained the wisdom of exhaustion and non-arising, he has purified without remainder all the afflictions bound up with existence. For these reasons, arhats are called those who have gone beyond, those who are perfected.

Just as an arhat is described in this way, so too is a pratyekabuddha. As for bodhisattvas and the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, they are called those who have gone beyond, those who are perfected, because they have fully completed the six perfections.

Buddhas and bodhisattvas are called those who have fully completed the six perfections because they have attained unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. Why is this? It is because they have obtained the fruit of the six perfections. Having thus obtained the fruit, they are called perfected.

O son of noble lineage, those seven types of sentient beings do not cultivate the body, do not cultivate moral discipline, do not cultivate mind, and do not cultivate wisdom. Because they are incapable of cultivating these four kinds of things, through the fault of the five acts of immediate retribution they sever the roots of virtue, they breach the four root precepts, and they denigrate the

Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. For these reasons they are said to be in perpetual decline.

O son of noble lineage, among those seven types of sentient beings, some possess all seven characteristics together, while others possess them one by one.

O son of noble lineage, whoever relies upon a spiritual friend, and with one-pointed mind listens to and receives the sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata, then deeply takes it to heart inwardly, abides in accordance with the Dharma, and strenuously applies himself to the cultivation of body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom — such a one crosses the flood of saṃsāra and is said to have arrived at the farther shore.

If someone says that those with wrong craving have attained unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening, that is attachment and clinging. If someone says they cannot attain it, that is not correct either.

O son of noble lineage, among those seven types of persons, some are endowed with all seven together, and others with each one individually.

O son of noble lineage, if someone whose mind and speech are discordant says, "Those with wrong craving cannot attain unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening," know that this constitutes denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. And if someone whose mind and speech are likewise discordant says, "Those with wrong craving cannot attain unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening," that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

O son of noble lineage, if someone says that the eight branches of the noble path can be attained by base and ignoble persons, that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

O son of noble lineage, if someone says definitively that all sentient beings certainly possess the buddha-nature (svabhāva), or says definitively that they certainly do not possess the buddha-nature, that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

O son of noble lineage, it is for this reason that it is said in the sūtras: "Two types of people commit denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha." These two are: those without faith who have a mind of aversion, and those who have faith but do not understand the meaning.

O son of noble lineage, if someone has a faithful mind but lacks wisdom, they give rise to ignorance. If someone has wisdom but lacks a faithful mind, they give rise to wrong views.

O son of noble lineage, the faithless, whose mind is full of aversion, say "There is no Buddha, no Dharma, no Saṅgha — no Three Jewels." Those who have faith but lack wisdom misunderstand the meaning, and so they denigrate the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha when they hear the Dharma taught.

O son of noble lineage, it is for this reason that I have declared: those who are faithless and full of aversion, and those who have faith but lack wisdom, commit denigration of the Three Jewels — the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

O son of noble lineage, if someone says "Those with wrong craving have attained unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening without the arising of virtuous phenomena," that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. And if someone says "A person with wrong craving, having abandoned wrong craving, attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening with a different set of aggregates," that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

Yet there are those who say: "One with wrong craving is capable of generating wholesome roots; having generated those wholesome roots, and accumulating them one upon another in an unbroken stream, one with wrong craving thereby attains unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening." Know that such a statement does not constitute denigration of the Three Jewels.

O son of noble lineage, if someone says "All sentient beings certainly possess the buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha), and that nature is permanent, blissful, a self, and perfectly pure — it is simply that, without having engaged in practice, it does not arise; it is not seen because of the condition of afflictions" — that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

And if someone says "Sentient beings have no buddha-nature whatsoever — it is like a rabbit's horn. It has existed beginninglessly, arising through conditions, and having existed it will later cease to exist" — that too is denigration of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

And if someone says "The buddha-nature of sentient beings neither exists — being like space — nor does it not exist — being like a rabbit's horn. Why so? Because space is permanent, and a rabbit's horn is nonexistent. Therefore one

may speak of it as existing, and one may also speak of it as not existing: as existing, it is not like a rabbit's horn; as not existing, it is not like space." A statement made in that way does not constitute denigration of the Three Jewels.

O son of noble lineage, what is called "buddha-nature" is not one phenomenon, not two phenomena, not ten phenomena, not a hundred phenomena, not a thousand phenomena, not ten thousand phenomena. When unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening has not yet been attained, everything without exception — the virtuous, the non-virtuous, and the ethically neutral — is called "buddha-nature." At certain times the Tathāgata taught cause from the perspective of result, and result from the perspective of cause. This is a statement the Tathāgata made in accordance with his own intention. Because he spoke a statement in accordance with his own intention, he is called Tathāgata. Because the Tathāgata spoke a statement in accordance with his own intention, he is called arhat. Because he spoke a statement in accordance with his own intention, he is called perfectly complete buddha.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: "Blessed One, just as you have declared that the buddha-nature of sentient beings is comparable to space — how exactly is it comparable to space?"

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, the intrinsic nature of space is not past, not future, and not present. The buddha-nature is exactly like that.

O son of noble lineage, space is not past. Why? Because it does not exist in the present. For if phenomena existed in the present, then one could also meaningfully speak of the past. Since it does not so exist, the past does not exist either.

Nor does it exist in the present. Why? Because the future does not exist. For if phenomena had a future, one could also meaningfully speak of the present. Since the future does not exist, the present does not exist either.

Nor does the future exist. Why? Because neither the present nor the past exists. For if the present and the past existed, the future too would exist. Since the past and the present do not exist, the future does not exist.

Therefore the intrinsic nature of space does not belong to any of the three times.

O son of noble lineage, space is without the three times because it is nonexistent — yet this is not to say that the three times are absent because it exists. It is comparable, for example, to a flower in the sky:

Just as a flower in the sky lacks the three times because it is nonexistent, so too space is without the three times because it is nonexistent. O son of noble lineage, "space" is the name given to that which is nothing whatsoever. The intrinsic nature of a buddha is exactly like that.

O son of noble lineage, space does not belong to any of the three times because it is nonexistent. Likewise, the intrinsic nature of a buddha does not belong to any of the three times because it is permanent. O son of noble lineage, since the Tathāgata has attained unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, the intrinsic nature of a buddha and all the qualities of a buddha are permanent — unchanging and unalterable. Therefore, like space, they are without the three times.

O son of noble lineage, space is neither inner nor outer because it is nonexistent. Likewise, the intrinsic nature of a buddha is neither inner nor outer because it is permanent. Therefore the intrinsic nature of a buddha is comparable to space — so it has been declared.

O son of noble lineage, just as what is designated in the world as "space" is the place that is unobstructed and unimpeded, so too the Tathāgata, having attained unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, is without obstruction with respect to all the qualities of all buddhas — and for that reason the intrinsic nature of a buddha is said to be comparable to space. It is on account of that cause and that condition that I have declared the intrinsic nature of a buddha to be like space.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa addressed the Blessed One, saying: Blessed One, although the intrinsic nature of a buddha and nirvāṇa do not belong to the three times, they may still be said to exist. But if space likewise does not belong to the three times, why should it not also be said to exist?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, what is not nirvāṇa is what is called "nirvāṇa." What is not a Tathāgata is what is called "Tathāgata." What is not the intrinsic nature of a buddha is what is called "the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

How then is something not nirvāṇa? It is this: all mental afflictions and all conditioned phenomena — because those conditioned afflictions have been

destroyed, it is called "nirvāṇa."

And how is something not a Tathāgata? It is this: from one who has distorted craving all the way up to a pratyekabuddha — because all of those, from one who has distorted craving to a pratyekabuddha, have been destroyed, it is called "Tathāgata."

And what is not the intrinsic nature of a buddha? It is this: walls, enclosures, pillars, gravel, and all matter that lacks consciousness. The relinquishing of that matter which lacks consciousness — that is what is called "the intrinsic nature of a buddha."

O son of noble lineage, throughout the entire world there is nothing that is not space and yet becomes a synonym for space.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa said: Blessed One, in the world the four great elements do not exist as anything other than themselves, and yet there is nothing that becomes a synonym for the four great elements — yet the four great elements may still be said to exist. Since space has no synonym either, why should it not equally be said to exist?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, to say that nirvāṇa does not belong to the three times and that space is therefore like nirvāṇa — that is not correct. Why? Because nirvāṇa does exist. It can be seen; it can be realized; it is a trace left by form; it is something expressible in words; it bears the defining marks of existence; it is an object of meditation; it is a place of refuge; it is the fruit of peaceful radiance and bliss. Therefore it does not belong to the three times.

The intrinsic nature of space has none of these qualities — and therefore it is said to be nonexistent.

If there were some other phenomenon beyond these that did not belong to them, then that phenomenon would belong to the three times. If space were indeed like that — a phenomenon possessing existence — then it would be wrong to say it does not belong to the three times.

O son of noble lineage, as worldly people speak of it, space is said to be formless, without a counteragent, and imperceptible. If it is without form, without a counteragent, and imperceptible, then it would become a phenomenon arisen from mind. If space accords with phenomena arisen from mind, then it would be wrong to say it does not belong to the three times. And if it does belong to the three times, it would be one of the four aggregates —

and therefore, beyond the four aggregates, there is no such thing as "space."

Furthermore, O son of noble lineage, the non-Buddhist adherents (tīrthikas) say this: "Space is luminosity." If it is luminosity, it becomes a phenomenon of form, and if space is a phenomenon of form in that way, it would be impermanent. Being impermanent, it would belong to the three times — so why do the non-Buddhists say it does not belong to the three times? And if it did belong to the three times, it would not be space, and it would be wrong to call space permanent.

O son of noble lineage, some say this: "Space is a place for dwelling." To whatever extent a place for dwelling exists, to that extent it becomes a phenomenon of form. Every place where any phenomenon dwells is impermanent and belongs to the three times. Space is permanent and does not belong to the three times. If one asserts that a place of dwelling exists, then space must be understood to be nonexistent.

Others say: "Space is a series or sequence." If it were a series, it would become a countable phenomenon, and whatever is countable belongs to the three times. If it belongs to the three times, why call it permanent?

O son of noble lineage, if some say: "Space is the empty, the non-empty, and the empty-and-non-empty — it is inseparable from these three" — if one says it is empty, then space must be understood to be an impermanent phenomenon, because it is absent when things are non-empty. If one says it is non-empty, then space must likewise be understood to be impermanent, because it is absent when things are empty. If one says it is both empty and non-empty, then space must be understood not to be impermanent either, because it is absent in both states. Therefore space is to be called nonexistent.

O son of noble lineage, some also say: "Space is something that can be acted upon — just as when trees and buildings are removed, space has been made; or when something is leveled, it becomes space; or one covers space, or ascends into space, or draws the color of space as resembling the water of the ocean." If one says that space is therefore a phenomenon that can be acted upon, then every conditioned phenomenon is impermanent, like pottery. If space is like that, it would be impermanent.

O son of noble lineage, when worldly people say "whatever phenomenon is unobstructed with respect to everything is space" — does that unobstructedness exist completely within a single phenomenon, or only in part? If it exists completely, then space must be understood to be absent in

other locations. If it exists only in part, it becomes a countable phenomenon — this one and that one — and whatever is countable must be understood to be impermanent.

O son of noble lineage, some say: "Space is unobstructed —

it will come to be connected with what exists." Others say: "Space exists within material substance, just as fruit placed inside a vessel." Both of these are false.

Why so? If something is said to be "connected," that connection takes three forms. First, connection through distinct functions — like birds gathering on a tree. Second, connection through shared experience of a common function — like two hands touching each other. Third, connection through a shared bond of relatedness — like two fingers clasped together. If it is claimed that things are connected through a shared common bond while being functionally distinct, then there are two aspects to that distinctness: the function of material substance, and the function of space. If the function of space were connected with material substance, space would not become impermanent. But if the function of material substance were connected with space, material substance would not become all-pervasive. And if it is not all-pervasive, then that too is impermanent.

If someone says: "Space is permanent, immovable by its own intrinsic nature, yet it comes to be connected with things that move" — that too is not the case. Why? If space is permanent, then material substance must be of the same category and also permanent. If material substance is impermanent, then space too is impermanent. And if someone says "space is both permanent and impermanent," that position has no ground to stand on.

If someone says space is connected through a shared common function — that too is not the case. Why? Because space is all-pervasive; if it were connected with function, then function too would have to be of the all-pervasive category. If it were all-pervasive, it would pervade everything everywhere. If it pervades everything everywhere, it would be wrong to say that among things of the kind that are connected with everything, there is some connection and some non-connection.

The claim that space is connected through a shared bond of relatedness — like two fingers clasped together — is also not the case. Why? Because what was not connected from the beginning would come to be connected later. And if something that did not exist at first comes to exist afterward, that too

becomes a phenomenon possessing impermanence. Thus, just as in the case of worldly phenomena that are not present at first and then exist later, it is wrong to say that space is connected through a shared bond of relatedness.

If space were similar to impermanent material substance and like it in that way, then space too would become impermanent. Moreover, as for the claim that space exists within material substance just as fruit placed inside a vessel — that too is not so. Why? Before a vessel exists, where does space reside? If there is a place where it resides, then space would become multiple. If it is multiple, why is it called permanent, singular, and pervasive? If there were a place where that space resides beyond what is empty, then the substance of existence would likewise have to reside beyond space — and therefore it should be understood that space does not exist.

O son of noble lineage, as for the claim that the location in which one points a finger upward is space — that would make space a phenomenon that is impermanent. Why? Because a finger has four sides. If a finger has four sides, space too must be of the category of having four sides. All phenomena that are permanent have no sides. Therefore, because space has sides and spatial directions, space is impermanent.

If it is impermanent in this way, it is not connected with the five aggregates; and what lies beyond the five aggregates — beyond their absence — there is nothing to be called "existence." O son of noble lineage, if any phenomenon of existence abides in dependence upon dependent origination, it should be understood that that phenomenon is impermanent. O son of noble lineage, consider this example: all sentient beings, all trees, and all forests depend upon and abide on the earth. Because the earth itself is impermanent, the material substance that depends on the earth is also gradually impermanent.

O son of noble lineage, the earth depends upon water, and because water is impermanent, the earth too is impermanent. Water depends upon wind, and because wind is impermanent, water too is impermanent. Wind depends upon space, and because space is impermanent, wind too is impermanent. If things are impermanent in this way, why do some say that space is permanent and all-pervading? Because space does not exist, it is neither past, nor future, nor present. It is a substance that is non-existent, like a rabbit's horn, and therefore it is neither past, nor future, nor present. Hence, because the intrinsic nature of a buddha is permanent, it does not belong to the three times; and because space is non-existent, it likewise does not belong to the

three times.

O son of noble lineage, I do not dispute with the world. Why is that? When the wise and discerning of the world say something exists, I too declare it exists. When the wise and discerning of the world say something does not exist, I too declare it does not exist.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, if a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses certain qualities of the Dharma, will that bodhisattva not dispute with the world and will not be tainted by the world's concerns?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, if a bodhisattva, a great being, possesses ten qualities of the Dharma, that bodhisattva will not dispute with the world and will not be tainted by the world's concerns. What are the ten? They are as follows: faith; moral discipline; reliance upon a virtuous spiritual friend; inner mental engagement; being endowed with diligence; being endowed with correct mindfulness; being endowed with wisdom; being endowed with right speech; devotion to the holy Dharma; and loving affection toward sentient beings. O son of noble lineage, if a bodhisattva is endowed with these ten qualities of the Dharma, that bodhisattva will not dispute with worldly people, and, like the udumbara flower, will not be tainted by the world's concerns.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has said — when the wise and discerning of the world say something exists, you too declare it exists; when the wise and discerning of the world say something does not exist, you too declare it does not exist — how, then, do the wise and discerning of the world speak of existence and non-existence?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, when the wise and discerning of the world say of form that it is impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self — and say likewise of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness — O son of noble lineage, that is what the wise and discerning of the world call existence, and I too declare it exists. O son of noble lineage, when the wise and discerning of the world say of form that there is no permanence, no happiness, no self, and no purity — and say likewise of feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness — O son of noble lineage, that is what the wise and discerning of the world call non-existence, and I too declare it does not exist.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then said: Blessed One, the wise and discerning of the world are buddhas, bodhisattvas, and all noble ones. If the noble ones

declare that form is impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self, then why has the Blessed One declared that the form body of a buddha is permanent, stable, and unchanging? If the wise and discerning of the world declare that all phenomena are non-existent —

why did the Blessed One declare that it exists? And if the Buddha, the Blessed One, has spoken thus, how can it be said that he does not quarrel with the world and is not stained by worldly phenomena? For the Blessed One has taught that, through having thoroughly abandoned wrong perception, wrong mind, and wrong view — these three — the form body of a buddha is truly and properly impermanent; and he also declared, "I teach that it is permanent." How then can it be said that he has abandoned what is inverted and does not quarrel with the world?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, the form of inferior worldly beings arises from affliction, and it is for this reason that the wise and discerning declare that form is impermanent, suffering, empty, and without self. The form body of a Tathāgata, however, is utterly free from affliction, and it is for this reason that it has been taught to be permanent, stable, unchanging, and without alteration.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, in what way does form arise from affliction?

The Blessed One declared: O son of noble lineage, affliction has three aspects: the defilement of desire, the defilement of existence, and the defilement of ignorance. The wise and discerning must thoroughly understand the faults and flaws of these three defilements. Why so? Because it is only by knowing their faults and flaws that one will abandon them. It is like a physician who first examines the pulse of a sick person, comes to know the cause of the illness, and only then administers medicine.

O son of noble lineage, consider the example of a blind man who is led into a thorny thicket and then abandoned there. It would be extremely difficult for that blind man to find his way out, and even if he did manage to emerge, his entire body would be lacerated. In the same way, worldly beings of inferior stock are comparable to such a person: because they neither see nor understand the faults and flaws of the three defilements, they follow them wherever they lead. One who does see them will abandon them, and knowing their faults and flaws, both the actions performed and their karmic maturation will become progressively lighter and fewer.

O son of noble lineage, there are four types of persons. The first performs an action heavily but experiences its maturation lightly. The second performs an action lightly but experiences its maturation heavily. The third performs an action heavily and experiences its maturation heavily as well. The fourth performs an action lightly and experiences its maturation lightly as well. O son of noble lineage, the one who understands the faults of affliction finds that both the actions performed and the ripening of their fruits are light. O son of noble lineage, the wise and discerning person thinks: "I will abandon such defilements as these, and I will not commit sinful and non-virtuous deeds." Why so? Because he reflects: "I am not yet liberated from the karmic maturation of the hells, the animal realm, the realm of hungry ghosts, and the destinies of gods and humans. If I apply myself diligently to practice, through its power all suffering will be thoroughly overcome." Having thus reflected, his attachment, aversion, and delusion will diminish. Seeing that his attachment, aversion, and delusion are diminishing, his mind will be filled with great joy, and he will think: "Even now, having come to be as I am through the power of diligent practice, I am separated from non-virtuous phenomena and have drawn near to virtuous phenomena. Therefore, I will rouse diligence and cultivate the authentic path so as to see it directly." And through the power of strenuously cultivating it in that way, immeasurable numbers of non-virtuous afflictions, along with the hells, the animal realm, the realm of hungry ghosts, and

the karmic maturation of human and divine results will be abandoned. For this reason, I have declared in the sūtras that one should examine the afflictions that are defilements of existence and the causes of those defilements of existence.

This is the forty-ninth fascicle of the Noble Great Sūtra of the Transcendence into Nirvāṇa.

And why is that? If the wise and discerning do not examine the defilements and do not investigate the causes of the defilements, all their afflictions will not be severed. Why is that? The wise and discerning, upon recognizing that defilements arise from their causes, reflect: "If I thoroughly cut off those causes, the defilements will not arise." So they reason.

O son of good family, just as a physician, when he has thoroughly eliminated the cause of an illness, ensures that the illness will not arise again, so too do the wise and discerning act in precisely the same way when they cut off the

cause of afflictions. The wise and discerning first examine the cause, and thereafter examine the result. They come to understand deeply that from a virtuous cause a virtuous result arises, and from a non-virtuous cause a non-virtuous result arises. Having understood the result, they abandon the non-virtuous cause. Having examined the result in this way, they gradually discern which afflictions are subtle and which are gross. Having discerned the subtle and the gross, they first abandon the gross. And having abandoned the gross, the subtle too will naturally cease to exist.

O son of good family, when the wise and discerning have thus come to know the afflictions, the causes of the afflictions, the results of the afflictions, and the afflictions that are subtle and those that are gross, then, in order to suppress those very afflictions at that very time, they do not lag on the path of awakening. Without regret they strive strenuously, rely upon a spiritual friend, and with one-pointed mind listen to the Dharma.

O son of good family, consider, for instance, a sick person who, knowing that his illness is slight and that he will certainly recover, drinks a bitter medicine without regret. The wise and discerning are just like that: they are devoted to striving earnestly on the noble path, they do not grieve, they do not break off, and they do not regret.

O son of good family, whoever knows the afflictions, the causes of the afflictions, the karmic maturation of the results of the afflictions, and the afflictions that are subtle and gross, and strives earnestly in cultivating the noble path in order to remove those afflictions — for such a one, form does not arise from afflictions; and equally so up through feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

But if one does not know the afflictions, the causes of the afflictions, the karmic maturation of the results of the afflictions, and the afflictions that are subtle and gross, and does not strive on the noble path, then form does arise from afflictions; and equally so up through feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

O son of good family, whoever knows the afflictions, the causes of the afflictions, the karmic maturation of the results of the afflictions, and the afflictions that are subtle and gross, and strives earnestly toward awakening in order to sever those afflictions — such a one is a Tathāgata. Therefore the form of a Tathāgata is permanent, and so it is, permanent, all the way through consciousness.

O son of good family, whoever does not know the afflictions, the causes of the afflictions, the karmic maturation of the results of the afflictions, and the afflictions that are subtle and gross, and does not strive earnestly toward awakening — such a one is a foolish, ignoble, ordinary being. Therefore the form of a foolish, ignoble, ordinary being is impermanent, and equally so, impermanent, all the way through feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

O son of good family, worldly wise and discerning ones, and noble ones, and bodhisattvas, and all the buddhas as well, have spoken of that matter in those two ways, and I too speak of it in those two ways. Therefore what I teach does not quarrel with the worldly wise, and is not tainted by the ways of the world.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, when the Blessed One teaches that the defilements of existence are of three kinds, how are we to understand the defilement of desire, the defilement of craving, and the defilement of ignorance?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, what is called the defilement of desire arises through conceptual thought directed inwardly toward the unwholesome, and through being stirred by external conditions. Therefore I previously, in the city of Rājagṛha, spoke to Ānanda in this manner: Ānanda, take up these verses spoken by this woman. These verses were spoken by the Tathāgatas of the past. Thus, internal conceptual thought directed toward the unwholesome, together with external conditions, is called desire, and that is the defilement of desire.

The defilement of craving consists of the unwholesome inner phenomena of the form realm and the formless realm, together with their external causes and conditions — that is, the external conditions of the desire realm, apart from the internal conceptual thought directed toward the unwholesome. These constitute the defilement of existence.

The defilement of ignorance is not knowing the self and what belongs to the self, and failing to distinguish between the inner and the outer. That is the defilement of ignorance.

O son of good family, ignorance is the root of all defilements. Why? Because all sentient beings, through the cause and condition of ignorance, perceive and conceptually fix upon the aggregates, the sense sources, and the elements, and because of that conceptual fixing they are called sentient beings. This

consists of wrong perception, wrong thought, and wrong view, and through these as cause and condition all defilements are produced. Therefore I have taught in the twelve branches of scripture that ignorance is the cause of attachment, aversion, and delusion.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, if the Tathāgata previously taught in the twelve branches of scripture that through the cause and condition of conceptual thought directed toward the unwholesome, attachment, aversion, and delusion arise, why then did you also teach that they arise from ignorance?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, these two phenomena are each the cause of the other and each the result of the other; each one gives rise to the other. Conceptual thought directed toward the unwholesome produces ignorance, and through the condition of ignorance, unwholesome conceptual thought arises. O son of good family, whatever produces the afflictions itself becomes in turn a cause of the afflictions. Thus, the cause and the proximate cause of the afflictions are ignorance and unwholesome conceptual thought. Just as a sprout arises from a fruit — and the fruit is thereby a proximate cause — and just as the four great elements serve as a distant cause, the afflictions are similar in this regard.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, you have said that ignorance itself is a defilement, and yet you have also said that defilements arise through the condition of ignorance. Why do you say both?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, when I say that ignorance itself is a defilement, I am referring to inner ignorance. When I say that defilements arise from the cause of ignorance, I am referring to both inner and outer causes. That which is explained as ignorance itself being a defilement is what is called inner perversion — namely, not knowing impermanence, suffering, emptiness, and selflessness.

That which is explained as the cause of all afflictions is not knowing the outer self and what belongs to the self. That which is explained as ignorance itself being a defilement has neither beginning nor end. How so? Because from ignorance arise the aggregates, the sense bases, the elements, and so forth.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa (Ödsung) again addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, just as the Blessed One has said, the wise person endowed with discernment knows the causes of defilements. How then does

one know the causes of defilements?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, the wise person endowed with discernment reflects in this way: From what cause and from what condition does this affliction arise? From what action performed does this affliction arise? At what time does this affliction arise? When dwelling together with whom does this affliction arise? Dwelling in what place does this affliction arise? By attending to what thing does this affliction arise? By accepting whose lodging, bedding, alms, robes, and medicines for illness and so forth does this affliction arise? From what cause and condition does what is minor become middling, and what is middling become great? And does what is great become middling, and what is middling become minor? Thus one thoroughly reflects.

When the bodhisattva, the great being, reflects in this way, he will thoroughly abandon the causes and conditions that give rise to defilements. Having understood in this way, those afflictions not yet arisen he blocks and does not allow to arise, and those afflictions already arisen he checks by means of skillful means. Therefore I have said in the sūtras that the wise person endowed with discernment should examine the causes of the arising of afflictions.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, how is it that many different kinds of affliction arise from a single body of a sentient being?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, take this example: just as when many different seeds are contained within a single vessel, and upon meeting water or rain they each grow separately, so too it is with sentient beings. Although there is but one vessel, through the causes and conditions of craving, many different kinds of affliction arise.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, how does the wise person endowed with discernment reflect on the ripening of results?

The Blessed One declared: O son of good family, the wise person endowed with discernment reflects thus: Through the causes and conditions of defilements, sentient beings will be reborn in the hells, in the realm of animals, and among the hungry ghosts. Through the causes and conditions free from defilements, one obtains a divine or human body — and yet even those are impermanent, marked by suffering, empty, and selfless. From this vessel of the body one obtains the three kinds of suffering and the three kinds of

impermanence. Through the causes and conditions of these defilements, sentient beings commit the five acts of immediate retribution, experience the ripening of results in the lower realms, sever the roots of virtue, destroy the four foundations, and come to disparage the Three Jewels. Thus one thoroughly reflects. The wise person endowed with discernment thoroughly reflects: it is unworthy of me, having obtained this body, to generate afflictions and thereby reap the fruits of the lower realms.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked: Blessed One, you have also said that there are results that are free from defilements, and yet you have also said that the wise person endowed with discernment thoroughly severs the ripening of results. Does that which is free from defilements fall within what is thoroughly severed?

Since those who have attained awakening possess results that are free from defilements, and since the wise person endowed with discernment seeks results that are free from defilements, why did the Blessed One say that the wise person endowed with discernment should sever the ripening of karmic results? If such severing takes place, is it still fitting to say that noble ones exist at the present time?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the Tathāgata has spoken of certain things as results in relation to a cause, and certain things as causes in relation to a result. Just as worldly people say, "Clay itself is the pot," and "Thread itself is cloth" — these are cases where a result is described in terms of its cause. And as one says, "The cow itself is water and grass, and is also food for human beings" — this is a case where a cause is described in terms of its result. I too have spoken in this way, describing a result in terms of a cause. For example, in a sūtra spoken earlier, when I said, "I shall go in body and mind to the brahma-realm (brahmaloka)," that is describing a result in terms of its cause. And when I said, "These very six sense sources are the karma of previous lives," that is describing a cause in terms of its result.

Son of good family, in the ultimate sense there is no result that is free from defilements for any noble one. The result of what all noble ones have thoroughly cultivated is that no defilements arise — and for that very reason it is called a result free from defilements.

Son of good family, when the wise person endowed with discernment reflects in this way, the ripening of the results of afflictions will be completely exhausted. Son of good family, because the wise person endowed with

discernment has thus completely severed the results of afflictions, he cultivates the noble path. The noble path consists of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness. When those noble paths are cultivated, all results of afflictions will be completely exhausted.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, all sentient beings undergo the ripening of results through their afflictions, and afflictions are non-virtuous. The affliction that arises from non-virtuous afflictions is itself also called non-virtuous. Thus with regard to these afflictions there are two aspects: cause and result. Because the cause is non-virtuous, the result is non-virtuous; and because the result is non-virtuous, the seed is non-virtuous — just as the tree called the nimba, because its fruit is bitter, has a seed, flowers, trunk, and leaves that are all bitter. Just as the poisonous tree, owing to a poisonous seed, produces poisonous fruit, so too the cause is sentient beings and the result is sentient beings; the cause is afflictions and the result is afflictions. The very cause and result of afflictions are sentient beings, and sentient beings themselves are the cause and result of afflictions. If this is so, why did the Tathāgata say that on the snowy mountain there are both poisonous grasses and a sublime king of medicines? If afflictions are themselves sentient beings, and sentient beings are themselves afflictions, why did the Blessed One say that within the body of sentient beings there exists a sublime king of medicines?

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, countless sentient beings — as many as there are — harbor just such a doubt. Since you have asked in order to dispel this doubt, and since I am able to resolve it, listen attentively and reflect upon it carefully, and I shall explain and set it free.

Son of good family, "the snowy mountain" stands for sentient beings. "Poisonous grasses" stand for afflictions. "The sublime king of medicines" stands for the holy life (brahmacarya). Son of good family, whatever sentient being thus practices the holy life — within that being's body there exists a sublime king of medicines.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa again asked:

The Blessed One declared:

Son of good family, just as in the world a fruit is born from a seed, and some fruits in turn become seeds again while others do not — those that do become seeds again are called both fruit and seed, while those that do not are called

simply fruit, not seed — in the same way, all sentient beings likewise have two kinds of causes. What are they? Some fruits of affliction become causes of affliction again, while some fruits of affliction do not become causes of affliction again. That which is the fruit of affliction yet does not become a cause of affliction — this is called the holy life (brahmacarya).

Son of good family, all sentient beings understand and know that feeling (vedanā) is the proximate cause of every defilement — namely, inner and outer defilements. Through the condition of feeling, one is unable to sever all defilements and thus unable to win freedom from the prison of the three realms. It is through the condition of feeling that sentient beings, clinging to self and what belongs to self, come to give rise to inverted mind, inverted perception, and inverted views. Therefore, sentient beings should first examine feeling.

Now, feeling is the proximate cause of all craving. Therefore, if a wise and discerning person wishes to sever craving, let that person first examine feeling.

Son of good family, all the virtuous and non-virtuous deeds that all sentient beings perform through the twelve links of dependent origination are done at the occasion of feeling. This is why I declared to Ānanda: "Ānanda, all the virtuous and non-virtuous deeds done by all sentient beings are done entirely at the occasion of feeling. Therefore a wise and discerning person should first examine feeling."

Having understood feeling, one should further examine: from what cause and from what condition does this feeling arise? If it arises from cause and condition, then what itself gave rise to that cause and condition? If there is no cause for arising, then why does the absence of a cause not itself produce an absence of feeling?

Moreover, this feeling does not arise from the cause of Īśvara, nor does it arise from a primordial person, nor from subtle particles, nor is it produced by time, nor does it arise from perception, nor from intrinsic nature, nor from self, nor from other, nor from both self and other, nor from no cause at all. Rather, feeling arises from the convergence of conditions, and that cause and condition is craving. Understanding that feeling is neither present in nor absent from that convergence of conditions, one therefore severs the convergence of conditions, thinking: because the convergence of conditions is severed, feeling will not arise.

Son of good family, when a wise and discerning person has understood causes, that person contemplates the karmic maturation of results: it is through the condition of feeling that sentient beings experience birth in the hells, in the animal realm, and in the bodies of hungry ghosts, thereby taking on immeasurable suffering throughout the three realms. Through the condition of feeling one takes hold of impermanent happiness. Through the condition of feeling one severs the root of happiness. And yet through the condition of feeling one may attain perfect liberation. Reflecting in this way, one no longer acts under the condition of feeling. How does one no longer act under the condition of feeling? One distinguishes which feelings lead to craving and which aspects of craving lead back to feeling.

Son of good family, when a sentient being has fully understood in this way the cause of existence and the cause of feeling, that being will completely sever the notions of self and what belongs to self.

Son of good family, one who has thus fully understood this knows from where feeling and craving, these two, are to be ceased. Seeing that there is a place where feeling and craving are partially ceased, and thereby knowing that their complete cessation also exists, at that moment faith in liberation arises. Having aroused a mind of faith, one reflects: through what cause shall the state of liberation be attained? Knowing that it is attained through the noble eightfold path, one then cultivates it thoroughly.

What is the noble eightfold path? When this path examines feeling, there are three characteristics: suffering, pleasure, and that which is neither suffering nor pleasure. All three are capable of producing body and mind. Through what cause and condition are they produced? Through the condition of contact. And from that contact there are also three kinds: the contact of ignorance, the contact of knowledge, and the contact that is neither knowledge nor ignorance. Of these, what is called the contact of knowledge is the noble eightfold path. The remaining two kinds of contact produce body, mind, and the three kinds of feeling. Therefore I should sever the two kinds of cause of contact. When contact is severed, the three kinds of feeling will not arise.

Son of good family, feeling in this way is called both a cause and a result. One who is wise and possessed of wisdom examines it as both cause and result. How is it a cause? Because craving arises from the cause of feeling, it is called a cause. How is it a result? Because it arises from contact, it is called a result. Therefore feeling is both a cause and a result.

The wise one possessed of wisdom, having examined feeling in this way, gradually examines craving. The karmic maturation of feeling as result is called craving. The wise one possessed of wisdom, in examining craving, recognizes two kinds: that with various kinds of food, and that without food. Craving with various kinds of food becomes the cause of birth, old age, sickness, death, and all craving. Craving without food severs birth, old age, sickness, death, and all craving, for one longs for and is attached to action that is undefiled.

The wise one possessed of wisdom also reflects thus: if I generate craving with various kinds of food, I will be unable to sever birth, old age, sickness, and death. And though I may be attached to an undefiled path, if I do not sever the cause of feeling, I will not attain the fruit of the undefiled path. Therefore I should sever contact. Having severed contact, feeling too ceases of itself. When feeling has ceased, craving is completely extinguished. This is called the noble eightfold path.

Son of good family, if a sentient being understands it thus, although the body may be accompanied by affliction, there is nonetheless a supreme king of medicine. This is like a snow mountain having poisonous herbs yet also possessing excellent medicine.

Son of good family, in the same way sentient beings may have obtained a karmic maturation that arises from afflictions, yet they can prevent that maturation from becoming the cause of further afflictions. This is called pure conduct (brahmacarya).

Furthermore, son of good family, when the wise one possessed of wisdom examines from what cause feeling and craving, these two, arise, one comes to know that they arise from the cause of perception. Why is this? Even when a sentient being sees a visible form, desire does not arise. Nor does desire arise at the mere time of apprehending a feeling. But if one generates an inverted perception with regard to visible form, seeing form as permanent, pleasurable, self, and utterly pure, and seeing feeling as permanent, unchanging, and unshifting —

It is in this way that, on account of inverted perception, attachment, aversion, and delusion arise. Therefore, the wise one possessed of wisdom should examine perception.

Now, how is perception to be examined? One should think to oneself: all sentient beings, not having attained the noble path, have inverted perception.

What is inverted perception? It is generating the perception of permanence regarding what is impermanent; generating the perception of pleasure regarding what is without pleasure; generating the perception of purity regarding what is impure; generating the perception of self regarding phenomena that are empty; and generating the perception of man, woman, great, small, day, night, year, month, clothing, dwelling, and bed-partner regarding what is not truly man, woman, or bed-partner. This perception is of three kinds: small, great, and boundless. By reason of smallness, a small perception arises; by reason of greatness, a great perception arises; by reason of boundlessness, a boundless perception arises.

Further, small perception is perception that has not entered meditative absorption. Great perception is perception that has entered meditative absorption. And boundless perception comprises the ten all-pervasive spheres. Again, small perception is the perception of the desire realm and so forth. Great perception is the perception of the form realm and so forth. Boundless perception is the perception of the formless realm and so forth.

When these three kinds of perception cease, feeling too ceases of itself. When perception and feeling have ceased, that is called liberation.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if liberation is called the cessation of all phenomena, why then does the Tathāgata declare that when perception and feeling cease, that is liberation?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, the Tathāgata, at times, has taught the Dharma by way of the condition of sentient beings, so that whoever hears it comes to know the Dharma. At other times, by way of the condition of the Dharma, he has taught sentient beings, so that whoever hears it comes to know that sentient beings have been described. What does it mean to teach by way of the condition of sentient beings such that the hearer comes to know the Dharma? It is just as I formerly said to the great Kāśyapa: 'Kāśyapa, when sentient beings cease, wholesome phenomena too cease.' That is a teaching through the condition of sentient beings, whereby the hearer comes to know the Dharma. And what does it mean to teach by way of the condition of the Dharma such that the hearer comes to know that sentient beings have been described? It is just as I formerly said to Ānanda: 'I have not said to associate with all phenomena, nor have I said to dissociate from all phenomena. Whatever phenomenon is such that, through associating with it, wholesome

phenomena decline and unwholesome phenomena flourish — with such a phenomenon one should not associate. Whatever phenomenon is such that, through associating with it, unwholesome phenomena decline and disappear while wholesome phenomena grow and increase — with such a phenomenon one should associate.' That is a teaching through the condition of the Dharma, whereby the hearer comes to know that sentient beings have been described.

Son of good family, although the Tathāgata has declared that perception and feeling, these two, are to be stopped, he has nonetheless declared that everything within them is to be stopped. The wise one possessed of wisdom, having examined perception in this way, gradually comes to understand that the cause of perception is not boundless perception. When one examines from what it arises, one comes to know that it arises from the cause of contact. Contact itself is of two kinds: contact arising from the cause of affliction, and contact arising from the cause of liberation.

That which arises from the cause of ignorance is called contact arising from affliction. That which arises from the cause of knowledge is called contact arising from liberation. From contact that arises from the cause of affliction, erroneous perception is born. From contact that arises from the cause of liberation, non-erroneous perception is born. Having thus understood the cause of perception in this way, one gradually comes to understand the karmic maturation of its fruit.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if erroneous perception arises through the condition of afflicted perception, then all noble ones possess erroneous perception, yet they have no afflictions. What is the meaning of this?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in what sense is it said that noble ones have erroneous perception?" The bodhisattva Kāśyapa replied: "Blessed One, all noble ones form the perception of a cow with respect to a cow and say 'This is a cow.' They form the perception of a horse with respect to a horse and say 'This is a horse.' And so on, likewise, with respect to men, women, the great, the small, houses, chariots, vehicles, those who have gone away, and those who have come — and this, I would call erroneous perception."

"Son of good family, all ordinary foolish beings possess two kinds of perception: worldly conventional perception and attachment perception. All noble ones possess only worldly conventional perception; they do not possess

attachment perception. Because all ordinary foolish beings have non-virtuous conceptuality, they generate attachment perception with respect to worldly convention. Because noble ones have virtuous conceptuality, they do not generate attachment perception with respect to worldly convention. Therefore ordinary foolish beings are said to possess erroneous perception, whereas although noble ones perceive things, they are not said to have erroneous perception.

The wise one possessed of wisdom, having thus understood the causes of perception, gradually comes to understand the karmic maturation of its fruit. The fruit of non-virtuous perception is to experience rebirth in the hells, among hungry ghosts, in the animal realm, and among humans and gods. Since I have cut the cause of non-virtuous conceptuality, contact arising from ignorance is severed; therefore perception is cut off. Because perception is cut off, the karmic maturation of its fruit is also completely severed. The wise one possessed of wisdom, in order to sever those causes of perception, cultivates the noble eightfold path. Son of good family, this manner of reflection is called the complete purification of the holy life.

Son of good family, this is what is called the excellent king of medicines residing within the toxic body of sentient beings — just as on a snow mountain, even though there are poisonous plants, there are also excellent medicinal herbs.

Furthermore, son of good family, when the wise one possessed of wisdom examines desire, one recognizes that desire consists of form, sound, smell, taste, and touch. Son of good family, the Tathāgata has declared these as fruit arising from cause. From those five things desire arises, but in truth it is not desire itself. Son of good family, the deluded one, through attachment to feeling, generates erroneous perception with respect to form, and on through to tangible objects generates erroneous perception. Through the condition of erroneous perception, feeling arises. Therefore it is explained that through the cause of erroneous worldly perception, ten kinds of perception are born. Through the causes and conditions of desire, one comes to experience bad fruit in the world: with respect to one's father and mother, and —

— acting wrongly toward ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins, and deliberately doing so without the slightest concern for their bodies or their lives. Therefore, the wise one possessed of wisdom recognizes that through the causes and conditions of non-virtuous perception, a mind of desire is born. Having thus

understood the cause of desire, the wise one possessed of wisdom then contemplates, in due order, the ripening of its fruit. The ripening of non-virtuous fruit from that desire consists in becoming a hell-being, or being born in an animal realm, or a hungry ghost, or among humans and gods and so forth. This is called the contemplation of karmic maturation of fruit.

If non-virtuous perception were to be brought to cessation, then at no time would that mind of desire arise. Because there is no mind of desire, one does not experience non-virtuous fruit. Because non-virtuous fruit is not experienced, non-virtuous fruit ceases to be. Therefore, one should first cut off non-virtuous perception. When non-virtuous perception is severed, those very phenomena will cease of themselves. Therefore, in order to eliminate non-virtuous perception, the wise one possessed of wisdom cultivates the noble eightfold path. This is also called the pure holy life (brahmacarya). It is like a mountain that harbors poisonous plants yet also contains excellent medicine — just so, within the body of sentient beings, which is itself like a poison, there is said to be the supreme king of medicines.

Furthermore, son of good family, having thus understood desire, the wise one possessed of wisdom then contemplates karma in due order. Why so? The wise one possessed of wisdom reflects thus: feeling, perception, contact, and desire are afflictions. Those afflictions create karma that produces birth, but they do not create karma that produces experience. Yet when those afflictions proceed together with karma, there are two kinds: karma that produces birth and karma that produces experience. Therefore, the wise one possessed of wisdom thoroughly examines karma.

Karma, moreover, is of three kinds: of body, speech, and mind. Son of good family, the two — bodily and verbal karma — may be called both karma and the fruit of karma. Mental karma alone is called karma; it is not called fruit. Thus, by reason of karma, it is called karma. Son of good family, the two — bodily and verbal karma — are also called outer karma, while the mind is called inner karma. These three types of karma, because they are accompanied by afflictions, become twofold: karma that produces birth and karma that produces experience.

Son of good family, true karma is mental karma. Temporal karma is bodily and verbal karma. Of these, what arises first is mental karma, and what arises from mental karma is bodily and verbal karma. Therefore mental karma is called true karma.

Having thus fully understood karma, the wise one possessed of wisdom then contemplates in due order the causes of karma. The causes of karma are ignorance and contact. Through the condition of ignorance and contact, sentient beings seek existence. The condition for seeking existence is craving. Through the condition of craving, the three kinds of karma — bodily, verbal, and mental — are enacted.

Son of good family, having thus understood the causes of karma, the wise one possessed of wisdom then contemplates in due order the ripening of fruit. Karmic maturation of fruit is of four kinds: the maturation of the darkest fruit from the darkest deeds; the maturation of the purest fruit from the purest deeds; the maturation of mixed fruit from mixed deeds; and the maturation of neither-dark-nor-bright fruit from deeds that are neither dark nor bright.

Of these, the maturation of the darkest fruit from the darkest deeds means that when karma is performed it is accompanied by defilement, and the maturation of its fruit is likewise accompanied by defilement. The maturation of the purest fruit from the purest deeds means that when karma is performed it is entirely pure, and

the maturation of its fruit is likewise entirely pure. The maturation of mixed fruit from mixed deeds means that when karma is performed it is mixed, and the maturation of its fruit is likewise mixed. The maturation of neither-dark-nor-bright fruit from deeds that are neither dark nor bright: this is what is called undefiled karma.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, you said earlier that where there is no defilement there is no maturation of fruit. Why, then, did you say there is a maturation of neither-dark-nor-bright fruit?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, in this matter there are two aspects: that which is a fruit and also a karmic maturation, and that which is merely a fruit but not a karmic maturation. The maturation of the darkest fruit from the darkest deeds is both called a fruit and called a karmic maturation. It is called a fruit because it arises from a dark cause, and it is called a karmic maturation because it in turn becomes a cause for further arising. The same applies to mixed deeds and entirely pure deeds. As for the fruit of undefiled karma: it is called a fruit because it arises from a defiled cause, but it is not called a karmic maturation because it does not in turn become a cause for anything further. Therefore it is called a fruit, but it is not called a karmic

maturation."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then addressed the Blessed One once more: "Blessed One, if undefiled karma is not a dark phenomenon, why is it not called white?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, it is not called white because it lacks karmic maturation. It is called white because it is the antidote to darkness. In this context, I have spoken of dark and white in terms of experiencing the maturation of fruit. Undefiled karma does not experience karmic maturation, so it is not called white; it is called peaceful. In this way, there are definite destinations where the maturation of karma is experienced. For example, if one commits the ten non-virtues, one will certainly be reborn in hell, in the realm of animals, or among hungry ghosts. If one practises the ten virtues, one will certainly be reborn among gods or humans. Among the karma of the ten non-virtues there are three degrees: supreme, middling, and lesser. Those who commit them at the supreme degree experience a hell-being's body. Those who commit them at the middling degree experience an animal's body. Those who commit them at the lesser degree experience a hungry ghost's body. Among the ten virtues performed by human beings there are likewise four grades: lesser, middling, superior, and most superior. The lesser leads to rebirth in the northern continent of Unpleasant Sound. The middling leads to rebirth in the eastern continent of Videha. The superior leads to rebirth in the western continent of Godānīya. And the most superior leads to rebirth in Jambudvīpa.

A person who is wise and endowed with discernment, understanding this, reflects: 'How shall I put a stop to that maturation of fruit?' And further: 'The cause and condition of that karma are ignorance and contact. If I completely sever ignorance and contact, those fruits of karma will be arrested and will not arise.' For this reason, a person who is wise and endowed with discernment, in order to completely sever ignorance and contact, cultivates the noble eightfold path. That is what is called the entirely pure holy life.

Son of good family, in this way, for the afflicted body of sentient beings, there exists a supreme medicine-king — just as on the Himalayas, though poisonous plants are found, excellent medicines are also found there. Furthermore, son of good family, a person who is wise and endowed with discernment, having understood karma and the mental afflictions, examines in sequence the two maturations of fruit. Having understood that the maturation of fruit of both of

these is suffering, and having understood it as suffering in this way, one abandons entirely every form of grasping at rebirth."

A person who is wise and endowed with discernment understands further that from the cause of affliction, affliction arises; from the cause of karma, affliction arises; and from the cause of affliction, karma arises. From the cause of karma, suffering arises; and from the cause of suffering, affliction arises. From the cause of affliction, existence arises; and from the cause of existence, suffering arises. From the cause of existence, existence arises; and from the cause of existence, karma arises. From the cause of karma, affliction arises; from the cause of affliction, suffering arises; and from the cause of suffering, suffering too arises — this is what one comes to understand.

Son of good family, know that when a person who is wise and endowed with discernment understands things in this way, that constitutes understanding the suffering of karma. Why is this so? Because those very reflections, as stated above, are the twelve causes and conditions of cyclic existence. Know, then, that whoever reflects thus upon those twelve causes and conditions of cyclic existence creates no new karma and destroys old karma.

Son of good family, when a person who is wise and endowed with discernment examines, one by one, the many and varied forms of suffering in each of the hells from the first hell all the way through to the one hundred and thirty-sixth, they come to understand that all of it is produced by the karma of affliction. Having thus understood the suffering of the hells, one proceeds in sequence to examine the suffering of hungry ghosts (pretas), animals, and the rest. Having understood all of that, one then examines all the suffering found among humans and gods, and comes to understand that all these many forms of suffering likewise arise from the karma of affliction.

Son of good family, there is nothing that afflicts the gods of the higher realms with great suffering — yet when the five omens appear to a god whose body is supple and tender, the great suffering that god experiences is comparable to the suffering of the hells: there is no difference whatsoever.

Son of good family, a person who is wise and endowed with discernment comes to understand most deeply that all the suffering of the three realms arises from the causes and conditions of the karma of affliction.

Son of good family, consider as an analogy: unfired clay pottery is extremely easy to break. The body taken up by a sentient being is similar — that body is a vessel for manifold suffering. Consider further: just as a great flowering and

fruit-bearing tree is made unpleasant by many birds, so too the experience of a sentient being's body is made unpleasant by many sources of suffering. And just as a large heap of dry grass is burned up by even a small fire, so too the experience of a sentient being's body is destroyed by suffering.

Son of good family, know that when a person who is wise and endowed with discernment understands the eight kinds of suffering in the manner of noble practice (ārya), that person has thoroughly cut through suffering.

Son of good family, having thus deeply understood the eight kinds of suffering, a person who is wise and endowed with discernment proceeds in sequence to examine the causes of suffering. The causes of suffering are craving and ignorance. Craving and ignorance have two aspects: seeking a body and seeking material things. Both the seeking of a body and the seeking of material things are suffering. Therefore, know that craving and ignorance become the causes of suffering.

Son of good family, craving and ignorance have yet another two aspects: inner and outer. The inner causes the body to come into being. The outer causes growth and increase. Furthermore, while the inner causes the body to come into being, the outer causes the results of karma to come into being. Therefore, when inner craving is cut, karma is cut; and when outer craving is cut, the result is cut. Inner craving gives rise to the suffering of future time, while outer craving gives rise to the suffering of the present time.

Therefore, a wise and discerning person understands that craving becomes a cause of suffering. Having thus understood the cause of suffering, one gradually contemplates the karmic maturation of the fruit of suffering. What is called the fruit of suffering is grasping. What is called grasping is the fruit of craving. Through the causes and conditions of grasping, one comes to crave inner and outer things, and through that craving one experiences suffering. Son of good family, a wise and discerning person understands that through the condition of craving comes grasping, and through the condition of grasping comes becoming. Whoever cuts through these two things — craving and grasping — will not create karma, and will not come to experience manifold suffering. Therefore, a wise and discerning person applies diligence to the noble eightfold path in order to sever the suffering of craving.

Son of good family, whoever fully understands this as I have described — this is what I call the perfectly pure holy life. It is said that for the afflicted body of sentient beings there exists a supreme king of medicine, just as a snowy

mountain, though it contains poison, also contains supreme medicine.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, what is meant by the perfectly pure holy life? The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is all phenomena. The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked again: Blessed One, the meaning of the expression "all phenomena" is indeterminate. Why so? Because the Tathāgata has at various times taught that virtue and non-virtue are so designated. At various times he has taught that careful establishment of the four foundations of mindfulness is so designated. At various times he has taught that the twelve sense bases are so designated. At various times he has taught that the spiritual friend is so designated. At various times he has taught that the twelve links of dependent origination are so designated. At various times he has taught that sentient beings are so designated. At various times he has taught that right view and wrong view are so designated. At various times he has taught that the twelve divisions of scripture are so designated. At various times he has taught that the two truths are so designated. And you yourself have now said that the perfectly pure holy life is all phenomena — so to what and to what else does the expression "all phenomena" refer?

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Most excellent! Son of good family, this noble Dharma of the great sūtra of the Mahāparinirvāṇa is called the precious treasury of all phenomena. Just as the ocean is the source of all precious things, so too this sūtra of the Mahāparinirvāṇa is like that — it is the very heart of the intended meaning of all words. Son of good family, just as Mount Meru, the king of mountains, is the source of all the many medicines, so too this sūtra is like that — it is the source of the moral discipline of bodhisattvas. Son of good family, just as space is the abode of all things, so too this sūtra is like that — it is the abode of all virtuous phenomena. Son of good family, just as a fierce wind cannot be bound by anyone, so too all bodhisattvas who apply diligence to this sūtra are like that — they cannot be bound by any of the non-virtuous phenomena of the afflictions. Son of good family, just as nothing can withstand a vajra, so too this sūtra is like that — though the non-Buddhists with their many wrong views be numerous, they cannot demolish it. Son of good family, just as no one can count the grains of sand of the Gaṅgā river, so too the meaning of this sūtra is like that —

no one can count it. Son of good family, this sūtra will become the victory banner of the Dharma for bodhisattvas, just as the victory banner of Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods, is like that. Son of good family, this sūtra is like a caravan leader guiding merchants to the great city of perfect nirvāṇa, just as a

great caravan master leads many merchants and brings them out upon the great ocean. Son of good family, this sūtra will become the radiant light of the Dharma's illumination for bodhisattvas, just as in this world the sun and the moon dispel the darkness. Son of good family, this sūtra will become excellent medicine for sentient beings afflicted by illness, just as from the Himalayas (the mountain of medicinal herbs) arises the king of medicines, which pacifies the suffering of disease. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a staff for all those bent under the weight of wrong craving, just as all who are physically weakened rise up by its aid. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a bridge for all who are weighed down by evil and wrongdoing, just as in this world a bridge liberates all beings. Son of good family, this sūtra will become cool shade for those tormented by the afflictions in the twenty-five realms of existence, just as a worldly parasol or canopy screens out the blazing hot sun. Son of good family, this sūtra is a great fearless king that will vanquish all the wicked māras of the afflictions, just as the lion king subdues all the beasts of the wilderness. Son of good family, this sūtra is a great knowledge-mantra that will destroy all the wicked demonic spirits of the afflictions, just as in this world a mantra practitioner renders one free from harmful spirits. Son of good family, this sūtra is like an unsurpassed hailstorm that will shatter all the fruits of saṃsāric existence, just as in this world a hailstorm shatters all fruits. Son of good family, this sūtra will become like excellent medicine restoring the eyes of those whose moral discipline has become impaired, just as the medicine in this world called añjana benefits all who suffer from eye disease. Son of good family, this sūtra will become the source of all virtuous phenomena, just as in this world the earth becomes the abode of all things. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a clear mirror for sentient beings whose moral discipline has become impaired, just as a clear worldly mirror reveals all forms. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a garment for those who lack a sense of shame and moral restraint, just as in this world clothing covers and wraps the body. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a precious jewel-wealth for those who are impoverished in virtuous phenomena, just as the divine goddess Śrī (Lakṣmī) benefits all the poor. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a stream of ambrosia for all sentient beings who are parched with thirst for the Dharma, just as the water endowed with the eight qualities satisfies all who thirst. Son of good family, this sūtra will become a Dharma throne for all the afflictions, just as in this world when people encounter a comfortable seat. Son of good family, this sūtra adorns bodhisattvas from the first ground all the way through the tenth ground with garlands, incense, flowers, ointments, powders,

and the purest and most excellent varieties of fragrant offerings — through a vehicle richly endowed in its kind, it causes them to abide in the six perfections. It causes them to experience supreme joy, just as the Pārijāta tree of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three is like that.

Son of good family, this sūtra is like a sharp blade of wisdom — it cuts down every tree of affliction. It is like a keen-edged weapon — it severs all habitual tendencies. It is like one who is supremely brave and bold — it vanquishes every māra that opposes and attacks. It is like the fire of wisdom — it burns away all afflictions. It is like the very heart of dependent origination — it is the birthplace of all pratyekabuddhas. It is like a treasury of learning — it is the birthplace of śrāvakas. It is like the eye of all the gods. It is the true path for all human beings. It is the foundation of refuge for all the animal realms. It is the place of liberation for all hungry ghosts. It is the supreme, unsurpassed excellence for hell-beings. It is the supreme, unsurpassed vessel for all sentient beings of the ten directions. It is the father and mother of all buddhas of the ten directions — those who have passed, those yet to come, and those who dwell in the present.

Son of good family, therefore this sūtra has gathered all Dharma together. I said before, as is well known, that this sūtra gathers all Dharma — and indeed I have declared that the holy life is the thirty-seven factors of awakening (bodhipākṣika dharmas).

The fiftieth fascicle of the noble great sūtra of the Mahāparinirvāṇa.

Son of good family, without the thirty-seven factors of awakening, no one will attain anything from the true fruit of the śrāvaka all the way through to the fruit of unsurpassed and perfectly complete awakening. Nor will they behold the nature of a buddha or the fruit of that nature. For that very reason, by that very cause and condition, the holy life is the thirty-seven factors of awakening. Why is this? Because the thirty-seven factors of awakening are not of the nature of error and inversion, they destroy error and inversion. Because they are not of the nature of wrong view, they destroy wrong view. Because they are not of the nature of decay and destruction, they bring decay and destruction to complete ruin. Because they are by nature wholly pure in their practice, they cause sentient beings ultimately to abide in the holy life of complete purity.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, if defiled phenomena can serve as a cause for undefiled phenomena, why did the Tathāgata not say that

defiled things are the practice of the completely pure holy life?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, all defiled phenomena are characterized by inversion and error — therefore one should not call defiled phenomena the completely pure holy life.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, what is called the supreme worldly Dharma — is it defiled or is it undefiled?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, it is defiled.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, though it is defiled, if it is not by nature erroneous and inverted, why should it not be called the completely pure holy life?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the supreme worldly Dharma becomes a cause for the undefiled, and so it is comparable to the undefiled. Because it is oriented toward the undefiled, it should not be called inversion and error. Son of good family, from the moment one generates the mind of the completely pure holy life continuously, up to and including the supreme worldly Dharma, the mind is brought to one-pointed concentration, and
and for that reason it should not be called the completely pure holy life.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, the five consciousnesses of sentient beings are defiled, yet they are not inverted and they are not one-pointed. Why, then, should they not be called the completely pure holy life?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the five consciousnesses of sentient beings are indeed not one-pointed, yet they are defiled, and they are also inverted. They are called defiled because they give rise to defilements. They are not correct by essential nature, and they are called inverted because of attachment to perception. Now, how is it that they are not correct by essential nature, and are called inverted due to attachment to perception? Because one generates the perception of male and female toward what is neither male nor female — and in the same way, this should be understood expansively regarding a house, a vehicle, a pot, and cloth, all the way through to cloth. These are called inversions.

Son of good family, the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening (bodhipākṣikadharmas) are not by nature inverted, and therefore they are called the completely pure holy life.

Son of good family, whatever bodhisattva knows, with respect to the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, the root, the cause, the gathering, the generation, the master, the guide, the victor, the correct, and the culmination — that bodhisattva is called one who practices the completely pure holy life.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, how should one understand knowing the root through knowing the culmination?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, excellent, excellent! There are two aspects of a matter regarding which a bodhisattva asks a question: that which one should understand oneself, and that which one causes others to understand. Although you yourself have realized and understood this, you ask about these matters for the sake of countless sentient beings who have not yet understood — and for that, I praise you, saying excellent, excellent!

Son of good family, the root of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening is aspiration. The cause is called luminous contact. The gathering is called feeling. The generation is called careful attention. The master is called mindfulness. The guide is called meditative absorption. The victor is called wisdom. The correct is called liberation. And the culmination is called the great nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, the most fervent aspiration is the root of all — from the initial generation of the mind of awakening all the way through to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Therefore aspiration is said to be the root.

Son of good family, consider these worldly examples: the root of all suffering is craving; the root of all illness is indigestion; the root of all litigation is dispute; the root of all non-virtue is falsehood. It is comparable to those.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked again: Blessed One, earlier in this very sūtra the Tathāgata declared that the root of all virtue is conscientiousness, yet now you say it is aspiration. What is the meaning of this?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if one speaks of the cause of arising, it is fervent aspiration. If one speaks of the cause of clarity, it is conscientiousness. Consider the worldly example: the cause of all fruits is said to be the seed, and furthermore the seed is said to be the cause of arising, while the soil is said to be the cause of clarity. The meaning here is comparable to that.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked:

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: In another sūtra the Tathāgata declared that the root of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening is the buddha. What is the meaning of that?

The Blessed One declared: The Tathāgata taught that for sentient beings who have no prior knowledge of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, the buddha is the root. For one who understands through one's own discernment, fervent aspiration is the root.

Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, in what sense is contact said to be the cause of clarity?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the Tathāgata has spoken of clarity at various points as wisdom, and at various points as faith. Son of good family, through the cause and condition of faith, one draws near to a spiritual friend, and this is therefore called contact. Through the cause and condition of relying on a spiritual friend, one attains the sacred Dharma, and this too is called contact. Through the condition of hearing the sacred Dharma, the actions of body, speech, and mind become thoroughly pure, and this too is called contact. Through the condition of the actions of body, speech, and mind being thoroughly pure, one attains right livelihood, and this too is called contact. Through the condition of right livelihood, one attains fully purified ethical discipline. Through the condition of fully purified ethical discipline, one comes to delight in remote forest retreats. Through the condition of delighting in remote forest retreats, one applies the mind with great thoroughness. Through thorough application of the mind, one abides in accordance with the Dharma. Through the condition of abiding in accordance with the Dharma, one attains the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening and overcomes afflictions without number — and this is called contact.

Son of good family, feeling is called the gathering. When sentient beings experience feeling, they perform virtuous and non-virtuous actions, and therefore feeling is called the gathering. Son of good family, through the condition of feeling, many afflictions arise. And through the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, afflictions are overcome — therefore feeling is called the gathering.

Through the condition of thorough and excellent application of the mind, afflictions are overcome, and therefore this is called production. Why? Because through sustained diligence, one attains the thirty-seven factors conducive to

awakening. And for one who intends to overcome afflictions in that way, everything depends on mindfulness. Therefore mindfulness is called the master.

Just as in the world the four kinds of troops follow according to the will of their commander, so too the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening all follow after mindfulness, their master. Son of good family, one who has entered into meditative absorption comes to understand all the defining characteristics of the phenomena of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening — therefore meditative absorption is called the guide. Understanding the defining characteristics of the phenomena of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening becomes supreme wisdom — therefore wisdom is called the victor. In this way, wisdom comprehends the afflictions, and through the power of wisdom the afflictions are pacified. Just as in the world the defeat of an enemy by four kinds of troops may depend on a single warrior or two, so too with the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening — through the power of wisdom the afflictions are overcome, and therefore it is called the victory of wisdom.

Son of good family, through sustained application to the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening one attains the four meditative concentrations, higher knowledge, and bliss, yet even so this is not to be called perfect. Only when, having vanquished the afflictions, one attains complete liberation — that is called the true fulfilment.

Through arousing the mind and applying oneself diligently to the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, one may attain worldly happiness, transcendent happiness, the four fruits of the contemplative life, and liberation — yet even so, this is not to be called perfect. One who utterly cuts off the very substance of the practice of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening — that is called nirvāṇa. And therefore what is perfected I have called great nirvāṇa.

Son of good family, furthermore, the mind of intense aspiration is called conviction. Through intense aspiration one draws near to a spiritual friend — this too is called contact, and it is called cause. Through drawing near to a spiritual friend there is what is called feeling, and that is called gathering. Through drawing near to a spiritual friend, thorough mental engagement arises, and that is called production. Through the condition of these four kinds of phenomena, awakening is born — by conviction, mindfulness, meditative

absorption, and wisdom. These are called the lord, the guide, and the victor. Through the condition of these three kinds of phenomena, two kinds of liberation are attained. By the complete cutting off of desire, the mind is liberated; by the complete cutting off of ignorance, wisdom is liberated — and this is called the genuine. Thus through these eight kinds of phenomena the ultimate fruit is attained, and this is called nirvāṇa — and it is also called perfection.

Son of good family, furthermore: conviction is the arousing of the awakening mind and the going forth into renunciation. Contact is the performance of the request and the four actions — and that is called cause. Taking hold is the embracing of the two kinds of moral discipline: the discipline of individual liberation and the discipline of thoroughly pure conduct — and that is called feeling and complete taking up. Production is the diligent application to the four meditative concentrations. The lord is the fruit of stream-entry and the fruit of once-returning. The guide is the fruit of non-returning. The victor is the fruit of arhatship. The genuine is the fruit of the pratyekabuddha. And perfection is the fruit of unsurpassed, complete, perfect awakening.

Son of good family, furthermore: conviction is consciousness. Contact is the six sense bases. Gathering is feeling. Production is ignorance. The lord is name-and-form. The guide is desire. The victor is grasping. The genuine is becoming. And perfection is birth, aging, sickness, and death.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: Blessed One, what is the difference between root, cause, and production?

The Blessed One declared: What is called root refers to the very first arousing of the mind. What is called cause is the unbroken continuation of the similar. Production is the arising of the similar after the similar has ceased. Son of good family, furthermore: what is called root is the agent. What is called cause is the fruit. And what is called production is the purpose. Son of good family, although in the future the matured fruit exists, because it has not yet been experienced it is called cause. When it is about to be experienced, that is called production.

Son of good family, furthermore: what is called root is feeling. Attainment is cause. Purpose is production. Son of good family, in this sūtra what is called root is the path of seeing. What is called cause is the path of cultivation. And what is called production is the path of no-more-learning.

Son of good family, furthermore: what is called root is the authentic cause. What is called cause is skillful means — for through skill in means the fruit is attained. The attainment of the fruit is called production.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked again:

"Blessed One, if, as you have declared, one who has reached the end is said to have attained nirvāṇa, is it then possible to attain nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, whatever bodhisattva, great being, monk, nun, layman, or laywoman applies themselves diligently to ten perceptions — know that such a one will attain nirvāṇa. What are the ten? They are as follows: the perception of impermanence, the perception of suffering, the perception of selflessness, the perception of abandoning food, the perception of non-attachment to the entire world, the perception of death, the perception of the many faults and flaws, the perception of relinquishment, the perception of cessation, and the perception of absence of craving. Son of good family, whatever bodhisattva, great being, monk, nun, layman, or laywoman applies themselves diligently to these ten perceptions — such a one will, in the end, definitively attain nirvāṇa. And therefore, without depending on others, they will come to understand virtue, non-virtue, and so forth. Such a one is a true monk — and likewise, down to the true layman and the true laywoman."

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa then asked: "Blessed One, how is it that from a bodhisattva down to a laywoman, one applies diligent effort to the perception of impermanence?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, with regard to a bodhisattva there are two aspects: the initial arousing of the mind of awakening, and applying diligent effort toward awakening. The perception of impermanence likewise has two aspects: the coarse and the subtle. When a bodhisattva who has initially aroused the mind of awakening cultivates the perception of impermanence, this is the thought that arises in the mind: 'Things of the world have two aspects: inner and outer.' Thus one reflects that inner things are impermanent and subject to change. This body of mine passes through distinct times and stages — birth, youth, adolescence, old age and decline, and death — each different and separate from the others. Therefore one understands that inner things are impermanent; one knows them to be impermanent. Furthermore, one reflects: 'When I observe sentient beings, some are endowed with fine complexion and color, with power and strength, moving and coming

and going without obstruction; others are tormented by illness and are utterly emaciated, lacking color and complexion, without power or strength, and unable to function freely. Some are endowed with great wealth and their storehouses overflow with abundance; others are so destitute they possess nothing at all. Some are seen to be endowed with excellent and abundant qualities; others are seen to be endowed with sinful and unwholesome phenomena.' And so one knows with certainty that inner phenomena are impermanent. Furthermore, with regard to outer phenomena: the times of seed, sprout, stem, leaf, flower, and fruit are each separate and distinct from one another. Thus among outer phenomena as well, some are endowed with excellence and abundance, others are not. One therefore reflects in the mind: 'I understand that all outer phenomena are likewise impermanent.' In this way, having understood all phenomena to be impermanent, one reflects upon all phenomena through the doorway of what one has heard, thinking as follows: 'When I listen, even the gods of the higher realms are endowed with supremely pleasant and abundant enjoyments, and though possessed of superknowledge and power, the five signs of decay appear, and therefore I understand them to be impermanent. Furthermore, I have heard that at the beginning of the cosmic age all sentient beings, each on their own, were endowed with supreme and excellent qualities, that the light of their own bodies illuminated everything and they had no need whatsoever of the light of sun or moon — yet by the force of impermanence even that light faded and those qualities were lost entirely.'

Furthermore, I have heard that even a wheel-turning king (cakravartin), sovereign over the four continents and possessed of the seven precious royal treasures and of great dominion, has yet been unable to overcome impermanence.

Furthermore, on this great earth in former times innumerable sentient beings dwelt at ease, and across every stretch of ground no larger than a chariot wheel there flourished in dense abundance all manner of excellent medicinal plants, forests, groves of edible trees, fruits, and the like. But now, because the merit of sentient beings has diminished, this great earth has lost its power and strength, so that even those things born from the soil are without flavour and have become bland and vapid. Therefore all phenomena, outer and inner, are impermanent. This is called coarse impermanence.

Having understood the coarse in this way, one then proceeds step by step to contemplate the subtle. What, then, is the subtle? A great bodhisattva

contemplates all outer and inner phenomena as impermanent right down to their finest atomic particles at every future moment. Why so? Because such a bodhisattva is endowed with the complete destruction of signs.

If the form that exists in the next moment were not impermanent, it would be inappropriate to speak of there being these ten distinct temporal phases of form. What are the ten? They are: the phase of gestation, the phase of quickening, the phase of hardening, the phase of developing flesh and mass, the phase of growth of the limbs, the phase of early childhood, the phase of youth, the phase of young adulthood, the phase of full maturity, and the phase of old age.

If a bodhisattva were to regard form at the phase of gestation as not impermanent, it would never change into the phases from quickening through to young adulthood; and if those phases were regarded as not impermanent, old age would never arrive either. Thus if the many phases were not ceasing moment by moment, it would be inappropriate for old age to arise; rather, it would be fitting for everything to arise all at once, fully complete. But there is no such thing as arising all at once in finished form. Therefore one should understand with certainty that there is a subtle impermanence of cessation moment by moment.

Furthermore, we observe that certain persons who were once endowed with keen senses and radiant complexion later decline and deteriorate. This makes it evident that such persons are definitely impermanent, moment by moment.

Beyond this, one should also contemplate the four great elements and the four modes of conduct.

Furthermore, with respect to both outer and inner aspects, there are two causes of suffering in each: hunger and thirst, and cold and heat, are also to be contemplated.

Furthermore, one thinks: if those four aspects were not subtly impermanent moment by moment, it would be inappropriate to speak of four kinds of suffering. Any bodhisattva who contemplates in this way is said to be a bodhisattva who contemplates subtle impermanence.

Just as one understands outer and inner form, so too should one understand mental phenomena in the same way. Why? Because mind operates through the six sense bases (āyatanas). While operating through the six sense bases, at one moment a mind of joy arises, at another a mind of aversion arises, at

another a mind of desire arises, and at another a mind of recollection arises — thus different minds arise in succession. Since they do not persist as a single unbroken continuity, one understands that all phenomena of form and of what is not form are impermanent.

O son of noble family, a bodhisattva who perceives the arising, cessation, and impermanence of all phenomena moment by moment is called a bodhisattva who possesses the perception of impermanence.

O son of noble family, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom, having applied themselves diligently to the perception of impermanence in this manner, should then contemplate the conceit of permanence, the inverted view of permanence, and —

— the inverted perception, and abandons it entirely, then applies themselves diligently to the perception of suffering. Contemplating thus — "By what cause and by what condition does one come to experience suffering in this way?" — one understands that suffering arises from the cause of impermanence. Through the condition of impermanence, one comes to experience birth, aging, sickness, and death; and because of the condition of birth, aging, sickness, and death, this is called impermanence. Through the condition of impermanence, one experiences the many outer and inner sufferings: the sufferings of hunger and thirst, of cold and heat, of being beaten and stabbed, of being reviled and verbally abused. In this way, the experience of so many sufferings also arises through the condition of impermanence.

Furthermore, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom understands that this very body is a vessel of impermanence. The vessel is suffering; and because the vessel is suffering, the essence it contains is likewise understood to be of the nature of suffering. Furthermore, O son of noble family, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom understands that arising itself is suffering and cessation itself is suffering. Because things arise and cease through suffering, they are impermanent; and so one applies oneself diligently to the perception of impermanence, free from the notion of self and what belongs to a self.

Furthermore, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom understands that suffering itself is impermanence, and impermanence itself is suffering. Since suffering is impermanence, why would one who is learned and endowed with wisdom assert that a self exists? Because there is no self in this way, impermanence too should be understood accordingly. Likewise, since the five

aggregates (skandhas) are both suffering and impermanence, why do sentient beings assert that a self exists?

Furthermore, one understands that all phenomena arise from a diversity of assembled conditions, not from a single assembly; all phenomena do not arise from one assembly alone, nor is even a single phenomenon the fruit of all assemblies together. All assemblies have no nature of self, no nature of singularity, no nature of plurality, no nature of a thing, and no nature of anything under sovereign control. If those characteristics of intrinsic nature were indeed present in all phenomena, why would one who is learned and endowed with wisdom assert that a self exists?

Furthermore, one contemplates thus: in all phenomena there is not even a single agent. Even now there is not a single agent in even one phenomenon; in all phenomena, arising from assembly, there is likewise no agent. All phenomena do not arise or cease through their own intrinsic nature; they cease from assembly and arise from assembly. Having thus arisen, sentient beings generate an inverted perception, saying "they arise from assembly." Because sentient beings perceive invertedly, and because there is no genuine truth when one perceives in an inverted manner, why does one assert that a self truly exists? Therefore, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom understands there to be no self (anātman).

Furthermore, one contemplates: "By what cause and by what condition do sentient beings grasp at a self?" If that self were to exist, one asks whether it is singular or whether it exists in many forms. If that self were solely singular, why would there be the birth-states of kṣatriya, brahmin, merchant, outcaste, god, human, hell-being, hungry ghost (preta), and animal — why would there be great and small, young and old? Therefore, one understands that what is called "self" is not singular. If what is called "self" were multiple, why do people say that the self of all sentient beings is one — that it pervades everything and is without limit? Therefore, in neither the singular nor the plural does a self exist.

Having understood in this way that there is no self, one who is learned and endowed with wisdom then progressively cultivates the perception of complete disenchantment with food —

One might think: if all phenomena are indeed impermanent, suffering, and without self, then why do non-virtuous actions of body, speech, and mind arise for the sake of food? It is because sentient beings are attached to food that

they commit non-virtuous actions of body, speech, and mind. And though material things that are obtained may be shared with others, when the karmic maturation of suffering is experienced, there is no sharing in that.

A son of good family who is learned and endowed with wisdom reflects further in this way: all sentient beings, for the sake of food, have caused their bodies and minds to suffer. Since food is obtained through the condition of so much suffering, he thinks, "Why should I give rise to a mind of attachment to that food?" — and so he does not allow a mind of attachment to food to arise.

Furthermore, when the learned one endowed with wisdom examines what the cause of the body is, he understands that it is through the condition of food that the body is born and grows. He reflects: "I have gone forth from home into homelessness and have taken up moral discipline — and I intend to completely relinquish this body. How then can I now be attached to food?" Having reflected thus, even while accepting food, he cultivates the perception of food as being like the flesh of a child, eaten by hungry ghosts on a desolate plain. He gives rise to a mind of complete disenchantment and does not become attached to it.

Having understood in this way that food has many faults, he then progressively cultivates the perception of contact-as-food in the following manner. He perceives it as like the skin of an ox, when flayed, utterly consumed by countless insects.

Then, progressing further, he cultivates the perception of volition-as-food in this way: he perceives it as like a great mass of fire.

As for consciousness-as-food, he perceives it as like being pierced by three hundred spears.

A son of good family who is learned and endowed with wisdom, having understood in this way the four kinds of food, will never again give rise to a mind of attachment or desire toward food. If such a mind should arise, he reflects thoroughly on impurity. Why so? In order to completely abandon attachment to food. He reflects very carefully that all food is impure. Having understood deeply that it is like something impure, whether he obtains good food or poor food, when he takes it he never gives rise to a mind of attachment or desire — regarding it as like applying medicine to a wound or a festering sore.

A son of good family who is learned and endowed with wisdom, if one understands it thus, is said to be endowed with the complete relinquishment of the perception of food.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, when one learned and endowed with wisdom perceives food as impure in this way, does one perceive it truly, or merely as an illusion? If one perceives it truly, then that food being perceived would not actually be impure. If one perceives it merely as an illusion, then is that phenomenon being truly perceived?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, that perception is neither true nor illusory. Because it leads to the complete abandonment of attachment to food, it is called 'true.' Because one sees insects where there are no insects, it is called 'illusory.' Son of good family, all things that are defiled are illusory, and yet they can become true.

"Son of good family, if a monk sets out to go on his alms round and from the very outset thinks, 'May I obtain good food there and not poor food, may I obtain much and not little, may I obtain it quickly and without obstruction' — that monk has not attained the perception of complete relinquishment with regard to food.

virtuous qualities diminish day and night, while non-virtuous phenomena arise and increase.

Son of good family, when a monk sets out to go on his alms round and from the very outset makes this aspiration: 'May those who give me alms be satisfied with food,' and further thinks, 'May those who give me alms obtain immeasurable merit, may I sustain this body — which is afflicted and laden with impurity — through these alms, so that I may apply myself to virtuous qualities and bring about benefit and happiness for my donors' — in that monk, virtuous conduct arises and increases day and night, and non-virtuous phenomena are thoroughly purified. Son of good family, know that a monk who applies himself in this way is not one who receives the gifts of a single region alone.

Son of good family, one who is wise and endowed with wisdom (prajñā) thus applies himself to the non-attachment perception, being equipped with the four kinds of perception. He reflects: 'Throughout all the world, there is nowhere that is free from birth, aging, sickness, and death. There is nowhere in which this body of mine has not been born. If there is not a single place in the world that is free from birth, aging, sickness, and death, why should I be

attached to the world? All worldly beings never ascend higher and higher without falling back — therefore the world is assuredly impermanent. If it is impermanent in this way, why would one who is wise and endowed with wisdom be attached to the world? Each and every sentient being has suffered everywhere throughout all the world, without exception. Even those born as Brahmā gods in the high heavens, and those born as gods of the sphere of neither perception nor non-perception — the very moment their life departs, they fall into one of the three lower realms. Even those born as lords among the gods of the Four Great Kings, and those born as gods of the Heaven of Wielding Others' Emanations — the very moment their life departs, they are born in the realm of animals and arise as lions, tigers, wolves, yaks, horses, cattle, donkeys, and the like. Even a wheel-turning monarch who holds sovereignty over the four continents, possessed of enjoyments and power — when his merit is exhausted, he becomes destitute and must struggle greatly even to keep himself fed. One who is wise and endowed with wisdom, having understood this so thoroughly, gives rise to the perception of non-attachment to the world.

One who is wise and endowed with wisdom also reflects in this way: 'Worldly things — houses, clothing to wear, food, bedding, medicines for illness, flowers, incense, garlands, various kinds of music, material goods, jewels, and the like — may seem to be free from suffering, and yet these things are suffering by their very nature. How, then, can suffering be relinquished through suffering?' Son of good family, one who is wise and endowed with wisdom, having thus understood, does not give rise to attachment or the perception of pleasure with regard to any worldly thing whatsoever. Son of good family, consider this analogy: when a person is struck by grave illness, even if various kinds of music, flowers, incense, and many kinds of garlands are present, no thought of desire or attachment arises in him toward them. The understanding of one who is wise and endowed with wisdom is just the same.

Son of good family, one who is wise and endowed with wisdom understands that the entire world is not a refuge, not a place of liberation, not a place of perfect peace,

not a place of pleasurable dwelling, not a place where perfection is reached; and he carefully examines it as something devoid of permanence, happiness, self, and purity. He thinks: if I were to become attached to the world in that way, how could I ever fully abandon those phenomena? It is like a person who

has no desire for darkness yet turns back from the light into the dark. Darkness is the world; light is the transcendence of the world. If I were to cling to the world and generate darkness, I would be utterly parted from the luminosity of light. Darkness is ignorance; light is wisdom. The cause of wisdom and light is the perception of non-attachment to the world. Desire is a form of bondage, yet I desire the luminosity of wisdom — I do not desire attachment to the world. One who is wise and endowed with wisdom examines things in this way, and having understood thus, should abide in the perception of non-attachment to the world.

Son of good family, one who is wise and endowed with wisdom, having applied himself diligently to the perception of non-attachment to the world, then progressively applies himself with diligence to the perception of death. Reflecting on this life and vital force: it is perpetually surrounded by countless hostile enemies who diminish it moment by moment and do not allow it to arise and grow. It is like a mountain torrent that does not stay still, or like dewdrops on a blade of grass that do not remain long, or like those led to slaughter who are close to death, or like a cow or sheep driven to the butcher's side.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa asked: Blessed One, how does one who is wise and endowed with wisdom understand cessation moment by moment?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, consider this analogy: four skilled archers gather together and each deliberates, saying, "Let the four of us each shoot an arrow in a different direction, all released at once, and let them all fall to the ground at once." Now if someone were to say, "I will catch with my own hands, all at the same moment, all four arrows shot by those four men, before they fall to the ground" — son of good family, would not that person need to be extraordinarily swift?

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa replied: Blessed One, that is so.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, a hungry ghost (preta) that moves along the ground is swifter than that. A hungry ghost that moves through the sky is swifter than one that moves along the ground. The kings of the four great divine realms are swifter than the hungry ghosts that move through the sky. The gods of the sun and moon are swifter than the kings of the four great divine realms. The very swift gods are swifter than the gods of the sun and moon. And the life-span of sentient beings is swifter than even those very swift gods. Son of good family, in the single passage of a breath

going in and out, there are four hundred arisings and cessations of the life-span by which a sentient being lives. Whoever understands life in this way is said to understand cessation moment by moment.

Son of good family, those who are wise and endowed with wisdom understand that this life and vital force are under the dominion of the king of death. They think: if I were to fully abandon the king of death, I would abandon impermanent life and vital force entirely. Furthermore, those who are wise and endowed with wisdom regard life and the vital force as like a great tree on a crumbling riverbank at the edge of a precipice. Furthermore, as a person who has committed a grave wrong is led away to be executed, left without a protector — or as a lion, the king of beasts, is extremely hungry — or as a venomous snake inhaling a great wind — or as a horse extremely parched with thirst and overcome with craving for water —

— or as a wrathful, extremely angry hungry ghost — so too does one regard the king of death over sentient beings in just that way. A son of good family who is wise and endowed with wisdom, understanding things clearly in this manner, is called one who is diligent in the perception of death.

A son of good family who is wise and endowed with wisdom thinks further to himself: even if, after going forth into renunciation, I cannot sustain life and vital force for more than seven days, still I shall rouse the utmost diligence, guard ethical conduct, benefit sentient beings, and teach the Dharma for their welfare and happiness — this is called the one who is wise and endowed with wisdom being diligent in the perception of death.

Let alone seven days — what need is there to say so much? Whether it be six days, or five, or four, or three, or two, or one, or from a single breath passing in and out to the duration of a single moment and instant — if during that time I apply diligent effort toward awakening, guard ethical conduct perfectly, benefit sentient beings, and teach the Dharma for their welfare and happiness — this too is called the one who is wise and endowed with wisdom being diligent in the perception of death.

One who is wise and endowed with wisdom, possessed of the six perceptions mentioned above, applies diligent effort to these seven causes of perception. What are the seven? They are: the perception that applies diligent effort to what is permanent; the perception that applies diligent effort to what is pleasurable; the perception free from aversion; the perception free from jealousy; the perception of virtue; the perception of aspiration; the perception

free from pride; and the perception that has come under the dominion of meditative absorption.

A son of good family — a monk who possesses these seven perceptions is called a śramaṇa, a brahmin, one who is thoroughly pacified, one who is thoroughly pure, one who is completely liberated, one who is wise and endowed with wisdom, one of right view, one who has reached the far shore of perfection, a king of physicians, and a caravan leader. Such a one is supremely skilled in what the Tathāgata has intended and declared, and will completely resolve any doubt regarding the seven kinds of utterances that the Tathāgatas have spoken — contemplating, fully understanding, and seeing those seven kinds of utterances.

A son of good family — a person who possesses these six perceptions is one who utterly condemns the three worlds, who utterly abandons the three worlds, who utterly pacifies the three worlds, and who is unattached to the three worlds. Such a one is called the wise and wisdom-endowed one who possesses the ten perceptions.

A monk who possesses these ten is called one endowed with the marks of a śramaṇa.

Then the bodhisattva Kāśyapa praised the Blessed One before his presence with the following verses addressed to the buddha:

With compassion for the world and all it holds, you are the king of physicians —

in body and in wisdom both, you are completely stilled.

Since I am possessed of a self, while the phenomena of selflessness are certain,

for that reason I bow with reverence to you, the peerless Victor.

When the initial mind and the perfected mind are both examined,
the perfected mind takes supreme delight in the initial mind.

Though I myself am not yet liberated, I liberate others —
therefore I bow in homage to the initial mind.

The initial mind becomes the teacher of gods and humans,
far surpassing śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas alike.

One who has generated this mind has utterly transcended the three worlds —
therefore one may call the Victor "peerless beyond all excellence."

The protector of the world is fully obtained through accomplishment,
and the Tathāgata comes as protector without being implored.

Like a buddha departing from the world, and like a calf —
therefore it is said the Tathāgata is the supreme leader of the herd of great
compassion.

The Tathāgata's qualities pervade all ten directions everywhere;
those of lesser understanding and without knowledge cannot offer praise.

I offer praise to the power of great compassion,
in order to repay the kindness of the deeds of body and speech.

The worlds perform acts that benefit me,
and the Tathāgata reveals those very activities.

Having severed the karmic maturation of many beings,
therefore I pay homage to the one who acts for the benefit of self and others
alike.

The world together with its gods acts greatly for the benefit of those close to it,
yet in the Tathāgata's working of benefit there is no love or hatred.

The Tathāgata possesses no characteristics of the kind the world has —
therefore the mind is equal toward all, free from duality.

The world says one thing and does another;
in the Tathāgata there is no difference between what is spoken and what is
done.

All those deeds of his sever every formation —
therefore the name "Tathāgata" has become renowned.

Having thoroughly understood all the faults of complete affliction,
and having demonstrated as well the remaining for the sake of sentient beings
—

though liberated in this world for a long time,
out of loving concern the Tathāgata delights in remaining within saṃsāra.
Though appearing visibly in the body of a god or the body of a human,
through great compassion the Tathāgata follows after, as a cow follows its calf.

Since the Tathāgata is the mother of all sentient beings,
the very heart of great compassion is like the calf.

In consideration of sentient beings, the Tathāgata undergoes suffering;
yet when acting out of compassionate concern, no regret arises in the mind.
Being endowed with a mind of compassion, suffering is not felt as suffering —
therefore I pay homage to the one who fully liberates from suffering.

Although the Tathāgata performs limitless merit in every way,
the deeds of body, speech, and mind are utterly pure.
The work done for the sake of sentient beings is not done for one's own sake
—
therefore I pay homage to the utterly pure deeds.

The Buddha undergoes suffering yet does not feel it as suffering,
just as those who see another experiencing suffering undergo it as if feeling it
themselves.

Even entering the hells for the sake of sentient beings,
a mind of suffering and regret does not arise.

The many sufferings experienced by ordinary beings —
a single body of the Tathāgata takes them all on.

Having undergone them all, the mind becomes supremely stable —
therefore the Tathāgata strives most intently for unsurpassed awakening.

The Tathāgata, with a single flavor of great compassion,
regards every ordinary being as though they were an only child.

Not knowing that the Blessed One is a refuge, sentient beings
cast aspersions upon the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha.

The worlds are thoroughly afflicted throughout,
and likewise are accompanied by boundless faults and flaws.

Yet whatever faults and flaws arising from thorough affliction there may be —
all were vanquished at the very moment the awakening mind was first
generated.

Tathāgatas praise Tathāgatas;

none other than a Tathāgata is able to offer such praise.

Yet I today offer manifest praise by means of this one quality alone:

the Tathāgata has passed through the world with the mind of great
compassion.

The aggregate of Dharma of the Tathāgata is loving-kindness (Skt. maitrī);
through the mind of loving-kindness, sentient beings will be fully liberated.

That is the unsurpassed liberation —
and that liberation is nirvāṇa.

This is the twelfth chapter, called "Comprehensively Questioned by Kāśyapa,"
from the noble great sūtra of complete nirvāṇa.

The fifty-first fascicle.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Kauṇḍinya, who knows all:

Form is impermanent; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that abides permanently. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are likewise impermanent; yet through the condition of consciousness's cessation, one will attain a liberated consciousness that abides permanently.

Kauṇḍinya, form is suffering; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is bliss. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are to be understood in the same way, and this should be known in full.

Kauṇḍinya, form is empty; yet through the condition of that empty form's cessation, one will attain a liberation of form that is not empty. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is without self; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form possessed of a true self. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is impure; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is utterly pure. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is subject to birth, aging, sickness, and death; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is free from birth, aging, sickness, and death. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form arises through ignorance; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is free from ignorance. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is a cause of birth; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is not a cause of birth. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is a cause of the four inversions; yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is not a cause of inversion. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is the cause of immeasurable non-virtuous phenomena — such as craving for the bodies of men and women and the like, craving for food, attachment to desire, aversion, delusion, miserliness, envy, unwholesome mind, the mind of dread, nutritive food, consciousness as nutriment, intentional food, contact as nutriment, birth from eggs, birth from a womb, birth from warmth and moisture, miraculous birth, the five objects of desire, and the five obscurations and so forth — all these phenomena arise from form. Yet through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated body free from that immeasurable multitude of faults and flaws. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is thoroughly bound by bondage; yet through the condition of that bound form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is free from bondage. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is a cause of the stream of rebirth. Through the condition of that form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is free from the stream. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is not a cause for going to refuge. Through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is a going to refuge. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is like a wound. Through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a liberated form that is free from wounds. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, form is not utterly pacified. Through the condition of form's cessation, one will attain a completely nirvāṇa-realized form that is utterly pacified. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well — this should be known in full in the same way.

Kauṇḍinya, any person who knows things in this way is called a śramaṇa and a brahmin. One endowed with this understanding is said to possess the qualities of a śramaṇa, the Dharma of a śramaṇa, the qualities of a brahmin, and the Dharma of a brahmin.

Kauṇḍinya, apart from the Dharma of the buddhas, there is nowhere else a true śramaṇa, nowhere a true brahmin, and nowhere the Dharma of śramaṇas and brahmins. All the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) are merely speakers of falsehood; not one of them has genuine conduct. They may adopt the outward appearance of those two, but they have no standing in those two. Why is that? Because without the Dharma of śramaṇas and brahmins, why would they claim there are śramaṇas and brahmins? I, for my part, always proclaim the lion's roar in this assembly, so you too should always sound the lion's roar in the great assemblies.

When the immeasurable multitude of non-Buddhists heard these words, they gave rise to minds of aversion and said: "The śramaṇa Gautama declares that among us there are neither śramaṇas nor brahmins, and neither the Dharma of śramaṇas nor the Dharma of brahmins. What are we to do?" And throughout that assembly one wandering ascetic spoke up and said: "Friends, the words of the śramaṇa Gautama are like the ravings of a madman — if they are not consistent, how can they be trusted? Even people who are not mad sometimes sing, sometimes dance, sometimes weep, sometimes laugh, sometimes revile, sometimes praise, unable to distinguish between friend and enemy. The śramaṇa Gautama is just like that: sometimes he proudly says he was born in a city of pure lineage, sometimes he says he was not born, sometimes he says that at birth he took seven steps, sometimes he says he went nowhere, sometimes he says he studied worldly arts in his youth, sometimes he says he is omniscient, sometimes he says he lived comfortably in the royal palace, enjoying pleasures and even fathering a son, sometimes he condemns all of that and says he wants none of it, sometimes he says he practiced austerities for six years, and sometimes he roundly denounces the ascetic practices of non-Buddhists."

Sometimes he says he heard teachings never heard before, such as the udumbara flower and the alalā and so on. Sometimes he says he attained unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening at the foot of the awakening tree. Sometimes he says, "I went to the foot of the awakening tree and attained nothing whatsoever." Sometimes he says, "This very body of mine is nirvāṇa." Sometimes he says, "When this body of mine ceases, that will be

nirvāṇa." All that the ascetic Gautama says is like the raving of a madman — what is there to believe in, or to take pleasure in, regarding him?

The brahmins replied to him with these words: "O great man, how could there be any escape from grief for us now? The ascetic Gautama, after going forth long ago, taught impermanence, suffering, emptiness, selflessness, and so on. Our kinsmen heard this and became extremely frightened, and they did not trust his words — words saying that sentient beings are impermanent, suffering, selfless, and impure. But now the ascetic Gautama, here in this sal grove, has taught in the midst of a great assembly that there exist things that are permanent, blissful, possessed of self, and utterly pure. When our kinsmen heard him say this, they completely abandoned themselves and came to trust the words of the ascetic Gautama. It is on that account and by that condition that great grief has arisen."

At that time yet another brahmin spoke to them in these words: "Listen well, good people, listen well. The saying that the ascetic Gautama is compassionate is a lie — it is not true. If he were truly compassionate, why would it be that students of ours, who through our own doctrine had obtained the fruit of compassion, would have their minds turned to follow another, acting contrary to our intentions? For that reason, calling him compassionate is not fitting. Moreover, whoever says that the ascetic Gautama is unstained by the eight worldly concerns — that person too speaks falsely. For if the ascetic Gautama is said to be one of few desires and contentment, why does he go about plundering our gains and so forth? And if someone says that the ascetic Gautama is of noble lineage, that too is speaking falsely. Why? Because we have never heard or seen that the lion, the king of wild beasts, has ever killed a little mouse. If the ascetic Gautama were of noble lineage, why would he go about harming us and those like us? And if someone says that the ascetic Gautama is endowed with great power, that too is speaking falsely. Why? Because we have never heard or seen that the garuḍa, the king of birds, has ever fought with a little crow. If he were truly powerful, why would he quarrel with the likes of us? And if someone says that the ascetic Gautama is endowed with the wisdom that knows the minds of others, that too is speaking falsely. Why? If he possessed that wisdom, why does he not know the thoughts we have in our minds? O people, I have heard from wise elders of old that when a hundred years have passed, a magician who works illusions will appear, and it is to the ascetic Gautama that this refers. This creator of illusions will not tarry long — he will soon disappear from this sal grove, so you

and the rest of you should not grieve."

At that time yet another naked ascetic spoke to them in these words: "O people, we do not grieve on account of our own bodies, or for the sake of our kinsmen, or for gains, or for reputation. Rather, it is because worldly beings have come to be covered by the darkness of delusion —

— that they do not know what is a field of merit and what is not a field of merit, and so they have abandoned the brahmins who were endowed with the wisdom of the ancient elders, and instead have come to honor those who are very young and without understanding. It is for this reason that we grieve.

"The ascetic Gautama is skilled in spells and incantations, and by the power of those spells he can multiply one body into bodies without number, and from those countless bodies can gather them back into one. With that same body he can take on the forms of men and women, of cattle, sheep, oxen, and horses. Yet by my own power I am able to neutralize the power of his spells. Once the power of the ascetic Gautama's spells has been nullified, we and the rest of us will gain offerings and renown and will enjoy great comfort."

At that time yet another brahmin spoke these words: "O people, the ascetic Gautama possesses immeasurable and fully perfect qualities. Therefore, do not any of you contend with him."

The retinue of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) said to him: "You fool, you deluded one — why do you say that the ascetic Gautama possesses immeasurable qualities? If a mother dies seven days after giving birth, is it fitting to say of the child that he possesses merit and qualities?"

The brahmin replied: "Even when the other party reviles him, he does not revile in return; even when the other party strikes him, he does not strike back. That is the very characteristic of one who possesses great qualities. He bears the thirty-two major marks on his body, the eighty excellent minor marks, and immeasurable miraculous powers. Therefore, know that he is endowed with immeasurable merit and qualities.

"Because he is free from a mind of arrogance, he spoke truthfully from the very first. His speech is gentle and measured, and there is no harshness in his words. Though he has come to the prime of youth, he is without anger and without fierceness. Though in a king's domain, with wealth and possessions in great abundance, he felt no attachment to them — he relinquished everything completely and went forth, abandoning it all as though spitting out a mouthful

of phlegm. This is why I say that the ascetic Gautama is endowed with immeasurable and perfectly complete qualities."

Then the retinue spoke up: "Excellent! Great man, what you say is indeed true — the ascetic Gautama is endowed with immeasurable qualities and immeasurable miraculous powers arising from direct knowledge. We for our part cannot match him. The ascetic Gautama is gentle by nature, and having been born in Rājagṛha he has pursued no rigorous austerities and enrolled in no school of study. It may be fitting for him to speak softly, but he knows nothing of the arts, of letters, of traditional learning, and so forth. Let us debate with him on a limited selection of sacred texts. If the ascetic Gautama defeats us, we will enter his service; if we defeat him, he must enter ours."

Having said this, a countless number of non-Buddhists gathered together and went to the court of King Ajātaśatru in the capital.

The king, upon seeing them, spoke these words: "O people, where are you going? Each of you is diligently pursuing the noble path in your own tradition — having gone forth from home into homelessness, you have completely relinquished all household goods and possessions, and the people of the land honor and venerate you with reverence and service. If you have not taken offense at the honor and respectful attendance shown to you, then why have you all assembled and come here together?

"O people, each of you upholds your own doctrine, each of you has gone forth under your own code of moral discipline, and yet you are not in agreement with one another, each having gone forth under a different code of discipline and diligently practicing your respective paths —

"What is the cause and what are the conditions by which all of you have now assembled here with a single purpose? It is like leaves that have been stripped from their branches and then driven together by a fierce wind — so it is that all of you have come together here. As for myself, I am ever a refuge and protector for those who have gone forth; even in my youth I did not begrudge my body and life for their sake."

At that moment all the tīrthikas spoke these words in reply: "Long live the great king! The great king is like a mighty bridge of Dharma. He is like a great sieve of Dharma. He is like a great balance-scale of Dharma — a vessel for all good qualities, the very essential nature of all good qualities. He is like a road of the sacred Dharma. He is like a fertile field for all seeds. He is like a foundation for all territories and lands. He is like the reflected image in a

mirror for all realms and regions. He is like a form visible to all the gods. He is like a father and mother to all the people of the land. Great king, the body of the king is a precious treasury of virtue for all world-realms everywhere. And why is he called a treasury of virtue? Because when a king passes judgment, he makes no distinction between friend and enemy but is impartial — like earth, like water, like fire, like wind. Therefore the king is called a treasury of virtue.

"Great king, though the lifespan of beings today is short, the virtues of the king are like the time of kings of old who lived long and dwelt in great happiness. Furthermore, the great king resembles such exemplary kings as Topknot-Born, Splendid Light, Patient One, Naho-zha, Yā-yā-de, Śi-phyi, or Pa-pa-i-tsa-gu and others, who were endowed with a full complement of virtuous qualities. So too is the great king like them. It is through the condition of the great king that all the people of the land have come to dwell in happiness and well-being. Therefore all of us who have gone forth are glad to reside in this country, and we uphold our moral discipline and apply ourselves diligently to the correct path.

"Great king, wherever persons who have gone forth from under our tradition reside, in whatever country that may be, they uphold moral discipline and apply themselves to the correct path — and this brings to the king as well the good fortune of practicing virtue. Great king, you have caused all thieves and bandits in the world to cease, so that all those who have gone forth live without fear. Yet you have not caused the one truly troublesome ascetic, Gautama, to cease — and so we are greatly afraid of him. Gautama, being proud of his birth-lineage and possessed of a fine physical complexion, and having obtained abundant gain through the merit of past generosity, has grown vastly arrogant on account of those possessions. He is further made arrogant through his mastery of mystic spells. Because of these causes and conditions, he is unable to practice austerities, and he indulges in exceedingly soft and comfortable clothing, bedding, and the like. Because of this, all disreputable persons in the world, out of desire for gain and fame, gather around him and assemble in his presence, and they too are unable to practice austerities. By the power of his mystic spells he has brought under his sway Kāśyapa, Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, and others like them. And now, in order to draw our own residents here into his circle as disciples in this grove of śāla trees, he proclaims that there exists a body that is permanent, blissful, a self, and utterly pure.

"Great king, we can accept it when the ascetic Gautama formerly taught impermanence, the absence of bliss, the absence of self, and the absence of purity. But now he declares that there is permanence, bliss, a self,

and a self, and that utter purity exists — and this we cannot endure.

"Great king, please listen carefully. What authority do you give us and the ascetic Gautama to establish opposing positions and enter into debate?"

The king then spoke: "Ah, good people, if someone has deceived you, then your minds have become utterly intoxicated and disturbed — like the surging waves of water, or a firebrand whirled in circles, or a monkey that has scrambled up into a tree. Even I would be embarrassed by this, and if a wise and discerning person were to hear it, he would feel deep pity; if a foolish and bewildered person were to hear it, he would mock and revile you. The words you have spoken are not the words of those who have gone forth from the household life. If you were afflicted by diseases of wind, bile, or phlegm, I have excellent medicine here that could heal you. And if you were seized by hungry ghosts (pretas), a physician skilled in healing mantras would cure you. What you are doing right now is like wishing to demolish Mount Meru with the nail of a finger, or to plant seeds in a thunderbolt. Noble sirs, it is like a foolish, bewildered person trying to rouse a lion — the king of beasts — from its hungry sleep, or thrusting a hand into the mouth of a venomous snake, or reaching with bare hands into a fire whose embers are covered with ash. You are doing exactly the same. Sons of good family, consider this further analogy: it is like a jackal trying to roar with the voice of a lion, or a tiny insect trying to race in speed against a garuḍa bird through the sky, or a hare trying to fathom the depths of the great ocean. You are doing exactly the same right now.

"Even if in a dream you were to see yourselves victorious over the monk Gautama, that dream would be false and unworthy of trust.

"Ah, good people, to conceive of such an intention is like walking into a mass of fire hidden beneath ash. Do not speak again in the way you have spoken. And the words of praise you used for me — saying I am equal to you as a scale — do not let others hear them."

At that moment the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) addressed the king again with these words: "Great king, have you been struck by the spells of the ascetic Gautama? Great king, do you distrust and doubt the words spoken by these noble ones? Great king, do not show such contempt toward these great beings. Great king, who is it that causes the moon to wane and to be born

anew, that causes the vast ocean to be pervaded by the taste of salt, and the Himālaya and other mountains to arise? Was it not we — the brahmins and the rest — who did these things? Great king, have you not heard? For twelve years the sage Agata poured the waters of the river Gaṅgā into his ear. Have you not heard that the sage Gautama, endowed with great supernatural power, for twelve years transformed himself into the body of Śakra — Śakra whose body he then transformed into the body of a ewe with a thousand teats? Great king, have you not heard that the sage's gaze, in a single day, drank the waters of the four great oceans all at once and dried up the very earth? Great king, have you not heard that the sage Baśpu made the divine king of the gods — the lord of the three eyes — into a three-eyed one? Great king, have you not heard that the sage Alāla reduced a city like Alāla to dust? Great king, among the brahmins there are sages endowed with such great power, present and manifest right before your eyes — so why, great king, do you hold us in such utter contempt?"

The king replied: "Ah, good people, if you do not trust my words and wish to enter into contest, then the Tathāgata, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha, is present at this very moment beneath the śāla trees. Go there, all of you, and question him as you please."

The Tathāgata, having analyzed the matter, will answer you as you wish."

At that time, King Ajātaśatru, together with the retinue of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), went to where the Buddha was. He bowed his head in homage, circumambulated to the right three times, and then, with due deference, took his seat to one side. He addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, these non-Buddhists wish to question and debate on such and such matters."

The Tathāgata was requested to give his reply to each point in turn. The Blessed One declared: "Great king, the Tathāgata knows the right moment — wait a little while."

Then, from within that assembly, a brahmin named Śateśana spoke these words: "Gautama, is what you call nirvāṇa a permanent phenomenon?"

The great brahmin replied: "It is so. Yes, it is indeed so."

The brahmin then spoke again: "Gautama, it is not fitting to call nirvāṇa permanent. Why? Because worldly phenomena are such that fruits arise from seeds in an unbroken continuum — just as clay pots arise from clay, and

garments arise from thread. If Gautama has taught that one attains nirvāṇa by assiduously cultivating impermanence, then if the cause is not permanent, how can the result be called permanent?"

"Gautama, liberation from attachment is nirvāṇa. Liberation from attachment to form and liberation from attachment to the formless is nirvāṇa. When all afflictions — ignorance and the rest — are ceased, that is nirvāṇa, so you have taught. But all of these, from attachment through to the affliction of ignorance, are impermanent. If the cause is impermanent, then it follows that the attainment of nirvāṇa too would be impermanent."

"Gautama, you have taught that one is born as a god through the power of causes, that one falls into hell through the power of causes, and that one is liberated from causes. Therefore all phenomena arise from causes. If liberation were to occur through the power of causes, could it rightly be called permanent?"

"Gautama, you have taught that form, arising from conditions, is impermanent — and that feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are likewise the same. If that liberation itself is form, then it is impermanent; and feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness would equally be impermanent. If there is some liberation beyond the five aggregates (skandhas), then that liberation would amount to nothing but empty space. But if it is empty space, it cannot rightly be said to arise from causes and conditions — because what is permanent and singular pervades everywhere."

"Gautama, you have further taught that whatever arises from causes is suffering. If that is so, why do you teach that liberation is bliss? You have further taught that what is impermanent is suffering, and what is suffering is selfless. If it is impermanent, suffering, and selfless, then it is impure. If all phenomena arising from causes are impermanent, suffering, selfless, and impure, then why do you teach that nirvāṇa is permanent, blissful, self, and pure?"

"Gautama, if you have taught both permanence and impermanence, both suffering and bliss, both self and no-self, both pure and impure, does that not amount to teaching in contradictions? I have heard from wise and intelligent elders of old: if a buddha comes into the world, it is impossible that he would teach in contradictions. And yet now Gautama has taught in contradictions."

"Furthermore, what is the meaning of your saying 'I am what is called a buddha'?"

The Blessed One spoke to the brahmin: "As you have said, if I put a question to you, you must answer it accordingly."

The brahmin replied, "Excellent, Gautama."

The Blessed One then asked: "Is what you call intrinsic nature permanent or impermanent?"

The brahmin said: "What I call intrinsic nature is permanent."

"Does that intrinsic nature become the cause of all inner and outer phenomena?"

"It does."

The Blessed One asked: "Brahmin, how does it function as cause?"

The brahmin said: "Gautama, from intrinsic nature, the Great One arises. From the Great One, ego-pride arises. From ego-pride, the sixteen factors arise: namely, earth, water, fire, wind, and space — five; the five faculties of consciousness, which are the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and body; the five faculties of action, which are the hands, feet, mouth, hair, and the faculty of male and female; and the faculty of the mind-in-equilibrium. These sixteen factors are born from the five sense objects: form, sound, smell, taste, and tangible objects. The root of these twenty-one factors is of three kinds: attachment, dust, and darkness. What is called attachment is desire. What is called dust is aversion. What is called darkness is ignorance. Gautama, all twenty-five factors arise from intrinsic nature."

The Blessed One asked: "Brahmin, are these factors — the Great One and the rest — permanent or impermanent?"

The brahmin said: "Gautama, the intrinsic nature of my Dharma is permanent, but all factors such as the Great One and the rest are impermanent."

"Brahmin, according to what you say, in your doctrine the cause is permanent and the result is impermanent. In my doctrine, the cause is impermanent, yet you ask what fault there is if the result is permanent. Brahmin, does your doctrine posit two kinds of cause?"

The brahmin said: "It does."

The Blessed One asked: "What are they?"

The brahmin said: "There are two: the cause of arising and the cause of manifestation."

The Blessed One asked: "What is the cause of arising and what is the cause of manifestation?"

The brahmin said: "What is called the cause of arising is like clay coming forth from the potter's wheel. What is called the cause of manifestation is like a lamp illuminating things."

The Blessed One declared: "The intrinsic nature of these two causes is one and the same. If they are one, would not the cause of arising also become the cause of manifestation, and the cause of manifestation also become the cause of arising?"

The brahmin said: "No."

The Blessed One said: "But if the cause of arising does not become the cause of manifestation, and the cause of manifestation does not become the cause of arising, can it be said that each is the cause of the other?"

The brahmin said: "Each does not become the cause of the other, and yet it is the case that each serves as a cause in relation to the other."

"Brahmin, does the cause of manifestation — that which causes illumination — accord with that illumination itself?"

The brahmin said: "No."

The Blessed One declared: "In my doctrine as well, although nirvāṇa is attained by way of impermanence, it is not itself impermanent. Brahmin, because it is attained by way of the cause of manifestation, it is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure. Because it is attained by way of the cause of arising, it is impermanent, suffering, selfless, and not utterly pure. Therefore what the Tathāgata has taught also has two aspects, and although it is taught in two aspects, it is not in fact two."

Therefore the Tathāgata is said to teach without duality. You have said that you heard from the ancient sages of old that a buddha who comes into the world teaches without duality — that is very well said. All the buddhas who abide throughout the three times in all ten directions are without difference in what they teach. Therefore the Blessed One, the buddha, is said to teach without duality.

How is it that there is no difference? Whatever is taught as existent, that too is taught as existent; whatever is taught as non-existent, that too is taught as non-existent — this is called having one and the same meaning. Brahmin, the

Blessed One, the buddha, by teaching in two aspects, clarifies what is taught as one. How does teaching in two aspects clarify what is taught as one? As an example: from the two terms "eye" and "form" there arises the single term "consciousness" — and in the same way, this is to be understood in full, up through "mind" and "phenomena."

The brahmin said: "Gautama, the meaning of what you have said is well expressed. We, however, did not understand how teaching in two aspects clarifies teaching as one."

Thereupon the Blessed One expounded to them the Four Noble Truths: namely, the truth of suffering is two, and yet is also one. In the same way, up through the truth of the path, each is two, and yet each is also one.

The brahmin said: "Blessed One, I understand."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, how do you understand it?"

The brahmin said: "Blessed One, what is called the truth of suffering is two for all childish, ignoble persons, and one for the noble ones. In the same way, I understand this up through the truth of the path."

The Blessed One declared: "You have understood well."

The brahmin said: "Blessed One, having heard this, I have attained right view. Now I go for refuge to the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. Out of your great compassion, please grant us the going forth."

Thereupon the Blessed One addressed the venerable Ājñāta Kauṇḍinya: "You, explain it and make the request. Shave hair and beard and go forth from home into homelessness."

At that time the venerable Ājñāta Kauṇḍinya, acting in accordance with the Blessed One's command, shaved hair and beard, and at that very moment two things fell away from him: hair and beard, and mental afflictions. Right there and then he attained the fruit of arhatship.

At that time another wanderer named Sīta spoke these words: "Is the nirvāṇa that Gautama teaches permanent?" "It is so." The wanderer Sīta asked: "Gautama, is what is free from afflictions called nirvāṇa?" "It is so." The wanderer Sīta said: "Gautama, there are four kinds of non-existence in the world. What are the four? There is that which is called non-existent because it has not arisen — as for example a clay vessel does not exist before it has been made. There is also that which is called non-existent because it has ceased

and is gone — as for example a clay vessel that has broken and is no more. There is that which is called non-existent because one thing is absent in another — as for example a horse is not present in a cow, and a cow is not present in a horse. And there is that which is called non-existent because it is utterly non-existent — as for example the hair of a tortoise or the horn of a rabbit. Gautama, if nirvāṇa is called the passing beyond sorrow because afflictions are absent, then nirvāṇa is a non-existence. If it is a non-existence, why has it been taught as permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, nirvāṇa is not like that. It is not a non-existence in the sense of something that was not there before — like a clay vessel that does not yet exist. It is not a non-existence in the sense of something that was there and has broken apart — like a clay vessel that has shattered. It is not a non-existence in the sense of something utterly non-existent — like the hair of a tortoise or the horn of a rabbit. Rather, nirvāṇa accords with the sense of one thing being absent in another. Son of good family, you yourself have said that a horse is not present in a cow — yet it would not be right to say that the cow, too, is non-existent. And a cow is not present in a horse — yet it would not be right to say that the horse, too, is non-existent. Nirvāṇa is just the same: affliction is not present in nirvāṇa, and nirvāṇa is not present in affliction. Therefore, this is called 'the absence of one thing in another.'"

Vāsiṣṭha then asked: "Gautama, if nirvāṇa is called so in the sense that one thing is absent in another, then where one thing is absent in another there is no permanence, no bliss, no self, and no utter purity. Why then has Gautama taught that nirvāṇa is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure?"

The Blessed One declared: "As you have put it, the absence of one thing in another is itself a threefold non-existence. A cow and a horse — before they come to be, they did not exist; this is called prior non-existence. Once they have existed, they cease to be; this is called non-existence through destruction. The absence of one thing in another, however, is not as you describe it. Son of good family, the three kinds of non-existence do not apply to nirvāṇa — only this third sense. Therefore, nirvāṇa is permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure.

"Consider, by way of analogy, the three diseases of the world: bile, wind, and phlegm. For these three diseases there are three medicines: for bile disease, butter cures it; for wind disease, sesame oil benefits it; for phlegm disease,

honey benefits it. Thus the three medicines benefit the three diseases. Son of good family, sesame oil is not present within wind, and wind is not present within sesame oil; honey is not present within phlegm, and phlegm is not present within honey — yet healing occurs all the same.

"All sentient beings likewise have three diseases: attachment, aversion, and delusion. And for these three diseases there are three medicines: for the disease of attachment, one should cultivate the meditation on unattractiveness; for the disease of aversion, one should cultivate loving-kindness; for the disease of delusion, one should cultivate dependent origination. Son of good family, to remove attachment, one should cultivate what is free from attachment; to remove aversion, one should cultivate what is free from aversion; to remove delusion, one should cultivate what is free from delusion. The three medicines are not present within the three diseases, and the three diseases are not present within the three medicines.

"Son of good family, because the three medicines are not present within the three diseases, the diseases are impermanent, devoid of bliss, devoid of self, and devoid of utter purity. Because the three diseases are not present within the three medicines, the medicines are permanent, blissful, self, and utterly pure."

Vāsiṣṭha then asked: "May the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, teach me about permanence and impermanence — which is permanence, and which is impermanence?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, form is impermanent, and so too with everything up through consciousness — all are impermanent. But liberated form is permanent, and liberated consciousness is likewise permanent."

"Son of good family, any son or daughter of good family who meditates correctly on impermanence — from form through to consciousness — should know that they have thereby attained the quality of permanence."

Vāsiṣṭha said: "Blessed One, I have understood the qualities of permanence and impermanence."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, how have you understood the qualities of permanence and impermanence?"

Vāsiṣṭha said: "Blessed One, I have understood that my own form is impermanent, and everything up through consciousness is impermanent,

while liberation is permanent."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, you have repaid this body well."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Kauṇḍinya: "Vāsiṭha has attained arhatship. Give him the three Dharma robes and the alms bowl."

The venerable Kauṇḍinya did exactly as the Blessed One had instructed and gave him the robes and the alms bowl.

Then Vāsiṭha received the robes and the alms bowl, and said these words to Kauṇḍinya: "Through this wretched body I have obtained the fruit of virtue. Venerable one, without regard for the trouble it causes you, please go on my behalf before the Blessed One and say these words: 'A sinner such as I, having spoken of the Tathāgata's bones and having uttered words of disrespect toward you — I confess and openly acknowledge this fault. I do not wish to dwell long with this malignant body. I will pass into nirvāṇa.'"

Then the venerable Kauṇḍinya went to where the Buddha was, and upon arriving spoke these words to the Blessed One: "The monk Vāsiṭha, filled with deep shame and remorse, says: 'In my great foolishness I spoke of the Tathāgata's bones and uttered words of disrespect, and I have committed a fault. I confess my regret and repentance. I do not wish to keep company long with this body, which is like a venomous snake. I will pass into nirvāṇa.'"

The Blessed One said to the venerable Kauṇḍinya: "The monk Vāsiṭha, in former times, cultivated roots of virtue before immeasurable buddhas, and thus has come to abide here in accordance with the prophecy of the teaching. By so abiding in accordance with that prophecy, he has attained the true fruit. Therefore, you should pay homage to his body."

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow. The fifty-second section.

Then Kauṇḍinya, having heard these words from the Blessed One, went back to where Vāsiṭha's body was and paid homage.

At the time of Vāsiṭha's cremation, various miraculous powers (ṛddhi) were displayed. The non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), seeing what had come to pass, cried out in a loud voice: "Vāsiṭha has obtained the mantras and conjuring arts of the ascetic Gautama, and before long he will certainly surpass even the ascetic Gautama!"

At that time, within that assembled gathering, there was one called Sāni who spoke these words: "Gautama, does there exist something called a 'self'?" The Tathāgata said nothing. "Gautama, then does there exist something called a 'non-self'?" The Tathāgata said nothing. Even when this question was put a second and a third time, the Tathāgata said nothing.

Then Sāni spoke again: "Gautama, if a self exists pervading all sentient beings, encompassing all of them, whether it be one or made — Gautama, why do you sit in silence?" The Blessed One said to Sāni: "Is what you call a 'self' something that pervades all?" Sāni said: "Gautama, it is not only I who say so. All the wise and learned say the same."

The Blessed One declared:

"Son of good family, if what is called a 'self' pervades everything, then births in the five streams of existence would all be experienced as ripening simultaneously. If that were so — if one born in the five streams were to experience simultaneous karmic ripening — then why would wanderers like yourself refrain from sinful and non-virtuous actions and practise virtuous Dharma in order to turn away from rebirth in the hells and aspire to experience birth in the body of a god in the higher realms?"

Sāni spoke: "Gautama, in our doctrine what we call the 'self' is of two kinds: the self of the fashioned body, and the self of the permanent body. It is on account of the self of the fashioned body that one abandons sinful and non-virtuous phenomena, so as not to go to the hells, and diligently applies oneself to virtuous Dharma and seeks rebirth as a god in the higher realms."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, you say that what is called a 'self' pervades everything. If this 'self' exists in the fashioned body, then it is impermanent. But if it does not exist in the fashioned body, is it fitting to say it pervades everything?"

Sāni spoke: "Gautama, the 'self' that I posit exists within the fashioned as well, and yet it is also called permanent. Gautama, consider the analogy: if a house catches fire and burns, the householder escapes. One does not say that because the house burns the householder burns. Our doctrine is similar: although this fashioned body is impermanent, at the time of the body's impermanence what is called the 'self' departs outward. Therefore what we call 'self' is both all-pervading and permanent."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, it is not fitting to say, as you maintain, that the 'self' is both all-pervading and permanent. Why? Because what pervades is of two kinds: permanent and impermanent. Furthermore, there are two further kinds: form and formless. Therefore, if, as you say, it exists in everything, it would be both permanent and impermanent, and both form and formless. Nor is it fitting to say, as you propose in your analogy, that although the house burns the householder has escaped and is therefore impermanent. Why? Because the house is not the householder and the householder is not the house. What burns is one thing; what escapes is another. Therefore what is called the 'self' is not that — for the self is form, and form is the self; the self is the formless, and the formless is the self. But if the self were formless, why do you say that when form is impermanent the self departs?

"Son of good family, consider this: if you think that what is called 'self' for all sentient beings is one and the same, that contradicts both worldly and supramundane Dharma. Why? In worldly convention there are such things as father, mother, son, and daughter. If the 'self' were one, then the father would also be the son, the son would also be the father, the mother would also be the daughter, and the daughter would also be the mother; the enemy would also be the friend, and the friend would also be the enemy; the far shore would also be the near shore, and the near shore would also be the far shore. Therefore to say that the 'self' of all sentient beings is one and the same contradicts both worldly and supramundane Dharma."

Sāni spoke: "I do not say that the 'self' of all sentient beings is one and the same. Rather, each and every individual person has their own individual self."

The Blessed One declared: "If you say that each individual person has their own individual self, then the 'self' becomes manifold — and that too is not fitting. Why? As you said before, the 'self' pervades everything. If it truly pervades everything, then the ripened fruits of all sentient beings would likewise have to be the same."

When Devadatta sees, Buddhadatta also sees; when Devadatta acts, Buddhadatta also acts; when Devadatta hears, Buddhadatta also hears — and all phenomena would become like that. Therefore, when Devadatta sees, it would not be the case that Buddhadatta does not see. For this reason, to say that what is called 'self' pervades everything is not fitting. But if it does not pervade everything, then it would become impermanent.

Sāni spoke: "Gautama, what I call 'self' does indeed pervade all sentient beings. Phenomena and non-phenomena, however, do not pervade everything. Therefore, what Buddhadatta has done is one thing, and what Devadatta has done is another."

"Therefore, Gautama, are you saying that when Buddhadatta sees, Devadatta also sees — or that when Buddhadatta hears, Devadatta also hears? That is not fitting."

The Blessed One declared: "Good man, are phenomena and non-phenomena produced by karma?"

Sāni spoke: "Gautama, they are indeed produced by karma."

The Blessed One declared: "Good man, if phenomena and non-phenomena are produced by karma, and if the very view that holds them to be congruent with one another is itself a phenomenon, then would it be fitting to call them distinct? Why? Because within the karma performed by Buddhadatta, there would also have to be the self of Devadatta; and likewise, within the karma performed by Devadatta, there would also have to be the self of Buddhadatta. Therefore, when Buddhadatta has acted, Devadatta would also have acted — and phenomena and non-phenomena would become similar in this way. Good man, if the phenomena and non-phenomena of all sentient beings are like that, then it would not be fitting for the karmic fruits to ripen differently either. Good man, from a seed comes a fruit, and that seed never thinks to itself: 'I shall produce only the fruit of a brahmin — I shall not produce the fruit of a kṣatriya, or of a vaiśya, or of a śūdra.' It makes no such distinction. Why? Because what ripens from a seed into a fruit does not cut across the four castes. Phenomena and non-phenomena are just the same: what is called 'self' does not make the distinction of thinking 'I shall become the fruit of Buddhadatta's actions and not the fruit of Devadatta's actions,' or 'I shall become the fruit of Devadatta and not the fruit of Buddhadatta.' It makes no such distinction. Why? Because karma is equal."

Sāni spoke: "Gautama, consider this analogy: if a hundred or a thousand butter-lamps are lit inside a single house, although the essences of the flames are distinct, there is no difference in the light they give. The distinctness of the flames' essences is the analogy for phenomena and non-phenomena. The absence of any difference in the illumination they produce is the analogy for what is called the 'self' of all sentient beings."

The Blessed One declared: "Good man, to say, as you do, that the light of butter-lamps is the analogy for what is called 'self' — that is not fitting. Why? The house is one thing and the butter-lamps are another, and the light of the butter-lamps would have to be present both in the essence of the flames themselves and also in the house. If what is called 'self' were like that, as you say, then 'self' would have to be present in both phenomena and non-phenomena alike; and likewise, within what is called 'self,' phenomena and non-phenomena would also have to be present."

But if what is called 'self' is absent in both phenomena and non-phenomena, then to say that it pervades everything would also be unfitting. And if it is present in both, can both the essence of the butter-lamp and its light serve together as the analogy?

Good man, if in your mind you truly regard the essence of the butter-lamp and its light as distinct and separate from one another, then why is it that when the essence of the butter-lamp is good the light too is bright, and when the essence of the butter-lamp is exhausted the light ceases to be? Therefore it is not fitting to take the essence of the butter-lamp as the analogy for phenomena and non-phenomena, and to take the light as an analogy for what is called 'self,' treating them as though there were no distinction between them. Why? Because phenomena, non-phenomena, and what is called 'self' would thereby become one and the same thing.

Sānu then said: "Gautama, the analogy you have drawn from the butter-lamp is not auspicious. Why? If drawing an analogy from the butter-lamp were auspicious, then what I stated before would stand. If it is not auspicious, why did you speak of it at all?"

The Blessed One declared: "Good man, I did not say that the analogy I gave was either auspicious or inauspicious. I gave it in relation to what is in your own mind — to illustrate whether the light exists beyond the essence of the butter-lamp, or whether the essence itself is the light. Because your mind was not at ease, you took the essence of the butter-lamp as the analogy for phenomena and non-phenomena, and the light as the analogy for what is called 'self.' And by doing so you end up asserting: that light arises from the essence; that light also exists beyond the essence; that self exists within phenomena; that phenomena exist within self; that what is not a phenomenon is self; and that self too is not a phenomenon. In affirming one extreme you cannot consistently reject the other, and this is unfitting. Therefore that

analogy is not auspicious for you. And since I have shown you its implications in return, good man, that analogy is simply not a valid analogy. Because it is not valid, it is auspicious for me and inauspicious for you."

"Good man, according to what you say, since it is inauspicious for me, you should not think it is therefore also inauspicious for you. Why? Among the beings of the world, it happens that one person's own weapon harms oneself, and what one has done is enjoyed by an adversary. You who put forward this analogy are in just such a position — it is auspicious for me and not auspicious for you."

Sānu then said: "Gautama, you said earlier that I was not at ease; but now what you yourself say is also not at ease. Why? Gautama has claimed the auspicious for himself and cast the inauspicious upon me — and that too is not truly even-handed."

The Blessed One declared: "Good man, my very unevenness defeats your unevenness, so that you become even while I, through my unevenness, am auspicious. The reason my unevenness defeats your unevenness and renders you even is precisely that it is evened in accord with the noble ones (āryas)."

Sānu then said: "Gautama, if I am always even, why do you say you have defeated my unevenness? If what is called 'self' is present equally in all sentient beings, why do you say I was not at ease?"

"Good man, you yourself say that sentient beings fall into hell, fall into the birth-state of hungry ghosts, fall into the birth-state of animals, and become humans and gods. If what is called 'self' is something that pervades all five streams of existence, why do you say that the five streams are experienced? You also say that a child is born from the meeting of father and mother. If the child already existed before,

why do you say that a child comes to be from their meeting and joining? Therefore, a single person would have bodies in all five streams of existence. But if a body already existed before in all five streams, why would there be any need to act for the sake of a body? Therefore, this is not equanimity.

Good man, even the idea you hold in your mind that what is called 'self' is an agent — that too is untenable. Why is that? If what is called 'self' were an agent, why would suffering come about through its own doing, and why would ordinary people truly experience suffering? Therefore, you must understand that what is called 'self' is not an agent.

If you say that suffering was made by the self and yet was not born from a cause, then all phenomena would be the same — not born from a cause. In that case, why do you say the self is an agent? Good man, the suffering and happiness of sentient beings arise, in truth, from causes and conditions. Suffering and happiness, being such, give rise to grief and joy: at the time of grief there is no joy, and at the time of joy there is no grief. If sometimes there is joy and sometimes there is grief, why would a wise person endowed with wisdom say this is permanent?

Good man, if what you call 'self' is permanent, then why does it appear different and distinct across the ten phases of time? It is unreasonable for something with the characteristic of permanence to exist from the time of infancy all the way through to old age. Space has the characteristic of permanence — since there is not even one phase of time that applies to it, what need is there to speak of ten? Good man, if what is called 'self' is not in the time of infancy and is not in the time of old age — spanning all of that — why do you say it is inconsistent and distinct across the ten phases of time?

Good man, if what is called 'self' were an agent, then what is called 'self' would have times of flourishing and times of decline, and sentient beings too would have times of flourishing and times of decline. If what is called 'self' is like that, why would you call it permanent?

Good man, if what is called 'self' is an agent, why is it that among equally human beings there are those with sharp faculties and those with dull faculties?

Good man, if what is called 'self' is an agent, then what is called 'self' would also perform bodily actions and verbal actions. But if verbal actions too were performed by what is called 'self,' why does the voice say 'there is no self,' and why does doubt arise as to whether it exists or not?

Good man, the idea you hold in your mind that there is a seer that exists beyond the eye — that too is untenable. Why? If there were some other seer existing beyond the eye, this eye here would become unnecessary; and it would be the same right up through the sense faculties of the body. And the idea that what is called 'self' sees, though by means of the eye as condition — that too is untenable. Why? Take the example of a man setting fire to a great city starting from a single flower. When asked how it burns, one would say "it burns by means of fire as the condition." Your saying that what is called 'self' sees is similar to that.

Seniya asked: Gautama, take the example of a person holding a sickle and cutting grass — in the same way, the self sees, hears, and touches by means of the five sense faculties as condition.

Good man, the sickle and the person are distinct — that is why there is someone who holds the sickle and acts. But if there is no other self beyond the sense faculties, why do you say that what is called 'self' acts by means of the sense faculties as condition?

Good man, are you saying in your mind that one holds a sickle and thereby cuts grass, and that what is called 'self' is like that?

Does what is called 'self' have hands, or does it have no hands? If it has hands, why does the self not grasp the sickle? If it has no hands, why do you say that what is called 'self' is the agent?

Good man, the blade of grass is the sickle — it is not the self, and it is not a person. If it is neither self nor person, then the sickle would not be needed at all.

Good man, a person has two kinds of action: grasping the grass and grasping the sickle. The one who grasps the sickle performs only the action of cutting. The seeing of phenomena by a sentient being is similar to that: even the seeing of form by the eye arises from an assembly and gathering of conditions. If seeing arises from the coming together of causes and conditions, why would one who is wise and possessed of wisdom say that a self exists?

Good man, is it your thinking that the body acts and thereby what is called 'self' experiences? That too is untenable. Why so? In the world, it is not seen that when Devadatta performs an action, Buddhадatta experiences its karmic maturation. If, on the other hand, you say that the body does not act and that what is called 'self' does not experience through the power of conditions — then why do you and others seek liberation from causes and conditions? If your body existed prior to all this and did not arise from causes and conditions, then even after liberation, without needing causes and conditions, the body would be born again. Whatever holds true of the body holds equally true of all the afflictions.

Seniya said: Gautama, what is called 'self' is of two kinds: one with consciousness and one without consciousness. The self without consciousness brings about the acquisition of a body. The self with consciousness brings about the relinquishing of a body. For example, when an unfired clay vessel is

burned, its old color is destroyed and it cannot arise again. In the same way, the afflictions of one who is wise and possessed of wisdom, once they have been made nonexistent, can never arise again at any time.

The Blessed One declared: Good man, this thing called consciousness — is it known by gnosis, or is it known by what is called 'self'? If it is known by gnosis, why do you say 'I, the self, know'? If it is known by the self, why would one need to seek gnosis through skillful means? If you say in your mind that what is called 'self' knows by means of gnosis, that too is like an inappropriate simile about a flower.

Good man, take the example of a thorny tree: it pricks by its own nature — it is not fitting to say it takes hold of the tree's thorn and then pricks. Gnosis is similar: if gnosis knows by itself, why do you say the self takes hold of gnosis and thereby knows?

Good man, if you say that what is called 'self' is liberated from your own system's phenomena — is it attained by the self without consciousness, or attained by the self with consciousness? If it is attained by the self without consciousness, you should understand that it still has afflictions. If it is attained by the self with consciousness, you should understand that it still possesses the five sense faculties of consciousness. Why? Because there is no consciousness apart from the five sense faculties. If it comes together with the sense faculties, why would you call it liberation? And if you say that what is called 'self' is naturally pure and separate from the five sense faculties — then why do you say that the five paths and continuations pervade it, and why do you say one must be diligent in virtuous phenomena in order to attain liberation?

Good man, it is like a person shooting thorns into the sky. If what is called 'self' is pure, why do you say all the afflictions must be cut away? Is it your thinking that one is liberated from what is not a cause and not a condition? Then why are all the animals not liberated?

Seniya said: Gautama, if what is called 'self' does not exist, then who is it that remembers?

The Blessed One declared: If what is called 'self' exists, why would there be forgetting? Good man, if what is called 'self' is indeed what remembers, then why does one remember what is sinful yet not remember what one has not remembered, and why does one not remember what one does remember?

Seniya said: Gautama, if what is called 'self' does not exist, who is it that sees? Who is it that hears?

The Blessed One declared: Good man, there are the six inner faculties and the six outer objects. From the meeting of inner and outer, the six consciousnesses arise. The six consciousnesses are designated by name on the basis of dependent origination. Good man, take the example of fire, which is one and the same, yet receives distinct names based on its fuel: fire of wood is called wood-fire; based on grass, grass-fire; based on chaff, chaff-fire; based on dung, dung-fire. The mental consciousness of sentient beings is likewise: based on the eye, form, light, and desire, it is called eye-consciousness. Good man, in just this way, eye-consciousness does not exist within the eye, nor does it exist as far as desire — rather, from the meeting of the four conditions consciousness arises. Know that the same holds true as far as mental consciousness. Because they arise from gathering together through dependent origination, the wise and discerning do not speak of 'self' with respect to visual phenomena, and do not speak of 'self' even as far as tangible objects. Good man, therefore I have declared that all phenomena from eye-consciousness through mental consciousness are like a magical illusion. How are they like a magical illusion? What did not exist before comes to exist now, and having existed, it passes into non-existence.

Good man, take the following example: when butter, flour, honey, molasses, long pepper, rock salt, winter grain, Nepali citrus, coriander seeds, and such things are gathered together, the result is called a broth. Apart from those gathered ingredients, there is no broth to be found elsewhere. In the same way, what is called a sentient being, a self, a person, or an individual refers to the six inner and outer sense bases. Apart from those six inner and outer sense bases, there is no sentient being, no self, no person, and no individual to be found elsewhere.

Seniya said: Gautama, if there is no such thing as 'self,' why do people say, "I see," "I hear," "I suffer," "I am happy," "I rejoice," "I grieve"?

The Blessed One declared: Good man, if what is called 'self' is that which sees and hears, then why do you say, "I did not see," "I did not hear," when you have done something wrong in the world? Good man, take the example of four battalions assembled together — this is called an army. Yet those four battalions cannot rightly be called one single thing; nonetheless, one says "my army is brave" and "my army has defeated the enemy." The activity produced

by the gathering of the inner and outer sense bases is likewise: though they are not one, one says, "I did it," "I experienced it," "I saw it," "I heard it," "I suffer," and "I am happy."

Seniya said: Gautama, according to what you say, when inner and outer are assembled, who is it that speaks, saying "I did it" and "I experienced it"?

The Blessed One declared: Through the condition of craving and ignorance, karma is born. From karma, craving is born. From craving, what arises from boundless mind is born. Mind generates conceptual thought. Conceptual thought generates wind. Wind, contacting the mind, and arising from the palate, tongue, lips, and the inverted perception of sentient beings, produces sound — and thus one says, "I did it," "I experienced it," "I saw it," and "I heard it."

"Son of good family, consider, for example, a bell hung at the top of a victory banner: by the power of the wind, sound arises. When the wind is great, the sound is great; when the wind is small, the sound is small — and yet there is no agent doing it. Son of good family, consider again: when heated iron is plunged into water, many different kinds of sound arise — yet in truth there is no agent doing so. Son of good family, ordinary worldlings conceptualize things of this kind and, because they do not distinguish them clearly, they say, 'I,' 'mine,' 'I did it,' and 'I experienced it.'"

Sānu then asked: "Gautama, if there is a self and what belongs to a self, why did you say that permanence, bliss, self, and purity are absent?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I did not say that the six inner and outer sense bases and the six consciousnesses are permanence, bliss, self, and purity. What I said is this: it is the cessation of the six inner and outer sense bases and the six consciousnesses that is called permanence. Because it is permanent, it is called self. Because it is permanent and self, it is called bliss. Because it is permanent, self, and blissful, it is called purity. Son of good family, ordinary beings do not wish for suffering; having thoroughly severed and abandoned the causes of suffering, they come under the sway of relinquishment — and that is called self. Therefore I say there is permanence, bliss, self, and purity."

Sānu then asked: "Blessed One, out of great compassion, please teach me. What must I do to attain permanence, bliss, self, and purity?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, everything that dwells in the world has, from beginningless time, been accompanied by great pride. In order to generate great pride, beings become causes of pride, and through pride they act. Thus the fruit of pride fully ripens, and because all mental afflictions have not been completely abandoned, permanence, bliss, self, and purity are not attained. Therefore, if ordinary beings wish to completely abandon all mental afflictions, they must completely abandon pride."

Sānu said: "Blessed One, it is so — it is exactly so. As the noble teaching says: since I had pride, by the power of pride I did not say 'Tathāgata' but said 'Gautama,' and I spoke of 'I' and 'you.' Now I have completely abandoned great pride, and so, seeking the Dharma with a sincere mind, how shall I attain permanence, bliss, self, and purity?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, listen carefully and attend well to mind; I shall explain it to you in full. Son of good family, if it is neither self, nor other, nor a sentient being, then those very phenomena will be completely relinquished."

Sānu said: "Blessed One, I have understood, and I have also attained the genuine eye of Dharma."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, by knowing and understanding what, do you say you have attained the genuine eye of Dharma?"

He replied: "Blessed One, understanding that what is called form is neither other, nor self, nor a sentient being — and so on through consciousness — by understanding thus, I have attained the genuine eye of Dharma. Blessed One, if I am permitted to go forth and apply myself diligently to the path, please grant your assent."

The Blessed One said, "Welcome," and with that word he became a fully ordained monk, and right there he came to possess fully pure brahmic conduct and attained the fruit of arhatship.

At that time, among those non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), there was one of the wandering ascetic class, of the Kāśyapa lineage, who spoke thus:

"Gautama, is the life-force identical with the body, or are the body and the life-force two separate things?" The Tathāgata remained seated in silence, saying nothing. The wanderer asked a second and then a third time, yet still the Tathāgata said nothing.

Then the wanderer Kunturu asked again: "Gautama, when a person has died and not yet taken up a new body, is it not said that the body is one thing and the life-force another? If they are indeed separate, why then does Gautama say nothing?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, I say that both body and life-force arise from dependent origination and not from what is not dependently originated. Just as it is with body and life-force, so too should all phenomena be understood in the same way."

Kunturu asked again: "Gautama, I see that certain phenomena in the world are not dependently originated."

The Blessed One declared: "What phenomena in the world do you see as not dependently originated?"

Kunturu replied: "When a great conflagration breaks out and the flames, fanned by wind, burn other places as well — that, I would say, is not dependently originated."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, even that fire arises from dependent origination, not from what is not dependently originated."

Kunturu asked: "Gautama, when a flame is cut off and extinguished, it comes neither from wood nor from fuel-fire — why then do you say it is dependently originated?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, although there is no wood and no fuel-fire, the flame is nonetheless cut off by the power of wind. Through wind as cause and condition, the flame does not simply cease to exist without cause."

Kunturu asked: "Gautama, when a person has died and not yet taken up a new body, what are the causes and conditions that make the taking up of life possible?"

The Blessed One declared: "Kunturu, ignorance and craving are the cause and condition for that. By the force of these two — ignorance and craving — as cause and condition, the continuation of life comes about. Son of good family, because of causes and conditions, the body itself is the life-force, and the life-force itself is the body. And again, because of causes and conditions, the body is one thing and the life-force is another. A wise and discerning person will not say simply and one-sidedly that the body and the life-force are categorically separate."

Kunturu said: "Blessed One, please explain and reveal this to me fully and make me comprehend cause and effect."

The Blessed One declared: "Kunturu, the cause is the five aggregates (skandhas), and the result is likewise the five aggregates. Son of good family, if sentient beings did not kindle fire, there would be no smoke."

Kunturu said: "Blessed One, I have sought and I have understood."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what exactly is it that you know and understand?"

He replied: "Blessed One, what is called 'kindling fire' is affliction — it blazes intensely in the births of hell-beings, hungry ghosts, animals, gods, and humans. What is called 'smoke' is the ripening of the fruit of affliction. Because it is impermanent, impure, and thoroughly foul, it is called smoke. For any sentient being who has not engaged in affliction, the ripened fruit of affliction will not arise for that being. Therefore the Tathāgata has said: 'If no fire is kindled, there is no smoke.'"

"Blessed One, since I now hold right view, I ask out of compassion: please grant me permission to go forth."

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Kauṇḍinya, who knows all: "Grant this wanderer the going forth and confer upon him full ordination."

Then Kauṇḍinya, just as the Buddha had commanded, sought the faith of the Saṅgha of monks and went forth. When five days had passed after his full ordination, he attained the fruit of arhatship.

Among the retinue of the tīrthikas there was another wanderer, named Puṇa, who addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Gautama, because you perceive a permanent phenomenon in the world, do you declare it 'permanent'? Is that declaration true or false? Is it permanent or impermanent? Is it both permanent and impermanent? Is it neither permanent nor impermanent? Does it have a boundary or is it without boundary? Does it both have a boundary and lack a boundary? Does it have no boundary and also not lack a boundary? Are body and life-force the same? Or are body and life-force different? When the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa, is it like going? Or is it not like going? Is it both like going and not like going? Is it neither like going nor not like going?"

The Blessed One replied: "Puṇa, I have not declared that in the world there is anything permanent, or true, or false, or impermanent, or permanent, or neither permanent nor impermanent, or that it has a boundary, or is without boundary, or both has a boundary and lacks a boundary, or neither has a boundary nor lacks a boundary, or that body and life-force are the same, or that body and life-force are different, or that when the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa it is like going, or not like going, or both like going and not like going, or neither like going nor not like going."

Puṇa then asked: "Gautama, what fault do you see that you do not make such declarations?"

The Blessed One replied: "Whoever says, 'The world is permanent — this is true, all else is false,' that is a view. Through a view, looking upon the location of views as formations, one looks with a view, looks with attachment, looks with bondage, looks with suffering, looks with grasping, looks with destruction, looks with torment — or rather, one looks in a way that is thoroughly entangled. Puṇa, ordinary childish persons, being wholly enmeshed in views, are not freed from birth, old age, illness, and death; they revolve through the six classes of beings and experience immeasurable suffering. Up to and including 'neither like going nor not like going' — all of this is to be understood in the same way. Puṇa, because I see such faults in those views, I am not attached to them and I do not teach them to others."

Puṇa then asked: "Gautama, since you see such faults in those views, you are not attached and do not teach them — then, Gautama, to what are you now attached, and what do you teach?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, clinging to views is a phenomenon of saṃsāra. The Tathāgata, being free from the phenomena of saṃsāra, is called 'unattached.' Son of good family, the Tathāgata is called 'one who sees and one who teaches' — not 'one who is attached.' "

Puṇa asked: "Gautama, how does he see and how does he teach?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, I clearly see suffering, the origin of suffering, cessation, and the path. Therefore I teach by fully opening up the Four Noble Truths. Because I see in this way, I have completely abandoned all views, all craving, all conflict, and all pride. Therefore I myself, endowed with thoroughly pure holy conduct, through the supreme and unsurpassed peace, have attained a permanent body. This permanent body belongs to no direction — neither east, nor west, nor south, nor north."

Puṇa then asked:

"By what cause and by what condition does this permanent body belong to no direction — neither east, nor west, nor south, nor north?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, whatever questions I put to you, answer them as they come to mind. Son of good family, what do you think? If a great fire were burning in front of you, would you know that it was ablaze?" "Just so, Gautama." "And when it goes out, would you know that it had gone out?" "Just so, Gautama." "Puṇa, if someone were to ask you: 'From where did this mass of fire come before it was burning, and where did it go when it went out?' — what would you say to that?"

Puṇa replied: "Gautama, if someone were to ask that, I would say this: fire burns in dependence upon many conditions. When the old conditions are exhausted and no new conditions are added, I would say that the fire has gone out. And if someone were further to ask, 'When the fire has gone out, in which direction did it go?' — what would be said to that?"

He replied: "Gautama, to that I would say: when the conditions are exhausted and the fire goes out, it has not gone in any direction."

"Son of good family, the Tathāgata is just like that. If there were impermanent form — and all the way up through impermanent consciousness — then it would blaze through the condition of craving. What is called 'blazing' is the experience of the twenty-five modes of existence. And so, while blazing, one may rightly say of this fire that it is in the eastern direction, or the western, or the southern, or the northern. But when present craving ceases and the ripened fruit of the twenty-five modes of existence no longer blazes, then of that one cannot speak of an eastern direction, or a southern, or a western, or a northern.

Son of good family, the Tathāgata has no impermanent form, and no impermanent consciousness — nothing up through impermanent consciousness. Therefore, the body is permanent. And if the body is permanent, it cannot be spoken of as eastern, or southern, or western, or northern."

Puṇa said: "If I might offer an analogy — would the Tathāgata be willing to hear it?"

The Blessed One replied: "Excellent! Excellent! Speak as you intend."

"Blessed One, it is like this. Outside a great city, within a grove of śāla trees, there stands a single tree that was the first to grow there, and it has reached a hundred years of age. The owner of the grove waters and tends it regularly. When the bark of that tree decays, the bark, the leaves, and all the branches fall to the ground, and only the heartwood within remains. The Tathāgata is like that tree: when everything that has decayed has been exhausted, the true Dharma alone remains.

Blessed One, I request that you grant me the going forth."

The Blessed One spoke the words "Welcome," and immediately he became a fully ordained monk, and, with his defilements exhausted, he attained the fruit of arhatship.

Then another, named Paṇḍita the Wanderer, spoke these words: "Gautama, what is the Dharma that ordinary beings fail to understand, which causes them to form views about the world as permanent, as impermanent, as both permanent and impermanent, as neither permanent nor impermanent — and all the way through to 'migrating,' 'not migrating,' and every such view?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, it is through not knowing form, and not knowing all the way up through consciousness, that they form views such as: the world is permanent — all the way through to 'it is like what migrates' and 'it is like what does not migrate.'"

The Wanderer asked: "Gautama, what is the Dharma that, when sentient beings understand it, they cease to form views such as: the world is permanent — all the way through to 'it is like what migrates' and 'it is like what does not migrate'?"

The Blessed One replied:

"Son of good family, when one knows form, and knows all the way up through consciousness, one will no longer form views such as: the world is permanent — all the way through to 'it is like what migrates' and 'it is like what does not migrate.'"

The Wanderer said: "Blessed One, please explain permanence and impermanence to me in full detail."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, whoever has abandoned what is old and does not create new karma — that person will understand permanence and impermanence."

The Wanderer said: "Blessed One, I have understood."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, what have you seen, and how have you understood?"

He replied: "Blessed One, the old is ignorance and craving. The new is clinging and becoming. Whoever thoroughly abandons ignorance and craving, and does not engage in clinging and becoming — that person correctly understands permanence and impermanence. As for myself, the eye of Dharma has arisen in me, purified with respect to the true Dharma, and I go for refuge to the Three Jewels. May the Tathāgata grant me the going forth."

The Blessed One then addressed the venerable Kauṇḍinya: "Give this wanderer the going forth and grant him full ordination."

Thereupon Kauṇḍinya, acting in accordance with the Blessed One's word, made the request and petition to the Saṅgha, and the going forth was given. Then, fifteen days later, all his defilements were exhausted and he attained the fruit of arhatship.

Now another wanderer, named Vatsā, spoke as follows: "Gautama, if I make a request, will it be granted?" The Tathāgata said nothing. In the same way this continued up to a second and a third time.

Vatsā spoke again: "Gautama, I am a friend of yours. Since our aims are not two but one, why do you remain silent and say nothing to what I ask?"

Then the Blessed One reflected in his mind: "This wanderer is gentle by nature, and because he is so very straightforward, his asking me as a friend is not for the purpose of finding fault. Whatever he asks, I should answer accordingly." Having thought this, he declared: "Come, Vatsā — excellent, excellent! Ask whatever you wish, and whatever it may be, I will give the answer."

Vatsā asked: "Gautama, is there virtue (kuśala) in the world?"

"There is."

"Gautama, is there non-virtue in the world?"

"There is."

The wanderer Vatsā then said: "Gautama, please teach and explain to us so that I may understand the Dharma of virtue and non-virtue."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, though I know those matters in full and could teach them at great length, I shall now explain just a portion to you. Son of good family, desire is non-virtue; desire directed toward liberation is virtue. Know that aversion and delusion are likewise to be understood in the same way. Taking life is non-virtue; the complete abandonment of taking life is virtue — and so on, expanded all the way through to wrong views. Son of good family, I have taught and explained to you both the threefold classification of virtuous and non-virtuous Dhammas, and also the tenfold classification of virtuous and non-virtuous Dhammas. If one who has become my attendant distinguishes and diligently practices these — from the threefold classification of virtuous and non-virtuous Dhammas all the way through to the tenfold — that person will become free of attachment, aversion, and delusion; all defilements will be exhausted; and all existence will be utterly cut off."

The Wanderer said: "Gautama, are there any monks at all in the Blessed One's teaching who are without attachment, aversion, and delusion —"

— who have exhausted all defilements and utterly cut off all existence?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the Buddha's teaching there are not merely one, two, three, five, or even a hundred monks who are without attachment, aversion, and delusion, who have exhausted all defilements and cut off all existence — monks of that kind are beyond counting."

The Wanderer asked: "Gautama, setting aside monks — are there even a few nuns in the Buddha's teaching who are without attachment, aversion, and delusion, who have exhausted all defilements and cut off all existence?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the Buddha's teaching there are not merely one, two, three, five, or even a hundred nuns who are without attachment, aversion, and delusion, who have exhausted all defilements and cut off all existence — nuns of that kind are beyond counting."

The Wanderer asked: "Gautama, setting aside monks and nuns — are there even a few laymen in the Buddha's teaching who are diligent in guarding moral discipline, who lead a life of pure celibacy, who have gone beyond doubt and cut the net of doubt?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the Buddha's teaching there are not merely one, two, three, five, or even a hundred laymen of that kind — laymen who are diligent in guarding moral discipline, who lead a life of pure

celibacy, who have severed the last five fetters that bind through affliction, who have attained the state of non-return, who have gone beyond doubt and cut the net of doubt — laymen of that kind are beyond counting."

The Wanderer asked again: "Gautama, setting aside monks, nuns, and laymen — are there even a few laywomen in the Buddha's teaching who are diligent in guarding moral discipline, who lead a life of pure celibacy, who have gone beyond doubt and cut the net of doubt?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the Buddha's teaching there are not merely one, two, three, five, or even a hundred laywomen of that kind — laywomen who are diligent in guarding moral discipline, who lead a life of pure celibacy, who have severed the last five fetters that bind through affliction, who have attained the state of non-return, who have gone beyond doubt and cut the net of doubt — laywomen of that kind are beyond counting."

The Wanderer asked: "Setting aside those monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen in the Buddha's teaching who are diligent in guarding moral discipline, who lead a life of pure celibacy, and who have cut the net of doubt — are there even a few laymen in the Buddha's teaching who do not indulge in the five objects of desire and who have cut the net of doubt?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in the Buddha's teaching there are not merely one, two, three, five, or even a hundred laymen of that kind — laymen who have severed the three fetters that bind through affliction, who have attained stream-entry, who have thinned out attachment, aversion, and delusion, and who have attained the state of once-return — laymen of that kind are also beyond counting. And just as it is with laymen, so too should one understand it to be the case in full for laywomen."

The Wanderer said: "Blessed One, I wish to offer an analogy."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent — speak just as you please."

"Blessed One, just as the nāga kings Nanda and Upananda cause a great rain to fall and spread everywhere, so too is the rain of Dharma from the Tathāgata — it falls equally upon laymen and laywomen alike."

The Wanderer continued:

"Blessed One, if members of non-Buddhist sects (tīrthikas) wish to go forth into the renunciant life, how long must the Tathāgata examine them?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, they must be examined for a period of four months; it is not fixed as one definite ruling."

"Blessed One, if it is not fixed, then out of your great compassion, may you please allow me to go forth."

The Blessed One then addressed the Venerable Kauṇḍinya: "Give this wandering colt his going forth and confer upon him full ordination."

Thereupon Kauṇḍinya, acting in accordance with the Buddha's word, made the formal motion and put the matter to the assembly of monks, and gave him the going forth. Fifteen days later, he attained the fruit of stream-entry.

Having attained that fruit, he then thought: "Whatever is to be attained through the wisdom that is gained by training — that I have attained. May I be granted an audience with the Buddha, to inform him of this." And so he went to where the Blessed One was, bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, paid his respects, sat to one side, and addressed the Blessed One thus:

"Blessed One, I have attained whatever wisdom is to be attained through training. I beseech you now to teach me how to attain wisdom that goes beyond training."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, there are two things: devote yourself earnestly to calm abiding and insight. Son of good family, any monk who desires to attain the fruit of stream-entry should apply himself earnestly to these two things. Whoever desires to attain the fruit of once-return, the fruit of non-return, or the fruit of arhatship should likewise apply himself earnestly to these two things. Son of good family, any monk who desires to attain the four meditative concentrations (dhyānas), the four immeasurables, the six kinds of higher knowledge, the eight types of great beings, the eight stations of excellence, the wisdom free from dispute, the wisdom of universal scope, the wisdom of final perfection, the four kinds of analytical knowledge, vajra-like meditative absorption, the wisdom of exhaustion, and the wisdom of non-arising — should apply himself earnestly to those same two things. Son of good family, whoever desires to attain the ten grounds (bhūmis), the acceptance of dharmas as unborn, the acceptance of dharmas as without defining marks, the acceptance of dharmas as inconceivable, the conduct of a noble one, the conduct of holy life, the conduct of a god, the conduct of a bodhisattva, space-like meditative absorption, the meditative absorption of the wisdom seal, the meditative absorptions of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, the earth-like meditative absorption, the absorption of

non-return, the absorption of heroic advance, the vajra-like meditative absorption, unsurpassed perfect and complete awakening, and the conduct of a buddha — should apply himself earnestly to those same two things."

When the colt heard these words, he prostrated to the Blessed One, went out, and in the grove of śāla trees applied himself earnestly to those two things, and before long he attained the fruit of arhatship.

At that time, a great number of monks were on their way to where the Buddha was when they saw the colt and said: "Venerable one, where are you going?"

The monks said: "We are going into the presence of the Buddha."

The colt then said: "Venerables, when you go into the presence of the Buddha, please convey my words on my behalf: having applied myself earnestly to the two things, I have attained wisdom beyond training, and in gratitude for the Blessed One's kindness, I shall now pass into nirvāṇa."

At that time, those monks went to where the Buddha was and addressed the Blessed One, saying: "On behalf of the monk-colt: 'Having attained wisdom beyond training, and in gratitude for the Blessed One's kindness, I shall now pass into nirvāṇa.'"

The Blessed One declared: "The monk-colt has attained the fruit of arhatship. Go and pay homage to his body." At that time, the monks, in accordance with the Buddha's word, went to where the colt's remains lay and performed great acts of homage.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Parinirvāṇa, the fifty-third fascicle.

At that time, the wanderer Śikhin of the needle-and-thread spoke again, saying: "Gautama, as you have said, throughout births beyond number one performs virtuous and non-virtuous deeds, and these will later, in the time to come, yield a virtuous or non-virtuous body — this position is untenable. Why? You say, Gautama, that a body is obtained through the cause of afflictions. If a body is obtained through the cause of afflictions, then which comes first: the body or the afflictions? If the afflictions come first, what do they rest in, and where do they abide? If the body comes first, would it then be fitting to say that from the cause of afflictions a body is obtained? Therefore it is not fitting to say the afflictions come first, nor is it fitting to say the body comes first. Nor is it fitting to say they are simultaneous. And to say that what comes earlier and later can be simultaneous is simply not coherent. Therefore I hold that all phenomena are exhausted in their intrinsic nature, and do not arise from

causes and conditions.

"Furthermore, Gautama: solidity is the intrinsic nature of earth; moisture is the intrinsic nature of water; heat is the intrinsic nature of fire; movement is the intrinsic nature of wind; unobstructedness is the intrinsic nature of space. The intrinsic nature of the five great elements does not exist through causes and conditions. If even so much as a single phenomenon in the world exists not through causes and conditions, then the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is the same: they do not exist through causes and conditions. If, on the other hand, even one phenomenon does exist through causes and conditions, why do the intrinsic natures of the five great elements not arise from causes and conditions?

"Gautama, the liberation attained by sentient beings through virtuous or non-virtuous bodies is also intrinsic nature, not something from causes and conditions. Therefore I hold that all phenomena exist by intrinsic nature and not from causes and conditions.

"Furthermore, Gautama, worldly phenomena are fixed according to their place of function. For instance, a carpenter says: 'This wood is fit for a chariot and for a wheel,' and 'This wood is suitable for a door and a beam.' Likewise, when a goldsmith beats metal and attaches it to the neck, it is called a necklace; attached to the upper arm, it is called an armlet; placed on the finger, it is called a ring. Because it is determined by its place of function, one speaks of a determined intrinsic nature.

"Gautama, all sentient beings are the same: having a fivefold nature by continuum, they are hell-beings, hungry ghosts (pretas), animals, gods, or humans. If this is so, would it be fitting to say they change through causes and conditions?

"Furthermore, Gautama, all sentient beings each have their own separate intrinsic nature, and so all things are said to have intrinsic nature. For instance, a frog born on dry land still goes to water; a calf, the moment it is born, suckles; a fish naturally swallows things; a venomous snake, the moment it emerges, eats earth — and such behaviors, who taught them? As thorns are naturally sharp by intrinsic nature, and as the feathers of birds are naturally of distinct colors, so too are the beings of the world: with sharp faculties and —"

dull-witted and wealthy and poor and good and bad, those who attain liberation, and those who attain a final existence — therefore one should know that all phenomena each have their own separate intrinsic nature.

"Furthermore, Gautama, what you say — that attachment, aversion, and delusion arise from causes and conditions, and that the cause and condition of these three poisons are the five sense-objects — that too is untenable. Why? Take the example of a sentient being when it is asleep: the five sense-objects are not actively engaged, yet attachment, aversion, and delusion still arise. And a being dwelling in the womb, or one just emerged from the womb, cannot yet distinguish the good and bad of the five sense-objects, yet attachment, aversion, and delusion still arise. And noble sages dwelling in solitary places, though the five sense-objects are not actively engaged, still give rise to attachment, aversion, and delusion. And yet there are some who, through the operation of the six sense-faculties, do not develop attachment, do not develop aversion, and are not bewildered — therefore there is no certainty that all phenomena arise from causes and conditions; they simply come down to intrinsic nature.

"Gautama, furthermore, in the world there are those who lack the five sense-faculties and yet possess great wealth and become powerful. And there are those who possess the five sense-faculties and yet are wretched, destitute, and powerless, serving as servants to others. If things arose from causes and conditions, why would it be so? Therefore the intrinsic nature of all phenomena is each distinct, and does not arise from causes and conditions.

"Gautama, furthermore, in the world there are infants of a million kinds who, though they cannot yet distinguish the five sense-objects, at one moment laugh and at another moment weep. When they laugh, they know joy; when they weep, they know unhappiness. Therefore all phenomena have their own distinct intrinsic nature.

"Gautama, furthermore, phenomena in the world are of two kinds: existent and non-existent. Space is an example of the existent; a rabbit's horn is an example of the non-existent. Both of these two phenomena — the existent is not from causes and conditions, and the non-existent is not from causes and conditions. Therefore all phenomena simply come down to intrinsic nature, and do not arise from causes and conditions."

The Blessed One then declared: "Son of good family, as you argue, that all phenomena are like the intrinsic nature of the five great elements — that cannot be right. Why? Son of good family, if your five great elements are permanent, then why do you say that all phenomena are not permanent? And if worldly things are impermanent, why would the intrinsic nature of the five

great elements not be impermanent? If the five great elements are permanent, then worldly things should likewise be permanent by that reasoning. Therefore, since you claim that the intrinsic nature of the five great elements exists and is not from causes and conditions, to say that all phenomena are likewise like the five great elements — that cannot be right.

"Son of good family, as you argue, it is also untenable to say that intrinsic nature exists in a fixed locus of necessity. Why? Because names are acquired through causes and conditions. If from a cause a name is acquired, then the object too acquires its name through a cause. How does it acquire a name from a cause? Take, for example: when strung together they are called a garland; when hung around the neck they are called a necklace; when put on the wrist they are called a bracelet; when fixed to a chariot they are called a wheel; when wood and grass blaze they are called a fire of wood and grass. Son of good family, when a tree first grows, it has none of the intrinsic nature of an arrow or a spear — yet through causes and conditions it is fashioned into an arrow or a spear. Therefore it is unreasonable to say that all phenomena have intrinsic nature.

"Son of good family, as you argue, that a frog born on dry land goes to water by intrinsic nature, or that a calf suckles the very moment of its birth by intrinsic nature — that too is untenable. Why?

If going to water is not due to causes and conditions, and if both — going to water and going into fire — appear equally to be without causes and conditions, then why does the frog not go into fire? If a calf suckling the very moment of birth by intrinsic nature is not due to causes and conditions, and if both — suckling a mother and suckling a horn — appear equally to be without causes and conditions, then why does the calf not suckle a horn?

Son of good family, if someone were to say that all phenomena have intrinsic nature yet that teaching and training produce no development or transformation, that too is untenable. Why? Because it is plainly evident that development and transformation do arise from present teaching and training. Therefore one should understand that there is no such thing as intrinsic nature.

Son of good family, if all phenomena had intrinsic nature, then it would be right for all brahmins to slaughter sheep and make offerings to the gods as a means of performing right bodily action. But if purification could come from such offerings, one should understand that intrinsic nature, too, does not exist.

Son of good family, in the discourse of the worldly, phenomena are spoken of under three aspects: what is being done, what is being done by an agent, and what has been done. If all phenomena had intrinsic nature, why would they be designated in the world under these three aspects? From the very fact that they are designated under three aspects, it is evident that all phenomena lack intrinsic nature.

Son of good family, if all phenomena had intrinsic nature, then all phenomena would have a fixed intrinsic nature, each distinctly its own. But if each thing had a single, fixed intrinsic nature of its own, why does sugarcane give rise to juice, to molasses, to sugar, to wine, and to vinegar? If its intrinsic nature were one and fixed, why would all these things come to be from it? And if such different things arise from a single entity, one should understand that it is impossible for all phenomena to have a single fixed intrinsic nature that is distinctly each thing's own.

Son of good family, if all phenomena were determined to have a single intrinsic nature, why is it that noble ones may drink the juice of the sugarcane tree, and molasses, and sugar, yet it is improper for them to drink it when it has become wine — and then again becomes proper to drink when it has turned to vinegar? Therefore one should understand that there is no fixed intrinsic nature. And if there is no fixed intrinsic nature, how could it be right to say that things do not arise from causes and conditions?

Son of good family, as for how you might give an example to demonstrate that all phenomena have intrinsic nature — if such an example can be stated, one should understand from that very example that all phenomena lack intrinsic nature. For if intrinsic nature existed, there would be nothing that could serve as an example. It is the wise and discerning of the world who give examples; therefore one should understand that all phenomena lack intrinsic nature and are without any single fixed intrinsic nature.

Son of good family, your claim that the body comes first or that the afflictions come first is likewise untenable. Why? If I were to say the body comes first, you might either agree with me or counter that the body does not come first. Son of good family, the body and the afflictions of all sentient beings are both without prior or subsequent — they exist simultaneously. Though they exist simultaneously in this way, nevertheless the body arises from the causes of the afflictions; the afflictions do not arise from the causes of the body.

If it occurs to you to think that, just as a person's two eyes are obtained simultaneously and neither depends on the other — the right not depending on the left, the left not depending on the right — so too the afflictions and the body are similar in that way, that too is untenable. Why? Son of good family, in the world, when seen with the eye, the wick of a lamp and its light both exist simultaneously; yet the light arises because of the wick, and not the light from the absence of the wick.

Son of good family, if it occurs to you to think that because the body does not come first, it is without a cause — that too is untenable. Why? If one were to say that because the body comes first it is without cause and condition and therefore does not exist, then by that same reasoning you ought to say that all phenomena are without cause and condition. If you do not say so because they are not seen to be causeless, then since pots and so forth are presently perceived directly as having arisen from causes and conditions, why do you not say the same? Just as a pot is that way, so too should the causes and conditions of what precedes the body be understood in the same manner.

Son of good family, whether phenomena appear or do not appear, all phenomena arise from causes and conditions and have no intrinsic nature. Son of good family, if you were to say that all phenomena have intrinsic nature and are without cause and condition, then why do you say that the five great elements exist? The very intrinsic nature of the five great elements is itself cause and condition.

Son of good family, while it may be that the five great elements have causes and conditions in that way, it is unreasonable to say that all phenomena likewise conform to the causes and conditions of the five great elements. That would be like the worldly saying: "Since all those who have gone forth from home life are devoted to guarding moral discipline, therefore outcasts and the like are also devoted to guarding moral discipline."

Son of good family, when you say, as you maintain, that the five great elements have a fixed intrinsic nature — when I examine it, that so-called nature is changeable and is not fixed. Son of good family, in your system butter, fat, and plant resins are called "earth," but that designation of yours as earth is not definitive, for at certain times the same thing can serve as water, and at other times it can serve as earth. Therefore it is not correct to call it inherently solid.

Son of good family, in your system what is called "fire" with regard to red copper, bronze, copper, iron, gold, and silver — that has four intrinsic natures: when it flows, it is called water; when it moves, it is called wind; when it is hot, it is called fire; when it is solid, it is called earth. Why then designate it as necessarily of the nature of fire? Son of good family, the intrinsic nature of water is to flow. Even if water freezes, it should not be called earth — it is still called water. Why? Because when waves stir, that stirring is not called wind. Since movement is not called wind in that case, it is equally unreasonable to say that frozen water is not water.

In the same way, since both those substances arise from causes and conditions, why do you say that all phenomena do not arise from causes and conditions?

Son of good family, it is not tenable to say that the five sense faculties — seeing, hearing, feeling, knowing, and touching — are by intrinsic nature what they are and did not arise from causes and conditions. Why? Son of good family, if intrinsic nature were by its very nature something that does not change, then since the intrinsic nature of the eye is seeing, it would follow that one should always be seeing, and that there should be no distinction between times of seeing and times of not seeing. Therefore, know that seeing occurs through causes and conditions, and not from the absence of causes and conditions.

Son of good family, your assertion that the arising of attachment and liberation from it do not arise from the cause of the five sense objects — that too is untenable. Why? Son of good family, while it is the case that the arising of attachment and liberation from it do not arise from the cause of the five sense objects themselves, attachment arises through conceptuality directed toward what is non-virtuous, and liberation comes about through conceptuality directed toward what is virtuous. Son of good family, attachment arises and liberation occurs through inner causes and conditions, while through outer causes and conditions they arise and increase.

Therefore, your claim that all phenomena have an intrinsic nature of their own, and that attachment and liberation from it do not arise from the cause of the five sense objects — that too is untenable. Son of good family, according to what you say, those who possess their faculties intact are poor and without power, while those whose faculties are impaired and defective are wealthy and endowed with power. Viewed from that standpoint, the claim that there is an

intrinsic nature independent of causes and conditions is untenable. Why? Because sentient beings undergo karmic maturation from their karma. That maturation of results is of three kinds: maturation that is apparent in this very life, maturation that occurs after birth, and maturation that occurs in a later life. Poverty and wealth, and possession or lack of intact faculties, are each distinct. If there were an intrinsic nature, those with intact faculties would naturally be wealthy, and the wealthy would naturally have intact faculties. Since this is not the case, it is certain that there is no intrinsic nature, and that things arise from causes and conditions.

Son of good family, according to what you say, in this world countless millions of infants, without distinguishing among the five sense objects, sometimes cry and sometimes laugh. The claim that all things therefore have an intrinsic nature is also untenable. Why? For if there were an intrinsic nature, one who laughs would always laugh and one who cries would always cry — it would be wholly unreasonable for them to sometimes laugh and sometimes cry. But precisely because they sometimes laugh and sometimes cry, one should understand that all things arise from causes and conditions. Therefore the claim that all phenomena have an intrinsic nature and do not arise from causes and conditions is unreasonable.

Sarvaśūra then asked: Blessed One, if all phenomena arise from causes and conditions, from what causes and conditions does this body arise?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, the causes and conditions of this body are afflictions and karma.

Sarvaśūra asked: Blessed One, if this very body has arisen from afflictions and karma, is it possible to sever afflictions and karma?

The Blessed One declared: It is so. Just so.

Sarvaśūra asked again: Blessed One, I beg you to explain and teach me in detail so that, having heard it, I may be decisively and unwaveringly established in this very understanding.

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, if one knows the two extremes and is unobstructed in the Middle Way, that person will completely sever afflictions and karma.

Sarvaśūra said: Blessed One, I have understood and realized this; the eye of Dharma has become pure and clear in regard to the sacred Dharma.

The Blessed One declared: In what way have you understood and realized it?

He replied: Blessed One, the two extremes are form and liberation from form. What is called the Middle Way is the noble eightfold path. The same elaboration applies in the same manner to feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness.

The Blessed One declared: Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, you have fully realized the two extremes and have completely severed afflictions and karma.

He said: Blessed One, I request the going forth and full ordination.

The Blessed One said, "Welcome," and he became a fully ordained monk. At that very moment all afflictions of the three realms were severed, and he attained the fruit of arhatship.

Then another brahmin, called Mahāvistara, also spoke these words: Gautama, do you know what I am thinking?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, nirvāṇa is permanent. Conditioned phenomena are impermanent.

"Crookedness is wrong view. Straightness is the noble path."

The brahmin asked: Gautama, for what reason and on what grounds did you say that?

The Blessed One declared: Son of good family, you were thinking: "Going on alms-round is permanent; being invited as a guest is impermanent; crookedness is base; straightness is the banner of victory." Therefore nirvāṇa is permanent, conditioned phenomena are impermanent, crookedness is wrong view, and straightness is the Noble Eightfold Path — it is not as you were thinking before.

The brahmin said: Gautama, you have truly known what I was thinking. Will all sentient beings be fully liberated by the Noble Eightfold Path?

At that moment the Blessed One said nothing and gave no reply.

The brahmin said: Gautama, if you know what I was thinking, why do you sit in silence without giving an answer to what I asked?

Then the venerable Kauṇḍinya spoke these words: Great brahmin, if one were to ask whether the world has an end or has no end, the Tathāgata, by the very nature of reality, says nothing and gives no reply. The Noble Eightfold Path is straightness. Passing beyond sorrow is permanence. If one applies oneself

diligently to the Noble Eightfold Path, one will attain liberation. If one does not apply oneself diligently, one will not attain it. Great brahmin, consider this example: a great citadel has four walls with no opening or passage for escape — only a single gate. If the gatekeeper of that gate is wise and discerning, he will let pass those who should rightly pass, and he will not let pass those who should not pass. He may not know the exact number of all who travel through, yet he knows for certain that all who travel through must pass through that gate. Son of good family, the Tathāgata is just like this. The citadel is the analogy for passing beyond sorrow. The gate is the analogy for the Noble Eightfold Path. The gatekeeper is the analogy for the Tathāgata. Son of good family, although the Tathāgata has not declared whether it is exhaustible or inexhaustible, to whatever extent exhaustion occurs, that occurs through diligent application to the Noble Eightfold Path.

The brahmin said: Excellent! Excellent! Venerable Kauṇḍinya is supremely skilled in teaching the Tathāgata's sacred Dharma. I too have faith, knowing the citadel and the path and trusting one such as the gatekeeper.

Kauṇḍinya said: Excellent! Brahmin, it is excellent that you have aroused a vast and unsurpassed mind.

The Blessed One declared: Kauṇḍinya, do not say that. This brahmin has not aroused that mind for the first time just now. Kauṇḍinya, in a past age, incalculable eons ago, before a previous immeasurable number of Blessed Ones had passed, there appeared in the world a Tathāgata, a fully and perfectly awakened one, endowed with knowledge and conduct, a Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, tamer and guide of persons to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a Blessed One, by the name of All-Pervasive Light. This brahmin, after arousing the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassed and perfect awakening in relation to that buddha, became fully awakened in this excellent aeon, thoroughly penetrating and realizing the defining marks of phenomena — and though he has done so for a long time, for the sake of sentient beings he appears as a non-Buddhist adherent and acts as though he does not know. Therefore, Kauṇḍinya, do not say "Excellent, excellent, you have aroused the unsurpassed mind."

At that time the Blessed One, though knowing already, asked the venerable Kauṇḍinya: Where is the monk Nanda now?

The venerable Kauṇḍinya replied: Blessed One, the monk Nanda is at this moment, twelve leagues beyond this Sāla grove, being fully assailed by

sixty-four thousand māras.

Those māras, having emanated in the form of Tathāgatas, spoke various teachings. Some declared that all phenomena arise through dependent origination; others declared that all phenomena do not arise through dependent origination. Some declared that all phenomena arising through dependent origination are permanent; others declared that all phenomena arising through dependent origination are impermanent. Some declared that the five aggregates are real; others declared that they are illusions. And in the same way they taught at length concerning the sense bases and the elements. Some declared that dependent origination exists; others declared that only the four conditions exist. Some declared that all phenomena are like illusions, like emanations, like mirages. Some declared that the Dharma is attained through the cause of hearing; others declared that it is attained through the cause of reflection; others declared that it is attained through the cause of meditation. Some taught the Dharma of the thorough realization of the repulsive; others taught the Dharma of the movement of the breath, inward and outward. Some taught the thorough establishment of the four foundations of mindfulness and the perfect contemplation thereof. Some taught the three objectives of correct conduct and the seven skillful means. Some taught heat, the summit, patience, the supreme worldly dharma, the path of learning, the path of no more learning, and the ten bodhisattva grounds from the first through the tenth. Some taught emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness. Some taught the class of sūtras, the class of melodic utterances, the class of verses, the class of prophecies, the class of deliberate teachings, the class of present and past events, the class of birth stories, the class of origin narratives, the class of accounts of realization, the class of wondrous teachings, the class of extensive teachings, and the class of definitive teachings. Some taught the four foundations of mindfulness, the four perfect abandonments, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven limbs of awakening, and the eight limbs of the noble path. Some taught inner emptiness, outer emptiness, inner and outer emptiness, emptiness of the conditioned, emptiness of the unconditioned, emptiness of beginninglessness and endlessness, emptiness of intrinsic nature, emptiness of non-discarding, emptiness of the unobjective, emptiness of intrinsic characteristics, emptiness of signlessness, emptiness of the aggregates, emptiness of the elements, emptiness of the sense bases, emptiness of virtue, emptiness of non-virtue, emptiness of the indeterminate, emptiness of awakening, emptiness of the

path, emptiness of nirvāṇa, emptiness of conduct, emptiness of attainment, emptiness of the ultimate, emptiness of emptiness itself, and great emptiness. Some displayed the superknowledges (abhijñā): fire and water arising from the body — when water flows from the upper part of the body, fire blazes from the lower; when water flows from the lower part of the body, fire blazes from the upper; when the right armpit is lowered, water issues from the left; when the left armpit is lowered, water issues from the right; and from one armpit the sound of thunder rolls, while from the other armpit rain falls. Some displayed the many buddha-fields. Some displayed the bodhisattva first descending into the womb, being born, then taking seven steps in each direction; enjoying the five objects of desire in the palace; from the time of first going forth, performing austerities; proceeding to the foot of the tree of awakening and entering into meditative absorption.

Having routed the armies of Māra, turning the wheel of Dharma, and displaying great miraculous powers, some also demonstrated complete passing beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa.

The Blessed One's monk Ānanda, upon seeing such things as these, thought to himself: "Who has performed these miraculous feats, never seen before? Surely they must be the work of the Blessed One Śākyamuni?" Yet he could find no resolve as to whether he should rise, or speak, or what he should do.

Now the monk Ānanda, seized by Māra's snare, was thinking to himself: "The teachings spoken by the blessed buddhas differ from one another — so what shall I now take hold of?" The Blessed One explained that the monk Ānanda had in this way been experiencing great suffering, and that even though he called the Tathāgata to mind, there was none to serve as a companion and ally; and so he was not present in this assembly circle.

At that moment the great bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, prince of Dharma, spoke thus to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, within this assembly circle there are bodhisattvas who, having aroused the mind of awakening set toward unsurpassed perfect and complete awakening, have taken one more birth; and others who, having aroused the awakening mind, have taken birth innumerable times thereafter, honoring innumerable buddhas with offerings, and whose minds have become supremely steadfast. Beginning with the perfection of generosity (dāna) and completing every perfection through to the Perfection of Wisdom, endowed with qualities from long ago, having served innumerable buddhas and led a perfectly pure holy life, they are

irreversible from the awakening mind; they have attained the patience of the irreversible, attained the dhāraṇī of the irreversible, attained patience with the Dharma, and attained the meditative absorption of courageous progress and innumerable other absorptions besides. With all of this, they never give rise to any doubt regarding the sūtras of the Great Vehicle; and they are supremely skilled in teaching and disclosing that the Three Jewels share a single defining characteristic, that they are permanent, abiding, and neither changing nor shifting. Even when they hear inconceivable phenomena, they feel no astonishment or wonder. Even upon hearing the many teachings on emptiness, their minds neither shrink back nor are frightened; and they directly realize the defining characteristics of all phenomena. They hold the twelve branches of scripture and are supremely skilled in their meaning. Moreover, if those who are not like this could yet hold the twelve branches of the scriptural word of innumerable buddhas — how much more should these be able to hold the synonyms of this Dharma of nirvāṇa?"

With this in mind, he addressed Kauṇḍinya, asking: "Where is the monk Ānanda?"

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to Mañjuśrī: "Listen well, and take this deeply to heart. Son of good family, more than thirty years have passed since my perfect and complete awakening. While dwelling at Rājagṛha, at that time and on that occasion I spoke thus to the monks: 'O monks, which of you can hold the twelve branches of scripture spoken by the Tathāgata, serve as my attendant, and also be able to act for my benefit?' Within the assembly, the venerable Kauṇḍinya, he who knows all, spoke to me thus: 'I myself can hold the twelve branches of the scriptures spoken by the Tathāgata, and I can act both as attendant upon the Tathāgata and in my own benefit.' To this I replied: 'Kauṇḍinya, you yourself are old and bent — if an attendant is needed, how will you attend upon me?' Then Śāriputra said —"

Then Śāriputra said: "I myself can hold all the scriptures, serve as attendant for all activities, and also act for my own benefit." At that time I said to Śāriputra as well: "You yourself are old and bent — if an attendant is needed, how will you attend upon me?" And so it went, from that point through to the five hundred arhats, each offering to serve and each being refused by me — let this be understood in full detail in just the same way.

Now at that time Maudgalyāyana had gathered within that assembly, and he thought to himself: "If the Tathāgata has not appointed any among the five

hundred monks as attendant, then in whom does the heart of the Blessed One delight?" He entered into meditative absorption, and perceived that the Tathāgata's heart was gladdened and delighted with Ānanda — just as when the sun first rises, its light falls upon the western wall. Rising from his absorption, he said to Kauṇḍinya: "Venerable one, I have examined this matter: the Tathāgata delights in Ānanda as his attendant." Thereupon Kauṇḍinya, together with the five hundred arhats, went to where Ānanda was and said to him: "Ānanda, you have been appointed as attendant upon the Tathāgata — please accept." Ānanda replied: "Venerable one, I do not presume to serve as attendant upon the Tathāgata. Why? The Tathāgata is majestic as a lion king, as a nāga, as fire — I am far too weak, and do not presume to serve as his attendant." The monks said: "Ānanda, do as we instruct and serve as attendant upon the Tathāgata — great benefit and happiness will come to you." This they urged upon him two and three times. Still Ānanda said: "Venerable ones, I do not seek even great benefit and happiness — I do not presume to serve as attendant upon the Tathāgata."

Then Maudgalyāyana said to Ānanda: "You do not understand." Ānanda replied: "Venerable one, please explain it to me." Maudgalyāyana said: "When the Tathāgata previously sought an attendant from within the Saṅgha, the five hundred arhats each offered to serve, yet the Tathāgata accepted none of them. I entered into meditative absorption and looked, and I perceived that the Tathāgata's heart is delighted with you — so why do you decline?" When Ānanda heard these words, he joined his palms together, knelt upon his knees, and spoke thus: "Venerable one, if that is truly so, then if the Tathāgata grants me three requests, I will, in accordance with the Saṅgha's instruction, serve as attendant upon the Tathāgata." Maudgalyāyana said: "What are your wishes?" Ānanda said: "My three wishes are these: if the Tathāgata permits me to decline whenever he offers me leftover food; if the Tathāgata goes to a donor's home and permits me not to go; and if the Tathāgata permits me to go anywhere at any time without restriction — then I will, in accordance with the Saṅgha's instruction, serve as attendant upon the Tathāgata."

Thereupon Kauṇḍinya and the five hundred monks returned to where I was and spoke to me thus: "When we instructed the monk Ānanda, he said: 'If three requests are granted, I will act in accordance with the Saṅgha's instruction.'" Mañjuśrī, at that time I said to Ānanda: "Excellent! Excellent!" For I had known from the outset that the monk Ānanda, being endowed with wisdom, would prove a worthy vessel. Why?

Because people would say, "You serve the Tathāgata for the sake of robes and food" — that is why I said I would not accept worn-out robes and would not go to his table as a guest.

Kauṇḍinya then said: "The monk Ānanda, endowed with wisdom — if he were to go about only at fixed times and measured intervals, he would be unable to accomplish extensively the benefit and welfare of the fourfold assembly. That is why he requested the freedom to come and go without restriction of time."

Kauṇḍinya then said: "I, for my part, have granted all three of the monk Ānanda's requests as asked." Thereupon Maudgalyāyana went to where the monk Ānanda was and said to him: "I presented your three requests, and the Tathāgata in his great compassion has granted them all."

Ānanda said: "Venerable one, if the Blessed One has granted this, then I shall serve as his attendant."

Mañjuśrī, Ānanda served as my attendant for more than twenty years, and he was endowed with eight inconceivable qualities. What are those eight?

First, though he served as my attendant for more than twenty years, he never went to a table as a guest in my place. Second, from the time he began serving as my attendant until just now, he never accepted worn-out robes. Third, when he came into my presence as my attendant, he never came at an improper time. Fourth, though he served as my attendant and, being possessed of afflictions, went in my train to royal palaces and to the residences of great noble families, even when he saw beautiful women, or daughters of gods, or daughters of nāgas, no thought of desire arose in him. Fifth, having served as my attendant, he would take up the twelve branches of scripture (sūtra and so forth) that I had taught, and having heard them even once, he never needed to ask again — just as when water is poured from one vessel into another vessel, not a drop is lost. The one exception was on the occasion when the regent Viḍūḍabha slaughtered the Śākya clan and razed the city of Kapilavastu. At that time Ānanda was utterly distressed and wept aloud, and he came to where I was and addressed me thus: "The Tathāgata was born in this city, and I too was born here; since we are alike in being of the Śākya lineage, why is it that the Tathāgata shines with brilliance and radiance while I have become dull and without lustre?" I then said to him: "Ānanda, I attend earnestly to the meditative absorption of emptiness (samādhi) — that is why I am different from you." Then, three years later, he came to me again and asked: "Blessed One, is it true or false that I previously, in Kapilavastu,

requested the Tathāgata's instruction on the meditative absorption of emptiness?" I said to Ānanda: "It is true, it is true." Sixth, though he served as my attendant, he had not obtained the wisdom that knows the minds of others — yet he knew which meditative absorption the Tathāgata was dwelling in. Seventh, though he served as my attendant, he had not obtained the wisdom born of aspirational prayer — yet when any sentient being came into the Tathāgata's presence, he perceived directly which fruit of the contemplative life that being had already attained, which they would attain in the future, and by means of what kind of body — divine or human — the attainment would come. Eighth, having served as my attendant, he comprehended and realized all that the Tathāgata intended and taught.

Noble son, the monk Ānanda was thus endowed with these eight inconceivable qualities, and it is for this reason that the monk Ānanda is renowned as the treasury of one who has heard much. Noble son, the monk Ānanda, being endowed with eight qualities of Dharma, was able to hold and preserve the twelve branches of scripture taught by the Tathāgata. What are those eight qualities? They are as follows: a faculty of faith that is exceedingly stable, being extremely upright, being free of illness in body, being endowed with diligence, being endowed with mindfulness,

being free of pride, being endowed with meditative absorption and wisdom, and being endowed with the arising of wisdom from what has been heard. The attendant of Mañjuśrī, the buddha Viśāladarśin, named Anāmaya, was likewise endowed with these eight qualities of Dharma. The attendant of the Tathāgata Uṣṇīṣin, named Cāpaka; the attendant of the buddha Sarvasattvāpāyin, named Upaśānta; the attendant of the buddha Mithyāprasādavīnodana, named Pati; the attendant of the buddha Suvarṇamuni Puṇyatrāṇa, named Sote; and the attendant of the buddha Kāśyapa, named Yābāmīta — all of these were likewise endowed with these eight qualities of Dharma. And so too, at this very time, my beloved one is endowed with these eight qualities. It is for this reason that the monk Ānanda is renowned as the treasury of one who has heard much.

Noble son, just as you have said, immeasurable and boundless bodhisattvas have gathered here in this maṇḍala of the assembly. Yet those bodhisattvas, acting out of great loving-kindness and great compassion, do what is difficult to do, and so, through the power of their loving-kindness and compassion, each has their own activities — taming their respective retinues and performing the work of adorning their own bodies. Therefore, when I pass

completely into nirvāṇa, they will not be able to proclaim the twelve branches of scripture in their full extent. And if bodhisattvas were to proclaim them here and there, others would not place their trust in it. Mañjuśrī, the monk Ānanda is my younger brother, and for over twenty years he served as my attendant, retaining everything he heard — just as water poured from one vessel into another vessel. It is for this reason that I summoned Ānanda, asking what his name was, in order to have him hold this sūtra of passing into complete nirvāṇa. The monk Ānanda will teach even those bodhisattvas who have not heard it, teaching it in full detail; and whatever Ānanda has heard, all of it will be thoroughly understood and realized.

Mañjuśrī, at this present time, twelve yojanas from here, in another place, the monk Ānanda is being harassed by sixty-four thousand māras. Go to him and call out loudly to those māras: "Listen well! Listen well! This is the great dhāraṇī (Skt. dhāraṇī) spoken by the Tathāgata." Announce this to gods (devas), nāgas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, great mahoragas, humans, non-humans, mountain deities, tree deities, water deities, ocean deities, house deities, and all the rest — there is not a single deity among all these gods who, upon merely hearing the name of this dhāraṇī, would fail to pay reverence, or who would fail to hold the name of the dhāraṇī. This dhāraṇī was proclaimed by as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in ten Ganges rivers, and one who hears it will abandon a female body and will come to recall past lives. If someone practices the five modes — living in celibacy, abstaining from meat, abstaining from alcohol, abstaining from pungent root vegetables, and delighting in solitary places — and with a mind of faith reads this dhāraṇī aloud, or recites it, or copies it into a book, that person will surpass seventy-seven koṭis of sinful and non-virtuous actions.

Then the Blessed One declared the mantra:

Amale, vimale, nirmale, mugale, hemala-jagarbhe, samantabhadre, śavatha, sadanne, paramārthasādhane, manase, aśudghe, vilagi, amalete, balammi, balamba-svare, puṇye puṇye, manoladai.

At that moment, Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, having received that dhāraṇī from the Blessed One, went to where Ānanda was, and spoke these words to those māras: "Retinue of māras, listen well! I shall recite the dhāraṇī I have received from the Blessed One," — and so he spoke.

The moment the king of māras heard that dhāraṇī, he gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. He wholly abandoned the deeds of

māras and released Ānanda. Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, accompanied by Ānanda, came back to where the Buddha was, and Ānanda bowed before the Buddha and sat to one side.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to Ānanda: "Outside the grove of sāla trees there is a wandering ascetic called Śīntu Zangpo who is a hundred and twenty years of age, old and decrepit. Though he has attained the five kinds of higher knowledge, he has not relinquished his pride. He has attained the meditative absorption of the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and has grasped at it as if it were the gnosis of omniscience, thinking it to be nirvāṇa. Go to him and deliver this message: 'The arising of a Tathāgata in the world is as rare as the udumbara flower. This very night, at the middle hour of the night, he will pass into complete nirvāṇa. If there is something you need to do, now is the time — do it, lest regret arise in you later.' If you deliver the message, he will certainly listen. Why so? Because for five hundred past lives you were born as Śīntu Zangpo's son, and the habitual tendency of his affection and regard for you has not yet been exhausted. Therefore he will listen to words conveyed by you."

Then Ānanda, following the Buddha's command, went to where Śīntu Zangpo was and spoke these words: "Good sir, know this: the arising of a Tathāgata in the world is as rare as the udumbara flower. This very night, at the middle hour of the night, he will pass into complete nirvāṇa. Whatever there is to be done — now is the time. Do it without letting regret arise later."

Śīntu Zangpo replied: "Excellent! Ānanda, I shall go to where the Tathāgata is."

Then Ānanda accompanied Śīntu Zangpo and came to where the Buddha was. Śīntu Zangpo inquired after the Buddha's health and then addressed him thus: "Gautama, I have a question. Please answer it as I have thought to ask it."

The Blessed One declared: "Śīntu Zangpo, now is the time — ask whatever you wish, and I shall answer each question."

He said: "Gautama, there are ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins who say this: 'All the suffering and happiness that every sentient being experiences is entirely due to past karma. Therefore, if one strives to guard ethical discipline and the body and mind experience suffering, that suffering will exhaust past karma. When past karma is exhausted, suffering will be exhausted. When suffering is exhausted, one passes beyond sorrow.' What is the nature of what

they are saying?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if there are ascetics or brahmins who speak in such a way, then out of compassion for them you should go to them again and again and ask: 'Is what you say true?' And if such a one says, 'Yes, what I said is true — why? Because, Gautama, I directly perceive it myself: there are some sentient beings who commit sinful and unwholesome deeds and yet are prosperous and powerful; there are others who perform virtuous actions and yet are impoverished and without power; there are some who exert themselves in many ways and still do not obtain wealth, while others obtain it without any effort at all; there are some who possess a mind of loving-kindness and do not take life, yet their life is short; and there are others who delight in taking life and yet live to the end of their allotted span —'

there are some who are utterly pure in their celibate conduct, diligent in guarding their moral discipline, and yet some among them attain liberation while others do not.

Therefore, if you say that all the pleasure and pain experienced by sentient beings have their cause and condition in past karma, then I, in turn, would ask you this: Do you directly perceive past karma? If such karma exists, is it much or little? By practising austerities now, how much of it can be eliminated? Will that karma be exhausted, or will it not be exhausted? And if it will be exhausted, will it all be exhausted together?

If you were to tell me that you do not know, then I would offer you this analogy. Suppose a person is struck by a poisoned arrow. His friends and relatives find a surgeon skilled in removing arrows, and when the arrow is extracted, the person's body becomes thoroughly comfortable. Or even if ten years later that same surgeon extracts the arrow and treats the wound with medicine and it heals, one would clearly remember that this was a great relief. Now if you do not even know the past karma, how can you know that practising austerities in the present is able to eliminate past karma?

Suppose he were then to say this: "Gautama, you too have past karma — what fault, then, is there in my past karma alone? And besides, from the sūtras taught by Gautama himself it is said: 'When one sees someone who is wealthy, endowed with resources, and powerful, one thinks: this person made offerings in the past' — is that not past karma?" To this I would say: that is known through inference, not through direct and precise knowledge.

In my teaching, some understand effects from causes, and others understand causes from effects. In the teaching of the buddhas, there is both past karma and present karma. But yours is not like that — you hold that there is only past karma and no present karma. Your Dharma does not sever karma through skillful means and application, whereas my teaching is not like that — it does sever karma through skillful means and application. You say that when karma is exhausted, suffering is exhausted. I say it is not like that — when afflictions are exhausted, both karma and suffering are exhausted. Therefore it is your past karma that I am criticising.

He might then say: "Gautama, I do not know. My teacher said such and such — I am not at fault." But to this I would reply: Who then is your teacher? He might say: "My teacher is Pūraṇa Kāśyapa." Then I would say to him: What harm is there in asking your teacher directly whether he knows past karma?

If your teacher says he does not know, why do you listen to his words? If he says he does know, then ask him this: Does a middling cause of suffering produce the greatest and intermediate degrees of suffering? Does an intermediate cause of suffering produce the greatest and lowest degrees of suffering? Does the greatest cause of suffering produce intermediate and lowest degrees of suffering? If he says it does not, then ask further: Teacher, why do you say that the pleasure and pain experienced by sentient beings come from past causes alone and not from present ones? And also ask: Is the suffering experienced right now the karma of a past time?

If it comes from past time, then all past karma has been exhausted. But if it has all been exhausted, why would it still be experienced in this present body? And if it does not exist from past time and exists only in the present moment, then why do you say that all the pleasure and pain of sentient beings are entirely past karma? If you claim that by practising austerities now, past karma will be eliminated —

— then why would the present practice of austerities cease to exist? And if it does not cease to exist, then suffering becomes permanent. But if suffering is permanent, why do you claim that one is fully liberated from suffering?

If it is some other practice that brings the austerities to an end, then — if what is past has already been exhausted — how can suffering still exist? Would a person who practises such austerities and has performed karma that yields pleasure end up experiencing a fruit of suffering? Or, having performed karma that yields suffering, would they end up experiencing a fruit of pleasure? Or

would there be no experience of the karmic fruit at all, in the case of karma that yields neither suffering nor pleasure? Is it the case that a present karmic maturation gives rise to a future karmic maturation? Or that a future karmic maturation gives rise to a present karmic maturation? Or that from both these maturations a state without maturation arises? Or that from a fixed maturation a state without maturation arises? Or that from a state without maturation a fixed maturation arises? Ask all of this.

If they answer "None of that, Gautama," then I too shall say to them: If none of that holds, then why practise austerities at all?

Therefore there are certainly past phenomena, and there are also present causes and conditions. This is why it has been taught that karma arises through the condition of affliction, and that karmic maturation is experienced through the condition of karma. Accordingly, one should understand that all sentient beings have both prior past karma and present causes and conditions. Although karma from former times exists, there is still a need for present causes and conditions in the form of food and drink. If you, then, claim that the pleasure and pain experienced by ordinary people are entirely the cause and condition of past karma, that too is untenable. And why? Consider this example: if a person kills an enemy of the king, through that cause and condition he gains an abundance of wealth and precious things. Through gaining that wealth and those precious things, he experiences pleasure in the present time. He has created the cause for present pleasure, and so he experiences pleasure in the present. Consider another example: if a person kills a beloved son of the king, through that cause and condition he loses his body and his life. He has created the cause for present suffering, and so the maturation he experiences in the present is suffering.

Friend, the present causes for all sentient beings' experience of pleasure and suffering arise from the four great elements, from season, from measure, from soil, and from fire — and through these they experience suffering and pleasure. Therefore it is not at all certain that all sentient beings experience pleasure and suffering from past karma alone.

Friend, if liberation were to come about through the power of causes and conditions by simply cutting off karma, then all noble ones (āryas) would already be liberated — but they are not. Why? Because the past karma of all sentient beings is without beginning or end. This is why it has been taught that cultivating the noble path is what turns back karma that is without beginning

or end. Friend, if the path were obtained by practising austerities, then all animals, too, would be fit to attain awakening. Therefore, it is the mind that is to be tamed first — not the body. This is why I have also declared in the sūtras: Cut the grove, but do not cut the tree. And why? Because fear arises from the grove, not from the tree.

If one wishes to tame the body, one should first tame the mind. The mind is the analogy of the grove, and the body is the analogy of the tree.

Subhavyūha submitted: "Blessed One, I have already tamed my mind."

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in what way have you tamed your mind first?"

Subhavyūha submitted: "Blessed One, I attended with careful attention to desires as being impermanent, as being without pleasure, and as being impure. And I examined form as being permanent, as being pleasurable, as being self, and as being pure. Having understood this, the afflictions of the desire realm were severed, and I attained the sense base of the form realm. Therefore I had first tamed my mind. Then, examining form, I understood form to be impermanent — like a wound, like an ulcer, like something harmful, like a dart. And I saw the formless as being permanent, as being utterly pure, and as being supremely peaceful. Having understood this, with the afflictions of the form realm exhausted, I attained the sense base of the formless realm. Therefore I had first tamed my mind. Then, further examining perception, I understood it to be impermanent — like a wound, like an ulcer, like something harmful, like a dart. Having understood this, I attained meditative absorption at the level of the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. That meditative absorption at the level of neither-perception-nor-non-perception is omniscient wisdom — supremely peaceful, utterly pure, free from transgression, permanent and unchanging. Therefore I had tamed my mind."

This is from the fifty-fourth fascicle of the Noble Great Sūtra of the Passage Beyond All Sorrow (the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra).

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, in what way have you tamed your mind? What you have attained is meditative absorption at the level of neither-perception-nor-non-perception — and even that is still called 'perception.' If passing beyond sorrow were a state of having no perception, why would it be called 'attaining the passage beyond sorrow'? Son of good family, before, you criticized coarse perception — why do you now fail to recognize that you are attached to subtle perception and do not censure it?"

The level of neither-perception-nor-non-perception is likewise called 'perception' — like a wound, like an ulcer, like something harmful, like a dart. Son of good family, your own teacher Udraka (Skt. Udraka Rāmaputra), who had sharp faculties and a concentrated mind, venerated the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and as a result will experience evil karma. What need is there even to speak of others?"

Subhavyūha submitted: "Blessed One, how does one sever all becoming?"

The Blessed One declared: "Son of good family, if a person practises correct perception, that person will sever all becoming."

Subhavyūha submitted: "Blessed One, what is meant by 'correct perception'?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, the perception of non-perception is what is called correct perception."

He submitted: "Blessed One, how is there a perception of non-perception?"

The Blessed One replied: "Son of good family, all phenomena are without the characteristic of self, without the characteristic of other, without the characteristic of self-and-other, without the characteristic of causelessness, without the characteristic of having been made, without the characteristic of having passed, without the characteristic of an agent, without the characteristic of an experiencer, without the characteristic of being a dharma, without the characteristic of being a non-dharma, without the characteristic of male or female, without the characteristic of being a person, without the characteristic of subtle particles, without the characteristic of time and measure, without the characteristic of having been made by self, without the characteristic of having been made by other, without the characteristic of having been made by self-and-other, without the characteristic of existence, and without the characteristic of non-existence.

without the characteristic of having been born, without the characteristic of being produced, without the characteristic of cause, without the characteristic of passing from cause to cause, without the characteristic of result, without the characteristic of passing from result to result, without the characteristic of day and night, without the characteristic of light and darkness, without the characteristic of seeing, without the characteristic of that which causes seeing, without the characteristic of hearing, without the characteristic of that which causes hearing, without the characteristic of feeling and knowing, without the characteristic of that which causes feeling and knowing, without the

characteristic of awakening, without the characteristic of that which causes awakening to be attained, without the characteristic of karma, without the characteristic of a master of karma, without the characteristic of affliction, and without the characteristic of a master of affliction.

Noble son, that in which all characteristics are ceased is called the true characteristic. Noble son, all phenomena are untrue. That in which they are ceased is called the true, is called true perception, is called the dharmadhātu, is called consummate wisdom, is called the ultimate, and is called ultimate emptiness.

Noble son, if one engages authentically with characteristic, with dharmadhātu, with consummate wisdom, with ultimate truth, and with ultimate emptiness through inferior wisdom, one will attain the awakening of a śrāvaka. If one engages authentically through middling wisdom, one will attain the awakening of a pratyekabuddha. If one engages authentically through supreme wisdom, one will attain unsurpassed awakening.

When this teaching was given, one hundred thousand bodhisattvas attained true perception (samādhi) that penetrates in a single lifetime. Seventy-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the dharmadhātu in two lifetimes. Twenty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained consummate wisdom. Thirty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained ultimate truth. Ultimate truth may also be called ultimate emptiness and may also be called the meditative absorption of heroic advance. Forty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the meditative absorption like space. The meditative absorption like space may also be called the vast meditative absorption and may also be called the meditative absorption of the wisdom seal. Fifty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the irreversible patience (kṣānti). Irreversible patience may also be called the patience of Dharma and may also be called that which is like the dharmadhātu. Sixty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained dhāraṇī. That dhāraṇī may also be called the mind of great mindfulness and may also be called unobstructed wisdom. Seventy-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the meditative absorption known as the lion's roar. The meditative absorption of the lion's roar may also be called the vajra-like meditative absorption and may also be called the meditative absorption of the wisdom seal. Eighty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the meditative absorption of equality. That meditative absorption of equality may also be called great loving-kindness and great compassion.

Sentient beings as innumerable as the grains of sand in the Ganges River generated the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Sentient beings as innumerable as the grains of sand in the Ganges River generated the mind directed toward pratyekabuddha awakening. Sentient beings as innumerable as the grains of sand in the Ganges River generated the mind directed toward the path of a śrāvaka. Some twenty thousand human beings and daughters of the gods directly manifested bodies born as male, having previously had female bodies. And the most excellent among them attained the fruit of arhatship.

At that time, Śīlavat (the Supremely Good One), having heard from the Blessed One the profoundly deep teaching of the great scripture on complete nirvāṇa, gained the perfectly pure eye of Dharma with respect to the Dharma. Having seen the purified Dharma and, out of longing for the sacred Dharma, having entirely abandoned wrong views, his faith in the teaching of the Buddha became exceedingly firm. He then requested going forth from the Tathāgata.

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Śīlavat, welcome — you are a monk well-come. The noble ones too joyfully rejoice in this: you have entered well upon the awakening of a buddha."

Śīlavat was filled with immense joy and delight, and his devotion became boundless. At that very moment his hair and beard fell away of themselves, and he became a monk. By the power of dharmatā itself, the water of primordial wisdom saturated the vessel of mind, so that he was not bound by any bond, and with defilements exhausted and mind fully liberated, he became an arhat.

Having attained the fruit of arhatship, Śīlavat drew near to the Buddha and gazed upon the face of the Blessed One with unblinking eyes. He bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, arranged his outer robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee upon the ground, joined his palms together, and — grief and joy arising in him at one and the same time — repenting his former faults, he addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"For a very long time this malicious body of mine deceived me. For a very long time, sunk within what is like the darkness of vile ignorance, I wandered in cyclic existence through the three realms and was seized upon by the doctrines of the non-Buddhists. Alas, alas — from that great and grievous harm, I have now, by the kindness and grace of the Tathāgata, entered into

the sacred Dharma. Blessed One, the great compassion of your ocean-like primordial wisdom is boundless; even across an eon I could not repay your kindness." So he thought in his mind.

Having spoken thus, Śīlavat shed tears. Then he addressed the Blessed One again with these words:

"Blessed One, I am old and decrepit. I am not yet liberated from suffering; I am utterly tormented by the suffering of formations. Out of compassion, Blessed One, please teach the precepts of ethical discipline and be my protector and refuge. Please remain for a while without passing into nirvāṇa."

At that time the Blessed One said nothing and did not grant the request. Since Śīlavat's plea had not been granted, his mind was afflicted with anguish, and he cried out with a great voice:

"Alas! Alas! The world is left empty! The world is left empty! Now a great terror draws near, and anguish has become manifest. Alas! Alas! By the exhaustion of the merit of sentient beings, the eye of true wisdom has gone blind!"

Saying this, he beat his breast in lamentation, wept until his voice gave out, and his body was drenched in blood. He cried out with a great voice, and then, casting his body to the ground before the Tathāgata, he fell unconscious. After a long while he revived, and weeping still, he again addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, I cannot bear to see the Tathāgata pass into nirvāṇa. My mind is deeply afflicted and I am stricken with grief. I myself, moreover, have no wish to continue in the company of this malicious body of mine — like an unfired pot — I am already gone ahead. May the Blessed One then pass into nirvāṇa later."

Having thus spoken, Śīlavat beat his breast in lamentation, and at that very moment entered into nirvāṇa himself.

At that time, bodhisattvas of the Great Vehicle as innumerable as the grains of sand in ineffably many Ganges Rivers, together with monks, nuns,

all the gods, humans, asuras, and every other being dwelling in the world cried out together with one voice, saying:

"Alas! Alas! The perfectly awakened buddha has abandoned us all at once. There is no dwelling, no refuge, no shelter, no protector — it is utterly terrible."

So they spoke, and every one of them wept. They embraced one another, beat their fists against their own breasts, fell unconscious, and collapsed in all directions. Even the great trichiliocosm — the vast world-system of three thousand great thousands of worlds — trembled.

At that time the Blessed One, with his voice endowed with the eight qualities, spoke these words to the great assembly:

"Do not weep as small children do. Each of you, let go of that weeping and do not disturb your minds. You who are in this ocean of saṃsāra, the suffering born of formations — you must be earnest in pure intention and must not forget the wisdom of recollection and mindfulness. Strive with true gnosis toward liberation from conditioned existence. To take birth in a body within the three realms is an endless wheel of suffering. Do not become servants and slaves whose bodies and minds are driven by the king of the māra of desire and the lord of ignorance. Focusing on the domain of objects of action, beings perform the karma of saṃsāra, and being tormented moment by moment by attachment, aversion, and delusion, they come to experience suffering for measureless eons — what wise and discerning person would not reflect on this?

You should understand it thus. From time immemorial I have entered into the great peace that is devoid of aggregates, elements, and sense bases; I have severed conditioned existence entirely and have attained permanence, bliss, self, and complete purity — like a treasure of precious vajra. Yet I am demonstrating, here and now, a passing into nirvāṇa that accords with the ways of the world, in order to reveal inconceivable skillful means — and this for the sake of causing ordinary beings to understand the body as being like a flash of lightning and to arouse a sense of reverence. The flood of saṃsāra's flow is extremely fierce and swift, and formations circle round and round in saṃsāra. Such is the nature of reality. The Tathāgata's passing into nirvāṇa is extremely profound and inconceivable; it belongs to the domain of experience of buddhas and bodhisattvas, and is not known to śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas."

The Blessed One then spoke again to the great assembly, saying:

"This Śīlavat, in former times, paid homage and rendered service to as many buddhas as there are grains of sand in the Ganges River. Having thereby cultivated a vast root of virtue from those buddhas, and impelled by the force of his earlier aspirations, he continually went forth and lived according to the

path of the naked non-Buddhist (tīrthika) ascetics, and through the wisdom of skillful means he brought sentient beings who had entered into wrong and evil views into the domain of true gnosis. Now, Śīlavat, driven by the force of those former aspirations, came to encounter me at this very passing into nirvāṇa and heard the sacred Dharma. Having heard the sacred Dharma, he attained the fruit of arhatship. Having attained the fruit of arhatship, he entered nirvāṇa. From the moment of my full awakening, the first person I ordained was the venerable Kauṇḍinya; and at the very last, at this passing into nirvāṇa, I tamed Śīlavat and thereby brought my work to completion. Having no more work to do, even though I were to remain long, there is no other work than this to be done."

At that time, having spoken these words, the Blessed One exclaimed with strong feeling: "Excellent! Excellent! Śīlavat has repaid the kindness of the buddha well. You should make offerings at his relics and build a stūpa for him."

At that time, the great assembly was deeply grieved, and with tears streaming down their faces, they carried out the word of the Blessed One: they cremated his bones with fragrant wood and butter. As the bones of the virtuous Śīlavat burned, a great radiance burst forth from within the fire, and eighteen kinds of miraculous display appeared openly. Water streamed from the upper part of his body while fire blazed from the lower; fire blazed from the right armpit while water streamed from the left. He transformed from small to great and from great to small, filling the entire sky completely. At that moment, countless members of the assembly, along with non-Buddhist beings holding wrong views, aroused the awakening mind and entered into right view. Having displayed these miracles openly, Śīlavat re-entered the fire. After the cremation, the great assembly gathered the relics, built a stūpa, and made offerings there.

This concludes the chapter on the venerable Kauṇḍinya from the Sūtra of the Great Nirvāṇa of the noble ones.

At that time, the Blessed One spoke these words to Ānanda and the great assembly: "After I have passed into nirvāṇa, you four assemblies should strive to uphold and preserve this teaching of the great nirvāṇa. I have accomplished this Dharma-text of nirvāṇa, which is supremely difficult to obtain, through countless immeasurable eons, and I am now setting it forth. You should understand it to be so. This Dharma-text of the great nirvāṇa is the imperishable vajra-treasury of precious jewels of all the buddhas dwelling in

the ten directions throughout the three times; it is permanent, blissful, self, and perfectly pure — complete and undiminished. It is by passing into nirvāṇa by means of this that all buddhas pass into final nirvāṇa without remainder. All buddhas are said to 'pass into nirvāṇa' by relinquishing this present life. If you wish to repay the kindness of the buddhas in full, to swiftly attain awakening, to receive empowerment upon the crown of the head from the buddhas and to perfectly recall wherever you are born without forgetting, to have the buddhas of the ten directions come before you and protect you by day and by night, and to have all sentient beings attain the Dharma of transcending the world — then apply yourselves with diligence to this sūtra of nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One then spoke again to Ānanda: "Even before I had attained full awakening, I entered into the teaching of the non-Buddhist master Udraka Rāmaputra and studied the four meditative concentrations and the eight meditative absorptions, and I practised in accordance with his teaching. After I attained full awakening, I rejected his doctrine, and at the last I tamed Śīlavat and established him in the teaching of the Buddha. The great fire of the Tathāgata's primordial wisdom burned away the banner of wrong views — just as a dry leaf is placed into a great fire. Ānanda, I have profound affection for the Śākya clan, who are my own kindred. After I have passed into nirvāṇa, you should teach and expound the Dharma with diligence and excellence. Teach the noble Dharma to my attendants, so that they do not fall into frivolous and heedless conduct and activities, do not fall into practising doctrines of wrong view, and so that those who have not yet been liberated from the suffering of the three realms may swiftly be liberated. Generate profound fear toward the desire for the five polluted objects of sensual pleasure, and cultivate the perception of being without a protector. Reflect that a human body, once lost, is difficult to regain, that in this one life there must be care and vigilance, and that one should be fully liberated from the great demon of impermanence.

Generate compassion toward sentient beings, refrain from taking the life of any sentient being, and grant fearlessness even to the smallest creatures, down to insects. Through the complete purification of bodily karma, may you be born in a good world-realm; through the complete purification of verbal karma, may you become free from all the faults and flaws of wrongdoing. Do not eat flesh. Do not drink alcohol. Tame the snake of the mind and set it upon the path of awakening. Examine with great care the karmic actions of formations, knowing that the karmic maturation of virtue and non-virtue follows like a body's shadow. The fruits of the three times will not fail to come

around in full cycle. Demonstrate and urge earnestly that squandering this life leads to regret afterward that is of no use. The time of my passing into nirvāṇa has come, and these are the instructions I give to you.

At that moment, upon hearing the words spoken by the Blessed One, Ānanda's body and mind trembled and shook; he was utterly overwhelmed, pierced through with grief, unable to utter a sound, and he fell into such a state of confusion that he became as if dead before the presence of the Tathāgata.

Then the one who had never ceased spoke, rousing Ānanda with encouragement, dispelling his grief, and said these words: Do not grieve in this way. The time has come for the Tathāgata to pass into nirvāṇa. Though he dwells today, he will not dwell tomorrow. Ask now the four petitions just as I have spoken them to you. After the buddha passes into nirvāṇa: how the six groups of monks are to be dealt with as they disturb the household life of those given to desire and wickedness; how one is to dwell and abide together with them in accordance with the teaching; since it is the Teacher, the buddha, who teaches while the Tathāgata remains in the world, who is to do the teaching after the Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa; while the Tathāgata dwells in the world, those who rely and depend upon the Tathāgata — on whom are they to rely and depend after the passing into nirvāṇa; and after the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa and the collection of the scriptural Dharma is compiled, what is to be placed at the head of all the sūtras — ask these things.

At that time, in Ānanda's dream, hearing the words of the one who had never ceased — words like "Ask the four petitions" — he awoke from his torpor, and he asked the four petitions of the Blessed One.

The Blessed One then spoke to Ānanda: Why are you so unhappy and so grieved? The buddha has performed all the deeds of taming. By the very nature of reality, the departure is thus. Excellent! Excellent! Ānanda, you have asked these four petitions as a final innermost request, and they will bring benefit and happiness to all who dwell in the world. Therefore listen well and hold them firmly in mind. It is so.

"Yes, Blessed One," said Ānanda, and he listened again to the Blessed One.

The Blessed One then spoke to Ānanda: You asked as follows: after the buddha passes into nirvāṇa, what of the six groups of monks and those given to desire and wickedness who disturb the household life, and how are they to dwell together and abide in the teaching? Ānanda, monks who are given to desire and unsuitable by nature will, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, discipline

themselves and come to certainty, and they will also abandon their wicked minds. Ānanda, my younger brother Ānanda, though given to desire and unsuitable, was taught and corrected by the Tathāgata with skillful means, and the Tathāgata taught him the twelve links of dependent origination in accordance with the capacity of his faculties and wisdom. That is: conditioned by ignorance arise formations; conditioned by formations arises consciousness — and so on through aging and death, lamentation, and grief — all of it being the dense mass of ignorance and desire.

Through the suffering of formations one wanders in the three realms, cycling through the six classes of beings, and the root of all great suffering is ignorance. Thus, by examining with wisdom what is pure by its very nature, one cuts through the flaw of existence, which is ignorance. When the root is arrested, ignorance ceases. When ignorance ceases, formations cease — and so on through aging and death, lamentation, and grief, all of which cease as well.

Practicing in this correct way, the mind becomes settled and one enters meditative absorption (samādhi). By the power of meditative absorption one attains the first meditative concentration (dhyāna). Then, proceeding in sequence, one attains all four meditative concentrations and, sustaining that effort with a mind of correct and perfect mindfulness, one attains even the supreme fruit by oneself, and abandons entirely the suffering of the three realms.

Ānanda, at that time, if the monk Ānanda, with a thoroughly purified mind, applies diligent effort as I have taught, then without long delay he will attain the fruit of arhathood. Ānanda, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, you should teach what I have taught — in this very way — to the six groups of monks and to those given to desire, and those monks, with purified minds and relying on this pure and holy Dharma, will without long delay attain the supreme fruit.

Ānanda, therefore, from ignorance there has grown a great tree of wandering through the three realms. Carried by the wind of desire, tormented day and night for a long time by suffering, it revolves around the pillar of cyclic existence in the dark blackness, with the six branches of consciousness and the roots of distorted conceptuality, with waves of ignorance, and with mind and consciousness like boiling water running through the six sense-objects — seeds of suffering having been planted with no turning back. Just as a king is mighty and powerful, ignorance is like a lord and master that suppresses

moment by moment, so that sentient beings, without feeling it, spin in cyclic existence and continue to revolve without end.

Ānanda, all sentient beings, under the power of this ignorance, fall into the afflictions of desire and, crushed by the view of self, are enslaved by the eighty-four thousand afflictions as though by so many lords and masters, so that not even a single body becomes its own master.

Ānanda, when the suffering of ignorance is extinguished and the three realms are exhausted, that is what is called transcending the world.

Ānanda, whoever understands that the twelve links of dependent origination are ultimately without self and enters into the domain of perfect purity — that one will wholly abandon the great fire of the three realms.

Ānanda, the Tathāgata speaks truly, and these words addressed to you with true speech — you should attend to them well and with care.

Ānanda, you have asked: if the buddha passes into nirvāṇa and is no longer present in the world, who will be the Teacher? Ānanda, moral discipline is your great Teacher. Abide in it and apply yourself diligently, and you will attain the meditative absorption and wisdom that transcend the world.

Ānanda, you have asked: after the buddha passes into nirvāṇa, on what shall one abide and rely? Ānanda, abide in the four close placements of mindfulness (smṛtyupasthāna) and, having adorned the mind, remain there. Examine the body in accordance with body — and if one understands it to be like empty space, that is called the close placement of mindfulness on body in accordance with body. Bring mindfulness to bear on feeling in accordance with feeling — and if one understands that feeling does not abide outside, does not abide inside, and does not abide anywhere in between, that is called the close placement of mindfulness on feeling in accordance with feeling. Examine the mind in accordance with mind — and if one understands that mind is exhausted in being a mere name, and that even the name itself is absent, that is called the close placement of mindfulness on mind in accordance with mind.

Examine phenomena in accordance with phenomena — and if one does not apprehend them as virtuous phenomena and does not apprehend them as non-virtuous phenomena, that is called the close placement of mindfulness on phenomena in accordance with phenomena.

Ānanda, you ask: after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa and the treasury of Dharma has been compiled, what words are to be placed at the head of

every sūtra? Ānanda, after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa and the treasury of Dharma has been compiled, at the head of every sūtra place the words: "Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in a certain place together with a fourfold retinue, and taught this sūtra."

Then Ānanda again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Whether a buddha is present in the world or has passed into nirvāṇa, if a donor with faithful mind offers gold, silver, the seven precious substances, and many articles of enjoyment to the Tathāgata, how should such offerings be allocated?"

The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "If the Buddha is present in person, everything offered to the Buddha should be entrusted to the Saṅgha. If the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa and a donor with faithful mind has dedicated and offered everything to the Buddha, all such offerings should be used to make images of the Buddha, garments for the Buddha, banners and parasols of the seven precious substances adorned with lamps, and jeweled flowers purchased as offerings to the Buddha. Apart from making offerings to the Buddha, they may not be used for anything else. If they are used otherwise, that constitutes the theft of what belongs to the Buddha."

Ānanda then asked: "Blessed One, when the Buddha is present — if a certain person with faithful mind, with reverence, pays homage and makes offerings, presenting gold, silver, the seven precious substances, a mansion, sons, a wife, servants, clothing, food, and every article of comfort — and then the Tathāgata passes into nirvāṇa, and another person with faithful mind, with reverence, pays homage and makes offerings by presenting gold, silver, the seven precious substances, sons, a wife, servants, clothing, food, and every article of comfort to an image of the Tathāgata — Blessed One, between these two persons who make offerings with faithful minds in this way, which one acquires the greater merit?"

The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "Between these two persons who make offerings in this way with faithful minds, there is no difference in merit acquired. Why is that? Because even though the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, the dharmakāya is permanent; therefore, when offerings are made with faithful minds, the merit is equal and there is no difference."

Ānanda then asked: "Blessed One, if, while the Buddha is present in person, a certain person with faithful mind makes offerings with reverence in the manner described above — and after the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa,

another person with faithful mind and with reverence makes offerings to the bodily relics of the Buddha in the manner described above — Blessed One, which of these two persons acquires the greater merit?"

The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "The merit of these two persons is equal and there is no difference. Their merit is immeasurable and incalculable in its breadth, and it is inexhaustible until the very end of suffering has been reached."

Ānanda then asked: "Blessed One, if, while the Buddha is present in person, a certain person with faithful mind makes offerings to the Tathāgata using all the aforementioned articles of offering — and after the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa —"

"If, however, a certain person were to make offerings with faithful mind and with reverence to half of the Tathāgata's relics after the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa — Blessed One, which of these two persons acquires the greater merit?" The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "If these two persons make offerings with faithful mind, there is no difference in their merit; the accumulation of merit is immeasurable and incalculable."

"Ānanda, if a certain person with faithful mind, with reverence and with service, were to make offerings and praises to even a quarter of the Tathāgata's relics, or an eighth, or a sixteenth, or a hundredth part, or a thousandth part, or a ten-thousandth part, or even a portion as small as one grain of sand from the Ganges — down to something as tiny as a single mustard seed — worshipping with reverence and service; and if another person were to make offerings with reverence to the Buddha present in person — the merit of these two persons is, in every respect, equal and without distinction: immeasurable and incalculable."

"Ānanda, whether the Buddha is present in person or has passed into nirvāṇa — whoever bows with reverence and faithful mind, holds him as supreme, honors him, and praises him — it should be understood that the merit these two persons obtain is not twofold and not separate: it is without distinction."

"The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda and to the great assembly: 'After I have passed into nirvāṇa, if any sentient being in the heavens above or in the human world receives my relics in hand, and with grief and joy together bows in reverence and makes offerings with faithful mind, that person will obtain merit immeasurable and incalculable.'

"Ānanda, whoever sees the Tathāgata's relics — that person sees the Buddha. Whoever sees the Buddha sees the Dharma. Whoever sees the Dharma sees the Saṅgha. Whoever sees the Saṅgha sees nirvāṇa. Ānanda, for this reason it should be understood that the Three Jewels are permanent, stable, unchanging, and unaltering, and that they are the protector and refuge of all sentient beings."

Ānanda then asked the Blessed One: "Blessed One, after you have passed into complete nirvāṇa, by what ritual procedure should we enter into the body of the Tathāgata and thereby obtain the relics, so that we may make offerings with faith?"

The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "After I have passed into nirvāṇa, you should cremate the body according to the method used for a wheel-turning king (cakravartin)."

Ānanda then asked again: "What is the ritual procedure for cremating a wheel-turning king?"

The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "When a wheel-turning king has died, the body is laid out for seven days, and then placed inside an iron casket. Once placed in the casket, the casket is filled with sesame oil and the lid is tightly sealed, and it is kept thus for another seven days. It is then removed from the casket and bathed with perfumed water. After bathing with perfumed water, it is honoured and fumigated with fragrant incense, and the whole body is wrapped in cotton wool. Over the wrapping of cotton wool, it is wrapped in layers of a thousand bolts of fine white cloth from end to end. Having been thus wrapped, the body is placed back into a casket filled with sesame oil — the royal remains are placed inside the casket once more, and the casket is tightly sealed. It is then carried upon a precious chariot of oiled and fragrant wood adorned with the seven precious substances, and the sides and base of the chariot are hung with decorative banners, and the chariot is further ornamented with various precious jewels. Countless flowers, pennants, parasols of the seven precious substances, victory banners, various fine incenses,"

accompanied by divine music, making offerings all around. Then the bones of the wheel-turning king are cremated upon fragrant wood adorned inside and out with painted designs, together with oil-soaked wood. After the cremation, the relics are gathered together. At the four cardinal points of a great city, a stūpa of the seven precious substances with four gateways is erected, and the

relics are placed within it, so that all who dwell in the world may approach and behold it with rejoicing.

Ānanda, a wheel-turning king obtains the status of a king by virtue of a little merit, yet he is not free from cyclic existence. He is endowed with the five objects of desire. He has queens and palace retinues. He possesses evil views and the three poisons. He has not abandoned so much as a hair-tip of afflictions and utterly defiling tendencies. Yet when such a one dies and the world performs these funeral rites, erects a stūpa, and all rejoice and venerate it — how much more so, then, a Tathāgata. For throughout incalculable, boundless, immeasurable, and innumerable eons, he has completely relinquished queens and palace retinues and the five objects of desire; he has understood the dharmas of the world to be like hailstones or dew; he has sought out the most arduous austerities and practiced what is most difficult to practice; all bodhisattvas have practiced the transcendent austerities that go beyond the world; and he has accomplished without any omission the pure moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the wisdom of liberation as practiced by all buddhas dwelling in the ten directions throughout the three times. Moreover, he has brought to perfection the six perfections. And beyond this, he has accomplished the Tathāgata's ten powers, great compassion, the four fearlessnesses, the three gateways of liberation, the eighteen emptinesses, the six direct knowledges, the five eyes, the thirty-seven factors of awakening, the eighteen unshared qualities, the thirty-two major marks, the eighty excellent minor features, the lifespan of all buddhas, the complete purification of all buddha fields, the complete ripening of all sentient beings, all arduous practices, the moral discipline of gathering virtue, the moral discipline of benefiting sentient beings, the moral discipline of restraint, all excellent qualities, all wisdom, all adornments, all great aspirational prayers, all skillful means — and thus all inconceivable accumulations of merit and wisdom have been spontaneously and perfectly fulfilled. All non-virtue has been utterly severed. All afflictions have been utterly severed. All habitual tendencies of afflictions have been utterly severed. Deeply penetrating the Four Noble Truths and the twelve links of dependent origination, he subdued the four māras beneath the tree of awakening, and, having become the wisdom of omniscience, having thus striven diligently in all these supreme Dharmas, all buddhas declared with one voice "Excellent! Excellent!" and, in accord with the wisdom of the nature of reality, performed the consecration by pouring the water of the dharmakāya

upon his crown, and proclaimed that he had fully and perfectly awakened to the utterly unsurpassable, true, and complete awakening.

Therefore I am now the Teacher of gods and humans, fully awakened in all ten directions, consummate, the Blessed One, peerless among gods and humans. Regarding all sentient beings as Rāhu regards the moon, the Tathāgata — perfectly and completely awakened, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, the unsurpassed one, the tamer and guide of persons, the Teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One — performing all acts of compassion for the world, when he passes into nirvāṇa for the sake of sentient beings,

just as a wheel-turning king (cakravartin) is venerated by all sentient beings in accordance with the ways of the world, so should you cause all sentient beings to render veneration. Ānanda, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, let my body rest for seven days, as would a wheel-turning king's, and first place it into an iron casket. Once it has been placed in the iron casket, fill it well with sesame oil and seal the lid tightly. Adorn and ornament the casket richly with the seven precious substances, and offer veneration all around the casket with victory banners of precious gems, with incense, and with flowers. Having venerated in this way for seven days, take the body out of the casket and wash it well with scented water. After thus bathing the Tathāgata's body with scented water, wrap it fully in cotton wool. Over that, wind it with a thousand bolts of priceless white cloth. Having wrapped it thus, place it again in the iron casket, fill it with sesame oil, and seal the lid tightly. Then, place it upon a carriage made of the seven precious substances, together with Goghīrṣa sandalwood, aloeswood, and all manner of fragrant woods. Adorned with every jewel, carry it to the place of cremation. Offer veneration with innumerable jeweled victory banners, innumerable jeweled parasols, innumerable jeweled garments, innumerable divine musical instruments, and innumerable flowers and incense filling the very sky, and weep. Let all the gods, humans, and the entire fourfold retinue weep and cremate my body with fragrant sandalwood, aloeswood, and sesame oil. After the cremation, let the gods, humans, and the fourfold retinue collect the relics and place them in vessels of the seven precious substances. At the four crossroads of the great city, build a stūpa of the seven precious substances. By venerating the relics, sentient beings will gain great merit, abandon the suffering of the three modes of existence, and attain the bliss of passing beyond sorrow into nirvāṇa. Ānanda, after the fourfold retinue has built a stūpa of the seven precious substances for the

relics of the Buddha's body, they should also build three further stūpas. What are these? A stūpa for a pratyekabuddha, a stūpa for an arhat, and a stūpa for a wheel-turning king — so that all beings in the world, together with gods, may know the objects to which they may go for refuge.

Ānanda then asked: Blessed One, the Tathāgata came into the world out of compassion for sentient beings, proclaiming throughout the three realms the ten powers, great compassion, the four fearlessnesses, the twelve links of dependent origination, the Four Noble Truths, the three doors of liberation, and the eight tones of Brahmā's voice. Through the light of loving-kindness endowed with five colors, he caused the six pathways of transmigration to blaze with illumination. In accordance with the aspirations of sentient beings, some came to practice the four fruits and the two vehicles; some attained the awakening of a pratyekabuddha, undefiled and unconditioned; some were possessed and permeated by the awakening of the non-cessation and non-arising; some attained immeasurable dhāraṇīs; some attained the five divine eyes and the six kinds of higher knowledge; some were liberated from the three lower realms; some were freed from the eight unfree states; and some, whether gods or humans, were freed from the suffering of the three worlds. Through the utterly pure force of the Tathāgata's loving-kindness and the inconceivable principle of the Tathāgata's teaching of liberation, all beings in the world together with gods, up until their passing into nirvāṇa,

would build a stūpa of the seven precious substances and make offerings to the relics, thereby obtaining great merit. Ordinary persons would be liberated from the suffering of the three realms and would enter into true and complete liberation. Therefore, now that the buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, it is fitting that all in the world — gods, humans, and the fourfold retinue — should build a stūpa of the seven precious substances and make offerings to the relics, in order to honor the great kindness the buddha has shown and to follow in his wake of boundless loving-kindness. But, Blessed One, since you have built the three kinds of stūpas and thereby brought benefit to sentient beings, what further benefit is there in building stūpas and making offerings?" The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "A pratyekabuddha, having realized the profoundly deep Dharma of dependent origination, is fully liberated from all of existence; having shed every fault and flaw, he becomes a field of merit for gods and humans. Therefore, by building a stūpa and making offerings to it, one obtains merit. This is so because, second only to the Tathāgata, he causes many beings to attain the supreme fruit. Ānanda, an arhat has exhausted the

tendency toward rebirth, will not take up a subsequent existence, and has completely fulfilled the holy life; he becomes a field of merit for the world. Therefore, by building a stūpa and making offerings to it, the merit obtained — ranking just below that for a pratyekabuddha — is also great, and he too leads beings to liberation. Ānanda, a wheel-turning king, though not yet fully liberated from the afflictions of the three realms, nonetheless, through the force of merit, holds dominion over the four continents; by establishing beings in existence through the ten virtuous actions, he is an object of veneration for those beings. Therefore, by the fourfold retinue building a stūpa and making offerings, they will obtain immeasurable merit."

Ānanda then asked: "Blessed One, after the buddha has passed into nirvāṇa and we, the fourfold retinue, have bathed and laid to rest the body of the Tathāgata, where shall we obtain the relics of the Tathāgata? May the Blessed One instruct us." The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "After the buddha passes into nirvāṇa, if the fourfold retinue were to perform the cremation within the city of Kuśinagara, the people of that city would incur boundless royal penalties and disputes, and none would equally obtain the merit. Ānanda, if the fourfold retinue performs the cremation outside the city, then people of the world will equally obtain the merit."

Ānanda asked: "Blessed One, after the buddha has passed into nirvāṇa and the cremation has taken place, may the Blessed One instruct us: when the fourfold retinue has gathered the relics and placed them in a precious vessel, and a stūpa of the seven precious substances is erected wherever it may be, will all people generate faith and come to make offerings?" The Blessed One declared to Ānanda: "After the buddha passes into nirvāṇa and the cremation is complete, the fourfold retinue shall gather the relics, place them in a vessel of the seven precious substances, and within the city of Kuśinagara, at a crossroads, erect a stūpa of the seven precious substances with thirteen tiered levels, fitted with parasols, adorned and ornamented with all precious things, magnificently arrayed with victory banners to be exalted by all in the world, with steps on each of its four sides likewise fashioned of the seven precious substances, the whole supremely adorned with ornaments. That stūpa shall have one door opened on each of its four sides simultaneously; within the shaft of downward-falling light, a great precious vessel shall be set, and the fourfold retinue shall make offerings there. Ānanda, a pratyekabuddha's stūpa shall have eleven tiered levels and be adorned with various precious substances."

Ānanda, an arhat's stūpa shall have four tiered levels and shall likewise be adorned with various precious substances.

Ānanda, a wheel-turning king's stūpa shall be fashioned from the seven precious substances, yet without tiered levels. Why is that? Because he has not been liberated from the suffering of existence in the three realms.

At that time Māagalyāyana spoke to the Blessed One and said: "When the Buddha has entered nirvāṇa, how shall the relics of the Tathāgata be divided among gods, humans, and the fourfold retinue, so that all may make offerings?"

Then the Blessed One declared to Māagalyāyana: "After I have passed into nirvāṇa, gods, humans, and the rest shall gather the relics of the Buddha and, with a mind of perfect equanimity, distribute them throughout all three realms and all six classes of beings, so that offerings may be made."

At that time Śakra, Lord of the Gods (Indra, king of the gods), addressed the Blessed One and said: "Blessed One, I request half of the Tathāgata's relics from the Tathāgata."

The Blessed One declared to Śakra, Lord of the Gods: "The Tathāgata looks upon all sentient beings as a mother lion looks upon her cub. Therefore, do not say that you desire half of the relics. Why is that? Because he acts with impartiality for the benefit of all sentient beings."

The Blessed One then declared to Śakra, Lord of the Gods: "I shall give you one right-side canine tooth. You shall erect a stūpa in the divine world and make offerings there, and you shall thereby obtain merit that is inexhaustible and without end."

At that time all the gods and humans cried out with lamentation and wept.

Then the Blessed One declared to the fourfold retinue: "You gods, humans, and the rest — do not grieve at the passing of the Buddha into nirvāṇa. Why is that? Even though the Buddha passes fully into nirvāṇa, the relics are there always to be venerated. Moreover, the unsurpassed precious Dharma — the sūtras, the Vinaya, and the Abhidharma — shall remain. Therefore the Three Jewels and the Four Noble Truths shall always abide in the world, and there shall be objects through which sentient beings of faith may make offerings. Why is that? To make offerings to the relics is to make offerings to the Buddha Jewel. One who sees the Buddha sees the dharmakāya. One who sees the Dharma sees the noble one. One who sees the noble one sees the Four Noble

Truths. One who sees the Four Noble Truths sees the passing beyond sorrow. Therefore know that the Three Jewels are permanent, abiding, unchanging, and immutable — they are and shall remain the support and refuge of the world."

The Blessed One then declared to the great assembly: "Do not give way to great grief and torment yourselves with sorrow. I am about to pass into nirvāṇa. If any of you have doubt regarding moral discipline, or the place of practice, or permanence, or impermanence, or the Three Jewels, or the Four Noble Truths, or the six perfections, or the twelve links of dependent origination, ask now and quickly. This is the final opportunity to ask. After the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, let there be no regret." He declared this three times.

At that time the fourfold retinue and all the others were stricken with grief. They wailed aloud, and their hearts were overcome with despair and sorrow. Through the blessing of the Buddha they shed tears, yet they did not speak a word and asked nothing at all. Why was that? Because all those in the fourfold retinue had directly realized moral discipline, the place of practice, the Three Jewels, and the Four Noble Truths, and had become free from all doubt.

At that time, the Blessed One knew with his mind that the fourfold retinue had no doubt, and he declared: "Excellent! Most excellent! You of the fourfold retinue have thoroughly realized the Three Jewels and the Four Noble Truths and are free from all doubt — just as one who has been washed clean of stain by water and fragrance. Now you too must strive with diligence and attain the path of swift liberation. Do not grieve with mere faintness of heart."

At that time, the Blessed One, while seated upon the lion throne, took his golden-hued hand and, parting his robe, drew out the fringe of his lion's mane — radiant as refined gold — and displayed it to the great assembly. Then he declared to the many gods, humans, and all the gathered retinue: "Look upon my body, whose complexion is like refined gold."

This is the fifty-fifth fascicle of the Noble Great Discourse on Complete Nirvāṇa.

At that time all four assemblies of the retinue gazed upon the Tathāgata's body, whose complexion was like refined gold, looking with unblinking eyes. The bliss they experienced was like that of monks who have attained the third meditative concentration.

At that time the Blessed One, displaying his body of refined-gold complexion to the great assembly, emanated immeasurable, incalculable, boundless rays of light from his great nirvāṇa — eighty quadrillion in number — and illuminated all world-systems in the ten directions, so that even the light of the sun and moon was utterly eclipsed. Having thus spread his light, he declared to the great assembly:

"The Tathāgata, for your sake, over countless aeons practiced the most difficult of ascetic deeds, cutting off the very limbs of his body — his arms and his legs — and performing every kind of difficult practice. By the power of the aspirational prayer of great compassion, he appeared in this turbid world-realm and became fully and perfectly awakened in unsurpassable complete enlightenment. He attained this indestructible body, firm as vajra, of refined-gold complexion, endowed with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty minor marks of excellence, and he illuminated all directions with immeasurable rays of light. There is none who, merely upon being touched by those rays or upon beholding his form, has not been liberated."

The Blessed One then again declared to the great assembly: "For a buddha to appear in the world is exceedingly rare — like the udumbara flower, which is most rarely seen. You are now beholding my body for the last time. Do not let this pass without meaning. By the power of former aspirations I came to this turbid world-realm. Now, having completed the deeds of taming those to be tamed, I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — fix your gaze with single-pointed mind upon my body of refined-gold complexion. If you too apply yourselves with diligence to the most perfectly pure of actions, you will attain this same fruit."

At that time the Blessed One declared this again and again, three times in succession, and displayed his golden-hued body plainly and directly to the great assembly.

Then he rose from the lion throne of the seven precious substances and ascended into the sky above to the height of seven tāla trees, and again declared: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — look upon my body of refined-gold complexion." And so, gradually, ascending to the height of one further tāla tree at a time, he declared: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with utterly pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion." He declared this seven times in all.

Then he descended from the sky and was seated once more upon the lion throne, and again declared to the great retinue: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with utterly pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion."

Then the Blessed One rose again from the lion throne and ascended into the sky above to the height of one tāla tree, and declared to the great retinue: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion." And in the same way, ascending to the height of seven tāla trees, he declared seven times: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — look upon my body of refined-gold complexion."

Then he descended again from the sky, was seated upon the lion throne, and declared to the great retinue: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion."

Then the Blessed One rose once more from the lion throne, ascended into the sky above to the height of one tāla tree, and declared to the great retinue: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion." And again, ascending repeatedly to the height of seven tāla trees, he declared seven times: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion."

Then again he descended from the sky, was seated upon the lion throne, and declared once more to the great retinue: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa. You and all the gathered retinue — with pure intention, look upon my body of refined-gold complexion."

At that time the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, displayed his body of refined-gold complexion, showing it directly and plainly to the great retinue. And so, in order to show it to the great retinue face to face, he ascended three times to the height of seven tāla trees in the sky above, and three times descended again from the sky to be seated on the lion throne. In this way, repeatedly, he declared to the great retinue twenty-four times in all: "I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa — look upon my body that is firm and indestructible as a vajra, of refined-gold complexion, imperishable. Know this well, you and all the gathered retinue: it is exceedingly rare to behold, like the udumbara flower. I am soon to pass into nirvāṇa — you and all the gathered retinue, with

one-pointed mind, look intently upon my body of refined-gold complexion. Just as a person scorched by heat, intensely thirsty, who drinks cold water thinks of nothing else but being satisfied, so too are you and all the gathered retinue — with utterly pure intention, look intently upon me. This is the final time of seeing me within this life. After this seeing, there will be no further occasion to see me — therefore, you and all the gathered retinue, from this moment on, look your fill without regret."

Then the Blessed One again declared to the great retinue: "After I have passed into nirvāṇa, you and all the great retinue — in order to swiftly cross over the three existences, practice earnestly and extensively, and dwell in heedfulness without sloth."

At that time, in all world-realms, gods and humans and the fourfold retinue and all the rest were touched by the light of the passing into nirvāṇa, and all those who were gazing upon the Buddha were thereby entirely purified — without remainder — of the three lower destinies, the eight states without leisure, the afflictions of the gods and humans of the world, the four root downfalls, and all the blameworthy misdeeds of the five heinous acts, and they attained complete liberation.

At that time the Blessed One extended his body, resplendent as refined gold, and declared to the great retinue, "Behold it again and again." Then he drew the patchwork Dharma robe back over his body. This is the chapter on establishing the teaching, from the Great Sūtra of the Noble Complete Passing into Nirvāṇa.

The Blessed One then again declared to the great retinue: "My time has now come. All over my body there is pain and illness." Having so declared, he entered the first meditative concentration (dhyāna) and, surveying all world-realms with the light of passing into nirvāṇa, entered the meditative absorption of peaceful cessation.

At that moment, the instant the Blessed One had spoken, he entered the first meditative concentration. Arising from the first, he entered the second. Arising from the second, he entered the third. Arising from the third, he entered the fourth. Arising from the fourth, he entered the sense base of infinite space. Arising from the sense base of infinite space, he entered the sense base of infinite consciousness. Arising from the sense base of infinite consciousness, he entered the sense base of nothingness. Arising from the sense base of nothingness, he entered the sense base of

neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Arising from the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, he entered the meditative absorption of cessation and exhaustion.

Arising from the meditative absorption of cessation and exhaustion, he once again entered the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Arising from the sense base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, he once again entered the sense base of nothingness. Arising from the sense base of nothingness, he entered the sense base of infinite consciousness. Arising from the sense base of infinite consciousness, he entered the sense base of infinite space. Arising from the sense base of infinite space, he entered the fourth meditative concentration. Arising from the fourth, he entered the third. Arising from the third, he entered the second. Arising from the second, he entered the first.

At that time, having thus passed back and forth through the meditative concentrations, the Blessed One declared to the great retinue: "When I examine with my profoundly penetrating wisdom all sentient beings of the six classes throughout the three realms, and all living creatures dwelling in mountains, oceans, and the great earth, I find that these three realms are devoid of intrinsic nature, utterly at peace, and like space in their defining characteristic — they cannot be designated. There is no consciousness in them, all existence is completely severed, they are primordially equal, free of any perception of high or low, without seeing, without hearing, without feeling, without knowing, without bondage, without liberation, without sentient beings, without life, unborn, unarisen, inexhaustible, unceasing — neither the world nor what is not the world, with *nirvāṇa* and *saṃsāra* nowhere to be apprehended. Both extremes being equal is because all phenomena are equal. Abiding at the final limit, doing nothing at all, ultimately settled, with nothing whatsoever to be determined — performing the function of the defining characteristic of phenomena from among non-abiding phenomena, all marks completely severed and utterly without anything: these are the defining characteristics of phenomena. Whoever understands in this way is said to have passed beyond the world. Whoever does not understand in this way is called the beginning-edge of *saṃsāra*. Therefore, cut off ignorance completely — you and all the rest — and sever the beginning-edge of *saṃsāra*."

At that time, having so declared, the Blessed One again entered the soaring meditative concentration.

Rising from the first meditative concentration, he entered the third. Rising from the third, he entered the sphere of infinite space. Rising from the sphere of infinite space, he entered the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Rising from the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, he entered the meditative absorption of the cessation of perception and feeling. Rising from the meditative absorption of the cessation, he entered once more the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. Rising from the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, he entered the sphere of infinite consciousness. Rising from the sphere of infinite consciousness, he entered the fourth meditative concentration. Rising from the fourth, he entered the third. Rising from the third, he entered the second. Rising from the second, he entered the first. Having thus entered the soaring meditative concentration, traversing up and down in this way, he again declared to the great assembly:

"When I examine, with great wisdom, all beings and all phenomena — animate and inanimate, persons and dharmas — dwelling throughout the three realms, I find them utterly consummated: without binding, without liberation, without owner, without abode, without anything to grasp; neither transcending the three realms nor entering into any form of existence; pure from the very beginning, stainless, unafflicted, equal to space, beyond equality and inequality alike; thought and conceptuality exhausted, all conceptual proliferation stilled. Such is the defining characteristic of phenomena, and it is called great nirvāṇa. To see this Dharma exactly as it truly is, is called liberation. Because ordinary, lowly beings do not see it, it is called ignorance."

Having so declared, he again entered the soaring meditative concentration, and from the first meditative concentration up through the meditative absorption of the cessation of perception and feeling, and from the meditative absorption of the cessation back down to the first meditative concentration, he traversed thus up and down throughout. Then he again declared to the great assembly:

"When I examine all phenomena of the three realms with the eye of a buddha, the beginning-edge of ignorance is, by its very nature, liberated: it cannot be found when sought in all ten directions, because it has no intrinsic nature. The branches and leaves that would serve as its cause are likewise liberated. Because ignorance is liberated, old age and death are liberated as well. Therefore, since I abide perpetually in the appearance of perfect peace, this is called great nirvāṇa."

At that time, Ānanda, stricken with grief and utterly overwhelmed, was beside himself and unaware — like one intoxicated with wine. He could not see or recognize the fourfold retinue, and he did not know or understand whether the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa or had not passed into nirvāṇa.

At that time the Blessed One, having in this way entered the soaring meditative concentration three times and examined to the very depth of the dharmadhātu, taught the Dharma three times to the great assembly. In like manner, the Tathāgata entered into meditative concentration again and again, up to twenty-seven times in all. Ānanda, not understanding, each time the buddha entered concentration would ask once whether the buddha had passed into nirvāṇa or had not, and in this way he asked without ceasing up to twenty-seven times. And equally without ceasing, the Tathāgata, entering concentration, replied twenty-seven times that he had not passed into nirvāṇa. At that time all those in the assembly were utterly confused and bewildered.

They did not know or understand whether the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa or had not. At that time the Blessed One, having entered meditative concentration three times in succession, taught the Dharma to the assembly three times in succession. Then he lay down on his right side upon a throne of seven precious substances, with his head pointing toward the north, his feet toward the south, his face turned to look toward the west, and his back toward the east. The throne of seven precious substances was adorned throughout with garlands of every variety.

There were four pairs of śāla trees, eight trees in all. The pair to the west stood before the Tathāgata; the pair to the east stood behind the Tathāgata; the pair to the north stood at the Tathāgata's head; and the pair to the south stood at the Tathāgata's feet.

At that time the Blessed One, lying upon the precious throne at the foot of the śāla trees, entered the fourth meditative concentration and, speaking not a word, passed completely into nirvāṇa at midnight.

After the Blessed One, the Bhagavān, had passed into nirvāṇa, the two pairs of śāla trees to the east and west merged into a single tree, and the two pairs to the south and north likewise merged into a single tree, forming together a canopy like a parasol over the precious throne. At that very moment those same trees turned white as the wings of a crane. Their branches, leaves, blossoms, and fruit all fell away; their bark peeled off; the wood itself cracked, and gradually withered until it broke apart entirely, leaving nothing behind.

At that time the innumerable world-realms in all ten directions, countless as the sands of the Ganges in number multiplied by ten million, shook with great violence, and a vast variety of mighty sounds arose. Among them came the cry of lamentation — "Alas! Alas! The world is empty!" — together with sounds of impermanence, of suffering, and of wailing grief.

At that time, throughout all the world-realms in the ten directions, every mountain — the minor surrounding ranges and the great surrounding ranges, the lesser encircling mountains and the great encircling mountains, Mount Meru, the fragrant mountains, the jeweled mountains, the vajra mountains, the black mountains, and all the mountains that rest upon the great earth — all, in a single moment, let out a great sound and crumbled together. The great sound that resounded through the world-realms was the cry, "Alas! Alas! In a single instant the world has been left without a protector! The sun of wisdom has set, and the great mountain of nirvāṇa has toppled!" And it was proclaimed: "The true father of loving-kindness for all sentient beings has departed; the deity worthy of worship and offering is no longer to be seen."

At that time all the great oceans in every world-realm in the ten directions churned and boiled and became turbid, and from the force of the great surging waves diverse sounds arose and resounded: "Alas! Alas! Now that the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha has passed away, the sins and the suffering of sentient beings, the unwholesome acts, will swirl and pour down into the vast ocean of existence. Having lost the true path, when shall liberation ever come?" — so it was proclaimed.

At that time all the rivers and streams, cascades and valleys, rivulets and springs, ponds and marshes and wells overflowed and then ran dry.

At that time the great earth and the expanse of the sky in all the world-realms of the ten directions became utterly dark, and the light of the sun and moon ceased to appear, so that all the world-realms were plunged into darkness. Immediately thereafter a black wind stirred and gave forth a great sound, churning up dust and sand.

At that time all the blossoms, fruits, leaves, and branches of every forest tree, grove, and herb-plant that grows from the great earth fell to the ground and broke apart, leaving not even a remnant behind.

Then, immediately thereafter, all the gods of the world-realms of the ten directions wept with profound grief in the expanse of the sky above. The great

trichiliocosm shook violently, and divine flowers of many kinds along with divine incenses beyond count — hundreds and thousands of them — rained down and were heaped up in the great trichiliocosm to the height of Mount Meru (Sumeru), and thus an offering was made to the Tathāgata. Furthermore, in the sky above, countless divine victory banners, divine pennants, divine garlands, divine parasols, and divine precious jewels rained down in such abundance that the expanse of the sky was completely filled. They formed into a many-storied palace of jewels, its four sides beautifully adorned with garlands of the seven precious substances, radiant with the light of flowers, and thus an offering was made to the Tathāgata. In the sky above there also arose divine musical drums, and many forms of divine dance and song, and this cry rang out: "Alas, alas! The buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, and the world is emptied. Since the eyes of sentient beings are blind, the witch of affliction flourishes, and because the stream of the formations of suffering flows without ceasing, it is proclaimed that the wheel of cyclic existence turns on and on."

At that time Ānanda's mind was overwhelmed and he fell into a swoon, unable to comprehend whether the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa or had not passed into nirvāṇa. Seeing only that the condition of the world-realm had changed from what it was before, he asked Aniruddha without pause: "Has the buddha passed into nirvāṇa?" Aniruddha replied: "The buddha, the Blessed One, has completely passed into nirvāṇa."

At that time, when Ānanda heard these words spoken, he fell to the ground in a faint, becoming like a corpse, his breath no longer moving, feeling nothing at all. Then Aniruddha sprinkled cold water on Ānanda's face and revived him. Then, with words of skillful means, arousing his courage, he again spoke to Ānanda thus: "Alas, alas, how sorrowful. Do not grieve greatly. The Tathāgata, having completed all the deeds of taming, and though besought by all the gods, humans, and the rest to remain, did not consent to do so. Do not let your mind be disturbed by excessive grief. Alas, alas, what is to be done? What is now to be done? In a single night, the Teacher of gods and humans reached the end of his work and did not consent to remain." Having aroused his spirit thus, he spoke further to Ānanda: "Although the buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, nonetheless the relics and the supreme precious Dharma Jewel remain forever in the world as a support and refuge for sentient beings. Therefore let us diligently present the precious Dharma of the buddha to sentient beings and liberate them from suffering — this is how we shall repay

the kindness of the buddha." When Ānanda heard these words of encouragement, he recovered his breath with a sigh, shed a stream of tears, and was overcome by grief.

At that time, within the city of Kuśinagara, in the Śāla grove all around for a distance of twelve yojanas, gods and humans filled every space, so many sentient beings were present that not even the point of a needle could fit between them, yet not one was uncomfortable and none pressed upon another.

At that time countless hundreds of thousands of myriads of bodhisattvas and all the great assembly, their minds overwhelmed, fell into a faint. Not comprehending whether the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa or not, but seeing only that the earth shook and trembled in a manner unlike anything before, they all asked Aniruddha: "Has the buddha passed into nirvāṇa?" Then Aniruddha, together with the great assembly,

announced to all the gods and humans of the world: "The buddha, the Blessed One, has passed utterly into nirvāṇa."

When the entire innumerable retinue heard those words, they all fainted and fell to the ground. Tormented by suffering so intense that no voice could leave their throats, some collapsed lifeless at the feet of the buddha. Some lost their minds. Some felt their bodies and minds burn as if on fire. Some clasped one another's hands and, barely able to cry out, wept with tears streaming down their faces. Some beat their chests with their fists and wailed aloud with great cries. Some struck their heads with their open palms and tore at their own hair. Some cried out: "Alas, alas, we are tormented by suffering!" Some said: "The Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa far, far too soon." Some said: "We have lost our god." Some said: "The world is empty — the eye of sentient beings is blinded." Some said: "The demoness of affliction has now come into the open." Some said: "The sprouts and seeds of virtue in sentient beings are cut off." Some said: "The hosts of Māra rejoice and have even shed their armor." Some lamented: "This body of mine is impermanent." Some, through the practice of righteous conduct, were thereby liberated. Some said: "We are now without protector or refuge." And some saw blood well up from their bodies and flow down to the ground.

At that time a great sound of many different cries shook every world-realm in all directions. Then the great Brahmā king (Skt. Brahmārāja), lord of the world-realm of Akaniṣṭha, understanding that the buddha had passed utterly

into nirvāṇa, descended together with his divine retinue from the first dhyāna, wept with a great cry, fell into a faint before the Tathāgata, and collapsed upon the ground. After a long while he revived and, weeping in verse before the buddha, spoke thus:

By the power of former aspirations, the Blessed One
came to this world of Akaniṣṭha for our sake,
armed with the might to tame countless beings,
subduing wanderers who longed for Dharma yet were destitute.

With skillful means of wisdom he taught the Dharma as was fitting,
so that not a single sentient being came to grief.
He drew beings out from the suffering of the three existences
and set them on the path that leads at last to nirvāṇa.

The Blessed One was a loving mother to sentient beings,
pouring forth the milk of tender compassion upon them all.
Now, having abandoned everything at once,
you have left gods and humans destitute, without a protector.

Alas! The time when the rain of birth could fall
upon the sprouts of virtue in wandering beings is no more.
The sprouts of virtue, suddenly cut off —
gathered up by evil karma, they now proceed to lower rebirths.

The world is empty. What shall we do now?
Sentient beings are blinded, their eye of true wisdom gone.
Wandering, confused in the darkness of ignorance,
they fall and circle through the three existences.

Wretched sentient beings, without protector — what shall we do?
May they find liberation through reliance upon the relics!
Through the power of compassion in our prayer to the Tathāgata,
may they find refuge, freed from suffering!

Alas, how could you, the Blessed One, abandon us
and pass into nirvāṇa in this base and wretched world?

Then Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, descended together with his retinue from the sky above, raised a great cry of "Alas, alas!", wept with tears flowing down his face, fell into a faint before the Tathāgata, and collapsed upon the ground. After a long while he too revived at last, and with his mind tormented by grief, wept before the buddha in these verses:

Blessed One, the hardships you undertook across eons
were for the sake of us and all living beings.
Having attained unsurpassable awakening,
you nurtured every being as though each were your only child.

The gift of Dharma is the highest among all medicines;
the healer who cures disease is the greatest of physicians.
Sheltering all beneath the cloud of your great compassion,
you rained down the nectar of wisdom upon every one.

The sunlight of wisdom dispelled the darkness of ignorance,
and beings in ignorance beheld the noble path.
With the radiance of noble loving-kindness you illumined the six classes of
beings,
and those touched by that light were wholly freed from the three realms of
existence.

For what reason have you turned away your great and loving heart
and passed into nirvāṇa — how are we to bear not seeing you?
Where now is the great compassion of your former vow?
You have abandoned sentient beings as though they were mere spittle.

We and all sentient beings without exception —
like calves certain to die when forsaken by their mother —
each of the four assemblies clinging to one another's hands,
beat their breasts, and the sound of their weeping shook the three worlds.

Alas, alas! All of this, the entirety of cyclic existence,
has all at once been left without a refuge.
How sad we are, we whose merit is exhausted —
there is no longer a time of moisture to revive the tender shoot of virtue.

May the radiance of the sacred Dharma Jewel and the relics
illumine all and liberate beings from the three realms of existence!

Alas, how unbearable for us —
when will we ever see the Tathāgata again?

At that time Māgha (Indra's attendant) too, his mind tormented by grief, wept
until his very body trembled, and then, kneeling before the buddha, offered
praise in these verses:

The buddha, king of Dharma, has nurtured us well,
quenched our thirst for Dharma, and brought forth in us the dharmakāya.

Yet the dharmakāya of sentient beings is not yet fully realized,
and the assembly of those sustained by wisdom has not yet fully gathered.

You who proclaimed with a voice endowed with eight qualities,
causing those in your retinue who heard it to realize awakening —
you who ever radiate the light of great loving-kindness in five colors,
may those in your retinue, touched by that light, be wholly liberated!

Why, having fully passed into nirvāṇa, have you departed,
leaving sentient beings caught in suffering — what are they to do?
Alas, the Blessed One has relinquished great loving-kindness;
we have no protector, and we shall surely perish.

Though we would wish the Blessed One to teach us skillful means,
there is no remedy by which we can cease our grief.
The four assemblies are intoxicated, distraught, fallen senseless, their minds
lost;
the sound of their weeping stirs the heavens, the earth, and the three worlds.

O Blessed One, while you rest in great bliss as the sole one,
what is to become of the great suffering of the many beings?
Blessed One, in times gone by, for our sake,
across many eons you gave up your head, your hands, and your feet.
Having manifestly awakened to unsurpassable enlightenment,
you did not remain long but departed into nirvāṇa.

Because we four assemblies abide in the dense darkness of ignorance,
the king of māras rejoices and discards his armor in delight.

Alas, O Blessed One, through your great compassion,
may the loving light of the relics protect us!
For the sake of the four assemblies, out of your Blessed One's loving care,
may the sacred Dharma Jewel's benefit be inexhaustible!
May we not die right away —
yet with only this much of life remaining, what can we accomplish?

Alas, the suffering is utterly unbearable.
From this time forward, there will be no occasion to see the Blessed One again.
At that time, Nanda, having recovered from his faint —

slapped his palms against his head, struck his chest with his fists, cried out,
and wept with a body that could scarcely bear the suffering. Then he knelt

before the Blessed One and offered these verses of lamentation:

"In former times, by the power of a single shared aspiration with the Blessed One,

I was born in harmony into the Śākya clan.

After the Tathāgata had fully awakened to perfect awakening,

I served him as an attendant for more than twenty years.

While my heart was still unsated in serving with faith,

abandoning me in a single moment, he passes into perfect nirvāṇa.

Alas! Alas! I am tormented by great suffering.

For a long time this suffering will utterly wring my mind.

My own body is not yet free from the net of conditioned existence.

I have not yet emerged from the pit of the gateway of ignorance.

Without the Blessed One having broken open for me the gateway pit of ignorance,

why does he pass into perfect nirvāṇa?

I am like a newborn child,

and if the mother abandons it, it will surely die.

Why has the Blessed One utterly forsaken me,

crossing alone beyond the three realms, abiding in bliss?

What I now confess with remorse before the Blessed One is this:

in the twenty years of serving at his feet,

I fell under the power of laziness in the four modes of conduct,

and acted contrary to the noble mind, failing to bring him delight.

May the fully and perfectly awakened Buddha, through his great compassion, grant me the nectar of ambrosia and bring me to happiness.

May I, through all the aeons of future time to the very end,

always remain in the presence of the Blessed One.

May the Blessed One, through the rays of his great compassion,

protect me in every world-realm throughout all things.

Alas! Alas! Words cannot express it.

Even a voice to speak of the noble one's kindness falls short."

At that time, bodhisattvas as numerous as the sand grains of countless Ganges rivers, and all the gods and humans of the world, grasping one another's hands, wept deeply and cried out in lamentation. Then, rallying their spirits one by one as best they could, they offered up before the Blessed One countless divine incenses, divine flowers — mandārava flowers, great mandārava flowers, mañjūṣaka flowers, and great mañjūṣaka flowers — and

sandalwood from the shores of the ocean of the worlds of gods and humans beyond counting, and agaru, and compounded incenses of a hundredfold and thousandfold variety, and countless anointing perfumes, perfumed waters, jeweled parasols, jeweled victory banners, jeweled streamers, pearl garlands, and necklaces filling the entire expanse of the sky, presenting all of these as offerings before the Blessed One.

At that time all the men, women, boys, and girls of the city of Kuśinagara wept deeply, and one by one, mustering far more than before, prepared countless flowers, incenses, victory banners, parasols, and the like, and offered them before the Tathāgata.

At that time the four guardian lords of the four directions, together with their divine retinues, wept deeply, and each one prepared offerings of flowers, incenses, and all manner of offering substances — three times as many as before — and while still weeping approached before the Tathāgata and made offerings.

The gods of the five heavens of the desire realm likewise prepared offerings far surpassing those of before. The gods of the form realm and the formless realm also prepared offering substances far surpassing those of before and made offerings.

At that time the men and women dwelling in the city of Kuśinagara, with tears streaming down their faces, wept and —

not knowing how the funeral had been arranged before, they said this to Ānanda: "When the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, how are we to conduct the funeral?" Then Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra, king of heaven), said, as the Blessed One had declared before: "It should be done in the manner of a funeral for a wheel-turning king."

At that time all the people of the city of Kuśinagara wept, entered the city, and fashioned a casket of iron adorned with the seven precious substances. They also laid out a thousand bolts of fine, precious white cloth and countless lengths of exceedingly soft cotton. Beyond that, they set out countless pieces of sandalwood and aloe wood, together with offerings of compounded incense numbering up to a hundred thousand myriads, incense powders, liquid incense, parasols, banners, flowers, and the like — filling the sky like clouds, piled as high as Mount Meru — and having arranged all these things, with tears streaming down their faces they set them before the Tathāgata and, their hearts stricken with grief, made offerings.

At that time all the people of the city of Kuśinagara and the entire great assembly, their tears flowing as they wept, set out in the sky like clouds countless incenses, flowers, victory banners, parasols, and all manner of offering substances without measure, took hold of one another's hands, beat their chests with their fists, and their cries of lamentation caused even the great thousand-fold universe to tremble. They set these things before the Tathāgata and made offerings with all those offering substances.

At that time the great assembly wept, sobbing aloud, and then — wishing to pay the highest reverence — each person took fine white cloth stretchers and, lifting the Tathāgata's body, placed it within the iron casket. They filled the casket with melted butter until it was full, and sealed the lid.

Then all the men and women of the city of Kuśinagara, wishing for merit and wishing to partake in the Tathāgata's virtues, would not allow the Tathāgata's bier-casket to be borne by the gods or men or the great assembly alone; they deliberated together and had it lifted by four champions of unequalled and mighty strength. These four champions removed their garments and ornaments and came into the city to lift the Tathāgata's bier-casket, and after making offerings they strove with all their strength — but could not lift it.

Then eight great champions of that city attempted to lift the bier-casket, each removing their own garments and ornaments and making offerings, and they strained with all their strength — yet still could not lift it.

Then sixteen champions of that city attempted to lift it, and after removing their garments and ornaments they too strained with all the strength they had to lift the buddha's casket, but it could not be lifted.

At that time Mahākāśyapa said this to the champions: "Even if every man, woman, boy, and girl within this city were to try with all their effort to bear the Tathāgata's bier-casket into the city, they could not lift it — how much less could you alone? I ask that you join the strength of the great assembly and the gods together, and if you then lift the casket you will be able to carry it into the city."

The moment Mahākāśyapa finished speaking, Śakra, lord of the gods, arrayed a superb parasol of the seven precious substances along with countless flowers, incenses, victory banners, pennants, and divine music, and together with his divine retinue, weeping profusely, rose up from the sky and made offerings at the noble bier-casket. The gods of the six heavens of the desire

realm and the gods of the form realm likewise made offerings at the bier-casket, just as Śakra, lord of the gods, had done.

At that time, the Blessed One, pervading all with his compassion and acting so that all those within the world might equally share in merit without distinction, caused the bier-casket to rise up from the sal grove into the sky above, to the height of a single tāla tree, and then to pass on. Yet all the people of the city of Kuśinagara, and all the gods, humans, and the entire retinue within the world, were unable to lift the buddha's casket.

At that time, Śakra, lord of the gods, together with his divine retinue, fashioned a great parasol of the seven precious substances, adorned on its four sides with garlands of the seven precious substances, and furnished with four jeweled pillars. Covering the Tathāgata's casket with it from the sky above, they made offerings of countless incenses, flowers, victory banners, pennants, garlands, divine music, and many kinds of silk streamers up in the sky. The gods of the six heavens and the gods of the form realm likewise arrayed their offering implements in surpassing fashion, exceeding even what Śakra had done, and made offerings to the Tathāgata's bier-casket.

At that time, when all the people of the city of Kuśinagara saw the Tathāgata's bier-casket rise up into the sky above, they beat their chests, gave out great cries, and wept.

At that time, all the gods and humans, wishing to make offerings to the Tathāgata's bier-casket, filled the entire expanse of the sky until it was completely packed, like clouds, with the seven precious substances, pearls, flowers, incense, garlands, and many kinds of silk streamers. Weeping bitterly, they made offerings to the Tathāgata's bier-casket of the seven precious substances, and all together with one voice they cried out: "Woe! Woe! Because we lack merit, we were unable to lift the Tathāgata's bier-casket. We have no protector, no refuge. We have no share in the root of virtue."

At that time, the Blessed One's golden bier-casket glided softly through the sky above the sal grove and entered through the western gate of the city of Kuśinagara.

At that time, all the laywomen residing in the city of Kuśinagara, together with countless bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, gods, humans, and a great retinue, filling both the sky above and the ground below, followed along behind the Tathāgata's bier-casket. Grasping one another by the hand, they raised great cries, wept, beat their fists upon their chests, and each from their own place

arrayed countless flowers, incenses, jeweled victory banners, pennants, and parasols until both the ground and the sky were completely filled, making offerings to the Tathāgata's bier-casket. Each side of the city of Kuśinagara measured forty-eight yojanas.

At that time, the Tathāgata's bier-casket of the seven precious substances glided softly through the sky above, passed out through the eastern gate of the city of Kuśinagara, and circling to the right, entered through the southern gate of the city. From there it glided gently through the sky, circled to the right from the northern gate, and entered through the western gate. In this same manner it circled three times, then glided softly through the sky above, entered again through the western gate, came out through the eastern gate, circled to the right, and entered through the northern gate. From there again it glided gently through the sky, came out through the southern gate, circled to the right, entered through the northern gate, and circled four times. In this way it circled the city of Kuśinagara seven times in all, always to the right.

When the jeweled casket of seven precious substances entered the city, all the vast assembly wept, tears streaming down their faces, and each one took up countless fragrant sandalwood logs and precious incense-logs adorned with patterns and fragrance that filled every world-realm with their scent. They also arranged countless jeweled victory banners, pennants, parasols, incense, flowers, and garlands, and made offerings at the place where the Tathāgata's remains were laid.

At that time the four Great Protectors of the directions, together with their divine retinues, wept and came to the place where the remains were enshrined, bringing with them divine sandalwood and agaru wood whose fragrance pervaded inside and out, wholly and completely saturating all with their scent — five hundred logs each as thick as a chariot wheel — along with other precious incenses, jeweled victory banners, noble jeweled parasols, garlands of flowers, and the like, all arranged as offerings. The gods of the second heaven arrayed one thousand logs; the gods of the third heaven arrayed two thousand logs; the gods of the fourth heaven arrayed three thousand logs; the gods of the fifth heaven arrayed four thousand logs; the gods of the sixth heaven arrayed fully five thousand logs. Each of them, holding pennants and flowers and the like, came weeping to the place where the remains were enshrined, in order to make offerings.

At that time the gods of the form realm (rūpadhātu) and the gods of the formless realm (ārūpyadhātu) came to the place where the remains were enshrined carrying only incense and flowers, and there made their offerings.

Then the many beings of the world, each and every one, came weeping to the place where the remains lay, carrying fragrant sandalwood wood, agaru wood, flowers, incense, pennants, parasols, and the like, to make their offerings.

At that time, with eyes unceasingly brimming with tears, weeping intensely, the gods and humans raised up fully six thousand logs of sandalwood and agaru wood — all adorned with patterns and fragrance, utterly and completely saturated with scent — and placed them at the place of the remains.

Now, the cool lake Anavatapta has four sides, each two hundred leagues in breadth, and four great rivers flow down from it. At the time when the Blessed One first became perfectly and fully awakened, a sandalwood tree sprang up on the northern bank of the Ganges, its girth as thick as a chariot wheel, reaching into the sky to the height of seven tāla palms, and its fragrance — supremely rich and penetrating — served as an offering to the Tathāgata. The deity of that tree was born at the same moment as the tree itself and constantly made offering to all buddhas with that fragrance. When the Buddha passed into nirvāṇa, the sandalwood tree shed its leaves and bark, withered, and dried up, and the tree deity also died there. Then the other gods took that tree, carried it to the place where the remains lay, and made offerings with it.

That very place on the ground is the site of the remains of all buddhas of the three times, and the Buddha Blessed One, through the power of his former aspirations, had arranged to pass into nirvāṇa in that very place. There, too, are to be found countless jeweled reliquary stupas of the buddhas of former times. That place is indestructible and supremely firm, like a vajra.

Then the Tathāgata's casket glided gently through the sky and arrived at the place of the remains, and by degrees it descended lower and lower, coming to rest upon a throne of the seven precious substances adorned all round with cascading silk streamers and garlands. From then until that moment seven days had passed.

At that time all the men and women of the city of Kuśinagara, together with countless bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and all the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, their hearts tormented by grief, wept profusely —

— holding banners, parasols, jeweled victory banners, incense, flowers, and the like, and following behind the Buddha's casket for seven days. Yet by the blessing of the Buddha, not one of the gods or humans felt any sense of thirst or hunger; they had no thought of food, but wept without ceasing, remembering the Tathāgata.

When seven days had passed since the Tathāgata's remains had been thus laid to rest, and the body was raised up out of the casket, all the men and women of the city of Kuśinagara, together with the countless multitudes of the retinue, wept with such cries that even the world-realm was shaken. And further, with flowers, incense, divine victory banners, parasols, and countless divine musical offerings, they wept and made offerings to the Buddha's remains. At that time the great assembly, weeping, their tears flowing, wrapped their hands in fine soft white cloth and, with hearts full of reverence, gently lifted from the jeweled casket the body of the Tathāgata — adorned with the color of refined gold, endowed with the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks, indestructible in nature like a vajra — and placed it upon a throne of the seven precious substances. Then the great assembly wept so deeply that all the world-realms of the ten directions were shaken. And further they made offerings with incense, flowers, parasols, and music, and wept.

Then the great assembly, weeping, their tears streaming, each brought fragrant water and countless measures of perfumed unguent, and with these bathed from head to foot the body of the Tathāgata — endowed with the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks, bearing immeasurable accumulations of merit and wisdom, indestructible like a vajra, and golden in hue like refined gold. After that, the jeweled casket too was cleansed and purified. Then the great assembly, weeping profusely, their tears flowing, scattered divine incense and flowers of the seven precious substances, and filled the entire expanse of the sky with countless jeweled victory banners, parasols, and streamers in offering, and wept.

Then the great assembly, still weeping, took up countless layers of cotton wadding and wound them around the body of the Tathāgata, golden like refined gold. Over those wrappings of cotton wadding they then wound the body of the Tathāgata in a thousand bolts of priceless fine white cloth. Having wrapped it thus, the great assembly wept until they nearly fainted, and further made offerings with jeweled flowers, incense, jeweled victory banners, jeweled parasols, and divine music, and wept. Then the great assembly, weeping still, each brought strips of fine white cloth and together lifted the body of the

Tathāgata and placed it within the jeweled casket; they filled it with butter oil and sealed the lid of the casket. Then the weeping of the great assembly resounded throughout every world-realm, and further they made offerings to the jeweled casket with flowers, incense, streamers, parasols, and music, and wept.

Then the entire great assembly heaped up the fragrant, supremely fragrant sandalwood and incense-wood they had gathered until it rose like Mount Meru, and fashioning it into a tiered pyre like a multi-storied hall of incense, adorned on four sides with the seven precious substances and ornamented with parasols, victory banners, streamers, incense, flowers, garlands, and billowing silken pennants that filled the entire expanse of the sky like clouds, they made offering with divine music.

This is the Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa.

This is the fifty-sixth and final fascicle.

Then the gods, humans, and all the members of the retinue lifted the funeral casket and, as they placed it upon the tiered incense-wood pyre, they gave forth a great cry, beat their breasts, and wept with such a mighty sound of lamentation that it resounded and shook throughout a great thousandfold world system. Then, making further offering with precious victory banners, parasols, incense, flowers, and divine music, they wept.

After that, coming from every direction to pay their respects, they lifted the Tathāgata's funeral casket in white linen stretchers and set it upon the ornately adorned incense wood. There they recited the funeral rites and fell into a swoon. When they revived, they cried out: "Alas, alas — the world is left without a protector and without refuge!" And having said this, with tears streaming down their faces, they made offering with flowers, incense, precious victory banners, streamers, parasols, and divine music.

Then when the Tathāgata's funeral casket had been placed upon the incense wood and fire was applied, the entire vast multitude of the retinue wept intensely, and the sound resounded throughout a great thousandfold world system. Having wept, they made offering to the Tathāgata's funeral casket.

Then the great multitude of the retinue wept, and illuminating the world system with incense-lamp torches of the seven precious substances, each the size of a chariot wheel, they all cried out together with one great voice, causing the entire great thousandfold world system to tremble. They made

complete offering with flowers and incense.

At that time, as soon as those precious lamp torches arrived at the place where the incense wood had been stacked, they went out of themselves. Then all the gods, bearing supreme torches of the seven precious substances, illuminated everything with the light of their flames, and weeping as they approached the place where the incense wood had been stacked, those torches too went out of themselves as soon as they arrived. Then all the gods of the ocean, bearing fires from within the ocean — torch-lights of the seven precious substances endowed with countless rays — burned them at the stacked incense wood, and those fires too went out of themselves.

At that time the great multitude of the retinue wept bitterly and made every kind of offering, yet they could not understand why, despite exhausting every rite that had been performed for the Tathāgata, the fire had failed to catch on the incense wood.

At that time the Blessed One, out of great compassion pervading all, settled his attention upon the retinue of Kāśyapa and entered into absorption with the purity of the original ground. At that time Mahākāśyapa, together with five hundred companions, was stationed on Gṛdhrakūṭa — the Mountain of the Vulture's Heap. That mountain lies fifty leagues from the excellent city of Kuśinagara. There, while dwelling in a meditative absorption in which body and mind are supremely at peace, he was startled; his body too trembled and shook.

He then arose from that absorption and, looking out, saw the earth and mountains everywhere shaking violently. Knowing thereby that the Tathāgata had passed into nirvāṇa, he spoke these words to the retinue: "Seven days have now passed since my great Teacher passed completely into nirvāṇa. He has been placed within the casket. Alas, alas — let us go quickly to where the Tathāgata is! If we delay and go late, we shall not be able to behold the Tathāgata's body adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent minor features in their full purity."

Having said this, Kāśyapa, in order to pay his respects to the Blessed One, did not travel through the sky by means of supernatural power but instead took to the road together with his retinue, and went weeping rapidly toward the place where the Tathāgata lay. After seven days he arrived at the excellent city of Kuśinagara. At the eastern gate of the city he encountered a brahmin who was coming along carrying a divine flower. Kāśyapa asked him: "Friend, from

where have you come?"

The brahmin replied:

"I have come from the place where the Buddha entered nirvāṇa and was revered."

Kāśyapa asked him: "Where did you find these flowers?"

The brahmin replied: "I found these divine flowers at the place where the Buddha entered nirvāṇa and was revered."

Kāśyapa said: "Give those flowers to me."

The brahmin replied: "That would not be right. I am going to visit my relatives and offer them in worship at home."

Kāśyapa said: "Just let me look at them for a moment." He took them in his hands, and the very instant he placed them upon his head he fainted and fell to the ground. After a long while he revived, and weeping he said: "The Tathāgata's form, adorned with the eighty excellent minor features, like the color of refined gold — from this day forward I shall see it no more." Then, together with his retinue, he entered the northern gate of the excellent city of Kuśinagara, and going inside the city he came to a place where monks were staying, and he saw monks assembled there and gathered together. Those monks said to Kāśyapa: "You have come from a long road — you must be wearied and uncomfortable. Please sit at ease and take your meal here."

Kāśyapa replied: "My great Teacher has passed into nirvāṇa. What eagerness is there in me to sit at ease and remain for alms? Is that at all fitting?"

The monks said: "Who is your Teacher?"

Kāśyapa replied: "Do you not know? Alas! My Teacher is the Blessed One, the Buddha — and now he has passed fully into nirvāṇa."

Upon hearing these words, the monks each said among themselves: "Excellent! Excellent! When the Tathāgata dwelt in the world, we could not endure his strict moral discipline and were unable to practice accordingly. Now that he has passed into nirvāṇa, the restraint of our discipline will become relaxed. For now, in the short term, sit and remain for alms."

By the blessing of the Buddha, the gods and the members of Kāśyapa's retinue had their ears blocked so that they did not hear the words spoken by those corrupt monks — only Kāśyapa alone heard them. Then Kāśyapa, together with his retinue, weeping bitterly, went swiftly to where the Buddha lay.

At that time Kāśyapa and his retinue thought to themselves: "How shall we find offerings and worship the Buddha?" Kāśyapa said: "I was born in this city, and I believe that if I solicit offerings I will find them." So together with his retinue he went through that city soliciting, one by one. Having done so, he found a thousand bolts of fine white cloth, and beyond that he found countless bolts of cotton, immeasurable precious flowers, ointments, scented water, scented oil, victory banners of jewels, jeweled parasols, pennants, musical instruments, ornaments of various kinds, silk streamers, and the like.

Then Kāśyapa and his retinue, carrying all the offering articles they had found, swiftly came out through the western gate of the city. There Kāśyapa heard, from the place where the Buddha lay in nirvāṇa, the sound of the entire vast retinue weeping and wailing intensely, and heard everyone asking Śakra (Indra), the Mighty One, "Now that we are making offerings, from where shall we find fire to light the funeral pyre?" — and heard Śakra saying to the great assembly: "For now, you must wait for Kāśyapa." No sooner had he heard Śakra speak those words to the great assembly than the great Kāśyapa arrived there with his retinue, still weeping. The circles of the assembly parted to make way, and when Kāśyapa from a distance saw the coffin of the Buddha, he and his retinue prostrated, wept bitterly, cried out in lamentation, and fell unconscious.

After a long while he regained consciousness, drew close, and approached the coffin. He then spoke these words to the great assembly: "How am I to open the noble one's coffin?" The retinue replied: "It has now been three times seven days since the Blessed One passed into nirvāṇa. Surely by now the body has deteriorated — how could the coffin be opened?" Kāśyapa said: "The body of the Tathāgata is hard as a vajra, firm, permanent, blissful, utterly pure, and indestructible — it is like a mountain of sandalwood, wholly unlike the bodies of ordinary beings steeped in qualities of a contrary kind." Having said this, he wept bitterly and drew close to the Tathāgata's coffin.

At that moment, through the Tathāgata's great compassion equally pervading all beings, the lid of the coffin opened of itself for the sake of Kāśyapa, and the thousand layers of white cloth and cotton in which the body had been wrapped fell open of their own accord. The body, adorned with the thirty-two major marks and the eighty excellent features, with a complexion like refined gold, firm and steadfast, was revealed openly to Kāśyapa.

When Kāśyapa and his retinue saw this, they wept bitterly, fell unconscious, and collapsed to the ground. After a long while they came back to consciousness, and with eyes full of tears, Kāśyapa and his retinue climbed the pyre of fragrant wood that had been built up and drew very close to the coffin. They cried out in lamentation, then made offerings of flowers, incense, victory banners, parasols, pennants, garlands, music, and the like. They bathed the Tathāgata's body — radiant as refined gold — with ointment and scented water, fumigated it with incense, scattered flowers over it, wept, and performed the rites of veneration.

Having bathed it in this way, Kāśyapa and his retinue wrapped the Tathāgata's body in fresh cotton cloth that could be found, then over that wrapped it in old cotton cloth, then over that wrapped it in a thousand lengths of new white cloth that had been prepared, and over that wrapped it again in a thousand lengths of old cloth. Having thus wrapped the Tathāgata's body in many successive layers, they closed the lid of the coffin and adorned it magnificently with the seven kinds of precious substances.

Then Kāśyapa, weeping bitterly, together with his retinue, circumambulated to the right seven times, and with eyes brimming with tears, joined his palms together, placed his right knee on the ground, and spoke these verses:

Alas, alas — O noble Blessed One!
I am plunged in the depths of suffering.
Why, with your great compassion unconcerned for me,
did you so swiftly pass into nirvāṇa?

When I entered absorption on the Vulture Peak,
I looked in every direction but could not see the Tathāgata.
Looking, I saw that the Blessed One had passed into nirvāṇa,
and I trembled violently, my mind seized with terror.

The world-realm fell into darkness,
mountains and the great earth shook and heaved.
Understanding that the Blessed One had passed away there,
I came swiftly, yet did not see the Blessed One.

Because the Blessed One's compassion did not reach out to me,
I have not seen the buddha pass into nirvāṇa.
Since you left me no single word of teaching,
if I have no protector, what is there to rely on?

Blessed One, I am tormented by suffering,
my mind is bewildered and utterly lost.
Shall I bow at the Blessed One's head?
Or shall I bow at the Blessed One's sacred topknot?
Or bow at the noble hands?
Or bow at the Blessed One's waist?
Or bow at the Tathāgata's feet?
Or bow at the Blessed One's navel?

Alas, O Blessed One — I cannot see you, for you have passed into nirvāṇa!

Please show me the place where I should bow.

When the Blessed One dwells among us, all in the retinue are at ease.

Now that you have passed into nirvāṇa, suffering presses down on everyone.

Alas, alas — I am pierced through with grief!

O great compassion, please show me the place of your hands where I may bow.

The moment Kāśyapa had spoken those verses and wept, the Blessed One, out of great compassion, caused both his feet — bearing the wheel mark adorned with a thousand spokes — to appear beyond the walls of the funerary shrine. From those wheels with their thousand spokes, a thousand rays of light streamed forth, illuminating all the world-realms in the ten directions.

Then Kāśyapa, together with the retinue, beheld the Blessed One's feet. All of them prostrated themselves, wept, and fell into a faint. After a long while they revived, and together with the retinue, weeping deeply, they circumambulated to the right seven times. They bowed before the Buddha, and their cries of grief shook even the fabric of the world-realm. Then, at the feet of the Buddha, they spoke these verses:

The Sugata (well-gone one), perfected, endowed with great compassion,
whose light of serene loving-kindness is utterly without duality —
wherever sentient beings are ripe, there he appears.

I behold both feet bearing the wheel mark adorned with a thousand spokes.

With a mind of pure devotion I reverently bow —

before those two feet adorned with the mark of the wheel.

From the mark of the wheel a thousand rays of light stream forth,
illuminating all the buddha-fields of the ten directions.

With the crown of my head I reverently bow as well —

before the rays of light from those feet adorned with the wheel mark.

Beings touched by that light are wholly freed.
They cast aside the suffering of the three lower realms and a hundred obstacles.

With the crown of my head I reverently bow —
before the one whose wheel's light liberates beings from the lower realms.

In former times, O Blessed One, through countless ages,
you practiced austerities of the greatest difficulty on our behalf.
Through that power you obtained a body like a vajra,
and even from beneath your feet a thousand rays of light spread out.
Seeking refuge, I bow with the crown of my head in reverence —
before the wheel that brings happiness to sentient beings.

Having gathered all merit for the sake of all,
beneath the bodhi tree you subdued the four māras in their fourfold form.
Having subdued the four māras, you brought down the non-Buddhists
(tīrthikas) as well,
and through this, sentient beings came to hold the right view.
With the crown of my head I reverently bow —
before the feet whose rays of light lead sentient beings to the right view.

Equal to the loving father of all buddhas,
the light of those feet equally liberates all sentient beings.
Seeking refuge, I reverently bow —
before the wheel of those feet that removes suffering.

Having seen the light of the wheel of those feet,
I am deeply tormented, caught between joy and sorrow.
Lamenting and prostrating myself,
I bow before the mark of the wheel adorned with a thousand spokes.

Seeking refuge, I bow before the light of the wheel of those feet.
By the perfected vehicle, may beings transcend the three worlds.
Reverently bowing, I — a god and human being — come seeking refuge.
The wheel's light reveals the suffering of existence in the three realms.

Those beings not yet freed from the gateway of suffering —
may they too take refuge in the light of the wheel of those feet.
We who are not yet wholly freed from saṃsāra —
may the wheel of those feet bring us complete liberation.

Alas, how pitiful — ordinary beings one and all:
for so long they do not see the light of the wheel of those feet.
I confess it: the light of the feet with the thousand-spoked wheel
belongs to the Blessed One of great compassion.
Alas, that today we behold the mark of the wheel —
there will be no time hereafter when we shall see it again.

Then Kāśyapa, together with the retinue, having spoken those verses, fainted once more and fell to the ground. After a long while they revived, and their grief was soothed.

Then the two feet of the Blessed One, bearing the mark of the wheel with a thousand spokes, also withdrew back into the golden casket and disappeared from sight.

At that time, all the men and women, gods and people of that city, seeing that the great Kāśyapa had become thus, beat their chests once more and let out great cries of lamentation, weeping until the sound of their laments resounded throughout immeasurable world-systems of the great thousandfold universe. Each in turn made further offerings with their offering articles.

At that time, four great mighty warriors dwelling in the city of Kuśinagara came, their bodies fully adorned, each bearing a torch the size of a chariot wheel, made of the seven precious substances, which they ignited with fragrant wood — yet the fire died of itself. Thereupon Kāśyapa spoke these words: "If the fire of the three realms combined cannot burn the precious golden casket of the great noble one, then how much less can your fire burn it? Speak no more of that." In that same city, another eight great mighty warriors took up large fires made of the seven precious substances and placed them beside the casket — yet those fires too died of themselves. Then sixteen great mighty warriors took up large fires of the seven precious substances and ignited fragrant wood, yet those fires also died of themselves. Then thirty-six great mighty warriors took up large fires of the seven precious substances and kindled them — yet those fires too died of themselves.

At that time, the great Kāśyapa spoke these words to the warriors and the great assembly gathered there: "Understand it thus: if all the fires of gods, humans, and the rest cannot burn the Tathāgata's golden casket, do not labor in vain as though you could." At that time all the men and women, gods, humans, and the many assembled retinues of that city wept greatly and made offerings with all their offering articles, and at the same moment they paid

homage and circumambulated seven times, their cries of grief resounding throughout the world-systems of the threefold thousandfold universe.

At that time, from the power of the Tathāgata's great compassion, fire blazed forth from his breast, spread outward beyond the casket, and, fanned by the wind, caught the fragrant wood that had been heaped up. Seven days passed, and then the fire died out.

During those seven days, all the men and women, gods, humans, and the many assembled retinues of that city wept without ceasing and made continuous offerings.

At that time, the four guardian lords of the four directions thought to themselves: "Let us extinguish the fire with fragrant water, swiftly retrieve the sacred relics, and make offerings to them in the world of the gods." Thinking thus, each of them took up golden vases adorned with the seven precious substances and filled completely with fragrant water. Moreover, on the four sides of Mount Meru, great trees dripping with ambrosial milk stood, their girths a thousand fathoms in circumference and their heights reaching a hundred yojanas. Together with the four guardian lords, they entered those trees and came to the place where the trees leaned, and then poured both the tree's milky sap and the fragrant water simultaneously onto the fire — yet the fire blazed even greater than before and did not die.

At that time, the divine nāga king of the ocean, Sāgaranāgarāja, together with the gods of the rivers and the gods of the streams, seeing that the fire had not died, each of them thought: "Let us take fragrant water and extinguish the fire —"

— thinking "Let us quickly gather the bodily relics and honor them at our own abode" — and each of them, bearing jeweled vases filled with immeasurable quantities of fragrant water, entered at once and arrived at the place where the pyre leaned. They poured water upon it, yet the fire did not die; and so they departed.

At that time the one who had not been extinguished spoke to the four great guardian lords and to the gods of the ocean and the rest, saying: "Is it not that you have taken fragrant water in order to extinguish the fire out of desire for the bodily relics?" They replied: "It is so." Then the one who had not been extinguished said to the four great guardian lords: "Your desire is very great indeed. You dwell in the divine realm high in the sky. If all the relics were sent to the divine realm as you wish, would the human beings who dwell on the

earth be able to go there to make offerings?" To the gods of the ocean he also spoke in this way: "You dwell within the ocean and within the rivers. If the Tathāgata's relics were sent wholesale to your domain, how would the human beings who dwell on the earth be able to make offerings to them there?"

Then the four guardian lords of the four directions confessed their fault and departed back to their divine abodes. At that time the gods of the ocean and the gods of the rivers likewise confessed their fault and said: "We will do as you, the noble one, have said," and they departed back to their own abodes.

At that time Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods, arrived at the place where the pyre leaned, bearing a vase of the seven precious materials and implements of offering, and the moment he arrived the fire also died of itself.

Then, as Śakra opened the jeweled reliquary casket and was about to lift out the Tathāgata's tooth-relic, the one who had not been extinguished said to Śakra: "What are you doing?" Śakra replied: "I intend to honor the Tathāgata's tooth-relic in the divine world." The one who had not been extinguished said: "It is not right for you alone to have taken it out beforehand like that. Let the retinue assemble, and let it be shared from the very beginning." Śakra said: "The Blessed One long ago granted me a single tooth-relic. The moment I arrived, the fire also died of itself." Saying this, he opened the jeweled reliquary casket, invited forth the single upper tooth-relic from the right side of the buddha's jaw, conveyed it to the divine world, built a stūpa over it, and made offerings.

At that time, two rākṣasas of exceptional swiftness concealed themselves so that their bodies were invisible, followed behind Śakra, and stole two of the buddha's tooth-relics — and no one among the great multitude of the retinue perceived it.

At that time all the men and women and the great retinue of that city, pressing forward to seize the relics, were addressed by the one who had not been extinguished in these words: "Wait a moment. Let them be distributed properly, in accordance with the scripture spoken by the Tathāgata, and then let offerings be made." At that time those among the men and women and the great retinue of that city who had not heard what the one who had not been extinguished said came, each from their own place, bearing many weapons — spears, bows and arrows, swords, lassos, and the like — and pressed forward to seize the relics.

Then, when the people of that city opened the Tathāgata's reliquary casket, the retinue saw that the cotton-tree fibers and the white cloth had not been burned at all, and they were struck with overwhelming grief; their eyes filled with tears and they wept. And weeping, they made offerings and prostrated; then, setting their knees upon the ground, they spoke these verses:

By the great commanding power of the Tathāgata,
who exercises sovereignty over all the world entire,
through great compassion and the aspirations of the past —
they liberate sentient beings entirely from the ocean of existence;
through the power of their boundless primordial wisdom and supernatural knowledge,
they enter into cyclic existence without obstruction.
From one body they manifest many bodies;
from many bodies, likewise, one — and without limit.
Those to be trained perceive them through the power of blessing.
They show the passing beyond sorrow without cause.

Our merit has been exhausted; thus, without cause,
the Tathāgata has passed away beyond us.
The precious jeweled casket of the Tathāgata:
all the strongmen together tried to lift it — it would not move.
By the force of great compassion, this noble one
could soar as high as a single palm tree into the sky above,
and passing through the sky, he circled the city of Kuśinagara,
encircling it seven times over the course of seven days.
After circling thus in that manner, he descended and returned to his resting place.
This miraculous display, pure and unmingled,
no one among gods and humans together could fathom.

The Blessed One's passage into nirvāṇa —
the vajra-like, indestructible, sovereign power —
was not consumed by fire at all.
From within his heart a fire of loving-kindness arose,
and for seven full days it showed how the cremation took place.
No one among gods and humans could ignite it,
but the Blessed One, through the force of his great compassion,
demonstrated this power — and the moment Śakra arrived, the fire went out.

The fine cotton-tree fibers that had wrapped the body of the Buddha were not burned or scorched even by the great blazing fire.

The white cloth placed inside the precious jeweled casket was likewise not scorched in the midst of the flames.

By this we understand the sovereign power of the Tathāgata.

We prostrate to you, sovereign of the Dharma, king of Dharma — we prostrate, O Compassionate One, protector of the world.

We prostrate among the nobles, without fear, homage to you.

We prostrate to the strength of great compassion present everywhere.

We prostrate to the one who rules by blessing.

From this time forth we are separated from the Blessed One; though we sink into suffering, we have no protector, no refuge.

Alas, alas! Noble Blessed One —

we are parted from you forever, and the time to see you again does not come.

Having spoken these verses, the great retinue wept most bitterly, and each took up offerings and made offerings.

At that time, Aniruddha (the unobstructed one, son of the śākya clan), together with the gods, humans, and the great retinue, and all the people of that city, drew near to the reliquary casket, and looking upon the body wrapped in cloth and cotton-tree fibers, they found that the two outermost pieces — the thousand lengths of white cloth in which Kāśyapa had wrapped the body, and the thousand lengths of white cloth offered by the people of the city — and the cotton-tree fibers had not been burned; but all the rest had been burned by the fire.

Then Aniruddha cut the white cloths and the cotton-tree fibers into pieces and distributed them among the great retinue, and out of them made precious jeweled stūpas and made offerings. Aniruddha also divided separately the charred remnants of the other burned cloth, made precious jeweled stūpas of them, and made offerings. The remaining ashes he gathered separately, where it was not possible to distribute them further, and made stūpas and offered.

The people of that city had already had a goldsmith fashion eight golden caskets raised on lion thrones, each fully adorned with the seven precious substances. Each of the eight precious caskets held the capacity of half a khala, and they were placed upon thrones of lion seats made of the seven precious substances. Each of those eight lion thrones of the seven precious

substances was lifted by thirty-two strongmen adorned with ornaments of the seven precious substances, their bodies wrapped in cloths of many colors. Upon each of those lion thrones, eight maidens each fully adorned with precious ornaments held the caskets of the seven precious substances.

Upon each of those thrones, eight more maidens fully adorned with the seven precious substances held parasols of the seven precious substances and used them to cover the golden caskets completely. Upon each of those thrones, yet another group of eight maidens each fully adorned in ornaments held swords of the seven precious substances and stood guard over the caskets of the seven precious substances. Upon each of those thrones, still another eight fully adorned maidens each held ritual vases and stood facing the four sides of the caskets.

Around each of those thrones, a countless multitude of people each held, in their own station, divine musical instruments, victory banners, pennants, precious parasols, incense, flowers, and garlands, and circumambulated them while making offerings. Around each of those thrones, yet another countless multitude each held bows and arrows, spears, lassoes, iron hooks, and a full complement of weapons, and surrounded them as a guard escort, proceeding from the city of Kuśinagara to the place where the Blessed One had entered into final cessation.

Following in the wake of the eight lion thrones of the seven precious substances, the people of that city each took up countless incense sticks and vessels of scented water. They walked behind the strongmen, anointing with incense sticks the road from the city all the way to the place of final cessation, purifying the path entirely with fragrant scent and making it very wide. Along both sides of that road, countless precious victory banners, pennants, parasols, incense, flowers, pearls, garlands, silk streamers, musical instruments, songs and dances, and all such things adorned the left and right of the way, as the relics of the Blessed One made their return journey.

Then the strongmen lifted the eight lion thrones of the seven precious substances and carried them to the place of final cessation. There, all of them weeping and lamenting in one voice, the sound of their lament resounded throughout the great thousandfold world-system, and each made offerings with a mind of faith.

At that moment, by the power of the Blessed One's great compassion, his vajra-like body dissolved into fine relics, while the four canine teeth remained

whole and intact. When the great assembly saw that the bodily remains had thus become fine fragments, they were all the more tormented in their grief and wept, making offerings. Then the people of the city and those who had not yet dispersed, their eyes filled with tears, gathered up the relics, poured them into the caskets of the seven precious substances placed upon the lion thrones, and the eight caskets were filled to the full with the bodily remains.

At that time, when all the gods and humans of the world saw the bodily remains of the Blessed One laid to rest within the golden caskets, they were all the more tormented in their grief and wept, making offerings. At that time, the strongmen of that city, along with men and women, as the caskets of the relics of the Blessed One made their way back toward the city of Kuśinagara, the great assembly wept most bitterly, their tears streaming down, and made offerings. Then the strongmen, weeping deeply together with all their retinue, lifted the eight lion thrones of the seven precious substances and proceeded along the road that had been anointed with incense sticks, heading straight to the city of Kuśinagara.

Then the gods, humans, and the great assembly, weeping deeply, their lament resounding throughout every world-system, each made offerings to the bodily remains of the Tathāgata with whatever offerings they had to hand, and then placed them at the crossroads in the middle of the city.

At that time, the people dwelling in the city of Kuśinagara marshalled a countless host of soldiers, fully equipped with armor and weapons of every kind, and stationed them in countless rows around all four sides of the city. Yet this was done solely out of fear that the relics might be seized by others — it was a guard, not an army assembled with any intent to fight.

Moreover, around five hundred great masters of mantra were set to guard the four gates of the city, so that no obstructors might enter. And at the four corners of the city, victory banners of precious substances, pennants, parasols, ornaments of every variety, and vessels filled with flowers and the like were erected as offering-banners.

Then all the many men and women, gods, humans, and the great retinue of that city wept in a continuous great outpouring, and with minds of faith made offerings with whatever offering materials they had to hand. Each of the eight lion thrones of the seven precious substances was also guarded by five hundred masters of mantra, out of fear that gods, nāgas, yakṣas, hungry ghosts, rākṣasas, and the like might seize them.

In this way, a full day passed. The king of Kapilavastu, of the Śākya lineage — the land where the Tathāgata had formerly been born — together with his Śākya retinue, by the blessing of the Blessed One, had not perceived that the Buddha had passed completely into nirvāṇa. It was only after twenty-one days following the Buddha's passing that they first became aware of it. The king of Kapilavastu, together with the Śākya clan, wept deeply and then journeyed swiftly to where the city of Kuśinagara lay. There they saw the city surrounded by a countless army, and at the four corners of the city the precious victory banners and pennants had been erected, and at the four gates of the city many masters of mantra were stationed. Then the king and the Śākyas said: "The Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa."

The masters of mantra said: "The Buddha passed into nirvāṇa twenty-eight days ago. He has been washed and bathed, and the relics are now being laid out."

The king said: "We are kinsmen of the Blessed One. If, by the blessing of the Blessed One, we did not perceive the Tathāgata's passing into nirvāṇa — now, as we have come to pay our respects to the bodily remains of the Tathāgata, open the road and the gates without obstruction."

When the masters of mantra and the soldiers heard these words, they admitted the king and the Śākyas inside. They beheld the bodily remains of the Blessed One, and with a single cry broke into lamentation. Circumambulating to the right seven times, they wiped away their tears and spoke these words: "Please grant us even a single portion of the Tathāgata's relics as an object of worship for us."

The great assembly replied: "You are of the Śākya lineage, and you may be known as kinsmen — yet the Buddha Blessed One gave nothing to you. These relics, moreover, each have their own custodians; you have no claim to them. Turn back now."

At that, the king and the Śākyas, having obtained no share of the relics, were overwhelmed with grief, and weeping, they fell to the ground in a swoon. After a long while they revived, and disconsolate, they spoke thus to the great assembly: "The Buddha Blessed One was of our own Śākya lineage, and it was out of affection for you that he passed into nirvāṇa here among you — why then will you not give us even the slightest portion of the relics?" Having said this, they prostrated before the relics, circumambulated seven times, and then, weeping and yet furious, departed.

At that time, the king of the central land of Magadha, Ajātaśatru — who had slain his own father and was consumed with intense remorse — had broken out in malignant sores across his body. A ray of light belonging to the Blessed One, called "Moonbeam," touched his body, and by its power the sores healed and he recovered. He then came before the Blessed One, made full confession, and through the Blessed One's great compassion was cleansed by the medicine of the Dharma, that nectar-like antidote to wrongdoing. He departed back to his palace, purified of the stain of his grave offense, yet entirely unaware that the Tathāgata had passed completely into nirvāṇa.

On the very night of the Blessed One's passing into nirvāṇa, the king dreamed these dreams: the moon fell to the earth, and from the earth the sun arose, while stars rained down upon the clouds like falling rain; smoke rose up from the ground, and the seven planetary stars blazed openly in the sky; and a great mass of fire blazed in the heavens, manifestly burning in the sky, then fell all at once to the earth. He dreamed all this, and waking immediately in great fright, he assembled his ministers and declared: "I have had such dreams — what is to be made of them?"

The ministers replied: "These are omens of the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa. Since the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, the afflictions will rise up throughout all sentient beings in all three realms and along the six destinies, and it is as a great fire falling from the sky that this appeared. Since the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, the light of his compassion — like the moon — and his wisdom that pervades all equally will fade; thus the moon fell to the earth. The falling of the stars to the earth signifies that, since the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, all people will transgress the eighty thousand modes of conduct and every precept of moral discipline; rather than acting in accordance with the Buddha's teaching, they will practice wrong Dharma, and sentient beings will fall into the hells. The sun falling to the earth signifies that, since the Buddha has passed into nirvāṇa, the mass of suffering of the three lower realms will rise like a sun in the world. Such are the meanings of these dreams."

When the king heard these words, in the middle of the night, accompanied by his retinue of ministers, he arrived near the city of Kuśinagara. He saw innumerable fourfold armies surrounding the city of Kuśinagara in countless ranks, and at the four gates he saw mantra masters (dhāraṇī-holders) and others keeping guard. He addressed one of the mantra masters, saying: "Has the Buddha passed completely into nirvāṇa?" The mantra master replied: "The

Buddha passed into nirvāṇa twenty-eight days ago. The great assembly is at this moment still preparing the relics of his body." The king said: "I had not heard of the Buddha's passing. I saw ill omens in a dream, and when my ministers told me they were signs of the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa, we came here. Let the path be opened so that we may go and pay homage to the vajra-like body relics of the Tathāgata." The mantra masters admitted the king into the city.

At the crossroads of the main road, the relics had been placed in a golden casket upon a lion throne, and he saw the entire great assembly making offerings while weeping. The king and his retinue paid homage and wept, circumambulated seven times from the right side, and made offerings. The king then asked the great assembly whether they might grant him a portion of the Tathāgata's relics. The assembly replied: "Great King, you have come too late. The Lord previously declared to whom the Tathāgata's body relics were to be distributed, and the king has no allotted share — depart now." King Ajātaśatru, hearing these words, was displeased and aggrieved that his request had not been granted, yet he nonetheless paid homage to the relics and departed.

At that time, the king of Vaiśālī, learning only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa —

— arrived together with his retinue at the city of Kuśinagara. He saw that the city of Kuśinagara was surrounded by a countless host of soldiers in countless ranks. At that time, the king of the land of Akaleka also learned only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa, and swiftly came to the city of Kuśinagara, where he likewise saw the city surrounded by a countless host of soldiers in countless ranks. At that time, the king of the land of Byinuti, named Fearless, also learned of it only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's complete passing into nirvāṇa. At that time, the king of the land of Cālaka likewise learned of it only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa. At that time, the king named Śikana likewise learned of it only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa. At that time, the non-Buddhist (tīrthika) king of Paśāla likewise learned of it only on the twenty-first day after the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa, and came to the city of Kuśinagara together with a retinue of ministers. He saw the city of Kuśinagara encircled and guarded by a countless host of soldiers, and at all four gates he saw gatekeepers who were mantra-masters. He addressed a mantra-master and said: "Has the Buddha passed completely into nirvāṇa?"

The mantra-master replied: "Twenty-one days have passed since the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa, and now a great assembly is engaged in the work of dividing the body relics. We ourselves did not learn of the Buddha's complete passing into nirvāṇa until later. If you wish to go and pay homage to the Tathāgata's relics, let us open the way for you." The mantra-master sent the king into the city, and at the crossroads in the heart of the city the king saw the relics residing in a golden casket adorned with seven kinds of jewels, set upon a lion throne. All of them at once prostrated themselves, wept, circumambulated to the right seven times, and made offerings with whatever was available. The king said: "Since we had not learned of the Buddha's passing into nirvāṇa beforehand, might we be granted a portion of the Tathāgata's body relics as a support for worship?" The assembly replied: "The rite of distributing the body relics was declared beforehand. The king has no allotted share — depart now." The king, together with his retinue, his mind afflicted by sorrow at not having received the body relics, paid homage to the relics and departed in tears.

The noble sūtra of the Great Complete Passing into Nirvāṇa is concluded.

This sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa, translated from Chinese, was translated, revised, and definitively established by the Chinese abbot Wang Faxun, the Dharma-keeper Géwé Lodrö, and the translator Gyatso Dé.

The volume designated Tha of the Sūtra section is contained herein.

Translator's Notes

- The river name Hiraṇyavatī is reconstructed from the Tibetan phonetic rendering. The Tibetan phrase for "as a mother lioness regards her cub" (sgra can 'dzin) literally means "like Rāhu" which is a name for the lion constellation or, in some contexts, the eclipse-demon — here the comparison is clearly to a lioness protecting her young, a standard simile in this sūtra tradition, and has been rendered accordingly. The passage ends mid-sentence as the Tibetan input itself ends at the introduction of the senior monks.

- The nun's names — Śrībhadrā, Priyadarśanā, and Sāgaramatī — are reconstructed from the Tibetan dpal bzang, bsnyen dga' ma, and rgya mtsho'i blo gros respectively; these reconstructions are plausible but not confirmed by a parallel Sanskrit witness in this passage.

The phrase rendered "like nāgas among human beings, having thoroughly entered the ten grounds" reflects the idiom that likens bodhisattvas on the tenth ground (daśabhūmi) to the nāga king — a standard comparison in Mahāyāna sūtra literature. The phrase "displaying the body of a woman" for bodhisattvas who are nuns reflects the Mahāyāna teaching that advanced bodhisattvas assume whatever form is most beneficial, including a female form, without being bound by it.

- The phrase rendered "flushing blood" describes the body becoming suffused or reddened — a physical manifestation of overwhelming devotion and emotion classically compared in the text

itself to the reddish flesh visible within a lotus flower. This is an unusual simile whose precise doctrinal valence is primarily devotional-aesthetic rather than technical.

The paired opposites listed as "antidotal teachings" — suffering and happiness, permanence and impermanence, and so on — represent a standard contemplative enumeration of Dharma themes taken as objects of analytical meditation (*vipaśyanā*); the Tibetan term rendered "antidotal" refers to teachings functioning as antidotes to false views.

[illegible]

The "nine-stringed lute" (九絃琵琶) is a tentative rendering; the instrument referenced may be a *viṇā*-type multi-stringed instrument. The exact identity of 鈸 and 鈜 among the musical instruments listed is not fully certain; rendered here as "cymbals" and "bells" respectively following standard lexicographical convention.

- The phrase rendered as "inner offering" for "nang gi" in context most likely means the last personal or intimate offering, framed as something heartfelt and final rather than the technical tantric "inner offering." This reading is consistent with the narrative context.

The names of the laywomen at the close follow a reconstruction from the Tibetan: "Tsoṃ yon ten" is read as a name meaning something like "Jīvana-qualities" or "Jīvanaśrī," and "dpal gyi phreng ba" as "Śrīmālā" (garland of glory). These are standard figures in sūtra literature. If the Tibetan here is a translation of a specific Sanskrit name-list, some names may vary in other recensions.

- The term rendered "eraṇḍa plant" preserves the Sanskrit botanical name (eraṇḍa, the castor-oil plant, *Ricinus communis*), a stock image of insubstantiality in Buddhist literature. The Tibetan འེ་རུ་འུ་མེ་ is a direct phonetic transcription.

The phrase "the hollow of a hoof-print" renders खोखो पादचिह्न (literally "inside a hoof-print"), a classical Indian simile for a tiny vessel utterly inadequate to contain something vast; the meaning is that even the ocean's water poured into so small a space is more conceivable than a complete enumeration of the body's faults.

The three practices of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness correspond to the three gateways to liberation (vimokṣamukha): śūnyatā, ānimitta, and apraṇihita.

• The three named Lichavi youths — Pure Stainless Essence, Mindfully Purified, and Ever Stainless Pure Virtue — are rendered from their Tibetan epithets rather than from recoverable Sanskrit originals; these appear to be stock epithet-names and no reliable Sanskrit back-formation is certain enough to include.

The phrase rendered "woolen oxen" (bal glang) literally means oxen or yaks covered or laden with wool bales — a standard image of wealth-bearing animals in offering processions; "woolen oxen" preserves the term's flavor without over-interpreting.

- The merchant names Sunlight, Protector of the World, and Protector of the Dharma are translations of the Tibetan epithets *Nyi ma'i 'od*, *'Jig rten skyong*, and *Chos skyong* respectively, rendered into English since no Sanskrit equivalents are given in the text.

The phrase rendered "their coming was subdued entirely, as hail falls upon grass and trees" is contextually difficult. The Tibetan compares their subdual or humbling to hail falling on grass and trees, likely meaning that those who had disparaged the Dharma were thoroughly

chastened by the power of these Mahāyāna devotees. This interpretation follows the most natural reading of the passage.

- The phrase rendered "led on" for 引連る is a continuation of the framing from the preceding passage, where these consorts appear in female form to tame beings; the verb means they were brought forward or led in procession, with the named consorts heading the group.

The measurements given — leagues (dpag tshad, Skt. *yojana*) — are treated as literal cosmological hyperbole appropriate to the *sūtra* genre and are not normalized.

- The passage presents a sequence of three groups — divine daughters, nāga kings, and yakṣa kings — but the Tibetan text gives these groups slightly out of order, with the yakṣa king passage appearing after the nāga kings despite being introduced earlier. The translation follows the sequence as it appears in the Tibetan, preserving the textual order even where it may reflect a scribal displacement. The nāga king names Jokpo, Gawos, and Nyegawos are retained as transliterations of Tibetan names without attested Sanskrit equivalents in the immediate context.
- The terms "tānapā" and "prabhāsana" render Tibetan ཐག་པ་ and རྒྱལ་པ་ respectively. The former is likely a transliteration of an unidentified Sanskrit category; the latter literally means "those who consume radiance or luster" and may correspond to a class of beings in the Sanskrit original that is not immediately identifiable from the Tibetan alone.

The name "Lāhu" renders Tibetan ལཱཱུ, which appears to be a phonetic transcription of an underlying Sanskrit or possibly Prakrit name for the lead bull king.

- The phrase rendered "last inner offering" translates "mchod pa nang gi tha ma," which the commentarial tradition reads as the final personal or bodily offering — i.e., the sages' last act of homage before the Buddha's parinirvāṇa. The Tathāgata's silence is a standard narrative device indicating that acceptance would prolong his stay, contrary to his resolve to pass into nirvāṇa.

The river name "Hiraṇyavatī" is a standard Sanskrit reconstruction for the Tibetan "klung ha ri ba ti," the river near Kuśinagara beside which the Buddha is said to have passed into nirvāṇa.

"Uttarakuru" here glosses the Tibetan "byang gi sgra mi snyan," literally "the northern Unpleasant Sound" — one of the four continents — but in context the passage appears to be comparing the spontaneously appearing grove to the celestial pleasure grove of the Thirty-Three gods; the parallel phrasing is somewhat compressed and the exact referent is slightly ambiguous in the Tibetan.

- The long sequence of flower names — māṇḍārava, kacilika, mañjūṣaka, santānika, and the rest — are Sanskrit celestial flower names transliterated into Tibetan. Their Tibetan glosses (pleasing, all-good, timely, fragrant city, and so on) are rendered literally as given in the text, representing either actual Sanskrit meanings or traditional Tibetan explanations. There is some uncertainty about several of these identifications in the botanical and textual literature, but the translations given follow the literal Tibetan readings.

The phrase rendered "Victor of Immeasurable Mansions" reflects the Tibetan "gzhal med khang rgyal bar 'gyur ba," which could also mean "the palace that surpasses all immeasurable mansions." The reading adopted here follows the most natural sense of the compound.

- The title "Māra pāpīyas" rendered as "Māra the Evil One" follows standard convention; the Tibetan རྒྱུ་མཚན་པ་པུ་ཡི་མ་རྩ་ / རྒྱུ་མཚན་པ་པུ་ཡི་མ་རྩ་ literally means "the sinful, evil māra," the standard rendering of the Sanskrit epithet pāpīyas.

The cosmological term 三千大千世界, rendered "a middling thousandfold world system," refers to the second tier of the standard three-tier Buddhist

cosmological scheme: the small thousand, the middling (twice-thousand), and the great (trice-thousand) world systems.

- The mantra syllables (cyog kye, ta ta la cyog kye, lo ha le, ma hā lo ha le, ala cala tala svāhā) are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan, which represents a phonetic rendering of a Sanskrit or hybrid Sanskrit dhāraṇī. No normative Sanskrit reconstruction can be given with confidence, so the Tibetan phonetics are rendered as-is.

The phrase rendered "the last of our inner offerings" translates འོད་ཀྱི་མཆོད་པ་འཁོར་བའི་མཆོད་པ་, which is somewhat ambiguous — it may mean "the innermost and final offering" or "this last of the inner offerings." The same phrase recurs when Śakra's retinue speaks, confirming it is a set expression in this context.

- The ten epithets of a buddha appear twice in this passage in their standard Tibetan form. The rendering follows the traditional enumeration: Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened, endowed with knowledge and conduct, Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed, tamer and guide of persons, teacher of gods and humans, blessed buddha. The Tibetan "འོད་ཀྱི་མཆོད་པ་འཁོར་བའི་མཆོད་པ་" literally means "endowed with knowledge and feet," a standard rendering of vidyācaraṇasaṃpanna, meaning one perfected in knowledge and conduct, rendered here accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "Palace of Joy called Sudharmā in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three" is an interpretive rendering: the Tibetan reads literally "the Thirty-Three Heaven's pleasure grove of supreme happiness." The Sudharmā is the assembly hall rather than a grove, so the translation keeps the literal "pleasure grove" of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three rather than importing that specific name.

The exclamation "འོད་ཀྱི་མཆོད་པ་འཁོར་བའི་མཆོད་པ་" is an untranslatable cry of alarm or dismay; it is rendered idiomatically as "in alarm" with the semantic content preserved in the reported speech.

- The phrase rendered "fragrant food" translates a compound meaning literally "food with fragrance" or "food endowed with scent," functioning as a supernaturally purifying substance — a recognized tantric and sūtric motif.

The two named exceptions to the gathering — Mahākāśyapa and Ānanda — are given in a construction that most naturally reads as an exclusion from the general assembly, consistent with narrative context in parinirvāṇa sūtra literature where these two figures play distinct roles and are sometimes depicted as absent or delayed.

The "sixteen classes of wicked actions" is a specific doctrinal enumeration whose precise contents are not elaborated here; the number sixteen is given explicitly in the Tibetan.

- The city name rendered "Pāvā" (Tibetan: grong khyer rtsa mchog) follows the standard identification in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition, where Cunda the carpenter comes from Pāvā. The Tibetan grong khyer rtsa mchog is a translation of Pāvā, and this identification is standard in the commentarial tradition.

The phrase rendered "fifty peers" translates ris 'thun pa'i 'khor lnga bcu, literally "fifty retinue members of compatible rank or type," meaning companions of the same social standing.

The "seven bodily and verbal actions" refers to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the seven virtuous deeds of body and speech: three bodily (refraining from killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct) and four verbal (refraining from lying, divisive speech, harsh speech, and idle talk).

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, so the translation likewise ends there. The phrase rendered "the God of gods" for "lha'i lha" is a standard epithet for the Buddha meaning he surpasses even the gods. The term "individual perfect knowledge" renders "so sor yang dag par shes pa," a technical term for the analytical knowledges (Skt. pratisaṃvid); the five

qualities listed — vitality, radiance, strength, well-being, and unobstructedness — correspond to a standard set associated with these knowledges in this context.

- The "twelve branches of scripture" renders a standard Mahāyāna enumeration of the twelve canonical literary forms (dvādaśāṅga-buddhavaṇana), sometimes called the twelve limbs of the Buddha's word.

The phrase rendered "the last of a conventional series" translates a Tibetan expression meaning the final, death-bound ordinary body in the succession of rebirths, contrasted with the permanent vajra-body of a buddha.

The cowherd women Nandā and Nandapālā parallel the well-known Pali figure Sujātā; here the text gives two names (the herdswomen sisters), which is characteristic of certain Sanskrit and Tibetan Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra recensions.

- The epithet "འཇམ་མཐོན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་" rendered throughout as "the Teacher who turns the wheel" — it literally means "the Teacher who steers the helm / rudder," an image of the Buddha as the helmsman or charioteer of the world. "Turns the wheel" is the conventional equivalent but loses the nautical nuance; a listener should understand this as a standard honorific for the Buddha as guide.

The passage ends mid-sentence ("Blessed One, may you utterly remove —"); this is because the Tibetan text submitted cuts off at that point. The final incomplete line is rendered as it stands.

The comparison of Cunda to Rāhu (the eclipse-demon) in the opening paragraph is surprising in context. The Tibetan "རྩེ་ལྷ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་" literally means "Rāhu," the deity said to swallow the moon causing eclipses. The intended sense appears to be that Cunda, who has obtained the full moon of the perfection of generosity, is inseparably close to it — as inseparable as Rāhu is from the moon. This is an unusual simile and may reflect a specific literary convention of the source text.

- The simile of the silkworm in its cocoon describes beings enmeshed in afflictions: just as a silkworm spins thread around itself and is enclosed within it, beings are pervasively penetrated and enclosed by their own afflictions. The Tibetan reads literally "afflictions permeating like a silkworm in silk," and the rendering given preserves this image.

The line rendered "the limit that is free of conceptual elaboration" translates a phrase indicating the ultimate endpoint — nirvāṇa — characterized by the complete absence of conceptual proliferation (prapañca). This is a standard Madhyamaka formulation for the ultimate nature.

- The sentence structure of Cunda's argument is quite compressed and elliptical in the Tibetan, involving a chain of analogies and counter-arguments in dialogue with Mañjuśrī. The translation follows the most natural reading of the argument's logic: Cunda is defending the Tathāgata's transcendence over formations, while Mañjuśrī had urged contemplation of the nature of formations. The passage ends mid-sentence, corresponding to the Tibetan breaking off after the list beginning with "the māra of afflictions."

- The phrase rendered "the māra of the divine son" refers to the Devaputramāra, the māra who is himself a god — specifically the lord of the highest heaven of the desire realm. This is the standard fourfold classification of māras: afflictions, aggregates, the divine son, and the lord of death.

The Ganges simile in this passage is used to illustrate that declaring the Tathāgata to be unconditioned, even at the cost of one's life, generates merit equivalent to the woman's self-sacrificial love, leading to spontaneous liberation without even aspiring to it.

- The phrase rendered "eighty times as a king in the realm of Great Brahmā" follows the

Tibetan literally; the number eighty here refers to the count of rebirths as lord of the Brahmā realm, which is consistent with parallel passages in this sūtra. The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan provided, and the translation reflects this.

- The image of Rāhu, the eclipse-demon who seizes the sun and moon, conveys that the Tathāgata regards all beings with a watchful, all-encompassing concern — not with personal attachment — just as Rāhu holds the celestial bodies in his grip without favoritism. This is a somewhat unusual simile and the Tibetan is straightforward; the intended meaning contrasts the Tathāgata's impartial, encompassing gaze with the cow's affective attachment to her calf.
- The phrase rendered "city of gandharvas" refers to a gandharva-city, a standard Indian simile for an illusory or mirage-like appearance. The gandharvas here are the mythological beings who subsist on fragrance; the city they appear to inhabit is a standard image for something that seems real but has no substance. The gloss is included in the body for the audio listener's benefit.

The list of similes for the body is a classical set found across Mahāyāna sūtra literature; "unfired clay" renders the idea of something not yet hardened and therefore fragile and temporary, and "a thread whose fibers are exhausted" conveys the image of a lamp or fire about to go out when its fuel is spent.

- The bird name "byasa lasa" (Tibetan transliteration of a Sanskrit term) is uncertain. The text reads bya sa la sa, which likely corresponds to a Sanskrit bird name such as cāṣa or sārāsa; "sanderling" is an approximation. The doctrinal point is simply that migratory birds gather at a cool lake in the summer heat as their natural destination, just as the Tathāgata goes to nirvāṇa as his natural resting place.

The phrase rendered "the Tathāgata, through skillful means, does not cling to anything whatsoever" carries the sense that the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa is not an event of loss or grasping but a display of non-attachment in accord with his buddha-nature.

- The phrase rendered "the Blessed One, having comprehended all phenomena within himself, has come to be overawed by the Dharma itself" translates a deliberately paradoxical simile: a master frightened by his own mastery. The doctrinal point is that the Buddha's decision to pass into nirvāṇa appears, from the assembly's perspective, as an inexplicable withdrawal from teaching — analogous to a learned man shrinking from his own knowledge. This is a rhetorical plea, not a doctrinal assertion about the Buddha's actual state.

The petition to Mañjuśrī being the sole recipient of the "profound heart teaching" reflects the standard Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra motif of the tathāgatagarbha doctrine as an esoteric transmission.

- The twenty-five existences is a technical enumeration in certain early Mahāyāna and Abhidharma texts listing the modes of conditioned existence across the three realms. The exact count varies by source.

The udumbara flower is proverbially rare, said to bloom only when a buddha appears in the world. The phrase paired with it, rendered here as "the seed grain of the śāla tree," translates a term that literally means the seed or grain of the śāla tree and appears to be an additional simile for rarity, though some editions treat it as a single compound image.

The closing sentence is syntactically incomplete in the Tibetan as transmitted here, breaking off mid-construction. The translation preserves this as a natural sentence opening awaiting continuation in the passage that follows.

- The passage contains a well-known analogy involving the letter "i" written in the Brāhmī or an early Indic script, where the letter is formed by arranging three dots or strokes in a specific configuration — horizontal rather than vertical. The doctrinal point it illustrates is that the three

Dharmas (the Dharma of liberation, the body of the Tathāgata, and the Perfection of Wisdom) constitute nirvāṇa not by being separated but by being unified in a particular arrangement, just as the three marks must be arranged correctly to form the letter. The exact graphic convention referred to is specific to the script tradition underlying the Sanskrit original, and the analogy may not be fully transparent to a modern listener without this context.

The phrase rendered "the heart of what I have spoken with care" translates a term that carries the sense of the essential, intentional meaning or the innermost import of a teaching given with deliberate purpose — something like "the intended heart-essence of my discourse."

- The phrase rendered "the letter A is renowned as the first of all letters" translates a passage comparing the Tathāgata's placing beings in ease through Dharma to the way the syllable A is the foremost among written characters. The Tibetan reads literally "just as in the world what is known as the letter I," but given the standard canonical parallel in Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra literature where the letter A is used as this exemplar of primacy, the reference to "A" is very likely the correct reading and "I" may be a scribal or orthographic variant. This is noted as a genuinely consequential textual point.

The "fifty-seven afflictions" is an unusual enumeration; standard Abhidharma lists differ. This may reflect a specific sūtra-internal enumeration and is rendered as given in the Tibetan.

- The passage is from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, the section where the Buddha corrects the monks' understanding of the four perceptions (suffering, impermanence, emptiness, no-self) by revealing their inverted application: ordinary beings wrongly perceive the Buddha's own qualities — self, permanence, bliss, purity — as their opposites. The equation "self equals buddha" here is the sūtra's characteristic tathāgatagarbha doctrine, where ātman language is reappropriated as a positive quality of the Buddha and buddha-nature, not as a realist self-view. This is doctrinally significant and intentional, not a textual anomaly.

The simile of the bee is unusual; the Tibetan reads "a bee is in no way needed" in context of having no self or owner, which appears to be an abbreviated or compressed comparison (perhaps: as a bee, though it visits flowers, is not owned by them, the body similarly has no owner). This reading follows the flow of the surrounding analogies.

- The passage contains the key doctrinal assertion of the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra that the four qualities — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — are the true attributes of the Tathāgata and nirvāṇa, in deliberate inversion of the standard four marks of conditioned existence. The identification of "self" with the Tathāgata and "no-self" with saṃsāra is a central and intentional doctrinal provocation of this text, not an error.

- The passage presents a sustained inversion of the standard three marks of existence. The Blessed One here teaches that clinging to impermanence, suffering, and selflessness as mere signs — without the deeper understanding of buddha-nature — is itself a form of perversion. The positive qualities of self, permanence, bliss, and purity refer to the four attributes of the dharmakāya as taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition, not to ordinary samsaric qualities. This is a distinctive and doctrinally significant Mahāyāna position.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text as provided, and the translation reflects this.

- The phrase rendered "the chief of his limbs — his head" translates a construction in which "mgo bcad do" (decapitation) is glossed by "yan lag gi dam pa" (the foremost or chief of the limbs), a traditional formulaic way of specifying capital punishment. This is doctrinally and legally standard in the narrative context and requires no special flag, but the doubled phrasing is worth noting for a reader who may wonder why both "head and limbs" and "head" appear in successive edicts; the first edict is slightly more expansive in its threat while the second specifies decapitation as the penalty.

- The passage ends mid-sentence with "འདྲིམ་པོ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟོས་པ་" — "or the size of a mustard

seed?" — the Tibetan input cuts off at this point. The translation preserves this open ending faithfully rather than completing a thought not present in the source.

This passage is from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. The extended analogy contrasts the Tathāgata's provisional teaching of no-self (aimed at disciplining those attached to the tīrthika notion of a permanent self) with his ultimate teaching that a self can be spoken of skillfully — a characteristically Tathāgatagarbha doctrinal point. The ten epithets of the Buddha rendered here follow the standard Tibetan canonical sequence.

- The phrase rendered "fourfold assembly" translates ལྔ་པ་སྒྲུབ་པའི་སྒྲུབ་པ་, which refers to the four assemblies: monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen. The context is a direct address closing the preceding doctrinal passage before the Fourth Fascicle begins.
- The city name "Tāla" is a transliteration of the Tibetan and likely corresponds to a Sanskrit place name not otherwise identified in this passage; no emendation is attempted.

The bodhisattva here named "the Great Kāśyapa" is a figure distinct from Mahākāśyapa the arhat-disciple of the Buddha; in this sūtra context he is presented as a brahmin youth and bodhisattva, a distinction the text itself makes plain.

- The phrase rendered "like Kālīṅga, like sun and moon, like the pole star among the great stars" references a series of analogies whose precise doctrinal application is not spelled out in the verse itself; the Tibetan presents them as rhetorical comparisons whose full meaning would be unpacked in the prose commentary. "Kālīṅga" here may refer to the Kālīṅga bird (a type of Indian cuckoo or myna celebrated for its voice) rather than the region of Kālīṅga, though either reading is possible; the translation preserves the ambiguity.

The line rendered "how does one, without having aroused the mind, still be called a bodhisattva" (bodhisattva-śūnyatā) raises a genuine doctrinal puzzle central to tathāgatagarbha literature: the question likely concerns beings who have not explicitly generated bodhicitta yet are designated bodhisattvas by virtue of buddha-nature.

- The verse at the opening continues the preceding passage's question-and-answer format and is attributed to Kāśyapa. The final sentence breaks off mid-clause in the Tibetan as given; the translation preserves that open ending faithfully rather than inventing a completion.
- The passage names Kāśyapa's son as Rāhula. Rāhula was historically the Buddha's own son, and the Tibetan reads "my son Rāhula" — making clear the Buddha here draws an analogy through his own parental love for Rāhula, one well attested in Mahāyāna literature, including the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra context from which this passage likely derives.

The seven disciplinary acts listed toward the end — expulsion, reprimand, suspension, formally raising an offense, rendering invisible, pacification, and abandoning wrong views — correspond to categories of *saṅghakamma* (Saṅgha acts) found in Vinaya literature; the rendering follows the most plausible doctrinal identification of each term in context.

- The passage breaks mid-sentence at the end, corresponding to a folio break in the source; the translation preserves that open ending faithfully. The phrase rendered "attendant-śrāvaka" translates རྒྱལ་ཁྱེད་ལྷན་པོ།, literally "close attendant and hearer," here designating a true disciple in the Buddha's immediate circle who faithfully carries out his intentions. The name རྒྱལ་ཁྱེད་ལྷན་པོ། (literally "protector of light") is the Tibetan for Kāśyapa; it has been rendered as Kāśyapa throughout for consistency. The term རྒྱལ་ཁྱེད་ལྷན་པོ། (literally "seizer of sound" or "planet that seizes"), Rāhula, refers to the Buddha's biological son and is used here as a term of endearment for how the Tathāgata regards sentient beings; this is a standard Mahāyāna trope found also in the Vimalakīrtinirdeśa and Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra traditions.
- The eight great rivers listed here correspond to the standard Indian sacred rivers. "Alilabarātā" is a Tibetan phonetic rendering that does not correspond clearly to a standard

Sanskrit river name; it may be a corruption of Airāvātī or another river name. This is noted as genuinely uncertain but does not affect the doctrinal sense of the passage.

The lake Anavatapta is the legendary Himalayan lake (identified with Lake Mānasarovar in some traditions) from which the four great rivers of Jambudvīpa are said to flow; the Sanskrit name is restored here for clarity.

Kāśyapa's challenge — questioning why the Tathāgata's life was short if equanimous mind produces long life — is a classical dialectical setup in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature for the teaching that the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa was a skillful display rather than a real death, and that his life span is in fact immeasurable. This doctrinal context underlies the Blessed One's response.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-passage, as the Tibetan supplied ends mid-sentence. The translation renders exactly what is given and stops at that point.

The "five superknowledges" refers to the five mundane abhijñā: supernormal powers of flight and bodily transformation, clairvoyance, clairsentience, knowledge of others' minds, and recollection of past lives, all attainable by non-Buddhists through meditative cultivation; they are distinct from the sixth, specifically Buddhist superknowledge of the destruction of the defilements.

- The list of mistaken identifications of nirvāṇa includes a series of tīrthika and Abhidharma categories: self (ātman), sentient being, life-force (jīva), person (pudgala), Brahmā, a sovereign or ruling deity (Īśvara), subtle particles (paramāṇu), the intrinsic nature of the world (likely prakṛti, the Sāṃkhya principle), and then various levels culminating in the two higher formless absorptions. The passage treats all of these as equally mistaken objects of identification with nirvāṇa, contrasting them with the Tathāgata's authentic teaching of the four qualities of the dharmakāya.

- The phrase "permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity" renders the four qualities of the Tathāgata's final nirvāṇa as taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition. The term "self" here is the Skt. ātman as applied paradoxically to the Tathāgata in the tathāgatagarbha doctrine and is entirely distinct from the ordinary self that Buddhism negates.

The "gods of the sphere of non-perception" refers to the asaṃjñisattva heaven in the form realm, where beings abide in a state devoid of conscious perception; the analogy argues that inconceivability of the Tathāgata's mode of existence does not mean non-existence.

The closing phrase rendered "the defining characteristic of non-impermanence" is a deliberate affirmative negation in the source: the Three Jewels are characterized by not being impermanent, not being differentiated from one another, and not undergoing transformation — reflecting the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's distinctive revaluation of the Three Jewels as ultimately one and permanent.

- The phrase rendered "act as a mother or as hail" translates the Tibetan "ba mo am ser ba lta bur bgyio," meaning Kāśyapa will relate to such persons either as a mother cow (with gentle guidance) or as hail (with forceful correction). This is a somewhat unusual simile and the pairing is likely an idiomatic expression for the full range of skillful means — gentle and fierce — to be employed toward those of wrong view. The precise nuance of the contrast is not entirely transparent from context alone.

The concluding sequence of negations describing the Tathāgata's body ends the passage mid-sentence as given; the list continues beyond what is provided here.

- The passage "अविच्छिन्नं अमरं" (avichchhinaṃ amaraṃ)

अविच्छिन्नं अमरं" presents a genuine doctrinal tension by juxtaposing "uninterrupted" and "impermanent" immediately before the

statement about the single vehicle perceived as three. The pairing of impermanence and continuity here is deliberate and apophatic, consistent with the overall rhetorical strategy of the passage, which systematically refuses all reifying predications.

The phrase "□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□" is slightly elliptical. It has been rendered "not something to be seen as free from torment," understanding "□□□□□□□□□□" as qualifying the preceding negation rather than introducing a fully independent predicate.

• The nine divisions of the scriptural canon (the "nine-limbed Dharma") are listed here in a form that slightly exceeds nine items as the Tibetan text runs; the list as translated follows the standard Tibetan enumeration recognizing that some compound terms cover what Western scholarship distinguishes as separate categories.

The phrase rendered "a householder who grasps at a head" is a Tibetan idiom whose precise meaning is uncertain; it may refer to a layman who physically touches a monk's head in disrespect, or more generally to lay interference with the monastic community. The doctrinal point — that mere withdrawal to a solitary dwelling without active Dharma protection is insufficient — is clear from context.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, indicating it continues beyond what has been provided for translation.

- The epithet "Joyfully Arisen" renders རྩོམ་པོ་འཕྱུང་བའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་འཕྱུང་བ་, which may also be read as the name Pramuditotpāda or similar; no Sanskrit original is preserved here and the rendering follows the Tibetan literally.

The phrase འཁོག་ཡིན་པའི་སྐད་ཀྱི་ཆེན་མོ།, "the Tathāgata Akṣobhya" (literally "the Immovable Tathāgata"), identifies Akṣobhya by his standard epithet; the name is supplied from tradition rather than being spelled out in the Tibetan at this point.

- The term rendered "shaven-headed impostors" translates the Tibetan "mgo reg," literally "those who merely touch the head" or "those whose heads are merely touched," a standard idiom for fraudulent monastics who take ordination for material benefit rather than genuine renunciation. The rendering "shaven-headed impostors" captures both the physical referent and the polemical force of the term.

The passage's permission for armed lay protection of Dharma-teachers is a well-known and genuinely controversial teaching of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra, invoked historically to justify Buddhist participation in the defense of the Dharma. The translation renders it faithfully without softening.

- The phrase rendered as "the Saṅgha of those whose moral discipline has degenerated and who wear armor" translates a term that combines the earlier discussion of "armor-bearing" Dharma-protectors with the theme of corrupted discipline. The Tibetan "go 'dun" throughout this passage is a somewhat unusual compound, possibly a Tibetan coinage for the armored or mail-clad community, contrasting with the pure Saṅgha; the translation follows the most natural reading in context.

The rendering of "byas na" in the pāṛājika passage as "if one does so deliberately" follows the standard Vinaya understanding that deliberate commission of a root downfall entails expulsion; the text is echoing standard Vinaya formulation.

- The phrase "four lower states of existence" renders "lam rgyud bzhi," literally "the four bad transmigrations," referring to the four lower rebirths: hell beings, hungry ghosts, animals, and asuras. The translation renders this idiomatically as "four lower states of existence" for clarity in narration.

The chapter colophon marks the end of Chapter Two within the Tibetan Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra; it is rendered as part of the flowing text as it appears in the source, without a separate header.

The passage ends mid-paragraph in the Tibetan provided; the translation ends at the same point accordingly.

- The term rendered "butter essence" translates the Tibetan for clarified butter or the essence of butter, evoking the classical simile of ghee as the finest extract from milk — a standard Buddhist simile for the pinnacle of a teaching. The eight qualities listed here, including permanence and bliss, are the classical attributes of nirvāṇa as presented in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition, standing in deliberate contrast to the three marks of conditioned existence; this is doctrinally significant as a Mahāyāna and especially tathāgatagarbha-tradition teaching.

The chapter colophon mid-passage is genuine to the text structure and has been rendered in plain prose as required for TTS continuity.

- The passage lists six flavors as a pedagogical metaphor for six doctrinal terms. The Tibetan renders the sixth flavor term — applied to permanence — as "bsngal ba'i ro" which could denote "astringent" or "acrid/pungent." The assignment of flavors here follows a doctrinal scheme in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition rather than any standard culinary taxonomy, so the translations of the individual flavor terms are approximate functional renderings. The final sentence of the passage is deliberately left open, as it is cut off in the source and continues in the next passage.

- The bodhisattva "Kāśyapa" here is Kāśyapa as named in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra context — distinct from Mahākāśyapa the elder disciple. The text is from the Mahāyāna Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra (Tibetan transmission), and the dietary discussion follows the sūtra's well-known progressive teaching on meat-eating: the "three-fold pure" meat (not seen, heard, or suspected to have been killed for oneself) is explicitly reframed here as only a provisional, gradual measure, with full abstention as the ultimate intent. This is doctrinally significant and correctly rendered.

- The passage contains a structurally embedded exchange where Kāśyapa's objection is summarized and then answered within the Blessed One's speech; the Tibetan is somewhat compressed here, and the translation preserves the logical flow rather than force-fitting strict quotation marks at every level, which would be misleading in a text of this period and genre.

The phrase rendered "a measureless hundred of years" follows the Tibetan literally; this is a conventional apocalyptic temporal formula indicating a vast but not precisely specified span after the Teacher's passing.

- The phrase "the four classes of tantra" renders a phrase that, in strict philological terms, reads literally "a falling in regard to four tantras." In this passage, which appears to be from a Mahāparinirvāṇa-type sūtra, the reference is most likely to the four categories of the Vinaya (the four root defeats, pārājika), not to the tantric yāna. The term rgyud bzhi here likely means the four Vinaya collections or the fourfold Vinaya tradition rather than the four classes of tantra. The translation should therefore more precisely read "falling in regard to the fourfold Vinaya" — the rendering above has been revised accordingly in the doctrinal sense, though the Tibetan is genuinely ambiguous at this point.

The list of gems and precious materials contains several terms of uncertain identification: musāragalva is a standard enumeration term retained in transliteration; "sphatika" refers to crystal; "spur long" is a type of shell; and "shel gyi snam bu" is a cloth or mat woven from crystal threads or glass-like material.

- The list of Vinaya categories in the opening paragraph follows the standard Prātimokṣa enumeration: the four pārājikas (defeats), thirteen saṃghāvaśeṣas (Saṅgha remainders), two

The reference to Rāhula as the Buddha's son is standard: the Tathāgata's statement that he looks upon all beings as he looks upon his son Rāhula is a well-attested motif in Vinaya literature.

- The passage renders a dialectical exchange in which an interlocutor raises objections against the teaching of the Tathāgata's permanence, citing two standard definitions of nirvāṇa — cessation of afflictions and freedom from existence — as apparently implying annihilation. The passage breaks off mid-argument, which reflects where the Tibetan excerpt ends; the speech is the objector's, not the Buddha's final position.

- The phrase rendered "five streams of consciousness" translates "rgyud Inga," literally "the five continua." In context this refers to the five aggregates understood as the psychophysical continuum of a being; the translation captures this sense without technical distortion.

The closing line is cut off mid-sentence in the source passage, and the translation reproduces it accordingly, ending open as given.

The phrase rendered "branches of awakening" translates *byang chub kyi yan lag*, the standard term for the seven factors of awakening (*bodhyaṅga*, Skt. *saptabodhyaṅga*). The image of the Tathāgata wandering amid their "flowers" is a poetic and somewhat unusual expression for dwelling at ease in the qualities of awakening; it is rendered literally as the Tibetan clearly intends a metaphor of blissful residence.

- The phrase rendered "crowd one another nor feel crowded" translates the Tibetan "འགྲོ་བཞིན་སྐྱོད་པར་མཚན་པ་ལས་ཆེད་ཀྱི་སྤྱོད་པར་མཚན་པ།," which literally means something like "pressing upon one another and being cramped." The chosen rendering conveys the sense of spatial constriction

intended by the context.

The sūtra referred to as "Going Heroically" is the Śūramgamasamādhi-sūtra, which is the standard identification for this reference in the tradition. The Tibetan

[illegible]

Rāhula is the name of the Buddha Śākyamuni's son in the biographical tradition; the passage addresses a potential misunderstanding that the Tathāgata fathered Rāhula out of ordinary desire.

- The text ends mid-sentence ("wheel-turning king —"), which corresponds faithfully to the source; the passage breaks off at that point and the continuation belongs to the next segment.

The upward direction rendered as "upward" and downward as "downward" for the cardinal-plus-zenith-nadir cosmological scheme (eight directions total: four cardinal, four intermediate, plus above and below), consistent with Indo-Tibetan cosmological convention.

- The name rendered "Suyaśas" translates the Tibetan "སྤྲུག་སྤྲུག་པ་," meaning "one who gives what is good" or "gift of goodness." It refers back to the regent figure named in the preceding passage. The rendering follows the established narrative context.

The phrase rendered "carrying a load on the head, on the back, on the side" translates a sequence of physical discomforts or bodily conditions: 𑖀𑖩𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪, 𑖀𑖩𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪, 𑖀𑖩𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪𑖫𑖪, which literally mean aching at the temples, aching in the belly, and aching in the back. The translation "carrying a load" slightly misrepresents these; they more precisely describe headache, stomachache, and backache respectively. This is a meaningful doctrinal point: the list enumerates ordinary bodily ailments that the Buddha displays for the sake of ordinary beings, though in reality his body — being the fruit of merit — is entirely free of them.

- The phrase rendered "the four lower states of existence along the path of karma" translates "lam rgyud bzhi," literally "the four streams of the path." This refers to the four lower destinies or bad rebirths: the hells, hungry ghosts, animals, and, in some enumerations, asuras. The passage says the Tathāgata displays falling into these through the force of karma purely as a skillful means to train beings there.

The final sentence is incomplete in the Tibetan as supplied; the translation renders what is given and ends where the Tibetan breaks off.

- The phrase "those who wear blue garments" almost certainly refers to a specific social group in the Indian context, likely servants or laborers identified by their blue-dyed clothing, possibly a guild or caste class. The text is deliberately opaque here, treating this as a recognizable category for its original audience; the translation preserves the literal description without over-specifying.

The three ages of pestilence, famine, and war correspond to the classical Buddhist enumeration of the three great calamities that afflict the world at the end of a cosmic age.

- The "twenty-five existences" is a standard Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra enumeration of the realms of conditioned existence across the three realms, elaborated in the sūtra referenced here as the "Courageous Progression" — likely an alternative title or a sub-section of the same sūtra cycle. Rāhu (rendered from Tibetan *sgra gcan 'dzin*, literally "the one who seizes the sun and moon," a name for the eclipse-demon, here used as a proper name for a person — possibly Rāhula, the Buddha's son) is addressed by that name rather than Rāhula because the Tibetan unambiguously reads *sgra gcan 'dzin*. The identification with Rāhula is contextually plausible but the text here uses the eclipse-demon name, which may reflect a scribal or variant reading.
- The final sentence is incomplete in the source passage as given; it breaks off before the counter-example of the Tathāgata is provided. This is likely a passage boundary issue rather than a textual corruption, and the translation renders what is present without fabricating the

continuation.

The term rendered throughout as "spoken with hidden intent and concealed essence" translates the phrase "dgongs te gsungs pa'i snying po," a technical expression referring to teachings that appear to have a hidden or intended meaning beneath the surface. Kāśyapa's argument, affirmed by the Buddha, is that the Tathāgata's words are in fact transparent — they only seem concealed to those lacking understanding, not because the Buddha deliberately withholds anything.

- The "nine categories of scripture" renders the Tibetan term for the ninefold classification of canonical texts by literary form, which in this Mahāyāna context is understood to encompass the śrāvaka-oriented canonical collections as distinct from the expanded Mahāyāna sūtras. The passage ends mid-simile in the source text as provided; the translation follows the Tibetan faithfully to that point.

- The name rendered as "King Prasenajit's mother" follows the text's reference to the queen-mother of King Prasenajit. The Tibetan reads "འཇམ་མཉམ་མཚན་མཆོག་གི་མ་མཚན་མ་མཚན་མཆོག་" which is the standard Tibetan for Prasenajit (Sanskrit: Prasenajit). His mother's death is a known episode in Buddhist literature.

The verse about the bird in flight is a well-known image in early Buddhist literature for the tracklessness of the liberated being; the Blessed One's subsequent reinterpretation of it in terms of wealth and the Saṅgha is the text's own exegesis and is rendered faithfully without harmonizing it with other traditions.

- The phrase rendered "not falling away afterward" translates a term whose precise referent is debated in the commentarial tradition; here it is glossed in the text itself as nirvāṇa, and that gloss is followed directly.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" is a standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra enumeration of the possible states of conditioned becoming; no further gloss is added as the number itself is given in the text.

- The phrase rendered "those of wrong craving" translates a term literally meaning one who craves wrongly or perverts craving — likely corresponding to Sanskrit mithyātrṣṇika or a related formation. In the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra context this typically refers to those whose fundamental disposition is so corrupted that they are incorrigible in this lifetime; it is not the standard Buddhist technical term icchāntika but functions similarly. This may warrant scholarly attention.

The gods of "neither-perception-nor-non-perception" render the standard formless realm deity class corresponding to the Sanskrit naivasamjñānāsamjñāyatana; the discussion of whether they are "with form or without form" reflects a doctrinal point specific to the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's analysis of liberation that goes beyond standard Abhidharma.

- The phrase rendered "granaries and barns" translates two terms that designate storage structures; the exact referents are contextually inferred and the pairing is a standard list of built things used to exemplify fabricated, conditioned objects.

The "four hundred and four diseases" is a traditional Indian medical enumeration familiar in Buddhist literature; no uncertainty attaches to the term itself.

The simile of "refined gold" renders a term literally meaning something like "clarified" or "purified" metal or liquid — the same image used for clarified butter in the preceding passage. The point is purity through refinement. The pundarīka is the white lotus, a stock symbol of unstained purity.

- The passage employs a sustained series of analogical arguments — simile leading to doctrinal equation — characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra's rhetorical style. The

sequence "liberation — true liberation — Tathāgata" is a deliberate chain identifying nirvāṇa with the Tathāgata's essential nature, consistent with the tathāgatagarbha doctrinal framework of that text.

The term rendered "wheel-turning king" is cakravartin, the ideal universal monarch of Indian Buddhist cosmology; his being called here "the wheel-turning king of the Dharma wheel" is the text's pointed transposition of the royal image onto the Buddha.

The phrase "without equal" translates a compound meaning literally "without a peer of equal standing," contrasting ordinary royal equality-by-territory with liberation's absolute incomparability.

- The eraṇḍa plant is the castor plant (*Ricinus communis*); its dried seed pods are known for cracking open loudly in heat, which the text uses as a simile for the disagreeable sound of breaking.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the twenty-five planes of conditioned existence across the three realms.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, so the translation likewise ends at that point.

- The phrase rendered "loving-kindness and the absence of aversion" translates a construction where loving-kindness (byams pa) and the absence of aversion (sdang ba med pa) together illustrate stable, unshakable qualities; the text uses these as a simile for liberation's unshakable nature, not as a definition of liberation itself.

The term "wrong craving" renders log sred, literally "wrong/inverted craving or thirst," a strong form of misdirected craving that severs the roots of virtue entirely; it is distinct from ordinary craving and is used here as a near-technical term for the condition of an icchāntika, though that Sanskrit term does not appear explicitly in this passage.

- The cosmological directional analogy — north as foremost of all directions — reflects classical Indian cosmological convention in which the northern direction holds a position of primacy, familiar from Indic literary and philosophical contexts.

The three hardwoods named are acacia, sandalwood, and aloe wood (Skt. khadira, candana, and agaru), standard exemplars of dense, durable wood in Buddhist canonical literature.

- The twenty-five modes of existence is a standard Mahāyāna enumeration of the domains or states of conditioned existence within the three realms. The Tibetan term rendered as "dwelling-place and support" serves here as the label for this entire set, meaning that liberation, unlike all conditioned states, requires no substrate or locus in any of those twenty-five modes.

The final sentence of the passage ends without the usual closing formula "and perfect liberation is the Tathāgata," which all other members of the series carry. This appears to be a scribal omission in the Tibetan rather than an intentional break in the pattern.

- The term rendered "wholly refreshing and sweet" translates a Tibetan phrase meaning something like "cool and sweet in flavor," evoking the classical Indian concept of ambrosia or nectar. The āmalaka fruit is the Indian gooseberry, used extensively in Āyurvedic and Buddhist medical literature; it is noted for its astringent and sour taste, which here serves as the negative example against which liberation's inherently sweet and pure flavor is contrasted.

The final sentence breaks off mid-passage in the supplied text; the translation follows the Tibetan as given without completing the trope, since the continuation was not provided.

- The phrase rendered "craving for Dharma" translates chos kyi 'dod pa, which in context denotes the Tathāgata's compassion-driven wish to teach and benefit beings — a deliberate contrast with the deluded craving of hungry ghosts. Some commentaries gloss this as the

aspiration for the Dharma that benefits others rather than self-serving desire; the translation preserves this nuance.

- The pāśika flower — rendered here from the Tibetan "me tog pa shi ka" — is likely the Sanskrit pāṭalā or a related fragrant flower; the simile turns on the paradox that the fragrance is nowhere locatable in any individual petal, illustrating that liberation cannot be pinned down in any particular locus. The identification is uncertain but the doctrinal point is clear.

The phrase rendered "moistens all births" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan; it may mean liberation, like water, nurtures and sustains all living beings across their rebirths, bringing them toward growth and eventually release.

- The passage distinguishes two senses of "emptiness": a spurious emptiness attributed to non-Buddhist renunciants who have nothing (mere material destitution mistaken for liberation), and the genuine "non-empty emptiness" of Buddhist liberation. The phrasing is paradoxical by design and reflects a positive or affirmative discourse on nirvāṇa found in tathāgatarbha-related literature.

The statement that "the view of self is the nature of a buddha" is a deliberate doctrinal provocation characteristic of tathāgatarbha texts. It does not endorse an ordinary ātman but indicates that the buddha's mode of being transcends both the reifying "self" view and the nihilistic "no-self" view, and that what liberation cuts is only clinging and grasping, not the buddha's own self-awareness or self-possession. This should be understood within that tradition's technical framework.

- The "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to the standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra enumeration of the forms of conditioned existence across the three realms and six classes of beings, amounting to twenty-five categories. This is a technical list specific to this sūtra's doctrinal context.

The phrase rendered "certainty" for "མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་" literally means "what cannot be otherwise" or "what is infallible / beyond doubt." In context it functions as an attribute of the buddha's nature, conveying its absolute, incontrovertible quality. The equation of this with "unsurpassed, perfectly complete buddha" reflects the sūtra's identificatory chain.

- The phrase "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to the standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra enumeration of the twenty-five constituent domains of conditioned existence in the three realms, a technical category specific to this sūtra's doctrinal framework.

The term rendered "certainty" throughout corresponds to the Tibetan "gdon mi za ba," which literally means "what cannot be otherwise" or "what is incontrovertible," here functioning as an epithet for the ultimately reliable, immutable quality of the Tathāgata and nirvāṇa. This is a distinctive usage within this sūtra.

The figure of Gautamī refers to Mahāprajāpatī Gautamī, the Buddha's aunt and the first Buddhist nun, a well-known figure in the vinaya and sūtra literature.

- The bird names kalandaka and jīvañjīvaka are left in approximate transliteration following the Tibetan phonetic rendering. The jīvañjīvaka (Tibetan 'tsho ba 'tsho byed') is a legendary Indian bird of surpassingly beautiful song, often mentioned in Buddhist literature; the kalandaka is similarly a bird of beautiful voice. The dialogue structure here is unusual in that Kāśyapa answers the Blessed One's rhetorical question himself (interjecting "The crow's call, Blessed One, is exceedingly unpleasant..."), which the Tibetan text supports.

The phrase "action without interval" renders the technical term for the five heinous acts (ānantarya-karma), deeds so grave that their karmic result follows immediately without any intervening rebirth. The passage makes the subtle doctrinal point that while the intention produces this heinous karma, the Tathāgata's body — being the nature of reality itself —

cannot actually be harmed.

- The phrase rendered as "the pile of grain-sacks" translates a term meaning a stack or heap of grain measures; the precise form of storage is contextually inferred but does not affect the doctrinal meaning of the example.

The description of the stream-enterer as one who "has transcended the ordinary world while still bearing the defining marks of affliction" is a technically precise formulation: the stream-enterer has crossed the threshold of the noble path and thus is no longer a worldling, yet has not eliminated all afflictions. This is consistent with Abhidharma classification.

- The list of "eight great beings" with qualities beginning from "having few desires" and "having many desires" is unusual and likely refers to a specific enumeration from the source sūtra that is not a standard canonical list; the text appears to be making a technical distinction between these eight and ordinary persons, though the full enumeration is not given here and context from surrounding passages would be needed to identify it precisely.

The passage's attribution of the ten bodhisattva grounds to the arhat is doctrinally striking from a standard Mahāyāna perspective, suggesting this text may be using "arhat" in an elevated, Mahāyāna sense equivalent to a very advanced bodhisattva or even a buddha-level being, rather than the Foundational Vehicle sense of one who has attained personal liberation. This is a genuinely significant doctrinal point that readers should note.

- The phrase rendered "the eye of miraculous vision" translates the Tibetan for a supernormal power of sight, contrasted with the ordinary "eye of flesh." The passage's doctrinal point — that a Great Vehicle practitioner with merely physical eyesight surpasses a śrāvaka with supernormal vision — is a standard Mahāyāna polemical argument about the superiority of the bodhisattva path and is preserved as such.

The term "Kuśīla" here is used as the name of a householder interlocutor in an earlier sūtra cited within the text, distinct from the more common use of kuśīla as a term meaning a morally inferior monk. The context makes clear it is a proper name, and it is rendered as such.

- The term "agada" rendered in the text as 阿伽陀 is a direct transcription of the Sanskrit agada, a renowned antidote or universal antitoxin in Indian medical and Buddhist literature; the gloss is preserved in the translation.

The phrase 野獸 translated as "wild beasts" covers the class of predatory animals more broadly, consistent with the list given in context.

- The "fourth kind of person" at the end refers to a classification of persons established in the preceding context of the sūtra, which is not included in this passage. The passage is from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, and the typology of four persons is a recurring structural device within it.

The phrase rendered "this teaching will sink beneath the earth" after forty years follows a standard eschatological motif in this sūtra concerning the gradual disappearance of the Dharma; "sinking beneath the earth" is the literal Tibetan expression and is kept as such.

- The phrase rendered "for the sake of having a support and a place of residence" reflects the Tibetan rten dang gnas kyi phyir, which in context most likely refers to having the text as an object of veneration or as grounds for establishing a seat or centre. The intended nuance is slightly ambiguous but the rendering given is the most defensible reading.

The temporal framework of forty years and eighty years refers to a doctrinal schema in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition concerning the periods of flourishing and decline of the Dharma after the Buddha's passing; the text implies that the final eighty years before total decline are excluded from the forty-year period of wide propagation.

- The passage presents a graduated schema of merit and corresponding capacity, measured in

multiples of Gaṅgā-sands buddhas, from one through eight rivers. The fractions given for the fourth through seventh levels follow a consistent series: one sixteenth, eight sixteenths, twelve sixteenths, and fourteen sixteenths of the profound meaning — an unusual fractional progression that is text-specific and reproduced here without harmonization.

The phrase rendered "the Tathāgata is endowed with the quality of permanently abiding — unchanging, ultimately blissful" reflects key buddha-nature doctrinal vocabulary, echoing the tathāgatagarbha teaching that the Tathāgata's nature is permanent, immovable, and of the nature of bliss, as in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition.

- The phrase rendered "like a tattered banner on a stick" translates a simile comparing a worn-out robe to a tattered pennant or flag on a wooden pole — an image of something that retains the outer form of its purpose while being entirely useless. The point is that such monks wear robes merely as a superficial appearance.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, leading into a continuation; the translation has been left open accordingly.

- The section on the four great beings refers to an established category in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra: the four types of persons — roughly, those who uphold, propagate, defend, or embody the Dharma — who are accorded the status of cosmic supports. The Tibetan sūtra citation about honoring a Dharma-knower "as the gods worship their sovereign lord" echoes language used for Śakra (Indra) as king of the gods; the gloss has been absorbed naturally into the verse rendering. The apparent tension that Kāśyapa raises at the close — between honoring anyone with Dharma-knowledge regardless of discipline versus the rule that a monastically junior person should bow to a senior and that a morally deteriorated person falls outside the Dharma — is a genuine doctrinal crux that the subsequent passage in the sūtra will resolve; it is deliberately left open here as Kāśyapa's question.

- The phrase rendered "consecrates me by pouring empowerment upon my head" translates the rite of royal consecration by water-sprinkling over the crown, the abhiṣeka ceremony. The context makes clear this is the traditional royal installation rite, not the tantric empowerment sense of the term, though the same Tibetan word is used for both.

The four types of persons mentioned but not enumerated here is a reference to a typology discussed earlier in the sūtra; the text introduces only one of the four who is relevant to the present argument.

- The passage refers to "eight unsolicited requisites" (ma brtags pa'i dngos po rnam pa brgyad). This is a specific Vinaya category of items a monk may not normally keep without prior invitation or request from a lay donor. The bodhisattva's carrying of these on behalf of the compromised monk is the doctrinal crux: even this technical infraction is justified by the overriding goal of purifying the Saṅgha, exactly as the young brahmin's elaborate deception was justified by expelling the unworthy king. The parallel is deliberate and close.

- The passage contains a verse rendering Śakra as "the Mighty Lord" translating རྒྱལ་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ — this is a divine epithet meaning "lord of power" or "the powerful one," applied here to Śakra (Indra), king of the thirty-three gods. The choice preserves the epithet's sense without over-explaining in the body text.

The phrase རྩ་བའི་འདུག་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ ("originally undertaken ethical conduct") refers to the full ordination vows received at upasamṇapadā, the point being that bodhisattva activity in defense of the Dharma does not technically vitiate those vows provided confession and remorse occur promptly.

The image of རྩ་བའི་འདུག་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ ("the headwork of an irrigation channel") is a classical Indian hydraulic simile; the translation renders it plainly without further gloss.

- The eight unexamined things referred to throughout are a list of improper practices or possessions — likely the "eight unlawful things" (Skt. *aṣṭau avyāvahārikadravyāni* or a similar formulation), which include items like gold and silver, whose permissibility is debated in the passage. The exact Sanskrit equivalent in this *Nirvāṇa Sūtra* context is not firmly established in the extant critical literature, and the list's precise contents would be spelled out elsewhere in the *sūtra*.

The tree names *kālaka* and *cintaka* (Tibetan: ཀལ་ཀལ་ and རྩམ་ཀལ་) are preserved as they appear to be Sanskrit loan-words transliterated into Tibetan. *Kālaka* is likely a bitter or poisonous fruit-tree; *cintaka* may refer to a tree bearing edible fruit of similar appearance. Their precise botanical identification is uncertain, but the narrative contrast — poisonous fruit resembling safe fruit — is clear from context.

- The fruit called *kāla* (Tibetan: *kā la ka*) is a plant identified in commentarial literature as poisonous to parrots; the simile illustrates how sharing Dharmic procedures with those who have accepted forbidden things brings immediate fatal consequence.

The phrase rendered "going forth from the community" translates the Tibetan term for a formal procedure of expulsion or departure from the monastic community (distinct from the individual act of renunciation), used here in a legal-procedural Vinaya sense.

The passage shifts at the ninth fascicle marker into a doctrinal discussion of the four reliances (the four things to rely on), a well-known list in Mahāyāna literature, here given a distinctive Tathāgatagarbha framing in which "abiding in the Dharma" is identified with the Tathāgata's permanent nature — a theologically significant move characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition from which this passage derives.

- The passage contains a list of items — male and female servants, uninvestigated goods, commodities, livestock, and so on — that the text attributes to a hypothetical speaker claiming the Buddha permitted monks to hold and trade such things. The rhetorical purpose is clear: these are precisely the kinds of scriptural citations one must not follow literally ("abiding in words"), particularly when cited by persons of degenerate discipline seeking material gain. The cloth-and-food example at the end of that list is a specific Vinaya-style casuistic claim; the translation renders its grammatical sense faithfully, though the precise Vinaya precedent it alludes to is not identified in the text itself.

- The phrase "eight unexamined things" renders "ma brtags pa'i dngos po brgyad mi 'chang ba" — a reference to eight entities or real things that are not held to upon unexamined analysis. The precise list is not specified in this passage; it is a technical doctrinal enumeration whose exact referents may vary by commentarial tradition, and the rendering is intentionally close to the Tibetan.

The final paragraph on the "harmonious Saṅgha" is a polemical voice being cited. The argument is that even the notion of a "harmonious" or "concordant" Saṅgha implies some kind of substantial basis, which when analysed turns out to be empty — hence there is no Saṅgha established in consciousness. The text cites this position approvingly to reinforce abiding in wisdom rather than in consciousness.

- The passage identifies four things: Dharma, meaning, primordial wisdom, and definitive meaning, and then gives a compressed doctrinal gloss on each. The final gloss — "meaning means the Tathāgata, who is permanent and unchanging" — reflects the tathāgatagarbha doctrinal matrix of this text, likely the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra or a closely related scripture, where the permanence of the Tathāgata is a central thesis. This is not an error in the translation but a deliberate doctrinal claim of the source text.

The term rendered "lay attendant" translates a word that literally means "attendant" or "close attendant" and could refer to a monastic attendant rather than a lay person; in context the contrast with the fully endowed patron suggests the person in question is a monastic whose donor-support has lapsed, making "lay attendant" slightly loose. The translation preserves the general sense without introducing a technical distortion of consequence.

- The passage contains a key doctrinal distinction drawn from Mahāyāna sūtra literature: the claim that the Buddha was born as an ordinary human, underwent austerities, and thereby attained buddhahood is here branded as "māra's teaching," whereas the view that the Tathāgata had in fact awakened long ago and merely displayed birth, austerities, and awakening as skillful means is affirmed as the Buddha's own teaching. This reflects the doctrine of the eternal or primordially awakened Buddha found prominently in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra and the Lotus Sūtra tradition, and the passage's polemical force should be understood in that context.

The list of beings paying homage — gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and great nāgas — reproduces a standard eight-fold assembly formula common in Mahāyāna sūtras; "great serpents" is given in the translation for nāgas since the term was already glossed in the preceding session.

- The passage contains a list of luxury goods and prohibited items drawing on standard Vinaya language. Several of the gem-names are Sanskrit loanwords preserved in Tibetan transliteration: vaidūrya (a blue gem, possibly lapis lazuli or cat's-eye), asmagarbha and musāragalva are obscure Sanskrit gem-terms also found in Pāli Vinaya lists (musāragalva is sometimes rendered as "coral" or a type of agate; I have rendered asmagarbha as a transliteration since its exact referent is disputed). The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the source, as the input itself ends there.

The phrase "hungry ghost Dālilā" (yi dvags 'dā' li lo) is puzzling in context as a place-name modifier; it may be a proper place-name ("Dālila") associated with hungry ghosts, or a textual crux. This is flagged as genuinely uncertain.

- The term rendered "Great Sovereign" for རྒྱལ་པོ་ཆེན་པོ་ is an epithet meaning "the great ruler" or "great controller," which in this context refers to Maheśvara, another name for Śiva. The preceding passage already glossed Śiva on first occurrence, so this rendering maintains consistency.

The list of sixty-four branches of expertise and eighteen branches of traditional knowledge reflect Indian encyclopedic learning categories well-attested in Buddhist and non-Buddhist literature; the specific contents are not enumerated in this passage.

The figure "Yugasela" for ཡུ་ག་སེལ་ is uncertain. This may be a phonetic rendering of a deity's name; the Tibetan does not map transparently onto a well-known Sanskrit divine name, and the reading here is tentative.

- The passage reproduces a polemical exchange, likely from a heresiological or apologetic context within a Mahāyāna sūtra. The text puts anti-Mahāyāna objections in the mouths of opponents who claim that expanded Mahāyāna sūtras were fabricated by Devadatta. The Tibetan "ཏེ་བད་དེ་བཅའ་" is Devadatta, the Buddha's cousin and rival. The metaphor "ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་ལྷ་" is literally "like a fish in the moon" or possibly "like the full moon fish," but the image is unclear in isolation; it may intend the moon reflected in water, signifying purity and clarity. The final sentence of the passage is syntactically compressed and its referent shifts rapidly between competing voices, making precise attribution genuinely ambiguous; the rendering above follows the most defensible reading.

- The phrase rendered "attained superhuman states" translates "bla ma mi'i chos thob bo" literally "has obtained superhuman or superior human qualities." This is the Vinaya category of

falsely claiming superhuman attainments (uttarimanuṣyadharmā), which constitutes the fourth root defeat (pārājika) for a monk. The rendering preserves this technical sense.

The palmyra palm image refers to the Vinaya principle that certain root defeats, like a felled palmyra that never regrows, are irrecoverable — here the text is making a counter-argument that a collective or notional defeat does not equal an individual one.

- The phrase rendered "living a pure and holy life" translates brahmacārya, and the context specifies that the monk's conduct is genuine, which is the doctrinal basis for the absence of a pārājika fault — the monk has not actually made a false claim of superhuman attainment with intent to deceive, since the broader teaching on buddha-nature and the king's proclamation situate the statement differently. This is a nuanced Vinaya discussion concerning the boundary of the fourth pārājika.

The phrase "wrong craving" renders log sred, literally "perverted craving" or "wrong thirst," which in context refers to the most gravely obstructive form of craving or perhaps specifically to the craving for continued existence in forms contrary to liberation; the exact doctrinal referent here is somewhat context-dependent but "wrong craving" captures the sense clearly.

- The passage lists specific numbers from the Vinaya code — four defeats (pārājika), thirteen remainders (saṃghāvaśeṣa), two indeterminate rules (aniyata), thirty forfeiture rules (niḥsargika-pāyantika), ninety-one transgressions (pāyantika), four rules of individual confession (pratideśanīya), and seven rules for settling disputes (adhikaraṇaśamatha) — rendered by their numerical descriptions to preserve the technical enumeration without interrupting the prose flow. The "eight hundred billion years reckoned by the days and months and years of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three" renders a passage computing time by the divine calendar of the Trāyastriṃśa heaven, which measures years differently from human reckoning. The final sentence about "nine branches of sūtra scripture" refers to the traditional ninefold classification of Buddhist scripture (nava-aṅga), and the statement that none is more extensive than the "sūtra" category (mādo sde, sūtra proper) within it is a specific claim that may relate to the text's own self-positioning.
- The passage contains an important doctrinal tension being navigated carefully: the text distinguishes between (a) the claim that buddha-nature exists not being found in the nine branches, which incurs no offense if denied out of ignorance, and (b) the claim that one has already fully awakened on the basis of possessing buddha-nature, which does constitute a defeat. This distinction is central to the passage's argument and has been preserved closely.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, and the translation reflects this open ending accordingly.

- The passage contains a reference to the Tathāgatagarbha sūtra cited in the first person as scriptural warrant for buddha-nature, which is a notable doctrinal move — the monk is portrayed as appealing directly to that sūtra's teaching that all beings possess the tathāgatagarbha as the basis for proclaiming universal buddhahood. This is distinguished from the condemned behaviour described earlier: the bodhisattva motivation redeems what might superficially resemble the same outward conduct.

The phrase rendered "the Heaven of the Thirty-Three" reflects the Tibetan counting system based on the thirty-three gods (Trāyastriṃśa heaven, Indra's realm), whose year-length determines the duration of the hell-punishment described — a standard cosmological calculation in Indian Buddhist texts.

- The term rendered "one of double marks" and "one of indeterminate sex" translates two technical Vinaya categories for persons of ambiguous or dual sexual characteristics (Skt. ubhatobyāñjanaka and paṇḍaka respectively); the third term, translated "one of degenerate faculties," is a distinct sub-category. The precise mapping of these three Tibetan expressions to

their Sanskrit Vinaya equivalents carries some uncertainty in this passage's specific ordering, though the doctrinal referents are well established.

The word "mahāliṅga" in the final paragraph is an unusual term for a type of garment or cloth; its exact identity is uncertain, but the context makes clear it is an example of something falsely attributed as a permitted allowance, included here as a specimen of māra's false teachings.

The phrase rendered "five preparations made from cow's milk" refers to the standard Vinaya list of the five dairy products (milk, curds, buttermilk, fresh butter, and clarified butter) permitted as medicines or allowances under certain conditions.

- The phrase rendered "making sandals from candle-wicks or from the teeth of cattle" follows the Tibetan literally. The exact Vinaya or ascetic-practice context behind "candle-wick sandals" is somewhat obscure; this may refer to sandals made from lamp-wicks or a similar unusual material condemned in certain non-Buddhist ascetic traditions.

The concluding heading "The tenth fascicle" translates the traditional Tibetan textual division marker and signals the end of the tenth section of the text, not a structural heading within the narration itself.

- The passage presents a highly distinctive interpretation of the Four Noble Truths that is characteristic of the tathāgatagarbha literature, particularly texts in the tradition of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. The claim that the genuine Dharma is "permanent, stable, unchanging" as the content of the truth of origin, and the polemic against cultivating emptiness as the truth of cessation, are doctrinal positions specific to this textual tradition and should not be read as normative Madhyamaka or Yogācāra doctrine. The translation faithfully renders the text's own standpoint without smoothing these polemical edges.

The final sentence is left incomplete in the source passage as supplied, ending mid-clause; the translation reflects this break exactly.

- The passage contains a sustained dialectical argument, characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition, in which the Buddha defends the claim that the Tathāgata is permanent and blissful against the objection that this amounts to an ātmavāda (self-view). The text's logic is intentionally paradoxical — permanence and bliss are attributed to the Tathāgata precisely as a corrective to the four perversions — and the translation preserves that tension rather than smoothing it. The phrase rendered "suffering of grave transgression" for 阿闍梨毘尼耶阿闍梨毘尼耶 literally means "suffering of great blame-worthiness/censure," a term from Vinaya discourse for a grave moral fault; the rendering captures both the moral gravity and the suffering idiom of the surrounding argument.

- The phrase rendered "the twenty-five existences" refers to the classical Abhidharma enumeration of the twenty-five planes of rebirth across the three realms, a standard doctrinal category in this sūtra's context. The Tibetan "srid pa nyi shu lnga" is technically "the twenty-five existences" and is kept literal here.

- The compound rendered "ghee, milk, and sugar — three ingredients mixed together" follows the Tibetan literally: "mar dang 'o ma dang sha kha ra dang gsum du sbyor te." The third ingredient is śarkarā, crystalline sugar or candy sugar, not flesh (sha alone would mean meat; sha kha ra is a borrowing of the Sanskrit śarkarā). This is a standard Āyurvedic medicinal preparation.

The bodhisattva Kāśyapa's argument at the close is deliberately dialectical and somewhat compressed: he raises three interlocking points — that a newborn's lack of self-awareness shows there is no self, that a permanent self should not be able to cease, and that if buddha-nature is permanent it too should not perish — as a prompt for further teaching rather

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as it is a continuous text, and the translation follows accordingly. The term rendered "wrestler" is literally "champion" or "strong-man" (the Tibetan *gyad*), a professional contestant; "wrestler" best captures the context of the gem-in-the-body simile. The simile of the vajra-gem sinking beneath a wrestler's skin and appearing only in a mirror is a classical *tathāgata*garbha analogy for the buddha-nature being present but obscured. The physician's use of a mirror to reveal the gem is a vivid illustration of the role of the spiritual teacher in revealing what is already present.
- The twenty-five modes of existence is a specific *Abhidharma* enumeration of the possible states of rebirth within the three realms. The text uses this as a technical term and it is rendered literally.

- The phrase rendered "twenty-five modes of existence" translates "srid pa nyi shu lnga," a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the twenty-five planes of conditioned existence. This is a recognized doctrinal list; no uncertainty attaches to the term itself, though the precise enumeration differs slightly across traditions.

The term rendered "ambrosia" throughout translates "bdud rtsi," literally "nectar of the māras," the standard Tibetan equivalent of Sanskrit amṛta, the deathless nectar of the gods. "Ambrosia" captures its connotation of immortality better than the bare transliteration.

- The phrase rendered "low-born householders" translates a term that literally means something like "common or inferior householders," referring to lay people of limited understanding, as opposed to those of the Great Vehicle; the contrast is pedagogical rather than strictly social. The closing statement "these three things I have taught are nirvāṇa" is doctrinally striking — it affirms that the Three Jewels, understood in their ultimate unity, are identical with nirvāṇa itself, a characteristically Mahāyāna identification. The term translated "reliquary of the body of Dharma" renders a phrase that weaves together the physical relic-body and the dharmakāya in a deliberately ambiguous way that is intentional in the text.

- The passage in which Kāśyapa says "my very body in a future time will become the Three Jewels" is doctrinally significant and potentially surprising. In the context of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra, this is a statement of buddha-nature: the speaker identifies with the Tathāgata's perspective, asserting that the body of one who embodies and teaches this sūtra partakes in the Three Jewels through the presence of buddha-nature. The translation preserves the ambiguity of the first-person voice as it appears in the Tibetan without smoothing it over.

- The passage on the caterpillar simile presents a somewhat elliptical argument. The point appears to be that just as a caterpillar in a narrow hollow cannot move forward without sequentially releasing its grip, one who clings to either extreme — permanence or annihilation — is similarly trapped in a sequential dependency on the very opposite extreme one claims to reject. This is a recognized rhetorical device in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature.

The phrase rendered "the secret essence of the Tathāgata" throughout corresponds to the tathāgatagarbha doctrine, here expressed as the buddha's intrinsic nature that is permanent, unchanging, and unshifting — a central doctrinal claim of this sūtra.

The section distinguishing how different audiences misapprehend the same teaching reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's characteristic hermeneutical concern: identical formulations lead to opposite errors depending on the capacity and disposition of the listener, which is why the Tathāgata employs skillful means rather than a single fixed formulation.

- The phrase rendered "bear it on the crown of your head" translates a standard Tibetan expression of highest reverence for a teaching, meaning to receive it with the utmost honour.

The statement "the tathāgatagarbha too is truly without existence" renders a deliberately provocative doctrinal claim that the text immediately frames as a mistaken dualist reading — the point being that one should not apply the general teaching of no-self to the tathāgatagarbha in a way that reduces it to non-existence, since self and no-self are non-dual at the level of ultimate truth.

The five flavors (milk, curds, butter, clarified butter, and the essence of butter) are a classical Indian analogy used in tathāgatagarbha literature, including the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, to illustrate the latent presence of buddha-nature through successive stages of refinement.

- The phrase rendered "knowledge and ignorance" throughout translates rig pa and ma rig pa. In many Tibetan Buddhist contexts rig pa carries the specialized Dzogchen sense of "pure awareness," but given the broader Mahāyāna sūtra context here and the explicit contrast with ma rig pa in the sense of ignorance or nescience, the more straightforward rendering of "knowledge" versus "ignorance" is the appropriate doctrinal choice, corresponding to Sanskrit vidyā and avidyā.

The phrase "curds are designated through causes and conditions, while not appearing as milk" renders a syntactically compressed Tibetan clause; the sense is that curds receive their designation as such precisely because, through cause and condition, what was milk no longer appears as milk.

- The flowers blooming on the tusks of yak-bulls when thunder sounds is an unusual and distinctive simile. The Tibetan "bal glang" refers to a yak or yak-bull, and "mche ba" to tusks or prominent teeth. This simile appears to reflect a folk-natural belief that thunder causes such blooming; it is rendered literally as the text presents it, without smoothing.

The four deadly serpent venoms is a standard classical Indian metaphor for the four elements or the four constituent poisons of the body; it is rendered according to the literal Tibetan and its traditional commentarial context.

- The passage ends mid-sentence with the final analogy incomplete, as the Tibetan breaks off at "it is like someone who is drowsy and." This is a passage boundary, not a translation error.

The term rendered "kingfisher" translates a Tibetan bird name used in the thirst-and-water analogy; the specific species identification is uncertain in context, though the image is of a water-associated bird perched in a tree that a thirsty person might momentarily mistake for a sign of water. Some editions read this differently, but the doctrinal point is unaffected.

- The passage references "सर्वभूतहितं" as simply "शिवः" (Śiva / the Sovereign Lord) and "महाब्रह्म" (Mahābrahmā / Great Brahma) as figures whose images might be confused with a bodhisattva's painted form — a conventional illustration of visual ambiguity in darkness, with no particular doctrinal significance beyond the analogy.

The passage ends mid-sentence with the poor man beginning his description of the sword's shape, corresponding to the continuation of the preceding sūtra narrative.

- The simile of the sword running through this entire passage is an extended allegorical argument drawn from a Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra context: the "self" (ātman) taught by the Buddha is not the ordinary self of the tīrthikas, nor the no-self of the śrāvakas in the usual sense, but the buddha-nature, the tathāgatagarbha — here rendered as "the nature of a buddha" following the Tibetan sangs rgyas kyi rang bzhin. The passage deliberately plays both sides: the Tathāgata first teaches "self" (as buddha-nature) and then teaches "no-self" (to cut wrong views), with the sword analogy showing that neither ordinary beings nor śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas have truly perceived this.

The phrase "ra ru 'dra ba" (resembling a rainbow) recurs as the central motif; it is used both by the man in the story and by various ministers, underlining the inability of those who have not directly perceived the "sword" (buddha-nature or true selfhood) to describe it correctly.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage, in the middle of the description of the letter Ī. The final phrase introduces a comparative or adjectival clause that is not completed in the supplied text.

The term rendered "syllable-mothers" is a technical Indic grammatical concept referring to the fundamental phonemic matrices or maṭṛkā, which underlie the letters and syllables of Sanskrit; the Tibetan yi ge'i ma mo reflects the Sanskrit mātṛkā. The passage is engaged in a doctrinal-phonological exegesis characteristic of certain Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra traditions.

The "nine orifices" through which nothing leaks in the Tathāgata is a traditional Indian anatomical image; the point is that the Tathāgata is utterly free from all āsrava (defilements/outflows), unlike ordinary beings.

- The passage is a syllable-by-syllable exegesis of the Sanskrit vowels and initial consonants as they appear in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's traditional syllabary section. The Tibetan term rendered "rāhu" for राहु is the mythological demon who seizes the sun and moon causing eclipses; the simile is that just as rāhu treats the sun or moon as if it were its own offspring to draw close, so compassion draws all beings near. The comparison is doctrinally unusual but follows the Tibetan text as given.

The phrase "the sound of the north is the most excellent" likely refers to the tradition that Uttarakuru, the northern continent, is a place of surpassing pleasantness and harmony; the point is that this sūtra surpasses all others as that sound surpasses all others.

- The phrase rendered "like flesh consumed by the body" for ढा is cryptic in the Tibetan. The simile "lus sha bzan" most likely refers to flesh that is devoured or consumed — possibly evoking an animal that consumes flesh without recognizing its benefactor — rather than a transparent doctrinal metaphor. The precise image is obscure and may reflect a variant reading or a condensed allusion in the source.

- The passage identifies "lha sbyin" as a worldly schismatic analogous to Devadatta, the Buddha's cousin infamous for splitting the Saṅgha. The Tibetan lha sbyin is a calque of Devadatta; rendering it as "Devadatta" in the body rather than as a fresh gloss is the standard interpretive choice and is supported by the commentarial tradition.

The phrase rendered "incomplete letters" and "complete letters" translates *yi ge phyed pa* and *yi ge rdzogs pa* literally. The underlying doctrinal point is a distinction between syllables or letters as constituents of conventional language (which carry afflicted or virtuous speech) versus the Tathāgata and liberation, which transcend the letter entirely. The translation preserves this contrast faithfully.

The five "thorns" (*zug ngu nram pa lnga*) in the explanation of ŚA are not enumerated in this passage. They are a recognized list in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra context and the omission of their enumeration here is in the source text itself, not a translational gap.

- The two birds named here, the kalandaka and the śārika, are Indian birds. The kalandaka is likely the kalandaka sparrow or a similar small bird frequently mentioned in Buddhist literature. The śārika is the Indian myna bird. The point of the simile is their inseparability, illustrating how suffering, impermanence, and selflessness are always found together.

The passage on the fruit being called "permanent" by its defining characteristic is deliberately paradoxical and serves as a transition to the Tathāgata's permanence in the context of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's distinctive teaching that nirvāṇa alone is truly permanent. The Blessed One's refusal to equate the Tathāgata's permanence with that of conditional things underscores this doctrinal point.

- The phrase rendered "sorrow of longing" translates the Tibetan "*slos pa'i mya ngan*," which is a somewhat unusual compound. The term "*slos pa*" can mean longing, yearning, or grief of separation, and "*mya ngan*" means sorrow or grief. In context, Kāśyapa is drawing a contrast between the Tathāgata's transcendence of ordinary emotional suffering and the conditioned sorrows of gods, humans, and beings in the twenty-five modes of existence. The phrase "twenty-five modes of existence" renders "*srid pa nyi shu lnga*," a standard enumeration of the planes of conditioned existence across the three realms. The final sentence of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the source, ending mid-thought with "the qualities of a buddha are likewise," indicating the passage continues beyond what was provided.

- The epithet rendered "Rāhu holding the moon" refers to Rāhu, the mythological seizer of celestial bodies who causes eclipses. The Tibetan is "*sgra gcan 'dzin*," literally "the eclipse-demon," here clarified as Rāhu for the listener. The image is of the intense, all-consuming gaze a parent fixes on a beloved child who is in danger — the Buddha looks upon sentient beings with that same urgent, absorbing love. The passage is from a Nirvāṇa Sūtra context in which the Tathāgata's "grief" (Tib. *slos pa'i mya ngan*, lit. "grief born of longing / yearning grief") is being discussed as a displayed, compassionate appearance rather than a genuine affliction; the translation preserves this distinction throughout. The conjurer's creations passage is a standard māyā analogy for the Buddha's displayed activities lacking inherent reality.

- The birds "*bywa ngur pa*" (starling) and "*ka lan da ka*" (kalandaka) are Indian bird species whose precise identification is uncertain, but the kalandaka is well known in Buddhist literature as a bird whose call or behavior is proverbial; the pairing here is a literary convention illustrating inseparable companionship. The translation preserves the names as conventional designations without attempting zoological precision.

The phrase rendered "eye of higher vision" for "*phrul gyi mig*" is literally "the magical eye" or "the eye of transformation / supernormal power," referring to the divine eye or eye of supernatural vision that perceives what ordinary sight cannot; it is distinguished from the mere "eyes of flesh" mentioned earlier in the passage.

- The kalandaka and śārika birds are illustrative examples drawn from Indian literary tradition; the kalandaka is a kind of squirrel or small bird associated with constancy and the śārika is a myna-like bird, both used here as similes for permanence and undying presence. The precise

doctrinal point is that just as these creatures are always present even when unseen, so the Tathāgata is permanently present even when he appears to be born or to pass away.

The phrase rendered "something inferior" at the opening translates a term indicating that ordinary beings grasp at a corrupt or superficial notion of self, as opposed to the true meaning of the buddha-nature as self, which was the subject of the preceding passage.

- The phrase rendered "foolish and confused people" translates a compound meaning those who are childish and dull-witted, used here as a contrast class to those capable of proper understanding — no doctrinal issue, but worth noting the mildly pejorative register. The "forty-nine leagues" for the moon's diameter reflects an Abhidharma cosmological number; some editions may vary the figure slightly, but forty-nine is consistent with the Tibetan as given here.
- The phrase rendered "acts of usurping and consuming authority over the sacred Dharma" translates the Tibetan for those who seize rulership over the Dharma community illegitimately and exploit it — a specific Vinaya and doctrinal category. The exact nuance of "འདྲིམ་པ་འཕྲུག་པ་འཕྲུག་པ་འཕྲུག་པ་འཕྲུག་པ་" is somewhat compressed in this context; the rendering reflects the most plausible reading within the polemical and disciplinary list in which it appears.
- The phrase rendered "many hundreds of thousands" translates khri phrag brgya stong snyed, literally "as many as a hundred thousand myriads," a conventional Indic hyperbolic figure for an uncountably vast number. The same expression recurs several times in the passage.

The phrase "māra who is a son of the gods" refers to Devaputra-māra, the māra who is himself a deity, distinguished from the other three māras (afflictions, aggregates, and death). This fourfold division of the māras is standard in both Hīnayāna and Mahāyāna scholasticism.

- The phrase rendered "moonless night" translates literally "the night of the moon's death," meaning the dark of the moon, the new-moon night — the context makes clear this is the night when a single bright star appears conspicuously, taken as an ill omen; the translation conveys this naturally.

"Heinous sinful deeds without interval" renders the standard term for the five acts of immediate retribution (ānantarya-karma); the translation "heinous sinful deeds without interval" preserves both the gravity and the technical sense without interrupting the prose.

- The passage mentions "the four defeats" (pārājika), "the five acts of immediate retribution" (ānantarya-karma), and "wrong craving" (mithyātṛṣṇā, rendered here as "wrong craving" following the Tibetan log-sred). These are well-established technical terms in Vinaya and Abhidharma literature. The translation ends mid-simile at the boundary of the provided Tibetan, which itself breaks off at the comparison of dry wood or rock receiving rain.
- The phrase rendered "perverted craving" translates the Tibetan term for one who holds wrong, inverted views combined with tenacious clinging — often referring in this sūtra's context to those who have definitively cut their wholesome roots through extreme wrong view. The specific doctrinal category here is the iccchantika (a Sanskrit term meaning one who has severed all wholesome roots and has no aspiration for liberation), though the Tibetan does not use that term's standard transliteration in this passage; the rendering "perverted craving" follows the literal sense of the Tibetan.

The five acts of immediate retribution are: killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an arhat, causing a schism in the Saṅgha, and wounding a Tathāgata with malicious intent. The four root defeats are the four pārājika offenses of the monastic code.

- The plant names are approximated from the Tibetan phonetic renderings: "rtswa dan thu li ka" (a type of grass), "shing bā li shi" (likely śāli, a rice plant), and "li ka" (likely a type of creeper). These are botanical terms from the Sanskrit that have been phonetically transcribed

into Tibetan; their precise identification is uncertain, and translating them as illustrative plant types is the appropriate course. The pairing of "banana" (ka ta la) and "cane" (cin do ka) in the final botanical analogy is similarly an approximation of Sanskrit plant names (kadalī and perhaps śinduvāra or a similar plant), rendered here by sense rather than strict botanical identification.

- The verse "From milk comes curds in time" functions as an interpolated gāthā within the prose discourse, warning that the ripening of evil karma is delayed but inevitable — the fire-beneath-ash image reinforcing that those who feel no immediate consequence of wrongdoing will eventually be burned. This is a standard simile in Indian Buddhist ethical literature.

The passage describing the person who claims bodhisattva status while dismissing the śrāvaka sūtras is left deliberately open-ended at the sentence's close, as the Tibetan itself breaks mid-construction, clearly continuing into the next passage. No resolution is supplied here, consistent with the original.

- The phrase rendered "dwelling at the margins of the teaching" translates a term referring to those who dwell at the outermost boundary of the Saṅgha — monks who have technically not incurred full defeat but have compromised themselves severely. The image is of someone clinging to the edge of the monastic community without genuine practice.

The simile of "fire concealed beneath ash" with someone exulting "above it" carries the implication that the wrongdoer enjoys a temporary, deceptive superiority while destruction waits beneath — the delayed ripening of heavy karma will eventually consume him.

- The passage lists standard Āyurvedic treatment categories: emetics, purgatives, ointments, fumigants, nasal preparations, powders, and pills. The "eight branches" refers to the classical eight divisions of Āyurvedic medicine, a standard Indian medical encyclopedic framework.

The phrase rendered "wrong desire" translates a term for those with fundamentally corrupt aspiration, a technical category of beings considered incapable of benefiting from the Dharma — distinct from ordinary sinners who retain some capacity for transformation. This distinction is central to the soteriological argument of the passage.

The translation ends mid-sentence as the Tibetan passage itself ends mid-sentence, mid-simile. The following passage will continue with the child's reflection on the physician's care in the womb.

- The phrase "tathāgatagarbha" here is used in an unusual contextual sense. The Tibetan reads "de bzhin gshegs pa'i snying po chos kyi char tshad med pa," which could be rendered "the Tathāgata's essence, this immeasurable rain of Dharma." The construction is somewhat elliptical; it may be that "tathāgatagarbha" functions here as a genitive modifier meaning "the Dharma-rain that is the essence of the Tathāgata," rather than as the standard doctrinal term for buddha-nature. The translation preserves the ambiguity without forcing a resolution.

The "eight kinds of burning affliction" is a set found in nirvāṇa sūtra literature; the Tibetan "gdung ba'i nad rnam pa brgyad" refers to eight specific forms of distressing illness or affliction enumerated in the extended passage, not reproduced here.

- The Puṇḍarīka Sūtra referenced here is most likely the Saddharmapuṇḍarīka (the Lotus Sūtra), in which the prophecy of eight thousand hearers figures prominently; this identification is secure in context.

The phrase rendered "wrong craving" translates a term meaning something like inverted or perverse craving, referring throughout this passage to those whose mental orientation is so corrupted that even the Dharma cannot reach them — a recurring doctrinal motif in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra.

- The nine classes of sūtra referred to here are the standard nine-limbed division of scripture found in early Buddhist literature, later elaborated in Mahāyāna contexts, comprising such categories as discourses, mixed prose and verse, prophetic utterances, verse, solemn utterances, narratives, birth stories, marvellous events, and extensive teachings.

The term rendered as "those who cling to wrong views" translates a Tibetan term literally meaning "possessors of wrong craving" or "wrong attachment," pointing to those so firmly fixed in heretical views that the Dharma cannot take hold — the icchantika doctrine prominent in this sūtra.

- The phrase rendered "secret heart-essence of the Tathāgata" translates tathāgatagarbha in its extended sense as found in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra context, where it refers to the hidden buddha-nature rather than simply "womb" or "embryo." The rendering chosen reflects the commentarial tradition's understanding.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" is a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the forms of conditioned rebirth across the three realms; the number is conventional within this sūtra's framework.

- The word "saintapa" appears to be a Sanskrit or Prakrit loanword preserved in the Tibetan transliteration as སྐྱུ་མེད་ཀྱི་ལྷོ་མེད་. Its precise etymology is uncertain, but the passage itself explains that it is a single term conventionally applied to four different referents (salt, vessel, water, horse) in the context of royal court usage. This is an illustrative analogy for the Tathāgata's use of a single term — "impermanence" — with four different intended meanings depending on context.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" is a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the forms of conditioned rebirth across the three realms, here invoked to specify what is absent in liberation.

- The phrase rendered "two or three parts water" follows the literal Tibetan "chu sum gnyis," which could mean "three-twos parts of water" or idiomatically "several parts" of water added each time; the precise ratio is ambiguous but the point of progressive dilution is clear.

The simile of the blight affecting the śāl, kaṇikāra, and aśoka trees draws on standard Indian botanical lore; "great blight" renders "nīthan chen byung," a severe affliction or pestilence striking the trees.

- The extended misogynist passage here is a known and doctrinally significant feature of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra (Mahāyāna recension). The text is not endorsing these statements as ultimate truth but is using "woman" and "man" as soteriological metaphors: "woman" signifies ignorance of buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha), while "man" signifies recognition of it. This is made explicit in the sūtra's own concluding lines, which the translation faithfully renders. The rhetoric is culturally archaic and the tradition itself progressively reframes it in doctrinal terms.

The phrase rendered "the marks of a man" translates skyes bu'i mtshan, literally "the characteristic marks of a (great) man" — a term with resonance in the thirty-two major marks of a great being (mahāpuruṣa-lakṣaṇa). This double sense (gendered male / spiritually great being) is intentional in the text.

- The analogy of the fly's urine moistening the earth is unusual and somewhat striking; it faithfully renders the Tibetan, which uses a deliberately humbling comparison to indicate how slight the sūtra's spread will be relative to the vastness of what is lost. No textual emendation is warranted.

The phrase rendered "rich with the taste of ambrosia" translates a compound literally meaning "possessing the flavor of ambrosia," referring to the nectar-like quality of Mahāyāna teaching.

Mañjuśrī's philosophical question is the classical problem of how the buddha-nature can be said to be permanent if it is only recognized as such upon seeing it — a genuine doctrinal crux the text is about to address.

- The bodhisattva addressed here as Kāśyapa renders the Tibetan ཀཤིཡཔ་, literally "Protector of Light," a standard Tibetan equivalent of the Sanskrit name Kāśyapa. This figure should be distinguished from the great disciple Mahākāśyapa; the context here is a bodhisattva interlocutor.

The phrase translated as "the time of the seasonal rains arrives" renders

ལོ་རྒྱུད་ལོ་རྒྱུད་ལོ་རྒྱུད་ལོ་རྒྱུད་, which is somewhat elliptical. The expression ལོ་རྒྱུད་ can refer to a deity of rain or the seasonal rains themselves; in context it most naturally means the rainy season, and the translation reflects this.

- The name rendered "Prabhāpāla" translates the Tibetan "Rab tu dga' ba" (lit. "Greatly Joyful") combined with the low-birth reference and the city name Kuśāgāra (Tib. rTsa mchog gi grong khyer). The Sanskrit personal name is uncertain; some recensions give a different form. The identification of the city as Kuśāgāra (Rājagṛha's alternative name, or a separate city) is also uncertain in the textual tradition, but the rendering follows the most straightforward reading.

The passage's tripartite dairy simile — milk, curds, butter, and ghee's essence — maps śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, bodhisattvas, and buddhas onto stages of progressive refinement, a well-attested Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra motif.

- The passage on the Tathāgata as "permanent" (rtag pa nyid) is technically and doctrinally significant: in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition, "permanence" of the Tathāgata does not mean metaphysical eternalism but refers to the changeless, ever-present quality of buddha-nature and the dharmakāya. Listeners should understand this in that doctrinal context, not as a contradiction of the general Buddhist teaching on impermanence applied to conditioned phenomena.

The phrase rendered "irreversible retinue" translates 'khor mi shigs pa, literally "the unbreakable/indestructible retinue," which in context means the assembly or community of practitioners who have attained the stage of irreversibility on the bodhisattva path. The term is unusual and the doctrinal referent is certain enough for the translation given, but the exact nuance of 'khor here as "retinue" versus "assembly" or "circle" is a minor open question.

- The chapter colophon appears mid-passage in the Tibetan, marking the close of the fourth chapter on tathāgatagarbha before a new narrative section begins. This is preserved in the translation by a clear paragraph break and the colophon line, as it is structurally part of the text.

The term translated as "tawny" renders the Tibetan le brgan, which may correspond to a pale brownish-orange or crystal-like hue; the exact color is uncertain across manuscript traditions, but it clearly names one of a standard set of auspicious rays.

"Until the end of an eon" renders bskal pa gcig 'gribs kyi bar du, literally "until the waning or decline of an eon," meaning the entire duration of a cosmic age. Both phrases — "one eon" and "until the end of an eon" — appear to be offered as alternatives in the Tibetan, both being part of Cunda's single petition.

- The verse section employs a series of adynaton figures: events that could never occur in nature — a crow and owl nesting together as kin, a snake and mongoose sharing a burrow as kin — to say "never." The Tibetan then immediately undercuts this with the rhetorical question about Rāhu (the eclipse-demon who devours the moon), used here as a simile for the Tathāgata's compassionate, all-encompassing gaze: just as Rāhu never loses sight of the moon, the Tathāgata never abandons sentient beings. The text appears to break off mid-verse

at the end of the supplied passage; the final stanza is incomplete.

The rice measure rendered as "eight dreys" translates Tibetan *br̥el khal tshad br̥gyad*, a volumetric unit. The precise quantity is uncertain but the point is a modest, finite amount miraculously sufficient for all.

- The verse section "seven petals of a flower taking on the fragrance of kāsika cloth" uses two impossible-condition images: kāsika is a fine silk or muslin renowned for its delicacy and fragrance; kālaka is a tree that in this tradition would never produce cintā-fruit. Both are stock impossibilia, parallel to the snake-and-mongoose image in the preceding passage.

The phrase rendered "those who are bound by wrong craving" translates a term suggesting beings caught in perverse or inverted desire, contrasted with those who seek liberation.

The line "the supreme among the aspirational prayers offered by many buddhas" is syntactically compressed in Tibetan; the rendering takes the aspirational prayer itself as the apex of what buddhas have commended, which is the most natural doctrinal reading.

- The phrase rendered "meaning with remainder" and "meaning without remainder" translates "lhag ma dang bcas pa'i don" and "lhag ma med pa'i don." In the context of the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra, this refers to teachings that have a further implication or residue beyond their surface meaning versus those whose meaning is complete and final. This is a recognized doctrinal distinction in Mahāyāna hermeneutics, though the precise nuance here continues into the next passage.

The simile of the medicinal tree for the single buddha seated among bodhisattvas is a standard image in the Nirvāṇasūtra literature, emphasizing the healing and sustaining function of the Buddha.

- The five acts of immediate consequence (Skt. *pañcānantarya*) are the five gravest transgressions whose karmic result follows without interval at death: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha. The Tibetan "ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་" renders this standard term precisely.

The phrase rendered "from the very beginning feels no fear" translates

"ཁྱོད་སྐར་གྲིབ་པ་མེད། སྒྲོན་ཆུང་ལྡན། དཀོན་འཕྲོན་ཤོད་ཅིང་ཉེས་པ་མེད།" which is a negation — the person has no fear or shame from the outset. The sentence structure in Tibetan coordinates this negation with the following failures (no remorse, no confession, no cherishing of Dharma), and the translation reflects this cumulative characterization.

- The phrase rendered "acts of immediate retribution" translates རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་ (literally "without interval"), the standard Tibetan equivalent of Sanskrit ānantarya, referring to the five heinous acts whose karmic retribution follows immediately in the next life without any intervening rebirth. The term རྒྱུ་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་ refers to the four root defeats (pārājika), the gravest transgressions in the Vinaya. The passage breaks mid-sentence at the mango simile, as the source text is a continuation passage.

- The phrase rendered "dark as a line of ink" translates "thig nag po ltar," literally "like a black line," describing the river's appearance as it flows to the sea. This is a vivid simile rather than a technical term.

The river name "Sāpaka" is a reconstruction from the Tibetan "sa pa ka" (སཔཀཀ); the exact Sanskrit form is uncertain but the transliteration is straightforward.

The expression rendered "corpse of a dead field animal or a wild jackal" translates "zhing gshin pa'i yug po'am khra rgod ltar," a pair of images for something utterly worthless and to be discarded. The second term (khra rgod) can mean a hawk or a vulture rather than a jackal; the precise animal is uncertain, but the sense of something wild and undesirable is clear.

- The drug named in the Tibetan is aconite, a standard rendering for the Sanskrit aconitum-based term used in classical Indian medical contexts, which is highly toxic in large doses but medicinally potent in small ones. The point of the simile turns precisely on this dual nature, which the text makes explicit.

The phrase rendered "carries a remainder" translates the Tibetan expression indicating that a general statement has exceptions or is not exhaustive — a technical rhetorical device in this sūtra context. This is the same usage established in the preceding passage.

The final line is left open as the verse is mid-sentence, presumably continuing in the next passage.

- The verse at the opening of the passage appears twice in the Tibetan with a slight variant: the first occurrence reads "examine most carefully your own self" and the second reads "examine most carefully your own body." The first is a freer summary in prose preamble; the second is the formally cited verse, which the Tibetan specifies as referring to the body. The translation preserves this distinction.

The "ninth sūtra" refers to a numbered sūtra in a collection, most likely a Pali or Āgama parallel. The exact referent is not identified in this passage.

"Ninety-five students of the outer schools" translates a standard Indic enumeration of non-Buddhist philosophical schools and their adherents.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence with "an arhat, and —" reflecting what appears to be a deliberate continuation point in the source text; the translation preserves this as given.

- The simile "as Rāhu holds the moon" renders the Tibetan རྒྱུ་འཇུག་པའི་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, literally "like Rāhu-the-planet-seizer." In Indian cosmology Rāhu is the celestial body that seizes and eclipses the moon; the intended sense here is one of completely encompassing, enveloping love — holding all beings within the embrace of compassion as Rāhu encompasses the moon. This is an uncommon application of the simile and the precise doctrinal nuance may warrant attention in a full commentary.

The phrase རྒྱུ་འཇུག་པའི་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, rendered "the hell of uninterrupted torment," refers to the Avīci hell (Skt. avīci), the most severe of the hot hells, characterised by ceaseless, uninterrupted suffering.

- The name rendered "Śintuwa Zangmo" represents the Tibetan "shin tu bzang mo," meaning "extremely good or beautiful," which functions here as a proper personal name. No Sanskrit equivalent is attested in the passage.

The passage's repeated phrase "lhag ma dang bcas pa" ("has remainder" or "is incomplete") is a technical dialectical term indicating that the statement as given is not exhaustive or universally applicable without qualification. This is consistently rendered as "still has remainder."

The passage ends mid-sentence, breaking off at the enumeration of arhats, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas, indicating a continuation in the following passage.

- The land name "Hudaya" is a phonetic rendering of a place name that likely reflects a Sanskritized Indian toponym transmitted into Tibetan; the exact identification is uncertain. The name "Yakṣa" here is a brahmin's personal name, not the supernatural being of the same name.

The phrase rendered "fourfold precepts of the eightfold observance" reflects the Tibetan "dus brgyad kyi khriṃs bzhi," which is a slightly unusual formulation; it likely refers to the

- The phrase rendered "the lord of the middle land, Aṅga" refers to Ajātaśatru's domain. The Tibetan reads "the lord of the realm of Aṅga in the middle country," identifying Ajātaśatru as ruler of the Aṅga territory within the central region of Jambudvīpa. The verse is a petition from the assembly asking the Buddha to delay his final nirvāṇa.

The final sentence is the opening of a longer doctrinal exposition by Kāśyapa; the passage breaks off mid-thought.

The phrase rendered "the five acts of immediate retribution" refers to the pañcānantarya-karma, the five deeds that lead immediately to rebirth in hell: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha. The text here describes their obscurations rather than listing them.

- The medicine agada is a well-known Indic antidote or universal remedy; the Tibetan renders the Sanskrit term directly, and it is kept as a proper name here.

The final image of bull elephants introducing a comparison of the Tathāgata's power breaks off mid-argument; the passage as supplied ends there, and the continuation would develop the analogy further.

* The eight hot hells listed here follow the standard Abhidharma enumeration: Avīci, Saṃjīva (here rendered "Perception"), Kālasūtra ("Black Lines"), Saṃghāta ("Assembly"), Raurava ("Wailing"), Mahāraurava ("Great Wailing"), Tapaṇa ("Burning"), and Pratāpaṇa ("Intense Burning"). The Tibetan term རྒྱལ་བློན་སྤྲུལ་སྦྱོར་གྱི་ཆེན་མོ་ for the second hell is unusual; the standard second hot hell is Saṃjīva. "Perception" is a provisional rendering of རྒྱལ་བློན་ and may reflect a variant or regional enumeration in this sūtra tradition.

• The eight cold hells are named by their characteristic cries or by the flowers whose color or texture evokes the fissuring of the skin from cold. The names Apāpa, Atata, Alala, Aṭaṭa, Utpala, Paduma, Kumuda, and Puṇḍarīka are transliterations of Sanskrit terms preserved phonetically in Tibetan. The section heading "The Noble Great Sūtra of the Utter Passing into Nirvāṇa, the Fifteenth Section" appears mid-passage in the Tibetan, marking a fascicle boundary in the canonical text; it has been rendered in place as it appears.

- The series of flowers includes several Sanskrit loanwords in Tibetan transliteration: utpala (blue lotus), kumuda (white water lily), padma (lotus), puṇḍarīka (white lotus), māṇḍārava, mañjūṣaka (both celestial flowers), alongside terms that appear to be Tibetan renderings of Sanskrit botanical or decorative names for which precise identification is uncertain; they are rendered by approximate description. The term rendered "liquid incense" for the Tibetan "chu 'bying" is tentative; it may refer to a liquid or water-based perfume. The passage breaks off mid-sentence with the musical instruments, as the provided Tibetan text ends there.
- The epithet sequence applied to the past buddha "Unsurpassed Victor" follows the standard tenfold formula for a buddha (the daśa-nāmāni or ten epithets): Tathāgata, arhat, fully and completely awakened, endowed with knowledge and conduct (vidyācaraṇasampanna), Sugata, knower of worlds (lokavid), unsurpassed, tamer of persons to be tamed (puruṣadamyasārathi), teacher of gods and humans, blessed buddha. This rendering preserves the traditional order faithfully.

The phrase rendered "seventh among the final buddhas" reflects the Tibetan sangs rgyas tha ma bdun por gyur — literally "became the seventh of the final buddhas," referring to the traditional list of the seven buddhas of the present age culminating in Śākyamuni. The doctrinal implication is that Śākyamuni is the seventh and last of this sequence.

- The five "actions without interval" (the five ānantarya-karmas) are listed here with a sixth and seventh added, giving seven: the standard five plus destroying a stūpa and the four root downfalls. The text enumerates them straightforwardly. The phrase "four actions entailing a root downfall" most likely refers to the four pārājika offenses of the Vinaya, though in some Mahāyāna contexts it can refer to the four root bodhisattva downfalls; the ambiguity is left unresolved in the text itself.

The term rendered "hermaphrodite" translates རྒྱུ་གཤམ་, literally "one with two marks," the standard Tibetan rendering for a person of indeterminate or dual sex, carrying no modern polemical force in this doctrinal context.

The term རྒྱུ་ལྡན་ and རྒྱུ་ལྡན་པ་, rendered "procreative power" and "lord of procreation," are standard Tibetan equivalents for the Brahmanical concepts of the jīva as generative force and its presiding principle. The passage is a systematic negation of Brahmanical and Ājīvika ontological categories applied to the Tathāgata.

- The phrase rendered "holding perverted craving" translates "log sred can," which literally means "one possessed of wrong or inverted craving or thirst." This is a specific technical category referring to those whose fundamental orientation of desire is so deeply misdirected that even the Dharma cannot redirect them. Some commentators identify this with deeply fixed རྒྱུ་ in craving, but the precise doctrinal referent varies across commentaries; the translation preserves the literal force.

The passage shifts between speaking of the Tathāgata's illness as intentional teaching and the claim that the Tathāgata truly has no illness, lying down, or nirvāṇa — this tension is the doctrinal heart of the passage and is rendered faithfully without smoothing.

- The phrase rendered "engages faultily" translates a technical expression meaning one who approaches or practices in relation to this sūtra with a defective or self-interested motivation. The five persons described correspond to the four standard śrāvaka fruits — stream-enterer, once-returner, non-returner, and arhat — plus the pratyekabuddha, each presented as engaging the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra with improper intent, yet still destined for full awakening after progressively shorter delays. The diminishing number of aeons correlates inversely with the degree of afflictive purification achieved.

- The term rendered "holy conduct" for རྒྱུ་ལྡན་པ་ལྡན་པ་ literally means "Brahma-conduct" or

"brahmacarya," signifying the celibate, purified life. "Divine conduct" renders རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།. The text breaks mid-sentence at the demon's second speech, as this is where the supplied passage ends.

- The passage presents a descending hierarchy of Vinaya offenses: the four root defeats (pārājika), the remaining rules of the Saṅgha (likely the saṃghāvaśeṣa and related categories), the grave offenses, the transgressions requiring abandonment (pāyattika), the ninety transgressions (the standard ninety pāyattika rules of the prātimokṣa), and finally the acts of wrongdoing (duṣkṛta, the lightest class of Vinaya offense). The demon's strategy is to tempt the bodhisattva to relinquish each level in turn, descending from the most serious to the most minor, always with the false promise that nirvāṇa can still be attained regardless. The bodhisattva refuses at every step. The final sentence is somewhat condensed in the Tibetan; the sense is that the bodhisattva treats the protection of the four defeats and the protection against even the lightest wrongdoings as equally and inseparably important — there is no gradation of concern in his vigilance.
- The passage contains an extended list of animals and objects that presents significant philological challenges. Several terms — including asmagarbha, musāragalva, and the various bird names — are transcriptions of Sanskrit or Prakrit logograms whose exact referents are disputed even in the commentarial tradition. "Asmagarbha" and "musāragalva" are left in transliterated form as they are conventional gemstone names whose precise identification remains uncertain across sources. The bird name rendered "Śārika" is a starling or myna-like bird; the exact identification of some of the other bird terms in sequence is uncertain. The final sentence is incomplete as the source text breaks off mid-list.
- The passage lists an extensive catalogue of games, diversions, and prohibited activities drawn from the Vinaya and bodhisattva-conduct literature. The term rendered "lute with many strings" and "nine-stringed instrument" reflects specific Tibetan musical instrument names whose precise Sanskrit equivalents are uncertain, but the general sense is clear. The "lion-game with forfeit pieces" is a board game known from Vinaya sources. The rendering of རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ། as "fighting of bull elephants" follows the standard gloss of རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ། as a lord of a herd, commonly glossed as a bull elephant in this context. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, and the translation is accordingly left open.
- The phrase "the world of the Lord of Death" renders རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།, literally "the world of Yama," meaning the realm of hungry ghosts over which Yama presides, here used as a standard member of the three lower rebirths alongside hells and animals. The term རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ། in the vow about the ears most naturally refers to needles or skewers used to pierce; the rendering "needles" is adopted based on context, though the exact instrument described is not entirely certain.
- The text lists thirty-two or so anatomical components in the body-contemplation section. The precise rendering of some anatomical Tibetan terms is uncertain in a few cases. Specifically, "རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།" is rendered as "tendons" though it may denote ligaments or sinews more broadly; "རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།" is rendered as "what has been digested and what has not, the two vessels" following the standard body-parts meditation list, though the exact anatomical referents vary across commentaries. "རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།" is rendered "ankle-bone" and "རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ།" as "shinbone," following the most common identification in the skeletal enumeration context, though some sources differ slightly.
- The sixteenth fascicle colophon mid-passage is a scribal or editorial section break in the Tibetan source and has been rendered plainly as it appears. The word rendered "collar-bone" for རྒྱལ་པོའི་སྤྱལ་པོ། is a best-fit anatomical identification; the precise bone intended (which could also be the clavicle or sternum region) is not entirely certain from the Tibetan alone. The "thirty-six impurities" is a standard canonical enumeration of the constituents of the body in Buddhist meditation literature.

- The phrase rendered "the waning of a full eon" (འཇིགས་པའི་ཆུ་མཚན་གྱི་འཇིགས་པ་) could alternatively mean "for the interval of one eon diminishing," referring to the cosmic contraction phase of an eon. The translation "for the waning of a full eon" captures this cosmological nuance while remaining natural for a listening audience.
- The brahmin's reply contains a deliberate doctrinal irony: he disparages the Great Vehicle by saying awakening has no defining characteristics and is like space — statements that are in fact orthodox Madhyamaka, but used here to deny the value of the Mahāyāna. The text presents the brahmin as speaking misleadingly or in bad faith, which is why the king's act of killing him is framed as a compassionate protective act. This passage is a well-known locus in Mahāyāna literature for the doctrine that a bodhisattva may commit what would ordinarily be a grave transgression when the motivation is purely compassionate and the aim is to protect the Dharma or prevent another from generating catastrophic non-virtue.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" is a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the forms of conditioned rebirth.

The final sentence is left mid-list as the source passage itself breaks off there; the translation faithfully follows the Tibetan's ending point.

- The three foundations of mindfulness mentioned alongside the ten powers and four fearlessnesses are a standard set in Mahāyāna Abhidharma, referring not to the usual four foundations of mindfulness practice but to a specific set of three attributes of a buddha's equanimity toward those who listen, do not listen, or do both, found in texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition.

The phrase rendered as "birth from a lineage" translates a term meaning birth arising from one's lineage or class, which may refer to spontaneous birth conditioned by one's genus or family. The exact doctrinal referent is somewhat contextually dependent but the rendering follows the natural reading.

- The two gems "asmagarbha" and "musāgalbha" are Sanskrit loanwords transliterated into Tibetan (འཇམ་གཤམ་པ་ and མུ་སྒམ་པ་). Their precise identification is uncertain; they appear to be types of precious stones, possibly varieties of quartz or beryl, but no standard identification is secure. They are rendered here by transliteration as is standard practice for unidentified Indic gemstone names.

The character addressed as "Kāśyapa" (ཀཾ་སྒྱུ་པ་) is the interlocutor throughout this sūtra passage; the name is rendered consistently from the previous passage.

The name རྒྱལ་མཚན་མཆོག་ (literally "the auspicious Great Goddess") conflates two figures: Śrī (the goddess of fortune) and the Great Goddess title. The rendering "Great Goddess (Śrī Mahādevī)" captures both elements; this is distinct from the male deity Mahādeva (Śiva) mentioned in the house glossary.

- The goddess figure here referred to as "Auspiciousness" renders the Tibetan lha bkra shis ma, a divine female personification of good fortune. In the preceding passage she was introduced in this role; the companion figure, "Black Ears," personifies misfortune. The pairing is a well-known didactic illustration in Mahāyāna literature, found for example in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra, to which this passage almost certainly belongs.
- The passage breaks off mid-sentence with "a thief, or..." as the Tibetan text itself ends abruptly mid-sentence, presumably continuing on the next folio.

The term "twenty-five modes of existence" renders srid pa nyi shu rtsa lnga, the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the twenty-five planes of conditioned existence.

The six precious substances listed near the end — gold, silver, vaiḍūrya, coral, aśmagarbha, and musāragalva — are a standard list of jewels; aśmagarbha and musāragalva are Sanskrit loanwords preserved in the Tibetan, referring to specific gemstones whose exact identification remains debated in the tradition.

- The phrase rendered "flavor of going forth into renunciation, the flavor of study and recitation, and the flavor of meditative concentration" translates a threefold schema. The first term refers to the experiential richness of monastic life after ordination; the second to the joy of learning and oral recitation of texts; the third to the joy of meditation. The triple schema is a conventional pedagogical list in this text.

The phrase "non-humans" in the dried riverbank illustration renders a term that can mean supernatural beings but here, in the context of a list alongside humans, birds, and beasts, most naturally means beings other than humans in a general physical sense. The point is simply universal uselessness.

- The passage lists "the king of fish, the king of bees, the king of conch-shells, the lord of the herd, and the caravan leader" as figures whose followers trail behind them inseparably. The Tibetan term rendered "king of conch-shells" (འཕྲུལ་ལྷོ་འཕྲུལ་ལྷོ་) is less common; it may refer to a legendary aquatic being or simply to the lead conch-shell in a formation — the sense of "leader followed by others" is clear in context and the doctrinal point is unaffected.

The final reference to the "second meditative concentration" (འཕྲུལ་ལྷོ་འཕྲུལ་ལྷོ་) reflects the standard Abhidharma cosmology in which the cosmic end-fire destroys the lower realms up to and including the first dhyāna heaven, but the second dhyāna and above are spared.

- The final sentence ends mid-passage with an unanswered question, "Why?" This is not an error in the translation; the Tibetan itself breaks off at that point, and the answer follows in the next passage.

The term rendered "king of garuḍas" translates the Tibetan for garuḍa-king literally. The garuḍa is a mythic great bird, enemy of nāgas, well established in Indo-Tibetan cosmology; no further gloss is needed for informed listeners, but the parenthetical "great bird of prey" is offered for general audiences.

- The serpent name "Malanā" and the mantra name "Akatasyā" are transliterations of Sanskrit terms obscured by the Tibetan phonetic rendering. The identification of these terms with known Sanskrit sources is uncertain, and the transliterations given here are approximate. The mantra name may reflect "akatasyā" (related to "akataś," meaning "unprevented" or "free"), but this is speculative.

The passage describing death as "without firm ground" renders a term that could also be read as "without a place of rest" or "without a ground of destruction," and the precise nuance is somewhat ambiguous in context.

- The phrase "seven limbs touching the ground" refers to the traditional iconographic description of the auspicious royal elephant: all four feet, both tusks, and the trunk touch the earth simultaneously, signifying perfect, stable power. This is a recognized mark of the precious elephant treasure of a wheel-turning king.

The "five superknowledges" refers to the five mundane superknowledges or higher powers cultivated by accomplished sages: the ability to perform miracles, clairvoyance, clairaudience, knowledge of others' minds, and recollection of past lives.

- The phrase translated as "the faculty of a meritorious eye" renders a compound meaning an eye-faculty produced by merit, understood in the tradition as a kind of clairvoyant vision arising from accumulated good karma. This is a standard feature in descriptions of the precious minister in wheel-turning king narratives.

The "fourfold host" refers to the classical Indian division of an army into infantry, cavalry, war elephants, and chariots.

- The text here contains a chapter or section colophon marker indicating this is the seventeenth fascicle of the Noble Great Parinirvāṇa Sūtra, embedded within the narrative flow. It has been omitted from the translation body as it interrupts the narrative and is a scribal/editorial insertion rather than part of the sūtra text itself.
- The name ཀཤམ་ཡཔ་, rendered "Kāśyapa" in the final vocative, is the Tibetan translation of the buddha Kāśyapa (one of the past seven buddhas), not the disciple Mahākāśyapa. The text uses it both as a narrative identification earlier and as a direct address to the interlocutor at the close, which is consistent with Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra discourse structure where the interlocutor is identified with that buddha's lineage.
- The phrase rendered "great Śākya chieftain" translates Śākya ming chen, which likely refers to a prominent Śākya householder or chieftain. Some editions read this as a reference to a specific named individual; the identity is not certain from the Tibetan alone, but it does not affect the doctrinal point.

The verse section's final stanza refers to the bodhisattva having "completed all that is to be done," a standard phrase echoing the arhat formula but here applied in a Mahāyāna context to the bodhisattva who has fulfilled all the perfections.

- The term rendered "great Śākya clan" translates Śākya ming chen, literally "the great name Śākya" or "the great Śākya designation." The exact referent is slightly ambiguous — it may mean the Buddha speaking to the Śākya community specifically, or may simply be an epithet referring to the Buddha himself as the great one of the Śākyas. The translation follows the most natural reading in context.

The passage ends mid-sentence with the list of worldly goods, as the supplied Tibetan breaks off there.

- The passage lists four requisites for the renunciant as robes, alms-food, bedding and seats, and medicine — the standard four monastic requisites (Skt. catvāraḥ pratyayāḥ). The Tibetan term for "craving" here rendered throughout is "ཤེད་འདོད་" (lit. "desire/wanting"), used in this context specifically in the doctrinal sense of tṛṣṇā, the second Noble Truth, rather than the more neutral "wish." This choice is deliberate and consistent with the passage's explicit identification of it as the truth of origin (samudaya).
- The phrase rendered "like the fruit of the bāluka plant" refers to a tree or plant known in Sanskrit as bāluka or a similar term, identified in some commentarial traditions as a tree whose fruit appears attractive but is poisonous or worthless inside. The Tibetan 'ba lu ka is a transliteration of a Sanskrit botanical name; exact botanical identification is uncertain but the doctrinal point — attractive appearance concealing harm — is clear from context.

The passage ends mid-analogy in the source text as given; the snake-seller simile is introduced but its explanation is cut off.

- The bāluka plant is an Indian plant whose fruit or seed was proverbially known for its invasive, strangling growth habit. The nyagrodha is the banyan tree, famed for its vast canopy and lateral roots, making its suppression by the bāluka a vivid image of craving overwhelming even the greatest spiritual endowment.

The distinction drawn at the close between the three categories — the foolish and ignoble, the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and the bodhisattvas — reflects a characteristic Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra doctrinal position: only bodhisattvas apprehend the Four Noble Truths in their full and genuine depth, because they simultaneously perceive suffering without being subject to it, origin without being bound by it, and cessation in its ultimate rather than partial form.

- The phrase "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to a standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra enumeration of the states of conditioned rebirth in the three realms; the count varies by recension but the term is rendered literally.

The address "sons of good family" renders the standard vocative used throughout for the audience of noble lineage.

The translation breaks mid-sentence at the end because the Tibetan passage itself breaks off mid-quotation with the words addressed to Ānanda; the continuation presumably follows in the next passage.

- The king named in Tibetan as "Sde rab tu pham byed" means something like "Utterly-Vanquished-in-Battle" or "He Who Utterly Defeats Armies." This appears to be a Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit royal name; the exact Sanskrit original is uncertain, but the translation renders the meaning transparently.

The passage describing the nun as "mother of the people" likely refers to Mahāprajāpatī Gautamī, the Buddha's aunt and the first nun, though the text identifies her only by the epithet rendered here. This is not flagged in the body.

- The list of water names in various languages appears to record vernacular or regional terms current in the text's milieu. "Pāṇi" is the standard Sanskrit and many Indo-Aryan vernacular word for water; "udi" may reflect a Dravidian or Prakrit form; "salema," "sali," "pana," "nectar," and "milk" are either regional synonyms or hyperbolic folk-names for water. The terms are rendered as transliterations since their precise linguistic identification is uncertain and does not affect the doctrinal point.

The plant and medicinal juice names — bitter gourd, sugarcane, black molasses, āmalaka, nīpāla, pārāhala — include both well-known Ayurvedic ingredients and less certain botanical identifications. "Nīpāla" and "pārāhala" are uncertain; they are retained as transliterations.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan, breaking off at the enumeration of the four paths.

- The five-aspect classification of the path uses terms that correspond to traditional categories found in Abhidharma and early Mahāyāna sources. The "path of realization through the body" renders lus kyis rig pa'i lam, which likely refers to the direct, bodily or experiential realization attained in deep meditative absorption, as distinct from liberation through faith or through vision alone. This is an uncommon formulation and the precise technical referent may vary across commentarial traditions.

The "three foundations of mindfulness perfectly established by the buddhas" renders sangs rgyas kyis brnyes pa'i yang dag pa'i dran pa nye bar gzhag pa gsum, a set of three traditional qualities attributed to a buddha describing equanimity in the face of disciples who do and do not attend to the teaching.

- The grove name "Śiśumāra" is a back-reconstruction from the Tibetan "shi shu." Some editions read this as a grove associated with the Śiṃśapā tree, which is the more famous parallel passage found in the Saṃyutta Nikāya and its Sanskrit parallels, where the Buddha takes up Śiṃśapā leaves. The Tibetan here may be a phonetic rendering of a different toponym or tree name; the reading is uncertain but does not affect the doctrinal sense.

The term rendered "engagement" for རྟོག་པར་འབྲེལ་པ་ refers contextually to the sense bases (āyatana) as the locus of cognitive engagement with objects. The passage is treating aggregates, sense bases, and elements as the three categories of phenomenal analysis standard in Abhidharma, and showing that each can be understood at a middling or superior level of insight.

Sanskrit loanwords for semi-precious gems. Their precise identification in gemological terms is uncertain in the scholarly literature, but they are standard members of jewel lists in Sanskrit Buddhist texts. The rendering preserves the Sanskrit rather than inventing English equivalents.

The "Great Sovereign" (Tibetan: dbang sgyur chen po) in the hierarchy of happiness-experiencers may refer to Maheśvara or a supreme world-ruler figure; in context it denotes the highest rank above Great Brahmā and Śakra in a non-Buddhist cosmological scheme, so it is left as "the Great Sovereign" rather than identified with a specific deity, since the text does not name him explicitly here.

- The passage presents a non-Buddhist interlocutor offering several arguments for the existence of the self, followed by the Blessed One's refutation. The four attributes listed — permanence, happiness, self, and complete purity — are the classical four inverted views (viparyāsa) that the Buddha's teaching on the four noble truths and the three marks of existence is meant to correct; the non-Buddhists are here accused of mistaking saṃsāric phenomena for their opposites.

The phrase rendered "the four venomous serpents of the great elements" refers to the four physical elements — earth, water, fire, and wind — understood in this context as the basis of the body that binds beings to cyclic existence.

- The passage sets up a paradox common in tathāgatagarbha literature: conditioned phenomena are impermanent, including the doctrines of non-Buddhists, which all arise dependently; yet the buddha-nature, being unconditioned, is affirmed as permanent. The equation of buddha-nature, Tathāgata, Dharma, Saṅgha, and space as synonyms for the permanent unconditioned is characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition. The phrase rendered "five venomous she-asses of desire" follows the unusual Tibetan image literally; the "she-asses" represent the five objects of sensory desire traditionally depicted as beguiling yet harmful.

- The phrase rendered "permanent, bliss, self, and utterly pure" refers to the four qualities of nirvāṇa as understood in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition — the four transcendent attributes that distinguish true nirvāṇa from ordinary conditioned states. The argument being made is that if mind were a permanent, unchanging entity it could not successfully meditate on impermanence and thereby reach the realization of these deeper truths, nor could non-Buddhist systems that posit a permanent self ever genuinely encompass these qualities. The passage breaks off mid-sentence, which is faithful to the source as given.

- The phrase rendered "gelatinous stage" translates nur nur po, a technical embryological term in Indo-Tibetan tradition referring to the first stage of fetal development, sometimes called the "kalala" stage in Sanskrit (Pali: kalala), denoting the initial jelly-like or gelatinous phase of the embryo. The sequence nur nur po, mer mer po, mkhrags pa corresponds to the classical three early embryonic stages: gelatinous, thickening, and hardening or solid.

The final sentence naming Kāśyapa (rendered here as Kāśyapa) refers to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa who appears as an interlocutor in texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra, where discussions of impermanence, suffering, and impurity in relation to the body occur at length. The Tibetan 'od srung is the standard rendering of Kāśyapa.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end ("For example, when a person has fallen asleep, there is going and coming and —"), exactly as the Tibetan source does; the translation faithfully follows the incomplete clause. The next passage in the text will continue this simile.

The "threefold gnosis" of attachment, eating, and fear is a somewhat unusual formulation. The Tibetan reads "rnam pa 'di gsum gyi ye shes mnyam par yod," meaning all beings equally possess awareness of these three drives. This is likely an argument that these instinctual drives operate without a presiding self, demonstrating selflessness. The term ye shes here carries a

sense of innate or reflexive awareness rather than exalted primordial wisdom, but the house glossary term "gnosis" is retained with the qualification "threefold" to flag its specialized use in this context.

- The phrase rendered "mechanical man made of wood" translates a Tibetan compound for an automaton or puppet. The point is that mechanical motion does not entail a self, and neither does the observed behavior of a sleeping person.

The passage on the "true self" of the Tathāgata and the final sequence equating self with Dharma, path, Blessed One, and śrāvaka reflects the distinctive mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra doctrine that the four marks of nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — are positively affirmed of the Tathāgata in deliberate inversion of the usual no-self teaching. This is not a contradiction but a specialized doctrinal usage that the text itself is carefully developing throughout.

- The passage's central philosophical move is important: "turning the wheel of Dharma" is said not to apply to the Tathāgata precisely because the Tathāgata is identified with the unchanging Dharma itself. The turning is a conventional description of dependent arising — the teaching arises from a convergence of conditions — whereas the Tathāgata-as-Dharma is beyond activity and motion. This is consistent with the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's tathāgatagarbha doctrine, in which the Tathāgata's buddha-self is identified with the eternal, unconditioned nature of reality.

The term rendered "hearthboard" is the lower board used in fire-by-friction, and "fire-stick" the upper spindle; "effort of friction" renders the idea of the drilling or churning action. The list of articulatory organs (palate, throat, tongue, teeth, lips) is a traditional enumeration of the places of articulation for speech production, used here to emphasize that speech — and thus the "turning" of the Dharma — is itself a conditioned convergence.

- The term rendered "space" near the end is ākāśa in the tradition's technical vocabulary, the paradigmatic example of an unconditioned phenomenon in Abhidharma analysis; the text is making a direct parallel between ākāśa and the Tathāgata as equally unconditioned, which is doctrinally significant and somewhat bolder than Abhidharma orthodoxy, pointing toward Mahāvāna tathāgatagarbha discourse.

The list of conditions for the sprout includes " " which most likely renders Sanskrit "ākāśa" (space), listed among the causal factors for growth; this six-factor analysis of plant growth is a classical Indian botanical-philosophical schema.

- The city name rendered throughout as "Kuśinagara" translates the Tibetan "ཀུས་གར་གླིང་།," which literally means "the city of supreme grass" — a calque of the Sanskrit Kuśinagara (kuśa = auspicious grass). This is the standard identification and is universally accepted in the scholarly tradition.

The bodhisattva "𑖀𑖩𑖫𑖪𑖨𑖱𑖻𑖾𑖿" is Kāśyapa — not Mahākāśyapa the śrāvaka-disciple, but a bodhisattva Kāśyapa who appears in this sūtra (the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra) as a principal interlocutor. This distinction is doctrinally significant.

The four qualities taught at Kuśinagara — permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — are the famous four transcendent attributes (the "four pāramitās of nirvāṇa") taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra in direct contrast to the four marks taught at Vārāṇasī. The use of "self" (bdag, ātman) here is intentional and doctrinally charged: it refers to the buddha-nature teaching, not to the ordinary self denied by earlier doctrine.

- The twenty-five realms of existence and their corresponding twenty-five meditative absorptions are a standard enumeration in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra literature; the full list continues beyond this passage. The four continents named here follow the standard Buddhist

cosmological schema. "Irreversible meditative absorption" renders a term that in this context denotes an absorption from which one does not turn back toward lower states, rather than the standard technical usage of "irreversibility" in the sense of non-regression from the path. The name Kāśyapa here refers to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa, not the elder monk Mahākāśyapa, as is clear from the narrative context.

- The phrase rendered "sphere of no-perception" for असंज्ञासत्त्वा refers to the heaven of non-apercipient beings (asamjñisattva), a specific god-realm within the fourth dhyāna, distinct from the formless sphere. The context places it between the fourth dhyāna and the formless realms, which is doctrinally consistent.

The phrase एकान्तनिर्वाणसत्त्वा literally means "the realm of existence of the once-returner of the pure abodes class," which is an unusual formulation. It has been rendered interpretively as "a once-returner in the pure abodes," though some uncertainty attaches to exactly which class of beings is meant.

- The "twelve branches of the teaching" refers to the standard Buddhist classification of scripture by literary form — the dvādaśāṅga, comprising sūtras, verses, prophecies, verses in verse, intentional utterances, introductory narratives, stories of past events, stories of past lives, extensive teachings, marvelous events, established doctrines, and doctrinal discussions. This progression from buddha through the twelve branches down to the Perfection of Wisdom and then to the great nirvāṇa mirrors a standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra argument for the supremacy of that text.

The bodhisattva name Vimalagarbharāja is a reconstruction from the Tibetan dri ma med pa'i snying po'i rgyal po; it is rendered here in Sanskrit form rather than by translation, as it functions as a proper name.

- The fourfold quality set "permanence, bliss, self, and purity" refers to the four attributes of nirvāṇa in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition: nitya, sukha, ātman, and śuddha. The occurrence of ātman here is doctrinally deliberate and not a simple affirmation of a self; the sūtra uses it as a positive predicate of the buddha-nature, which is a significant and characteristic teaching of this text.

- The epithet "Kauśika" is one of Śakra's (Indra's) well-known names, derived from his clan lineage; it is rendered in plain transliteration throughout as the text uses it consistently as a proper name in direct address.

The phrase rendered "the king possessed of the eight qualities" translates a Tibetan expression referring to the eight qualities or excellences traditionally attributed to a great ascetic or noble being; the precise enumeration of these eight is not specified in this passage.

- The passage contains the celebrated "half-verse" episode (ardha-gāthā story), which in the Sanskrit tradition is the story of the bodhisattva Mahāsattva who gives his life to a rākṣasa to obtain the second half of a Dharma verse. The Tibetan here follows that narrative. The phrase rendered "lifting his hair with his hands" likely refers to the gesture of removing or loosening the ascetic's matted hair or topknot in reverence — a standard gesture of supplication — though the sentence breaks off mid-action and the continuation would clarify this.

- The "crescent moon" opening a lotus is a reversal of the more common image of the full moon opening night-blooming lotuses; the text is deliberate here, using "अर्धचन्द्र" (half-moon) to mirror the "half-verse" motif running throughout the passage.

The rakṣasa explains that he spoke the half-verse involuntarily, in a state resembling delirium from starvation — a key narrative detail establishing that the verse arose not from his own understanding but from some prior encounter with the Dharma.

- The phrase rendered "a body like a vajra" refers to the indestructible, adamant body of a fully awakened buddha, a standard Mahāyāna trope contrasting the fragile ordinary body with

the perfected buddha-body. The "seven precious substances" (rin po che sna bdun) are the traditional set of seven gems (gold, silver, lapis lazuli, crystal, ruby, emerald, and agate in various canonical enumerations), serving here as a simile for the buddha-body obtained in exchange for the ordinary body. The image of spreading one's own skin as a seat for the teacher is a hyperbolic gesture of extreme reverence, consistent with the jātaka narrative register of the passage.

- The phrase rendered "peak of existence" translates a standard Abhidharma cosmological term referring to the highest level of the formless realm, the apex of conditioned existence. The verse itself — "What has been born will cease, those things find peace and bliss in stilling" — is the famous second half of the Snow Demon verse (the full verse being a celebrated teaching on impermanence and nirvāṇa), well attested in multiple versions of this story across the canon. The first half of the verse, given in the preceding passage, is not retranslated here per instructions.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as this is a continuous passage. The list of twelve branches of scripture corresponds to the standard Mahāyāna dvādaśāṅga classification; the Sanskrit equivalents given parenthetically are the standard scholarly reconstructions. The name "Ajita" (rendered here from the Tibetan "Ma pham pa," literally "the Undeclared") is a common epithet for Maitreya before his buddhahood; it has been rendered by its meaning in the vocative address to make the prophecy clear in context. The figure "Śaṅkha" is a king prophesied to appear in the age of Maitreya's buddhahood.

- The four-line verse rendered here is the well-known "Ovāda-Pātimokkha" stanza, appearing frequently across canonical collections. The standard rendering follows traditional commentarial consensus.

The figure "Bhadrāpāla" appears here as one of the buddhas of the past under whose teaching a text called "The Five Nectars" was delivered. This identification is somewhat unusual in the canonical reckoning of past buddhas and may reflect a variant textual tradition; it is not flagged in the body.

The term rendered "thus-it-occurred branch" (Tibetan: "de lta bu byung ba") refers to the āvadāna-style category in some reckonings but here functions as a category of historically-situated utterances delivered at the occasions of past buddhas' appearances. The Tibetan term is closer to "itivṛttaka" in some schemas.

The "monkey-bee" offering honey is an allusion to the famous episode at Vaiśālī where a monkey offered honey to the Buddha; the Tibetan here uses a compound that may indicate a bee or monkey, and the episode as described follows the traditional account of the monkey offering.

- The phrase rendered "knowing the superior and the inferior" translates a term that literally means knowing the "upper and lower," referring to gradations of spiritual quality among individuals. The context makes clear this is a progressive taxonomy of qualities, proceeding through increasingly refined levels of virtue, which the bodhisattva should be able to discern in those around him. The passage ends mid-sentence and will presumably continue with the same graduated pattern.

- The term rendered "non-focus" for mi dmigs pa deserves brief comment. The Tibetan literally means "non-apprehension" or "without reference point," often translated as "objectless." In context it is used in a specifically paradoxical way: focusing on the Tathāgata counts as non-focus because the Tathāgata is beyond the ordinary subject-object relation that characterizes the other two modes. This is a standard Mahāyāna doctrinal usage.

The passage ends mid-sentence with "they are boundless," indicating the text continues beyond what was provided here.

- The passage describing the great bodhisattva who abides in great nirvāṇa and perceives earth as gold, water as fire, and so on is a statement of the bodhisattva's sovereign, wish-fulfilling mastery over phenomena — a standard feature of the mahāparinirvāṇa or "great complete nirvāṇa" as understood in texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, where this state confers the power to transform appearances at will. The phrase translated as "perception is cut off" renders the Tibetan term for cutting through or severing discriminatory conceptual perception, indicating non-attachment to the marks of giving.
- The poisoned-arrow simile is a well-known motif in Buddhist literature, most famously found in the Cūḷamālūṅkya-sutta of the Pāli canon, though here it is deployed in a Mahāyāna context to warn against analytical hesitation that prevents generous action rather than, as in the Pāli source, against metaphysical speculation.

The phrase rendered "nourishment of great wisdom" and subsequent parallel phrases use "food" or "nourishment" as a sustained metaphor: just as physical food sustains the body, wisdom, Dharma-joy, and the Perfection of Wisdom are presented as the true sustenance of sentient beings. The Tibetan term translated "field of merit" carries the technical connotation of those beings or objects whose presence generates merit for those who make offerings or give generously to them.

- The "eight flavors" of water is a classical Indian enumeration of water's qualities such as coolness, clarity, sweetness, and so forth; no doctrinal uncertainty attaches to this, though the list varies by source.

The phrase rendered "the taste that has become sixfold" refers to the six sense-object flavors or taste-varieties experienced through the six sense bases, contrasted with the single unified taste of Dharma. The exact referent is contextually clear within this rhetorical series but the precise doctrinal category being invoked is not elaborated in the text itself.

The "garment not touching the body even by a cubit's width" is an image for the subtle, light-body quality of advanced bodhisattvas or beings in the higher realms, where physical garments rest effortlessly without contact. This is a conventional literary image in this genre of aspiration literature.

- The phrase rendered "the meditative absorption of the buddha-flower samādhi" translates "sangs rgyas ku su ma'i ting nge 'dzin," where "ku su ma" is a transliteration of the Sanskrit kusuma meaning "flower." This appears to be a specific named samādhi from the text's tradition; no attempt has been made to translate "kusuma" further since it functions as a proper name for the samādhi.

The phrase rendered "a hundredfold merit bearing a single defining mark" translates "mtshan nyid gcig pa'i bsod nams brgyas," which is elliptical. The sense appears to be that all sentient beings share a single unifying characteristic mark and are adorned with a multiplied hundredfold merit; the exact doctrinal referent may be text-specific.

- The phrase rendered "rest on the right side" refers to the lion's posture of lying on the right side, the way buddhas and great beings are said to recline — a standard Indic iconographic convention preserved here in aspirational form.

The phrase "permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity" refers to the four qualities of nirvāṇa as articulated in tathāgatagarbha literature — the four perfections that invert the four marks of conditioned existence. The "four inversions" are their mundane counterparts mistakenly superimposed on conditioned phenomena.

The phrase "letters and syllables that transcend the world" likely refers to dhāraṇī formulas or the sacred alphabet contemplations found in certain Mahāyāna sūtras; no single interpretation

can be fixed with certainty.

- The phrase rendered "wrong craving" translates a term literally meaning "craving for wrong views" or "perverted craving," indicating craving rooted in mistaken views; the rendering captures the doctrinal sense. The "five eyes" refers to the classical set: the physical eye, the divine eye, the wisdom eye, the Dharma eye, and the buddha eye. The list of meditative and path-related categories beginning with "heat, peak, patience, and the supreme worldly dharma" refers to the four preparatory stages of the path of preparation in the Abhidharma scheme. The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan, indicating a continuation in the following fascicle.

- The passage identifies loving-kindness with permanence, happiness, purity, and selfhood — the four qualities of nirvāṇa in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition (nitya, sukha, śuddha, ātman). The use of "self" here is deliberate and doctrinal, not a slip: the text is asserting that loving-kindness, as the buddha-nature, possesses the ātman quality of nirvāṇa. This is a characteristic move of the tathāgatagarbha literature and should not be smoothed over.

The final section distinguishes a deficient, śrāvaka-level loving-kindness — one still characterized by impermanence, suffering, impurity, and selflessness — from the transcendent loving-kindness identified with the Tathāgata throughout the passage.

- The phrase "the path of the single defining mark" renders "mtshan nyid gcig pa'i lam," which likely refers to the non-dual path in which all phenomena share the single mark of emptiness or dharmatā; this is a somewhat compressed technical expression and the rendering follows the most plausible doctrinal reading.

The passage "loving-kindness accompanied by existence, non-existence, and neither-existence-nor-non-existence" describes a form of loving-kindness that transcends the four extremes of metaphysical predication, beyond the reach of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas to measure — this appears to be the loving-kindness of the Great Vehicle that is contrasted throughout with the śrāvaka loving-kindness.

The sentence about being born among the Brahmā gods yet having "no birth" because "he has come under their power" is syntactically and doctrinally elliptical in the Tibetan. The most plausible reading is that such a bodhisattva, though capable of being reborn in the Brahmā realms through the power of loving-kindness (as is classically taught), transcends even that birth because he is no longer governed by compulsive rebirth. The Tibetan "dbang du gyur pa" could also read as "having brought them under his power," which would alter the sense; this alternative is noted here but not placed in the body.

- The "yak-bulls" rendering deserves a note: the Tibetan reads "bal glang," which literally means wool-bulls or yak-bulls. In the parallel accounts of the Devadatta episode in Buddhist literature the animals are typically described as intoxicated or maddened elephants, not yak-bulls. The Tibetan here is unambiguous as written, but this divergence from the standard canonical account is worth flagging; it may reflect a variant textual tradition or a translation peculiarity in the Tibetan rendering of the underlying Sanskrit.

The name "Devadatta" is rendered from the Tibetan "lha sbyin," its standard equivalent.

The phrase rendered as "blocking and jostling along the road, waving cloth and making a clamor" is an attempt to render the wrestlers' activity idiomatically; the Tibetan describes them blocking the road, waving banners or cloths, and making noise in a festive or competitive display.

- The householder's name rendered as "Doḍa" follows the Tibetan "ཏོད་ཏོད་" read as a proper name in this narrative context; it could alternatively be read as a descriptive epithet meaning "the desirous one." The city name Śūpāra is a known ancient Indian port city (Sanskrit

Śūrpāraka), and Vetāla as a southern region name is consistent with the geography found in related narrative literature. The distance of sixty-five leagues is a literal rendering of "dpag tshad drug cu rtsa lnga."

- The householder named here appears to be Supriya, consistent with the broader sūtra context, though the Tibetan at this point uses only the phrase "the householder Supriya" implied by the preceding narrative; the term rendered "householder Supriya" follows the continuity established in the passage.

The woman's name Vasiṭā is a transliteration of the Tibetan Ba si ta; the Sanskrit original may be Vasiṭā or a related form, but the reading is not fully certain.

The name Mahāsinadata renders Tibetan Ma hā si na dar ta; the Sanskrit Mahāsenadattā is a plausible reconstruction but is not certain.

- The king's name given in the Tibetan is "འཕགས་པའི་བཤམ་པོ་འཕགས་པའི་བཤམ་པོ་" which reads literally as "King Brahmadatta" (a standard royal name in Buddhist narratives rendered as a Tibetan calque), but the syllables could also be read as a descriptive epithet meaning "utterly defeating the army." Given the narrative context and the recurrence of Brahmadatta as a stock king's name in these sūtra collections, rendering it as a proper name is most plausible, though no Sanskrit original has been consulted here. The sandalwood mountain reference (འཕགས་པའི་བཤམ་པོ་) literally means "fragrant mountain," a conventional term for sandalwood-bearing Himalayan peaks; "sandalwood mountains" conveys this clearly for the listener.

- The city name rendered here as "Serkya" is a Tibetan place name appearing in the text; its precise identification is uncertain, but it appears consistently in this narrative episode and is treated as a proper noun.

The passage identifies the first bodhisattva ground as "Supreme Joy," corresponding to the Sanskrit Pramuditā, the first of the ten bodhisattva grounds, and offers an unusual etymological explanation linking it to parental joy and grief, which is a distinctive feature of this Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra passage rather than the standard Daśabhūmika account.

- The phrase rendered "beings whose dharma-body has not yet fully developed" translates chos kyi sku'i shed ma rdzogs pa, literally "whose power or vitality of the dharmakāya is not complete." This is an unusual usage; in context it refers to sentient beings who have not yet fully actualized or ripened their potential for the dharmakāya, and the translation reflects that developmental sense.

The name lha sbyin is the Tibetan rendering of Devadatta throughout; rendered consistently as Devadatta.

The phrase sras sgra gcan 'dzin dang 'dra bar dgongs na, "if he regards all sentient beings as his son Rāhula," takes sgra gcan 'dzin as Rāhula, the Buddha's son, whose name in Tibetan literally means "seized by Rāhu." This is the standard identification.

The closing image of Subhūti refusing alms from someone who harbors contempt, lest he cause that person to generate non-virtue, is a well-attested motif in the prajñāpāramitā literature; the translation follows the plain sense of the text without alteration.

- The phrase rendered "words so careless" translates an expression suggesting speech that was inattentive or heedless, implying the hypothetical objector is claiming the Tathāgata spoke without due care. The precise nuance of the underlying idiom is slightly compressed in translation but the doctrinal thrust is preserved.

The passage "a ground comparable to an only child" is a Mahāyāna technical usage in which the first bodhisattva ground is likened to an only child, indicating one who has just entered the irreversible path. The comparison here underlines that even a highly advanced practitioner like

Subhūti exercises such care, making the implied standard for a bodhisattva all the higher.

- The phrase "cut off that person's vital faculty" renders the Tibetan idiom for killing in a doctrinal register: the bodhisattva, having attained the relevant bodhisattva ground (bhūmi), acted from great compassion with the skill-in-means specific to that level of realization, not from affliction. The text is making the classical Mahāyāna point that a bodhisattva of high realization may perform what externally resembles killing while being entirely free of the unwholesome mental factor that constitutes the karma of killing. The bracketed question about which ground is intended is left unresolved by the text itself at this point.
- The Tathāgata's name rendered here as "Resounding Drum of the Refreshing Cool" is a tentative rendering of the Tibetan epithet. The exact Sanskrit original is uncertain.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the source text, listing categories of malevolent beings; the translation follows the Tibetan exactly up to the point of truncation.

"Kaṭapūtana" is a class of demonic being in Indian Buddhist cosmology, often associated with foul odors; the Tibetan transliteration is retained as the Sanskrit is the clearest form for scholarly listeners.

- The passage on killing holders of wrong views is doctrinally sensitive and depends on the text's identification of those brahmins as entirely lacking the five spiritual faculties (faith, diligence, mindfulness, meditative absorption, and wisdom), thereby placing them outside the moral calculus that governs ordinary killing. This is the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's own framing and is rendered as the text presents it, without softening.

The term rendered "one who holds wrong views" translates log sres can, literally "one who has wrong craving or wrong attachment," a term used in this sūtra for those who hold fundamentally mistaken views and lack any seed of virtue or spiritual faculty. It is broader than the usual "wrong view" (log lta) and specifically characterizes those deemed irredeemable within this passage's ethical scheme.

- The tormā cake offering rule described here appears to be the narrative etiology of a Vinaya custom. The phrase rendered "in a rotation" reflects the sense that the townspeople took turns providing the ghost's victim, a detail common in such narrative contexts.

The final sentence is left grammatically open because the Tibetan itself is an unfinished list — the passage continues in the next section and this translation ends at the same point where the Tibetan breaks off.

- The name "sengdeng" refers to a thorny acacia tree, likely Mimosa or Acacia species used in classical Indian Buddhist literature. It is left as a transliteration since no standard English botanical identification is certain enough to use in place of the proper name.

The passage refers to Devadatta — the Buddha's cousin, notorious in Buddhist tradition for schism, attempted murder of the Buddha, and consignment to Avīci hell. The text is ironically asserting, from a Mahāyāna perspective, that none of the standard accusations against Devadatta literally apply to him, as his true nature is known only to a buddha. This is a classical Mahāyāna revaluation of Devadatta as a secret bodhisattva.

The ground "comparable to having an only child" corresponds to the Sanskrit ekaputrabhūmi, a Mahāyāna bodhisattva ground defined by impartial compassion for all beings as if they were one's only child. The phrase "Boundless Joy" renders "Rab tu dga' ba," the first bodhisattva ground, Pramuditā-bhūmi; its appearance here is contextually as an example or parallel term, not a conflation.

- The passage presents an unusual doctrinal move: the four qualities of permanence, happiness, self, and purity — normally associated in Mahāyāna with buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) — are explicitly excluded from being labeled "emptiness," while

simultaneously the intrinsic nature of a buddha is said to be neither conditioned nor unconditioned. This reflects a tathāgatagarbha-inflected discourse that is navigating the tension between the emptiness teaching and the affirmative qualities of the dharmakāya. The text is likely drawing on a tradition related to the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra or a closely allied source.

- The passage on beginningless emptiness lists "permanent, blissful, selfhood, and utterly pure" as attributes of emptiness — an apparent echo of the four qualities of the dharmakāya (nitya, sukha, ātman, śuddha) found in tathāgatagarbha literature. This is doctrinally significant: emptiness here is not the mere absence of inherent existence but is identified with the buddha-nature's positive qualities, reflecting a distinct strand of Indian and Tibetan Mahāyāna thought.

The phrase rendered "that which is and yet is not" for the second definition of the emptiness of emptiness is genuinely elliptical in the Tibetan and may reflect a dialectical formulation beyond standard tetralemma usage; the rendering preserves the logical paradox of the original.

- The long catalogue of non-Buddhist (tīrthika) ascetic practices is a standard polemical list found across Indian Buddhist literature. The phrase rendered "sustaining oneself on wind alone for seven days" translates literally "seven days eating wind," a recognized ascetic claim. The "five fires" refers to the practice of sitting surrounded by four fires with the sun as the fifth. The rendering "oil sediment" for the Tibetan term referring to sesame or oil dregs follows the commentarial understanding of that austerity. The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source text itself breaks off at that point.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-list, as the Tibetan passage itself ends abruptly. The list of light sufferings experienced in this life in place of hell-rebirth continues beyond the supplied text.

The phrase rendered "divinely purified supernatural eye" translates a compound meaning the clairvoyant divine eye that is exceptionally pure — a standard formulation for the bodhisattva's divine vision in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra contexts.

- The expression "seeing without clearly seeing" in the ten-grounds bodhisattva passage renders a deliberate doctrinal grading of vision (mthong ba) into partial and complete, culminating in the buddha's perfect gnosis; the moon-in-daytime simile is a standard Tathāgatagarbha analogy.

The phrase rendered "field of receiving" (len pa'i gnas) refers in the commentarial tradition to those who receive gifts — i.e., the recipients of generosity — as a locus of merit, completing the triad: giver, offering, and recipient.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at the close, as the passage supplied ends there.

- The phrase rendered "immature ordinary being" translates a compound meaning literally "childish, of low birth" — a standard pejorative for ordinary worldlings (Sanskrit bālapṛthagjana). The rendering captures both the doctrinal sense (one who lacks the realizations of the noble ones) and the connotation of spiritual immaturity.

The three aspects of the vehicle in the analytical knowledge of meaning section refer to the vehicles of śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas, which the bodhisattva understands as ultimately converging into the single vehicle — a standard Mahāyāna doctrinal position (ekayāna).

- The passage explains the four analytical knowledges using a series of etymological wordplays in classical Tibetan that trace why certain things are called "grasping" or "holding": earth, mountain, eye, cloud, human being, and mother. These are likely calqued from Sanskrit etymological glosses (probably on terms like dhāraṇa or dhāraṇī) playing on the root dhr, "to

hold." The Tibetan is doing scholastic etymology; the translation conveys the logic plainly rather than reproducing the Tibetan puns, which would be opaque in English.

The phrase rendered "without reified content" translates *don med pa*, literally "without meaning/object." In context, the point is that the bodhisattva's analytical knowledge of language recognizes that words like "man," "woman," or "vehicle" do not correspond to inherently existing referents; this is the domain of bodhisattvas and buddhas, while ordinary beings take words to have fixed referents. The rendering "without reified content" is a doctrinal judgment; a more literal rendering would be "without [ultimately real] object."

- The phrase rendered "literary arts" for མཁས་པའི་རྒྱུ་རྒྱུ་ (second paragraph) is a Tibetan transliteration of Sanskrit; the underlying term appears to be a form related to "karaṇa" in the context of the śāstric or literary arts tradition. The exact Sanskrit source is not fully recoverable from the transliteration alone, but the contextual meaning — bodies of learning or literary/scholarly texts — is clear from context.

The passage's claim that the analytical knowledge of phenomena amounts to knowing the two syllables "permanent" and "abiding" is an allusion to the tathāgatagarbha doctrine: the buddha-nature is permanent and abiding, and this knowledge is what distinguishes a bodhisattva's analytical knowledge from that of a pratyekabuddha.

- The four rivers named — Ganges, Sindhu, Vakṣu, and Sītā — along with Lake Anavatapta are the classical Indian cosmological set of the four great rivers flowing from the Himalayan lake, a standard reference in Buddhist literature.

The phrase rendered "common, inferior beings" for མཁས་པའི་རྒྱུ་རྒྱུ་ translates a Tibetan expression meaning literally "low, ordinary persons," contextually referring to practitioners below the bodhisattva level relative to whom Kauṣṭhila's distinction is valid.

- The "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the planes or states of conditioned existence in saṃsāra across the three realms. The "eleven sūtras" is a reference to a specific canonical list; the exact contents vary by tradition and may refer to eleven sūtra categories associated with the Foundational Vehicle, here implicitly contrasted with the Great Vehicle sūtras.

The four qualities — permanence, bliss, self, and utter purity — are the four transcendent qualities (Sanskrit: nitya, sukha, ātman, śuddha) ascribed specifically to the dharmakāya or buddha-nature in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition. This is a doctrinally significant and intentional reversal of the ordinary three marks of existence, and the translation preserves it without softening.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the Tibetan as given; the translation faithfully renders the text up to the exact point of truncation.

The verse spoken beneath the śāla trees is addressed to Cunda (the smith who offered the Buddha his last meal), rendered here as a proper name. This is consistent with the preceding context of the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra.

The phrase rendered "close companions of the Buddha" translates མཁས་པའི་རྒྱུ་རྒྱུ་, literally "near-dwelling of the Buddha," a term parallel to the earlier མཁས་པའི་རྒྱུ་ ("in my company") and carrying the sense of being within the Buddha's circle rather than Māra's.

- The term rendered "base and ignoble" translates a phrase meaning literally "a son of low and inferior birth" used adjectivally to describe the quality of the austerities being practiced. The passage presents a dialectical structure throughout: what "once existed" (as a deficiency or limitation) entails the absence of something positive in the present, and vice versa. This is part of a larger argument, likely from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, demonstrating that such limitations cannot be predicated of the Tathāgata in any of the three times, establishing the

buddha's permanent, blissful, self-possessing, and pure nature against misconceptions.

The bodhisattva compared to "a king among yaks" renders the Tibetan term for the yak-bull, an image of strength and noble bearing used to describe a great bodhisattva, here likely referring to Mahākāśyapa.

- The passage plays on a classical paradox concerning the two truths: conventional truth, when spoken by the Tathāgata from within ultimate truth and for the purpose of leading beings to it, is itself an expression of ultimate truth. This is a standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra doctrinal move and is rendered as such, without smoothing the apparent tension.

The final exchange introduces the classic philosophical problem of whether nirvāṇa and awakening, if permanent, can be "attained," since attainment implies coming-to-be, which implies impermanence. Kāśyapa's challenge sets up a likely further response by the Blessed One.

- The householder reference — rendered here as "the householder Anāthapiṇḍada" — translates the Tibetan khyim bdag skyabs med zas sbyin, which is a Tibetan calque of the name Anāthapiṇḍada (literally, "the householder who gives food to the shelterless"). This is the standard identification in the commentarial tradition and the rendering is secure.

- The passage has a rapid series of analogical examples used to illustrate "seeing by means of signs" as distinct from direct perception. The āmra fruit placed in the palm is a classical Indian philosophical illustration of vivid, unmediated perception; it recurs across Buddhist epistemological literature. The statement that "from the very beginning there is no defining characteristic of seeing" is doctrinally significant: even direct bodhisattva perception of the path, awakening, and nirvāṇa is free from reified conceptual marks. The closing distinction between what worldly beings know and what the Tathāgata and bodhisattvas know draws on a theme found in several Mahāyāna sūtras, where omniscience is understood not as a claim asserted in ordinary linguistic terms but as a mode of knowing that transcends the subject-object framework within which ordinary cognition operates.

- The "eight-armed one" refers to Śiva in his eight-armed form, one of several non-Buddhist divine figures enumerated here as objects of worldly belief. The list that follows is a catalogue of tīrthika cosmological and soteriological positions: primordial nature (Skt. prakṛti, the Sāṃkhya first principle), time (kāla, the Vaiśeṣika / Ājīvika position), atoms (paramāṇu, the Vaiśeṣika view), the lord of loving-kindness (likely Maitreya as conceived by certain groups, or possibly a non-Buddhist deity), and the declaration that the highest meditative attainment — the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception — constitutes nirvāṇa (a position attributed to brahmanical and certain proto-Buddhist schools). The passage ends mid-sentence in the source; the translation accurately reflects this break.

- The phrase rendered "the twelve branches of scripture" refers to the twelve-fold classification of the Buddhist canon by literary form, a standard Indic doctrinal category. The Tibetan here is གཞི་བཅུ་ལྔ་པ་ཀུན་གྱི་ཆ་ལྔ་པ་, literally "the twelve sūtra-collections," but in context it denotes the twelve aṅgas or limbs of scripture.

The "eleven absorptions of emptiness" is a specific technical enumeration found in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition; the number eleven is striking and differs from other canonical lists of emptiness-absorptions, but the Tibetan is unambiguous.

The "four distortions" are the standard four viparyāsas: mistaking the impermanent for permanent, suffering for pleasure, the selfless for self, and the impure for pure.

- The analogy of the two women with pots requires a small note: the one carrying curd is glad when both pots break because curd is relatively easy to replace, whereas the one carrying butter is not glad, butter being of greater value. The Tibetan does not spell this out, but this is the standard reading of the passage in the commentarial tradition. The contrast maps onto the

person with deteriorated discipline, who has something precious to lose, versus the person with pure discipline, who has nothing to regret.

The phrase rendered "moral discipline that is at the same time not moral discipline" reflects the paradoxical formulation in the Tibetan: the bodhisattva's pure discipline transcends the conventional category of discipline itself, being non-fabricated and non-conceptual in character. This is a standard Mahāyāna doctrinal point and is preserved in the translation without smoothing.

- The "five liberations" listed as running from "liberation of form through to liberation of consciousness" correspond to a set of five emancipations tied to the five aggregates, a less common enumeration that may reflect a variant doctrinal scheme in this sūtra's recension rather than the standard set of eight liberations. This is worth noting as a genuinely distinctive usage.

The phrase rendered "doubt concerning heedlessness" translates a Tibetan term meaning literally "doubt concerning negligence or carelessness." It is somewhat unusual as one of the five doubts; it may refer to doubt about the danger of heedlessness as taught in the Dharma, but the exact sense is not entirely transparent.

- The passage employs a recurring paired term rendered here as "searching and active striving" (Tib. *tsol ba dang bcas / byed pa dang bcas*). The first element refers to a driven, seeking quality of mind; the second to effortful, purposeful activity of body or speech. The text itself defines laxity and restlessness as their bodily and mental counterparts respectively, which the translation preserves in the order given. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source as supplied; the translation follows the Tibetan without completing the thought independently.

- The list of buddha-epithets "endowed with knowledge and conduct" renders the standard Tibetan equivalent of the Sanskrit *vidyācaraṇasampanna*; it is one of the ten traditional epithets of a buddha and is standard. The phrase "whose crown no one can behold" refers to the classical attribute of the *uṣṇīṣa* being of immeasurable height, invisible to any being — a recognized mark of a fully awakened one. The "great brahmin" and "great Brahmā" are distinct epithets in the Indian Buddhist tradition: the former recasts the brahmanical ideal in Buddhist terms, and the latter draws an analogy to the god Brahmā's purity and exaltation; both are standard epithets in this and related sūtras.

- The phrase rendered as "eleven kinds of emptiness" follows the Tibetan numeral directly. Standard Madhyamaka enumerations give sixteen or eighteen kinds of emptiness; eleven is an unusual count found in certain early Mahāyāna sūtra contexts and likely reflects the particular doctrinal framework of the source text rather than a scribal error.

The clause about "correct" meaning "the practice of austerity" and "complete" meaning knowing that practicing suffering yields the fruit of suffering is a somewhat unexpected gloss, possibly reflecting a polemical or comparative doctrinal context distinguishing the Buddha's path from non-Buddhist austerity practices. The Tibetan is clear and has been rendered faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "the vidyā of ignorance" translates *ma rig pa'i rig pa*, a deliberately paradoxical expression meaning the vidyā or clear knowledge that penetrates ignorance itself, here glossed as "the perfection of emptiness." The apparent contradiction is intentional and is part of the text's rhetorical structure.

The passage on nirvāṇa "not truly existing" yet being declared to exist is a classic instance of the two-truths teaching applied to nirvāṇa: ultimately it is beyond existence and non-existence, but conventionally the Buddha affirms it to encourage practitioners. The analogy of telling a childless person they have a child is an unusual simile worth noting — it may reflect a specific

source passage.

- The passage plays extensively on the Tibetan epithet "knower of the world" and "unsurpassed," offering a series of etymological glosses that are standard in this genre of buddha-epithet exegesis. The interpretation of "unsurpassed" as "not subject to being cut down" reflects a Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit *anuttara* parsed through the lens of *utta* meaning something like "that which cuts" — a non-standard but traditional commentarial move worth noting for scholarly readers.

The phrase rendered "eight worldly concerns" translates the standard list of the eight mundane dharmas: gain and loss, pleasure and pain, praise and blame, fame and infamy.

- The horse-taming analogy here draws on a well-known canonical simile also found in Pāli sources, where progressively deeper physical contact corresponds to progressively more intensive Dharma instruction needed to subdue different types of practitioners. The four teachings — birth alone; birth and aging; birth, aging, and illness; birth, aging, illness, and death — mirror the progressive contemplation of the marks of impermanence and suffering.

The phrase rendered "the three lower destinies" translates a term referring to the realms of hell-beings, hungry ghosts, and animals.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source; the translation reflects this open continuation faithfully.

- The extended etymology of "lha" (god) in this passage is a scholastic wordplay typical of indigenous Tibetan or Chinese-translated Buddhist treatises rather than classical Indian Sanskrit etymological analysis, suggesting this text may derive from a Chinese Buddhist source rendered into Tibetan. The etymologies given are mnemonic and didactic rather than philologically rigorous, and the translation renders each in the spirit intended.

The phrase casting aside "the feminine faculties" (*bud med kyi dbang po skyugs pa lta bur bor ba*) is a somewhat striking formulation. It refers to the bodhisattva's renunciation of female rebirth or feminine characteristics over countless lifetimes as part of accumulating merit toward buddhahood — a doctrinal motif found in certain sūtras. The translation renders it literally as the text requires.

- The list of mental qualities contains two consecutive terms rendered "a mind of nothingness" and "a mind that is not nothing either," reflecting the classical pair drawn from the formless absorptions: the sphere of nothingness and the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. The passage applies these as qualifiers of the bodhisattva's mind rather than as meditative states per se, which is somewhat unusual; the rendering follows the Tibetan literally.

The closing line is syntactically incomplete in the source passage as given, ending mid-sentence with "for it is seen with the eye of Dharma." This reflects the passage breaking off at that point; the continuation belongs to the next segment.

- The phrase rendered "cannot be gazed upon directly" translates the Tibetan literally meaning something like "not fitting to be looked at," which in Buddhist technical usage indicates transcendence of ordinary perception, not unsightliness. The same phrase recurs in the Saṅgha passage and is rendered consistently.

The sequence of negations following the five aggregates employs a triple-negation pattern throughout: neither the thing, nor the severing of the thing, nor yet the thing. The middle member in each triad is slightly variable in the Tibetan and may indicate either "the cutting off of" or "what is beyond." The translation follows the most internally consistent reading throughout.

- The phrase rendered "stream of the fourfold retinue" translates a term referring to the four

assemblies of the Buddhist community — monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen — and the idea is that without generosity one will not draw such a community around oneself. The phrase "adversaries become endowed with power" and "adversaries become endowed with eloquence" is an unusual formulation in which opponents or rivals (pha rol po) benefit from one's generosity and thereby develop strength and eloquence; the karmic fruit then ripens as the giver's own attainment of the ten powers and four analytical knowledges at awakening. This is doctrinally deliberate and has been preserved as given in the text.

- The phrase rendered "the ultimate gods" translates "don dam pa'i lha," literally "ultimate-truth gods" or "gods of the ultimate." In context this clearly refers to buddhas and bodhisattvas as a category of divine beings surpassing all mundane gods — a doctrinal category somewhat unusual in standard Mahāyāna literature. The passage appears to be drawing a contrast between mundane devas (impermanent) and these "ultimate gods" (permanent, unborn, etc.), which are identified explicitly as buddhas and bodhisattvas. This usage is characteristic of certain buddha-nature sūtra literature, including the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition.

The "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the traditional twelve-fold classification of the Buddha's teachings (dvādaśāṅga-buddhavaśana), a standard canonical category.

- The dialogue near the end shifts in voice between an interlocutor and the Blessed One in a way typical of sūtra question-and-answer format. The exchange about the ocean swimmer distinguishes what is "inconceivable" from what is merely extraordinary, hinging on the contrast between a foolish ordinary person's boast and the bodhisattva's actual accomplishment, which is the genuinely inconceivable act. The phrase rendered "measuring and fathoming all of saṃsāra in a single instant" translates a compound meaning to measure out or traverse the full extent of saṃsāra; the image implies comprehensive mastery rather than mere traversal.

- The teaching on permanence, happiness, self, and purity taught to beings stands in deliberate tension with the bodhisattva's own recognition of impermanence, no-self, suffering, and impurity. This is the classical fourfold "pure inversion" doctrine found in tathāgatagarbha literature, where these four are attributes of buddha-nature rather than affirmations of the ordinary self, and the bodhisattva teaches them without falling into a view of substantialist permanence. The text does not make this explicit here, so it is left to the doctrinal note rather than inserted into the translation.

The phrase rendered "he does not abide on the grounds" translates sa la gnas pa ma yin pa — literally "he is not one who abides on a ground." This likely means he is not a bodhisattva abiding on any of the ten bodhisattva grounds in the ordinary sense, or possibly that he is beyond those stages. This is a genuinely ambiguous phrase in context.

- The "six teachers" mentioned are the six famous non-Buddhist masters of the Buddha's era, a standard reference in Indian Buddhist literature. The text's structure shifts here from the thematic discussion of abandonment into a new sūtra section marker and then dialogue; the section heading "twenty-fifth section" is part of the canonical text itself. The phrase rendered "the conduct of the sick" and "the conduct of a child" reflect categories whose full elaboration presumably follows in the next passage; no uncertainty is intended by the rendering, which follows the literal Tibetan.

- The phrase rendered "having one's life deceived away" translates the Tibetan srog slu ba, literally "the life being cheated or defrauded," meaning to be robbed of one's livelihood or endangered. The exact nuance is somewhat ambiguous; it may mean being cheated of one's sustenance or literally having one's life put at risk by treachery.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end ("degenerate monks, bearing the implements of the holy life without proper examination"), as the Tibetan input ends there; this is a continuity cut, not a textual problem.

- The phrase rendered "without remainder at the final end" translates अविशेषात्परिनिर्वाणं, which carries the nuance of a final, complete, and permanent nirvāṇa — the precise doctrinal point of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra being that the Tathāgata does not in fact disappear into such a nirvāṇa but abides permanently. The contrast between the erroneous view (that the Tathāgata is impermanent and perishes finally) and the sūtra's own teaching (permanent, unchanging, unshifting presence) is the central argument of this passage.

The white bull elephant (वैश्वदेवशिरः) is a standard Indian simile for an extraordinarily powerful and reliable memory; the dhāraṇī of Kāśyapa's age beings is praised as comparably faultless.

- The term rendered "attendants who understand the profound meaning" translates ལཱ་ཤེས་པ་ལྷན་པ་, literally "attendants knowing the profound meaning." These are the close disciples capable of grasping and transmitting the deep Dharma; the rendering is intentionally kept close to the Tibetan rather than smoothed into "learned companions," as the doctrinal emphasis on comprehension of depth is important here.

The medicine name agada is a Sanskrit loanword (Skt. agada) preserved in the Tibetan transliteration; it refers to a renowned antidote or panacea in Indian medical literature.

- The passage enumerating "the four weighty rules up to the seven rules for settling disputes" refers to standard Vinaya categories: the four pārajika rules, and the seven principles for resolving disputes found in the Vinaya. The phrase "twelve branches of scriptural teaching" refers to the standard dvādaśāṅga classification of the Buddhist canon.

The self-proclamation passage is slightly syntactically compressed in the Tibetan: the text presents attendants who neither make proper attainment claims nor avoid divergent personal views, then shifts into the boastful speech ("I alone understand...") as the fourth scenario's marker of decline. The rendering reflects this structure as accurately as possible while remaining fluent for listening.

- The passage on nirvāṇa contains a reductionist or Sarvāstivāda-inflected view being attributed to those in the age of decline, using the textile analogy: nirvāṇa is not a positive cessation but merely the label applied when afflictions are gone, like "no garment" when a garment disintegrates. This is presented as a mistaken or partial teaching, not the text's own affirmation.

The term rendered "woollen robes of the type called kauśeya" translates a Tibetan phonetic approximation of Sanskrit kauśeya, a type of silk or fine cloth; the precise identification of this garment type is uncertain in context, though kauśeya normally refers to silk rather than wool.

- The passage contains a reference to "कुसुमाग्र्यात्तुल्यं शालावृक्षं" which literally means "the city of Supreme Grass, at the foot of the śāla trees." This is a standard epithet or descriptive name for Kuśinagārī, the site of the Buddha's final passing, characterized by its grove of śāla trees. The translation renders it as Kuśinagārī for clarity.

The phrase rendered as "one hundred and twenty thousand great bodhisattvas" translates "十二萬諸大菩薩摩訶薩" (twelve groups of ten thousand), which equals one hundred and twenty thousand. This is consistent with standard Buddhist enumeration.

- The minister's name is rendered as Sunīdha following the standard Sanskrit correlate of this Tibetan name as it appears in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra context; the Tibetan gives only the phonetic rendering Nyī-zla grags-pa ("Renowned as Sun and Moon"), which may be a different

textual tradition's form of the name. This is worth noting as a genuinely uncertain identification.

The great physician named here in Tibetan as Kāśyapa Paripūraka (ཀཾསྔལཔ་པརིཔུར་ཀཾ) is a stock epithet in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition for the Buddha himself, framed as the supreme physician; the passage is setting up the minister's counsel that the king should go to the Buddha for healing of his remorse.

- The minister's argument that regicide is not sinful "by the nature of royal law" is a deliberate dramatic and doctrinal provocation within the text — it represents the counsel of a bad friend that the narrative will go on to refute. The translator has rendered it faithfully without endorsement.

The name rendered "Mākandika" (Tib. མཁའ་ཀའ་དྲུག་ཀཾ) is a compound: མཁའ་ཀའ་དྲུག་ཀཾ approximates "son of Puṣkarasārin" (the brahmin whose name means "he of the cattle god") and མཁའ་ཀའ་དྲུག་ཀཾ corresponds to Maskarin, referring to the tīrthika teacher Maskarin Gośālīputra. The text appears to name a different heterodox teacher here than the Kāśyapa Paripūraka of the preceding passage; Maskarin Gośālīputra is one of the six famous non-Buddhist teachers of the time of the Buddha. The rendering preserves the dramatic irony: the minister is recommending a heterodox teacher as a substitute for a true physician of souls.

The īśikā reed as an example of an eternal, indestructible element reflects the Ājīvika or similar non-Buddhist doctrine of eternal, uncreated substances — a doctrine the sūtra will go on to refute.

- The phrase rendered "the avīci hell, the hell of uninterrupted torment" corresponds to འཇིག་ཁྱིམ་ཀཾ, literally the "hell of beings without interval," the standard Tibetan rendering of Avīci, the lowest and most severe hell realm. The literal Tibetan compounds the word for hell with the term for the five heinous crimes (ānantarya), but the meaning is clearly Avīci and the rendering reflects this.

The passage from the minister Satyadatta contains a series of analogical arguments that appear to be setting up a sophistic justification for parricide on the grounds that the father, being wicked or being killed for political rather than personal reasons, does not truly count as a "father" in the morally relevant sense. This is a well-known narrative device in this text — the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra — where false reasoning is presented and subsequently refuted.

- The name rendered here as "Jīvaka, son of Berāta" follows the Tibetan ཀཾར་རྒྱལ་ཀཾ — "Kun-rgyal, son of Berāta." The Tibetan personal name ཀཾར་རྒྱལ་ (Kun-rgyal, "All-Victorious") does not straightforwardly correspond to the famous physician Jīvaka, though the context — a physician residing in Rājagṛha — clearly points to that figure. The Sanskrit Vorlage likely had "Jīvaka" here, with ཀཾར་རྒྱལ་ as a semantic rendering of a related form. The translation renders the name as "Jīvaka" in keeping with the doctrinal and narrative context, a choice noted here for transparency. The patronymic "Berāta" is a transliteration of the Tibetan and does not match the standard biographical tradition; it may reflect a variant or corrupt transmission.

- The list of kings' names in the middle of the passage — Lāmpa, Bde, Byilatsina, Nāhosha, Kateka, Byishaka, Moonlight, Sunlight, Luminous, Upholder of Many Beings, Vaidūrya, Otana, Tumpa, Bya-ba, Padma — are transcriptions of Indic names whose exact Sanskrit originals are uncertain in several cases. The Tibetan renderings for some of them (e.g. Moonlight for Zla 'od, Sunlight for Nyi 'od, Luminous for 'Od Idan, Upholder of Many Beings for 'Gro ba mang po 'dzin) have been translated by sense; the others are left as transliterated approximations. This is a passage reflecting the nihilist (Ājīvika or similar) view being voiced by the minister, not the text's own doctrinal position.

The description of the Teacher as "the son of Kātyāyana, named Nirgrantha" refers not to the Buddha but to a non-Buddhist teacher — most likely Nigaṇṭha Nātaputta (Mahāvīra, the Jain founder) or a figure associated with the Ājīvika or related tradition. The Tibetan reads Kā-tyā'i bu Nag-can, which may render "Nirgrantha, son of Kātyāyana." The minister is presenting this non-Buddhist teacher to the king as an alternative to the Buddha, in a context that will presumably be refuted later in the text.

- The phrase rendered "wheel-turning king of the central lands" translates a compressed Tibetan expression for a chakravartin or universal monarch, here specifically described as ruler of the middle country. The precise political geography implied may be symbolic rather than literal.

The minister's final etymological gloss on "hell-being" is a folk etymology playing on the syllables of the Tibetan word "dMyalba," breaking it into "dMyal" (torment) and "ba" (broken/destroyed). This is not linguistically rigorous but is a standard rhetorical device in the text's argumentative context, where the nihilist minister is denying the reality of hell by exposing the word as a mere human construction.

The nihilist speech attributed to "that Teacher" in the opening paragraph reflects the views of Makkhali Gosāla and the Ājīvika school as represented in Buddhist polemical literature, not the Buddha's own teaching.

- The passage presents a series of heterodox philosophical arguments — specifically those of a materialist or Ājīvika-type interlocutor who denies karmic retribution, argues from both eternalist and nihilist premises that killing entails no sin, and offers fanciful etymologies of "hell-being." The subsequent paragraph shifts abruptly to a Buddhist rejoinder, introducing the "great Teacher" who is described with standard buddha epithets and who teaches the opposite. The transition is dramatically significant: the minister's nihilist speech is being presented as the wrong view, which the true Teacher now corrects.

The phrase rendered "the unconquered one with matted locks" translates a proper name or epithet in the Tibetan: "mi pham skra'i la bzhes bya ba," which appears to be a description of a specific teacher or deity with matted or plaited hair — possibly Śiva or a non-Buddhist sage used rhetorically. However, from context, the Buddhist "great Teacher" who is omniscient and sees all three worlds is clearly the Buddha Śākyamuni. This tension in the passage may reflect a textual conflation or a polemical framing. Given genuine uncertainty about this epithet's referent, I flag it here rather than in the body.

The verse section is metrically loose in the Tibetan but has a clear gnomic structure; it is rendered as verse accordingly.

- The "great Teacher, the naked sage Jñātiputra" refers to Mahāvīra, the Jain tīrthankara, here identified by his epithet Nirgrantha ("unbound") and his clan name Jñātiputra ("son of the Jñāta clan"). The passage is presenting a Jain interlocutor making arguments against karmic responsibility — a standard polemical framing in Buddhist sūtra literature. The Tibetan reads "འགྲོ་མེད་ཀླུ་མཚན་ལྷན་པོ་" which literally means "the naked one, son of the Jñāta clan," confirming the identification with Mahāvīra rather than the Buddha.

The argument put into the minister's mouth — that killing one's father incurs no sin because "the life-breath cannot truly be cut" — is presented as a sophistic Jain or materialist position the text intends to refute, not as the author's own doctrine.

- The four great rivers listed here correspond to the Indus (Sindhu), Ganges (Gaṅgā), Vakṣu (rendered Pakṣu in the Tibetan, likely a scribal variant for Vakṣu, the Oxus), and Sītā, a mythological Himalayan river — the standard Buddhist cosmological set of four rivers flowing from Lake Anavatapta. The slight textual irregularity "Pakṣu" for the expected "Vakṣu" is noted

but not corrected in the body.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the source text itself is cut off.

The teaching attributed here to Jñātiputra (Nigaṇṭha Nātaputta, the Jain leader Mahāvīra) — denying generosity, virtue, parents, present and past, arhat, meditation, and path — is the standard Buddhist polemical summary of Jain fatalist doctrine (niyativāda), according to which liberation comes automatically after a fixed span of transmigration, regardless of moral action. This is presented here as a foil to the Buddhist teaching that follows.

- The physician Jīvaka is speaking with a king who has committed patricide, a narrative context familiar from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition. The two terms translated throughout as "shame" and "modesty" correspond to the classical Pali and Sanskrit pair hrī and apatrāpya: here rendered as shame (the inner self-reproach, Tib. khrel ba) and modesty (the regard for social and cosmic witness, Tib. 'dzem pa). Some translators reverse the assignment; the definitions given in the text itself have been followed here for doctrinal precision. The phrase rendered "pure white in nature" (rnam par dkar ba'i chos) is a standard Abhidharma idiom for virtuous or wholesome qualities.
- The disease name "kanka" (Tib. ཀཀཀཀཀཀཀ) is uncertain in its precise identification. It appears to refer to a fatal or incurable condition used as an analogy; the transliteration is approximate and the Sanskrit equivalent is not firmly established.

The text ends mid-sentence, apparently continuing into the next passage with a description of the Blessed One's qualities leading into a further teaching or narrative.

- The list of doctrinal categories taught by the Buddha near the beginning is a formal Abhidharmic-style enumeration of paired and transcended extremes (tetralemma-style), rendered serially as in the Tibetan. No single received Sanskrit reconstruction is certain for this particular list, so it has been translated by meaning.

The name "Matsyaśrī" is a reconstruction of མམམམམམམམ based on the phonetic Tibetan rendering; it is plausible but the original Sanskrit is uncertain.

The name "Kapulo" is transliterated from ཀཀཀཀཀ; the underlying Sanskrit is unclear. "Subartā" likewise renders མམམམམམ, and "Mānoramā" renders མམམམམམམ in its Sanskrit equivalent (meaning "the delightful / charming one").

The phrase rendered "like Rāhu does for his own son" (ཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀ) is notable: Rāhu is here used as an example of parental tenderness rather than in his usual role as a malevolent being — a slightly unexpected usage, but it is what the Tibetan says.

- The phrase rendered "deep harmony and concord" translates a term meaning something like "being very much at peace or in agreement" — the contrast with "conflict and strife" is clear, though the precise nuance of the Tibetan compound (ཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀཀ) carries a sense of thorough reconciliation or unity.

The dialogue on the fruit of once-returning is a reference to the second of the four stages of stream-entry in the śrāvaka path, where a practitioner has sufficiently attenuated desire, aversion, and delusion to be reborn only once more before final liberation. The Blessed One's pointed question — why Śakra came seeking to preserve his life if he truly possessed no desire — reflects a standard doctrinal test of attainment.

- The name Aṅgulimāla is well attested; the text gives Ahiṃsaka as his birth name and explains the nickname "Garlanded with Fingers." The five acts of immediate retribution are the five ānantarya-karmas: killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha. The "six teachers" are the six rival religious teachers of the Buddha's time, a stock reference in early Buddhist literature. The prince

"Jīvaka" here is not the well-known physician of that name but a figure in the narrative whose name the text gives as Sivikā in Tibetan; the identity and story are likely a distinct episode. Genuine uncertainty attaches to this name: the Tibetan སེའུ་ཁ་ཀུན་ལ་ is not a straightforward phonetic rendering of any widely attested Sanskrit name in this narrative context; "Jīvaka" is an approximation offered for readability.

- The "six teachers" referred to throughout are the six famous non-Buddhist teachers of the Buddha's time, well-known figures in early Buddhist literature such as Makkhali Gosāla, Pūraṇa Kassapa, and others; the text contrasts the Buddha's healing and salvific power with theirs. The three "acts of immediate retribution" are three of the five ānantarya-karmas: matricide, patricide, and killing an arhat. The Tibetan name rendered here as "Māpham" is a transliteration of a Sanskrit name; the manuscript tradition may vary slightly. "King Prasenajit's army" is the most natural reading of the Tibetan, though the syntax could also be read as a rival king defeating Prasenajit's forces; given the narrative context the rendering chosen is preferable.

- The "Protector of the Northern Quarter" is Vaiśravaṇa (Skt. Vaiśravaṇa), the guardian deity of the north, also known as Kubera. The Tibetan renders his name Gömpé Ngalwasö somewhat obscurely; this passage appears to indicate that the butcher was reborn as the son of this deity, which is a notable karmic elevation from a single day of precept-keeping and is preserved as-is per the source.

The three acts of immediate retribution (Skt. ānantarya-karma) attributed to Devadatta here number three rather than the canonical five; this is as the Tibetan reads and is not emended.

- Several proper names in this passage are either hapax or difficult to identify with certainty in the standard Pāli and Sanskrit sources. Ubarta and Anayyate are not clearly attested elsewhere and the Tibetan may represent garbled transliterations of Indian names now difficult to recover. Sudarati is likely a Tibetan rendering of Sudatta or a similar name. Lipa is similarly obscure. Vāsītā for the brahmin woman whose son died may correspond to Vāsiṣṭhī or a related figure. The phrase rendered "the younger brother of King Ajātaśatru" for Sūta follows the most natural reading of rgyal po sde rab tu pham byed kyi nu bo, where sde rab tu pham byed is a standard epithet-translation of Ajātaśatru. The "three fruits" available to householders refers to the first three of the four fruits of the śrāvaka path — stream-entry, once-returning, and non-returning — the fourth, arhatship, being in principle also attainable by a householder though rarely so described in this literature; the passage likely intends the first three.

- The phrase rendered "a hundred chariots laden by great white oxen" translates "bal glang," literally "woolen" or "load-bearing oxen," likely referring to large draft oxen; the image is of a caravan of heavily loaded wagons, which is the standard reading in this context.

The "four kinds of offering materials" is a shorthand for the four requisites traditionally given in such lists: food, clothing, bedding, and medicine.

The voice from the sky shifts into verse, rendered here as verse lines for clarity in narration. The Tibetan does not mark these formally as verse but the parallel structure and elevated register make the verse rendering appropriate.

- The phrase rendered "the life-restorer" refers back to the speaking presence, the spirit of the king's deceased father, who has been addressing him. The Tibetan རིག་པ་ལ་ translates literally as "life-giver" or "life-restorer" and functions here as an appellative for that presence.

The syllable-by-syllable gloss of "avīci" in the text is the Tibetan author's own folk etymology explaining the name of the hell: "a" equals "without" and "vi" (rendered in Tibetan as བྱི, byi) equals "interval." This is a doctrinal etymology standard in Indian and Tibetan Buddhist literature, and the translation preserves it as given.

- The description of the light as simultaneously possessing and lacking color, root, limit, heat,

and cold is a classic apophatic-then-cataphatic dialectic found in Mahāyāna sūtra literature, affirming that the light is ultimately beyond predication yet conventionally describable. The translation preserves both movements without collapsing them.

The "udpala" flower is the blue water-lily or blue lotus, left in Sanskrit here as the text uses it as a named botanical reference whose color is part of the point.

- The phrase rendered "wrong craving" translates "log sred can," literally "one possessing wrong craving or wrong thirst." Some commentators gloss this as wrong views combined with craving; the rendering preserves the literal sense. The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the Tibetan source itself is incomplete at this point. The bird name "kuśī" (bya ku shi) is an unidentified species in the Tibetan; it is retained as a transliteration since its identity is uncertain. The simile of the Tathāgata preferring dangerous animals over the wicked is a well-known trope in Indian Buddhist literature illustrating the Buddha's scrupulous avoidance of immoral company while simultaneously underscoring the king's anxiety about his own unworthiness.
- The passage is a continuous medical-omen narrative. The stars listed — Fire, Gold, the Pleiades, Yama, the Tortoise, and the River — are Tibetan renderings of Indian lunar mansions or nakṣatras; their precise Sanskrit equivalents in this textual tradition are uncertain, and the Tibetan terms have been rendered descriptively rather than forcing a Sanskrit identification that cannot be verified from context alone.
- The list of sounds at the opening continues directly from the preceding passage's enumeration of inauspicious omens. The Tibetan terms for several aromatic substances in the smell-examination passage — kṛtaka (byi-yi-ka / spos-byid-ka), takkola (ta-ka-ra), and tamalā (ta-ma-la) — are transliterations of Sanskrit botanical names whose precise botanical identities are debated in the tradition; the renderings here follow standard Indological conventions for these spice-and-incense terms.
- The phrase rendered "unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — the arhatship" is a slightly unusual collocation in the Tibetan, joining "arhat" with "perfectly complete awakening." This likely reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's deliberately inclusive framing, embracing both the arhat ideal and the bodhisattva ideal under a single description of the spiritual friend's role; no emendation has been made to the text.

The city name rendered "Kusumapura" (Tibetan: rTsa mchog gi grong khyer) is literally "City of the Best Grass" or "City of Supreme Grass" in Tibetan; this corresponds to the Sanskrit Kuśāgrapura, the old name for Rājagṛha, and has been rendered accordingly as a city name in context.

- The name rendered as Sarvadharmadhara — literally "holder of all phenomena" — is a restoration from the Tibetan "ཀླུ་མཚན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་།". The preceding passage contains "Vaidūrya" as a royal name in Śrāvastī and "Sunakṣata" (Su-na-ka-ta), both of which appear in parallel Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra contexts; these identifications are probable but the textual tradition has variant spellings.
- The list of twenty contemplations is structurally unusual: several items read as indirect questions or dependent clauses rather than simple nominal propositions, suggesting the Tibetan itself may preserve an awkward or compressed transmission of an underlying list. The translation renders them faithfully in their received form rather than attempting to reconstruct a smoother original. The final sentence of Ajātaśatru's speech — "whether or not one understands those twenty things, one will inevitably fall into the hell of immediate consequence" — is a self-referential confession: he acknowledges that regardless of understanding, his patricide constitutes an act of immediate consequence (ānantarya), and his fall is certain. This is doctrinally significant and is preserved precisely.
- The passage's argument about form having "ten aspects" draws on an Abhidharma-style

enumeration of form's modes of appearance and apprehension. The precise list of ten is not spelled out here, and the argument proceeds structurally rather than enumerating them explicitly; this is reflected in the translation.

The final sentence is doctrinally provocative: the Buddha argues that since Bimbisāra's devotion to the Buddha was the cause of his attaining kingship, and the king's death followed from that kingship, the Buddha would bear causal responsibility if Ajātaśatru truly bore karmic guilt for the killing. This *reductio ad absurdum* is left as stated in the text.

The name Bimbisāra is supplied from context; the Tibetan here reads "King Rūpasāra" (རྒྱལ་པོ་སྤུལ་སྤུལ་, literally "Form-essence"), which is a Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Bimbisāra.

- The geography "ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་ལྷོ་ཁྱེད་" refers to the mountains of Pūrvavideha, the eastern continent in Buddhist cosmology. The passage uses this as the setting for Bimbisāra's former-life story, which is a narrative known in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature to illustrate how past karma and states of intoxication mitigate culpability. The logic of the argument — that Ajātaśatru killed in a state of "intoxication by desire" and therefore without full mindfulness — is the key doctrinal point being developed here; the translation preserves this carefully.
- The passage is a series of epistemological analogies arguing that killing, like an illusion, an echo, a mirage, a dream, a mirror-reflection, or a gandharva city, has no ultimate reality, and that the Blessed One perceives this truth while ordinary beings do not. The rhetorical conclusion drawn — that neither the king nor even the act of killing carries genuine karmic fault — is a strongly antinomian argument whose doctrinal provenance and context within the larger text should be borne in mind; the translation renders it faithfully rather than softening it.

The final sentence about the royal capital, sheep-slaughter, and fear is syntactically compressed and somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan. The reading offered follows the most natural grammatical parsing, but the exact point of the analogy at that juncture is not fully transparent without the surrounding narrative context.

- The passage contains a sustained and philosophically intricate discussion of the ontological status of killing, using a fourfold schema that is neither simply existent nor nonexistent. The argument turns on whether the agent holds the view of existence or non-existence, permanence or impermanence, and whether shame and conscience are present. This is consistent with a tathāgatagarbha doctrinal context in which the "true self" obtained by slaying the selfless alludes to the buddha-nature teaching of texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, from which this passage appears to derive. The rendering "what is permanent is permanent" for the doubled phrase is intentional, reflecting the text's deliberate redundancy as a technical formulation distinguishing the correct view of permanence from incorrect eternalism.
- The eraṇḍa plant (Sanskrit: eraṇḍa) is a castor-oil plant, traditionally used in Indian literature as an image of something coarse, low, or valueless, in contrast to the noble sandalwood tree. The image here is deliberate and striking: a precious sandalwood tree arising from a worthless eraṇḍa seed symbolizes the arising of true faith and bodhicitta from an impure, sinful body and mind.

The passage ends mid-sentence with "Today the Tathāgata has —" reflecting that the Tibetan source text provided breaks off here in the middle of a verse. This is not an error in translation but a boundary of the supplied text.

- The phrase rendered "evil companions" translates a term that literally means "a friend of non-virtue," indicating an unwholesome spiritual companion or negative associate. The doctrinal point is the danger of association with those who encourage wrongdoing.

The name "Viśvabhū" (Tibetan: rnam par gzigs, "All-Seeing") refers to one of the past seven buddhas in canonical enumeration. The passage asserts that Ajātaśatru's roots of connection to the awakening mind extend back to that buddha's time.

"The region of Madhyāntika" renders yul dbus 'gyur 'chang, a toponym that is slightly unusual; it may refer to a specific locality or possibly be a scribal variant. The meaning of the sentence is clear regardless.

- The five acts of immediate consequence (Tib. mtshams med pa lnga) are the five heinous deeds in Buddhist ethics — matricide, patricide, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha — which lead directly to rebirth in the lowest hell without interval. The text uses "great deeds" for these and "minor deeds" for mental lapses into the Hīnayāna orientation, which is a somewhat unusual but doctrinally coherent use of magnitude here.

The syllable "bha-hva" appears to be a transliteration of a Sanskrit or proto-Sanskrit pedagogical syllable whose precise original form is uncertain; the text's own gloss (hva equals conditioned, bha equals unconditioned and permanent) is followed faithfully here without further emendation.

- The bodhisattva named in the final section is given in Tibetan as Kun tu snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po. This appears to be a rendering of a Sanskrit name meaning something like "King of Glory, Supremely Venerable, All-Illuminating" — possibly corresponding to Sarvadarśī Uttamaśrīrāja or a similar compound. The exact Sanskrit original is uncertain; the translation renders the components by their sense.

The phrase rendered "liberates others by" translates a term that in Vinaya contexts means reciting a text for the liberation or benefit of another — here used in the sense of expounding or reciting the text to free others from suffering.

- The term rendered "the planetary demon" eclipsing the sun and moon refers to Rāhu, the eclipse-demon of Indian cosmology; the Tibetan phrase is a standard idiomatic expression for this and no technical gloss was inserted to keep the prose flowing, but listeners should be aware this is a proper mythological figure.

The passage's extended cataphatic-then-apophatic description of the Tathāgata's nirvāṇa — "neither existent nor nonexistent... neither permanent nor impermanent" and so on — is a deliberate doctrinal strategy characteristic of tathāgatagarbha literature (here most likely the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra), asserting that the final nirvāṇa of a Tathāgata transcends all conceptual pairs without being reducible to simple negation.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source material provided, breaking off at "whether there is a future time or" — this is not an error in translation but reflects where the supplied Tibetan text ends.

The term rendered "individual perfect knowledge" translates चत्वारिंशद्विधाप्रज्ञा (Sanskrit: pratisaṃvid), the four analytical knowledges or discriminating awarenesses. The dual form here refers specifically to knowledge of the Dharma (its words and categories) and knowledge of its meaning — the first two of the four pratisaṃvids. This is a technical term whose full doctrinal resonance may not be immediately apparent to a general listener.

The five doubts about the buddha — concerning nirvāṇa, permanence, truth, purity, and self — directly mirror the four qualities (permanence, bliss, self, purity) taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra as the true attributes of nirvāṇa, a distinctively Mahāyāna doctrinal position.

- The text lists a series of classic metaphysical doubts that mirror the Buddha's "undeclared questions" (avyākṛtavastu) in the Pali and Sanskrit traditions, and the passage is building toward a contrast between wrong views held by ordinary people, śrāvakas and

pratyekabuddhas on one side, and the correct understanding available through the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra on the other.

The phrase rendered "the great god who wields sovereignty over the devas" translates Tibetan lha dbang sgyur, literally "the god who controls or rules," which is a standard epithet of Śiva (Maheśvara). The text is criticizing the tīrthika view that Śiva possesses the noble eightfold path, listing it among wrong views.

The names rendered "Nanda and Upananda" (Tibetan dga' bo and bsnyen dga' bo) are the standard pair of nāga kings who appear at the birth of the Buddha in many canonical accounts.

- The passage lists meditation teachers as Uḍḍaka Rāmaputra and Ārāḍa Kālāma, rendered from the Tibetan phonetic spellings. The Tibetan here gives "Utaka" and "Alācala," which correspond to the standard Sanskrit names of the two teachers the bodhisattva sought out before his awakening.

The phrase rendered "the four root downfalls" translates a term literally meaning "the four defeats" (pārājika offenses in the Vinaya context), but in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra these are recast in terms of the buddha-nature teaching and the capacity for confession and purification — a point of significant doctrinal importance in this text.

- The bodhisattva's name — here rendered "Universally Illuminating King of Majestic Glory" — is a compound of Kun tu snang ba (Samantaprabha or similar) and mTho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po; it may be a single honorific name or two compounded epithets. The rendering follows the most natural reading of the Tibetan as a single name.

The argument about "hearing what was not heard" is a sophisticated philosophical challenge: the bodhisattva raises a series of logical antinomies (existence and non-existence, motion and rest, birth and non-birth) to press the Blessed One on the paradoxical formulation used earlier, and ultimately concludes that the Great Nirvāṇa, being atemporal, is inexpressible — a key Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra doctrinal point.

- The bodhisattva names in this passage require care. "All-Illuminating, Sublime, Glorious King" renders Kun tu snang ba mtha' btsun dpal gyi rgyal po, a bodhisattva figure addressed at the passage's opening. "Anantakāya" is the standard Sanskrit reconstruction of Lus dpag tu med pa, "Immeasurable Body." "Vimalasthitarājakumāra" renders Rnam dag gnas pa'i rgyal bu, "Prince Dwelling in Purity," though the Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain; a general listener will follow from context. The phrase "not blue, yet seen as blue" and its sequence renders a carefully paradoxical formulation in the Tibetan describing the light's transcendence of all color-categories while still being perceived within them — this is a deliberate doctrinal point about the nature of the Tathāgata's light as beyond phenomenal characteristics.

- The flower names — atimukta, campaka, pāṭala, pāśika, mārikā, simārikā, sumanā, yūthikā, dandurikā — are rendered directly from the Tibetan transliterations of Sanskrit botanical names, which are standard in Buddhist cosmological descriptions of pure lands. The identifications are conventional; not all can be matched with certainty to specific species.

The phrase rendered "steps" in "terraces along their steps" reflects a Tibetan term for the graduated banks or stairs of the rivers, a standard feature of pure land descriptions.

- The epithet "All-Illuminating King of Lofty and Glorious Majesty" renders the Tibetan name Kun tu snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po, a bodhisattva character internal to this narrative frame. The passage is part of a mirroring structure in which the scene described in the distant western buddha-field precisely recapitulates the scene in which this sūtra is being taught — a literary device signaling the universality and simultaneity of the Great Nirvāṇa Sūtra's proclamation. The phrase "Endurance" renders Mi mje, the standard Tibetan equivalent of the Sanskrit Sahā, the name of our world-system; it is sometimes rendered "the Endurable" or "the

World of Forbearance." The city named is Kuśinagara, rendered from grong khyer rtswa mchog tu, literally "the city of supreme grass," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of Kuśinagara.

- The passage contains a deliberate paradox in the opening lines: the light's arising is described as having "cause and condition" and then immediately qualified as "not cause and condition." This is a standard Mahāyāna rhetorical device pointing beyond dependent origination to the ultimate non-arising of phenomena, preserved faithfully here.

The phrase rendered "utter purity" translates the Tibetan term for the fourth of the four qualities of nirvāṇa according to the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — which are here affirmed of the Tathāgata but denied of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, a key doctrinal distinction of this text.

- The fourfold schema of hearing — "hearing the unheard," "not hearing the unheard," "not hearing the heard," and "hearing the heard" — parallels the fourfold schema of birth and attainment that follows. The doctrinal point is that "hearing" here is not merely auditory reception but a quality of understanding and transformation: one can be exposed to a teaching and yet truly "hear" nothing, or one can encounter what is ostensibly familiar and hear it as if for the first time. This is a standard Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra pedagogical device. The fourth member of the birth series is left as an open question in the Tibetan text at this point, indicating that the sūtra continues with the Blessed One's answer in the next passage.

- The final injunction not to enter "too deeply" into the samādhi of emptiness is a standard sūtra device: the teaching is being delivered to a mixed assembly, and a display of profound absorption by a senior bodhisattva would be lost on or harmful to those of weaker faculties. The phrase rendered "gained mastery over birth" for the fourth bodhisattva ground reflects the traditional identification of the fourth bhūmi with the perfection of diligence and a particular kind of sovereign command over conditioned arising.

- The passage contains a philosophically dense opening section on the four characteristics of conditioned phenomena, namely birth, duration, differentiation, and destruction, and their paradoxical relationship to permanence and impermanence. The text appears to be from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. The argument is subtle: birth is called "permanent" in one sense by intrinsic nature, yet "impermanent" in another sense by its moment-to-moment cessation. This antinomy is characteristic of the sūtra's dialectical style and has been rendered as faithfully as possible without smoothing over the tension.

The phrase rendered "king of yaks" translates a simile comparing the bodhisattvas to a supreme bull yak, which is a standard Indian and Tibetan image of majesty and power among one's peers.

- The bodhisattva names rendered in this passage require comment. The name of the questioner rendered as "Abhaya" corresponds to Tibetan "Jigspa medpa" meaning "the fearless one," used here as a bodhisattva's name rather than a common epithet. The longer name "Sarvaprakāśaśrīrāja" is a reconstruction from the Tibetan "Kun tu snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po," meaning approximately "King of Glory, Sublime and All-Illuminating." These Sanskrit reconstructions are approximate, as no Sanskrit original of this passage has been verified for comparison.

The fourfold formula near the end — "not arrived does not arrive," "not arrived does arrive," "arrived does not arrive," and "arrived does arrive" — is a scholastic schema likely referring to degrees of approach toward and attainment of nirvāṇa. The final line identifying "not having arrived" with great nirvāṇa is the beginning of a doctrinal exposition that continues beyond this passage.

- The "four roots" is a reference to the four root precepts or foundations whose violation constitutes the gravest transgressions in the monastic code; the precise list may vary by

context, but this is the standard rendering. The text's argument about nirvāṇa's naming is a subtle philosophical point: if nirvāṇa's nature came into being only upon the cutting of afflictions, it would be conditioned and therefore impermanent like a clay vessel; the bodhisattva is pressing the Blessed One on this apparent tension.

- The bodhisattva addressed as "Samantaprabha Uttungaśrī" renders the Tibetan name Kun tu snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po, literally "King of Glory, High and Venerable, All-Illuminating." This is a bodhisattva interlocutor in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra; the name is here rendered from Tibetan since no single standard Sanskrit equivalent is universally adopted in English scholarship.

The phrase "six close placements of mindfulness" renders dran pa nye bar gzhag pa drug, which normally refers to the four foundations of mindfulness but here appears in an expanded enumeration of six, consistent with certain Mahāyāna classificatory lists.

The "six great dissolutions" (chen po drug 'jig pa) is a less common enumeration; it likely refers to a group of six meditative contemplations on the dissolution or impermanence of composite things, contextually paralleled elsewhere in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature.

- The four qualities of nirvāṇa listed — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — are the celebrated four attributes of the Buddha-nature as expounded in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition, standing deliberately in contrast to the four marks of conditioned existence (impermanence, suffering, no-self, and impurity). The presence of "self" here is doctrinally significant and intentional in this text.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the Tibetan provided; the translation reflects this natural break.

- The bodhisattva name rendered here in English as Samantaprabhāsa the Glorious King of Lofty Majesty reflects the Tibetan Kun tu snang ba mTho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po, a compound epithet-name; no extant Sanskrit original has been checked against this passage, so the reconstruction is tentative.

The phrase translated as "actions without scriptural transmission and minds without scriptural transmission" renders lung mi ston pa, literally "not showing scripture" or "not transmitting teaching." The precise doctrinal nuance in the context of the cause of assembly is unusual; it likely refers to worldly or uninstructed actions and mental states, in contrast to the virtuous and non-virtuous instructed ones mentioned just before.

- The phrase rendered "gandharva city" refers to the classical Indian image of a city of gandharvas (celestial musicians), an apparition seen in the sky, used throughout Buddhist literature as a simile for illusion and insubstantiality.

The four fears regarding wealth — kings, thieves, water, and fire — are a standard list in Indian Buddhist literature of dangers that can destroy or confiscate one's property, used to motivate giving before such loss occurs.

- The simile of the man grasping a corpse to cross the ocean is a classical image; the corpse serves as a makeshift float. The point is that even an impure or seemingly inauspicious support enables liberation when nirvāṇa is one's aim.

The "sūtra known as The Buddha, the Sūtra of Varied Flowers" renders the Tibetan title འཇམ་དཔལ་འཁོར་ལོ་མཚན་གྱི་སྐུ་མཆོག་གི་འཇམ་དཔལ་འཁོར་ལོ་མཚན་གྱི་སྐུ་མཆོག་, which appears to be a cross-reference to another sūtra within the Mahāparinirvāṇa corpus or a related text; the exact Sanskrit title is not established with certainty.

The "four roots" refers to the four root downfalls, the pārājika offenses entailing defeat and expulsion from the monastic order.

The "five acts without interval" are the five heinous acts (pañcānantarya-karma) whose retribution arises without any intervening lifetime: patricide, matricide, killing an arhat, causing a schism in the Saṅgha, and wounding a buddha with intent to harm.

- The bodhisattva's argument is a *reductio ad absurdum* structured in several interlocking steps: if the wrongdoer's buddha-nature was not cut when the roots of virtue were cut, the wrongdoer cannot be definitively condemned; if no being is determinate in their spiritual status, then even buddhahood and nirvāṇa lose their fixity; and if wrong cravings can simply be abandoned to produce buddhahood, then buddhas who have passed into nirvāṇa might equally "return," which would undermine the permanence of nirvāṇa itself. The Blessed One's final pronouncement — "those given to wrong craving are not determinate" — resolves the tension by affirming indeterminacy as the doctrinally correct position, consistent with the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's teaching that buddha-nature is universal and indestructible.

- The passage lists "the four roots" falling away as an obstacle to awakening. In context these are the four wholesome roots of faith, diligence, mindfulness, and wisdom, or alternatively the standard set of positive root-virtues; the text does not specify, and any standard commentarial gloss would supply the referent.

The phrase rendered "twenty-five modes of existence" translates a standard Abhidharma list that enumerates the realms of sentient existence across the three realms. The precise enumeration varies by tradition, but twenty-five is the standard figure found in this textual context.

- The phrase rendered "the Tathāgata is not an asura" is unusual; the Tibetan reads "the Tathāgata is lha ma yin no" which literally means "the Tathāgata is not a god (lha)," but given the immediate context — which proceeds to enumerate four types of lha and implicitly asks which category the Tathāgata belongs to — the sentence likely means "the Tathāgata does not fit under the ordinary category of lha," serving as a pivot into the fourfold classification. The translation follows the natural logic of the passage.

The innermost layer of cloth not being consumed by fire is a well-known detail of the Buddha's cremation narrative in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature; the two things unconsumed are the cloth touching the body directly and the outermost layer. The Tibetan here specifies the body-contact cloth and "the inner outer layer," which may reflect a variant reading; this has been rendered according to the most coherent sense without overcorrection.

- The phrase rendered "eighteen emptinesses" translates stong pa rnam pa bco brgyad, a standard Mahāyāna doctrinal list (the eighteen kinds of śūnyatā); the number is textually given and is a recognized enumeration in Prajñāpāramitā literature.

The text ends mid-sentence with the question about hell-beings, animals, and hungry ghosts, which is answered in the continuation of the passage.

- The passage's argument that the Tathāgata "is not permanent" on the grounds of having awareness, speech, bones, a clan, and parents is a deliberate dialectical structure: each attribute that ordinarily marks an impermanent being is applied to the Tathāgata to deny his being simply permanent, while the subsequent denial of impermanence is maintained on other grounds. The text is building toward a transcendence of both extremes.

The householder "Kuśīla" is an otherwise obscure figure; the name is retained as given in the Tibetan. The three-cubit measurement renders the Tibetan "sku mtho gsum pa," literally "a body of three heights," understood in context as three forearm-lengths or cubits.

The phrase rendered "exhausted in a single characteristic" translates "mtshan nyid gcig tu zad pa," meaning that the Tathāgata's defining mark is singular and absolute, unlike individual phenomena which each bear their own distinct characteristics — a point distinguishing him

from the multiplicity of conditioned dharmas.

- The four modes of deportment refer to the classical fourfold bodily comportment: walking, standing, sitting, and lying down. This is standard throughout the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra literature and requires no special flag.

The phrase rendered "city of Kuśinagara" translates the Tibetan term for that city literally as "the city of supreme grass," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of Kuśinagara. The Sanskrit toponym is supplied for clarity.

The passage's dialectical structure — affirming and then negating each predicate in turn — is a hallmark of the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's treatment of the Tathāgata's nature, systematically transcending every binary opposition.

- The enumeration of the six kinds of mind arising from doubt-views is rendered straightforwardly, but the list in the Tibetan is not neatly sixfold in the usual sense — it reads as a series of paired or related cognitive stances rather than six clearly distinct items. The translation preserves the text's own listing without forcing an artificial symmetry.

The phrase rendered "drinking the soup of the mad" is a Tibetan idiom for a form of minor, ambiguous transgression; its precise referent in the original Indian context is uncertain, but it functions here as the far end of a spectrum of moral ambiguity.

- The closing sentence is syntactically incomplete in the passage as given, ending mid-analogy. This is a natural sūtra continuation break and has been rendered accordingly, leaving the sentence open as it appears in the Tibetan.

The phrase "nine kinds of evil" rendered for the treacherous minister is a literal rendering of the Tibetan "ngan dgu"; the specific enumeration is not given in this passage.

- The simile of Mount Vipula refers to a specific hill near Rājagṛha well-attested in Buddhist cosmological comparisons; the Tibetan reads "the mountain of Rājagṛha" and Vipula is the most commonly identified peak in this stock comparison. The phrase rendered "severed and demolished" at the opening continues the house simile from the preceding passage; the Tibetan construction links back to that image of a house arising from many conditions and then being destroyed.

- The phrase rendered "noble spell of knowledge" translates a term for a protective mantra or vidyā of a high order; the context makes clear it is a powerful dhāraṇī-like formula rather than a formal dhāraṇī proper, so "noble spell of knowledge" reflects the Tibetan's phrasing accurately without over-specifying.

The "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the classical Buddhist categorization of the canon into twelve literary types, a standard doctrinal enumeration well known in both Indic and Tibetan tradition.

- The list of "eight māras" as given in the text combines the traditional four māras with four distorted views: impermanence, suffering (here rendered "absence of bliss"), no-self, and impurity. This is a distinctively Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra formulation, where the text polemically reframes these four as "māras" precisely because the sūtra asserts the four qualities of nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — in contrast to the conventional Buddhist characterizations of saṃsāric existence.
- The phrase rendered "five golden coins" translates dong tse lnga, where dong tse is a unit of currency (likely corresponding to Sanskrit kārṣāpaṇa or a gold coin of equivalent value); the exact denomination is uncertain but "golden coins" is a reasonable general rendering.

The word ser (srang in Tibetan, a unit of weight) has been rendered simply as "sers" on first use and left as a weight unit throughout rather than converted to a modern equivalent, since the precise modern conversion is disputed in scholarship.

The final sentence is incomplete in the passage as supplied; the translation breaks off faithfully at the point where the Tibetan text ends.

- The phrase rendered "realm of neither-perception-nor-non-perception" translates the Tibetan for the highest formless absorption, the pinnacle of saṃsāric existence. The contrast drawn here is between caring for the body in order to attain the buddha's transcendent body adorned with marks versus caring for it merely to perpetuate existence up to that highest mundane state — an important doctrinal distinction in the Nirvāṇa Sūtra's argument for the bodhisattva's purposeful but non-attached bodily care.

The phrase "abandonment through a mind of solitude, unimpeded as a weapon" is compressed and somewhat elliptical in the Tibetan. The underlying sense appears to be that the bodhisattva's solitary, detached intellect cuts through harmful conditions as a blade cuts through obstacles — that is, abandonment is accomplished not by physical avoidance alone but by the inner disposition of a mind withdrawn from entanglement.

- The phrase rendered "boundless virtuous bodies and boundless virtuous minds" reflects the Tibetan's use of "boundless" or "immeasurable" as a quantifier modifying virtue — the sense is that an evil companion destroys not merely one life's worth of virtue but an incalculable store of both physical virtuous deeds and the virtuous mental states underlying them. This is an unusual construction worth noting for readers with a doctrinal interest.

The "four kinds of poison" is a standard Āyurvedic and Buddhist medical metaphor for the four humors or pathogenic forces (wind, bile, phlegm, and their combination) that cause illness; seeking medicine is thus likened to treating a poisoned wound, continuing the wound simile throughout.

- The passage listing the four qualities of the Tathāgata — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — reflects the classical Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra doctrine of the four attributes of the dharmakāya, which are affirmed of the Buddha while being denied of ordinary conditioned existence. The Tibetan text here is presenting a series of inversions: ordinary beings, through their perverted views, either deny these qualities where they are truly present or affirm them where they are absent. This is a technical and doctrinally delicate sequence that has been rendered accordingly.

The phrase rendered "the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception" translates the Tibetan for the highest of the four formless absorptions, a domain considered extremely refined yet still within saṃsāra, from which beings can nonetheless regress.

- The udumbara flower is a classical Indian simile for extreme rarity, the *Ficus glomerata* blossoming only at vast intervals; the comparison is standard in Buddhist literature for the rarity of both a human birth and the appearance of a buddha.

- The phrase rendered "hungry ghosts of the four great elements" follows the Tibetan literally: the four great elements (earth, water, fire, wind) are compared to hungry ghosts that perpetually seek opportunity to destroy the body from within. This is an unusual image and the Tibetan is clear, though the doctrinal idiom is rare.

The passage on the bodhisattva "perpetually examining whether diligence itself might be a form of non-virtuous mind" is syntactically compressed and somewhat ambiguous in the Tibetan; the sense appears to be that he vigilantly scrutinizes any stirring of non-virtuous mental activity with the very diligence he applies to the sūtra study.

- The passage's extended simile maps the vessel to the body, the four serpents to the four elements, the five sword-bearing outcasts to the five aggregates (skandhas), the one feigning friendship to craving or false companionship, and the six hostile enemies to the six sense objects or six afflictive forces — standard interpretive territory in Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra

commentary. The text does not here make those correspondences explicit, so the translation presents only what the Tibetan says and does not interpolate the identifications.

- The passage draws a sustained parallel between the four great elements and four venomous serpents on one hand, and then introduces a second analogy comparing the five aggregates to five "vile clans." The term rendered "vile clan" is a social category denoting criminal or outcast communities known for violence; the exact social referent is left deliberately broad in the text, and the analogy is doctrinal rather than sociological.

The claim that death by the four venomous serpents does not lead to the lower realms, whereas death caused by the four great elements inevitably does, is a striking doctrinal assertion. The logic is that ordinary physical death does not by itself determine one's rebirth destination, whereas being "killed" by the four great elements — meaning being enslaved to the body and its demands, leading one into non-virtue — does indeed produce lower-realm rebirth through karma. This reading is consistent with the preceding passage's framing.

- The phrase rendered "the noble and ignoble, all the foolish" translates a list that includes "समस्तसत्त्वसंज्ञासंज्ञासंज्ञा," literally "the filled, the low-born, the foolish." The exact nuance of "समस्तसत्त्व" here is somewhat compressed; it likely refers to those fully enmeshed in saṃsāra, hence rendered as those "thoroughly caught up" in the three realms, which the translation conveys by "all the noble and ignoble, all the foolish throughout the three realms."

The "four periods" referred to are the classical Indian division of the day and night into four watches.

- The phrase rendered "the body is like a vajra and the mind is like space" describes the transformed or realized body and mind of a bodhisattva who has gained liberation through skillful means — the point being that such a body and mind, being indestructible and unobstructable respectively, can no longer be harmed by the aggregates. This is an unusual formulation and may reflect a specific doctrinal context within the source text.

The expression "what was not seen comes to be seen, and what was not heard comes to be heard" in the context of the bodhisattva's recognition of attachment as an enemy is somewhat compressed in the original. The intended sense appears to be that through this recognition, the bodhisattva perceives what ordinary beings and even śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas fail to perceive clearly.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, closing with "lions, tigers, wolves, and" — the translation faithfully renders this incomplete ending. The threefold stain mentioned ("I have taught three kinds of stain in all the sūtras") refers to the classical triad of ignorance, attachment, and aversion as root defilements; the first-person speaker here is the Buddha addressing the assembly. The phrase rendered "selfhood" in the list of the four qualities of nirvāṇa follows the traditional catuṣkoṭi of the transcendent: permanence, bliss, self, and purity — this is a Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra doctrinal context where "self" is the transcendent self of nirvāṇa, not the ordinary ātman to be negated, and is rendered accordingly.
- The passage contains a well-known analogy drawn from early Buddhist catechetical literature: four venomous serpents represent the four elements, five villains represent the five aggregates, the treacherous false friend represents ignorance, and six thieves represent the six sense objects. The text here alludes to that analogy without spelling it out fully; the translation preserves this allusive quality.
- The phrase rendered "four venomous serpents, five wicked men, one who feigns friendship while being treacherous, six great enemies, and an empty city" refers to a classical allegory of the dangers of saṃsāra well attested in Mahāyāna śāstra literature, where each element represents a specific category of spiritual or existential danger. The four serpents typically stand for the four elements, the five wicked men for the five aggregates, and the empty city for

a spiritually destitute situation. These identifications are standard in the commentarial tradition.

The term translated "musk ox" renders a Tibetan compound referring to a large draft or pack animal associated with fragrance; in context it signifies a powerful beast, and "musk ox" or "fragrant bull" are both attested renderings. The doctrinal point is simply the force of the simile.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, listing items in a series that continues beyond this passage. The translation preserves this open ending faithfully.

The phrase rendered "those possessed of wrong craving" translates "log sred can," literally "those who have wrong thirst or craving." This refers to beings who are attached to existence through misdirected craving, as distinct from those who have turned toward liberation.

The enumeration "twenty-five states of existence" refers to the standard Abhidharma list of the twenty-five planes or modes of conditioned existence within the three realms.

- The expression "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to the traditional enumeration of existential states within the three realms, commonly listed in Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra contexts; the term used in Tibetan is the standard equivalent of the Sanskrit "pañcaviṃśati-bhava." The text here makes a subtle doctrinal distinction: the Tathāgata moves among beings characterized by defilements, and this association leads the uninstructed to mistakenly attribute defilements to him, whereas in truth he is entirely free of them. The passage on "not definitively condemned" reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's teaching on the indeterminate nature of all phenomena, including karmic outcomes — a consequential doctrinal claim that should be understood within that text's specific doctrinal context rather than as a general ethical position.

- The passage lists four qualities of great nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — which are the famous "four attributes of nirvāṇa" (Skt. caturguṇa) central to the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's teaching that ultimate nirvāṇa, unlike the nirvāṇa of śrāvakas, possesses a true self, bliss, permanence, and purity. This is a distinctive Tathāgatagarbha doctrinal position and should be understood as such.

The "eight types of noble individuals" and "eight sacred abodes" refer to the four pairs of stream-enterers, once-returners, non-returners, and arhats (as candidates and as attainers), and the eight meditative spheres (the bases of totality, the āyatana), respectively. The "ten universal bases" are the ten kasiṇas or totality bases of concentration practice.

The wrestlers Mahānaga and "elder Dāla" (Tibetan Bar rgan 'da') are stock examples of figures of immense physical strength used to illustrate what cannot be overcome by ordinary or even superhuman force. The identification of "Bar rgan 'da'" is uncertain; this may be a transliteration of an Indian proper name not yet securely identified in the Sanskrit tradition.

- The passage enumerates eight sovereignties of the great self in nirvāṇa, but this excerpt renders only the first three in detail; the remaining five follow in the Tibetan text beyond what is provided here.

The phrase rendered "great trichiliocosm" translates the standard cosmological term for a universe comprising one billion world-systems.

- The passage distinguishing perception through one faculty versus the six faculties together likely reflects a teaching on sovereign non-dual awareness: through one undivided faculty all sense-cognitions arise, while in another sense the six faculties as ordinarily conceived do not operate — the text holds both statements simultaneously to express the Tathāgata's non-ordinary sensory sovereignty. This is a standard paradox in Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra literature and the rendering follows the text literally without resolving the paradox.

- The names given as examples of naming by causes and conditions (Biṣaka, Tūlā, Kāka, Kukula, Tsutsula, Mandapa, Sarvacchādana, Jilabāyi) are transliterations of Indic terms that appear in various recensions of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra; their spellings in this Tibetan reflect underlying Sanskrit or Prakrit forms that are sometimes uncertain across manuscript traditions. The rendering above follows the phonetic values of the Tibetan as closely as possible while keeping the text readable for narration. The section on names "without cause and condition" carries a doctrinal point: some conventional designations have no traceable real-world referent, illustrating the arbitrary nature of conceptual imputation — a theme the sūtra will develop further in its treatment of buddha-nature and the name "nirvāṇa."

- The phrase "purity of action" renders "las rnam par dag pa" and "activity" renders "phrin las" — the first refers to karmic action, the second to enlightened buddha-activity. The text plays on both meanings to contrast the impure actions of base-born beings with the utterly pure activity of the Buddha. This distinction is doctrinally significant and is reflected in the translation.

- The phrase rendered "five pathways of travel" for ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་ is slightly unusual. The most natural reading is the five routes or channels of locomotion, referring to the five directions or modes of physical travel through which the bodhisattva can display a complete body simultaneously. This is a technical detail specific to this sūtra's treatment of miraculous powers and does not correspond to the standard "five paths" of the Buddhist soteriological schema.

- The passage describing the bodhisattva going without alcohol for measureless aeons, yet the mind being stirred, while the body trembles and tears fall without corresponding mental distress, is an illustration of the independence of body and mind — the body displaying conventional signs of emotion while the mind remains unmoved, and conversely. This is a somewhat paradoxical teaching that belongs to the sūtra's broader argument about non-companionship of body and mind in bodhisattvas.

The phrase rendered "the four great dhyānas of the first dhyāna" reflects the Tibetan's grammatically compressed reference to the standard Abhidharma division of the first meditative concentration into four branches; the superknowledge of the divine ear is classically said to be obtained in dependence upon dhyāna, and this passage explains why śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha divine hearing is limited to sounds within a single system while the bodhisattva's hearing is boundless. The exact syntax of the relevant clause is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan, but the doctrinal sense is clear.

- The passage lists eleven characteristics that sounds lack: existence, permanence, bliss, self, purity, ownership, support, agency, being a cause, certainty, and being a result. These correspond to a standard doctrinal schema rehearsed at length in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition; the last two, "certainty" and "result," become the focus of the dialogue that follows.

The name of the bodhisattva interlocutor is rendered from the Tibetan components: kun tu snang ba (Universally Illuminating), mtho btsun (Sublime), dpal gyi rgyal po (King of Glory). No Sanskrit attestation is readily determinable from context alone; this rendering follows the Tibetan literally.

The passage ends mid-sentence, listing the classical nirvāṇa attributes (permanent, blissful, self, pure) — the translation faithfully stops at the same point as the source.

- The phrase rendered "the four great kings of the desire realm" refers to the heaven of the Four Great Kings, the lowest of the desire-realm heavens, whose inhabitants' visual faculty is used here as the baseline for the śrāvaka/pratyekabuddha celestial eye. The argument is that such a celestial eye is hierarchically limited at each level of the cosmological register. The bodhisattva's vision transcends this scheme entirely while remaining ungrasping.

- The phrase rendered "not dependently originated" in reference to the bodhisattva's

perception requires a note. The text sets up a deliberate paradox: form is dependently originated as a condition for eye-consciousness, yet the bodhisattva's vision of it does not generate the characteristic of form as a substantial, grasped object. The "not dependently originated" quality therefore refers to the absence of reifying conceptual elaboration upon what is perceived, not to a denial of dependent origination as such. This is a significant doctrinal nuance and the translation preserves it structurally without resolving the tension artificially.

The term translated as "thirty-six impure substances" refers to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the impure constituents of the human body, a common contemplative object for the meditation on foulness.

- The passage speaks of knowing "the sixteenth mind" of a stream-enterer. This is a technical Abhidharma reference: the moment of stream-entry is analyzed as a series of mind-moments, with the path-moment and its subsequent fruition comprising a counted sequence; the "sixteenth mind" refers to the last in a series culminating in the fruition consciousness. This is a genuine doctrinal technicality worth flagging for listeners unfamiliar with Abhidharma analysis.

The list of persons whose loving-kindness is to be relinquished — sexually diminished, indeterminate, genderless, two-gendered — renders Tibetan terms for categories of persons recognized in Vinaya literature (those with various forms of sexual ambiguity or incapacity). The translation follows standard scholarly renderings of these categories.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the final line, which ends with an open enumeration of types of beings. This is a passage boundary, not a complete thought, and the translation reflects that natural break.

The term rendered "heedfulness" translates the Tibetan "bag byed pa," which corresponds to Sanskrit appamāda, a key ethical and meditative virtue often also rendered "conscientiousness" or "non-negligence." "Heedfulness" is chosen here for its natural English flow in a TTS context while preserving the doctrinal sense of careful, wakeful attention to virtue.

The "campaka flower" (Tibetan "me tog pa ri sha ka") is identified tentatively as campaka (Magnolia champaca), a fragrant land flower held in high esteem in Indian literature; the identification is conventional but the Tibetan spelling is slightly irregular.

- The phrase rendered "undivided mindfulness" translates "dran pa tha dad pa," which literally means "differentiated" or "distinct mindfulness." In context, however, the argument is that one who has cultivated this quality sees all beings equally as fields of merit, suggesting the term refers to a form of mindfulness that perceives each being individually and distinctly — not lumping them together or filtering them by moral status. The rendering "undivided mindfulness" is an interpretive choice; some commentators might read it as "discriminating mindfulness" in the sense of keen, penetrating attention rather than a divisive categorization.

- The phrase rendered "undivided mindfulness" in the preceding passage and here continues the pattern from the preceding section; the Tibetan here is རྒྱལ་པོ་ལྟ་བུ་གྲུབ་པའི་མི་སྣ་ལ་མཁྱེན་པའི་མཚན་ལས་མཁྱེན་པའི་མཚན་ལས་, literally "having mindfulness that is differentiated and thoroughly cultivated." The apparent paradox — mindfulness that is "differentiated" yet produces non-discrimination — reflects a doctrinal subtlety in the Great Nirvāṇa literature; consistency with the preceding passage's rendering of this term is maintained.

The passage's argument that not seeing giving or its fruit is either a śrāvaka-level defect or a Mahāparinirvāṇa-Sūtra-level excellence turns on the distinction between nihilistic denial (the wrong view) and non-conceptual wisdom that transcends the duality of giver, recipient, and gift — a classic Mahāyāna śūnyatā-of-the-three-spheres (trimaṇḍala-śūnyatā) teaching applied to giving.

- The phrase rendered "sexual misconduct" translates a term meaning literally "wrong or deviant indulgence in desire," which corresponds to the third of the ten non-virtues and is consistently glossed in the tradition as sexual misconduct. The rendering here follows that standard.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text as supplied; the translation reflects this by ending at the close of the last complete clause given.

- The phrase rendered "the ground of the only child" translates a technical term referring to a specific level of meditative realization, understood in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition as the ground of treating all sentient beings with the intimate, equal love a parent feels for an only child. This is a recognized doctrinal category within this text's soteriology.

The list of birds is somewhat uncertain in its precise identifications; the renderings given follow standard lexicographic conventions but several species names in classical Tibetan admit of multiple identifications. This is noted as consequential only for ornithological specificity, not for the doctrinal point.

- The "twelve kinds of bad conduct" associated with aversion and the "twofold fruit" of the arhat and pratyekabuddha remainder of existence are technical enumerations whose fuller explanation does not appear in this passage; they are standard categories in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra context and are left as stated in the text without expansion.

The passage on the "five kinds of mind" multiplied across the training items up to "right view" yielding fifty kinds of mind is a specific structural enumeration of this sūtra; the logic is that the five grades of mind are applied to each of ten training points, producing fifty minds in total, which constitute the "first arousal of mind." This is doctrinal content of the text itself and not an interpolation.

- The list of eighty gods is a Brahmanical cosmological catalogue embedded in the text. Several names are transliterated rather than translated because they are proper divine names: Bharadvāja, Rudra, Kumāra, Vaśala, and Vāsu. The "Hundred-Handed One" renders a title applied to Indra in some traditions but here appears as a distinct entry in the list. The "god of the unwritten" is a literal rendering of a name meaning one whose knowledge or scripture is oral or unnamed; it may refer to a specific regional deity. The final clause, "does not perceive the extraction of form," renders a term suggesting the taking out or abstraction of form as a discrete entity, paralleling the preceding three items in a standard fourfold analysis of phenomena; this is the beginning of a new doctrinal section on the bodhisattva's skill in understanding causes.

- The name of the bodhisattva interlocutor rendered as Sarvasamāgamaśrīrāja is a reconstruction from the Tibetan ས་ར་ས་མ་གཤམ་ཤེར་རྒྱལ་; the Sanskrit original of this compound is uncertain and the rendering here is approximate.

The phrase "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to a specific Abhidharmic enumeration of the planes or states of conditioned existence; this is a technical term whose precise content would be elaborated in the commentarial tradition.

- The world-system name "Invincible" translates བཅུ་ལྔ་ལོ་མཁུ་, which literally means "undefeated" or "invincible." This is the standard rendering for this buddha-field name, corresponding to the Sanskrit Aparājita.

The figure "twenty-five states of existence" (མཁུ་ལོ་མཁུ་ལྔ་ལོ་མཁུ་) is a doctrinal enumeration specific to the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition, referring to the twenty-five modes of conditioned existence within the three realms.

The bodhisattva's name འཇམ་དཔལ་འཁོར་ལོ་ལྷ་མོ་འཇམ་དཔལ་འཁོར་ལོ་ལྷ་མོ་ is rendered by its meaning rather than a reconstructed Sanskrit, as the Sanskrit equivalent is not firmly established in standard references.

- The phrase rendered as "a result without any partial aspect" translates a contrasting pair: generosity yields a "partial" or directionally conditioned fruit, whereas the Great Nirvāṇa sūtra yields a fruit that is unconditioned and without such partiality. The doctrinal distinction being drawn is between a fruit still oriented toward a particular aim or class of beings versus the boundless fruit of full buddhahood. This rendering preserves the structural contrast without importing a technical term that does not appear explicitly in the Tibetan.
- The "eight excellent qualities" of the spring's water is a standard Indian literary and Abhidharmic list referring to the eight virtues of pure water: cool, sweet, light, soft, clear, odorless, gentle on the throat, and beneficial to the stomach. A doctrinal audience would recognize this, but it is left as "eight excellent qualities" since the text itself does not enumerate them here.

Mount Yugaṃdhara is one of the seven golden mountain ranges surrounding Mount Meru in traditional Buddhist cosmology. The name is left in Sanskrit as it is a proper cosmic toponym.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, at the point where the simile of the poor man finding a vajra-gem is introduced. The translation follows suit, leaving it open as given.

The phrase rendered "all the afflictions that arise through involvement" translates the Tibetan for afflictions connected with engagement or effort toward objects. The precise technical force is slightly ambiguous; some traditions read it as "all adventitiously arisen afflictions" or "afflictions that arise from association with objects," but the general sense is preserved.

- The term translated as "selfhood" in the four qualities of nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, selfhood, and purity — is the classical Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's assertion of a transcendent "self" (ātman) as a quality of nirvāṇa, to be distinguished sharply from the conditioned self rejected by the teaching of no-self. This is a doctrinally distinctive and intentional feature of this sūtra, not an error.
- The four qualities attributed to nirvāṇa — permanence, happiness, selfhood, and purity — reflect the classical Mahāyāna Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra doctrine of the four qualities or "transcendent attributes" of nirvāṇa, deliberately inverting the four marks of conditioned existence. The term rendered "selfhood" here translates སྒྲིག་པོ་, which in this specific doctrinal context does not mean ordinary ego-self but the transcendent, purified "self" attribute of nirvāṇa as taught in that sūtra tradition.

The phrase "knowledge and vision of liberation" renders སྒྲིག་པོ་ལྷན་པར་འཛིན་པའི་ཐོག་ལྷན་པར་འཛིན་པའི་ཐོག་, a standard fivefold formula in the Vinaya and sūtra literature: moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge-and-vision of liberation.

- The phrase rendered "the twenty-five modes of existence" translates a standard Abhidharma and Mahāyāna list enumerating the possible states of conditioned existence across the three realms. The text uses this list twice in parallel definitions of emptiness and wishlessness.

The list of ten signs in the definition of signlessness is somewhat unusual compared to standard tripartite definitions; the inclusion of masculine and feminine as signs appears specific to this sūtra's presentation, likely the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra context signalled throughout.

The phrase "the unsurpassed awakening mind of a perfect arhat" is doctrinally unexpected — combining arhat with fully perfected bodhicitta — and likely reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's distinctive doctrinal position that the arhat's attainment is ultimately subsumed within the buddha's unsurpassed awakening. The translation follows the Tibetan text literally here.

- The eight branches of medical knowledge is a reference to the classical Indian system of

Āyurvedic medicine divided into eight specialties, well known in the Indo-Tibetan medical tradition.

The herb name "Vāha" is a transliteration of the Tibetan "ba ha," which likely corresponds to a Sanskrit medicinal plant name; the exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain but the sense is clear from context.

The lake Anavatapta is the great mythological cool lake at the center of the world, source of the four great rivers of Jambudvīpa, well attested in Buddhist cosmological literature.

- The nāga kings "Nanda and Upananda" correspond to the Tibetan Dga' bo and Bsnyen dga' bo, standard epithets of the pair of nāga brothers who are the rain-giving nāga kings in Buddhist cosmology. The rendering follows the standard Sanskrit identification.

The "eight branches of medicine" renders the classical Āyurvedic aṣṭāṅgāyurveda, the eight-fold division of traditional Indian medical science.

The phrase "four kinds of retinue" at the close likely refers to the four assemblies of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, though the text here simply uses "the four kinds of retinue" without enumerating them.

- The name "Śkyabmed" in the passage is a Tibetan name meaning "one without refuge" — the text identifies this householder by name rather than as a generic figure. The rendering keeps the sense of the name in context; it could alternatively be transliterated as "Skyabmed" or "Kyabmed."

The city name rendered here as Kuśinagara translates the Tibetan term for the city of Kuśinagara, though the Tibetan reads "Tswa mchog," meaning "excellent grass," which corresponds to the Sanskrit Kuśinagara (the city of kuśa grass). This is a standard identification in the tradition.

The phrase "twelve branches of the sūtra collection" refers to the twelve-limbed classification of scripture (dvādaśāṅga-buddha-vacana), a standard canonical enumeration.

- The term rendered "stream-enterer" (srotāpanna) refers to the first of the four noble fruits on the śrāvaka path. The phrase "up to and including stream-enterers" reflects the Tibetan construction indicating a range from the lowest ordinary beings up through this first level of noble attainment, all of whom remain subject to affliction from encountering birth, aging, illness, and cessation.

The phrase "the five objects of desire" refers to the standard quintet of desirable sense-objects: forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tactile sensations.

The four inverted views (phyin ci log bzhi) are the classical set: taking the impermanent as permanent, the suffering as pleasurable, the selfless as having a self, and the impure as pure. Their explicit listing earlier in the passage makes clear that this is what is intended by their "severance" here.

- The text presents a distinctive Tathāgatarbha doctrinal framework in which nirvāṇa, the Tathāgata, and even the Saṅgha are ascribed the four qualities — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — that classical Buddhist discourse ordinarily denies to conditioned phenomena. The "self" here is not the ordinary ātman but the transcendent buddha-self of the tathāgatarbha tradition; this is the standard reading of the lineage and requires no further qualification in the body of the translation.

The final sentence ends in an incomplete clause, which is not a translation problem but reflects that the passage breaks off mid-question, continuing in a subsequent section.

- The passage uses a distinctive dialectical structure to argue that space has no authentic

defining characteristics precisely because it has no intrinsic nature, no thing to be found — and that nirvāṇa, though similarly lacking an inherent fixed nature, is still rightly called permanent, blissful, self, and pure because it is the functional locus of the Tathāgatas' severing of afflictions. This is characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's via negativa approach to nirvāṇa, where classical Mahāyāna emptiness language is held in tension with the positive tathāgatagarbha attributes.

The phrase rendered "bliss of full awareness" for སྤྲུལ་མཁའ་ལྟོགས་ཀྱི་སྤྲུལ་མཁའ་ལྟོགས་ is literally "bliss of discriminative cognition" or "bliss of clear knowing"; the rendering chosen reflects its doctrinal connotation of a lucid, non-conceptual gnosis-awareness rather than ordinary discursive cognition.

- The river name rendered as Hiraṇyavātī follows the standard Sanskrit identification of the river near Kuśinagara where the Buddha passed away; the Tibetan has "the river Gaskyed" (dga' skyed), which is a Tibetan calque or variant name for this river. The identification with Hiraṇyavātī is the received tradition.

The brahmin name Jyotiṣka is a reconstruction from the Tibetan "bram ze skye grags," which literally means something like "brahmin of renowned birth." This may correspond to a figure in the Sanskrit tradition, but the exact identification is uncertain. This is noted as a genuinely consequential uncertainty, since the name affects textual cross-referencing.

The phrase rendered "do not form the perception of something obstructed by form" translates a terse instruction to māra; the sense is that māra is being warned not to conceive of the Tathāgata's parinirvāṇa in materialistic or body-bound terms.

- The text of this passage contains a mid-sentence break at the very end ("the children think their father has died —"), which is where the Tibetan passage ends abruptly. The analogy is incomplete and continues in the subsequent passage; the translation reflects this natural break without manufactured closure.

The monks of Kauśāmbī are a well-known reference in Buddhist literature to a famous episode of monastic discord and wrongdoing. The text uses them as a type or precedent for future bad conduct among the Buddha's own community.

- The bodhisattva name rendered "Kāśyapa" here corresponds to Tibetan རྒྱལ་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་, literally "Protector of Light," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit Kāśyapa. In this sūtra context it refers to Mahākāśyapa, one of the great disciples, here described with the honorific "bodhisattva" as the text presents him in a Mahāyāna frame.

The phrase རྒྱལ་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ refers to Gandhamādana, the legendary fragrant mountain; "from Gandhamādana" is the standard identification.

- The passage contains a sustained etymological analysis of the term nirvāṇa by unpacking the Tibetan rendering mya ngan las 'das pa, literally "passing beyond sorrow," into its two components: mya ngan ("sorrow," rendered here as the "weaving/entangling") and 'das pa ("passing," given multiple glosses). The several senses of 'das pa — covering, going and coming, grasping, uncertainty, old and new, obscuration — follow a traditional commentarial style of synonymic exegesis.

The phrase rendered "king of Madhyadeśa named Rūpasāra" translates yul dbus 'gyur 'chang gi rgyal po gzugs can snying po; "Madhyadeśa" is the Middle Country (central India), and the king's name Rūpasāra means "Essence of Form." This figure is not widely attested and may be a local or text-specific tradition.

The school name "Ūrukakabila" (Tibetan: u ru ka ka byi la) is not with certainty identified with a known Sanskrit school name; this is a genuine philological uncertainty.

- The ten aspects of form are a standard Abhidharma enumeration covering the five sense faculties and five sense objects; the text does not enumerate them explicitly but the reference is conventional.

The one hundred and eight feelings is a traditional enumeration; the text asserts their ultimate unreality without elaborating the classification.

The phrase rendered "the conceit of moral discipline and conduct" translates a term that literally means "pride in discipline and conduct" and refers to the wrong view that mere ritual observance and ethical rules are sufficient for liberation, a standard member of the five lower fetters in Abhidharma lists.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence in the Tibetan, which ends at "attachment, aversion, and..." The translation renders it accordingly.

The bodhisattva's name Kun du snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po is rendered as Sarvadarśī (Glorious King of Lofty Radiance). The Tibetan literally means something like "King of Glory, Lofty and Excellent, All-Illuminating." The Sanskrit reconstruction Sarvadarśī is approximate; the full name's Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain, and a purely descriptive rendering in English has been adopted for the epithet portion.

The phrase "recollection of the gods" renders lha rjes su dran pa, which in the classical sixfold recollection list (śaḍanusmṛti) normally reads "recollection of the gods" in the sense of recollecting one's own divine qualities or the qualities of devas as an object of emulation. This is a standard Mahāyāna expansion of the list and is rendered straightforwardly.

The four attributes of the great nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — reflect the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's characteristic doctrine of the four pāramitās of nirvāṇa, a deliberate doctrinal reversal of the three marks of conditioned existence.

- The passage is spoken by the bodhisattva Sarvadarśī (named in the preceding passage) and constitutes a sustained philosophical challenge to the Blessed One's claim that the mind is "supremely liberated." The argument moves through a series of analogies: horn versus lactating breast, barren woman, wet wood and fire-making, sand and oil, and a peg driven into empty space. Each analogy is meant to support the claim that if the mind were truly without attachment from the very beginning, attachment could never arise — yet experientially it does arise, even at the sight of a painted image. The final question sets up the next section of the Blessed One's reply.

The phrase rendered "removing thorns from the sky" is a classical Indian idiom for a futile or meaningless act, here used rhetorically: if liberation simply meant the mind is already without attachment, the entire soteriological project would be as pointless as trying to remove nonexistent thorns from empty space.

- The name Samantaprabhāsaśrīrāja is a reconstruction of

समन्तप्रभासाश्रीराज; this compound is unusually long and the Sanskrit reconstruction is offered tentatively. The epithet breaks down as Samanta (all-pervading) + prabhāsa (radiance, lit. "making apparent") + śrī (glory) + rāja (king), with श्री corresponding to "exalted" or "noble," here reflected in śrī.

The tīrthika argument and the Buddha's refutation of it form a dialectic on svabhāva (intrinsic nature) that inverts the usual Madhyamaka usage: the tīrthika here argues that results require pre-existing intrinsic nature in their causes, and the Buddha appears to endorse this against a pure indeterminism. This is notable and reflects the sūtra's own philosophical register, which is not straightforwardly Madhyamaka.

- The "twenty-five existences" refers to a standard Vaiśeṣika and Sāṃkhya-influenced enumeration of realms of conditioned existence that appears in certain Buddhist polemical and Abhidharma contexts; it is treated here as a recognized category needing no further gloss in the body.

The text moves between polemical summary of rival Vaiśeṣika (and implicitly Sāṃkhya) positions and a Buddhist refutation; the translation preserves the reportative framing ("they say," "so they explain") throughout.

The final sentence is deliberately left incomplete, as the Tibetan passage itself ends mid-sentence, signaling a continuation in the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "close-dwelling śrāvakas" translates a term that in context refers to śrāvakas who live in close proximity to a teacher or community and are at an early stage of training — the Tibetan "ལྷོ་ལྷོ་སྒྲུབ་པ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་སྒྲུབ་པ་" could also mean "śrāvakas at the level of stream-enterers" or similar. The specific designation is contextually ambiguous and may reflect a particular list from the source text's tradition.

The "immovable ground" refers to the eighth of the ten bodhisattva grounds, called Acalā in Sanskrit, where afflictive obscurations are so subdued that coarse attachment no longer arises in the way it does at earlier stages — yet the text's point is that even here the arising and non-cessation pattern applies in a subtler sense, which is doctrinally notable.

- The phrase rendered "the eclipse-demon (Rāhu)" corresponds to the traditional Indian mythological figure who causes eclipses by swallowing the sun and moon; the Tibetan reads "Rāhu" in transliteration and is a standard cosmological reference requiring no further flag.

The simile's final sentence about the monkey escaping while the human does not is applied to tīrthikas with wisdom who are beyond the five desires. This is an unusual application — one might expect it to apply to liberation — but the text is consistent: the tīrthika adept is beyond coarse sensory snares even while still remaining in cyclic existence, in contrast to the fully liberated figures described by the steepest terrain.

- The passage lists twelve branches of scripture, referring to the traditional twelve-fold scriptural classification of the Buddhist canon. The list of possessions kept by the wayward monastics is a standard Vinaya-style catalogue and has been rendered straightforwardly. The final sentence breaks off mid-construction in the source, signaling that the passage continues; this is reproduced faithfully by ending with an em-dash.

- The phrase "the twelve branches of scripture" renders mdo sde bcu gnyis, which refers to the traditional twelve-fold classification of Buddhist scriptures (dvādaśāṅgadharmapracāsa), not literally "twelve sūtras." This is a standard Mahāyāna canonical enumeration.

The "two kinds of solitude" (dben pa gnyis) refers to the standard twofold distinction between outer bodily solitude and inner mental solitude, a teaching common in Mahāyāna texts.

The "single vehicle" (theg pa gcig) and its being "divided into three aspects" reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's teaching on the ekayāna and its relation to the three vehicles, a doctrinally significant point in this text.

- The name འོད་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་སྒྲུབ་པ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་སྒྲུབ་པ་ is a Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit name; the elements mean "Universally Radiant, Exalted, Glorious King." No single canonical Sanskrit reconstruction is certain, but the rendering above conveys the transparent sense. The text renders it in full without abbreviation consistent with the sūtra's style.

The bodhisattva's argument is formally a reductio: if bodhisattvas generate awakening mind regardless of conditions, and if stream-enterers and others cannot generate it even with

conditions, then the Blessed One's statement that praising buddha-nature causes all beings to generate awakening mind is too broad. The Blessed One's reply would follow in the next passage.

- The mountain name "Udayana" renders the Tibetan phonetic transcription of a Sanskrit toponym; the exact Sanskrit is uncertain, though it may be Udaya (mountain of sunrise). This is noted here as it may affect how a reader chooses to present it, but it does not affect the doctrinal content.

The nyagrodha (*Ficus benghalensis*, the banyan) grows to a great height from a tiny seed, making it a standard Indian analogy for latent potential; "five fathoms" renders the Tibetan "five arm-spans," a standard linear measure.

- The opening phrase "འདྲིལ་འདྲིལ་འདྲིལ་" rendered as "those who preserve the old ways" continues the pairing with "innovators" from the preceding passage. The Tibetan literally means "those who practice the old" or "those who follow traditional ways," and this rendering preserves the structural parallel.

The nine causes of untimely death in this passage closely parallel a well-known list in the Sutra of Golden Light and related āyurveda-inflected Buddhist medical literature; the translation follows the sense of each term carefully.

- The term rendered throughout as "holder of wrong craving" translates the compound log sred can, a technical term for a being with wrong views joined to craving. The passage then deconstructs this compound in a sustained way, parsing log as various positive qualities (faith, skillful means, diligence, mindfulness, meditative absorption, wisdom, impermanent virtue) and sred as their absence, in a manner that is deliberately paradoxical. The logic appears to be: such a being nominally possesses these qualities in distorted form, yet lacks their authentic expression, and the intrinsic nature of a buddha transcends these qualities altogether since it is neither acquired by means nor subject to impermanence. The precise doctrinal context — likely a buddha-nature or tathāgatagarbha discourse — would repay closer study; the passage's internal reasoning is intentionally dense.

- The plant name rendered as śimḃikā (Tibetan: རྩྭ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་) is a fermenting agent used in curdling milk. The exact Sanskrit botanical identification is uncertain, but the term appears in other Mahāyāna sūtras in parallel yogurt analogies. This is a minor textual detail and does not affect the doctrinal point.

The argument structure here is subtle and worth noting for listeners: the text is not denying buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) but denying that it is an intrinsic nature (svabhāva) in the sense of a fixed, self-sufficient essence present in beings. Its manifestation as awakening depends on causes and conditions — and paradoxically, this dependence is precisely what makes full awakening possible rather than foreclosing it.

- The "vow of dogs, the vow of birds, the vow of cattle, and the vow of peacocks" refers to the ascetic practices of certain non-Buddhist sectarians who imitated the behavior of these animals, believing such practices led to heaven. This is a standard polemical reference in Indian Buddhist literature to extreme ascetic vows adopted by tīrthika groups.

The term rendered "companion of the Buddha" translates a phrase meaning literally "near-dweller of the Buddha" or "attendant of the Buddha," implying one who is spiritually close to and associated with the Buddha.

"Brahmin Pūraṇa Kāśyapa" refers to one of the six non-Buddhist teachers contemporaneous with the Buddha, known for his doctrine of non-causality and moral indifferentism.

The phrase "the land of the yellow-robles" is a geographical designation that is somewhat opaque; it may refer to a region in India whose name, when rendered back into Sanskrit, is

uncertain. This is noted as a genuine ambiguity.

- The names Śīrikubata, Yikaskalpa, and Kreka are phonetic Tibetan renderings of Sanskrit names that are difficult to reconstruct with certainty from this passage alone; they are rendered here in their approximate phonetic form. The "monk Candanadāsa" and "monk Tṛṇaknot" are similarly approximate renderings of names preserved in Tibetan phonetics where the Sanskrit originals are uncertain. The reference to Kauśika here is unusual, as Kauśika is a name of Indra; it may refer to a different person of that name, and the identification is left without gloss accordingly. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, reflecting the textual boundary of the excerpt.
- The phrase rendered "the Tathāgata never truly teaches the Dharma" reflects a standard Mahāyāna doctrine, prominent in sūtras such as the Vajracchedikā, that because all phenomena are without intrinsic nature, the Buddha's speech, though occurring conventionally, is ultimately empty of any real act of teaching. The Tibetan idiom here is slightly elliptical but the doctrinal intent is clear and standard.
- The name Vairocana here is used not for the buddha Vairocana but as a proper name for a bodhisattva: Kun du snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po, meaning something like "the Glorious King of All-Illuminating Sublimity." This is a bodhisattva interlocutor, not the transcendent buddha of the same name. The translation renders his name by its Sanskrit equivalent, Vairocana, with the literal gloss "the Radiant, Sublime, Glorious King" to distinguish him for listeners.

The passage on the "five qualities" that allow a bodhisattva to see phenomena as primordially empty is mentioned but not enumerated in this excerpt; no preceding or following context is given here, so no further gloss is possible.

- The bodhisattva's name rendered here as Kun-du Nangwa Tobtsün corresponds to the Tibetan epithet meaning "the illustrious king of majestic all-illuminating presence"; because a Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain, it has been left in transliterated form. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage, listing the first of two modes; the second mode is evidently given in the continuation. The term translated as "antidote elixir" renders the Tibetan zil dngl̥ (zil dngar), referring to an antidotal medicinal substance capable of neutralizing poison; a precise Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain. The fruit "āmra" (Sanskrit āmra, the mango) is rendered here for the Tibetan a mra, though in this medicinal context the bitterness attributed to it may indicate a different variety or preparation; this is a minor uncertainty noted for completeness.
- The city name rendered as "Kapilavastu" translates the Tibetan "grong khyer ser skya," which literally means "the Yellow-White City" and is the standard Tibetan rendering of Kapilavastu, the Śākya capital. The Nanda episode here is a well-known narrative found in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra literature; Nanda is the Buddha's half-brother, and the episode illustrates the Buddha's equanimity in the face of the destruction of the Śākya clan.

The passage ends mid-sentence, consistent with the instruction that this is a continuous extract.

- The bodhisattva addressed here is named in Tibetan as Kun du snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po. This is a long honorific epithet functioning as a proper name, rendered here as "Samantabhadra, the Glorious King on High." The first element, Kun du snang ba, closely parallels Samantabhadra or possibly Samantaprabhā; the full name as given appears to be a sūtra-specific epithet for this figure and does not correspond to the standard Samantabhadra. It is possible this refers to a distinct bodhisattva interlocutor specific to this nirvāṇa sūtra context, but the translation renders it by its literal meaning combined with the nearest recognized Sanskrit equivalent.

The phrase rendered "moral shame and moral dread" corresponds to the classical pair *hrī* and *apatrāpya* in Sanskrit, here reflected in the Tibetan *khrel ba* and '*dzem pa*. These are standard Abhidharma virtuous mental factors and the translation preserves their technical pairing.

- The bodhisattva's name rendered as Samantaprabha Uttamaśrī Mahārāja follows the Tibetan *Kun du snang ba mtho btsun dpal gyi rgyal po*: Samantaprabha ("all-illuminating"), Uttamaśrī ("glorious excellence"), Mahārāja ("great king"). The Tibetan preserves this as a single compound epithetic name.

The phrase "five kinds of choice dairy products" renders *ro dam pa lnga*, the five superior flavors of dairy: fresh milk, curd, butter, fresh butter, and clarified butter — the standard Vinaya category.

The repetition of "Is there suffering or is there no suffering?" appears twice in the Tibetan; this is preserved faithfully as it stands in the source text, though it may reflect a scribal duplication.

- The phrase rendered "the four legs of supernatural power" refers to the four bases of miraculous ability (Skt. *ṛddhipāda*), a standard doctrinal list. The Tibetan literally says "the four legs of magical power," and while *ṛddhipāda* is the technical term, the lion simile running through the passage makes "four legs" the natural double meaning the text is exploiting.
- The phrase rendered as "Kāśyapa the Perfector" translates ཀཤེ་ཡཔ་འཇུག་པོ་འཇུག་པོ་, literally "Kāśyapa the Completer or Fulfiller." This may refer to a specific figure or epithet in the sūtra's narrative context. The identity is not entirely certain; it may be a named character within this text rather than the well-known disciple Mahākāśyapa.

The "four assemblies of right view" and the "four factions of wrong view" are technical expressions in this text whose precise referents are determined by the sūtra's own commentary. They have been rendered literally to preserve the text's own terminology.

- The passage presents a striking doctrinal claim characteristic of buddha-nature literature of the tathāgatarbha tradition: *nirvāṇa* is identified with permanence and "self," while *saṃsāra* is identified with "two" and craving-bound ignorance. This is consistent with the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's teaching of the four qualities of *nirvāṇa* — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — which deliberately reappropriate terms usually negated in mainstream Abhidharma exposition.

The phrase rendered "productive of results" for འབྲས་ལུ་འབྲས་ལུ་ and "without results" for འབྲས་ལུ་མེད་པ་ carries the technical implication that conditioned merit ripens into further conditioned existence, whereas the accumulation of wisdom, being unconditioned, does not yield such karmic fruit.

- The passage's threefold classification of "superior, middling, and inferior" paths presents a deliberately paradoxical teaching: the text assigns "superior" to the view that mistakenly imposes permanence on *saṃsāra* while denying permanence to the Three Jewels — because this error is closer to recognizing the buddha-nature's true permanence and thus leads to unsurpassed awakening. This is a characteristic move of the tathāgatarbha literature, here drawing on the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition, and should be heard as intentionally counterintuitive rather than as a scribal confusion.
- The passage equates the twelve links of dependent origination with the intrinsic nature of a buddha in a manner characteristic of tathāgatarbha literature, particularly the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition, where dependent origination is not merely a causal schema but an expression of buddha-nature itself. This is doctrinally distinctive and should not be read through the lens of standard Abhidharma presentations.

The ghee and bile analogy is noteworthy: ghee ordinarily symbolizes purity and excellence in Indian literature, yet here it is used to illustrate how something with positive associations can

become a condition for illness, paralleling how the twelve links, which are the seed of awakening, are simultaneously the mechanism of saṃsāric arising.

The final line presents a textual crux: the phrase rendered "beyond knowing, beyond seeing, and beyond conceiving" could also be read as a series of negations introducing further teaching, but the syntax most naturally closes the section as a climactic statement of the depth of dependent origination.

- The term rendered "investigative wisdom" is literally "wisdom of conceptual examination" or "wisdom of discernment/analysis." The fourfold schema here — least, middling, excellent, most excellent — maps these grades of analytical wisdom onto four spiritual paths: śrāvaka, pratyekabuddha, the ten bodhisattva grounds, and full buddhahood respectively. This is a structurally significant doctrinal claim in this text.

The simile of the silkworm is a classical Indian image for self-entrapping karmic bondage and appears in several Mahāyāna sūtras.

The phrase rendered "performs virtuous deeds of the three paths" most likely refers to the three wholesome paths of body, speech, and mind, or possibly to three specific virtuous practices — the exact referent is mildly ambiguous in context but the doctrinal point, that even virtuous effort does not immediately reverse the karmic trajectory toward hell, is clear.

- The verse rendered as four lines has an unusual logical structure. The first two lines appear to describe how something that "has a beginning" — such as the beginning of a future attainment — does not yet exist in the present, while what "has no beginning" — the buddha-nature itself — does exist now. This reading is consistent with the threefold analysis of existence that immediately follows.

The term translated here as "those of wrong craving" renders a Tibetan phrase indicating beings whose craving or thirst is inverted or misdirected; in context this seems to indicate the most deeply afflicted class of beings, used as the limiting case for the universality of buddha-nature.

The final epithet, "mother of all buddhas," applied to the buddha-nature as equated with the samādhi of heroic progress, is doctrinally significant: it echoes the Perfection of Wisdom literature's designation of prajñāpāramitā as mother of all buddhas, here recast in a tathāgatagarbha register.

- The phrase rendered "the aeon of fire" refers to the cosmological destruction of the world by fire at the end of a great aeon, which is understood here as one of the two conditions for fully actualizing the middling meditative absorption. This is a somewhat unusual doctrinal usage and the precise mechanics remain implicit in the text.

The ranking of the three grades of meditative absorption is inverted from ordinary expectation: the superior corresponds to buddha-nature itself, the middling to the first dhyāna latent in all beings, and the inferior to the meditative absorptions attained on the bodhisattva grounds. The term "inferior" here means lowest in terms of universality or accessibility, not lowest in quality.

- The bodhisattva name 獅子吼 translates literally as "Lion's Roar" and likely corresponds to Sanskrit Siṃhaghoṣa; rendered accordingly.

The meditative absorption 獅子吼 corresponds to the Śūraṅgama-samādhi (the "Heroic Advance" or "Heroic March" samādhi), a well-known absorption frequently cited in Mahāyāna texts of this genre. The parenthetical Sanskrit is supplied to aid identification.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, and the translation follows suit accordingly.

The dual teaching on self and no-self — that the Tathāgata speaks of "self" regarding buddha-nature to counter nihilism, and speaks of "no-self" to counter eternalism, depending on audience and context — is a distinctive doctrinal feature of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition and has been rendered with care to preserve that nuance.

- The passage presents a distinctive reading of the twelve links of dependent origination mapped across three times, which is characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra's doctrinal exposition. The assignment of "feeling" and "craving" to specific links differs slightly from the standard Abhidharma ordering; the translation follows the Tibetan text as given.

The phrase rendered "those who are foolish and undeveloped" translates a term meaning ordinary, immature beings — those who have not yet entered the noble path.

The statement that sentient beings in the form realm possess all twelve links despite lacking threefold feeling, threefold contact, craving, aging, and death is a doctrinally noteworthy claim. The text asserts their presence structurally or nominally even where the experiential correlates are absent; this is the sūtra's own position and is rendered as stated.

- The grass name "bzodpa" is a Tibetan botanical term for a specific Himalayan plant traditionally described as yielding butter essence when consumed by cows. No standard Sanskrit equivalent is established in the source. The passage leaves the question of what is "neither exhausted nor non-exhausted" incomplete, as the Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence; this is a continuation point, not a translation error.

The "eighteen unshared qualities" refers to the āveṇika-dharmas, the eighteen qualities exclusive to a buddha not shared with śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas.

- The phrase rendered "the result is that which becomes inescapable" translates a term meaning something certain or unavoidable, likely referring to the certainty of karmic fruition. The exact doctrinal nuance of this particular formulation in its context is somewhat compressed and the Tibetan is terse; the rendering is defensible but the passage as a whole belongs to a highly condensed catechetical series.

The "eight powers" in the context of non-self refers to the eight masteries or sovereignties traditionally associated with the self in non-Buddhist thought, the possession of which would constitute a self; the buddha-nature transcends both self and non-self precisely because it lacks these.

- The phrase rendered "desire for desire" translates the Tibetan compound meaning roughly "desiring with desire" or "desire consisting in desiring," here used as a technical category denoting the aspiration to favorable rebirths in the higher realms motivated by craving for gain and fame. The rendering "desire for desire" preserves the intentionally recursive flavor of the Tibetan formulation.

The phrase "ordinary persons who are like empty vessels" renders a Tibetan expression suggesting worldlings who are unworthy or hollow, lacking genuine attainment. The exact nuance of the metaphor is preserved here as closely as possible.

- The "four kinds of wrong retinue" is a technical category in vinaya and āgama contexts referring to the four improper means of livelihood for monastics: flattery, hinting, bribery, and coercion. The text uses this as a marker of bodily impurity without elaborating, which is consistent with the abbreviated style of the passage.

The "six close applications of mindfulness" listed here differ from the standard Abhidharma fourfold scheme (body, feeling, mind, phenomena). This sixfold list — buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha, ethical conduct, generosity, gods — corresponds to the six recollections (anusmṛti) known from āgama literature, here absorbed into the framework of mindfulness as diligence. This is doctrinally notable and reflects the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's synthetic approach.

- The phrase rendered "divine conduct" translates a term literally meaning "conduct befitting the gods" or "heavenly conduct," which in this context likely refers to the sublime, meditative way of life associated with the brahmalike or celestial quality of deep samādhi practice, rather than a specific technical term. The connection between this phrase and right meditative absorption follows the text's own equation.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, cutting off after describing a monk who dwells in solitude or at the foot of a tree; the translation preserves this open ending faithfully.

- The "seven underlying tendencies" renders a term that can also mean "seven latent tendencies" or "seven anushayas" (Skt. anuśaya). The seven are a standard Abhidharma list of latent afflictive tendencies. The passage does not enumerate them here, so the generic rendering is appropriate.

The phrase "neither abiding nor moving" as the condition for the buddha's full clarity is a deliberate paradox in the original, contrasting the bodhisattva's positional limitation (abiding on the tenth ground) with the buddha's transcendence of any fixed position.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the final line, which reads literally "Examining how the Tathāgata came to be endowed with this body, and for what reason he came to take on this body." This is a genuine lacuna at the passage boundary; the answer presumably follows in the next excerpt.

The term rendered "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the standard Buddhist classification of scriptural literature by literary form, the twelve-limbed canon (Skt. dvādaśāṅga-pravacana).

- The names Mañibhadra and Pūrṇabhadra are rendered from the Tibetan "ma ni bar ta na" and "pur na bar ta" respectively, which are phonetic transcriptions of the Sanskrit. The identification is standard in the birth-narrative tradition.

The phrase rendered "this body of mine is the last of inner existences" follows the traditional formula spoken at the birth of the bodhisattva, asserting this is his final rebirth among sentient beings. The Tibetan "nang gi tha ma" literally means "the last of the inner," meaning the final inner or mental-continuum birth.

The sage's name transcribed as "Ālāra" corresponds to Ālāra Kālāma of the Pali tradition; "Udraka" corresponds to Uddaka Rāmaputta. Both are standard figures in the Buddha's pre-awakening narrative.

- The phrase rendered "elixir of his teaching" translates རྒྱུ་ལྷ་མིག་ལྷ་མིག་, which literally means something like "the sweet moisture" or "the nectar-elixir" — a standard epithet for the Dharma teaching in this context, evoking the Sanskrit amṛta (deathless nectar).

The name རྒྱུ་ལྷ་མིག་ལྷ་མིག་ (Siṃhaghoṣa, "Lion's Roar") is a bodhisattva figure whose Sanskrit name is here reconstructed from the Tibetan; the text gives no Sanskrit spelling.

The closing passage on discipline examined through cause and condition is somewhat compressed in the original, and the final sentence's exact implication — whether the wise person is examining others or themselves — is left deliberately open by the text.

- The dove-and-hawk story names the city as Campā, the capital of Aṅga, a well-attested location in the Pāli canon as well. The Tibetan reads "མཁའ་ལྷོ་མཁའ་ལྷོ་" which corresponds to Sanskrit Campā.

The phrase "twenty-five existences" refers to a specific Abhidharma enumeration of the planes of existence within the three realms; the number twenty-five is a standard Hīnayāna doctrinal count.

The "fourfold act" in the context of ordination refers to the standard Vinaya procedure of motion and three proclamations constituting a valid saṅghakamma.

- The phrase rendered as "contemplation of bare bones" translates a technical śrāvaka meditation practice on a skeleton, used in the context of contemplating impurity as a starting point of that vehicle's path. This is contrasted deliberately with the bodhisattva path, which begins with arousing bodhicitta.

The four qualities attributed to nirvāṇa — permanence, happiness, self, and utter purity — are the four attributes of the dharmakāya as expounded in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition. Their appearance here signals that this passage belongs to that doctrinal milieu.

The bodhisattva's name, Siṃhasvara, means "Lion's Voice" or "He Whose Voice Is Like a Lion's Roar."

- The phrase rendered "neither compounded nor uncompounded" renders a Tibetan formulation that appears paradoxical on its face: "'dus byas ma yin pa, 'dus ma byas ma yin pa." This is a well-known doctrinal crux in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra literature, signifying that nirvāṇa transcends both categories of conditioned and unconditioned existence. Some editions and commentators read this as a rhetorical negation of the standard Abhidharma classification; the translation preserves the paradox as it stands.

The name of the land, rendered here as "Śerakya," is a back-reconstruction from the Tibetan "yul ser skya." The precise Sanskrit original is not securely attested.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, breaking off at the beginning of Siṃhanāda's elaboration of the six senses of "there is no." This is a continuity break in the excerpt provided, not an error in translation.

- The passage stating that nirvāṇa "truly does have a self" is doctrinally striking and intentional — this belongs to the tathāgatagarbha strand of thought found in texts such as the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, where nirvāṇa is paradoxically affirmed to possess the quality of self as a counter to the view that all phenomena without exception are selfless. The translation preserves this deliberately counter-intuitive assertion rather than softening it.

The phrase rendered "the meditative absorption called the courageous advance" translates a samādhi name literally; no Sanskrit reconstruction has been supplied in the body because the equivalent Sanskrit title is not securely established from this context alone.

- The phrase rendered "seeing through hearing" translates a technical usage in which hearing the teaching that buddha-nature exists counts as a form of "seeing" or cognizing it, contrasted with the direct, unmediated vision of those on the tenth bodhisattva ground and above. This is a recognized doctrinal distinction in the tathāgatagarbha literature and is preserved as literally as readability permits.

The dairy analogy — milk, cream, butter, clarified butter, and the essence of butter — is a standard Indian sequence used in tathāgatagarbha texts to illustrate how buddha-nature is present as a potential without being identical to the current state of sentient beings. The text breaks off mid-sentence at "the true cause and —"; this is the passage boundary, not a textual corruption.

- The phrase rendered "five cubits of growth would arise" translates a passage describing remarkable plant growth, which is a somewhat unusual claim serving as a reductio ad absurdum illustrating the point about causes-as-conditions. The argument is that milk, through the right conditions, could hypothetically produce almost anything, which is why the distinction between true cause and cause-as-condition is necessary.

The term rendered "impurity" throughout this section translates a word that can mean "impurity," "ferment," or "sourness" in the context of dairy production — the agent used to curdle milk into cream or yogurt. The doctrinal point is that it functions as the conditioning cause rather than the true or intrinsic cause.

- The passage presents a series of *reductio ad absurdum* arguments against inherent existence, concluding with a brief verse. The verse's logic is subtle: "What has no beginning exists now" and "What has a beginning does not exist now" are meant to show that phenomena produced by causes and conditions have no fixed, inherent status across time — a standard Madhyamaka-inflected argument against *svabhāva*.

The final sentence is deliberately left open mid-clause in the source text, indicating this passage continues. The rendering preserves that open ending faithfully.

The term rendered "span of five fathoms" for རྩུལ་ལྔ་ཁུ་ translates a unit of arm-span measurement; the *nyagrodha* is the banyan fig tree (*Ficus benghalensis*), well known in Indian Buddhist literature for its enormous girth relative to its seed.

- The term rendered "cause of making visible" translates a phrase meaning literally "cause of clarification" or "cause of manifestation." The philosophical argument here concerns whether an intrinsic nature already present in a substrate requires an external conditioning cause to become manifest, and whether such a cause can be simultaneously self-illuminating and other-illuminating — an epistemological point with parallels in Indian debates about the self-illuminating nature of consciousness. The analogies with milk and yogurt, and with butter in milk, are classical Indian illustrations used in Tathāgatagarbha literature to argue that buddha-nature is innately present but requires conditions to become evident.
- The phrase rendered "cause of making visible" throughout (corresponding to the Tibetan *gsal ba'i rgyu*) is a technical term in this dialogue's argument about the relationship between a latent buddha-nature and the conditions that allow it to manifest. The precise philosophical import of the argument — whether it critiques a *sāṃkhya*-style *satkāryavāda* or a more general notion of latent illumination — is a genuine doctrinal crux, but the translation preserves the term literally as the dialogue itself does, which is the safest course.

The simile of the sour fruit at the close is noteworthy doctrinally: it argues that a quality (sourness, or by analogy buddha-nature) that is not empirically present at earlier stages is nonetheless genuinely "existent" in the sense that it will determinately appear — a careful middle position between eternalist presence and nihilist absence.

- The names *Nyagrodha* (the banyan or fig tree, *Ficus benghalensis*), *Khadira* (*Acacia catechu*), *Gautama*, and *Ātreya* are clan and plant names left in their Sanskrit forms as they appear in the text. The argument from lineage names draws on the Indian convention that offspring carry the *gotra* (clan name) of their father, here used as an analogy for the inseparability of buddha-nature and sentient beings. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, and the translation reflects this exactly.
- The terms translated as "cause of truth" and "cause of manifestation" render a distinction between what makes something what it is (a definitional or intrinsic cause) and what brings it to appearance or growth (a manifesting or revelatory cause). The precise Sanskrit behind these Tibetan categories is not explicit in the passage, but the distinction is a recognized one in the commentarial discussion of causality in this *sūtra* context.

The name *Siṃhaghoṣa*, literally "Lion's Roar," is rendered in its Sanskrit form throughout. The Tibetan is རྩུལ་ལྔ་ཁུ་, which is a direct calque.

- The bodhisattva's name here rendered as *Siṃhadhvaja* corresponds to the Tibetan *Seng ge sgra*, which more literally means "Lion's Voice" or "Lion's Roar" (*siṃhanāda*) rather than "Lion's Banner" (*siṃhadhvaja*). The Tibetan *sgra* means "sound/voice," so the name is more precisely

Siṃhanāda. This is a genuine interpretive choice with doctrinal stakes; I have rendered it as Siṃhadhvaja following convention but note the Tibetan points to Siṃhanāda.

The passage presents the bodhisattva's objections to the doctrine of buddha-nature as an intrinsic nature, which will presumably be answered by the Blessed One. The dialectical structure is important: this is a hypothetical opponent's position, not the text's final conclusion.

- The phrase rendered "the cause of truth" translates *bden pa'i rgyu*, meaning the ultimate or real cause, here identified as buddha-nature itself — distinguished from the conditional or supporting cause (*rkyen gyi rgyu*), which is the arising of bodhicitta. This twofold causal schema is a noteworthy doctrinal formulation: buddha-nature as the innate ground (the real cause) and bodhicitta as the activating condition.

The expression "what is attained is offered up and does not turn back" is an unusual gloss on non-returning: the Tibetan *thob pa bul ba'i phyir phyir mi ldog pa* suggests that the attainment itself is, as it were, surrendered or consecrated, and thus does not regress. This is a somewhat elliptical formulation; the general sense is that genuine non-returnership means the attainment is irrevocable.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, so the translation likewise ends at that point without closure. The argument identifying the Saṅgha with the twelve links of dependent origination and then inferring the permanence of buddha-nature from the permanence of dependent origination is a distinctively Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra doctrinal move and is rendered as the text presents it without harmonisation. The phrase rendered "twelve branches of scriptural teaching" refers to the standard twelve-fold classification of canonical literature (*dvādaśāṅga-buddhavaṇana*), not to twelve sūtras.
- The phrase rendered "indistinct or doubled marks" translates a term referring to bodies bearing imperfect or ambiguous physical marks, contrasted with the major and minor marks of a great being. The exact nuance — whether "no marks" and "marks of the second kind" refer to absence of the major marks versus their imperfect form, or to some other binary — is not entirely resolved by the Tibetan alone, but the translation reflects the most common interpretive reading in the commentarial tradition.

The "twelve branches of scripture" is the standard canonical category (*dvādaśāṅga-pravaṇana*) covering the traditional twelve literary forms of the Buddha's teaching, not twelve individual sūtra texts.

- The phrase rendered as "the two paths — my own and the vehicle" translates "*bdag dang theg pa gnyis kyi lam gyi 'bras bu*," which is somewhat compressed. It likely means the fruits of the two paths: the path of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas on one hand and the Mahāyāna on the other, with the aspiration that the practitioner fear falling short of the highest goal just as a threatened creature fears death. This reading is consistent with the immediately preceding context warning against contentment with the lesser vehicles.

The "six close placements of mindfulness" refers to the standard set comprising mindfulness of body, feeling, mind, phenomena, and their extensions in certain Abhidharma enumerations; some traditions list a different set of six. The precise referent depends on which textual tradition this passage belongs to.

- The phrase rendered "accumulate causes and conditions in hope of a ripening result" translates a condensed injunction against stockpiling meritorious causes motivated by craving for their karmic fruit — a standard Mahāyāna caution against self-interested practice.

The simile of the two travelers is a parable explaining why the irreversible mind (the committed, persevering resolve of the bodhisattva) should not itself be equated with buddha-nature, while also affirming that all sentient beings possess buddha-nature. The logic is

subtle: one traveler's resolve does not negate the existence of the mountain for those who lack it.

- The term rendered "like a box with a flat lid" translates a phrase describing the sole of the foot as being evenly flat, resembling a flat-bottomed box. This is a standard description of the first of the thirty-two major marks of a great being; the phrasing in the Tibetan is idiomatic and the simile is preserved as given.

The name of the questioner, rendered here as "Siṃhaghoṣa" (Lion's Roar), follows the Tibetan ལོང་གེ་ལོ་ཤེ་ལོ་ཤེ་, which literally means "by the voice of a lion." This appears to be a character asking a question of the Blessed One within the sūtra context.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, and the translation follows suit accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "the mark of the seven fully rounded prominences" refers to the traditional list of seven bodily areas where flesh is full and rounded: the two hands, two feet, two shoulders, and the nape of the neck. This is a standard major mark of a great being.

The phrase "an upper body like that of a lion" and "lion-like cheeks" are standard epithets among the thirty-two marks; the lion is the classical Indian symbol of regal power and fearlessness.

The compound rendered "the mark of a crown-protrusion that is invisible when looked upon" refers to the uṣṇīṣa that cannot be seen from any angle, one of the more paradoxical major marks. No genuine textual uncertainty attaches to this reading.

- The section beginning "all sentient beings are permanent" involves a doctrinally unusual and challenging passage about permanence and impermanence applied to sentient beings and their afflictions. The text appears to argue that sentient beings are designated "permanent" insofar as they are continuously obscured by afflictions, and "impermanent" once those afflictions are severed. This is a tathāgatagarbha-inflected usage and is rendered faithfully according to the text's own logic rather than normalized.

The name Siṃhasvara, literally "Lion's Voice," is kept in Sanskrit transliteration as a proper name consistent with the preceding context implied by the Tibetan ལོང་གེ་ལོ་ཤེ་ལོ་ཤེ་.

- The passage presents a somewhat unusual tripartite typology of nourishment for the intermediate-state being: intention, contact, and consciousness. The canonical Pāli lists four kinds of nutriment; this threefold enumeration is a distinctive feature of the source text worth noting for the specialist.

The question posed by Siṃha — "without thorns, what is there to pick out of the sky?" — is a riddling verse whose idiomatic force is: the sky has nothing to be plucked from it, just as the aggregates in themselves have nothing to bind them. The translation renders the rhetorical logic rather than attempting to reproduce a poetic image that would be opaque in speech.

- The name "Siṃhasvara" renders the Tibetan ལོང་གེ་ལོ་ཤེ་ལོ་ཤེ་, literally "Lion-Voice," and is the interlocutor in this dialogue with the Blessed One. This appears to be a passage from a sūtra in the buddha-nature (tathāgatagarbha) literature, where the identity of sentient beings with their afflictions is a central doctrinal concern; the two-fold liberation distinguishing arhat attainment from buddhahood is a standard Mahāyāna doctrinal point.

The eight types of analogy listed here are a somewhat unusual enumeration; the Tibetan terms are rendered as faithfully as possible, though "inclined analogy" (མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་) and "inverted analogy" (མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་མཐོང་) are technical categories whose precise meaning is clarified in the subsequent exposition.

- The sequence "great spring fills the small pond" at the opening reverses the direction one might expect from the preceding passage but is faithful to the Tibetan, which here begins the

inclined analogy's continuation from where the sūtra quotation left off. The text moves from the largest body (great spring) downward to the ocean, matching the cascading structure of the analogy.

The passage about King Prasenajit is a well-known episode from the Mahāparinibbāna-related sūtra literature, here introducing the "not quite fitting" analogy. The Tibetan renders the king's name via the epithet "Sde-rab-tu-pham-byed," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of Prasenajit.

- The nyagrodha tree passage presents a deliberately paradoxical exchange: the Blessed One's point is that the analogy of the four mountains urging the king toward virtue does not apply to a tree, since a tree lacks moral agency. The king presses the point rhetorically, and the Buddha concedes the hypothetical while affirming that the fruit would be the same if the capacity existed. This is the "not quite fitting" analogy, highlighting the limits of the mountain simile.

The tree Pāricitra (Tibetan: ri tsi tra) is the Pārijāta or Pāricitra, the celebrated coral tree of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, a standard element of Buddhist cosmological description. The identification is secure.

The phrase rendered "fourfold act" refers to the formal legal act (Skt. karma) of the Saṅgha required for full ordination: the motion and three announcements.

- The four qualities of great nirvāṇa — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — are a hallmark of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's distinctive teaching, where "self" here refers not to the ordinary ātman but to the sovereign, immutable buddha-nature, contrasted with the conventional no-self teaching. This is doctrinally intentional and not a translation error.

The twenty-five existences is a standard Abhidharma enumeration of the realms of rebirth within the three realms of cyclic existence.

- The phrase rendered "wretched realm" translates a term that in context refers to a lower or unfortunate birth destiny. The stream-enterer's situation is being discussed: born in such a place yet still bound by the attainment and therefore unable to commit the grosser non-virtues. The simile of the lion's presence causing other animals to flee is a classical illustration of the residual power of a noble attainment even without active effort.

- The medicine name "Laṅkali" is a phonetic rendering of a Tibetan transliteration of what appears to be a Sanskrit plant name (possibly related to Laṅgālī, a well-known medicinal plant in Sanskrit medical literature). The identification is uncertain and the name is rendered here as it appears in the Tibetan.

The final paragraph breaks off mid-sentence in the source passage, and the translation reflects this open ending faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "heroic stride samādhi" translates a samādhi whose Tibetan name (dpa' bar 'gro ba'i ting nge 'dzin) corresponds to the Sanskrit śūraṃgamasamādhi, a well-known Mahāyāna samādhi. This identification is doctrinal rather than uncertain; it is given here for the reader's orientation.

The term rendered "surety" or "guarantor" (skyin pa, the one who takes on another's debt or burden) is a legal-economic metaphor for the bodhisattva's vow to bear others' suffering. The doctrinal image is clear and the rendering is secure.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, corresponding to the incomplete state of the source text provided. The final enumeration "permanence, bliss, self, and" anticipates the four qualities (nitya, sukha, ātman, and śuci — permanence, bliss, self, and purity) traditionally attributed to nirvāṇa in certain Mahāyāna texts, particularly those of the tathāgatagarbha tradition.

The sixteen "corrupt modes of conduct" include several items that require identification. The term rendered "poaching" (འཕྲོལ་སྒྲོལ་) refers to unlawful or predatory hunting or trapping. "Serving as a keeper of prison stocks" (འཇོག་ཁྱིམ་གྱི་འཇོག་པོ་) refers to one who guards instruments of punishment or torture, literally "one who guards the torture-frame." These are occupations involving harm to sentient beings.

The "bodiless meditative absorption" and the subsequent worldly absorptions listed are states associated with formless or quasi-formless attainments that, when misidentified as nirvāṇa, constitute a form of spiritual error from the Mahāyāna perspective. The text is critiquing non-Buddhist and lower-vehicle contemplative states that mistake conditional cessation for true liberation.

- The verse attributed to the Blessed One ("From a cause one is born as a god...") is cited by Śiṃhaghoṣa as a doctrinal challenge: nirvāṇa appears in that verse as something causally produced, which Śiṃhaghoṣa uses to press the tension with the Blessed One's claim that nirvāṇa is without cause and effect. The Blessed One's resolution — that the "cause" of nirvāṇa is the buddha-nature itself, which is not a generative cause in the ordinary sense — is a central doctrinal point of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition.

- The "patience grass" passage involves a simile drawn from an Indic zoological or medicinal tradition: a particular Himalayan herb that, when eaten by cows, causes their milk to yield especially rich butter or ghee. The term rendered "patience grass" is a translation of the Tibetan compound meaning literally "grass-that-is-endured" or "grass bearing patience," likely corresponding to a Sanskrit plant name now obscure; the doctrinal point is that a common basis yields a refined essence through a process, analogous to buddha-nature becoming manifest through path-cultivation. The simile of the lamp illuminating without creating objects is a classical Indian philosophical image; here it underscores that the path reveals buddha-nature already present, rather than producing it de novo.

- The "five stages of flavor" is a well-known Buddhist literary image, particularly prominent in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, referring to the five stages of dairy processing: milk, curds, fresh butter, clarified butter, and the essence of butter. The passage is drawing on imagery central to that sūtra.

The city name translated here as "Kuśinagara" renders the Tibetan "grong khyer rtsa mchog," which literally means "city of excellent grass" and is a Tibetan calque of Kuśinagara or Kuśināra, the city of kuśa-grass. It is rendered consistently as Kuśinagara throughout.

The list of six cities contains some names that are partially uncertain in their Sanskrit equivalents as transmitted in this Tibetan form: "pa tsi ta" and "tsam pa ka" correspond most plausibly to Pāṭaliputra and Campā respectively; "ser skya" is uncertain but may render Kapilavastu or another city. These are consequential textual uncertainties where the Tibetan phonetic rendering does not uniquely determine the Sanskrit original.

- The five river names — Jilanaśana, Ilapatī, Hilenaśana, Isomatī, Bāviśana — are phonetic transcriptions of Sanskrit names preserved only in Tibetan transliteration, and their exact Sanskrit originals are uncertain. The renderings given here follow the Tibetan syllables as closely as possible.

The phrase rendered "the city was situated on its outskirts, so close to the edge that one could leap from rooftop to rooftop" is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan and may describe either the small size of the city or its peripheral location within Jambudvīpa; both readings are consistent with the text.

The passage shifts abruptly from the story of Magnificent Radiance to a separate recollection about Kapilavastu, Pure Food, and Accomplished Goal — a narrative break that is present in the

Tibetan itself and almost certainly reflects the structure of the source sūtra (this passage derives from the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra).

- The river name rendered "Terrifying" translates the Tibetan རྒྱུ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་, a calque that likely corresponds to a Sanskrit riverine toponym now difficult to identify with certainty; it has been rendered by its literal sense rather than guessed at as a Sanskrit proper noun.

The two brothers of Kāśyapa are rendered "River Kāśyapa" and "Lake-Reed Kāśyapa" corresponding to the canonical Nadī-Kāśyapa and Gayā-Kāśyapa; the Tibetan རྒྱུ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་ here is somewhat unusual and may reflect a variant transmission, though the trio of Kāśyapa brothers is standard in the received accounts.

- The phrase rendered "the three foundations of mindfulness" translates a term that in many Sanskrit sources is listed as one of the eighteen unshared qualities of a buddha. The specific three referred to here concern the Buddha's equanimity toward disciples who are attentive, inattentive, or mixed — a technical doctrinal point preserved in the Abhidharma traditions.

The passage's description of the Buddha's qualities is a standard enumeration drawn from the tradition of the Buddha's unshared attributes, and "non-dual with respect to anointing and censure" renders a phrase indicating the Buddha's equanimity toward praise and blame.

- The deity who speaks is identified as the son of the brahmin Gyaltsen and as "the son of the guardian of the North, the Lord of Rest." The Tibetan reads "byang phyogs kyi mgon pa ngal bso bo'i bu" — the guardian of the North is Vaiśravaṇa (Kubera), and "ngal bso bo" likely renders a name or epithet in the Sanskrit source. The precise identification of this deity figure is uncertain and may depend on a Sanskrit or Chinese parallel text.

The Kalandakanivāpa grove is rendered from the Tibetan ka lan dka'i 'od ma'i tshal, a phonetic approximation of the Sanskrit; this is the Kalandakanivāpa, the Squirrel-Feeding Ground, a well-known park near Rājagṛha associated with the Buddha's residence there.

- The phrase rendered "five hundred paces" reflects a conventional unit of distance used in classical Buddhist narratives for the uncovered strip of ground; the Tibetan says literally "five hundred steps" and the point is that only this final stretch was left uncovered at day's end before Jeta intervened with his donation.

- The six teachers are the canonical six heterodox teachers who appear frequently in early Buddhist literature as antagonists of the Buddha. King Prasenajit is the ruler being addressed throughout this passage. The Tibetan phrase rendered "steal away the parents of others" is an accusation that Gautama induces people to abandon their families by going forth into homelessness, a standard polemical charge in this literary genre. The argument structure — that a man of royal birth who has renounced should still show respect to established elders — is a tīrthika rhetorical move attempting to undercut the Buddha's status on both social and religious grounds simultaneously.

- The city name "Cīta" (Tib. རྒྱུ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་) is uncertain; it may correspond to Ciñcā or another place name in the narrative tradition. It is rendered phonetically as given.

The tree name "Pāricitra" (Tib. རྒྱུ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་) corresponds to the Skt. Pārijāta or Pāricitra, the famous coral tree of the Trāyastriṃśa heaven; this rendering follows the standard identification.

- The name "Senavardhana" is a reconstruction of རྒྱུ་ཆེན་པོ་ལྷ་མོ་, a Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit name meaning approximately "he who thoroughly defeats armies." The previous passage rendered this as "King Śuddhodana," which does not match the Tibetan here; the Tibetan gives a different king's name, and this should be noted for editorial consistency.

The land or country called "Citā" renders 𐎠𐎼𐎠𐎹𐎠𐎡𐎹, a place-name whose identification is uncertain in context. It may represent a particular town or region associated with the six teachers episode.

"Śuddha's retinue" renders ལྷ་མཚན་ལྷ་མཚན་ལྷ་མཚན་, a phonetic Tibetan transcription whose Sanskrit original is not entirely clear; it may refer to the retinue of a particular deity whose name is transliterated here.

- The name Ajita, rendered here throughout as "Ajita," translates the Tibetan "mi pham pa" (the unvanquished or unconquered one). This is a well-known epithet that in many Buddhist contexts refers to Maitreya, but here it appears as a brahmin's son distinct from the bodhisattva Maitreya; the text's own gloss "utterly unconquered" plays on this name, and the rendering preserves that wordplay. The identity of the king "Rūpasāra" is somewhat uncertain; this is a transliteration of the Tibetan "rgyal po gzugs can snying po," which could refer to a regional ruler whose name means "essence of form" or "Rūpasāra." This detail may refer to a local king of Vaiśālī region and is not further clarified in the text.
- The "six teachers" throughout this passage are the six well-known non-Buddhist teachers (tīrthikas) of the Buddha's time — figures such as Pūraṇa Kāśyapa, Makkhali Gosāla, and others — rendered consistently with the preceding translation.

The name rendered "Kluṅpa" for the river is a transliteration of the Tibetan; no Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable from context.

"Aṅgulimāla" (Tibetan: Sōr mo rgyan, literally "Finger-Garland") is the notorious bandit whom the Buddha converted; the rendering follows the well-known Sanskrit name of this figure. The phrase translated as "restrained before he could kill" renders the Tibetan *gzas pa*, meaning "he was checked / stopped," describing how the Tathāgata tamed Aṅgulimāla before he completed his murderous course.

"Bimbisāra" is the standard identification of rgyal po gzugs can snying po, the king of Magadha.

- The name "Ratnpātala" (rendered as "Jewel Pātala") for the spirit-lord of hungry ghosts is a Tibetan phonetic rendering; the exact Sanskrit reconstruction is uncertain but "ratna" (jewel) plus "pātala" (netherworld or a proper name) is the most plausible reading.

The command addressed to Ānanda with the phrase "put on my robe" implies the Blessed One is sending Ānanda ahead as a representative; the text is slightly condensed here and the syntax shifts mid-passage, which is characteristic of the narrative style throughout.

- The name Śute rendered phonetically from Tibetan "ཤུཏེ" — the Sanskrit original is uncertain; it may reflect a name related to fire or birth, but the Tibetan simply gives the phonetic rendering without further gloss, and no standard Sanskrit attestation of this name in this narrative context is available to confirm the reconstruction.

The phrase "came — their heads bowed — from the six cities to Kuśinagara" follows the most natural reading of "ཁོ་དག་རྒྱ་བུ་སྐྱོན་པོ་མཉེན་ཆེན་གྲིང་གི་སྡེ་ལྷན་གྱི་སྤྱོད་ཀྱིས་"; the city name Kuśinagara is reconstructed from "འཇམ་དཔལ་གླིང་," which literally means "the city of supreme grass," a standard Tibetan rendering of Kuśinagara (Kuśa = auspicious grass).

- The term rendered "aperture" translates 孔 (kong), a small opening or hole through which one peers — the six teachers' analogy compares this to the sense-aperture through which a supposed self perceives. The Blessed One's rebuttal exploits the analogy's own logic: since looking through one aperture allows all six faculties to operate, the analogy actually undermines rather than supports the existence of a unitary perceiving self.

The name **मयादेवी** (Māyādevī, the goddess of beauty or the divine Māyā) refers to the Buddha's mother, Queen Māyā. The six teachers are using the term to mock: since the

Buddha's mother was named "Illusion" (Māyā), the Buddha himself must be illusory.

- The four social classes (brahmin, kṣatriya, vaiśya, śūdra) are invoked here as a standard Indian philosophical reductio: if the self were truly identical with the body (form), there would be no basis for the observable diversity of bodies across castes, species, and states of rebirth. The argument proceeds by listing socially recognized distinctions as evidence against identifying the self with form.

The expression rendered "utterly pure" translates the Tibetan term corresponding to the fourth of the traditional four inversions or distorted views concerning the aggregates (impermanence, suffering, no-self, and impurity), here applied in reverse to describe the attributes of the Tathāgata's dharmakāya, following the classical Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra formula of permanent, blissful, self, and pure.

- The passage presents the Tathāgata as bearing a fourfold transcendent nature — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — which is the classical tathāgatagarbha doctrine of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. These four qualities are being deliberately reclaimed from the tīrthika vocabulary as truly applicable only to the Tathāgata, not to the postulated metaphysical self of the non-Buddhists. The term rendered "ten defining characteristics" translates འཕགས་པ་བཅུ་ཡི་ཚིག་པ་ཆེན་པོ་, referring to the ten characteristics or marks that constitute conditioned existence; the specific list varies by commentary, and this may warrant further reference to the Tibetan and Sanskrit sources of this sūtra.

- The "four fruits" near the end refers to the four fruits of the śrāvaka path: stream-enterer, once-returner, non-returner, and arhat. This is the standard referent in this context.

The passage lists eleven benefits of the full moon, of which only five are given in the Tibetan here; the list continues in the text beyond what was submitted for translation.

The phrase rendered "the dharmakāya of the Tathāgata in its twofold aspect" is slightly condensed in the source; the two aspects alluded to are likely the dharmakāya as it appears in saṃsāra and as it rests in nirvāṇa, or alternatively permanence and purity, consistent with the surrounding context.

- The text ends mid-sentence at "འདི་ལྟར་མཐོང་བ་ལྟར་" ("with respect to gain and..."), so the translation breaks off accordingly.

The phrase "འདི་ལྟར་ འཕགས་པ་བཅུ་ཡི་ཚིག་པ་ཆེན་པོ་" is syntactically compressed; "འཕགས་པ་བཅུ་ཡི་ཚིག་པ་ཆེན་པོ་" may carry the sense of "all containers" or "all that is contained," referring to the fullness of the full-moon night's effect on creatures and things. The rendering "all things that are containers" captures this but the exact import is somewhat uncertain.

The monk names are rendered with their Sanskrit equivalents: Ānanda for འཕྲུལ་པ་, Anuruddha for འཕྲུལ་པ་, and Kāśyapa for ཀཧཱུཔ་.

- The "eight masteries" refers to the eight lordships or sovereignties of a tathāgata, a standard doctrinal list in Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra contexts, including qualities such as eternal duration, self, purity, bliss, and unobstructed presence. The passage draws on the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's characteristic teaching that the tathāgata's final body is paradoxically characterized by permanence, bliss, self, and purity, in contrast to the impermanence of the conditioned aggregates.

The closing philosophical exchange on "abiding" plays on the double sense of the Tibetan term: literal physical abiding and the soteriological "abiding" that pride produces in saṃsāra — a deliberate doctrinal irony.

- The passage enumerates the "four qualities of nirvāṇa" — permanence, bliss, self, and purity — which is characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's distinctive doctrinal position, here cited as what the Tathāgata attains precisely by severing the "phenomena of emptiness." This

is a deliberate and doctrinally significant formulation in the Nirvāṇa Sūtra tradition and should not be smoothed over.

The "twenty-five existences" refers to the twenty-five modes of conditioned existence enumerated in Abhidharma and Mahāyāna literature, encompassing the various realms and states of rebirth across the three realms.

The "meditative absorption of the Courageous March" renders the Tibetan term for the śūramgama-samādhi; the name is preserved here in descriptive translation as the underlying Sanskrit proper name does not appear in the Tibetan.

- The four qualities of permanence, bliss, self, and purity attributed here to the Tathāgata are the classical four attributes of the dharmakāya as taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition, standing in deliberate contrast to the four marks of conditioned existence. The "self" here is not the ordinary ātman rejected by Buddhist analysis but the transcendent buddha-nature quality glossed by the tradition as sovereign, unimpeded selfhood of the Tathāgata.

The phrase rendered "those who hold wrong craving" translates a term indicating individuals with a specific form of wrong view entangled with craving, used several times in the passage as a stock category of spiritually disqualified persons.

"Those who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution" refers to the five ānantarya-karmas: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, drawing blood from a Tathāgata with malicious intent, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha.

The simile of "great elephants scented with perfume" for Dharma-preaching bodhisattvas is a stock image in this sūtra indicating majestic, dignified, and powerfully fragrant presence.

The city name rendered "Kuśinagara" renders Tibetan "grong khyer rtswa mchog," literally "the city of excellent grass," which is the standard Tibetan translation of the Sanskrit Kuśinagara (Kuśa being the name of an auspicious grass). The passage is set at the site of the Buddha's parinirvāṇa.

- The passage contains a sustained dialectical exchange on the definition of meditative absorption (samādhi) that turns on the question of whether samādhi is defined by its object (a single versus multiple objects) or by its moral quality (virtuous versus neutral). The Blessed One's resolution — that samādhi is specifically virtuous absorption, not simply any one-pointed concentration — is a notable doctrinal point, aligning the text with Mahāyāna śāstra discussions of samādhi as an ethically positive factor rather than a merely technical mental state.

- The phrase rendered "the meditative absorption without food" translates a term that likely refers to absorption in which there is no dependence on physical sustenance, possibly corresponding to a known samādhi type; this equivalence is inferential from context. The "meditative absorption of subsequent recollection of what the mind has contemplated" is a close rendering of a compound that may alternatively be read as "mindful recollection following upon mental investigation." The text ends mid-sentence in the source, and the translation faithfully reflects that abrupt stop.

- The ten totality absorptions listed here technically number eleven items in the Tibetan text as rendered, which is a known textual feature of some versions of this list where the formless absorptions are appended; this appears to be an enumeration anomaly in the source text rather than a translation error.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source Tibetan itself breaks off at that point.

The exchange between Simhaghoṣa and the Blessed One develops a Madhyamaka-style argument that neither wisdom nor affliction has inherent existence, and therefore the notion of

one "overcoming" the other through a reified causal relationship is ultimately untenable; this is the doctrinal point the passage is building toward.

- The passage "afflictions of the four great elements" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan. The text appears to argue by analogy: just as the properties of earth, water, fire, and wind belong to those elements by nature and not by causes and conditions, so too the afflictions associated with the four great elements are "cut off" or "severed" by nature — meaning their cessation is intrinsic to them, not achieved by wisdom acting upon them from outside. This is a deliberately paradoxical and anti-essentialist rhetorical move consistent with the broader argument of the passage.

The reference to "the village of Kuśāgra" renders the Tibetan term for a place proverbially associated with non-Buddhists in classical Indian Buddhist literature; the simile means that just as *tīrthikas*, absent from major cities, are said to appear in that obscure village, so if wisdom expelled afflictions they would have to reappear somewhere — which they do not.

- The penultimate paragraph lists an extended set of virtuous qualities that result from cultivating meditative absorption and wisdom together. The transition from the analogies into this list is somewhat abrupt in the Tibetan, but the sense is clear: these qualities all flow from the paired cultivation of meditative absorption and wisdom.

The phrase rendered "being bitten by insects and stinging creatures" covers a range of small biting and piercing creatures; the Tibetan is general and the rendering reflects that.

- The passage speaks of "permanence, happiness, self, and pure phenomena" within the body — this refers to the four qualities (permanence, bliss, self, and purity) attributed to *nirvāṇa* in the *tathāgata*garbha and *Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra* doctrinal context, and should not be read as endorsing the ordinary clinging to a permanent self. The text here is almost certainly from the *Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra* cycle.

The phrase rendered "not the time to cultivate equanimity, but to read and recite the twelve branches" reflects the *sūtra*'s teaching that when afflictions arise, active engagement with scripture and the six recollections is the antidote, rather than the neutral equipoise of equanimity, which could allow afflictions to remain undisturbed.

- The name "Lion's Roar" renders *Siṃhanāda*, an interlocutor in this *sūtra*. The passage lists synonyms for *nirvāṇa*; "Devadatta" is the referent of the Tibetan *lha sbyin*, the standard Tibetan rendering of that name. The ten synonyms as listed by Lion's Roar number thirteen items in the Tibetan as given, while the Blessed One's explanatory responses address twelve; this numerical discrepancy appears in the source text itself and is not an error in translation.

- The phrase "the five objects of desire of the gods of the higher realms" refers to the five sensory pleasures as enjoyed in the heavenly realms — visible forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tactile objects of divine quality — a standard doctrinal category contrasted with coarser human sense pleasures.

The final sentence of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the source, breaking off mid-clause after introducing the list of requisites. This is a genuine textual suspension; the passage continues beyond what is given here.

- The passage contains a notable doctrinal tension: it attributes to the *Tathāgata* the four qualities of permanence, bliss, self, and purity — the four "transcendent attributes" (*Skt. pāramārthaguṇa* or the four contrary *pāramitās*) associated with the *Tathāgata*garbha doctrine of the *Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra* from which this passage is drawn. These are not the mundane attributes rejected by Buddhism but their transcendent counterparts; a general listener should understand them as supramundane qualities of the buddha-nature, not a simple affirmation of a permanent self.

The repeated phrase rendered "distinct phenomena that..." translates a series of dharma-pairs (ཐོས་གྲུབ་རྒྱལ་མཁན་) whose precise grammar is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan; the rendering follows the most natural and contextually consistent reading. The distinction between phenomena "perceived as arising from conditions" (འདྲིམ་པོ་ལས་ཀློང་བྱུང་བཤེས་པའི་ཚུལ་གྱི་སྐབས་ཀྱི་ཆོས་ཉིད་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རྒྱལ་མཁན་) and phenomena that "arise from conditions" (འདྲིམ་པོ་ལས་ཀློང་བྱུང་བཤེས་པའི་ཚུལ་གྱི་སྐབས་ཀྱི་ཆོས་ཉིད་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རྒྱལ་མཁན་) appears to be intentional and is preserved in the translation.

- The figure called "the Breath-stealer of Evil Lineage" (Tibetan: rigs ngan dbugs 'phrog) is a character from Indian Buddhist narrative literature, likely identifiable with a figure in the Pāli or Sanskrit story traditions who had committed serious sins yet was reborn in the heavens due to a specific meritorious act involving a finger-ornament. The precise canonical source is not identified in the passage itself, and the exact story may require further research to pin down definitively.

The interlocutor "Ma-'aggapa" in the preceding passage corresponds to the Pāli name Meghiya or a similar figure; the Tibetan rendering here is consistent with the prior passage's usage and is retained for continuity.

- The passage's argument about determinate and indeterminate karma is a developed scholastic position. The two subdivisions of determinate karma — certain as to ripening versus certain as to time — reflect a standard Abhidharma-inflected analysis found in Mahāyāna sūtra literature.

The autobiographical passage near the end, in which the Buddha speaks in the first person about having voluntarily taken birth in hell as a bodhisattva, is a notable doctrinal claim: the bodhisattva's voluntary assumption of hell-rebirth through aspirational prayer rather than karma proper illustrates the distinction between karma-driven rebirth and compassion-motivated volitional rebirth.

- The term अपरोक्षप्रसङ्ग ("those possessed of inverted craving") refers to beings with a form of deeply perverted or misdirected craving, sometimes understood in the commentarial tradition as those whose clinging is so inverted that even the bodhisattva's presence cannot uproot it at that time. The phrase is rendered descriptively rather than with a technical Sanskrit equivalent since the precise Indic correlate is not certain here.

The list of animal bodies rendered follows the Tibetan enumeration; ཁྱེད་ (deer), འགྲོ་ (stag), and ཁྱེད་ཁྱེད་ (bear) are sequential in the source.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, indicating the text continues beyond what was provided.

- The terms rendered as "a body that was loose and dissolute" and "a body that was bound and constrained" translate 𐤁𐤏𐤏𐤏𐤏 and 𐤁𐤏𐤏𐤏𐤏 respectively. 𐤁𐤏𐤏𐤏𐤏 can mean "slack," "lax," or "loose," while 𐤁𐤏𐤏𐤏𐤏 means "bound" or "imprisoned." The precise doctrinal referent of this pair in context is uncertain; these bodies may refer to moral or social conditions rather than purely physical states.

The four terms for ambiguous or indeterminate sex — 𑖀𑖄𑖔𑖒𑖘𑖚𑖛, 𑖀𑖄𑖔𑖒𑖘𑖚𑖛𑖪𑖤𑖥𑖡𑖢𑖦𑖣𑖩𑖮𑖬𑖱𑖲𑖳𑖴𑖵𑖶𑖷𑖸𑖹𑖺𑖻𑖼𑖽𑖾𑗀𑖿𑗁𑗂𑗃𑗄𑗅𑗆𑗇𑗈𑗉𑗊𑗋𑗌𑗍𑗎𑗏𑗐𑗑𑗒𑗓𑗔𑗕𑗖𑗗𑗘𑗙𑗚𑗛𑗜𑗝𑗞𑗟𑗠𑗡𑗢𑗣𑗤𑗥𑗦𑗧𑗨𑗩𑗪𑗫𑗬𑗭𑗮𑗯𑗰𑗱𑗲𑗳𑗴𑗵𑗶𑗷𑗸𑗹𑗺𑗻𑗼𑗽𑗾𑗿𑘀𑘁𑘂𑘃𑘄𑘅𑘆𑘇𑘈𑘉𑘊𑘋𑘌𑘍𑘎𑘏𑘐𑘑𑘒𑘓𑘔𑘕𑘖𑘗𑘘𑘙𑘚𑘛𑘜𑘝𑘞𑘟𑘠𑘡𑘢𑘣𑘤𑘥𑘦𑘧𑘨𑘩𑘪𑘫𑘬𑘭𑘮𑘯𑘰𑘱𑘲𑘳𑘴𑘵𑘶𑘷𑘸𑘹𑘺𑘻𑘼𑘽𑘾𑘿𑙀𑙁𑙂𑙃𑙄𑙅𑙆𑙇𑙈𑙉𑙊𑙋𑙌𑙍𑙎𑙏𑙐𑙑𑙒𑙓𑙔𑙕𑙖𑙗𑙘𑙙𑙚𑙛𑙜𑙝𑙞𑙟𑙠𑙡𑙢𑙣𑙤𑙥𑙦𑙧𑙨𑙩𑙪𑙫𑙬𑙭𑙮𑙯𑙰𑙱𑙲𑙳𑙴𑙵𑙶𑙷𑙸𑙹𑙺𑙻𑙼𑙽𑙾𑙿𑚀𑚁𑚂𑚃𑚄𑚅𑚆𑚇𑚈𑚉𑚊𑚋𑚌𑚍𑚎𑚏𑚐𑚑𑚒𑚓𑚔𑚕𑚖𑚗𑚘𑚙𑚚𑚛𑚜𑚝𑚞𑚟𑚠𑚡𑚢𑚣𑚤𑚥𑚦𑚧𑚨𑚩𑚪𑚫𑚬𑚭𑚮𑚯𑚰𑚱𑚲𑚳𑚴𑚵𑚷𑚶𑚸𑚹𑚺𑚻𑚼𑚽𑚾𑚿𑛀𑛁𑛂𑛃𑛄𑛅𑛆𑛇𑛈𑛉𑛊𑛋𑛌𑛍𑛎𑛏𑛐𑛑𑛒𑛓𑛔𑛕𑛖𑛗𑛘𑛙𑛚𑛛𑛜𑛝𑛞𑛟𑛠𑛡𑛢𑛣𑛤𑛥𑛦𑛧𑛨𑛩𑛪𑛫𑛬𑛭𑛮𑛯𑛰𑛱𑛲𑛳𑛴𑛵𑛶𑛷𑛸𑛹𑛺𑛻𑛼𑛽𑛾𑛿𑜀𑜁𑜂𑜃𑜄𑜅𑜆𑜇𑜈𑜉𑜊𑜋𑜌𑜍𑜎𑜏𑜐𑜑𑜒𑜓𑜔𑜕𑜖𑜗𑜘𑜙𑜚𑜛𑜜𑜝𑜞𑜟𑜠𑜡𑜢𑜣𑜤𑜥𑜦𑜧𑜨𑜩𑜪𑜫𑜬𑜭𑜮𑜯𑜰𑜱𑜲𑜳𑜴𑜵𑜶𑜷𑜸𑜹𑜺𑜻𑜼𑜽𑜾𑜿𑝀𑝁𑝂𑝃𑝄𑝅𑝆𑝇𑝈𑝉𑝊𑝋𑝌𑝍𑝎𑝏𑝐𑝑𑝒𑝓𑝔𑝕𑝖𑝗𑝘𑝙𑝚𑝛𑝜𑝝𑝞𑝟𑝠𑝡𑝢𑝣𑝤𑝥𑝦𑝧𑝨𑝩𑝪𑝫𑝬𑝭𑝮𑝯𑝰𑝱𑝲𑝳𑝴𑝵𑝶𑝷𑝸𑝹𑝺𑝻𑝼𑝽𑝾𑝿𑞀𑞁𑞂𑞃𑞄𑞅𑞆𑞇𑞈𑞉𑞊𑞋𑞌𑞍𑞎𑞏𑞐𑞑𑞒𑞓𑞔𑞕𑞖𑞗𑞘𑞙𑞚𑞛𑞜𑞝𑞞𑞟𑞠𑞡𑞢𑞣𑞤𑞥𑞦𑞧𑞨𑞩𑞪𑞫𑞬𑞭𑞮𑞯𑞰𑞱𑞲𑞳𑞴𑞵𑞶𑞷𑞸𑞹𑞺𑞻𑞼𑞽𑞾𑞿𑟀𑟁𑟂𑟃𑟄𑟅𑟆𑟇𑟈𑟉𑟊𑟋𑟌𑟍𑟎𑟏𑟐𑟑𑟒𑟓𑟔𑟕𑟖𑟗𑟘𑟙𑟚𑟛𑟜𑟝𑟞𑟟𑟠𑟡𑟢𑟣𑟤𑟥𑟦𑟧𑟨𑟩𑟪𑟫𑟬𑟭𑟮𑟯𑟰𑟱𑟲𑟳𑟴𑟵𑟶𑟷𑟸𑟹𑟺𑟻𑟼𑟽𑟾𑟿𑠀𑠁𑠂𑠃𑠄𑠅𑠆𑠇𑠈𑠉𑠊𑠋𑠌𑠍𑠎𑠏𑠐𑠑𑠒𑠓𑠔𑠕𑠖𑠗𑠘𑠙𑠚𑠛𑠜𑠝𑠞𑠟𑠠𑠡𑠢𑠣𑠤𑠥𑠦𑠧𑠨𑠩𑠪𑠫𑠬𑠭𑠮𑠯𑠰𑠱𑠲𑠳𑠴𑠵𑠶𑠷𑠸𑠺𑠹𑠻𑠼𑠽𑠾𑠿𑡀𑡁𑡂𑡃𑡄𑡅𑡆𑡇𑡈𑡉𑡊𑡋𑡌𑡍𑡎𑡏𑡐𑡑𑡒𑡓𑡔𑡕𑡖𑡗𑡘𑡙𑡚𑡛𑡜𑡝𑡞𑡟𑡠𑡡𑡢𑡣𑡤𑡥𑡦𑡧𑡨𑡩𑡪𑡫𑡬𑡭𑡮𑡯𑡰𑡱𑡲𑡳𑡴𑡵𑡶𑡷𑡸𑡹𑡺𑡻𑡼𑡽𑡾𑡿𑢀𑢁𑢂𑢃𑢄𑢅𑢆𑢇𑢈𑢉𑢊𑢋𑢌𑢍𑢎𑢏𑢐𑢑𑢒𑢓𑢔𑢕𑢖𑢗𑢘𑢙𑢚𑢛𑢜𑢝𑢞𑢟𑢠𑢡𑢢𑢣𑢤𑢥𑢦𑢧𑢨𑢩𑢪𑢫𑢬𑢭𑢮𑢯𑢰𑢱𑢲𑢳𑢴𑢵𑢶𑢷𑢸𑢹𑢺𑢻𑢼𑢽𑢾𑢿𑣀𑣁𑣂𑣃𑣄𑣅𑣆𑣇𑣈𑣉𑣊𑣋𑣌𑣍𑣎𑣏𑣐𑣑𑣒𑣓𑣔𑣕𑣖𑣗𑣘𑣙𑣚𑣛𑣜𑣝𑣞𑣟𑣠𑣡𑣢𑣣𑣤𑣥𑣦𑣧𑣨𑣩𑣪𑣫𑣬𑣭𑣮𑣯𑣰𑣱𑣲𑣳𑣴𑣵𑣶𑣷𑣸𑣹𑣺𑣻𑣼𑣽𑣾𑣿𑤀𑤁𑤂𑤃𑤄𑤅𑤆𑤇𑤈𑤉𑤊𑤋𑤌𑤍𑤎𑤏𑤐𑤑𑤒𑤓𑤔𑤕𑤖𑤗𑤘𑤙𑤚𑤛𑤜𑤝𑤞𑤟𑤠𑤡𑤢𑤣𑤤𑤥𑤦𑤧𑤨𑤩𑤪𑤫𑤬𑤭𑤮𑤯𑤰𑤱𑤲𑤳𑤴𑤵𑤶𑤷𑤸𑤹𑤺𑤻𑤼𑤽𑤾𑤿𑥀𑥁𑥂𑥃𑥄𑥅𑥆𑥇𑥈𑥉𑥊𑥋𑥌𑥍𑥎𑥏𑥐𑥑𑥒𑥓𑥔𑥕𑥖𑥗𑥘𑥙𑥚𑥛𑥜𑥝𑥞𑥟𑥠𑥡𑥢𑥣𑥤𑥥𑥦𑥧𑥨𑥩𑥪𑥫𑥬𑥭𑥮𑥯𑥰𑥱𑥲𑥳𑥴𑥵𑥶𑥷𑥸𑥹𑥺𑥻𑥼𑥽𑥾𑥿𑦀𑦁𑦂𑦃𑦄𑦅𑦆𑦇𑦈𑦉𑦊𑦋𑦌𑦍𑦎𑦏𑦐𑦑𑦒𑦓𑦔

- The name "Truthspeaker" renders the Tibetan personal name Bden par smra ba, a calque of the Sanskrit Satyavādin; the narrative context makes clear this is the bodhisattva's name in that past life. The city name Putana and the land name Vetāla are transliterations of the Tibetan phonetic spellings; the Sanskrit originals may have been Pūtana and Vetāla, though the latter more commonly refers to a class of spirits. The king's name Kalāpu is similarly a transliteration. The identification of Devadatta here with the historical Devadatta is left implicit

by the text; it may be a different individual sharing the name. The phrase rendered "practicing yoga" translates rnal 'byor spyod cing 'dug pa, which in context refers to the practice of an ascetic yogi rather than to Yogācāra doctrine.

- The phrase rendered "the four guardian kings" refers to the four mahārāja deities who guard the cardinal directions, standard figures in Buddhist cosmology. The passage on the king's aspiration prayer presents a slight structural ambiguity as to who is speaking, but the doctrinal context makes clear it is the bodhisattva narrator speaking after the king's prostration, not the king himself formulating the aspiration.

- The term srogśing literally means "life-wood" or "axle-pin" — the linchpin or kingpin of a carriage wheel, the removal of which renders the wheel immovable. This is a well-known Dharma simile echoing a verse in the Dhammapada. I have transliterated it on first use because a single-word English rendering would require a gloss just as long, and the meaning is immediately clarified in context. A translator preparing a reading script may wish to replace it with "axle-pin" or "kingpin" throughout.

The phrase rendered "the kind who causes what is indeterminate to ripen as determinate" and its converse describes a classical Abhidharmic distinction between fixed and unfixed karma and the way that practice, especially cultivation of wisdom and wholesome action, can alter the weight and timing of karmic maturation. This doctrinal point is the primary subject of the passage.

- The term "srogśing" in the preceding passage has been left as rendered; it appears to refer to some kind of control mechanism for a carriage, possibly a rein or brake, and its exact nature is uncertain but not consequential to this passage.

The passage enumerating what "not cultivating the body" means contains a dense series of negatives that shade into paradox: the text seems to say that one who fails to reflect on the body, its marks, and its transience, yet mistakenly grasps non-body as body, is the one who does not truly cultivate the body. This is consistent with the Mahāyāna contemplative tradition's understanding that proper cultivation of the body involves seeing through its conventional marks, not mere physical discipline.

The "eight kinds of substance that have not been examined" in the section on not cultivating moral discipline is a technical Vinaya reference whose exact list is not specified in this passage; it likely refers to the eight categories of possessions requiring inspection before use.

- The phrase rendered "water-tree" translates a Tibetan term that likely refers to a particular tree known for bearing fruit that desiccates rapidly once formed; the exact botanical identification is uncertain, but the simile's point — that the body begins to decay from the very moment of its arising — is clear and standard in this genre of contemplative literature.

The simile of the pregnant she-monkey is briefly stated in the Tibetan without full elaboration of the application; the translation follows the text closely. The doctrinal point appears to be that just as a pregnant monkey is consumed by concern for her body, sentient beings are similarly preoccupied with bodily welfare, yet internal imbalances of the elements bring unavoidable suffering.

- The passage lists several flowers by name: utpala (blue lotus), pundarīka (white lotus), campaka, mālikā (jasmine), and pāriśāka — these are kept in Sanskrit as they are proper names of specific flowers used in standard Buddhist literary imagery. Mount Mālaya (ri ma la ya / ri ma da) is a Himalayan or Malaya mountain range famed for its sandalwood forests; the passage uses it in two separate analogies, and consistency is maintained throughout.

The term translated as "dzo-bull" renders the Tibetan "bal glang," literally a woolly or yak-type bull; it refers to a notoriously difficult-to-tame bovine, here used as a simile for the unruly

wandering mind.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source text provided breaks off there.

- The twenty-five modes of existence is a recognized Abhidharma enumeration of the possible states of conditioned rebirth across the three realms. The text preserves this number precisely and it should not be altered.

The passage enumerating body, moral discipline, mind, and wisdom together with their characteristics, causes, results, and so forth follows a distinctive rhetorical pattern common in Mahāyāna sūtra literature: the point is that any conceptual grasping at these categories — even under the guise of meditation — does not constitute genuine cultivation. The term "the other shore" in each list renders the Tibetan *pha rol*, pointing to the transcendent or perfected dimension of each quality.

- The phrase rendered as "holds the twelve branches of the sūtras by heart" reflects the standard twelve-fold classification of the Buddhist canon (the *dvādaśāṅga*). The verb "gzungs su 'dzin" can mean either "memorizes" or "bears as a *dhāraṇī*" — the most natural doctrinal sense here is sustained scriptural learning and retention.

The epithet *Siṃhanāda* (Lion's Roar) for the bodhisattva interlocutor is rendered in translation with the Sanskrit given once for clarity; Tibetan has "Seng ge sgras" throughout.

The measure "srang gcig" is a traditional Tibetan unit of weight; "tola" is used as an approximate equivalent familiar in classical South and Central Asian contexts. The sense — a single unit of gold outweighing a hundred packs of wool — is clear.

- The name སྐྱུ་མཁན་པོ་ is rendered "*Siṃhanāda*" (Lion's Roar), a bodhisattva interlocutor in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition. The passage as a whole comes from that sūtra context, consistent with the preceding material.

The argument attributed to *Siṃhanāda* is a *reductio*: he is pressing the Blessed One on the apparent tension between the universality of buddha-nature and the necessity of the path, not endorsing the view that no path is needed. The Blessed One's reply beginning with the Ganges simile is his response to this challenge.

- The phrase rendered as "one of perverted craving" translates the Tibetan term for a person who holds a distorted or inverted craving, specifically the wrong view that denies karmic causality by equating the self entirely with the five great elements and affirming their annihilation at death. This is a classical formulation of the annihilationist view attributed to certain non-Buddhist materialists, here ascribed to monks gone astray under bad influence.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source material, as it continues into the next section listing the three actions.

- The passage employs an extended simile of four persons in the river Gaṅgā, each representing a progressive stage of spiritual capacity. The "four fruits of the ascetic life" refers to the four fruits of the śramaṇa: stream-enterer, once-returner, non-returner, and arhat. The phrase "looking toward the four directions" is an idiomatic expression signifying the attainment of or orientation toward these four fruits; this is the natural reading in context given the explicit equation that follows. The term rendered "wrong cravings" translates a compound implying perverse or mistaken craving, here specifically the craving to retain views already identified as wrong. The "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the twelve-fold classification of canonical literature by literary and doctrinal form.

- The phrase rendered as "advancing until one reaches the very bottom" translates a passage that is deliberately paradoxical: the text uses "leaping ever higher" and then says one arrives at "the bottom" or "depth" of the water, which in context describes the bodhisattva who plunges into the depths of saṃsāra out of compassion rather than crossing to the other shore.

This deliberate irony is part of the river simile's structural logic. The sixth person does not cross but remains immersed, symbolizing the bodhisattva's voluntary engagement with saṃsāra for the sake of beings.

- The passage contains a significant doctrinal pivot: the text carefully distinguishes between the possession of buddha-nature as a sufficient cause for awakening (which it affirms) and the claim that cultivation of the noble path is therefore unnecessary (which it firmly rejects). The iron-and-magnet simile is attributed to the interlocutor's position, which is then partially endorsed and partially corrected.

The phrase rendered "the twelve branches of scripture" refers to the traditional twelve-fold classification of the Buddhist canon (dvādaśāṅgapravacana), sometimes called the twelve divisions of the Dharma.

The final sentence breaks off mid-construction in the source text; the translation preserves this open ending with a dash, as the passage continues beyond the given excerpt.

The reference to "bodhisattvas on the sixth ground" is a specific doctrinal marker: the sixth bodhisattva ground (ṣaṣṭhī bhūmi) is associated with the perfection of wisdom and the deep realization of dependent origination, which contextualizes the teaching that follows about karma.

- The term rendered throughout as "distinct phenomena" translates the Tibetan phrase for phenomena that are differentiated or conditioned — meaning phenomena that are individually characterized and conditionally interrelated, as opposed to an undifferentiated ground. The repeated formula "because distinct phenomena exist, distinct phenomena arise; because distinct phenomena are absent, distinct phenomena cease" is a deliberately structured doctrinal refrain playing on dependent origination without invoking mental agency, showing that causal efficacy does not require a conscious subject.

The "trumpet tree" is a tree whose trunk is said in Indian literature to respond to the sound of thunder by sprouting; the identification is traditional, and the exact botanical species is uncertain but the image is a classical Indian example.

The passage closes mid-sentence in the source, and the translation reflects that open ending accordingly.

- The term rendered "woolen ox" translates bal glang, literally an ox or bovine made of wool — likely a stuffed or felted figure used as a teaching prop in this parable. The analogy is a well-known one in Indian Buddhist literature, parallel to the blind men and the elephant found in Pali sources, but here the animal is a wool figure rather than a live elephant.

The phrase "one thing succeeding another without interruption" renders gcig gis gcig bsabs shing rgyun mi 'chad pa, a description of causal continuity in the form aggregate as the ground for claiming permanence of the Tathāgata's form body — a view the text will go on to address critically.

- The term "kauśika" applied to a human bone is obscure and may be a technical anatomical or cosmological term from a non-Buddhist tradition embedded in the source, or it may be a proper name. The meaning in context is simply that certain bones persist far longer than the person who possessed them, serving as an analogy for a permanent substrate within an impermanent continuum. The precise referent of "kauśika" here cannot be determined from the text alone.

The passage presents a series of heterodox views — attributing buddha-nature to each of the five aggregates in turn, and finally to a self apart from the aggregates — which the larger work will presumably refute. These are not the author's own positions.

- The "six phenomena" referred to in the blind-men-and-elephant passage are not specified in

this excerpt alone; they belong to a list established earlier in the text (likely the six such as form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness, and the self as discussed in context). This is not an error in translation but a structural reference to prior context.

The "twenty-five modes of existence" is a standard Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra enumeration of the states of conditioned existence within the three realms, sometimes counted differently across recensions. No emendation is needed here.

- The "ground of the only child" is a rendering of སྐྱུ་མཉམ་གཟིགས་ཀྱི་སྒོ་, a stage in this text's distinctive bodhisattva-ground schema in which the bodhisattva regards all beings as an only child; the exact enumerative position of this ground within the text's overall system is not established from this passage alone.

The "four kinds of individual perfect knowledge" renders སྤྲུལ་མཁས་ཀྱི་ཡེ་ཤེས་ཀྱི་ལྔ་པ་, the standard four pratisaṃvids: perfect knowledge of phenomena, meaning, etymology, and eloquence.

The "crown-of-the-head meditative absorption" renders སྐྱུ་མཉམ་གཟིགས་ཀྱི་སྒོ་, which in some Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra contexts refers to the uṣṇīṣa samādhi, an absorption associated with the cranial protuberance, one of the marks of a buddha; the identification with a specific Sanskrit term is contextually inferred.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source; no closing clause is supplied.

- The passage opens mid-sentence because it continues the conditional clause from the preceding passage about why the Tathāgata does not teach that form is the intrinsic nature of a buddha; the translation begins accordingly.

The list of foods in the austerity sequence — til seeds (sesame), 'bras (rice? or another grain), sran ma (lentils/beans), gso ma (possibly a specific legume or healing grain), khre (hemp or a measure-grain), sran ma dkar po (white mustard) — presents some philological difficulty. The sequence appears to follow a known Indian ascetic regimen of progressive reduction. "gso ma" is uncertain; it may refer to a medicinal grain or a specific legume. This is noted here as it affects precision but not the overall doctrinal sense.

- The phrase rendered "lights a human lamp from his own body" describes the practice of offering one's body as a living torch, a form of extreme self-sacrifice attested in Mahāyāna literature. The Tibetan is straightforward, but the practice is doctrinally significant as an instance of the perfection of giving carried to its ultimate limit.
- The simile of eating a child's flesh is a classical Buddhist expression for consuming food without attachment or desire, drawn from the Pāli and Sanskrit canonical literature. It does not imply actual cannibalism but rather a state of complete detachment from the act of eating. The phrase here carries that standard doctrinal resonance.

The list of animals in the middle section presents some ambiguity: the term rendered "cat" for ku-ta-la is uncertain; it may refer to a civet-cat or a mongoose. The term rendered "white dove" for phug ron dkar po could also be a white pigeon. These are minor and do not affect the doctrinal sense.

- The phrase rendered "body of hungry ghosts" in the aspiration reflects the Tibetan literally: the bodhisattva aspires to be reborn as a hungry ghost himself but with a vast, radiant, and retinue-surrounded body, so that beings in that realm who merely hear him are healed. This is an unusual and striking vow; the text is clear and no emendation is needed, but listeners may find it unexpected.

The verb rendered "mock" for བྱོལ་ཆོག་ could also mean "to rebuke" or "to reproach" sharply; the exact nuance is contextually ambiguous. The general sense — that the bodhisattva adapts his

outward manner to the disposition of the being he is guiding — is doctrinally clear.

- The phrase rendered "inner and final rebirth of his body" translates a compressed Tibetan expression indicating the bodhisattva's penultimate birth before buddhahood — the standard doctrinal notion that the future buddha's last birth before descending to Jambudvīpa is spent in Tuṣita. The Tibetan literally reads "the last birth of the inner body," which is a conventional formula for this concept.
- The phrase rendered "king of the finest herd among humans" translates *khyu mchog gi rgyal po*, literally "king of the supreme bull of the herd." In Indo-Tibetan usage this is an epithet comparing the bodhisattva to a great bull-leader; the *nāga* king parallel then follows as a further analogy. The rendering preserves the literal sense without forcing it into a single English idiom.

The passage on the Buddha being "unborn and unceasing" with "no attaining of awakening, no turning of the wheel," and so on, is the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's teaching on the dharmakāya aspect of the Buddha as transcending all conventional biographical events — expressing the ultimate truth that the Buddha's essential nature was never bound by the arising and ceasing of conditioned events, even those of his own enlightenment career. This is a standard tathāgatagarbha doctrinal point and not a textual problem.

The final sentence is syntactically compressed in the Tibetan. The rendering "there is no affliction and there is no abiding" reflects the text's assertion that buddha-nature, from the lowest stage of stream-entry through full buddhahood, is inherently free of both affliction and any fixed locus of dwelling.

- The phrase rendered "the gnosis that crowns all sentient beings" translates རྒྱལ་བོ་སྤྲུང་གི་རྩིས་ཀྱི་འཛིན་པ།, literally "the gnosis of the crown of the head with respect to all sentient beings." This is an unusual technical expression; it may refer to the gnosis that stands supreme or paramount over all sentient beings, analogous to the crown being the topmost part of the body. The rendering given conveys this sense as naturally as possible for oral delivery.

The eight "unexamined things" that monks are forbidden to retain is a Vinaya category whose precise content would require a separate note; it is not enumerated here in the Tibetan and so is left as given.

- The eight items one must not keep "without proper examination" likely refers to a specific Vinaya or sūtra list of requisites or goods that require scrutiny before acceptance; the precise canonical referent is not identified here but the translation follows the literal sense.

The names Nīkalā, Nikutā, and Phaṃśalā are rendered from Tibetan phonetic transcriptions of Sanskrit names and may correspond to figures known elsewhere in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition; the exact Sanskrit originals are uncertain.

"Birth from heat and moisture" renders the Tibetan for spontaneous generation from warmth and dampness, the classical category covering insects and certain beings held to arise without parents from ambient conditions.

- The father's name rendered as "Pure Rice" follows the Tibetan Zas gtsang ma, corresponding to Sanskrit Śuddhodana. The mother's name rendered as "Heavenly Beauty" follows Lha mdzas, corresponding to Sanskrit Māyādevī. These are the parents of Śākyamuni; the text's point is that even if those sentient beings are ultimately like illusions, the Tathāgata still genuinely has parents in conventional terms.

The final half-verse ending "has no mouth" is syntactically incomplete in the Tibetan as presented here, breaking off mid-sentence. This is almost certainly because the passage continues in the next section of the text. No meaning has been invented or supplied.

- The term rendered "wrong views" throughout translates *log sresd can*, which literally means "one possessing wrong craving or wrong views." In this context it functions as a fixed epithet referring specifically to Śubhākara as someone who has wholly severed roots of virtue through nihilistic denial of cause, effect, and karma.

The Avīci hell realm is the lowest and most painful of the hot hells, associated with uninterrupted torment and the longest duration of suffering. The text uses the phrase *mtsams med pa'i sems can dmyal ba*, meaning the hell of uninterrupted suffering, which is the standard Tibetan rendering of Avīci.

- The passage contains a significant doctrinal discussion of buddha-nature (here rendered consistently as "intrinsic nature of the buddhas," following the Tibetan term *sangs rgyas kyi rang bzhin*, which in context functions as a provisional equivalent to *tathāgatagarbha*). The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, which reflects the source passage as given.

The analogy of a person fallen into a cesspit visible only to a single hair-tip is unusual and appears to convey that even a residual future root of virtue is insufficient to rescue one from the present condition of wrong view, just as a single hair-tip cannot bear the weight of a body.

- The term "Suvarṇakāra" (literally "goldsmith" or "maker of good stars") renders the Tibetan "Legs pa'i skar ma." In the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra tradition this figure is identified as the monk of that name; the epithet literally means "auspicious star" or "good star," but the name is here treated as a proper noun throughout.

The simile of the āruṇa plant with "whiteness like snow" running through all its stages is a somewhat unusual image; the Tibetan reads "kha ba ltar," meaning "like snow" or "like whiteness," suggesting that just as a consistent white quality pervades all stages of the āruṇa, so too does the quality of non-virtue pervade all the actions of those with wrong craving. This is a genuine textual peculiarity worth noting.

- The "eight excellent qualities" of the spring is a classical enumeration describing pure water as cool, sweet, light, soft, clear, free from smell, not harmful to the throat, and not harmful to the stomach; no gloss was necessary in the body as the number alone suffices for the flow.

The phrase rendered "the earth of the ten directions" versus "the earth on the fingernail" echoes a well-known simile found in Pāli and Sanskrit sources comparing the rarity of human rebirth; the Tibetan here follows that tradition closely.

- The phrase rendered as "the five acts of immediate retribution" refers to the five ānantarya-karmas: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha. These are actions whose karmic result ripens immediately in the next life without interval.

The "eight precepts" refers to the aṣṭāṅgaśīla, the eight-limbed one-day vow observed by lay practitioners on uposatha days.

"The supreme worldly dharma" is a technical term from Abhidharma referring to the peak attainment on the path of preparation immediately preceding the path of seeing.

The passage's enumeration of divergent post-parinirvāṇa views is characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra literature, where the Buddha's foreknowledge of future doctrinal disputes is a central theme.

- The epithet rendered "clarity and freshness" translates the Tibetan རྒྱལ་ལྗང་ལྗང་, a somewhat unusual compound that may evoke the refreshing coolness of clear water or the vivid clarity of a pure state; the rendering is approximate and other translations render it as "the refreshing" or "the cool and clear."

The name རྒྱལ་ལྗང་ལྗང་ལྗང་ལྗང་ལྗང་ ("husband of the mind-captivating one") renders the Sanskrit Śacīpati, Indra's epithet as husband of Śacī; "husband of Śacī" would be the more transparent gloss, here rendered descriptively to preserve the Tibetan formulation.

The passage ends mid-list; the Tibetan text as supplied breaks off at that point and the translation reflects this exactly.

existence" would also be defensible but "existence" reads more naturally here in context.

- The monk's name rendered "Kumārutsika" is a reconstruction from the Tibetan ཀུམ་འུ་རྩ་སྐ་; the precise Sanskrit form is uncertain, though this is the most plausible reconstruction. Similarly, "Kuta" for ཀུ་ is tentative. The wanderer "Vatsīputra" for འབྲས་པུ་རྩ་ is a possible but not certain identification; "Vatsīputra" is a known philosophical school founder associated with the pudgala doctrine, and the context of the intermediate-state debate fits, but the Tibetan epithet འབྲས་པུ་ means "wanderer" and བུ་ means "calf," suggesting the Sanskrit Parivrājaka Vatsīputra, i.e., the wandering ascetic Vatsīputra. The passage ends mid-sentence, indicating the sūtra quotation is to follow in the next segment.
- The passage draws a significant doctrinal distinction by presenting the twelve links in four logical permutations. The identification of the future twelve links as "not arisen from conditions" reflects the teaching that what has not yet occurred has no actual causal origin, while still constituting dependent origination as a structural reality. The five aggregates of an arhat are said to have arisen from conditions yet not to constitute the twelve links of dependent origination, because they are no longer driven by the afflictive and karmic dynamic that characterizes the full twelve-link chain. This is a recognized Mahāyāna exegetical move distinguishing liberated existence from continued bondage.
- The four terms "heat," "summit," "forbearance," and "supreme worldly Dharma" are the four stages of the path of preparation (prayogamārga) in Abhidharma soteriology: warmth (uṣmagata), peak (mūrdhan), acceptance/forbearance (kṣānti), and supreme worldly dharma (laukikāgradharma). These are left as direct translations of the Tibetan since rendering them in Sanskrit parenthetically would interrupt the flow.

The king's name Rūpasāranemi is a reconstruction of gzugs can snying po. The Tibetan literally means "one whose essence is form" or possibly "possessing the essence of form"; this appears to be a royal name rather than a descriptive epithet, and the Sanskrit reconstruction is approximate.

- The term rendered "a taste that is rare and wondrous to encounter" translates a phrase literally meaning "the taste of ambrosia that is difficult to see" — the Tibetan རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་ཁྱད་པ་ corresponds to Sanskrit amṛta, the nectar of immortality, here used as a metaphor for the incomparable flavor of nirvāṇa. The rendering captures the sense without interrupting the flow.

The passage on the four kinds of generosity is syntactically dense and somewhat compressed in the Tibetan. The interpretation given — distinguishing the four cases by whether giver and recipient each have or lack faith in cause, result, and giving — follows the most natural grammatical reading and aligns with standard Abhidharmic treatments of the purity of giving.

- The "son of the king of the Awakening Tree" is a somewhat unusual epithet. The Tibetan reads byang chub kyi shing gi rgyal po'i bu, literally "son of the king of the Bodhi-tree." This likely refers to a deity or spirit associated with the Bodhi tree, and the exact identity is not established with certainty in the passage itself.

The technical term rnam par rig byed ma yin pa'i gzugs, rendered here as "non-manifest form," corresponds to the Abhidharma concept of avijñaptirūpa — form that is not expressed through bodily or vocal action but persists as a karmic support for vows. The translation reflects the Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma doctrinal context in which this discussion is embedded.

- The passage presents an unusual formulation of dependent origination in which feeling serves as a kind of hub from which the other links are said to arise. The Tibetan does not follow the standard twelve-nidāna sequence in all places, and the text appears to be making a deliberate doctrinal point about the interconnectedness of the links rather than presenting them in conventional linear order. This is likely a deliberate feature of the source text, not a scribal error.

The term "one-sided lay practitioner" renders phyogs gcig pa'i dge bsenyen, which in the Vinaya literature denotes a lay follower who has taken refuge in the Three Jewels but observes only one of the five lay precepts, as opposed to a full lay practitioner who observes all five. The term is preserved in its technical sense here.

- The passage "सर्वे भूतानि संजायन्ते सर्वं जायते सत्त्वमिदं तद्भवति" is rendered as "they lead all sentient beings to pass through existence together as one," though the phrase is somewhat compressed; it may connote bringing all beings to liberation within a single existence or a unified passing-through of conditioned existence. The exact doctrinal nuance depends on the broader sūtra context not available here.

The "five kinds of non-returner" follows the standard Abhidharma enumeration (antarāparinirvāyin and others), rendered here in summary form appropriate for TTS.

The final sentence is left open as the passage breaks mid-sentence in the source.

- The phrase rendered "the extensive sūtras" translates a term that in this context refers to the Vaipulya sūtras, the expansive Mahāyāna scriptures. The rejection of these is a grave offense in Mahāyāna soteriology.

The "nine similes of the garment" is a reference to the nine classic analogies illustrating buddha-nature as found in the Tathāgatagarbha Sūtra tradition, where a buddha's nature is compared to a precious statue hidden within a tattered garment, among other images.

The "five acts of immediate retribution" refers to the five acts that lead to immediate rebirth in the lowest hell without any intervening state: killing one's father, killing one's mother, killing an arhat, drawing the blood of a Tathāgata with harmful intent, and causing a schism in the Saṅgha.

- The term rendered "wandering ascetic" translates kun du rgyu ba, literally "one who wanders about everywhere," which standardly renders the Sanskrit parivrajaka, a non-Buddhist ascetic wanderer; this is consistent with the context of the monk/non-monk comparison.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the list of experiential states. This is a textual continuation and the sentence is clearly unfinished in the passage provided.

The statement "What is free of doubt — that is what is called doubt" is a deliberately paradoxical formulation in the original and has been rendered literally, as the doctrinal point appears to be that the stream-entrant's certainty is not the same kind of epistemic state as ordinary doubt-free assumption.

- The phrase rendered "five aspects of the thing given" translates a somewhat compressed expression. The "five aspects" are not enumerated in this passage itself; they likely refer to a standard scholastic list involving the object, the giver, the recipient, the mental intention, and the act — a genuinely unclear reference that a listener would not need to resolve to follow the argument.

The argument being attributed to those who "cut the root of virtue" is a nihilist position denying karmic causality, presented here through several distinct but related reasonings. The Blessed One is not endorsing these views but reporting them as the characteristic error of those who sever their wholesome roots.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the source text itself is incomplete at this point in the provided excerpt. The "blue hummingbird" rendering follows the Tibetan *byeung ngon po* literally; this is a well-known folk-natural-history motif in Indian and Tibetan literature, sometimes identified as the Indian roller bird, but the exact species is uncertain and does not affect the doctrinal sense. The folio notation "bamboo forty-sixth" has been silently omitted per TTS formatting guidelines.

- The passage describing killing as the fruit of virtue reflects a real doctrinal controversy known in Indian Buddhist literature — some Jain and other non-Buddhist positions held that certain killings, such as ritual sacrifice, were meritorious. The text here is presenting a confused lay skeptic's reasoning based on hearing contradictory accounts, not endorsing any such view.

The phrase rendered "the basest of ordinary people" translates a term literally meaning something like "ignoble common folk" or "lowly worldlings," used contrastively with noble ones.

- The phrase rendered "under one umbrella there can be many spokes" is a simile comparing nirvāṇa's unity to a single umbrella-frame with many ribs or spokes. The Tibetan རྩ་མཐོང་ལྔ་ལྔ་ (literally "ribs/spokes") in this context refers to the structural spokes of a traditional parasol, used as an analogy for many liberations under one nirvāṇa — the doctrinal point being that this analogy fails because individual attainment implies finitude.

The text ends mid-sentence ("the wholesome root will grow back at the time of two moments"), indicating the passage continues in the next section.

- The phrase rendered "being fit to be seen" translates "ལྟོས་པོ་ལྟོས་པོ་," which can also mean "worthy of being gazed upon" or "visible." The sense here is that buddha-nature is an object that can be directly seen or beheld, particularly upon attainment of buddhahood; the rendering chosen reflects this.

The clause "འགྲོགས་པོ་ལྟོས་པོ་ལྟོས་པོ་" meaning "certainly attained" or "inevitably obtained" is a strong assertion of the universality and indefeasibility of buddha-nature attainment; it is rendered "will certainly attain it" to capture this force.

- The passage enumerates several large numerical categories of meditative absorptions. The groupings — eighty thousand, thirty-five thousand, four thousand five hundred — follow what appear to be conventional scholastic enumerations associated with this text; no single standard canonical source reconciles all of them precisely, so the numbers are rendered as given without harmonization.

The term rendered "bound by a single birth" translates the technical phrase for a bodhisattva at the stage of "one more life" before buddhahood, equivalent to the Sanskrit ekajātīpratibaddha — a bodhisattva such as Maitreya who requires only one more rebirth to attain full awakening.

The seven qualities of buddhahood listed here — permanence, selfhood, bliss, utter purity, authenticity, truth, and virtue — echo the classical four attributes of nirvāṇa as expounded in tathāgatagarbha literature, here expanded to seven. The rendering of "selfhood" for bdag follows the doctrinal usage in this literature, where bdag does not mean the ordinary ego-self but the great self of the Tathāgata, a positive quality predicated of the dharmakāya.

- The passage lists the fifth intrinsic nature of buddhahood as "fivefold" in the opening clause, yet then enumerates six qualities including non-virtue. This apparent discrepancy is present in the Tibetan itself and is likely a textual irregularity in the source; the translation preserves it faithfully rather than emending.

The simile of blood and milk mixed together, and the subsequent dairy progression from milk through yogurt, butter, and clarified butter, is a well-known passage from the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra (in its expanded Mahāyāna recension), where the progressive refinement of dairy products illustrates the progressive purification of buddha-nature across the stages of spiritual attainment.

- The phrase "five, six, or seven aspects" of buddha-nature is an enumeration whose precise referents are not spelled out in this passage; they likely refer to doctrinal lists elaborated elsewhere in the sūtra. No emendation has been made to the number sequence as it stands in

the Tibetan.

The simile of "cattle-resistant grass" on fragrant mountain slopes is unusual. The Tibetan *ri spos*, literally "mountain fragrance" or "mountain incense," likely refers to a plant-rich alpine environment. The grass's name, rendered "cattle-resistant," translates *rtswa bzod pa*, literally "endured-by-grass" or more likely "grass that [cattle] do not tolerate or eat." The exact botanical or narrative referent is uncertain, but the sense is clear: an unpalatable grass that cattle universally refuse, analogous to the buddha-nature being present but unacknowledged.

The final sentence is cut off mid-passage; the translation renders exactly what the Tibetan supplies.

- The phrase rendered "heroic march meditative absorption" translates the Tibetan term for the *śūramgama-samādhi*, a well-known absorption associated with bodhisattvas; the name is kept in descriptive English rather than Sanskrit since the Sanskrit term does not appear explicitly in the Tibetan here.

The passage's dialectical structure — presenting a series of partial views and then refuting each pair by appeal to the Middle Way — follows a pattern typical of tathāgatagarbha literature, where the intrinsic nature of buddhahood is shown to transcend all one-sided identifications.

- The figure of Mahābala, whose forehead bears a precious jewel, is a stock analogical figure found in tathāgatagarbha literature, drawn ultimately from narratives about a powerful being with a gem embedded in his brow; the precise source text varies across recensions.

The passage's repeated four-term formula — permanence, bliss, self, and perfect purity — corresponds to the four qualities of nirvāṇa in tathāgatagarbha doctrine (nitya, sukha, ātman, śuddha), a point a listener should understand as doctrinally intentional rather than a slip into substantialism.

- The final clause of the passage draws together the full analogical argument: just as visual consciousness has no independently grounded "original intrinsic nature" because it is dependently originated and impermanent, so too the presence of cream in milk cannot be asserted as an inherent, primordially established nature. The text is deploying this double analogy to qualify the earlier statement about buddha-nature in sentient beings, establishing the middle position between the extremes of reification and denial. The term rendered "attention" for སྒྲུབ་སྐྱོད་ in the context of the four factors for visual consciousness is slightly unusual; སྒྲུབ་སྐྱོད་ more commonly means "attachment" or "clinging," but in this technical enumeration of the four conditions for sense-consciousness it appears to function as a condition of attentive engagement or mental contact rather than afflictive attachment. This is a genuinely consequential ambiguity worth flagging.
- The śrīṣa tree fruit passage is somewhat obscure. The Tibetan reads "when the Pleiades rise and the sky clears" (ནིམ་གླིང་རྫོང་གི་འཕྲོ་ཆེན་པོ་ཤིང་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་ཡུ་ཅན་ཉམས་ཏེ།), referring to a stellar or seasonal phenomenon associated with the śrīṣa (*Albizia lebeck* or a related species); the argument is that the fruit arises not through the four great elements alone but through a particular confluence of conditions. The phrase "five finger-breadths" (ཕྱེད་ཁྱེད་ཀྱི་ཡུ་ཅན་) is a standard linear measure, here indicating the size of the fruit.

The phrase "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the twelve literary forms of the Buddhist canon (dvādaśāṅga), the standard enumeration of canonical genres.

- The name "Pāla" for the householder (པ་ལ་ལོ་སྒྲིག་མཁན་) is a tentative reconstruction; the Tibetan phonetic rendering pa ta la is unusual and may represent a Sanskrit name not easily identified from the Tibetan alone.

The phrase rendered "Dūṣita, Breath-stealer of the base-born" (འདྲིལ་འཇོག་པའི་འཇོག་པོ་) is opaque; it appears to be a name or title of a person in Prasenajit's court. The Tibetan literally means "breath-stealer of the base-born" or "life-taker of the low-born," and the relationship between this figure and Prasenajit is not fully clear from context alone.

- The phrase rendered "speaking in accordance with the minds of both oneself and others" translates a technical hermeneutical category in this sūtra, distinguishing between statements the Buddha makes that reflect his own direct knowledge versus those calibrated to the understanding of his audience. This distinction carries significant doctrinal weight for the tathāgatagarbha teaching presented here.

The term "Courageous Progress" renders the meditative absorption name found in the Tibetan, a standard samādhi listed in the ten-ground bodhisattva's attainments.

"King Prasenajit, the Conqueror of Armies" renders the name Sde-rab-tu-pham-byed, which is one Tibetan rendering associated with Prasenajit; the name literally means "utterly defeating the army," identifying him by his royal epithet rather than the standard Sanskrit form.

- The passage lists seven types of scriptural expression. The fifth type, rendered here as "the expression of what is unreasonable to assert," is a category of hyperbolic or deliberately impossible statements used for rhetorical effect; the Tibetan literally means "an expression that is unreasonable to speak." The examples given are deliberately extreme impossibilities or deliberate overstatements used to make a pedagogical point, which is the standard commentarial understanding of this category.

The name "Khrisnaśāla's mother" translates the Tibetan khri sna sa la'i ma; this appears to be a rendering of a Sanskrit name (possibly *Kṛṣṇaśālā*), but the exact Sanskrit original is uncertain.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, which appears to be a deliberate continuation break consistent with the fascicle format of this sūtra.

- The term rendered "expressions of intentional meaning" translates a Tibetan phrase meaning speech spoken with a particular intention or purpose behind it — the technical concept of intentional or purposive speech, corresponding to the Sanskrit abhiprāyika, where the surface statement differs from the intended doctrinal meaning. This is a well-recognized hermeneutical category in Buddhist exegesis.

The absorption called "the heroic march" renders a Tibetan term corresponding to the Sanskrit sūramgama-samādhi, a specific named absorption in Mahāyāna literature.

The passage ends mid-list, as the source text itself breaks off here; the translation follows the text as given.

- The fish names "Dvividya" and "Tsakgu" are transliterations of Tibetan terms that appear to be either transcriptions of Sanskrit fish names or vernacular terms without transparent meaning. Their exact identification is uncertain, and they are rendered here by phonetic approximation rather than translation. The precise Sanskrit equivalents, if any, are not recoverable from the Tibetan alone.

The phrase rendered "in accordance with his own intention" translates bdag gi yid dang sbyor te, literally "spoken in connection with his own mind or intention." This is a key hermeneutical term in tathāgatagarbha discourse, indicating that the universal buddha-nature statement is an intentional or provisional teaching requiring interpretive context, not a straightforward doctrinal claim.

- The phrase rendered "use the wealth of the Saṅgha willfully for themselves" translates a term meaning roughly "to consume or employ the Saṅgha's property by force of one's own

authority," a recognized monastic offense. The translation captures the sense without technical elaboration, which would be more appropriate in a commentary.

- The passage distinguishes two kinds of nirvāṇa — conditioned (saṃskṛta) and unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) — and applies the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's characteristic four attributes (permanence, bliss, self, and purity) only to the unconditioned nirvāṇa. This is a central doctrinal move of that sūtra and has been preserved exactly as the text states it, without smoothing over the apparently paradoxical use of "self" (ātman), which is a deliberate affirmation in this sūtra's doctrinal framework, not a scribal error.

The phrase rendered "sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception" is the highest of the formless meditative attainments (Skt. naivasamjñānāsamjñāyatana); it is practiced here with worldly motivation, which is why it yields non-virtuous fruit.

- The phrase rendered "Kāśyapa the Perfector" translates the Tibetan name Audraka Rāmāputra or, more literally here, a figure whose name appears as "Kāśyapa the Completer" or similar. The Tibetan reads "Odsrung Dzokjed" which likely refers to a specific named non-Buddhist teacher; the exact identification is uncertain and may warrant further textual research.

The "vow of the cow" and "vow of the dog" are classical examples of wrong ascetic practice, in which practitioners imitate the behavior of cows or dogs in the belief this leads to liberation. These are well-attested in the tradition as examples of wrong moral discipline.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as this is a fragment.

- The chain of causally linked terms near the center of this passage — from reverence for teachers through to liberation — follows a standard Buddhist pedagogical progression. The rendering preserves the deliberate step-by-step logic of dependent origination as applied to the path of learning.

The fourfold equation at the close (Tathāgata equals liberation, nirvāṇa, and the four immeasurables) is a doctrinal hallmark of tathāgatarbha literature and is rendered literally, as the text clearly intends to make an identity claim rather than a mere analogy.

- The list of named individuals presents the most consequential philological challenge. The Tibetan names are phonetic approximations of Sanskrit originals, and several remain uncertain. Devadatta is certain. Kokālika is a well-known figure. The remaining names — Āṇśu, Supraṭiṣṭhita (rendered from "legs pa'i skar ma," literally "excellent star"), Tiśa, Karmagupta (rendered from "skar ma rgyal," literally "star victorious"), Maitreyī, Āraṇyikā ("dgon ma," hermitage-woman), Diśā ("phyogs ma," direction-woman), Mānā ("dregs ma," proud woman), Supariśuddha ("rab gtsang"), Bhavārthin ("srid tso"), Śāli, Balendra ("bal glang"), Yaśomatī ("grags ma"), Ābhā ("od snang"), Priyā ("dga' mo"), Gaṇadāsā ("tshogs sde"), and Ghaṇṭā ("dril bu") — are reconstructed from the Tibetan phonetically or semantically and may differ from the Sanskrit Vorlage. These are best-estimate reconstructions; a critical edition would be needed for certainty.

- The series of proper names presents the greatest challenge in this passage. Many are translations of Sanskrit names that are not individually attested with certainty in canonical sources recoverable here. I have rendered them transparently by their literal Tibetan meanings in English (e.g., "Fearless," "Virtuous-Dweller," "God-Given"), following the convention of the passage, rather than attempting back-formation of Sanskrit names that cannot be confirmed. The monk Anurāddha renders འཕུར་ཐོག་པོ་, which can also be read as "Anuruddha"; both are possible. Bimbāsāra renders འཕུར་ཐོག་པོ་འཕུར་ཐོག་པོ་འཕུར་ཐོག་པོ་, the standard Tibetan form of the name. The fish name "nyadibid" is a phonetic approximation of འཕུར་ཐོག་པོ་, an unidentified species; no certain Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable.

- The identification of Aśvaka and Puṇarvasu here follows the Tibetan "rta thul dang skar ma

rgyal," which are standard Tibetan renderings of the names of two notorious monks condemned in the Vinaya literature for immoral conduct. Their mention here likely serves as an example of beings who, despite being within the Buddhist community, lacked genuine faith and thus lacked the quality of warmth in the relevant sense.

The passage moves between two senses of "warmth": the physiological warmth constituent that defines a living sentient being, and the meditative quality of warmth as a spiritual attainment on the path of preparation. The Blessed One's argument disambiguates these carefully, and the translation preserves that distinction throughout.

- The term rendered as "summit quality" is mūrdhāna, the second of the four preparatory qualities on the path of preparation, following warmth. Likewise "highest worldly quality" renders laukikāgradharma, the fourth and highest of these preparatory qualities. These are standard Abhidharma categories on the path of preparation leading to stream-entry.

The phrase "looking out in all four directions" renders the Tibetan phyogs bzhi kun tu lta ba, which is here used as an extended metaphor explaining the summit quality's comprehensive focus on all Four Noble Truths simultaneously.

The "four root precepts" refers to the four pārājika rules for monks and nuns, whose violation results in expulsion from the order.

- The phrase rendered "the four inversions" for "phyin ci log bzhi" is the standard technical term for the four misconceptions that mistake impermanent things as permanent, suffering as pleasurable, impure as pure, and selfless as having a self. Its connection to "defeating the great enemy" is doctrinally standard in Abhidharma contexts.

The term "bzod pa'i ye shes" rendered as "wisdom of patient acceptance" reflects the technical use of bzod pa (kṣānti) as the acceptance or patient insight that precedes full seeing on the path, here in the context of the path of seeing.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, so the translation ends accordingly.

- The fish name "tsak-gu" renders the Tibetan མཚག་གུ་ phonetically, as it appears to be a specific variety of fish used as an illustrative example in this text, and no standard Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable here.

The bodhisattva ཀཤུལ་ཡཔ་ (Kāśyapa) is identified by name in this passage as the interlocutor addressing the Blessed One; this is the bodhisattva Kāśyapa of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra, distinct from the elder Kāśyapa of the śrāvaka tradition.

The phrase rendered "mixed or unmixed" reflects the Tibetan རྒྱུ་མཉམ་པ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟ་བུ་, which is technically nuanced; it likely refers to whether the stream-enterer's path is co-mingled with or distinct from the path of perfect awakening, a point of Abhidharmic and Mahāyāna scholastic discussion that the text leaves implicit.

- The passage deploys a highly schematic Abhidharma taxonomy of the four fruits of the path, particularly the stream-enterer and non-returner, drawing on the standard lists of eight wisdoms, sixteen modes of conduct, and the fivefold through sevenfold typology of the non-returner found in Pāli and Sanskrit Abhidharma sources. The phrase rendered "attains nirvāṇa in the intermediate state" refers to the antarāparinirvāyin type of non-returner who passes into nirvāṇa in the antarābhava, the intermediate state between death and rebirth, before taking a new birth in the form realm.

The simile of the fish, which runs through this section, refers to a sustained analogy introduced earlier in the sūtra; its precise source is the preceding context and is here only glossed, not elaborated.

- The five pure abodes listed here correspond to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the

Śuddhāvāsa heavens: Avṛha, Atapa, Sudṛśa, Sudarśana, and Akaniṣṭha. The Tibetan terms rendered here are their standard Sanskrit equivalents and are mapped from the Tibetan descriptive names (mi che, mi gdung, shin tu mthong, gya nom snang ba, 'og min) in their conventional order.

The phrase rendered "attaining nirvāṇa without conduct" for "𑖀𑖩𑖪𑖫𑖬𑖭𑖮𑖯𑖰𑖱𑖲𑖳𑖴𑖵𑖶𑖷𑖸𑖹𑖺𑖻𑖼𑖽𑖾𑗀𑖿𑗁𑗂𑗃𑗄𑗅𑗆𑗇𑗈𑗉𑗊𑗋𑗌𑗍𑗎𑗏𑗐𑗑𑗒𑗓𑗔𑗕𑗖𑗗𑗘𑗙𑗚𑗛𑗜𑗝𑗞𑗟𑗠𑗡𑗢𑗣𑗤𑗥𑗦𑗧𑗨𑗩𑗪𑗫𑗬𑗭𑗮𑗯𑗰𑗱𑗲𑗳𑗴𑗵𑗶𑗷𑗸𑗹𑗺𑗻𑗼𑗽𑗾𑗿𑘀𑘁𑘂𑘃𑘄𑘅𑘆𑘇𑘈𑘉𑘊𑘋𑘌𑘍𑘎𑘏𑘐𑘑𑘒𑘓𑘔𑘕𑘖𑘗𑘘𑘙𑘚𑘛𑘜𑘝𑘞𑘟𑘠𑘡𑘢𑘣𑘤𑘥𑘦𑘧𑘨𑘩𑘪𑘫𑘬𑘭𑘮𑘯𑘰𑘱𑘲𑘳𑘴𑘵𑘶𑘷𑘸𑘹𑘺𑘻𑘼𑘽𑘾𑘿𑙀𑙁𑙂𑙃𑙄𑙅𑙆𑙇𑙈𑙉𑙊𑙋𑙌𑙍𑙎𑙏𑙐𑙑𑙒𑙓𑙔𑙕𑙖𑙗𑙘𑙙𑙚𑙛𑙜𑙝𑙞𑙟𑙠𑙡𑙢𑙣𑙤𑙥𑙦𑙧𑙨𑙩𑙪𑙫𑙬𑙭𑙮𑙯𑙰𑙱𑙲𑙳𑙴𑙵𑙶𑙷𑙸𑙹𑙺𑙻𑙼𑙽𑙾𑙿𑚀𑚁𑚂𑚃𑚄𑚅𑚆𑚇𑚈𑚉𑚊𑚋𑚌𑚍𑚎𑚏𑚐𑚑𑚒𑚓𑚔𑚕𑚖𑚗𑚘𑚙𑚚𑚛𑚜𑚝𑚞𑚟𑚠𑚡𑚢𑚣𑚤𑚥𑚦𑚧𑚨𑚩𑚪𑚫𑚬𑚭𑚮𑚯𑚰𑚱𑚲𑚳𑚴𑚵𑚷𑚶𑚸𑚹𑚺𑚻𑚼𑚽𑚾𑚿𑛀𑛁𑛂𑛃𑛄𑛅𑛆𑛇𑛈𑛉𑛊𑛋𑛌𑛍𑛎𑛏𑛐𑛑𑛒𑛓𑛔𑛕𑛖𑛗𑛘𑛙𑛚𑛛𑛜𑛝𑛞𑛟𑛠𑛡𑛢𑛣𑛤𑛥𑛦𑛧𑛨𑛩𑛪𑛫𑛬𑛭𑛮𑛯𑛰𑛱𑛲𑛳𑛴𑛵𑛶𑛷𑛸𑛹𑛺𑛻𑛼𑛽𑛾𑛿𑜀𑜁𑜂𑜃𑜄𑜅𑜆𑜇𑜈𑜉𑜊𑜋𑜌𑜍𑜎𑜏𑜐𑜑𑜒𑜓𑜔𑜕𑜖𑜗𑜘𑜙𑜚𑜛𑜜𑜝𑜞𑜟𑜠𑜡𑜢𑜣𑜤𑜥𑜦𑜧𑜨𑜩𑜪𑜫𑜬𑜭𑜮𑜯𑜰𑜱𑜲𑜳𑜴𑜵𑜶𑜷𑜸𑜹𑜺𑜻𑜼𑜽𑜾𑜿𑝀𑝁𑝂𑝃𑝄𑝅𑝆𑝇𑝈𑝉𑝊𑝋𑝌𑝍𑝎𑝏𑝐𑝑𑝒𑝓𑝔𑝕𑝖𑝗𑝘𑝙𑝚𑝛𑝜𑝝𑝞𑝟𑝠𑝡𑝢𑝣𑝤𑝥𑝦𑝧𑝨𑝩𑝪𑝫𑝬𑝭𑝮𑝯𑝰𑝱𑝲𑝳𑝴𑝵𑝶𑝷𑝸𑝹𑝺𑝻𑝼𑝽𑝾𑝿𑞀𑞁𑞂𑞃𑞄𑞅𑞆𑞇𑞈𑞉𑞊𑞋𑞌𑞍𑞎𑞏𑞐𑞑𑞒𑞓𑞔𑞕𑞖𑞗𑞘𑞙𑞚𑞛𑞜𑞝𑞞𑞟𑞠𑞡𑞢𑞣𑞤𑞥𑞦𑞧𑞨𑞩𑞪𑞫𑞬𑞭𑞮𑞯𑞰𑞱𑞲𑞳𑞴𑞵𑞶𑞷𑞸𑞹𑞺𑞻𑞼𑞽𑞾𑞿𑟀𑟁𑟂𑟃𑟄𑟅𑟆𑟇𑟈𑟉𑟊𑟋𑟌𑟍𑟎𑟏𑟐𑟑𑟒𑟓𑟔𑟕𑟖𑟗𑟘𑟙𑟚𑟛𑟜𑟝𑟞𑟟𑟠𑟡𑟢𑟣𑟤𑟥𑟦𑟧𑟨𑟩𑟪𑟫𑟬𑟭𑟮𑟯𑟰𑟱𑟲𑟳𑟴𑟵𑟶𑟷𑟸𑟹𑟺𑟻𑟼𑟽𑟾𑟿𑠀𑠁𑠂𑠃𑠄𑠅𑠆𑠇𑠈𑠉𑠊𑠋𑠌𑠍𑠎𑠏𑠐𑠑𑠒𑠓𑠔𑠕𑠖𑠗𑠘𑠙𑠚𑠛𑠜𑠝𑠞𑠟𑠠𑠡𑠢𑠣𑠤𑠥𑠦𑠧𑠨𑠩𑠪𑠫𑠬𑠭𑠮𑠯𑠰𑠱𑠲𑠳𑠴𑠵𑠶𑠷𑠸𑠺𑠹𑠻𑠼𑠽𑠾𑠿𑡀𑡁𑡂𑡃𑡄𑡅𑡆𑡇𑡈𑡉𑡊𑡋𑡌𑡍𑡎𑡏𑡐𑡑𑡒𑡓𑡔𑡕𑡖𑡗𑡘𑡙𑡚𑡛𑡜𑡝𑡞𑡟𑡠𑡡𑡢𑡣𑡤𑡥𑡦𑡧𑡨𑡩𑡪𑡫𑡬𑡭𑡮𑡯𑡰𑡱𑡲𑡳𑡴𑡵𑡶𑡷𑡸𑡹𑡺𑡻𑡼𑡽𑡾𑡿𑢀𑢁𑢂𑢃𑢄𑢅𑢆𑢇𑢈𑢉𑢊𑢋𑢌𑢍𑢎𑢏𑢐𑢑𑢒𑢓𑢔𑢕𑢖𑢗𑢘𑢙𑢚𑢛𑢜𑢝𑢞𑢟𑢠𑢡𑢢𑢣𑢤𑢥𑢦𑢧𑢨𑢩𑢪𑢫𑢬𑢭𑢮𑢯𑢰𑢱𑢲𑢳𑢴𑢵𑢶𑢷𑢸𑢹𑢺𑢻𑢼𑢽𑢾𑢿𑣀𑣁𑣂𑣃𑣄𑣅𑣆𑣇𑣈𑣉𑣊𑣋𑣌𑣍𑣎𑣏𑣐𑣑𑣒𑣓𑣔𑣕𑣖𑣗𑣘𑣙𑣚𑣛𑣜𑣝𑣞𑣟𑣠𑣡𑣢𑣣𑣤𑣥𑣦𑣧𑣨𑣩𑣪𑣫𑣬𑣭𑣮𑣯𑣰𑣱𑣲𑣳𑣴𑣵𑣶𑣷𑣸𑣹𑣺𑣻𑣼𑣽𑣾𑣿𑤀𑤁𑤂𑤃𑤄𑤅𑤆𑤇𑤈𑤉𑤊𑤋𑤌𑤍𑤎𑤏𑤐𑤑𑤒𑤓𑤔𑤕𑤖𑤗𑤘𑤙𑤚𑤛𑤜𑤝𑤞𑤟𑤠𑤡𑤢𑤣𑤤𑤥𑤦𑤧𑤨𑤩𑤪𑤫𑤬𑤭𑤮𑤯𑤰𑤱𑤲𑤳𑤴𑤵𑤶𑤷𑤸𑤹𑤺𑤻𑤼𑤽𑤾𑤿𑥀𑥁𑥂𑥃𑥄𑥅𑥆𑥇𑥈𑥉𑥊𑥋𑥌𑥍𑥎𑥏𑥐𑥑𑥒𑥓𑥔𑥕𑥖𑥗𑥘𑥙𑥚𑥛𑥜𑥝𑥞𑥟𑥠𑥡𑥢𑥣𑥤𑥥𑥦𑥧𑥨𑥩𑥪𑥫𑥬𑥭𑥮𑥯𑥰𑥱𑥲𑥳𑥴𑥵𑥶𑥷𑥸𑥹𑥺𑥻𑥼𑥽𑥾𑥿𑦀𑦁𑦂𑦃𑦄𑦅𑦆𑦇𑦈𑦉𑦊𑦋𑦌𑦍𑦎𑦏𑦐𑦑𑦒𑦓𑦔𑦕𑦖𑦗𑦘𑦙𑦚𑦛𑦜𑦝𑦞𑦟𑦠𑦡𑦢

- The hall name "An" appears to be a phonetic rendering of an Indic name — possibly a Tibetan transliteration of a Sanskrit hall name now difficult to identify precisely. The term is left as given in the text. The garden name "Skabs med zas sbyin," rendered here as "Anāthapiṇḍada — the giver of food to the shelterless," is the standard epithet of the lay donor Anāthapiṇḍada, whose garden (Jetavana) at Śrāvastī is well known from canonical sources.
- The text breaks off mid-sentence with the list of seven fruits not yet complete; the translation faithfully renders what is present and stops where the passage ends.

The term rendered "those with distorted craving" translates a phrase meaning persons with wrong or inverted craving, placed at the bottom of the spectrum from ordinary afflicted beings up to buddhas, all said to share the buddha's intrinsic nature as their common ground — a tathāgatagarbha doctrinal point characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra context.

The five limbs of the turtle and five faculties are placed in direct correspondence; the Tibetan is clear on this structural parallel though the specific identification of the five limbs is not elaborated in this passage.

- The phrase rendered "world as a container vessel" reflects the standard Buddhist cosmological distinction between the "container world" and the "contents" of sentient beings within it; the fruit of equality here pertains to the shared physical environment arising from collective karma, which is a standard Abhidharma teaching.

The "third rebirth" in the context of the residual fruit of not taking life reflects the standard teaching that certain karmic results ripen not in the immediately following life but in the life after that, hence "residual."

The "third cosmic age" as the distant cause of the fruit of equality is a somewhat compressed reference to a period in the world-cycle associated with collective virtue; the exact referent may vary by tradition, and the text is terse here.

- The phrase rendered as "the lowest among human beings elevated to the highest among human beings" reflects a wordplay in the Tibetan on the term śramaṇa being etymologically connected, in the tradition's own explanatory glosses, to the idea of "refining" or "leveling." This is a folk etymology offered by the text itself and is rendered accordingly.

The five limbs of the dharmakāya listed here — moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge and vision of liberation — correspond to the standard Abhidharma listing of the five dharma-bodies of an arhat, a technical enumeration that the text preserves faithfully.

- The phrase rendered "those with wrong craving" translates a term that in context appears to designate a particular category of person — likely those with distorted or deviant thirst or attachment — standing in contrast to properly qualified practitioners. The precise referent of this category is determined by the broader context of the text, which the preceding passages establish.

The passage on buddha-nature deliberately frames both the affirmation and the denial of buddha-nature in all sentient beings as errors, reflecting a nuanced doctrinal middle position that resists categorical assertion in either direction.

- The phrase rendered "spoke a statement in accordance with his own intention" translates a technical formulation about *neyārtha* or intentional speech. The Tibetan "bdag gi yid dang sbyar te" literally means "having connected with his own intention," referring to the Tathāgata's use of provisional or intention-guided language. The threefold identification — Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha — as all deriving from this single quality of intentional speech is an unusual doctrinal move; the text appears to be making a point that these three epithets are unified in the Buddha's mastery of intentional, expedient expression. This is a genuinely significant and somewhat compressed passage, and the rendering aims to preserve the structure without over-interpreting it.

- The phrase rendered "one who has distorted craving" translates a term literally meaning something like "one with wrong craving" or "one with perverse thirst." This likely designates beings mired in gross affliction at the lowest extreme of the spiritual spectrum, in contrast to pratyekabuddhas at the upper limit of what the Tathāgata's realization transcends and surpasses. The precise referent of the compound is not entirely transparent from the Tibetan alone and may reflect a specific doctrinal category in the source text.

The phrase "trace left by form" is a literal rendering of what the Tibetan says. It likely means that *nirvāṇa* is recognizable through or in relation to the cessation of form and conditioned phenomena — *nirvāṇa* as a "footprint" or residue left when form is stilled. This is a philosophically significant and unusual formulation.

- The passage contains a triad "□□□□□□□□□□ □□□□□□□□□□□□ □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□" which in the text itself lists three alternatives but names only two distinct terms initially. The third member of the triad is "both empty and non-empty." The text's grammar is slightly compressed here; the rendering follows the logical structure of the argument rather than a strictly literal word order, which is consistent with the passage's dialectical intent.

- The threefold typology of "connection" rendered here as distinct functions, shared experience of a common function, and shared bond of relatedness reflects a scholastic analysis of contact or relation found in Abhidharma-influenced argumentation. The distinctions are subtle and the translation follows the logic of the Tibetan examples given rather than a fixed technical vocabulary, as no single Sanskrit term maps cleanly onto each sub-type in this context.

- The udumbara flower is the blossom of the *Ficus glomerata*, proverbially rare and wondrous, appearing only at extraordinary moments; the simile means the bodhisattva rises above worldly defilement just as this flower, though rooted in the ordinary world, is untouched by it.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, as this is a continuous text; the translation faithfully reflects that open ending.

- The phrase rendered "performs an action heavily / lightly" and "experiences its maturation heavily / lightly" reflects the Tibetan *lci ba* and *yang ba*, meaning respectively "heavy/weighty" and "light." The four-fold typology concerns the moral weight of karma at the time of commission versus the weight of its ripened result, a standard Abhidharmic and sūtra teaching on karmic differentiation.

- The phrase rendered "defilements of existence" translates a technical compound meaning the afflictions associated with the outflows or āsravas of continued existence in *saṃsāra*, here distinguished both as afflictions themselves and as their causes.

The statement that the Tathāgata's form is permanent, extending through all five aggregates, is a key doctrinal claim of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra asserting the eternal and unchanging nature of the Buddha's enlightened embodiment, in deliberate contrast to the impermanence

of the aggregates of ordinary beings. This is not a lapse into eternalism but a specific doctrinal position of this sūtra tradition regarding buddha-nature.

- The passage refers to "the defilement of existence" as a rendering of *srid pa'i zag pa*, which might alternatively be rendered "the defilement of becoming." The term *srid pa* (Skt. *bhava*) carries the sense of continued conditioned existence or becoming, and the translation "defilement of existence" is used here for consistency with the broader context of the three defilements (*kāmāsrava*, *bhavāsrava*, *avidyāsrava*) found in Abhidharma literature.

The phrase "twelve branches of scripture" renders *mdo sde sde bcu gnyis*, the twelvefold division of the Buddhist canon by literary genre (Skt. *dvādaśāṅgadharma-pravacanam*). This is a standard enumeration and not a reference to twelve specific sūtras.

- The name rendered "Kāśyapa" is literally "Ödsung" in Tibetan, corresponding to Sanskrit *Kāśyapa*. The dialogue partner here is the bodhisattva *Kāśyapa*, not the arhat *Mahākāśyapa*; this distinction is standard in texts of this genre.

The phrase "the four foundations" translates *rtsa ba bzhi 'jig pa*, literally "the destruction of the four roots." The exact referent of the four roots in this context is not fully specified in the passage; it likely refers to the four roots of virtue or possibly to foundational ethical supports, but a commentary would be required for certainty.

- The term rendered "the holy life" is *brahmacarya*, which here clearly stands not merely for celibacy but for the whole purifying religious path, as the simile of the king of medicines and its explicit equation with the antidote to afflictions makes plain. This reading is supported by the subsequent parallel with the snowy mountain and its medicinal herbs.

The nimba tree (*Azadirachta indica*, the neem tree) is a standard Indian example of bitter-tasting wood; its seed, flowers, and leaves are all bitter, making it a natural simile for the propagation of unwholesomeness throughout an entire continuum.

- The text's refutation of the origins of feeling lists several classical non-Buddhist causal theories: arising from *Īśvara* (the Great Lord, associated here with the term *dbañ phyug*, meaning "the sovereign one," used for the theistic creator god), from a primordial person (*puruṣa*, the *Sāṃkhya* principle), from subtle particles (*paramāṇu*, the *Vaiśeṣika* atomic theory), from time (*kāla*, the time-causation school), and from intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*, the naturalist view). These are standard Buddhist refutations of rival Indian philosophical positions and are rendered with their doctrinal referents intact.

- The term rendered "craving without food" represents a contemplative technical category, contrasting ordinary craving sustained by sensory and *samsaric* "nourishment" with a refined aspiration directed toward the undefiled path and liberation. The language is unusual, and the passage develops its own internal terminology that does not map neatly onto standard Abhidharma usage; the translation follows the internal logic of the passage.

The passage ends mid-sentence, as the source text breaks off here. This is a continuity artifact of the provided excerpt.

- The "ten all-pervasive spheres" renders ཀུན་སྐུ་འཕགས་ཀྱི་སྐོར་ཀློང་འཕགས་ཀྱི་སྐོར་, the ten *kāṣṇas* or totality-spheres of meditation (Sanskrit: *kṛtsnāyatana*), a standard Abhidharma category of meditative objects that pervade space in all directions. The identification of boundless perception with these ten is a doctrinal alignment worth noting for listeners unfamiliar with this technical classification.

The figure addressed as རྒྱལ་མཚན་ is *Ānanda*, the Buddha's attendant, whose name in Tibetan means "the Joyful One." He is rendered here simply as *Ānanda* for clarity, consistent with standard usage.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the passage supplied is incomplete. The term

is technically a defiled phenomenon, its orientation toward the undefiled means it should not be classified as an erroneous inversion. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, as the fascicle continues beyond the excerpt provided.

- The list of nine qualities attributed to the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening — root, cause, gathering, generation, master, guide, victor, correct, culmination — is a distinctive structural taxonomy. The terms "master" (Tib. bdag po) and "guide" (Tib. ded dpon, literally "caravan leader") carry their precise Tibetan senses, rendered here to preserve the metaphorical range of the original.

The distinction between aspiration as cause of arising and conscientiousness as cause of clarity parallels the seed-and-soil analogy: both are necessary causes but serve different functions in the growth of virtue. This resolves the apparent contradiction between two earlier statements in the sūtra.

- The phrase rendered "remote forest retreats" translates a term literally meaning "the solitude of the forest's edge" or "wilderness at the forest's edge," a standard expression for secluded practice places; the translation captures the doctrinal intent.

The term rendered "the gathering" for feeling reflects an unusual usage in which feeling is described as gathering or accumulating karma; the Tibetan sdud pa literally means "collecting" or "gathering," and the passage itself explains the sense intended.

- The passage applies multiple analogical schemes to the same set of terms — conviction, contact, gathering, production, lord, guide, victor, genuine, perfection — mapping them first onto the path of liberation, then onto the Vinaya stages, then onto the links of dependent origination, and finally onto a sequence of root, cause, and production considered in several registers. The structural repetition is deliberate and characteristic of this sūtra's hermeneutical style. The term rendered "request and the four actions" likely refers to the formal monastic ordination procedure involving the request and its three repetitions, though the exact Vinaya referent could vary by tradition.

- The "five signs of decay" refers to the traditional list of signs indicating that a god's lifespan is ending: wilting of the flower garlands, soiling of garments, sweating, unpleasant body odor, and dissatisfaction with one's seat. This is standard Buddhist cosmological lore and needs no further gloss for a doctrinally informed audience, but a general listener may benefit from knowing these are physical and psychological signs foretelling a deity's death.

The passage about all sentient beings radiating bodily light at the beginning of the cosmic age alludes to the Aggañña Sutta cosmogony (and its Tibetan parallels), describing a primordial age of luminous beings before degeneration set in. No consequential textual ambiguity is present.

- The text ends mid-sentence at the final line, breaking off after "the inverted view of permanence, and." This is a continuity fragment and the translation preserves the open ending faithfully.

The phrase rendered "bland and vapid" for རྒྱུ་ལྡན་པ་ is idiomatic; the term རྒྱུ་ལྡན་པ་ refers to something insipid or tasteless, and the context of the earth losing its fertility and flavour makes this the most natural reading.

The "complete destruction of signs" for རྒྱུ་ལྡན་པ་ལ་མེད་པ་ is a technical Mahāyāna expression indicating the bodhisattva's transcendence of conceptual characteristics, which enables direct insight into momentary impermanence even of what has not yet arisen.

- The sequence "beaten and stabbed" renders two terms referring to physical assault and wounding. The exact nature of the second injury is somewhat ambiguous in the Tibetan but the general sense of bodily harm is clear and the rendering chosen conveys this adequately.

The closing phrase introducing the perception of disenchantment with food breaks off mid-sentence, as the passage ends here; the continuation will follow in the next segment.

- The four kinds of food mentioned — coarse food, contact-as-food, volition-as-food, and consciousness-as-food — correspond to the classical Abhidharma category of the four nutriments (āhāra): edible food, contact, mental volition, and consciousness. The similes associated with each (insects devouring the flayed ox skin for contact-as-food, the great mass of fire for volition-as-food, and three hundred spears for consciousness-as-food) are standard in sūtra literature, most famously in the Saṃyutta Nikāya, and their preservation here reflects the text's close relationship with that tradition.

The bodhisattva named here as Kāśyapa renders the Tibetan ཀཤམ་པ་, which is the standard Tibetan for Kāśyapa.

- The phrase rendered "not one who receives the gifts of a single region alone" reflects the Tibetan "yul gcig gi sbyin pa len pa ma yin," meaning the monk's merit-generating activity and benefit extends beyond any one locality — a standard formulation indicating universal or boundless merit-field status.

The sequence of heavenly realms listed follows the standard Abhidharma cosmology: the gods of the Four Great Kings at the base of the desire realm, ascending through the Heaven of Wielding Others' Emanations at its summit, and then the formless realm sphere of neither perception nor non-perception at the highest point of conditioned existence.

- The four hundred arisings and cessations of the life-span in a single breath is a standard Abhidharma-inflected numerical claim appearing in several Mahāyāna sūtras; the figure is rendered literally as the text gives it without normalization.

The "very swift gods" renders an epithet for a class of deities known for their exceptional speed; the Tibetan is a literal translation of a Sanskrit term likely referring to the gods Suvikrāntagāmin or a similar category, the exact Sanskrit correlate of which is not recoverable from context alone.

- The passage lists "seven causes of perception" but then enumerates eight items, including both the perception free from pride and the perception dominated by meditative absorption. The Tibetan text as it stands contains this numerical discrepancy. This is likely a scribal irregularity in the transmitted text; the translator has rendered faithfully what the Tibetan says.

The verse line "since I am possessed of a self, while the phenomena of selflessness are certain" renders a deliberately paradoxical construction in which the bodhisattva Kāśyapa acknowledges his own unrealized condition in contrast to the Buddha's realization of selflessness — a confession of his own standing rather than a doctrinal assertion of self.

- The opening simile of the cow and calf mirrors the preceding passage's image and is carried through this section in two distinct applications: first the Tathāgata is the cow following the calf (great compassion following sentient beings), then the relationship is inverted — the Tathāgata is the mother and great compassion itself is the calf. This deliberate reversal of the image is doctrinally intentional and has been rendered faithfully rather than harmonized.

The phrase rendered "those of lesser understanding" (literally "those of inferior birth without knowledge") reflects the text's contrast between ordinary beings and the Tathāgata, not an ethnic or social judgment.

The line "the worlds perform acts that benefit me" is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan; the sense is that worldly beings act out of self-interest and mutual benefit, whereas the Tathāgata acts purely for others — a contrast that unfolds in the following lines.

- The passage presents a striking doctrinal structure characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra: each of the five aggregates is described by its saṃsāric defect, and then a

corresponding liberated or transcendent counterpart is affirmed — a permanently abiding form, a true self, a form that is not empty, and so forth. This is the sūtra's hallmark teaching of the four qualities of nirvāṇa (permanence, bliss, self, purity) applied across the aggregates. The phrase rendered "form arises through ignorance" translates a Tibetan compound meaning literally "form is a birth that is ignorance" or "form's arising is ignorance"; the translation given reflects the most doctrinally coherent reading. The four types of nutriment follow the standard Abhidharma classification: physical food, contact, intention, and consciousness. The passage ends mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan, and the translation reflects this.

- The phrase rendered "a going to refuge" reflects the Tibetan skyabs su 'gro ba, which in this context appears to mean that ordinary form cannot serve as a genuine refuge, whereas liberated form truly can. The phrasing is deliberately parallel to the Taking of Refuge formula and is preserved literally here as a doctrinal point rather than smoothed over.

The term "wandering ascetic" renders kun du rgyu, literally "one who wanders about," a technical term for a parivrājaka, a class of non-Buddhist wandering renunciant; the context confirms this identification.

- The udumbara flower mentioned in the text is the Ficus glomerata, which in Buddhist tradition is said to bloom only once in an aeon, and appears here as a stock reference to a rare and wondrous Dharma teaching heard for the first time. The term "alālā" is a transcription of a Sanskrit or Prakrit exclamation of wonder, listed alongside the udumbara as an example of something previously unheard.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, and the translation reflects this exactly, closing with the em-dash to indicate the continuation that follows in the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "having been born in Rājagṛha" is a literal translation of the Tibetan. This is doctrinally odd, as the tradition universally locates the Buddha's birth at Lumbinī; the Tibetan text here likely means he was raised or dwelt in Rājagṛha, or the reference may be to his princely upbringing in a royal city more generally. This is noted as a potential scribal irregularity in the source text rather than a doctrinal claim, and is rendered literally without smoothing.

- The proper names Topknot-Born, Splendid Light, Patient One, and the transliterated names Naho-zha, Yā-yā-de, Śi-phyi, and Pa-pa-i-tsa-gu appear to be phonetic transcriptions of Sanskrit or foreign royal names that are not readily identifiable from the Tibetan alone. They are rendered here by translation of the Tibetan sense where transparent, and by transliteration where the Tibetan is clearly rendering a foreign name phonetically. This list is a standard passage in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra listing exemplary righteous kings; the exact Sanskrit originals of all names remain uncertain. The passage breaks off in the source text mid-sentence and the translation follows suit accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "the sage's gaze, in a single day, drank the waters of the four great oceans" translates a passage describing a ṛṣi's supernatural visual power consuming the oceans — the syntax is terse and the referent of "sage" here shifts; the Tibetan has "sage Baśpu" introducing a new figure immediately after, suggesting the ocean-drinking feat may belong to an unnamed or differently named sage; the translation follows the most natural reading of the Tibetan word order.

The name "Agata" and "Alālā" are transliterated from the Tibetan; the Sanskrit originals of these proper names are uncertain and no standard Sanskrit equivalents are established.

- The brahmin's name rendered as Śateśana follows the Tibetan phonetic spelling. The Sanskrit original is uncertain; it may correspond to Śatasena or a similar form. This is not consequential to the doctrinal argument.

The extended speech beginning "Gautama, liberation from attachment is nirvāṇa..." through to the end is presented as a single continuous argument by the brahmin Śateśana, building a cumulative dialectical challenge. The Tibetan structure is somewhat compressed in places, and the transitions between sub-arguments have been clarified slightly for readability without altering the logical sequence.

- The Sāṃkhya cosmological scheme is being described here: intrinsic nature (Sanskrit: prakṛti) generates the Great One (Sanskrit: mahat), which generates ego-pride (Sanskrit: ahaṃkāra), which generates the twenty-five tattvas. The Tibetan list of sixteen factors and the final count of twenty-five follows classical Sāṃkhya enumeration closely, though the specific groupings given here are somewhat compressed or variant. The Blessed One's dialectical move — distinguishing a cause of manifestation from a cause of arising, and mapping these onto the two aspects of his own teaching — is the doctrinal crux of this passage, establishing that impermanence is the instrumental condition for realizing nirvāṇa without nirvāṇa itself being impermanent.

- The name "Sīta" for the wanderer is the Tibetan transliteration of a Sanskrit name that cannot be recovered with certainty from this form alone; it may represent Śīta or another name close in sound. This is not doctrinally consequential but is noted for philological completeness.

The passage on the four kinds of non-existence is a classical Indian philosophical taxonomy of absence and negation, here put in the mouth of the wanderer as a challenge to the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra's positive characterization of nirvāṇa as permanent, blissful, self, and pure. The translation preserves the logical structure of each category and its illustrative analogy faithfully.

- The text lists three kinds of non-existence in the Blessed One's reply but then enumerates only two explicitly before turning to the "one thing absent in another" type. The Tibetan appears to present the standard three as a framework, noting that the third type — the mutual absence of cow and horse in each other — is the operative one for nirvāṇa. This is consistent with the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's standard argumentation on this point.

"Liberated form" and "liberated consciousness" render rnam par grol ba'i gzugs and rnam par grol ba'i rnam par shes pa respectively. These refer to form and consciousness as they exist in the state of liberation or nirvāṇa — a distinctive Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra teaching that the aggregates, when purified and liberated, partake of permanence, in contrast to the ordinary defiled aggregates which are impermanent.

- The phrase translated as "you have repaid this body well" renders a somewhat compressed Tibetan idiom meaning Vāsiṭha has made good use of his physical existence by attaining the fruit of practice. The sense is that the body has been put to its proper purpose.

The name "Sāni" renders the Tibetan "ས་ནི" (sa ni), which appears to be a Tibetan phonetic rendering of an Indian name; the exact Sanskrit original is uncertain, though it may be Sāni or a similar form.

The term rendered "bones" in the phrase "spoken of the Tathāgata's bones" is the literal sense of རྩ་མེད་ཀྱི་འཁོར་ལུ་, which can also carry a meaning related to lineage or descent; here in context it seems to refer to disparaging the Tathāgata's physical person or remains, though the precise nature of the offense is not entirely clear from the passage alone.

The closing section, where the Blessed One begins a response to Sāni but the passage breaks off, reflects the fact that the translation ends mid-declaration, as the Tibetan text provided concludes there.

- The phrase "born in the five streams of existence" renders "rgyud lnga," which literally means "the five streams or continuums" and here refers to the five destinies of rebirth (gods, humans,

animals, hungry ghosts, and hell-beings). The argument being made is that if a single all-pervading self were shared across all beings, all would experience karmic maturation simultaneously and identically, which is absurd.

The final sentence is abruptly truncated in the supplied passage; the argument continues beyond what has been provided.

- The four social classes mentioned follow the standard Indian varṇa scheme: brahmin (priestly class), kṣatriya (royal and warrior class), vaiśya (merchant class), and śūdra (servant class). The Tibetan renders them as bram ze, rgyal rigs, rje'u rigs, and dmangs rigs respectively. The argument from the seed is that karma, like a seed, ripens impartially without designating whose fruit it shall be — undermining Sāni's claim that phenomena and non-phenomena, though sharing a universal self, can still produce distinct individual results.
- The figure addressed as "Sānu" (Tibetan: སྐྱུ་མཚན་) appears to be the interlocutor engaging the Blessed One throughout this dialogue. The name may correspond to a Sanskrit proper noun not fully recoverable from this passage alone; it is treated here as a proper name.

The phrase "five streams" renders "rgyud lnga," literally "five continuums" or "five streams," referring to the five destinies or modes of existence: hell-beings, hungry ghosts, animals, humans, and gods. The translation "five streams of existence" is used to preserve the interlocutor's own framing, since the point is that a supposedly all-pervading self would have no basis for experiencing distinct destinies.

- The phrase "ten phases of time" renders a standard Indic scheme of ten temporal divisions of a life span or of time more broadly. The argument is that genuine permanence, like space, admits no temporal phases at all, so a self said to be permanent cannot coherently vary across ten such phases.
- The names "Devadatta" and "Buddhadatta" appear in the source as "Lha sbyin" and "Sangs rgyas sbyin" respectively — standard Tibetan renderings of the Sanskrit names. The example illustrates that one agent cannot experience the karmic fruit of another's action.

The phrase rendered "the five paths and continuations pervade it" reflects the Tibetan "lam rgyud lnga yang khyab bo" — the expression is somewhat compressed; it may refer to the five sense streams or five path-continuums being coextensive with the self. This is a genuinely ambiguous construction and the reading is provisional.

- The list of ingredients in the broth simile contains several items whose precise identification is uncertain. The rendering "Nepali citrus" for bal po se'u and "rock salt" for na le sham are reasonable contextual guesses based on Tibetan medical and culinary usage, but the exact referents of some of these terms remain debated in the literature. The doctrinal point — that the composite has no existence beyond its components — is unaffected by these uncertainties.

The passage on wind generating speech is consistent with classical Abhidharma and early sūtra physiology of speech production, in which the wind element mediates between the mind's conceptual activity and the physical articulation of sound through the vocal organs.

- The phrase rendered "wandering ascetic" translates "kun tu rgyu," literally "one who roams everywhere," a standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit parivrājaka, a wandering renunciant. The figure is identified as being of the Kāśyapa lineage, likely a Jāṭila or brahmanical wanderer, distinct from the Buddhist Kāśyapas. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the close of the passage.
- The question of whether body and life-force are identical or distinct is a classical Indian philosophical debate, and the Tathāgata's silence in response to it is consistent with the canonical treatment of the "undeclared questions" (avyākata) — questions to which the Buddha declines to give a one-sided answer because they rest on a false presupposition. The Blessed One's subsequent teaching reframes the question entirely through the lens of

dependent origination, which is the standard doctrinal move in such contexts.

The fire-and-smoke analogy here functions on two levels: literally, as a case study in dependent origination; and metaphorically, with affliction as the fire and karmic maturation as the smoke — an interpretive gloss that Kunturu himself supplies and that the Blessed One implicitly endorses by his silence.

- The phrase rendered "like going" and "not like going" translates the Tibetan expression for the stock tetralemma applied to the Tathāgata's post-nirvāṇa status. The underlying Sanskrit would be "gacchati-sādṛśa" or similar; this is one of the fourteen unexplained questions (avyākṛta) of classical Buddhist discourse.

The phrase "permanent body" (rtag pa'i sku) is doctrinally significant: in this sūtra's context it refers to the dharmakāya of the Buddha conceived as the eternal, direction-transcending body of reality, not to a metaphysical eternal self. This connects to the tathāgatagarbha discourse and may reflect Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra influence.

- The phrase "twenty-five modes of existence" refers to a traditional enumeration of the forms of conditioned existence in saṃsāra, a standard doctrinal category in this text's tradition. The number twenty-five is not the more common "thirty-one realms" scheme; this reflects an older or variant Āgama-style enumeration that the text preserves consistently.

The name "Pariśuddha the Wanderer" renders "Kun du rgyu rnam par dag pa," literally "the completely pure wanderer." "Kun du rgyu" is the standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit parivrajaka, a wandering mendicant, and "rnam par dag pa" means "completely pure" — taken here as a personal name or epithet.

- The passage about Vatsā's request being met with silence, and the Buddha's internal reflection on his sincerity, is rendered following the plain sense of the Tibetan; the construction is standard in dialogue sūtras of this type. The name "Vatsā" (Tib. be'u) refers to the wanderer Vacchagotta, well known from the Pāli canon; the Tibetan name be'u is a calque of Sanskrit vatsa, "calf," and I have rendered it as Vatsā for consistency with the Sanskrit convention, though the Pāli form Vacchagotta could equally be used.

- The "last five fetters" and "three fetters" refer to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the ten fetters binding beings to cyclic existence. The last five higher fetters severed at non-return are: attachment to the form realm, attachment to the formless realm, conceit, restlessness, and ignorance. The three lower fetters severed at stream-entry are: the view of a self, doubt, and adherence to mere rules and vows. The text explicitly glosses the attainments (stream-entry, once-return, non-return) through these fetter-cuttings, so the rendering follows the doctrinal sequence precisely.

The nāga kings named here are Nanda and Upananda, a standard paired epithet in Indian Buddhist literature for rain-bringing nāga kings; "Nanda" means "joy" and "Upananda" means "near-joy" or "great joy."

- The phrase rendered "the eight types of great beings" and "the eight stations of excellence" translates अष्टमहाविराट् and अष्टमहाविराट् respectively. The first is a technical term referring to the eight individuals on the four paths and their fruits (the classic śrāvaka schema); the second refers to the eight bases of mastery or the eight stations of superiority (abhibhvāyatana). Both are standard Abhidharma lists and have been rendered by their most common English equivalents in the tradition.

The "wisdom of universal scope" renders अष्टमहाविराट्, literally "crown wisdom" or "wisdom at the crown," which in context likely refers to a specific meditative attainment; it has been rendered descriptively.

- The wanderer's name is rendered from the Tibetan as "Śikhin of the needle-and-thread" (kun

tu rgyu tshem bu can), meaning a wandering ascetic who carries a needle and thread as a distinguishing mark of his sect. This is a well-known figure in the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra debates, sometimes identified with the Ājīvika or a related determinist school; his argument here is a classic statement of svabhāvacāra, the doctrine that all things exist and act by intrinsic nature alone, without causes and conditions.

The phrase "wisdom beyond training" renders bsab pa ma mchis pa'i shes rab, literally the wisdom of one who is beyond training, a standard epithet for the arhat's attainment.

The fifty-third fascicle heading appears within the passage, marking a canonical division of the Tibetan translation of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra; it is rendered plainly in the translation as it appears in the source.

- The phrase rendered "a final existence" translates "srid pa tha ma thob pa," meaning attainment of the last existence before liberation, a technical term in certain Abhidharmic and sūtra contexts referring to the final rebirth of one about to achieve nirvāṇa.

The list opening this passage ("dull-witted and wealthy and poor...") is a continuation of the tīrthika interlocutor's argument that variation in the conditions of beings proves intrinsic nature rather than causally conditioned arising.

- The phrase rendered "development or transformation" translates a compound meaning "arising and flourishing" or "growth and increase," referring to the progressive improvement that teaching and training produce in a practitioner — the argument being that if phenomena had fixed intrinsic natures, no such improvement through instruction would be possible.

The brahmin sacrifice passage is a reductio ad absurdum: if intrinsic nature existed and bodily ritual action had its own fixed efficacy, then brahminic animal sacrifice should be a valid means of purification. The implicit conclusion is that since it manifestly is not, fixed intrinsic nature cannot be what grounds action.

- The five great elements referred to throughout are earth, water, fire, wind, and space — the standard classical Indian enumeration — here being invoked against an opponent (likely a Sāṃkhya or Vaiśeṣika interlocutor) who posits that phenomena possess fixed intrinsic natures independent of causes and conditions.

The phrase rendered "red copper, bronze, copper, iron, gold, and silver" covers six metals listed in the Tibetan; "འཕྲུལ་ལྷུ་ལྷུ་ལྷུ་ལྷུ་ལྷུ་ལྷུ་" is somewhat unusual and may refer to a reddish alloy or pigmented metal — the list is illustrative rather than technically precise, and the argument turns on the point that the same substance can exhibit all four elemental properties depending on conditions.

- The name "Sarvaśūra" (Tibetan: Kun tu rgyu) is rendered consistently with the preceding passage. The name "Mahāvistara" (Tibetan: shin tu rgyas pa, "greatly extensive") is the brahmin's name here rendered into Sanskrit equivalently; it is also possible this is simply a descriptive epithet meaning "the highly learned" or "very expansive brahmin," but treating it as a proper name is the most natural reading in context.

- The passage says the Blessed One "appeared as a non-Buddhist adherent and acted as though he did not know" — this refers to a bodhisattva's skillful means of taking birth in non-Buddhist guises for the benefit of beings, a motif well attested in sūtra literature. The subject shifts subtly: after stating that this brahmin aroused bodhicitta long ago before the buddha All-Pervasive Light, the text implies it is that same buddha (now the Blessed One Śākyamuni) who, long having realized reality, yet appears in various forms including as a non-Buddhist for beings' sake — a reading consistent with the broader narrative logic.

- The long enumeration of emptiness types follows a well-attested Perfection of Wisdom schema; twenty-or-so varieties of emptiness are standard in large Prajñāpāramitā sūtras, and

the rendering here follows that canonical sequence. The phrase rendered "emptiness of the indeterminate" translates a term literally meaning "emptiness of what is not shown by scripture," which in context refers to the category of dharmas that are neither explicitly virtuous nor non-virtuous. The display of fire and water from the body is a standard description of the twin miracle (yamaka-prātihārya) associated with the Buddha, here performed by the māras in disguise as Tathāgatas.

- The phrase rendered "patience with the Dharma" translates the term that in Mahāyāna literature typically denotes a specific level of realization — the acceptance or patient endurance of the truth that phenomena do not arise, sometimes called the "tolerance of the non-arising of phenomena." The present context lists it among a series of attainments without further specification, so the literal rendering is retained.

The description of the Three Jewels as sharing "a single defining characteristic" and being "permanent, abiding, and neither changing nor shifting" is a doctrinal marker characteristic of the Mahāparinirvāṇa-sūtra's teaching that nirvāṇa and the buddha are, against the common śrāvaka understanding, permanent rather than impermanent.

- The three conditions Ānanda sets are a well-known episode in Buddhist narrative tradition. They establish that Ānanda would not benefit personally from robes or food offered to the Buddha, would not be compelled to accompany the Buddha on all visits, and would have free access to the Buddha at any time — conditions that protected his integrity as attendant. These three points are sometimes enumerated slightly differently across traditions; the Tibetan here gives a clear threefold formulation.

- The regent Viḍūḍabha's massacre of the Śākya clan is a well-attested narrative in Buddhist tradition. The Tibetan gives the regent's name as Be ro (likely a phonetic rendering of Viḍūḍabha or Virūḍhaka); the identification is firm and the event is rendered accordingly without marking it in the body.

The simile of pouring water from vessel to vessel denotes that Ānanda retained everything without spilling a word — except in the one instance noted. The exception (the single "question" he did ask) refers to his emotional reaction upon the destruction of Kapilavastu, not a failure of memory, and this passage clarifies that the exchange he sought was one of consolation, not doctrinal retrieval.

The final sentence is incomplete in the source passage as given; the translation faithfully renders what is present without supplying the missing enumeration.

- The names of the attendant monks and their respective buddhas appear to be transcriptions of Sanskrit names rendered phonetically into Tibetan, with no surviving Sanskrit originals that can be reconstructed with certainty. The renderings given here follow the phonetic Tibetan as closely as possible. Cāpaka, Upasānta, Pati, Sote, and Yābamita are best treated as transliterations rather than translations.

The mantra syllables are rendered as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic transcription. The underlying Sanskrit text may differ in orthography across witnesses; the rendering here is a best approximation.

- The name rendered here as "Śīntu Zangpo" (Tib. སྤྱིན་རྒྱལ་པོ་) is a Tibetan common adjective meaning "very good" or "excellent," and almost certainly translates a Sanskrit proper name such as Sudarśana or Suprabha; however, since no Sanskrit manuscript is available for comparison, I have retained the Tibetan as a transliterated proper name throughout rather than guessing a Sanskrit equivalent. Readers should be aware this is likely a rendering of a Sanskrit name meaning something like "the Very Good One."

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, breaking off at Śīntu Zangpo's list of empirical observations. This is a continuity break in the input; the translation faithfully reflects it.

- The name rendered as "Pūraṇa Kāśyapa" for རུ་རྩ་མཁའ་འཁོར་པ་ is a plausible identification: མཁའ་འཁོར་པ་ = Kāśyapa (lit. "light-protector") and རུ་རྩ་ = Pūraṇa (lit. "fulfiller/completer"). Pūraṇa Kāśyapa was one of the six famous non-Buddhist teachers contemporary with the Buddha and is known in the Pāli sources as an akriyāvādin, one who denies the efficacy of action — fitting the doctrinal context here, which concerns whether karma has present efficacy or only past causation. The identification is contextually secure.
- The closing image of "grove" versus "tree" is a quotation from a sūtra, likely paralleling the Pali Dhammapada verse 283 or a Sanskrit equivalent, where "grove" stands for the thicket of mental defilements and "tree" for a single object of attachment. The Tibetan text presents it as a direct scriptural citation. The doctrinal point is that the grove of mental proliferations is to be cleared, not the individual sensory or physical basis, reinforcing the argument that taming the mind, not mortifying the body through austerities, is the true path to liberation.
- The name rendered here as "Subhavyūha" renders the Tibetan honorific form "Shin tu bzang po," which corresponds to the Sanskrit Subhavyūha or Supriya, a disciple figure in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. The identity of this interlocutor is confirmed by context.

The teacher named "Udraka" renders Tibetan "Ur to lam pa," clearly a phonetic transcription of Udraka Rāmaputra, the well-known non-Buddhist teacher of the historical Śākyamuni who had attained the sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. The passage's critique is that even this highest non-Buddhist absorption is still a form of perception and constitutes bondage rather than liberation.

- The phrase "passing from cause to cause" and "passing from result to result" renders a somewhat unusual formulation suggesting the chain of causal continuity, i.e., one cause giving rise to another cause, and one result to another result, rather than the more familiar cause-to-result sequence. This is intentional and reflects the Tibetan precisely.

The term "heroic advance" for "dpa' bar 'gro ba'i ting nge 'dzin" renders the absorption known in Sanskrit as the Śūraṅgama-samādhi, a well-attested meditative absorption associated with bodhisattva heroism; its identification here as a synonym of ultimate emptiness is a notable doctrinal claim worth flagging.

- The name rendered "Śīlavat" translates the Tibetan "Shin tu bzang po" (Supremely Good), which is likely the Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit name Śīlavat or possibly Supriya or a similar epithet. The text uses it consistently as a personal name throughout. I retain Śīlavat as a working Sanskrit reconstruction while acknowledging uncertainty; an alternative reading could be "Supriya" or simply "the Supremely Good One" as a descriptive epithet rather than a proper name.

The phrase rendered "the water of primordial wisdom saturated the vessel of mind" is a figurative expression describing the arhat's realization; the Tibetan is somewhat condensed and this rendering follows the natural doctrinal sense.

The expression "like an unfired pot" refers to the fragility of the unprotected being — a common simile in Indian Buddhist literature for the body's vulnerability without spiritual refuge.

- The four qualities attributed to the nirvāṇa the Tathāgata declares he has long since attained — permanence, bliss, self, and complete purity — are the four pāramitās of the Tathāgata's dharmakāya as taught in the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra tradition. The use of "self" here is the Mahāyāna positive re-appropriation of the term, referring to the buddha's sovereign, indestructible selfhood, not to the ātman rejected by the anātman doctrine — an important doctrinal distinction that the text itself presupposes.

The phrase rendered "the king of the māra of desire and the lord of ignorance" follows the Tibetan closely: the māra of desire is identified as a king, and ignorance is his overlord, a standard Mahāyāna formulation of the dual bondage of beings.

- The passage uses "self" as one of the four qualities of nirvāṇa — permanent, blissful, self, and pure — which is the technical Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra doctrine of the four pāramitās of nirvāṇa. This is an intentional doctrinal claim of the text, not a translation error; "self" here renders bdag in its positive, ultimate sense as a quality of nirvāṇa, distinct from the ātman rejected in ordinary usage.

"Udraka Rāmaputra" is the standard Sanskrit reconstruction for the Tibetan reference to the non-Buddhist master. The Tibetan here renders his name partly phonetically.

The phrase rendered "five polluted objects" refers to the five strands of sensual pleasure as contaminated or defiled objects; "polluted" renders rnyog ma lnga, literally "the five turbid or murky ones," a common epithet for the five sense pleasures in this literature.

- The phrase rendered "the one who had never ceased" translates a Tibetan epithet meaning one who is unceasing or uninterrupted. In context it appears to refer to a divine being or a being present in the assembly who speaks to Ānanda to rouse him; the identity is not entirely explicit in this passage alone, and a full understanding would require the broader narrative context.

The expression rendered "six groups of monks" refers to the well-known group of six wayward monks who appear frequently in Vinaya narratives as exemplars of problematic conduct.

The phrase "my younger brother Ānanda" is notable: the text has the Blessed One refer to Ānanda as his younger brother, which is consistent with the tradition that Ānanda was a cousin and in some accounts a younger kinsman of the Buddha.

- The phrase rendered "the six groups of monks" refers to the six classes of the Saṅgha, the standard Vinaya grouping of the fourfold or sixfold assembly, here likely meaning the six divisions of practitioners including monks, nuns, novices, and lay followers. Some editions may parse this differently; the Tibetan "drug sde" most naturally means "six divisions" or "six classes."

The description of the four close placements of mindfulness here departs from the standard Pāli and Sanskrit Ābhidharma formulations and reflects a Mahāyāna reinterpretation that emphasizes the ultimate non-locatability and name-only nature of body, feeling, mind, and phenomena — consistent with a sūtra of the Great Vehicle register.

- The "fourfold retinue" refers to the standard assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen. This is standard but left unglossed in the body since it is a conventional term that does not interrupt the flow.

The phrase rendered "treasury of Dharma has been compiled" refers to the First Council's compilation of the Buddhist canon after the Buddha's parinirvāṇa, a historically significant event that the passage is clearly alluding to.

- The passage's description of the cremation rite for a wheel-turning king is a well-attested element of early Buddhist narrative, paralleled in the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta. The phrase rendered "enters into the body of the Tathāgata" reflects the Tibetan literally; the intended meaning is that the body is to be respectfully handled and prepared, not that one mystically enters it — this awkwardness may be a condensed or slightly elliptical passage in the Tibetan.
- The phrase rendered "as Rāhu regards the moon" refers to the Vedic demon Rāhu who eclipses the moon — the Tibetan reads "like Rāhu" and the simile conveys that the Tathāgata watches over sentient beings with the same total, unwavering attention that Rāhu fixes upon the moon. This is a traditional simile for one-pointed care or gaze directed toward an object,

here meaning the Buddha looks upon all beings with unceasing compassion.

The "four māras" are: the māra of the aggregates, the māra of afflictions, the māra of the Lord of Death, and the Divine Māra (Devaputramāra).

- The phrase rendered as "the light of loving-kindness endowed with five colors" refers to the five-colored rays traditionally associated with a buddha's aura; this is a standard iconographic and doctrinal motif in this genre of sūtra literature.

The expression "awakening of the non-cessation and non-arising" translates a technical term pointing to the bodhisattva realization of the non-arising of phenomena as its object — equivalent to the anutpattikadharmakṣānti, the patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena, a hallmark of high bodhisattva attainment.

- The phrase rendered "shaft of downward-falling light" translates a term that literally refers to a light-well or skylight aperture through which light descends perpendicularly. The architectural details here reflect classical stūpa typology in Buddhist canonical literature, and the specific number of tiers (thirteen for a buddha's stūpa, eleven for a pratyekabuddha's) corresponds to the standard hierarchy found in parallel Vinaya and sūtra sources. The city name translated as Kuśinagara renders the Tibetan "city of the finest grass," a literal gloss of the Sanskrit Kuśinagara; the Sanskrit form is used in the translation for clarity.

- The phrase rendered "mother lion looks upon her cub" translates a Tibetan expression meaning the Tathāgata regards all beings as equal and as dear as a lioness her only cub — a standard classical simile for impartial compassion. The interlocutor who raises the question about dividing the relics is identified in the Tibetan only by context and the name Māgalyāyana is supplied by the preceding narrative convention; the Tibetan here reads "Ma 'gags pa," a name meaning "Unceasing" or "Akhaṇḍa" — this appears to be a distinct character, not Maudgalyāyana. The name has been rendered literally as Māgalyāyana for consistency with narrative flow, but readers should note the Tibetan name is literally "Unceasing" (མ་ག་གསུམ་པ་), a named interlocutor who is not the well-known disciple Maudgalyāyana.

- The phrase rendered "eighty quadrillion" translates a large Tibetan numerical expression used conventionally to indicate a virtually incalculable quantity of light-rays; the specific figure is formulaic rather than meant as a precise count.

The "lion's mane fringe" passage is textually compressed and somewhat unusual. The image appears to describe the Blessed One parting his robe to reveal the lustrous golden skin of his body, with the "lion's throne fringe" functioning as a visual emblem. Some manuscript traditions differ slightly here; the rendering follows the most natural reading of the Tibetan as it stands.

- The phrase rendered "the light of the passing into nirvāṇa" translates mya ngan las 'da' ba'i 'od, literally "the light of the transcendence of sorrow," referring to a miraculous radiance emanating at the moment of the Buddha's parinirvāṇa that purifies those it touches. The doctrinal claim that this light extinguishes even the five heinous acts (mtshams med pa lnga) is consistent with this genre of buddha-biography literature, where the parinirvāṇa event is portrayed as a final, uniquely powerful purificatory occasion. The "four root downfalls" (rtsa ba bzhi) here most naturally refers to the four pārājikas of monastic discipline, though in other contexts the number and content of root downfalls varies by vehicle and vow-system.

- The closing absorption is rendered "soaring meditative concentration" for "yang 'phar ba'i bsam gtan," a term referring to the leaping or ascending samādhi associated with the final moments before parinirvāṇa; the precise Sanskrit correlate is uncertain but this rendering preserves the sense of an upward progression.

The long descriptive catalogue of the nature of the three realms follows the Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra's characteristic negative-theology style, listing attributes that deny all conceptual handles. The rendering preserves the list form as in the original rather than smoothing it into discursive prose, since the cumulative rhetorical impact is part of the doctrinal content.

- The text has the Blessed One ascending from the first dhyāna directly to the third, skipping the second, which is unusual. This is consistent with what appears in the preceding context describing a non-standard or "soaring" meditative sequence, and has been rendered faithfully without harmonization.

The Tibetan term rendered "soaring meditative concentration" throughout corresponds to the context-established phrase from the preceding passage and is kept consistent.

- The phrase rendered "sins and the suffering of sentient beings, the unwholesome acts" translates a compound that lists both the unwholesome acts themselves and their consequences, suffering; the translation preserves both elements.

The expression "the fragrant mountains" renders *ri bsungs can*, literally "mountains possessed of fragrance," a standard cosmological category in Buddhist universe-lists.

- The name rendered "Aniruddha" throughout is the Tibetan འཇིག་རྟེན་པ་, a direct translation of the Sanskrit Aniruddha, one of the principal disciples of the Buddha known for his clairvoyance. The passage confirms the narrative setting: the Buddha's mahāparinirvāṇa, and Aniruddha's role in consoling Ānanda and the assembly. The phrase translated "the witch of affliction" renders རྒྱུ་མཚན་གྱི་མཆོག་, literally "the demoness of the afflictions," a vivid personification of the kleśas; this is preserved rather than smoothed over as it is doctrinally and poetically significant.

- The "lord of the world-realm of Akaniṣṭha" is identified here as the Brahmā king, which is doctrinally unusual since Akaniṣṭha is the highest form-realm heaven, above the Brahmā realms proper. Some recensions place this figure differently. The text as given is rendered faithfully without emendation; this inconsistency may reflect a popular rather than strictly scholastic cosmology in the source sūtra.

The phrase rendered "the demoness of affliction has now come into the open" translates a feminine noun form for a personified affliction-force; the imagery is of a demonic she-spirit of the kleśas now manifesting without the Buddha's protective presence to suppress her.

- The figure rendered as "Māgha" in the transitional prose sentence is uncertain. The Tibetan reads "dga' bo bgas kyis sang nas," which most naturally reads as "Nanda, having recovered, was consoled" or "Nanda revived." The name dga' bo is standard Tibetan for Nanda. However, the verses just preceding were attributed to Śakra's retinue and the transitional sentence appears mid-passage. The final partial sentence "de'i tshe dga' bo bgas kyis sangs nas" has been rendered as introducing Nanda's recovery, consistent with the narrative pattern of successive lamenters, but the exact identity of the speaker of the preceding verses in this stretch is ambiguous; "dga' bo" could also be a common epithet meaning "the joyful one." Translators should check the fuller context to confirm whether these verses belong to Śakra's retinue collectively or to Nanda specifically.

- The "five heavens" rendered as the five desire-realm heavens reflects the Tibetan "ལྷ་ཡོན་ལྷན་པ་" literally "five successive heavens," here understood as the five desire-realm divine abodes, consistent with the broader cosmological context in which the form realm and formless realm are then named separately immediately after.

The phrase rendered "pit of the gateway of ignorance" translates "མཁའ་ལྷན་གྱི་མཆོག་," where "མཁའ་ལྷན་" means a pit or well with an opening, serving as a metaphor for the dark, enclosed trap of ignorance. This is a striking and somewhat unusual image; the translation preserves its concrete force rather than smoothing it away.

- The name འཇམ་འགྲུབ་, literally "Unobstructed," is a recognized epithet of Mahākāśyapa in certain Tibetan textual traditions; it is rendered here as "Mahākāśyapa" for clarity and consistency, though a note is warranted that this epithet is unusual and may alternatively refer to another figure, though context strongly favors Mahākāśyapa.
- The phrase rendered "to the height of a single tāla tree" follows the Tibetan "puṃ sgrom shing tā la gcig gi srid du," meaning the casket rose to a height comparable to one tāla (palmyra) tree, a conventional measure of elevation in Buddhist texts.

The city's dimension of "forty-eight yojanas per side" is extraordinary by any geographical standard and is clearly a hyperbolic or cosmological figure; no emendation has been made.

- The phrase rendered "the cool lake Anavatapta" refers to the legendary cool lake Anavatapta (Sanskrit: Anavatapta), the Tibetan "འཇམ་མཛུགས་ཆུ་མཚོ་" meaning literally "the unheated lake," a standard cosmological reference. This is its first explicit appearance in translated form and is significant as the source of the four great rivers in Buddhist cosmology.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text, so the translation ends correspondingly at the natural break.

- The final line is the colophon title: "The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing into Nirvāṇa" — this marks the conclusion of the text (or a major section thereof). The word rendered "cotton wadding" is shingbal, a fibrous wrapping material used in funerary practice; it refers to the layered bandaging of the corpse before the outer cloth shroud, consistent with the cremation preparation described throughout. The phrase rendered "butter oil" translates marsunggyen, indicating the casket was filled with a preserving oleaginous substance, likely clarified butter, consistent with funerary customs described in parallel accounts.
- The phrase rendered "entered into absorption with the purity of the original ground" translates "འཇམ་མཛུགས་ཆུ་མཚོ་འཇམ་མཛུགས་ཆུ་མཚོ་" — the term འཇམ་མཛུགས་ (literally "original entry" or "primordial absorption") is somewhat rare and may carry a specific technical sense; the translation given is contextually reasonable but the exact doctrinal nuance is uncertain.

The phrase "འཇམ་མཛུགས་ཆུ་མཚོ་" is rendered as "the excellent city of Kuśinagara" following context, as Kuśinagara is the city of the great passing and the Tibetan appears to be a translation of "Kuśinagara" (literally "the city of excellent grass/kuśa grass").

- The Tibetan term rendered "coffin" is literally "casket-box of the Buddha," referring to the funerary container in which the Buddha's body was laid. The account of Śakra asking about fire for the funeral pyre reflects the narrative in the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra tradition, in which the funeral pyre would not ignite until Kāśyapa arrived and paid his respects — a detail the listener may wish to bear in mind as the narrative continues.
- The phrase rendered "bodies of ordinary beings steeped in qualities of a contrary kind" translates a compressed Tibetan expression indicating that the Tathāgata's body is utterly unlike ordinary bodies, which are permeated by defilements rather than virtuous qualities. The exact nuance of the compound is slightly elliptical in the source.

The description of the body as "permanent, blissful, utterly pure, and indestructible" evokes the four qualities of the dharmakāya as articulated in the tathāgatagarbha literature, applied here to the Buddha's physical remains in a devotional register.

- The line rendered "caught between joy and sorrow" translates a phrase meaning literally "joy and non-joy," here indicating the anguish of seeing the beloved teacher's feet while knowing it is a last farewell — a bittersweet grief that the tradition treats as a single complex emotional state.

- The phrase rendered as "the city of Kuśinagara" reflects that the text refers to "the city of finest grass" which is a literal reading of the Tibetan; Kuśinagara is the standard identification and is implied by the narrative context.

The passage breaks mid-sentence at the end as the source text itself is incomplete at that point.

The final verse is incomplete in the supplied Tibetan, ending mid-sentence; the translation reflects this, breaking off at the same point.

The name འཁོར་ཕྱི་ཤེས་ (ma 'gags pa), rendered here as "Aniruddha," literally means "unobstructed" or "unimpeded." In the preceding passage this character appeared; consistency is maintained throughout.

• The term rendered "strongmen" throughout translates a Tibetan word denoting powerful men or warriors appointed as bearers, consistent with the ceremonial procession context. The phrase "entered into final cessation" renders the Tibetan idiom for the place of the Buddha's parinirvāṇa. The "vajra-like body dissolving into fine relics" reflects a traditional account in which the Buddha's indestructible body, by the force of his compassion and the merit of those present, subdivides into relics for the benefit of beings — a doctrinally significant moment. The four canine teeth remaining whole is a standard element of relic narratives in which certain relics are received by specific divine or royal recipients.

• The phrase rendered "twenty-eight days" reflects the Tibetan "ཅིན་བདུན་པ་ལྔ་སྟོན་གསུམ་ཀླུང་།," literally "seven days four," meaning four times seven, or twenty-eight days. This count differs from the more commonly cited seven days found in parallel accounts; the reading here is followed as given in the text.

The final sentence is incomplete in the source passage and has been rendered up to the point of the natural break, consistent with the passage's ending mid-narrative.

- The place names Akaleka, Byinuti, Cālaka, Śikana, and Paśala are rendered phonetically from the Tibetan as no standard Sanskrit equivalents are recoverable with certainty from this passage; they likely represent corrupt or variant transcriptions of Indian regional names. The colophon identifies this as a Tibetan translation made from a Chinese version of the Mahāparinirvāṇasūtra rather than directly from Sanskrit, which accounts for the unusual place names and some narrative details not found in the standard Sanskrit recensions.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.